**From The Sidelines**

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| Collections: | BakuDeku Euphoria, "To all the Fandom's I've never been that invested in before" Collection, fics that blessed my eyes and cursed my sleeping schedule, MHA fics that remind me why I'm alive 🌱 (previously "mha fics that keep me from working like a functional adult"), Bakudeku supremacy, bkdk fics that ARE A MUST!!!, Top Tier BNHA Fics, Fics I believe everyone should read-BNHA edition, best of bkdk :'), BNHA Top Tier, bkdk the world, Fanfics que deveriam virar livros, I'm Gonna Rec It, 💖My Hero Smut Life💖, 💔My Hero Stories That Made Me Cry💔, ⭐My Hero Stories Worth Your Time⭐, BBDF (AEETWWW): Best BakuDeku Fics (And Everyone Else They Work Well With), My Hero Academia Favorite Fics, shooks' fave bkdk fics, absolute gems i keep coming back to, bnha fics that make me drop my croissant, These BNHA Fics Are Novel Quality, The Good (finished) BkDk, BEST COMPLETE BK, GBFOAT: Greatest BakuDeku Fics Of All Time 💥🥦, Stellar Fics: A Wonder Duo Collection ☆★, fics that pull me from the depths of despair, ✨ ~ TBMHAFTHEE: The Best My Hero Academia Fics To Have Ever Existed ~ ✨, bakudeku unlimited, That good bkdk juice, Paiiinnn, My Hero Academia, Adored Fics, Fav BKDK Fics, Haru's Happy & Horny Horde, Subscribed books I've finished, A+ fucking works, MHA BKDK LOVE, bkdk favs :), Legitimately The Best Works I've Ever Read, Good soup, that good shit, Fics that cause me to be sleep deprived, Favs mesmo, Favoritas só que um nível acima, twin stars ♡, OTP Fics That Ruined Me, Bakudeku books That leave you squealing, Leo's Top Tier, pain. suffering even. agony if you will., These are Bundles of Emotions (and I Love them af), what in the bkdk is this, Hollis approves of these fics, BNHA best fics, Touched my soul, To Be |

Bound, Amazing Reads and Inspiration for BNHA, The "I wish I had amnesia so I can read this all over again" BKDK Collection, This made me sob at 2 pm on a tuesday., absolute favorites, bnha fics that kept me company at night, Cel's fav bkdk fics, retro-triscuit's favorite (bkdkbk) fics, BKDK fics that both broke and healed my soul 🧡💚, fics for my BakuDeku addiction, Kori's fic collection, bkdk fics that single-handedly cured my depression, Who needs sleep when there is BKDK, lil' bkdk box of skittles (+others), I would sell all 10 toes to read these fics for the first time again, Bakudeku Fics That Ripped My Heart Out And Made Me Question Existence, Decchan Supremacy., now THIS is bkdk, BakuDeku Goldmine, MAC MHA Faves, Out of this World - literally., Fics that ruined me, my top top bkdk/dkbk faves, Bkdk, best bkdk fics!!, Like a river flows: a bkdk fanfics collection, BKDK, Fics I loved, The Best Fan-works of Bakugou Katsuki!, Favorite Bakugou Angst with a Dash of Fluff, Best fucking read of my life, The Abyss Records, fics i cant stop thinking about, a literal treasure if u ask me, ~ angry pomeranian approved ~, ☆ Potterette's Neverland Treasure ☆, exquisitas obras de literatura 🚬🚬, BKDK fics that are written better than BNHA 🥦💥, bkdk euphoria ;)., Best of BKDK 💚🧡, Zaang Reading List (Complete Fics), bookworx26's marvelous collection of BNHA fics, bkdk made me want to live🥦💥, Absolute masterpiece, Best shit ever, 🖉, ✧˚ ₊ ⋆｡♡˚ , *chef's kisses*, Bakudeku gems, losing myself in, best long fics, My Favourite Fanfics, Favorite Well Written Reads, MHA746, them tears™ (bnha edition), This Some Good Shit Right Here, Creative Chaos Discord Recs, My Absolute Favorites, My hero academia, Favorites, Dekussun Favorite BKDKBK Fics, bkdk fics that own my 👣, My Hero Academia, Fics That Keep Me Up At Night, I've read this and it never left my mind since, My drugies, My Hero Academia, Absolute Favorites, best of bkdk, ❀ㄹ|아❀'s library, Fav bkdk, BKDK🫶🫶, SMALL COLLECTION OF ABSOLUTE PERFECTION | BNHA, The best reads, BNHA Must💥🥦, bkdk yuh, my BNHA favs, Best bakudeku fics, omg!, B is for Brilliant

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# From The Sidelines

by suffocatingspring

Summary

When long-time enemies, Bakugo Katsuki--the all-star athlete and rascal of Ise--and Izuku Midoriya, the town sweetheart, are paired together for a long-term project, the quiet beachside town of Ise suddenly gets a bit louder.

In which, Katsuki is an asshole pole vaulter, Izuku is going to fail psychology, and both are about to have the most intense spring semester yet.

# Chapter 1: The Track Field

Chapter Notes

retro playlist:
https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy?si=NLy4bSzxQCqhPLCqv8xgPA&dl_branch=1

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There has always been an unreachable space between the two of them. Izuku pondered that thought as he stands on the other side of a chain-linked fence separating the track field and the sidewalk.

Katsuki was always high in the sky, touching the stars every time he jumped, while Izuku made his place on the ground, and the distance between them forever a constant.

There was nothing wrong with the ground. Izuku liked how the grass feels between his toes, how the page of a book flips through his fingers as he lays against a tree, all of the sort. But there was something about watching Katsuki as he pole vaults: running up to the line, then jumping, so high into the sky that Izuku wonders if he had wings.

It was only on the field that Katsuki had a calm demeanor on him. The concentration in those ruby eyes were evident, as was the intentionality of every movement. No ounce of energy was wasted in any unnecessary action. It was one of the few times where Katsuki was quiet.

In order to get home, Izuku had to walk past the track field every day, and Izuku found solace in the fact that it was one of the rare moments that he could look at the explosive male and not have it turn into an argument. He could even stand there and watch for a few minutes, and nothing would happen. He thinks: he's probably been watching Katsuki like this for a few minutes every day since they were 11. That was 6 years after their friendship dissipated. And 7 years ago from today, as they were now both 18 in their final year of high school.

In a city as quiet as Ise, someone like Katsuki was a huge deal. The blonde, ever since he laid his hands on a pole, had been indestructible when it came to the sport. At first, it was light hearted praise: the young 11 year old who could get 14 feet of air on a pole vault and swept local competitions. He was a child prodigy, but people expected him to reach his peak soon enough. After all, small-town boy from a small school district: what's the most that could happen.

And then, as Katsuki's 15th birthday approached, and he was now taking a monopoly on *regional* competitions, the talk around town became a little more serious. He was unbeatable, a talent that was truly blessed to few in the world. He was bred for this.

And now, as Bakugo Katsuki is 18 years old, he was in the top five in the entire country in the youth division to be recruited for pros at a personal record of 17.6 feet. Some even say in about three years, he'll represent the nation in the Olympic League.

In a town that doesn't seem to offer much, Ise's extremely well put-together pole vault team, and its star Bakugou Katsuki, was the city's pride and joy, minus the blonde's reputation. To the rest of the world, pole vault isn't as popular of a sport as soccer, football, baseball, or the like; however, to Ise, everyone and their mother's cousin's dog knew of it. And if they knew of pole vault, then they knew of Bakugo Katsuki. Although there are 44 types of track-and-field events, it was the only one that really mattered here.

Izuku had never taken his eyes off of his former friend, no matter how much he wanted to. Katsuki was mesmerizing to watch. And if the blonde's teammates on the team noticed him there, they haven't said much, probably knowing what kind of relationship or lack thereof they had.

Once upon a time, they might have been childhood friends, but Izuku could barely remember the last time Katsuki gave a smile rather than a sneer his way. At some point when they were both 5 years old, Katsuki's personality just flipped on him. Suddenly, the blonde became a lot harsher, with his words and his actions.

Izuku couldn't even pinpoint what incited it, and he didn't bother asking. Katsuki probably wouldn't tell him. Middle school was especially bad, but as they entered high school, something was different. Izuku gained a bit more confidence, and gained new friends: Ochaco, Iida, Shoto, and the bunch. And Katsuki, who previously was surrounded by assholes, was slowly integrated into his group of friends who were much better influences on him: Kirishima, Denki, Mina, Hanta. All of whom were also part of the high school pole vault team.

At some point in their first year, Izuku and Katsuki had gotten into a fight. Katsuki had caught Izuku sketching the blonde's form during a jump from memory in class, and had taken his notebook.

When Izuku finally caught up to the blonde in the back parking lot of this cafe called Ground Beta, it got heated. In fact, it was the very first time Izuku had raised his hand and hit Katsuki back.

He immediately felt horrible, and was shocked to see that Katsuki's eyes had widened, even though Izuku knew his punch did not hurt. Izuku wasn't nearly as physically strong then as he was now, so he knew for a fact that his punch hadn't hurt. And yet, Katsuki looked surprised. At first, Izuku was upset. Did Katsuki expect him to take his punches forever?

But the day after, and the day after that, and then the day after that, Izuku was just confused. No longer upset. Just confused. Because Katsuki never raised a hand to him again, never touched his things again, and never said anything more cruel than that he was weak, or

annoying, or weird. They were more of normal enemies, rather than the toxic shitfest that they were before.

Izuku hadn't been truly afraid of the other for a while either.

However, that didn't mean they didn't argue every chance they got. It got to the point where most teachers at Ise High kept them as far apart in the classroom as they could. Most of the time, it was Katsuki being a prick, and Izuku trying his best to argue calmly, which would make the blonde even more upset. Despite all that, Izuku continued to stop by for a little bit to watch, every day. Classes end at around 3:30 in the afternoon, and by the time Izuku finishes his afterschool meetings for organizations he's a part of, he gets to catch Katsuki and his team in the middle of practice. More than just admiring the talent, Izuku enjoys analyzing: the form, the momentum, the details. He has a little notebook of it all that he keeps at the bottom of his backpack in case it gets stolen again.

Sometimes, Izuku wondered what had happened all of those years ago between them. And then, he realizes that it probably wouldn't have mattered. Even if they had stayed friends, their paths were always bound to divulge. Katsuki was meant to become a national-ranked athlete given a couple more years, and Izuku will likely go into some perfectly high-paying profession here in Ise after going to some college in the area.

Izuku had been too caught up with his thoughts that he hadn't even realized that the sun had been blocked.

When he did, Izuku jumped at the sound of the chain linked fence rattling at the pressure of a hand gripping it.

"Oi, nerd," Katsuki snapped to get his attention.

Izuku blinked, pulling himself back to the moment, and tilted his head up to look at Katsuki. The tall and incredibly well built athlete stood on the opposite side of the fence as him, one arm resting against the fence, and his chest was heaving from practicing.

"Kacchan," Izuku let out, mustering up his confident voice in case the blonde wanted to start an argument. He never kicked the habit of using his nickname. And Katsuki had stopped trying a long time ago.

"How long are you gonna stalk me for?" Katsuki questioned, raising an eyebrow while grinning menacingly.

Izuku frowned, "I wasn't…"

"Oh? You weren't?" He asked, "So you just stop right here a couple minutes on your way home every day just to, what, fucking bird watch?"

Izuku's face turned red. He hadn't realized that Katsuki had noticed, for the blonde had always seemed to be too focused to take note of his surroundings when it came to his sport. Izuku would have thought that he would have said something by now if he had noticed. After all, it's been years since he's made a habit of stopping for just a couple minutes every day to

watch Katsuki practice: either with the team or by himself. From when Katsuki was merely 11 years old and 5'0 feet tall, barely making it to the 13 feet mark in pole vault, to now, at 6 feet 4 inches clearing 17 feet of height, the blonde had never approached him during a practice.

This would mark the first time the blonde had ever confronted him about it, and Izuku wasn't quite sure what to say that wouldn't incite a petty fight.

"I mean, the birds *are* nice," Izuku looked to the side, awkwardly making an attempt at a joke. But that wasn't them. That wasn't the kind of relationship they had. They didn't joke.

When Katsuki didn't laugh (Izuku didn't know why he even thought that he would), the greenette stammered out a, "But I'm not stalking you! It's just…" Should he just say it? Katsuki never handled compliments very well. "Cool to see you jump! It looks like you're flying, and the aerodynamics of your body is incredible to see in real lif-"

"Don't tell me shit I already know, Deku," Katsuki huffed and then stepped back from the fence, "And stop the damn muttering."

"Ah," Izuku rubbed the back of his neck, "You could've just said thank you."

"Don't tell me what to d-"

"Don't tell you what to do, yeah yeah, I know," Izuku was used to the blonde's words by now and he just shrugged it off. This was probably one of the calmer arguments they've had, most likely because Katsuki was still in his pole-vaulting mood.

"If you know, then stop doing it," Katsuki clicked his tongue.

"I'm not-" Izuku was about to raise his voice, but then took a deep breath and calmed himself, "Okay, it's fine. I'm going home now. Have a good rest of your practice, Kacchan."

Katsuki rolled his eyes, "Of course, I will. Now get out of my sight, and get your ass home before your mom fucking goes beserk on you, goodie-two shoes."

Izuku frowned some more. His mother was, in fact, just a tad bit overprotective, but what got him frowning was that Katsuki remembered that. He was just surprised that the blonde still knew that detail about his life.

"R-right," He looked away, and began walking forward. Katsuki started heading back to the track field as well, but right before Izuku could get out of ear-shot, he hears his classic nickname being called.

"Deku!" Katsuki's signature yell called out. *What now*, Izuku thought and turned around, expecting another random nitpicky fight.

Izuku pursed his lips before asking, "Yes?"

"If you're gonna come be a stalker," Katsuki yelled, "Then at least make yourself useful, and get me a damn gatorade."

Izuku cupped his hands around his mouth and shouted back, “You’re just going to throw it away and say you don’t need anything from me,” He paused and then added, “And I’m not a stalker!”

“Sure, and I’m not blonde,” Katsuki shouted back sarcastically. It was a bit strange, having them yell back and forth over this distance when Izuku should be getting home and Katsuki should be practicing.

“To a blind person, you aren’t!” Izuku reasoned.

Katsuki gaped at him for a second, “Yeah, and to a deaf person, you aren’t an idiot. Now get the fuck away.”

Izuku sighed and let himself continue his trek home. Their interactions were always something like this, short and heated. Even when it wasn’t that serious. It was better than what it used to be, but by no means ideal. He wonders what it would be like to have a normal conversation with the person he looked up to so much.

It was April, the beginning of the school year in Ise, and the weather was a lot warmer this spring than it usually was. The days were getting longer slowly, as they just came out of winter. It never got particularly cold here, which Izuku liked. There was usually a warm breeze, and quite a bit of humidity when Spring and Summer comes.

Ise was a small town near the western coast of the country, with a population of 15,000 or so. It had the charm of the 80s, like it never left the decade, with its quiet and spaced-out suburban homes, children riding on bicycles through the neighborhood, tire swings in everyone’s backyard, and the ocean just walks away. On a quiet afternoon, it feels like you could hear the ticking of a clock in a neighbor’s house or the drip of a water faucet that wasn’t turned off all the way. On a hot day, popsicle sticks littered the driveway of families whose kids spent the evening playing in the sprinkler or with cheap plastic waterguns.

There were plenty of lakes near too, and on the eastern border of the town, there were a few green mountains that framed the place. There were some basic things to do in Ise if people knew where to look: a couple of swimming holes where teens would tie a rope to a tree and swing into the water. A movie theatre that hasn't been renovated since the *actual* year of 1987. An arcade with pachinko machines and neon signs decorating the interior. Drive-in restaurants were popular hang-out places for young adults at night when it was too hot outside, and they'd prefer to sit in the car with a bowl of donburi and a soda.

Most people had a small family-sized boat to take out onto the water, either at the lake or on the ocean.

There were two high schools, one library, and one small hospital. The closest indoor mall was about an hour away in a bigger city, even though Ise had nice boutiques and plenty of generational mom-and-pop shops set up in outlet strip malls.

Its main industry was very obviously commercial fishing being so close to the ocean, and second to that was a little bit of tourism: because, although in Japan, Ise had the quaint aesthetic of a Japanese town mixed with an American coastal city from the 80s. An odd mix, most would say, but it had its charm that most people, even those who lived there, didn't see.

In Ise, the sunsets were always an orangish pink, and the crickets always chirped a sweet song at night. The teenagers threw parties after soccer games, and once in a while, there were bonfires out in the fields. Cicadas shed its shells on Ise's plentiful trees, and the waters were always a clear blue.

Like most small to mid-size towns, all the adults always wanted to stay, and all of the kids always wanted to leave.

It was their senior year, and most of Izuku's friends, including himself, already had plans to leave Ise. Or at least, intentions to. He had already submitted his applications to several places in bigger cities without telling his mother who wanted him to stay near. He's hinted at the idea, but she always seemed to be distraught when he brought it up, so he drops it every time, applying to some closer universities to appease her.

Ochaco, being as clever as she was, was eyeing a university in Tokyo. Shoto was practically already accepted to anywhere he would want to go because of his father's status. Shoto lived here in Ise with his mother, while his father lives in Osaka for business. Iida was going to university where his older brother went.

A year from now, he'll begin his life as an actual adult. Izuku didn't mean to rush things. It would just be nice to experience the outside of Ise for once. His mother, as sweet as she was, wasn't the type to travel. Or let him travel.

Funnily enough, the strangest part to wrap his head around was the fact that out of everything that would be changing in a year, the change that Izuku was wary of the most was that for the first time in almost two decades, he will be separated from Katsuki.

Despite what they were, Izuku's always been near the blonde. Katsuki was his inspiration for ambition, for hard work, for passion. Because no matter how subjective everything else is, one thing that *was* objective were the passionate parts about Katsuki. Aside from looks, there's was something so beautiful about the way Katsuki, mid-air during a pole jump, looked, as if the blonde felt nothing else but power and joy, that made Izuku think: that is what *I* want for myself. Izuku wanted to find something--a hobby, an ambition--that would make him feel the way Katsuki felt about pole vault.

Izuku was smart. He had incredible grades, perfect for a pre-med track at university. He was athletic enough. He was no Bakugo Katsuki, but once high school started, he became fit enough and played badminton. He was strong enough to hold his own, plus some change. And yet, something just felt missing. Something he couldn't quite put his hands on yet.

As Izuku approaches his house, a quaint two story suburban home with a trimmed front yard and a swinging chair on their porch, he hesitates before opening his door. From the outside, he could smell the savory aroma of spring onion popping in hot oil and what smelled like braised pork and freshly steamed rice.

As soon as he opens it, Inko Midoriya rushes out of the kitchen and over to him, pulling Izuku into a hug, “Izuku! How was school today? You were a little late, coming home. Was everything okay? Did anything happen?”

Izuku nodded with a smile, “It was fine. And I just stopped for a second to watch Kacchan practice.”

“Oh! How is Katsuki doing? Mitsuki told me he’s been really preparing for the new season,” Inko ushered him over to the kitchen.

Izuku had never told his mother about Katsuki. The woman of course knew they drifted apart, after Katsuki stopped coming over, but Izuku never told her the details. A subconscious part of him had already prepared for the possibility of Katsuki ever being friends with him again, and had refrained from telling his mother about anything. The behavior kind of made him embarrassed, and yet he hadn’t made a move to change the fact.

“He seems pretty focused,” Izuku smiled.

"Of course he would be," His mother agreed, "This season is really important for him, isn't it."

"It is," He nodded.

“It’s been years since he’s come over,” His mother then took note, “Maybe I should call Mitsuki and invite hi-”

“That’s definitely not going to happen,” Izuku told his mother quickly, voice a little higher than intended.

She frowned in confusion, “Why not?”

“Kacchan is always busy, and I don’t want to bother him,” Izuku explained. And then, he made a point to switch the subject for the rest of their conversation.

The truth was that there was no way in *hell* it would ever turn out well if Katsuki were to come over. He wasn’t even going to bother. A part of Izuku, even after all of this time, wanted them to get along. And the other part of him knew it was impossible, and even if it were possible, he’d have to earn Izuku’s trust again. That was the more rational part.

Most of the school knew the tension between the two of them. Their friends were friends with each other, but they almost never hang out if either Izuku or Katsuki were around. Of course, there were exceptions like big parties and such. Not that Izuku went to many. He enjoyed them when he did go, but the opportunity didn’t arise way too often.

He was invited to all of them, but his mother wasn't keen on letting him go out too late or go out a whole lot in general. He had a clue of where his mom got her overprotectiveness from, but he was saving that conversation with her for another day, if it ever came at all, considering how passive he tended to be with people as important as his mother.

Although he didn't go to too many gatherings, he's gone to enough and he's heard enough to know. The textbook stereotype of a 'jock' was a person who was generally not very intelligent, good at athletics, peaked in high school, and slept around.

Katsuki was only the second and fourth description. But the truth was: stereotypes were just stereotypes. They were mystified versions that don't actually depict the truth.

Katsuki had the best of everything, because of course he did. Kacchan wasn't just extremely athletic, but he was extremely smart. The blonde didn't have to pick a sacrifice: an A in advanced calculus or an impressive sports record. He chose both. Katsuki was particularly good at physics, which made sense considering his sport. Izuku oftentimes felt tempted to ask for help, but refrains. Another thing was that Katsuki wasn't going to peak now, not ever probably. Not when there were already offers from colleges and pro-teams scouting him. Unless he gets injured or suddenly quits, he was on track to make his way through the world.

Kacchan did, however, sleep around. Not too much, but not too little either. Not that it should matter. A person's body is their choice, Izuku believes, but that didn't mean he didn't hear the stories. All of which always made him blush ten shades darker.

But how could he help it. Objectively, Katsuki was attractive. Once the blonde hit 18, Izuku was convinced he couldn't get any more adonis-like. There's no way. Because Katsuki as he is now, was built from pure muscle. Anyone could tell through his shirts that he was lean muscle with a tiny percentage of body fat. And his jaw, sharp and strong. His gaze was deadly and seductive. And on top of that, he was smart and athletic?

Before Izuku ever lets himself drift off for too long thinking of the topic, he pulls himself together.

This was a person he does *not* get along with, at all. Not in the slightest. To the point where their dynamic is known by most of the school.

And even the teachers, most knew not to put the two of them together.

Keyword was *most* .

There was a particular teacher who honestly did not give any shits in the world about the two of them. The ever kind but often idealistic Mr. Toshinori, who taught the upper levels of psychology, is teaching them for the second year in a row, and knew very well how they interacted with each other, and yet, never made a move to separate them if a conflict arose.

Izuku was, in fact, probably the teacher's favorite student and Mr. Toshinori adored him to no end, but when it came to the well-known bad blood between Katsuki and Izuku, the older teacher did not intervene.

The beginning of this final year was tough. Not only did they have to juggle post-high school plans, but also upper-level classes. Although the new semester started merely a week ago, most of his teachers had already assigned a ridiculous amount of work.

But *nothing* , Izuku repeats, *nothing* was as bad as what Mr. Toshinori revealed was going to be their semester-long project.

It was merely the day after Izuku had been called out by Katsuki for watching his practices, and it's actually been a relatively fine afternoon.

On the walk from his house to the school that morning, there had been a hazy orangish tint to the morning sky, as if golden hour had come despite it being 7AM. A faint breeze lifted Izuku's mood, and a cat had let him pet it. In the morning, he had ran into Katsuki and instead of getting his eardrums destroyed by the blonde's yells, Katsuki merely just told him in a normal tone to learn how to fucking walk correctly and left it at that. And for lunch, they had a cherry garcia cake in the cafeteria.

The day had been going quite well until his beloved teacher starts to open his mouth about some semester long project.

Since this particular psychology course was the second sequence of a set, they had the exact same classmates as the previous year; therefore, the teacher knew their personalities well enough. That didn't justify the project, however.

"I know it's early in the year for a project, but last year, we covered the basic core principles of psychology. This year, we are going more in depth," The frail man began the class, "We have 4 units. 4 tests. A biweekly quiz. And a final project. This is similar to how a typical university class will grade, so consider this preparation. Of course, all of this was outlined in the syllabus I gave in the beginning of this semester, which was last week so I hope none of you have lost it already. However, your final project will actually begin *tomorrow* , and will require a once-a-week effort at the minimum until the last week of the semester."

Some students in the class groaned at the notion; however, Izuku thought it was a more convenient system. Unlike most classes, there wasn't a test and a new unit every week, random pop quizzes, and a ton of busywork. Rather, there were few grades, but each had a large impact to ensure that students are retaining information, rather than memorizing it for a test then forgetting it a week afterwards. That being said, a semester long project is quite rough.

"One of the biggest themes in this course will be how different environments can influence a person," Mr. Toshinori continued, "Of course, an environment is made of many different factors: socioeconomics, living situation, family, region, friends. Now, we can't just change

our socioeconomic status or pick a different family. But what we *can* change is who we surround ourselves with, which will also have a huge impact on our behaviors."

He had barely been given any information yet, but Izuku was suddenly getting a *really* bad feeling about this. He was not particularly spiritual by any means, and yet, his gut was telling him something is going to go wrong.

The teacher proceeded, "Thankfully, the reason why this project works so well is that I had the chance to observe this class last year, since this is a two-semester sequence. Therefore, I generally have an understanding of how each of you externally behave. Your general qualities, likes, dislikes."

Curious, the class is quiet in anticipation for what the project actually is, considering that their teacher had seemingly put a lot of thought into this.

"I paired every one of you with one other person, who I think will create the most juxtaposition and therefore the biggest environmental change in each of your lives. They might be your friend, they might be someone you've never talked to, or they might be your enemy," Izuku felt as if that part was intentionally said, but he kept listening, "But most importantly, they are someone who is essentially a character foil or a character complement to each of you."

He took a breath, "You will spend a minimum of one day a week for just an hour or however more with your partner, either inside of school or outside of school."

Mina Ashido, from the back of the classroom, voiced her complaint, "Mr. Toshinori! Isn't making people hang out outside of school a little weird?"

Mr. Toshinori shook his head, "Do you not do group projects with people outside of school? If the idea doesn't suit you, don't consider it hanging out. Instead, just view it as homework that can be a bit more fun."

Izuku gulped. The bad feeling in his gut only grew larger.

"As I was explaining," Their teacher went on, "You will spend about one day a week with your partner. Afterwards, I want you to each keep a journal with thoughts. I will not be taking this up at the end of the semester. The journal is simply for your convenience when you write your final paper. You'll have all of the details there in note form, rather than digging through your memories. What I *will* be taking up is a weekly proof that you are completing the project: a photo with a date and time stamp. And an analysis paper at the end of the semester, incorporating your personal experience and opinions as well as concrete topics that we will cover in this course. I have all of the details about the project printed out here, and I will give it to you each in a second after revealing your assigned partners." Mr. Toshinori held up a stack of papers, clipped together by twos indicating the pairings.

"And remember," The man says, "We don't have a lot of graded assignments. So this project is 30% of your grade."

And with that, Mr. Toshinori called out the first pairing, coming to each of their desks to hand them the project details.

“Tokoyami Fumikage and Aoyama Yuga,” He called out the first pairing.

Izuku thought that was a good pair. Tokoyami was quite a dark person, with interests vastly different from Aoyama, who had a more flamboyant and bright persona. That would be an interesting paper to write. He analyzed the situation to prevent himself from thinking of the pairing that he practically could smell coming from a mile away.

“Uraraka Ochaco and Mina Ashido.” Izuku also could see the intrigue in that pairing. They were both his friends, but Izuku would have had to be blind to not see that Ochaco was definitely a more shy and sugar-coating person, while Mina was more forward about everything. There were strengths and weaknesses in both people.

Other pairings got named. And Izuku only got more nervous. Todoroki and Denki: two opposites on the seriousness spectrum. Koji and Mineta.

Izuku knew that there were about 10 more people he could be paired with, and yet, his mind was only on one person. It would have been a perfect character foil: he and this person were renowned for it. God, it couldn’t have been more obvious who his partner was going to be even if it was stamped on the chalkboard when they had walked in. Mr. Toshinori had mentioned that it could be your enemy, but who else in the fucking class even fit that description besides himself and K-

“Bakugo Katsuki and Midoriya Izuku,” Mr. Toshinori called out, after a moment of hesitation that the entire class took note of. It was dead silent.

Izuku knew it. He knew it, and yet, it didn’t make it any less surprising when a packet of papers detailing the project was dropped on his desk and at the top, in bright green marker, it said: Midoriya Izuku and Bakugo Katsuki.

Bakugo Katsuki. Kacchan. *Kacchan* . He had to hang out with Kacchan once a *week* for the entire semester. The entire semester. They could barely hold a conversation with each other for five seconds without it turning into a squabble. This was Izuku’s nightmare, but he knew it was Mr. Toshinori’s dream. It was the perfect pairing. Who else could his partner had been except for Kacchan. It was a psychiatry teacher’s best experiment.

It seemed as if their class were holding onto their seats. Half were staring at Katsuki, waiting for a reaction. Half were staring at Izuku. But all were incredulous.

“Mr. Toshino-” Izuku began, stammering while his palms were sweating.

“No,” Katsuki then spoke up, loud and clear. It wasn’t a scream, but a very deadly and adamant *No* . Izuku wasn’t sure whether or not to feel offended or glad.

“Mr. Toshinori,” Izuku tried again, “I don’t think you’re making the best decision.”

“Hate to say it, but I agree with the nerd,” Katsuki borderline growled.

“I made a decision based on plenty of observations and my own expertise. I am fully aware of the dynamic between you two, and knowing that, I still trust my decision, so I want *you* to trust me,” Mr. Toshinori paused before speaking, “Both of you are very good students who ended the previous year with high grades. But I am telling you now, if you do not do this project, you will not do well in this class.”

“I can afford to fail a class,” Katsuki gripped his pen tighter.

Izuku turned his attention to Katsuki, “Kacchan, don’t say you’d rather fail.” That wasn’t the Kacchan he knew. It was the essence of what made him who he was. The fact that he’ll never lose. To hear that Katsuki would rather fail hit him like a train to the gut. He wouldn’t. Izuku was sure. This wasn’t the most ideal situation for him either, but Izuku had to bring himself to realize that he needed to do well in this course.

Mr. Toshinori cut in before they could argue, “But can you afford to be benched from practice.”

Katsuki’s eyes widened at this, before they went back to the scowling position, “You couldn’t.”

“I can and I will,” Their teacher spoke with authority, “Your coaches are required by the school to bench any athlete if a teacher confronts them with enough evidence of underperformance in an academic class. Young Bakugo, I admire you as an athlete and a student. Please, you have high potential in both departments. Do not waste one, or you will waste the other.”

If Katsuki gripped his pen any tighter, it was going to break under the pressure. Even Izuku, who was unhappy with the situation, felt worried for the ink that might fly everywhere. The whole classroom was tense, but it felt like it was only Mr. Toshinori, Izuku, and Katsuki who were in the room.

“What am I even supposed to do with the nerd? Fucking talk to him? Be all buddy buddy after all these years of…” Katsuki caught himself from continuing, and Izuku’s eyes widened partially at the almost acknowledgment of their rugged past that still weighed heavily on their present.

“Please refrain from cursing,” Mr. Toshinori requested, “And yes, talking to him would be a start. And none of this has to be hard. Young Bakugo, just take Midoriya with you to do things you like to do. And Midoriya, you could do the same. It does not have to be as complicated.”

Katsuki tapped his foot impatiently against the floor, “Listen, you do-”

“Kacchan,” Izuku stepped into the conversation, bringing his eyes over to meet the fiery ruby ones that never fail to stop him in his tracks, “If you just do this with me, I’ll get out of your sight for the rest of the year.”

Their school year began in April, which was now, and the first semester would end in July. That would be four months of this project continuing. And after that, they would have

summer break and then two more semesters before their senior year will officially end March of the following year. If Izuku and Katsuki could last these four months, then Katsuki wouldn't have to see Izuku for the remaining 8 months.

Izuku, no matter what had happened between them, had never actively made an effort to stay far away from Katsuki before, so this offer was a bit surprising. Izuku had always kept himself at arms length, but as the greenette thought about him parting ways with Katsuki next year anyways, he figures that what he needs is practice anyways. If he could force himself to stay away once the project ends, then it will be easier later on to truly be rid of the biggest source of motivation and strange comfort.

At this, Katsuki paused. A handsome eyebrow raised, as he looked at Izuku for some kind of trick. The boy in question suddenly felt shy, because he doesn't remember the last time the blonde had ever looked at him with something other than malice or annoyance. Now, it just seemed like it was curiosity.

"Will you now?" Katsuki raised a brow.

Izuku bit his lip. It was necessary, he told himself, and then nodded, "Yes."

After another few moments of contemplation, the blonde's grip on the pen forcibly relaxed and he turned his head back to Mr. Toshinori, gaze still determined, "If I'm going to do this, old man, I'm going to make you give me the best damn grade you've ever given."

Understanding what Katsuki was saying, Toshinori laughed a bit, "That's an odd way of saying you'll try your best, but it works."

"Don't put words in my mouth," The blonde looked over to the side.

Izuku, watching the entire interaction, let it hit him. He just agreed to his last four months with Katsuki. And it wasn't just any four months, where they could continue their usual interactions of getting into petty arguments for five minutes then not interacting at all outside of that. No. These were four months that they will have to spend *time* with each other. And that was if Katsuki didn't have some sneaky plan under his belt to avoid the check-ins and come up with some bullshit to throw a paper together. But that didn't sound quite right either. That didn't sound like the Katsuki who put all of his effort into the things he agrees to do. Which was why the blonde never agree to many things in the first place. Katsuki was the type to go all in or nothing.

Mr. Toshinori then went back to calling out more pairings, and it felt like everyone in the class could take a breath. Although it seemed like everyone else was getting back to normal, Izuku's heart was still racing from the entire interaction and the implications of it. And here he was, hoping for a quiet ending to his final year.

The next day was just confusing to Izuku. The project officially started today, but the doe eyed boy had no idea how to even begin. He was sure that with the other pairings, it was probably easy to strike up a conversation and figure out something to do. Ochaco could easily

go up to Mina and just ask to hang out at a coffee shop for an hour or so. But Izuku? How was he even supposed to approach Katsuki about this.

They most definitely did not have the type of relationship where Izuku could just march up to the other, say “Let’s hang out. Where do you want to go? The movie theater? An ice cream parlor?” And that be just that. They probably haven’t talked like that since they were, what, five years old? And so, as he sees everyone else making their plans with their partners in the first five or so minutes of psychology when Mr. Toshinori took attendance, he sat awkwardly in his seat on the opposite side of the classroom as Katsuki, who also made no move to come talk to him. The blonde had his earbuds in, and most definitely would not appreciate Izuku talking to him. Not now. Not probably ever.

And by the time class ended, still nothing happened. Izuku went through his remaining biology and literature classes simultaneously listening to the teacher and also thinking about how the hell he was going to start this project with the blonde, when the latter hadn’t even made a move to talk to him.

And then afterwards, as he made his way home, shortly after leaving the school building, almost out of habit, Izuku found himself once more stopping in front of the track, eyes already looking for a certain person. It was a Thursday, which meant that the pole vault team didn’t have practice.

But that only meant that Katsuki came by himself for individual practice. Sometimes, he had a coach along. Other times, he was alone. Izuku’s feet was glued to the ground as he watched Katsuki’s form. The blonde wore a jersey and athletic shorts, sweat had already built up, and was currently running from the start position with a pole in hand.

As he approached the launch area, his speed picked up considerably, before his pole struck the launch box and within seconds, he was airborne, catching a good 17 feet of air. It once again reminded Izuku of the fact that if Katsuki was not 18 and in high school, he would have been recruited a long time ago for pro clubs. 17 feet of air was practically the gold star for starters at national competitions. Although this was probably the millionth time Izuku had seen Katsuki pole vault, he was still awestruck.

And it only took him catching Katsuki’s eye from a distance away from him to step back and realize what he looked like. Those fiery eyes looked up through Katsuki’s hair before climbing off of the mat.

Izuku stepped back from the fence, holding his backpack straps, as he awaits Katsuki’s approach.

“Stalking me again, huh,” The blonde says once he was about eight feet away.

Izuku huffed, “I’m not stalking you.”

“Right,” Katsuki sounded unconvinced.

And then now, instead of turning away and heading home, or stamming some awkward excuse to leave, Izuku just kind of stands here, hands playing with the strap of his backpack

as his eyes look anywhere else but Katsuki. Now would be the perfect time to ask, since Katsuki just came up to him instead of him seeking out the blonde on his own time. He needed to ask now about the project, before he loses the opportunity and then, he'd have to be the one to go up to the other.

"Spit it out, fucking nerd. I can tell you want to say something," The blonde snapped at him, which made Izuku rush into his words.

"The project!" He exclaimed, a little more loud than he intended, "I just wanted to know how we're doing this, because you have a busy schedule and I have a busy schedule. And also, you don't like me. And I don't like that you're mean to me. And all we do is get into arguments, and we never really have normal conversations with each other. So I don't really know where to start. Or how we're going to do this." Izuku let it all out.

Katsuki stood there for a moment, before taking a swig out of his water bottle. They were separated by the chain linked fence, so Izuku didn't really feel threatened even though he just had an outburst, which he knew the other disliked.

When Katsuki spoke again, he made it very clear what his thoughts were, "You're right. I don't like you."

Hearing it didn't make it any better.

Katsuki continued, "And you irritate the shit out of me. But you know what else irritates me just a bit more right now? Mr. Toshinori forcing me to do this. So if I'm going to do it, I'm going to get a good fucking grade so this isn't just a waste of my time. So here is what's going to happen."

Izuku listened intently. This was probably the first time in a while that there was some agreement between the two of them. Neither of them wanted to waste their time.

"We're gonna do this shit. I'm going to *try* not to want to fucking scream your head off every second, so try not to make me," Katsuki laid down the rules, "And then we get a good grade at the end of this and you keep your word."

Izuku hesitated, pursing his lips for a second before speaking, "Fine, but I get to have my own demands too."

Katsuki looked like he wanted to heavily protest, but after rolling his eyes, muttered a "What are they, you needy fuck."

"At least *try* being civil with me," Izuku requested.

"That's what I already fucking said," Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

Izuku frowned, "Trying not to scream my head off and being civil are two completely different things, Kacchan."

"Sounds the same to me," Katsuki shrugged.

“Kacchan!” Izuku complained, "They're not the same things at all. One is you tolerating me. Another is you actually putting in some effort. I'm not going to want to do this if you are ju-"

“Fucking fine,” Katsuki growled, “What does civil even mean anyways. If you’re expecting us not to argue anymore, you’re being naive.”

“No, I don’t expect that,” Izuku shook his head, “I just don’t want us to start arguments over small things.”

“Well, what the fuck do you consider small things,” Katsuki kept questioning.

“I don’t know, like” Izuku struggled to come up with an example, “like that time where you yelled at me for looking your way *once* in class.”

“Your big ass eyes are creepy,” Katsuki reasoned.

Izuku sighed, "Kacchan."

“Fine, fine, I’ll fucking stop,” The blonde huffed before taking another sip of his water. A bead of sweat ran down the side of his neck and Izuku tried not to look at it. Or the matted shirt.

After a few seconds of silence, Izuku awkwardly spoke up, too nice for his own good, “Erhm, if this whole situation makes you uncomfortable, you can just consider us hanging out charity work.” His attempt at a joke was barely funny.

But it had Katsuki’s raising one brow, “Ah, yes. My favorite charity. Adopt-A-Nerd. Where I get to bless a nerd with my time to make him a little less of a loser.”

“You’re just as much of a nerd,” Izuku mumbled under his breath.

“The fuck did you just say to me?” Katsuki leaned down through the fence to Izuku’s eye level.

“I said,” Izuku stood up confidently, “You’re just as much of a nerd, and I don’t take it back. Because we have a fence between us and you can’t get to me.”

Katsuki gave him a sneer, “And I’m a god at pole vault. Jumping over things is my specialty.” The blonde said before both hands were on the fence, and in a swift move, he pushed himself up and over the fence.

As soon as Izuku saw it coming, the greenette’s eyes widened and he began running away. God, this new temporary arrangement he had with Katsuki was about to be destroyed in seconds if he finds himself dead within minutes.

Izuku yelled out behind him, as he felt Katsuki’s footsteps and long strides getting closer, “Don’t kill me! They’ll know it was you! You don’t want that for your future, do you? Everyone will know it was you!”

And then, Izuku felt himself get tackled from behind before a pair of strong arms lifted him, backpack and all, and threw him over the opposite shoulder, so that Izuku was in a really awkward position where he was tugging the blonde's sweat-drenched jersey for mercy. Izuku was not weak by any means, not after he began working out consistently, but the positioning was difficult to leave.

Izuku couldn't tell where he was being taken until he heard the sound of a fence opening and suddenly, he was inside of the track practice field. He's never actually been inside of the practice field, having no reason to. He's only ever watched from outside of the fence.

And then suddenly, Izuku was roughly set down on the bench nearby. Quickly, he scrambled backwards and fixed his hair, not that it wasn't a mess to begin with.

And then he stammered, "Why am I in here?"

Katsuki ran a hand through his blonde hair and dropped into a lunge position to stretch out his calves, "To get our 1 hour in for the week."

"For the project?" Izuku asked, "Here?"

"Yes, the project. What the fuck else," Katsuki said, "And yep. Mr. Toshinori said to take you to see what I like to do, right? This. This is what I like to do." Katsuki said before picking up his pole.

Izuku was in awe. It was one thing to watch from 30 feet away on the sidelines. Still incredible, but it was nothing like this. Here, the high bar, set at 17'5 feet, looked massive, and it was suddenly more impressive what Katsuki had to get over. That bar from afar looked high already, but from up close, it seemed impossible.

And Katsuki himself. The 4:00 PM sun was behind his head, making it look like a halo around the boy who was about to jump into the heavens with his vault. It looked as if the sun exploded around Katsuki, who stands there in perfect form for his sport. And in a way, that described Katsuki well, in Izuku's opinion: an explosion. Katsuki was just that: an explosion of passion, anger, pride, ambition, beauty, absolute talent and determination. And Izuku hated how in awe he was.

"Besides," Katsuki mentioned one last thing, turning his head partially to glance at the boy who he claimed annoyed him to no end, "Aren't you tired of watching from the sidelines?"

Chapter End Notes

I hope you guys like it so far !! :3
& pole-vault is a really beautiful sport if you've never seen it!

I’m going to try to update every week!

# Chapter 2: The Diner

Chapter Notes

11.5k word chapter ahead!

retro playlist (you'll want this pls!):
https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy?si=NLy4bSzxQCqhPLCqv8xgPA&dl_branch=1

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku watched Katsuki build up a sweat as he repeats the 17'5 bar about five times. From repeatedly watching the blonde over the years, Izuku recognizes this as his warmup routine. It was crazy. To think that many people's best run after years and years of training was just a mere warm-up for Katsuki. 17'6 was the personal record that Katsuki had last season, and since then, the athlete was able to get it consistently. The increments of 17'7 to 17'9 got increasingly harder for Katsuki, and he has so far maxed out at 17'9, only clearing it 30% of the time. But Izuku believed in him more than anyone else probably did: it was only a matter of time before his former friend would be able to clear that one consistently.

As Izuku continues watching the practice, he took in every detail that he could. The perfect form. The transition between the sprint to the run. The angle at which Katsuki stuck the pole into the launch box. And then his favorite moment: the few seconds that Katsuki was in the air.

The way the orange sun glowed behind the athlete as his back bent over the bar. In that moment, it looked as if the boy was flying, and Izuku never felt so stunned. Seeing it from just mere feet away reinforced how elite the athlete in front of him was.

After clearing what looked like his half set, Katsuki came over to the bench where he had set his water.

"Oi, if this shit is boring you, you can go home and round this to an hour," Katsuki told him as the blonde picks up his water bottle and downs it all in one go.

The plastic crunched under his large hands, and Izuku watched as some trickles fell down the side of his chin and down his shirt from how hurriedly he was drinking. When he was done, he chucked the empty bottle into a nearby trashcan on the side of the track and wiped his sweat with a towel.

Izuku was distracted looking at it that he only switched back in the moment when Katsuki snapped his fingers at him.

“Shitty nerd, did you hear me?” The blonde asked.

“Oh! Yeah, I did,” Izuku nodded, before looking away shyly, “And um, it’s not boring me. I like watching. As y-you already know,” His cheeks reddened as he reminded himself that all these years, Katsuki had *known* he’d been watching. At this remark, Katsuki raised a brow.

“Besides,” Izuku looked up at his partner, “We haven’t taken a photo for proof yet.”

“Take one now then,” Katsuki suggested gruffly, then waved his hand, “Then you can do whatever the fuck you want. Leave, stay, I don’t care.”

Nodding, Izuku took out his phone from his back pocket and stood up, fumbling to open up the camera. He heard a ‘tch’ sound as Katsuki got behind him and crouched down so that he was in the frame. Although the blonde was not pressed up against him, Izuku could still feel the heat radiating off of him through his back. Izuku held his phone out and let out a huge cheeky smile and snapped a photo.

Afterwards, he stepped back and shaded his phone from the sun so he could look at the photo. His eyes looked like crescent moons because of how wide he was smiling. Behind them was the track field with the pole vault equipment set up, under the backdrop of the orange Ise sun, the terracotta brick school building in the background, and even further back, the faint outline of the green mountains that cupped Ise.

And Katsuki had his usual straight face. Handsome, but not happy.

Izuku frowned, “Does it hurt you to smile here and there?”

“I do smile. Just not around you,” Katsuki snorted.

Ouch. Izuku couldn’t help but talk back, “What you do to get girls can barely be called smiling. That’s more of an ‘I’m Kacchan, so you should sleep with me’ smirk. Smirking is not smiling, Kacchan.” Izuku said as he tries to see if there’s a way to photoshop a smile onto Katsuki’s face.

“Oh?” Katsuki lifted a corner of his lip, “So not only do you stalk me here at practice, but you know all about *that* , too?”

Izuku glared at him before shaking his head, “Kacchan, the whole school practically knows everything about your life. Not only that, but you know I *do* go to some of the same parties you do, right?”

“Auntie lets you go to parties?” Katsuki looked curious.

“You still call her Auntie?” Izuku asked, not sure why that makes him feel a tiny bit happy but it does.

“Not the point, nerd.”

Izuku shrugged, “Once in a while.” He was 18. It was embarrassing to admit he still has such restrictions.

“Huh.” Katsuki took in the information.

“Anyways, my point still stands,” Izuku affirmed, “You should smile more.”

“Fuck no,” Katsuki runs a hand through his hair, “I’ll get smile lines when I’m old and wrinkly, and get ugly.”

Izuku’s eyes are on his phone as he mumbled, “Kacchan wouldn’t be ugly.”

“Hah?” Katsuki wondered if he caught that right.

“I said,” Izuku redacted his words, “Frowning all the time will give you face lines too.”

Katsuki was sure that’s not what was said but didn’t care enough to push it.

“What’s your phone number?” Izuku asked suddenly and held out his phone with wide eyes.

Katsuki snorted, “Not interested. Not my type.”

“You’re not mine either!” Izuku practically lied, “I like people who are nice to me. And...and,” He struggles to think of features that doesn’t fit Katsuki, so he describes his favorite actor, “Brunette! And would do nice things like g-give me flowers and stuff. So not you!” He went on defense mode.

Izuku didn’t like Katsuki like that. They barely knew each other anymore. It just happened to be that Izuku’s ideal type coincidentally looked like Katsuki. The truth was that he loved blonde hair, red eyes, tall and athletic build, nice to him, but still will push him to be better. Izuku likes to think he wasn’t thinking of Katsuki, because the man was missing the “nice to him” part. And so, it didn’t count.

Katsuki looked as if he honestly did not care and voiced it too, “Alright.”

“A-anyways,” Izuku was mad he got so caught up in the accusation, “I was asking so I can send you the picture. You know you have to turn it in too, right?”

“Tch,” Katsuki said while grabbing Izuku’s phone to put his number in, “Could have just said that.”

“You’re impossible,” Izuku groaned while receiving his phone back.

“And you’re distracting me,” Katsuki retorted as he walks towards the pole on the ground, “I’m finishing up the second half of practice. I don’t give a shit what you do.”

Izuku probably *should* get home, or at least text his mother that he’ll be late. But he couldn’t bring himself to. Not when the person he’s been watching from a distance all these years has let him off the sidelines to see him up close. Not when Katsuki for the first time gave him the option to stay. And so he sits back down on the bench, and texts Inko a quick ‘ *I’ll be late, mom.”* And went back to watching.

After another half hour, Izuku watched as Katsuki made a quick jog up to the bench he was currently sitting on, and wiped his face with the towel again. The blonde was drenched in sweat, shirt practically matted to his body. He smelled like both sweat and the sweet cologne that he always had on. Izuku looked up him as Katsuki scratched at his throat. Kacchan was probably thirsty, Izuku thought, but noticed that he only brought one bottle of water that he had already finished.

“You’re still here?” Katsuki commented, chest breathing heavy from the intense practice.

“As you can see,” Izuku smiled at him.

The blonde rolled his eyes, “You want a cookie or something?”

“A cookie would be nice,” Izuku answered.

“Got jokes now, huh,” Katsuki didn’t laugh.

“Sometimes, they’re good. Sometimes, they’re not,” Izuku scratched the back of his head, then asked, “Kacchan, do you not have anymore water? You just practiced for a while.”

“I’m a fucking god. I don’t need it,” The blonde remarked.

“Kacchan…” Izuku narrowed his eyes.

In turn, Katsuki shrugged, “I usually bring four or so that will fit in my bag to school. And I end up finishing them all before I can get through the entire practice. My throats fucking dry after practice usually, but I can just go home afterwards.”

“Oh, I see,” Izuku nodded in understanding.

“Anyways, how’d you like being all up close and personal on the track,” Katsuki questioned, grabbing his practice bag off of the ground and swinging it over his shoulder, “It’s the shit, ain’t it.”

“It is!” Izuku exclaimed, eyes lit up in excitement, “The perspective is completely different than off the field! I got to see your form up close too. Kacchan, how do you get your back to bend like that when you first jump over the bar? What exercises are you doing to train your back like that? And how do you know which moment to spe-”

“Calm your ass down. You can fanboy in your nerd notebook later,” Katsuki shoved a hand in his pocket.

Izuku figured that was Katsuki’s way of telling him he didn’t feel like answering those complicated questions at the moment. He just accepted it. They were forced to hang out for the rest of the semester. He’ll have plenty of time to pester Katsuki with his questions.

They stood there for a second before Katsuki made a move to leave, turning around.

“I’m fucking hungry. I’m gonna go grab some food. Walk home or something,” The blonde held onto his practice bag strap and made his way towards the fence gate of the field.

Izuku stood rooted in his spot for a couple seconds, before jogging up to behind Katsuki, unsure of what gave him the confidence, “Can I come with you?”

“You can’t be serious,” Katsuki spoke as he continued walking forward, pushing the gate open.

“So?” Izuku asked, unsure why he felt so adamant to not go home yet, “Can I come?”

“No,” Katsuki said clear and straight, heading towards the parking lot.

“Why not?” Izuku asked, matching his pace with the athlete, which was a feat in of itself.

Katsuki gave him a look as if he was dumb, “Because we’ve done our one hour for the week. And I have no intention on seeing you any more than that, nerd.”

Izuku didn’t let it get to him. Instead, he moved so that he was in front of Katsuki, walking backwards so that the athlete would be forced to look at him.

“But I’m hungry,” Izuku complained, still walking backwards.

“That’s not my damn problem,” Katsuki replied, pulling his keys out from his bag, “Auntie always got food ready for you.”

“Maybe I don’t want to eat it,” Izuku was persistent, wondering how much he can push before he ruins the slightly better attitude Katsuki was giving him.

“Again, that’s not my damn problem.”

“It is if I faint right here,” Izuku shrugged, continuing to walk backwards, “Then, yo-”

He said before waving his arms around almost cartoonishly and feeling his body weight move backwards as he tripped over something. Before he could fall back onto the ground, a strong and very firm hand gripped his forearm and roughly stabilized him. Izuku looked away in shyness over looking like a clumsy fool.

“Oi, watch where you fucking walk. Asphalt is not fun to fall backwards on,” Katsuki growled before letting go on his forearm.

Izuku rubbed at it subconsciously before trying again, “Let me come with you.”

“Are you gonna bother me forever if I don’t?” Katsuki clicked his tongue as he unlocked his car from a distance away.

“I mean,” Izuku pondered the question, “I would’ve eventually given up, but who knows how long that would take. Really, forever shouldn’t be a term that’s used too light-”

“Just shut up and get in the car,” Katsuki pointed at Izuku towards the passenger seat when they arrived in front of his car.

Katsuki, being the person he was, kept a pristine and lovely car. It was a black Audi A8 with a red interior made of red leather. It was all very “Kacchan”-esque if someone had asked Izuku.

Katsuki was already making his way towards the driver’s side door, and Izuku just looked at the car over once then over to the blonde, before smiling in success and climbing into the passenger side.

“You’re fucking annoying,” Katsuki grumbled once they were both inside and the seatbelts were buckled.

The blonde’s car smelled like leather and wild cherry car freshener, and the air conditioning was put on full blast in order to dry off some of his sweat. Izuku watched as Katsuki put the car in drive, and took them out of the parking lot, onto the main road.

“So you’ve told me,” Izuku replies, hands in his lap as his knees bounce in the passenger seat.

The car ride to wherever they were going was fucking *awkward* . There was a bit of music playing on the radio: ‘Every Breath You Take’ by The Police. A classic hit, and to fill up the very empty silence between them, Izuku hums the melody to himself quietly.

They weren’t used to conversing, and there was nothing in particular to argue about in the moment, so now, they were left with nothing to do except sit in their respective seats silently. Izuku looked over to see Katsuki concentrated in his driving, face wearing his usual scowl, and seemingly not interested in conversing at all.

The sun was a golden orange, basking its glow over the town of Ise. Izuku, in order to not focus too much on how awkward it was, took in the details of what they drove past. A park with a recreational baseball field that some young-looking kids were playing on. An ice cream truck was parked to the side, waiting for customers.

On his left, towards Katsuki’s side of the car, were rows of quiet suburban-looking homes similar to his own. Shadows casted from the trees in people’s front lawns created leaf patterns over the exterior of their houses. Some teens younger than them were racing their bike down the sidewalk.

Katsuki took a couple more turns, and they got out of the centralized part of Ise, and over to where small businesses or restaurants usually were. Sometimes, if it was too hot, shop owners would sit out on the storefront porch with a fan and holler at passerbys to get them to come in.

Katsuki pulls up to a diner and places the car in park. Izuku looked up at the diner. Hana’s Diner. The neon sign didn’t glow too much, since the sky wasn’t dark yet, but it was quite cute. The outside was painted a light blue, and there didn’t seem to be too many customers.

Stepping into the diner, Katsuki made his way towards a booth table that sat right next to the window and slid in. Izuku followed suit, placing himself in the booth and ignoring the cracked leather seating from years of usage. The blonde was looking out the window with his arms crossed. Izuku wanted to see what he was looking at, but there wasn't much of a view besides the parking lot and the gas station across the street.

"Katsuki!" Izuku heard the voice of what seemed to be an older woman call out, and he whipped his head around the same time the blonde athlete did.

The woman had smooth skin, despite her age seemingly old, and an apron was tied around her waist. Her hands seemed a bit calloused after years of hard work, but her eyes shone brightly with an aura of kindness. Izuku was more surprised of her casualty with Katsuki, who he's never seen to let people get too close.

"It's been a while since you've came," She smiled as she set down two pairs of utensils and a menu for them, "Niko has missed you. You promised him you'd take him on a ride last time you were here."

Katsuki just nodded at her while glancing over at Izuku, as if he was cautious of the green-eyed boy's presence, before giving the woman a curt response, "Tell him I've been busy."

"Oh, he understands," She happily says before turning over to Izuku, "Who's your friend here?"

Izuku beamed at the kind-looking woman and waved, "I'm Midoriya Izuku! I'm Kacchan's...erm, partner for a project."

"I'm Hana. It's very nice to meet you, Midoriya," She pointed to the interior neon sign of the diner's name, "It's nice to see a new face here for once," She laughs, "Katsuki's been coming since he was a little boy, and has always been so generous with helping us o-"

"Hana." The blonde in question says firmly, tone not amused as he looked away.

"Fine, fine," Hana exasperatedly gives up, and gets back to business, "Anything I can get you boys to drink?"

"Water, please," Izuku answered chirpily, and Katsuki asked for the same.

When she left, Izuku remained with a feeling of curiosity. Kacchan looked very uncomfortable with the woman's praise of him, and the reveal of what looked to be a side of Katsuki no one ever really sees was surprising. Izuku bookmarked it in the back of his mind.

After a moment of silence, Izuku asked, "Who's Niko?"

At the question, Katsuki groaned then ran a hand down his face, "Hana's grandson. The kid's a total brat. Thinks I'm a celebrity or something."

Izuku laughs, "You kind of are."

"You want an autograph?" Katsuki sarcastically said.

Izuku nodded, “Yes, please. And then I can sell it in a few years when you’re in the Olympics and get myself some easy money.”

At this, Katsuki almost seemed to want to crack a smile, “You’d sell my precious autograph, for some couple hundred bucks?”

“Please,” Izuku stuck out his tongue, “You’d probably sell my liver for a gas station lollipop.”

“Don’t think so low of me, bastard,” Katsuki leaned back in his seat, “It’d be more of a scoop of ice cream. At Cedar’s Creamery, the fancy store. That’s like, what, about four dollars a scoop?”

Izuku rested his chin on his hands, “How kind of you, Kacchan. At least tell me what flavor you’d sell me for.”

“Banana pudding, hands down. There’s no other correct answer,” The blonde seemed very adamant about this answer.

Izuku’s eyes widened, “I forgot you like that flavor.” Memories of his childhood flashed back, and then he shook his head, “I will never forgive you for hypothetically selling me for a scoop of *banana pudding* ice cream.”

“What would you prefer? Mint chocolate?” Katsuki threw his hands up in ridiculousness, “That shit is so nasty, and the only reason why it’s your favorite is because it’s green like your creepy ass eyes.”

“And hair.” Izuku said, to cover up his surprise that Katsuki still knew that about him after all these years.

“That only added to my point, Deku,” Katsuki palmed his temple.

This type of banter wasn’t vicious. Not like usual. This was more playful, albeit aggressively playful. But Izuku found himself not minding it that much, or maybe his standards for interactions with Katsuki was low.

Hana came by a moment later, and took their orders. Izuku got a plate of fried chicken tossed in garlic oil, fried shallots, and a soy sauce honey glaze, while Katsuki got marinated strips of beef laid on top of a bowl of thick noodles, covered in a savory peppery glaze sauce. After biting in, Izuku’s eyes widened at the burst of flavors coating his tongue. It was delicious, and a rush of dopamine flooded his brain.

“Kacchan, this is amazing!” Izuku announced in awe. The diner was very unassuming, but the food was incredible.

“Of course it is,” Katsuki acknowledged, “I don’t eat shit food.”

They ate their meal in peace, savoring the flavors and textures of this mom-and-pop diner experience. The sun outside was getting a little lower, and the Ise sky was washed with

ribbons of purples and pink, painting the clouds with gorgeous colors. Outside, the neon street sign advertising the diner looked more prominent.

Finally, Izuku spoke up, “What should we do next week?”

Katsuki finished swallowing his bite, took a sip of water, before looking up at the boy, “Hell if I know.”

“Hm, I guess it’s my turn,” Izuku looked up at the ceiling in contemplation. He could feel Katsuki’s eyes on him, as the blonde was now done eating, and it was confusing as to why Katsuki’s gaze made him feel so naked.

Ultimately, Izuku couldn’t think of much and sighed, resting his chin on his palm once more, “I just realized I don’t go out very much. And when I do, I have to ask permission about a week in advance, so sometimes, I don’t even bother.”

“You’re fucking 18,” Katsuki commented.

Izuku shrugged with a smile. He got this reaction a lot, “I know. She just gets a little paranoid when I go out. Anyways, you can choose what we do until I figure out what I want to do.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “I don’t like to plan things. You should just do something when you feel like it.”

The greenette frowned at that, “Are you sure you don’t like to plan things? Your life is literally regimented.”

Katsuki sat there, back against the booth, waiting for the other to explain.

“I m-mean,” Izuku scratched the back of his neck, “You wake up every morning to train and go to the gym. And before you call me a stalker, remember that you are ‘Kacchan’ and that everyone talks about everything you do. Er, and then, you have practice practically every day, even when the team doesn’t practice. And you have to watch your food, and your sleep, and all of that. It seems like everything is planned.”

“Stalker,” Katsuki responded.

“Kacchan!” Izuku was about to kick the other under the table.

“But that’s exactly my point, nerd. Everything else in my life is so damn regimented, so I’m not gonna plan out the details of my free time too,” Katsuki played with the straw in his water glass, “If you plan shit out too much, you lose the excitement of spontaneity. Just do shit when you want to do shit.”

Izuku leaned back against the seat, “That’s easy to say, but my mom would never agree to that.”

“So?” The athlete asked.

“ *So?* ” Izuku repeated as if the question hurt his soul to hear, “ *So* she’ll go berserk on me and I’d never hear the end of it.”

“Don’t you want to live for yourself for once?” Katsuki set his debit card out on the table.

Izuku pulled out his own and did the same, splitting the check, “What do you mean by that.”

Whatever Katsuki had been thinking, it had gone out of his head, for the blonde just said, “Nothing.”

After their payment was received, both boys stepped out of the diner and into the now dark parking lot. The street lights, diner interior, the gas station across the street, and some distant shops and signs were the only light on this street at the moment. In Ise, the stars were always readily available to see, due to little light pollution, but tonight, there were too many clouds. The moon, however, was pretty bright.

Although Izuku was full, he needed to make his way home, and so the greenette began walking towards the direction of his home. The backpack on his shoulders as well as the food weighing him down, but he was oddly happy with how his evening played out. In a turn of events, he was able to hang out with Katsuki without either of them going insane.

From behind him, Izuku heard the athlete’s unmistakable voice call out.

“Oi, where the fuck do you think you’re going,” Katsuki called out to him.

Izuku turned around, looking at Katsuki who had the driver’s side door open, one arm resting on his hood.

“I need to get home! It’s about a twenty-minute walk, so I need to get going,” Izuku called back.

“Are you fucking dumb?” Katsuki called out to him, “I have a damn car right here.”

Izuku blinked at him, before his voice shyly said, “Oh...I thought you were just going to drive me to the diner…”

“And get murdered by Auntie for letting you get stabbed at night on your way home?” Katsuki asked as if he was stupid, “Hell no. Get your ass in the car. I’m driving you home.”

Izuku bit his lip, trying to understand Katsuki, before walking back over and into the passenger seat.

The drive to his house was a lot less awkward. Their windows were down, and Izuku let his arm out the window to feel the warm spring night air as they drive through the streets of Ise. Maybe it was the fact that they’ve had a little bit of time by now to acclimate to each other’s presence. Or maybe the food high was relaxing them a bit more, but Katsuki bantered with him a little bit more before they arrived in front of Izuku’s home.

Katsuki pulled his car to a stop, and unlocked the door.

Izuku then noticed his mother pacing the porch, all of their front lights on. Her hand was clutching her phone tightly, as the small woman looked extremely anxious. Izuku internally groaned, and prepared himself for what he knew was about to come.

The sound of his door opening and him getting out was enough to get Inko to turn around quickly. Upon seeing Izuku come out of the car, Inko stepped down from her porch and made her way across their green lawn, face both worried, relieved, and angry all at the same time.

“Izuku!” She called out.

Izuku internally prepped himself. The crickets and Katsuki’s engine were the only sounds that filled their quiet street. Although his mother was angry, Izuku knew she was kind. And her anger was always presented in a kind way which would make him feel guilty every time.

“Mom, I texted you that I was going to be late ea-” He began.

“But didn’t tell me where you were, how long you were going to go out, or who you were with!” Inko cupped his face in her hands and looked at him with worrying eyes, “Did you know how worried I was? What if you lost your way? Or if something happened to you?”

“Mom,” Izuku said with a very kind and calm tone, “Nothing happened to me. I was with Kacchan. I watched his practice, and we went out to eat at a diner.”

“Katsuki?” Inko asked, curious, “You went out with Katsuki?”

And then she finally looked over to a couple feet away where said blonde still had his car stationed, looking away from the scene and down at his phone which Izuku was silently grateful for. But he knew that Katsuki had heard. His window was down after all. At the mention of his name, the athlete looked up and nodded at them.

“Y-yes. He’s my partner for my psychology project,” Izuku said, looking down at the ground.

“Oh…” Inko’s shoulder relaxed a little bit, “I guess...if it’s Katsuki, then it’s okay.” And she turned over to Izuku, “But next time, I need you to give me more than just a ‘I’ll be late,’ okay honey?”

“Right, I’m sorry,” Izuku nodded. His mother has always particularly liked Katsuki because of her relationship with Mitsuki, and Izuku thinks that his mom secretly always wished that they would be best friends or something. He never told her that for a long time, that was what he wished too. Although his mom really liked his other friends, Izuku knew that if it had been anyone else, he would probably have gotten in more trouble.

And then, as if she suddenly realized how awkward the situation was, remembered that they were on the front lawn on a quiet street, and she came over to Katsuki’s car window with a bright smile, “Katsuki! It’s been so long. I barely see you when I come over to Mitsuki’s. Look at you, all grown and handsome. In our household, we always keep track of your accomplishments, you know. Especially Izuku over here.” She beamed at him. Izuku looked at the interaction from a distance, face heating up from being exposed.

The blonde nodded at her, “I’m usually busy, sorry Auntie.” He chose to ignore that last part, which Izuku thanked the heavens for.

“No, I completely understand,” Inko pushed in his cheeks which Katsuki frowned at and Izuku found himself smiling a bit, “You must always be busy from all that training! Say, how tall are you now?”

Katsuki shrugged, “Around 6 foot 4 inches,” As if that was not enormously tall. Which is absolutely was.

Katsuki and his mother continued their small talk for a little bit more, before Inko finally decided to let him go. She stepped back a little bit, and just as Katsuki puts his car off of the parking mode, Izuku caught his eye. It was only for a split second, but it was an odd look, as if he had been observing their interaction and came up with a conclusion. But before he could ponder it any longer, Katsuki was already down the street.

When the blonde was gone, Inko came up next to him and rested her head on his shoulder, “Katsuki’s become quite the handsome boy, hasn’t he.”

The question took him off guard and he looked down at his mother for a moment before smiling a little bit. There was no point in lying, Katsuki was handsome, “He has.”

The next couple days was wholly quiet. More or less radio silence on both of their ends. Izuku didn’t contact the other first because he assumed he’d just get yelled at. And Katsuki didn’t seem to bother either, since his phone was completely dry. And he has not been talked to in person about anything.

It was a little weird, because last Thursday at the diner, it felt like they were making a decent amount of progress. They didn’t yell at each other seriously for anything. Katsuki was merciful enough to give him a ride to and from the diner, and allowed him to accompany the other. And Izuku was given entry inside of the track field and got to see Katsuki fly.

Although none of that meant that they were friends by any means, Izuku felt a little stupid for enjoying those interactions and hoping to see more as the project progresses. And yet, it was now the following Wednesday and he’s heard nothing from the other. Of course, for the project, Mr. Toshinori required one hangout a week, which would mean Monday until Friday. So they still had two days left until the week expires, but Izuku was habituated to have things more planned out. Since it was a school project, his mother was more lenient with him asking a day or so in advance rather than about a week, but she still demanded details.

After each school day ended, Izuku still stands outside of the fence for a couple of minutes to watch Katsuki. It was a habit he wasn’t sure he could break, and wasn’t sure he wanted to. It was beautiful to watch Katsuki fly. Sure, sometimes he watched the others do their runs, but it wasn’t the same. He couldn’t describe it, but there was something about the blonde that was just different than anyone else when it came to the sport.

He felt needy saying it, but watching from the outside doesn't feel the same anymore. Not after he was granted permission that one time to watch from within the fence, right there underneath the bar. That was a breathtaking experience that made watching from outside the fence feel lackluster in comparison. He wanted to be in there again, to see up close the talent, the form, the passion.

Izuku looks away every time Katsuki makes eye contact from a distance with him during practice, taking it as his cue to start heading home.

Katsuki's never acknowledged him until the other week, but this recurring eye contact during practice only proved to Izuku that Katsuki truly had known he'd been watching this entire time. He's just choosing now to make it obvious that he knew.

When Thursday, Katsuki's solo practice day, rolled around once more, Izuku couldn't handle watching from the edges anymore. During team practice, he was a lot more nervous. Of course, if any of Katsuki's teammates had a problem with him watching, they would have said something already. But even then, he didn't want to take up anymore space. But when it was just Katsuki by himself on a Thursday, he still felt intrusive but not as much.

After class let out and he finished up his meetings, Izuku made his way towards the left-wing exit where he always left and upon coming up on the track field, he sees him. The all-star athlete doing his runs with the bar set up. He wore a black tank with athletic shorts, and looked to be very deeply focused.

Izuku was about to walk past the fenced gate, but then he remembered last week. How it felt to see the boy up close. How stunning it was to watch Katsuki block the sun with his jump. And before he could back out, Izuku opened the gate and slipped through, making his way slowly to the bench where he had been sitting the other day. Meanwhile, Katsuki was preparing to jump a 17'7 foot bar.

At the sound of the gate opening, Katsuki paused watching the greenette make his way over silently. The pole was positioned in his hands, ready to go, but Katsuki just stood there for a moment watching and waiting to see what the fuck Izuku wanted.

Instead of saying anything, Izuku sat down on the bench, and pulled out his notebook and a pen. His ankles were crossed togehter, and he tried to act casual. If he wasn't bothering Katsuki, then hopefully the blonde won't mind him doing this.

Before settling into his seat, Izuku reached into the side of his backpack one more time and pulls out one thing.

A cherry gatorade.

With a small smile up at Katsuki, Izuku wordlessly sets it next to Katsuki's practice bag. He had picked it up earlier from the vending machine, after wondering for some odd reason if Katsuki had run out of water for the day. And more importantly, he remembered what Katsuki told him the other week: 'If you're going to be here, at least make yourself useful and bring me a gatorade.' Or some rendition of that. He decided to do it, hoping Katsuki lets him remain there.

After putting it down, Izuku looks away and goes to prepare his notebook.

After a moment or two of silence, Izuku hears the shuffling of Katsuki turning his back to him and continuing his practice. Not a single word was exchanged, but Izuku knew that this was Katsuki allowing him to stay.

He looks up and drinks in the details of the blonde's entire run, taking in as much as he can, before writing little details down in his notebook next to some sketches. It was an odd hobby to have, but he enjoyed it. The notebook wasn't just Katsuki, or else that would be weird. It was all of his favorite athletes. Izuku didn't particularly want to be an athlete himself, but he loved seeing the way they moved. And more than anyone else, he loved seeing Katsuki move.

He watches as much as he can, until he gets a text from his mother, telling him to hurry up whatever meetings he has before food gets cold. Frowning, he wanted to stay more, but knew he should probably leave. Sighing to himself, he takes one more look at the blonde, about to start another run, before putting away his notebook and picking up his backpack. Slinging it over his arms, Izuku made his way towards the gate again.

After he was a good distance away from the field, Izuku turns back one more time. Katsuki, taking a break, picks up the bottle of cherry gatorade and Izuku wonders if he'll throw it away. He only lets himself look for another second, and felt more delighted than he needed to be when he sees the blonde unscrewing the cap and bringing it to his lips. Izuku turns, and continues walking home.

Earlier that day, during the lunch period, Izuku had complained about the situation.

"He hasn't message me back yet about what we're doing for this week," Izuku placed his face in his hands.

Ochaco twirls her fork in her food, "Maybe he's busy."

"Not busy enough to go to that party Wednesday night," Shoto commented, "Izuku, I think he just doesn't want to talk to you."

Izuku pouted at that, and Iida waved his arms at Shoto, "Don't be so harsh!"

"No, he's right," Izuku stabbed his rice with a pair of chopsticks, "I sent him a message yesterday and today, and both say 'read' with no reply."

Ochaco tried again, "Um, maybe he has texting anxiety?" That was a stretch.

Izuku gave her a look, and Ochaco laughed, "Alright, maybe not."

It was making him a bit anxious. He needed a good grade, and also he needed some form of communication to ease his mind. The last interaction they've had was yesterday at the solo practice, but even then, Katsuki hadn't even said a word to him. And now, the school day was more than halfway over and still nothing.

When Friday came along, Izuku feels like he should just leave it. Katsuki obviously at this point had no intention of hanging out. He's thought about sending another text, but figures that will result in an argument. He plans on probably just confronting the other sometime next week about trying harder with this damn project, but even the thought of that conversation made him nervous. Katsuki *knew* that Izuku needed advanced permission to go out, and so the fact that it was Friday and there was radio silence on the other end told Izuku enough. He was upset, but took a deep breath and pushed the negative feelings away. It was fine. It was whatever. He'll just have to smile and deal with it.

Even then, as he goes through the day and the end of class gets closer and closer, Izuku finds himself still hoping that Katsuki comes to him with *some* sort of explanation. Izuku could easily confront him in person, but the blonde doesn't really seem approachable in class just about ever. Fine, if Katsuki wanted to be like that, he could too.

When Izuku gets on his way home from school, he tries not to be petty. He really does, except it ended up being a bit harder to do. Because instead of stopping and watching for a few minutes, just out of pure irritation at Katsuki's ignoring him, Izuku just walks home continuously. He really hates being petty, especially when he was sure the blonde wouldn't even notice, but Katsuki has always been the one to bring out the worst in him.

Izuku eats dinner as usual, talks to his mother for a bit, then heads up to his room for the night as he normally does. His nightly routine switches up from time to time, but he generally just talks to his friends here and there on the phone, read books or comics, maybe watch a movie, work out, and then go to sleep.

It wasn't a very detailed or exciting regimen, but it was one that he really had to suck up and deal with since his mother kept a leash on where he goes. He spends part of the Friday evening wondering if Katsuki had forgotten their arrangement, another part of it wondering if he changed his mind on it, and then another part of the night a bit upset and then taking deep breaths to push those feelings away.

Suddenly, it was about 11:40 PM at night, and he probably should be getting ready for bed. Izuku changed quickly into a graphic t-shirt and a pair of soft sleeping shorts that came up to his mid-thigh. His mother was already fast asleep down the stairs, as he knew, since she slept around 9PM or 10PM most nights like parents generally do.

And so, Izuku stands in the yellow bathroom light and looks at his unruly hair as he brushes his teeth. He's tried taming it plenty, but it likes to stay wavy.

He hears a faint tapping as he brushes his teeth, and Izuku turns around quickly eyes scanning his perimeter. The tapping stops and he's uneasy as he spits and washed his mouth out. What in the world.

And then, the tapping starts again except a bit harder, and Izuku internally freaks out as he opens a bathroom cabinet to pull out a pair of scissors. It was coming from the window. He wasn't sure how much good a pair of scissors can do, but it was better than nothing.

As he exits his bathroom with a pair of scissors in his hand, Izuku almost let out a scream upon seeing someone outside of his window. But just as he was about to actually let a sound come out that would wake up the entire neighborhood, the greenette makes out the all too familiar build and appearance.

*Kacchan!?* Izuku thought to himself. The boy in question was perched on the window ledge, foot on the roof and it looked as if he had climbed the tree next to it in order to get up there, and Izuku could faintly hear a "Deku" come out of the other's mouth from the outside.

He stops himself from screaming, and instead, goes into a panic mode. He drops his scissors on the ground and made his way across his room, before throwing the window open.

"Finally, that took you long eno-" Katsuki started.

Izuku whisper-screamed, afraid of waking up his mother, "Kacchan?! What are you doing here?"

"Serenading you," Katsuki sarcastically commented, "No shit, what the fuck do you think I'm doing? Sneaking you out, come on."

"Lower your voice, my mom is right downstairs," Izuku flicked Katsuki on the side of the head, "And what do you *mean* 'Come on'. I can't just go with you! It's almost 12 in the morning, and I'll actually be killed if my mom finds me gone." He shooed Katsuki away, but the blonde stayed on his window ledge not budging.

"But we have a project to do," Katsuki said as a matter of fact.

Izuku felt almost offended that Katsuki had the audacity to act as if Izuku was the one who was putting their project in jeopardy, "Oh so *now* you want to worry about the project. Kacchan, if you didn't know, in about 10 minutes, it's going to be *Saturday* . I've been waiting for you to reply all week, and now you decide to show up?"

"Why didn't you just come talk to me in person, nerd," Katsuki asked with a menacing grin. Now, he was just trying to get on Izuku's nerves.

Izuku sputtered, as if he couldn't believe what he was hearing, "Kacchan, you act like you are just the *most* approachable person in the wor-"

"Woah woah, lower your voice. Didn't you say your mom was sleeping downstairs?" Katsuki teased him.

And Izuku was this close to pushing him off his roof. He's not supposed to be pissy. He's not supposed to be mean, he tells himself, but the words end up slipping out anyways, "I'm going to kill you."

"Great. Kill me in the car. Now come on," Katsuki ushered him.

"No!" Izuku shook his head while whispering, "I told you, I'll die if she finds me gone."

“Does she usually check up on you in the middle of the night?” Katsuki asked with a blank face.

Izuku shrugged then mumbled, “...No.”

“Then why would she suddenly assume that her precious goodie-two shoes son is going to sneak out?” Katsuki made a fair point, “You’ll be fine, now get out here before I tell Mr. Toshinori that I tried to get us to hang out and you just refused.” He snorted.

“You wouldn’t!” Izuku glared at him. He couldn’t jeopardize his relationship like that.

“You’re right. I wouldn’t. That takes way too much effort. But for real. Let’s go,” Katsuki said before he and Izuku had a stare down.

Outside, the crickets were chirping but other than that, it was quiet on this street. In the corner, Izuku could see where Katsuki had his car pulled up, far enough that the sound of the engine doesn’t wake up his mother.

Finally, Izuku sighed and gave in, “Where are we going?”

“Does it matter? I’m running out of patience, come on,” Katsuki responded as he stepped away from the window and walked carefully towards the edge of the roof, grabbing onto a sturdy tree branch.

Izuku, looking nervous, slowly hoisted himself out of his window and inched his way towards the edge of the roof. Looking down, if he were to drop, he would definitely break a bone or two.

“I’ve never snuck out before,” Izuku muttered as he grabbed onto the same branch he saw Katsuki grabbing onto earlier. Placing his legs in the correct position, Izuku pushed himself onto the tree branch and on top of it. Now, all there was left to do was climb correctly.

“Oi, don’t put your foot there. You’ll lose balance,” Katsuki pointed out, tapping the place Izuku should place his foot instead, “Put it here.”

Izuku looked down and corrected his feet placement, feeling more sturdy and continued his descent following Katsuki’s lead.

“I still don’t know why you couldn’t have done this during daylight hours and not last minute,” Izuku voiced his question.

From below, Katsuki finally hit the ground and looked up at the greenette, “I told you last week, Deku. I don’t like planning shit.”

“So you sneak people out at almost 12 in the morning often?” Izuku laughed, trying to keep his voice still quiet as he reaches the ground.

Katsuki broke into a light jog towards his car, with Izuku following suit, and the blonde just said back, “Not often at all.”

“So what do I owe the honor,” Izuku rolled his eyes as he climbed into the passenger seat of Katsuki’s car. The smell of leather and cherry once again filled his nose.

“The fact that it’s Friday, and I’ve been too busy all week to do this project with you,” Katsuki shrugged, before turning on his engine and putting the car in drive.

Izuku looks out his window, nervous and expecting to see his mom turn on all of the lights and run after him through the yard any second now. But nothing happened, and they were instead, on their way to some undisclosed location. Sneaking out was so much easier than he thought it would be, not that he’s thought about it much. None of his friends were particularly the spontaneous type on most days, so he’s never really done things like sneak out. It was a bit exhilarating and a bit terrifying.

Once Katsuki got out of the neighborhood streets, his speed picked up but continued to drive with only one hand. The other was resting against the console. Izuku wonders if that move was perfected to rub up on someone’s thighs when he’s driving, or if Katsuki actually just drove like that. His driving arm had prominent forearm veins and his hands looked so large and strong.

“What the fuck are you staring at, nerd? Got something on my teeth?” Katsuki asked.

Izuku averted his gaze back onto the road, “No…”

“Sure,” Katsuki didn’t believe him, but changed the topic, “You recognize this road?”

Izuku looked forward. They’ve driven towards the forest edge of Ise, and now, there was only one or two houses every mile or so. Some abandoned. Others were occupied, but just looked run down. Izuku definitely does not recognize the road, nor the weird turns they were making. Katsuki switched to his high beams because it was too dark to see with his normal headlights.

“It doesn’t feel familiar,” Izuku decided, looking over at Katsuki with curious eyes.

The blonde seems a bit caught off guard for some reason at his sudden stare, but ultimately shoved whatever it was he was thinking away, “You kidding me? What kind of teenage life are you living?”

Izuku frowned and defended himself, “Hey! I’ve done stuff. I’ve gone to the beach several times. I’ve been to Lake Roy here and there. And I’ve explored a fair bit of Ise, thank you very much.”

Katsuki snorted, “Tourists have been out more than you, Deku.”

“There’s nothing wrong with staying inside,” Izuku sat back in his seat. The radio was playing “Somebody’s Watching Me” by Rockwell, and it added to the slightly creepy atmosphere of the dark roads they were driving down at midnight, “I like my hobbies an-”

“No one talked shit about staying inside, idiot,” Katsuki glanced over at him, “But are you staying inside because you want to or because you have to.”

Izuku knew the answer to that. It was glaring in every aspect of his life: how difficult it was to go anywhere if it wasn’t for academic purpose, how he could only stay out for 2 hours at a time if he *did* go out.

“I don’t understand why it matters to you,” Izuku gave a shy smile as he looked down at his lap. Since when did anything about his life matter to Katsuki? And yet, ever since their little project had started, it seemed like the blonde was fixated on screwing over his safe life and his relationship with his mother.

The blonde pulls up to a very unassuming parking lot, seemingly abandoned and surrounded by woods. It didn’t seem like the parking lot led to nowhere, until Izuku noticed a small concrete path leading into the woods, but it had been covered by fallen branches and shrubbery that it might as well haven’t been there. There was only one dim street lamp that barely did much to light up the whole place.

Upon parking, Katsuki opened his door, but before leaving, turned his head back around to reply, “As someone who hates watching other people do the shit that I want to do, it’s an eyesore to see someone on the sidelines of their own life.”

He said before stepping out and closing the door, but Izuku was quick to come outside too. Immediately, the sound of cicadas filled his ear and the hoot of owls. The car’s automatic lights were turned off.

“Is that why you hate me?” Izuku asked, trying to keep his voice level, but his neck was sweating, “B-Because I do that?”

At this, Katsuki laughed. Actually laughed, even though nothing was humorous. Izuku’s face heated up. It wasn’t a genuine joyful laugh, not the one that he wanted to hear from the blonde, but an ironic kind of laugh.

“No, no,” Katsuki shook his head, “That’s a whole lot deeper than this, Deku.”

Izuku looked down at the ground, covered in shedded pine cone needles, and bit his lip, “Are you ever going to tell me?”

To this, Katsuki had a fairly odd response, “Are you ever going to ask?”

The question caught him off guard, and he looked over at Katsuki with wide eyes. All of this time, and he’s convinced himself not to ask. In his head, his reasoning was that he knew Katsuki wouldn’t tell him, but did he actually know? Or did he just assume that, and it fit the narrative that Izuku actually wanted. He’s only realizing now that all this time, he’s never asked for a more straightforward reason: he didn’t want the confrontation, even if it ended up not being something his fault. Which it probably wasn’t. He just wanted them to move on, without the confrontation. That would have been messy. Izuku would have gotten angry, sad, all of these emotions that he’d rather not feel.

Quietly, Izuku honestly replied, “I’m not sure...Maybe not…”

Katsuki scoffed, “Of course you wouldn’t.”

“What’s that supposed to m-”

“Forget it and come on. Time won’t wait for your slow ass,” Katsuki said before heading on the abandoned-looking path. It led straight into the woods, and combined with a multitude of factors, it all looked very creepy. This was small town life for sure.

“Kacchan, it doesn’t look like anyone comes here,” Izuku made an astute observation.

Katsuki walked ahead, pushing past some shrubbery, “This was a small park back in the 70s, but since it was hard to get to, over time, it got abandoned.”

Izuku nodded, taking in the information, “Is this where you finally plan on murdering me?”

At this, Katsuki looked like he was about to laugh, pushing air out of his nose, but Izuku couldn’t see him from behind, “Like you said before, everyone would know it was me.”

Izuku complained, “Glad to know that’s the only thing stopping you, Kacchan.”

Instead of responding, the blonde shook his head and continued walking forward, Izuku trailing behind him. Although it was a very short walk, they probably had to slap about ten fireflies so they would stop buzzing around their face. To which Katsuki cursed like a sailor and Izuku laughed.

They probably only walked a couple hundred feet down the odd path, but finally they reached the end. The cracked concrete pathway ended at the edge of what looks to be a lake, and a couple feet in front of them was the start of a dock made of wood floorboards.

The dock went out into the water for about 40 feet or so, and although the place was clearly abandoned, the structure seemed sturdy enough.

The water, even under just the moonlight, looked to be very clear and calm tonight. This little pocket of the lake looked to be surrounded by tall trees, but making way for the bright moon to envelope the water in a glossy whitish gleam.

But if Izuku had to guess, what made this lake particularly special rather than just some other lake in Ise was that a couple feet above the water, many fireflies were emitting their light. There were so many of them, floating about 3 feet above the surface of the water, making this area of the lake looked liked it literally sparkle with tiny yellow bursts of light. Izuku’s eye widened at how pretty it looked, even though he simultaneously had to slap one or two out of his face.

“Don’t drop your jaw too much, a damn firefly will get in,” Katsuki commented before walking out onto the dock.

Izuku broke into a light jog to catch up with the blonde, “I wouldn’t mind, They’re so beautiful!”

“Tch,” The athlete scoffed, “Right now, yeah. But have you ever seen one of these fuckers during the day?”

Izuku thought about it. Fireflies were nocturnal insects, so during the day, they were usually in the grass where he wouldn’t see them, “Hmm, I don’t think I have.”

“They’re creepy, that’s what. It’s like you’re getting catfished,” Katsuki complained then threw up his arms, “By a damn bug of all things. I get fucking trust issues because of these lying shitheads.”

At this, Izuku let out his pretty laugh, “Kacchan, they’re just bugs.”

“They’re not just bugs, they’re my mortal enemy,” He sounded dead serious.

Izuku grinned at his former friend, “I thought I was your mortal enemy.”

At this, Katsuki lifted a tiny corner of his lip, as if wanted to grin, “You’re a close second, Deku.”

Izuku pretended to be devastated, “I can’t believe I lost to some bugs.”

It was oddly nice to hear something so mundane come out of Katsuki’s mouth, like a dislike for bugs. It wasn’t often that Izuku gets to hear mundane, everyday things about Katsuki’s likes, dislikes, or such. It’s been a while since Izuku has known something so nonchalant about the athlete. He knew details of the blonde from childhood, details about his record as an athlete, and knew of the things relayed around the school. But as for all of the developments and small things that don’t really get talked about around the school, he didn’t know much of it.

They now stood next to each other at the edge of the dock. It was peaceful, and the fireflies now had learned their lesson not to get too close, since they moved out of the way when the two walked anywhere. It was surprisingly loud out here. As always, many crickets. An Ise signature. And the water splashing up against the posts of the dock.

Suddenly, Katsuki reached his hand out, “Oi, give me your phone real quick.”

“Hm?” Izuku looked up at the taller, “Why?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “I’m gonna take a picture. My phone’s dead.”

Izuku reached into his pocket, “Oh! No problem.”

The moment he handed Katsuki his phone, the blonde took it, then in one swoop, the athlete used one arm to shove Izuku backwards off the dock and into the water. Izuku fell in with a surprised yell and a large splash.

Immediately, Izuku felt the cold water surround him, and he was going to definitely strangle Katsuki once he got to the surface. Well, no he wouldn’t, but he wanted to. At least the blonde had been considerate enough to ask for his phone so it wouldn’t get wet. But still!

Izuku rose up to the surface and treaded water. He was absolutely soaked, obviously, and yelled at Katsuki.

“Kacchan! You horrible person!” Izuku yelled, water dripping from his hair into his eyes, “Why did you do that! I’m go-“

And then Izuku stopped, because he noticed it all of a sudden.

Katsuki was laughing. Izuku’s eyes widened. Of course, it was at his expense, but it felt a little different. Izuku could discern between a mean laugh that was meant to be scornful and make another person feel bad, and a laugh that was just genuinely because a person felt happy. And this was the latter. Of course, it probably wasn’t great that Kacchan felt happy pushing Izuku into the water, but the nice deep sound of the boy’s voice erased that thought from his mind.

Izuku tried to yell some more, but his voice broke into small laughs that he tried to suppress, “You’re such an asshole,” Izuku tried not to laugh alongside the other as he splashes water up onto the dock at Katsuki, “And a liar.” He accused.

“I didn’t lie,” Katsuki reasoned, “My phone is actually dead. And we do need to take a stupid photo at some point. I just didn’t say *when* .”

“Okay so you’re not a liar,” Izuku pouted, “But you’re still an asshole.”

“But you already knew that, didn’t you *Deku* ,” Katsuki smirked, kneeling close to the edge of the dock.

Deku grabbed a hold of the edge of the dock, and pushed himself upwards trying to grab at Katsuki’s shirt to drag him in, but the blonde jumped back in time and snorted at the attempt.

Back in the water, Izuku called out, “Coward! Get in here if you’re not a coward!” He waded backwards into the lake, now used to the temperature.

Finally, Katsuki grinned his usual menacing grin and then reached down to the hem of his shirt to pull it up and over his head.

Izuku felt his throat suddenly dry. It was then that he realized that Katsuki only ever practices with athletic clothes on. Pole vaulters always wore a very tight sports vest and shorts that reduced the forces of drag when they’re running or up in the air. It looked like a tank top for the most part, except way tighter. Izuku had already known that the blonde would have a great figure, but to actually see the extent of it. He was in awe.

Katsuki was absolutely ripped. Every muscle shredded, and a full pack of abs are now on display. His hip dipped in a sharp v-line, and those *pecs* . Everyone knows that the blonde’s arms were huge and bulked up since he was always in a tank top, but to see the full set was entirely different. Katsuki has come a long way from the child Izuku used to play with. Izuku didn’t have a bad figure at all, by any means. He worked out, had strong arms, legs, and torso. He was quite lean, and was overall very strong due to working out ever since his first year. But compared to Katsuki, the 6’4 god, he felt tiny.

Izuku shook his head, getting the thoughts out, and focused once more. There was nothing out of the ordinary about admiring someone's physique. Physiques never indicated anything about a person's personality except for their dedication. But still, *damn* .

Katsuki took a couple steps backwards, prepping himself, before running forward at full speed. Once he reached the edge of the dock, the athlete jumped off, doing one flip before splashing into the water. All the fireflies dispersed elsewhere at the sudden disruption of their peaceful environment.

When Katsuki surfaces, he shakes his wet hair. The usual spikes were now flat against his head, and Izuku laughed.

"What is it, nerd," Katsuki growled, as he freestyle-stroked towards Izuku.

The greenette continued laughing as he treaded water, "Y-your hair." He said between laughs.

Katsuki used one arm to push a wave of water into Izuku's face, "Shut up! Yours ain't much better. Now we can see that fat ass forehead of yours."

Izuku gasped and flung water back at the blonde, then swimming away, "Kacchan! That's mean!"

The athlete in question gave him a look of incredulousness, before swimming towards the smaller, "Don't you fucking act all innocent now, you bastard. You started it. Come back here, shitty nerd."

Izuku *did* start it by laughing at his matted hair, which was now pushed back and looked unfairly good, but that didn't mean he deserved death.

The fireflies at this point were staying out of their way because of all the splashing they were doing. The sounds of Izuku and Katsuki's yells could probably be heard over the trees, considering how no one else but them were probably in the area.

"W-wait a second!" Izuku screamed as he tried to swim viciously away from Katsuki, who was approached closer and closer, "Can't we come to a truce? I didn't mean it! Your hair looks fine, Kacchan. Wait! Wait a second. Mercy!"

But it was too late. The blonde had caught up to him, and bombarded him with childish water attacks as if they were small again. Izuku, tired from treading water, didn't have any time to counterattack, and he ended up with water up his nose and all in his mouth.

Although it could be seen as stupid, what they were doing at midnight out near an abandoned dock, Izuku was going to lock this in his memories forever.

There wasn't trust between them. There wasn't friendship between them. There wasn't much but years of walking the line between enemies and simply tolerating each other.

There was only tonight, and this little pocket of joy that it brought Izuku.

In one night, Izuku had just broken the untouched barrier between the teenage experience he currently had and the teenage experience he didn't know he wanted. No, Izuku didn't feel the need to go to every party (not that someone couldn't if they wanted to), or go all out.

If there were more moments like these, where he can let go for a little bit and see what it feels like to come alive in this way, then that's more than enough.

At some point, Katsuki grabbed Izuku's phone off the edge of the dock where he had left it and using one arm to keep him stable in the water, brought the phone down and took a picture for proof. The flash lit up the water, and the blonde managed to capture the image of Izuku mid-laugh in the water. The background was completely dark, but the flash lit up Izuku well enough and the foreground water and the edge of Katsuki's wet hair.

"Hey, don't drop my phone in the water!" Izuku reminded, swimming over near the dock where Katsuki was.

Katsuki made a show of pretending to drop it, before placing it on safe ground again. Suddenly, Izuku noticed something he hadn't earlier, since he was staring at Katsuki's back when the blonde had reached up to put his phone away.

"You have a tattoo?" Izuku asked in awe.

Katsuki paused, looking over his shoulder as if he could see his own back tattoo, then nodded in affirmation.

Tattoos were kind of taboo, but Katsuki generally did what he wanted. Izuku felt suddenly nervous asking, but he reached a tentative hand out.

"...Can I?" He asked, eyes wondering. He wasn't sure what kind of answer he was expecting.

It seemed as if Katsuki thought about it for a moment, uncharacteristically quiet. Izuku was about to redact his hand, when Katsuki then turned his back around in the water.

Izuku was greeted to the sight of black ink etched on the athlete's shoulder. It wasn't anything too extravagant. It was a simple line sketch of a hawk with its wings outstretched flying, and underneath was a date. Without thinking, Izuku reached a hand out to trace the lines of the ink, and immediately felt Katsuki tense from the sudden contact as if he hadn't expected Izuku to touch him with a ten foot pole, much less his hands. Instead of getting angry and throwing him off, the blonde stood there for another moment or two before turning away. Izuku's hands dropped back down to the water.

"It's beautiful, Kacchan," Izuku commented.

The blonde in question rolled his eyes, "Yeah, yeah. I didn't get it because it's fucking pretty or whatever."

"You know," Izuku tested his courage, "It's okay to say that it's beauti-"

Katsuki groaned, "Just be quiet, will you."

Izuku shut his mouth at that, and they waded for a couple more seconds before the green eyed boy's curiosity got the best of him, "What exactly does it mean?"

Katsuki then floated on his back, and Izuku did the same. It was quiet for a little bit, and Izuku thought he wasn't going to reply. That was fine. This was nice: although they weren't talking which was probably for the best, it was oddly peaceful. A juxtaposition to who Katsuki was. But then he did answer.

"The date was the first time I've ever picked up a pole and vaulted," Katsuki said finally, "I was a newbie and only got a pathetic 7 feet of air. But it was the first time I felt what it was like to fly. Hence, the hawk. And hawks are the fucking best. A predatory bird. Like me. I'm gonna win fucking everything. Just watch."

Izuku turned his head to look at the blonde, catching his side profile as the athlete floated on the water's surface. And he was just reminded once more of the trait Katsuki had always possessed that he would never deny made him in awe every single time: his passion. It was what kept Izuku watching from the sidelines all of these years, what kept him motivated funnily enough.

Izuku had an easy response to that. Smiling, even though the other couldn't see, Izuku went back to floating and uttered out an, "I will."

Chapter End Notes

ahh!! ty so much for reading, the comments & kudos for the 1st chap.
I'm literally so happy over it, and I love u <3

updates: about every week around Sunday-Monday!

# Chapter 3: The Kick-Off

Chapter Notes

13.8k words

Strongly suggested : https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy?si=NLy4bSzxQCqhPLCqv8xgPA&dl_branch=1

sorry for the 11pm cst update !

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Climbing up a tree with wet clothes that were now freezing was by far one of the more difficult experiences Izuku has had to deal with. His teeth were chattering, and Katsuki had to give him a boost up to the first branch. They came back from the firefly lake at around 2 in the morning, even though Izuku would be lying if he said he didn't want to stay a little longer. Feel his fingers prune in the cold water a little longer. Listen to the sounds of splashing and cicadas chirping a little longer. But alas, all experiences must become memories, at one point or another.

On the ride home, the windows were down in an attempt to dry off their wet clothes, and maybe it was because 2AM was well past when he usually slept, but Izuku rambled on to Katsuki. Waking up the next morning, Izuku could barely remember what he had rambled about. Something about Shoto's flirting fail with someone he had an eye on, and he had faint memories of giggling a lot. The only clear memory he possessed from the last 20 minutes of last night when his eyelids began to get droopy and his mouth started to run off on its own, was the fact that during the entire time he was rambling, Katsuki never told him to stop.

The weekend passed, and Izuku spent much of that time staying home helping his mother out with some work stuff since he had the time. Their relationship was a close one, for the most part. Izuku's dad had left when he was younger, but at least he left behind for Izuku some distant but fond memories of trips to the playground or sneaking away from Mama Inko to get some ice cream and go to the beach.

When his dad left, Inko channeled all of her energy into two things: Izuku and work. She was the most present mother, sometimes almost *too* present, and also the hardest worker that Izuku admired greatly, having opened up her own custom prints shop. It was known for having odd hours. The shop opened at 7AM and closed at 3PM. It made sense when Izuku was smaller and needed someone home when he got off of school to take care of him, but as he got older, the more useless the hours were. He could take care of himself. That didn't mean he didn't appreciate the time they had together, as overbearing as it sometimes was. He was taught to appreciate everything.

But Izuku could feel it. Something strange but new is coming into his life, rolling in like a storm with clouds so dark that he couldn't see past the frontier. It was unpredictable, exhilarating, terrifying, but most of all, a force of change. And Izuku wasn't sure how that will play out, neither for himself or his relationship to others: his mother, Kacchan, or the like.

Monday and Tuesday flew by and once again, there wasn't much word from Katsuki. It was fine, for Izuku never expected them to actually be consistent in whatever growing acquaintanceship they had. Katsuki made it clear that he would prefer it if they did their one hour for each week, and just leave it at that. And Izuku believes that is for the best.

However, it didn't stop the greenette from looking forward to their one hour for the week, especially since Katsuki has been relatively tame since they made the deal to become partners for this. And then he'd pinch himself when he found his mind getting too excited, because Izuku didn't need to do that. They weren't friends.

Izuku was digging his spoon into the matcha cheesecake he's been anticipating all day, sitting with his friends for lunch that Tuesday, when one of the pole vaulters came over and placed his hands on their table. The pole vault team was small but talented, and they usually took up a whole table to themselves. Izuku looked up to see it was Kirishima Ejirou, and then over to the empty seat besides Katsuki where he had just come from. The blonde was busy eating, and didn't seem to notice his teammate was gone.

Kirishima was Izuku's friend too, albeit they weren't necessarily close. The redhead was always very outgoing and friendly towards others, so naturally, his social circle was large. In Izuku's particular friend group, all of them knew Kirishima and a couple others of Katsuki's friends pretty well. But if Izuku and Katsuki were in the same vicinity, the two groups would suddenly disperse.

"Hey!" Kirishima took a seat on an empty spot next to Shoto, "What's good?"

Shoto slapped an arm around the redhead's back and gave him a warm greeting, "Just eating lunch. How's vault?"

Kirishima smiled, but scratched the back of his head, "Eh, I could do better. Being on a team with Bakugo Katsuki makes you feel both motivated and discouraged at the same time," He laughed, "I'm definitely going to make it past regionals this year though...I think…"

Izuku smiled, "You will! I've seen your practice runs!"

Kirishima laughed at this, “And here I thought you only stopped by to look at one person.”

At this, the greenette blushed. Meanwhile, the others carried on the conversation with the incomer for a couple minutes, catching up for a little bit even though some of them shared classes.

Finally, Kirishima asked, “Listen, I wanted to ask if you all are coming to the season kick-off barbecue Thursday night?”

Ochaco perked up, “Oh! I was planning on coming. Mina invited me the other day. It’s going to be big, isn’t it.”
“Yeah!” He replied, “It’s the season kick-off for all of the track and field events, but really everyone’s focused on pole vault, long jump, and cross country.”

Iida responded that he was busy, and Shoto hummed, “I’ve been hearing about it. Where is it at?”

“Tetsutetsu’s beach house. You know, the modern looking one off the corner of Hine Street and Baki?” Kirishima revealed, “It’s not going to be crazy or anything. It’s just a kick off. The highlight of the night’s going to be the *tradition* ,” He said with a wink.

Ah, the season kick-off tradition, Izuku thought to himself. Everyone at school practically knew of it. Izuku himself has never been to the annual kick-off, courtesy of his mother, despite being invited every year, but even then, he knew of the tradition. It’s always supposed to be a nice barbecue at one of the track member’s homes, with just a little bit of drinking and other shenanigans but nothing too hearty. However, about ten years ago, some member of the cross country team and another from the hurdles team got into a physical fight over something so small and insignificant, and some others joined in.

For some reason, since then, it’s been a tradition at the kick-off to have a fight night. Where some of the athletes would voluntarily tussle each other and fight for a little bit to get the season started, with absolutely no bad blood.

Izuku knew Katsuki participated every year. He also knew that the blonde *won* every year, against whoever it was he was matched up against. It looked fun, especially since there are no actual conflicts that leads to the fighting, and was just an odd tradition. Sure, he wanted to go, but whether or not he’d be able to was a different question.

“Mom, can I go to the season kick-off this Thursday? It’s a cookout,” Izuku nervously asked Inko later that night when they were eating dinner. He had begrudgingly skipped watching Katsuki during practice in order to get home early to make his mother happy. She knew that Izuku has been stopping by for a few minutes to watch Katsuki practice for years now, but always preferred for him to go home as soon as he was done with his school-business. So in an attempt to maybe put Inko in a good mood, Izuku headed home earlier today and did practically everything she asked as soon as she asked it. Put the laundry in the dryer? Done. Get the rice ready? Done. Set up the table? Done.

And now, he sits awaiting the answer to his request. The last time he was able to go to a big function was probably around last month, and even then, he had a curfew of 9PM. It was irritating, because he was known as that friend who always left when things got started. In middle school or so, it was understandable because most kids were under those rules also. But now, he was well above the age to take care of himself.

Asking for permission to do things always felt like he was walking on eggshells, or like he was trying to diffuse a bomb and had to carefully choose the correct colored wire or else the house would blow up. The funny thing was: when Inko got mad, she didn't yell. She didn't get angry. Instead, she'd kindly be in opposition, and make him feel guilty for instigating arguments. He's taken enough psychology courses to know by this point that his mother's tactics were a tad bit manipulative, but he was sure that wasn't her intention.

Inko took a few more bites of her food, taking her time intentionally which drove Izuku crazy. She always did this when he asked to go out. She'd get really quiet, continue on with what she's doing, and make him wait in agony before giving him a half-baked response. The sound of the spoon scraping against the plate was excruciating to his ears.

"Izuku, honey, why are you only asking two days ahead?" Inko looked up from her plate and asked with a soft voice.

Izuku bit his lip, "I feel like that's a reasonable time to ask. Besides, I only got officially invited today."

"Who invited you?"

"Kirishima," Izuku responded.

"The pole vault boy? He's one of Katsuki's friends, right?" She asked.

Izuku nodded, "Yes."

"It should have been his responsibility to ask you sooner, Izuku," Inko insisted.

Izuku felt his hands tense up, but he relaxed himself, "Mom, most people don't ask at all, much less two days in advance. So why can't you be a little bit more lenie-"

"I don't *care* about most people, 'Zuku," Inko clasped her hands together slowly, "You're my son, and I'm allowed to have standards for what I think is acceptable behavior towards you. You're so precious to me, you know, and I can't stand to have people not be responsible with your time and en-"

"Why can't I have my own standards?" Izuku looked down at his plate and asked quietly. Raising his voice would only make his mother play the victim.

"Because," Inko took his hand into her own, "You can't just think about yourself, Izuku. You also have to think of other people's feelings and your family. And the impact of the choices you make."

Suddenly, Izuku didn't think this was about the kick-off anymore, "Mom, is this about-"

“Whatever you’re about to say, Izuku,” Her voice was as sweet as nectar, “Please don’t. We never argue. I don’t really want this nice day to be ruined.”

Izuku goes silent at this, and for a moment, the air is heavy until he tries one more time, “Mom, can I go?”

At this, Inko sighs and asks, “Where is it?”

After hashing out *every* single detail down to the T, including the address, his exact curfew, and more, Izuku was finally allowed to go as long as he was home by 10PM. If it started at 6PM, then that was a good amount of time, Izuku thought to himself, and although he should be satisfied, more than anything else, he felt frustrated that he had to go through this same conversation and this same process everytime he wanted to go out somewhere. Inko wanted him to go to a college nearby, an hour at most, so that he can commute back and forth from home, and so, he wasn’t sure *when* he was allowed to have more leverage in his life.

With an exhausted soul, after dinner, Izuku walked upstairs to his bedroom, locked the door, and laid back on his bed. He stared at the ceiling and took deep breaths. Don’t get mad. Don’t be frustrated. Don’t get sad. He regulated himself until he was able to stop thinking about how upset he was, and wonders what it would be like to have more control.

Katsuki suddenly popped up in his head, and Izuku found himself thinking about the athlete. When he was with Katsuki the other night, it seemed so easy. To have a sense of control. Izuku didn’t know what it was, but with Katsuki’s confidence and pestering, it was the push he needed to do something out of his comfort zone.

Izuku pulls up the picture that Katsuki had taken on his phone from the night at the lake. He looked at his own smile, big and carefree as he treaded water in the darkness under the beautiful night sky. Without thinking, he pressed the call button.

When he had realized what he had done, Izuku bolted straight up on his bed and freaked out at his phone, dropping it in the process. He fumbled onto the ground, reaching for it and desperately needing to end the call, but right as he picked it up, Katsuki picked up.

“Deku?” Katsuki asked with annoyance evident in his tone. They hadn’t talked since the night at the lake.

Izuku clutched his phone tightly, bringing it to his ear, “A-ah! Kacchan!” His voice was a little too loud in the speaker.

“Shit, lower your voice. You’re going to fucking blow up my ears,” The blonde said through the phone.

Katsuki’s voice on the line sounded husky, and Izuku shook his head, “Sorry!”

“Sorry for what? For blowing up my ears? Or for missing my practice today?” Katsuki teased, “What, am I not interesting enough anymore?”

“That’s not true!” Izuku said a little too quickly before realizing how creepy he sounded, “Er, I had something to do at home. But  you noticed?” Izuku found himself slightly smiling at that. It was funny.

After a beat of silence, Katsuki asked, “So what the fuck did you want?”

Oh, right. Izuku forgot that in a trance, he had called the blonde by accident. He wasn’t sure if he just wanted to feel the same sense of freedom that being around Katsuki gave him, even if it was for the few hours they were together, or if his finger really did move by itself. And now, he had already taken up thirty seconds of Katsuki’s time, and was going to get a fat yelling at if he didn’t say something worth those seconds.

“U-um,” Izuku thought quick, “I need help with the physics homework.”

After a couple moments of silence, Izuku thought the line had been cut but then Katsuki spoke up again.

“You’re a shitty liar, Deku,” The blonde stated as a fact.

Izuku paled, “W-what do you mean.”

“You have the highest average in physics is what I mean,” Katsuki spoke gruffly, “The fuck you need my help for? You trying to make fun of me or something?”

“No!” Izuku found himself exclaiming in a panicked tone, “It’s just that you have the second-highest, and I missed the lesson today because I was at the dress rehearsal for student council initiation.” That part wasn’t a lie.

Katsuki considered the situation, “Not my problem.”

“Kacchan, please,” Izuku pleaded, suddenly realizing now that he really did need to be caught up.

“Mr. Aizawa will catch you up, nerd,” Katsuki put out.

That was true. However, Izuku argued, “But the homework is due tomorrow.”

After a bit of shuffling on the other end, Katsuki then spoke directly into the phone, voice deep as usual, “You really want it that bad, huh. What are you going to do for me, *Deku* .”

At this, Izuku’s face heated up, and his brain desperately tried to crawl out of the gutter. It was just that those words were often heard in *other* circumstances, that Izuku’s mind went straight there.

Swallowing, he responded shyly, “What do you want?”

There’s a pause on the line, as if Katsuki was thinking. Izuku sits there waiting patiently on the other line, as he wonders what bargain the blonde will strike. Katsuki would really never ask anything of him, even if he couldn’t do it himself. So Izuku wasn’t sure what was going to be the other end of the deal.

“Sneak out,” Katsuki finally interrupted the silence, “Right now. By yourself.”

Izuku looked appalled at the phone, “R-right now? Kacchan, it’s not even dark out yet!”

“I have eyes too, Deku,” Katsuki stated boredly.

Izuku clutches his hair, “I’m going to get caught. I c-can’t.”

“But you want to,” Katsuki stated as a matter of fact.

Izuku paused, “What do you mean.”

“Admit it, Deku. You want me to give you an excuse to break the rules. Isn’t that why you called me?” Katsuki said, and Izuku could practically see him smirking from the other side of the phone.

Izuku could barely say anything. Was he doing that? Was that why he had clicked the call button in the first place? Why Katsuki was the first person he thought of after the debacle with his mother?

If it was, he refused to admit it, and said one more time, “Kacchan, I called you to get help on my physics homework.”

Katsuki hummed, then stated his ultimatum, “Then sneak out.”

Izuku sputtered and looked out his window. His mother right now was in her room going through her work mail. He could hear her concentration music playing downstairs from here. And then he spoke into the speaker, “Where do I even go?”

“You know the playground near that yellow gas station?”

Izuku’s hands froze. The playground near the yellow gas station? Was Katsuki kidding? Did he know it? How could he not. It was almost more surprising that Katsuki had asked him the question in the first place. It was where they met all those years ago.

With a quiet tone, the greenette responded, “Of course I do. I guess you’ve forgotten.”

“Meet me there. In ten. Bring your shit. I’ll begrudgingly help you, but you owe me,” Katsuki demanded.

Izuku huffed out a “Fine.”

Then, he made sure his bedroom door was locked, before opening his laptop. In a moment of pure genius, Izuku clicked on a video titled “Snoring Sounds” that played for 4 hours and set it on his bed at a normal volume. Then, as quietly as he could, he lifted his window with his homework clutched in his armpit and prayed that he wouldn’t get caught.

Izuku ran to the playground in record time, trying to gain as much distance as he could from his house to feel safer from his mother's all-seeing eyes. Once he could see the playground in the vicinity, Izuku's memories flashed back to summer afternoons spent with a certain blonde on the swings talking about their favorite superheroes and athletes. Or Katsuki spinning him on the merry-go-round while he screamed in excitement. To see them both now, about a decade and more older, as two separate people, made him feel a bit sad inside.

Izuku saw the other boy on one of the swings, hands holding his own homework, and looking down at the paper in concentration. Seeing Katsuki's tall and muscular body in the tiny kid's swing made him laugh out loud, and at the sound, the blonde looked up then rolled his eyes.

"Bastard," Katsuki clicked his tongue, "You actually did it."

"I did!" Izuku smiled before plopping in a swing next to Katsuki, "Aren't you proud of me?"

"For betraying your poor mother?" Katsuki smirked, "What a terrible son."

Izuku looked appalled, "You're the one who told me to!"

Katsuki waved him off, "Did I? Can't recall."

Izuku stuck out his tongue and swung his feet back and forth for a moment or two, "Do you come here often?"

Katsuki looked back down at his homework, which was halfway done, "None of your damn business. How much of wave oscillation do you got down?"

Izuku thought about it, "Not much. I was only there for the first ten minutes of the lesson."

Turns out, Katsuki was an impatient teacher. Who could have guessed. Izuku was absolutely brilliant at motion physics, and not so great at sound physics. It made sense, considering his love for analyzing movement and athletes like Katsuki. Everytime he took a second too long to understand a concept, the blonde would wack him on the top of his head with his own homework. It never hurt, but it was a bit annoying. It proved to be effective though, because Izuku was determined to get it right quickly.

After about forty minutes or so, Izuku had understood the lesson enough to have completed the homework, but instead of going home, he sat there for a little longer. His mother hadn't blown up his phone with a billion text messages yet, so he assumed his scheme had worked. And being a little bit proud of himself, Izuku told Katsuki about it.

"So the poor woman thinks you have snoring problems now," Katsuki snorted at this.

Izuku shrugged as his feet swing back and forth, "Better than her thinking I'm going out and doing crack."

"But really, you're just going out to get help on your homework," Katsuki pointed out, "What a nerd."

“Hey!” Izuku frowned, “You’re the one who is *helping* me. So who’s the nerd, now.”

“Still you,” Katsuki insisted, “I’m fucking built like a god, so any nerdiness I have cancels out.” The blonde says before slapping his own thick biceps. Izuku couldn’t disagree with the first part.

“That’s not how it works,” Izuku rolls his eyes, “And I’m strong too, you know.”

Katsuki raised a brow at that, “Oh yeah?”

“As a matter of fact, yes,” Izuku huffed and stood up to his full height, putting his hands on his hip and puffing his chest out.

Grinning mischievously, Katsuki hopped off his swing and stood up to *his* full height and took a step closer until he was towering above Izuku and looking down at the green-eyed boy. Izuku felt heat travel up his neck. Katsuki was so... *tall* and big.

“How about you come to the kick-off Thursday night, and we can see just how strong you are. You can probably take on Tokoyami or something,” Katsuki spoke.

“I can probably take on you,” Izuku in a moment of confidence responded, looking up at the taller.

“Oh?” Katsuki took a step forward until Izuku’s back was against the post of the swing set, and leaned down to the greenette’s height, “You think so?”

Izuku felt like he couldn’t breathe and he didn’t know why, “You never know.”

Stepping back and sitting back down in his swing, Katsuki let out a gruff laugh, “Is that so.”

Izuku sits back down on the swing next to him, and holds onto the chains, rocking back and forth. It was funny that he didn’t really feel awkward. He was more surprised that he wasn’t kicked out of Katsuki’s sight the moment they were done. The sun was slowly setting, as if it was giving Izuku enough time to get a little bit more conversation in with the person he considers his long-time adversary, as if it was wanting him to get closer and touch the fire.

The playground looked exactly like how it did when he was little, except that Katsuki was no longer a lanky child, but a handsome all-star athlete with a personality problem. And Izuku was not the same person either.

Izuku breathed in the evening spring air as he listened to Katsuki complain about this one member on the pole vault team when Izuku had asked him how practice went, and wondered at what point along the road did this stop being their normal. And then as they lightly argued about whether baths or showers were better for the next ten minutes, Izuku then wonders if at any point this could once again become their new normal.

And then he remembered. All experiences have to eventually become memories. Because this? This was a one-semester deal.

When the street lamps in Ise turned on, it was Izuku cue to go, even though he could stay for longer if he wasn't too paranoid. Hopping off of his swing, Izuku stretched and turned to Katsuki, who was still sitting there.

"Are you going to be out here for much longer?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki took out his phone and looked at the time, "No."

"Oh," Izuku stood there awkwardly before pointing in the direction of his home, "I'm gonna...go. Before it gets too dark."

"You don't need to announce it," Katsuki said, shoving his phone back into the pockets of his sweatpants.

"Right," Izuku laughed shyly, then turned to walk out of the playground. Now that it was dark, he could feel less nervous about climbing back up into his window. He probably would need to jump to reach that first branch, and hope it doesn't make too much of a ruckus.

Right as he was about to take another step, he heard Katsuki call out behind him.

"Oi, clumsy bastard. Watch your damn step right there." Katsuki warned, nodding down to his feet.

"Hm?" Izuku looked at the blonde, then down at his feet. Right in front of his left foot was a jagged rock that looked hidden by the playground's grass.

"I said watch your damn step. You always trip right there," Katsuki pointed out with a blank face.

Izuku cocked his head. He always...tripped right there? And then, Izuku remembered. All of the bruises and small cuts on his knees when he was younger, from falling again and again on this particular rock on his way home. The tears running down his cheeks as smaller Katsuki had to run and get his mom for him. The scold he got for never remembering the rock was there.

Izuku looked back up at the blonde, who was still sitting on the swing, then smiled.

"So you do remember," Izuku grinned.

As if he was caught doing something he wasn't supposed to do, Katsuki's eyes widened for a split second before looking away and back down at his phone. *But,* it was just long enough for Izuku to catch.

When Thursday came, Izuku stood in front of his mirror looking at himself. He wasn't wearing anything too crazy, but it wasn't his ordinary outfits either. For a top, he was wearing a nice white sweater with dark blue spandex leggings underneath. Since he worked out, his

legs and ass looked great in the leggings, and he was satisfied with himself even though the pants were a bit tight. He had come over to Ochaco's house so that he, Shoto, and her could ride together in Ochaco's car to the beach house. Before he left his house, his mother made sure to emphasize going home on time.

The beach house was built in a very contemporary manner, in terms of architecture.

It was very different from what the majority of Ise looked like, which resembled more of a beach and lake town from the 80s with its classic aura and retro feel. Most of Ise had a colorful, traditional feel to it, but this particular house seemed to be all glass, marble, and greyish white stone.

Since Tetsutetsu's family specialized in the steel business, they made an exuberant amount of money. It looked like the typical high school backyard cookouts that Izuku seen in movies.

There were tiki torches in the open backyard where the cook-out was being held. And the house had mostly glass panels that could slide open and close to let people in and out. There was an infinity-edge pool attached to the side deck, with an artificial waterfall design at the front of the pool, where there were plenty of people hanging out around or swimming. There were cars lined up in the driveway and down the street, and the noise could be heard down the block as they walked up.

It was in the huge backyard where all of the action went down. The lawn was perfectly manicured, and it was lit up quite nicely. There were tables of food and drinks. The back patio leading out into the backyard had a huge banner saying "Season Kickoff" and there were people in every corner. Some downing seltzers, which wouldn't get them drunk considering there was only 5% alcohol content. Others just talking. Some tossing a ball around. Since the land was private property next to the beach, there was no fence separating their backyard from the sand and ocean. And so the view was gorgeous. Ise's beaches were always beautifully clean with white sands and the backdrop of mountains in the distance. And during this time in particular, the colors of the sun on the water made it look like liquid gold.

Izuku spotted Katsuki standing in a group over where some of the athletes were. The blonde was wearing a tight gray tank and a pair of ripped jeans, which shouldn't look as good as it does. But everyone at the cook-out would say the same, so Izuku doesn't feel weird for thinking that.

Izuku would officially say that he's probably interacted more with Katsuki in this past week than he probably did last month. The other day was at the playground. And then on Thursday, Izuku once again stayed to watch the athlete's solo practice session with a cherry Gatorade in hand. They once again didn't say much to each other, but Izuku appreciated the fact that he was allowed to stay and watch nevertheless, even if he had to leave a bit early again.

And then later Thursday, which was today, the night of the kick-off, he sees the blonde once more, even though Izuku was sure they won't interact. There was quite literally everyone else to talk to rather than each other.

Izuku lets himself get dragged along by his friends to talk to one friend group or another, and Izuku, being considered somewhat as the town's sweetheart, appreciated the social interaction and was welcomed by everyone. The night crept up on them, but everyone was having a fun time. The music was loud, and had a nostalgic synthwave theme to it, remixed with some classic tracks. The ocean was beautiful, as was the house and the vibes. At around 7, the fight matches begun.

In the middle of the backyard, there was a large brown tarp that served as the ring, and half of the spectators had lawn chairs stationed around the tarp, and the other half just either sat on the ground near the chairs or just stood up to watch. It was well lit, with plenty of tiki torches, outdoor lights, and the lights from inside of the house. Some people didn't really care to watch and instead, hung out in other corners of the property doing whatever they wanted.

But for Izuku in particular, never having witnessed the kick-off party tradition himself, wanted to spectate. He sat on a lawn chair right next to the tarp with a lite strawberry beer in his hand. Izuku didn't think that beers affected him much, so it didn't hurt to have one. Ochaco was to his side, excited to watch, and Shoto was off somewhere doing who knows what. There was a good crowd around the tarp watching a match between two long-jump athletes. From across the mat, opposite from him, was where Katsuki sat.

The blonde was near his friends. He was sitting on top of a cooler, leaned forward with his elbows on his knees, watching the matches. On his arm was an unfamiliar girl that Izuku has never seen before, with long black hair and a pair of gorgeous foxy eyes. Her hand was on his bicep, and Izuku wondered what she was feeling right now. Was his arms as thick and sturdy as it looked? He wanted to know for physics purposes, of course. It didn't matter to him what or who Katsuki did. That wasn't his business, but it didn't mean he didn't get shy thinking about it.

When Katsuki caught him staring and their eyes made contact, dark ruby red with wide green eyes, Izuku looked away quickly and back at the match. It had been an easy win, and the victor helped the loser up off of the ground and they high-fived as if they weren't just beating the shit out of each other moments before. It was honestly a stupid tradition, considering that if any of these athletes get seriously injured, then that ruined the purpose of a good-luck kick off party. That didn't mean it wasn't entertaining as shit.

As the matches went on, Izuku found himself analyzing the forms and techniques of the participants to Ochaco, who he was sure was only paying half attention. It didn't matter, though, since he gets excited about these kind of things and needs somewhere to rant about it that wasn't just his notebook. Izuku was probably annoying some people near him with his constant chattering about this person's form, or that person's technique, or what they did great, or what they could do better, but he couldn't shut his mouth. Ochaco nodded along, but he was sure she was too busy staring at the biceps of one of the cross country athletes who was up against a pole vaulter at the moment.

When that match concluded, Izuku was suddenly interrupted in his ramblings by a guy with yellow hair and a scowl that he has never met before. The boy's face looked annoyed as he snapped his fingers at Izuku.

“Yo, greenie,” The stranger got his attention and Izuku turned to him, frowning, “If you think you know so much, how about you get in the ring, huh?”

At this, Izuku waved his hands in front of him, “Oh no! Is that what it looked like? I’m sorry, it’s just a bad habit I have. I just like to analyze people’s performances. I don’t mean anything by i-

But before Izuku could finish his statement, the yellow-haired stranger stood up and clapped his hands loudly, walking to the center of the ring, “Hey everyone!”

Izuku paled.

“This guy right here,” He pointed straight at Izuku, “desparately wants a match!”

At the same time Izuku waves his arms and shouts in protest, the crowd around them yells in delight and encouragement. Some people were patting him on the back, egging him on. Suddenly, Izuku could feel Katsuki’s eyes on him.

The instigator continued, “And he thinks he’s the *shit* .”

Izuku yelled out, “I never said that!” But the crowd was hollering again, loving the confidence.

“So how about,” The stranger announced loudly, “We let him go up against the best of the best,” And then pointed to, “Bakugo fucking Katsuki.” He ended with a loud thunder and then the crowd went quiet.

Izuku thought back to their conversation at the playground when he had mentioned that he could probably take on Katsuki. Oh *fuck* . He had manifested this, didn’t he. He jinxed himself, didn’t he. Fuck, fuck, fuck. From besides him, Ochaco was panicking. No one in the crowd was cheering anymore, knowing Katsuki and Izuku’s connection with each other.

“U-uh, Monoma…” Kirishima nervously chuckled from the other side of the tarp near where Katsuki was, “I don’t think that’s a great idea…”

Izuku looked over at Katsuki, who was still leaned forward on his elbows, except this time, he was looking straight at Izuku, with a raised eyebrow. It was if the blonde was telling him *are you gonna take the challenge or not* . It was almost playful, and yet competitive at the same time. Izuku suddenly didn’t feel that scared anymore. The Katsuki that he’s interacted with recently was rude, annoying, and had some issues. But Katsuki was no villain. Izuku would be okay.

“R-right,” Ochaco panickly commented from his side, “Not the best idea.”

“Why not?” The stranger, apparently named Monoma, asked. The crowd looked uneasy, but Izuku wasn’t having it.

“Yeah, why not?” Izuku leaned forward in his seat and looked at Ochaco and then at Kirishima.

“Izuku!” Ochaco’s eyes widened, “He’s Bakugo.” She said his name with emphasis, “And you’re Izuku.”

“Tch,” Katsuki stood up, shaking the girl off of him, “The fuck kind of friend you are if you don’t think he stands a chance. If the nerd doesn’t want to fight me, he can speak for his damn self.”

“That’s not what I meant…” Ochaco rolled her eyes.

Izuku was internally surprised. It almost sounded like Katsuki was advocating for him. Or maybe, the blonde just wanted to get the show on the road so that he could beat him up. Either way, he found himself agreeing with Katsuki on this odd situation.

“I know what you meant, Ochaco,” Izuku smiled at her, “But I’ll be fine. Kacchan plays hard, but he plays fair,” And then, Izuku turned to look at the blonde, “You won’t go easy on me, will you Kacchan?”

Katsuki smirked and stretched his arms and legs, “Not even if you beg for it, *Deku* .”

The way Katsuki said his nickname sent shivers down his spine, but Izuku was suddenly very excited. And that energy transferred over to the crowd, which was now alive again and chanting for them to fight. Izuku predicted that he would lose. But that didn’t mean he was weak, because he wasn’t. It just meant that Kacchan was over 6 feet tall, an incredible athlete, pure muscle and bulk, and Izuku had a physiological disadvantage. He *could* win, although those chances were slim. However, if he was going to go out, he was going to go out strong.

When the whistle blew, Izuku knew that if he didn’t take the initiative then he would lose the opening that’s presented at the beginning of each match. He has noticed in almost every match of the night so far that when the whistle blew, the opponents would kind of snake around each other, testing out the waters for a minute or so, before going in. To pad for his lack of height and weight, Izuku needed to use that as his opening.

Therefore, the moment the whistle blew, Izuku ran in, catching the blonde off guard, and instead of going for a high hit, the greenette slid to the ground and used his momentum to hook himself around Katsuki’s legs and make the athlete fall to the ground in a thud. The crowd roared in delight, but Izuku knew that it would be about five seconds before he was in dangerous waters. And so, as soon as he got Katsuki on the tarp, he climbed on the blonde’s back and used his body weight to hold the boy’s arms down on his side.

The struggle lasted a whole eight seconds, before Katsuki threw him off and onto his back. Before he could be pushed back down to the tarp, Izuku rolled over and pushed himself up on his feet. Katsuki, if anything, was a fast learner. He didn’t let an opening happen, but instead, lunged forward towards Izuku, with his left side going in first. Noticing that immediately, Izuku dodged to the right. At the last moment, Katsuki switched his trajectory by pivoting his feet to the right, and slammed his left leg in a roundhouse kick straight into Izuku’s back. *Fuck* . More than in pain, Izuku was further impressed at how quickly Katsuki could sense Izuku’s directional changes and adapt just as quickly.

Feeling the full force of the kick, Izuku fell to the tarp on both elbows, and the pressure hurt his joints. But Izuku thought fast. Just as Katsuki's left leg was coming down from the roundhouse kick, Izuku pushed himself off and towards the single leg that was rooted to the ground and pulled up, making the blonde lose his balance and fall. Izuku made quick work to climb on top of the athlete while he was experiencing the shock of hitting the tarp, and kneeled on the blonde's ribs, pushing in, while his right arm pulls back to land a punch square on the side of Katsuki's jaw. The crowd screamed. Some whistled at the way Izuku was practically straddling him. This was *not* what they had been expecting from Midoriya Izuku of all people. There was actual *struggle* , instead of a straight knockdown.

Just as Izuku was about to land another one, Katsuki did a crunch and got a hold around Izuku's waist, suddenly lifting up the smaller off of his ribs, and stood up in a feat of raw strength, and then threw the greenette over his shoulder. Izuku landed roughly on his left shoulder and head. There was what looked to be a jagged rock underneath the part of the tarp that his head landed on, and upon landing, it cut through the tarp and slashed part of Izuku's forehead. Some trickles of blood ran down the side of his forehead, down his face, and he looked both badass and terrifying.

He still didn't yield. In fact, neither of them yielded for a while. Katsuki was getting in hits, slams, jabs. But Izuku wasn't faring too badly himself. In fact, he managed to get more in on Katsuki than anyone else had in the years that the blonde had been participating in the tradition, despite his size. Adrenaline coursed through his veins, and he could barely feel the cuts and bruises that he had been accumulating. The fight was getting a bit long, but the crowd was still as excited as ever.

Then, at the same time Izuku was diving down for a lower-body move, Katsuki read him and dove even lower, until they clashed and Katsuki grabbed Izuku by the waist. *Fuck* . In a second, Izuku was hoisted up into the air, and before he knew it, he was slammed with all of Katsuki's momentum on his left side into the ground, and Izuku immediately felt a searing pain in his shoulder and sides. He wasn't sure if something dislocated, but he wouldn't be too surprised. Opening his mouth in a small cry, Izuku clenched his eyes shut at the pain, before he felt Katsuki's body loom over him, one hand on his neck, and knees pinning him down.

And it was then that Izuku let out a pained, "Yield." The crowd erupted in screams, and once more, Katsuki was the victor. But even with that fact, Izuku was being cheered on too. Both of their names were being shouted, and Izuku used his right side to push himself up into a sitting position, and he flinched at the pain in his left side. It hurt like hell.

The crowd around them was loud, and already seeking a new match pair, but Katsuki then crouched down next to him and shouted over the hecticnesss. The athlete flicked him on the side of the face to get his attention.

"Oi," He said, "Stand up. Get off the fucking tarp."

Izuku looked up at the blonde then nodded, using his right side to push himself up, before sitting back down in pain as his left shoulder and sides felt piercing sharp discomfort, and he clenched his eyes shut for a second before opening them with a panted breath. Katsuki witnessing this then took a look at his shoulder, which burned in agony at the touch.

“Shit,” Katsuki said under his breath, and then looked around hurriedly.

Ochaco was quickly walking towards him, yelling over the noise if he was okay, and Izuku nodded with a smile even though his left was hurting like hell. Before she could get a word in, Izuku felt a hand on his right side where it didn’t hurt.

Suddenly, Katsuki had put Izuku’s injured arm around the blonde’s shoulder, and helped him up so that he could put more pressure on his right side and less on his left. Ochaco worried opened his mouth to ask him if he was alright.

But Katsuki barked at her, “Fucking get out of my way, Round Face.” And in shock, she just froze and let him past, crutching Izuku on his side.

“Kacchan, I’m fine!” Izuku insisted.

“You fucking idiot,” Katsuki scolded as they entered back into the house, “Your shoulder is a hair close to being dislocated. You should have yielded minutes earlier, you dumb fuck.” He sounded annoyed.

“But then you would have won,” Izuku reasoned.

“I won either way. Or did you get a concussion too?” Katsuki responded before calling out to someone, “Oi, Tetsutetsu. Where the fuck is your first aid.”

Tetsutetsu, the owner of the house, was off on the side with a red solo cup in his hand and he quickly pointed down the hall, “Down the hall and to the left. It’s in the laundry room, in the left side cabinets! Is he okay?”

“The shitty nerd’s got a bleeding forehead, nearly dislocated shoulder, and a bruised side,” Katsuki grumbled, before dragging them both down the hallway.

Upon entering the laundry room, Katsuki turned the bright fluorescent lights on, and hauled Izuku over to the washing machine.

Letting go, Katsuki reached down and picked him up by his thighs. Izuku, both shocked and shy at the contact, quickly placed his hands on Katsuki’s shoulders, as those large rough hands hold onto his thighs. The way he was picked up was so effortless, before Katsuki set him down roughly on top of the washing machine. Izuku winced in pain, but watched as Katsuki went to the cabinet and pulled out a first aid kit, hydrogen peroxide, and some ointment, all while grumbling under his breath.

“Kacchan, I can do it myself,” Izuku tried to convincingly say. It was odd to see Katsuki, who seemed like he wouldn’t give a shit about what happened to anyone, be so focused on something like this. Izuku hypothetically could do it himself. He knew exactly what to do to treat something like this. The only problem was that it would be extremely difficult with one arm.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “Just shut the fuck up and sit still.”

He decides to sit there as Katsuki feels around his shoulder. He winced and bit his lip to ward off the pain. From the looks of it, it seemed like during the last slam, his already battered arm had enough, and now, his shoulder wasn't exactly in the wrong frame, but it wasn't exactly in its socket correctly either. After feeling around for a little bit, Katsuki took his upper arm in one hand, and the junction between his shoulder and his neck in the other.

"This shit is about to hurt," Katsuki told him before shoving a hand towel nearby in the greenette's mouth. Izuku bit down. And then in one quick movement, Katsuki pushed the two together and popped his shoulder correctly into place again. Izuku screamed into the towel, and his eyesight felt blinded by the pain for a second, but after a minute or two, he felt much relief already, and let the towel drop from his mouth.

"That hurt," He affirmed.

"Told you, brat," Katsuki replied, "I popped it back into place, but for the next couple days, try not to strain your shoulders or arms. Lift up your shirt."

"What?" Izuku blinked at the athlete.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, "Lift up your damn shirt, Deku. I'm going to apply ointment to your bruise to help with the pain."

"Oh," Izuku nodded before lifting his shirt slightly to reveal the huge bruise on his left sides. He watched as the blonde applies the numbing ointment with thick calloused fingers. Izuku bit his lip to suppress a shiver at the surprisingly gentle touch from such large hands that slid over his soft skin. It was quieter in here than the rest of the house, but they could still hear the music and chattering of people outside. Izuku wasn't sure in what world he could imagine Katsuki treating his wounds voluntarily. But to be fair, he did cause them, but since it was a mutual agreement, it was okay.

And then, Izuku asked with a smile, "How are you so good at this."

Katsuki hummed, "At being incredible in anything athletic? Or at treating your shitty wounds."

"Both, I guess," Izuku laughed, "But more on the latter."

Katsuki was focused for a second, not answering, before speaking up, "When I first started pole vault and didn't know proper landing techniques, I used to get tons of shitty bruises. Even dislocated my shoulder once or twice. The old hag gave me this shit and told me to fix it myself."

Izuku smiled a bit at the ground, "Aunt Mitsuki has always been a do-it-yourself kind of person, hasn't she."

"Sure is," Katsuki affirmed, "Where do you think I get it from." He sneered.

Izuku giggled then mentioned to Katsuki, "Also, I *told* you I could take you on."

Katsuki flicked him on the nose, "Annoying brat."

Izuku groaned playfully, “Kacchan, just admit that I was cool.”

“Stay still,” Katsuki hissed as he took a hold of Izuku’s chin and used his other hand to rub the peroxide-soaked gauze over Izuku’s face to clean off the blood and the cut. After a few moments, Katsuki finally grumbled, “You were a little less lame tonight.”

“Woohoo!” Izuku dramatically pumped his fist, “A little less lame! That’s a new accomplishment for me.”

“Fuck, I said stay still,” Katsuki grabbed his chin tighter.

Izuku stilled himself, and ignored the sting of the hydrogen peroxide on his cut. Katsuki was very focused, and Izuku couldn’t help but look up through his eyelashes at the athlete, who was, as of right now, very very close to him. Izuku could smell the expensive cologne off of the other and the sweat. From this distance, Izuku notices that Katsuki’s eyes had speckles of black in them, like coal in a fire. Katsuki’s eye shape always made it look like he was angry, but when he was focused like this, they seemed to get a bit less down-tilted.

He then got caught staring, as Katsuki switched his gaze down to stare Izuku right in his wide green eyes, and Izuku parted his lips to say something but wasn’t sure what to say. Sorry I was staring? I just noticed you got black specks in your eyes?

“What did I tell you?” Katsuki broke the silence, “Stop looking at me with those creepy-ass eyes.” And then went back to cleaning his cut.

“I wasn’t,” Izuku lied.

“I told you before, Deku. You’re a shitty liar,” Katsuki said in a low voice. Izuku gulped.

Before he could say anything in response, the sound of laughter and the TV playing got louder from the outside. Both Izuku and Katsuki turned their heads towards the sound.

“Are they watching The Blue Ember outside?” Izuku tries to pinpoint. He thought he recognized a quote.

Katsuki listens for a second before nodding, “They are. More importantly, they have shitty taste in movies.”

Izuku hates to admit he was right, “That’s mean, Kacchan.”

“Maybe, but don’t tell me you fucking disagree. That movie was ass,” Katsuki put some topical antibacterial cream on his cut.

“Ugh, it was!” Izuku exclaimed, “How in the world do they have the best actor in the country in that film, and give her ten seconds of screentime?”

“Because they’re idiots, that’s how,” Katsuki complained as well, “The shittiest part was that one stupid character...fuck, who was it…” Katsuki pauses and thinks.

Izuku perked up and laughed, “I know what you’re talking about! Dr. Kun. What kind of villain reveals their entire plot in front of everyone? I thought that trope was over for years now.”
“It’s not even just that,” Katsuki found himself chuckling to himself, “At the end, he had that rushed sob story to try and make the audience tear up, but that shit was so fucking cringy. You’re telling me that being told you sucked at piano *once* by your mom is enough to make you become a mass murderer? Shit was ridiculous.”

Izuku found himself nodding and laughing in agreement. Even after Katsuki finished putting on a bandaid for his forehead cut, which was thankfully hidden enough by his hair that his mother wouldn’t freak, Izuku had roped him in enough into the conversation that Katsuki didn’t move from his spot for a good thirty minutes.

The conversation was so casual that Izuku forgot the type of relationship they had with each other. Katsuki, much to Izuku’s surprise, had a lot of insight on movies, and Izuku could have taken it as an opportunity to call the athlete out on being as much of a nerd as he was, but decided that he didn’t want to ruin the moment. The party was still going on strong outside. The fights were still commencing, the crowds were still loud, the music still playing on the surround sound speakers, but the two of them were oddly enough in the laundry room talking about movies. Izuku wasn’t surprised to find out that Katsuki didn’t like romances, but instead loved horror.

“Thriller horror? Or supernatural horror?” Izuku asked for clarification. He inched his body to gauge how it was feeling. His left hip was still in relative amounts of pain from being slammed. And his arms could barely lift.

“You kidding me? Supernatural horror,” Katsuki answered with no hesitation, “That shit’s the stuff.”

Izuku shook his head, “I love it, but I can’t handle it very well.”

“Just admit that you’re weak and go,” Katsuki made fun of him, and Izuku stuck his tongue out.

He liked this, Izuku thought to himself. He liked this conversation, and he likes talking to Katsuki like this. When they were only arguing and picking fights playfully rather than in a hostile manner. When Izuku was allowed to ramble about something, and Katsuki would actually have a response other than ‘shut up.’ When for a split second or two, Izuku gets to see Katsuki chuckle at something he says. This was nice.

Izuku was quiet for a moment. And Katsuki stood off to the side, leaning against the washer. After another couple seconds, the greenette looks over to the athlete and says.

“Kacchan, I know where I want to go. Pick me up tomorrow night after practice,” Izuku requested, hands on his lap.

“So you’re making demands now, huh,” Katsuki leaned his head up against the wall.

Izuku blushed, “I m-mean, you don’t have to.”

“Where is it,” Katsuki crossed his arms.

Izuku shrugged, “Pick me up and see.”

“You taking us to a movie theatre or something?” Katsuki took a guess.

“No,” Izuku shook his head, “I’ve never actually been here before, but I want to go.”

Katsuki pushed himself off of the wall and placed his hands in his pocket, “Did this not count as our one hour?” He waved his hand over their situation.

Izuku laughed, “No, Kacchan. This is a party. It doesn’t count. And you just beat me up, which makes it count even *less* .”

“Needy,” Katsuki accused him.

Just as Izuku was about to retort, the same girl from before who was hanging onto Katsuki’s arm, with the long black hair and pretty eyes, poked her head in, and upon seeing Katsuki, her face lit up.

“Bakugo! I’ve been looking for you,” She said sweetly, and made her way into the laundry room towards him.

Katsuki turned towards her, “Sara. I was taking care of something.”

At this, the girl, Sara, turns towards Izuku with a wide smile, “Oh! Right! Are you okay?”

Izuku nodded and gave her a smile in return, “I’m okay! Thank you for asking.”

She was actually really nice, but Izuku truly was having fun with his and Katsuki’s conversation, which he knew was now over by her entrance. Although he felt only a tad bit disappointed, it was fine, he thought. He had more of Katsuki’s time recently than he could ever actually fathom, and he should probably take a pause now before their problems start up again.

As he’s thought before, it wasn’t his business what or *who* Katsuki did. Even if he *was* hot, personality aside. Even if everyone at their school had fantasized about him at one point or another, including Izuku. \ Because at the end of the day, they were just partners in a project.

Still, as Izuku sees Sara now with her hand up against the athlete’s chest and another on his waistband, he knows what she wants. It was obvious what she wanted. But he wonders. Izuku wonders if she’s gonna get it. And when Katsuki places his nice athletic hands around her waist, Izuku knew his answer.

Turning to Izuku for a second, Katsuki asked the greenette, “Oi, how well can you move?”

Izuku dangled his legs off the washer, before using mostly his right side to hoist himself off and onto the ground. He was sore, had flashes of pain here and there, but other than that, he was going to be fine if he didn’t wave his arms around too much.

“Well enough!” Izuku affirmed, “I’m gonna…” He pointed outside awkwardly, “Go back out.”

For the next hour or so, Izuku hung out with his friends or people he didn’t usually talk to at school, and overall had a great time. He came out into the kick-off a legend for being able to do so well against Katsuki, and he had to tell people to refrain from giving him a pat on the back. He still felt the pain from Katsuki’s roundhouse kick. The fights were still going on, but Izuku decided to instead spend that time socializing. Shoto had been picked up by one of his dad’s employees moments earlier because of some family business that just appeared. And Ochaco, after chilling with him for a little bit, was now talking to that long jumper that she had been eyeing earlier. Katsuki was once again standing with that girl, and a couple of his pole vault friends. One particular vaulter, with brown hair, light gray eyes, and looked to be about 6 feet tall, threw a glance in Izuku’s direction once in a while, but Izuku tried to pay it no mind. Izuku has seen him jump when he goes to watch Katsuki’s practices, and although the person was good, he was nowhere near Katsuki’s level.

That aside, this left Izuku talking with a group of people near the pool, with a watered-down drink in hand. Although his body was in agony, the vibes were nice tonight. The sun has been down for a while now, and they could barely see the ocean in the distance, only the white foam from the crashing waves. The house was nicely lit up, and pool had beautiful blue lights embedded in it. He’s been talking to some of his friends Jiro, who was on the Sprint team, Hagakure, Shinso who always seemed to take a bit of a liking to him, and Momo. It was nice to be with people outside for once, and Izuku was having a great time.

That was, until someone who was clearly cross-faded came up to their group, more specifically, he came up to Izuku. The person seemed to be conscious enough to know what he was doing, but it was also obvious that he had a little bit of substance in his system. His words hasn’t slurred yet, but the boy was feeling the effects of alcohol that makes you feel more confident and bold.

“Midoriya!” He shouted, and placed both his arms on Izuku’s shoulders. Slightly surprised, Izuku set his drink on the table off to the side and chuckled lightly.

“Have we met before?” Izuku asked with a smile.

“No! But your fight was very,” He gave a weird thumbs up as if his coordination was slightly off, “nice! I’m Yosetsu.”

Izuku nodded with a cheeky smile, “It’s nice to meet you, Yosetsu. You’re wobbling a bit. Do you want to sit down?” Izuku offered.

Yosetsu shook his head no and giggled. Izuku looked over to his friends, who were pursing their lips trying not to laugh.

“No! I want to swim…with you,” Yosetsu insisted, “Do you want to,” He pointed a finger and wagged it around, “swim?”

Izuku scratched the back of his head with his right arm, “Oh! I’m sorry. I can’t really swim right now. The left side of my body can barely function. Hey, are you sure you don’t want to sit dow-”

At this, Yosetsu’s brows furrowed but then he grinned with a full set of teeth, “I don’t want to sit down! I said I wanted to swim.”

And then the boy pulled his arms back, and around him, Izuku’s friends’ eyes widened and made a move towards the disillusioned boy at the same time Izuku opens his mouth to scream stop. But it had been a tad too late, because in less than three seconds, he felt two arms push his chest backward and he fell into the deep end of the pool with a splash. Was that just his fate these days, Izuku thought as water submerged his body, to get pushed into bodies of water? At least with Katsuki, that was when he was in tip-top shape. This was just plain cruel, and Izuku wanted to get mad, but he knew Yosetsu was under the influence. That didn’t mean that this wasn’t a little bit of a problem.

From the shock, water rushed into his mouth and up his nose. His eyes were open, so he could see the faint shape of his friends above him yelling and preparing to go in. He made his left arm move, and underwater, cried out in pain, which only sent bubbles to the surface. He knew that once he rose to the surface again, it would be impossible to wade with one arm, so he was hoping someone drags him out *quick* before he looks stupid flailing.

Izuku probably fell in the pool for less than 10 seconds, before to his right, he saw a body dive in headfirst. He obviously couldn’t see well underwater, but he knew the shape of that body even by its outline. He wanted to internally sigh. Why did it feel sometimes as if his life was a movie. Who else could it be but Katsuki.

Izuku rose to the surface and gasped for breath, struggling to be stable with one arm, and then he felt a tight strong hold around his waist and he was pulled closer to a larger, firmer body.

“You clumsy shit,” Katsuki growled, as he swims towards the edge with a firm grip on Izuku’s waist.

Izuku coughed up some water and headbutted Katsuki lightly, “It wasn’t my fault!”

Without saying anything, Katsuki got a hold of the edge and used his upper body strength to hoist himself up on dry land first, before pulling Izuku out of the water and onto the edge of the pool. It was now very cold, as his clothes were exposed to the air, and his teeth chattered a bit. He clutched his left arm, which was not having fun right now, as he watched Katsuki, also soaking wet, get up on his feet and begin moving.

Momo had gone to grab a towel off of a nearby chair and wrapped it around Izuku’s shoulders, while Katsuki made his way across the pool and within seconds, the blonde roughly shoved Yosetsu’s chest, and the boy stumbled backwards.

“You fucking idiot,” Katsuki scowled at the other, “Put down the damn drink, or I’ll fucking kill you.”

Izuku's eyes widened, and he opened his mouth to speak, but others were already at it. Kirishima and some others made their way towards the forming crowd, already trying to calm the blonde down. There was a mixture of feelings in the atmosphere from everyone. Anger at how reckless Yosetsu was. Surprise that Bakugo Katsuki was angry on Midoriya Izuku's behalf. Nervousness at the energy radiating from the athlete.

"B-bakugo," Denki called out nervously, "Just leave it. We'll deal with hi-"

But Katsuki pulled Yosetsu up by the shirt and pointed a finger back at Izuku, "The shitty nerd can barely use the left side of his shitty fucking body, and you want to push him in the damn pool? Are you fucking dumb? Do you want to find out what it feels like?" Katsuki threatened and dragged Yosetsu until he was dangling and leaned over the pool, with only his feet on the sides, "Should I break your arm and throw you in?"

Izuku called out, "Kacchan! It's okay. He was drunk." He got up on his knees.

Katsuki looked over at Izuku with his typical evil grin, "I can get drunk too." And looked back at Yosetsu, "Would that make it better, bastard? More accurate?"

Yosetsu panicked and shook his head no, before stammering, "M-Midoriya said it's o-okay, so just leave me alone! It was a mistake!"

"Tch," Katsuki shoved him to the ground and stepped away, "You don't sound so drunk now, huh. And that's because the nerd doesn't have enough self respect to get angry."

Izuku's eyes widened at the odd statement. Katsuki seemed to be very sure of what he meant by that, but Izuku, on the other hand, didn't understand that statement at all. Self respect? To get angry? But before he could ponder it any longer, the tenacious blonde spoke again, angrily.

"Let me ask you again," Katsuki took a menacing step towards Yosetsu, "Should I show you what it feels like? Or have you learned your fucking lesson."

A group of the vaulters nervously crowded Katsuki in case the blonde went forward, but after a moment, Yosetsu stammered out an "I've learned." And Katsuki rolled his eyes before stepping back. It was quiet for a moment, everyone taking in the tense situation.

When Sara piped up, walking towards Katsuki.

"Bakugo," She laughed nervously, "Since when did you care so much Midoriya?"

The crowd that formed looked at the girl with judging and weird expressions for that. Could she not read the room? It didn't matter if it was Izuku who fell in the pool or Mina Ashido or a complete stranger.

In the state that Izuku was in, for him to be pushed in like that was enough to get anyone angry. Katsuki, despite his reputation and relationship with Izuku, only went so far, and it was only basic human decency to help Izuku when the greenette could be, you know, *dying* .

Izuku knew this. Katsuki, no matter what he felt for Izuku, wouldn't just let him drown. It did not mean that he cared more than any average person would care about a human life.

Still, seeing Katsuki angry on his behalf when he refused to get angry was a new situation. One that neither Izuku nor the rest of the people here expected to ever see.

Katsuki gave her a glare, and she shut her mouth quickly, before growling, "I don't have to fucking care about the nerd to not let him die, you dimwit." She turned red in embarrassment.

You *do* have to care to some extent, however, to get angry about it afterwards though, Izuku thought to himself. But he wasn't going to humor that thought.

Looking back at Yosetsu, Katsuki spat out, "If you can't trust yourself around a damn drink, don't fucking pick one up."

Staring down at the ground in shame, now completely sober, Yosetsu nodded.

"Fucking hell," Katsuki made his way back towards Izuku, eyes shone with residual anger, and told the crowd to go fuck off, before crouching down to help Izuku up once more, letting himself be used as a crutch, "Come on. We're gonna dry your dumb ass off."

Izuku leaned onto the athlete, and walked alongside him back into the house. Although everyone was going back to whatever they were doing, Izuku knew that there were curious eyes here and there. There was no reason as to why Midoriya Izuku's actual friends rather than his adversary couldn't help him dry off, but there was Bakugo Katsuki himself, helping the boy into the house.

"Kacchan…" Izuku said in a soft tone, "Thank you."

"Shut up," Katsuki dismissed, "I'm only helping you because I need to dry off too."

Izuku laughed lightly, "Not just that. For getting me out of the water. And...and warning Yosetsu."

Izuku thought back to Katsuki's words. -*doesn't have enough self respect to get angry.* What did that even mean. What does self respect have to do with anger.

"'Ts whatever," The blonde said, "This is the second time you've been pushed into a body of water in the past 7 days, nerd."

Izuku managed to get a laugh out at that, "And you were to blame for the first one, Kacchan."

"The difference is that you could swim fine then," Katsuki rolled his eyes as they slowly ascended the stairs onto the second floor where the bedrooms were.

"That's true," Izuku nodded as he walked along, "The other difference was that I actually liked it." He airily laughed to himself.

Katsuki made a quick glance in his direction at this comment, but other than that, made no reply.

Finally, Katsuki opened a random room and set Izuku on the edge of the bed, before locking the door. Quickly, Katsuki threw off his shirt and unbuttoned his jeans, climbing out of his wet clothes. Izuku found himself looking even though he was sure he's supposed to turn away. But Christ, this view was unfair.

And then, the blonde interrupted his thoughts, "You're gonna keep looking? Or are you going to stop being a creep and turn away."

Izuku squeaked out an apology before closing his eyes. He heard another article of clothing drop, and then Katsuki's footsteps towards the connected bathroom, where he rummaged for a towel. After a few minutes, Izuku heard the footsteps come back out and over to the other side of the room, where he then heard the sound of a closet opening.

"Kacchan, we can't just take their stuff!" Izuku voiced, "We don't even know whose room this is."

"It's Tetsutetsu's," Katsuki confirmed, "And he'll be fine. Have you seen the kid's house? He won't notice if some of his shit goes missing for a few days. Calm down."

A moment later, Katsuki stood in front of him, and Izuku opened his eyes. The blonde was now dressed in a tight fitted t-shirt and a pair of sweats. He threw a large tshirt and a pair of boxers at Izuku.

Without making Izuku lift up his arms, Katsuki reached down to the back of the greenette's wet sweater and pulled upwards from behind so that it goes through his head first, and then all he needed to do was slide the sleeves down the arms without making Izuku lift them. His face was slightly red, but he was grateful. Izuku worked on his physique, so he thought it looked nice, but still, being like this in front of this pure-bred athlete felt intimidating. Careful not to rub too harshly on the bruises, Katsuki dried his torso off with a towel, grumbling to himself the entire time.

And then suddenly, Katsuki's hands were on the waistband of Izuku's leggings, about to take them off, before Izuku in a state of panic grabbed onto the blonde's larger hands to prevent him from going any further.

"W-wait!" Izuku asked, hands holding Katsuki's larger ones back.

"The fuck?" Katsuki gave him a look, "Listen nerd, I'm not go-"

"I'm not wearing anything underneath," Izuku sputtered out, cheeks red, as his grip on Katsuki's hands got tighter.

Katsuki's eyes widened for a split second, before his hands flicked the wet spandex of Izuku's waistband, "You wanna try then? Do you see how fucking tight these are? And now it's wet too? If you want to attempt that with one good arm, go for it."

Izuku pursed his lips. Getting off *normal* wet clothes was frustrating because of how sticky and matted it gets. But getting skin tight leggings that were *also* wet off of his body was going to take some strength that he doesn't have on his left side.

Katsuki turned around, and Izuku attempted to shimmy his way out of the too small pair of leggings only using his right hand to pull down his left side. It was as hard as trying to peel something superglued to his skin. He could probably do it, if he had another fifteen minutes. But giving up, Izuku looked nervously to the athlete standing facing away from him.

"C-can you do it?" Izuku asked, "It's taking too long. But you can't look!"

Katsuki rolled his eyes as he turned around, "Why the fuck would I want to."

And then he got really close. Too close. It didn't seem to bother Katsuki one bit, as his face was past Izuku's shoulder. Lips parallel to his ear, but at least, Katsuki wouldn't be able to see from that position. The athlete's arms were around Izuku's waist, and his hands were once again on the waistband of his leggings. Katsuki started pulling at the wet spandex.

Rather than shutting the fuck up, Katsuki growled in his ear, "You're a dirty fucking slut, aren't you, Deku. Walking around with no underwear?" He said as he tugged.

Izuku's well-shaped and plush ass rubbed against Katsuki's knuckles as he pulled at them. It was clear just how thick Izuku's bottom was by how his ass spilled out of the spandex leggings as they were being tugged off.

"T-that's not it," Izuku bit his lip, trying not to focus on the way Katsuki talked to him just now. *Stop it, Izuku. Stop it. You're not even friends. Stop it.* , "Wearing underwear with leggings makes it, um, get stuck. So it's just more comfortable without it. Plus, I was wearing a sweater on top that cove-"

"I was messing with you. Calm down," Katsuki groaned and rolled his eyes, then continued, "Lift your ass for me."

Izuku wanted to scream. He knew that was just how Katsuki talked, and the blonde didn't think anything of it, but why did he have to say ' *for me* .' Katsuki could have easily just said "Lift your ass" and be done with it, but the extra two words made Izuku's brain rattle.

Izuku used his right arm to hook around Katsuki's shoulders and pulled himself to lift up his body just enough that Katsuki could pull it through, before sitting back down, and mumbling, "Why do you talk like that…"

Katsuki still didn't look as he tugged the spandex all the way down Izuku's thighs and legs, "Talk like what."

So Katsuki really didn't understand the power of his rhetoric, Izuku thought, and frowned before dismissing, "Never mind."

Once the leggings were off, Katsuki threw them off to the side and turned around, "You can put on your own boxers. I'll help you with your shirt."

Izuku nodded and quickly grabbed the boxers, “Thank you!” He said hurriedly before stressing to put them on. He really hated feeling useless, but he could only do so much in this state. After some pain killers and a good night’s sleep, he’ll probably feel better in the morning. With a bit of struggle, Katsuki helped him put on his shirt somehow without making him lift his arms much. It required a lot of stretching the neckline, but it was eventually doable. Izuku found himself laughing a lot at how Katsuki was getting frustrated with the t-shirt. It probably would have been easier to go with a button up.

“Right there. No! Put that arm in first!” Izuku tried to direct the other.

Katsuki barked, “Deku, I’m going to leave you to do this yourself if you keep bossing me around.”

“I’m telling you!” Izuku ignored him, “Just get a button up. Then we only need to slide my arms i-”

“No,” Katsuki insisted, intent on doing this, “I’ve already put way too much damn energy into this thing. It is *going* to go on.”

“Then put the left arm in first!” Izuku ordered.

“Shut up,” Katsuki told him.

“No you shut up,” Izuku bit back, and they go back and forth on this before finally after actually listening to Izuku’s advice, they were able to get it on. It shouldn’t have been as hard as it was.

They came down the stairs not too long afterwards, clutching the wet clothes in a plastic bag they found in the bathroom. There were a couple curious eyes pointed towards the two people who usually couldn’t stand to be within meters of each other, and now just came down the stairs together. Of course, the reasoning was obvious, but that didn’t make the sight any less unusual.

“Where’s your ride,” Katsuki looked around as they reached level floor.

Izuku craned his neck to search the area, before spotting Ochaco on the leather couch making out with the same guy she’s been eyeing all night. He would usually cheer for her to get it, but he really needed to head back right now.

Izuku groaned, “Probably going home with someone else tonight.”

“Where’s your other friend? The half and half bastard,” Katsuki asked.

“He went home a while ago,” Izuku frowned.

Katsuki then ran a hand down his face and after a moment, gestured over to the door, “Come on.”

“Hm?” Izuku asked while following behind.

“I’m headed home,” Katsuki responded, “I’ll drop you off. But you fucking owe me gas money.”

Izuku spoke up in protest, “But it’s only 10! I don’t want to make you leave early and take me ho-”

Katsuki stopped and turned around, looking down at the greenette, “You’re not making me do *anything* . I’m going home because I only stay out late on weekends. It’s a Thursday. I have class and practice tomorrow. This shit ain’t all about you, *Deku* .”

“Oh…” Izuku closed his mouth then nodded, “In that case, thank you, Kacchan!” He smiled up at the other, “You’ve done a lot for me tonight.” It was different. It felt like this past week or two, Izuku was able to experience Katsuki in a new way: one that is still the same gruff, rude Katsuki, but with a little bit more considerateness.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and weaved back through the crowd standing on the driveway shooting hoops, “Don’t fucking forget I beat your ass earlier. Don’t be so damn grateful, shitty nerd. If it wasn’t for me, you wouldn’t even needed the fucking help.”

“It was consensual!” Izuku reminded him as they walked down the road filled with parked vehicles until they reached Katsuki’s ride, “Besides, I got in a couple bruises too. Speaking of that, are you okay?”

“I’m fine,” Katsuki stated blankly, opening his driver’s side door and climbing in.

Izuku followed suit, and using his right arm, hooked the seatbelt over and settled himself inside.

The drive back was tiring. Izuku hadn’t known how exhausted he was until he relaxed in the passenger seat and felt the waves of sleepiness kick in. It was earlier than then we would usually go to sleep, which was around 12AM or so, but because he’d been so physically active and in pain, the energy was slowly dissipating from him.

He was conscious enough to make small comments here and there and listen to the lyrics of Elton John’s Your Song on the speakers. Izuku’s noticed by now that Katsuki liked a lot of 80s music, especially the ones with crazy and loud beats. That or nostalgic synthwave once in a while, and occasionally a modern rap or pop song. This particular song was more mellow though.  Izuku liked it too.

When they pulled up to his house, the lights were off. Thank god. That meant his mother had gone to sleep instead of waiting up to make sure he’s home on time. He was only late by about thirty minutes, but it probably would have been a big deal if she was awake. Besides, now he doesn’t have to explain to her why he’s holding his left arm like this, and why the pain in his hip was making him walk a little funny. If Izuku forces it, he can straighten out his walk, but he was sure it would go away by tomorrow.

The left arm? Probably 3-4 days, but that was easily hideable for the most part. And the cut was hidden by his hair.

As Izuku opened the door, there was obvious exhaustion in his droopy eyes, but he had just enough energy to turn around and ask Katsuki.

“Kacchan?” Izuku asked, followed by a yawn.

The blonde looked up from his console, “What is it.”

“Are we on for tomorrow night?” Izuku reminded before looking down at the ground, “You never actually answered.”

They had to do something tomorrow either way, since it was the last day for their project. Unless they wanted to count the evening at the playground doing physics homework as their one hour. But Izuku didn’t grab a picture for that. And there was something Izuku really wanted to do.

Katsuki thought about it, before skeptically asking, “Auntie’s gonna let you go out with last minute permission?”

Izuku blinked. He was so caught up in his desire to go that he didn’t even consider that. However, his answer wouldn’t have changed even if he had thought about it beforehand. He needed a change in his life, and he couldn’t believe it took a little freedom brought on by the town rascal and super-athlete sneaking him out to a lake and giving him a taste of what it means to feel *alive* to get him to act.

Looking determined, Izuku told the blonde, “She’s going to.”

Katsuki took a second to respond, but ultimately shrugged, “Be ready by 6.”

Chapter End Notes

do I not know how to write short chapters? Does anyone actually care about what the house looks like? No bahahsd. But thank you so much for the love and support!!

Also! I feel like every Monday is way too long.
I finish up these chapters in like 3 days and take 1-2 to edit. So I think my update schedule is probably going to be every 4-6 days.

# Chapter 4: The Drive-In

Chapter Notes

18.7k words, im so sorry

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy?si=NLy4bSzxQCqhPLCqv8xgPA&dl_branch=1

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Friday entered the week and brought a beautiful blue sky and a warm breeze along with it. The day itself hasn't been too bad. It was a bit more intrusive than usual at school, as Izuku was confronted a couple times about the previous night at the kick-off: "I heard you did really well against Bakugo Katsuki," "What did it feel like when Bakugo Katsuki treated your wounds. You're so lucky!" "Why did Bakugo Katsuki get so mad at Yosetsu?" Izuku, although well-known in school for being kind and helpful, has never received this much questioning from random people, and never knew how to reply. He wonders how suffocating it could feel for Katsuki.

Other than that, his Friday has been going well: watching Katsuki after practice for a little bit went as it normally did, his presentation in chemistry went well, and he couldn't lie, he was looking forward to being picked up at 6PM. Izuku, being well aware that they are merely just hanging out because of a required project, still finds himself liking the time spent with the blonde, and slapped himself over it, muttering under his breath that it's not genuine time spent.

Once again, earlier, Izuku found himself having to ask permission to go out too late in advance: this time, it was the day *of* . He was nervous, but knew he had to be successful since he had already confirmed the plans with Katsuki. He had psyched himself up to ask permission, and did so when he got home. Under the excuse that he was going with Katsuki and that it was an emergency for the project, Inko had reluctantly allowed him to go but only because it was Katsuki. Izuku could tell that there was more that she wanted to say to him, but whatever it was never left her lips as Izuku jumped in for a hug and ran off to his room.

And as of current, Izuku closed his eyes and let the locks of his hair flutter over his brows as he smiles faintly to himself. He was now sitting on the steps of his porch, waiting for the sound of Katsuki's engine to roll down his quiet suburban street. Izuku wore a pair of shorts, a plain light blue tee, with a flannel tied around his shoulders. His hair was still the same mess it always was, but it was clean and that's all that mattered. The blue sky has now transitioned to a golden orange as the 6PM sun climbs its way down the horizon. With little clouds in the atmosphere tonight, there was an even glow of deep orange throughout all of Ise. Even the black ravens perched on top of the telephone poles were enjoying the beautiful sight.

When he heard the rumbling of a car exhaust stop in front of his house, Izuku tilted his head back down and then waved to the familiar black car. Katsuki rolled down the passenger side window and hollered out to him.

“Oi nerd!” He yelled past the front lawn, “You gonna come here or what?”

Izuku pushed himself off of his sitting position and lightly jogged over to the car before climbing in, “Kacchan!”
“ *Christ* ,” Katsuki cringed, “I know I’m fucking incredible, but calm down.”

The greenette laughed at the comment, closing the passenger side door, “Why? When you’re happy, you should express it.”

The blonde rolled his eyes, “Don’t tell me what to do. What’s got you all in a good fucking mood.”

Izuku fastened his seatbelt, “I’m hanging out with Kacchan.” He smiled.

For a split second there, Izuku thought he saw a faint look of surprise on the athlete’s face but then the expression went back into its usual scowl. Katsuki was wearing a plain white t-shirt with some black athletic shorts and a silver chain around his neck. From across the seat, Izuku could smell the boy’s signature sugary cologne.

“Tch. Shitty nerd,” Katsuki grumbled before placing his large hands on the wheel, “Where are we even going anyways.”

“Oh!” Izuku’s eyes lit up and he pulled up a map of directions on his phone, “I’ll direct you. Go straight and turn left on Lean Street.”

“Are you serious.” Katsuki deadpanned the boy, “You’re going to give me turn by turn directions?”

Izuku nodded, “Yes.”

“You can’t just tell me or something?” Katsuki bothered him.

The greenette shook his head no and ushered him forward with his hands, “It’ll ruin the element of surprise, Kacchan. Now go, drive!”

Complaining, Katsuki finally put the car in drive and did as Izuku told him.

“Can’t believe you’re telling me what to do in my own damn vehicle,” Katsuki said as he headed towards Lean Street, “And I’ve been to way more places than you, Deku. How much surprise is there going to be.”

Izuku frowned, having thought of that too, but ultimately just replied with a shrug, “Then hopefully it’ll still be fun.”

The drive was as quaint and cute as it always was in the town of Ise, although it was a bit long. Izuku has only heard mentions of this place, since it was in the next town over, but has

never been there himself. It wasn't anything too extravagant, but he thought it'd be an activity both he and Katsuki would enjoy. They drove past basketball courts with some middle schoolers drenched in sweat throwing hoops, past one of the bigger lakes in Ise and saw the sun-kissed water surface past the line of trees, and they now are driving through the yellow dirt-covered roads that lead out of Ise, running parallel to the mountains, with only a few houses near farmland on either side of them. Because the orange glow has not yet disappeared, it was a pretty sight especially with Maniac by Michael Sambello playing on the radio. Izuku's windows were down, his hands feeling the evening wind as they flew through the road.

"Where even are we," Katsuki looked around at the nothingness with one hand on the wheel.

Izuku turned to the handsome blonde, "On the way to Dolly."

Katsuki gave him a look through his Ray Bans, "The fuck are we gonna do in Dolly? Doesn't that place have 30 residents?"

Izuku shook his head, "3000 residents, Kacchan. And you'll see."

Katsuki groaned, "This better be worth the gas."

"If not, I'll cover your dinner," Izuku smiled cheekily.

"Since when are we getting dinner," Katsuki looked over, right hand tapping the console.

Izuku pursed his lips, and responded shyly, "Since you probably haven't eaten yet because practice runs late on Fridays and you picked me up not too long after."

Katsuki was quiet for a second before teasing, "Stalke-"

"I swear to god Kacchan," Izuku groaned, "If you call me that again-"

Katsuki then started laughing before stopping in the middle of the road within seconds, lurching Izuku's body forward. It wasn't necessarily a busy road, but it was still illegal to stop in the middle of it for no reason.

And then the blonde leaned over his seat towards the wide-eyed and confused Izuku and provoked the other, "What are you gonna do."

Izuku blinked, not sure whether or not he should be more concerned with the sudden change of atmosphere or with how unfairly sharp Katsuki's features were up close.

Katsuki repeated, "If I call you that again, what are you gonna do, *Deku* ." He grinned, "Wanna tussle some more?" Referring to their fight the other night.

"K-Kacchan," Izuku said, "You can't just stop in the middle of the road."

At this, Katsuki grinned some more, "Why can't I?"

Izuku frowned, "Because! People use this road. There will be cars coming soon."

At this, the blonde seemed even more amused and suddenly gripped Izuku by the chin, not in a way that hurt, and took a good look at the boy's freckles while tsking.

"Deku, Deku, Deku," Katsuki repeated with a comical tone, "When are you going to learn? Here, let me tell you a little something."

Izuku's cheeks flushed from the contact, but Katsuki dropped his hands and turned up the music to the point where it was deafening. Then, he opened his car door before stepping out, leaving it wide open and then stepped out onto the road. Katsuki walked around to the middle of the road, and then spread his arms open wide like an eagle before yelling over to Izuku.

"When you do dumb shit like this, the most anyone will ever say to you," Katsuki yelled out, "is 'Sir, you can't park here. Sir, you can't be here. Sir, you can't do that.' And that is when you put on a charming fucking smile and tell them 'Sorry sir, I'll be on my way.' or "Sorry sir, I won't do it again.' And that's that."

Izuku gaped. It couldn't be that easy, or else why the hell would there be so many arrests or court warnings. And then he realizes it: it was Katsuki's confidence. And probably the fact that he was Bakugo Katsuki.

"The truth is" Katsuki continued shouting over the music, "No one actually gives a shit as long as you don't give them more trouble or hell to deal with. In a shitty town like Ise, you think the cops care about some teenagers sneaking around and fucking in parking lots? About kids like us jumping off docks at that firefly lake that's been closed off for safety hazards?"

Izuku listened, for some reason feeling as if every word Katsuki spoke was meant to punch him in the gut and make him realize something without mentioning Izuku's name even once.

The blonde then walked over to Izuku's window and peered inside, placing his arms on the window sill before grinning, "Everyone here is trying to find some shit to make their lives a bit less fucking pathetic. Waking up. Going to work at a damn job they don't even want. Going home to a wife who ain't even love them. Watching the same reruns on TV that's been playing on channel 5 since the fucking 80s. Then sleeping it all away so they can fucking dream about the life they'd rather have. Saying that they're alive, but really, they're barely even fucking living, "

Izuku's mouth was parted as he looked Katsuki dead straight in those ruby eyes, and they held this strange contact. One in which Izuku was trying to figure out if Katsuki was being fucking serious, and Katsuki was challenging him without saying a damn word. Saying they're alive, but they're barely even *living* .

Izuku could feel the truth seep within him as he replays every word the blonde just said. It wasn't just Ise, the beautiful, small town that had a hypnotic pull. What Katsuki said could probably be applied to every city on Earth: big or small, rural or urban. Everywhere, people are trapping themselves in cycles that they convince themselves they are completely stuck in. Businessmen in the city who wished they've taken an art career stuck in their 9-5 desk jobs and going home to their lonely bachelor pad, falling asleep with a glass of wine that'll dull their senses. Or people here in a town like Ise, who never leave the vicinity of their neighborhood all of their lives and get sick of the golden Ise sunset but do nothing about it.

But right then, Izuku didn't think Katsuki was referring to some businessman in the city, or some neighbor in the city of Ise. No, Katsuki was hinting at *him* . At Izuku. At what the trajectory of his life seemed to be, and Izuku has never felt so offended yet enlightened in his life.

"You're crazy," Izuku whispered, not breaking their eye contact.

Katsuki laughed and looked at him once more, "Yeah. And you need some of it."

Izuku blinked. *You need some of it* . Fuck. *Everyone here is trying to find some shit to make their lives a little less fucking pathetic* . Fuck. Fuck. Fuck. Izuku remembered thinking of that exact thing the other week when Katsuki first confronted him about watching his practices. Thinking of how he had a good life: great grades, a nice mother, great friends, some hobbies. But how something was missing. Something that he didn't know. *Everyone here is trying to find some shit to make their lives a little less fucking pathetic* . Fuck.

Izuku then opened up the sunroof of Katsuki's car and then stood up on his seat, moving his body upwards and through the sunroof. He climbed up there and then sat on top of the car with his legs still dangling inside of the sunroof opening.

"Drive," Izuku asked, eyes shining as he nervously holds onto the edge of the sunroof opening. The sound of On The Run by Timecop 1983 played next.

Stepping back, Katsuki gaped his mouth, "What are you doing."

Izuku bit his lip nervously and then shyly looked over to the blonde, "Living."

At this, Katsuki had a brief look of surprise before raising a brow, "We'll probably get pulled over, you know."

The thought of that made Izuku nervous, but then he remembered, and gave Katsuki the best charming smile he could muster, "In that case, I'll just put on a charming smile and tell them 'Sorry sir, I won't do it again.' And that's that. Right, Kacchan?"

Izuku repeated the athlete's words right back at him, and Katsuki knew it too. Feeling as if he was being challenged, Katsuki shook his head while walking over to the driver's seat.

"How's your arm. Can you even hold on?" Katsuki nodded towards Izuku's left arm.

Izuku moved it, "Oh, this? It still hurts a bit, but there's nothing wrong with my grip. I'll be fine!"

"I'm such a bad influence," Katsuki muttered to himself as he closed the car door, "Auntie's going to kill me."

Izuku laughed at this, "Kacchan! You were over here giving me a dramatic speech just moments ago, and *now* you want to take it all back?"

Katsuki put his seatbelt on and gave a quick glance upwards towards Izuku who was sitting on top of his sunroof, "Who said anything about taking it back? Now hold on, nerd."

Izuku tightened his grip, and looked at the scenery. On either sides of him was flat farmland, but further on his left were the beginnings of the treeline that led to the mountains. Telephone poles had flocks of birds on them, and the wheatfields were basked in the beautiful orange that they've been experiencing this entire car ride. Then, the car lurched forward as Katsuki pressed on the gas. The athlete accelerated slowly, not wanting Izuku to fly backwards and break a bone.

Immediately, the breeze picked up, blowing Izuku's hair back, but the greenette smiled with all teeth. This was ridiculously dangerous if Katsuki suddenly breaked too hard or accelerated too fast, but Izuku for some reason trusted the blonde. Katsuki gradually picked up the speed until Izuku could feel a full blast of wind and the music was not as loud as it was before. It still wasn't as fast as they'd usually go. When Katsuki got to a constant speed, slowly, Izuku let his hands go.

He raised his arms across the width of the car and then began laughing. It felt like his chest was letting go of metal weights as he closes his eyes and feels the wind hit his body and the music fill his ears.

From below, Katsuki called out, "How is it?"

Izuku continued laughing, and peered down through the sunroof opening, "Kacchan, it's amazing! You should try it next!"

"And let you drive my car?" Katsuki looked appalled at the suggestion, "Hell fucking no."

Izuku leaned back on his arms, "Your loss."

They drive like that on the straight road for a while, listening to the music play and Izuku's excited hollers and Katsuki's occasional check-in. It was absolutely stupid. And yet, he would absolutely do it again. When Izuku climbed back down, his hair was completely windblown. He straightened it out in the mirror and told Katsuki, "At the next stop sign, take a left."

"You done having your moment?" Katsuki snorted as he takes the left.

Izuku relaxed into his seat, "Yes. That's was tiring. Maybe I'll go back to my wife that doesn't love me and watch reruns that's been on TV since the 80s," Izuku joked.

Katsuki flicked the other on the side of the head, "Oi, shut up."

Izuku laughed.

They enter the town of Dolly, which was tinier than Ise and was significantly less beautiful. It looked to be mostly a car-stop town, where the only people who drop by are those who need a small bite to eat or a night at a bed-and-breakfast before heading back on the road to go somewhere more important. There were small houses tucked into raggedy neighborhoods where kids played rock paper scissors on the driveway, and rustic looking diners and shops that have an abandoned feel to them. Izuku doesn't reckon they get much business.

After a couple more streets, Izuku sees where he wants to be.

Up ahead on their right, there was a metal arch that had writing at the top. Mel's Drive-In.

"Ah!" Izuku mentioned, "We're almost there."

"Where is there," Katsuki looked around, slightly confused, "And why are we here."

"Because," Izuku looked over to the athlete, hugging his knees to his chest, then smiled, "You said you liked them."

Katsuki raised a brow, "Liked what."

"Horror movies," Izuku responded, "I wanted to go to a drive-in theatre. They're playing She Watches tonight, and I th-thought," He suddenly felt a little nervous, "...that it'd be fun."

Katsuki looked at him for a moment, "You wanted to go because I said I liked horror movies?"

Izuku pursed his lips, "I mean, yes. But also because I like them too! It's not lame is it?"

After a moment of looking at Izuku with curious eyes, the athlete drives towards the metal arch, "It's not lame. Let's go."

The metal arch was right next to a ticket booth that had a woman boredly chewing sugar-free gum fanning herself from the heat. One or two cars were in line in front of them, which purchased their tickets, before continuing past the arch and onto a small  dirt road that bent around a corner.

Katsuki pulled his car up next to the booth, "Two tickets to the 7:00 screening."

Sounding as if she was done with the heat and her job, the woman tells them the cost and before Izuku could fish out his wallet, Katsuki already handed her the amount.

"The radio channel is 101.3. Just dial it in your car when the movie starts to get the audio," She recited monotonously.

"Here, I'll pay you back," Izuku said, opening up his wallet again.

"Don't bother," Katsuki said as he pulled forward past the arch and onto the dirt road, "I'm loaded."

Izuku gave him a look, "Kacchan, I can't believe you just said that. In that case, I take back what I said earlier! You can get your own dinner!"

Katsuki shook his head, "Nope. You already said you'd cover it."

"I said I'd cover it if the drive-in wasn't worth the gas!" Izuku complained, "But wait, does that mean you agree to grab dinner?"

Katsuki groaned playfully, “Shit, that means an extra hour with your dumb ass, doesn’t it.”

Izuku stuck out his tongue, “That drive was almost an hour, and this movie is about to be two hours. One more won’t kill you, Kacchan. I won’t bite you if that’s what you’re scared of.”

Katsuki barked out a laugh, “Ho ho! *You* won’t bite *me* ? If that’s what I’m scared of?”

Izuku leaned on his palm, attempting a joke, “Yeah, since I beat you up so bad last night at the fight that you’re terrified of me now, right?”

The blonde grinned, “We must be thinking of different fights.”

“But I recall you crying and begging me for mercy,” Izuku joked, feeling happy and bold.

“Do you now?” Katsuki stopped the car and reached over, lightly jabbing at Izuku’s left arm and sides that were ticklish, “You recall?”

Izuku tried slapping Katsuki’s hands away to no avail as the blonde continues to poke at him, making him both laugh and yell at the same time, “Stop!”

“You recall what now?” Katsuki asked holding up Izuku’s injured arm, “Me crying and begging for mercy?”

Izuku all while laughing yelled at Katsuki to stop poking his ticklish sides, even though the blonde was careful enough to not touch the bruising, “Okay! Okay! I’m done!”

Katsuki let go just as a car behind him honked at him for stopping in the middle of the dirt path. While muttering obscenities at the car, even though it was his fault, Katsuki moved his vehicle forward.

“But really, are we going to get dinner?” Izuku looked over at Katsuki, “Because we both need to eat.”

“Stop worrying over me, Deku,” Katsuki frowned, and after a moment, “Yeah. We can get dinner. *Fuck* , I deserve extra credit.”

Izuku was about to yell out in a happy holler, but decided not to jinx his luck.

Just around the bend, the dirt road led to a large open area with ground made up of both gravel and dirt where cars just parked wherever. And in front of the open lot was a huge screen that the movie will be projected on.

Neither Katsuki nor Izuku had ever been to a drive-in movie before, but have always seen them in the movies. In real life, it looked just as classic and endearing.

The sky was now a deep purple, about a dozen or so cars were parked, and a young boy was in charge of the concession stands selling popcorn, soft drinks, and candy.

Katsuki pulled up to where they were pretty close to the screen but far away from other cars, and dialed into the radio channel to sync up with the audio of the drive-in theatre which was,

as of current, only playing ads. The movie doesn't start until the sun completely sets so that the projector would work well, so they had some time to kill.

Katsuki leaned his seat back and put his hands behind his head. Izuku searched around for the lever and did the same until he got to a comfortable position. Since the huge screen was blank, Izuku laid across the lowered seat on his side so that he could look directly at Katsuki with his head resting on the side of his arms.

"I can feel your creepy ass eyes staring at me, you know," Katsuki said without turning an inch, "You got something to say?"

Izuku blinked a couple of times before averting his gaze, "You need to come up with better insults for my eyes, Kacchan."

"Never thought I'd live to see the day where you tell me you're bored with my insults, Deku," Katsuki chuckled, then turned his head over to meet eyes with the greenette.

"And *I'd* never thought I'd live to see the day where we hang out again without screaming," Izuku clapped his hands lightly with a small *yay* satirically leaving his mouth, "Miracles do come true!"

"Cheesy bastard. Don't forget in that brain of yours that this is out of obligation," Katsuki reached over lazily to flick Izuku lightly on the forehead.

"That doesn't make it any less fun," Izuku spoke positively, "Just makes it a little less genuine. But I'd like to believe you don't actually feel miserable. Don't correct me if I'm wrong."

"Don't?" Katsuki asked to clarify the strange choice of wording. Isn't it usually *Please, correct me if I'm wrong* ?

But Izuku just nodded, "Don't. Because I'd really like to believe it. Even if it's not true." He smiled.

Katsuki gave the boy a strange look, and Izuku turns his eyes away, before the blonde changed the topic, "You mentioned miracles earlier, but you know what would be a fucking miracle? If this movie ends up being scarier than the first one. I never flinch at shit, but the first one made me lose sleep for a solid night."

" *Just* a night?!" Izuku exclaimed, leaning over a little, "Kacchan, you're amazing! I lost sleep for almost a week. I literally had to barricade my closet because I was scared I'd see something through the crack."

Katsuki snorted at that, then added, "I went to see it in theatre with Shitty Hair and Dunce Face. Both of them left the lights on in their room for a fucking week. At some point, I was pretty sure Ejirou went to sleep in his parents' room."

"I was tempted too," Izuku laughed, "But Tsuyu already went to see this movie. She said it was scarier than the first."

“I don’t fucking believe it,” Katsuki stated his skepticism, “There’s no way.”
“Hmm, guess we’ll find out,” Izuku grinned, before he suddenly remembered something.

Letting out an *Oh!* , Izuku reached into the backseat where he had tossed his bag and tugged at a tightly tucked item from inside.

Finally, Izuku managed to pull out a pretty large blanket, albeit it was not very thick, from inside of the bag that he had stuffed the hell out of, and brought it up to the front where he was sitting currently.

“I brought a blanket! It’ll get a little cold because of the AC in the car, but this is big enough to stretch across the both of us!” Izuku excitedly informed while throwing the other side of the green quilted blanket across the console to wear Katsuki was sitting.

The blonde threw it back and rolled his unfairly beautiful ruby eyes, “I’m not sharing a fucking blanket with you, nerd.”

Izuku frowned, “Why not? It’s just a blanket. You’ll get cold, Kacchan. It’s not like I have bad germs or anything.”

“Jesus,” Katsuki leaned up from his seat, “Does it look like I’m 5? I don’t give a shit about germs. I’m just not gonna share a damn blanket with you.”

Izuku pursed his lips then sat back against his lowered seat, pulling the fabric up to his chest, “So you can share a bed with people you barely know, but you can’t share a blanket with me, who you’ve known all of your life.”

Katsuki raised a brow at that and leaned over the medium between them, “You wanna know what I’ve noticed, *Deku* ?”

Suddenly, Izuku was a tad bit nervous, “What?”

Katsuki leaned in a bit closer, until the intensity of his gaze was nearly unbearable, “That you’re *awfully* invested in my sex life.”

“That’s not true!” Izuku’s face flushed three shades darker, “I was just making a point!”

He didn’t think that he was invested. Well, sure, he took note of most conversations he’s overheard about Katsuki’s sex life, wondered a bit here and there about it, and mentally observes all the girls and occasional guys that he sees Katsuki with. And sure, he’s imagined here and there how good Katsuki would be, if everyone is obsessed with him. But that didn’t mean he was *invested* , nor was it any of his business.

“Yeah?” Katsuki had a lopsided grin, “You sure do make a lot of comments about it.”

“I’ve literally made four,” Izuku could barely breath and his grip on the blanket on tighter.

“Four too many,” Katsuki replied, “I wonder why you’re so curious. What. You want to know what the hype is about or something?”

Izuku blinked several times, trying to avert those eyes that were so close to him but ultimately failing to do so. Deciding to just play it cool, Izuku mustered up some confidence and looked at the blonde, “It’s probably just hype anyways.”

Instead of being deterred, Katsuki took the opportunity to tease him some more and spoke more closer to Izuku’s ear, lowering his voice to where he knew it just *hits* , “I bet you’d want me to fuck your brains out just so you could find out, don’t you.”

Suddenly, all the confidence Izuku managed to muster up disappeared down the drain, and his eyes went wide at how crude and explicit Katsuki’s words were. He couldn’t tell which to be more mortified of: the fact that he felt the wave of an odd feeling rush through his body, or the fact that he couldn’t tell if Katsuki was joking or not.

“K-Kacchan!” Izuku pushed the blonde back into his seat and then reached for his bag and repeatedly hit Katsuki with the bag, “You’re a terrible person!” He continued to smack Katsuki with the bag.

Katsuki cackled, putting both hands in front of his body in self-defense from the bag repeatedly being thrown at him, “I was fucking joking, you can stop it now! If you give me an injury, my coach will kill you Deku,” He warned through his cackles.

Izuku dropped the bag and rolled his eyes at Katsuki, “Stop being so dramatic! And fine. If you don’t want the blanket because I’m just *so* disgusting, then you can freeze over there.” Izuku said while hogging the fabrics to himself.

“Give it,” Katsuki then tugged for it, grabbing it back, but Izuku held on tightly to it.

They essentially played tug of war for the blanket, with Izuku saltily exclaiming, “So *now* you want it! Too late!”

Katsuki finally got a better grip and took some for himself, “Stop being so goddamn petty!”

“Me? Petty?” Izuku looked apalled. Katsuki really brought out the worst in him, and he knew it, “I can’t stand you.”

“I can’t stand you either,” Katsuki responded without missing a beat, and they stared each other down for a solid minute, both staking claim to their half of the blanket.

Before Izuku bursted into a fit of laughter, which Katsuki rolled his eyes and let out a couple of chuckles shortly afterwards. It was so stupid. The things they fought over were always *so* fucking stupid, that Izuku wondered if these conflicts were *actually* conflicts, or if they were just a part of who they were now.

“The movie is about to start,” Izuku took notice and turned his attention back outside of the window, bringing his knees up underneath the blanket and laying his head back, “Why am I already kind of scared?”

Katsuki snorted, “It’s the bad energy. I heard the movie was cursed. But then again, I don’t believe a goddamn thing Mineta says.”

“Cursed?” Izuku looked over to Katsuki for clarification.

“Yeah,” He replied, “Like if you watch the movie, you just feel a really evil presence around you for a while. But that’s all bullshit.”

Izuku gave an *well shit* look as he turned his head back to the screen, “...an evil presence…” He muttered to himself.

They took a photo for the project evidence, and continued whatever conversation it was they were having.

It was completely dark by the time the movie started, and the professional-grade projector illuminated the white screen. From the car radio, the sound synced up to the film, and the only thing that gave Izuku a sense of comfort was that Katsuki was on his left and that there were about a dozen other cars in the drive-in theatre.

The movie ended up being about 1 hour and 45 minutes long, and about ⅞ of it was pure terror. The other ⅛ was the introduction to the main cast at the very beginning before everything went to shit. On the surface, the film’s premise was simple. A man moves into this apartment. There is a figure in all black, with long fingers sharpened to a tiny point, and every single night, it just *stands* there in the corner, not doing anything except staring its beady red eyes on its otherwise faceless black nothingness at the person sleeping on the bed. No one can see it, but the man.

And every single night, it moves six inches closer. Until weeks into moving in, the figure then stands just three feet from where the main character was sleeping, never saying anything or doing anything. Just standing there, staring at the man with its red eyes. It wasn’t one of those jump-scare horrors, but rather, one of anticipation and build-up of tension.

The entire time watching the movie, it almost felt like the black figure was there somewhere near them. Standing by, not doing anything but staring at them, moving closer every few moments. What made Izuku feel a lot better was that Katsuki made commentary throughout the entire film, pointing out things here and there. Izuku did the same, since it made the car less ominous with just the sound of the movie playing and violin scratches.

When it finally ended, Izuku felt as if he could finally take a breath, even though the thoughts of the movie still lingered there in his head.

Katsuki stretched in his seat, “I thought the first one was scarier.”

“Are you kidding me?” Izuku gave him a look, “This one was so much worse.”

“Nah,” Katsuki stood by his statement, “I mean, this one was scary, sure. But I’ll sleep fine tonight.”

Izuku placed his chin in his palm, “Really? You won’t…” He then wiggled his fingers around, “open your eyes to see a figure standing there?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes and removed the blanket, “The only nightmare I have is you doing that finger wiggling shit. Stop it.”

Izuku laughed, “I’ll see you in your dreams then.”

Katsuki lazily turned his head to the greenette, “I’ll see you there, nerd.”

Izuku smiled gently at that, and they sit in the car for a little while longer. Katsuki says he’ll wait for the other cars to file out of the screening area, since he doesn’t want to single-file out of the tiny dirt path that led here. And Izuku was secretly grateful, because he liked sitting here with Katsuki just talking about whatever it was that was on his mind for a little bit. Sure, the athlete would tell him to stop his rambling here and there, but regardless, still listened to what he had to say and replied to it. Katsuki’s replies, unless they were sarcastic, were generally thought out too, which Izuku appreciated.

Outside, the projector screen was playing static once the movie credits ended, providing enough light for all the cars to find its way out of the open space. The people working the concessions were packing up and filing out too, it seems. But Katsuki still didn’t make a move to leave the lot, and instead, sat there for a little while more, staring out the window, and getting caught in whatever whimsical conversation Izuku was spurring on. Finally, the static on the projector turned off, and the last person left the lot.

Izuku plays with a lock of his hair, “Wait, she actually said that to you?” In response to a story Katsuki was telling him.

“Sure as hell did,” Katsuki nodded, “I didn’t even fucking reply. What the hell was I even supposed to say to that?”

Izuku laughed, “I would’ve just left too. Also, this is completely off topic, but did you know that there is a haunted house near here? I was reading up on Dolly, and apparently, it’s really nearby.”

Katsuki raised a brow, “Is there?”

Izuku nodded, pulling out his phone to search it up, “It’s really the only interesting thing from Dolly’s Wikipedia. ‘Next to Dolly’s signature drive-in theatre,’” Izuku began reading off of his phone, “‘is the Gaines Family home, abandoned since the 1960s. The house belonged to a coal miner and his family. The coal miner was reported to be one of Dolly’s favorite community members, with a happy spirit and a desire to volunteer with any neighbor’s projects. Then, on June 15th, 1962, seemingly out of nowhere with no instigating incident, the coal miner axed murdered his wife and adult kid, before taking his own life. People say the acts of violence were spurred on by demon possession,’” Izuku finished up, “Anyways, isn’t that terrifying?”

“That’s really fucking weird, yeah,” Katsuki agreed and looked surprised at the violent twist, “But I’m pretty sure the dude was just deranged. Back in the 60s, everyone blamed everything on demonic possession.”

“But they said that everyone in Dolly loved him! And that he was really sweet,” Izuku countered.

“How about we go ask him,” Katsuki suggested before turning off his car engine, affecting shutting off the air conditioning and headlights, before opening the side of his car and going over to open Izuku’s.

As the passenger side door opens, Izuku just sits there and looks up at Katsuki through the dark and an open mouth, “What do you mean we go ask him?”

Katsuki had a mischievous glint in his eyes, “You said the house is near, right? Let’s go check it out. All that shit’s fake, but if you really believe the house is possessed, then let’s go see.”

“I never said I think it’s real,” Izuku clarified before sputtering, “But that doesn’t sound like the best idea, Kacchan!”

“If it’s not real, then there’s nothing to be afraid of,” Katsuki reasoned, ignoring the second part.

“B-But we literally just watched a horror movie!” Izuku countered, not leaving his seat, “And now you want to explore a potentially abandoned house? Kacchan, you’re actually crazy.”

Katsuki then stepped away from his car, “You can stay here if you want. In this dark, empty lot all by yourself. With that,” Katsuki wiggled his fingers to imitate Izuku earlier, “tall figure in the bushes over there.”

“Okay, now you’re just being mean,” Izuku said before climbing out of the car and jogging to catch up to Katsuki.

Leaving their car in the empty lot, Izuku and Katsuki followed the map to where the house was supposed to be. Apparently, it was not too far from the drive-in, so it shouldn’t take too long to find the place. However, since they were technically off-roading, the two had to step over some tall grass and shrubbery at the edge of the property. The crickets in Dolly sounded different than those in Ise, if that even made any sense.

When Izuku mentioned that to Katsuki, the blonde strangely agreed to that fact, although Izuku was sure if he said that to anyone else who didn’t live in Ise, they would be confused. Maybe it was the chirping pattern, or the pitch, or maybe they were making things up, but it just felt different. Finally, the two hit a chain linked fence separating them from what they recognized to be the house they were looking for. It sat on a quiet land plot, and Izuku immediately looked at it warily. The windows were boarded up, but the door was busted open. There were some vandalization on the property, as Izuku was sure they were not the first teens to try and explore this place. The moonlight was dim tonight, and so the battered and worn-out looking home seemed even more demonic. Izuku was very skeptical of supernatural things, but that doesn’t mean he wasn’t terrified at the thought of it, like most people would.

Katsuki then placed both hands on the fence and quickly jumped over, similar to how Izuku has seen him do it before. The fence rattled, and it broke the silence that surrounded their

vicinity. Feeling weird that he was on one side of the fence by himself, Izuku quickly made work of climbing the fence too.

When he reached the other side, the greenette stared up to the taller athlete, “Well, we’re here.”

Katsuki walked forward, “Let’s go, before the coal miner gets scared off by my incredible presence.”

For some reason, hearing Katsuki’s overconfident remarks made Izuku’s nervous feeling ease up in his gut, and he walked side by side with the athlete across the overgrown lawn to the raggedy broken steps. The house entrance was broken in, but as they entered the actual home, it was more or less unremarkable. Most of the furniture had yellow dusty sheets covering it, which were probably once white but has since collected mold, cobwebs, and stains. Everything else seemed to have been raided into and scattered all over the ground: broken dishes, wooden cabinets, porcelain doll collections. It was odd to think that people were ax-murdered in this house a couple decades prior, but any traces of that is gone. It just looked like any other abandoned house.

Izuku and Katsuki walked through every room cautiously, making conversation as they went to reassure the other that they’re still nearby, even if they didn’t realize that was what they were doing. Occasionally, a rat would scurry by and Izuku would see Katsuki flinch and he’d laugh.

At the end, there really was nothing. Sure, it was creepy, but not necessarily because of the story behind it, but rather, the fact that it was abandoned and nighttime was enough. At the point where the two boys began making jokes about some of the rooms in the house, that was when they knew it was probably time to leave, as there truly was nothing there. As the two made their way over the fence again and through the shrubbery, Izuku internally rejoiced at how stupidly teenager this entire night has been, if that even made any sense. It had been dumb, and yet, something he knew he wouldn’t forget for a long time. Especially not as Katsuki was currently ranting to him about some article he hated about cryofreeze, which was just so mundane and random, but was a detail about Katsuki that Izuku was embarrassed to say he treasures.

They end up laying back on the hood of Katsuki’s car, or at least, Izuku was. He laid with his back against the front windshield, eyes looking at both the night sky speckled with stars that looked like confectioner’s sugar and at Katsuki who was sitting up. His tall stature did not allow the athlete to lay back comfortably, so Katsuki just sat on his hood, leaned back on his right arm as they talked. Izuku thinks that this side of Katsuki was nice. Izuku could tell him that the movie has been over for a while now, and it was going into 11PM, but he was afraid that would break the nice little pocket of the world they were in together at the moment.

As long as Katsuki didn’t say anything, Izuku wouldn’t either. They can stay in this frozen moment of space a little while longer.

“The stars are pretty,” Izuku breathily said, as he stares into the abyss. His blinks were slow, and the warm spring air kissed his skin.

Katsuki tilted his head up to look at them.

Izuku continued, “I like…” He thinks about it, “I like the thought of laying in a field somewhere, with yellow flowers, and looking up at the stars. So it feels like I’m floating in them.” And then, he turns to Katsuki, “How about you? What’s something you really want to do?”

At first, Izuku wonders if this is the kind of question that Katsuki isn’t likely to answer. But he waits anyways. After a moment of contemplation, Katsuki just shrugs, “Can’t really think of anything.”

Izuku gives him a look and curious smile, “How can you not think of anything?”

Katsuki seemed to shift uncomfortably, and before anything could break the peace they had at the moment, Izuku tried to change his words, “But that’s fine.” Izuku laughed nervously before attempting a joke, “Not everyone can have such a vivid imagination as me.”

Katsuki gave him a half-smirk, “And you call me arrogant, shitty Deku.”

“You are,” Izuku poked him gently in the sides.

Katsuki moved his head so that he was looking directly down at Izuku, “You fucking dip your french fries in ice cream. I’m trusting nothing you say.”

“The contrast between flavors is great, Kacchan!” Izuku defended himself, “You have the salty crunch of the french fries, and then the sweet softness of the ice cream. They complement each other!” Then Izuku thought about it, “Hey, it’s kind of like you and me. I’m sweet, or at least try to be. And you’re just salty.” Izuku points at him..

Katsuki flicked his forehead, “Oh so you want to be a smartass? Guess what. Fries are also hot, so I’m fucking hot too. Hot and salty. That’s not a shabby combination.”

Izuku laughed, but didn’t deny anything, “The point is that the juxtaposition of flavors is super unique,” He begins before rambling a bit about the flavor profiles, while Katsuki sits there kicking his right foot against the front bumper.

“Have you ever eaten an onion and grape jelly sandwich, Deku?” Katsuki asked after his little rant was over.

Disgusted by the thought of it, Izuku shook his head, “No? Have you? Kacchan, that’s disgusting.”

“Of course I haven’t, idiot. No one in their right mind has,” Katsuki replied, “Point is: there are some things you just don’t mix. French fries and ice cream. Onions and grape jelly.”

“Kacchan, those are two entirely different situations,” Izuku argued.

He doesn’t know how long that conversation ended up lasting, or how many other stupid things they branched off into talking about, but he also didn’t really care. Nor did he care that his mom probably would’ve wanted him to get home by now. He was busy intently having a

conversation about how innocent black cats are demonized because of their reputation in movies.

Katsuki's phone has been blowing up with text messages for the past two minutes or so. He had checked the first message and then nothing since then, and it had distracted Izuku from whatever story he was telling, and so he spoke up about it.

"Kacchan, you should probably check your phone," Izuku nodded at it.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, "Don't want to."

"Why not?"

"It's my coach bitching." Katsuki said, before pulling out his phone to confirm, before blowing out some air looking away. He looked frustrated.

Izuku got up on his elbows, frowning, "About?"

Katsuki clicked his tongue, "Same shit that he's been bitching about for months."

Izuku waited for clarification, and when it didn't come, Izuku tried to pry a little bit, "What is it?"

"Nosy little shit, aren't you," Katsuki muttered, before shrugging, "I haven't cleared 18' feet yet, but you already knew that."

Izuku blushed. Of course, he did, "Yeah. But you're getting there!"

"He's been hearing rumors that some bitchass my age who's gonna be at national qualifiers is clearing 18'2," Katsuki's kicking against the front bumper got louder, "I don't care what Coach says. He can talk as much shit to me as he wants. It doesn't matter to me"

"It's okay to care, you know," Izuku looked over at him, wondering if he was crossing a line, "I think you should. You shouldn't just pretend you don't feel the way you d-"

"Deku, I don't fucking need your advice," Katsuki made it pretty clear.

"Kacchan, you're nervous, so admi-" Izuku had a habit of meddling in things where he's not asked to.

"I don't have to admit *shit* to you," Katsuki clenched his hands, and Izuku could not just emotionally but physically see Katsuki closing up to him, and he panicked.

"I'm sorry," Izuku let out, bringing himself up to a sitting position, "I don't mean to pry. I'll drop it, but…" He paused, "I just wanted to say one more thing, and it's that I believe in you." He felt so cheesy and weird saying it out loud, "I know you can do it." He repeats.

Katsuki after a moment unclenches his fists and looked away from Izuku to the trees past the blank projector screen. With a breath of air, Katsuki chuckled lightly as he says something Izuku considers strange, "Of course you do."

“Kacchan, your front bumper is going to fall off if you kick it anymore,” Izuku then takes the time to mention, gesturing to the back of Katsuki’s feet hitting back against it.

Katsuki waved it off, “You think I’d drive a car that isn’t as tough as me?” And then flashed his abs for a second.

“Hmm, let’s see,” Izuku pretended to feel the windshield, “I wonder what will happen then if I punch the windshield.” And made a gesture to fake punch the glass.

“Deku, if you do that, I will actually fucking k-” And then Katsuki stopped all of his words. Izuku looked at him, but Katsuki’s eyes were not on him, but rather, somewhere behind him. The teasing look on the blonde’s face was also gone, and replaced by a both serious and cautious one.

Izuku was about to turn around to look where Katsuki’s eyes were when the athlete’s hand comes up to grip his right arm, and Izuku looked down at the touch before up at Katsuki, who still wasn’t looking at him.

“Deku, when I let go, fucking jump off the hood and get inside of the car,” Katsuki said to him in a low tone.

“W-what?” Izuku was confused.

“Just do it. I’m going to run to my side, you’re going to go into your side, and we are booking it the fuck out of here,” Katsuki said quickly, eyes not leaving whatever it was behind Izuku once.

Flabberghasted, Izuku turned his head, and his eyes in a millisecond grew to the size of saucers. Just about 150 feet away or so, there was someone standing there. In the dark, all he could see was their silhouette, but it looked as if they were cocking their head to stare at the two of them on the car hood some more. Katsuki reached into his pockets slowly and searched for his keys before unlocking the car door with a *beep* and a flash of taillights.

At the sound, the figure began walking forward.

“What the fu-” Izuku was about to yell, but Katsuki let go of his arm.

“Fuck! Go, go! Get in the fucking car,” Katsuki yelled as he hops off of the hood the same time Izuku did and over to the driver’s side door. Both of them slammed it shut as soon as they got in, and Katsuki locked the doors before turning on the engine. The headlights flooded the empty lot. From outside, Izuku could hear a yell coming from the figure, but he couldn’t make out what they were saying.

Katsuki didn’t care.

“Go, go, go. Drive!” Izuku gripped the edge of his seat.

“I’m fucking trying!” Katsuki yelled back as he puts the gear in drive and whipped around.

“Try faster!” Izuku pressured, forgetting to put his seatbelt on as the car drifted to the other direction.

“Shit! Fuck, I’m going!” Katsuki shouted in a state of combined hysteria and haste.

Izuku then began laughing, out of amusement, adrenaline, and fear combined, to which Katsuki shook his head and laughed along at the oddity of the situation.

“Who is that?” Izuku held onto his seat as his neck craned to see out the back window.

“No fucking idea. It was probably a worker or cop. I thought I saw a flash of a nameplate,” Katsuki said while driving at 50MPH out of the dirt road that led out of the lot.

“I didn’t see a nameplate,” Izuku frowned.

“Maybe it was the coal miner’s ghost, then,” Katsuki snorted, making fun of Izuku.

The greenette complained, “Kacchan, that’s not funny!” Then added, “I don’t know why they didn’t call out first, before deciding to act all creepy.”

“My fucking question exactly,” Katsuki said as they exited past the metal arched gate and back into the main roads of Dolly, “Fucker could’ve also been some kid in the neighborhood trying to mess with us.”

“I mean,” Izuku grinned then settled back into his seat,”It worked. Kacchan, when you told me to get off and run inside the car on your mark, that was terrifying enough. It literally felt like one of those thriller scenes.”

“Shit, I didn’t know what the guy wanted,” Katsuki explained in retrospect, “One moment we were fucking talking on the hood, and the next moment I looked up and someone was standing there.”

Izuku shivered and rubbed at his arms, “Don’t say things like that, it freaks me out.”

“Whatever,” Katsuki rolled his eyes, “Anyways, dinner?” The blonde looked over to Izuku.

Feeling safe again, Izuku sunk back into his seat and nodded profusely, “Yes, please.”

Dinner was at a sketchy take-out store on a strip-mall in Dolly with only about 8 shops, and half of them seemed shut down. The other half were closed for the night except for the one American take-out shop in the middle of it, lighting up the otherwise dark outlet with its eerie blueish white fluorescent light, and the flickering neon orange sign that reads “Gib’s Burgers & Fries.” Since it was nearing midnight, most restaurants were closed, which left this as their flimsy last resort.

Walking in, the doorway shook in its frame and they walked up to the counter, where an older teen girl rolled a strawberry lollipop around her mouth. The takeout store looks like it hasn’t

been renovated for decades, with 70s and 80s posters and vinyls decorating the wall and a clock that doesn't seem to function correctly anymore.

Upon seeing the two of them walk in, the girl's head popped up and her eyes widened fractionally. They were focused mostly on Katsuki, and Izuku figured that she was either struck by his handsomeness or she knew of the athletic star of Ise.

"H-Hi, Welcome to Gib's," She looked a little distracted as she sat up straight.

Katsuki ignored her and just grabbed a menu off of the front, while Izuku greeted her warmly, elbowing the blonde in the sides to do the same which of course didn't work. Katsuki leaned his side against the counter with the menu open in his hands, eyes scanning the selection of foods.

Izuku without thinking stood right next to the blonde, body almost pressing on the side of the athlete, and peered over at the menu, even though he could reach out and grab his own. Izuku had to crane his neck a little bit because the angle was off; but he stopped when Katsuki looked down at him. Izuku suddenly felt a bit embarrassed, partly at how close they were and partly at how he didn't think twice at his actions.

Before he could move, Katsuki rolled his eyes, looking away, before lowering the paper menu down to an angle that would allow Izuku to see better, not making a move to shove the shorter boy away.

Izuku, although slightly surprised, tried to play it off cool and continued trying to find something to eat, although now very aware of Katsuki's body heat.

"Loaded cheese fries sounds pretty good. I can get a vanilla soft serve with that," Izuku thought out loud.

Katsuki snorts, "Not if you're going to dip it."

"This is food discrimination," Izuku complained.

"Sure is," Katsuki affirmed then nudged the smaller, "You know what you want?"

Izuku tilted his head up to look at the athlete, "Yup!"

"Alright," Then Katsuki turned his head to the cashier, "Get me a double Swiss burger, 6 piece spicy wings, medium jalepeno poppers, and a water. Oi, nerd. Order."

"Oh!" Izuku fumbled, "Can I just get the loaded cheese fries with extra steak and a medium vanilla soft serve?"

"O-Of course, Bakugo," The girl stammered even though it had been Izuku who was speaking last, and Izuku just gaped at her while Katsuki chuckled, "Are these separate checks ? Or together?" She eyes the two of them with an odd look.

Izuku was about to open his mouth, when Katsuki interjected and placed his debit card on the counter, "Together."

“T-together?” The girl’s eyes widened as she rung up the total.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “Listen, I don’t know what you’ve heard about me all the way out here in Dolly, but I’m not fucking him if that’s what you’re gonna text your bitch friends from Ise High about.”

The girl’s face heated up red and she waved her arms, “I-I’m sorry!” Before hurriedly getting back to work.

Izuku blushed at the mention and then interjected, “Kacchan, I could’ve gotten my own.”

“It would’ve taken longer, shut up,” Katsuki replied and took his card back.

It took about ten to fifteen minutes for the food to finish up, and it consisted of Izuku and Katsuki standing on the far left side of the tiny takeout shop mentioning how weird it was that even in the middle of nowhere, Katsuki was recognizable.

Izuku fails to mention to the other that if he was in the girl’s situation, he would have been just as nervous. Even if Izuku had not known Katsuki before the blonde became a pro-athlete, the greenette knew that if he were to stumble across a picture or video of Katsuki somewhere, he wouldn’t ever forget that face.

They ended up taking the boxes of food outside of the shop and sat down on the curb of the sidewalk adjacent to the strip of outlet stores, and set their meal between them. Katsuki’s car was parked mere feet away, and the shop was right behind them diagonally, but it wouldn’t really matter if they just sit there on the concrete to eat.

“That’s so much food, Kacchan,” Izuku took note.

Katsuki snorted, “Have you ever tried feeding an athlete? We have to eat a shit ton of food to build muscle.”

“No,” Izuku answered his question, “But if you come over next week, I could try.”

Katsuki raised a brow at this, “For our one-hour?”

Izuku looked away and bit gently on his inner lip, “Well, no. Let’s do something else for that. But you can come over just to...chill.” He didn’t know why he thought this random invitation would have been a good idea.

“And why would I want to do that,” Katsuki asked, which was borderline offensive if Izuku wasn’t so used to it.

Fiddling with his fries, Izuku shrugged, “I mean, there’s free food.”

“Free food, huh,” Katsuki took a swig of his water, “I’ll think about it.”

Izuku beamed at this. A maybe was better than a straight-up no, especially when it came to Katsuki. Feeling happy that Katsuki would *possibly* consider being near his vicinity in a context that wasn’t the project, Izuku chomped on his food.

By the time they arrived back in Ise and were dropping Izuku off, it was well past 1 in the morning, and Izuku could officially say that this was becoming a habit when hanging out one-on-one with Katsuki. The lights of his home were off, and his mother the next morning would surely have thought he was home by 10PM, so Izuku made sure to get inside the house as quietly as possible not to disturb that assumption. He had looked back one more time at Katsuki when the blonde went to drop him off, and found himself between the lines of feeling tired and not exactly wanting to leave. But he says his goodbyes anyways, feeling comfort in knowing that he'll see him again soon.

Katsuki did indeed end up coming to dinner on Tuesday of the next week after his practice ended and the athlete had dropped by his own house to take a shower, changing into a fresh pair of joggers and a gray shirt.

When he had shown up at Izuku's door, the greenette opened it and almost pissed himself. There he was, Katsuki Bakugo in all of his freshly showered tall-and-buff glory, and Izuku, who had no idea that Katsuki was coming today, was standing around in his superhero-themed loungewear, a mud mask on his face, and the front pieces of his curly hair tied up into a tiny knot on top of his head. Izuku wanted to run away. He looked like Shrek.

Mouth gaped, Izuku stammered, "Kacchan! What are you doing here?"

Katsuki rolled his eyes, "You invited me over last Friday, dipshit. And I'm hungry."

"Why didn't you text me first!" Izuku borderline screamed, mortified of how he looked at the moment.

Katsuki let out a laugh, "What. So you could have time to get ready, and I'd miss *this* sight? Fuck no. I should take a picture."

That's it. Izuku was officially deceased.

Before his soul could float out of his body, the sound of light footsteps came out into the main room, and Inko, upon seeing Katsuki, let out an enthusiastic reaction.

"Katsuki!" Inko came in for a hug, shocked that she barely came up to his chest, "What a nice surprise!"

"Auntie," Katsuki nodded then pulled out a glass pan from under his armpit, "Oh, here's the dish you left at the hag's place the last time you came over."

"Oh thank you!" Inko received the pan then ushered the athlete inside, "You know, it's nice to have you come over for once. It's much easier on my soul than Izuku asking to go out all the time," She laughed.

"Mom!" Izuku wanted to snap, "I don't go out all the time. I barely go out at all."

“Izuku dear, I was just making a joke,” Inko calmed him, “I understand you have to do your...,” She waved her hands around, “Project or whatever it is.”

She says it was a joke, but Izuku knew that when his mother wanted to convey a point but wanted to safeguard against Izuku potentially getting offended over it, she would pose her statement as a joke. So that if Izuku gets upset over it, it would be his fault and not hers.

“Mr. Toshinori says it’d be too easy if the partners were to just go over to each other’s houses for the project every week, so he requires that we have to go out and do something each week,” Katsuki straight up lied. And Izuku knew it too.

Mr. Toshinori never said anything of the sort. As long as the partners were hanging out, their teacher did not care if they stayed in a musty basement and played video games an hour a week. Izuku saw what this was.

Katsuki was lying so that his mother would be forced to let Izuku go out at least once a week for this project, unless she wanted him to get a bad grade. Izuku wasn’t sure whether he felt bad for lying to his mother, or absolutely delighted at Katsuki’s genius.

“Did he?” Inko’s eyes widened, “Izuku never mentioned that criteria to me.”

“Ah! It was in the project instruction sheet,” Izuku scratched his neck, “I thought I had mentioned it to you.”

Inko frowned, but ultimately sighed, “That just makes me a bit worried, you know? If you’re going out all the time, so much could happen. I’d just feel safer if you-”

“Nothing’s going to happen to him,” Katsuki suddenly sounded all gentlemen-like, and Izuku wanted to tease the blonde for it, “We’ll take care of each other.” Izuku wanted to blush because that is *definitely* something Katsuki would *never* say, unless it was in front of an adult that he needs to be on good terms with.

Inko rubbed at her arms then gave a small smile, “Well, that’s nice to hear. And I suppose I can’t just have Izuku do poorly in the class, but I need to have details of everything, okay? You won’t understand until you become a parent.”

Izuku wanted to argue that. Most parents weren’t like this, and to say that he wouldn’t understand his own treatment is to undermine his own thoughts on the matter. But Izuku stayed silent.

Ultimately, after a couple more minutes of talking to Katsuki, Inko left to go back into her work room, and Izuku then took a deep breath, before looking up at the blonde.

“Thank you,” Izuku spoke in a quiet voice to him, referring to the little lie Katsuki told.

“Don’t mention it. That whole interaction was suffocating,” Katsuki rolled his eyes.

Izuku lightly slapped him on the shoulder, “Kacchan! That’s my mom.”

“I literally do not give a fuck.”

Izuku then smiled coyly, “You cared enough to say all of those sweet things,” He teased, “What was it? We’ll take care of each othe-”

Before he could finish, Katsuki shoved a hand over his mud-mask covered face, forcing him to shut up, and Izuku just laughed.

Since Izuku had to clean himself up and take off the mud-mask before they could start cooking, Izuku hesitantly led Katsuki up to his room, praying that he had hidden away everything that was supposed to be stashed away.

Izuku’s room wasn’t anything too extravagant, but it definitely looked a bit like a child’s room. Although Katsuki had probably seen glimpses of it from outside of his window, Izuku was sure that the athlete hasn’t seen the inside of his room since they were small kids. It wasn’t much better now: posters of his favorite superheroes and athletes were strung up everywhere, figurines of characters he liked, trophies and plaques of his academic achievements, and *oh fuck,* Izuku forgets that he has *that* .

Before he could throw everything off of that one particular shelf, Katsuki hollered out.

“Ho, ho! What is this?” Katsuki grinned menacingly as he strutted over to one particular shelf and peered at the items, “You really are a fan.”

Izuku’s face flushed under the mud mask as Katsuki stares at his almost-shrine of Katsuki. It wasn’t an *actual* shrine. He just had nowhere else to put all of his “merch.” It wasn’t much, so it wasn’t weird or anything. It was just like a fan to their favorite baseball or soccer or football player.

But with Izuku, his favorite sport to watch was pole vault, and his favorite person to watch was Bakugo Katsuki. And so, he had ticket stubs from tournaments that he had attended, newspaper clippings from some of Katsuki’s biggest accomplishments, and a jersey with the athlete’s name on it.

“Go away!” Izuku shielded himself between Katsuki and that part of the shelf, “You are *not* allowed to see this!”

“But it’s of…me…” Katsuki said confused, “I don’t see why not. Also, I didn’t know you had a jersey of me,” Katsuki teased, “I’m not sure if I’m more creeped out or honored.”

“I got that when I was 13!” Izuku reasoned.

“Oh really?” Katsuki reached around and read the tag, “Because it’s in a size adult medium.”

Izuku gave up and sat on the bed, “I...liked wearing oversized things.”

“Uh huh,” The blonde sounded unconvinced, but continued looking at the shelf, a slight hint of a smile playing at his lips. Izuku never expected for Katsuki to come up here, much less look at his little corner dedicated to the boy. He was mortified, and yet a little intrigued, because funnily enough, Katsuki looked almost happy, “What’s this.”

Katsuki's hands reached out for a little box, but before he could, Izuku stopped him, "No, don't open that. Please."

Rolling his eyes, Katsuki sat back, "Hurry up and wash your face, so we can fucking get the show on the road. I'm starving."

Izuku did not know what he was thinking when he offered to *cook* for Katsuki, because for as long as he could remember, Inko had made his every meal. Of course, there were times when she wasn't home, and Izuku had to fend for himself, but those meals were usually extremely basic.

And so, after about fifteen minutes of Izuku rummaging around the kitchen, muttering up a storm to himself about what to cook and how to cook it, Katsuki finally stepped off of the counter stool and complained up a storm about Izuku being a terrible host before taking over the kitchen himself.

"How the fuck are you going to invite someone over for *dinner* ," Katsuki said while dicing up cubes of chicken, "But not know how to cook."

Izuku, taking it easy, sat with his feet dangling off the counters, "I just thought I'd wing it, you know? I still could!"

Shaking his head, "Hell no. Stay on the counter. I'm about to fucking make this kitchen my bitch."

"Kacchan! My mom is," Izuku aggressively pointed towards the door, "Right. In. There."

Katsuki replied just as punctually, "I. Don't. Care."

Izuku threw his head back and groaned, knowing that he had brought this upon himself. Katsuki's brash, slandering, and loud attitude was a stark contrast against his quaint and sugary home. While Izuku walked on eggshells with every word he spoke, Katsuki ran through fire. And yet, Izuku liked him here, in his house.

He liked how his mother was okay with it because it's Katsuki, even though she didn't really know him and only adores him because of who he was and the fact that he was Mitsuki's son. He especially liked how Katsuki cooked up a storm, all of which ended up being delicious, for the two of them, plus leftovers for Inko. But Izuku thinks out of the whole night, what he liked the most was that Katsuki had been distracted enough to have stayed an extra two hours and talked.

Izuku didn't know why it was so easy. It wasn't easy weeks ago before the project started. But it felt like the moment Katsuki decided to accept the criteria to treat Izuku normally, it seemed as if everything Izuku had ever wanted their relationship to be was actually happening.

He just didn't fully understand: if it was this easy all along, then what about Izuku had made Katsuki repulsed all of this time. Izuku could ask, but he knew he wouldn't. Not when it may

ruin this bubble of peace he was in: one where Katsuki takes him out to lakes at midnight or comes over to his house for dinner.

When Katsuki actually left, Izuku noticed that it wasn't because he got bored or sick of his presence, but rather, his phone was blowing up. When the blonde decides to finally look at it, he shoved the thing back in his pockets and stood up off of the couch that they were chilling on.

"I'm gonna head out," Katsuki said, "I'd say thanks for dinner, but really, you should be thanking me."

Izuku laughed at this, "Thank you, Kacchan."

The blonde began walking towards the door, but before he could, Izuku felt bold enough to call out.

"When are we hanging out again?" Izuku asked, eyes hopeful, "For the project."

Katsuki smirked at this, "Miss me already, nerd?"

Izuku rolled his eyes, "No. I just need to know so I can give my mom the details." He partially told the truth. Really, he just wanted to know.

"She don't need 'em," Katsuki stated as a matter of fact, "And you don't need to give 'em," He grinned mischievously, "Till next time, Deku."

The boy in questions parts his lips, as if to say something else, but settles with a, "Till next time, Kacchan."

He didn't know it at the time, but the tempo completely changes after this point.

Next time happened to be that Wednesday, which was much sooner than Izuku would've thought, but by no means unwanted. It had been an average day, with his usual routine, in which he stopped by for a couple of minutes to watch Katsuki practice. Yet today, much to Izuku's surprise, the athlete approached him. Leaving his team for a quick minute, the blonde had jogged up to the fence that separated them on team practice days. Izuku only ever came inside when Katsuki had his solo days.

"Oi nerd," Katsuki called out.

Izuku, eyes wide, looked up at the taller boy standing on the other side of the fence, "Kacchan?"

"Why the fuck do you look so surprised? You're the one coming to *my* practice," Katsuki smirked, "Anyways, you got something to do tonight?"

Izuku thought about it, looking up at the sky, "Tonight? Hm, I don't think so. Just the same stuff I usually do."

“Be ready by the time I get off practice, and I’ll pick you up. I got somewhere I wanna go,” Katsuki practically ordered.

Izuku’s mouth dropped, “I can’t just do that!”

“Why not?” Katsuki argued, “You want to. And your mom already thinks we have to go out once a week. Just use that excuse.”

“Who said I wanted to,” Izuku said defensively.

“Hm, so you don’t want to?” Katsuki asked, in a tone that indicated he already knew the answer.

Izuku really didn’t want to give him that benefit, but ultimately bit his lip, huffing, “Okay fine.”

“That’s what I thought,” Katsuki smugly responded before letting go of the fence, walking backwards, “I’ll pick you up soon.”

Once again, it felt so redundant asking for permission, like he’s had the same conversation hundreds of times. It was a bit easier this time around because he got to use the excuse of the project, just like Katsuki had suggested, but that didn’t mean Inko was satisfied with the fact that Katsuki hadn’t told Izuku exactly what it was that he *wanted* to do. Because of this, Izuku and his mother got into a small scuffle over the matter, but the greenette refused to let it get the best of him.

And all thoughts of whatever slight argument he had with his mother went away when Katsuki picked him up later, roaring down the quiet road with his car blaring “Material Girl” by Madonna out the speakers. It definitely didn’t seem like something the athlete would listen to, and Izuku told him that exact thing to which he recieved Katsuki yelling his ear off about how this music was the greatest of all time for the entire car ride to wherever it is they were going.

The blonde ended up taking the two of them to explore some abandoned grain silos on the outskirts of Ise. When Izuku had arrived there, he was immediately weirded out and intrigued by the sheer creep factor of it all: cobwebs everywhere, a rusty broken down gate entrance, the shrubbery growing out of the windows of the facilities, how quiet it all was.

It didn’t really seem like an activity many would find interest in, but Izuku trusted whatever the boy had in mind. The grain silo was an entire abandoned facility, made up of the three silos, some shipping warehouses, and a barn. Rust building up on everything and ivy climbing up all the walls made everything look more vintage and outdated, but the pair of delinquents still explored every corner, even climbing up into one of the silos for the fun of it.

“Oi, look at this,” Katsuki said, as they were stepping over some fallen wires.

Izuku looked over to see that Katsuki had a stick in his hand, and with the stick, he picked up a...Izuku’s eyes bulged, “Is that a…”

“Used condom?” Katsuki barked out a laugh, “Sure is. Looks like some farmers were getting it on back here.”

And then Katsuki waved the stick towards Izuku, who took a step back, “Kacchan, get that away from me.”

Ignoring the boy and instead, giving a mischievous grin, Katsuki began stepping towards Izuku with the stick.

“H-Hey!” Izuku held out a hand, “I’m warning you! Hey!” He started running backwards, “Hey, I said back off! Kacchan!”

Even as Katsuki chases the shorter boy around the abandoned grain facility, which was a safety hazard in of itself considering how much broken equipment is everywhere, Izuku still thinks to himself: he doesn’t really want to forget these hangouts, even if they’ll end when the semester does. Even if it means nothing to the other. Even if it’s all for a project.

He doesn’t want to forget this day.

Or the next.

Or the next. Or the one after that.

Because this was Izuku’s life for the next almost two weeks. He didn’t know how it happened, whether Katsuki had forgotten they were only required to hang out once a week or something else, but Izuku finds that he wasn’t being rejected when he would ask to see him again, even after their one hour was over.

And when it happened the third time, Izuku was convinced that Katsuki had not noticed they were hanging out more than once a week. And if he did notice, then the blonde didn’t say anything.

Katsuki wasn’t ever the one to initiate the plans, but it seemed like if Izuku managed to work up the courage to ask, even if they had already hung out twice that week, then Katsuki, after making a show out of Izuku being annoying to be around, would manage to say yes.

And even the Friday that had followed the Wednesday spent at the abandoned grain silo, it didn’t seem all too special if someone were to say it outright, but Izuku never thought that playing in the mud would actually be fun.

When the blonde had picked them up, Katsuki had taken them to a creek out in the woods, with shallow water that came up to their ankles and rocks slicked with algae that would make them slip if they walked too hastily. It had rained on Thursday, making the ground around the creek deep in thick clay-like mud.

When Katsuki had accidentally sunk down to his knee in the mud and Izuku ended up laughing harder than he meant to, the athlete picked up a wet and drippy chunk of the mud

and threw it at the greenette, which marked the beginning of their mud war. At some point, Izuku had the upper hand, getting in more throws at the taller man.

“Get back here, you little shit!” Katsuki yelled as he waded through the mud after Izuku who was attempting to run away, “I’ll take this pile of mud and shove it so far down your throat, it’ll look like shit when it comes out your ass.”

“Kacchan, that’s disgusting!” Izuku yelled back, trying to move his legs through the mud, “Just accept that I win!”
“Never,” Katsuki reached down to grab a huge chunk and threw it at Izuku’s back.

He missed, and Izuku laughed hysterically, “This is why you do pole vault, and not basketball.”

Their clothes were beyond fixing, and Izuku’s white t-shirt will never be white again, but he regretted nothing. As for the state of Katsuki’s car after their mud soaked selves got inside of it, let’s say the blonde needed a deep clean the very next day.

Explaining it to his mother later that night when he got home, on top of Inko already being upset at him for going out twice that week, was difficult, and Izuku had to apologize profusely at 11PM.

Of all days to wait up for him, Inko had chosen the day where Izuku comes back with his entire body caked in mud, which almost gave the woman a heart attack. Izuku could practically see Inko losing her nerves as he and his mother stand in the living room this late into the night, and he was beginning to wonder what it would take for his mother to raise her voice. This has been going on for twenty minutes, and he was exhausted.

“Izuku,” Her voice shook slightly, “First, you go out for the second time this week, even though your project requirement for the week is fulfilled, and argue when I told you no. Second, you come home late, and looking like this. I’m not sure what you want me to say,” She asked, voice polite, but beginning to sound condescending to Izuku’s ears.

But he took a deep breath, making himself calm and his tone respectful, “I just want you to ask me if I had fun, and if I was being safe. Why can’t that be enough.” He said quietly. The hazy yellow lights of the living room and how quiet it was in his house never irritated him more.

“Had *fun* ? You want me to ask you if you had *fun* ?” Inko asked with a hint of ridiculousness in her voice, “Izuku, I love you, but do you know how ridiculous you look right now? Coming home this late looking like that?”

“Why does it matter?” Izuku was close to crying. She was making him feel embarrassed, as if the mud on his clothes and smile on his face walking in were foolish behaviors instead of joyous nostalgic ones. It had been at least twenty minutes since he’s gotten home, and he hadn’t even been allowed to go up to his room to shower, “I was happy, and it was a really nice night, Mom. Why does it matter?” He repeats.

Upon seeing tears threaten to spill out of her son's eyes, Inko rushed forward, and use her hand to thumb Izuku's cheeks, softening her voice to coo him.

After a few minutes, the kind sounding woman ushered him gently, "Izuku, you *are* happy. You're a happy little child, you always were. Happy and kind. I don't want to stop you from having fun, Izuku, but I want you to understand that you don't have to go out and do…" She waved her hands around, "stupid stuff like this to have fun. You can have fun here too! With m-"

"It's not stupid," Izuku whispered, pulling himself away with a smile so that she doesn't think he was mad at her, "I'm going to take a shower mom. I love you, Goodnight."

He knew as he turned away to head up the stairs, the look on his mother's face made it obvious her shock, even though he didn't particularly say anything shocking.

Izuku thinks, more than anything else, underneath that initial shock, what his mother was afraid of most was change.

And change happened, all right. It didn't just happen. The normalcies in Izuku's life were beginning to dissipate before his eyes, and he thinks the worst part of it all was that he was reaching his hand out to it. Change in the form of Bakugo Katsuki.

In about one and a half weeks after the mud fight, the pole vault team will have their first tournament: a local one held at the Daichi County Track & Field Stadium, where about three neighboring schools compete.

It was the beginning of their tournament season, and by the end of the semester, the top performers may receive the chance to go to the National Youth Qualifiers or the National Qualifiers for adults. Katsuki has been to the National Youth Qualifiers every single year since he had entered high school, and had won his division every time.

Since this would be the blonde's first year competing as an 18 year old, which is considered an international adult, Katsuki will, for the very first time, be competing in the adult National Qualifiers, opening him up to a pool of completely new and more heavily experienced competitors.

Some say Katsuki Bakugo, one of the highest scouted high school athletes in the entire country, will end up sweeping the adult Nationals. Some say this is where he'll fall.

Considering that this season may be a huge decider in the trajectory of Katsuki's path, the blonde trained with more rigor these next two weeks than he ever had before, even though it was a local tournament that he knew he'd sweep easily. Every victory counted. Izuku knew it too: he could see the extra hours Katsuki was putting in. He could tell the blonde had been training at home too. And on the Thursdays that Izuku would come in to watch and drop off a cherry gatorade, he could tell: Katsuki was not playing around this season. From the trickles of sweat to the bulging muscles as he jumped, Katsuki's power was explosive.

That being said, Izuku doesn't know how to explain the other biggest change to his life: the fact that, once again, he wasn't being rejected when asking to hang out. Izuku doesn't mention the required hour in case it happens to be that Katsuki just forgets each time they hang out that the one hour was passed a long time ago. But Katsuki was smart, and Izuku knew it. There was no way the other didn't know.

After the mud fight, Katsuki had knocked on Izuku's window again at 9 P.M. the following Monday. It was a bit easier to convince the other to leave this time, since he's done it twice before and gotten the hang of it now. That didn't lessen the slight guilt he felt for disobeying his mother, but any thoughts of that disappeared when that night, Katsuki and him wandered through the empty town square, with its closed shops and restaurants, feeling as if they were the only people in this town.

Most things in Ise closed pretty early, except for the diners, skate rinks, bars, and other places that teenagers frequent. But teenagers never really frequented the town square, which was more for moms who liked boutique shopping and coffee shops. Besides, all the bars were on the other side of town, adjacent to the beach.

The town square looked like the classic centers you'd see in those old films, where there were wooden stands set up for farmer's market vendors during the day, lots of beautiful landscaped flower bushes, plenty of outdoor shops painted in a vintage 80s style to match the theme of Ise, and a big fountain in the middle with an angel spouting water from her hands.

Near the fountain was a pretty large splash park, where water sprayed from the ground. During the day, kids would come and splash around in it, then grab a popsicle from a vendor nearby. At night, it was just them.

Feeling antsy, Izuku threw off his shoes and ran towards the splash park, immediately being sprayed with the jets of water shooting up from the ground. Underneath his feet were sounds of water splashing everywhere, and he kicked the water onto Katsuki who was standing nearby. It seemed like no matter what they do, at some point in the night, they had to somehow annoy the shit out of one another.

"So you choose to die today, huh," Katsuki shouted before running towards Izuku, kicking up water in front of him to soak the shorter man's back.

"Not if you can't get me!" Izuku teased, and kicked some water back.

At some point, they ended up wrestling in the splash park, like dumb teenagers with nothing better to do than go out late at night to wander the empty town square then play in puddles.

When Izuku's back hits the wet ground, he decides to stay there, with streams of water spraying up between him, and stares up at the sky. After a moment, Katsuki does the same and lays down in the middle of the splash park. And they're quiet for a little bit, catching their breaths.

Izuku then asked, "I thought you don't stay out late on weekday nights."

"What time is it?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku checked his phone, grateful he had a waterproof case, “Nearing 11:30.”

Katsuki tsked, “Fuck, we’ll head back in a second. If I can get 7 hours of sleep in, I’ll be good. Why. You sick of me already, Deku?”

“No,” Izuku turned his head slightly, “Just a little happy because I thought you meant to stay out a little later with me.” He admitted.

Katsuki seemed as if he wasn’t sure how to reply to this, “Fucking cheesy nerd.” And got himself up, “Come on, I don’t have time for this.”

Izuku frowned, “Time for what?”

“For tonight to get sappy,” Katsuki curtly replied, wringing his shirt out.

Izuku’s voice quieted itself, “Oh, I didn’t mean to…”

“‘Ts nothin. Let’s get you home before Auntie’s spidey senses tell her you’re not where you’re supposed to be,” Katsuki told him.

It’s funny that Katsuki said that, because oddly enough, Izuku was beginning to think that this was where he was supposed to be. But it was then that Izuku learned quick: to try and calm his sentimentalism if he wanted to keep hanging out with Katsuki and develop their friendship.

Expressing those kind of emotions were things that came so naturally to Izuku, that it felt odd to see an adverse reaction from Katsuki every time something sentimental or personal came up.

Before Katsuki dropped him off that night, Izuku asked him just before the athlete drove off, hands nervous for no reason, “Kacchan, can we...um, hang out again Thursday?” Izuku hesitantly asked.

Katsuki took a moment, hands on his steering wheel, and simply told the shorter man, “We’ll see. No promises.”

Katsuki had said that, and yet, when Thursday came, the blonde was at his door at 6 P.M., greeting Inko first.

“Ah Katsuki! Are you here to pick Izuku up for the project?” She asked, eyes wide and searching even though there was a smile on her lips, “He didn’t say anything about it today.”

“That’s because I didn’t tell him today,” Katsuki replied straightforwardly.

“You...didn’t tell him…” Inko nodded slowly with pursed lips, and Katsuki could tell that wasn’t the answer he wanted. Still, the woman smiled brightly, “Next time, I just think it’d be nicer if you gave us a heads up!”

Katsuki had no intentions to, but said anyways, “Of course.”

It’ll be the second lie he’s told to this woman’s face, and he feels like it won’t be the last. When Izuku comes rushing down the stairs, his hair is windblown, but his smile was wide.

“Kacchan! So you came after all,” He laughed.

The boy in question rolled his eyes, “Yes, now come on.”

That evening, they spent a couple hours in the arcade, which was much longer than the average customer. But the both of them being extremely competitive made sure that they played the fuck out of each game before moving onto the next one.

On the other side of the arcade, they could hear a group of girls fawning over the well-known athlete, and making curious comments about Izuku. Not mean of course, but definitely curious.

“Kacchan, you know they’re talking about your, um, dick right now,” Izuku said as he leaned against the sides of the machines watching Katsuki play a hunting simulation game.

Katsuki snorted at this, “And what exactly are the fuckers saying about it.”

Izuku blushed at this and twiddled with the screw on the machine, “Um, that it’s big.”

At this, the blonde paused his game and looked up at Izuku with a raised brow, “And you’d like me to confirm it? Is that it, Deku?”

Izuku sputtered, “No, I’m good!” He definitely did not need to imagine Katsuki’s dick at the moment.

They were there for another hour, before Katsuki got hungry, and the two decide to hit up a small Italian hole-in-the-wall restaurant owned by an immigrant family. Italian was actually one of Izuku’s favorite cuisines, yet his go-to-dish was chicken parmigiana because it was slightly similar to katsudon. Fettucini alfredo with shrimp was Katsuki’s go to.

Izuku doesn’t know how long he can keep talking to Katsuki about random things, but so far, he hasn’t found a limit where his throat completely gives up, so until then, the greenette will continue.

And Katsuki, surprisingly enough, does his fair share of rambling as well, usually spurred on by something Izuku would say. The green-eyed boy wouldn’t say it out loud, in fear that it might trigger Katsuki’s dislike for sappiness, but he believes that they bounce off of each other well. Sure, their relationship was far from conventional, but Izuku liked to think it worked.

After a couple more times hanging out and then a couple more small turmoils with his mother when he got home or before he left, Izuku knew that things were changing at a rapid speed..

As almost two weeks passed since the mud fight, Izuku could barely hold onto the changes. If he were to think about it, two weeks is not that long, merely 14 days. And yet, it felt as if he has done more in those 14 days than he had in the past four years.

What was *supposed* to happen is that Izuku meets Katsuki for a total of once a week, but somewhere along the line, those directions got blurred and it was now about two to three times a week.

Skipping rocks and taking a nap on the riverside. Finding an abandoned tree house out in the woods and climbing into it. Swimming some more at some of the more local lakes. Izuku wasn't sure how to feel about the fact that he was looking forward to Katsuki's company so often.

By the time Katsuki and the team's first local tournament comes up, Izuku finds that time was moving a little too quickly. How many more weeks until this was over, until Katsuki demands that he gets out of his way like he had promised. How many more weeks does he get to be near the explosive blonde, talk to him like they've never stopped, have stupid confusing conversations that don't matter to the rest of the world but mean everything to him?

And now, as he sits on the stands where a crowd of people and spectators from Ise High were situated, he feels tunnel vision with Katsuki. There were other members on the team, of course. The one who was stealing looks at Izuku from the kick-off was still doing so now, but Izuku could only see one person.

Katsuki, in his perfect form, is his perfect everything, about to absolutely dominate this local competition. He won't even have to touch anywhere near his previous record in order to win this one, since the tournament was small, the bar was literally low.

It was almost a crime to have let Katsuki compete. It probably would have been more fair to other athletes to allow Bakugo Katsuki to skip the preliminary local tournaments and head straight to regionals, but unfortunately for everyone else, that wasn't how it worked.

Izuku thought back to a couple days ago, when they were sitting on the curb of a food truck sidewalk together.

"You coming to the tournament Sunday?" Katsuki had asked him.

And Izuku remembered replying, "Kacchan, I've been watching you for forever. Why would I stop now?"

And he was watching alright. As Katsuki's turn finally comes around and he stands at the starting position, pole gripped in his hands, Izuku watches. As Katsuki waits for the timer to count down and calculate his movements in the meantime, Izuku watches. As the athlete begins his sprint, determined, and ups it to a full on run, Izuku watches. As Katsuki hits the pole into the box and it bends, lifting the boy off of the ground and into the air, Izuku watches, hands clutching his seat even though he knows the boy will make it.

And as Katsuki's back bends easily over the bar set at 13'5, the starting height for all local competitions which was way below Katsuki's record, for a moment, the sun gets blocked and all Izuku could see was Katsuki, with the sun's glow behind him, high up into the sky, filled with passion and explosive energy and raw intensity.

And *fuck* , suddenly, Izuku feels something strange in his chest. It bloomed in his lungs, and he found himself a little out of breath as his heart rate increased. What? He stilled himself, and his mouth went dry.

Flutters.

That's what he was feeling. Flutters in his damn chest. Fucking *flutters* .

*Oh no. Oh no. Oh no. Not this.* Izuku thought to himself, even though he wasn't even sure what *this* even is. One moment, he was in awe watching the person he looked up to the most soar into the sky, and the next moment, he felt it: a faint flutter in his chest.

Unsure and unaccepting of what it was, Izuku chalked it down to him being dehydrated, since it was true that he hadn't drunk enough water today, and the boy got up from the stands and down the metal stairs. The flutters were still there, and Izuku clutched his stomach, forcing himself to take deep breaths as he neared the water fountains.

After taking a long sip, Izuku stood up, wiping the excess liquid from his mouth, then sighed. That was better. The flutters were gone, and he considered that a done deal. It had been slight dehydration. That was all. Izuku places both hands on the side of the water fountain, head down, as he takes a deep breath.

Katsuki ends up sweeping the tournament, as everyone had expected. By the end, he managed to win this one without the bar ever raising even close to his previous record, for the other competitors maxed out way before. Out of everyone on Ise High's pole vault team, all but one had made it past this local tournament, and to be fair, the one person who didn't had suffered an ankle injury two months before and wasn't completely healed.

After the tournament's award ceremony concluded, Izuku headed back down the bleachers and went back to the fountain to take another sip of water. For the past seven minutes, Katsuki had been bombarded with people: friends, coaches, spectators, love interests, everyone wanted a piece of the blonde. And Izuku, having watched from afar, knew this was Katsuki's element. This was where he thrived. This was where Katsuki felt alive, and all Izuku could do was watch from the sidelines.

It was times like this when the blonde seemed a bit unreachable, surrounded by so many people, so much recognition. Izuku felt a sudden urge to reach out and take a little bit of the boy for himself, but he shakes his head to rid the thought. He sees the blonde's name being chanted and all of the people surrounding him, and Izuku smiles gently to himself before turning away.

Now, he stands under the bleachers once more, near the fountain as he waits. He pulled out his phone, meaning to text his mother to come pick him up, when he was interrupted by an unfamiliar voice.

“So what did you think of the tournament?” The person asked, and Izuku’s head popped up.

His large green eyes came to look at smooth gray ones, almond-shaped with strong eyebrows and a Cupid’s bow lip. The guy who stood in front of him seemed to be around 6’0, and was brunette with a nice easy-going smile. Izuku recognized him to be the one pole vaulter who kept on stealing glances at him at the kick-off and from time to time when he’d come to watch practice. Izuku couldn’t exactly remember his name, however. They’ve never actually talked.

“O-Oh! I thought it was amazing!” Izuku answers genuinely, “Everyone did so well! I saw your vault too, and your form was so well executed, you must have been doing this for a while!”

The vaulter laughs, “Well, I’m no Bakugo Katsuki, but I try my best. My name is Kaito Sen. Just call me Kaito.”

Izuku beams, “I’m Midoriya Izuku!”

“I know,” Kaito grins, “You’ve been coming to our practices for years now. We all know it’s for Bakugo, but I can’t say I don’t hope sometimes that you might notice me too.”

Izuku blinked a couple times at the comment. Was he *hitting* on him? Izuku shrugs with a smile, “I’ve noticed.”

Which was the truth. Although Izuku came mainly for Katsuki, he’s gone to enough practices to notice all the other members of the pole vault team, and get to know their styles and maneuvers, even if he doesn’t even know all of their names. Kaito was good at pole vault too, their whole team was,  really. His record was 16’3, which was incredible for a high school student. It was just that when you have someone like Katsuki on a team, incredible isn’t good enough anymore.

Kaito grins at this, “I should have introduced myself earlier. But hey, we’re all seniors now. When’s a better time than this.”

“Better late than never,” Izuku affirms, happy to have a new friend who was suspiciously looking like he wanted to be a little more than friends.

“Exactly. Listen, I want to get to know you more, when I’m not sweaty and gross. So…” Kaito takes out a piece of ripped paper from his gym bag and scribbles something on it in pen, “I want you to have my number. In case you wanted to talk or…” He winked with a genuine playful smile, “anything else.”

Izuku laughed at this but took the paper anyways out of politeness, “Well that is quite forward.”

Kaito shrugged with a sheepish smile, “Honesty is the best policy.”

Izuku nodded in affirmation then smiled, “Well, thank you Kaito. But fair warning, I’m not that interesting.”

“I’m sure you’re plenty interesting,” Kaito looked down at the shorter male, before searching around, “And I’m not sure what your relationship to Bakugo is, but I can assure you that unlike him, I’m much more of a gentleman,” Kaito winked playfully.

Izuku pursed his lips at the comment, and for a second there, felt like defending the fact that he didn’t need a gentleman. He didn’t need more structured rigidity in his life, or perfect seeming people with manicured actions.

Izuku looked down, “I-I’m not sure what you’re trying to assume about my relationship to him, because we’re just project partners.”

“Then that’s even more perfect,” Kaito then asked him. “Are you waiting for a ride home right now?”

Izuku nodded, “Yeah, I was about to text my mother.”

“If you want, I can take you ho-“ Kaito genuinely offered but was interrupted without notice.

“He’s got a ride, fuck face,” The booming voice of Bakugo Katsuki approached the two of them. Katsuki had his gym bag slung over his shoulders, a water bottle in his hand, his vault uniform was still on, and his hair was slightly damp from the sweat.

“Kacchan! Don’t call him that, that’s mean!” Izuku gaped.

Kaito just laughed it off, “It’s fine. Everyone on the team is used to it. I’m Fuck Face. Ejirou is Shitty Hair. Denki is Dunce Face. The list goes on.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, then turned to Kaito, “Don’t you got a shower to get to? You fucking reek. Good luck trying to get in the nerd’s pants smelling like that.”

Izuku turned five shades darker at the comment, and all words left his brain.

Kaito slapped Katsuki playfully on the back, “Dude, you don’t smell much better. You were out on the track longer than anyone, so I think you have a date with a shower too.”

“My sweat doesn’t smell. Genetics or some shit,” Katsuki rolled his eyes, before nodding to Izuku, “Oi Deku, how long till Auntie gets here.”

“I haven’t texted her yet,” Izuku replied.

Kaito interjected, “I thought you said he’s got a ride.”

“He does now,” Katsuki grinned at his teammate then tugged his bag forward, gesturing towards Izuku, “Let’s go.”

Izuku blinked, before hopping along, “Are you sure? My mom might make you come inside to tell her about the tournament.”

Katsuki gave him a funny look, “Who said I was taking you home?”

Izuku gaped his mouth, then closed it again smiling. He was so going to die, but tensions have been on the slight rise in his household anyways so what more could one more night hurt. He texted his mom that the tournament was running late, before turning back to Kaito.

“It was nice to meet you Kaito!” Izuku yelled back before rushing to catch up with Katsuki.

From behind, Kaito Sen had a curious eye kept on Bakugo Katsuki, before shifting his gaze over to Izuku, cupping his hands around his mouth to shout, “Text me!”

Izuku made no promises.

Their odd little expeditions continued, and Izuku was pretty sure he was living someone else’s life, because this didn’t feel like his. Since when did he have this much freedom, albeit, most of the time, he had to sneak out or suffer through an uncomfortable conversation in order to leave the house. Since when did he do things that seem so far out of his comfort zone, and probably most peoples? Since when did he looked at Bakugo Katsuki and feel like he couldn’t get enough of his time, like a fool. Izuku would shake those odd thoughts out of his head the moment they came, but that doesn’t mean they don’t creep up on him at night.

Ise was a beautiful small town, with an assuming nature to it. The kids bike around the neighborhoods, the older folks gather on Tuesdays for some afternoon tea, the adults take their children out to the lake for fishing trips, and dumb teens like Izuku and Katsuki were always in search of something odd to do.

That following Tuesday, that “something odd” was going through a scrap metal yard, which was situated on the western corner of town. There were piles upon piles of scrap metal, old cars, broken televisions, and the like just sitting around, and the two were trying to see what weird or interesting shit that was in it. It had only lasted so long until the sound of dogs barking filled the air, and it wasn’t just any dogs, but they were dobermans. Doberman Pinschers. *Fuck* .

“Who’s idea was it to *leave* my fucking car two miles away?” Katsuki yelled at the shorter man as they ran.

Izuku defended himself, “I wanted to have a nice walk! And someone would have been suspicious if your car was parked near here!”

“If we’re gonna get eaten by dogs, I’ll kill you,” Katsuki threatened.

“Not if they kill you first,” Izuku reasoned, before spotting something in the corner of his eyes.

Running towards it, Izuku picked up a metal bike that looked relatively in good condition. It had an extra seat in the back, and he checked the tires. It was on its way to being flat, but it will work. Climbing on, Izuku shouted.

“Kacchan, get on the back!” He ushered.

Katsuki looked at it, “Hell no. Get off, I’m peddling. You get on the back.”

“Oh, can you just put aside your pickiness for a moment?” Izuku complained, “The dogs are right *there* .”

Katsuki looked back and his eyes widened, “Fuck! Fine!” He said as he uncomfortably climbs on the back, snaking one arm around Izuku’s waist. He was taller than Izuku even sitting down, so it felt like the greenete could feel the athlete’s chin near the top of his head, and the press of a firm body up against him. The arm around his waist made Izuku pause for a moment, but when he heard shouting for him to go, Izuku shook his head and began peddling like a mad man. It was ridiculously hard to get the bike to go fast enough to haul two men out of the junkyard at a quick enough speed, but without effort and extreme pain to his calves and thighs, Izuku was slowly outbiking the demon dogs. Katsuki’s long legs hung awkwardly off the sides of the bike, and his feet almost touched the ground, and they probably looked stupid, but it didn’t really matter because Izuku was happy.

And at some point, their new acquaintanceship was slowly becoming the hot topic of their little friend groups. And probably many other little friend groups. When two people who were previously reknowned for having a shitty relationship suddenly start spending a ridiculous amount of time together, even if it was for a “project”, people began to talk.

In school, Katsuki never talked to Izuku. The blonde would maybe give him a glance as they passed each other, but other than that, it was like they were strangers. And when they *did* talk inside of the classroom, it was usually a debate. However, instead of making everyone tense from their arguments, people were now just confused. Because it felt almost...playful? In an aggressive way.

And even at practice, Katsuki never really acknowledge him either, unless it was to tell him to be ready later that day, or on Thursdays when he had solo practice. Izuku accepts the situation, but still finds it funny how when no one was around, they would saunter through Ise together swimming in streams or beaches, or climbing up water towers. Yet if anyone were to see them in school, no one would be able to tell. The only reason people *did* notice was because people were sighting the two of them *everywhere* .

“Izuku,” Ochaco stared at him while chewing her food, “Why is everyone telling me that Bakugo Katsuki skipped Itsuka Kendo’s huge party last night to hang out with you? People saw you guys at the old stone factory.”

Izuku blushed and scratched the back of his neck, “O-Oh...I didn’t know there was a party.”

Shoto interjected, “She didn’t mean it in an offensive way. Everyone is surprised, that’s all. Bakugo is usually at Kendo’s functions.”

“Yeah,” Ochaco tucked a piece of hair behind her ear, “I mean, you’ve been telling us you’re hanging out with him more often, but it seems a little intense, especially for him. He *never* hangs out with anyone this much.” She asked curiously.

“To be fair,” Shoto pointed out, “Midoriya and him are project partners. It’s not like Bakugo is skipping everything. He went to Taki’s the other week. I think he went home with Etsuko.”

Izuku found himself looking down at his food at the comment. He knew Etsuko, she was in his literature class last year. She’s pretty. Izuku found himself feeling something strange in his gut, but he shook his head and smiled back up at his friends.

“I don’t really know,” Izuku honestly replies, “It just feels like we’ve kind of picked up where we left off a long time ago. And although he’s still pretty mean to me, it’s different you know?”

“Mmhm,” Ochaco leaned in closer, “Except when you left off, both of you were 5. And now, Bakugo is a 6’4 incredibly ripped, incredibly hot, incredibly smart, super-athlete, and you are also super hot and super smart. I’m sure it’s *different* ,” She said with a wink.

Izuku buries his face in his hands, “I-It’s not like that.”

“Then what is it like?” Iida finally piped up.

Izuku thought about it. What was it like? He didn’t know how to even begin to describe that. He didn’t even know if he was allowed to call them friends, or if he should just stick to project partners.

Katsuki was the rudest person he’s ever met: never missing an opportunity to tease him, push him into any body of water, get into petty arguments with him.

He was also the most low-key person he’s ever met: calming his mother here and there when Izuku felt like he couldn’t, scolding him but still making sure he eats, drinks water, and doesn’t get hurt when they do stuff. Katsuki was also one of the most closed off: they never associated in school, the blonde always avoided conversations concerning his emotions or anything vulnerable, and he often gave Izuku odd comments about Izuku’s own competence, but never cares to explain them. And yet, Katsuki was the most exhilarating person he’s ever come across: because who else but Kacchan would whisk him away on little adventures, blast 80s music down the highway, make him lose track of his hours. Katsuki was complicated, to say the least.

But if Izuku were to describe what it was like in the most simplest form, it would be this:

The greenette turned to his friends, smiling before answering his question, “It feels like flying.”

Chapter End Notes

this is literally going to be 100k+ omg i hope ill be able to keep your attention until then

I’m excited for the next chapter hehe , stuff gets *intense*

& also, I actually want to cry bc yall's comments and love have made me SO SO happy. thank you so much for reading.

# Chapter 5: The Lake Party

Chapter Notes

24k chapter ahead, i keep telling myself I'll keep it to 8k

it def picks up near the end ahsdfasd
underaged drinking ahead, but like, if you made it this far, I'm sure that's expected haha

spotify playlist: https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy?si=6bac412c696244d2

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The water is warm on his skin, but salty on his tongue. Izuku leans his head back, dipping the back of his green hair into the ocean, and relaxes his body into the current of the waves. He thinks that he'd like to make this moment last forever.

And when Izuku opens his eyes again and straightens his head forward, he's met with the sight of Bakugo Katsuki, shoulder deep into the salty water, saying something he couldn't really make out through his water-clogged ears, against the backdrop of one of the most beautiful sunsets the city of Ise has seen.

Ise, if nothing else, is static: it doesn't really change much, just like its people. Sometimes, the thought is comforting. Other times, it's suffocating.

Even the sunsets don't change, always a beautiful array of colors painting the sky. Puffs of clouds in different hues of pinks, oranges, reds, and purples. But, no matter how beautiful a sunset is, you can only watch it so many times. No matter how delicious a dish is, you can only eat it so many times. No matter how euphoric a song is, you can only hear it so many times.

No matter how easy and comfortable a life is, you can only live it so many days. Before you begin to wish for change: crave it, thirst for it, desire it more than anything else. And Izuku has been feeling that for a while now ever since he was able to taste freedom.

Although the sunsets were gorgeous, it was so unchanging that Izuku sometimes wished it would rain. The rainfall during Spring and Summer months in Ise was not much, but when it *did* rain, it rained like hell.

Today was not one of the days where Izuku wished it would rain, because then the glow of the sunset behind Katsuki's blonde hair would disappear. Because then, the ocean water

wouldn't be as warm. Because then, there wouldn't be the pink reflection of the sky on the water's surface like there is now.

When he came back to Earth, Katsuki was snapping his fingers in his face.

"Oi, Deku," Katsuki's deep voice caught his attention, "Did you hear a fucking word I said?"

Izuku blinked, drawing all of his senses back into the moment, then sheepishly answered, "No, sorry. I was thinking about something. Can you repeat that?"

The blonde rolled his eyes but did so anyway, bouncing to jump over the incoming wave, "I was saying that I had a dream last night. You were in it. I woke up pissed off that I had to see you in real life all the damn time just to see you again when I sleep."

Izuku shook his head, splashing water into Katsuki's face. He would've taken this opportunity to remind Katsuki that they only had to see each other *once* a week, but for the past however long, they were going on 2-3 times a week, which is insane considering Katsuki's schedule. The tournament season was jammed packed. However, Izuku was not going to bring up that fact to Katsuki and potentially ruin whatever it was that they were.

"I apologize that my imaginary self invaded your dream," Izuku sarcastically giggled then asked, "What was I doing in your dream?"

Katsuki then floated back onto the water, letting his body loose and closed his eyes. Izuku watched him and swam closer, making sure the blonde didn't float away into the current.

"We were heroes. And we didn't go to Ise High. It was a school with a weird name, two letters or something. UE? UA? I don't know," Katsuki recalled his dream, eyes still closed.

"UA?" Izuku laughed, "That was the name of the hero school we came up with when we were kids, remember?"

"Was it?" Katsuki asked, "Anyways, I was saying. We were heroes. I had this fucking cool ass power, where I could make things explode from the palm of my hands using my sweat."

"Sounds like a power you'd have," Izuku smiled, sliding over the sand underneath his feet, "Very versatile."

Katsuki hummed, then opened his eyes, looking over at Izuku, "And you weren't born with powers, but got some by swallowing Mr. Toshinori's hair. Dreams are fucking weird," He chuckled, "But it gave you super strength. And then for some reason, we had to beat up Mr. Toshinori together for a test at the hero school."

"Did we win?" Izuku asked, intrigued.

Katsuki got back in an upright position and shrugged, "I don't know. I woke up."

Izuku looked up at the pretty pink clouds, "Do you believe in alternate realities?"

Katsuki rolled his eyes at this, “We’re getting philosophical now, nerd?” Before huffing out, “But nah. Because that means there’s an alternate reality where you’re cooler than me, and that just defies the laws of the universe.”

“Kacchan!” Izuku kicked the athlete under the water, then shrugged, “But I don’t know. I think it’s a fun idea to think about. Maybe in another world, we could be heroes.” Then Izuku thought about it some more, “Or hero partners! How about that?”

Katsuki grinned at the greenette, “Me? Partners? With you? Hell no.”

Izuku frowned, then sauntered over where Katsuki was, the water slowing him down, “Kacchan, you’re partners with me right *now* .”

“Yeah and it’s a pain in the ass,” Katsuki teased, coming in to poke Izuku in the chest, “And now, you’re starting to call me at night, too? Christ, it’s like a full time job, Deku.”

That was true. This past week, Izuku would find himself randomly calling Katsuki some nights just to talk for a little bit, if it means that it would drown out the tensions that has been building up in his household. He thinks that maybe if he hears Katsuki’s voice, it would make his mother’s guilt-tripping and strained voice from one of their awkward disagreements go away.

Izuku wonders if Katsuki could tell that’s why he was calling, because Izuku would usually open up a call with some slight breakage in his voice. He’s always been prone to cry, and hated that about himself. He’s tried every single time he felt the urge to tear up to suppress it, to think of all the reasons why he shouldn’t be upset, to control his emotions, but it’s really fucking difficult. If Katsuki knew, then he had kept quiet about it.

“No one is making you pick up, Kacchan,” Izuku reasoned.

Katsuki didn’t have a good response to this, and instead, diverted the conversation by turning around, telling Izuku, “Whatever. Oi, you wanna see how far we can swim out?”

Izuku looked towards the horizon, then back at Katsuki, “What if we get caught in a riptide?”

“Swim parallel to the shoreline until you’re out of it,” Katsuki responded fairly quick, turning his back towards Izuku and eyes set on the horizon, “You in or not.”

“Sure, but hey...” Izuku frowned as he swam a bit closer to Katsuki, noticing something on the taller’s back.

They seemed like long scratch marks that started from the athlete’s shoulders and ran down his back in thin lines, like fingernail patterns. That was odd, Izuku hadn’t seen those before when they had gone swimming at the lake again a couple days ago. It must have been recent.

Izuku had an idea of what they were, but for some reason, felt the urge to ask anyway.

Izuku without thinking touched his fingers to the scratches, and Katsuki’s back tensed up as he turned his head to the side to eye the greenette.

Izuku looked up through long lashes before asking, “What are these?” His fingers lightly traced them, feeling Katsuki’s firm back muscles as he did so.

From the side, Katsuki gave him a look and raised a brow, before turning to grab a hold of Izuku’s wrist, stopping the contact.

“Sex,” The other replied frank as can be.

With his wrist in Katsuki’s rough hands and those ruby eyes staring down at him, Izuku felt the urge to step back, “Huh?”

Then the blonde spoke, “Don’t tell me you’ve never been fucked so hard that you leave scratches on someone’s back.”

So that confirms it. Izuku blushed and looked down to the side, wrist still in Katsuki’s hold. He wasn’t about to admit that no, he hasn’t. He tries not to envision it: Katsuki, the boy in front of him, fucking someone so rough that they drag their nails down his back like that.

He tries not to think about it, because then, that odd feeling in his gut will persist. The one that is currently making Izuku confused, because *why* is his stomach feeling like it’s being pulled taut at what Katsuki implied.

“That’s none of your business,” Izuku blinked up at Katsuki a couple times, and tried to find something to derail the conversation.

Katsuki looked at him strangely then, before bringing a hand up to gently swipe something off of Izuku’s cheek.

Izuku looked down to where Katsuki’s hand touched his face in a manner that was almost like a caress, “What is it?”

Katsuki dropped his hand, “An eyelash.”

“Oh,” Izuku said, feeling a bit ashamed that his neck flared up with heat at the contact.

Katsuki chuckled, then, “But I have to ask, Deku…” He said before turning back around towards the horizon.

After a moment of no continuation, Izuku swam after him and asked, “Yes?”

While still stroking through the water, Katsuki turned his head for a quick moment to flash Izuku a grin, “Why’d you ask me a question that you already knew the answer to.”

Nope, Izuku was not going to reply to that one. Did he know what those scratches were? Sure, he had a very sure guess. Did he ask anyways? He absolutely did. Why? That was a tougher one. Izuku doesn’t let himself ponder on the thought, but somewhere deep inside himself, he knew exactly why he asked. He asked because simply, he wondered if there could’ve been another explanation. As for why he hoped for that, he didn’t know.  That was no lie.

They swam further out, and yet they never reached the horizon. That was the beautiful thing about the ocean: it felt as if it never ended. Although Izuku was slightly paranoid about the mysterious things that may be swimming underneath him as he ventures further out, he was more focused on how tired his limbs were getting. When it comes to swimming out deep, a person gets no breaks. If you stop swimming or treading water, then you drown.

“Kacchan, I’m getting tired!” Izuku called out, “If I drown, my ghost will forever haunt you for this idea!”

Katsuki stopped swimming forward then turned around, “Fuck, I’m getting to that point too.”

“So we’ll both be ghosts,” Izuku chimed, “How much longer can you tread water?”

Katsuki looked out to shore, “Enough to get us back to shore. Oi look, we made it pretty fucking far.”

Izuku looked back, and was pleasantly surprised by how far out they got. Sure, there was probably more than 40 feet of ocean beneath them, and they had long passed where the ocean floor dropped off, but hey, they got pretty far. Swimming back however, is much harder, because of the current.

“But can we make it back is the real question,” Izuku pondered as he starts his journey back, doing freestyle strokes, “Maybe I should have listened to my mother and stayed home after all.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes as he followed in suit, “You’ll make it back, nerd. I’m not gonna let you drown.”

Izuku laughed through labored breaths, “What a surprise!”

Katsuki swam ahead of Izuku, splashing water in the greenette’s face, “For that, I just might.”

They did make it back to shallower water, and the moment Izuku’s feet hit sand, he hollered out in rejoice, before realizing he doesn’t have much more lung capacity to holler out. Katsuki, who was used to intense cardio on a daily, was breathing a bit more heavily than usual, but otherwise, looked fine.

And so they messed around in this stretch of beach for a while longer, not really wanting to leave the warm confines of the beautiful ocean water. As the sun goes down and twilight comes, the color of the water was turning into more of a deep purple.

On the left side were the mountains that situated itself near Ise, lush and green, and going all the way out into the water. On their right side was the rest of Ise and whatever there was on

the coast. Some beachside shops sporadically placed here and there, some beach houses, or just anything else.

Further down the strip of beach about a mile or so was Ise's dock and marina, where all of the citizen's boats were stored. Katsuki's family had a nice speed boat docked down there, and another one at Lake Enic, one of the bigger lakes in the area. And a mile from the ocean marina was the commercial fishing port. Those waters were usually never swam in because of how many fishing boats are out there every single day.

But on the stretch of beach that they were currently playing around in, the sands were so white and clean that it squeaked beneath their feet. The waters were just as clean and beautiful, aside from the occasional jellyfish. And the backdrop was plain gorgeous.

To top it off, Izuku finds himself laughing a lot in Katsuki's presence. Every moment felt like he was in a movie: where the two main characters have some type of beautiful fun in the sun, with their heads thrown back in laughter, and some sappy song playing in the background. But with Izuku, instead of a sappy song, he gets to hear Katsuki yelling at him for stupid things.

After another thirty minutes of messing about near the shallow end, Izuku commented, "Ice cream sounds nice right now."

Katsuki splashed some water in his own face, slicking his hair back. The way his hands were bent over his head revealed the nice toneness of the athlete's arms and lats, "Shit, that does sound good."

Katsuki then waded out of the water, legs dragging against the waves, heading towards the shore. Izuku, feeling slightly weird about being in the now-dark ocean by himself, followed suit.

"We're going up?" Izuku asked to confirm.

Katsuki hummed in response, "Gonna get us some ice cream. I know a shop near here."

"Really?" Izuku hurried his pace, excited.

Katsuki looked back at him, "Your eyes get all big and shit when you're excited. Fucking stop it. It's creepy."

Izuku rolled his eyes and frowned, "You're still saying that?"

"Yup," Katsuki nodded, grabbing the towel they left on the beach and drying himself off. Izuku did the same.

Without putting on a shirt, Katsuki did a light jog towards the car. Not wanting to be left behind, Izuku ditched putting on his shirt and did the same.

The ice cream parlour was barely five minutes down the road, directly parallel to the beach. Although it would have taken longer, they honestly could have walked.

But instead, Katsuki wanted to drive down the boulevard at night with the windows down so that it would dry his hair and his damp torso. Izuku leaned back against his seat, head tilted to lazily look over at the handsome athlete from the side, and wondered to himself how unfair it was. There was only so much talent and beauty in this world, so how was it that Katsuki took so much of it. But then again, he reasoned with himself, there was also so much room for assholery in this world, and Katsuki took a good amount of that too.

When they pulled up to the parking lot of the ice cream parlour, Izuku frowned.

“It’s closed for the night,” The greenette says.

From the outside, it was an adorable place, matching with the retro theme of Ise. The outside had bright neon green and pink lights that lined the perimeter of the store windows.

Above the entrance, it read “Seaside Ice Cream” in blue neon, and underneath that, smaller text that read “Open since ‘82.” Izuku has faint memories of his dad taking him here once when he was young. He had no recollection of anything else about the day, just the name of the parlour.

The inside was dark, considering that it was closed. Chairs were stacked on top of the tables, and the booths were wiped clean. The area where the ice cream was kept at the side of the store where the checkout was located was lit up slightly by backlit neon paneling running behind the signs. So there was a hazy neon blue glow inside too, despite everything else being dark.

Katsuki looked over to the side at Izuku, before taking off his seatbelt and grabbing something from the center console, “I know.”

And then, the blonde exited the car, heading for the entrance. Izuku, confused but curious, leaves the vehicle as well, going up behind Katsuki, who went straight up to the door and pulled out a metal pick. That was probably what he had grabbed from the console. And then, he inserted the thin piece of metal into the lock.

Izuku’s eyes widened, “Kacchan! I understand half the things we do aren’t really legal, but breaking into a place is just a *tad* bit more illegal.”

Katsuki, focused as he moves the pick through the lock, assures the greenette, “Relax. It’s my uncle’s. He thinks I’m the fucking family jewel and that I can do no wrong. Which to be fair, I can’t. He’d probably be honored that I’m breaking into his shop.”

Izuku stands outside, turned towards the street as if on guard. He was antsy, bouncing on his toes as he realizes how suspicious Katsuki looked. This was not one of the situations where

the athlete could simply smile and say “Sorry sir, I won’t do that again.” And get away with it.

“It still makes this breaking and entering!” Izuku argued.

“If you’re so scared, go back in the car,” Katsuki humored, still trying at the lock.

Izuku pursed his lips, but stands watch anyways. Fuck, for the fiftieth time, Izuku faces the fact that Katsuki brings out the worst in him. Yet, he thinks to balance it out a little bit, Izuku likes to believe that he’s bringing out the best in Katsuki, little by little. Sure, the blonde is extremely emotionally unavailable and avoids anything sentimental when possible, but there have been moments of time when Izuku can maybe get a little something out of him: like when Katsuki told him how sad he got after his old dog died. Izuku considered that a victory. Sadness. So the great Katsuki is able to feel that too.

When Izuku didn’t move, Katsuki chuckled, “That’s right. You stay there, and be my Bonnie.”

Izuku laughed at this, “Bonnie? As in...the criminal duo Bonnie and Clyde?”

“Who the fuck else,” Katsuki asked.

Izuku ran a hand through his hair, and wondered how odd they looked. Two boys shirtless and huddled in front of a closed shop. He also does not disclose that Bonnie and Clyde were not just a duo, but a couple. But that wasn’t what Katsuki meant, so he left it silent.

“Why do I have to be Bonnie? Why can’t you be Bonnie? I want to be Clyde,” Izuku pestered the other.

Katsuki paused what he was doing then stood up to his full height, turning slightly to look down on Izuku who barely reached his shoulders, then flexed just how much larger he was in terms of body mass and muscle. It was an intimidation factor, and Izuku knew it, but that didn’t mean he didn’t feel like he shrunk to the size of a pea.

Staring right down at Izuku, Katsuki quirked an eyebrow then smirked, “This is why.”

Izuku mentally forced himself to not stammer, before shoving Katsuki slightly, “Don’t forget I stood a fair chance at beating you up, Kacchan.”

Katsuki shrugged then went back to lock picking, which was taking a terribly long time. It wasn’t as if the blonde picked locks often, “Never said you didn’t. There’s nothing wrong with being Bonnie. She was badass. Or are you sexist or something,” Katsuki sneered.

Izuku was tempted to kick him over, “You always make me out to be the bad guy. I would never!”

Katsuki snorts and then the lock clicks finally, “I fucking know. You wouldn’t even hurt a fly even if it deserves it. It’s one of the things I hate about you.”

Izuku gaped at the comment. Katsuki said it so casually, that it was surely just a jest.

“Are you serious,” Izuku frowned in confusion.

“Nah,” Katsuki replied almost bored, “Anyways, you coming in or not.”

Izuku pursed his lips then walked into the now open door, “I can’t believe you actually managed to get in.”

“After all this time, you still can’t believe it?” Katsuki laughs as he closes the door behind them, “It’ll be fine. I’ll put a $10 on the counter so it’s not like we really stole any ice cream.”

Katsuki then walked over to the back where the employees would work and then turned on the device connected to the parlour’s speakers. After browsing a bit, Katsuki put on I Want To Know What Love Is by Foreigner. Another classic. Izuku wonders how the athlete can listen to so many sentimental songs, but feel none of it.

As the music begins to play in the background, Katsuki then leans his forearm over the glass casing on top of where the ice cream was. The soft neon glow in the otherwise dark parlour highlighted the sharp features of Katsuki’s face.

“Oi, shitty customer with the shitty hair. Welcome to Seaside Ice Cream,” Katsuki pretended to be an employee from behind the counter, “Which flavor of liquid calories can I delight your ass with today.”

Izuku grinned to himself, and sauntered slowly across the array of ice cream available, not breaking eye contact with Katsuki the entire time, “One scoop of mint chocolate chip and one scoop of cherry garcia.”

Katsuki shakes his head in disapproval, “Did I hear banana pudding? I think I heard banana pudding.”

Izuku giggles, “Then you need to get your hearing checked.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes but grabbed a waffle cone, and slid open the glass doors to scoop out one mint chocolate chip and one cherry garcia scoop. Izuku pretended to wait at the cashier’s counter, leaned over and smiling to himself as he hums along to the music. He could see his faint reflection in the glass of the ice cream covering.

Izuku’s hair was dry, but looked like it was windskept with the ocean’s salt still in it. His cheeks were freckled and pink from the slight sunburn he obtained being out in the water for so long, and his nicely lean but sturdy build looked a bit tanner too.

Katsuki came over to the counter where Izuku was waiting, and leaned on it as well, handing the greenette his cone, before declaring his price, “That’ll be four-ninety-five, bitch.”

Izuku takes his cone, and grins, “Oh no. I didn’t bring any cash.”

Katsuki leaned on his elbow some more and gives him a sly smile, “Shitty customer. In what way do you plan on paying me then?”

Izuku snorts at how ridiculous they were being. It was obvious that the two were messing around, with the over-the-top acting like they were in a porn scenerio.

But Izuku doesn’t stop, trying not to laugh as he licks his ice cream while maintaining eye contact with the blonde, before asking, “How would you like me to pay?”

It looked as if Katsuki was trying to hold back a laugh himself at the sight, even if his eyes did dart down to Izuku’s tongue once, and then cracked his knuckles, “A damn foot massage would be nice. Fuck, vault practice has been killing me lately.”

Which completely ruined the moment, and Izuku bursted out into laughter, his shoulders shaking gently. With Katsuki, it can sometimes be so easy to let go and laugh like this.

He was happy. And he’ll continue to be happy for another thirty minutes or so, as Katsuki gets his own ice cream, two scoops of banana pudding ice cream,  and they settle on top of the counter to eat it and talk. Izuku would occasionally glance out of the window, paranoid that he might see the flashing blue and white lights of police once they see two random boys inside of a closed ice cream parlour. But other than that, the vibes were wonderful. Izuku has always had a thing for beautiful neon glows, and the way the blues, oranges, pinks, and reds faintly covered different parts of the shop was stunning, combined with the softness of the music.

Katsuki was currently talking about this one particular pole vaulter who was a new transfer from a different school when he was at a tournament, and the boy had talked up a storm about winning, just to get his ass handed to him from Bakugo Katsuki himself.

Izuku ate the last piece of his waffle cone while listening intently, enjoying every word that comes out of the other’s mouth. He was getting used to the way Katsuki talked: gruff, brash, rude, informative, yet the words were casual, and for him. They didn’t seem to have a true bite in them, and Izuku found himself always immersed in some kind of conversation with the other.

They stayed there for a while, until it was nearing 11 P.M. At this point, both of their hairs were dry, but sticky from the salty ocean water, and their skin was speckled with residual sand that stuck to their legs and arms.

Suddenly, Izuku’s phone rang, with the familiar ringtone that often causes Izuku a bit of dread, and he fishes the device out of his pocket before checking the Caller ID. He looked at it for a moment, lips pursed, eyes darting away. Izuku noticed Katsuki watching the interaction with curious eyes, as if waiting to see what the greenette was going to do.

Izuku picks up his phone, and puts on a bright voice, “Hi mom!”

“Izuku?” She repeats herself then, worry evident in her tone, “Izuku? Where are you?”

Izuku looks around, biting his lip. She'd know that every ice cream parlour was closed by 11 PM. So he just says, "I've been at the beach."

"At night?" Inko sounded disapproving, "There are no lifeguards at night, and the riptides can be dangerous. Izuku, do you know how irresponsible that is? Do you know what I'd do if you disappeared?"

Izuku wanted to protest, but he bit down harder on his lip and tried to think happy thoughts to calm his upsetness, "Thank you for worrying, but I'll be fine, Mom. I'm a strong swimmer, plus I was having fun!" He tried to reason politely.

"Fun needs to have *boundaries* , 'Zuku," Inko exasperated said through the line, voice still sweet, "I don't want you or Katsuki to be going to the beach at night from now on. I don't want to do this Izuku because you've always been such a good boy, but if you don't listen to me, I will register a tracker on your phone."

Izuku's eyes widened and he gaped at the phone. A *tracker* ? His mother, no matter what, has never gone that far. To be fair, he has never gone out to this extent, and their conversations lately have been filled with juxtapositions: moments of good conversation, then moments of tense uncomfortable ones, back and forth.

But this was a tad bit far. He would feel absolutely terrible and violated in terms of privacy if Inko was able to check where he was every moment of the day. The potential loss in autonomy scared him.

Izuku glanced over at Katsuki, who also seemed slightly surprised at her suggestion that sounded more like a threat, but his stoic face went back to its usual position and he tapped his fingers on the counter. Izuku almost felt embarrassed.

"You won't have to," Izuku said softly, "I'll head home right now."

Inko sounded excited, "Great! Do you ne-"

He cut off the line, not wanting to hear her voice anymore. He stood there for a second in silence, trying to collect himself so that he doesn't get angry. She was worried, irrationally, but that's how it was. Getting angry never fixed anything, and so he took deep breaths and looked back up at Katsuki. Izuku had no intention of getting a tracker on his phone, not when life was going this well.

"You're not getting that shit in your phone," Katsuki declared finally.

Izuku smiled and looked down, "I don't plan to. If it ever comes down to it, I'll just leave my phone in my room and pretend I'm asleep."

"Or you could just tell her to fuck off," Katsuki suggested.

"And ruin my relationship with her?" Izuku gaped, "No thank you, Kacchan."

"It was ruined the moment she started treating you like a lap dog," Katsuki rolled his eyes.

Izuku frowned, “She does no-”

“Lap dogs are kept in the house all the damn time. When they’re allowed to go out, it’s on a leash with their owner. And if they randomly go out by themselves, what do the owners do? Panic. Because sure, dogs that leave their house might come back. Or they might not,” Then Katsuki added, “You want to know what it is? I think...that Auntie is afraid that one day, you might not want to come back to her and be her lap dog,” Katsuki completed his analogy, not missing a beat.

Izuku felt defensive, “I’m not a dog,” He stated, “And she’s just worried about my safety.”

“Sure. I’m sure that’s a part of it too,” Katsuki tapped his fingers some more, “But you ever think about this, Deku? When did she start acting like this? Did a certain fucking event happen? Come on,” He snapped his fingers in Izuku’s face, “Think, Deku.”

Izuku pushed Katsuki’s condescending fingers out of his face, “She’s just always been like this. I get the frustration, but I don’t know why you have such a problem. She’s a good person, Kacchan.”

“I wasn’t saying she’s not,” Katsuki sounded irritated at the conversation.

Izuku felt on the line between defensive and agreeing, “But you’re misunderstanding her intentions.”

“I’m not misunderstanding shit,” Katsuki tongued his cheek,  “Listen, I’m getting real fucking impatient with you. If you want to stay ignorant, do it. I don’t give a flying fuck.”

“Of course you don’t,” Izuku found himself breathing out, looking away.

But not quick enough to have missed the faint and brief look of surprise present on Katsuki’s face at the accusing comment, as if he had expected Izuku to have different thoughts on the matter. The air was suddenly just a tad bit tense, and Izuku didn’t even know why the conversation switched to what it had. After a moment of silence, Katsuki spoke again, voice normal as if they weren’t squabbling moments earlier.

“Oi, when I drop you off, you think Auntie will let me take a quick shower at your place?” Katsuki cracked his neck and asked.

Izuku blinked in confusion, “I mean, of course she will. But why can’t you shower at your house?”

“Because I got somewhere to fucking be after,” Katsuki rolled his eyes, while turning off the music and hopping over the counter.

Izuku was curious, “Oh, okay. Where do you have to be?”

Katsuki laid a $10 bill on the counter and turned his head to look down at Izuku from the side, with the slight quirk of his brow, “An appointment.”

Izuku snorted, “An appointment, Kacchan? What kind of appointment is at this time?”

Katsuki shoved his wallet back into his pocket then quirked his ruby eyes, stepping closer until Izuku was staring up at the blonde's chin. Katsuki used one finger to tilt Izuku's chin up to look at him, "Use that brain of yours, Deku. What kind of appointment do you *think* it is. Ain't that hard to figure out. Or are you really that sheltered."

Izuku blushed red, his green eyes blinking a couple times and he forced his chin away. In a moment of delirium, his mind had blanked.

Of course the athlete was talking about *that* kind of appointment: a fucking dick appointment. The term seemed adolescent, but it was enough to get Izuku to understand now.

He felt this strange sensation in his gut, one that he has been feeling a couple times recently when it came to Katsuki. Each time, he'd ignore it and pretend that there was another logical explanation as to why his stomach would hurt a bit everytime Katsuki would say something like this. He thought of who it might have been. Who Katsuki was planning on seeing tonight. And then he mentally cursed himself. Shoving the odd feeling in his stomach away, he told himself it didn't matter.

"Oh," Izuku breathed out, feeling fidgety.

Katsuki grinned, "So you *do* know."

"Kacchan, don't treat me like a child," Izuku said with pursed lips as he looked up at the taller, "I'm not a kid anymore."

Izuku could tell for the most part. Katsuki still viewed Izuku as someone who was naive when it came to certain things, and in turn, Izuku will never be grouped in the same category as the girls or guys that the blonde fucks. In Katsuki's eyes, Izuku knew that he was seen as inexperienced, naive, and the like. Izuku didn't know why he felt such an incessant need to prove the athlete wrong, even if he wasn't *entirely* wrong.

Katsuki only continued to smirk at this and pushed forward, causing Izuku to take a step back, holding his breath, "Not a kid anymore, huh. Little nerd, you wear superhero pajamas, have your mommy breathe down your neck everywhere, got these little freckles, and you blush like a fucking middle school brat at everything. Now move aside and let the adults play," Katsuki practically breathed near his face.

Izuku felt stuck in his spot, barely able to handle the proximity between the two of them. Katsuki's presence was always so domineering, making Izuku feel tiny. He was almost offended by Katsuki's comment. He knew that he was not as 'out there' as other people, but the fact that Katsuki barely saw him as an adult with desires, mature thoughts, and what not made Izuku want to prove so badly how wrong he was. Not that he knew how.

And so, instead, Izuku just elbowed the athlete in the gut and huffed his way towards the door, "I hope whoever you hook up with tonight doesn't cum. And I hope she thinks your dick is small, Kacchan."

It was definitely an uncharacteristic statement, but Izuku was slightly mad. The reaction to this was priceless though.

As Katsuki exits the parlour locking the door behind him, he then claps, “Well fuck. Would you look at that. So you *can* talk back,” He barks out a laugh, “But I must disappoint you, nerd. Neither of those are happening.”

Izuku throws back a middle finger, and Katsuki fakes being offended as they both settle into the car.

If it’s one thing that having Katsuki accompany him into his house is good for, it’s that having the blonde there prevents Inko from getting onto Izuku too much, for she wouldn’t berate him seriously in front of a guest. When he had arrived home, the woman was sitting on the barstool, sipping from a cup of warm milk, and seemed as if she’s been watching the door for a while.

The exchange was kept as brief as possible, with Izuku wanting to minimize the time he has to endure his mother’s paranoid and overly obsessive eyes on him. And although her words and tone were normal as she talked to Katsuki and him, Izuku still felt as if her eyes were begging him for something.

Dragging the blonde up into his room, Izuku tossed him a towel and a pair of oversized clothes that would hopefully fit the taller well enough, before Katsuki entered the bathroom hogging the shower.

Meanwhile, Izuku settles on the edge of the bed, sitting on his knees, and he stares at his room. Childish figurines, rows of comic books, raggedy t-shirts and shorts flung here and there. And he looked at his reflection from the full-body mirror hanging off his bathroom door.

*Just look at me* , Izuku thinks to himself. His messy green hair will probably never get into place, and now, there was salt and sand all up in it. He reached a hand up to touch his freckles. They made him look even more childish. And then his large eyes. His body wasn’t delicate and slender, but instead, lean and fit. At least that was something. Izuku realizes just then that he never really thought too much about his appearance or how he presented himself.

Maybe Katsuki was right, and he *did* look naive. With a slightly heavy heart, Izuku caresses his face and wonders why even though he works out, he’ll never lose the baby face.

His self-staring session came to a halt when the bathroom door opened, and out came the boy who was blessed with the appearance of a god: everything from Katsuki’s chiseled jaw, to his sculpted figure, to the intensity of his red eyes were unreal. His clothes were a tighter fit on the athlete, but he still looked incredible. Life was unfair.

Izuku’s eyes were locked on Katsuki’s as the freshly showered athlete walked forward to where he was kneeling on the corner of the bed, hands in his lap. The only light that illuminated the room came from the partially open bathroom.

“You’re gonna go?” Izuku asked. It was a dumb question. Of course, the blonde was going to go. For what reason would he stay.

Katsuki ran a hand through his hair, “In a few minutes.”

Izuku felt a kick in the gut again. He kicked back, ignoring the mysterious feeling, “Okay, have fun.”

The words felt numb on his tongue, and he struggled to find a reason why.

Katsuki sneered and reached for his wallet and keys that he had set down on the bed, “See ya, nerd.”

Izuku gave him a soft smile, before shooing the other out, “See you, Kacchan.”

And as Katsuki leaves through his bedroom door, Izuku stupidly wonders why his hands were gripping the fabric of his shorts so tightly. And he wonders why in his head, he asks himself questions he isn’t sure he even wants the answers to: who is Katsuki meeting, what are they like, what do they *look* like, do they watch Katsuki like he does. Before biting his lip so hard that it almost bled. He had no reason to be thinking such thoughts. Katsuki is just a partner and a growing friend, if he dares say.

Izuku sat at the lunch table with his friends, cheek resting on his palm, as he thinks. He’s been quiet throughout the day, and it was making his three other friends uneasy. The quartet came early to the cafeteria, settling down at their table that was too large for them. Ochaco had recapped what had happened to her mean cousin the other day at the mall, Shoto was once again complaining about his dad, and Iida just told them some interesting fact he picked up from the class he had just left.

“Midoriya, are you okay?” Shoto asked while stabbing his pork cutlet, “You’ve been staring out into space.”

Izuku blinked then shook his head yes, “Yeah! I’m okay. I guess I’m just thinking.”

“About?” Ochaco sipped on her strawberry milk.

The way Izuku blushed revealed enough, and Ochaco snorted, “Never mind. I know *who* you’re thinking about.”

“Midoriya, I can’t say pursuing Bakugo Katsuki is the best idea considering his reputation with romance,” Iida picked up the hint as well.

Izuku waved his hands in front of him, “No! You guys have got it all wrong!. I’m not pursuing him, and we’re n-not like that. We just hang out together like friends,” Izuku then added, “At the end of the day, someone else is keeping Kacchan company. He doesn’t see me like that.”

He dug into his katsudon, stuffing his cheeks full of food as he looks intently at his plate. He could tell his friends' lingering eyes on him.

"You sound jealo-" Ochaco began.

Izuku freaked for a second, almost exasperated, "I'm not jealous!"

And then, an unfamiliar addition to their lunch group spoke up, "Not jealous of what?"

Izuku turned his head to see that Denki Kaminari had sat down next to him, face equipped with a large electric smile and a pat on the back. But it wasn't just Denki.

Almost all of the vaulters started moving into their table, and since Izuku and all of his friends knew them pretty well, they were met with welcome. Katsuki sat two seats diagonal from him, and didn't really say any greeting to Izuku or any of his friends really, even though everyone else did. To be fair, Katsuki rarely ever talked to him in school.

Izuku turned his head to where the male pole vaulters usually ate their lunch, to see that the table has been occupied by what looked to be the school's county inspectors, who come once in a while to check the condition of everything and everyone.

And so instead, since Izuku and his friends' solely occupied a table with 10 seats, there were 6 left for some of the pole vaulters, and two just had to share seats.

"Sorry for the intrusion, guys," Kirishima smiled widely, "We got booted out of our table for today."

Shoto shrugged, "Don't say sorry. We're all buds."

Sero leaned over to look at Ochaco, "Uraraka! How's your flight lessons going? I've been seeing you post about it, and it looks really badass!" He laughed.

"I got to fly my first piston plane yesterday! It was amazing, and felt like I was defying gravity," She laughed, "My instructor said I did really good, and that she'll recommend me for an aviation university in Tokyo after graduation."

Izuku smiled as he listened to Ochaco then talk excitedly about it. He adored his friends, and truly did like when all of them came together like this to talk. It felt easier, now that he and Katsuki were not at each other's throats, but that didn't mean it wasn't slightly strange that everyone in their school at this point practically knew that they hung out, but would never see Katsuki nor Izuku interact with each other in school.

The conversation in the group was easy and boisterous. Izuku chimed in here and there, and everyone felt pretty comfortable as the lunch period continued. There was a lot of laughter, and it looked like everyone liked the new company.

Then, someone who hadn't talked yet piped up.

"So Midoriya," Kaito Sen suddenly calls out, fork digging into a strip of marinated steak, "How's badminton coming along? You play here and there with the Ise block rec team,

right?"

Izuku was a bit surprised that Kaito knew, since he was pretty lowkey about it. Katsuki lifted his head up from where he was eating and gave Kaito a funny look, which the vaulter ignored.

"Yeah! How did you know?" Izuku asked with a smile.

"I saw your name on the roster," Kaito scratched the back of his head shyly.

Izuku shrugged, "The season starts in the summer, but I really only play so that I can test out some of my hypotheses about some techniques and analyze movements."

"Oh really? Are you trying to go into sports medicine at university?" Kaito asked, curious.

"Ah…" Izuku tucked a stray hair behind his ear, "Well, my mom wants me to do something nearby, so I don't know."

"Hm, well," Kaito encouraged him, "If you ever have the time, I'd love to hear more about your analyses, as an athlete myself. Maybe over coffee or something?"

A coffee date. So normal, Izuku thought, then bit his tongue. It was supposed to be cute, and a traditional move. He hadn't even agreed yet, but he's already feeling hesitant. *Stop that, Izuku* , he told himself, *He's a nice person* .

Katsuki then enters their conversation to leave a quick remark, "Tch, if you want the nerd to talk your head off for hours, then sure. Fucking go for it."

Izuku found himself agreeing with Katsuki, and did feel kind of sorry about that. It seems as if he really does often talk forever to Katsuki when they were hanging out about random topics, including what new things in the realm of sports, particularly Katsuki's pole vault, that he is obsessed with or trying to figure out.

However, when he does this, the blonde would occasionally tell him to shut up, but ultimately, will listen and give him surprisingly great feedback. The athlete has even told Izuku some of his footwork techniques that he uses to gain more momentum. And so, even if Katsuki complains, Izuku doesn't truly believe he hates listening.

However, Kaito, not knowing this, turns to Katsuki and casually grins, "That's fine with me. Bakugo, unlike you, I care about what Midoriya has to say."

Suddenly, the tension at the table heightened, as everyone's body goes rigid at the slight jab at Bakugo Katsuki of all people. Kaito had said it with a full smile on his face, yet there was a condescending undertone. And Izuku suddenly felt a bit of panic. Looking over at Katsuki, the greenette notices that the blonde has now stopped eating and opted instead to give Kaito a look. He wasn't even glaring, and yet, Katsuki seemed as if his eyes were telling Kaito to not test him.

"Oh? So you want to play a white knight now?" Katsuki asked, with humor in his voice, which was almost even more patronizing than if he were to yell, "Talk to me when you work

up the fucking balls to talk more than a couple sentences to the shitty nerd instead of jacking off to him into a sock."

"Bakugo," Kirishima ushered from across the table, "Remember, it's just Kaito. He always does this."

"Kacchan," Izuku stammered, "You don't have t-"

But then Kaito decides to speak up again, "You know, the only reason Midoriya is even friends with you, if anyone can even call you guys that, is because you're good at vault. Without vault, you'd be nothing to him. Or to anyone. He's way too good to be friends with y-"

Izuku *now* felt insulted, "That's not true," The tension in the table shifted over to Izuku, who was trying really hard not to get angry, "Kaito, I don't appreciate you speaking for me. I'm right here. I'm not some dainty and delicate damsel in distress where you should feel the need to protect me. I can choose my own friends, so please don't ever say that again, not about me or about Kacchan."

At Izuku's slight outburst, Kaito then looked a bit embarrassed. Izuku could tell the table was now focused really hard on their food. Even Katsuki, who was no longer eating, didn't say anything, allowing Izuku to have his moment to talk, although he did look fairly annoyed.

Kaito after a moment then looked genuinely apologetic, "Sorry. I really didn't mean to."

Izuku relaxed his shoulders, "It's okay."

But Kaito palmed his temple, "Shit, I kind of fucked it up early on, didn't I. I just got a little angry."

Izuku shook his head and gave him a kind smile, "You didn't mess anything up. Kacchan makes everyone a little angry sometimes." He laughs.

"Watch it nerd," Katsuki pointed his utinsel at Izuku, "Remember that you can't drive, and I'm the one taking you to pick up that comic release."

Izuku apologized immediately, laughing as he did so, "Wait, wait! Give me one more chance."

"You still haven't massaged my feet for that ice cream," Katsuki joked.

Kaito sits there, watching their interactions, "Excuse me, what?"

"It's a fucking joke, Fuck Face. Calm down," Katsuki rolled his eyes.

And it surprised the table. The two of them making jokes? Of course they knew the two weren't on as bad terms as they used to be, but to see it in real life was something else.

After a good moment or two of recovering from the slight surprise, finally the table picked back up on the conversation again, avoiding any odd topics that could start an argument as much as possible. Meanwhile, Izuku, in his seat being relatively quiet now, was reeling over the fact that although a small detail, Katsuki didn't deny that they were friends. Of course, he was sure the blonde would never admit it either, but he sure didn't deny it. Victory number two? He wonders.

Katsuki had an excused leave from school after lunch for the rest of the day, for a sports editor from some big shot company wanted to capture some pictures and snag an interview of Katsuki to be featured in the new edition starring up and coming adult athletes. The blonde had mentioned it to him a couple of days ago, but when his seat was empty in their psychology class, Izuku still felt a little out of sorts.

He wonders at what point did he begin to crave the athlete's company when he wasn't there. That was a normal thing to feel with a friend, right? He didn't think too hard on the matter, or else, Izuku was afraid he'd come to a conclusion he's too scared to face.

It also felt odd to walk home adjacent to the practice track, and out of habit, stop to watch, only to find that Katsuki wasn't there. Of course, this happens relatively frequently. Katsuki was practically a star, and because of that, he was pulled out of school once every couple of weeks: he was wanted for sports articles, magazines, photoshoots, or maybe he had an away-tournament.

Either way, Izuku feels as if he knows two Katsuki's. The one that sneaks him out of his house to walk around a town square, who breaks into ice cream shops with him, who likes to blare 80s tracks in his ironically modern car. And the one who was recognized by many to be the future of the nation's pole vault team, a prodigy with more records and sports articles written about him since he was 14 than he can count, the playboy who can get practically anyone he wants.

Funnily enough, both Katsuki's felt unreachable to Izuku. The second for obvious reasons. And the first for the reason that everytime Izuku reaches out, no matter how close they seem to be getting or how much time they were spending with one another, he felt as if he'll be burned if he gets too close. Katsuki was a walking explosion, bound to burn him if he dares to get closer.

Izuku gets snapped out of his thoughts when the fence rattles, and for a second, the familiarity of the action makes him think it could have been Katsuki. However, he comes face to face for the second time that day with Kaito Sen, soaking in sweat and seeming as if he had just finished his warm ups and were waiting for his turn on the track again.

"Kaito?" Izuku asks, giving the taller boy a wave.

"That's my name," The athlete in question responded with a smile, "If you're looking for Bakugo, he's not here today."

Izuku nodded with a gentle smile, “I know.”

“That’s why you’re leaving, right?” Kaito let out a small laugh.

Izuku wasn’t exactly sure what to say to that, and settled with a, “I’m just a little tired.”

“Understandable,” Kaito nods, “School’s a drag.”

Izuku chuckles, “Sometimes.”

“Are you sure there isn’t a way I can make you stay?” Kaito asks lightheartedly, and Izuku laughs at the question.

He *was* truthfully a bit tired, so with an apologetic expression, the greenette simply replies, “Not today.”

“Then another day?” The taller male asks.

Izuku pretends to think hard on it and tells the other, “Maybe.”

Kaito pumps his fist, “I’ll hold you to that then.”

Izuku feels weird when he gets home. It was a mix of both tiredness and frustration, over reasons he wasn’t even entirely sure about. It was like he was heavy with all the odd emotions he’s been feeling the past couple days, and maybe even weeks. And today during lunch, the odd exchange between him, Kaito, and Katsuki left an odder feeling in his head, combined with the newfound insecurities about how he presents himself and his desirability.

He kept conversation with his mother short, but enough to satisfy her curiosity about how his day went. Stating he was exhausted, Izuku was excused to head up to his room to rest.

But rest didn’t come easy. Rather, Izuku found himself unable to stop thinking, about things he didn’t even want to think about. He thought about Kaito, how the athlete had good intentions, was nice and handsome, He was clearly interested in Izuku, yet the greenette couldn’t feel himself gravitating towards the guy.

He thought about his mother: how their relationship has been so off ever since he’s been going out more. The way she’d almost plead with him with her large eyes and pretend that he was abandoning her everytime he went out. The way she’d immediately quiet her voice and sigh, waiting for him to ask her what was wrong. And when he’d cave in and ask, she’d tell him ‘ *nothing.’*

And then, goddamnit, he thought of Katsuki. Katsuki, with his unachievable aura, with his ability to drag Izuku along everywhere and he’d never protest, with his pole vault. Izuku almost hated thinking about the blonde, because he knew the other probably wasn’t thinking

about him. Izuku feels almost embarrassed that he likely adds nothing to Katsuki's life, despite the other having added so much to his. But…

*But* . The way Katsuki tries too hard to hide his laugh at something Izuku would say, only to end up letting out later. The way Katsuki without a word make sure that he never gets too far away when they're doing something a bit sketchy. The way Katsuki would, without realizing it, be engaged in a conversation Izuku spurred on. Izuku didn't want to think he added nothing.

And then, there were those eyes. Those ruby eyes that always looked at him with irritation and challenge, those hands that would occasionally brush up against his waist when he'd walk past, those lips that would lean over and whisper something usually rude about a stranger in his ear.

Izuku felt his chest get hot, and as he laid on his bed, his fingers trailed up to his lips. Izuku felt the soft skin of his own lips, and wondered what they'd feel like raw and bruised after being on...No. *No, no no,* Izuku chanted to himself as he sat up suddenly. He was *not* going to think of Katsuki that way, someone who would never even look his way sexually. Izuku felt his heart race, and he breathed slowly to even it out.

Now that he thinks about it, he hasn't touched himself in a while. It wasn't that he didn't want to. Izuku thinks that deep down, it was because he was scared of what he'll find once he lets his imagination take over. And so, he's kept his pink sex toy in his drawer of underwear where he knows his mother won't rummage through for a bit now, not having used it. But as he remembers his tiredness and frustration, the 7 inch dildo seems tempting.

After all, masturbating is meant to release endorphins and lets you sleep faster afterwards, right? In a state of lust, Izuku digs through his drawer and fishes out the pink sex toy, shaped like a real dick with veins and all, and his face flushes even though he was in the privacy of his own room. He promised himself to think of *normal* sexy thoughts to get off, and not his own *friend* .

As he strips naked, clothes gathered on the ground, Izuku steps in front of his mirror and takes a moment to admire. His body was smooth, with genetically little hair, and nice legs. His thighs were pretty and thick, from both eating and never skipping leg day at the gym. The thighs then led up to a perfectly round ass, which shook prettily when he walked.

His shoulders were not wide, and his collarbones showed, but he was by no means princessy and delicate. His torso looked toned and he was strong. His body was a nice mix of masculine and feminine.

He avoided looking at his face, the babyish theme of it all. His hands ran up and down his body, exciting all of the sensitive nerves everywhere, until he was sufficiently turned on. He collapsed back on his bed, and brought himself into the moment.

The lamp in his room were dim, and the curtains on the window helped make it a bit moodier in the room, even though it was still light outside. Izuku closed his eyes, and dragged his fingers down his throat, over his nipples which have become hard from the nipping cold air, and down his flat stomach.

When he finally got around to inserting one finger soaked in lube to begin stretching himself, the greenette bit down on his bottom lip while suppressing a gasp. He was never one to be quiet, and usually, he would play music when he was touching himself. His hole was even more sensitive than usual, after a while of not being touched. It felt like all of his nerves were heightened, as his index fingers pushed through the tight ring of muscle, *Fuck* , he's definitely gotten tighter from being out of practice, but Izuku kept pushing.

His legs were spread wide on the bed, back a bit arched as he threw his head back while inserting another finger in. His tempo was slow enough, and he scissored his fingers out of impatience to get the stretching to go along quicker. He wanted something inside of him then and there, and patience never felt more like a virtue than now.

After the stinging pain dissipated, Izuku found himself panting and wanting more. He needed more. He hadn't even realized how sexually frustrated he's been feeling until now, when suddenly, it felt like two, then three, and four fingers wasn't enough.

With trembling hands, Izuku lubed up the pink dildo until it was slick enough, and positioned the silicone tip at his entrance. The greenette didn't bother going slow, and instead, in one go, shoved the entire toy inside. His eyes flew open at the sudden and sharp sensation, and his muscles contracted around the thick toy, making it feel even tighter. Rather than starting at a slow tempo, the boy began ramming it inside of his raw and pink hole. The sounds of the dildo going in and out of his juicing entrance was probably enough to reveal exactly what he was doing if his mother decided to go up the stairs. However, he could barely care.

He needed this so bad, and so he gave it to himself. With a hand on his cock, and the other pumping the toy in and out of him at a rapid speed, Izuku wanted to cry out in desire. And he kept going like that for a while, shamelessly on his freshly changed sheets.

And yet, it still didn't feel like it was enough. He wanted more: thicker, bigger, rougher. This dildo and his hands can only do so much. It wasn't enough. Izuku turns over so that his face was pushed up against the pillow and his ass was in the air. He had one arm reached over to the back, to fuck himself with the dildo as he bites into the pillow. He wanted more so badly.

Just then, a flash of Katsuki's fucking incredible physique flew through his brain in a moment of weakness. Izuku's mind fell down the gutter, because he just *knew* it was big. Probably much bigger than the dildo he had inside of him right now. He wonders if it was pink too, with veins running down the sides, and thick enough to not fit in his mouth.

Izuku found himself shoving the toy in rougher and deeper into him. Would Katsuki fuck him like this, or harder? He wonders what it'd feel like right now if there were rough, large hands on his hips, holding him down as he gets fucked into the mattress. Izuku finds his spot, and begins ramming into it like crazy. His knees wanted to collapse, and his lips were parted, drool collecting slightly on the pillow, and he probably looked absolutely filthy. And he felt filthy.

When he finally realized that at some point, in a moment of weakness, he had began to imagine Katsuki, it was too late and Izuku was well on his way to coming. He felt absolutely dirty: thinking of his friend like that, and embarrassed. He hadn't meant to. It had just slipped into his mind.

And soon enough, ribbons of cum soiled the sheets underneath him as he reached his peak. And without any energy to ride it out, Izuku drops the dildo onto the cum stained sheets and falls onto the bed, feeling the waves of orgasm wash over his body. He was panting, head still buried in the pillows, but his body was bare and laying sideways adjacent to where he had just came.

*Oh my god,* Izuku thought to himself, *Did I just do that.* And feelings of embarrassment, confusion, and guilt wanted to take over him, but so did feelings of exhaustion. This must have been his last straw, because instead of being a decent person and cleaning himself up, Izuku lazily pulls his blanket up to cover his bottom half and feels his eyelids getting heavy.

A thirty minute nap. That's all he'll allow himself, he promised, and then he'll get up, change the sheets, then clean himself up. Ideally, he'd do it right away, but he was just so *tired* . His hair was most definitely all rused, and beads of sweat still decorated his back, but he couldn't find the energy to care. As the world drifts farther away, all Izuku could do was promise he'll get up in thirty minutes.

Thinking back, he should have set an alarm. Because when Izuku *did* wake up, it was not the most ideal situation. In fact, when he woke up, rather than it being his body naturally wanting to get up or his mom knocking on his door, it was instead getting his forehead flicked.

Immediately, Izuku's eyes flew open and upon seeing someone who was definitely *not* his mom standing next to the bed, Izuku let out a yelp and bolted straight up in his bed with a scream. With incredibly quick reflexes, a hand goes to cover his mouth and Izuku snaps out of his post-nap daze to realize who it was.

Katsuki hovered above him, hands clutched over Izuku's mouth to prevent him from screaming, as he looked towards the locked door.

"Fucking hell, Deku," Katsuki growled, "Calm down."

Katsuki let go, and Izuku was quick to defend himself, "Kacchan! If you were sleeping and someone breaks into your room, you'd do the same!"

"No I wouldn't," Katsuki begged to differ.

"Yes you would," Izuku glanced over at the clock then. Holy shit, he'd been asleep for two hours. He turned back to Katsuki, "Speaking of, how'd you get in?"

Katsuki nodded towards Izuku's window, "I jogged here. And your window was cracked open."

"So you just…" Izuku blinked, "...broke in?"

"I'd say I invited myself in, but sure," Katsuki rolled his eyes, then looked down at Izuku's attire, or more so lack of one.

Izuku, then realizing that he was completely naked save for the blanket that was now barely covering his bottom half, panicked and grabbed at the blankets, pulling them up to cover his entire body. It wasn't that Katsuki hasn't seen his upper body before. He was just now shy, because although Katsuki didn't know the context of why he was naked, Izuku sure did. And the thought that he had came hard with Katsuki in his brain was mortifying and a topic he won't allow himself to indulge in.

That was the wrong move, because the moment his blankets got pulled up to cover him, on the sheets where his cum was still obviously there, revealed the thick pink dildo that he had up his ass just earlier.

Izuku's face could not be any more red than it was now. The dildo was still *clearly* very wet, and Katsuki wasted no time switching his gaze from Izuku's body down to the now revealed pink dildo. Izuku was mortified. Of course, he knew most people masturbate, but that doesn't mean he wants people, especially Katsuki, to *find* his dildo, much less used and uncleaned.

Wanting to disappear, Izuku reached for it.

But not before Katsuki swiped his hand away, one brow raised as he asked Izuku, "So you've been having fun, huh."

Izuku honestly did not know how to answer that, and his mouth parted and closed like a fish. His eyes begged for this conversation to be over.

And he settled with replying, "O-Obviously."

Katsuki then reached down to pick up the toy, with his whole hand, while it still had his cum on it and whatever leftover lube was there. And then, Katsuki turned it over and looked at the object.

"Kacchan!" Izuku's voice came out high-pitched, "Put that down! I haven't washed it yet. It still has…" His ears were tinged pink, "...stuff on it."

Katsuki ignores him, looking at the pink toy some more, before looking right at Izuku and tells him, "Obviously."

Katsuki's gaze was intense as it always was, and Izuku felt his tongue go dry as he came up with a way to escape to another country, "Can I...have it back?"

The blonde yet again ignores the request, "Fuck," Katsuki said almost breathy as if surprised, then looked over at Izuku's covered body, "You put this thing inside you?"

Izuku bit the inside of his cheek as he stared at his dildo, still wet, in Katsuki's grip, "I m-mean, that's the whole purpose, right?"

Katsuki nods to himself before asking, "This is good enough for you?"

"What?" Izuku asked, flustered, "It's fine."

“You telling me this shit is big enough for you? It’s a bit on the smaller end,” Katsuki sneered, “You don’t need something better?”

Izuku let out a small voice, “Small?” The thickness of his toy and the 7 inch length was by *no* means small, especially when the average penis was around 5 inches erect. And so, to think that Katsuki views 7 inches as small makes Izuku reel in disbelief.

“That’s what I said, shit nerd,” Katsuki then tosses Izuku his toy, “Anyways, go wash that and clean your sheets, you nasty bastard. I’ll be on the bean bag.”

Izuku first demands, “Hand me my clothes first, please.”

Grumbling, the athletes picks up Izuku’s clothes off the floor and tosses it at the greenette who slips into his clothes from underneath the sheets. Meanwhile, Katsuki cleaned off his own hands.

While Izuku was putting on new sheets, the greenette asked, “I forgot to ask! What are you doing here anyways?”

“Figured you’d miss me,” Katsuki leaned his head back on the chair, with a lazy grin, and grabbed a comic off of Izuku’s shelf.

Izuku tucked the new sheets and in a moment of curious confidence, turned to the blonde with a shy smile, “And what if I said I did?”

Katsuki looked at him with a raised brow, before huffing out a laugh, pulling himself up in the seat to lean on his elbows, “Well shit, I guess I’m here.”

Izuku laughed and bounced back on his clean bed, “How was your interview?”

Katsuki flipped through the pages of the comic, “Shitty as always. The fucker took forever too. I hate missing practice.”

The greenette leaned back on his arms, “If it makes you feel any better, Kacchan, I’ll buy the magazine edition when it comes out.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “Why would that make me feel better, nerd. What. You gonna put it on that shrine?” He nodded to the shelf.

Izuku felt slight embarrassment, “And what about it?”

The athlete chuckled, “You’re getting real bold for someone who has a shrine to me.”

“It’s not a shrine,” Izuku defended, “I told you, I needed somewhere to put the things. If you want to see a shrine, I have an All Might shrine in my closet for you to look at.”

Katsuki got up to check out the closet, “Have you ever seen old pics of Mr. Toshinori before he got all scrawny?”

“No?” Izuku frowned.

“They’re online,” Katsuki mentioned, “He used to be some type of fighter and body builder back in his hay days. The man kind of looked like All Might.”

Izuku was shocked, “I’m gonna search this up. You have to be lying.”

“Nope,” Katsuki shook his head as he stared at the figurine collection, “Go ahead.”

Izuku pulls out his phone to fact check the athlete.

Meanwhile, Katsuki closes the closet, “In all seriousness, I need you to catch me up on what I missed today in class.”

Izuku looked up and poked fun at the blonde, “Are you asking me for help?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “No. Consider this returning the favor for the time I helped you with physics.”

“Whatever you say, Kacchan,” Izuku said in a sing-song voice, chuckling to himself as he gets off the bed to fish for his notes.

And so, Izuku helps the athlete catch up on lessons for the next however long. Izuku’s window was still open, so there was a slight breeze coming in lifting up the curtains. Outside, the sky was getting much darker, as Izuku’s nap went way past overtime.

They had papers spread out on the floor, and Katsuki was on his stomach, elbows digging into the ground as he stared at his notebook in concentration. Izuku chewed on the edge of his pen as he waits for Katsuki to get each topic before moving on. It was surprisingly nice to see them do something so normal, staying in to go over lessons and watching Katsuki be serious in a context outside of vault. Inko had knocked on his door at one point, to which Izuku had told her that he was on the phone with Katsuki to talk about the lessons. Later on, Izuku had crept down to his kitchen and made some simple sandwiches, before bringing them up with some drinks for the two of them to munch on.

“If you leave any spills on my carpet, I’m gonna fight you,” Izuku warned, “Do you know how hard it is to get stains out of the carpet?”

“Of all people, you’re worried about *me* spilling something?” Katsuki almost looked offended.

“Yes,” Izuku spun a pen around his thumb, “Now back to work. Chop chop, Kacchan. We’re on social cognition.”

Katsuki reached over to flick him on the head, “Stop telling me what to do, Deku. I’ve been letting you get away with it too damn often.”

It was oddly domestic. They continued until the iconic Ise crickets could be heard outside, chirping its pretty song for the moon and stars to hear. Yet they were cooped up on the floor of this bedroom, with a warm lamp glow as light and the two of them getting distracted every fifteen minutes. Studying in a group is never a good idea. Katsuki was fairly concentrated. It was just Izuku who would wander off in different tangents while the athlete was trying to memorize some notes, which caused some scolding but no serious repemands.

And even when it looked like they were done, Katsuki wasn't leaving. Izuku didn't mind. The blonde turned on his back, spreading out like a 6 foot 4 inch starfish and looked up at Izuku's ceiling, listening to whatever it was that the greenette was saying.

"Oi, you mind if I stay for a little while longer?" Katsuki asked, "My old hag is having some guests over, and I really don't want to fucking play nice."

"Of course you can," Izuku nodded, "And since when do you ever play nice?"

Katsuki lifted his head slightly to give Izuku a look, "Have you fucking met my mother? She'll kill me if I don't act decent when she needs me to."

"Oh, so the great Bakugo Katsuki is afraid of something after all," Izuku poked him in the sides.

At this, Katsuki got up on his elbow and looked at Izuku, brows pulled together, "Say that again."

"Say what?" Izuku asked.

"My name," Katsuki repeats, "Say it again."

Izuku blushed, now realizing that he, probably for the first time in a long time, referred to the athlete by his real full name, to his face.

"Why?" He asked.

"Just do it," Katsuki told him.

"B-Bakugo K...Ka...." He had a hard time repeating the first name, which only now feels more intimate on his tongue as he thinks about it some more.

"Katsuki," The athlete finishes for him, still looking at Izuku with those piercing ruby eyes, "Say it. Katsuki."

Izuku wanted to look away. He wondered why the blonde wanted him to say it so bad, but he managed a small and soft, "Katsuki."

That would probably mark the first time he's said that name alone. Sure, he's had to clarify to others before who he was talking about when he says ' *Kacchan'* by saying the athlete's full name, but never has he just used the first name alone.

Although Katsuki was the one who told him to say it, the blonde still looked a bit startled when Izuku said his name and they held this odd sort of eye contact for another couple seconds, before Katsuki lays back on the ground again.

“That sounds fucking weird,” Katsuki remarks, even though Izuku thought he looked a little stunned over something seemingly small.

Izuku chuckles gently, “Doesn’t it?”

“I guess that stupid nickname you gave me fucking stuck,” Katsuki sneered, “You know how hard it is to explain to people who ‘Kacchan’ is?”

Izuku looked down at his hands, “I can stop if you want.” Izuku didn’t want to. He really didn’t want to.

Katsuki seemed like his answer was quick to form, “Nah. Keep it.”

Izuku felt some happiness bloom in his chest over that. And he leans back against his bed frame while sitting on the floor still, “Hey, you want to go to the ravene on Friday?”

Katsuki grabs a rubber ball from the floor and tosses it in the air, “Nah. I’m going to the lake-house party at Enic Lake,” Then looked over at Izuku, “Oi, ain’t one of your friends going to that too?”

“Yeah, Ochaco is,” Izuku nods.

Once in a while, some people in the school, mostly seniors and juniors, go to Enic Lake, and have a lake house party.

The funny part is that most of the party isn’t actually in the lake house, but rather, on the lake itself on the open water. Since most people in Ise owns a boat, considering that the town had just a ton of water-based activities, people would just bring their boats to an empty part of the lake and anchor it near each other until there is just a mass of 10 or more boats, touching and rocking against each other, close enough that people can hop from boat to boat like a damn trampoline park. Some boats were just simple pontoons or bass boats, while others had larger cabin cruisers or even a small yacht. Izuku’s seen videos and pictures from these parties, but like most events, he’s never actually been.

“And you’re not going?” Katsuki inquired.

Izuku shrugged, “I’d just have to sit through an excruciating conversation to get permission, but we’ll see.”

“You can’t just sneak out or something?” Katsuki suggested.

“I could,” Izuku finds it funny how he doesn’t freak out that much over the notion anymore, “But I think I’d be a lot less paranoid if I just asked for permission, and I’ll just tell my mom I’m going to sleep over at Ochaco’s house or something.”

Katsuki gave him a look, “And she finds no problem with you sleeping over at a chick’s house?”

“I mean, she won’t like me staying out at all, but,” Izuku laughs, “She knows I like boys, Kacchan. It’s not like she thinks I’m going to do anything.”

Katsuki hummed in acknowledgement, “Right. Well, get your ass out of the house on Friday and have some goddamn fun.”

Izuku rubbed his arms shyly, “I hope you don’t just see me as some charity case, Kacchan. I don’t mind staying in sometimes.”

Katsuki ran a hand through his own hair, “That’s not what I- Fuck. That’s not what I fucking meant.”

Izuku frowned but nods, before laughing airily, “We’ll see, okay? Either way,” He looked off to the side, “It’s not like you talk to me in public anyways.”

To that, Katsuki says nothing. And they leave the conversation where it is.

The topic switches, and they settle into more comfortable discussion about this and that as time wanes by. Soon enough, Izuku was pretty sure it’d be 10 P.M. soon, but he is still sitting there on the floor talking. Although, the greenette could begin to hear Katsuki’s words slurring, as his responses become slower and slower. Katsuki was getting tired, he could tell, and laying on the floor like that, the blonde was bound to fall asleep.

It took another ten or so minutes, but when Katsuki stopped replying, Izuku stupidly grinned to himself at how peaceful and innocent Katsuki looked when he was sleeping. The green eyed boy sat there with his knees up for another two minutes or so, taking out his phone to document a picture for their project proof. These days, they hung out a fair bit, so they’d have to force a reminder to take pictures for proof to turn in to Mr. Toshinori. Izuku thinks his teacher will appreciate this photo of Katsuki sleeping with his arms and legs sprawled all over his floor.

After another moment, Izuku got up, legs going slightly numb, and grabbed some extra blankets and a pillow out of the closet and went over to crouch where Katsuki was. Careful to raise his head, Izuku slipped the pillow under and then covered the blonde in some fleece blankets, before going to turn the light off. Stepping quietly into the bathroom, Izuku does his nightly routines and brushed his teeth before climbing into bed himself.

He thought about how precious this moment was going to be to him in the future. It was like their sleepovers when they were little all over again. Katsuki was sprawled out on the floor, and he was in his bed, after hours of talking and trying to get work done. This was nice. And perfectly friendly. He didn’t even remember the fact that he had came to the thought of Katsuki just hours prior.

When Wednesday came around, Izuku was laying in his mother's room, just hanging out with her as they usually did. The things Izuku does with his mother are usually either domestic and very quaint. Inko Midoriya was a mellow person, who enjoys being comfortable more than she enjoys being excited. Who prefers a dish she's eaten a million times and knows is good over anything new and unpredictable. Her hobbies include taking care of their garden, working, hanging out with Izuku, cooking, and making Sunday afternoon runs to the farmer's market to see what cool items they have.

And so, much of the things Izuku does with his mother were rather simplistic in nature: hanging out on the couch or in her room, cooking together, picking blueberries at the farm once in a while, going to bookshops, manicuring the garden. And he doesn't generally mind. Sometimes, life is meant to be taken slow.

But he didn't realized how much he needed change until Katsuki had come along. But not all things have to change.

Izuku still enjoys moments like this current one, where he lays in his mother's bed, and Inko sits above him, stroking his hair like when he was young, and they talk about all sorts of quaint things.

Izuku tells her about his times at school or something cool that he's picked up. And she'd tell him stories from work: snobby customers, sweet ones, entitled kids, humble travellers. She told him how a couple days ago, this man in his mid-20s threw a fit and had broken one of her items. She said she wasn't mad, but simply dealt with the man and done what he had asked so that he can leave her shop quickly.

Inko has always taught him to be kind, caring, and grateful, which were all wonderful traits that he is thankful for. And Izuku could see that she practices what she preaches, for he truly believed his mother was kind at heart. The way she went about things was odd and her treatment of him can be disagreeable, but Izuku was always in a state of confusion when it came to her.

She was a mix of reasonable and unreasonable. Paranoia and understanding. Kindness and condescending. When she spoke with sweet words that tasted like nectar, Izuku couldn't tell sometimes if it was genuine or if she was trying to guilt trip him.

"So Izuku," Inko teased while poking him, "Do you have the hots for Katsuki?"

Izuku whipped his head around and looked at her appalled, "Mom!"

"What!" Inko kindly laughed, "I was just asking. So is that a yes or a no?"

Izuku settled back into his spot, feeling strange as he says, "No, I don't like him like that."

"You look at him as if you like him like that," Inko countered.

Izuku gives her a sly look, "And how exactly do I look at him?"

Inko raised her head to watch the fan spin, before dramatically going into speech mode, “As if you could talk to him for hours, and still dream of his voice when you sleep. As if you could have white diamonds in front of you, and still prefer the ruby of his eyes.”

Izuku for some reason felt his heart tug at the statements. And felt embarrassed to realize that he probably did prefer rubies over diamonds, and that he most definitely had Katsuki in his dreams here and there.

But he playfully threw a pillow at his mother, “If I didn’t know any better, Mom, I’d think *you* liked Kacchan.” He teased.

Inko pinched his nose, “Oh I adore him, ‘Zuku. He’s so tall, handsome, smart, and athletic.”

“Everyone else thinks that too,” Izuku pouted unintentionally, “But we’re...just friends.”

Inko hummed, “Hm, well you know what they say. Love is friendship that has caught on fire.”

Izuku noted that quote in his head. How interesting. The conversation topic shifts quickly, thank god, because he wasn’t sure how much longer he was able to hold off before his mind does some deeper thinking into the matter. They lay there for a while, Inko playing with his fringe while she talks.

“Hey mom,” Izuku said while playing with some loose strings on the fabric of his blanket, “Can I sleep over at Ochaco’s on Friday?”

Inko still played with his hair, but she as usual goes quiet and pretends to think about it, even though Izuku knew that if she had her way, she’d have one answer prepared for everything he could ever ask for. Izuku’s heart was beating. It was silly that he was 18, about to graduate, and his heart would still beat out of nervousness when asking his mother to leave the house. No wonder Katsuki thought he was still naive. He bit his lip at the thought.

“If you’re going to sleep anyways, why not just sleep at home?” Inko asks him gently.

Izuku shrugged, “Because it’s more fun, you know?”

“You can’t have fun here?” Inko questions him, and Izuku knows this marks the beginning of the emotional guilt tripping, “You’ve been going out a lot lately.”

“I know…” Izuku’s voice is quiet, “You’ve told me.” Several times, “And I do have fun here. You know I love being with you, mom. I just want to hang out with my friends since it’s our last year together in Ise.”

“It’s also *our* last year together, ‘Zuku,” Inko pursed her lips.

Izuku turned his head back to look at his mother and smiled, “Mom, aren’t you the one who wants me to stay near after high school? Why do you change your words when it fits what you want?”

At this, Inko's eyes widened, as she had realized what he meant. And her hands stopped playing with his hair, as if she had gone stiff and then accused him with the soft voice that he almost hated hearing in moments like this, "Izuku, why do you always make me out to be some evil person?"

Izuku was confused, "I'm not, mom. And I'm going out more these days because I'm 18. And everyone is allowed to do things, and I'm barely even allowed to driv-"

"You're not everyone, Izuku," Inko coos to him, "You're special. You're my baby, Izuku." The boy sighed. They've had the same conversation over and over again, "Mom, don't you think every mother on Earth thinks that about their child? That they're special?"

Inko goes silent at this, and leans her head back against the headboard of her bed, "Why do we have to argue so much lately? I hate it, 'Zuku. Getting angry is never good for anything."

Izuku closes his eyes and says softly, "I know. I don't want to either."

After a couple more moments of silence, Inko sounded reluctant, "You can go. To Ochaco's. But I need to put it out there that I like how we were before...all of this started. I liked that much more."

Izuku then sat up, happy that he got permission but sad at the final remark, "Mom, why do you have to say things like that? It makes me feel like you're only happy when I'm doing everything that you want and being exactly who you want me to be."

*Like a lap dog* , Izuku thinks back to what Katsuki had said before.

Inko looks at him shocked, as if hurt, "Why would you say that, Izuku? I want the best for you, that's all."

"I know! Gosh, I know," Izuku looked frustrated as he runs his hands over his face, " *Everything* you do is because you're worried, I *know* , Mom."

"Izuku," Inko's tone was both pleasant but subtly warning, "Please calm down. You're getting angry. We don't need to be like that."

Izuku closed his eyes and breathed, deep breaths, before looking anywhere but her, "I'm sorry."

"It's alright," She said carefully, "Here, go wash your hands and we can prepare dinner together."

Izuku didn't want to. He didn't want to eat right now. Victories never feel like victories with his mother, and he just wanted to go up to his room, sneak out, and do something that'll take his mind off. But Katsuki was busy, his friends rarely initiate anymore because of how afraid they were of his mother, and all he had were the four walls of his bedroom. He wanted to cry.

On Thursday, Izuku brings the cherry gatorade again and sits off to the side watching Katsuki jump. Izuku personally hated the flavor despite liking cherries, but he knew it was the athlete's favorite. When they were little, Katsuki probably drank more of the sports drink than he did water.

Ever since Izuku began coming on Thursdays for solo practice, he's brought one with him for the blonde. And Katsuki would wordlessly drink it, and Izuku liked that fact. In a way, he felt as if it symbolizes Katsuki accepting his presence and accepting his care slowly.

The blonde was getting a consistent 17'10 at this point, but he'd fail to clear 17'11 every time. And in the world of competitive sports where people won by the slightest margins, even one inch makes the biggest difference. If it was true what his coach had said about another athlete in the Adult division his age already clearing 18'2, then Katsuki was going to lose. Izuku could tell there was something odd with the way Katsuki would approach the bar, but he couldn't pinpoint what it was.

They don't really talk to each at practice. For Izuku, it was a bit of a respect thing: he needed to allow Katsuki full concentration. And so, he'd just watch silently until he had to be home. That was enough for him.

"Ochaco, can you help me look less..." Izuku sat on the edge of her bed that Friday around 5PM, "...babyish?"

The lake party started at 7PM, but it would probably take a while to get ready, not to mention, Ochaco had to drive down to the lake marina, and get her family's pontoon boat out of the dock slot.

Ochaco, who was currently laying out dresses on the bed, looked over to him, "Why? You're already cute."

"It's not that I don't like how I look," Izuku cups his cheeks, "I just...think that I dress and look kind of naive all the time. It'd be fun to look a little bit more mature for once."

Ochaco nods and then narrows her eyes, "That makes sense, but tell me, where did this come from? You've never really thought twice about your appearance before. Even when you began working out, it was because you wanted to get strong."

"Is that a bad thing?" Izuku asked genuinely, "To think about your appearance? That's not shallow is it?"

"No, of course not," Ochaco replied while bringing up a black dress to her body, "If it was, then why would I bother trying to look hot tonight? Izuku, as long as we understand that appearance isn't all that matters, then it's perfectly okay to care what we look like. Or to not care. It's all about personal choice."

“Right!” Izuku laid back, “I think I was wondering more about my own sex appeal.”

“What do you mean?” She sat with him and asked.

Izuku’s head thought back to what Katsuki said about moving aside and letting the adults play. Although it was a joke, Izuku still knew that for many people, they probably could never see Izuku in a sexual manner.

“I feel like it’s hard for others to imagine me mature in, you know, *that* way,” Izuku shyly said, “Because of how I look and act.”

Ochaco thought about it, “I don’t think that’s true. But I would say that people *do* generally see you as the town’s sweetheart and everyone’s brother, be it younger or older.”

“See? That’s what I mean!” Izuku threw his hands up, “I just want to be sexy for once.” He laughs at how ridiculous he sounded.

“Ohh,” Ochaco then nodded, “I get it. You’re having a little coming of age movie moment here,” She waves her hands around, “Where you’re embracing your sexual side and letting go of your innocence.”

“Don’t talk like that! It’s creepy,” Izuku giggled, “But yeah. I’ve been thinking about it a lot lately. I don’t know why.” He *does* know why.

“In that case,” Ochaco whips out a brush, “I will help!”

The first thing Ochaco does is mess up his hair some more, as if it wasn’t already messed up. When asked why, the brunette says that it makes him look a bit sexier, as if he just rolled out of bed after a one night stand, to which Izuk laughed at her tactics.

She then asked a question that made Izuku halt.

“Do you, um,” Ochaco began, “Want to cover up your freckles?”

Izuku looked over to the vanity mirror, and touches his cheeks gently, “My freckles?”

“Yeah, it’s up to you,” She said.

Covering up Izuku’s freckles was different from just putting on different clothes, or applying a bit of blush to his cheeks. Izuku felt conflicted, because he knew they made him look younger, but he’s always secretly liked them. He wonders how far he’ll go and how much that he actually liked about himself would disappear in this process.

Izuku knew this was definitely not an every day thing, because he was comfortable in his day to day attire for the most part, but still. He thinks back to the people he’s seen Katsuki take home before. Their skin was always flawless, not a blemish, not a single mole. They were all beautiful.

*Wait* , he stops and asks himself why he thought of Katsuki and the people he fucked. That had nothing to do with him. But Izuku would be lying if he didn’t accredit his recent thoughts

about his appearance to the blonde. He wasn't sure if it was a good thing or a bad thing, but he knew that the line between how much he was doing this because he wanted to fit Katsuki's standards and how much was because he genuinely wanted to look more desirable from time to time is getting really blurred.

Because Izuku knew he should want to change to someone else's desires, but he was beginning to confuse himself. So shoving all thoughts away, Izuku gave her the thumbs up.

"Go ahead."

When they entered the marina, Izuku stepped out of Ochaco's 2018 Honda Civic feeling and looking completely different than what he was used to. And yet, he didn't feel like he was forcing himself to be someone he's not. If this was every day, then he'd feel suffocated. But Izuku thinks that dressing up and appealing to his sexual side once in a while can be very empowering.

His hair was rused up, and his skin looked flawless, not that he ever considered his freckles a flaw.

He had stared at himself shocked in the mirror after Ochaco had done his makeup. His freckles were gone, and he immediately look more mature. The contouring helped with his ankles, and lifted both his cheeks and eyebrows. He had a light pink gloss painted on his lips, a faint blush, and basic makeup that made it look like he barely had any on. Glitter sparkled near his undereye and that was it.

But it was truly his outfit that was completely out of his usual attire. Since it was a lake party on boats, most everyone will be in swimwear or clothes that can easily be taken off to reveal swimwear. Even Ochaco was wearing a sheer black mesh slip on top of a golden bikini underneath. All she had to do was take the see through mesh slip off, and she'd be ready to swim.

Izuku wore a silver necklace that spilled across his chest with little thin bands ending in tiny crystal arrowheads. It was not too flashy, and a nice touch in the center of his chest. The silver was real, so it wouldn't smell upon touching water if he decides to swim with it on. He had a sheer white buttoned shirt that was two times his size and made of airy chiffon fabric, and everyone could definitely see through the fabric like glass.

He only buttoned the middle button, leaving the top part of his chest and bottom part of his abdomen relatively exposed with every puff of wind that would blow the light fabric. The left sleeve kept falling off of his shoulder, so at times, he would forget about pulling it up. And underneath the oversized 'shirt,' Izuku wore a pair of skin tight black spandex swim shorts that began at his hips, hugged his perfect ass together, and ended right below where his ass and thighs met. It was borderline underwear, but damn did he look good.

And on his right leg was a silver thigh chain that wrapped around his thighs in a teardrop formation that sparkled with crystals every time he walked. He had been told not to bring shoes because he wouldn't need them on a boat anyways, so that was that.

Ochaco drove the pontoon at 40 mph on the water, and on their way, they saw a couple others who were headed towards the part of the lake where the party was hosted too.

This wasn't going to be like the Kick-Off. This was a full on party, with alcohol, smokes, blaring music, and those classic teenage party vibes except they were on the lake, which was so much better. The party was going to last until morning, most likely.

Izuku knew Katsuki didn't smoke or participate in any drugs at all. Partly because he didn't want to kill his performance, and partly because as an athlete, he gets drug tested before practically any event. And if there is even a trace of any substance, he's done for. And even when it came to alcohol, Katsuki didn't drink too much either. Not only is his tolerance high, but he didn't like the feeling all that much.

Izuku, however, didn't care for any of those rules. He's taken hits out of wax pens before, but didn't like the feeling, so he never indulged in it again. Alcohol was a once in a while thing, since he didn't go to parties much. When he does, he usually had to go home, so it was only a can or two of beer or seltzer for him. But tonight, he could stay at the party until morning if he wanted to, so he didn't have any restrictions, not that he wanted to get shitfaced or anything.

The sun was setting behind them, as they rode through the smooth lake water. Around the lake were all tall trees blooming green, and everyone was beginning to turn on both their internal and external boat lights. As they approached the site, Izuku began to hear the music.

Summer Lovers by Michael Sambello. This was definitely a more lowkey track, but fit the mood well, with the upbeat atmosphere of the lake party. Plenty of people were already there, with about 11 or so boats all anchored near each other. If anyone in the middle of the flock needed to go home early, they were shit out of luck because then everyone would have to unanchor themselves.

And so, anyone who came had to practically stay until others began leaving. The smart ones who couldn't go all night chose to come later so that their boat was anchored on the outside of the mass. Or others just anchored their boats far away in general and swam the distance before climbing onto someone else's boat.

It was a whole wild mess, but Izuku and Ochaco both were excited already. The music was playing from ridiculously loud speakers on someone's bass boat that had been dedicated to be the music boat. There were people everywhere. Some were swimming in the water off to the side. Others were mingling and boat-hopping to talk to others. Some were situated on a deck somewhere drinking and laughing.

Some rowdier people climbed to the second floor of this two-tiered boat and dived into the water off of it. Others danced to the music with a bottle of pink whitney in her hands or a beer. The sun was setting quick, and the vibes were only beginning. The boats would rock together everytime someone would jump from one to another, but people got the hang of it after some time. They were from Ise after all. All of these teens grew up boating.

Ochaco anchored their pontoon on the outskirts, dropping it into the water, and the people adjacent to them yelled a cheer upon seeing Ochaco's and Izuku's familiar faces, giving them

both high fives and helping them connect their boats together. Izuku was immediately bombarded with a ton of comments, everyone excited and shocked at how different he looked.

“Damn Midoriya!” Kohima from his physics class commented from high up another boat, a beer in his hand. He yelled, “You look great! I mean, you look great before, but you look great in a different way now!”

Izuku laughed and yelled back, “That was my goal!”

A more familiar face, Tsuyu Asui, was swimming in the lake nearby in her cute green bikini set, “Uraraka, Midoriya! Come swim!”

Ochaco waved to her, “Hey Asui! I’ll come swim later! I think me and Izuku are going to grab ourselves a drink first.”

Although Ochaco was driving the boat, they both agreed to at least stay out all night and stop drinking by midnight so that their bodies will have at least a couple hours to flush the alcohol out of their system. Unless one of them gets blacked out, then they didn’t really have a plan.

Hopping a couple boats and after talking to some people, they managed to find some people situated around a cooler, who waved them over excitedly.

Tokoyami clapped, “What’s good, guys? What do y’all want. We got beers, liquors, and all kinds of stuff. I recommend some absynth. That is some dark stuff right there, really lets you meet the devil.”

Ochaco gave him a high five and laughed, “Tokoyami, you’re always saying some dark things. Can we just get some malts to start? We don’t want to go heavy right away.”

“Sure thing,” The dark haired boy said before grabbing some malt liquor with 15% ABV from the cooler and tossing it to them.

Izuku grabbed it, and cracked it open, taking a small sip to begin. He wasn’t the type to get drunk easily, or even tipsy.

He had a fair amount of muscle, a good metabolism, and genetically, it just took him a fair amount, so he wasn’t worried about getting wasted right away. The liquid was bitter, and honestly disgusting, but people rarely drink alcohol for the taste.

Ochaco grabbed him by the arm then led him onto another larger boat nearby where some people were dancing, and they both got pulled into the crowd. Yelling the lyrics to transparent soul by willow, a relatively modern song, Izuku bounced up and down on his feet and felt himself with his left arm which wasn’t holding the drink.

He got approached about three times by different people, but Izuku couldn’t find himself holding a long enough conversation, especially when they clearly wanted to fuck. The

greenette had definitely accomplished emitting a different kind of energy than he usually did, because he felt good about himself and every boat he went to in order to greet a friend was surprised.

They just enjoyed themselves for a while, and sipped slowly while hanging out and dancing here and there. The sky was dark now, save for the boat lights which was more than enough, and it felt like the night was beginning.

When he climbs onto a larger decked boat, with nice lights and plenty of familiar faces, Izuku reaches out to help Ochaco over. On this deck, Izuku sees Mina, Kirishima, Denki, Sero, and a couple of other familiar faces, and so, he assumes that soon, he'd be seeing-

Fuck. It was as if he manifested it then and there. Because coming up from the bottom deck, the objectively most attractive blonde Izuku's ever seen in the form of Bakugo Katsuki came walking up, carrying a crate of seltzers. The blonde had a sharks tooth necklace around his neck, but other than that, a simple white tee and a pair of swim trunks, yet he looked so fucking good even if Izuku feels like he's seen a similar rendition of this outfit on Katsuki before.

"Here ya go, extras," Katsuki announced as he approached the group from behind and threw the crate on top of a table, "Go ahead and poison your livers."

Denki laughed, "You know you'll have one sooner or later."

Mina Ashido then whistled from a distance, causing Izuku to get his head back in the game, "Is that Midoriya and Uraraka?" She borderline screamed.

It caused Kirishima to turn and look around, slightly wobbling and shouting, "What? Where! My precious sweet Midoriya and Ura- Holy Fuck!" Kirishima spotted the two of them and yelled, "Holy shit. You guys don't look so sweet anymore, damn!"

"Jesus," Denki's eyes bugged out, "What happened to *you* , Midoriya?"

Izuku laughed, "Ochaco worked her magic on me," and the two of them made their way over.

Izuku caught Katsuki's eye as he walked over, and he didn't look too long afraid that he'd come off as trying too hard to gauge the other's reaction. But in the couple seconds they met each other's eye, Izuku could barely tell what Katsuki was thinking, only that those eyes most definitely trailed him. Before looking away, face not revealing too much.

Izuku saw enough in his peripheral to notice Katsuki cracked his neck, muttered something to himself along the lines of *fuck* , and then opened a bottle, bringing the seltzer to his lips and downing it in gulps.

"Izuku," Ochaco reached for one, "Are you finished with the malt? I'll crack us open a seltzer."

Izuku shook his head, a bit shy now at the odd reaction from Katsuki, “No, I still have a bit left.”

The music was still playing loud, and they sat in the leather cushioned chairs on the pontoon, and more people came to their little group. Everyone was just talking and having a good time, and the atmosphere was nice. People were still swimming, or dancing, or just doing what people at parties do.

At the moment, they were going around to tell dumb stories about what happens when a certain person gets drunk, and Izuku laughed a lot. He did notice however, that a majority of the time, unless he was speaking, the blonde didn’t really look at him.

And at some point, they played a game once more people came to the group and wanted to do something fun. It was a simple party game. It starts at someone random, and the person on their *left* gets to ask an intrusive question. It’ll usually be something weird, or sexual, or really anything random. If the person who’s ‘it’ answers, they move onto the next person. If they refuse to answer, then the person on their *right* gets to choose a punishment.

The game started with a person Izuku didn’t recognize, and the person on the stranger’s left had asked him if he loved his mother or his father more. It was funny, because the guy had quickly answered his mother, and moved onto the next person without a fuss.

Mina was next. And the stranger from before asked her a much more invasive question: “Who was the last person you hooked up with?” And after thinking about for a second, Mina’s eyes went wide and she tapped the leg of Shoto, who had just arrived, on her right. Izuku hadn’t even known his friend was coming.

“I’m not answering that,” She giggled, “Give me a punishment, Todoroki.”

Shoto thought about it for a moment, “In full clothing, jump off the boat right now.”

With a groan, Mina hauled herself up and turned around, spreading her arms out before falling purposely off the boat. Moments later, they heard a splash and then Mina’s cursing once she resurfaced. They continued the game once she climbed back on.

And they went around like this for a while, it getting funnier and funnier. Sometimes, it was sexual, as teenage party games tended to me. Other times, it was plain stupid. When it was Katsuki’s turn, he answered his question easily

“If you had to fuck everyone playing right now in order of most enjoyable to least enjoyable, where would I rank?” Kirishima asked while laughing.

Katsuki looked around and sneered, “Literally last. Dead last on the list, Shitty Hair.”

The group laughed at that, and Kiri took it well, pretending to sob. Izuku found himself chuckling too, amused knowing that if nothing else, he wasn’t last on that list.

After a couple more rounds, it came around to Izuku, and Sero, who was on his left, thought long and hard.

“Hm, what should I ask to expose sweet Midoriya,” He ponders and then laughs, clapping his hands, “I got it.”

Izuku grins, “What is it?”

“Midoriya Izuku,” He announced, “Who was the last person you’ve masturbated to?”

His grin immediately fell and his eyes widened. *Oh no* . That was *not* a question he wanted to answer. Hell, he barely faced the facts. In no world was he going to announce to this group, with Bakugo Katsuki in it, that the last person he’s done that to was sitting *right there* . He felt everyone waiting for his reply.

Without missing a beat, Izuku taps Ochaco, “Punishment please.” His eyes pleading.

The group *oohed* at his secrecy.

Tsuyu, who had climbed up to join the game, piped up, “Now you just made us more curious.”

Izuku chuckled nervously, “Well, um, too bad. Sorry to disappoint guys. That’s a little personal.”

Ochaco, thinking she had a great idea, jumped up to reveal the punishment, “One person, no, two people, have to spit alcohol in your mouth. And hard liquor too, after they swish it around.”

Izuku gaped at her, “I thought we were friends.”

“We are!” Ochaco frowned.

“I hope you know that when it’s your turn, I’m going to get you back,” Izuku warns playfully.

Ochaco turned towards the group, “Any volunteers?”

A member of the school’s soccer team, who went by Ren, got up from his seat. Izuku looked up at him. They’ve only talked a handful of times, but he’s always remembered Ren to be pretty nice to him. He was handsome, with dark grey hair and a nice face.

“Bet,” Ren grabbed a bottle of whiskey, “I’ll do it.”

Izuku blinked, “A-are you sure?”

Ren shrugged as if it was nothing, “Yeah, why not?”

Before bringing the bottle up to his lips, taking a gulp before leaving it in his mouth, and walked over to where Izuku was sitting. The greenette’s face was pink and this was definitely out of his element, but he scooted forward and tilted his head up, opening his mouth.

Ren leaned in relatively close, until they were about six inches apart, and then let the alcohol run from his lips into Izuku's mouth. The whiskey burned going down, and he shuddered as the last drop leaves the soccer player's mouth and Ren backs away. He heard cheers from the side at the display, and he hides his face, still feeling the burn of the whiskey. Ren just gave him a grin and went back to his seat.

"One more person!" Ochaco demanded, "Someone volunteer, or else I'll blindly point!"

She barely waits three seconds, before deciding that's what she'll do.

"1? 2? 3? Okay, no volunteers?" Ochaco rushed through her counting then closes her eyes and stands up, spinning and holding her pointer finger out, "I guess I'll blindly point!"

And when she opened here eyes, Izuku knew right away that the girl was peeking once her finger landed on Katsuki. She had definitely been peeking, and Izuku internally panics because there's no way Katsuki would do that.

And it'll be embarrassing if he's rejected like this, even though it's just a game, and Izuku find himself going on a mental rampage and he's mumbling to himself at such a rapid rate that he barely notices movement.

It was only when Katsuki gets up off his seat without a word and reaches for a bottle of strawberry vodka that Izuku stares wide eyed. The athlete unscrews the cap, not looking at him, before tilting his head back to take a massive gulp. The group cheered.

Holding the liquor in his mouth, Katsuki then turned towards him, walking forward until Izuku was sitting between his way. Izuku's eyes were still wide. The blonde's gaze was excruciating, and Katsuki puts one large hand on his jaw while the other used the thumb to pry open Izuku's mouth.

Feeling Katsuki's thick fingers at his lips, pushing for entrance, had him opening his mouth while tilting his head up towards the other.

The blonde then leaned down, much closer than where Ren had been, until they were probably an inch away from touching, and Katsuki then released the vodka into Izuku's mouth. It was a steady stream, and Izuku felt heated under all of the touching. Katsuki's hands on his jaw, the other keeping his mouth open, the proximity of his lips as the alcohol fell from it into Izuku's throat. Izuku definitely could not imagine this was going to happen to him tonight.

When Katsuki let go of the last drop, the blonde leaned his head over until he was right next to Izuku's ear, and issued a command in his deep voice, "Now swallow, nerd."

Izuku did so. And the heat in his throat from the vodka was not the only heat pooling in his body. When Katsuki moved back, his red eyes looked almost dazed, but he turned away and walked back to his seat as the group gaped at their incredibly tension filled interaction.

Katsuki collapses back on his chair, and doesn't think another second about it, while Izuku had to take a good minute before he could resume the game and ask Ochaco her question. For the rest of the game, Izuku's mind could not stop going back to the scene. The touches, those words, that expression. He felt flustered, but he couldnt stop thinking about it.

And when the game went around one whole time, they wanted to play again, but Izuku went to excuse himself. A couple others wanted to go off somewhere else too, but Ochaco stayed behind to play around round.

Stretching as he got up, Izuku moved his way through the group until he was out of the vicinity and then down onto another boat. He continued what he was doing before to clear his mind of how much he secretly enjoyed that whole performance, going from boat to boat to talk to friends or meet new people. He was asked by several more people if they could get him a drink. He had told them not now, and went on until he was at the fringe of the boats.

Unsure of what to do here, he was about to leave, before he heard a familiar voice.

"Oi Deku," Katsuki shouted from the boat below this taller one.

Izuku stepped over and looked down, "Kacchan?"

"Who the fuck else," The blonde rolled his eyes, "I'm about to swim. You gonna get in, or are you just gonna stand off in the distance like a loser."

Izuku stuck his tongue out at the athlete, then climbed down onto the shorter boat until he was next to the athlete, "I'll get in."

Katsuki stripped his shirt off until he was just in his swim shorts, "Oi, wait. Are you sober enough to swim?"

Izuku nodded, "Yeah, I don't get drunk very easily. Thank you for worrying though!"

"I wasn't," Katsuki stood off, as Izuku slides out of the sheer shirt easily, "I just didn't want to be liable for your death, nerd."

Izuku doesn't believe it and smiled with his eyes, "Sure, Kacchan." Before pushing the blonde in with a splash, and Katsuki flopped on his stomach.

When Katsuki rose to the surface, wet hair and all, Izuku jumped up and down on the boat laughing and pointing, "I finally got you back! Who's the boss now?"

And then Izuku jumped in himself, feeling the warmer lake water surrounding him. His body jewelry was still on, and when he opened his eyes underwater, the silver shimmered. Most of the boats had bright blue underlights that lit up the water a couple feet underneath them. The light would reflect back onto the sides of the white boats, creating watery light patterns.

He broke the surface with a gasp and treaded water.

Katsuki kicked him under the water, "You're a bitch, Deku."

“You did it first!” Izuku cackled, “This is just the natural order of life. It’s payback.”

The blonde then began swimming away and towards the underside of one of the larger boats, so that he could get the lighting from the water. The light patterns rippled on Katsuki’s face.

“This is something, huh,” Katsuki nodded his head to the lake party.

Izuku shook his head yes, “Yeah! I’ve never been to one before, so this is really fun. I didn’t expect there to be so many people though.”

“It gets more crowded every year,” Katsuki commented, “The cops know there’s underaged drinking, but none of them care. No one’s ever gotten hurt here.”

“Really?” Izuku looks skeptical, “There’s people jumping off boats while drunk.”

Katsuki, limbs getting sick of treading water, then holds on the boat hook underneath the cruiser, that’s usually attached to a trailer that pulls the boat on land. Meanwhile, Izuku continued to tread water.

“There’s always a sober friend in a group to be on the look out,” Katsuki shrugged.

Izuku hummed in acknowledgement.

“So,” Katsuki grinned, “You convinced Auntie to let you go.”

Izuku groaned, “Don’t even talk about that. Thinking back on the conversation makes my head hurt.”

“That bad, huh,” The athlete commented.

“It could have been worse,” Izuku admitted, trying to think positively.

“Also could’ve been better,” Katsuki countered, “Is she expecting you to come home early or some shit?”

Izuku shook his head, “No, she thinks I’m sleeping over at Ochaco’s,” Then he laughs, “Imagine if I show up at home 3 in the morning with that outfit on and my breath reeking of alcohol. I’d never see the light of day again.”

Katsuki considered that, “So it was Round Face’s idea, huh.”

“What was?” Izuku asked, “Oh, the outfit? It was my idea. She just brought it to life.”

“Your idea?” Katsuki raised a brow, “And what brought on that, huh?”

Izuku, instead of answering that question, decides to redirect the topic, “Kacchan, it’s a little unfair that you get to hold onto the boat hook, and I’m stuck treading water. My arms are tired too, you know.”

“Then come here,” Katsuki told him, “Hold onto me, nerd.”

Izuku blinked, “Huh?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes and reached one arm out until it hooked around Izuku’s waist, and pulled him closer through the water. Moving his arm down, Katsuki moved Izuku’s legs so that they rested around Katsuki’s torso, allowing the water buoyancy to hold him up. Izuku, shy, held onto Katsuki’s shoulders as his legs were now wrapped around the blonde’s waist. Katsuki continued to hold onto the boat hook with his left arm, and his right arm held Izuku in place.

“You’re not afraid of a little proximity, are you Deku?” Katsuki asked with a sneer, “I don’t fucking bite.”

Yes. Yes he was afraid. But Izuku didn’t want to move, “Yes you do,” He argued, “Remember when we were four, and you bit me when we were playing vampires? You were supposed to *pretend* bite me, not *actually* bite me.”

“Oh give me a break,” Katsuki groaned, “It was a tiny bite!”

“Tiny?” Izuku looked incredulous, “I have a *scar* .”

“You’re fucking lying,” Katsuki accused, “Show me.”

Izuku raised his left arm and pointed at a bump on his inner forearm, “See? Right there.”

“Deku, that’s literally a mosquito bite,” Katsuki deadpanned.

“It’s literally not,” Izuku retorted.

“Yes it is,” He insisted, “There’s no way I left a scar. You’re being fucking overdramatic. Auntie would have killed me. I wouldn’t be here right now if I had left a scar. That’s my proof. Where’s yours?”

Izuku was this close to dunking Katsuki’s head underwater, “You were a feral child, Kacchan, do you remember that? It’s not exactly out of character for you to have bi-”

“Your freckles,” Katsuki suddenly interrupted, eyes scanning his face intently, “Where are they.”

“Huh?” Izuku then brought a hand up to his face, feeling his skin, before remembering, “Oh, my freckles?”

“Yeah, where the fuck did they go,” Katsuki brought his free hand that was holding Izuku in place up to cup Izuku’s cheek while his thumb rubbed at his skin roughly, pushing some of the makeup away. But Ochaco’s waterproof setting spray was impossible to get rid of.

Izuku squirmed out of his hand, “Kacchan, stop that. You’ll rub off the foundation. Ochaco worked hard on it,” He said.

“She covered them up?” Katsuki’s brows furrowed.

Izuku nodded, suddenly looking away and into the lit up water underneath them.

Katsuki raised a brow, “And you let her?”

The boy in question just shrugged, “Yeah.”

“Why.” Katsuki inquired.

“Because,” Izuku tried to play it cool, “I don’t know. They kind of make me look...childish.”

Katsuki looked at him skeptically, “Since when did you care about how you looked.”

Izuku frowned, “Why can’t I?”

“You can,” Katsuki then asks, “Is this about what I said the other day?”

“No!’ Izuku exclaimed, unsure if he was telling the truth, “It’s not.”

“Then why,” Katsuki seemed persistent.

Izuku shrugged, not really wanting to get into the converstion.

Katsuki pursed his lips then said, “Oi, just tell me. Do you like your freckles?”

Izuku doesn’t understand why they’re having a conversation about his freckles, but he purses his lips. Of course he does. He’s always liked them. And so he tells the truth, “Yeah.”

“Then don’t cover them up,” Katsuki stated clearly.

Izuku’s eyes went big, before he laughed to himself, “You almost sound like you miss them.”

Katsuki flicked him on the forehead with a dripping hand, “And if I say that I did, would you wipe your face off?”

Izuku smiled softly, “You wouldn’t ever say anything like that.”

“But if I did,” Katsuki repeats, “Would you?”

“Who knows,” Izuku said, waiting to play with Katsuki’s wet hair, “Maybe if you said it really nicely.”

“Really now,” Katsuki quirked a brow.

Izuku laughed, shrugging his shoulders.

And then he heard footsteps and the sound of some of Katsuki’s friends’ voices coming closer. He listened, and it sounded like Kirishima and Mina.

Hearing them too, Katsuki taps on Izuku's arm and told him, "Alright, climb off."

Izuku pursed his lips, before letting go and sliding back into the water, going back to treading.

Katsuki then swims towards the boat that they had jumped off from, and climbed onto the deck, shaking his hair to get the water out. His friends then spotted them and went towards the tall male. Izuku watched from the water, trying not to take it to heart that once his friends were around, Katsuki didn't really want to be seen near him. He tries not to let it hurt him, but he couldn't help but feel a sting. Katsuki had no problem treating his other friends like...well...friends, in public. So why was it so hard to treat *him* like a friend in front of others. After all, everyone knew they hung out.

Kirishima spots him in the water, and calls out, "Midoriya! You swimming by yourself?" Izuku let out a small smile and nodded, "Yeah, the water feels nice! I think I'll stay in here for a little while longer."

Kiri and Mina understood, wishing him a good time, before they called Katsuki along. Right before the blonde turned around, Izuku caught his eye, and the greenette made it a point to look away fast.

And so he swims by himself for a little while longer, stopping to hold onto something here and there while his arm rests. The water felt warm, and the bright blue glow was beautiful. He plans on getting back to the more centralized part of the lake party soon, but first, he wanted to just kind of sit there and take it all in. Aside from small things, he was pretty happy. He couldn't prove that Katsuki swam away because he didn't want to be seen with Izuku. Maybe he had just wanted to catch up with his friends. After all, Katsuki had literally spit in his mouth not too long ago in front of a group of people. And so, Izuku lets himself relax and enjoy it. He thinks about what the blonde said, about his freckles, and for a moment there, he felt himself being filled with this useless sense of joy at the fact that Katsuki might as well have told Izuku that he liked his freckles.

After a bit, Izuku climbs up on deck and just throws the sheer shirt on over his clothes, before hopping boats again towards where there was more people. Once again, he takes his time, stopping to talk to friends and catch up. He even sat with some of his badminton buddied and caught for a while, having a fun time. He caught Ochaco at one point dancing with a group of people on deck, and joined her briefly before sitting down somewhere.

He was by himself, swinging his legs off of the edge for a moment, before someone plopped down next to him.

He turned to the side, and came face to face with the Ren guy from earlier.

"Hey."

Izuku smiled and waved at him, "Hey Ren."

"Are you good?" He asked, "You're just kind of sitting by yourself, looking off," He laughed.

“No, I’m fine!” Izuku assured him, “I’m just taking in the moment.”

Ren nodded, “Earlier...that didn’t make you uncomfortable or anything, did it?”

“Oh no,” Izuku shook his head, “It’s just a game. Thank you for asking though. Even retrospectively,” He giggles.

Ren smiled kindly, “Can I get you a drink? Sorry to be so frank, but I’ve been eying you all night.”

Izuku looked over, surprised at the frankness, and he couldn’t really bring himself to say yes because of the connotation, but instead, offers, “Not right now. But,” He smiled, “You can walk me around?”

Ren nodded to himself then got up, extending a hand, “I can do that.”

And so they walked around, hopping boats, which was a fun activity in of itself. Ren was a nice person, who expressed his attraction to Izuku pretty soon, and the greenette wonders if this is how a hookup starts. Do they just hang out a little bit, before going for it? Either way, Izuku just wanted to walk around and chat for a little bit. Their conversation wasn’t anything special, but it was nice to catch up with an old classmate. Ren wasn’t shy about lingering his hands on Izuku’s waist or whispering something in his ear here and there. At some point, it seemed like the boy was going to shoot his shot.

“I’m not going to lie, Midoriya,” Ren turned to him at one point and got a bit close, “My cabin cruiser’s nearby. There’s a private captain’s quarters in there that I’d really,” He took a step closer, “like to show you, if you know what I mean.”

Izuku looked up at him, eyes blinking fast. A habit he’s developed when someone says something that caught him off guard. Ren’s been touchy with him and obviously flirtacious, making inuendos here and there so it shouldn’t be a surprise. But as someone with relatively little experience, Izuku wasn’t sure on how to act. He’s kissed like two people, and gave half-ass hand jobs before during his experimenting phase, and probably one blowjob; however, considering that he was never allowed to go out much, Izuku wasn’t given the opportunity to go further. And he barely felt any intimate connection with Ren, but then again, did he need to?

A cheer erupts from a boat adjacent to them, interrupting their conversation, and both Ren and Izuku turned to see what the commotion was. Turns out, it was merely a game of cup pong that was being played, with a good crowd around them. Kirishima and Mina were there, which means that if he hadn’t strayed of, then Katsuki would be with them too. And that’s when he spots the blonde.

Currently playing was this boy named Juzuo and up against a girl Izuku recognized to be Kimi from the school’s volleyball team. She was all legs, beautiful with almond eyes and full lips. Her slightly wavy brown hair reached the small of her back, and she had the cutest smile. Izuku always thought she was nice. A little on the wild side, but nice regardless. But that wasn’t what Izuku found himself focusing on. What he was focusing on the hand on her

waist that belonged to Katsuki. He shouldn't be surprised at this point, because this was what Katsuki was known for. And yet, Izuku felt those familiar gut pulls again, like his stomach was curling in on itself.

She picked up a ping pong ball, and got into position, before shooting it into the cup, making the opponent drink and ultimately winning. The crowd cheered, and Kimi jumped up, letting out a happy shout, before turning to Katsuki, and jumping up into his arms. He caught her easily, as if his large arms were meant to hold something as delicate as her, and lifted her up. She then leaned then to kiss him, and Katsuki returns the favor, getting into it right then and there.

Izuku remembers the time when the other girl from the kick-off, Sara, had came onto Katsuki. Although Izuku was curious as he always was, he wasn't feeling what he was feeling *now* . Then, he had been able to tell himself that it wasn't his business and walked away. But now? Now, he was entering a different turf. For a bit now, Izuku's been feeling these weird tugs in his chest every time he'd overhear something like this. But when he was standing just a boat away, watching it happen with his own eyes, seeing Katsuki's lips in an intense lock with someone elses, the sensation was incomparable.

Izuku panicked. He wasn't supposed to be feeling like this. He's been able to ignore it and brush it aside before, but now, it was coming on full force. Like he was sick to his stomach, and the twisting just wouldn't go away. He couldn't look away. Katsuki set her down, but continued to kiss her as the crowd cheered around him. Izuku looked down at his feet then, chest feeling like it was out of breath, and he wanted this feeling to go away.

And now, he couldn't deny it. He couldn't reject what it was, like he's been doing all of this time. The feeling slapped him in the face, and made him feel ashamed. Heat travelled up to his face as embarassment took over. He was so stupid. How could he let himself act so stupid. He couldn't pretend it wasn't there.

Jealousy. Izuku was jealous. And he hated that he was *feeling* jealous in the first place, because Katsuki wasn't his. And he didn't like the blonde like that, he thought. He fucking thought. But then, the athletes storms his way into Izuku's life and-. No, that didn't have to mean anything, Izuku told himself. He didn't like Katsuki like that, or at least, he didn't *want* to like Katsuki like that. Because that would have been a recipe for disaster. Because Katsuki didn't like people. Katsuki fucks whoever he wanted, and shoves them away if they seem to catch feelings. Katsuki purposely chose to keep himself emotionally isolated, and would not hesitate to drop anyone--even a friend--if they pry a little too hard into his emotional shell. Katsuki would never feel the same. Therefore, Izuku couldn't. Izuku *shouldn't* be feeling this way. He shouldn't be jealous, because that would be assuming that he wanted Katsuki. And that simply cannot happen.

Izuku rejects the notion. This can't happen. It won't happen.

"Midoriya?" Ren calls him from the side, hand on his shoulder, "Are you alright?"

This snaps Izuku back into the moment, and he looked over to the taller boy. He needed to get rid of this feeling. It isn't real, and he could make it go away if he tried hard enough.

“How about that drink?” Izuku asked, a hint of desparation in his voice.

But Ren didn’t catch any of it. Instead, the boy’s eyes lit up and he smirked, “Let’s go get us a drink then.”

It was more like several drinks. Because Izuku didn’t care how high his tolerance to alcohol was, he was going to get rid of this feeling. Izuku took a shot of hard liquor. Ren was right beside him, on someone’s bar they had set up on the boat. The liquid burned his throat going down, but he asked for another anyways.

Some people were nearby, and were shouting shots around them. When another one reaches his hand, Ren hooked arms with him and they both tilted it back at the same time. This one burnt less, because higher alcohol contents eventually numb your throat when it goes down.

“Another one,” Izuku demanded.

The girl in charge of pouring the shots looked at him carefully, “Are you sure? They hit quick. You probably can take it slow now.”

“Another one,” Izuku tried again, and she gave it to him. And he threw it back. Ren did the same.

The reason shots hit stronger and faster than anything else is because of two things: the ABV of the liquor used, and the speed of consumption. The quicker a person consumes alcohol, the more saturated their blood alcohol content becomes, and the more drunk they’ll get. However, genetics and body weight plays an important factor, so with Izuku sturdy figure and Ren’s athletic build, they didn’t get shitfaced immediately. And so, at his fourth shot, Izuku was feeling much looser, tinglier, his thought a bit more impaired. And he was giggling to himself, eyes a bit hooded.

Ren looked to be close to out of it too, leaning closer and swaying to the music drunkenly before whispering to him, “God, you look so sexy right now.”

Izuku giggled, the feeling he had before definitely gone now, “Do I?”

Ren brought a hand up to his chin and asked, “So how about that... trip to the captain’s quarters?”

Izuku covered his hand over the other’s and closed his eyes, “Sounds good to me…” He was slightly slurring, but was cognitive enough to walk.

Ren reached down to kiss him, and Izuku kissed back. The people around them saw it, but since both of them were drunk, didn’t think too much of it. Ren took him by the wrist and began leading the other off of some boats towards the left side of the party area. Izuku had a much slower time hopping on and off of cruisers, but when he made it into the captain’s quarters, partially surrounded by glass but had enough opague wood panels to cover half of the quarters, Izuku was pushed up and onto a drawer, his legs pushed open as Ren slots himself in between and continues to make out with the greenette. Sensations while drunk are dulled, and so you’d have to act a little bit more desparate.

Izuku wasn't sure where his head was at, but it wasn't on Katsuki, that was for sure.

Meanwhile, word was going around that Midoriya Izuku was wasted as hell, and seemed to be headed off somewhere with the soccer player Ren. No one was judging him for it or anything, just cheering him on since it was rare that anyone would see the usually safe-playing town sweetheart do anything risque. That being said, there was still the concerns of what Ren and Izuku could be doing, considering that they were both drunk.

"You know Midoriya?" Someone asks.

"Yeah, what about him?" Another person replies.

"Apparently, he's drunk as hell right now. Like, completely wasted on shots. He was going wild with it at the bar with Ren, the one from the soccer team?" They was recapping, "Anyways, they were making out, before the two went into Ren's captain's quarters together and-"

The rest of the conversation wasn't relavant, because to a certain blonde athlete who was standing in a group nearby to where the conversation was happening, that was all he needed to hear.

Izuku felt lips everywhere. Although his clothes were still on, he felt lips trailing his neck, his chest, his stomach. In his dazed state, he didn't care. He just wanted to feel any sensation besides the horrible one he felt earlier. Ren's arms were wrapped around his waist, the soccer player was standing between his spread legs, hard on rubbing up against Izuku's spandex swim trunks. He knew that the other was drunk as well, judging from the sloppiness of his actions. But Izuku could barely mind that at the moment.

He didn't know how long they were making out like that. They were so close to taking it one step closer. Ren slid Izuku's sheer shirt off easily, and grabbed at his thighs, kissing him sloppily as he does so. Ren then steps back, and undoes the buttons of his shorts before pulling the smaller back in to make out.

Breathing into his mouth, Izuku hears the other tell him, "You want to go further?"

His back was pressed up against the wood panel, and his legs were wrapped around Ren's waist. The boy in question kisses him again, and runs his hands through the messy green locks for about a minute before the door was flung open.

Suddenly, a cool breeze whips through the room, and everything that happens next went by ridiculously fast. A person who Izuku could recognize anywhere by the signature voice, hair,

eyes, build, everything comes slamming the door open, and makes his way to the two of them in the split second before throwing a punch square in Ren's jaw. And he fell to the floor.

"I'll fucking kill you," Katsuki's voice was terrifyingly normal tone, as if he had this deep rage that it didn't even make him shout, and he lifts Ren up by the shirt collar, "You hear me? I'll fucking kill you."

"Woah woah! Bakugo," Kirishima shouts after him, and a crowd forms outside of the entrance of the quarters, "Calm down!"

Katsuki ignores him and continues threatening Ren, "The stupid fucking nerd is drunk as shit, and you want to fuck him? Zip up your pants, you piece of shit. I'll break your legs if you don't get out of my sight right fucking now."

Ren looks terrified as he slurs, "But...what...I'm…" He could barely make out what the guy was saying.

Kirishima from the back, forces Katsuki back, "Bakugo. Fuck. Listen! The dude is drunk too. Ren is drunk too. Neither of them can consent, it's not just Midoriya. So calm the hell down, you're losing your shit!"

Katsuki, upon hearing that, looks over at the guy on the floor, clutching his jaw, and turns to Kirishima, "Why the fuck didn't you tell me before I beat the shit out of them?"

"I thought you knew!" Kirishima threw his hands up, "I thought you'd just go pull them apart or something so they both don't end up doing something they didn't want. I didn't think that you'd fucking try to break his jaw. Jesus, Bakugo. What the fuck?"

Katsuki stares at him for a second, incredulous, before telling the red head, "Take care of this son of a bitch. I'll deal with Deku."

"No offense," Kirishima started, "But I'm not sure most people here would trust you to deal with Midoriya."

Katsuki took a step towards Izuku, who was sitting confused on the ledge still, before turning, "What the fuck does that suppose to mean, Shitty Hair?"

Kirishima sounded a bit nervous. And the chattering of people outside watching the commotion didn't help.

"It's just that you guys aren't known to get along, even if you do hang out for the project...and I feel like someone who actually cares for him would be able to help him better," Kirishima confessed his thoughts on the matter.

And Katsuki's face was just blank. Nothing revealed itself.

From behind them, Denki scooted through the crowd to try and ease the tension, "Hey, maybe we can take care of Midoriya and you can just-"

Katsuki turned back around and walked over to Izuku, warning, “No one is fucking touching him. Do it, and I’ll break your damn hand,” And he turned towards them, “And trust me, as a pole vaulter, you’re going to need your wrists.”

Katsuki grabs the shirt off the ledge and drapes it over Izuku’s shoulders, buttoning it up slightly.

“Kacchan?” Izuku’s eyes focused, and he definitely knew what had been happening. He just couldn’t think much about it.

“The one and only,” Katsuki told him, focused as he checks for Izuku’s dilated pupils, “Can you walk?”

Izuku nodded slowly, “I can walk. Why’d you do that? Just...now.” He says slowly.

Katsuki brings him down to the ground, “Because, you should never fucking make those kind of decisions when you’re wasted.”

Izuku giggled, “But I can when I’m sober?”

Katsuki leads him out of the quarters, ignoring everyone’s stares, “I don’t give a shit who you fuck when you’re sober. But I’m not letting you do that kind of shit drunk, you hear me?”

Izuku complains, “Okay, I get it, but why does it have to be you who came.”

Katsuki turned to look back as they walked, “You wanted it to be someone else, nerd?”

In his delirious state, Izuku admits quietly, “Anyone else.”

“And why’s that,” Katsuki humored.

Izuku brings a finger to his lips and shh, “Can’t tell you.”

“I didn’t really care anyways,” Katsuki shrugged, “I came, so shut the fuck up and you can thank me when you’re sober.”

Izuku pouts, “You’re unfair.”

“And you’re stupid as shit right now,” Katsuki retorted, “I’m not listening to a word you say, so keep walking.”

“Where...are we going?” Izuku looked around, as Katsuki helps him on and off boats until they get to one on the quieter side. A white speedboat named Grand Torino.

“Home,” Katsuki replies curtly.

“Home?” Izuku, even in his dazed state panicked, “B-But my mom. She’ll k-”

“Not yours,” Katsuki barked, “Mine. The old hag ain’t home.”

Izuku's lips wobbled, "But Kacchan. I don't want you to miss the party. And it's not a school night either, so you can stay as long as you would have wanted."

Katsuki was quiet at this, and then as he begins driving away, tells Izuku, "I didn't care for it anyways."

When they got back on land, Izuku could walk pretty well to Katsuki's car after he docked the boat. The blonde had given them some food to eat and some water to drink in order to get the alcohol out of his system faster. And the ride back to Katsuki's house was mellow. There was some soft music playing, but Izuku's head was slumped against the head rest, while Katsuki was uncharacteristically quiet.

"What are you…thinking about?" Izuku asked. At this point, the deliriousness is out of his system and now he just feels slowed down.

Katsuki didn't look like he was going to reply for a while, but ultimately let out a, "Something somebody said."

"Hey, those words all started with an 's'," Izuku pointed out, laughing.

Katsuki tched, "Very observant."

But Izuku was cognitive enough to get back on track, asking softly, "And it bothered you?"

Katsuki shifted uncomfortable in his seat, and Izuku even could tell that he might be entering into some territory that Katsuki will keep him out of.

"I don't know," Katsuki replied, and weirdly enough, Izuku could tell he was speaking the truth.

"Oh," Izuku replied, not sure what to say to that. But he wonders what it is, and wishes he could delve into Katsuki's mind and figure it out. Yet Katsuki's point of view always felt closed off to him.

Katsuki then asked, "Thought you didn't get drunk easily, huh Deku."

"I don't," Izuku admits.

"Then why tonight?" Katsuki pulls up into his driveway. Izuku hasn't been here in years, and now, he shows up dead in the night and with a fairly high BAC.

Izuku tries to form coherant sentences, but then gave up. Letting out a quiet, "I had a bad reaction to seeing something. It was my fault, really."

Katsuki raised a brow at this, "What'd you see."

Izuku smiles but it doesn't reaches his eyes, before speaking, mimicking Katsuki's previous words, "Something somebody did."

Chapter End Notes

AHH i wanted to post on Sunday, but Monday night it is!
I'm going to reply to everyone's comments soon, bc they make me so happy, but I hope this chapter was okay I finished half of it today so I didn't have time to edit it :/ <3
i abs cannot wait to write the next chap.

# Chapter 6: The Airfield

Chapter Notes

32.6k words (i put the WC in case anyone is busy!)
i love how when I began the outline for this fic, I was like 'this will finish w/ 100k'
Also picks up near the end bahdasd
Spotify playlist: https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku wakes up to the sound of thumping, every couple of minutes. At first, it wasn't enough to stir him awake, but after the tenth one or so, the slight disruption caused Izuku's eyes to flutter open. He was immediately disoriented because this was not his room. And the silk sheets underneath him weren't his. This wasn't his bed, either. He looked around, experiencing a bit of vertigo from the confusion.

Before memories from the previous night came rushing back: the boat party, the swimming, the little fiasco with Katsuki and Kimi, drinking with Ren, the captain's quarters, and then the whole debacle of what happened afterwards when Katsuki had stormed in. Izuku's cheeks flushed at the thought, and he sat up, touching his chest, trying to force his emotions to not go berserk like it did the previous night.

He remembered his acceptance of his jealousy. That didn't mean he accepted his feelings. You can be jealous without actually liking someone, right? Izuku tried to justify to himself, even though it made no sense. He remembered watching the scene of Katsuki and Kimi unfold before his eyes, and that terrible twisted feeling in his stomach. Izuku pushed that down. Now was *not* the time to be harboring anything towards Katsuki.

He was expecting his head to feel worse than it did.

However, he overall felt fine. He was grateful for Katsuki having made him drink water and eaten food the previous night on their way to back to the blonde's home, for the alcohol was digested decently well into his system.

Izuku scanned the the room, and it looked to be a guest room, with creme colored walls and matching furnishings. On the nightstand, a glass of water and a painkiller was laid out, and Izuku felt a flutter of tenderness in his chest at the thought that Katsuki has a wordless way of showing care, even if he'll say any excuse to claim he didn't. Izuku takes the pill in case a headache ensues later, and slid himself off of the bed to see where the thumping sound came from.

Retrospectively, he felt a little strange about having to be taken care of, and the fact that Katsuki had left the party because of him, especially after everything that went down. Although his damp swim shorts were still on, Katsuki had changed him out of the wet shirt, taken the jewelry off, and gave him a black t-shirt instead. Izuku checked his phone to see several text messages and calls from his friends. The words overwhelmed him, as he saw names popping up from so many people, and he set the device down.

Izuku walked towards the window, which filtered in a beautiful hazy morning light into the already warm-toned room, and peered out.

The Bakugo family home had a large backyard, with a manicured green lawn in the middle. The fence was lined with trees, and it overall looked very clean. And in the middle of the green lawn was a pole vault practice set up. The last time Izuku had been here was so long ago, but he knew this was put in place probably when Katsuki began pole vaulting. Katsuki had poured cement onto part of the lawn, so that they could have a permanent pole vault pit set up. There was no track, but instead, just grass. Which meant that after practicing on grass, he'll be even faster on a track field.

The back pad was industrial grade, as well as the bases. The base was currently set at 17'11, and the blonde himself was there. This was so far, the highest bar Katsuki had attempted.

The thumping Izuku had awoken to earlier was Katsuki's pole hitting the vault box to launch him into the air. The greenette leaned against the window seal, and watched. The athlete began his run, pole correctly positioned in his hand, and then when he was in distance, hit the box with his pole and was airborne in seconds. And right as he reached the peak, Katsuki let go.

He didn't clear it. The blonde fell correctly onto his back, and wasted no time getting up, setting up the bar again, and going back into start position.

And then repeated it again. And again. And again. Izuku watched with awe. He has watched Katsuki from the moment the athlete began his sport, and yet, seeing the dedication and passion inside the boy still stunned him.

Many things about Katsuki can be disagreeable, disheartening, and off-putting. Izuku's confusing feelings of jealousy and flutters can be one of them. The greenette still cannot figure it out, or at least cannot admit to himself what was going on. His brain was in shambles.

But something that will remind Izuku every single time, of why he looked up to this man, was watching Katsuki fail again, and again, and again, and still get up to practice another round. Pole vault is the only place where Izuku has seen Katsuki vulnerable, even if it's not explicit, because it takes a lot to fall in front of others and get up again to fail another round. Maybe it was because Katsuki knew eventually, he'll be able to clear it. The blonde will never talk about it, or show his reaction to his failures to others, but Izuku still sees it. If he truly didn't care, then Katsuki would not have made it as far as he had in the sport.

Izuku stands and watches for a while, until at one point, he sees the blonde fall on the mat to his knees and his head tilted up, staring at the bar. A frustrated expression was on his face,

and Katsuki wiped the sweat off of his brow before taking a deep breath.

Frowning, Izuku suddenly felt the urge to come down there and encourage the other.

Whenever Katsuki doesn't clear a bar at practice and there's people watching, he plays it off well. He gets up immediately, resets it, and it looks like it doesn't bother him.

Suddenly, Izuku felt like he was invading on a private moment, because it's the first time that he sees Katsuki look clearly upset at repeated failure. He doesn't show this emotion when people are around.

With a heavy heart at the sight of Katsuki's frustration, the greenette found his way out of the bedroom and down the stairs. For not having came over for a long time, Izuku is surprised that he still walks around the Bakugo home as if he remembered every crevice. The stairs winded down to the living room, and Izuku walked his way towards the kitchen, where he knew there was a door that led to the back.

When he approached, there was someone in the kitchen. Tall, slender, and blonde, Mitsuki Bakugo stood in the kitchen pouring a cup of coffee. Izuku has seen her a couple times, when she's come over to his mother's house, but they were never alone in the same room. Katsuki had mentioned the previous night that his mother wasn't home, which meant that Mitsuki must have gotten back from some kind of business trip this morning.

"Izuku?" Mitsuki had noticed the greenette coming down the stairs, "Good morning!"

Izuku smiled and waved, "Good morning, Aunt Mitsuki!"

"Would you like a cup of coffee?" The woman asked, and Izuku nodded. She fished out another mug from the cabinet. Izuku decides that he'll sit for a couple minutes, and pulls out a bar stool from underneath the granite kitchen island.

"How have you been?" Izuku asks, genuinely curious. Mitsuki always had a strong aura everywhere she went, for her voice carried, her attitude was reasonable but firm, and she made everyone in every room respect her.

"I've been doing well, Izuku. Thank you for asking," She smiled with her eyes, as she slides over a cup of coffee chocked full of creamer and sugar for Izuku, "I remember when you were tiny, Inko would never let you drink coffee, but when you came over, you'd stare at me over the counter with those big adorable eyes and I'd give you a tiny little sip," She recalls, "But now, you're all grown up and handsome, aren't you?" She winks.

Izuku shyly scratches the back of his head, "I'm alright."

Mitsuki shakes his head, "You're too humble, Izuku. Have a little more confidence in yourself. I would have thought being around Katsuki all the time these days would rub off on you."

"It does," Izuku laughs, "But I don't think I'll be anything near his level of confidence no matter how much time I spend with him."

Mitsuki chuckles at that, “I suppose not. But really, you’ve grown up beautifully,” She smiles, “Inko’s always around when I’m over, so I haven’t had the opportunity to tell you that personally.”

Izuku was flattered as he sips from his mug, “Thank you, Aunt Mitsuki!”
“It’s no problem,” She replied then curiously joked, “I’m surprised Katsuki hadn’t made a move yet, considering how much he insisted that he will marry you when he was younger.”

Izuku was surprised at this and cackled, “You can’t be serious!”
“Oh I am,” She rolled her eyes at the memory, “The little brat would talk my ear off day and night about it. It was always *‘Zuku* this, or ‘ *Zuku* that. He was ready to propose then and there at the age of 4.”

The green eyed boy couldn’t stop laughing at this. Although he knew any sentiment of that was gone by now, it was nice to think that the child version of Katsuki wasn’t repulsed by him. He also could not remember the last time the athlete had referred to him by anything other than Deku and other nicknames.

“Honestly, knowing me, I would have said yes back then,” Izuku joked.

Mitsuki snorted, and took a large gulp of her coffee, “I don’t know what happened between you two, but I’m happy for this,” She gestured, “project. You’re a good influence on him.”

Izuku looked out the slightly opened blinds to the backyard and smiled, “He’s a horrible influence on me.”

Mitsuki shook her head with a grin at this, “Knowing how Inko is, you probably need some of it.”
At this, Izuku was reminded of what Katsuki had told him once, when they were on their way to Dolly. Izuku had called him crazy, to which the athlete had then told him that he probably needed some of it. He thinks it’s funny how Katsuki talked a little like his mother. If that’s indicative of anything, then maybe the blonde will mellow out over the years.

Izuku then hops off of the barstool, “Thank you for the coffee! I think I’m going to go out there and see how he’s doing,” Izuku then frowned a bit, “He seems a little frustrated.”

Mitsuki grabs the dirty mug to place in the sink, “Eh, I wouldn’t do that if I were you.”
“Hm?” Izuku looked over at her in confusion.

Her red eyes looked up at his, “If you’re right and he *is* frustrated, then Katsuki’s not going to want you to see, much less try to help.”

Izuku pursed his lips. He could have guessed something like that, “Why?”

The woman shrugged, “He’s never talked much about it, so I just stopped asking. The rascal hates not being able to do something. But I think what he hates more is having people who care about him see him unable to do something. You know what I mean?”

Izuku wasn’t sure he did, but still said, “I think so.”

And so, she breathed out and turned on the sink to wash, “Part of me thinks that people put too much expectations on him from such a young age, and this is his way of dealing with it.”

“By shoving people away?” Izuku laughs, “I’m not sure I understand.”
“More like by convincing himself he doesn’t care,” Mitsuki offers up her point of view, “Because if he can successfully tell himself that he doesn’t care, then if he disappoints someone, then it wouldn’t matter.”

Izuku feels as if he’s only read about the idea in psychology textbooks, but has ever seen emotional blockage like this in person, “And so, you and Uncle Maseru don’t bother anymore?”

“Nah,” Mitsuki shrugs, “He takes care of himself. Even if he’s frustrated, he gets over it. He’s been like that for so long that no one really bothers anymore. Not even his friends. It’s just how Katsuki is.”

Izuku frowned. Something about that felt wrong to him, almost neglectful. Even then, none of it explains why Katsuki and him fell off all of those years.

He wants to take a moment to ponder on it a little longer, but he does not have the time to, as the back door opens a moment later, and in comes the athlete covered in sweat and smelling like freshly cut grass from the outside. Any sign of frustration and vulnerability from earlier was replaced by his usual expression. Katsuki was good at switching back to his normal nonchalant state.

“Oi, you shits talking about me?” Katsuki grumbled as he heads straight for the fridge to get a cup of water, “Better be about how fucking great I am.”
Mitsuki had given up on controlling Katsuki’s vile language, so she rolls her eyes, “Not everything is about you, Katsuki. We were merely discussing how beautiful Izuku over here has grown up, don’t you agree?”

Izuku felt betrayed, because why in the world would she set him up like this. Izuku’s cheeks flushed, wanting this sequence of conversation to be over already.

Katsuki’s eyes flashed over to his while he drinks his water, and there’s no word until the cup is set down on the counter and Katsuki runs a hand through his damp hair, “Deku, did you drink some water?”

The blonde ignores his mother’s question altogether. Izuku was grateful. He had been expecting something either rude or sarcastic.

Izuku nodded, “Yeah, I did.”

“Good,” Katsuki said while throwing a sweat towel over his shoulder, “Because that shit from last night probably dehydrated the fuck out of you.”

Mitsuki eyed the two of them, “What happened last night, hm?”

“Nothing, hag,” The blonde shooed her away, “Go to work or something. Oi, Deku, come on. Let’s get you away before she spews propaganda down your ear.”

Izuku shakes his head and grins, “Kacchan, don’t call your mom that.”

“Why not?” Katsuki asked ridiculously, while jogging up the stairs, “You should try it sometime. I’m sure Auntie would be thrilled.”

Izuku looked terrified at the suggestion, following behind, “She’d perform an exorcism on me.”

“That’s actually fucking hilarious,” Katsuki grinned before throwing the door open to his room, “I’m gonna shower. Stay here, and don’t touch anything.”

Izuku most definitely did not listen, because the moment Katsuki disappears into his adjacent bathroom, the shorter male has a field day. Katsuki’s room has changed quite a bit since they were little, but not too much that it’s unrecognizable. The walls were painted an elegant navy blue, with dark gray hardwood floors.

A four poster bed with a white fur comforter and matching blue silk sheets framed the middle of the room, and there was warm lighting coming from a contemporary designed lamp. Katsuki’s room was relatively neat and organized, but didn’t look dead.

There was character there, for sure. There were shelves on either side of the TV mount with trophies upon trophies, medals, plaques, and all kinds of achievements all perfectly displayed in a glass case built into the wall. Katsuki didn’t have many pictures up, but instead, posters of pole vault legends or his favorite childhood superheroes were framed neatly.

On a small cabinet with glass doors, Izuku could peer inside and see old toys, figurines, and collector’s cards that Katsuki still kept on display, and he smiled at that.

On top of the drawer was more of a mess: small things here and there that the blonde didn’t seem to want to throw away but didn’t know where to put either. Some mixtapes of his favorite 80s tracks. A tube of chapstick. Some unopened condoms. *Um, okay* , Izuku thought to himself. A couple postcards from iconic hiking locations.

Oddly enough, two toy model airplanes that Izuku traced his fingers on. He remembered faintly of Katsuki’s interest in airplanes when they were little. And-

Izuku squinted. And reached out a hand to pick up the couple of photos that were just sitting there underneath a book, tugging it from underneath. He held it up and shuffled through the three photos.

The first was a picture of Katsuki and some of his pole vault friends. The athlete was not smiling in the picture, but everyone else was, arms thrown around each other with the track field and Ise’s green mountains behind them. Izuku smiled at that. The next was just a scenic photo of the view from what looks to be a beautiful waterfall lookout. Turning the photo over, it was dated around last year in some city about a day’s train ride away.

But it was the last photo that surprised Izuku, because as he turns to the next one, the last thing he expected it to be was the two of them, when they were little, with the playground they met at in the background, and Katsuki was holding onto his hands, and in this particular photo, *both* of them were smiling. Izuku stared at it for a while. He wasn't sure why Katsuki still had this. Izuku was positive that he's even lost his copy of this photo, but his heart beats a little quicker at the thought that the blonde, after all of this time, still keeps this photo around.

Izuku heard the door rummaging and he quickly tucks the photos underneath the book again, and plops himself on the comforter.

Katsuki exits the bathroom door to see Izuku splayed out on the bed like a starfish and snorts, "You enjoying yourself?"
Izuku lifts his head and nods, "This is so soft. I love it."

Katsuki sits down on a chair nearby, "Oi, how're you feeling."

Izuku pulls himself up to a sitting position, "I'm fine," And then he looked down shyly, "Um, thank you for...bringing me here last night."

Katsuki shrugged, "You were being an idiot. It's just community service."

Izuku threw a pillow at him, "Just say you're welcome like a normal person!"

The blonde caught the pillow and grinned, "Don't tell me what to do, nerd."

Izuku then sat with his legs crossed together and told Katsuki, "Kacchan, you seriously need to apology to Ren about what happened last night."

At the mention, it looked like Katsuki's tone soured as he sat back with a bored look, "And why should I."

Izuku bit his lip, "Kacchan...you punched him without knowing he was also intoxicated, and threatened to kill him. Twice."

Katsuki then looked down at his knuckles, turning his hand to see the redness from how hard he had hit Ren, "I did, huh."

"He might sue you," Izuku looked concerned.

Katsuki didn't look like he cared, "He won't. Because then, he'd have to admit he had alcohol in his system before being able to legally drink. We'd both get in trouble."

Izuku really wanted him to apologize, but knew how stubborn Katsuki was so he just sighed, "If you say so."

"I know so," Katsuki affirmed, "Either way. Calm your ass down. Kiri texted me this morning, said he took care of him, and the bastard is fine. He's a bit pissed, but understands my intentions. I don't have to say shit to him."

Izuku felt a little calmer after hearing that, “That’s good.”

The blonde then leaned forward, clasping his hands together, “So. Do you wanna stay here and annoy me for a couple of hours, or should I take you back.”

Izuku laughed, “Why do your invitations always sound so mean.”

“I can’t be letting you think you’re not bad to be around or anything,” Katsuki smirked, “That’d be the end of the world.”
Izuku’s eyes widened at this. Katsuki had simultaneously both admitted and not admitted that he didn’t mind Izuku’s presence, and although that should have been obvious since the blonde hung out with him more than the required project time, it was the first time Katsuki had said something about it, and Izuku couldn’t help but feel his heart begin to beat a little quicker.

Izuku beamed, “Even your compliments are mean. You’re truly something else, Kacchan.”

Katsuki snorted to himself, “Aren’t I?”

Since he had told his mother he’d be getting home around noon for lunch, Izuku was able to stay for a couple hours. In that time, the two of them just hung out in Katsuki’s room and played video games extremely competitively. Izuku should have taken the opportunity to call Katsuki a nerd for how intense and serious he took the gameplay, but decides to not get into an argument right then. Izuku was on his stomach on top of the blonde’s bed, while Katsuki was on the floor up closer to the screen, and since Mitsuki and Masuru were now both off at work, they could yell at each other as loud as they wanted to.
And later, when Katsuki drops him off at his house, he forgets for a moment the absolute crisis he had gone through the previous night. Because this morning had felt so normal, and he had woken up to the sight of Katsuki practicing so he was happy. Maybe the previous night’s feelings were just a bluff. He probably knew deep down that they weren’t, but when Izuku goes upstairs to collapse back onto his own bed, he makes it a point to not have his mind drift too deep into thinking. No good conclusion ever comes from doing that.

The next time Izuku sees Katsuki was on Tuesday, and since the both of them have been pretty busy with the beginning of the week, Katsuki decides to take it chill that evening and comes over to Izuku’s house for the project hour, rather than having them go out.

Izuku doesn’t mind. He likes having the other over, for it brought a bit more excitement into their otherwise mellow household. And also, his mother never had to cook if Katsuki came over, because the blonde would hungrily whip up something in their kitchen, with conveniently enough leftovers for both Izuku and Inko. Because of that, Inko never really protested if Katsuki dropped by the house. It was much easier to stay there, than to go out.

Ise High was now in the middle of their spring semester, which meant that things were picking up the pace: in classes, clubs, and everything else. And as the midpoint of the project

marks itself, the greenette finds himself remembering the deal that was made.

At the end of the project, he is to leave Katsuki alone and get out of his sight. Izuku remembers when he had first offered up the deal, and how although he didn't want to, he still felt as if he was able to. But now?

There was no way in hell the boy would have ever guessed that their relationship would look like how it does now. In no world would he have figured that Katsuki would start to become such a pivotal part of his life, such a prominent feature, that suddenly taking him out and getting out of the blonde's sight was doing things to his heart already. Every time he thought about it, Izuku felt dread course through his body and a longing that he tries to get rid of, but persists.

Izuku, as a part of the student council at Ise High, has been helping with the preparations for the Spring Dance, which was their school's equivalent of prom.

Everyone would dress up into their beautiful gowns, and go to the school's gym which would be decorated with beautiful lights, balloons, strings, and what not, and dance the night away. Izuku was in charge of contacting companies to cater for the event, so he's been busy with that.

And Katsuki? He's been practicing like crazy for the first regionals tournament that will be happening this weekend. All of the local ones have been cleared, and most of the school's vault team have passed into the first regional tournament, held at the stadium of the next county over, about an hour away.

Everyone is Ise, from the students to their grandparents, were deep into what was going on at Ise High, where the famed Bakugo Katsuki attends. There were predictions that during this first regionals tournament, which featured competitors from 4 different counties and 16 schools, Bakugo Katsuki will only need to jump 17'0, which was well below his record that he performed at the Youth Nationals the previous year. Katsuki himself was thinking the same thing. It'll only be in about 2 to 3 more tournaments will he begin jumping closer and closer to where his record was. And then after that is Nationals, but this time, in the Adult division.

And so, this evening, as Izuku and Katsuki sit on the greenette's bed and watches some superhero movie, they take the time to relax a little bit before continuing their hectic week. Izuku notices that Katsuki likes to make commentary throughout the entire movie, and he doesn't mind because he enjoys listening.

At some point, they had a disagreement about the best character in the film and a small popcorn fight ensues. Izuku was *not* going to enjoy cleaning that up, but what he did enjoy was the laugh he got out of the blonde. Katsuki's laugh was nice to hear, and it felt special since the blonde didn't laugh genuinely much. Izuku, as he listens to it, wonders to himself: was feeling this way towards Katsuki inevitable?

"I'd rate that a 6/10," Katsuki gives his final opinion when the movie's end credit scene begins, "The planes they used were cool."

Izuku smiled at that, “Kacchan, of all things to notice about a movie, it’s the planes?”

Katsuki shrugged, “I’ve always liked looking at them. Maybe it’s the pole vaulter in me, but when I was a kid, I wanted to fly like that. I think deep down, that’s why I started the sport in the first place. In my stupid ass kid brain, I thought maybe it’ll help me fly too. Ain’t that dumb.”

Izuku rests his chin on his palm, “I think that’s kind of sweet, actually.”

“Shut up,” Katsuki threw a stray piece of popcorn at him.

Izuku hummed then countered what Katsuki had said earlier, “Going back to the movie, I’d personally say it was a 4/10.”

“Oh?” Katsuki raised a brow, “Picky, eh?”

Izuku defended himself, “As you often remind me, I am a bit of a nerd, so I have high standards for these movies.” He beams proudly.

“Speaking of, how’s the comic issue that you forced me to drive you to get?” Katsuki leaned back on the bed and rolled his eyes in annoyance.

“It was great!” Izuku exclaimed, before twisting his body to face Katsuki, and then continuing to rant to the athlete, now that he was on a roll and the other had asked about it.

Izuku feels appreciated in times like this, when casually, Katsuki would ask him about something. And it was sometimes things that Izuku knew the other wasn’t that interested in, but the blonde would ask anyways. It was in moments like that where Izuku believes that the friendship wasn’t exactly one-sided.

“And so, it ended on a cliffhanger?” Katsuki asked, once Izuku was done ranting.

“Sadly,” The greenette leans on his arms, “I’ll have to wait a couple weeks for the next edition, and you’re going to take me to get that too.”
Katsuki leaned up for a second to flick at Izuku’s forehead, “You’ve been getting bossy, you little shit.”
Izuku laughed, “Or maybe you’ve been getting a little soft, Kacchan.”

Katsuki flexed his arms like a cocky bastard, “Me? Soft? Never.”

And then, Katsuki’s phone dinged with a text, and the blonde fished the device out of his pocket. Upon reading it, the boy slowly got up into a sitting position and replied to it. Izuku watched intently, wondering who it was.

“Who is it?” Izuku asked, wondering if he was being intrusive.

Katsuki pulled himself off of the bed, before reaching down to grab his keys. It was well over their one hour minimum, and they’ve already taken the picture for proof, so he could leave whenever.

“Kimi,” Katsuki replied, “You know her?”

Izuku’s stomach dropped. It happened so quickly, that he didn’t even have time to prepare himself for the sudden hit of emotions, serving as a reminder that *no* , the problem he encountered a couple days ago did not just disappear. It was still there all right, waiting for him to feed it.

And as Katsuki mentioned the girl’s name, Izuku’s mind flashed back to the way he held her, the way he kissed her. Izuku fucking hated how he was feeling, more than anything. And the fact that it was coming back full force only proved to him that he was fighting a pointless battle.

Izuku found himself letting out a strained, “Yeah, I know her. What does she want?”

Katsuki slid on his shoes which were stationed at the corner of Izuku’s room, “What do you think she wants.”

“Oh,” Izuku didn’t know why he kept asking questions he already knew the answer to. Each word punches him in the stomach, and he hated feeling like this.

“Anyways, you mind if I grab a water bottle from your fridge?” Katsuki asked as he grabbed the door frame, “I’m thirsty as hell. The popcorn fucking dried my throat.”

Izuku didn’t say anything. He merely stayed still in the position he had been in, staring at Katsuki as he began to leave. He had no right to want Katsuki to stay longer, yet he did. Izuku cursed himself for wanting such things. And he could barely think above the wrenching feeling in his stomach, so much that he ignored the blonde’s question altogether.

And when Katsuki noticed the silence, and looked back over at Izuku, he had to snap the other into the moment again, “Oi, Deku. Did you hear me?”

Izuku blinked, and caught eyes with those ruby red ones. And struck by them as he usually did, Izuku was hit with the need to have them near a little longer. So, without thinking, the greenette found himself asking.

He asked with a soft voice, “If I asked, is there any chance that you’d stay?”

He was so stupid. Why would he ask that, he wondered to himself once it slipped from his lips, and he regretted it even more when he saw something flash across Katsuki’s face before his expression went back to normal.

When Katsuki replies, Izuku feels like the blonde has all the cards in his hand, “And do what.”

Izuku pursed his lips, looking down at the sheets, “Never mind…” He laughed nervously, “It’s nothing as...exciting as what you’re about to do.” Why’d he ask in the first place. He was so, so stupid, he thought to himself.

Katsuki was silent for a bit, and Izuku was afraid he just made himself a little too obvious, before the blonde asked gruffly, “Well, you won’t fucking know if you don’t ask.”

Izuku looked up and blinked at Katsuki, feeling himself about to stammer, but he forced control in his voice, “Can you stay?”

Katsuki honestly should not have said that if he had no intentions on staying, because Izuku sat there feeling like a fool for a good moment as Katsuki stood there at the doorframe, looking at Izuku curiously. He felt like such a fool.

And he felt even more stupid and embarassed, when, without a word, Katsuki turns around and leaves.

Izuku felt so fucking dumb, and was probably going to think about this moment for the rest of the night. He hears the blonde’s footsteps going down the stairs, and then, Izuku not wanting to think about how foolish he just made himself look, numbly got himself off of the bed and into the bathroom to grab a small bag from underneath the cabinet.

Walking back inside, Izuku begins to silently clean up the mess they had made. He wanted to cry, but he knew crying would make him even more ashamed. Because this was his own fault, for acting out of his boundaries. And now, he didn’t want to think: not about where Katsuki was going, who he was going to, what he had just said, how obvious and idiotic he just looked. He picked up the popcorn from the floor, and places it in the bag, all while controlling his breath so he doesn’t cry at how he acted.

Then, Izuku heard footsteps going back up the stairs, and he honestly did not want to see his mother right now. He felt like any word was going to make him lose control of his emotions. And yet, his mother never came.

Instead, Katsuki sauntered back into the room, kicked off his shoes, and threw two water bottles on Izuku’s bed and set a tray of half sandwiches on a table nearby. Izuku watched him with wide eyes throughout the entire sequence of events, unsure of what to say or do. He was on his knees on his carpeted floor, bag full of stale popcorn in his hands, as he watches the blonde grab a water bottle and gulp down half of it in one go.

Katsuki threw it back on the bed, “I got us some real food and water, because no way in hell am I surviving off of popcorn.”

Izuku felt more relieved and happy than he should’ve been. Katsuki was staying. He was staying with him rather than going off to someone’s place, and having a lot more fun and pleasure. Izuku was *not* going to cry, he had to tell himself. Not over this. Not over this.

And so, the greenette laughs, eyes filled with delight, “You ate a big meal literally a couple hours ago, Kacchan.”

“My metabolism works fast, shut up,” Katsuki defended himself before crouching down to help Izuku with the popcorn, and then said, “Since I’m staying, you better be entertaining.”

Izuku snorted, then without thinking, said jokingly, “Do you want me to suck your dick or something to make up for it?”
And when Izuku had realized what he had said, which was completely not something he’d usually say, it was too late, for Katsuki had paused what he was doing from across him.

Izuku's cheeks decides to turn red now, as he nervously looked up at Katsuki. The athlete's eyes widen fractionally, before looking away, and Izuku wanted to yell out.

Izuku stopped what he was doing and pointed his finger in Katsuki's face, practically shouting, "Kacchan! Are you blushing?! No way, no way, no way!"
"Shut up," Katsuki slapped his finger out of his face, and scowled, "I'm not, you idiot."

Izuku giggled, "You most definitely were, Kacchan. I'm not forgetting this moment."
"I'm going to run you over, just enough that you'll lose your memory then. What kind of joke was that, you nerd," Katsuki threatened.

"I don't get it though," Izuku wanted to cry from laughing, "It's not like you're not used to hearing that."

Katsuki then flicked his forehead, "I am."

"Then what is it," Izuku leaned in to ask out of curiosity.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, "When you say it, it's just...different."

Izuku hummed, "How so."

The blonde leaned back, and ignored the question, instead, made a comment about the tournament this upcoming weekend, "Are you gonna make it to the tournament?"

Izuku shakes his head, "Yeah! I'm riding with Shoto."

"Round face and the other one ain't coming?" Katsuki asked.

"No," Izuku shrugs, "They have something going on Saturday. Also, why do you keep on asking? I always come."
Katsuki reached over to grab a half sandwich off of the plate, "You promise?"

Izuku softly smiles, less happy than he did before, "Yeah, until our project ends, of course. We made a deal, remember?"

At that, Katsuki goes silent. And looked back up at Izuku with his usual intense eyes, "I remember."

Izuku wished that he wouldn't.

Izuku also wished that he had let Katsuki go to Kimi's place that evening, because maybe then, the pain that would've resulted from that might have staved him off.

But instead, he digs himself into a deeper hole by having Katsuki stay, because now, he gets to hear that voice a little longer, see those eyes a little closer, and spend the rest of the

evening sitting on Izuku's comforter talking. The fact that they could just do this, and it felt like it was enough only made Izuku feel more doomed.

The sun went down, but neither Izuku nor Katsuki felt like getting up to turn on a lamp. So the bluish-purple dusk of Ise settled into the bedroom, until Izuku could barely see their shadows on the walls. Izuku sits against his pillows and headboard, while Katsuki lays spread out on his blankets.

And when he drifts to sleep later on, he doesn't even realize. But when Izuku wakes up the next morning, he was tucked into bed with the blankets covering him, although he knew for a fact he had fallen asleep sitting up against the wall. Katsuki had gone back home, but the thought warmed Izuku's heart to know that the blonde stayed with him until the end of their night. Because Izuku knew: Katsuki most definitely didn't have to.

It is Thursday when Izuku sees the blonde again, and it is at the athlete's solo practice. Izuku was a little late today, not that he had a deadline or anything, because of some things he had to take care of for the Spring Dance. The greenette hadn't even asked his mother about attending yet. Mostly because he knew she disapproves of Ise High's Spring Dance, which was notorious for being a little wild, especially the after parties.

Either way, Izuku practically ran to the practice field with a bottle of cherry gatorade in his hand. And when he pushes the chain linked gate open and hurries to his spot near the bench, Izuku sees that Katsuki is very immersed in his practice today, considering that the first regionals tournament is on Saturday. The blonde honestly didn't need to, since he will sweep the tournament easily, but Izuku admires the effort.

It seems like at the current moment, Katsuki had the bar set up at 17'11, the same height that it was at when Izuku had seen him fail in the backyard the other day. And from the look of it, Katsuki hadn't made any improvement with clearing the bar.

Izuku sits down, pulls out his notebook, and starts to take in more details about Katsuki's form, footwork, and whatever else as he watches the blonde do his runs. Izuku keeps a tally chart in the corner of the page, of how many times during this practice that Katsuki fails the bar.

Currently, it was at 23. And Izuku wonders how long could a person practice like this for so long in this heat. Since no one else was there, Katsuki had to also reset the bar manually each time. Izuku watched as Katsuki attempts to clear 17'11 over and over again, only to land on the mat with his back and the bar falling at his feet.

The expression on Katsuki's face was unreadable. His fiery red eyes were focused on the bar and nothing else, but Izuku could tell that something was brewing underneath the mask of indifference. Because after all, Katsuki was human, even if it sometimes didn't feel like it.

Today felt a little bit more tense. As Izuku sat there watching, he could see that the more times Katsuki knocks down the bar, the tenser the blonde seems to be. The tightness in his

shoulders and legs doesn't help with the jump, and Izuku witnesses Katsuki redo his runs over and over again.

And now, as Katsuki prepares for another go, Izuku could practically see the veins threatening to burst through the blonde's forehead. His grip on the pole seemed tighter, his breath more rigid, and all the signs pointed towards the fact that the athlete was frustrated. And yet, on Katsuki's face was blankness, feigning determination even though his body was worn out.

And when he misses this one, Katsuki slams his hand on the mat and it looked like the string inside his head snapped. The blonde grabbed his pole roughly, and walks over to the bench where Izuku sat.

"Can you go home," Katsuki for the first time ever since Izuku had started dropping by demanded, voice laced with tension.

Katsuki's tone felt like it was on the verge of yelling, but he was trying to keep himself sounding nonchalant. Izuku should've known better to feel offended.

Furrowing his brows, Izuku then asked the blonde, "Why? So that you can let out your frustration where no one can see?" Izuku probably shouldn't have said that.

The athlete's blank expression broke for a moment as he looked surprised, and then angry, "And what the fuck do you know, Deku."

Since it was too late, Izuku continued anyways, "Kacchan, I've watched you fail that bar over thirty times today, and I don't think any differently of you," Izuku tried to explain softly.

"This isn't about you, fucking idiot," Katsuki had a warning tone, and the grip on the pole looked bruising.

Izuku looked him straight in the eye, "Then why do I have to leave?"

Katsuki couldn't find words to reply to this, but his eyes still shone with anger, "Just fucking lea-"

"I don't want to," Izuku nervously said, "Do you think that I haven't seen you not clear a bar before? Kacchan, I stood on the other side of the fence when you were 11, and watched you barely make it past 9 feet."

"That was fucking different," Katsuki argued, "Then, no one had fucking expectations for me."

"And you think I do now?" Izuku asked, hands on his lap.

"Deku, you have a goddamn shelf with my jersey, my newpaper clippings, my pictures on it," Katsuki called out, "And you're telling me you don't have expectations for me? Bullshit. Get the fuck out of my sigh-"

“That’s not why I have those things,” Izuku frowned, “And since when did you care about what I think? Or what other people think?”

“I don’t,” Katsuki gave out his formulated response, “I just don’t need people to be on my ass when I disappoint them. Nothing annoys the shit out me more than seeing those disgusting sad eyes when I don’t perform or act how people fucking want me to.”

Izuku shook his head, “The people who care about you won’t be disa-”

“I don’t need a fucking lecture right now, Deku,” Katsuki threw down his pole.

He looked at Izuku for another couple seconds with now clearly frustrated eyes, before stepping away. He walked off to the landing mat, before sitting down on it and clasped his hands together, staring down between his feet before up at the bar that he couldn’t pass.

Izuku stared at the sight of the athlete from his spot on the bench, and wondered how Katsuki could handle everything by himself for so long.

He thought back to what Mitsuki had said. His parents don’t bother anymore. It was just how Katsuki was, and no matter how frustrated the blonde gets, he still gets through it and handles every situation himself. But Izuku was beginning to wonder whether Katsuki’s version of handling things was actually dealing with his emotions, or if it was waiting it out until he doesn’t feel anything anymore.

Izuku then realizes that this type of nonchalant acceptance of Katsuki’s emotional disconnection came from everyone, not just his parents: Katsuki’s teachers, teammates, friends, and basically everyone else had just accepted the fact that Katsuki was like this. And so they don’t bother anymore.

Izuku felt hurt inside at the realization, because although completely different, the greenette has experienced a similar kind of treatment. He’s always been a little bit in his shell, and as long as he remembered, his mother had been strict with his going out. And it wasn’t as if he’s been left out, but many people didn’t bother anymore.

Even his closer friends felt hesitant and rarely made plans with him, assuming that he wouldn’t be able to go. In a way, sometimes Izuku felt as if his life was passing by him, and he watched everyone else grow up and do things that all teenagers do while sitting in the confines of his room.

And none of that changed until Bakugo Katsuki came into the picture, did not give a shit about his mother’s restrictions, and made it possible for him to reclaim all of the years he lost. Katsuki was probably the only person who had ever bothered, even if it was because of a project.

Now suddenly, Izuku decides that he won’t just be a statistic. He won’t just accept that this is just how Katsuki is, even if it’s meddling in places where he wasn’t wanted.

Grabbing the drink from off of the bench, the greenette walks over slowly to where Katsuki was sitting and plopped down next to him. Katsuki’s head was down, but he accepted the

cherry drink when it was passed to him.

“You need to take a break for today,” Izuku quietly mentioned, “Your body is getting worn out.”

Katsuki says nothing to this, just unscrews the cap of the gatorade and takes a gulp, before sitting in silence once more. Izuku swings his legs above the edge of the mat, thinking of what to say.

“I read about the guy who can clear 18’2,” Izuku started, knowing this probably wasn’t what the other wanted to hear, “It’s true, not just a rumor. I’ve watched him too, in videos. He’s good, and I think his name is Toro Ito, from Tokyo,” Izuku just decides to keep talking, “He’s not your age, by the way. He’s two years older, but he’ll be competing in your division if you qualify for Nationals.”

Izuku keeps swinging his legs. In his peripheral vision, Katsuki holds the drink in his hands but doesn’t move. This conversation might go very wrong *very* soon.

“I’ve probably watched about a dozen videos of him vaulting. I get a little obsessed,” Izuku laughs, “But honestly, if someone were to ask me who I’d predict to be better by the time Nationals come, I wouldn’t hesitate to say you. And that’s not me being biased.”

Katsuki turned his head slightly to peer over at Izuku, and the greenette smiles at him gently.

Izuku then looks back down at his feet, “When I watch him, Ito I mean, I know he’s good. He looks and acts like he grew up with everything a big city has to offer, with private lessons from the best coaches in the country and high-end physical therapists to treat his every bruise,” Izuku stated his observations.

He continued, “But, as arrogant as you are, you’re a small-town boy from a high school that no one outside of Ise has ever heard of, unless it’s connected to your name. You taught yourself how to vault up until you got the low-key coach you do now, and you collected bruises on your arms, your sides, your legs, and your head and treated it all yourself with some ointment and bandages from our corner store.”

Katsuki was by no means poor. If anything, the blonde was upper middle class, and lived very comfortably even if they weren’t millionaires. But when you live in a town as small as Ise, regardless of wealth, there just isn’t going to be as many opportunities for dreamers. The best coaches, the best private gyms, physicians and what not were not going to be in Ise. And so Katsuki had to work so much harder than others to get to the place he was now.

“You’re so determined and passionate that it takes my breath away. Am I allowed to say that?” Izuku laughs, “I don’t mean it in a weird way, but yeah. I don’t doubt for a second that you are the best.”

Katsuki did not say anything to him for a while, and Izuku was okay with that. He just felt like filling in the silence just then with a little insight as to why he believed in the other so much. It wasn’t baseless. It never was.

And when Katsuki finally replied, it was gruff but not aggressive in the slightest, “Cheesy bastard. How are you not embarrassed saying shit like that out loud.”

Izuku giggled out loud, watching the clouds turn orange, “I am a little bit,” He admits.

And then, after a moment of silence, Katsuki looks up to the bar and tells Izuku, “I’m fucking nervous. Is that what you wanted me to admit.”

Izuku turns his head to the blonde, surprised with wide eyes, and his mouth parts slightly as he thinks of what to say. He wasn’t expecting anything like that to actually come out of the blonde.

Izuku swallowed, “I want *you* to want to admit it.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, but didn’t look malicious, “I’m good as I am, Deku. You’re trying to do something, I can tell. I’m taking psychology too, nerd,” And then he shrugs, “That’s all I’m going to say about it. I’m nervous. That’s it. I’ll get over it.”

Izuku was happy enough for now. Admitting is the first step.

The greenette then thinks and hums, “Hm, when you’re nervous, I read that you should do an activity that makes your brain focus on something entirely different. Although it’s just rec badminton, I sometimes get nervous too, and I like to whistle a song. It makes me focus on what note comes next, and calms my nerves down a little so I’m not as tense.”

Katsuki snorts at this, “What song.”

Izuku grins, “The chorus to Nothing’s Going To Change My Love for You.”

“By George Benson?” Katsuki laughs at him, “My god, you’re so fucking cheesy.”

“It’s a beautiful song!” Izuku elbows him, then sways in his seat side to side, before beginning to whistle the tune.

Izuku’s whistling wasn’t great, but the melody was there. The song was in fact beautiful, and Izuku has always imagined himself in a movie montage to this song when it came on in his playlists or the radio. Katsuki’s shoulders shook from laughing on the side, as Izuku tried to get in the moment.

“Finish it!” Izuku poked at the athlete.

Katsuki shakes his head, “I’m not fucking doing that. No way.”
The greenette begins to harass Katsuki a little more, elbowing him repeatedly as Izuku repeats the part of the chorus leading up to where he wanted Katsuki to finish.

“Fuck!” Katsuki defended himself, “Go away, goddamnit.”
Izuku refused, “Not until you finish the tune,” Then Izuku sings it half-assed, “ *Nothing's gonna change my love for you. You oughta know by now how much I love you. One thing you can be sure of, I'll never ask for more than your loveeee.* ” He dragged out the end, as his hands gestured for Katsuki to finish in a whistle.

Finally giving in, Katsuki rolls his eyes before taking a breath and whistling the rest of the chorus, to which Izuku clapped. Katsuki's lung capacity was much better than his, so he was able to go on without taking a breath between each line. At one point, Katsuki paused to think of the next note before continuing to whistle.

When he finished, Izuku cheered, "See? You had to actively think about what was next, so it helps with your nerves, right?"

Katsuki flicked him on the side of the head, "I'm not doing that."

Izuku pouted, "It works, but fine."

"Just be there and cheer me on," Katsuki told him, "And drag all of your goons too. I want a huge crowd, a giant banner saying I'm the fucking best, and a whole band."

Izuku shook his head and laughed, "Okay, now you're being greedy."

Katsuki's left side of his lip quirked up, "Just the first thing is fine too."

Izuku rested his cheek on his hand as he looks over to Katsuki with smiling eyes, "Why does it sound like I'm a good luck charm?"

Katsuki stood up and stretched, "It's your shitty aura. It scares all the competition away."

Izuku looked for a pebble to throw at the athlete, and then decides on something. He pursed his lips, before requesting the blonde, "Hey, can we drop by my house really quick?"

Katsuki had seen the slight pause, and gave Izuku a weird look, before shrugging, "Sure."

When Katsuki parks his car on Izuku's driveway, the greenette looked like he was thinking of something embarrassing. And when they enter the abode, Inko was talking on the phone with a customer in her room, so there was no need to sit through any small talk. Izuku led Katsuki up to his room.

Behind him on the stairs, the blonde asked, "Why are we here again?"

Izuku nervously laughed, "I have something to give you."

"Oh?" Katsuki spoke, "For what do I owe the pleasure."

Izuku scratched the back of his head, "You're not going to even like it."

When they enter his room, Izuku walks towards the shelf of things he has related to Katsuki, while the blonde plopped back on the bed. Izuku scans the shelf before taking out the little cardboard box that situated itself on the corner.

"Oi, ain't that the thing you told me not to touch when I first came in here?" Katsuki noticed.

Izuku smiled as he looks down at it, “Yeah, I never planned on actually giving it to you.”

Katsuki raised a brow from the bed, “How long have you had the thing.”

Izuku then looked over at Katsuki and confessed, “7 years.”

The blonde seemed off at the comment, but then asked, “What is it.”

Izuku then looked extremely shy, “Ah, I’m suddenly not sure anymore. It’s really stupid, an-”

“Oi,” Katsuki interrupted his ramblings, “Just show me.”

Izuku pursed his lips, then took off the lid on the cardboard box. And from the raggedy inside, he pulls out a white sports headband with absolutely horrible writing and doodles on it, before tossing it at Katsuki aggressively and stepping back.

Katsuki fishes it out of his lap and holds the sweatband in his hands so that he can see the writing, staring down at it while Izuku watches.

The white sweatband looked as if it’s been collecting dust. In terrible handwriting and in bright orange and green letters, which were Katsuki’s favorite colors when he was young, the words “IZUKU BELIEVES IN ME” were embarrassingly scribbled. And on the side, two stick figures of someone with green hair which Katsuki assumed was Izuku, and then of someone with spikey blonde hair. And on the other side, a terrible doodle of someone vaulting a high bar.

Izuku stammered, “I made it when I was 11...and you first started vaulting. I wanted to give it to you at your first tournament for good luck, but...you didn’t want to talk to me then, so it’s just been sitting here for a while.”

Katsuki still held the item in his hands then peered up at Izuku who was standing by awkwardly, “You don’t expect me to wear this, do you?”

“Yes, as a good luck charm,” Izuku laughs, “Probably not on your head because that’s embarrassing, but just keep it on you.”

Katsuki looked back down at the garment, and Izuku swore he saw the blonde crack a genuine smile for a second, but then the athlete looked up at him, “I feel very lucky now, nerd.”

“Now you have to wear it okay?” Izuku pushed.

Katsuki rolled his eyes then wrapped the sweatband twice around his wrist with the lettering facing inside out so that it can’t be seen from the outside, “There, you happy?”

Izuku notices the lettering was flipped with the inverted sweatband and chuckles, “Am I that embarrassing?”

Katsuki stood up to ruffle Izuku’s hair, “A little bit, yeah.”

Izuku tilted his head up to look at the much taller boy, always feeling a bit small when next to Katsuki, “Are you going to go home now?”

Katsuki didn’t hear him, and instead, had looked over to the shelf, “Oi.”

Izuku looks over there as well, “Yes?”

Katsuki then looked down at Izuku, “You have all this shit of me,” He gestured to the shelf, “And you’re trying to tell me you don’t got expectations for me? What kind of fan are you.”

Izuku blinked up at him, not expecting that question at all. His lips parted, as he tries to find a way to say it as accurately as possible why exactly he’s so invested in Katsuki, without having expectations. If Katsuki were to stay at 17’10 for the rest of his life, Izuku would still be okay with that.

“As someone who is always on the ground,” Izuku smiles, “Seeing you fly, no matter how high, is good enough for me.”

At this response, Katsuki looked at him with an odd expression, and Izuku wondered if he had said something wrong. The greenette was about to speak up, when Katsuki beat him to the chase.

“You know Humphrey Park?” Katsuki then asked, “The one with the small pond that everyone comes to feed those filthy ducks at.”

Izuku was confused but nodded, “Yes?”

“Meet me there in forty minutes,” Katsuki said as he walked to the door, “And change into something less restrictive. I’m gonna go home and grab some shit.”

“Wait, what?” Izuku asked, “In forty minutes?”

Katsuki nodded as he headed out, “Sneak out if you have to.”

“But Kacch-” Izuku started, but the blonde was already headed down the stairs.

Forty minutes was not that much time, Izuku realizes, because the park was about a 15 minute jog away, and he still had to eat dinner and change. Realizing that, Izuku rushes down the stairs and into the kitchen just as his mother leaves her room. He greeted her, and while she heated up dinner, Izuku wonder what it was Katsuki wanted to do. And when they sat down to eat, Izuku practically shoved his food in his mouth, chiming in here and there to his mother’s conversation, but overall rushing.

He practically runs up the stairs when he was done, before changing into some athletic shorts and kept the same t-shirt he’d been wearing on. Making sure there was nothing in his teeth, Izuku stomped back down the stairs and slipped on his shoes.

Inko, who was washing dishes, calls out, “Izuku? Where are you going?”

“To Humphrey Park!” Izuku tells her, “I’m meeting Kacchan there in a couple of minutes.”

“The park?” She paused her washing, concerned, “Now? But you haven’t even aske-”

“Sorry mom, I have to go!” Izuku tells her with a large wave as he rushes towards the door.

Inko puts down the plate and briskly walks towards him, “Izuku.”

The boy in question turns around as his hands are about to close the door, “Yes?” Fuck, he had completely forgotten that his mother wasn’t the type to just let him *go out* . How he had forgotten, he didn’t know.

Inko looked overly concerned and almost a bit panicked, “You haven’t asked me, yet. Or told me when you’ll be back.”

The comment sparked something in Izuku’s mind, and he asked himself why he had to give her every single detail of his life when most people at this age were allowed to take control of their own lives. All of his friends next year will be in a different city than their parents, so why did it matter where he went or when he’ll be back as long as he was taking care of himself? Izuku thought back to Katsuki’s question back at the ice cream parlour. *You ever think about this, Deku? When did she start acting like this? Did a certain fucking event happen?* Some theories go through his head, but it was so mean, and Izuku forced himself to defend himself but be calm.

Izuku looked at her apologetically, “I don’t know when I’ll be back tonight. Can I go?”

Inko looked at him as if he’s grown a third head, and softly told him, “No. You can ask again another day, but tonight, you’ve overstepped your boundaries. Now go back inside, and tell Katsuki y-”

“Mom, I’m going,” Izuku told her, voice gentle, and before the woman, whose eyes widened, could protest, he started jogging off.

Behind him, he heard a frantic, “Izuku!”

But he ignored her, making it the first time he’s done so.

“About time,” Katsuki leaned against his car at the park entrance when Izuku jogged up.

The greenette stopped a couple of feet away, and put his hands on his knees to catch his breath, “I’m not even late, Kacchan.”

Katsuki got himself off the car, “I can’t believe you can’t even fucking drive.”

“I have my licenses,” Izuku countered, “I’m just not really trusted by my mom to drive.”

“Speaking of,” Katsuki said as he reached into the side door to grab some things, “Did Auntie actually give you last minute permission? Or did you sneak out.”

Izuku pursed his lips, not really wanting to think about that right then, “Neither.”
Katsuki turned back to look at him curiously, not understanding, but shrugging, “Alright. Come on.”

Izuku walked behind Katsuki as he led the way into the park, “What are we doing?”

Humphrey’s Park was quaint and a multi-purpose area. There weren’t many trees, and it was mostly paved out anyways. A small pond with ducks was on the left, and pieces of bread that the birds don’t eat were on the ground. There was a playground that some kids were enjoying at the moment, a little league baseball practice field that was empty at the moment, some walking trails, and further back was an open tall grass field with a wide dirt area that connected to the park.

Katsuki walked towards the wide dirt area, and now, Izuku could see. Sitting in the middle of it, with the tallgrass field in the back, was a practice pole vault set up. Except it seemed like it was for beginners because the maximum that the bar went up to was about 12 feet. The landing mat looked worn with age and the sun beating down on it, but it held up. The running track was just the dirt area, and Izuku looked up at Katsuki to see why they were there.

The blonde then pulled out a small bluetooth speaker and set it on the ground nearby, before connecting his phone. After turning on Time After Time by Cindy Lauper, he shoved his phone in his pocket again.

From a large box next to the vault pit, Katsuki walked up and fished around for poles. There were about 10 or so fiberglass poles in there for communal use. The blonde picked out a shorter one than what he would use, and came back to where Izuku stood confused.

Then, from the bag Katsuki brought, he took out some white athletic tape and began to wrap the part of the pole that’s supposed to be gripped onto, all without a word. Izuku just watched.

Then, Katsuki shoved the pole in Izuku’s hands, and walks behind the greenette to hold it up in the correct positioning.

“Kacchan?” Izuku turned his neck to look back at the blonde, who was right behind him with his arms around his body helping Izuku hold the pole, “What are you doing?”

The athlete changed the grip placement on Izuku’s left hand before looking down at Izuku’s eyes and telling him straight. Izuku’s never found the color red so beautiful, as Katsuki says:

“Showing you how to fly.”

Izuku was stunned. *What* ? First of all, the blonde’s voice was uncharacteristically nonaggressive. Secondly, he was not prepared for this at all. After years and years of just

watching from a distance, now the blonde wants to take him off the ground?

“You’re what?” Izuku blinked up at him with big eyes, and Katsuki didn’t look away until a moment later.

“Turn back around,” Katsuki nodded his head forward, “You’re going to want to hold the pole up at this angle.” He said before moving it.

Izuku still wasn’t over it, turning his head back around to look up at Katsuki, “Wa-Wait, we’re actually doing this? Kacchan, it’s one thing to analyze your movement and another thing to actually do it. I don’t know the first thing about *actually* pole vaulting. I’ll fall on my head. Are you sure you can tea-”

Katsuki let go of where he was stabilizing the pole and used one hand to gently take hold of Izuku’s jaw and turn his head over to look at the vault pit, “Listen, we’re starting at 7 feet. That’s the absolute beginner height, see? A kid could do it,” He makes Izuku look, “You’ll be fine. Trust me, nerd. You said you were always on the ground, right? I’ll show you how to fly.”

*Trust me* . That was once upon a time much more difficult for Izuku, but now, as he feels secure in front of Katsuki and the boy tells him that he’ll be okay, Izuku listens to the lyrics a bit closer. *If you fall, I will catch you, I will be waiting. Time after Time.*

And takes a small breath, before telling the other, “Okay.”

“Alright,” Katsuki began, “So as I was saying, hold it at this angle. You’re not gonna be able to keep it there for your first few times, but once you get the hang of it, it’ll be easier.” And Katsuki lifts the pole to the angle described. Izuku felt heat from where the blonde was surrounding his smaller body, trying to get him in the right position. His hips were moved, and he looked down to see those large hands holding on to him.

“You keep your feet like this, right?” Izuku moved his feet to a position he knew Katsuki began with often.

Katsuki looked down, and in slight surprise, nods, “Right. Lift your left heel up a little more.”

It turns out, pole vaulting is absolutely difficult. Izuku would think that it’d be a bit easier, because he knew all of the mechanisms. He knew the methodology and the techniques. But to apply them is a different story. It honestly gave him an even  greater for pole vaulters.

Because it has been well over an hour since they’ve started, and Izuku has not managed to successfully clear the 7 feet bar. The amount of effort and control this sport took was insane.

Katsuki was a surprisingly good teacher, despite the excessive use of language and laughing everytime Izuku failed to land the bar. Despite that, the blonde always reset it for him everytime and told him to keep going until he makes one.

Izuku put his hands on his knees and looked over to Katsuki who was sitting on the dirt, “How do you do this?” He asked out of breath.

Katsuki grinned, “Exactly how I told you.”

Izuku threw his head back and groaned, “How many tries did it take you to clear 7 feet your first time?”

At this, the athlete looked smug as he reveals, “2.”

“2?” Izuku borderline yelled, “This is impossible.”

Katsuki then got up and over to where Izuku was, “It’s possible, nerd. You have the core and upper body strength for it. You’re a little on the short side too, so it’s a bit harder but it’ll work.”

Katsuki then slapped Izuku’s stomach, “I’m telling you. Right when the pole hits the vault box, put all of your energy into your core. Just imagine yourself as a slingshot or some other shit.”

Izuku just stares at him with disbelief, before deciding to trust the process. Katsuki made it sound so easy.

He brings the pole back up into position, and grips where the tape is. His hands are already feeling sore from holding the pole, which was heavier than he had anticipated. Getting his feet into position, he took a deep breath.

He thought of Katsuki, in those few seconds where the blonde is in the air, where he’s so amazing that he blocks the sun and mesmerizes a crowd. He’s always wondered what that felt like, ever since he saw Katsuki jump for the first time.

Today, he was determined to find out. Opening his eyes, Izuku broke into a sprint, mimicking the way Katsuki would start out. He knew from his notes that Katsuki sprinted for 8 seconds and ran for another 8 before he reached the launch box, and so Izuku counted. He transitioned from a run into the sprint and counted to eight. *1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8.*

He pushed the pole into the launchbox and it bent deeply, and right as it bent to its highest, Izuku pushed off the ground with as much force as he could before transferring all of his momentum into his core to lift it up. This was different. This was going to work.

Izuku’s eyes widened as his body continued lifting up from the pole straightening up again and then suddenly, he felt it.

From every crevice of his brain to the tips of his fingers, he felt it.

He was flying.

It was probably a couple seconds in total, but in that moment, when he was launched into the air, Izuku’s body seemed to float towards the sky. And the world seemed so big, but it felt as

if he could reach out for the clouds and they'd be there at the end of his fingertips. He could see nothing in his peripheral, so it was all clouds and blue sky.

What was it on Katsuki's back? A hawk? Yeah, he understood a bit more now. He felt incredible.

Izuku lets go of the pole and he clears the bar. When he lands, he does so on his back and instead of getting up, Izuku just lays there, staring back up at the sky. His chest going up and down to get air, but he was so happy. He felt *so* happy. Is this what Katsuki saw every day? Except 10 feet higher up?

Izuku heard clapping from the side and a *whoo* .

Katsuki approaches and jumps up onto the map, standing over him, "Oi look at you go, Deku. You fucking cleared it. Took you long enough."

Izuku sees Katsuki in his vision, and against the beautiful sky, Katsuki is the foreground. The blonde looked down at him, and Izuku could stare at those eyes, those lips, that grin every single day, and not get sick of it. He was beautiful. And it's that thought that would normally scare him, but right now, all Izuku could think was: *this boy. This is the boy that taught me how to fly* . Katsuki had taken him up in the sky with him, and as he realizes this, that was when he feels it.

The flutters again, but this time stronger, more in his face. He couldn't stop it, and he feels the panic coming up. But before he could, Katsuki sits down and lays back so that they were both staring up at the setting sky.

"How was it?" Katsuki asked, "Pretty fucking sick, huh."

Izuku, still stunned from the experience and shocked from the flutters, lets out a soft, "It was beautiful, Kacchan."

"Isn't it?" Katsuki affirmed, "You wanna get a hawk tattoo too, now?"

Izuku laughs at this, but he felt like crying. God, he felt like crying. These flutters. They won't just go away.

"I'll think about it," Izuku jokes back, then nudges Katsuki, "Hey."

Katsuki hums, "What is it."

"I'm obviously not an expert or anything," Izuku begins, "But I do know a good amount of sports physics. You know how you sprint for 8 seconds then run for 8?"
Katsuki nods, "I don't ever remember telling you that, but yeah, fucking stalker."

Izuku shakes his head, "I'm not! But anyways, if you're willing to try it sometime, I think it'd be good to test out sprinting for about 10 seconds and running for 6."

Katsuki snorts, "You're going to tell me, a national youth champion, how to pole vault, Deku?"

Izuku smiles, “No, but you can try it if you’d like. Not at the next tournament, of course. But maybe during practice. I think shortening your run time by just a little bit will put more power in your vault. But that’s just me theorizing.”

Katsuki seems to ponder it, and then after a moment, tells him, “I’ll see.”

Izuku gets up not too long afterwards, and tries again about six times. He managed to get it about half of the time, which was good enough now that he has the general technique down.

And when Izuku gets dropped off later that night in Katsuki’s car, he walked past his mother’s closed door and straight up the stairs to where he locked himself in his room and headed straight for the shower.

As he then stands under the trickling streams of warm water, Izuku clutches his chest which aches at the thought of Katsuki, and squeezed his eyes shut. Even the thumping of the water on his skin wasn’t enough to mask the rate that his heart was beating as he reminds himself of the blonde’s face standing above him after he cleared the bar.

Of all people, why did it have to be *him* . Of all people, why did it have to be the one person who would never even *want* to feel the same. Izuku has not completely come to terms with it, but he knows it’s only a matter of time. He can only deny it for so long.

To add to Izuku’s conflicted emotions, the next morning was absolute shit. Izuku should have seen it coming, considering how he had left off with his mother the day before.

When he left for the park, it was the very first time that Izuku would say he’s directly defied something his mother said to her face. Although Izuku would say he wasn’t rude about it, he should have remembered coming home that night that there *will* be consequences.

At breakfast, Izuku found himself sitting across from his mother awkwardly.

She was barely eating, hands settled on the smooth mahogany table. Her eggs and bread laid there getting cold by the minute. The only sound was Izuku cautiously eating his food and sipping from his water here and there. He tried looking at his mother, but she simply stared blankly somewhere on the table.

Izuku wonders if her not eating was a way to make him feel guilty, or if she was genuinely so upset that it ruined her appetite. Izuku knew he should apologize, but when thinking back to the moment yesterday evening when it felt like he touched the clouds that he always saw Katsuki flying through, he couldn’t bring himself to.

Finally, after fifteen minutes of eating in silence, Inko speaks up, her voice calm, but her face looking as if Izuku had come home having done meth.

“Izuku, honey,” Inko said, and the boy in question looked up from his nearly finished breakfast, internally nervous.

He just smiled at her to show he has no negative intentions, “Yes, mom?”

“Are you not going to apologize for yesterday?” She asked, searching his expression, “You made me so worried.”

Izuku held her gaze, and wished she wouldn’t ask him such a question. He played with his utensil, “I’m sorry for worrying you.” Nothing else.

It didn’t look like the answer Inko wanted, but she just sighed and palmed her temple, “Izuku, I’ve made a decision about something, and I need you to understand why.”

Izuku’s heart began racing faster. Was she going to go through with tracking his phone? He asked, “Yes?”

Inko looked falsely apologetic as she tells him, “I’ve already been thinking about this one thing for a while, because I just hate it so much. And with what happened yesterday, it really solidified to me that me and you need to put more boundaries on what goes in this house.”

Izuku waits for her to get to the point. He’s not touching his food anymore, either. The beautiful sunny morning rays coming in through their windows was starting to be ruined by the bitter aftertaste of this conversation.

“And…” She looked conflicted and hurt, “And I never thought I’d have to say this to you, ‘Zuku! You’ve never been like this, so *keen* to leave all the time and step out of line. What happened to the Izuku who hung out with momma as she works and cooks? Who watches movies every night with me?”

Izuku brought his hands up to his face and rested his elbows on the table, as he whispered, “Mom, please stop.”

She continued, voice so hurt, “What happened to the Izuku who understood what was safe and what wasn’t? Who listened to momma’s words? I barely recognize you anymore!”

Izuku didn't move from his position, but his voice was breaking, “What about me do you not recognize, mom? I’m still the same person. I’m still your boy,” He looked up at her then, eyes watering at her words, “I still watch movies with you, hang out with you. I’m being safe. I don’t understand. What do you not recognize?” And then his voice quietened, “Your lap dog?”

At this, Inko’s eyes widened and she goes silent for a good minute. The atmosphere in the house was completely stale, as if someone had sucked the moisture out of the entire place so it was dry and uncomfortable. Izuku probably should not have said that, but hearing her make him out to be some kind of monster hurt more than anything. She acted as if things needed to always stay the same. As if any change indicated that Izuku loved her less.

“You will never say that again, Izuku,” Inko responds quietly, “You are my *son* . It’s always been me and you. You are the only person that I have, and I care about you. That’s why I am the way that I am.”

Izuku was so sick of that reasoning, but he forced himself to be calm and not get angry at her. They sat in silence for another few minutes. At this point, Izuku was playing around with his

fork, trying to level himself.

Izuku then asked, “You know the VHS tapes you keep in the attic? From when you were growing up?”

Inko blinked at him, “...yes.”

Izuku looked at her with bright eyes and a sad smile, “When I was in middle school, I’d go up there to take some and watch them,” He glanced back down, “Because you never talked about dad. All I had were faint memories of him taking me out to ice cream, the beach, and wherever else he felt like going.”

Inko’s eyes widened, “Izuku, I put those away for a reason. We don’t need to be reminsci-”

“You and him looked so cool back in high school,” Izuku laughed gently but he was on the verge of tears, “He was always so adventurous, wasn’t he?”

“ *Too* adventurous,” Inko’s voice sounded strained, “Too much that he never knew how to sett-”

“Mom, when are you going to tell me why he left us?” Izuku asked her, hands almost shaking under the table, “Because as the days go by, I’m coming up with my own theories.”

“I don’t want to hear them,” Her voice sounded final, although she didn’t raise her pitch a bit, “And I am *not* going to talk about him. We’re here to talk about you, Izuku.”

Izuku wanted to argue. To say that the two subjects relate, but he saw something in his mother’s eyes that told him that she was not having it. When they argue, it always felt like this: so tense. Never any yelling, never shouting, screaming. Just this quiet, suppressed and dangerous aura where he felt like he had to tiptoe not to get seriously upset or make *her* seriously upset.

“I’m not allowing you to attend the Spring Dance,” Inko said, “That is my decision.”

Izuku blinked at her, and felt absolutely confused. What did that have to do with anything, “But I’m planning it.”

“You’re planning the *catering* part of it,” She corrected, “There’s no need for you to actually attend. I already called up to the school yesterday to inform them that you have matters at home that night. If you try to do what you did yesterday and go anyways, the attending adults there will text me right away.”

“You what?” Izuku stared at her. She’s never gone so far before. This was borderline insane. He asked, “But why?”

“Because you need to understand boundaries, Izuku,” Inko reached out for his hand, cupping them into hers. Izuku felt sick feeling her warm skin on his, “Actions have consequences. Not only that, but I’ve *never* wanted you to go, from the moment you entered high school. I’ve heard the Spring Dance was too wild, too crazy. I don’t need my son attending something like that! Instead, I think it’d be nicer if you stayed home with me and we can watch some movies

and have some bonding time to make up for everything." She tried to pad the punishment. Izuku was silent. It wasn't as if the dance was the most important thing in the world. But it was a basic thing that most teenagers *his* age should be allowed to attend. He already had little daydreams of the music playing, what he was going to wear, and the memories he'd come home with. He was a *senior* for goodness sake. The Spring Dance was *for* seniors, and something people looked forward to their entire time at Ise High.

Izuku just stared at her, unknowing of what to say.

"Izuku?" Inko asked as if she didn't just drop a bomb, "Can you say something?"

Izuku then begins laughing lightly and smiled at her, "Mom, what do you want me to say?"

Inko didn't have a response. Izuku looked at her funny. What did she want him to say? Hug her, tell her that she's completely right, and be grateful? Izuku was grateful for many things. It was how he was raised. But this?

Izuku got up, dishes in hand, "I'll stay home."

As if he had a choice. Izuku wonders why he couldn't bring himself to say anything else. To make her change her mind. Had she conditioned him that much to the point that he couldn't get truly rebellious if he tried?

When Izuku leaves the house to go to school that morning after the horrible encounter, he even felt pathetic for responding to her "Have a good day at school" with a false happy "Thank you."

The fact that cheerfulness was his automatic reaction, no matter how terrible he felt internally, killed him.

When Saturday's regional tournament comes around, Izuku rides with Shoto to the event. Thank god, his mother didn't restrict him going to tournaments, or else he actually would have lost it. Because being in the stands, looking out onto the track field as dozens of athletes prepare in their white tents, grabbing concession snacks in preparation, was something he's been doing for years.

When he was little, Inko would take him to see Katsuki, and he's been going ever since.

"I'm gonna go grab some food. I want a hot dog," Shoto nudged him as they weaved through a crowd outside of the mid-sized stadium, "You want anything?"

Izuku turned to his friend, "Can you get me a water and nachos please? No jalapenos."

"Got it. I'll find you," Shoto nods before heading off towards the concession stands.

Izuku walks past the gate that led inside, and stood on his tip toes to look for the entrance up to the outdoor stands. There were a fair amount of people, considering that a good number of

schools from several counties in the region were competing. The results were practically guaranteed for Katsuki to win, and everyone knew it.

From the side, Izuku felt a nudge, and he looked over and up to see Kaito. The brunette was already in uniform and he smiled down at Izuku, “Midoriya! You came to cheer me on today?” He laughs.

Izuku grins up at him, “Of course, I wish the best of luck to the team.” He puts a thumbs up.

Kaito chuckles and holds out his arm, “Are you trying to find the bleachers?”

“Yeah,” Izuku looked around, “This stadium is different from the one they usually hold the first regionals tournament at.”

Izuku lightly holds onto Kaito’s arm for politeness, even though he could very well just follow the other without doing so, and the athlete weaves through the crowd and up some stairs until they emerge outside and into the stands. It immediately got loud and bright, as they were greeted with the sun’s heat and the excitement of the crowd in the stands.

Izuku looked out. Far left were all the white tents with each school’s banner printed on top. And the athletes were huddled underneath, wrapping their hands, drinking sports drinks, and stretching.

Ise High’s tent was right in the middle, and Izuku could see their coach running around with a clipboard to each vaulter. The track field was large, and the bar was already set at the starting height.

“It’s my third time attending regionals, and I’m still nervous,” Kaito chuckled as he looked out onto the stadium.

Izuku assures him, “You’ll be fine, Kaito.”

“I’d say about half the team makes it to the second regionals tournament every year,” Kaito states, “Since this is my last year, I’m pretty determined to make it in that half.”

Izuku nods and wishes him luck, “Just focus on that goal, and I know you’ll do great.”

“Thanks,” The boy smiles, and then fishes something out of his gym bag, “Hey, you said you’d cheer me on, right?”

Izuku shakes his head, “Yes, of course!”

Pulling out a jersey with his name on the back, Kaito hands it over to Izuku, “I think this should fit. I think I’d work a little harder if I know a cutie is wearing this for me,” The boy winks at him.

Izuku’s lips parted and he slowly takes the jersey, “You were planning this, weren’t you?”

Kaito laughs, “I did. Is that embarrassing? You’re still going to wear it, right?”

The greenette smiles while rolling his eyes, and he slipped the jersey on top of his white shirt, “Since you tried so hard, I’ll wear it.”

“Great,” Kaito nods in success, “Hey, I gotta get back to the crew now. But I’ll be looking out for you, alright?”

Izuku waves bye to him, “Good luck!”

And when Shoto comes over to the bleachers with the food in hand and notices the change in attire, the mixed hair boy gives Izuku a look, to which the greenette merely shrugged.

The tournament was as fun as it usually was. Ise High sent up one representative at a time, and so far, he hadn’t seen Katsuki. Izuku made sure to notice the other teams too, since he wasn’t just interested in Katsuki, but the sport as a whole. The crowd from Ise High was the largest, since pole vault was the school’s pride and joy. They definitely were *that* crowd that annoyed everybody else. But none of them cared.

When it was Kaito’s turn to go up, Izuku made sure to cheer and get his friends to also. But since the boy was already popular, he had no problem getting cheers. His performance was actually incredible, and Izuku was happy for him. Kaito maxes out at one inch above his previous record, which earned a large whoop from the crowd.

However, there was one person who Izuku knew would hold his attention completely.

And after a couple more people, Bakugo Katsuki was up. Immediately, the crowd roared. After all, it was the legendary pole vaulter. It was in moments like these where Izuku realizes just how insanely popular Katsuki was. Everyone, even from other schools, knew him.

And if they knew him, then they knew that they were about to lose to him.

The blonde athlete steps out onto the track, and Izuku felt his heart beat faster again. There he was. His pole vault uniform was tight on his body for aerodynamics, and it hugged every muscle. Katsuki was six feet and four inches of pure adonis like energy, and power surged through his essence.

A look of determination was in those fiery eyes, and Izuku can’t describe the happiness he feels when he watches the blonde prepare. Stretching really quick, he steps into the starting area as the announcers begin to give their introduction of Katsuki, as if everyone didn’t already know him.

And when it was time to actually start the 2 minute limit, the crowd goes silent in anticipation. For many people in other teams, this will be the first time seeing Bakugo Katsuki in action this tournament season.

Katsuki stares at the ground in concentration, and Izuku notices the blonde blowing a breath out of his mouth to focus. Izuku knew he was not nervous, since the max heights for the 1st regionals were usually around the 15 or 16 feet range.

And then Izuku notices, and it brings a small swell of joy into his heart. On Katsuki's left wrist, he had the inverted sweatband wrapped around it like a bracelet cuff. Izuku had expected the blonde to take it off, but there he was, wearing it inside out for a tournament. Izuku wanted to pump his fist in success, before watching his runs begin.

And of course, Katsuki sweeps the tournament easily. Again, he does not jump near his previous official record. Everyone else maxed out before then, so there was no need for him to vault higher. Every time he cleared a bar, the crowd absolutely loses it. Because to hear about a legend and to see a legend in person are two different experiences. Every time he watches, Izuku felt as if it was for the very first time.

In the end, an incredible ¾ of Ise High's pole vault team make it the second regionals. And Izuku sees the entire team jumping together in shared excitement when the results come out. Katsuki was hoisted into the air, and Izuku laughed from afar.

The energy was high, and when people began to file out of the stadium at a snail's pace, Izuku and Shoto wait so that they do not get caught trying to leave in the intense traffic. And so he and his friend sit there for a while and talked while they wait for it to get a bit more empty. And once most of the traffic left the stadium, that was when Izuku and Shoto began heading down the stairs.

"I'm gonna take a shit," Shoto tells him, "The hot dog was not pleasant going down."

Izuku snorts, "Take your time."

And stands off to the side as he gets on his phone and waits.

A couple of people pass him. Mostly athletes who are just now packing up and leaving in little groups. The ones that he knows stops to greet him briefly before heading out. Izuku wishes he wasn't waiting for Katsuki, but he definitely was looking around the corner here and there.

And when he finally sees a hint of blonde spikey hair turn a corner, Izuku looks back down at his phone and pretends that he didn't notice. God, he felt so pathetic and was going to make fun of himself later for this.

"Nerd," Katsuki called out, and Izuku felt a little more excited than he wanted to be.

Izuku pretended to suddenly look up in surprise, "Kacchan!"

The athlete was still in uniform, with his gym bag slung over his shoulder, as he walked towards the shorter, "Check out this sick trophy."

Katsuki unzips his bag really quick so that Izuku could look at the glass trophy, and the greenette eyes him, "Kacchan, I don't think you should shove a glass trophy in your gym bag."

The blonde shrugged, "It'll survive. And if not, I have a million more."

Izuku shook his head at the arrogance, “If you’re not going to take care of it, I’ll be very happy to adopt the trophy.”

Katsuki smirked at him, “So you can put it in your shrine?”

Izuku flushed red, “I feel like at this point, I should just say yes.”

“You might as well, shitnerd,” Katsuki ruffles his hair before noticing something.

With an odd look, Katsuki’s hands travelled down to the jersey on Izuku’s body and he eyes it before looking back at Izuku, “Whose is this?”

Izuku looked down at the jersey, and had completely forgotten. Still, he glanced back up at Katsuki, “Oh! It’s Kaito’s. He wanted me to wear it to cheer him on.”

Katsuki looks off to the side and tongues his cheek, eyes blank. Izuku looks concerningly up at the taller male, and reaches out for the edge of Katsuki’s uniform shirt.

“Kacchan?” Izuku asked.

The blonde then turned to look at him, “Wear mine next time.”

Izuku blinked up at him, and his mouth gaped. He stammered, “What?”

“Wear mine next time,” Katsuki repeated, eyes staring him down.

Izuku was confused, “You w-want me to actually wear it?”

Katsuki had made fun of him for having it in the first place, and now he wanted him to wear it? Izuku stared wide-eyed up at the blonde.

“Fuck,” Katsuki tongued his cheek again as if holding himself back from saying something, and then stepped forward until he was staring directly down at Izuku. The greenette tilts his head up in surprise, and puts a hand out on Katsuki’s chest to keep them from touching so close. But the blonde pushed forward and lifts the jersey slightly, “That Fuck Face really annoys the shit out of me you know.”

Izuku felt like he couldn’t breathe, as the intense gaze stays on him, “Kacchan, j-just because he annoys you, doesn’t mean he annoys me.”

“I know,” The blonde looks off to the side, before moving his gaze back down to Izuku’s, and then lets go of the jersey, “This just fucking pisses me off.”

Izuku finds it curious. Is he… He felt nervous asking, “Kacchan, are you...jealous?”

Katsuki rolls his eyes, “Don’t be fucking stupid, Deku. Didn’t you hear me the other week? I don’t give a fuck who you sleep with.”

Oh. Izuku didn’t like that he wishes Katsuki *did* care. Because he knew that he sure did.

Katsuki continued, “I just don’t want that bastard’s name on your back.”

Izuku pursed his lips, “So if I wear yours, I’ll just be trading in one bastard’s name for another’s.”

Katsuki raised a brow and then lifted Izuku’s chin with one hand, “So you know how to be fucking cheeky now, huh.”

Izuku’s face is red from the contact, but he still lets out a, “You’re a bad influence on me.”

“And you still choose to see me three times a week,” Katsuki challenges him and lets go of his chin.

Izuku and Katsuki keep each other’s stares for a while, before Izuku just rolls his eyes.

“You’re right. So Thursday? Are you free?” Izuku laughs.

Katsuki backs off then, and shakes his head while flicking Izuku on the side of the head playfully, “You’re fucking getting on my nerves,” Katsuki comments before answering, “But yeah. I gotta pick up a suit I’m getting tailored after practice. But after that, I’m free.”

“Great, I got an idea,” Izuku grins.

“Finally,” Katsuki snorts, “I’m carrying our partnership here.”

“It’s not my fault,” Izuku frowns.

“I was serious about what I said earlier you know,” Katsuki reminds him, “Wear mine, next time.”

Izuku took a pause, and then laughed lightly. Before nodding, “Fine then.”

Katsuki then looks around, “You waiting for a ride?”

Izuku shakes his head, “No, I came here with Shoto. But he’s taking care of some business in the bathroom right now.”

“Gross. Was it the hotdogs?” Katsuki asked, knowingly.

Nodding furiously, Izuku replies, “Yeah! How’d you know?”

“Denki,” Katsuki laughs.

The following week passes by quickly as well. It felt almost unfair that Izuku still had to help plan the dance that was coming up on Friday, yet he wasn’t allowed to attend.

Things at home have been in a state of limbo. He couldn’t tell if his mother was good with him or not, and the tension was still hanging in the air despite their conversations being relatively normal. The weather was getting more humid by the day, yet it still has yet to rain

once in Ise. The rainy month was due to come soon though, Izuku knew, so he just had to wait.

Izuku occasionally spent his free period with Mr. Toshinori during his office hours, helping the teacher out with things or just talking to him. It was Wednesday, and Izuku was currently biting into his snack, a red bean bun, as he and Mr. Toshinori just caught up on life or talked about some random topics.

“Oh! Also, Mr. Toshinori,” Izuku mentioned, “I didn’t know you used to body build.”

The frail man laughed, “I also used to be pretty well trained in martial arts. How did you know that though? I don’t exactly make it known.”

Izuku finished his last bite, “Kacchan told me he saw old pictures of you online.”

“Young Bakugo?” Mr. Toshinori considered this, “Speaking of, how is the project going? Have you kept a journal?”

Izuku looked apologetic, “No we haven’t. I don’t really need to. I remember just about every detail.”

“I assume that’s a good thing?” The teacher chuckled.

The greenette looked off the side and bit his lip, “I can barely tell anymore.”

His teacher considered that response, “How so?”

Izuku didn’t exactly know how to explain it. How could he define the juxtaposition of emotions he’s feeling? The emotions that have been overwhelming him like a flood he couldn’t have ever prepared for? How could he explain the confusion of being grateful, mesmerized, and more alive than he’s ever been, being around Katsuki, while also being terrified, nervous, and in absolute pain at the fact that he could feel his thoughts towards the blonde morphe into something much, much more deep.

Quietly, Izuku asked his teacher without asking, “Why did you have to pair us up, Mr. Toshinori…”

The man in question looked concerned for a moment, “Is Bakugo treating you badly?”

Izuku shakes his head, and looks up at his teacher with a mixture of sadness and happiness in his eyes, “Most people might not believe it, but he’s been treating me great. He’s still Kacchan. He doesn’t coddle me, act happy-go-lucky, or is sweet by any means, but…” Izuku can’t believe he’s saying this, “...but it’s perfect.”

Mr. Toshinori nodded, then asked slightly confused, “Then, if I may ask, what is the problem.”

At this, Izuku laughs with a bit of pain in his tone, “The problem is that it will end. You heard the condition we agreed on that day in class,” Izuku reminded him, “The problem is that he

took me up into the sky, and now I'm afraid to go back onto the ground and be without him," Izuku's hands felt like shaking as he says it, "I sound stupid, don't I?"

Mr. Toshinori goes quiet, as he watches his student stare down at his empty hands.

And then, Izuku shaking tries to admit, "The problem is that I think that I'm feeling more than I should."

The psychology teacher then inches forward to place a hand on Izuku's shoulder, causing the greenette to look up into kind eyes, "If you're going to feel it regardless of whether you want to," The teacher began, "Then just embrace it. Life gets easier when you learn to accept that you can only control your emotions so much."

Izuku shook his head and smiled gently, "It's not that easy."

"Who said it was?" Mr. Toshinori humored.

Izuku just shrugged the conversation off, "Anyways, I don't think I want to talk about this right now," He shrugs nervously, "It already occupies my mind 75% of the time."

"That's fine," The teacher nodded understandingly, "Take your time. How are preparations for the dance coming along?"

Izuku shakes his head, "Oh no, don't get me started. Gina, the head of the decorations team, keeps on trying to boss my team around, and that's not even her job! But I just kind of shrugged it off. I'm sure she doesn't mean to."

And soon enough, the conversation was back on track to something less disheartening.

Izuku tells his teacher more about the comics that he's been reading, and the man replies with just as much enthusiasm. He really enjoyed Mr. Toshinori's company, and in a way, the man made up for the lack of a father figure Izuku's had, but eventually, the teacher had to get some things completed for his next class before the office hour period was over.

"Midoriya, could you take this to the copy room for me really quick and get me about 24 copies?" Mr. Toshinori handed him a packet of notes.

Izuku takes it out of his hand and nods, "Of course!"

Izuku exited the classroom and headed down several corridors. The copy room was on the far west wing of Ise High, and honestly, was always a little sketchy. Since it was hidden away behind some corridors, it was relatively isolated from the busy hallways and what not.

Izuku holds the papers close to his chest as he passes the almost maze-like hallways. Up ahead, he would have to turn a couple of small corridors before he would reach the copy room.

But as he neared the turns, Izuku paused in his footsteps. Because he was hearing voices, in which one was too awfully familiar. He steps a bit closer. And Izuku's stomach turns upside down.

As he got closer, the sound was definitely people getting something on. Maybe not *full* on, but something was happening, judging from the giggling, the sounds. That wasn't the problem. The issue was that Izuku could recognize one of their voices.

It became clear as day once Izuku got closer, and his heart was beating fast as he clutches the papers so tightly that it wrinkles. The breathing, the words, they all belonged to a voice Izuku hears in his dreams. He knew what was going on, and yet, Izuku still walked forwards towards the sounds, which were mixed with the labored breathing and high-pitched giggling here and there.

Izuku felt his fingers tremble a little bit and he bit his tongue as hard as he could to push down his emotions. But those twisting gut sensations began to hammer in.

As he turned the corner, seeing it made it worse. And only solidified to Izuku's mind exactly why he has to get rid of these growing emotions that he's been experiencing lately. Because it would never end well. Not with someone like Katsuki.

Who at the current moment had someone against the wall, with his large build leaning over her. Izuku didn't even bother to look who it was, because all he could see was Katsuki looking at someone else, hands on someone else. The girl would pull him down to say something, giggle, before kissing the blonde. Her hands traveled down to his waistband, and played with it.

"We could do it *here* , you know," She teased him.

Katsuki smirked, "I can't get kicked out. Got a future and all that shit," As his hands played with the fabric of her shirt.

Izuku felt like he couldn't breathe. He wished he was anywhere but there. Absolutely anywhere else. He couldn't stand to watch anymore, and Izuku bit his tongue tightly to distract himself from thinking.

Forcing his legs to move, Izuku walked forward trying to get past the two of them. He couldn't get the image of Katsuki out of his head: the one that whisked him away at night, who taught him how to pole vault, who sneaks into his room just to play video games. And then, the image in front of him just makes it hurt even more when thinking back to those moments.

Because it reminded Izuku that at the end of the day, Izuku was just *Deku* . The boy Katsuki hung out with, and nothing else.

It wasn't Katsuki's fault. Katsuki was not obligated to do anything, and it would be unfair of Izuku to want him to be a certain way when he just wasn't.

At the sound of someone approaching, the girl jumps back and yelps. Izuku glances briefly at her, and recognizes her to be someone from one of his extracurricular activities, but he

couldn't recall her name. Katsuki moves his head carelessly to look at who it was, but Izuku doesn't turn his head at all to see what kind of expression the other had when he realized.

"Midoriya?" The girl apparently knew *his* name, "God, you scared me! I thought you were a teacher or something."

Izuku looked down at the ground as he tried to shuffle past, "Sorry," He said softly.

But she didn't let it go, "Hey," She called out, "You're not going to snitch or anything, right? Aren't you, like, kind of a killjoy?"

That kind of hurt, because she wouldn't be the first to call him a goodie-two shoes, and she wouldn't be the last.

"Oi," Izuku heard Katsuki's voice warn her, "Don't call him that."

Izuku, without thinking, turns to Katsuki, avoiding those ruby eyes that always seemed to ignite a fire in his soul, "Kacchan, it's fine." His voice was gentle, in an attempt to not let it crack.

"I don't care if you fucking think it's fine," Katsuki tells him, but Izuku looked away by now, "Y-"

"Just please leave," Izuku let out in a small voice, "I'm trying to copy some papers, and you're in my way."

The blonde goes silent, and Izuku doesn't bother looking at him. He knew that if he faces him, it'll be obvious. It'll be so obvious how he's feeling, because his eyes always revealed everything.

After a moment of uncomfortable silence, Katsuki walks away first. Not bothering to take the girl with him, who doesn't take long to follow, calling out after the blonde.

Izuku numbly walks forward until he reaches the copy room. And then, as he waits for the papers to copy, Izuku leans over the machine and bites his lip hard in order not to cry. *You can't do this, Izuku* . He tells himself. *You can't want him* . He forces himself. *Anyon* e *but him* . Izuku didn't want to cry, not here, not now.

Izuku walked around school that day looking like an absolute mess. His hair was tustled from being grabbed out of frustration from his own fingers. His eyes were distant, and he obviously looked distracted. His friends had asked him what was wrong, but Izuku refused to admit it. He didn't want to feel any of these things.

As the greenette now walks down a relatively empty hallway after school to get to the gym, where all of the dance set-up was, Izuku's lips were in a permanent frown.

He hadn't even noticed someone was walking towards him until he heard a voice call out his name and jog up to him.

“Midoriya!” Kaito waves, “Are you headed to the gymnasium?”

Izuku nods his head with little energy, “Yeah. Are you on your way to practice?”

Kaito confirms with a head nod, “Sure am,” Then he notices the state of Izuku, “Hey, what’s up with the mood?”

Izuku blinks and purses his lips, “Sorry, I’ve just had a weird day.”

Kaito takes in the information, “A good weird or a bad weird?”

Izuku laughs gently, “I’d say a bad weird, but I’ll be okay.”

“Hm,” Kaito thinks on it, “Any chance I can help?”

The greenette smiles at Kaito’s attempt, “I’m not sure you can help with this one, Kaito.”

“Not even…” Kaito slyly leans over to Izuku, “If I take you out on a date tomorrow night? I promise I can make you smile.”

“I smile a lot already,” Izuku points out teasingly, “It’s not very hard to do, Kaito. I think you need to up your game.”

“Awe come on,” Kaito pretended to be wounded, “Give me a chance. I’ll wine and dine you, and if I’m lucky, I’ll get a kiss at the end of the night. And hey, if it goes further, I won’t mind.” He raises both of his hands.

Izuku shakes his head in amusement, “What a tempting offer.”

Wining and dining didn’t interest Izuku that much. It was sweet, but didn’t give Izuku the breathtaking feeling he got when he explored the woods or swam in the lake underneath the stars.

That being said, Izuku wonders if this was what he needed. A distraction, or a chance to make his feelings for a certain blonde go away. If nothing else, he might even get himself an outlet for sexual frustration, not that he wanted to use Kaito like that. Although Izuku respected people’s choices and sexual freedom, Izuku just wasn’t the type to do that kind of thing without a second thought.

“Tempting enough to say yes?” Kaito crosses his fingers.

Izuku considers it, “Tomorrow is Thursday, right? What time? I have to hang out with Kacchan for a little bit for the project, but after that, I’ll be good.” He’ll just tell his mother it’s running late.

“Bakugo, huh,” Kaito takes that into account, “How about 8? I’ll pick you up from where you and Mr. Perfect are. Just text me where.”

Izuku pursed his lips, but then nodded, “Okay.”

“It’s a date, then?” Kaito asked.

Izuku bounced on his feet a little, before nodding, “It’s a date.”

When Thursday came, Izuki dropped into the practice track as he usually did, with a bottle of Gatorade in his hand. The blonde athlete was already performing his runs, and Izuku’s heart beat again. Several thoughts flashed through his brain. The first was that *wow* , the boy was absolutely incredible. The second was the images of what happened yesterday, which caused a sensation of kicking pain in his gut.

They still haven’t talked since then. Not that Izuku was actively avoiding him, but they just haven’t seen each other.

And then the third thought was Izuku hating the fact that despite everything, he was still too fucking happy to be hanging out with the athlete again today. Because no matter how he felt, they still were friends, even if neither of them had actually said it. And friends had fun with each other, as he always did with Katsuki.

Usually, when Izuku would come in during solo practice, the blonde would ignore him until he was on a break. But this time, when Katsuki notices Izuku settle down on the bench, the athlete drops his pole and saunters over to the shorter male.

Izuku, slightly surprised, looks up with wide eyes at Katsuki.

The blonde had a slightly irritated look on his face, “Oi, you ever going to tell me what the fuck was going on with you yesterday?”

Izuku’s mouth gaped, and he looked away quickly, “What do you mean?”
Izuku thought he handled himself pretty well at what had happened.

“You acted like someone fucking kicked a damn cat,” Katsuki told him, “Didn’t even fucking look at me when you spoke. And then you took shit from the bitch.”

“Keep in mind, this is the same ‘bitch’ you are having sex with,” Izuku reminds him, feeling his tongue dry at those words.

“I didn’t fuck her,” Katsuki snapped, and Izuku looked up at him with confused eyes.

Izuku found himself asking, “Why?”

Katsuki looked taken off guard by the question, but then barked out a gruff, “That’s not for you to worry about, shitnerd. And you  never answered the damn question. What the hell was wrong with you.”

Izuku bit his lip, not willing to divulge. And so, he just tells the other, “I just had a bad morning.” Which wasn’t necessarily true.

At this, Katsuki's expression seemed to soften just a little bit, and the athlete looked over to the side, before walking off, "Tell me more about it after practice."

"Don't you have to pick up a suit?" Izuku calls out after him.

"Fuck," Katsuki remembered, "Then tell me when I pick you up to do whatever it was that you wanted to do. I'm not forgetting. You better tell me, you little shit." He said before picking up his pole.

Izuku smiles to himself. If nothing else, then he knew that in his own way, Katsuki cared. Even if it wasn't in a conventional way. Even if it was as a partner or a friend, the blonde was concerned about how he felt, even if he was the cause of it.

Izuku gets ready for both his hangout with Katsuki and the date with Kaito when he gets home. It probably wasn't the best idea that they were back to back, but he knew he wouldn't really be allowed to go out so easily with someone who his mother didn't know yet. Katsuki had texted him that he'll pick him up after he grabs the suit from the tailor, which wouldn't take too long.

And so, Izuku stands in his room, forced to dress himself instead of having his friends do it for him. Izuku stands there in just his underwear, wondering where to start. He didn't have a *lot* of non-basic clothes, but he was sure he had some pieces in his closet somewhere that would pair nicely.

Ultimately, after about thirty minutes of contemplating, the greenette settles on a pair of light-washed jeans that tapered at the ankles and seemed a little too tight on him, and on top, he wore a white silk long-sleeved shirt on top that was tucked loosely into his pants, giving him a more effortless but beautiful look. The top couple of buttons were left undone, to reveal a smooth expanse of skin. He looked put together enough. It wasn't anything intense, but it will work for a date.

And when he walks out the door to wait on the porch, he's thankful that the sky looks beautiful today. It was perfect for what he wanted to show Katsuki. As the blonde had mentioned before, there weren't many places in Ise that the blonde hadn't already been to. And so, like the drive-in theatre, Izuku's suggestions usually had to be a bit more out of the box. He wonders if the boy will like it.

And when the black Audi A8 pulls up to his house, Izuku walks the familiar path across his grass to the passenger door. From the rolled down windows, Izuku could see that the boy had Ray-Ban aviator sunglasses on, and there was music playing from the speakers, as usual. It was What's Love Got To Do With It by Tina Turner. Izuku personally did not like the intro of the song, but the chorus was instantly recognizable by just about everyone. Again, Izuku wonders how Katsuki could listen to all of these classic 80s love songs, and not understand what any of the emotions described in the songs mean or feel like.

Izuku opens the passenger door, and slides in, pulling his seatbelt on automatically.

“Kacchan!” Izuku greets, excited for what he has planned, “Did the suit come out fine?”

Instead of replying to him, Katsuki simply took a look over at Izuku. At the silence, the greenette pauses then turns to Katsuki for a response. Through the aviator glasses, he could still see the blonde’s eyes give him a look up and down with furrowed brows. Izuku suddenly felt very shy.

Katsuki then stated, “This is different.” Gesturing to Izuku’s outfit.

Izuku nervously chuckles and scratched the back of his head, “It’s not bad, is it?”

Looking back onto the road, the blonde put the car in drive and pulled forward onto the street, “No,” Katsuki admits with an indifferent tone even though he just implied Izuku looked nice, “What’s it for, nerd.”

Izuku suddenly felt weird about admitting it, as if it was wrong to, but he shifts in his seat, “I have a date later.”

Katsuki raises a brow and glanced over at Izuku, “A date, huh.”

Izuku nods, and then kind of just sat there quietly in his seat. Katsuki didn’t say anything either, just driving around for a little bit. Even though they didn’t actually have a destination put in.

Finally, the blonde asked him, “With who.”

Izuku thinks this was probably what he was most nervous about. Telling Katsuki who it was. But then he thought to himself, why did he have to be nervous. It shouldn’t matter to him.

“With Kaito,” Izuku tells him.

And Katsuki, oddly enough, doesn’t say anything snarky. Instead, the boy keeps on driving forward, not glancing over at Izuku. His expression was neutral, and Izuku doesn’t know why that almost disappointed him.

When the athlete speaks up again, he simply tells Izuku, “So Fuck Face finally got what he wanted. Good for him,” And then he slaps the steering wheel sarcastically with every word as he repeats, “Good. For. Him.”

Izuku looked over at him with slight concern, “Kacchan?”

“What is it,” Katsuki says, head leaning back against his seat as he drives.

The greenette fidgets with his thumb, “Is everything okay?”

The blonde nods, then reaches a hand out to ruffle Izuku’s hair, “Yeah. Why wouldn’t there be, nerd. Anyways, where are we going? I’ve been aimlessly driving.”

“Oh!” Izuku forgot to tell the other, “First, can we go to the grocery store? To pick up some snacks?”

Katsuki raised a brow, wondering what it was they needed snacks for, but shrugs, “Yeah.”

What should have been a ten minute grocery store run turned into an hour one. How in the world that happened could only be explained by Katsuki and Izuku. What was *supposed* to happen was that they drop in, grab things off of the shelves, pay, and then head out to wherever they were going next.

But what actually happened was that they were practically children, and the moment Katsuki saw in the fresh produce aisle that they had stalks of aloe vera over a foot long, the blonde ran over there and grabbed one. Holding it from the flat end, Katsuki pointed the sharp end at Izuku and announced an *en guarde* right then and there.

Quick to defend himself, Izuku grabbed one too, and pointed it right back at Katsuki. And there, they proceeded to have a sword fight with aloe vera stalks right there in the grocery store. The only reason they stopped was because a worker had came up to them, saying that they now had to pay for the two stalks since they were messing with it.

And so now, there were two aloe vera stalks in their cart that neither of the boys knew what to do with.

The second reason why the grocery run took so long was because they stopped by the bread section to argue what kind of bread was the best, even though neither of them planned on purchasing bread. The little argument caused a bit of a commotion, and no one around them could expect that they’d come to the grocery store to hear debates on whether whole wheat or white bread tasted better.

The actual process of picking out snacks barely took any time. Izuku and Katsuki respectively picked their own drinks. The greenette grabbed a soda pop, while Katsuki just took another sports drink. Grabbing some bags of chips, candy for Izuku, and grain bars for Katsuki, they finally got around to checking out, earning looks from the workers.

“I’m surprised we weren’t banned from there,” Izuku commented when they exited the store. The sky outside was a pretty pink, and washed over all of the clouds beautifully.

Katsuki was pushing the shopping cart towards his car, “I’m more concerned about what the fuck we’re supposed to do with these aloe vera stalks.”

And as they load the snacks into the back, Katsuki holds up the stalks as if conflicted.

Izuku laughs and just grabs them to put them down, “Just give them to me. I’m sure my mom could use it to grow something. They’re good for sunburns!”

“Who the fuck even gets sunburnt in Ise,” Katsuki asks as he closes the trunk, “It’s always goddamn sunny here. We’re all used to it.”

“Unless you’re my mother and I,” Izuku points out.

“Right,” Katsuki snorts, “I forgot Auntie’s a homebody. And you were too, before I corrupted your nerd ass.”

Izuku elbowed him, “Why do you have to say it like that? It makes me feel like I’m a demon or something.”

“You are,” Katsuki flicks the side of his head, and Izuku frowns, but Katsuki gestured to Izuku, “Get in.”

They were still outside, with Katsuki holding the shopping cart, so Izuku was confused, “Uh, where? The car?”

“The shopping cart,” Katsuki told him.

Izuku narrowed his eyes at the taller, but decided to just go with it. He’s past questioning the weird things that Katsuki wanted to do. And so, holding onto the sides, Izuku hoisted his body into the cart, which fit well, and he held his knees up to his body.

Suddenly, the acceleration picked up as Katsuki started pushing him while running with the cart in front of him. Izuku yelled, and held onto the sides. But the athlete just cackled, as he ran through the parking lot of the strip of stores, towards the cart corrals. Above them, the pink skies made their skin glow orange, and Izuku’s laugh mixed with some yelps at bumps on the asphalt filled the air.

And then, as they approached the cart corral with plenty of carts already in it, Katsuki lets go with one last push, and Izuku was rolling with the momentum the cart already had.

The greenette yelled out, “Kacchan, what the hell! The cart’s going to crash. Come back, I hate you!”

Katsuki yelled back, “You’ll be fine!”

Izuku turns back around, gripping tightly onto the sides of the cart, as it heads towards the other ones. And upon impact, the sounds of a dozen carts all pushing together was scary, and Izuku was afraid he was going to tip over while inside, but he was just tussled a little bit.

Feeling vengeful, Izuku hopped out of the cart and pulled it back out.

Shouting for Katsuki to get in, Izuku demanded, “Kacchan! Your turn. Get in.”

“You shitnerd,” Katsuki points at the cart, “You think my legs are going to fucking fit in that? If you haven’t forgotten, I’m 6’4.”

“I don’t care,” Izuku pushed the cart against Katsuki’s hip, “Get in, now!”

Grumbling, Katsuki hoisted himself in, and it looked awkward with his larger body trying to fit inside of the shopping cart.

Izuku was determined to make this hurt, and so the greenette began running around the parking lot, pushing the cart with the blonde inside. He went in circles and bumps, so that the

athlete yelled at him everytime he didn't slow down before a speedbump, but Izuku merely cackled like a psycho.

"That's enough, Deku!" Katsuki shouted over the velocity of Izuku's running.

The boy in question asked, "Are you sure, now?"

"Yes, fucking stop. I'm gonna hurl," Katsuki warned him with a yell.

"If you say so!" Izuku said, while swiveling the cart so that it was headed towards a pothole on the ground. It would flip over for sure. And then, he let go, sending Katsuki hurling towards it.

The blonde looked back at the green eyed boy and threw his middle finger up, "You piece of shit, Deku! I didn't do this to you, stop the cart *now* or I'll tell everyone you sleep with an All Might plushie."

"They probably could already guess," Izuku shouted back as he laughed.

And when Katsuki turns around, the cart was feet away from falling into the pothole. Shouting *fuck, fuck, fuck,* Katsuki got up on his feet, holding the sides of the cart, and then right before it crashed, hopped off and rolled on the ground once. Right then, the cart flipped over, and Katsuki gaped at it.

Then, the athlete began running towards Izuku at full speed, and the greenette, once he stopped laughing, barely had time to react before he was tackled off the ground and lifted into the air upside down, similar to how Katsuki first handled him on their very first project hang out.

"You trying to fucking kill me, you evil shit?" Katsuki playfully berated him, "And to think everyone at school thinks you're a perfect sweet little angel."

Izuku was upside down over Katsuki's shoulder, and still laughing, the greenette used the position to his advantage to try to pants Katsuki, which earned him a hit on the side of his thighs.

"Kacchan, okay okay!" Izuku tapped on Katsuki's shoulder, "Put me down! All the blood is moving to my brain!"

"Good," Katsuki barks out a laugh, "Maybe then, there will be something in your brain."

Izuku kicks in the air, "That's so mean, Kacchan!"

Katsuki then sets him down when they got back to the car, and tells the boy to get in. Izuku, still smiling to himself, gets in the side door and buckles up.

"So we got snacks," Katsuki gestures towards the back, "Now where are we headed."

Izuku suddenly gets nervous, "It sounds a little stupid, so I'm gonna direct you there."

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “Again? You pulled this shit last time.”

“Yeah, well,” Izuku shrugs, “I don’t want you to judge my suggestion before we get there.”

“Fine,” Katsuki turns towards him, turning the car on, “What road am I hitting.”

Izuku then grins, “A left on McLean Boulevard.”

Izuku ends up directing them on the East end of Ise, more inland and away from the coast. The greenette tells him turn by turn directions, and Katsuki follows them all the way until they approach a pretty flat paved area on their right side. It was an airport runway, for Ise’s local airport that only flew to about ten locations.

“The airport?” Katsuki asked as he took notice, “The fuck are we doing here?”

Izuku ignores him and points in the near distance, “Over that bend, make a roundabout and get off the road on top of the hill.”

Katsuki does so, driving up on higher ground. And then, at a hill, Izuku tells him to pull off the road and onto the grass, backing his car as that the trunk was facing the airport runway on the side of the road. No one seemed to be taking this road, for there was a newer airport road on the other side that people more commonly used.

When Katsuki puts the car in park, Izuku unbuckles his seatbelt and gets out of the car, going into the back into he could open the trunk. A moment later, Katsuki does the same, and watches as Izuku moves the snacks to the side and tosses the aloe vera over into the back seat.

And then, the greenette turns around and sits on the edge of the trunk, legs dangling off the sides of the car, and pats the spot next to him.

Katsuki looks at him weird, but sits down anyways, “As I was saying, why the fuck are we at the airport?”

Izuku just smiles at Katsuki, before looking down at his hands, feeling a bit shy as he confesses, “Because...you said you liked them.”

“What, the airport?” Katsuki tries to recall when he had said this.

“No, airplanes,” Izuku laughs airily. Katsuki had said so the evening when they had watched the movie, not to mention Izuku saw the two model planes in the boy’s room.

And then, Izuku looks out. From their position on top of the small hill, they had a perfect view of the small airport’s runway during sunset. A plane had recently took off, and it looked so large as it flies overhead. And currently, one was preparing to move onto the runway. Above them, the sky was deepening its pink and oranges, as the sun continues to set.

Katsuki then looks out too, tilting his head up just in time to see the previous plane passing right above them, leaving a trail of gas in its path. And then at the one preparing to take off.

And the blonde's eyes widened. Izuku watched Katsuki, rather than the sight, and saw a glimmer of awe in those ruby eyes. And his breath hitched. He kept digging a deeper hole for himself, and yet, in moments like these, he doesn't mind digging deeper.

The car was parked, but not completely turned off. And so, Katsuki's playlist was still running. Izuku recognized the beautiful voice of Kenny Rogers singing Lady in the background.

And he wonders how the next lyrics could be so perfect for the moment. As he stares at Katsuki looking out at the sight in awe, he finds himself lip syncing the next line. *You have gone, and made me such a fool.* He hates how he felt those words from the bottom of his soul.

Katsuki then relaxes back into the seat, and looks over at the shorter male, who then looks away, "You've said that before. You noticed that?"

Izuku glances back at him then, eyes big, "Hm? Said what?"

Katsuki makes a slight gesture, "At the drive in. You've said that before."

The greenette then remembers. At the drive in, when Katsuki had asked why they were there, Izuku had almost the exact same response. *Because you said you liked it* . Realizing it now, Izuku finds it funny, yet in a way, sweet. Because Izuku, during every time they hung out, felt as if he was the one experiencing something so incredible, so new. He loved everything, and Katsuki opened his eyes to how beautiful life can be, even if it wasn't intentional. Yet, it was also important to Izuku that the blonde also gets to be the one that experiences this kind of awe and surprise once in a while, when Izuku has some kind of idea. And so, he regrets nothing.

"Ah, I have," Izuku then admits before looking out again at the scene. The plane that had been preparing to take off was beginning to run faster. They both turn to watch it take off.

Katsuki watches silently, with the music in the background setting the frame, and they sat side by side as the flying machine takes flight. Izuku could see how as a little kid, these things mesmerized Katsuki enough to want to fly too. Finally, Izuku reaches back and grabbed some of the snacks and tossed them to Katsuki.

Katsuki popped a bag of chips open, and told the other, "This shitty picnic ain't that bad."

Izuku rolls his eyes with a grin, "You can just say that it's nice, you know."

"But what's the fun in that," Katsuki reasoned, as he leans back to watch the runway some more.

Izuku cracks his soda pop open, and takes a sip, holding the glass bottle between his fingers with one leg rested up on the trunk, "Have you ever been on an airplane before?"

Katsuki hums, “I’ve travelled here and there with the old hag and pops, yeah. You?”

Izuku shakes his head no, “Once or twice with my dad when I was tiny, but not since then.”

The blonde then turns his head slightly to look at Izuku, who meets his gaze, “You remember much of him?”

The green eyed boy shrugs, “Just things here and there.”

That conversation drops there, and Katsuki instead points out a plane that was parked in the distance, “You see that one right there?”

Izuku cranes his necks, before nodding.

“I got a model of that in my room. I fucking love it,” Katsuki grinned, and Izuku liked seeing the blonde sound so adolescent and carefree like this.

“I saw it,” Izuku informs the other, “You got two, right?”

“Sure do,” And then the athlete paused, taking a moment before asking Izuku cautiously, “Oi, what else did you see on the drawer.”

Izuku’s mind immediately flashed back to the photos on top of the drawer. The one of him and Katsuki when they were young, and he doesn’t voice it.

“Nothing,” Izuku tells him, “I just saw the models on top of it. What’s the other one?”

Katsuki then takes a large gulp from his sports drink, “It’s a Gemina A82 jet plane. They definitely don’t have it here.”

“Hm,” Izuku leans back on his arms, “Where do they have those?”

“In Germany,” Katsuki informs him.

And then, Izuku sits there and watches both Katsuki and the planes as the blonde then goes on a ramble to him about airplanes. It seemed like a hobby and interest that Katsuki hasn’t actually touched too much into since he was little, and has since grown out of it. But reminiscing cool facts from when he was younger seemed to excite the blonde, for Izuku smiles as he sees Katsuki’s red eyes light up once he would recall something interesting.

“The old hag takes fashion way too fucking seriously,” Katsuki said at one point when they began talking about him picking up a suit earlier, “So I was practically forced to get mine tailored for the dance. On the bright side, I look fucking incredible.”

Izuku figured that Katsuki was probably right, “What color is it?”

“You’ll see it at the dance, idiot,” Katsuki finished his drink, “Why the fuck are you asking now.”

Izuku sighed and swung his legs off the side of the car, “Oh, I’m not actually going.”

“The fuck?” Katsuki commented, “Aren’t you on the planning committee?”

“Yeah, it’s a little unfair, right?” Izuku laughs, “Guess what happened.”

“I’d bet $100 it was Auntie,” Katsuki snorts.

Izuku looked out, “And you’d be right.”

“You can’t just sneak out or something?” Katsuki suggested.

Izuku shook his head, “She said she called the school so that she’ll be informed if anyone sees me there.”

“That’s actually fucking psycho, Deku,” Katsuki frowned.

Izuku shrugged, not wanting to talk badly of his mother, “She means well. But it’s a shame,” Izuku smiled over at Katsuki, “I bet you do look pretty handsome with that suit.”

Katsuki just met his eye, and Izuku wondered if he should have said that at all. It had slipped out, and Izuku didn’t know where the confidence came from. Those ruby eyes held his for a moment, before the blonde looks back to the airfield.

“It’s a classic black,”  Katsuki then says.

“Hm?” Izuku asked out of confusion.

The blonde still doesn’t turn towards him, “You asked what color it was, didn’t you? It’s a classic black.”

“Oh,” Izuku takes into consideration, “Do you know how to dance?”

Katsuki snorts, “Of course, I do. Why. Don’t tell me you don’t.”

Izuku laughs, “I don’t. I was really looking forward to the dance. I was hoping I could learn before then, but I guess there’s no need to now.”

Katsuki takes this into consideration, “Maybe you could go to an afterparty. There’d be no one to snitch on you.”

“Maybe,” Izuku shrugged, “But things are a bit tense. I don’t want to risk it right now.”

“Suit yourself,” Katsuki said indifferently, “Oi, Deku.”

“Yes?” Izuku looked over.

Katsuki then pointed towards a plane in the distance, “Ain’t that one ugly? Who the fuck paints a plane lime green.”

Izuku frowned and defended it, “What’s wrong with green?”

And every time the conversation topic shifted, it was so smooth, without a lapse in space. Everything felt so natural, and Izuku could sit here for an eternity. Listening to the music, watching the planes take off underneath the stunning Ise sunset, and having good conversation with Katsuki. If he could keep this moment in his pocket and go back to it whenever he wanted, he would.

They sit there for a while, until the sky is nearly dark. And the crickets begin to sing its song in the grass. The runway lights turned on, and Izuku feels around for his phone.

“What time is it?” Izuku asks.

Katsuki turns off the music, and checks his phone, “7:24. Why?”

“I’m getting picked up at 8,” Izuku leans forward on his knees.

Katsuki stayed laying back looking out onto the runway, “So is Fuck Face is coming here? Or am I taking you back to your house.”

“He’ll come here,” Izuku replies, “I already texted him the address.”

“Great,” Katsuki rolled his eyes, “So now, I have to see the fucker outside of practice and lunch.”

Izuku elbowed him gently, “It’ll only be for a minute maximum, Kacchan!”

“A minute too long,” Katsuki then turned his head to face Izuku. Even in the growing darkness of the sky, those eyes still shone with intensity, “What are you two doing, anyways.” Katsuki asked nonchalantly.

The greenette thinks back to the conversation with Kaito in which he had agreed to the date, “He said something about wining and dining me...even though he can’t legally drink wine.”

At this, Katsuki actually cackles, almost patronizingly, “The shithead is gonna wine and dine you? What a fucking prick. You like that, Deku? Is that the kind of guy you like? A perfect little gentleman?”

Izuku frowned at the cynical statement even though Katsuki wasn’t necessarily wrong in his doubt. Although Izuku enjoyed a nice conversation over dinner, he much preferred the thrill of swimming at night somewhere or even walking around some abandoned building with no plan in mind. Spontaneous. That’s how Katsuki had described it.

But still, he was defensive about it, telling Katsuki, “I’m open-minded, Kacchan. I think it’s sweet.”

“Sweet? Sure,” Katsuki snorts, resting his forearm on his temple from his laid back position, “And then what. You gonna give him a little peck on the cheek when he drops you off? How fucking adorable.”

Izuku berated Katsuki for the comment, “Kacchan, is it really that hard to see me doing anything? You act like I’m your innocent  little brother or something,” Izuku frowned.

“You most definitely are not,” Katsuki looked at him then.

Izuku then sighed and laid back too, “Then I don’t understand why you always make comments like that. How many times do I have to tell you I’m not a child.” He wished that Katsuki could see him as a subject of beauty, like he did others.

“Never said you were,” Katsuki argued nonchalantly.

“But you act like it,” Izuku complained, “Besides, you literally saw me make out with Ren,” Izuku blushed at the memory, “I’m capable of more than just pecks, you know.”

Katsuki sneers, “Sloppily making out while drunk doesn’t say much, Deku.”

Izuku turned and did what Katsuki usually did to him, reaching out to flick the side of his head, “I’m good while sober too! Don’t make fu-”

Katsuki grabbed his wrist then when Izuku was going in, and sat up at the same he pulled Izuku forward. And so now, the greenette was leaned more towards the blonde, who was looking down at him with those intense red eyes and a slight smirk on the corner of his lips. Izuku’s wrist was held tightly in Katsuki’s rough palm, and Izuku blinked up at the taller man, confused.

“Show me, then,” Katsuki waited a moment before smirking and saying in his gruff voice, “ *Deku* .”

Izuku blanked. *What* ? Kacchan wanted him to do *what* , now? All thoughts in the greenette’s head flew out of the window for a hot minute as he continued to just look up into the other’s eyes, not breaking contact in the slightest as he searches for some type of answer to reveal itself. Or for the blonde to reveal that this was a joke. This was most definitely a turn of events that Izuku was not expecting, and the boy could not collect his thoughts for shit.

“S-show you?” Izuku stammered out. Maybe he was interpreting it wrong.

“Show me,” Katsuki repeated again, voice just as deep and alluring. And no wonder Izuku’s knees felt weak even though he was sitting.

“B-but,” Izuku’s throat went dry, “You...me…we aren’t…”

“It don’t mean anything, shitnerd,” Katsuki tells him, “I’m merely giving you a chance to prove yourself, that’s all,” He grins mischieviously, “It’s not like I’m asking to fuck you.”

Izuku wonders if there’s a way to rewind this conversation. He whispers, shocked, “Who in the world says things like that.”

Katsuki shrugged then let go of his wrists, leaning back against the backseats of his car from the trunk, and resting his head back on his crossed arms behind his head, “Don’t, then. Like I said, it don’t fucking matter,” He says with less than a care in his voice.

But Izuku continues to just stare at the other incredulously. Katsuki was so *nonchalant* about it, as if making out with his project partner and dare-say friend on a whim was just the

average Thursday night activity.

Izuku doesn't actually remember the last time he's kissed someone sober. It was probably a while, considering that he doesn't get to go out much, and now that he does, he only goes out with Katsuki who is kissing literally anyone else *but* him.

And then, Izuku wonders, like he has before secretly. He wonders what the blonde's lips felt like, on his. Katsuki looked as if he did everything roughly: he kissed rough, he fucks rough, he lives rough. The thought of that brought a feeling of desire and curiosity pooling to his stomach and his brain, and Izuku can't deny his physical attraction to Katsuki if he wanted to.

At the current moment, the blonde was just leaned slightly back, mentioning something to Izuku about the engineers of this one flight that crashed over the Pacific Ocean a couple years ago, eyes looking out onto the runway once more. The sky was just so beautiful, with its purplish hue illuminated the planes as they took off.

But Izuku couldn't pay attention. All he could think about was the offer. It was *right* there. Sure, it was so that he could 'prove' himself, although he didn't need to prove anything to Katsuki. And sure, it was definitely on the whim, and Izuku wonders how Katsuki could be so nonchalant about it. But *fuck* , the curiosity was killing him.

It would've been fine, right? If Katsuki said it didn't mean anything, then it would've been the same if the two of them were to go to a shop and buy some cheesecake, right? Izuku knew that it was not the same situation at all, and he also knew that whatever strange feelings he's been harboring will only set ablaze if he were to follow through.

And yet, in a moment of desire and spurred confidence, Izuku pushes himself on his hands closer to Katsuki.

At the movement, the athlete turns his head, which was still resting against his folded arms, and looks to see what Izuku was doing. The greenette obviously looked hesitant, but he pushed that away. Feeling his heart pound loudly in his chest was evidence that it didn't just mean nothing, but he still moved his body forward.

Katsuki watched him.

Izuku placed a hand on the blonde's chest so that he could slowly swing his body over where Katsuki was leaning back, and now, Izuku was practically straddling the other's hip. One leg on the left side and one leg on the right, with Izuku's hand lying a little too sensually on Katsuki's firm chest.

Understanding what was happening, Katsuki raised a brow as he watched all of this, but made no effort to move, simply watching as the doe-eyed greenette climbs up onto his lap. Izuku felt something twitch underneath him, and he didn't let his imagination get too far, because god, he was not in the right position to do that right now.

Izuku watched as Katsuki removed his arms from behind his head and placed them on either side of Izuku's pretty hips for more stability. And *fuck* , this was actually happening.

Katsuki got the cue, and the ease at which the blonde transitioned just solidified in Izuku's head just how *experienced* the blonde was. And he suddenly felt competitive. Izuku was not the type to feel competitive jealousy, but with Katsuki, the athlete just made him feel everything that he wanted to. Izuku wanted to prove himself, all right. Better than anyone else. The problem was *how* . He could talk the talk, but walking the walk is slightly different when he can't even remember the last time he's kissed someone.

But now, as Katsuki doesn't break eye contact with Izuku as he waits for the smaller boy to make a move, Izuku honestly threw all thoughts out of the window.

The greenette brings his smaller hand up to touch Katsuki's jaw, a little too softly. He likes how strong Katsuki's jaw was, how his hands could touch it now, and he knows he's not going to forget this sensation. And Izuku was sure this isn't the type of touches that the athlete liked. But he still went through with it anyways, leaning in closer until his eyes fluttered down to the blonde's lips then back up into those eyes.

The music was off, so all he could hear was his own heart beating fast.

Katsuki was close enough that the blonde could talk in a slight whisper, asking Izuku, "Oi, you always this hesitan-"

Izuku cuts him off and leaned in to kiss him, and Katsuki caught his lips immediately in a deep kiss. Izuku had his right hand gently on Katsuki's jaw, his left hand on the blonde's rib, and now, his lips on the other's.

Immediately, it felt like sensations bursted throughout his entire being. Kissing has *never* felt like this before. His heartbeat didn't slow down, his stomach flutters flared up, his face was heating up, but my *god* , his head was full of a dopamine high. Because Katsuki's lips were so soft, and tasted of cherries from the sports drink he had finished. Izuku was sure his own tasted like the sweetness of a soda pop. The blonde's hands still rested on his hips, and Izuku felt it hard to control the little pleasure high in his head.

Fuck, he was kissing the person that he most definitely shouldn't be.

Izuku moved slowly at first, and it was obvious that Katsuki was letting Izuku take the lead. Izuku liked to start his kisses soft, moving sensually and slowly in order to savor every single taste. He moved his head accordingly, and they matched well. And so there they were, sitting in the back of the car with the trunk open, overlooking an airfield, making out slowly in the back without a care in the world.

Izuku's head was fuzzy, and all he could taste, feel, smell, was the sweet sensations of Katsuki's lips.

Izuku didn't know when, but at some point, the greenette moved his hand from Katsuki's jaw deeper into the blonde's head, pulling them closer into an even deeper kiss, and his lips began moving with a bit more force against the other's. The buildup was making it *really* hard for Izuku to control himself down there.

And Katsuki, taking the hint, grabs onto Izuku's hips tighter, pulling him in until they were flushed up against each other, with Katsuki's back still leaning against the backseat. Izuku let out a small gasp at the sudden tightness of the position. God, he was so close to Katsuki, barely an inch between any part of their bodies, and it was getting hot in the car even though the trunk was open.

But Izuku couldn't stop. The pace picked up, as well as the intensity, because Izuku roughened the kiss a bit more, sucking a little bit here and there at Katsuki's bottom lip and nipping even a little bit to up the rigor. They gradually moved faster, looking almost desperate as Izuku buries his hands in Katsuki's hair, while the blonde athlete attempts to bring their hips even closer, rough hands digging into his sides. The intensity of it all made Izuku gasp when he came up for air, just to go back in, tugging at hair, clothes, skin, lips.

Izuku bites his lip to suppress a sound, but Katsuki pushes his way through and uses his teeth to bite and tug a bit on Izuku's bottom lip himself. Izuku was sure his lips were going to be bruised by the end of this.

" *Fuck* ," Katsuki breathed out in his mouth, and using his arm strength, moved the both of them so that Izuku's back hit the floor of the trunk, his legs dangling out of the car in a still comfortable way. And Katsuki was on top of him, no longer allowing Izuku to take the lead.

Izuku opens his eyes in a daze to see the athlete's large and strong build on top of him, and he knew that if Katsuki looked down at his pants, then he was fucked. Katsuki looked fucking hungry, and Izuku wanted his lips back on top of his own so badly now.

"Kacchan…" Izuku found himself breathing out, chest going up and down to catch some air.

Katsuki leaned down, and used a rough thumb to touch Izuku's soft and plush lips. His other hand cupped Izuku's soft face. The smaller looked up at him with big eyes, before Katsuki's thumb pushed down between his lips.

"Open your mouth," Katsuki ordered him in a gruff voice, face barely inches apart, and Izuku instantly complied as if his body wanted Katsuki so badly, that it didn't listen to anyone else.

The moment Izuku's lips parted, the blonde goes in and continues a deep kiss, but this time, Izuku felt a swipe of tongue inside of his mouth. And the odd sensation causes him to grab onto Katsuki's shoulders.

The blonde didn't mind, and in return, snaked his hands under Izuku's shirt, untucking it, and grabbing onto his hips with the athlete's rough hands on his bare skin. Katsuki kissed him with tongue, and Izuku was a quick learner, leaning in too in order to wrestle a little bit inside the mouth. The blonde was not playing around, and Izuku loved it. Izuku was right. Katsuki *was* a rough kisser, and he knew by the practical shoving of his tongue down Izuku's throat, the bites and tugs on Izuku's lips, and the bruising hold on his hips. Izuku matched his energy. The greenette was stuck in a loop of enjoying himself immensely, and having to think horrible, disgusting thoughts in order to keep it all under control down there.

"Wrap your legs around me," Katsuki demanded him again, and Izuku paused. There was no way that's happening, because then, the athlete would know for *sure* he was having a

problem down there. Izuku felt almost tempted to look down at Katsuki, but didn't. Instead, continued to make out with the blonde, without complying to the request.

Katsuki didn't drop it, however, and let go of Izuku's hip to grab Izuku's chin and tilted his head up, "I don't think you heard me, Deku."

Izuku wanted to tease him, "No, I heard you, Kacchan."

Quirking a brow, Katsuki smirked, "Did you, now?" Before going back in, rougher than before, and Izuku wanted to moan into Katsuki's mouth but prevented himself from doing so. He grabbed onto the other's back tighter, and Katsuki had no problem reaching his hands back under his silk shirt to grab onto his bare skin.

They were at that for another four minutes before an interruption lit up the relatively dark car. At the sound of a ringtone playing, Katsuki lifted his head off of Izuku's and shielded his eyes from the light coming off of Izuku's phone. The greenette reached out for his phone, but Katsuki beat him to it.

Lifting up the device, the blonde revealed that it was Kaito calling, and Izuku's eyes widened as he remembered his date. *Oh shit* . He had a date in not too long from now, but here he was, making out with Bakugo Kats-

He didn't have a chance to finish the thought, because Katsuki ended the call, tossing the phone to the side, and went back down to pull Izuku into a kiss, ignoring everything else. Izuku felt more heat pool to his stomach, but thoughts left his brain when the athlete began trailing his hands a little further.

They were originally on his hips or his waist, massaging his thumbs into Izuku's bare skin, but now, Katsuki seemed to want to explore a little further. Those large and rough hands began travelling, and Izuku knew Katsuki was heading up, where Izuku's budding nipples were perfect for playing.

And the way Katsuki was going about it was so natural, as if he's used to this natural progression of things. And then Izuku remembered, the blonde probably *was* . These hands weren't meant for him, and those lips, the way they moved, were not meant for Izuku either. All Izuku was doing was so called proving himself, to a boy who's done this plenty of times. At the reminder, Izuku suddenly didn't feel so good. He didn't regret the kiss, although he might later. But he didn't want Katsuki's hands going any further.

Izuku didn't want to just be another statistic in Katsuki's metaphorical chart of people who will give in to his every beck and call. He knew the blonde wasn't actually going to go any further, or at least he thought. The ending kind of confused him; however, the image of Katsuki having done this with others before caused a twisting feeling in his gut again.

Izuku usually didn't care about someone's sex life. It was their choices. Ochaco was beautiful, and even she didn't mind sleeping with people here and there if there was mutual attraction. In fact, he knew plenty of people who had a lot of sexual freedom.

But with Katsuki, Izuku couldn't help but to feel immense jealousy. And he didn't want to. He hated negative feelings: jealousy, anger, sadness, the sorts.

Izuku pulled away, and used his hands to take Katsuki's off of him. The blonde, taking it as a sign that Izuku was done, gets up off of him, and leans backwards on the side of the car, head tilted up and his breathing was also a bit heavy.

Izuku's face was red, and he pulled himself up too, now sitting across from Katsuki, looking at the other and trying to figure out what to say. The crickets sung its pretty song as always.

And for a while, it was just a little quiet. That had ended up being much more intense than the both of them seemed to have expected, and Izuku was still stunned. Everytime he closed his eyes, his head turned back the pages to relive the feelings of being kissed, being touched, being held like that by Katsuki.

Ultimately, Izuku decides to interrupt the quietness with a joke, "So," He starts, "Was that not the best makeout session you've ever had, or what?"

From the other side of the car, Katsuki chuckles, "Never thought you'd be a biter, Deku."

"And I never thought this would happen at all, Kacchan," Izuku scratched the back of his neck, "Was it...weird?"

"Why would it be," Katsuki stated, apathetically.

Izuku was quiet at that, and shrugged, "I don't know."

"I know I'm fucking amazing, but don't go thinking too much on it, nerd," Katsuki laughs sarcastically.

Izuku wanted to humble him a bit, so he lied, "You weren't even that special." Yes, he was.

Katsuki leaned forward at this, trying to detect the lie in Izuku's eye, and suggested, "Well, that's too bad, ain't it. Should I try again, and show you just how fucking special I can be?" He grins mischievously.

Izuku pushes the blonde's head away with a laugh, "So, did I pass the mighty Kacchan's test?"

Katsuki looked at him then, head still tilted up leaning against the back of his car. His eyes travelled down to Izuku's lips for a split second, and then up to those large green eyes. Izuku waits for a response.

When he did reply, Katsuki simply tells him, "You're a fucking walking piece of work, you know that?"

Izuku softly smiles at him, "That's barely an answer."

"It's been over five minutes, and if I hadn't told you by now you're disgusting, what does that tell you, Deku," Katsuki will say *anything* but the truth straight up.

This time, it was okay because Izuku got the message. He pumped his fist dramatically and giggles, “I’ll consider that a success, then.”

And then, his phone dings with a text. Suddenly remembering *again* that he had something to do at 8, Izuku panicked and grabbed for his phone that was tossed aside in the middle of their little make out session. Unlocking it, Izuku saw a text following up the declined call, saying that Kaito was going to be about five minutes late because of traffic. And then another text just now, saying that he was about three minutes away.

Izuku looked concerned, before pulling out his phone camera, checking his hair and his, *yes* , slightly swollen lip, “Oh my god.”

“What,” Katsuki deadpanned.

“Look at me,” Izuku slightly panicked as he tries to get his hair back to the normal mess it was, rather than a complete mess, “I look like I just-”

“Had my tongue shoved down your throat right before you had a date?” Katsuki laughs triumphantly, “That’s because you did, Deku. I’m sure Fuck Face would be very happy to know that.”

“You’re horrible,” Izuku mentioned with a strained voice as he fixes himself up. He’ll just say he ate something and it gave him an allergic reaction. Izuku stands outside of the trunk, and then tucks his shirt back into his pants. He felt Katsuki’s eyes watching him the entire time.

“You gonna kiss him like that tonight?” Katsuki asked, head still leaned back as he watches Izuku prep himself.

Izuku glanced up at Katsuki. He hadn’t really thought about it. Izuku wasn’t a prude, but he definitely didn’t go crazy with anything. And yet, for some reason, Izuku wanted to know what Katsuki would say if he said yes. To feel what he does when he sees Katsuki with someone else. But then again, that was only possible because Izuku already had budding feelings for the other.

Still, Izuku tells him, “If he wants to.”

Katsuki quirked a brow, a habit Izuku noticed that the other has, and watches as the greenette sits back down on the edge of the trunk waiting for Kaito to arrive.

Katsuki then asks, “Do *you* want to?”

Pursing his lips, Izuku replies with a, “Maybe.”

To that, Katsuki just went back to looking out at the airfield. Moments later, from the old road they had pulled up on, Izuku sees the headlights of a white car coming closer around the bend. Assuming that was Kaito, Izuku went ahead to hop out of the trunk. Katsuki did the same, standing up to his full height, right beside Izuku as Kaito’s car pulled up.

When the white car came up next to Katsuki's black one, Kaito rolled his driver's side windows down and greeted the both of the them. There was a slight tenseness in the air.

"Bakugo," Kaito nods.

Katsuki gives him a nod back, "Fuck Face."

Kaito laughs at this, used to the nickname, and waves kindly at Izuku, "Midoriya! You ready to get swept off your feet?"

Izuku smiles kindly at him, and lets out a small laugh, "You're putting a lot of expectations on yourself, Kaito."

"I'll meet them," Kaito winked at him before commenting, "You look gorgeous, by the way."

Izuku flushed red. From besides him, with his hands in his pockets, Izuku noticed Katsuki watching both of their interactions with curious eyes.

"Thank you," Izuku musters out, shyly.

And Kaito pats the side of his car, "You want to get in? I'm gonna roll my windows up before a mosquito flies in."

Kaito began rolling up his windows, and Izuku nodded before looking back up at Katsuki.

Izuku decides to make a light comment before he leaves, "Do you actually know his name, or do you just call him...um, Fuck Face?"

Katsuki rolls his eyes with the shake of a head, "Of course I know his name. I'm his fucking captain, so sadly, I gotta know all of the extras' actual names."

Izuku laughed, part of him not exactly wanting to go, but he bites his lip and smiles, "I'm gonna go now."

"You don't need to announce it, nerd," Katsuki's tone was relatively calm.

And Izuku nods to that shyly, before turning around, not wanting to keep Kaito waiting. But just as he got merely a couple steps in, Katsuki steps forward and holds onto his arm. This caused Izuku to turn back halfway and look up at the much taller male with surprised eyes. Katsuki looked down on him, and his lips were parted as if to say something. Those same lips that he just kissed.

"Kacchan?" Izuku asked, blinking up at the other.

He watched Katsuki look as if he had words to say, only to come up empty. The blonde's eyes had an odd look in them for a second, before they went blank. And he stepped back, putting his hands back into his pockets.

Then Katsuki just told him, "Have a good time."

It wasn't what Izuku had been expecting, but regardless, he smiles up at the athlete. It didn't completely reach his eyes. He almost wishes that the other hadn't said that. He almost wished that Katsuki *didn't* want him to have a good time, stupidly enough. Because of Katsuki, Izuku's thought process these days felt so backwards.

"Thanks, Kacchan," Izuku says before he walks over to the passenger side of Kaito's car.

Coming in, the boy was quick to strike up a conversation and be very active about it, pulling Izuku in. Kaito was nice. This was going to be fun, Izuku tells himself. But as they leave, the greenette's eyes were on the rearview mirror, and just as they were about to turn out of sight, he sees Katsuki sitting back down on the edge of the trunk, once more looking out onto the airfield.

Once they got back onto the main, busier roads, Kaito tells him, "I got us a reservation at this one restaurant near the town square. It's Italian. Do you like Italian?"

Izuku turns towards Kaito and nods, "I love Italian."

"Great," Kaito sounded proud of himself for picking well, "By the way, I was curious. What were you and Bakugo doing at the airport?"
"Oh!" Izuku tells him, "We just kind of sat there and watched the planes take off."

Kaito laughs, running his hands through his hair, "Was that Bakugo's idea? Sounds kind of lame, if you ask me."

Izuku looked down at his lap. It was *his* idea, and Katsuki didn't find it to be lame as far as he knew.

He says quietly, "It's not lame," But decides he wasn't going to let this dictate the rest of their date, so he enthusiastically asks Kaito, "So how does it feel to make it past regionals?"

"Oh man," Kaito looked happy, "I'm so nervous and excited at the same time, Midoriya. I think you wearing my jersey helped," He laughs.

Izuku clapped his hands, "I'm glad I could play my part!"

Conversation with Kaito was nice. The brunette was naturally pretty talkative, and made sure to be attentive with Izuku like a true gentleman. The conversation never died, which was good. The restaurant was a nicer italian one, and the food was absolutely incredible. Izuku had manicotti with alfredo sauce, while Kaito ordered chicken marsala. And then for dessert, tiramisu was always a good idea.

It was different. But it wasn't bad, Izuku thought to himself. Kaito was a fun person to be around. He had plenty of stories to excitingly tell and a handsome smile. The brunette made some sexual comments here and there, so Izuku knew for a fact that Kaito was interested in intimacy with him, but he wasn't disrespectful about it.

After dinner, Kaito decided to just walk around the town square to burn off their food. Izuku remembers visiting here with Katsuki at nearly midnight once, and playing in the splash ground. Going with Kaito was also really fun, for Izuku laughed a lot. And there was a lot of interesting things about the other.

When they got near the splash park again, Izuku looks up at Kaito and maybe he just wanted to let loose for a moment, but the greenette asked, “Do you want to play in the splash park?”

“The splash park?” Kaito looked over the fountains going up from the ground, “Isn’t that for kids?”

Izuku pursed his lips, “Yeah, but it’s nighttime and no one’s here.” Since when was he so spontaneous, he wonders.

“True,” Kaito nods his head and considers it, “Hm, maybe another time. I’d hate to have your pretty shirt wet. And mine,” He commented with a large smile.

“I don’t really mind, but,” Izuku goes along with it, “We can just keep walking.”

Kaito *did* end up kissing him that night. At no point did the other ask about Izuku’s slightly swollen lip, which was a blessing. It was right before they got back into the car to drive Izuku home for the night. The moonlight was basking on them prettily, and all of the shops were cleared of people.

Izuku saw it coming, and when Kaito touches Izuku’s face from the side, the greenette lets him. It’s been a pretty good night after all. And when the other leans down to kiss him, Izuku wondered how different it’ll be from the kiss he had earlier, so he meets Kaito halfway. It was nice, soft, and warm. But the explosions that were present when he kissed Katsuki, those were gone.

Still, as Kaito deepens the kiss, Izuku responds to it. Although he felt a little weird that this was the second person that he had kissed within a couple of hours. What felt even more weird though, was that for much of the kiss, Izuku’s mind flashed back to the one he had earlier.

“Can I see you again?” Kaito asks when he drops Izuku off at his house.

The greenette begins to open the door, but he turns to Kaito. It had been a good date, and Kaito is also good company. And so, without making a promise, he still tells the other, “Sure.” With a smile before leaving. It was fine.

The next day was absolutely hectic. Every senior at Ise High was talking about the dance happening that night. On one hand, Izuku was happy that he had helped with the planning and that people were excited about it. On the other hand, he was sad that he wouldn’t get to

attend. He couldn't even sneak out, and so, he'll just watch people's social medias or hear stories about it the day after.

He wonders what stories he'll hear about Katsuki the day after. Which girl or guy that he brought with him. If they went home together. He didn;t really want to know. And thinking back to the kiss just yesterday made Izuku reel, because yes, that *happened* . He still haven't told anyone about it, because to be honest, he hadn't completely recovered from the event himself.

Everywhere he went, people were talking about the dance. All of his friend's outfits were also meticulously planned out, and it was fun to see pictures and hear.

The Spring Dance was probably one of the biggest events at Ise High, especially for seniors. No one ever wanted to miss it. The budgeting was always pretty high, so they had good food, good lighting, good decor, and just good vibes.

It was what everyone thought of when they romanticized high school dances. Slow songs that couples swayed to. Fast songs that the whole crowd jumped to. Drama about who's going with who. Beautiful dresses and suits everywhere. Izuku was getting major fomo. No one given the option would skip it.

"Which afterparty are you all going to?" Shoto asked the group. The afterparties for the Spring Dance were always outrageously fun, and all of Ise High's seniors would never miss attending one. Probably more happened at the afterparties than at the dance itself.

Iida replies with a shrug, "I'm not going to any. I'm just going to be attending the dance."

Ochaco perked up, "I'm going to Kirishima's! It's the biggest one, isn't it? Everyone's gonna be there. Izuku, you can still go to the after party, can't you? Your mom just said you can't attend the dance."

Izuku shakes his head, "I can't go to that either. I mean, I could sneak out, but that's risky."

"Sneak out?" She looked at him with amused eyes, "You've been kind of different lately, Izuku."

"Oh," Izuku looked shy, "Is that bad?"

"It's actually a little refreshing," Shoto chimed in, "You look happier, Midoriya."

Izuku smiled at his friends, "I think I am."

And when classes ends and he finishes his last minute check ups for the dance, Izuku walks across the practice track field as he usually does. And stops for a moment to watch. The team was taking a short break, and he could hear bits and parts of the conversation from outside of the fence, talking about the dance. Izuku couldn't stay long, since he had to help his mother with unpacking some shipments.

But he caught eyes with Katsuki, who was standing with his group of friends talking, for a moment, the Izuku waved. Katsuki merely nodded at him before turning back to the group.

The rest of his night was lackluster, even more so considering what everyone *else* was doing. It took about two hours to unpack and take inventory of the shipments coming in for his mother's custom prints shop. He and his mother had pretty basic conversation. Inko could tell that Izuku didn't want to talk much, but didn't understand why not attending a dance could put him in such a mellow mood.

Like she promised, they ended up watching a movie together on the couch, and it was nice. By this time, Izuku knew everyone was at the dance. His group chats were blowing up with messages about people getting ready just an hour ago, and now, it was more quiet because everyone was there and didn't really check their phones aside from posting pictures or stories.

When Inko got tired, Izuku turned off the movie and they both headed to their respective rooms. Not tired himself, Izuku turned on his TV and proceeded to watch reruns of a ghost show while he aimlessly scrolls through social media.

At this point, he's seeing plenty of pictures and posts about the dance. Everyone looked beautiful and handsome, and Izuku smiled as he sees a picture of his friends all dressed up and making silly hand signs. There were little snippets of videos too, of people dancing to loud music, or just doing something stupid. From his bed, he watched everyone else.

On Mina's social, Izuku found himself stopping as he stares at a photo of a certain someone from behind, head turned slightly to the side. Katsuki looked handsome from the back, black suit fitting every single part of his body. His eyes were as stunning as they usually were, and Izuku smiled to himself. He wanted to see the front, he thought. He wondered what Katsuki was doing at the moment.

On the side, a girl with a beautiful red dress that had an open back walked close beside him, and Izuku assumed that this was his date. He looks at her for a while, and then at him again, and Izuku knew that if he were at the dance, he probably would have thought they were an absolutely stunning pair.

Scrolling past in order to make himself think less about it, Izuku just spends the next two or so hours doing the same things. He got text messages from some friends saying they wished he was there, or some crazy thing that just happened. He looked outside of the window, and for a moment, considered leaving. Or at least, going to the afterparties, which would probably start in another 2 hours once everyone got sick of the dance. Each person had to pay about $50 dollars to attend, so they probably would want to make the most of it. But deciding not to risk getting into even more trouble and having greater restrictions placed on him, Izuku just lays in bed.

It was only 10:30 PM or so now, and Izuku was getting really into a show that was premiering on his TV. The rerun he had been watching earlier was getting boring, and so he switched channels. And this was much more interesting. He doesn't even check his phone.

Completely immersed in the plot, Izuku jumps when he heard a disruption. Sitting up in his bed, Izuku looked around. There was something that he was hearing, but not well over the sound of the TV. So turning off the device and bookmarking the show for later, Izuku's room faded into darkness.

But not into silence. Because he heard music, outside of his window. It was faint at first, but then slowly, it got a bit louder. Izuku frowned, and got up from his bed. He stepped over some clothes he had lying around and headed towards the window.

Pushing his curtains open, and lifting up the window a bit, and right away, sound flooded in. And Izuku recognized the song well.

Take My Breath Away by Berlin.

Izuku absolutely loved this track, and when the planning committee was wondering which songs to request for the DJ they hired, this was the first one that Izuku asked for. It was perfect for slow dancing, not that Izuku knew how to. But when he imagined beautiful school dances with purple and pink lights, balloons and string banners everywhere, and what not, he thought of this song.

And then the song paused.

" *Fuck* !" Izuku heard from somewhere past his lawn. There was a car parked on the side, but it was partially hidden by the trees his neighbors had.

However, Izuku recognized that voice anywhere, especially when it was cursing. Izuku's eyes widened, and he wondered if he had heard wrong. He looked back to check his clock, to see that it was only about 10:45 PM. The height of the dance was right about now, so there'd be no way Katsuki was here.

And yet, when he emerged from the side of the treeline, Izuku felt his heart race, and his hands on the window sill gripped tighter.

The athlete was dressed in a full suit, and looked so incredibly perfect. Black shoes, black three piece suit, with a white shirt underneath. It was unbeatable, and the handsomeness of it all made Izuku's breath hitch. In the picture posted on Mina's social, Izuku thought he looked incredible. But to see the blonde in person was something else entirely. But more than stunned, Izuku was confused. Was this real? What was he doing here? There was a dance happening. In fact, it was a huge dance that no one in their right mind would miss. It was such a tradition at Ise High that people's parents who still lived in Ise still told stories of it to their children. And so, what in the *world* was Katsuki doing here.

In his arms was a large stereo. The ones that people hold on their shoulders. But Katsuki was messing with the buttons, trying to get it to work, and cursing out the machine. At some point, Izuku saw Katsuki kick the device, as if it'll make it work better.

And when it finally seemed to work again, the blonde restarted the song and started jogging up and onto Izuku's lawn. The yellow floodlights and porch lights on Izuku's house lit up the athlete, who stepped onto the grass with his nice dress shoes on.

Katsuki looked up to where Izuku was in the window, and then set the stereo down on the grass.

"Oi, nerd," Katsuki yelled up, disregarding the neighbors and the fact that his mom was inside, "You heard me coming down the street or something?"

Izuku was so confused as to what was happening, and then says to Katsuki, voice not as loud to not alert his mother, "Your music isn't particularly quiet, Kacchan. What are you doing here?"

"Can't hear you, Deku," Katsuki shouts, "Come down here."

Izuku looks around, and then speaks a little louder, "Kacchan! I can't sneak out. She'll kill me!"

Katsuki then chuckled, "Oh, are you trying to be quiet and not wake her up? In that case, let me," He started shouting louder, "yell louder! And turn the music up some more." He reaches down to put the music up louder.

And then he added one last thing, "Besides, who said I was sneaking you out?"

Izuku's eyes widened at this statement. And he stands there at his window for a moment, staring at the ridiculously handsome boy with the full suit lit up by his house's floodlights, before looking back inside. And then back at Katsuki, who stood down on his front lawn waiting.

Izuku then bit his lip and then hurried his way downstairs, practically stomping down because there was no way his mother was not already awake from the music. Izuku opened his door, and stepped out onto the porch barefoot.

Once Katsuki saw him, the athlete turned down the music back to a normal level and then looked back over at Izuku.

"Okay, I'm here," Izuku tells him, "So what are you doing here? Aren't you supposed to be at the dance?"

Katsuki kicks the grass with his nice shoes, and looked up at the sky, "Well, I don't gotta be anywhere, Deku. No one tells me what to do."

Izuku just shakes his head with an incredulous grin, "You know what I meant, Kacchan."

"Got bored," Katsuki then tells him, looking back down from the sky to catch Izuku with the eyes that Izuku was beginning to fantasize about when he closes his own.

"You got bored?" Izuku gave him a humorous look, "At the biggest event of the year? That you only get to go to *once* ? At the one thing that practically everyone was looking forward to

all semester?"

Katsuki gives him a sly grin and shrugs, "What can I say."

Izuku was still confused, and it was only a matter of time until his mother comes out, "That doesn't explain why you're *here* though. You know my mom is going to freak out, right?"

"Not if I just stay here," Katsuki argued, tapping his feet on the lawn, before telling Izuku, "You told me you wanted to learn how to dance, right?"

"Huh?" Izuku asked, holding himself for stabilization.

The athlete rolled his eyes, "The other day, you fuc-...you freaking dimwit, you said you wanted to go to the dance to learn. Come on, nerd, I brought the dance to you, so get out here." He paused, "I'll show you."

And then Katsuki held out his hand, perfectly pieced together with a gorgeous watch and a titanium ring on his index finger.

Izuku was still on his porch, and he was speechless. *I brought the dance to you* . He looked down at the stereo on the grass, then back at Katsuki, who had his hand outstretched to Izuku. He looked so handsome, Izuku couldn't get a grasp of what was happening. It was nearly 11 PM. Katsuki should be at a dance right now, a *real* dance. One that no one wanted to miss for literally anything else. With a beautiful girl in a red dress, and all of Katsuki's friends.

And yet, he was here, in Izuku's front yard, asking for a dance.

"Go back to the dance, Kacchan," Izuku laughs, almost wanting to cry.

Katsuki persists, "Why should I?"

"All your friends are there, and everything is happening *there* ," Izuku reasons with a funny smile, "You only get to go once. I don't want you to miss it."

"Well, I don't really give a damn what you want," Katsuki snorts, "I want a dance."

Izuku felt his heart want to jump out of his chest, and pour itself out to Katsuki right then and there.

"But...I'm dressed like this," Izuku gestured down to his body.

He was literally in his sleeping clothes, which consisted of a large t-shirt that had a comic figure that hung down to his thighs, and nothing underneath but underwear. He wasn't even wearing shoes. Meanwhile, Katsuki was dressed in a full formal suit, looking absolutely perfect, just a couple feet away from him.

Katsuki merely told him, "You look fine to me."

Izuku looked at him with wide eyes, searching for some kind of deception to reveal this was a mirage, and he found nothing. Izuku was wearing probably one of the dumbest things he

could have worn outside, and yet, this boy who stood in front of him dressed to the 9s still would rather dance with him than go back to the biggest event in all of high school.

Izuku hesitantly steps out onto the lawn with his bare feet, towards Katsuki. And slowly, Izuku reached out to take Katsuki's larger hand.

The blonde looked at him, and then over at the door, keeping his gaze there as if he was having a staring contest. Confused, Izuku turned around to see that his mother had been standing at the door, having it partially open, and half of her body was leaning on the sides watching.

Inko looked shocked, as she looked at what was happening on her lawn. Izuku sees Katsuki not breaking eye contact with the woman, as he holds onto Izuku's hand. It was obvious what was going on. Not only did the entire conversation happen out loud, but there was music and Katsuki was evidently in a suit. The shorter male looked back at his mom, to see her features softening with a bit of...guilt? Etched into her expression.

And then, with a small smile and eyes that look a little forlorn, Inko tells Izuku.

"Stay on the lawn, please," Inko says with a quiet voice, "And don't forget about 12:30."

Izuku's eyes widened, and then he watched as she quietly closes the door. And then, he was just left with Katsuki on the front lawn, yellow lights illuminating the place.

Izuku then tilts his head up to look at Katsuki, laughing, "I was wondering why you weren't cursing in every sentence."

Katsuki turned his gaze from the door back to Izuku, snorting, "Didn't want Auntie throwing a fit."

Izuku, still with his hands in Katsuki's, asks the blonde then in a slight whisper, as the taller boy pulls him a bit closer, "Why are you doing this to me."

Katsuki grins, "I told you, nerd. I got bored."

"That's it?" Izuku laughs airily.

Katsuki just affirms, "That's it."

Izuku just stares up at him for a second, admiring how the floodlights highlighted the angles of Katsuki's face, and says, "I like this song."

Katsuki takes this into consideration, "So put your hands on my shoulders, and let's dance."

Izuku tries to hide his smile, and puts his hands up on Katsuki's shoulder, while the taller places his own on Izuku's waist. And then, Katsuki began moving.

Izuku shakes his head, "I don't know what to do with my feet." He giggles.

Katsuki looks down between them and chuckles, "Step on my feet. I'll show you, idiot."

Izuku bites his lip. He only sees that in movies. And then when he thinks about it, he honestly could be in a movie right then. And he climbs so that his feet were on top of Katsuki's bringing them in closer. And he tilts his head up to look at Katsuki, when the blonde begins moving, pulling both of their weight as Katsuki tells him how to slow dance. *This formation* , Katsuki tells him the details, but Izuku could not pay attention.

He wasn't at the school dance. He had a t-shirt on, and was out on his lawn, and yet, it was perfect. There were no disco lights, perfectly catered food and DJ music, no smoke machines, no one but him and Katsuki. But as Izuku stares up at the boy in question, he thinks that he prefers this.

And then they dance for a while, playing different oldies with different moods. On the slow songs, Katsuki takes him into his arms and they dance to the tempo. Izuku was getting the hang of it, not needing to step on Katsuki's feet anymore. On the faster songs, they both jump and dance ridiculously as if they were at a party, like kids. They also sang out loud to some of the tracks, karaoking as it neared 12 in the morning.

Some of the neighbors turned on their lights, but it looked as if upon seeing the scene, no one wanted to say anything. To disrupt the beauty of teenage ridiculousness, when it was as innocent as it was, would be a crime. Izuku's cheeks hurt from smiling so much, but he couldn't stop.

He thought that if nothing else, this would be one of the nights he'll remember forever.

And at some point, they dance again to a slow track, tired of jumping around to upbeat music. Izuku likes this. He likes when Katsuki spins him around, or put his hands around Izuku's waist. And now, they just swayed close with each other.

Katsuki's chin was resting on top of Izuku's head, and the greenette had his cheek resting up against Katsuki's suit cladded chest, as they danced.

"Didn't you go with someone?" Izuku asked softly, letting the slow music be more in the foreground.

Katsuki took a moment to reply, but just hummed, "I did."

"And you just…" Izuku lets out a breathy laugh, "...left?"

"If she has a problem, she can take it up with me another day," Katsuki tells him straight.

Katsuki would rather dance with him. That was what Izuku picked up, and it made his entire body shiver. Katsuki would rather dance with him as midnight passes, in his front lawn, with stereo music playing in the back.

"Fuck Face was looking for you at the dance," Katsuki informs with a snort, "Pretty sure the shithead wanted to get a slow song in."

Izuku thinks about it, "Ah, I forgot to tell him I wasn't going."

Katsuki seemed to take a moment, before taking his chin off of Izuku's head to instead look down at the boy, "Yesterday. How was your date."

Izuku blinked up at him, and tells Katsuki, "It was good."

The blonde considers this, and asks with his forehead slightly leaned against Izuku's, "Did he treat you well."

Their proximity took his breath away, but Izuku found just enough to whisper to the blonde, "Yes."

With his answer, Katsuki didn't have much to say except for a quick, "Good."

Izuku bit his lip. He wished he knew what was going on in Katsuki's head, for the millionth time. The blonde didn't take his eyes away from Izuku, and spun the greenette around once.

"What about the afterparty?" Izuku asked, "Are you going to that? Kirishima's hosting it, right? That's your best frie-"

Katsuki just rolled his eyes, "Stop asking dumbass questions, nerd. If your ass feels guilty about me being here, don't bother."

Izuku looked concerned, "But y-"

" *This* is my after party," Katsuki tells him then, tone even.

And at the words, Izuku feels as if he was on a slide slick with oil. He couldn't stop himself from falling if he wanted to. How could Katsuki say things like that, and not expect him to feel the way that he did. Izuku did not want tears to well up in his eyes, and so he looked away at the uncharacteristically sweet statement.

Katsuki then looks down at his watch, "It's 12:29. What did Auntie mean earlier when she said to remember 12:30?"

Izuku suddenly remembers his mother saying that, and his eyes widened, "Oh."

"What is it?" Katsuki asked, frowning.

Izuku then laughed, "How much do you like this suit?"

Not understanding, Katsuki merely replied, "I can always get another one. Why."

Izuku, then looked up at Katsuki, eyes happy as he stares up at the other, "We have automatic sprinklers to water the grass at night. 12:30 is when they turn on."

And like it was perfectly timed, just as Izuku finishes the statement, they hear clicking from several parts surrounding the lawn, and then, water began shooting up in mist-like showers from the sprinkler system and onto the grass. Immediately, both Izuku and Katsuki feels the trickling of light water on them. The yellow lights make the falling water look ethereal.

Katsuki looked at Izuku as water began to fall on his suit, which could tighten the fabric, and then up at the sky, where the falling water made it look like light rain, and then he grinned. Izuku watched it all unfold, and he smiled to himself.

The stereo was still playing music, about to end a song. Looking back down at the shorter male, Katsuki then continued.

“My suit’s already wet,” He states, “We might as well continue.”

Not missing an opportunity to waste a second of this night, Izuku begins moving again, “Might as well.”

And so, with the sprinklers watering their grass and them while they dance, the two boys continued to prance around the front yard until practically every inch of them was soaked. But it barely mattered to Izuku.

A song then came on, one that Izuku haven’t heard in a while. It was one of those songs that he knew all the lyrics of, even if it’s been years since he last heard it play. Bonnie Raitt had sung this in her album Luck Of The Draw.

The song was, ironically enough, *I Can’t Make You Love Me* .

And in the final moments of their dance, Izuku finds himself softly singing it against Katsuki’s chest as they move.

“Turn down the lights,” Izuku began gently singing, “Turn down the bed. Turn down these voices, inside my head.”

Katsuki took notice of the quiet singing from below, “You ain’t half bad.”

“Thanks,” Izuku smiles.

Katsuki just listened. Izuku honestly hated this song, but he remembered never being able to stop listening to it. Because it hurt, before he even knew what the lyrics meant. And now that he did, it kind of hurt even more. And yet he still sings.

“Cause I can't make you love me if you don't. You can't make your heart feel, something it won't,” Izuku sings as Katsuki picks him up and spins him around once. He laughs, and continues, “Here in the dark, in these final hours, I will lay down my heart and I'll feel the power,” He wanted to reach up to Katsuki’s face, but didn't, “But you won't, no you won't. 'Cause I can't make you love me…” He takes a pause, “if you don't.”

Katsuki looks back down at him, nothing said between the two. Just listening to the sound of Bonnie Raitt and Izuku’s voice taking up the atmosphere. They keep swaying to the slow music. The wet fabric of Izuku’s shirt clung to his body, and the sensation of Katsuki’s hands on his waist were amplified.

“I'll close my eyes, then I won't see…” Izuku hated this line the most, “The love you don't feel...” He took a breath, “...when you're holding me.”

The lyrics hit him like a truck. And Izuku found himself unable to sing anymore, so he just continues dancing. He was surprised his mother didn't come out to berate him about getting wet, but even if she did, nothing could ruin how he felt.

It was a mixture of pure happiness that radiated from the core of his being and a feeling of doom hiding around the corner waiting to eat him up.

Izuku takes in the moment one more time. Here the athlete was, with all of the options in the world and the freedom to go to the biggest dance, with the most beautiful girl, and attend the most fun afterparties, and instead, Bakugo Katsuki was slow dancing with him under the sprinklers of his front lawn, because Izuku couldn't go. He thinks that this is one of the most heartfelt things to have ever happen to him, from one of the most heartbreaking people he's ever met.

And so, Izuku thought, even if this leads to heartbreak, even if this was merely an act of friendship or boredom, Izuku accepts it then, fully. And knowing it will hurt, Izuku also accepts the facts.

He was falling for Katsuki.

Chapter End Notes

I'll say it 1000x, but Tysm for reading! I'm so so grateful, wow
I grew up in a place like Ise so this fic is p special to me <3
See ya next week!

( CHAPTER 7 WILL COME ON TUESDAY-WEDNESDAY)
Also this is so random but if any of you guys live in waikiki/Honolulu and aren't weirded out, pls show me around I'm aloneee

# Chapter 7: The Cliff Of Wishes

Chapter Notes

32k words !

I know it's 1:47 AM in HST (where I'll be for 2 weeks). I'm so so sorry for the late update. I'm at a 2 week conference rn so the update schedule is kind of wack, but it WILL be normal soon! Plus, I had to be very careful with the dialogue in this chapter, so it took a while. I'm so sorry for making you guys wait. I'm so grateful & thank you for being patient <3 i chose the shittiest time to post this chapter, but I wanted to get it out as soon as possible, so I'm sorry if it gets lost in your emails!

spotify playlist: https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy?si=0f64a5cf1fdb4e8d

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Izuku accepted that he was falling for Katsuki, everything got more simultaneously beautiful yet painful at the same time. But isn't that what falling in love is like, Izuku thinks to himself: a beautiful kind of pain. One that crushes the air within his lungs, churns his stomach, and threatens to stab holes into his heart.

And yet, there's nothing like seeing the evening sun reflect off of Katsuki's eyes, hearing the boy's deep voice that tells him stories that Izuku knew he didn't tell others, or feeling the warmth of Katsuki's skin in the few lapses in time when the blonde doesn't mind Izuku's touch.

Whether it be taking something out of the athlete's hair, to wrapping Katsuki's fingers in athletic tape for him, to pulling him by the hand to go somewhere, Izuku feels almost pathetic for allowing the slightest touch to linger within his fingertips for hours. If he could help it, he would. And it wasn't as if Izuku was not trying. He most definitely was.

But effort seemed fruitless, when it felt like Katsuki was a black hole, and Izuku's path was bound to get sucked in.

The night that Katsuki had shown up on his front lawn to give him the dance he never got to experience, was also the same night he accepted the inevitability of it all. And it was also when Izuku understood that this was going to end in heartbreak and destruction.

After all, this was a one-sided affair. And he had the wrong end of the deal.

“Deku?” The deep voice coming in from the other side of the phone interrupted Izuku’s morning sleep. In a state of tired daze, he had picked up the phone around 5 in the morning upon seeing Katsuki’s contact name pop up. Izuku thought it was odd, considering that the blonde had never called at this time.

Izuku’s eyes were still practically glued shut, but he forced himself up on his elbows and put the phone on speaker, “Kacchan? What’s going on? It’s 5 in the morning.”

“I’m aware,” Katsuki chuckled in his slightly scratchy morning voice, and Izuku, even in this exhausted state that he was in, found the sound too alluring for his own good.

“Mm,” Izuku hummed, rolling onto his side and bringing the phone close to his ear, “Is everything good?”

The blonde then said through the line, and Izuku could practically see that playful grin, “Can’t I just call to say good morning, nerd?”

Izuku airily laughed through the phone, eyes slightly open as he watches the shadows on the wall of his dark room, “Good morning, Kacchan.”

The blonde then tells him in that gruff voice that Izuku could never get out of his head, “Good morning.”

Izuku snuggled back into his blankets, and smiled into the phone, enjoying how cutely domestic this was, contrary to how they usually talked, “Did you sleep well?”

At this, the athlete actually seemed amused and there was rustling in the phone as if he was getting up, “Well enough. Hm, I should do this more often.”

Izuku bit his lip and grins, “Do what? Call to say good morning? Now tell me Kacchan, what do you *actually* want.”

“You think too little of me, Deku,” Katsuki tsked, “Was it really hard to believe I just wanted to tell your ass good morning?”

Izuku just replied through the line, “A little.”

“You wound me,” Katsuki feigns hurt, “Anyways, are you up for leaving the house right now?”

“See?” Izuku points out, “There it is. I knew you were calling for a reason.”

Katsuki just repeated, “Just answer the question, geez.”

Izuku then paused, and looked over at the clock again. His mother was going to get up in about three hours. And it was a Saturday, so she definitely expected him to be home. The woman was beginning to check his room in the morning, even though Izuku wouldn’t say

that he does anything particularly suspicious. It was possible that she was beginning to suspect he was sneaking out here and there.

“It depends,” Izuku tells him quietly, “How long will we be out?”

“All day,” Katsuki answers automatically, with some more rustling in the back.

Izuku gaped at the phone, “Kacchan, you know I can’t do that.”

“You can,” Katsuki insists.

Izuku debates him on that, “I can’t.”

“What if I told you I already asked her yesterday night and she said okay,” Katsuki then dropped on him.

Izuku made a face at the phone, “Then you wouldn’t have asked me if I could leave.”

“I *didn’t* ask you if you could leave. I asked you if you were *up* for leaving,” Katsuki corrected him, “It’s 5 AM after all, and I’m not completely an asshole.”

“Wait, so you actually got permission from my mother?” Izuku asked, both a little shocked and touched, “ *And* you’re being considerate of my time? Is this even Kacchan I’m speaking to?”

“Shut up, you little shit,” Katsuki barked at him, “But yes. Took a while though. Auntie gave me a whole fucking speech about making sure you’re safe and to not let you get carried away when we go out, but ultimately said yes.”

Izuku felt embarrassed by her behavior sometimes, and then asked Katsuki, “And what did you tell her to make her say yes?”

“I told her we were going to my gramp’s farm for the day, and helping the old fart paint his house and do some farm work since the fucker got sick, and the hag is forcing me to go,” Katsuki tells Izuku, “And that we will be grueling and learning the value of a dollar or whatever. And I think that little part convinced her to let you go.”

“Okay, now…” Izuku laughs, “What are we *actually* doing.”

“What do you mean,” Katsuki asked plainly.

“You told her all of that to get me permission. So now tell me where we’re actually going,” Izuku humors.

Katsuki was silent for a second before snorting, “To the farm, nerd.”

Izuku blinked at that, before complaining a little loudly, “You are such an asshole, Kacchan! You’re trying to get me to go so that you don’t have to do all of the work yourself!”

“Well no shit,” Katsuki reveals, “It’ll still be fun. Come on.”

“You couldn’t have asked one of your stronger friends?” Izuku complained and then exaggerated himself, “I’m so tiny, and weak, and fragile, and-”

“Alright, you’re overdoing it,” Katsuki interrupts him, “Weak, my ass. You coming or not? I’m not forcing you to, shithead.”

Izuku knew he was going to go, because well, they were opposite poles of a magnet and Izuku felt compelled to be near him, but he played it off with a groan, “I guess.”

“Great,” Katsuki said quickly then, “I’ll be outside in 5.”

Izuku dislikes how his heart jumps every time he sees Katsuki. It wasn’t as if the boy had changed in appearance. Still the same hair. Still the same body: tall, handsome, larger than life. Still those same fiery eyes that burnt a hole through any defenses Izuku could ever build. Still those same hands that held his that one night they danced.

And yet, it *wasn’t* the same. Because Izuku would dare say that they’ve gotten closer, not that he would voice it out loud. After all, Katsuki has still to this day never even admitted they were friends. But through his actions, Izuku knew.

It was in the way that the blonde would hang out with him, saying that it was because he was bored and had nothing to do, and yet, when the greenettes goes to school the next day, he’ll hear someone say that Bakugo Katsuki didn’t show up to some party or major event that happened that very night.

It was in the way that Katsuki, when they were hanging out, looked more comfortable going on rambles too, when previously, it was more so Izuku who would go on rambles while Katsuki’s words were always collected and shielded. The shields were still there, but it felt more like heavily frosted glass rather than steel walls.

It was in the way that Katsuki might put a hand on the small of his back to stabilize Izuku if they were walking somewhere. In the way the green eyed boy might sometimes wake up in his bed with a blanket on him, even though he knew for a fact he had fallen asleep on the floor of his bedroom. In the way Katsuki made sure Izuku stayed close to him when they went out somewhere a bit sketchy together.

Which made it all the more funny that in school, they still never interacted with one another. Izuku wished that he would. Because he was tired of feeling as if he was too embarrassing to be a part of Katsuki’s life beyond the evenings and nights.

“Where exactly is your grandpa’s farm?” Izuku asked, as he stared out the window while Katsuki drove steadily out of the Ise’s town borders. It was still dark, but soon enough, the sun will be rising.

Katsuki drove with one hand on the steering wheel, and the other resting on the center console. At the question, Katsuki just stared forward and replied, “About an hour out of here. It’s at the foothills of the mountains: it’s not even a town. It’s literally just farmland for miles. The old fucker’s got a corn field and a wheat farm. And a barn full of filthy animals.”

“Sounds lovely,” Izuku honestly replies. He likes the quaint feeling of farms, so the thought of a corn and wheat field to frolic around in wasn’t too bad.

Katsuki snorts, “It’s alright.”

Izuku then finds himself staring down at the athlete’s arm that was resting against the center console. Prominent veins from working out rigorously ran down his entire arm, and Izuku admired how strong he looked. Those knuckles and hands looked thoroughly used from years of handling a vaulting pole.

Izuku was staring so intently that he hadn’t even noticed when Katsuki glanced over at him then smirks.

“You got a hand fetish or something, nerd?” The blonde teases him.

Izuku immediately reddens.

“No,” He replied honestly, before his voice got a little shy, “Your hands are just nice.”

“Just my hands?” Katsuki snorts with confidence.

Izuku wasn’t going to respond to that and give Katsuki the pleasure of knowing that *no* , it wasn’t just his hands. Oddly enough, what happened next caused Izuku to glitch because he wasn’t exactly sure what to do. While driving, Katsuki then flipped the arm that was on the console over so that the underside of his arm was there, and his fingers parted so that it looked like an invitation for Izuku to hold his hand.

The underside of Katsuki’s arms had even more veins running up. Izuku just stared at the arm that was still resting on the console, but turned up in an invitation. Katsuki still looked forward to the road. Izuku was sitting sideways anyways, knees pulled up slightly onto the seat, body facing the other.

When Izuku didn’t make any move, the athlete glanced over at the greenette with a raised brow.

“Go ahead,” Katsuki tells him, “If you want to admire, now’s the time.”

Izuku blinked up at him, staring at Katsuki’s sharp side profile as the blonde goes back to looking at the road. He wasn’t exactly sure what caused the other to invite Izuku’s touch, but the greenette found himself automatically taking up the offer.

Reaching out, Izuku slowly let his hands touch Katsuki’s palm. And softly, his fingers glided across the callused hands, admiring the physical proof of years and years of hard work on the track field. Izuku felt the urge to interlock their fingers, and the thought made his chest flutter a bit. Before he could stop himself, he aligned their hands, liking the way Katsuki’s larger

ones encompassed his own. He didn't intertwined them, but he practically did the next closest thing. If Katsuki minded, he didn't say anything.

Wordlessly, Izuku then used a few fingers to slightly trace over the athlete's wrist, and down his underarm, following the prominent forearm veins, enjoying how firm everything about Katsuki was. From the driver's seat, Izuku could feel Katsuki shift, and he paused immediately.

With wide eyes, Izuku spoke, "I'm sorry. I didn't mean t-"

"Don't stop," Katsuki tells him then, and Izuku wasn't sure to be shocked or to be delighted. It was in times like this where Izuku senses that the blonde, like most people, occasionally wants more gentle touches, but unlike everyone else, was never going to ask for it.

And so for the rest of the car ride, Izuku continues to place his hands on top of Katsuki, and habitually placed gentle touches here and there, and the both of them ignored how intimate a moment like this actually was. Instead, they masked it with casual conversations about anything that came up on their mind. Anything to distract from the fact that Katsuki was allowing himself to be touched like a lover.

When they got to the farm, it was exactly as Izuku had imagined it in his head, except maybe a little even more beautiful. Like Katsuki mentioned, it was at the foothills of a mountain, and on either side of a two story home with a traditional wrap around porch was green grass that was growing a little wildy, but had its charm.

Across the dirt road from the house was where the farmland started. Immediately, they see an expansive corn field that went above their heads, about 8 feet tall, and not yet ripe. Apparently, the wheat field was beyond that, but it was not in sight from their vantage point.

Katsuki pulled into the house side, and his tires crunched under the dirt and gravel road. It was now light enough outside, since the sun finally erupted from below the horizon, and the early morning light casted a beautiful pinkish-orange onto the creme colored house. Climbing out of the car, Katsuki pocketed the keys and led his way up the porch stairs and rung the doorbell.

Izuku felt the porch stairs creak underneath his feet, and saw some of the paint chip off. Izuku stood behind the taller man, and admired the quietness of the home. The nearest neighbor was probably about two miles away out here in the countryside.

A moment later, the door opened to reveal a tall but frail looking man with the same red eyes Katsuki had, yet they were warm and round, rather than sharp and blazing. The lines around his mouth were signs of much smiling during his younger years, as well as the crow's feet around the elderly man's eyes.

Upon seeing Katsuki, his grandfather broke into a smile and walked forward to the boy for a hug. Katsuki glanced down to the ground, before stepping in awkwardly to give the man a pat on the back. Izuku found the interaction odd, as was most interactions Katsuki has had that

required a bit more intimacy. It always looked a bit uncomfortable for the taller boy, even if it *was* his grandfather or whoever else.

“Katsuki,” The old man exclaims with a raspier voice, “It’s so nice to see you.”

Katsuki nodded to the man, “You too, gramps.”

“And I see you’ve brought a friend?” His grandfather tilted his head to the side to take a look at Izuku.

“Oh yeah,” Katsuki gestures to the greenette, “This is…”

And then, the athletes paused in his words. Izuku stared up at him, catching Katsuki’s eyes, and wondered what was the hold up. He wanted to internally laugh seeing Katsuki struggle with how to introduce Izuku in a way without getting him berated for the nickname Deku. Izuku took pity on him, and was about to pipe up and introduce himself to Katsuki’s grandfather, when the blonde finished the introduction himself.

“Izuku. Midoriya Izuku,” Katsuki then finished, voice careful but sure.

And Izuku felt his breath hitched as he immediately turned to Katsuki, but the blonde wasn’t looking at him. It’s been a while since Izuku had accepted that he will likely never hear that name on the blonde’s lips ever again; therefore, he could barely believe his ears this time.

It happened too fast. Izuku wanted to replay the moment, to hear his name roll off of that sweet, rough tongue again. Katsuki treated it like nothing, but the greenette *knew* that Katsuki understood what just happened was simply not normal.

“Midoriya?” His grandfather comes in to give Izuku a hug, “You must be Mitsuki’s friend’s son. Inko, was it?”

Izuku nodded his head with a bright smile, “Yeah, that’s my mom! It’s nice to meet you, sir.”

“Likewise,” The old man gave him a toothy smile, “Katsuki’s never brought a friend to meet me, before. You must be special.”

“Not really,” Izuku laughed and elbowed Katsuki, “He just didn’t want to do all of the work himself.”

His grandfather disagreed, “Then you must be even *more* special than I thought. Katsuki here doesn’t like to have people help him with anything,” The old man reaches out to pat Katsuki’s shoulders.

Katsuki shrugged him off, and brushed his way inside the home, “I’m right fucking here, gramps.”

“I’m aware, Katsuki,” His grandfather turned his head to holler back, then turned to Izuku with a wink and a finger to his lips, “Don’t mind the brat. His way of showing affection is a bit unorthodox.” Before urging the greenette inside.

Over tea, his grandfather forced the both of them to talk about their lives and catch him up. And so, they sat in a nice hickory wood room for a while, and Izuku admired the picture frames on the wall with all sorts of neat photos. Some of his grandfather when he was younger, many of Mitsuki and her siblings, some of Mitsuki and Maseru's wedding photos, and then plenty of Katsuki and some of Katsuki's other cousins.

Katsuki looked angry in all of the kid pictures that were hung up on the wall.

In one particular frame, the blonde looked as if he was going to bite the camera.

Noticing Izuku staring at that one, Katsuki's grandfather laughed and pointed at it, "Katsuki was so angry in that photo. When he was younger, Mitsuki would drop him off here when she and Maseru had a work trip, and I'd try to put the little brat to work out on the farm. But Katsuki, with his young little runner legs, would always try to escape and hide out in the river."

Katsuki added in aggressively, "And I was pretty damn good at it too. Until you sent that dog to find me."

His grandfather nodded, "That's where the photo was from. You two should head over to the river during your break. Although, I did hear from some girls down the road that there were some leeches in there."

"Leeches?" Izuku paled. He wasn't afraid of bugs, heights, or much, but the thought of a leech sucking the blood out of his body made him uncomfortable.

"Those are just rumors," Katsuki rolled his eyes, "I played in there all the time as a kid, and there weren't no leeches."

"I'm just relaying what I heard," His grandfather put his hands in the air with a cough, "Anyways, I've been a bit sick these past couple days, so there's plenty of things I haven't been able to get done. So I'm very grateful you boys have come to help me, because lord knows I don't have the energy to do it myself right now."

And then, the old man pulls out a wrinkled piece of notebook paper from his pockets and slides it over the table, "Here's a list of things that I really need to get done."

Katsuki holds it up and looks at it. Izuku reads from over his shoulder, and his eyes widened.

*Reinstall three of the creaking panels on the front porch, repaint the front porch white, replace the fertilizer and use rototiller to put fertilizer in the garden, feed the chickens out back and collect the eggs, return the pie dish to Mrs. Bua down the road, prune the tomatoes, replace the missing tile roofs on the tool shed, check cornfields to see if we have a black cutworm problem, measure the height of the wheat stalks.*

"Kacchan, that's a lot," Izuku whispered to Katsuki when the old man was getting up to grab something.

Katsuki whispered back, "I fucking know. The old man always does this shit to me."

“Better get started then,” His grandfather yells from the kitchen, having heard their commentary.

And then began their toils. They decided to generally tackle the tasks in the order displayed on the list, which meant that they first had to reinstall the creaking floor boards on the porch steps. Grabbing tools from the workshed, they trudged over to the front of the house, where the two boys then put both of their hands on their hips, staring at the porch.

Finally, Izuku turned to the side and asked, “So you know how to do this?”

Katsuki pursed his lips then shrugged, “I have a general idea. If not, we can always google it.”

“Kacchan, there’s no signal out here,” Izuku reminded him.

“Hm,” Katsuki reconsiders the situation, “Fuck.” Before shrugging, “Whatever. We’ll figure it out.”

Before they started, Katsuki jogs over to where his car was parked, pulls out the pill bluetooth speaker, and connected his phone.

“Why do you always play music?” Izuku asks out of curiosity, bending down to pick up a pry bar to pull out the nails from the wood.

Katsuki then played “Coming Around Again” by Carly Simmon, and set his phone aside, shrugging, “It makes me feel like I’m in a movie, even when I’m doing something fucking boring. Like this shit. If it’s one thing I hate, it’s people who want their life to be a certain way, but don’t do shit to change it. I’m not gonna wait around for movie moments. I’ll make my own.”

Izuku felt a little targeted, but he admires the go-getter mentality, something he was beginning to pick up from Katsuki by the day, “I won’t be bored if I’m with you.”

Katsuki paused at that, surprised at the candidness, and gives Izuku a flick on the forehead, “How can you just say shit like that, nerd.”

Izuku smiles cheekily at Katsuki as he begins too pry nails out of the porch, and laughs, “Unlike you, Kacchan, I’m not afraid of expressing my emotions.”

Oddly enough, Katsuki gives him a funny look as if he knew something Izuku didn’t and then replies, “Yes, you are.”

Izuku gave him a confused expression but shrugged to himself when Katsuki didn’t seem to want to offer up an explanation.

Izuku was right though. When he was with Katsuki, he wasn't bored. Not when both he and the blonde had so much to say, and bounced off of each other as well as they did.

To think that there was a time when this was unfathomable makes Izuku wonder again what all went wrong. He knew that one day, out of the blue, Katsuki stopped talking to him. He could barely remember what day it had been, with only snippets coming in through his memories. Some words and actions were exchanged, but he didn't know which ones. Something had happened, but he couldn't recall what exactly. Whatever it had been, Izuku knew for sure, wasn't enough to cause the reaction it did from Katsuki, because then, he would have remembered.

Still, he was happy for what they had now, even if it was bound to end, because for the first time in his life, it feels as if he was living, not just alive. Just as Katsuki said.

As the morning continued and the sun rises higher and higher into the sky, Izuku felt sweat on his back and the green flannel shirt he had on was sticking to his skin. From the side, he could see a bead of sweat fall down the side of Katsuki's face. It had taken them about an hour and a half to take out the porch steps and to reinstall new wood, and then another hour to completely repaint it white. Once they were done though, Izuku sat back on the grass and admired how clean it now looked. Katsuki's grandfather came out here and there in order to bring them water or refill their glasses.

By the afternoon, they had finished rototilling, feeding the chickens, and returning the pie dish to Mrs. Bua. Feeding the chickens and collecting their eggs was arguably Izuku and Katsuki's least favorite part. Not only was the smell of the chicken barn excruciating, but they had to essentially play Twister on the ground in order to avoid all of the excrement. Not to mention that the roosters were particularly feisty. Collecting the eggs was a different story, since some of the hens were protective over them. But they ultimately got a full basket and one small chicken scratch on Katsuki's leg.

"You boys working hard?" They were about to move onto pruning the tomatoes when Katsuki's grandfather stepped outside to where they had just come back from setting down the chicken eggs.

"Yes!" Izuku exclaimed through his exhaustion from the heat, "It hasn't been too bad."

"That's because you've been talking my ear off," Katsuki grumbled.

"So are you," Izuku stuck out his tongue.

His grandfather carried a woven lunch basket in his small arms, which Katsuki was quick to take off for him. The old man then gestured to the sack, "I made you and Midoriya lunch, so you two go take a break. It's too hot in the afternoon, anyways. You boys can probably start again around 3, and still finish up before dark."

"Oh, thank you!" Izuku was grateful for the food.

"It's nothing too fancy," His grandfather laughed, "Katsuki. Take him to the river, and eat your lunch there."

Katsuki cracked his neck and complied, “Alright. See ya later, old man.”

“Have fun,” The man in question insists.

The path to the river was an odd one. The two of them had to walk down the side of the dirt road which was the only one for miles, side by side with the lunch basket in Katsuki’s arm. The sun was beating down on them, and their shoes kicked up dust with every step. Izuku’s body felt sludged from the heat.

“-son of a bitch came at me, and I had to fucking run like hell,” Katsuki was telling some story from a while back when he was at the farm, “So that’s why I cannot stand cougars. They always jump out of the rocks and shit, catching you off guard. It’s cheating.”

“Who would win in a fight now?” Izuku asks, “You or the cougar.”

Katsuki laughed at this, as they took a detour off the road and waded through tall grass that may or may not have ticks in them, going towards the woods, “I’d love to say me, but who fucking knows. Maybe we could call the fucker out for a rematch. Bakugo versus Cougar, Round 2. But this time, I ain’t runnin.”

“Only dying,” Izuku teases, “But no running.”

Katsuki ruffles Izuku’s hair as they entered the woody area. The blonde weaves through the forest as if he knew the path by heart, “How about you, shitnerd. Any animal horror stories?”

“Well,” Izuku looked up at the sky to think about it, “One time when I was really little, my dad took me out to a ricefield so he could visit his old friend from high school. And when he wasn’t looking, I fell into the flooded fields, and when I came up, about five leeches were stuck on my legs.”

“Holy shit,” Katsuki cackles, “That’s fucking rough.”

“Yeah,” Izuku scratches his neck, “That’s why I’m not particularly keen on going to the creek.”

Katsuki shook his head as they walked towards the edge of the forest, where Izuku could now hear the sounds of a river flowing gently, “There’s no damn leeches.”

“How do you know?” Izuku doubts.

“I’ve been here more than anyone when I was a brat. Never seen a leech,” Katsuki replies.

“But times have changed,” Izuku argues.

“Not here,” Katsuki tells him, “Not in Ise. Not out here on the farm. Not for another four cities over. Nothing changes. Anyways, we’re here. It’s up ahead.”

Izuku turns his head to see that they were now about to break through the treeline. As they approached the river, the surrounding trees looked to be more and more scarce. There wasn't much shrubbery, so it was easy to walk through. The river itself was not particularly wide, about 30 feet across and looked to be about 10 feet deep max. It flowed slowly, enough that the current wouldn't wash anyone away, and the water itself was a pretty greenish-blue, which was a tell-tale sign of a clean body of freshwater. On the other bank was where the treeline continued again.

The sun's rays glistened on the surface, and Katsuki set the basket down near the trunk of a large tree that had a thick branch high up that hung about 10 feet above the water. And from the branch, Izuku then notices a dense rope tied to the thickest part, most likely for people who wanted to swing into the water.

Taking note of that, Izuku then sits down next to Katsuki on fallen pine needles and they pull out the food his grandfather had made out to eat. Izuku hadn't even realized how hungry he was until he bit into the corner of a sandwich.

The two of them, needing to refuel their energy, gulfed down the food easily and went for the other things within the basket. Chips, fruit, some harvested tomato salad. And they sat near the river, talking between their bites. Finally, the two washed down the food with water, before sitting back to let it all digest. Once in a while, a small fish would jump out of the water and surprise them. But other than that, it was peaceful and quiet other than the sound of Katsuki's music playing.

At some point, Izuku pulled out his phone to check the time.

"It's only 1. We have two hours before we have to go back," Izuku then looked up at Katsuki, "What should we do?"

Katsuki then stands up and stretches his legs, and with a mischievous grin, tells Izuku, "Get up, Deku."

Izuku slowly climbed up from his sitting position while eying Katsuki, "You're swinging into the water, aren't you."

He shouldn't have even asked. Katsuki switched the song to Little Lies by Fleetwood Mac, which Izuku thought was perfect for a day at the river, before tossing it to the side and unbuttoning his white shirt. Izuku watched, as Katsuki looked up midway through taking it off to catch Izuku's eyes on him. Embarrassed, the greenette looked off to the side, but Katsuki didn't say anything.

When the shirt was off, Izuku was free to admire under the ruse that he was just talking to Katsuki. It was the thousandth time he's seen Katsuki half naked at this point, but the shock of how incredibly well defined Katsuki was, especially now with his skin more tan as the season comes along, never goes away.

"Damn right I am," Katsuki finally says as he tosses the shirt to the ground, "And you are too."

“But leeches,” Izuku gestured towards the river, stepping back.

Katsuki threw his hands up, “I told you for the millionth fucking time. There’s no leeches.”

“And you gave me some bullshit philosophical reasoning about how,” Izuku makes exaggerated mimicking hand gestures, “nothing changes in Ise. Or on the farm. Like sure, people might not change. But that doesn’t mean leeches won’t somehow find their way into a river, Kacchan.”

To interrupt Izuku’s rambling, Katsuki rolled his eyes and sauntered over to where Izuku was, until he was mere inches away, and grabbed the collar of Izuku’s flannel. Izuku, shocked at the action, stepped backwards only for Katsuki to step forward once more.

And then, the blonde began to unbutton the top of Izuku’s shirt, eyes trained on the buttons, “You’re getting in.”

Izuku’s cheeks flared up, and their proximity and Katsuki’s hands undoing his shirt throws him off guard. He stares up at Katsuki, as those rough fingers move down his chest.

“If there *are* leeches, I’ll pay for your therapy,” Katsuki makes a deal, and undoes the last button.

Izuku just lets the flannel slips off of his shoulder, and that’s when Katsuki meets his eyes, looking down at the greenette with barely inches between them. Izuku hadn’t said anything this entire time. It would be so easy to reach up, and meet halfway. *So* easy. And yet, neither of them do it.

“The fuck is it, nerd,” Katsuki breaks the silence, before stepping back, giving Izuku room to breathe.

Izuku opened his mouth, before closing it. And then opening it again, saying with a slight laugh, “You have a habit of taking off my clothes, Kacchan.”

Katsuki thinks about it, pausing for a moment to tongue his cheek and looked at a rock as if recalling if this was true. The kick-off. The lake party. And just now. Before switching his gaze over to Izuku, “Seems like I do. You uncomfortable or somethin?”

Izuku goes to undo his pants, letting them fall to the ground as he steps out, and looks up at Katsuki’s eyes, “No.”

Katsuki goes first, simply because the taller seemed to have extensive experience doing this. The blonde held onto the main trunk of the tree, and reached his arms out over the water to grab a hold of the rope. When his hand got a grip, Katsuki pulls it back and steps away from the tree, further into the land until there seems like there’s going to be enough momentum to swing him far into the river. Izuku watches and takes note.

And then, grabbing on with both arms and securing himself, Katsuki then runs forward and right as he meets the border between the edge and where the river begins, the athlete tucks his

feet in and around the rope, swinging forward. And at the maximum point in the boy's trajectory, with a loud hollar, Katsuki lets go and flies into the water with a loud splash. Izuku laughs at the beautiful moment. And when Katsuki gets up, he pushes his wet hair out of his face.

And then yells out, "Your turn, shitnerd!"

"I'm coming, I'm coming," Izuku says as he makes his way to the edge of the tree, waiting for the rope to swing back his way, and grabbing onto it before it can go back into its pendulum motion. And bringing the rope back, Izuku did the same until he could run forward, push off the ground, and at the maximum height, releases the rope to fall into a spot next to Katsuki with a fun scream.

Izuku bursts out into laughter when he rises to the surface, treading water and shaking his hair. He felt like a kid again, except better. The sun shone through the tree canopy and onto the water, causing Izuku to shield his eyes while treading with one arm. The water wasn't even that cold.

Katsuki nudges the other from under the water, "So?"

Izuku slyly looks over at the blonde, and jokes, "It *might* be worth the leeches."

"Might?" Katsuki chuckles, "What can I do to make it fully worth it." The blonde asks as he swims a bit closer.

Izuku meets him halfway and pretends to think on it, "You tell me, Kacchan."

Katsuki gives him a lazy grin with his head tilted slightly up as they swam closer to each other, "Getting flirty now, eh Deku?"

It was a playful comment, so Izuku ended up throwing his head back in laughter, and Katsuki followed suit. Seeing Katsuki's smile was one of the nicest moments Izuku could witness. He wonders what he looks like in Katsuki's eyes. If his eyes were still as creepy as the blonde always said they were. If his smile was anything of note. If the water on his hair made him look silly or if he looked pretty with it.

He looked up at Katsuki, who in turned tilted his head down at the greenette, still treading water. With the pretty music in the background, Izuku wishes that he could kiss the other. For real this time, and not under some guise.

Katsuki broke eye contact, and began swimming towards the bank. Hollering back to Izuku, the blonde asked him, "Come on! Don't tell me you're only going to do it once, Deku."

Izuku, getting back into the environment, started swimming to the bank behind Katsuki, "Coming!"

When 3 o'clock almost arrived, the two boys were laid back on the river bank, bodies sore from exhaustion and treading water. Izuku's back was slightly sticky from the river water,

and he was sure when he sat up, pine needles will be matted to his back. And yet he didn't care, because laying in the warm countryside sun, drying off after repeatedly rope-swinging into the water with the boy who you are tragically falling for was going to stick in Izuku's mind for a while as one of the more beautiful moments to have come his way.

At one point, both Katsuki and Izuku attempted to get on the rope at once and jump off at the same time, but Katsuki ended up losing his footing and fell early, causing water to go up Izuku's nose from laughing too hard. And now, with a nice upbeat song in the background to mellow out the wild mood from earlier, Izuku relaxes.

"We have to go back to the farm in a moment," Izuku announced with his eyes still closed, soaking in the sun.

Katsuki hummed, "That's in a moment. Don't rush."

Izuku smiled, "I still can't believe you talked to my mom for permission. How was that?"

"Not fun," Katsuki replies, "But you're here. So it doesn't matter."

Izuku looked over at Katsuki and quietly took note with a fluttering heart how Katsuki has his own way of saying that he likes the company without ever saying it outright. Izuku knew that to some degree, he was appreciated.

After a few more minutes by the creek, the two boys trudged back up with wet boxers that made their actual clothes slightly damp. Once they got back to the farm, it was time to sludge again.

There was still about half of the list to complete, and it was already about 3:20 by the time they made it back and was ready to go. Pruning the tomatoes was much more difficult than either of them had originally thought. Izuku and Katsuki decide right then that they do not possess a green thumb, and Inko, who enjoyed gardening, may be disappointed in Izuku for this.

It got down in about an hour, making it halfway through 4 o'clock by the time they were ready for the next thing to do. And Katsuki predicted that replacing the tiles of the tool shed would take another 2 hours or so, considering that they had to uninstall and reinstall so many components. And so, the two started immediately to ensure that the sun stayed up.

Indeed it had, because by the time 6:00 or so rolled around and the sun was beginning its trajectory to the ground once more, they had completed the tool shed and now only had the corn field and wheat field to go. Both of those tasks were relatively easy. For the corn fields, they simply would just have to look at the stalks and branches for a certain type of pest. As for the wheat field, they really only needed to take a couple of measurements and average them together.

And so, the two stand in front of the corn stalks at the moment, staring up at the 8 feet stalks that threatened to engulf them. The breeze was picking up a little bit, and clouds above them

were plentiful. The corn field was a massive plot that looked like it never ended. The entrance was right ahead, but it was tiny and branched out into several directions, similar to a corn maze.  Katsuki's grandfather designed it like this simply because he wanted a way to go through the corn field efficiently.

"So we just...check to see if there's a pest problem?" Izuku asked the blonde.

Katsuki shrugged, "Yeah. That about sums it up."

"Hm," Izuku nods to himself, "How do we do that exactly?"

Katsuki entered the maze hedge and pulls down a stalk from the side, before turning to Izuku, "You check here and there if there are lots of stalks that look like some fuckers have eaten it, or if it has rotting parts inside. This shit doesn't take too long. Only about half an hour."

Izuku replies with an *okay* before taking the opposite side of the dirt path in between where the corn was planted, which was probably around 2 feet wide in total. And so, the two boys had to squish or walk parallel so that they don't run into each other in the tiny space in between where the rows are planted.

For the next about twenty or so minutes, they weaved in and out of the corn fields, stopping here and there to check for any odd signs of damage in the leaves and fruiting body. It was not a particularly exciting activity; however, the job was easy to do. So far, Izuku had not seen any damage other than one or two areas of the corn field, and that was not because of the pests but for other reasons. They would make that area with a blue plastic tie, so that Katsuki's grandfather would later be able to go through and see which parts needed to be looked at.

As they neared the half hour, Izuku was convinced that the corn field did not have a pest problem, and told Katsuki as such.

Izuku stares down at the flawless stalk of corn he just pulled down, and frowns.

"Kacchan, I don't think there's anything wrong with the corn," Izuku tells the other, "It all just looks normal."

He turned over and looked at the plant some more to double check, and when he didn't hear any answer, Izuku paused. He didn't just hear no answer, but he heard no sound either. Dropping the corn and looking up, Izuku turned his head both ways to realize that Katsuki was no longer there. But had left him somewhere.

Blinking fast, Izuku turned back and forth in his spot, wondering if it was intentional or if they accidentally got lost. But knowing Katsuki, Izuku would say that it was intentio-

"Deku!" A shout was hard from far away through the maze, "I've given you a head start. Now run, I'm gonna go get your ass!"

Izuku's eyes widened, and he cursed out to Katsuki, "You're a bad person, Kacchan!"

Before he realized his mistake. He had been given a head start. And so, he just revealed his general location just by having responded to Katsuki. And the blonde didn't take too long to reply.

"Shouldn't have done that," Katsuki yells from somewhere else within the corn maze. Izuku agrees. He shouldn't have. Because if he had not, then Izuku would also not be currently hearing the sound of fast rustling moving quickly through the corn stalks. And knowing it was Katsuki and how athletic he was, Izuku began running. The leaves shuffled in between them, and the sharpness of it scratched their legs here and there. Izuku felt the urge to look back every five seconds to see if Katsuki was close behind, and it felt like the sounds of rustling were coming closer.

Going into his maximum speed, Izuku kept reminding himself to take a million turns. If he takes many turns then he'll lose the blonde faster. And so at every corner he can find, Izuku takes a sporadic zig zag motion until it was harder to hear where Katsuki was.

Izuku was grinning the whole time from the adrenaline of being chased, and he stopped for a second to catch his breathe, knowing that it would be especially hard for Katsuki to find him if he was staying still and not making rustling noises.

"You can't hide!" Katsuki shouts from not too far away, and Izuku was not expecting the blonde to be so near.

Immediately, he begins running around, pushing past the stalks that threaten to cut his fingers and legs. At the continuation of movement, Katsuki hollers as he picks up the sound and starts running again too.

Izuku was pushing through some 8 ft tall stalks, when the boy stumbled and was shocked by the sudden change in atmosphere.

He knew that behind the massive cornfield was where Katsuki's grandfather's wheat field began, but he was so used to running through the green corn just now that suddenly seeing fields of yellow that seemed to go on for forever jolted him.

The wheat field was absolutely stunning. Behind him now was the edge line of the corn, and all he could see were the wheat fields with its gorgeous pale yellow stalks that blew in the direction of the wind. The 6:40 P.M. sun's glow poured over the fields like molten gold, and it looked as if it will never end. How beautiful.

Izuku's breath was taken, and he put his hands on his knees to rest while breathing heavily.

However, suddenly, from about 20 feet to his left, a Katsuki pops out from the corn fields and comes face to face with the wheat fields as well. But unlike Izuku, who stopped to stare at the sight, Katsuki ran straight towards the shorter male who was taken so off guard that he lost focus, allowing himself to be caught.

"I got you, shitnerd" Katsuki laughed out loud as he ran towards the greenette.

Then, to Izuku's surprise, Katsuki tackles him by picking him up by the waist, lifting him up, and spinning him around in the air. The gentle breeze blew pieces of green hair across his forehead as he's spun around in two circles, and Izuku laughed with his head tilted back. He lifted his arms to catch the breeze here up high, and everything was too stunning.

Izuku then wrapped his legs around Katsuki's waist and puts his arms around the blonde's shoulders. For stability, Katsuki moves his arms from the boy's waist to the bottom of his thighs, and Izuku could not help but feel as if their position was a little more intimate. Maybe for Katsuki, it wasn't anything. But to Izuku, his heart was racing faster being held up like this.

He tilted his head down to look at Katsuki, who shifted his gaze from the golden fields up to up at Izuku. From Katsuki's pocket, the pill speaker was playing These Dreams, and Izuku finds himself relating to the lyrics too much. No matter what he tried to do, the athlete will show up in his dreams. And within his slumber, the athlete holds him just like this. Touches him just like this. The golden sun of Ise illuminates his face just like this.

Lost in a trance, not breaking eye contact with Katsuki, Izuku forgets that he was not in one of his dreams, and he shouldn't do what he was about to do. And yet he did anyways.

Izuku brings a hand up from Katsuki's shoulders to carefully place on the side of the blonde's face, startling the other. Izuku's eyes looked at him with a curious gaze, wondering how someone could steal his breath away like this, as his palm caresses Katsuki's face. The rough skin met his fingertips with warmth, and Katsuki looked as if he was waiting to see what Izuku was going to do.

Izuku brought their foreheads together, just leaning gently against Katsuki's temple.

And with a breathy voice, the greenette asks the other, "Say it again."

Katsuki raised a brow, "Say what."

Izuku thinks back to this exact conversation they had the night that Katsuki had came over so that Izuku could help him with some homework, and ended up staying the night. He repeats what Katsuki said then when Izuku had said *his* real name.

"My name," Izuku's breath hitched, "Say it again."

He had been so shocked by how sudden and unexpected it was for Katsuki to have introduced him with his name earlier that he couldn't experience it fully. It's been a long time since Katsuki had called him Deku in a malicious way, but that didn't mean *Izuku* on the blonde's tongue excited him any less. The blonde searched through his eyes for reason and was silent for a moment. Izuku's hands was still on the other's face, and Katsuki then said in his usual gruff voice.

"Izuku," The athlete calls out to him.

The boy in question could cry right now, but he holds it back in favor of smiling ridiculously wide that his eyes look like crescents and his teeth stretch wide. Katsuki's expression widens

at this for a second, before going back into neutral and observant. This time hearing it, Izuku felt as if he could enjoy it fully.

The wind was picking up a little bit, and Katsuki uses an arm to reach up and take Izuku's hands off of his face. The action reminded Izuku that he had definitely done something Katsuki didn't particularly like. The athlete didn't *do* gentle.

And then, Katsuki settled him down on the ground again in front of him, and Izuku's neck tilts up to look at the taller boy.

Katsuki stares up at the sky. The clouds were moving quickly, and Izuku's flannel flapped a bit in the breeze.

"The winds are coming from the East," Katsuki announced while observing the sky, "They're gonna get pretty fucking strong."

Izuku frowned, "What will that mean?"

Katsuki then looks down at Izuku, their height difference prominent, and Izuku sees the background of the sky moving behind him. The blonde's hair flows gently, and his dark eyes stare at him.

Katsuki then answers him, "It means a storm is coming."

The signs of a storm coming became more and more prominent as the next week and a half moves by. Sometimes, Izuku would stop in his steps on the way to school and enjoy the strong but warm breeze hitting his body, and if no one was around, he'd spread his arms wide and feel it *fully* .

As Izuku has thought about before, Ise was static. The people, the motion of the ocean, and even the weather was static. The golden sunsets were beautiful, but they rarely ever changed. It gets to the point where he wishes for the occasional rain, which for him, was a symbol of change.

It reminded him that Ise wasn't *just* a computer-generated town, abandoned by its creators in a perfect state with its perfect sunsets, perfect location, perfect people, and perfect weather.

And so, he waits in participation for the first drop to fall.

On Monday, it does not come. The breeze was still there; however, the sky's appearance was as sunny and beautiful as it always was. After school had ended, Izuku was watching Katsuki at the field with his teammates from outside of the chainlinked fence.

Katsuki today was focused more on helping coach the others, as the captain of the pole vault team for obvious reasons, and Izuku admired seeing how Katsuki coached the others. He was not a kind or an easy teacher. He didn't give baseless praise, but what he *was* is effective. His

advice was catered to each of his teammate's personal styles, which Katsuki had been observing under the radar for years.

Just before he was about to leave, a fluffy head of brunette hair bounced towards him. And within a couple of seconds, Izuku looked up to see Kaito Sen standing on the other side of the gate, grinning down at him.

"Midoriya," The brunette calls out to him, "It's a beautiful day to see a beautiful person, isn't it?"

Izuku rolls his eyes with a smile, "You really just like to throw out compliments, don't you?"

Kaito shrugged, "I'm just shooting my shot. Anyways, are you free tomorrow night?"

Izuku thinks about it. He's been on two other dates with Kaito since the first one, and they had gone to the movie theatre and then a park another time. It was nice, and had the same vibe as it did before. Sweet and safe. Izuku felt bad, because he knew that he wanted someone else, but still, the hope that maybe another person who would want him back could sweep him off of his feet made him agree to a few more dates with Kaito.

Izuku learns a couple of things about Kaito. First, the brunette didn't really like spontaneous things, and would prefer if dates were planned out. Izuku was sure that Kaito had a romanticized image of things in his head before it happens, and wanted it to play out exactly how he plans it. Which was fine, since it ended up still being a fun time.

Secondly, Kaito enjoyed certain parts of Izuku and not so much other parts. Kaito liked Izuku's face, the fact that Izuku was smart and involved in a lot of clubs, the way Izuku talked, and he liked Izuku's happy personality. But from what the greenette noticed, Kaito *didn't* so much enjoy Izuku's strength, and it surprised him here and there when Kaito wanted to help him with something, just to find out Izuku could do it himself: carrying heavy things, and the like.

Kaito also didn't seem to like doing what he considers to be slightly 'childish.' No sneaking into places, no pushing each other in a shopping cart around a parking lot, none of the sort. Kaito prefers adult-like dates that could still be fun: dinner and a movie, walks around a park then ice cream, the classics. It was fine, Izuku tells himself.

Thirdly, more than anything else, Kaito Sen *hated* Izuku's relationship to Bakugo Katsuki. And he made it known.

On their second date, they had been sitting on a park bench when Kaito had asked him what he did last night.

"I climbed a water tower, and watched the sunset," Izuku says casually while eating ice cream, "It was really nice."

Kaito gives him a look then, and then asks, leaning back against the bench, "Isn't that illegal?"

“I mean,” Izuku pursed his lips, “It was a water tower that’s been abandoned. No one really owns or uses it anymore.”

“You know that’s dangerous, right?” Kaito looks at him and plays with a lock of Izuku’s hair, “You don’t know what’s broken or not in abandoned places since there’s no one to maintain the facilities. You could get serious hurt, you know.”

The familiarity of those words struck a cord and Izuku frowned. He knew that the sentiment was nice and out of concern, but he was also sick of being underestimated.

“If I get hurt, I’ll take responsibility for my own actions,” Izuku frowned, swinging his legs on the park bench.

“Nah, if anyone, Bakugo should take responsibility,” Kaito said in a slightly bitter tone, “He’s always planting these stupid ideas in your head, and making you go on these ridicu-”

Izuku defended himself, “It’s not stupid, and he doesn’t make me do anything. Kaito, I want you to know that I don’t just follow Kacchan around like a loyal dog. And some of these ideas are mine. He’s not the nicest person, but if there’s something I don’t want to do, he won’t even think about it. He knows my capabilities.”

Kaito looked at him, then pursed his lips, glancing down at the ground, “Sorry. I just get a little jealous. You’re with him all the time.”

*Jealous? Don’t we all* , Izuku thinks to himself. But just elbows the other, “We’re project partners.”

Kaito then looks at him as if he was stupid, “ *Just* project partners? Midoriya, we both know very well you two hang out much more than what’s required.”

Izuku looked down at his lap, “Kaito, me and Kacchan’s partnership is not any of your business.” He said, wanting to end the conversation.

“It is if I want you to be my boyfriend,” Kaito turns to him then, “I’m going to be real with you, Midoriya. I don’t want you hanging out with him. He’s a shitty person, you know. Great coach, great athlete, whatever. But he’s a bad person.”

Izuku gaped at him, unsure of what exactly to say to this.

Kaito looked frustrated as he talked further, “He’s emotionally fucked in the head. All he cares about is vault and winning everything. He can’t take losing. He doesn’t care about you. He doesn’t care about anyone but himself. All of your efforts are wasted on him, so I don’t even know why you try. If you were my boyfriend, I wouldn’t want you to hang out with someone like that.”

Izuku blinked up at Kaito, and there is a moment of silence, before he looks off to the side, “That’s why I’m not your boyfriend.”

“ *Yet* .” Kaito said, unfazed, and went back to a more charming version of himself, “You’ll come around.”

The conversation that day had ended there and left Izuku with an uncomfortable feeling in his stomach, at both the slander at Katsuki, but also his views on Kaito. It was obvious that the boy was speaking out of jealousy, he knew that much. But Izuku knew that he and Katsuki weren't anything like that.

Besides, even if he *was* Kaito's boyfriend, that still gave him no right to treat Izuku as if he owned him, or to police who he can or cannot be friends with. He had enough policing in his life.

And so back to the moment, Kaito was standing on the other side of the fence, and Izuku thought back to that conversation during their last time hanging out.

Smiling up at the athlete, Izuku shrugged, "I'm not sure."

"Well," Kaito says then, "If you're free, I'd like to take you to an art museum or something."

Izuku is curious, "There's no art museums near here."

"It's about a couple of hours away in a bigger city," Kaito explains, "I don't know. I was thinking we could go there, walk the museum. Explore the city a little bit. Grab dinner, and maybe even book a hotel room for the night and," He gives Izuku a look, " *you* know."

Izuku knew all right. Kaito wasn't exactly shy about wanting him in that kind of intimate way, and although they've made out usually at the end of their dates or played with each other's bodies for a little bit, Izuku has never thought of going all the way with Kaito. When Izuku thinks of his first time, he can't help but have an unrealistic image of someone who would never want him like that. And so, considering what Kaito was hinting at now, Izuku couldn't help but not feel entirely interested.

Kaito continued, "Your parents would let you go, right?"

Izuku wanted to laugh a bit. He had said it so automatically, that Izuku wonders if Kaito really knew him at all. If he really knew Izuku, he wouldn't have had to ask such a question.

"It's just me and my mom, actually," Izuku corrected, "And she definitely won't let me."

"Oh, my bad," Kaito looked apologetic, "Well, I'm pretty busy this next week after tomorrow, but could I at least take you to the county fair next Wednesday?"

Ah, the county fair. Izuku forgot that happened annually. He was usually allowed to go to the county fair, as long as he got back early enough. It was just a big carnival and fair event that happened on Ise's fairgrounds, and there was always good music, good food, and lots of cool rides that he probably was too old for.

Thinking about it, Izuku tells Kaito, "Sure, but I'll have to leave early."

"It's no problem," The athlete grinned, "It's a date then."

From behind Kaito, Izuku heard an all too familiar voice calling out to Kaito, “No, it’s fucking practice. Get your ass back to the pit. If I find you distracted again, you’ll do ten fucking laps with weighted vests.”

Izuku watched the blonde come up, and as if out of reflex, wanted to go up to Katsuki and strike up a conversation, dragging the other somewhere. And then he remembers: this was the big-shot Katsuki, the celebrity athlete Katsuki, the one who says the minimum to him in school.

Kaito huffed out some air, and turned to Katsuki, “So *you* can come over here whenever you want, but the moment I do it for ten seconds, you’re gonna be like that, Bakugo?”

Katsuki stepped up a bit, and the difference in build and power between Katsuki and Kaito was very clear. Katsuki had four inches on him, more muscle, a bulkier build, more of everything all around. To be fair, Kaito was very toned, athletic, and big. Just not in comparison.

And then the blonde athlete spoke near his teammate, “Ask me that again when you are a three time National Youth champion, when your tournament record is 17’6, when your personal record is 17’10, and never lost a fucking tournament in your life, Fuck Face.”

Kaito was silent. Because Katsuki was right.

And the blonde knew it, because he sauntered forward with a nasty grin, “That’s right. Now get back to the pit and run your record. We’re getting you to the next inch by Friday.”

Kaito breathed in and out, before stating a quick “Yes, captain.” And jogging off to the track field.

That left the two of them: Izuku and Katsuki, standing there now with a slight air of awkwardness that wasn’t usually there these days. Izuku made eye contact then with Katsuki for a split second, to find the blonde’s expression unreadable, his body language not revealing anything. And Katsuki says nothing either, before he turns and jogs back to the practice pit as well. *Odd* , Izuku thought to himself. *Odd indeed* .

“Kacchan, do you like Ise?” Izuku asks.

As of current, it was a slow moving Tuesday evening, and Izuku had his head laid back on an empty pit. Katsuki, after practice had ended, had stolen Izuku off to go to the stadium where the next Regionals tournament will be held.

At the moment, it was completely empty, and Katsuki had to climb over a metal gate in order to get in and unlock it from the other side. However, when they made it inside of the empty

stadium, it left Izuku in awe.

The outdoor stadium was about an hour or so from Ise, which wasn't too bad, considering that this was a big tournament. It was a stage both Katsuki and Izuku has been to before. After all, the blonde competes every year, and the greenette watches every year.

However, seeing it void of people gave off a completely different aura. Izuku was used to a large crowd, boisterous activity, and blaring speakers everywhere. Seeing the stadium empty, quiet, and missing any sort of activity made the place seem humongous.

The stands were plentiful, and the track field looked larger than average. Even the vault pit seemed enormous, so much that Izuku couldn't fathom how Katsuki could fly as high as he did.

The athlete hadn't taken him there to practice or anything. They had simply been driving with no actual destination in mind, just enjoying the conversation and the company over good music on the radio, when Katsuki swerved to pull into here. And here they were, an hour later after exploring the stadium and pretending they were the king of the world, shouting to each other from the tallest bleacher across the stadium, and they were now simply laying on the landing zone of the pole vault pit, staring up at the open sky, head nearly touching heads.

Izuku watches the clouds move, and the classic golden Ise sun reflects off of it. In his right hand was an empty bottle of some carbonated yogurt drink, and on his left he was snacking on a salmon roe onigiri. The wind was a little bit more mild today. Crows perched itself on top of the pole vault bar, cawing to each other, and they'd hear the occasional sound of a car zoom by from outside of the stadium on the quiet highway.

Katsuki raises a brow at the question, "Why are you asking, nerd."

Izuku gently elbows Katsuki from the side, "I don't understand why you can't just answer my questions easily, Kacchan,"

Katsuki snorts, "Who would I be if I made it easy for you."

"A better person," Izuku rolls his eyes with a grin, "But…" He thinks about it.

He's always thought this about Katsuki, but never found a way to tell the other. It wasn't like any of their more light hearted conversations, or intense but enjoyable debates, or random tangent that they go on. This struck a little deeper.

Izuku softly says then, "I feel like...you were born and raised in a town too small for you to spread your wings. Like you've always been meant to be far away from here. Far, far away," Izuku reaches his hands to trace the clouds in the sky, "Somewhere bigger and better than what Ise and our quiet streets could ever offer you." *Better than what I could ever offer you* , Izuku thought, but didn't say.

Katsuki was quiet for a moment, seemingly contemplating Izuku's words. Izuku found this to be rather thoughtful, and implied to him that the blonde was taking his statement with seriousness, rather than teasing playfulness.

“I’m right where I need to be,” Katsuki cryptically said, “Caterpillars are stuck in their cocoons before they become butterflies. But those cocoons are necessary. They provide protection, warmth, a place to grow. But at some point, you gotta break out and explore the world and shit, ya know? Can’t stay there forever.”

Izuku turned his head slightly to Katsuki, who was still looking up at the sky, “You’re a nerd too, you know. That just proved it.”

Katsuki threw a protein bar wrapper at Izuku, “Shut it.”

“I didn’t know you could be so philosophical,” Izuku laughed lightly, “Hm...so Ise is your cocoon, and you’re the caterpillar?”

“Nah,” Katsuki answers, “It’s not just me. Ise is your cocoon too. It’s time to break out, nerd. Where are you going to college.”

Izuku finds it funny that in all of their time together, the subject of university has never came up. He thinks it’s because there’s no point in asking about each other, or about Izuku at least. After all, they wouldn’t be associating come the end of this semester. The thought terrified the greenette, and so he avoids it whenever possible. But now, the question arrives from the star-athlete himself, and Izuku wished he had a more concrete and exciting answer.

“I…” Izuku found himself stuck, “...don’t know. My mom wants-”

“-wants you to stay near?” Katsuki finishes for him, “Could’ve fucking guessed. I should have asked where do you *want* to go to college.”

Izuku fidgeted with the hem of his shirt, before sighing, “I want to be in Tokyo. Their universities have the best sports medicine programs. It’d be nice to work in the sports industry, helping athletes figure out their best forms and techniques based on their bodies. I think it would match my interests and hobbies well.”

Katsuki hummed, “Have you applied?”

Izuku felt guilty, “...Yeah. To Waseda and the University of Tokyo”

“Did you get accepted?” Katsuki asked.

He felt more guilty, “...to Waseda, yes.”

“And let me guess,” Katsuki chuckled, “Auntie has no idea. And I bet you’re thinking on passing up the fucking opportunity to make things easier on her. Even though you hate the damn thought of rejecting it.”

Izuku bit his lip, “It wouldn’t be too bad. I could do a four-year nursing program at the college nearby, and-”

“And what,” Katsuki pulls himself up into a sitting position, “Get stuck in our shitty underfunded clinic that barely has a competent fucking surgeon? I’m sick of this conversation. You’re so fucking complacent. This is why I fucking hat-”

And then Katsuki pauses, and then thinks about what he was about to say. And Izuku lays there, looking up at the sitting athlete, waiting for the next words he's expecting to come out of the blonde's mouth. But after a moment, Katsuki's shoulders seem to relax, and he settled back into a nonchalant mode.

Izuku then pulls himself up to sit as well, and shuffles uncomfortable on the mat, "How about you? Where are you going to college?"

Katsuki flicks a leaf off of the landing mat, "Keio, It's 24 minutes from Waseda."

Izuku laughs bittersweetly, "Why did you bother telling me that? You don't want to see my face again after this project ends."

At this comment, the blonde looks away as if he just remembered, "Tell me honestly, Deku. Our deal. You like it?"

Izuku's mouth gaped. Of all questions, Izuku most definitely did not expect this one. It was the very first time that Katsuki was so candid about the topic, and wanted to know *his* opinion on it. Now that the opportunity arose, Izuku was terrified. He had never expected to be given the chance to reveal the truth. He wasn't sure if he should."

Izuku's fidgeting increased, but he decided to be honest, "...No."

Katsuki turns to him then, and steps off the mat, reaching out to lift Izuku's chin up and look into those bright green eyes for a moment, "Like I said. Complacent."

And he lets go immediately, turning around and taking a couple of steps forward to stretch his limbs, "Keio offered me a scholarship to be on their vault team. And I'm gonna play club, so I can qualify for Nationals and the Olympic trials come another couple years. I'll be in the city for a while. More than a couple of years. When I can't vault anymore, I'll settle back down in Ise."

"You want to come back?" Izuku asked.

"Sure," Katsuki says, "Real question is, am I gonna come back to find you in the exact same spot I left you."

*I left you* . Izuku tries not to repeat the ending part of that sentence. What Katsuki said slapped him in the face harder than he needed it to. He imagines it then. Katsuki's moving back into Ise a couple of decades from now, maybe married, maybe not, with plenty of stories to tell and sights he has seen.

Would Izuku still be walking the same boulevards they roam through as teenagers? Hanging out by the same ice cream shops whose sweets were getting a little numb on his aging tongue? Watching the newer generation go to the Spring Dance, while reminiscing his unconventional one and wondering to himself what the boy who swept him off his feet was doing in the city?

The thought killed him.

“I...don’t want to talk about this anymore,” Izuku barely whispers, eyes looking forlorn as he delves into the sadder part of his mind.

Katsuki takes in a breathe, and just says, “Fine by me.”

The wind was picking up again, and it pushes the metal gates within its frame, sending its loud echo throughout the entire stadium, and Izuku just listens quietly to it. Katsuki stands there looking up at the bar he knew he was going to clear. Izuku turns his head up towards the sky.

“It’ll be dark soon,” Izuku notices, “I heard there was going to be a meteor shower sometime between tonight and next Thursday.”

Katsuki nods, “It’s not gonna be tonight. I heard it’s gonna come next Wednesday. Why. You wanna make a wish on a shooting star, or something?”

Izuku smiles, “Maybe.”

“You won’t find any tonight, then,” Katsuki turns towards him, “But I know another place you can make a wish.”

Izuku tilted his head, “Yes?”

“You ever been to the cliff of wishes?” Katsuki asked, bending down to pull up some turf.

Izuku knew of it. Almost all of the students, and even adults in Ise has been there at some point in their life. It was almost like a town tradition. A little outside of Ise, up towards the mountains, there’s a rock cliff off the side of the road and it juts out pretty far so cars could actually drive on it. Most people park, and the tradition is to throw a rock off of the cliff while making a wish.

The rock will carry the wish down to the Mountain God, who will grant your wish. It was an odd tradition, but one most people have participated in.

“No,” Izuku shook his head, “Have you?”

Katsuki shook his head, “Nah.”

“Do you want to go?” Izuku asked, swinging his legs above the mat.

Katsuki saunters over, picks up his keys off the mat, and shrugs, “Sure.”

The drive to the cliff of wishes wasn’t too horrible. It still was a bit of a drive, since they had to go up the mountain road near Ise, and take the sharp incline that led to the rock cliff. The sun set behind them, and Izuku enjoys the wind blowing through his hair as they whipped up the mountainside. Izuku could tell Katsuki liked the incline, considering the boy loved to hike.

The cliff was obvious when they arrived, since it jutted out from the side of the mountains and there were tire marks from other cars having been there before.

When Katsuki pulled off the side of the road to drive on the rock, the sky was just about dark. Just a couple more minutes, and it would be completely night. Already, Izuku could see the stars and the moon. The ground was full of rocks and pebbles, perfect for throwing off of the cliff.

The greenette stepped out of the car once they parked, and slowly, he sauntered over towards the edge of the cliff. He didn't go far enough though so that something could accidentally happen and make him fall off. The wide cliff that jutted out overlooked all of Ise, some of the surrounding land, and had a gorgeous view of the ocean beyond their small town. It was absolutely beautiful, and Izuku turned to look at Katsuki with smiling eyes.

"Kacchan, look at the view," Izuku excitedly pointed.

Katsuki seemed to let out a grin at this, and ruffled the shorter boy's hair, "It ain't bad."

Izuku then began to squint while pointing out things, "There's my house. And there's your house. There's Lake Enid. And then there's the junkyard."

"There's no way you can fucking see our exact houses from here," Katsuki frowned.

"Oh, I can't," Izuku laughs, "I'm generalizing the area."

And for a little while, they both stand up there and point things out. Or at least, where they *thought* things were. Izuku finds it crazy how many more places he knew now because of Katsuki.

Finally, Izuku bends down to pick up one mid-sized pebble and holds it in his palms. He looks out onto the view and thinks. He knew not to say it out loud because of the stereotype. He could feel Katsuki's eyes watching him from the side.

He knew what he wanted to wish for. Closing his eyes and thinking about it, Izuku then steps back and throws the rock off of the cliff. The entire time going down, Izuku could hear the clanking as the rock continues to hit *more* rock, before the dirt muffles out the sound in the forest below.

"I made a stupid wish," Izuku holds his own cheeks in embarrassment.

Katsuki raises a brow, "What was it."

"I can't tell you," Izuku frowned, then noticed Katsuki wasn't making a move, "Are you not making a wish?"

The blonde in question shook his head, "I don't have any wishes."

Izuku looks at him funny, "None? How does a person not have wishes? You could wish to win Nationals, you know."

“If I win Nationals, there’s no way in hell I’m sharing the credits to some wish cliff,” Katsuki rolls his eyes, “It’ll be all me. And only me.”

“Very Kacchan of you,” Izuku notes, “Suit yourself. You don’t have any other wishes?”

Katsuki sighed, voice devoid of emotion, and shrugged, “No.”

Izuku felt like there was something off about that response, but leaves it anyways with an “Okay.”

Sitting near the edge of the cliff, with the moonlight so beautifully illuminating the city and the rock beneath them, Izuku was happy enough for now. It was a beautiful day, one that he will stockpile into his memories.

It was an unassuming Thursday when it decided to finally rain in Ise. It had began while Izuku was in class. The teacher’s voice droned on and on about something Izuku already studied to death the other night with Katsuki sitting nearby bothering him the entire time.

He was daydreaming about some fake scenario with two of his favorite comic characters that he shipped, wondering what headcanon he could come up with, when he heard it first.

The pitter-pattering of droplets on the window sill of his classroom. The gentle taps hit the glass and slid down in funny lines, and Izuku’s eyes widen as he stares at its trajectory.

It was the first rain of the season, and it felt as if he’s been waiting for a while. The clouds were finally dark and powerful. Soon enough, he’ll expect to hear the boom of thunder and bright flashes of lightning. But as of now, the rain was calm, and he could see the black asphalt roads begin to soak up the long awaited rainwater.

Ise was plenty humid, and the ocean nearby made all the plants look tropical, but rain only came now. He sat in his classroom, but wondered what the sensation of the crying sky on his fingertips felt like. He always found rain to be a sign of a transition, at least in Ise.

As his day progresses, the rain increases in intensity. The soft pattering had turned into a fast pour, that they can hear even from inside windowless rooms. The storm drains were working hard to swallow up all of the water so it didn’t flood the streets.

And when the school day ended, Izuku stands under the awning of the school, wondering what he should do. His mother had told him to pack an umbrella this morning, and Izuku had told her he already had one stowed in his backpack, only to realize it wasn’t there. He could text her, and ask her to pick him up. Yeah, that’s what he’ll probably do.

His feet were already a little wet from the wind blowing in some of the water. He stares out in the hazy atmosphere, blanketed in rain, and out onto the track field a bit of a distance away.

It was solo practice, and practically speaking, Katsuki shouldn't be there. But there he was, with the pole gripped in his hand, and wet clothes matted tightly to his body. Katsuki's hair was dripping ridiculously, and he had to stop to wipe the water off of his eyebrows so that it wouldn't fall into his eyes while he vaulted. Izuku was floored by the dedication, even though it didn't seem practical to pole vault in the rain, when the track field was slick, the pole was slippery, and the landing pit was collecting water. But evidently, Katsuki did not care.

Because Izuku watches from far away under the awning as Katsuki repeats his runs over again a couple of times. Izuku could barely hear anything over the sound of the rain, and occasional thunder. His books were clutched in his arms and he temporarily took off his backpack to place them in, and set it up against the concrete flooring as he digs into his pocket for his phone to text his mother. He types out a message, and was about to press send when he heard the dropping of a pole.

He tilted his head up and over to the track field, to see Katsuki had left his pole on the ground and was now looking over at Izuku from a distance, running a hand through his wet hair. Izuku makes eye contact, and shyly waves. Katsuki does not wave back, but instead, the blonde starts jogging lightly towards the gate and leaves the field. Once he gets about 100 feet away, he slows down to a walk, and his steps on the asphalt makes splashes in the puddles. Izuku still stands there dry and watching the other walk towards him.

When Katsuki was just a couple of feet away, Izuku admires the way the rain glistens off of his skin, and the slightly out of breathe look the athlete had. Katsuki simply stood for a moment, staring down at the shorter boy, seeming as if there was something he wanted to do. He didn't say anything, so Izuku didn't either. There was just a space of silence in between them, filtered out by the loud rain.

Finally, the blonde reaches out a hand, dripping with water that ran down his forearm, and Izuku stares at it. It was extended out towards him, similar to what Katsuki had done when he asked Izuku to dance. However, this was no dance.

Yet Katsuki's arm reached out, waiting for his, soaking under the pouring sky, with beads of water dripping off his fingertips. Katsuki's eyes were fierce as they usually were, and Izuku couldn't see them waver in the slightest.

Izuku doesn't know how long he stands there, in the warm confines of the awning, mostly dry. Perfectly content with the comforts that the protection over his head provided him. He stares at the turbulence that would be sure to come the moment he steps out and take Katsuki's hand. The wind, the rain, the uncertainties, the lightning, the dangers, and then the most turbulent factor of all: Katsuki himself.

And yet, Izuku hesitantly reaches out. His hands feel it first: the initial couple of droplets of rain that immediately soaked the sleeve of his shirt, and it was warmer than Izuku had expected it to be. How nice: the first rain of the season was a warm one.

When Izuku's hand meet Katsuki's, the blonde closed their grip and pulled Izuku forward, lurching the greenette until Izuku went from completely dry to soaked within seconds.

The warm rain immediately matted his hair to his forehead, and Izuku looked up at Katsuki through rain dripped hair. His shirt was getting stuck to his body, and the hold on his hand was still secure.

“Kacchan?” Izuku asked softly, barely enough to hear over the rain. The sky was a deep greenish-blue, even though it was still just 4:00 P.M., and the clouds completely covered the sky.

The boy in question met Izuku’s green eyes with his ruby ones, “Deku.”

Izuku used his other hand to brush water off of his eyelids, “What are we doing out in the rain? You know it’s thundering, right?”

Katsuki lets go of his hand then, and steps back, tilting his head up towards the sky and spreading his arms out while grinning, “I’m aware.”

Izuku laughed, pulling at his matted shirt, “If I get struck down by lightning, I hope I’ll at least gain superpowers.”

Katsuki smirks at this, then looks off to the side before turning back to Izuku, “Have you ever been swimming in the rain?”

Izuku was quick to answer, “I haven’t.”

Katsuki grins at this response, “Say less, nerd.”

Katsuki begins jogging in the direction of the beach, and Izuku has to yell out from behind to wait for him.

He had stopped to take out his phone and text his mother a quick “I’ll be home a little late. Around 10 or so.” and jogs after Katsuki.

The beach was about a 20 minute walk from Ise High, and so if they were jogging, it wouldn’t be too bad at all. But still, trying to run through the streets and sidewalks of Ise in the pouring rain was hard, considering their feet could hydroplane. And yet, Izuku has a fun time, laughing as he follows Katsuki quickly through the neighborhood streets, around the corner store, and down a shaded path until they reached the wet sand.

Because it had been raining all day, the sand was thick and matted, instead of the usual baby powder white they normally were. In the distance, they could barely see too far out because the fast winds and thick blankets of rain and clouds covered up anything they could possibly have seen. And yet, that was the fun of it. Izuku and Katsuki were the only two fools stupid enough to be out on the beach in this weather voluntarily. Katsuki hadn’t even finished practice yet, for all Izuku knew.

Since their clothes were both soaked, there was no need to strip down, and so both boys ran towards the ocean and immediately jumped in, fully clothed and ready to mess about for a while. The ocean water was cold compared to the warmth of the rain. Seeing the rainfall hit

the ocean's surface in tiny little dot patterns excited him, and with Katsuki swimming next to his side, Izuku felt ridiculously happy and unconcerned with just about anything else. Every other memory in the world can go to hell.

They played stupid water games, and just swam out far to tread water and talk. However, it was harder to talk when the waves were rougher than usual, and saltwater continuously got up their nostrils and into their mouths. Izuku would smile wider if he could.

"So I guess the rain means that Gasshi isn't hosting that party anymore?" Izuku asks, padding the water out far.

He wasn't going to it. He just knew that Gasshi, one of their mutual classmates, throws a huge party every year that Katsuki always went to, and this year, it was scheduled for tonight. But with the rain happening, Izuku was sure there were not going to be a lot of people showing, considering the weather. Not everyone had the guts to go out in the rain like this.

"I wouldn't know," Katsuki rolls his eyes, "I wasn't going anyways."

Izuku gives him a funny look, "You weren't? Why? Did something happen?"

"Nothing happened," Katsuki shrugged, "I just don't feel like going this year."

Izuku takes this into consideration. Lately, some word here and there had been going around the school about Bakugo Katsuki, and Izuku, being who he was, couldn't help but listen in and notice. Flutters of conversation throughout the school were proclaiming that the all-star athlete just haven't been very active in parties or anything else lately. In fact, he hasn't attended social events since the dance, and even then, the blonde had left halfway through to go to who-knew-where.

And it wasn't as if suddenly he has turned into a social shell, for he was still generally the same person within school. Except a bit...more off. Without seeming to know it himself, Bakugo Katsuki has picked up weird slang or sayings, and would occasionally go off on little tangents only to stop himself halfway. He still curses like a sailor, but the mean remarks had toned down just a tiny bit. If anything, it made people more obsessed with him: made him feel more attainable.

And yet, Izuku realized just then, Katsuki has not slept with anyone, in what seemed like a long time, too.

If he had, Izuku would have known, since that shit spreads everywhere, and quickly too. If he had, then Izuku would have wondered where in his schedule did he find the time, in between spending much of his days with Izuku and intensely practicing pole vault even outside of practice hours.

This realization made Izuku's heart go crazier than he needed it to. False hope seeped through his skin, and he was quick to try and kick it out, because he didn't need that for his mental stability. Pining hopelessly for the boy was enough. But if Izuku were to add in an element of

*what if,* it could ruin him. After all, just because Katsuki hasn't slept with anyone for a while, didn't mean anything aside from the fact that the blonde was extremely busy. Still, he was curious.

And that curiosity persisted for a while. The two swam in the beach some more, constantly having to wipe away both the saltwater of the ocean and freshwater of the rain from their faces. The waves were getting rough because of the wind, which made them come in from all directions, essentially tossing both Izuku and Katsuki around like a doll in the water.

Ultimately, it become more of a hazard to stay in, so the two climbed out of the water when the sky began to darken further. It should be about 6 o'clock right then, and if Izuku was correct, that meant the sun will begin to set behind the massive vat of clouds that covered it.

The fun was far from over. The boys ran through the sand, picking it up to their feet in big matted clumps. Katsuki grabbed his pill speaker from the shore, and they ran to a small awning at the edge of a closed down beach-side bar, where it was dry. Izuku's teeth chattered, going from being submerged in water to the windy surface air, and he held himself to keep warm. Katsuki was jogging in place to do the same, but put on a song. Against All Odds by Phil Collins.

Once he put on the slower, more sentimental song, Katsuki shoved his phone in his wet pockets, and turned towards Izuku. They looked at each other for a moment, before Izuku grinned at him with a small laugh at how stupid they were as a default state when together. Katsuki ended up laughing a bit too, and reached a hand out to ruffle Izuku's wet hair.

And then they ran off back into the rain, since it was warmer than standing in dryness allowing the wind to hit their clothes. The thunder above was consistently booming, The dark greenish-blue tint was getting even deeper, as the sky loses its light. And the boys ended up near an empty white warehouse on the side of the road, with a parking lot that had too many potholes in it. When the city's street lamps turn on, Izuku and Katsuki were jumping into potholes and kicking up water at each other.

Izuku had strong legs, so his splashes easily soaked the athlete, who would sometimes push him into a larger pothole, soaking his entire body in warm, gravel water that was probably really dirty. It was in dumb moments like these that seem meaningless where Izuku finds the most joy. If anyone were to ask, saying that he spent the evening jumping and splashing around in potholes near an empty warehouse was not the most interesting thing to describe, but he felt like this was truly living. And looking at the smile on Katsuki's face that he fails to hide, the blonde must think so too.

When the rain begins to slowly pass over them and the fall isn't as heavy, the two walk on the empty Ise roads, with their sneakers squishing from the water inside of the fabric, back to the school parking lot. It was a slow walk, and now that the rain was beginning to clear, they could hear each other's conversations better.

Izuku's cheeks, for the fiftieth time, hurt from smiling so much, but what could he do but accept it. He was happy. It was dark at this point, with only the white street lamps to light up the asphalt road slick with water. Occasionally, a car would whiz by, and Katsuki could pull

him in by the waist into the road so that he didn't get ran over, and the gentle contact flushed Izuku's cheeks.

When they got back to the parking lot, the rain had completely stopped, but the clouds were still plentiful above, which told them that the rain would begin again soon. Maybe in a couple of hours: possibly 2. But for now, it was quiet aside from the dripping of residual water off of the roofs of the school building. Katsuki had even turned the music off.

The boys laid back on the asphalt, side by side, soaking up the heat radiating from the ground after a long day of rain. It warmed their backs, and this type of heat would probably get them sick. But Izuku takes that option, over losing what little time he feels like he had left with Katsuki. Even though he still had a bit to go.

The darkness enveloped the parking lot, aside from the one street lamp that casted a faint white glow on both of their bodies laying flat on the ground. The crickets came out tonight as they usually did, and the singing was so in sync that Izuku wonders if there was a system to it all.

Meanwhile, the conversation between Katsuki and Izuku was softer, a little deeper, with more space spread out in between as they take in the moment that felt like it should only be in a movie. Still, the curious thoughts he had earlier about Katsuki persisted, and Izuku wonders if now would be the right time to ask. He attempts to do so in the most casual way he can.

"Kacchan," Izuku bit his bottom lip, as he stared up at the moving clouds. He thinks about how to ask, without directly asking.

Katsuki hummed, "Deku."

Izuku played with some loose rocks underneath his hands, and forced a laugh, "People have been wondering where you've been. They haven't seen you anywhere."

Katsuki snorts, "Think about it, shitnerd. If I'm not at practice, then where am I at?"

Izuku feels a tiny sense of pride saying it, but he admits quietly, "With me."

"Exactly. Tell the fuckers who are wondering that you're holding me hostage and forcing me to hang out with you," Katsuki tells him.

And Izuku pokes him from the side, "You initiate just as much as I do!"

"Do I?" Katsuki pretends jokingly, "You're making shit up, Deku."

Izuku rolled his eyes and grinned, "Why do I hang out with you."

Katsuki chuckles a bit, and it goes back to a peaceful silence as they feel the heat from the Earth go up into them. And Izuku still feels the curiosity lingering on the tip of his tongue.

And so he just says is, "You haven't really been with anyone for a while either."

At this, from the side, Katsuki raises a brow and turns his head slightly towards Izuku, who notices but refuses to make eye contact.

“You keep track or somethin?” Katsuki asked him.

Izuku shook his head, “No. Like I’ve told you before, word gets around. I know practically everyone you...do.” It hurt to say.

Katsuki considers this, and his voice comes out low when he mutters, “Everyone, huh.”

“Yeah,” Izuku feels breathless when he says it, and he now wishes that he never brought the conversation up, because the pangs of hurt and jealousy were beginning to arise from within his chest. He wanted the boy next to him so badly, he realized, that it hurt to be here just a couple inches away but not have him in the way others have had him before.

Katsuki shifts in his spot, but shrugs, “I don’t know.”

“Are you…” Izuku thinks of the right word, “frustrated?” He plays with the rocks more.

Katsuki chuckles, “Yeah, like crazy. I’m fucking frustrated as hell, but haven’t done shit.”

“Why don’t you,” Izuku was too quick to say.

This question made Katsuki pause a little, and Izuku waits for his answer, wondering if it will come at all. He pretends to be casual about it, but Izuku’s mind was racing to know.

When the athlete answers, he does so in an odd tone, “I got places I’d rather be.”

Izuku’s heart fluttered at this statement. Because although it could be literal, Izuku wanted to feel more than anything that Katsuki had meant that he’d rather go out and do things with him. To play in the rain, swim in the ocean during a storm, splash around in potholes. He wanted to think that these kind of things meant more to Katsuki than some one-night-stands. And Katsuki’s statement just now more or less confirmed him. Izuku felt a rush of dopamine, and wanted to hug the other so badly. But he knew that the other just wasn’t that type of person.

And so, Izuku just plays it off casually, “Like at a warehouse pushing me into potholes.”

Katsuki half grins, “Exactly, nerd. Like pushing creepy-eyed nerds into potholes.”

Izuku frowns, “Why do you always say that.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “Because it’s true.”

“Oh…” Izuku couldn’t help but feel slightly insecure. All of his life, he’s had mixed feelings on his eyes. They were so round, so large and feminine-looking. But most of all, incredibly expressive. No matter what he tried to hide, his true emotions show up in them. Anyone can tell when he was happy, when he was sad, just by looking at them. He’s had sketchy people and kind people alike tell him they’re gorgeous and doe-like. Katsuki was the only one who thought differently. And he knew one person’s opinion shouldn’t matter, but it was Katsuki.

Katsuki sits up, and Izuku follows suit, bringing his knees up to his chest.

“It’s almost 9. We should be getting back, before your mom bitches,” Katsuki mutters.

“Just a few more minutes,” Izuku says, opting to look at the ground next to him, “My clothes are almost dry.”

“Alright,” Katsuki says, before adding on, “Nerd, when do your badminton matches start.”

Izuku plays with the gravel, “Um, the first week of summer break, I’m pretty sure,” And then Izuku laughs with bitterness in his tone, “Why? Did you plan on coming to see me? After the project ends? Don’t ask things you don’t actually care about, Kacchan.”

Izuku couldn’t help but come off as a bit salty. He was living a perfect life, right now, aside from everything that was going on with his mom. He was happier than he’s ever been, while more conflicted than he’s ever been. Because he knew that the happiness with Katsuki was on a downward trajectory, bound to end in a heap of heartbreak. He was on a smooth sailing carriage to his doom, it felt like.

“Oi,” Katsuki’s voice sounded more serious, “What the fuck is up with you.”

Izuku’s brows furrowed and he bit the inside of his cheek. He took a deep breath, and attempted to let go of the frustrated, upset feelings plaguing him. He wasn’t supposed to get angry, or upset. That was never productive, so he tried to let it go, “It’s nothing, Kacchan.”

“No, look at me, you fucking nerd,” Katsuki tells him from the side.

Izuku shakes his head, not wanting to, and his fingers dig into the asphalt just to have something to do. He whispered out an “I don’t want to.”

“And why the hell not,” Katsuki’s voice was getting impatient, “Look at me, damnit.”

Izuku’s lips felt like trembling, but he held himself together. It wasn’t a big deal. And he’s had a great evening. There was no need to ruin it now. Izuku just shakes his head again, “No.”

Katsuki reaches out for his face, and Izuku sees the hand incoming. But the greenette, feeling the pressure inside of him build up without his permission, slaps it away, “Don’t touch me!”

Katsuki’s eyes widened, and Izuku sees it in his peripheral vision. The hand retracted, and Izuku’s voice seemed to waver as he says, “You…” He felt his breath hitch as he tries to keep his tone steady, “I don’t want to look at you...You don’t like my…” He looks down at the ground again with a slightly pained expression that he wanted to desperately hide, “my eyes.”

Katsuki was silent for a moment, and Izuku did wonder what was going on through the boy’s mind. The crickets seemed to chirp louder as their uncomfortable silence continued, and Izuku waits for any kind of response, but was ultimately okay if the conversation ended there.

Finally, Katsuki stood up and said with a frustrated tone, “For fuck’s sake, you’re not gonna look at me because I don’t-” He runs an irritated hand through his hair, “Fuck. Are you shitting me, Deku?”

Izuku’s brows stayed furrowed, “You say it all the tim-”

Katsuki then kneels in front of him, and uses both hands to grip onto the side of Izuku’s face and tilt it towards him, practically forcing the smaller to look at him. Izuku’s eyes widened as they met Katsuki’s gorgeous and dark red eyes once more, hating how they never cease to make his chest pound.

“Who fucking cares, nerd,” Katsuki growls, “Look at me when you speak to me.”

Izuku tries to tug Katsuki’s hands away to no avail, and frustratedly says, “First, you don’t want me to look at you with my *creepy-ass* eyes. Now, you’re telling me to look at you. Kacchan, you’re a mess and you don’t know what you want.”

“Yeah? And you know *exactly* what you want, and you don’t do shit about it and let people like me step all over you, you fucking piece of shit,” Katsuki tells him straight.

Izuku wanted to cry, and his fingers pried at Katsuki’s hands, “What does that even mean.”

“How much longer are you going to let people tell you what to do and how to feel about yourself and your life, huh?” Katsuki pressures him, “How much shit are you going to take from me? From your mom? From everyone else? Bastard.”

And then, Katsuki let’s go, standing back up. Izuku touches his cheeks, then stares at Katsuki angrily even though he tried to hide it in his tone, and got up to his feet.

“That’s none of your busi-” Izuku began, not actually having a good response.

“For fuck’s sake,” Katsuki threw his hands up in the air, “You wouldn’t even fucking look at me because I had a damn opinion on your eyes.”

Izuku wanted to control himself. He wanted to not get angry, or upset. But it was hard when Katsuki, the instigator of it all, was standing right there.

Before he could hold back, Izuku tells Katsuki, “Not everyone is emotionally fucked up in the head, Kacchan.”

And then, silence. God, it was silent. Katsuki’s eyes widened for a split second, before going back to neutral. Izuku felt immediately guilty. He knew where he had gotten that statement from. Kaito had said it a couple of days prior, and the statement glued itself to Izuku’s mind until now. Izuku knew he took it a bit far. It was true, but Izuku also wanted Katsuki to know that he was still there for the other. That he was willing to be patient, with the time they had left. But when Izuku let it out, it just seemed aggressive.

Finally, the blonde stepped forward while clapping his hands slowly. Izuku moved back, as the taller boy continues clapping out loud.

Katsuki let out an amused laugh, “There it fucking is. *There* it is. Good fucking job, Deku. You’ve said it.”

“I’m so sorry,” Izuku scrambled to apologize, and there was guilt in his eyes, “I didn’t mean it like th-”

Katsuki interrupted him with a wild grin, “Oh, you meant it alright. But I really want to hear more, Deku. Tell me more about how I’m emotionally fucked up in the head.”

Izuku shook his head while stepping backwards, “Kacchan, I’m sorry. I shouldn’t have said that. It was rude and out of-”

Katsuki interrupted him again, “Jesus fucking Christ,” And threw up his hands once more, “It’s always one step forward and two steps backwards with you, ain’t it, you prick.”

Izuku was confused, “What?” He didn’t understand, “What do you mean.”

“So you finally get some fucking guts to tell me how you really feel about me,” Katsuki meets his fiery gaze, “And now, you’re going back to your shitty ass apologize-for-everything mode. As expected from you.”

“I don’t know what you want me to do!” Izuku was feeling frustration pool up again.

“I told you want I want you to do, Deku,” Katsuki laughs at him even though nothing was funny, “Tell me more.”

“No,” Izuku shakes his head, not understanding why Katsuki wanted him to, “I...I don’t want to. I can’t.”

Katsuki takes this into consideration, then nods his head, looking off to the side like he was pondering over something, before turning back to Izuku, “This is why I fucking hate you, you know.”

Izuku’s eyes widened. There was a bit of silence as he lets Katsuki’s words, that seemed random, sink in. This topic has only been brushed aside before, never addressed. And now that it was here, Izuku couldn’t connect the dots. He stands on the warm black asphalt, with the parking lot lights shining faintly down, looking at the boy across from him.

“You hate me, because I won’t tell you why you’re…” *emotionally damaged?* Izuku couldn’t bring himself to finish the sentence.

“No,” Katsuki rolled his eyes, “How do you manage to miss the point, every damn time, Deku. Fuck, you’re so clueless, it pisses me off.”

“Because you never say anything straight up, Kacchan!” Izuku stepped forward, feeling the anger he hated to feel pile up, “You give cryptic little statements and will say *anything* other

than what you mean. How am I supposed to know what you're trying to tell me, if you do everything *but* tell me?"

"You're not fucking dumb. You should be able to figure it out yourself," Katsuki snaps at him.

Izuku looks at him as if he was insane, then laughs, "You're actually ridiculous. Figure it out *myself* ? You act like you're so easy to read. Figure it out *myself* ? Is that what you expected me to do when I was fucking five, and I lost the first friend I've ever made and you began to harass me?" Izuku practically yells without thinking twice, "Figure it out myself why you hate me so much?"

Katsuki dryly laughs, "I was wondering when you'll fucking talk about that. Or were you going to ignore the fact that I made your life a living hell for years. Because honestly, I wouldn't be surprised."

The humidity in the air was unbearable. Izuku looks to the side, "I didn't think you'd want to talk about it."

"What. So you were just gonna let me live the rest of my cushy life without facing the consequences of everything I've done?" Katsuki gives him an amused but angry look.

"Well, if you haven't noticed," Izuku shoots him a glare, "You don't handle things very well."

"You obviously think so fucking little of me," Katsuki steps forward, squaring Izuku up.

"Kacchan, you *hate* it when I say anything nice to you. When anyone says anything sweet to you," Izuku argues with him, "When we were at the diner, and Hana was saying how you were so helpful, you looked uncomfortable. When I try to ask you about your feelings on *anything* , you looked uncomfortable," Izuku's voice escalated with every sentence, "When you feel frustrated and nervous at practice, you make sure to hide it and not let anybody know. Why? Because your emotions make you uncomfortable."

"Shut up," Katsuki tells him.

"See?" Izuku laughs angrily, "You're doing it right now, too. And when you feel surprised, or when something makes you upset, or really happy, you let it show on your face for just a second, just enough for me to catch it, before you cover it up. To make it look like you don't feel anything. Why? Because your emotions make you *fucking* uncomfortable. You can't even hug your own grandfather in front of me, because you're uncomfortable," Izuku steps forward with pleading in his eyes.

And Izuku's eyes are watery as he looks down at his hands, trying not to let his voice crack, "And...and I don't know why. Bec-Because I like seeing it, K-Kacchan," He wiped away the water threatening to spill from his ducts, "I like seeing you happy. Or surprised. Or in awe. And I like being there for you when you're nervous, or scared, or-"

"I don't fucking need you to do shit for me," Katsuki turns away.

And Izuku steps forward, to grab for Katsuki's arm who pulls back, "But you want me to. Kaccha-"

"I don't want *shit* from you," Katsuki looks at him angrily.

Izuku was tearing up again, much to his dismay, "I know it's hard for you, Kacchan. I know the pressure you feel is heavy, and that people have expectations for you. I know that everyone wants you to be a certain way, but I promise I won't ever want anything from you other than your friendship. I don't need you to be the super athlete Bakugo Katsuki. I don't need you to break any records, or win Nationals. I just need yo-"

"You fucking say that, but when I don't, you'll react the same as the rest of them," Katsuki steps forward and points at Izuku's chest. The tension was high, "The more people who fucking care about me, is the more who have the ability to be disappointed. And there's nothing I hate *more* than seeing that look in people's eyes. I've said it once, and I'll say it again. I don't *need* you do fucking do shit for me. I'm fine on my ow-"

Izuku was crying at this point, almost desperately pleading for Katsuki to listen to him, and his hands were on the sleeve of Katsuki's shirt, to which the blonde shoved off, "The people who care about you won't ever feel disappointed in you, Kacchan. We'll support you no matter what. It's okay to fee-"

"God, shut the *fuck* up," Katsuki tells him angrily, "I fucking bullied you, and now, you're here trying to give me life advice?"

Izuku pursed his lips, and held Katsuki's angry eye contact. He shouldn't say it. He definitely shouldn't. But he does it anyways.

Starting with a cracked but normal tone, Izuku increases his volume slowly as he speaks, "You know what I think, Kacchan? I think you're insecure. And I think you're guilty, but you don't even know how to apologize. Why else would you constantly bring that up?"

Katsuki looked at him, with angry eyes.

But Izuku continued, "Kacchan, you took away a lot of my happy days when we were little. That's true," Izuku bit his lip to stop his tears, and he took a moment to collect himself, "But you've given me so many more. Every time I watch you jump, a little bit after class every day, I feel like I've been motivated. Every time you take me out, I feel like I've regained a day I've lost sitting at home wishing I could be anywhere else but here. Every time you make sure I eat, or make sure I sleep on time, or do something nice to me even if you have excuses for doing so, I feel like I'm being cared for. Kacchan, you're so much more than your past. You're insecure about how people view you, and that's why you close yourself off. Because you think that if you convince yourself to not care, then it won't matter what they think."

Katsuki stares at him then, both angry and surprised. And Izuku doesn't break his gaze. He was slightly out of breath, but he needed to tell Katsuki that. He needed the other to know that although Katsuki was opaque, there were still some parts that Izuku could see through.

Katsuki finally replied, and it was still as frustrating to hear as ever, “Great, so you’ve developed fucking stockholm syndro-”

Izuku wanted to yell, so he just gripped his hair out of irritation and shoved Katsuki away, “Can’t you take anything seriously? You know what I fucking meant, and you can’t just play it off with a joke. Talk to me, Kacchan! I need you to talk to me,” Izuku cried.

“What is there to say,” Katsuki spat out, “You fucking got it. Ding, ding, ding. You want a damn prize or something? I have fucking issues. I don’t know how to accept happiness. I don’t know how to fucking lose, and I’m deadly afraid of it. I don’t know how to be a normal fucking human being. What more is there to even say?” Katsuki doesn’t even limit how much he curses.

“That you’ll try. That you know it’s unhealthy to be like this,” Izuku begged, “That you’ll let me h-”

“I’ve lived 18 fucking years, and I’d say I’m pretty damn good at the game. I don’t need to-” Katsuki out of habit began to defend himself again. Izuku wanted to punch the other, but held back.

Instead, he just practically shouted, shoving Katsuki again, “You think you’re fine? Kacchan, you can’t even admit that we are *friends* . We spend all of our free time together, you bring me to bed when I fall asleep on the floor, you tell me everything that annoys you or that interests you, and yet, you don’t ever talk to me in school, you have never accepted something kind I’ve said about you easily, and you have never even admitted we are friends. You’re a coward, Bakugo Katsuki. You’re a coward, and you’re so closed off, you don’t know what’s good for you anymore.”

“You think *I’m* emotionally closed off?” Katsuki shoved him back, pissed off, “Real fucking funny. Sure. I’ll admit it. I have issues. You got it, Deku. I can’t tell real kindness from fake shit. Sure, whatever. But you think that *I’m* the one who is emotionally closed off?”

Izuku stepped backwards, as Katsuki moved forward, and there was barely any space between them, but Izuku stood his ground, “What are you trying to say.”

“You’re just as fucked up as I am, Deku,” Katsuki grins menacingly, both pain, anger, and amusement in his deep eyes.

“Kacchan,” Izuku laughs, “I don’t have a problem being happy.”

“Maybe not,” Katsuki shakes his head in agreement, “But you sure do have a problem being angry. Being sad. Being anything that isn’t a perfect happy-go-lucky son of a bitch.”

Izuku squinted his eyes at him, “There’s nothing wrong with that. Being angry doesn’t ever solve anything.”

“You sure about that?” Katsuki spoke as if he knew something Izuku didn’t, “It sure doesn’t fix anything either though. Don’t you think?”

“Kacchan, I don’t get the point. What does this have to do with anyth-,” Izuku felt as if they were too close. And the tension between them heated up the after-rain air more than it already was.

“You’re so complacent with your own mistreatment, it makes me sick,” Katsuki tells him.

Izuku was beyond stifled. He felt like they were both saying words, but none of them were stringing together. Katsuki was just throwing out some sentences that seem to make full sense to the blonde, but made none to him. Their communication was on different pages that it made it difficult to sync minds. Katsuki never wanted to say what he meant, while Izuku couldn’t pick up the hints.

Seeing how unproductive and straight up aggressive the conversation was, Izuku huffed, and turned away, wanting to go home. He’ll walk if he needed to. His heart was heavy, and Izuku just wanted to go home and cry.

“This is getting nowhere,” Izuku tells him, “Until you can tell me in real words and not cryptic statements, I’m going home.”

Izuku walked towards the awning, where he had left his backpack earlier, meaning to go pick it up and head back home. His mind was racing with too many thoughts that he couldn’t even pinpoint one string of reasoning from another. All he knew was that he was confused at how this argument started, where it was going, and how it was ending.

This was the first real argument that they’ve had in a long, long time, and that weighed heavily on Izuku’s shoulders as he turned away from Katsuki, who stood there, illuminated by the white street light and clothes still damp.

When Izuku gets about three meters away, Katsuki then speaks up. With yet again another enigmatic statement.

“Do you remember the day you broke my Endeavor figurine,” Katsuki asks, voice quiet amidst the natural sounds of Ise.

Izuku slowed to a stop, and swivelled around to his side, confused but looks at Katsuki. He thinks about it, and shuffles through his memories, before revealing, “...barely.”

It wasn’t a detail that Izuku really thought much about. It was as if someone asked him what he did in the afternoon on a warm summer day ten years ago. It was a hazy memory, but Izuku knew something of the sort happened. He had been messing around with Katsuki’s toys, when something had happened. He didn’t remember too much of what happened afterwards, other than a small argument ensued.

“We were in my backyard. 5 years old. And stupid kids,” Katsuki says, not looking at Izuku, “That was the day I decided I fucking can’t stand you.”

Izuku felt water well up again, and he hated how easily he teared up, “That day? Over something that small?”

Izuku had expected, all this time, that the reason why Katsuki hated him so much was some extravagant event. And his friends and others at Ise who knew of their terrible relationship in the past thought so too: it must have been something huge. Something worth all of the years of teasing and harrassment. Maybe Izuku had found out something about the other, which the taller bullied him to keep secret. Maybe Katsuki knew something about Izuku that he really didn’t like. But whatever it was, Izuku had always expected something crazy. But to know, it was over a broken toy, killed Izuku more. He didn’t understand.

“Over a broken toy?” Izuku’s voice was tiny and there were small streams sliding down his cheek that he was quick to wipe away, “Over a stupid broken toy?” He cried.

Katsuki still didn’t look at him, “I came in to get a drink. For just a couple of minutes. Meanwhile, you were messing with the toys I brought outside and you ended up breaking off the arm of my Endeavor figurine.”

Izuku’s shoulders were shaking, and he silently stood there listening.

“I barely gave a shit about that figurine, but I was a little bitch. Even when I was a small brat, I was an asshole. An overdramatic asshole with fucking anger issues. And so, I hit you,” Katsuki spat out quietly, “It was the very first time I’ve ever hit you.”

Izuku looked up, eyes a bit red, and glanced over where Katsuki stood there, not looking at him.

“It wasn’t a small tap either. I hit you and shoved you back into the dirt. You got a cut on your leg from falling on a stick, and a bruise on your jaw. I was a fucking shitty kid,” Katsuki laughed dryly, “But do you know what you did?”

Izuku listened, slowly recalling the event that didn’t really mean much to him personally before tonight.

“Nothing. Absolutely fucking nothing,” Katsuki sounded angry, “You got up. And smiled at me, said it was fucking okay. And apologized for breaking the figurine. After I hit you and shoved you to the ground. And when Auntie came to pick you up, you told her that you just fell.”

Izuku’s lips quivered and he played with his fingers, “It...wasn’t a big deal.”

Katsuki snorted at this, but looked both angry and pained at the same time, “Wasn’t a big deal…” He repeated once more, “Wasn’t a big deal? Deku, this is exactly what I fucking meant. I hit you, I fucking hurt you, and instead of getting angry, instead of getting justice for yourself, you shoved it off and said it was okay. But I’m not fucking dumb, Deku. I saw it, in those big eyes of yours that reveal absolutely *everything* ,” Katsuki’s knuckles were white from clenching his fists, “You were hurt. And disappointed. Just to hide it away a second later with that careless smile. You say I hide everything with a blank face, but you hide everything with a smile. And if you ask me, that is even more shitty.”

Izuku shook his head, not wanting to hear anymore. He knew his eyes were getting puffy, “Kacchan, stop. You’re so stupid. I don’t want to be hav-”

The blonde didn’t, “I hated you because you were fucking pathetic. Weak. And maybe it was fucking stupid what had happened, but you never proved me wrong. Everything you did after that point only proved it. Every time I hurt you, every time I said something fucking shitty to you, every time I shoved you away, you were going to smile at me in the hallway the next day or watch me from afar with that look in your eyes as if you’ve forgiven everything. No matter what I did to you, you would have smiled and pretended it was okay. Do you know how much it pissed me off?” Katsuki’s voice sounded strained, “What the fuck is wrong with you.”

Izuku’s bit his cheek to calm his voice, and he looked up at Katsuki with obvious tear streaks, “Is that why you left me alone after our fight? Behind that one cafe Ground Zero? When we were 15?”

Izuku remembered that after that one argument, where Izuku raised his hand to Katsuki for the first time, the blonde had left him primarily alone afterwards. But he never understood why. Until now.

“It was the first time you actually did some shit for yourself. Even if you apologized like a bitch for it afterwards,” Katsuki tells him, voice full of venom, “I fucking hate people who are fine living in their own shit. You shove all your anger and bullshit away, but I can see it in your damn eyes how much it hurts you. You’re so fucking easy to read, Deku.”

Izuku’s shoulders continued to shake from the shock and pain of hearing all of this relayed to him, as Katsuki keeps telling him.

“And it’s not just me,” Katsuki laughs, “You let everyone step over you. And you do nothing about it.”

The greenette shakes his head, “No I don’t.” Just to have some pride for himself, even though he knew Katsuki was right.

“Oh? You don’t?” Katsuki sounded extremely irked.

“I don’t,” Izuku makes his final attempt to save himself.

“You do,” Katsuki tells him, making his way over to the greenette and his words slap Izuku in the face, “You let your mom. You let other students. You let *yourself* step all over you, and you smile and pretends it’s all fucking dandy,” Katsuki looked at him incredulously, “Who the hell even taught you that? You think the only emotions worth feeling are happy-go-lucky giddiness and constant joy?”

Katsuki scoffs, “You think it’s *healthy* to shove away your anger, your sadness, all of the emotions that you think are *so* negative? Well let me teach you something too, Deku. You’re going to feel it either way, whether or not you want to. It’s a matter of now or later. You’re gonna feel angry, sad, frustrated, no matter how much you shove it away. You’re just saving it for later. You’re just building that shit up until it consumes you and once you let it go, and

trust me when I say you *will* let it loose, you're not going to even know what the fucking do with yourself."

Izuku's eyes widened. All of these statements, Izuku knew, applied to Katsuki as well. But up until now, he didn't know they could be applied to *himself.*

"I can't…" Izuku cries silently, "I can't help it."

"I want to see you get angry, Deku," Katsuki tongues his cheek and reaches out to tilt Izuku's chin up, "I want to see you get mad. I want to see you grow a pair of fucking balls, and stop taking shit. From me. From your mother. From anyone. Sure. I have fucking expectations on me. But you think you don't give in to your own? People expect you to be the town's sweetheart, to be perfect, to always fucking smile. And like me, you can't break out of it either."

Izuku shakes his head as if he didn't want to hear the truth, "Kacchan, it's hard. It's harder than you think."

Katsuki ignored him, "Have you ever told your mom about how fucking oppressive she is? Have you ever told anyone about how frustrated you are with your dad for leaving you, because I know you are. Have you ever told me how much you hate me for all that I did? Have you ever told anyone how sick you are of people thinking you're a goodie-two shoes? Hah, and you think I'm emotionally closed off."

"I don't hate you," Izuku shakes his head, eyes closed so that Katsuki couldn't see the redness as he cries, "I never hated you."

Katsuki ignores him, "Aren't you sick of being the perfect son? With the perfect plans, and the perfect attitude? Aren't you sick of it? I want to see you angry. It's fucking good for you. It's natural. You're letting everyone tell you how to feel, how to act, what to do except for your damn self, Deku. Even now, when you were lecturing me, you apologized way too much and demanded too little."

Izuku opened his eyes and stared up at those red ones, now filled with emotion. Frustration, anger, disgust, careful, but the one that Izuku was most surprised to see: pleading. Katsuki's thumb moved up to Izuku's cheek to wipe the tears away.

"Don't cry," Katsuki tells him.

Izuku laughs very softly through his tears, "How can I not? You just kind of destroyed any image of comfort I could ever possibly have."

Katsuki's tone this time was a lot less angry, and he continued to wipe away Izuku's tears, "You're allowed to feel negative things. You don't need to pretend you're happy when you're not. Excited, when you're drained. Content, when you want change. You're allowed to get mad at me, to defy people's expectations of you, to go off on people. And you said it ain't fucking productive? Bullshit. When is advocating for yourself not productive, Deku?"

Izuku leans into Katsuki touch, and his teary eyes glanced up at Katsuki, wondering how the blonde could give this advice but not take it himself, “Kacchan, I think I understand. But…”

“But I need to follow my own advice too, but in the opposite direction?” Katsuki rolled his eyes, but his tone was gentle, “I get it. I get it, alright?”

Izuku shook his head, and held onto Katsuki’s hand on his cheek with his own, “No, you have to promise me, Kacchan.”

“Promise you what,” Katsuki asks.

“Promise me you’ll try,” Izuku begs quietly, “Try to embrace your positive emotions, and I’ll try to confront mine.”

Katsuki looks down at the shorter male in front of him, and doesn’t move his hand from the intimate position, which could almost even be considered the first step. Izuku stares up at him with wanting eyes, and Katsuki takes his time to answer.

When he does, Katsuki bumps their forehead together and closes his eyes with a sigh, “We got shit to work on, don’t we.”

The admittance of this was just as important. But Izuku insisted with a whisper, “Promise me.”

Without moving from their position, Katsuki hesitantly tells Izuku, “I don’t make promises I don’t know if I can keep.”

“Then make sure you keep it, Kacchan,” Izuku searches him, “You told me to make more demands, right? Promise me then. Promise me you’ll try. And keep it.”

“Deku-”

“No,” Izuku shakes his head, “Not after you said all of that. Not after everything you just told me. Promise me, Kacchan.”

Katsuki looks at him with conflicted eyes, and Izuku knew it was not an easy road to change, and not an easy realization to even know you *need* change. Many years had made Katsuki into who he was. And it was going to be a long process to unwind all of that.

But ultimately, Katsuki tells him, looking away, “I promise.”

Izuku looked satisfied with this for now, but there was still something that seemed to be on the tip of his tongue, and Katsuki noticed.

“What is it, now.” The blonde asked, thumbing the smaller’s cheek.

Izuku’s voice seemed insecure as he spoke, “Do you...actually hate me?”

Izuku immediately felt like throwing up in anticipation for the answer, but he heard Katsuki sigh. And move his hand from Izuku’s cheek to run through the greenette’s hair, before

deciding to for the first time in their entire relationship, be honest about his thoughts towards Izuku, “No.”

Izuku felt as if he knew that internally, but he needed confirmation. Katsuki was always straightforward with everything except how he felt about him. He could be honest with quite about everything else except for his perception of Izuku.And at times like this, Izuku just needed Katsuki to tell him straight up rather than him having to guess and read between the lines.

Izuku looks up at the other, eyes shining with both relief and overwhelming feelings. The blonde stood across from him, hair still slightly damp, looking down at the shorter boy. And Izuku wanted to simmer in this powerful, but odd moment a little longer. Where he can replay all of the words Katsuki and he had just exchanged and simmer in it for a while.

However, before he had the opportunity to do so, Izuku saw the flash of a blue light. And his eyes darted towards that direction, to find that a car ws entering into the parking lot. At the disruption, Katsuki stepped away, putting his hands in his pocket, and turned towards the source of the interruption.

It wasn’t just any car that entered the parking lot, but what looked to be a police car. Since Ise was such a small town, both Izuku and Katsuki knew the entire small fleet of the police force, since they likely grew up riding their bikes next to the cops or maybe their parents knew them. The siren sounded once, and Izuku and Katsuki walked towards the cop car which was pulling up near Katsuki’s car.

Curious and wondering if they were in any sort of trouble, both of the boys began walking towards the cop car. When they were within earshot, the cop rolled down his windows to reveal that it was Mr. Hadashi, who knew his mother relatively well.

“Mr. Hadashi?” Izuku asked, probably looking like a mess. His eyes were most definitely red, there were likely streaks of tears dried up on his face, and his clothes were almost dry but clearly looked like he’s been playing in the rain.

Mr. Hadashi waved and looked surprised, “Midoriya? I’ve been looking for you.  I was going around the city looking for you, and saw a random car in the school parking lot. Turns out, it’s you two. Bakugo, good evening to you, too.”

Izuku came up to the window and leaned down a bit, furrowing his brows, “You’ve been looking for me? Is something wrong?”

“Ehhh,” Mr. Hadashi just kind of scratched the back of his head, “It depends.”

“On?” Izuku frowned, confused. He turned to look over at Katsuki, who just leaned against the car and shrugged at Izuku.

“On whether or not you’re okay,” Mr. Hadashi says, “So are you alright?”

Izuku shook his head furiously, “Yeah! I’m perfectly fine. Wait, why does it depend on if I’m okay? What’s going on? And why were you looking for me.”

“Oh, um,” The cop looked a little apologetic as he begins to tell Izuku, “Well, I got a 911 call about an hour ago. From Inko. Er, your mom.”

Izuku’s heart dropped, and his fists clenched up automatically. *You have to be kidding me* , he thought to himself.

“And,” Mr. Hadashi continued, “She was freaking out. Crying and begging, and everything. Saying that you went missing, and that you were gone. And so I asked her when was the last time she had contact with you,” The cop waved his hands around lazily, “Protocol, you know? And she says that you texted her earlier saying you’ll be home late around 10. And so I told her that it’s fine and to wait until 10. You weren’t missing. You probably went out with your friends, and didn’t specify where you were. My daughter does that here and there. It’s not that big of a deal.”

Izuku felt light-headed, and he couldn’t believe that his mother actually-

“But she insisted that you were missing, and that I needed to come find you. She threatened to call other cops, so I decided to just go find you so that she’ll calm down a little bit. Although I must say I was sure you were fine. I would advise though, knowing how Inko is, to just text her when you’ll be ho-”

“She called the cops…” Izuku tells him, as if wanting confirmation. His voice was unsteady, and he was stiff.

“...yeah,” Mr. Hadashi looked a little sorry.

“She called the cops, even though I told her I was going to be home around 10,” Izuku’s voice was taut and he checked his phone, “It’s 9. It’s literally 9:23.”

“Midoriya, I’m just doing my job,” Mr. Hadashi held out both hands, “And your mom insisted I find you.”

Izuku flipped his head over to Katsuki, who looked cautious of Izuku. He knew he must have looked tense right now. A vein was threatening to burst out of his forehead, and he felt both embarrassed, ashamed, angry, and sad all at the same time. Any momentary happiness he could have had today was completely turned upside down.

“And where is she now? Is she at home? Or at the station?” Izuku asked, voice very rigid and for a moment, terrifying.

Mr. Hadashi tells him, “She should be at home. I told her there’s no need for her to go to the station.”

“Good,” Izuku says, “Great.”

“Wait, Deku,” Katsuki began.

However, before Katsuki could finish any thought, Izuku had already taken off towards home. He didn't bother saying bye or grabbing his backpack from the awning. The greenette just ran towards the direction of his home at maximum speed, weaving in through neighborhoods to get on the fastest route. The entire time, anger and sadness surged through his head.

His mother was paranoid, sure. He accepted that fact a long time ago. From when he was 3 years old, and above, she's really only let him hang out with a select group of people. And she always restricted what he did. He had to stay within walking distance to his house. He had to text her back within an hour. He had to be home before 8PM. He had to always accept her rules, or not go out at all. And when he was old enough, he got to be home later but nothing after 10PM. He could be outside of walking distance, but she would give him a long talk beforehand. Everytime he's asked to hang out, it feels like fighting on a battlefield. The tension was so thick that he could cut it with a knife.

So yes, he *knew* she was overprotective. But this? Calling the cops *before* he had told her when he'd be home? This was something else. This was worse than calling up to his school to prevent him from attending the very event he planned. This was worse than taking away years of childhood and teenage experience. He was embarrassed. He saw that look of pity from the cop's eyes, from his friends' eyes, from Katsuki's mouth. They all knew of his situation, and they felt sorry for him. And now, the woman had gone so far as to call the cops on a full grown adult who should be able to decide to go home at 10PM, which was generous.

Izuku ran until his lungs felt as if they were going to collapse on him, but the anger that coursed through his soul pushed him forward. His footsteps left large splashes of leftover rainwater everywhere. He couldn't tell whether he wanted to cry or whether he wanted to scream. He hit the ground hard with every step, and he needed to get home *now* . He didn't know what he'll say when he sees her. He doesn't know what he'll do. He was utterly losing his mind.

He turned onto his street, and saw his house in the distance. The porch lights were on, and the door was wide open, but he couldn't see his mom. It was as if she was patrolling in and out of her house, waiting for him to arrive home.

Izuku felt anger just thinking about it, and he ran even faster. His legs wanted to give out, but he ran up on his driveway and onto the porch. When he got there, Izuku put his hands on his knees and heaved, catching his breath. His chest went up and down, regaining oxygen, and he tilted his head up.

Finally, Izuku walked into the house, and found his mom sitting on the kitchen stool, hands holding a mug of something and looking frantic and worried, muttering to herself with puffy red eyes and tears all over her face. When she finally noticed him at the front door, the woman's eyes widened and looking like her entire life force has been returned to her, cried some more and called out.

"Izuku?" Inko called out, getting off of the stool, "You're hom-"

“You called the cops,” Izuku just stated, voice even. His eyes were bloodshot, and his fists were clenched by his sides.

Inko ignored him, even though he *knew* she heard him, “Oh my god! Why do you look like that? You look like a mess! Have you been hurt? You’ve been hurt, haven’t you. That’s why you should have listened to m-”

“You called,” Izuku began again, tone much more serious now as he enunciated each word, “the cops.”

The air felt as if it was sucked out of the house, and even the wind outside began to whistle a little louder. Soon enough, it’ll begin raining soon. All they had to do was wait. Izuku’s eyes were unusually dark, and he could feel himself losing grip of all composure he’s built up over years and years of suppressing his feelings. It was like a dam of hidden anger and frustration leaking from a crack that was bound to burst.

Inko finally got the message that Izuku felt a certain way about this, and suddenly got defensive, “Of course, I did! I didn’t know where you were, and you just wouldn’t text or call me back! What was I supposed to do, ‘Zuku? You’re my baby. I have to make sure you’re ok-”

“You could have just trusted me,” Izuku gripped his phone tightly in frustration, “I texted you I’ll be home at 10. It was barely 9, when you called 911.”

“You didn’t tell me where you were, Izuku,” Inko’s voice was steady and as sweet as it always was. And Izuku was getting sick of it by the second.

“I’m 18. I can vote. I can drive. I am a legal adult. And yet, I can’t make my own decisions about where I go?” Izuku asked, tone incredulous as he stares at her with big eyes. His string was about to snap.

“You are still living under this house and my rules, Izuku,” Inko reminds him, “What I say *goes* .”

“If you keep doing things like this, then I won’t be for longer,” Izuku tells her then, voice tight and body filled with the weight of his anger.

His mother’s eyes widened significantly, and Izuku shook his head, wanting to collapse from how heavy it feels to live in this house, “Even if you do stop, I can’t live in this house any longer, Mom. I can’t do this anymore.” Izuku’s voice then cracked.

“Izuku, don’t say that,” Inko held onto her mug tightly, “You’re tired, and you don’t understand what you’re saying.”

Izuku takes a step closer, feeling his blood pressure rise with every sentence, “I understand *exactly* what I’m saying, Mom,” He begins to speak more firm and loud, “I can’t *do* this anymore.” He repeats.

Inko just tells him again, “You don’t mean it. You need to go up, take a shower. I’ll let your behavior go tonight, but we are going to be talking about this in the morn-”

“No.” Izuku tells her, “Let’s talk about this tonight! You were up for it a couple of minutes ago, weren’t you, Mom?” He steps forward some more with the hint of a smile on his face, one that revealed that he has given up.

He continues, “Why aren’t you up for it now? Because I’m not just bowing down and apologizing for getting home *before* I told you I was going to?” He had a crazed smile on his face, as if he was going insane.

Inko was quiet, but her mouth was gaped. She stared at Izuku as if she was looking at a different person. As if she was seeing a monster. If she wanted to see a smile so bad on her precious boy’s face all the time, then here it was. One that was devoid of happiness.

Izuku continued, walking one step towards her, voice crescendoing as he spoke, “Were you expecting me to come home and thank you for caring so much? So much that you called the cops and *wasted* their time? They have better things to do with their time, Mom. Do you understand that?” Izuku talked to her as if she was dumb, “They have better things to do than to look for normal adults doing normal activities at *normal* times! I was *fine* , Mom. I was fine! I don’t need you breathing down my neck every single minute!”

Inko looked cautious, but kept her volume level even, “Izuku, you know it was because I was worri-”

“Because you were worried for me,” Izuku waved his arms around dramatically, as if he was drunk, and turned around in place, “Because I’m your precious baby boy. Because you care about me. Because you know what’s best for me,” Izuku laughed, “Mom, do you know how many times we’ve had this exact conversation? Do you know how many times I’ve heard those words come out of your mouth?”

“Izuku, are you okay?” Inko looked at him as if he was going insane, “You’re not being yourself. You’re scaring me, ‘Zuku.”

Izuku only added to her perception, by laughing at her reaction, “I’m scaring myself, Mom. Everything’s been changing so fast that I feel like I can barely catch up. The world is moving around me so quickly, and I’m only beginning to stumble behind to grab my place. And yet, I feel more alive and aware than I’ve ever been. Isn’t that crazy?” He wipes at his eyes and laughs some more. He came from one hard conversation back in the damp humid parking lot to another one immediately the moment he stepped into his own home.

Inko shook her head, curling into herself, “Izuku, you need to go to bed. *Now* .”

“No,” Izuku tells her, feeling a surge of power at the fact that he just straight up defied his mother. He was going too far, he knew it. He looked deranged, he knew that too. And yet, this was what happened when 18 years of pent up anger comes out, and he didn’t know what to do with himself.

“I’ll drag you to bed, Izuku,” Inko warned him calmly, “Do not test me.”

Izuku shrugs and gives her a funny grin, “I’ll just sneak out.”

“What?” Inko blinked up at her son, shocked to hear such a response.

“I said,” Izuku repeats, giving up, “I’ll just sneak out of the house.”

Inko was taken aback, and Izuku wonders if this was enough to make the calm and collected woman lose her composure.

Inko shook her head, “You’d never. You’re a good boy, Izuku.”

Izuku smiles at her, “Mom, does it surprise you to know that I’m not that good of a boy? Does it surprise you to know that I sneak out at least once a week? And do things I only dream about and watch others do? Speaking of,” Izuku pretends to be curious, by thumbing his chin, “Why do I even feel like I have to sneak out? Shouldn’t I, at this age, be allowed to just leave? To go to an ice cream parlor? Or to a skating rink?” And then he shrugs as if he didn’t care, “That’s just what the whole world thinks. But not you, apparently.”

Inko shook her head and stared at him in horror, “No. No, this isn’t happening.”

“Mom, does it shock you to know that I do a lot of dumb stuff when I go out? I swim really far out into the ocean. I sneak into lakes at night. I go explore abandoned buildings here and there too. I also get hurt, sometimes,” Izuku shoves it in her face, “Little cuts here and there from rocks or branches. A bruise once in a while too. But I’m such a baby and I can’t take care of myself, right? And that’s why I need to be kept inside of this house all the time, right?” Izuku sarcastically laughs.

Inko puts her foot down on the carpet, “Enough. Izuku, you are far out of line. I don’t know what has gotten into you or why you are like this tonight, but you *will* deal with the consequences,” Her voice wavered, “I’m putting a tracker on your phone, and you are not leaving the house, not even for the project. I’ll contact Mr. Toshino-”

The boy in question just smiled lazily, but there was no humor in his face, “I’m far out of line? You called the cops.” He repeated for the third time.

“You’ve said that,” Inko said, voice more terse now but still candy-like, and Izuku wonders what it would take for her to get truly angry.

“And you haven’t given me an explanation that isn’t stupid,” Izuku giggles, feeling so out of it, he wanted to die.

He knew he looked insane, and yet, he couldn’t make himself think hard and tiptoe around his conversations with her like he’s used to.

Inko looked as if she was about to cry at his words, “You think me caring about you is stupid?” She sounded so hurt, “You think me wanting you to be safe is stupid, Izuku?”

“And there you go again,” Izuku raised his hands and gestured towards her, turning to a fake invisible audience, “There she is, everyone! Exhibit A! I call this The Manipulative Mother. She’s sweet. She takes care of you. But boy, when she doesn’t get the answers she wants or

expects, she makes you feel like the bad guy by acting like a victim. And *man* , does she make you feel bad."

Izuku's voice was cracking left and right as he speaks, and he begins to cry while talking, "She'll say everything all nice and soft, so that if you show any negative emotions, you'll look like the evil one. She'll twists your words around so that it looked like you don't like her! Isn't she amazing?" Izuku bowed to the fake audience in their broken living room.

"Why are you doing this to me, Izuku?" Inko spoke with a very gentle expression, voice pleading.

"And you're doing it again!" Izuku points out, crying with her, "You always do this, Mom! If I say anything unsatisfactory, you'll get all quiet. And you'll say things that make me feel like a bad and neglectful son. And I end up thinking that it was my fault. How is that fair?" Izuku looks down at his feet, "How is that fair?" He repeats while burying his face in his hands.

"I'm just doing my job as a mother," Inko tells him, making her case, "Because as a mother, I do what I have to do to keep my son safe. Even if you don't like it. When you have kids, you'll understa-"

"When I have kids," Izuku says, now completely serious although quiet tears slide down his cheeks, "I will not repeat your mistakes. I'm not going to suffocate them. I'm not going to make them feel like they can't talk to you about certain things in fear that you're going to freak out," Izuku slowly got louder, stepping closer to his mother for emphasis, "I'm not going to manipulate them into feeling bad about not being with me 24/7. I'm not going to make my kids m-"

"Izuku, you've been raising your voice. You need to calm down. Remember what I taught you. Getting angry never solve-" Inko began, words very careful.

"No! I'm sick of that!" Izuku shouted then, bursting out into big visible tears, eyes even more red while staring at his mother.

Inko, startled by the shout, dropped her mug onto the ground with a clang. Since it was plastic, it didn't break; however, the coffee that she had inside spilled out all over the floor and soaked into her slippers. It spread into the carpet of their living room, and Izuku knew the brown stain will forever remind him of this night. Izuku looked down at it, then back up at his mother, whose face was shocked and incredulous.

"I-I'm…" Izuku felt his chest heave up and down, but he was nervous. He's never said anything like this to his mother before, and he was habituated to never do so, "I'm s-sick of it, Mom. I'm sick of shoving away…" He cries some more as he thinks back to what Katsuki had said to him, and continues, "my negative emotions. I'm sick of having to be perfect. Of being happy all the time, even when I'm not. Of having to be grateful for everything, even if it hurts me. Of having to deny what my body natural feels, just so I don't make others feel bad," Izuku clutched the bottom of his shirt just to have something to hold onto.

“I taught you that way so that you could grow up into a respectable young man, Izuku,” Inko justified herself, “Negativity only weighs you down. It just hurts you. It clouds your judgement, and you end up doing horrible things and saying things you don’t mean. I don’t want that for my son. I want you to grow up a happy and bright child, with only love to give. What is so wrong with that?”

“What’s wrong is when I feel like I can’t give anything else *but* love. I’m so one-dimensional to other people, with no emotions besides positive ones and I get stepped on by eve-” Izuku tells her, throwing his hands up.

“I don’t *want* you to give anything else but love! It’s all you need in lif-” Inko tried to convince him.

“Don’t be naive, Mom,” Izuku laughs dryly, “If love was all we needed, why did Dad leave?”

Inko’s expression towards Izuku then was as if he shot her, and then he saw it: Anger fueling up inside of her, entering her body like a rain in a desert valley. He’s done it.

Inko opened her mouth, then closed it again. As if holding herself back, she grabs her things off of the counter and stomps towards her room. Izuku wasn’t going to let that happen.

The greenette ran towards her room ahead of her, while muttering, “No, no, no, no, no.”

“Izuku,” Her tone was not playing around, “Please move.”

“No,” Izuku stood in front of her door, blocking her entrance, “I deserve this conversation, Mom. You owe it to me.”

Inko looked up at him then, with equally red eyes, “I’m not talking about that man.”

“He gave you me,” Izuku pointed at himself, “If nothing else, why can’t we just appreciate that?”

Inko then looked like she was near her breaking point, “He was selfish, and never grew up. Always wanting to go too many places, do too many things. He had dreams that were bigger than his responsibilities. He never wanted to settle down, and be with family.”

“He did,” Izuku argued, “You just never wanted to go with him. He wasn’t perfect. He didn’t have priorities, but you never tried either. You never wanted to go anywhere, do anything!”

“I don’t need to!” Inko finally raised her voice, “I had you and him. And that was enough.”

“Mom, you have no ambition outside of me,” Izuku cries while shaking his head, “You opened up a shop because you needed to make money, not because you liked making custom prints. You never wanted to see the world, to experience more than just what this town had! And...and that’s fine. If you’re happy, that’s fine. But that doesn’t mean I have to live like that too. That doesn’t mean I have to live every day, wondering what more is out there or what could have been.”

“And so what now?” Inko sounded bitter, “You’re just going to leave this town, move to some city and go to some pretentious school? And what happens when you know nobody there? When you miss your momma? What happens when you realize that no matter what, nothing is like here, at home?”

“Then I’ll go home! To visit! Mom, you’re missing the point,” Izuku shook his head, “The point is that I want the option to come back and the option to leave without feeling as if I’m tearing us apart. Why does it have to be a choice? Why do I have to choose between my happiness and yours?”

“Our happiness can be the same, Izuku,” Inko stated.

“Sure, as long as it’s your definition of happiness, right?” Izuku laughed.

“ *Our* happiness,” Inko repeated.

“Really?” Izuku called her out, “Because you know what I want to do with my life. You’ve always known. From when I was a kid to now, you’ve seen me look up to athletes, to Kacchan. You’ve seen me dream, doodle, and analyze how they move. You *know* what I want to go into, and you know where I have the best opportunity to do what I love. And yet, you still think my best chance is here? I...I love Ise, but I’m not going to die here without seeing everywhere else. Without doing... *more* .”

Inko was quiet.

“So look me in the eye, Mom,” Izuku pleaded, “And tell me again that you know what my happiness means.”

Inko’s tears were pooling at her waterline, her mouth in a permanent wobble, as she turns her head away and wipes at her face. And her words were in agony when she speaks next, ignoring his question altogether.

“Why did you have to grow up, Izuku,” Inko moved away from him, “Why’d you have to go and change. We were perfect as we were. You and me. Mommy and s-”

“You’re afraid of change, Mom,” Izuku tells her and he tilts his head up to the ceiling lights, as if the tears will fall back inside of his tear ducts. He hiccups, “You’re like this town,” Izuku accuses, “Stuck in the past. And I don’t plan on getting left behind with you.”

Inko laughs at his futile attempt, “Izuku, where are you going to go? You have nowhere to go, but here.”

Izuku hates the way she was laughing at him, so he tells it to her straight, “I got accepted to Waseda University in Tokyo. I’ll take out loans, and spend ten years paying them off if I need to.”

His mother’s laugh stops then, as her entire body goes frozen and her eyes search Izuku in a desperate attempt to see if it was a lie. But Izuku stares at her straight on, so that she knew he was serious. He was completely serious, and she needed to understand now or never that if

she didn't change, he wasn't going to be anchored down to this house with her any longer. Inko was completely silent, not saying a word, just looking at him in horror. As if he had betrayed her in the worst way possible.

"Mom...do you know how much the way I was raised messed me up?" His voice was quiet now.

Inko's lips quivered and he could see her hands shake, but she said nothing.

"Whenever I talk to you or anyone else, I have to always think of what to say to make everyone else happy, even if I'm not. If I ever get angry or sad or even...jealous, I feel as if I have to shove it away. When we get close to arguing, I have to take a deep breath and suppress my anger or my frustration. And I repeat in my head *Don't get angry. Anger doesn't solve anything* in my head like a mantra, because you always taught me never to be unhappy or ungrateful."

Izuku bit his lip then, "But just because I suppress it, doesn't mean that it goes away. It's there, just building up. And I don't even know how to handle my anger anymore. Even now, I...I can't even control myself because I don't know what to do," Izuku says between small cries, "I'm angry. And I'm sad. I'm...frustrated. And I feel like the world is passing by me faster than I can hold on. And I don't know what to do," He hiccups between his tiny cries, "Mom, I don't know how to handle it, because I was never taught to be okay with these feelings," Izuku wiped at his face.

Inko has still said nothing at this point.

Izuku looked at his mother then, smiling gently, "You wanted to see me smile all the time, right? Here's my smile." He forces it, "Does it make you happy? Does it make you feel satisfied, Mom?"

Inko looked down at her hands.

"No, don't turn away. Look at your son," Izuku tells her, "You wanted me to smile so badly, right? Then look at me," Izuku cries while he smiles, "Should I be like this, forever? Will that make you happy?"

When Midoriya Inko refuses to answer, Izuku drops the fake smile and sighs. He knew his mother was a good person. He knew she had great qualities, ones he was proud to have inherited including her hard-workingness. But that didn't excuse her bad ones.

"I love you, Mom…" Izuku whispered, "I just want to love *me* too."

And then, Izuku walks away, stepping up the stairs, as he feels all of the tears he held back choke up in his throat. And outside, Izuku hears the rain start to pour again, and he didn't want to be here anymore. He didn't want to be in this house, breathe in this air, and feel all of the tension and strain interwoven around every floor board, every fiber of carpet, every square inch of this home. He couldn't stay here tonight, not when his mother and the conversation he just had snuck into every crevice of his brain. He felt so guilty. He felt so bad, for all that he's said and all that he's done to Inko tonight. But he constantly reminded

himself. He was allowed to feel anger. He was allowed to step up for himself. He was allowed to sit in pain, in sadness, and shouldn't shove it away just for it to get worse.

That didn't mean sitting in this house, with his mother right downstairs, wasn't difficult. And so, he didn't. He couldn't. Izuku couldn't stay here right now. Going into his room, the greenette paces around the floor and cries into his hands. He was panicking, and going delirious. He still had so much emotion pent up inside of him, wanting to pour out all at once but the floodgates were only so wide. He pulled out his phone, and dialed a couple of numbers. Nobody picked up, and Izuku felt more alone than ever. He felt completely and utterly alone, in a world and on a day that wanted to spit in his face. He needed someone, anyone. And he couldn't be in this damn house for another second.

Dropping everything but his phone, Izuku stepped back down the stairs. The lights of the living room were still on, and Izuku saw that Inko was sitting in one of the armchairs and her head didn't even turn to him when he walked past the living room. And Izuku cried some more, suppressing his sounds until he opened the door and walked out of the house in the rain. If she didn't know he left the house randomly before, then she did now. And didn't even look at him.

Izuku sobbed into the night air the moment he stepped out and onto the porch, pulling his body forward even though it wanted to collapse out of mental exhaustion. And he walked through the streets of Ise, as the rain soaks him for the second time this day. His shirt was once more matted to his body, but everything felt like a numbing sensation.

And he just wanted to feel anything. He could barely see through the downpour, and his only guiding lights were the white street lamps that were slightly blurred out by the rain. Izuku walked for a while, wondering when his tear ducts will dry up, but they felt endless.

He had never spoken to his mother like that, never let go of his mental restraints like that, never behaved like that, and he doesn't know what to do.

Izuku finds himself, more intentional than not, standing in front of a door that belonged to someone very familiar, shivering to himself because the rain was colder now than it was earlier. His lips were probably blue, his eyes were definitely red, but he couldn't even bother to think about that. Izuku wonders if he should knock.

But he was done wondering, when his body automatically reached up and rung the doorbell, as if he needed it. He wonders if Aunt Mitsuki or Uncle Maseru will come out to greet him. If they did, Izuku wasn't exactly sure if he can explain himself in this mental state. He was an absolute mess.

He stands out there on the front door for a bit, shaking in his spot and still crying to himself. He wanted to stop, but couldn't. Every time he'd try to calm down and force his tears to stop, one thought of what happened tonight and it was waterworks all over again.

Izuku was about to give up altogether, and accepted that he'll just roam the streets of Ise until morning, or at least until he can find the courage to go back to his house, when the door to the Bakugo family home opened. To reveal an irritated looking Bakugo Katsuki with rings around his eyes, holding the door aggressively as if ready to start a fight.

But once the blonde saw who was on his porch, the athlete's red eyes widened at the clearly distraught state of Izuku, standing there in the soaking rain looking as if he was ready to give up on trying.

"Deku?" Katsuki asked, unsure if he was actually seeing Izuku at his doorstep this late at night.

Izuku wiped at his eyes uselessly and tried to even his voice, but it still came out in hiccups, "H-Hi, Kac-Kacchan," He hiccuped, "I'm sorry for showing up at this time," His voice gets tinier at the end as his composure comes to a breaking point, and he cried near the end, "I-I just don't really have anywhere to be right now. And I just can't go home," He shook his head and his chest shook, "I don't want to bother you, but I just don't know where to go. And I just...And I just had an argument with my mom, and it just all hurts really bad. And I just can't be at home right now. So please, can I just ge-"

"Come here," Katsuki tells him, stepping back so that Izuku could go in.

And Izuku, taking what Katsuki said the wrong way, steps in and immediately throws himself onto the blonde, wrapping his arms around the athlete's shoulders and immediately sobbing. He just needed anyone right now, to hold him, to let him scream and cry. Izuku was desperate and at the first opportunity, jumped on the blonde. Katsuki, taken aback, just stood there for a second. Not holding the other back in a way Izuku needed him to.

Instead, he just stands there for a minute, as Izuku slumps against his body and his shoulders were shaking. Katsuki's clothes were immediately soaked with rainwater and tears.

"So I guess the talk didn't go well?" Katsuki asks, tone low and steady.

Izuku shakes his head, not bothering to have a verbal reply, and clings onto the taller boy while he continues to cry.

Katsuki just sighs, before bending down slightly to then pick Izuku up and lay the smaller boy across his arms, as if carrying him in a bridal style. Izuku was still wrapped around his shoulders, but Katsuki held him up, while telling the other.

"Come on, let's get you dried off and in bed," Katsuki tells the other, and Izuku didn't care where he ends up. He just was glad to not be in his own house.

Katsuki takes care of him well, in the usual silent way that he did. The blonde takes him into the guest bedroom that Izuku stayed in the first night he was ever here, and sits Izuku down on the edge of the silk bed, careful not to get the comforter soaked in water. The boy didn't want to let go, but Katsuki softly pried his arms away until he could go and get a towel and some new clothes.

When Katsuki came back, Izuku was still silently crying, but he was reduced to hiccups, instead of full on sobs. That was good, because it meant Izuku was coming up from his breakdown. Now, his head just felt hazy, and all he wanted to do was be with someone. And be held, and cared for. Katsuki dried his hair off with a towel, careful to not be too aggressive. And then peeled off his shirt, before wiping him down with the towel too.

When Izuku was dry, before Katsuki could put on another shirt, Izuku in a whisper tells the other to leave it. He'll sleep without it tonight. Katsuki hesitates, but complies anyways, before moving down on the legs. The blonde removes the matted wet shorts, and dries off his thighs and legs with the towel, careful with every movement. And steps back, turning around after tossing Izuku a pair of boxers to use as sleeping pants. In the meanwhile, Katsuki goes over to change into a new pair of pants, and ditches the shirt as well, considering that he got rain on it earlier from Izuku's hug. This sequence of actions felt as if it took forever, from the moment Izuku arrived at the house to when he got fully changed.

When Katsuki changes into new pants, the blonde walks back into the guest room with a glass of water in his hand, "Drink this."
Izuku reaches out with both hands, and takes it. Slowly bringing the cup to his mouth, and quenched his dry throat until the glass was half empty and then sets it on the nightstand. It was quiet for a while, and Izuku just couldn't find himself to say much. Katsuki didn't look like he'd pressure him to either, which he was grateful for.

He didn't want to rehash any of it. The blonde just stood there for a couple of minutes, off to the side of the bed, while Izuku sits on the edge, staring out into blankness. The rain outside persisted, and it was awfully dark in this room. But their eyes were adjusted to the dark blue tint of the bedroom, and the gleam of the silk sheets and comforter.

Finally, Katsuki quietly tells the shorter boy, "I'm going to head back to my room. Are you going to be alright?"

Izuku then turns to look over at the handsome blonde, filled with what he knew now to be the beginnings of love, "Kacchan."

The boy in question answers, "What is it."

"Can you stay with me tonight?" Izuku asks, wondering if it was too much, but ultimately not even caring.

"I'll be across the room," Katsuki tells him.

Izuku shakes his head, "No. Here, in this bed."

Katsuki's eyes widened at the suggestion, and he looks at the bed, before his eyes go back to Izuku, "Dek-"

"Please," Izuku whispered, "I just want someone near."

Katsuki looked conflicted for a moment, as if he was battling with his own mind. But Izuku's voice was so laced with desperation and plead, that it was impossible to say no. And so, Katsuki wordlessly makes his way to the other side of the bed.

Izuku, shifts to the left side, and crawls up to where the comforter was tucked in, and untucks in. He slowly slid himself in, until he was settled down on the soft pillows.

From beside him, Katsuki untucked the comforter as well, and slipped himself in on the opposite side, laying straight up with his arms crossed above the blanket. Izuku just stares at him from the side, and he wishes that he could touch the other. Right now, he wanted and needed nothing more than that. To touch and be touched. Izuku has been wanting him so badly, and at this moment of strife in his life, he felt as if he needed it. Izuku's body gravitated towards Katsuki like the moon to the Sun. The blonde's eyes were still open, as if he was thinking, and Izuku didn't want him to go to sleep. Not when he was this close. Not when they could do so much more.

Izuku was barely thinking straight, when he asked Katsuki.

"Can you hold me?" Izuku asked him, voice soft and with want clearly laced in it. So much that the definition of *hold* could be argued.

Katsuki's attention immediately shifted, and he turned his head over to where Izuku was leaned on his side towards the blonde, eyes looking away but body very clearly positioned towards the taller boy. Katsuki didn't seem to be expecting this request, for Izuku could hear the uncomfortable shifting in the bed.

"You're asking for too much, Deku," Katsuki warns him gently.

Izuku's heart felt like breaking all over again, but he needed it so much he couldn't give up.

"Then feel generous tonight," Izuku whispers to him. Once again, Katsuki looked confused and at a lost.

"I'm not…" Katsuki began, voice seemingly more genuine, "I'm not meant for those kind of touches, Deku," And Izuku knew exactly what the blonde meant by that. Katsuki was used to rough, to heavy, to aggressive touches that were purely sexual. He wasn't used to soft holds that were meant for close friends and lovers. The blonde continued, "I don't know how."

Izuku searched Katsuki's eyes, which were turned towards him, and the greenette could have guessed that about Katsuki. And he feels like if it was a normal day, and he was in the right mindset, he would understand. And he would care. And he would definitely not do what he was wanting to do next. However, it wasn't a normal day, and his mentality was out of whack at the moment, and so, in a moment of need and desire, Izuku slowly brought himself up to his elbow, sliding over just a bit to Katsuki, and reached out.

The athlete watched the other the entire time, from the look on Izuku's face to the way his neck was exposed to reveal delicious smooth skin, Katsuki watched as Izuku reaches his hand out to grab onto Katsuki's own hand as if guiding him. Izuku picks up Katsuki's right hand that was just resting there, and brings up closer, until it was headed towards Izuku's body.

"Then touch me in the way you know how," Izuku whispered out suggestively, eyes slightly hooded, as he brings Katsuki's hand down to touch his body, resting the athlete's large and rough palm against the chest, over the perfect budding nipples from the coldness of the room, and down his torso.

Katsuki lets the greenette play from a moment, before pulling his hand back and turning his head away, “Deku, stop.”

Izuku didn’t understand. What about Izuku was just so unappealing for Katsuki to not want him in the way he wanted the other. The boy scooted closer, until his body was quite near Katsuki’s side, and Izuku reached over to gently touch Katsuki’s jaw, bringing his face over to look Izuku in the eye. In the dim bluish tint of the bedroom, Izuku can still see the gleam of the red, and he wanted so badly for Katsuki to touch him, in any way, he didn’t care.

“Why,” Izuku whispered, bringing his forehead down to rest against Katsuki’s, “You don’t want to?”

The greenette then moved his legs so that they go over Katsuki’s hips, and pushed his body forward until he was now on top of Katsuki, straddling the blonde’s hip while his upper body still laid on top of Katsuki’s. Izuku was merely inches above the taller boy, and his palm was resting against Katsuki’s sharp jaw. Their lips were barely three inches apart, and they were touching chest to chest.

Katsuki breathed into his mouth, all without making contact, “Deku, you don’t want this. *Shit* .” He cursed as Izuku grinded his hip down.

Izuku hovered his lips above Katsuki’s, and they both played a game where they get so *so* close, but never actually touch, before asking the other, “How are you going to tell me what I want, Kacchan?”

Katsuki sounded adamant when he tells Izuku this next. The blonde’s hands were now on his hips, not actually trying to push Izuku off, but also not bringing him any closer, “You’re fucking angry, sad, frustrated, and you probably feel lonely as shit right now, Deku.” He growled in Izuku’s ear, “You. Don’t. Want. This. I could be anyone, and you’d think this is what you want.”

Izuku shakes his head no, and wanted so badly to go into a kiss, but his lips just kind of plays a game with Katsuki, grinding up against the other with his face right there, barely an inch apart, “So?”

“So,” Katsuki says angrily in a low voice, “Fucking stop it. You’ll regret it in the morning if you go any further, Deku.”

Izuku laughed prettily, and sits up, until he was truly straddling Katsuki’s hip, and Izuku tilted his head back while using his own hands to play with his pert nipples, making Katsuki watch him toy with his cute little buds, “You’re not stopping me.”

But Katsuki couldn’t reply. Izuku saw it too, under hooded eyes. Katsuki was watching him play with his nipples, twisting and pulling at him while parting his lips as if he wanted something in it. Something salty, or maybe even a bit bitter. The blonde’s eyes were watching him intently, words lost on the athlete, who lays there underneath him.

Izuku, to up the game, begins to grind up on Katsuki’s lap once again, making sure to bite his lip and smile lazily down at Katsuki. He then closes his eyes, tilts his head back and lets out a

quiet moan, enjoying the Katsuki's friction provided him.

After a moment, the blonde in question snapped out of it, and pulled himself up into a sitting position, with Izuku still on his lap, and gripped the boy by the chin. Izuku felt so small compared to Katsuki, but enjoyed the feeling of being on him like this. He blinked up at Katsuki with wide doe eyes.

"You need to fucking sleep, Deku," Katsuki warns him, eyes darkening, "You're fucking delirious. You're clouded by all of your damn emotions. You just need anyone to fuck you right now just so you can distract yourself, and you don't fucking deserve that."

Izuku raised an eyebrow up at Katsuki, who looked so serious, "And you care about what I deserve? What if I want that?" Izuku was just talking out of his ass, "Should I go ask someone else?"

That was the wrong thing to say, because suddenly, their positions were flipped and Izuku was on his back, while Katsuki was pinning him down from on top. The blonde's strength was unreal, and Izuku knew he couldn't move if he tried. He looked up at Katsuki with eyes filled with lust, and Katsuki had a wild, almost angry look on his face.

"You leave this room to get fucked by someone else, and I'll kill them," Katsuki warns with a dark tone. Izuku has noticed by now that Katsuki threatens that a lot.

Izuku tempts him, "Then fuck me, Kacchan."

The blatant request shocked Katsuki, who stared down at that freckled face which looked at him now with such need. Izuku's lips were slightly parted, chest breathing heavy, and nipples were still as hard as ever. Izuku knew he was doing *something* . He glanced down, to see that a slight tent had formed in Katsuki's pants. And so if nothing else, Izuku now knew that he had the ability to attract Bakugo Katsuki.

"No," The athlete declares, brows furrowing, "Clear your fucking head. You'll fucking hate the idea of being with me come morning."

"But will you?" Izuku ignores Katsuki altogether, "Kacchan, does it hurt?" The greenette gestures his head down to Katsuki's crotch, "I can help. You said you were frustrated, didn't you?"

" *Fuck* ," Katsuki mutters to himself, while his face was turned to the side, and then he looks back down at Izuku, "Fuck! Shut up," He breathes, "I'm going back to my room. You need sleep."

Izuku reached up to hold onto Katsuki's jaw and bring the blonde back down, and he comes a little too easily, and they dance around each other's bodies on the bed, "But why? I was told I give really good head." Izuku tells Katsuki.

And this made the aggressiveness in Katsuki spike to a high level, because at the comment, Katsuki stops their little game and pushes Izuku's shoulder into the mattress, with another hand on the greenette's face, thumb prodding at those lips.

“And who the *fuck* told you that,” Katsuki’s eyes were burning and his tone dangerous.

Izuku’s eyes widened, but he felt himself harden up a bit more at the mere thought that Katsuki could be jealous.

The blonde leaned down, pushing his shoulder into the mattress more and he shoved his finger down Izuku’s mouth, barking out a low, “Is that what you and Fuck Face have been up to? You’ve been sucking his cock?” Katsuki’s voice was pure venom.

Izuku doesn’t say anything, but instead, enjoys this look on Katsuki more than he should.

It made the other even angrier, “Tell me, nerd.” Katsuki sticks his thumb deeper into Izuku’s throat, and the shorter male loved it, “Does he make you get on your knees? I bet he fucking holds your hair back while he slaps his balls on your chin,” Katsuki looked so pissed, “God, I want to kill him. Should I?”

“Why?” Izuku laughs, when Katsuki pulls out his thumb, followed by a trail of saliva, “Who am I to you?”

At this question, it was like it jolted Katsuki awake, because the blonde took a step back and looked at Izuku as if the question burned him. Izuku, now a little confused, waits for some kind of response from the other, only to get nothing, as Katsuki lets go of his pinned shoulder.

And then, he just declares, “I’m not doing shit to you, and that’s final. You’re not leaving this room, and that’s final. I’m not your mom. I don’t want to fucking make your decisions for you. You’ve had enough of that shit already. But this? I’m not letting you go off and fuck just because you want a distraction.” Katsuki tells him, reaching out to tuck a streak of Izuku's hair behind his ear.

He knew where Katsuki was coming from, and yet, Izuku still felt rejected in a way.

Izuku’s eyes felt like watering again, “Why am I not enough?”

“Don’t fucking ask that,” Katsuki looked distressed at the question, and leans down again. The athlete was back on top of Izuku, but this time, in a much gentler fashion. This time, Katsuki puts a hand on his waist, and places his lips near Izuku’s chin, hovering featherlike touches from his lips down different parts of Izuku’s body, “I told you, Deku.”

Izuku watches him, heart pounding fast. Katsuki was so gentle right now, as if he knew how fragile izuku’s mind was at the moment. The athlete just moved down his torso and his waist, looking up at Izuku as he goes down, “Go to sleep. You won’t want me in the morning.”

Izuku, at just how careful Katsuki was handling him, felt a bit of his desperation seep out as he gets overwhelmed with something else: the feelings of falling in love with Katsuki. Katsuki, without even knowing Izuku’s feelings, wasn’t going to take advantage of Izuku’s deranged and desperate state, even when it was clear that the blonde was at least physically attracted to him. Katsuki naively thought that Izuku was suddenly feeling this way about

anyone because of how horrible his night has been, when it was more like Izuku's already felt this way to a minor extent, but his night made him feel as if he needed it.

And so, he tells the other softly, "And if I still do?"

Katsuki looks away then, "You won't."

Izuku just sighs, and lets his body go loose, a sign to Katsuki that he wouldn't try anymore. And then he lays back into the bed, looking off to the side. Katsuki sits in the same spot for a couple of minutes, and they let the silence simmer in between them, allowing Izuku to calm down further and for Katsuki to contemplate on something.

The greenette, after a couple more minutes to relax and reflect, hated that Katsuki was right. He was absolutely shameless in his desperation, and he wasn't going to enjoy the full experience, if the entire time, he was just praying it would distract him. Still, he felt rejected in a way.

Then, from his left, Katsuki slowly moves back under the covers and scooches right up next to Izuku, snaking an arm around the boy's waist and spooning him from behind.

Izuku lifted his head and looked down, before glancing back at Katsuki, "Kacchan?"

Katsuki hummed.

"What are you doing?" Izuku asked quietly, biting his lip.

"Holding you. Like you asked me to," Katsuki says, rounding back to how it had began in the first place, "I'm fucking shit at this, but I can...try. As a...friend." Izuku was initially shocked that the blonde finally admits that they were friends, but he was also bitter that Katsuki wasn't doing this because he wanted to.

Izuku tried to pry Katsuki's arm off of his waist, frustratingly, "I don't want your pity, Kacchan. Please. If you didn't want to before, then I don't want you to force yourself to do this just because you feel bad. Please, just get off of m-"

"Shut the fuck up," Katsuki growled, and pulled him even closer into the taller's chest, "I don't do shit I don't want to do."

Izuku then stopped his prying, and glanced back at Katsuki, but the athlete had his eyes closed. He was surprised.

"So just stay still and go to bed," Katsuki tells him, voice tired, "I'm okay with this. Just for tonight."

Izuku wanted to say something more. But Katsuki clearly didn't want to talk anymore, so Izuku slowly just laid back down, feeling the warmth of Katsuki's arm against his skin. Izuku was sure Katsuki has never held someone like this, but it was nice. And, this was also something Izuku might possibly regret in the morning, too.

“Just for tonight, huh,” Izuku whispered to himself, as the person behind him drifts into sleep minutes later. And with that, he hopelessly wished that tonight never ended.

Katsuki was right. He *did* feel slightly awkward around Katsuki, especially as they were getting ready for school early. Katsuki had actually picked up Izuku’s backpack from the awning the night before, and the car ride was a little weird. Because the previous night was a rollercoaster of emotions, including at the end. They didn’t talk about what had happened, and Izuku was grateful for that, because he honestly would not have known what to say.

However, despite it being a little bit awkward, Izuku knew that in a hang out or two, they will go back to normal. This wasn’t bound to go on for long, And more than the oddity that was last night, Izuku at least has the promise made between them that they will both try. Izuku will try to embrace his negative emotions more, and Katsuki will try to embrace his positive ones more, rather than trying to hide it behind a mask of nonchalant and apathy.

It was a quiet day. Izuku knew at some point, he needed to go home, but for now, he had school, which went as it usually did. Nothing too out of the ordinary. And when it ended, Izuku knew there was a team practice outside on the track field in a moment. After all, it was just a Friday.

Izuku wonders if he’ll do something today, and decides to just go for it. To see if Katsuki was all bark, and no bite. All talk, and no action. Izuku goes to the vending machine, and buys a cherry gatorade.

And when he leaves the school to walk towards the track field, instead of watching from the outside, like he usually does on team practice days when no one was around to see Katsuki and Izuku interacting, the greenette opens the gate and walks through. He steps over the grass, and then onto the polyurethane track field. The vaulters were simply stretching right now, but upon seeing someone who wasn’t part of their team walk up, everyone kind of paused to see.

They knew who he was. Izuku was the boy who always came to watch Katsuki from afar. Izuku was the town’s sweetheart with a rumored exhilarating side. Izuku was someone who was generally known to get along terribly with Bakugo Katsuki. And yet, he was inside of the fence.

Kirishima nudged Katsuki, who had his foot up against the bench, leaned down to tie his track shoes. At the nudge, Katsuki looks up at Kirishima, who nods in Izuku’s direction. And when Katsuki turns around, they make eye contact and hold it. Izuku was slightly nervous, but determined. He was determined to make this the first step in Katsuki’s mission to *try* . He knew everyone was watching them as Izuku approached the other, even if the rest of the team including the coach was pretending to have other conversations.

When Izuku was just two feet apart from the star-athlete, he stops. This was the Katsuki that he rarely interacted with: the one who was at school, rarely talked to him, surrounded by people, stars, lights, cameras, editorials. The one whose stage was the world, and whose stars feel too far for Izuku to reach. But today, Izuku decides he'll diminish that space in between.

Katsuki just looks at him, as if wondering what he will do. Izuku simply reaches into his bag, and pulls out the stupid cherry gatorade, and held it out for Katsuki. The blonde looked at him, and then at the bottle extended to him like a gift. The team was most definitely observing the interaction, expecting Katsuki to say something harsh or slap it away.

The athlete looked over to his team for a quick second, before back down at Izuku.

Without breaking the gaze, Katsuki reaches out to grab the bottle, and tells the shorter boy, "Thanks, nerd."

Izuku didn't know his heart had been beating fast, until he felt massive relief when Katsuki, in front of everyone, genuinely accepts his gift and offer of care with even a word of thanks. If there was shock within the crowd, Izuku wasn't paying attention. He was instead having his full attention on Katsuki. Somewhere in the crowd, Izuku was sure Kaito was feeling something, but he couldn't mind that much either.

Katsuki opens the bottle and takes a sip, before twisting the cap back on. Izuku holds onto his backpack straps, and looks up at the sky.

After a moment, Izuku tilts his head back down, the wind blowing strands of green hair across his eyes, and he smiles up at Katsuki, before telling the other, "I guess I'll head home now."

And he turned around, enjoying the weather and the crows perched on the telephone wires, about to walk a couple steps out towards the gate again, when Katsuki calls out from behind him, loud enough that people could hear.

"Oi, nerd," Katsuki shouts out.

Izuku turned his body halfway around, and shouts back, "Yeah?"

Katsuki jogs up to him then, and ran a hand through his blonde hair, before looking down at the boy, "Do you want to watch our practice? From the inside."

Izuku's eyes light up. And he smiles, so brightly his eyes squint together. And then, he laughs, "Sure."

Chapter End Notes

thank you so much for being patient. i love & appreciate you each so much, and every interaction brings me the greatest joy. I can't thank yall enough!
Like I said, this upcoming Monday's update may be delayed bc I'm at a very packed conference, but I will try to work as fast as possible while taking care of our characters and their development.

Note: next chapter will come out Monday around 8-11 HST!

& some of you guys found my really dry Twitter so might as well haha !
@suffocatingspr1

also !!! izuku finally stood up to inko !

# Chapter 8: The County Fair

Chapter Notes

[READ: you might have missed chapter 7 so pls see if you've read that first!]

24.9k words : I apologize for this horrible chapter pls bear w me :(

My laptop keyboard is water damaged so I finger typed this ch. on my phone I'm so sorry for the slow update but I MISS YOU GUYS. Also I'll edit typos in the morning haha

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Izuku doesn't remember the last time it rained this long in Ise.

The skies cried for weeks, and its tears swept through the streets, flooded the drains, and beat down on the rooftops of quaint pastel homes. Gray clouds blanketed the city and the greenish-blue tint just refused to go away.

The sunny afternoons, golden sunsets, and humid air that everyone in Ise was so used to disappeared for what seems like forever. The only semblance of what the beachside town normally looked like was at night on the few days where the rain would stop for a little bit. Izuku doesn't mind it too much; however, it was a bit of a hassle.

First, everything was cancelled or postponed. The yearly county fair that everyone looked forward to was pushed back three or so weeks, considering that the fairgrounds were flooded. After-school activities held outdoors were cancelled altogether.

Second, the melancholy weather did not add to the mood within his house. The afternoon following Izuku and his mother's fight once school let out for the day was the first time he'll see his mother since the fiasco of the night before. And Izuku had felt the negative energy and tension before he even stepped foot into the house. Life was sucked out of every crevice, every room, every pocket of space the house occupied.

From the walls of the house to the colorful decor neatly placed here and there, it felt gray against the awful lighting that the rainy days provided. And coupled with the depressing mood inside of the Midoriya household, Izuku could barely stand to be here.

Inko didn't talk to him. Food was prepared on the table. Their glasses of water filled. Their plates made. And so they eat dinner quietly at the table, across from one another. There was only 2 feet of table between them, but it felt like two oceans.

Izuku couldn't tell what his mother was thinking, and he couldn't even read it in her large and expressive eyes that he inherited. Inko had rings under her eyes, a somber but rather blank expression on her face, and bodily movements that seemed to be exhausted.

Izuku felt horrible. He felt so, so bad. Because he knew that he was the cause of it. He knew that he was reasoning for his mother's tears, lack of sleep, lack of energy, lack of life. And he was tempted to apologize, just so that the air between them is somewhat normal again.

He wanted so badly to automatically do what he's been habituated and taught to do his entire life and apologize just so that there is no negative feelings in the room.

But then, he thought, then what? If he apologizes, and gives in once more to her, then what? The cycle will only repeat. The arguments, the discontent, the tension, the horrible sentiments will only happen again, and again, and again. And then, he also thought to all that Katsuki had said to him in that one argument.

It wasn't a bad thing to be happy, to be forgiving, or sentimental. In fact, those were great traits. What was a bad thing was when he has to force those feelings, when he didn't want to. What was a bad thing, was when he doesn't have healthy amounts of anger and sadness when it is necessary for his own justice. And to give in and apologize to his mother, when he had done nothing wrong, would be doing an injustice to himself.

He needed to stand his ground, and advocate for himself. And so, although it was painful, although he loved conversation with his mother, although he wanted nothing more for them to be happy together again, Izuku sits through the quiet dinner.

Because it was not his responsibility to repair a broken house when he was not the one who broke it. Because he wanted to prove to himself not for Katsuki, not for the world, not for anyone else, that he can put his feelings first, for once. And not accept anything less.

And so, Izuku sat there and bore the awkward silence. And afterward, went up to his room without another word.

This goes on for weeks. Painful weeks.

And in those weeks, Izuku has left the house whenever he wanted right through the front door. No more sneaking around the corner, and no more asking for permission with a heavy heart and hours of self-preparation. In the rubble aftermath of the chaos within his house, Izuku took the opportunity to turn a new leaf. He just left.

And he'll spend his time after school or so at Katsuki's house, or wherever that they may be. In a creek, on some cliff, in rice patties just running around.

Laying back on the side couch of Katsuki's room, listening to the tapping of the rain against the window, wasting an afternoon away, was becoming one of Izuku's preferred activities.

They never put the lights on, preferring the ambiance of the dark rain clouds casting a greenish tint in the room, and when the sun actually goes down, the two boys are often left in a ghostly darkness. In which their eyes have adjusted long ago, and the pale yellow street

lamp from outside shining in, casting rain shadows in Katsuki's bedroom, was more than enough to see the outlines of everything.

They didn't really need to do much. Just sitting there in each other's presence was enough. They matched paces with the rainfall. When it was loud and thundering, their conversations were more boisterous and hectic, filled with hectic laughter and energy.

When the rain was gentle and light, their conversations were slower and softer in tone. And when it would stop for a couple of minutes here and there, they'd simply sit in quiet, enveloped in the homey atmosphere.

In those few minutes, Izuku would glance over at Katsuki, and the blonde would just stare up at the ceiling, arms on the sides of the couch as he leans into the seat. The greenette takes this moment to very quietly and subtly lay back, until his head is on Katsuki's lap and his feet are resting up against the ends of the couch.

In those quiet minutes, Katsuki, if he opposes the action, does not say anything. He just looks down at his lap, where a doe eyed boy now lays, and goes back to looking at the ceiling.

The second time Izuku did it, he played with the fabrics of Katsuki's shorts just to have something to do with his hands, while his mind drifts off into some superhero fantasy.

The third time Izuku did it, he softly traces his fingers along the veins of Katsuki's roughened hand, which was resting near his head. Oh, how he wanted to lace their fingers together.

The fourth time Izuku did it, Katsuki without saying a word, nonchalantly brushed his hand through Izuku's green hair. Katsuki had ruffled his hair before, or even tucked a piece behind his ear, but never has the blonde just ran his fingers through it like this.

The short male, startled by the initiation of a touch he wanted so badly, had to catch himself and forced his brain to calm down so that he doesn't move, and ruin the moment. And so instead, Izuku pretends that it didn't affect or surprise him: the way Katsuki's usually rough fingers softly glided through his hair and twirled pieces here and there.

"Your hair isn't as tangled as I thought it'd be, nerd," Even Katsuki's tone was softer than usual.

Izuku smiles gently, "It just looks like it would be, right? I've tried taming it a million times, but pieces just kind of go everywhere, no matter what I do."

Katsuki lifts the corner of his lips as he twirled a piece of green hair, "Yeah?"

Izuku giggles, "Yeah. But I've tried to no avail. I think it makes me look a little ugly and childish, you know what I mean?"

Katsuki tells him then after a moment, "No."

"No to what?" Izuku asks, tapping his fingers on the blonde's knees.

"No, as in," Katsuki says, "I don't know what you mean."

At this, the greenette turns his head slightly to look up at Katsuki with slightly wide eyes, and his face turned slightly red. He was unsure of what to say, and so he says nothing. But the comment sticks on his mind for a long time afterwards.

The conversation they had that one night in the school parking lot after it had rained never left Izuku's mind. And the boy could tell that his words had affected Katsuki as well. These weren't small issues or such that went away overnight.

Things like what they were asking each other required time, patience, and tender care. Izuku had asked Katsuki to be more in tune with his positivity, while the blonde had asked Izuku to be more in tune with his negativity.

But it wasn't as if one conversation can morph someone into a different person overnight. Years of build up and habits will linger in a person's bones for a long time, before they can shake it out.

And yet. In the small ways, Izuku could see that Katsuki was trying, even if it wasn't always perfect. Even if Katsuki wasn't fully aware he was trying. It's in the small acts of openness that Izuku can see that Katsuki was trying to make good of his promise.

When Katsuki talked to him in school unprompted for the first time, Izuku was so shocked he couldn't really say anything back. He shouldn't have been, since he asked for it after all. And yet, when Katsuki approached him during a break and asked about the new episode of this show they watched together, Izuku just stared at him wide eyed, as if he wasn't supposed to be there.

Izuku knew others were watching. And he held contact with those ruby eyes for a while as he tries to decipher the situation. And when he took too long, the blonde rolled his eyes, muttered out a *forget it* and walked away.

That was enough to had pulled Izuku out of his seat, and within minutes, he was no longer questioning anything. He just took up all of Katsuki's space, and babbled on and on, hoping that if he talks excitedly and fast enough, he won't stop to think that wow, Katsuki is trying.

It wasn't perfect. Izuku could tell that the other had his reservations about talking on certain things, or exhibiting certain behaviors. But that was to be expected. They argued. They fought. Katsuki was not suddenly open and sweet. But it was fine.

Besides, it wasn't as if Izuku was perfect either. His automatic reaction for any misdeed would be to make up excuses for it. Maybe they are just tired. Maybe they had a bad day. Maybe they didn't mean it like that.

But to rewire his brain to not accept excuses for being rude was difficult, but necessary.

His first opportunity came when he overheard a conversation walking past two girls saying that they didn't understand why Bakugo Katsuki spent all of his time with Midoriya Izuku, since as far as they knew, the greenette was a 'goodie-two shoes.'

Izuku has always disliked that nickname for him, because it put him in a box that he didn't even build for himself and gave people a preordained image of what he was like. However, he's always just kind of kept quiet and maybe laugh along jokingly when someone would use the nickname in reference to him.

This time, he paused near where they were speaking and his heart sped up. He was not a greatly confrontational person, especially in matters concerning himself. He'd much rather be hurt and avoid conflict, than make someone else feel guilty. But he thought about what Katsuki said, about him allowing himself to get stepped on or never being upset enough when he should be.

And so Izuku turned towards the two girls and with a polite smile, tells them kindly, "Please don't call me that."

It was nice, it was simply and non-aggressive. But it was more than what he would have done in the past. He can both be nice while standing up for himself in situations as such.

In a way, they balanced each other out well, slowly moving towards a point of equilibrium.

Izuku had friends. He had good friends too. But none like Katsuki. None who reached into the little crevices of his mind and pull out aspects of him he didn't know he needed. None who was slowly ditching practically everything but practice and tournaments just to be with him, even if they just spent the evening sitting in Katsuki's room.

Now that he felt like he could walk next to the taller in the hallways, or not hide away when they're in public, or acknowledge each other more than a quick glance or nod, Izuku only knew he was one step closer to being destroyed by this fire.

Katsuki has not gotten any less popular with admirers. If anything, the fact that he hasn't been with anyone in what seemed like a while, made his pursuers even more crazy and adamant. Everyone wanted to be the person that the famed Bakugo Katsuki wanted so badly, that he'd break whatever dry spell he was in. Izuku has heard the pole vaulter's friends ask the blonde too, what was going on. And every time, Katsuki would simply tell them that it wasn't any of their damn business.

And yet, it made him curious as well. He had asked Katsuki that one time; however, the answer wasn't exactly indicative of anything. The greenette felt as if it was a matter of time before his heart shatters again, and so, he wasn't getting his hopes up for anything. After all, maybe Katsuki was simply too focused on the pole vault tournaments that were getting more and more intense. The second regionals tournament had passed during the weeks that had passed, and Katsuki sweeped it. Izuku was not able to go, because he had a required student government meeting the Friday afternoon when it was hosted, but the greenette made sure to watch the footage afterwards.

Izuku also didn't know why he was still agreeing on dates with Kaito. Izuku thinks that he still consciously holds on for an opportunity to forget about Katsuki, even if it's not that successful.

When he kisses Kaito, his brain remembers the taste of Katsuki's lips. When Kaito holds his waist and pulls him closer, his mind recalls the sensation of Katsuki's hands.

When they do anything with each other, risqué or intimate, Izuku only wonders what it would be like with Katsuki.

He knew it was wrong, and that his intentions were not in the right place. And yet, every time Kaito asks to hang out here and there, Izuku's head flashes to the images of the girls or guys who are always on Katsuki, and ends up saying yes when he knew his heart wasn't in it. It wasn't fair to Kaito, nor was it fair to his feelings that were being starved.

It did, however, sometimes feel as if Kaito wasn't exactly being fair to him either. In a way, Izuku had the impression that Kaito wanted Izuku to be a certain type of person, and whenever he would 'break character,' it would make the taller male uncomfortable.

The greenette was surprised that the other hasn't asked him to be officially together yet. Izuku thinks that it was partially because Kaito already knew what Izuku would say.

And yet, the brunette athlete was very nice to him. He was, for the most part, the gentleman that every mother wants their child to bring home. He opened doors for Izuku, paid the bill at restaurants, and was overall, a very polite gentleman without being completely boring.

He had normal hobbies like sports and playing video games in his free time, and was going to go to school to be a lawyer, providing a stable income. Overall, Kaito was a platinum package, and yet, the idea of truly being with him almost felt suffocating to Izuku.

That being said, Izuku agrees to a date that Wednesday, when Kaito messages him saying that the weather was going to be clear tonight, after weeks of rain. They had missed the meteor shower that was supposed to happen weeks prior due to the cloud coverage from rain; however, another one was coming up tonight. Izuku didn't mind the rain though.

It was beautiful, and sometimes, he and Katsuki would just step out into it and just run somewhere. They swam in the rain. Katsuki taught Izuku how to pole vault once more in the rain. They biked around the neighborhood in the rain, stopping by the corner store to grab some snacks. Soggy potato chips were disgusting, but with Katsuki, they didn't seem as bad.

But Izuku guess that is what happens when you're falling in love: everything is just a bit more beautiful.

Kaito had told him that the dress code was casual, which was unusual, since the athlete liked taking Izuku to nice restaurants or just nice places in general, where he had to dress up a little. And so, when Kaito texted Izuku saying that he should just dress casual, Izuku raised

an eyebrow. Were they actually going to do something a little less formal this time? Izuku asks the other where they were headed, and Kaito simply replied ‘a drive-in diner.’

Now, Izuku was even more suspicious. A drive-in diner was definitely not Kaito’s vibe. Drive-in diners were where all types of cars just pulled up to booths, order greasy, messy, but delicious food, and eat it in their cars parked in the cool little place.

It was absolutely not Kaito Sen’s vibe, who preferred the elegance of sit down restaurants with white table clothes and water served in wine glasses. However, Izuku wasn’t complaining. The idea was nice.

When Kaito pulls up to his house, Izuku walks out of the house, still not accustomed to not telling his mother anything as he leaves, and the brunette is dressed in a workout tank and a pair of joggers. And their conversation on the way to the drive-in diner was pretty normal.

The other asked about his week, and Izuku asked him back. They talked about vault for a moment, and Izuku looked out into the sky. It was quickly getting dark, which was the best time to go to a drive-in diner anyways.

When they enter the vicinity of the drive-in diner, Izuku takes in the sight. The night sky seemed even darker when juxtaposed with the neon signs of the place. The cute little building was small, with a neon sign that read Ben’s Burgers & Shakes, and glass panels where people can see all the workers preparing the orders. And on either side of the tiny building were little booths for cars to pull in, right next to a screen displaying the extensive menu of fast food and endless milkshake options.

All of the booths that the cars pulled into were connected by an awning rimmed with pink neon lights, which created a gorgeous glow in the place. The middle section was grass and some cement tables and chairs, in case people wanted to eat on actual tables instead of inside of their cars, but barely anyone was there.

“The mushroom swiss burger here is really good,” Kaito mentions to him, “And the garlic butter fries.”

Izuku takes this into consideration, “Oh really?”

“Yeah,” Kaito laughs, “But I’m not going to order anything that’ll make my breath smell when I’m kissing you.”

Izuku flushes.

Kaito then turns to him, with a slight smile, “Should I not say something so explicit?”

Izuku shakes his head, “No, it’s fine,” He grins, “So what are you going to get then?”

“Hmm,” Kaito thinks then presses the button to order. A voice comes on, asking if they’re ready, and Kaito calls out, “Yeah, can I get an order of regular fries and a butter pecan milkshake? Midoriya, do you know what you want?”

Izuku blinked, “Oh, you barely gave me any time,” He laughed, “But I’ll get some fries too and a cherry garcia milkshake. Medium please.”

Kaito repeated the order, and then rolled his windows back up, sitting back into his seat. The athlete leans his seat back a little and stares out the windshield taking in the nice ambiance with a sigh. Izuku sits in the passenger seat with his knees pulled up to his chest, and watches his date.

“So,” Izuku asked, trying to make conversation, “Is there any particular reason you wanted to go here today? It’s not really our usual vibe.” He laughs.

“No reason,” Kaito says, looking over at Izuku, “Why? Do you not like it?”

“Oh no! I really like this,” Izuku doesn’t mention that he prefers it to expensive restaurants, “It’s cozy.”

“Hm,” Kaito nods, “That’s nice, then.”

Izuku nods as well, unsure of what to say now, “Have you been here before?”

“A couple of times,” Kaito replies, “Usually because my sister drags me.”

“Oh, I didn’t know you had a sister,” Izuku mentions, “Is she older? Younger?”

“Older,” Kaito tells him, “She’s nice. Her name is Yuki. She works in Kyoto, and comes home every couple of months to visit. You should meet her. You’re staying here for college, right?”

Izuku was about to open his mouth to speak, when Kaito nodded to himself and continues.

“That’ll be nice,” The boy makes commentary, “I can take the train back from the city every weekend to see you, and it’ll be easy.”

Izuku’s lips parted and he realized then that he hadn’t even been thinking that far with Kaito, and now that he was, didn’t like the idea that the other assumed that he’d just be in Ise waiting for Kaito to come home and take him somewhere.

“I’m…” Izuku looks down at his hands, feeling odd about his next statement, “...actually thinking about going to Waseda.”

Kaito looked over at him and raised both brows at this, “Waseda?”

Izuku nods, “Yeah! I’ve been thinking about it a lot.”

“Waseda is kind of far,” Kaito announced his observation, “Why don’t you want to stay in Ise? I could come visit you on the weekends.”

“Because,” Izuku frowned, “I really like the career opportunities there for what I want to go into.”

Kaito nods to himself, “Are you sure it’s not because Bakugo is going to school in Tokyo?”

“What?” Izuku felt like this conversation was going the wrong direction, “Why would it be?”

“I don’t know,” Kaito moves his head from side to side, “Maybe because you seem to want to be near him all the time? And it’s just so convenient that you’ve seem to have planned on staying in Ise for so long, and in the past couple of months, you suddenly want to go to Waseda?”

Izuku looks down at his lap, brows furrowed, “Kaito, you know I am my own person, right? I can have aspirations too, that have nothing to do with Kacchan, or you, or anyone else. I didn’t suddenly want to go to Waseda. I have just gained…” Izuku bit his lip, “confidence in what I want. Is that so bad?”

Kaito frowns, “Of course not. That’s good, I guess. But you’d understand why I’m concerned, right?”

Izuku snaps at him, “Kaito, please stop assuming everything I do is because of him. I hate how you pull him up in every conversation.”

“Fine, I’m sorry,” Kaito puts both of his hands up. Izuku disliked how the blonde came up at least once every time they hang out. As if Izuku didn’t think about Katsuki enough as it was.

“It’s fine,” Izuku sighed.

Kaito looks over at the side, out the window from across where they were parked, and then back at Izuku. The athlete leaned over, bringing one hand over to lift Izuku’s chin so that those beautiful green eyes were looking straight at Kaito’s gray ones. Izuku looked up at the boy.

“Let me express my apologies this way,” Kaito said before leaning down to pull Izuku into a kiss. It definitely took Izuku off guard, because of how random it was.

And yet, Kaito seemed very passionate about it, and this was not just a quick peck, but a deep kiss. In less than ten seconds, the athlete’s hands was around his jaw and top park of Izuku’s neck, holding his head firmly, as he takes Izuku’s lips onto his own.

Just going with the flow that seemed absolutely out of nowhere, Izuku kissed back, seeing how much Kaito seemed to be into it. The boy’s lips were definitely soft, and Izuku was getting used to the sensation of Kaito’s mouth. The athlete did like to kiss him a lot when they go out together, amongst other things.

And so, now, as they wait for their food, Kaito was practically going heavy for his lips, and Izuku was running out of oxygen.

He pulled away for a second, and Kaito utilyzed that time to go for his jaw, placing kisses along Izuku's soft skin, while Kaito's hand move from the base of his neck and down to his shoulders.

Kaito brushed aside part of Izuku's shirt, so that his shoulder was exposed, and the other's hands were massaging the skin of his right shoulder while kissing his neck, not leaving any marks. Izuku held onto Kaito's biceps, as he wonders what was Kaito moving so quickly for. This was usually fast, even for them.

Right when he was about to ask, the brunette came back up and locked lips with Izuku once more, biting down on the greenette's bottom lip so that it would swell up, and Izuku whimpered out in a slight pain that was more enjoyable when Katsuki did it. Immediately, once he whimpered, Kaito pushed his tongue down Izuku's throat, which also surprised the other, but in a moment of heat and confusion, Izuku just went with it. Meanwhile, Kaito's hands was pushing down on Izuku's shirt, trying to reveal more skin.

And he would have succeeded if several whoops and hollers didn't erupt from outside of the car, effectively scaring Izuku and making the shorter male jump slightly in his seat. Kaito back off him, but oddly enough, didn't bother to look at who was there and instead, looked over at Izuku.

Izuku, however, was shocked by the sudden intrusion of sound, and so he turned his head. And his heart immediately began to beat faster, because from across the parking lot, now coming onto the grass in the middle with all of the cement tables was the group of pole vaulters from Ise High. And they were hollering and whistling at the show that Kaito just practically gave them.

Denki Kaminari cupped his hands around his mouth and yelled out as the group got closer, "Kaito Sennnn! Get some, my man!"

Izuku's face flushed, and he looked over at Kaito, who didn't seem too bothered by it. The boy in question rolls down the windows, as some people approached. But Izuku was a bit overwhelmed and confused.

First of all, what was everyone doing here. Second of all, he literally just had Kaito's hands all over him and his mouth thoroughly explored as the group of pole vaulters are pulling up?

Thirdly, fucking hell, Bakugo Katsuki was with them. Izuku knew that Katsuki was busy tonight, but he didn't know it was going to be with his team.

Izuku spots Katsuki emerging from the car last, as the driver of a couple of the team members. They had to take three cars, in order to fit all the team, and they parked in the booths, before getting out.

And when he gets out, Izuku feels bile rising up to his chest. The blonde was wearing a simple white t-shirt that hugged his figure and black basketball shorts, and he immediately made eye contact with Izuku, whose face was still shocked by the sudden intrusion.

Katsuki had no expression on his face as he steps out of the car and pockets his keys, but as he walked across the grass, the blonde simply raises a brow before looking over at Kaito and then back at him.

Izuku then finds the will to look away from that piercing stare, and his brain travels back to that night in the guest bedroom when the taller had expressed obvious jealousy regarding Kaito. That knowledge made Izuku feel both smug and hopeful.

“Hey Midoriya!” Kirishima waved to him then nodded towards Kaito through the window when the group arrived, “Kaito, dude! You said you weren’t coming to the team dinner tonight, but you ended up coming here anyways? Didn’t you say you were sick of this place?”

Izuku looked over at Kaito strangely. And the boy in question seemed to understand that something was revealed that he didn’t mean to, for the brunette just shrugged nonchalantly while refusing to look in Izuku’s direction.

Izuku wasn’t stupid. He got it now. He knew exactly why Kaito took him here, even though he was apparently sick of this place, even though this wasn’t the type of establishment the other liked to frequent. He knew that this was where the pole vault team was going to be, particularly Bakugo Katsuki, and wanted them to be here to see this.

Izuku wasn’t sure whether or not to feel angry, annoyed, or oddly grateful for the opportunity to gauge that reaction on Katsuki’s face. He was sure he felt all three. Kaito’s jealousy was surely going to become a bigger problem, and Izuku needed to handle that fire before it gets out of hand.

“I didn’t say that,” Kaito denied, placing his right hand on Izuku’s left thigh.

Izuku wondered if he should move it, or would he be complicit furthermore and see where this could go.

From the side, a very aggressive and deep voice spoke up, and Izuku knew who it was right away.

“You definitely fucking did,” Katsuki Bakugo tells Kaito, and Izuku sees the blonde glance down to the hand that was casually resting on his thigh, thumbs moving to slide over Izuku’s soft skin. Katsuki continued, “So tell us, Fuck Face, why are you here if you’re so sick of this place, huh?”

Kaito was silent, simply staring blankly at Katsuki, who awaits his answer. Izuku sits in the passenger seat, feeling a bit awkward, even though it seemed like everyone else viewed the interaction as normal.

Kaito ultimately shrugged, “I thought Midoriya might like it. Now move Bakugo, you’re in the way of the waiter. He’s gonna get us our food soon,” Kaito tells him. Izuku’s eyes widened at the tone.

Katsuki raised a brow then turned to the group of vaulters, “Did you hear him, guys? We’re in the fucking way. Let’s get a move on so that Mr. Gentleman over here doesn’t throw a pissy fit.”

“Awh come on, Bakugo,” Kirishima attempted to put an arm around Katsuki’s shoulder, “Don’t be like that. Let’s go order.”

Katsuki snorts, “I ain’t hungry.”

Kaito, not okay with losing the last word, sticks his head out the window and calls out, “Why? Did something make you lose your appetite? You should order something sweet. That’s what I’m getting” Kaito knew exactly what he was implying, and Katsuki paused in his steps.

Izuku’s eyes widened at the odd implication, and he was about to tell Kaito to be quiet.

But Katsuki turned around, expression extremely annoyed, before glancing over at Izuku, and back at Kaito, “You want to give me some advice? How fucking kind. I’ll give you some back,” And then nodded his head in Izuku’s direction, “Next time, Fuck Face, try not to attack his fucking throat like a dog. Have some class. Maybe then, you might actually make him feel good.”

Kaito was quiet, but Izuku knew he was embarrassed.

“Kacchan!” Izuku said, “What is wrong with you.”

“Nothing,” Katsuki shrugs lazily, “Just looking out for you, Deku. You want to have a good time, don’t you?”

Izuku didn’t like the way Katsuki was speaking, giving Kaito advice as if he didn’t care, even if there was venom in his tone. There was clear anger in the blonde’s voice, laced with annoyance.

Right then, a waiter came out with their order, and Katsuki nonchalantly walked away with his hands in his pockets towards where all of the vaulters were, all ordering or sitting on top of the hoods of their cars, hanging out and laughing.

Izuku took his order of fries and milkshake, and Kaito did the same. And it was quiet in the car for a moment, as Izuku tries to process everything and figure out what he wanted to say next. He knew Kaito was waiting for him to say anything, and Izuku revelled in the fact that Kaito was nervous next to him.

“So this is why we are here,” Izuku finally says, eating a fry and sipping out of his shake. His tone was casual, and he thinks that almost scared Kaito more.

Kaito took a sip from his drink as well and looked over at Izuku, “Midoriya, look. I-”

“It was a nice show you put on,” Izuku smiled at him sarcastically with his eyes, “That was for Kacchan to see, right? You knew he was coming.”

Kaito leaned his head back, closed his eyes, and sighed, “I didn’t.”

“Oh, you didn’t?” Izuku felt almost angry that Kaito was trying to lie, “Then let’s go hang out with them. You were supposed to be with them here tonight, anyways right? We might as well join.”

Kaito looked opposed to the idea, “Why? We’re on a date. Let’s just stay in her-”

“So you can try to prove something in front of Kacchan again?” Izuku looks at him funny, before opening the car door, “No thank you. Let’s go, Kaito.”

“Shit,” Kaito muttered under his breath, and pulled Izuku’s wrist, “Are you mad at me?”

Izuku didn’t even know how to answer that. He knew he was upset, except finding a healthy way to express that and embrace it was a new concept for him. And so he was halfway through climbing out of the car, and just looked back at Kaito, whose eyes were swimming with apology and fear.

And Izuku knew that progress can only happen so fast. He was accustomed to giving people infinite chances, and so, it wouldn’t be too bad if he limited it to one more right? One more, and none after this.

“I’m…” Izuku finds the words, “...a little upset, yeah. But just give me a couple of days after tonight, okay? I need you to stop thinking that we are already together, and you have the right to do things like that,” He was afraid he was coming off as too aggressive, so he tacks on a, “Do you kind of understand why?”

Kaito looks at him, as if he wanted Izuku to be much easier about it and just let him slide now, and then finally nods, “Yeah.”

“Good,” Izuku smiles at him softly, then nods, “Come on. Let’s hang out with them.”

Given the ultimatum, Kaito complies and gets out of the car following Izuku, until they were over in the grassy area where the pole vaulters had ditched their cars and were hanging out with their food tickets in hand, waiting for someone to bring their orders outside.

Katsuki sat on top of a table, rather than in the seat, as he would. And friends were just all around having fun. Kaito joined the group sheepishly, and Izuku just sat down and entered the conversation. Kaito and Katsuki did not talk for the remainder of whatever time they all spent there.

And Izuku and Katsuki don’t talk much either, but the greenette will consider that a good thing, because it meant that maybe Kaito won’t have as much shit to base his hypotheses on.

The group of pole vaulters were fun, and Izuku knew them pretty well, considering he watches the sport and their practice pretty closely. And they liked him a lot too.

It was rarely ever a bad time when they all hung out as a group, since Izuku considers most of them his friends, aside from one or two that he hasn’t really talked to. Katsuki made comments here and there throughout the conversation, but overall, just seemed to sit back and

mouth the lyrics of the music playing from the outdoor speakers of the drive-in diner, nodding his head along.

It was Keep Me Hanging On by Kim Wilde, and Izuku finds himself singing the lyrics as well, catching Katsuki's attention. He always gravitated towards the blonde, no matter where he went.

"You know this one?" Katsuki asks him.

Izuku nods, smiling, "Yeah, Kim Wilde, right? That one British lady."

Katsuki nods, "Ain't it funny how so many of the classic American hits are sung by British bands or singers?"

Izuku thinks about it, "Hmm, WHAM!, Kim Wilde, Queen, Paul McCartney. Yeah, you're right."

"Of course I am," Katsuki leans back on his arms, "I'm always fucking right."

Izuku rolls his eyes playfully, "But it's still mostly American artists."

"Yeah, whatever," Katsuki leans forward again to flick Izuku on the forehead, "Anyways, you ditching your date?" Katsuki gestures over to Kaito, who was in a conversation with another teammate.

"Yes, help me run away," Izuku jokingly says, laughing.

The blonde shrugs his shoulders, "Just say the word, and I'll whisk you outta here."

Izuku leaned forward on his elbow, while sitting on the bench of the cement table, and sipped his milkshake while grinning, "You're a bad captain."

"I am?" Katsuki raised a brow with a sly grin, "Tell me more, Deku. How so."

"You're gonna abandon your teammates and take me somewhere?" Izuku sipped some more, while smiling up at the blonde.

Katsuki looks down at him, watching his movement, and chuckles, "I guess that'd be irresponsible of me, wouldn't it."

"Very," Izuku teases him.

"Then I guess you're stuck with Fuck Face, and I'm stuck with my shitty team," Katsuki wrinkled his nose.

The ambiance, if Izuku deletes that uncomfortable sequence of the night earlier out of his mind, was nice at the current moment. There was a light pink glow washing over the grass, from the awning lined with pink neon lights.

Everytime the little diner opened the door so that the waiters can go out to the cars and deliver the food, he could hear the plates clinking or the employees talking. And around them, all gathered up on the tables, seats, or even just sitting in the grass, everyone was just talking to each other over some music.

At some point, Kaito came to talk to him again, and Katsuki had rolled his eyes but ultimately just walked off to talk to some other people. By the time Kaito came to him once more, Izuku was a little more cooled off, and they had a conversation that was mostly normal. Some others joined their discussion, so it wasn't as awkward. And for a while, everyone just kind of hung around, eating their food and just talking.

Ultimately, when the drive-in diner was closing, someone had suggested they just leave their cars there for a little bit and go on a stroll to walk off the food.

Just following the feel of the crowd, everyone agreed and just got up from their spots after throwing away their trash, and the whole group just went on a stroll. There wasn't much in the area, since the drive-in diner was a little bit out of the way, so they ended up just walking along the gravel roads of Ise.

Just a big group of people, in what felt like the middle of the night. The amber street lamps lit up the streets, and if they looked up, they can see the swarm of bugs that were attracted to the light. The crickets were drowned out by laughter, as the group of friends just enjoyed each other's company.

Kaito made sure to walk side by side with Izuku. And so they just walked for a little while, until they saw some buildings here and there. It was all quiet, like the rest of Ise at night.

All, if not most, of the buildings in Ise just looked a little abandoned at night. There were no cars parked or any sign of life. And everything was casted in that same amber colored glow from the street lamps. It felt like a toy city, if Izuku were being honest. And so they just walked past the buildings, and talked all kinds of stupid shit.

Ultimately, Katsuki stopped in front of a thin structure, and looked up. Its appearance was like a bell tower, made completely out of wood and iron. The tower was extremely thin, and cylindrical in shape.

The wood looked like it was worn down, and the door was locked. At the top was a bell that looked crack and stopped ringing a long time ago. It looked utterly creepy at night, all abandoned like this.

"That's the old bell tower, right?" Sero asked, tilting his head up to look at the place, "My dad said it's not really in use anymore, but when he was young, he and his friends would sneak in and climb all the way to the top."

Katsuki turned his head and raised a brow at Sero, "Did he, now."

"Oh no. Don't get any ideas, Bakugo," Sero shook his head with a grin, "I know how you are."

“Then you’ll know that I ain’t gonna fucking listen to you,” Katsuki grinned, and turned to the group, “Anyone got a bobby pin?”

Izuku watched from the sides, and Mina took one out of her hair and tossed it over to Katsuki, “I got one, but I’m not going in with you.”

“Fine by me,” Katsuki shrugged as he begins working on the lock that was outside, “Anyone coming in?”

The group looked a little uneasy. It was definitely dark and probably creepy in the tower. It would be hard to see, plus who knew the condition of the stairs.

Besides, the area was a little haunting, considering that not a soul was in sight and every store window or so was pitch black, but the outside was lit up in an eerie yellow light from the street lamps. Izuku knew his answer immediately, but didn’t want to seem too eager so he waited to see if anyone else wanted to tag along.

When it seems as if no one else was up for it, Izuku just kind of laughs lightly, “You already know I will.”

Katsuki, at this, looks up at him with a grin and says, “Attaboy.”

From beside him, Kaito jumps in, “I’m not sure if that’s a good idea.”

“You think so?” Katsuki asked his teammate, although his tone didn’t actually sound like he gave a shit.

“I was talking to Midoriya,” Kaito tells Katsuki, then turns towards Izuku, “It could be dangerous. The steps might not be stable, and who knows what’s in there.”

Izuku was about to protest, when Katsuki piped up, still working on opening the lock.

“Answer me this, Fuck Face,” Katsuki says, “You think I can manage?”

“Huh?” Kaito looked annoyed at the interruption.

“You think I can handle going up there? Be honest,” Katsuki asked, picking at the wooden door.

Kaito sighed irritatedly, “Yes. *You* can. But D-”

“Then think the same about Deku, you shithead,” Katsuki tells him straight up, “Did you not fucking see him at the kick-off? The shitty nerd could beat your ass any second if he wanted to. What makes you think you have the right to try and protect him? Don’t treat him like a child.” Katsuki firmly says, and clicks the lock open.

And then, the blonde looks over at Izuku, “But you don’t need me to speak for you, right Shitnerd? Tell him yourself.” He nodded towards Kaito, annoyed.

Izuku felt a swell of pride at Katsuki's acknowledgement of his capability, and it sometimes felt as if Katsuki was the only  person in the world that realized his capability and didn't treat him as if he couldn't handle himself. He's had enough of that at home.

Nodding, wanting to be more kind simply because that was who he was, Izuku turned towards Kaito and nodded nicely, "Kaito, thank you for your concern. Really. But I'll be fine."

Kaito looked hesitant, even though he really had no say in the matter. He wasn't Izuku's boyfriend, and even if he was, still had no say in Izuku's personal decisions. But ultimately, the boy knew his place and just let the matter drop.

"Alright, stay safe," Then Kaito asked the group, who was off in their own conversations anyways, "Is everyone heading back then?"

"Yeah, it's getting late anyways," Kirishima responded, and the general group started slowly walking back.

Meanwhile, Katsuki stood in the doorway, holding the wooden door open with pitch black behind him, and Izuku was walking towards the blonde when Kaito stopped him and pulled him back. Reaching down, Kaito gave Izuku a short but deep kiss, before pulling away and nodding towards Bakugo.

"Are you getting him home?" Kaito asked.

"No shit. You think I'm letting him walk?" Katsuki asked, voice irritated.

Kaito didn't even bother replying to that, and Izuku almost felt sorry for the other for always being on the bad end of Katsuki's attitude.

When it was just the two of them, Izuku lets out a breath and peers through the doorway behind Katsuki. It actually did look terrifying, considering it was pitch black inside. A pair of eyes could be watching them from inside, and they'd never know.

"This is kind of scary, you know," Izuku commented.

Katsuki looked back and then opened the doorway widely, and a creaking sound echoed from within, "Oi, you want me to be honest about something?"

"I mean," Izuku giggled, "Honesty is always a good thing."

Katsuki nods his head, and peers into the darkness, "I'm so fucking glad you volunteered, because this is scary, you're damn right."

"Woahh," Izuku teased, to ease the mood, "Kacchan, you admit it?"

"This is exactly the reason why I don't admit shit to you," Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"No, No!" Izuku waved his arms, "I didn't mean to! I will never tease you again"

“For that, I’m going to make you go first,” Katsuki nudged him in.

Izuku stared into the dark. They would need to use their flashlights, and since it was a small cylindrical bell tower, it would not be very hard to find the spiral stair steps. However, it was pitch black in there, and who knows when the last time someone was in the rusty tower.

Not to mention, it was completely quiet at night, with mannequins in the windows of the nearby stores staring blankly out onto the yellow tinted streets.

Izuku then looked up at Katsuki, with pleading eyes. There was no way in hell he was going first, not when it was Katsuki’s idea.

“Don’t fucking look at me with those creepy ass e-,” Then Katsuki breathed out exasperated, “Fuck! Fine. I’ll go.”
“I’d like to remind you that this was your idea, and it’s not too late to join the group,” Izuku pokes at Katsuki.

“Hell no,” Katsuki shakes his head, “I started it. I’ll finish it.”

And with that, the blonde begins to venture inside, stepping into the darkness and being surrounded by the abyss. Izuku was quick to follow behind, not liking how eerie it was to be standing outside alone. The tower smelled like old wood and dust, which made sense considering the place hasn’t been used in a hot minute.

They both turned their flashlights on, and small beams of white light erupt from their phones, with enough power to illuminate only tiny portions at a time. Every way they’d point their flashlights, it would be just more gray wood or some spider webs.

Izuku was a little scared that if he moves his light a little too fast, he might see something scary or some figure will run fast. After all, it was quite dark and they were being relatively silent. Izuku stayed closer behind, always close enough that Katsuki was within finger distance. He could smell the blonde’s sugary cologne from where he was.

It was easy to find the stairs, since they were in a small circular room. All he had to do was walk the circumference to find them, and the stairs spiraled all the way up the tower. Outside, the wind blew here and there, creating some ghostly noises from within the tower.

And so, Katsuki began the ascent slowly, making sure to gauge each stair step with his body weight in order to make sure it wasn’t going to collapse. For the most part, the stairs looked fine.

There didn’t seem to be a lot of wood rottage, so the floorboards were intact. The only problem was that sometimes, the steps were uneven and it would suddenly get higher or lower than the step before.

“Watch your step. This one is uneve-” Katsuki had began, but he wasn’t able to finish his sentence before Izuku’s breath hitched, as he slightly loses balance.

Focused on staying close, Izuku had barely been paying attention to the commentary, and in a moment of panic, lost but then regained his balance moments later. His heart beat fast after he gripped onto the side railing and felt secure enough. One fall backwards and he would definitely break a couple of things coming down.

Katsuki offered additional support by gripping his wrist and keeping him in place while Izuku calms down. The greenette looks up at the blonde, whose expression was evidently worried.

“Oi nerd, I told you to watch your step,” Katsuki’s tone was uneven, “Are you alright?” Izuku nodded his head to reassure the other, “I’m okay! Just lost my balance for a second. Don’t worry about me, Kacchan!”

Katsuki just looked at him, the residual flashlight beams showing a slight humored yet incredulous expression, before the athlete just goes, “Get in front of me.”

And Katsuki steps back in order to allow Izuku forward, and he repeats, “The steps are sturdy enough. So get in front of me. If you slip again, I’ll be able to catch you, since I’m bigger.”

Katsuki’s hand was on the small of his back then, guiding him forward and Izuku felt pushed along, so he went up the stairs slightly in front of Katsuki, but looked back on the taller.

Even though Izuku was on higher steps, Katsuki from very close behind was still taller than him. And so when Izuku turns his head, he was looking straight up at the athlete, with Katsuki’s hands moving from his back to around his waist to stabilize him.

“And what if you fall, Kacchan?” Izuku asked, blinking up at the handsome male.

Katsuki was so close, that Izuku could practically smell the nice strawberry mint from the other’s lips, and he said in a low voice, “I won’t. Start walking.”

Izuku still kept asking questions, “Are you going to be…” His breath quickened, “...this close the entire time?”

Katsuki raised a brow at the question, “Why. You want me to back off?” Katsuki then bent down a little bit to whisper with a growl in Izuku’s ear, “You didn’t seem to have a problem being real fucking close with Fuck Face, earlier.”

“That’s…” Izuku felt hot from his core, “That’s different.”

“Oh? Is it?” Katsuki chuckled, and once again, his arms reached out and held Izuku’s waist from behind, and more quickly than not, Izuku was pressed into the side of the wall, and the greenette let out a confused yelp.

They were on a thin set of a stairs, who knows how high up, with no banister, and Katsuki had pushed Izuku’s front side against the wall, and pressed up real close from behind, hands tightly gripping the boy’s waist and his lips near Izuku’s ear.

“K-Kacchan?” Izuku feels the heat in his core get stronger, as he tries to figure out what was going on. It was so incredibly clear how sexual their positioning was.

“I want to know,” Katsuki’s hands slipped under his shirt, massaging his thumbs into Izuku’s bare skin, while the athlete’s lips buried itself in Izuku’s soft hair, “how it’s different. Tell me, Deku, is it because you’re just that into him?”

Izuku continues to be pressed up against the wall, body heat on body heat, and he breathes heavily, shaking his head, “T-That’s not it.”
“No?” Katsuki sounded satisfied, “I guess that’s good enough for me, then.” The blonde says before letting him go.

Izuku turns around right away, until his front was facing Katsuki’s front, and Izuku looks up to hold the other’s eye contact. They were always like this, and Izuku was going absolutely insane. Katsuki cannot just touch him like that, and then let him go as if it was nothing. Their game of push and pull was torture.

“You’re really weird, you know that Kacchan?” Izuku finally said, before shaking his head and continuing their trudge forward. He turned his face away, so that he could blush in peace.

His body reacted so well to Katsuki, it was almost embarrassing. If the blonde told him to get on all fours right then and there and spread his legs so that Katsuki could fuck him on the staircase, he probably would have given in.

From behind, Katsuki chuckled but followed closely, “You just followed me into this haunted looking bell tower, and you think I’m the only weird one?”

Izuku grinned from a short distance ahead, “That’s fair.”

They reached the top about five minutes later, considering that the bell tower was just a spiral incline the entire way up. And the little passageway up into the bell part was dark and narrow, but when they emerged, the two of them were greeted with fresh air that didn’t smell like old wood and books, and a haunting view.

The bell looked cracked and like it hadn't been used in forever, and the panoramic open views on all sides of the bell revealed some of the outlet strips and buildings on this side of Ise that is like a ghost town the moment it hits 5 in the evening.

Suddenly the boutiques, restaurants, and every other shop locks its doors for the night, and there isn’t a single person in sight. The street lamps made all of the buildings the same color, and it had the vibe that the dolls from the storefronts will begin walking out onto the lonely road and stare up at them. Or maybe the trees will become alive and saunter on the road.

They were high up, but it still felt like someone would appear from behind them on the bell tower any second now. Izuku stays close to Katsuki, who climbs onto the ledge and sits there.

His legs were dangling off of the bell tower, and he leans his back against the side of the open arch. Izuku follows and does the same, sitting down right next to the blonde. He stares out onto the sight below him.

“Kacchan, do you believe in ghost stories?” Izuku asked, staring intently at a mannequin through a window, as if he expected it to move.

“Nah,” The athlete replied, “But I heard a boy died here back in the 50s from a horse accident. If you call out his name, he’ll appear or some shit.”

“A horse accident?” Izuku laughs, “That’s kind of random.”

“Oh, you think it’s funny?” Katsuki grins, “Should I call out his name?”

Izuku shakes his head, “Noo. Don’t do it.”

Katsuki cups his hands around his mouth and shouts into the open air below them, “Jack, Jack! Come out to play. Jack, Jack! We’re here to stay.”

Izuku was trying to remove his hands from his mouth the entire time, as Katsuki continued to shake him off, “Kacchan, that’s so creepy!”

Katsuki laughed as Izuku lightly slapped him on the arm, “Keep an eye out, Deku. You might see him.”

Izuku sits back in his seat and sticks out his tongue, “I’d rather watch the meteor shower.”

“Oh shit,” Katsuki remembers, “That’s tonight, right? When are peak viewing hours?”

“It should be soon, and last until morning,” Izuku stares up at the clear sky. It was a beautiful night to go watch, especially considering Ise had practically no light pollution.

And so they wait. In the meantime, the two boys swing their feet over the bell tower. To be honest, anyone passing through the area would probably be terrified of the two random boys who were sitting on top of the old bell tower ominously like that, than they would be of anything else. Izuku and Katsuki made a deal that if any car walks past, they will go still and stare at the car the entire time it’s passing by just to scare the shit out of them.

“Oh!” Izuku just remembered as some point in the night, “I just remembered. I haven’t been able to find my Eraserhead sweatpants, which sucks because I really love those.” Izuku pouted.

Katsuki rolls his eyes, “They’re in my laundry, idiot. Here. From now on, if something goes missing, just fucking assume you left it at my place.”

Izuku’s eyes widened, “Wait, is it really? I’m sorry!”

“‘Ts fine,” Katsuki shrugged, “But forreal, just move into my damn guest room if you’re gonna come over and leave shit everywhere all the time.”

“Don’t tempt me,” Izuku laughs a little sadly.

Katsuki, for being emotionally deaf as he can be, picks up the fluctuation in Izuku’s voice, and asks, “Is shit at home still not good, nerd?”

Izuku purses his lips, and looks down at his lap, suddenly feeling the conversation shift into a more somber territory, “My mom hasn’t talked to me in weeks.”

Katsuki’s eyes seemed surprised at this, and then looked away, almost seeming a little guilty, “Was the argument that bad?”

Izuku hadn’t really talked about it since that night, not really wanting to rehash the whole situation. But now that it’s been a little bit, it still hurt but not as badly to finally talk about it.

Biting his lip, Izuku sighed, “You were right, you know.”
Katsuki looked over at him, waiting for an explanation.

“You were right,” Izuku said again, voice quieter, “about everything. I completely lost it, and...and I wasn’t able to control myself at all. And it felt good, and she deserved to hear it. But...now, everything in the house feels like it’s suffocating me.” Izuku wanted to tear up again thinking about it, but he was sure he had ran his tears dry by now.

Katsuki was quiet.

And so Izuku just continued, still quiet, “I hate the tension in our house, but...I can’t be complacent anymore,” And he looked over at Katsuki, smiling gently, “You hate complacent people, right? I won’t be complacent anymore.”

Katsuki looked conflicted, as if thinking to himself, before staring down at his lap in a way Izuku hadn’t really seen him do before, “Nerd.”

Izuku tilted his head, “Hm?”

Katsuki seemed hesitant but says so anyways, as he plays with a splintered piece of wood between his lap, “I was harsher than I intended to be that night, okay?” He pauses, “Deku, at this point, you can steal my car, and I probably wouldn’t hate you, alright? Don’t let it get to your head.”

Izuku’s eyes widened, and he immediately recognized this as Katsuki’s shitty attempt to be more open with Izuku. It was an attempt nevertheless, and Izuku wasn’t about to ruin the moment, and so he treated it casually.

“You’d let me steal your car?” Izuku tried to joke, “That’s a little intense, Kacchan.”
“I didn’t say I’d let you,” Katsuki points out the discrepancy, “You will most definitely get tackled and I will consider beating the shit out of you, but I won’t hate you.” He chuckles.

“That’s very generous of you,” Izuku sarcastically plays around, and smiles to himself.

“That’s what I’m known for,” Katsuki patted his own firm chest, “Being generous.”

“Of course, of course,” Izuku nods along, “Are you ready for the last regionals?”

During these next regionals, Katsuki will likely jump near his record height. Which should still be easy for the other, since his unofficial record was higher than his official one. Katsuki had been really grinding on his practice lately, and yet, still finds time to hang out with Izuku. The greenette tries not to feel too special that he was practically the only person Katsuki hung out with this often.

“As ready as I’ll ever be,” Katsuki shrugs, and runs a hand through his hair then looked over at Izuku, leaning closer, “Remember what I told you last time.”

“Hm?” Izuku asked.

“Wear my jersey,” Katsuki tells him, reaching a hand out to tilt Izuku’s chin up, looking at the boy, before dropping his hand, “I want to see you wearing my name.”

Izuku didn’t know what prompted him to be so bold, but he laughs, making a joke, “Ask me to marry you, then.”

Katsuki seemed surprised at that joke, for the blonde looked over at him with raised brows. Izuku, when he realized how odd that jest was, began blushing, and he looked away, about to apologize.

“Bakugo Deku, huh,” Katsuki ponders the name, “I can’t tell if that has a nice ring or what.”

Izuku gaped at him, “My name isn’t Deku, Kacchan. And who said I’ll be taking your last name?” And then he added, “Er...in this hypothetical world.”

“I did,” Katsuki barks out a laugh.

“You’re so unfair,” Izuku nudged him, before looking up, surprised, “Oh!”

Katsuki turned over to him, to see that Izuku was staring elsewhere, and followed suit.

Izuku’s eyes were pointed towards the sky, and they sparkled as he spots the first meteor. Excitedly, Izuku bounces in his seat and points up, “Kacchan, Kacchan! A meteor just passed, did you see it?”

Katsuki reached out to grip his arm, stabilizing him, “Oi nerd, calm down. You’re gonna fall off the tower.”

Izuku just laughs out loud, “I’m sorry. I just...never seen a meteor before.”

Katsuki tilts his head up to stare up at the sky, and after another moment or so, a meteor passed. This time, both of them saw it, and Izuku bursted out into laughter again, amazed by

how beautiful it was.

That beautiful laughter filled the air, and when the meteors start to increase in frequency, Izuku had a permanent smile lit up on his face. It was blinding, and Izuku felt happy. A lot of things were going on in his life that were difficult to navigate, but in moments like this, Izuku could trade all of those stressors in for these hours of pure happiness. His eyes were glued to the sky, mesmerized.

“Make as many wishes as you can. There’s a shit ton of meteors,” Katsuki tells him, “Fast cars, big house, successful career, for your mom to stop being a bitch. Wish for it all.”

Izuku giggles, “If only it were that easy, huh.”

Katsuki chuckles, “If only.”

Izuku continues to sit there for a while, eyes trained on the heavens, watching as streaks of light move across the cosmos. And it feels like if he reaches out, he could grab one and keep it in his pocket to stare at later.

He knew his grin stretched across his face, but he couldn’t help it. It was so beautiful, and he was just incredibly happy. Izuku lets out a happy sigh, before he feels as if he was being looked at. Looking over at the side, Izuku caught Katsuki’s eyes, that looked at him oddly.

The expression on Katsuki’s face was strange, but Izuku kept the eye contact.

Grinning curiously with his head tilted to the side, Izuku asked, “Kacchan? Is something wrong?”

Katsuki breaks off his gaze, and stares back up at the sky again.

Izuku adds, pointing a finger, “And before you say no, remember what you promised me! You need to tell me what you’re feeling.”

Katsuki only slightly grins, but it looked as if his head was plagued with thoughts. Thoughts that Izuku had no access to. Not being able to know what Katsuki was thinking sometimes drove him insane.

After a moment, Katsuki turned towards him, and stares at his freckles some more, and then his eyes.

“What’s wrong?” Katsuki thinks on it, before declaring, “Everything…” He takes another deep look at Izuku, exploring all of the boy’s features, almost making the boy in question shy in his seat, “And yet, nothing at all.”

Izuku looks at the athlete funny, “You’re still being cryptic you know.”

Katsuki looks over to the side then, still with a slight grin on his face, “I know.”

Izuku just accepts it, because he knew that there will always be things that are difficult to say. And looked as if whatever Katsuki was thinking felt difficult for the blonde to say. And so he

just leaves it at that for now. And he goes back to looking at the meteor shower.

He wanted to scoot closer to Katsuki. He wanted to kiss Katsuki under these stars, and have the blonde hold him. But he'll take what he can get for now.

Izuku is nudged awake at some point in the night, more like morning. And Izuku's eyes blinked slowly as he came to consciousness. Izuku sits up, and there is an arm stabilizing him greatly, and he figures out why when his brain catches up to his vision. He was still sitting on the edge of the bell tower, and the reminder caused him to jump back, and Katsuki held him steady.

"Easy," Katsuki tells him, voice groggy.

Izuku calms down when he remembers where he was, and realizes that he must have slowly fell asleep at some point while watching the meteor shower. It was still dark outside, the meteors were still falling, and Izuku looked at his position. He had fallen asleep, and Katsuki must have pulled him closer so that the blonde could keep an arm around him so that he didn't fall, and allow Izuku's head to rest on his shoulders. Izuku's heart beat faster. It was small acts like this that forced him deeper in his well of affection.

"What time is it?" Izuku asked, voice still laced with exhaustion.

Katsuki checks his phone, "4 in the morning."

Izuku's eyes widened, "I've been sleeping here for that long? I'm so sorry."

"It's fine," Katsuki tells him, "Did you enjoy the meteor?"

The greenette nodded profusely, "Yeah!"

"Then that's good enough," Katsuki shrugs, "Are you ready to head back?"

Izuku nodded slowly, "Yeah. I'm really tired."

Katsuki grins and gets off the ledge, helping Izuku with it. The way down the stairs was a lot easier, since they knew all the steps were sturdy, and didn't feel the need to be ultra careful. Katsuki walked ahead, allowing the groggier Izuku to place a hand on the athlete's strong shoulders for support.

And when they got down the ground, the walk back was quiet, but in a nice way. Izuku didn't feel pressured to talk all the time, because he knew it was important sometimes to just be in each other's company without saying anything else in the space between them.

And when they got back to the empty Drive-In Diner parking lot, all the lights were off, but Katsuki's black car was parked in the corner and Izuku climbed in.

He immediately felt his eyes get heavy, and he could barely pay attention when the car turns on and begins driving off, playing In Too Deep by Genesis.

The soft melody filled the car, and the lights of Ise passed by him in a blur as Izuku feels himself drifting back to sleep. The car ride could have been ten minutes, and it could have been an hour. Time was relative when he was this tired.

When he pulls up on the familiar street of his house, Izuku was going in and out of sleep. But he heard when he door opened, and the greenette was about to get out of the car himself, when he felt a body lean over and unbuckle his seatbelt.

The car was still on, and the song was still playing. The interaction was entirely silent, but Izuku felt arms under his legs and another around his back. And within seconds, he was lifted out of the car and hoisted into Katsuki's arms. Groggily, Izuku giggled and nuzzled his face in the crook of Katsuki's neck.

"Fucking nerd," Katsuki whispered under his breath, as they began moving. Katsuki kicked the door close gently with the back of his foot.

Izuku hummed, "Yes, Kacchan?"

Katsuki kept walking up the porch, and then pressed the doorbell a couple of times, feeling a little bad that he will be waking up Inko at this time of morning. He never did answer Izuku.

When Inko opened the door, her face went from curiosity to surprise to see that Izuku was all curled up in Katsuki's arms. And Izuku could generally still scope out the interaction.

Inko's speech was tired as well, but there was clear concern there, "Katsuki?"
"Hi Auntie," Katsuki said a little awkwardly.

"Is…" She looked at her son all cuddled up there, "...Is everything okay?"

"Yeah," Katsuki steps into the house, kicking his shoes off, "He's just tired and fell asleep in the car. Can I go up?"

Inko nodded, and Katsuki makes his way towards the stairs. From outside, his car was still on and playing music. Inko followed the blonde up the stairs, and when Katsuki gently kicks the door open with his knees, the athlete steps over some clothes strewn on the ground and heads towards the bed.

Inko watches from the doorway with curious eyes, dark circles evident underneath.

Katsuki lays the greenette gently on the bed, and sits on the edge. He proceeds to take off the boy's shoes and sets them on the ground. Followed by his socks. Then, he stands up and pushes Izuku's legs in more, grabbing the blankets and pulling it over. Izuku was tired, but aware of what was going on the entire time, and he snuggled up in his warm blankets.

"Mm," Izuku mumbles, "Thanks...Kacchan."

Izuku feels the other ruffle his hair, "No problem, nerd."

Katsuki then collects himself, and makes his way towards the bedroom door. Inko looks at him curiously, but all Katsuki does is nod in her direction and give a quick “Goodnight Auntie.” Before leaving.

And when the car takes off from the street a couple of moments later, Inko still stands there in the door of Izuku’s bedroom, arms crossed, deep in thought.

The county fair arrived the following Friday, and practically everyone was excitedly looking forward to it. The rain in Ise has persisted for so long now, that many people wanted the weather to clear up and for the festivities to begin again. The county fair was exactly what someone would imagine a small town fair to be like.

They had the whole ordeal there: ferris wheels, fun rides, basic fair games, funnel cake and greasy food, and a lot of teens screaming. The fair opened up at 3, but most of the older teens showed up later. Izuku had told Kaito that he would go with him, and so the athlete had shown up to his house around 5:30 P.M. with a bouquet of flowers that he didn’t really know what to do with. However, it was really sweet, and so Izuku was touched by the gesture.

They pulled up in the parking lot near where all of their friends were meeting up, and Izuku spots both of their friend groups. Ochaco, Shoto, and Iida were all there, along with the pole vault team and some others. It was really just a big group of seniors from Ise High, all kind of waiting for each other to show up, even though they were going to part ways anyways into smaller groups.

Izuku spots Katsuki leaning against the hood of his car, talking to his friends and a group of girls that wanted to surround him. Izuku watched the interaction, and found that although Katsuki replied to them, the blonde’s eyes were on his phone doing something else the entire time.

When Kaito and Izuku exited the car, Katsuki looked up. Their group of friends hollered them over, and Izuku waved and greeted everyone.

“Midoriya!” Mina yells out, “You came with a hot date!”

Kaito laughs, “No, I did.”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, as he looks back onto his phone.

“Hmm,” Mina looks at them curiously, “Are you two together now?”

Kaito looks over at Izuku for an answer, and Izuku was quite quick to answer. Shaking his head, the greenette tells her, “No, it’s not like that.” He smiles.

It was not the answer Kaito wanted to hear, he was sure. But he really could not think of an actual relationship with the brunette. At some point, Izuku needed to be more transparent

with Kaito about this thought, but for now, they were just friends who do stuff together attending the county fair.

There wasn't much to say about it other than that. Izuku's response quieted the crowd's curiosity and they went back to other conversation.

The group waited a couple more minutes for other friends to arrive, before actually heading into the fair grounds.

It was pretty large and on a usual day, it was just open grass; however, when the annual county fair comes along, the whole place transforms. The smell of corn dogs and funnel cakes filled the air, and Izuku already knew that was going to be delicious after being tired out by some rides or games.

There were a lot of colorful lights everywhere, whether it be advertising the food stalls, the lights installments on the rides and Ferris wheel, or the glow stick necklaces that people had on.

There was also lots of music everywhere. From large speakers played 80s music, to fit the theme of Ise, but there was also just a lot of background and foreground noise. People yelling or laughing. Dings and clinking from games and arcade like activities. Other sources of music overlapping each other. The merry go round's carousel song. There was just overall a lot of activity going on, and he didn't know where to start.

Kaito paid for this wristband ticket even though he was perfectly fine with getting his own, but he was grateful regardless. The red wristband was put on loosely and he was ready to go. As expected, the big group that they arrived in split off, but all agreed to meet back up in about an hour and a half to grab food and hang out as a group.

And so since Izuku has came here with Kaito, he'll just go off with the boy until they all meet up again. And it was objectively a fun time, because the entertainment was provided for them.

They didn't really need to go into detailed conversion or anything of the sort, because all of the entertainment was already there. The music was nice. The rides are fun and Izuku ride the swings that spun around off of the ground twice. And for a snack, Kaito got him a stick of cotton candy. It was just straight up fluffy sugar but fair food was never meant to be very nutritious anyways.

"I love fairs," Izuku exclaimed as he stepped off of a gravitron ride, one of those fair rides that spun so fast that gravity pulls you down to the back and pins you against the wall.

Kaito grins at him, "Good. I'm glad."

Izuku turned towards the taller and lets the boy take a bite out of the cotton candy stick that somehow survived the ride, "How about you?"

"Oh, fairs?" Kaito thinks about it, "They're fun, I guess. A little childish, but it can be fun. Especially with you," He winks.

Izuku rolls his eyes playfully, “You think everything is childish, Kaito.”

Kaito just grins and shrugs, “I just have more refined tastes in activities.”

Izuku wags his fingers at the taller, “If I wasn’t so excited here, I might actually take offense to that.”

Kaito just shakes his head and throws his arm around Izuku’s shoulder, “Come on, let’s go play a game or something.”

After about an hour and a half, most of the group migrated back so that they could all grab some food together near where all of the food trucks were. They were plenty of options. They had the classic fair food: onion rings, loaded hot dogs and chili, cheesy French fries, funnel cakes with strawberry creme. And then other fun food trucks: a fried chicken food truck, a Mac and cheese food truck, and even a taco truck. Although Ise wasn’t particularly known for having great Mexican food. Izuku was starving and wanted some food right then.

They all waited for different groups that had split off to come back, and then all went to order their food. Since they were at a fair, it made most sense to grab fair food since after all, they could get the other food literally anywhere else. But it was hard to find funnel cake or really ridiculous fried concoctions anywhere but at a fair.

And so Izuku, Kaito, and some of the other people including Katsuki stood in line to order at the several trucks that sold the traditional fare. Izuku ended up getting loaded tater tots and he and Kaito shared a funnel cake topped with chocolate drizzle, banana slices, and candied walnuts.

The group found a nice grassy area with a couple benches here and there, and set up camp, all gathered around in a big group after getting their food to eat and drink. They had to talk over all of the noise and music, but it was a good time.

Kaito kept on wanting to keep his hands on Izuku’s waist, but not liking it that much, Izuku continuously squirms his way out of the touch. There are times and places for Kaito’s affection, and in public was not one of them. Izuku didn’t want people to get that impression of them two, not when it would be unfair to Kaito’s probably already raised hopes.

“And so, Hinata fucking slaps the shit out of him and runs off!” Denki leaned against a bench and tells the story. The group laughed, and after he was done, Kaito got up to stretch and throw away their trash.

That inspired others to do the same and everyone cleaned up after themselves, afterwards splitting off again slowly to go do their own things.

“Midoriya, I’m gonna go get some ice cream,” Kaito mentioned, “Do you want any?”

Izuku thinks on it, “Um, can you just get me a popsicle? Any tropical flavor is good.”

“Got it,” The other said, “Stay here. I’ll be back.”

And so, as everyone kind of shuffles out except one or two groups that were still just chilling, Izuku stands there by himself just kind of looking off and enjoying the ambiance for the most part. He was wondering what Katsuki was doing, but didn't have to any longer, when the blonde spoke up from not too far away.

"So he's brunette, gave you flowers I heard, and is nice to you," Katsuki says, and Izuku knew who he was referring to, "The fucker is your type, right?"

Izuku just looked at Katsuki, hoping his eyes were as longing as his heart was, as the blonde approached closer. Katsuki was wearing green cargo shorts, and a black top.

Izuku knew it would have been fun to have gone to the fair with Katsuki, but he had already told Kaito weeks ago he'd go with the brunette. But my god, did seeing the boy he was tragically falling for make Izuku want to be near him so badly.

Izuku didn't reply, not wanting to admit that Katsuki was everything that he wanted. And that hurt him to even admit.

And so, with his hands in his pockets, Katsuki looks up at the sky, filled with smoke from the barbecue pits, and then back down at Izuku, with a curious expression, "Do you love him."

Izuku was surprised at the question, but more than that, he was amused. The way Katsuki asked that was so easy, and it made Izuku laugh. He felt like it was obvious that he didn't. Love was much more...special than whatever odd relationship he and Kaito has. Love was much deeper, and if Katsuki couldn't see that, then the blonde obviously didn't have a clear idea of what love is.

And so, softly but loud enough for Katsuki to hear, Izuku tells him, "You obviously don't know what love is if you can ask me that."

Katsuki looks away at the comment, "Maybe I don't. Answer me regardless."

And as the fairgoers pass by, and the bombardment of music plays, the space between the two of them is emphasized as Katsuki seemed to wait for his answer.

And after a moment, Izuku smiles sadly and shakes his head, "I don't."

Katsuki nods his head at this, and Izuku was curious.

"Answer me this then, Kacchan," The greenette proposed, "Why do you want to know?"
To that, Katsuki had a very basic answer that didn't really reveal much, as if the blonde could already guess Izuku would ask this and formed a predesigned response, "Just curious."

Izuku was about to open his mouth to say something, when Kaito had come back with some ice cream. The athlete had a vanilla soft serve, and he handed Izuku a mango flavored popsicle.

"Ah, thank you!" Izuku reached out to take a hold of it.

“It’s my pleasure,” Kaito grinned at him, “You want to head to the ferris wheel?”

Izuku looked back at Katsuki, who was now back on his phone, and then over to Kaito again,, “Um, yeah sure.”

“Alright, let’s go,” Kaito nodded to him before ushering Izuku forward, and about to trail behind, when something drops out of his back pocket. But the brunette kept on walking a couple more meters, before Katsuki called out.

“Oi, Fuck Face,” Katsuki put his phone back into his pocket, and alerted his teammate.

Kaito turned his head, expecting something snarky and already looked annoyed, “What is it, Cap?”

“You dropped your damn wallet,” Katsuki rolled his eyes. Although he fucking hated Kaito as anyone could figure, Izuku knew that Katsuki will always look out for his teammates. He wouldn’t be so attentive to their progress if he didn’t care at all.

“Oh shit,” Kaito then looked a little sheepish and even a bit grateful, “Ah, thanks.” Before walking towards it.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, and then bent down to grab the wallet, that had fell open. But then he paused, eying the contents.

Raising a brow, Katsuki picked up the brown leather wallet by its middle and held it in his hands, still in a squat position. Izuku was a bit of a distance away, but he still saw very clearly what was revealed to be in it when it was thrown open.

Along with a debit card and a couple of bills, in the clear pocket of the wallet was a condom and a packet of lube. Izuku’s face flushed, and he wondered if Kaito had that for tonight, or for any time.

Of course, he knew it was common to keep those items in people’s wallets just in case, but the brunette has paid for this things plenty of times, and Izuku has never seen a condom nor lube in the clear pocket of his wallet.

Katsuki stares at it, face blank, before standing up and moving his gaze up to where Kaito approached.

Upon seeing that it had opened, Kaito looked embarrassed and glanced back at Izuku before over at Katsuki, and he rubbed the back of his neck with one arm while reaching for the wallet with the other. Katsuki drops the wallet in Kaito’s hands.

“Hopefully, I get lucky tonight, you know what I mean?” Kaito mentions to the blonde, closing the wallet and holding it up with a grin and a wink, before going back over to Izuku.

Not really wanting to confront Kaito after that awkward reveal, Izuku buys himself a couple of seconds and says, “I forgot to throw away my wrapper!” And headed back towards the trash can with his popsicle wrapper still in his hands, closer to where Katsuki was. His face was flushed red.

Izuku tosses the wrapper away, and turns back around to walk back over to the brunette, when a rough hand on his wrist stops him in his tracks, and Izuku turns to be face to face with Katsuki, who looked down on him with a blank expression. Izuku glances up with wide eyes.

“Kacch-” Izuku began.

“You’re gonna let him fuck you?” Katsuki asked, tone low and a little on the edge. His eyes were sharp, and that gaze was dangerous. Izuku could tell a million thoughts were swimming around through Katsuki’s head, and he wanted to dive in that sea of knowledge that he was closed off to so badly. But all he had were those words, and that tone that almost felt jealous.

And Izuku thinks back to all of the times where he had watched from afar or heard words of Katsuki’s escapades with people wanted to be so bad. God, did Izuku wish he was one of those people who Katsuki touched, who Katsuki kissed, who Katsuki fucked. And the guttural feeling in his stomach when he thinks of all the experience the taller has had makes Izuku feel petty.

And so, the greenette tells Katsuki, “I could.”

Katsuki’s expression changes into something Izuku couldn’t exactly make out, but his arm is dropped. And they just stand there for a moment, before Kaito calls out to him, and Izuku walks away after keeping eye contact with the blonde of a good moment. But as he walked away, Izuku desperately wanted to know…what exactly was going on in the blonde’s mind as he gave his answer.

Kaito and Izuku just explore the fairgrounds some more for about another hour. It was decently large, with plenty of activities, so Izuku didn’t feel bored per se. However, his legs were indeed tired. After walking around for so long, and being on slightly nauseating rides, it made sense that his legs were exhausted.

They had done the ferris wheel, and Kaito had tried to kiss him, but Izuku was lost in thought recalling Katsuki’s dark expression when he had talked to him earlier. After that, they walked around some more, played some games, and then rode more rides.

The county fair was a classic Ise tradition, and Izuku felt like it never really got old. The lights, the energy, the music, and the food was a pivotal experience for a child growing up in this small town. And nothing could really ruin it.

“So why do you want to study law?” Izuku asked Kaito as they kind of strolled around the fairgrounds casually.

The brunette nods at the question, “Both of my parents are lawyers, so it’s kind of in my blood.”

“Oh! That’s cool,” Izuku nods, “What kind of law do you want to practice?”

“I’ll probably go into civil law,” The brunette answered, “It’s easy, and makes money, you know?”

Izuku hummed, “I see.”

“I’m gonna go to the bathroom really quick, okay?” Kaito says, before muttering, “I don’t really know where they are though…”

“Fair bathrooms are probably going to be nasty,” Izuku laughs, “But I think I saw some over there.” He points towards the left direction.

Kaito glances over there and nods, “Alright. I’ll be back. Can you stay here, so it’ll be easier to find you?”

Izuku nodded, “Of course.”

And so Kaito takes his leave, while Izuku fits a spot to sit down and rest his legs. His hands are on his lap, and he just reflects on tonight. It had been nice for sure. The fair was nice. The ambiance was great. The food was good. It was a pretty satisfactory night, even with some of the oddity between Katsuki and Kaito.

If Kaito was planning on making a move tonight, then Izuku would have to think about it. He hated that when Izuku thinks of his first time, it didn’t appeal to him to have it be with Kaito Sen.

A group of people walk by, and Izuku spots Katsuki in that group of people, but the blonde didn’t seem to be very into the conversation or activity. Instead, the athlete stood there, seemingly in contemplation, before glancing around and catching Izuku’s eye.

The greenette lifted a hand up to wave, but Katsuki looks away. Izuku frowned. That was odd. Katsuki hadn’t actually ignored him in public or so in a long time, so he wonders why exactly now.

But Izuku continued to observe the other under the radar. It seemed as if the boy was contemplating something heavily, because someone else was trying to get Katsuki’s attention, but the boy was ignoring her as well.

It was another minute before Katsuki began moving, but when he did, Izuku didn’t expect for the blonde to begin moving towards *him.* Katsuki’s eyes were on him then, and Izuku’s eyes widened in anticipation as the athlete got closer.

And just as he approached, Izuku heard the blonde mutter, “Fuck it.”

And once he was within reaching distance, Katsuki’s hand reached out for his own and pulled him up off the seat before leading Izuku away.

Izuku stumbled behind, “Kacchan? Is everything okay?”

“Let’s leave,” Katsuki tells him, guiding the path.

“Wait, what?” Izuku exclaimed.

“Let’s go. Let’s get out of here,” Katsuki repeats.

“Again,” Izuku was confused, as he was led through the fairground, weaving in and out of people, “Is everything okay?”

“Everything’s fi- It’s pe-…” Katsuki’s words were jumbled, “Nothing’s wro-
*Fuck.* Everything’s fine, okay? Let’s just go somewhere. Get out of Ise for a little bit. Just leave this town with me for a night. We can come back in the morning.”

Izuku sputtered. So nothing was wrong, “Kacchan, I can’t just do that right now. I’m literally here with someone. I can’t just leave Kaito.”

“Leave him,” Katsuki tells Izuku, “Text him you’re not feeling well.”

Izuku shook his head, “Kacchan, I can’t just do that.”

“And why not,” Katsuki argued.

Izuku shook his head out of Katsuki’s grasp and looked at the blonde concerned, “Kacchan, what is up with you right now? Why do we have to leave?”

“Nothing’s up,” Katsuki states.

Izuku frowns, “You’re obviously lying,” They were just in the middle of people’s walkway, having this conversation, “I told you that you need to be okay with openin-”

“It’s fucking hard, okay?” Katsuki frustratedly says, “I don’t even know…” The blonde just stops, and tries to collect his words as he looks around as if he’ll find the answer in the grass, “I don’t even fucking know what I’m feeling. I don’t fucking know okay? I just don’t want to be here.”

Izuku walked up towards Katsuki, wanting to reach out. He could tell Katsuki was struggling with something, and he knew that whatever it was is confusing the athlete, “Hey…”

The blonde ran a hand through his hair and took a deep breath. The environment was loud and easy to feel overwhelmed in.

He took a moment, and Izuku didn’t mind standing there with him. Finally, Katsuki told him, “If you want to stay here, I shouldn’t make you leave. I’ll go. You can find your way back to wherever Kaito is, right?” The blonde said seriously, and Izuku realizes this is one of the rare times he hears Katsuki use the brunette’s real name.

But Izuku doesn’t move from his spot, just stares up at Katsuki, who was looking off towards the area where his car was parked, before turning back down to Izuku.

“Well what are you waiting for,” Katsuki spoke, “I fucking dragged you away. Go back before the fucker wonders where you went.”

Izuku was conflicted. He knew he shouldn’t. But he wasn’t perfect. In some ways, Izuku was the asshole too.

He longed after Katsuki, while someone longed after him. And knowing that, the greenette still hasn’t done anything to clear the air. He was only human.

“I…” Izuku felt so bad, “I would. I would go, with you. But Kaito...He’s been really nice to me today, taking me out here, and spending time with me. He’s a good guy, Kacchan. I can’t just ditch him. He gave me flowers, a-and he’s been good to me.”

“I know,” Katsuki sounded conflicted, “I fucking know he has. I know he’s fucking good to you. Just…”

Katsuki seemed to be struggling with his words, which surprised Izuku who have always seen Katsuki to be articulate, even when they were arguing, “Give me a chance to be good to you tonight, too.”

Izuku’s eyes widened at the statement. In no world would he had expected such a thing to come out of Katsuki’s mouth, especially in such a struggling tone of voice, and yet it did. And Izuku was silent. He replayed the line over and over again, until it seared into his brain.

And his lips parted. Katsuki’s expression looked like a wreck, and it was clear he was having a hard time understanding what seems to be himself.

“What?” Izuku stammered, and held himself, “Why?”

“I don’t…” Katsuki sounded confused again, “I don’t fucking know. You’re just my,” He paused, “My closest fucking friend, okay? And there’s something I want to do, okay? There’s something I want to do.” He repeats at the end.

Izuku was floored. Katsuki had just admitted something that required a little bit more openness than normal. To confess to Izuku that he was the athlete’s closest friend was to reveal to the other that Izuku held influence and affection from Katsuki.

And that just wasn’t something that could possibly have been easy for Bakugo Katsuki of all people to admit. Izuku was so shocked, that he didn’t have a reply for a while. And he just looked at the taller male, wondering if he had heard incorrectly.

Katsuki lowered his head, and as if switching back and forth between his closed off and open self, the athlete grinds out, “I’m never repeating that again.”

But Izuku couldn’t be upset. He knew that whatever journey they were on was never going to be easy. The greenette’s eyes softened, and he stepped forward towards Katsuki. Grabbing onto the hem of the blonde’s black fitted tee, Izuku smiled softly at the face he adored so much.

“Okay, let’s go,” Izuku tells him.

Katsuki just looks at the other, eyes surprised.

And Izuku pulls out his phone, where he already saw a couple of text messages and two phone calls from Kaito. He wanted to be better to Kaito, who had been nice to him this whole time. Izuku felt like an asshole, he did. But he also knew that he won't find the will to do anything about it.

He calls the brunette who had given him flowers and treated him this entire day, with guilt laced in his voice, "Kaito?"

On the other line, the boy in question exclaimed, "Midoriya? Where are you at? I can't find you."

"I know," Izuku looked down at the ground, his words strained because he knew the pain of not being chosen and he knew how shitty this was going to feel for Kaito. Izuku wanted to cry at how he was so useless against Katsuki's words and requests, "Are you with people right now?"

"Uh, yeah," Kaito replies, "I saw some of my guys and headed over. They didn't see you, and said that Bakugo had just disappeared."
"He's with me, right now," Izuku wanted to tell the truth, and his voice was about to break, because he knew it was going to hurt. And he was such an asshole for this, he knew that too.

But he wasn't a perfect person, and he didn't make decisions that will satisfy everyone. Right now, he was being selfish, and he was going to be so mad at himself for this later. But he could only fight so much. He wasn't going to lie, or make up something so that Kaito would feel better about himself. Because that would be unfair to the other, who has been honest about his feelings towards Izuku, while Izuku had only been partially giving of his own.

Kaito was silent on the other line, and Izuku was slightly shoved to the side by a family walking past. It was all so hectic, and he was just standing there on the phone wanting to cry because he was inflicting a type of pain on somebody that has been inflicted on himself.

"We're going to leave early," Izuku is in pain with every word, "I still wanted to tell you that I'm very grateful for your company today," He felt like he was making the situation worse, "You're very sweet, and attentive, and honest, and if you want me to, I will make it up to you. But I just...have to go."

Kaito didn't say anything for a while, and Izuku didn't blame him. He wasn't going to ask the other to say something, just so that it will ease Izuku's feelings.

Because this wasn't about his feelings. He was hurting someone else, and if Kaito didn't want to talk to him because he was essentially ditched, then Izuku will have to accept that.

"You know how I feel about him," Kaito began.

Izuku knew, "I do."

Another pause, "And you're still just gonna go off with him somewhere?"

This time, Izuku was the one who stayed silent. It was horrible.

And then, the brunette tells him, “Okay. I get it. Stay safe.”

“Kai-“

“But Midoriya.” Kaito continues.

The doe-eyed boy looks down, “Yes?”
“You’re honest too,” Kaito tells him, “You might not say things you mean, but I can see the truth in your expression and in the way you act. I was playing a losing game from the start,” The boy laughs, “So I guess it’s my own damn fault.”

This was not the place to have this conversation. Izuku looks around, upset that he had been so obvious. It must have hurt more, “Kaito…”

“I’m not done,” The brunette speaks through the line, “This is not me being jealous, but me being a friend. I want to warn you now. He’s never going to feel the same, you know,” Izuku knew exactly what *He* was referring to, “He’s kinder to you, he’s more attentive and caring to you. I admit all of that. He’s been better because of you. But there’s a limit to what Bakugo Katsuki can handle,” He says and Izuku looks over at Katsuki who was leaning against a pole a couple meters away, “And love is well past the cut-off point.”

Izuku had nothing to say. He knew that coming in. It wasn’t as if he could help it.

And Kaito added one last point, “I still want to see you, you know.”

Izuku was shocked, “What?”

“It’s clear at this point we aren’t meant to date,” Kaito further explains, “But if you want to continue doing some of the

things we were doing, I wouldn’t be opposed.”

Izuku flushed, knowing what he meant, and let out an, “...Oh.”

“Think on it,” Kaito tells him, “Accept my offer sometime, alright? Listen, I’m gonna go. But I will text you.”

Izuku nodded, still feeling bad, “Okay...Okay. I’ll see you.”

The phone line hangs up, and Izuku puts it in his pocket. Although the conversation wasn’t heavy, the guilt weighed on him, and he walked over to Katsuki.

“You ready?” The blonde asked. He wasn’t going to question the phone call, because anyone could tell it didn’t sit right with Izuku.

Izuku  nodded to the taller, “Yeah.”

The walk to Katsuki's car was not awkward, but it was definitely a little quiet. In about thirty minutes, the night had morphed into something much more confusing than a simple trip to the county fair. Everything was turning into a mess, and Izuku just wished he was able to juggle everything at once. He could tell Katsuki was dealing with his own shit, and he wanted to respect that.

They got into Katsuki's car, and Izuku asked the other then, "Where are we headed?"
The athlete put his car in drive and moved forward, "You'll see."

Izuku frowned at the response, but laid back in the familiar seat. They had no music on, but that was fine. Katsuki drove out of the crowded parking lot, stuck in the line of people who were also leaving, and when they were finally out of the main road, Izuku turned his head to look over at the driver.

"Kacchan?" Izuku asked.

The other hummed.

"Are you okay?" Izuku genuinely wanted to know, and his hands played with the seatbelt as he waited for a reply.

The blonde nodded, and reached a hand out to ruffle Izuku's hair, "I'm fine."

And then after a moment of just driving on the roads of Ise, Katsuki glanced over and asked quietly, "How about you, nerd," He pauses, "Are you okay?"

Izuku blinked, and thought about it. He was now pretty relaxed, and so he nodded, "I'm okay."

"Good," The other said, before driving down very familiar streets.

Izuku took notice of the road he frequents very often nowadays, and waits to confirm his suspicions. And after a couple of minutes, he practically knew where they were going.

"We're going to your house?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki shakes his head, "I'm switching cars."

"What's wrong with yours?" Izuku wonders, looking around.

"Nothing's wrong with it," Katsuki replies, "I just want to drive something different tonight."

That was an incredibly odd thing to say, but Izuku has given up on pondering Katsuki's choices. They pull up to the familiar driveway of the Bakugou house, and the blonde tells Izuku to wait outside of the car. Katsuki runs inside and after about two minutes, Izuku hears a beep of the truck door unlocking.

Katsuki's dad drove a Tacoma truck, which really fit the old town vibes of Ise, and from inside the house, Izuku heard the other yell out for him to get in.

So just complying with it, Izuku opens the passenger door of the truck, and steps up to climb into the tall truck. After a couple more minutes of Izuku just playing around on his phone, the greenette sees Katsuki step back outside with a large black trash bag in his arms, hauling something out. Izuku just looks at the athlete, as he goes to the back of the truck and tosses the trash bag in the truck bed, and then climbs on there.

There is some sound back there for another couple of minutes, before he hears the truck bed door closing and Katsuki climbs into the driver's seat, putting the key in the ignition and cranking the engine on.

"What did you throw back there?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki backs out of the driveway while responding, "Just some supplies."

"What. Are we covering up a murder or something?" Izuku chuckles lightly, "That bag was stuffed."

"You're right on the money," Katsuki joked.

And then they began driving out. This time, Katsuki put the music on, and Izuku relaxed into his seat. Arthur's Theme by Christopher Cross played on the radio, and the blonde drives with one hand as they hit the highway and cruise out of this small town, out in what seemed like further into the countryside.

There was no light out here except for their headlights and the moon's rays, and so Izuku could barely see the landscape on either side of them. If he squints, he can see the dark silhouette of the mountains that cupped and expanded out of Ise.

Katsuki's mysterious location was making Izuku highly curious, but he knew they were driving for a while.

About forty minutes in, Katsuki pulled into a gas station, "We're nearly there. But let's grab some snacks and water."

The gas station had bright fluorescent lights, and they were the only ones there. It was a very sleepy gas station, with a small store inside. Since it was in the middle of nowhere, there didn't seem to be much business. It had a very liminal feel to it. The loud truck engine stopped, and both boys hopped out and stepped inside of the gas station.

The clerk was boredly reading a magazine when they came in, not bothering to look up. And so Izuku and Katsuki browsed the aisles for snacks. After a while of contemplating and arguing over which candy was worse between Sour Patch Kids and Mike & Ikes, Izuku grabbed some raspberry chocolates and a water.

And Katsuki grabbed some freeze dried fruit and a cherry gatorade. The cashier looked utterly bored as they checked out, and the two boys laughed about it once they left the store

and was back on the road again.

And they drive for about another ten minutes, before Katsuki began to take some weird turns. And they were not out of farmland and more into forest-like lands. Everything was extremely dark that Izuku wondered if the blonde knew where he was going.

Deciding he'll trust Katsuki's sense of direction, Izuku just hums along to the music as he sits there.

"We're approaching," Katsuki announced, "Close your eyes."

"My eyes?" Izuku laughed, "Why?"

"It will be cooler," Katsuki rolled his own, "Just do it."

Izuku just gives in, "Alright, alright." And closes his eyes.

And that is when they go off-road.

"Did we just go off the road?" Izuku asked, feeling the immediate bumpiness of the new terrain.

"Obviously," Katsuki responded.

Izuku hummed, "Is that why we're taking the truck? It's better for this terrain, right?"

The way the boy replied was incredibly cryptic, "Partially."

The uneven terrain goes on for a little over five minutes, Izuku wonders why they are going off-roading like this. Maybe Katsuki really did need to bury a body and wanted to risk no chance of anyone besides him finding out the location. The thought humored him and he laughed to himself.

"What are you giggling about over there, nerd," Katsuki asked.

Izuku just grinned to himself but shook his head, "Nothing important. Are we there yet? My eyes are tired."

"They're literally closed. How the fuck are they tired," Katsuki begged the question.

"From squeezing them shut," Izuku explained.

"No one told you to squeeze your lids shut, idiot," Katsuki barked. And then he pulled to a stop. Izuku waited until further instructions, and so he just sat there tapping his lap patiently. He unhooked his seatbelt.

Katsuki left the truck and for a couple of minutes, Izuku was left with the sounds of crickets and cicadas. He heard rummaging around and then after a moment, the passenger side door opened.

“Can I open my eyes no-” Izuku started. But before he could finish his statement, he felt a pair of strong arms around his waist and Izuku was lifted out of the seat and thrown over Katsuki’s shoulder.

Izuku opened his eyes then but was disoriented by the fact that he was upside down and moving that he couldn’t recognize anything until he was brought around and set down on the edge of the truck bed with a thud, and Katsuki let go of him.

Izuku sat with his legs dangling off the sides and he adjusted his vision. And was immediately confused but took everything in. They were in a field, that was for sure.

One that stretched for a while on every side of them, considering they were in the middle, and surrounded by 360 degrees of forest line. The grass was up to their mid calves. Looking back at the truck bed, the black trash bag was carrying a big thick comforter that was now laid on in the back with a couple of pillows.

Two thin throw blankets were just tossed in the back randomly, and the bag of snacks they grabbed from the gas station was thrown back there too.

But what shocked Izuku the most was what was what was *in* the fields. Flowers. But not just any flowers: flowers of a certain color. Yellow. He stared at them, what seemed like thousands of them.

And he felt speechless, so much that Izuku felt as if he had to ask.

“Why are we here,” Izuku whispered, almost shocked. His eyes were wide, his lungs felt like they were going to collapse from awe.

Katsuki looks around, standing in the tall grass, and looks out as well. It’s quiet for a moment, but then the blonde tells him.

“Because,” Katsuki’s deep voice broke the quiet, “You said you liked it.”

Izuku’s eyes widened in recognition, and his voice spoke before his brain even caught up, “Like what?”

And then Katsuki looks up at the sky, and recites something Izuku said from so long ago, it felt, “You said you liked it, remember? The thought of laying in a field somewhere, with yellow flowers, and looking up at the stars. So that it feels like you’re floating in them.”

And Izuku right then felt the world go numb. And all he heard, all he saw, all he felt was Katsuki. Katsuki, and his beautiful face, and his beautiful words. He couldn’t breathe.

The parallel hit him in the face. He remembered the times where he had said the same thing to Katsuki before. The same pattern of asking why there were somewhere. The same pattern of the reasoning being because the other liked something.

Except all of those other times, it has been Izuku who has been doing such things. It had been Izuku who had picked out carefully curated things that he knew Katsuki would specifically like.

But this time.

This time, Katsuki has done something for him.

Izuku remembered that conversation. It had been the night they went to the drive in theater and watched the horror movie. They had gone to the haunted house and upon coming back, the two of them laid on top of Katsuki's car.

And that was when he had mentioned that small detail that Izuku wouldn't have even remembered himself if Katsuki has not repeated it word for word just now. All this time, no matter what Izuku has thought, no matter what they did, no matter how small, Katsuki has been listening. And paying attention.

Word for word.

*"The stars are pretty," Izuku breathily said, as he stares into the abyss. His blinks were slow, and the warm spring air kissed his skin.*

*Katsuki tilted his head up to look at them.*

*Izuku continued, "I like…" He thinks about it, "I like the thought of laying in a field somewhere, with yellow flowers, and looking up at the stars. So it feels like I'm floating in them."*

Izuku just recalls the conversation now but he wanted to tear up. All around him, were yellow flowers.

And under the moonlight, it looked as if they glowed like stars. There were thousands, all around them. Like a sea of yellow flowers illuminated by the bright white moonlight. And when Izuku looks up, there were the actual stars.

What seemed like millions of them basking in its glory up in the heavens, and Izuku's heart began drumming. So fast that the cage couldn't contain it. This was the kindest thing and most attentive thing that someone has ever done for him, and although Izuku couldn't help but he floored at the presentation in front of him right now, with the beautiful stars and flowers that made him feel like he was floating in the cosmos, there was something else that felt almost more beautiful right now.

And it was Katsuki. The stars were stunning. The flower fields were fastastical. All of the preparation: the truck, the snacks, all of it made him more than grateful.

And yet, nothing seeped into his souls and imbedded itself into every fiber of his being except for how much he felt for Katsuki at this moment.

His eyes moved from the surroundings that he was blessed to experienced to the blonde who stands in front of him, currently looking up at the stars. Izuku took a deep look at the boy. The blonde hair. The ruby red eyes. The jawline.

But it was more than that. It was the way Katsuki ripped away all of the walls of his stuffed up house and introduced him to how beautiful life is. It was the way Katsuki cared for him and showed his affection in a way that never coddled him or placed any expectations on him. In the way Katsuki didn't care about the baggage or the restrictions that Izuku's life was plagued with, and stood up to the problems that everyone has given up on or ignored.

Izuku stared at Katsuki, fire in his eyes. And he knew what this was. He knew that everything up until now has been building up to this realization. It had been coming for a while, he knew he was falling in love. But now he was no longer falling.

He loved Katsuki.

He loved him. He loved him. *God,* he loved him. He loved him so much that it shredded the last pieces of his rationality. He loved him so much that the stars are dimmer than the shine in Katsuki's eyes. He loved him so much that the fire could not burn nearly as hot as the way Katsuki's touch burned his skin. He fucking loved this boy so much that his dreams are forever laced with the essence of Katsuki's voice.

And *shit*, he was fucked. He was so screwed. And this was the very reason why Izuku didn't want to come to this inevitable realization. Because if he thought he was screwed before, then he knew he was screwed now.

And so Izuku started crying. He didn't want to, but he began crying. His tears blurred his vision, and Izuku could barely see. His shoulders shook, and he tried to stop. Wiping away his tears with the sleeve of his shirt, but the steady streams came out like rain. He needed it to stop so that he didn't look ridiculous. Too late.

"Deku?" Katsuki noticed, and immediately, his hands cupped the shorter male's face, and his thumbs wiped away Izuku's tears, "Oi, what's wrong."

Izuku felt those rough hands on his cheeks that were warmer than he thought they'd be, and Izuku through his tears looked up at Katsuki and brought his own hands up to wrap over Katsuki's.

The blonde stopped to look at him, and Izuku smiled even though his eyes screamed tragedy.

"Kacchan," Izuku said all that he was able to at the moment, "Thank you."

Katsuki's eyes widened and he asked, "You're crying because you're thankful, nerd?"

Izuku laughed through his tears, "Is there something wrong with that?"

It was partially the truth. The other truth was because he was making peace with the beautiful disaster that he was doomed to.

"No, I just…" Katsuki looked a little lost, "Don't really know what to do…"

Izuku chuckled. Of course he didn't. That was okay. He threw his arms over Katsuki's shoulders and jumped on the boy in a big hug, and Katsuki, after a moment of shock, held onto him.

And Izuku just wanted to stay like that for a while; however, Katsuki then, with Izuku still attached on him, held the boy up so that the blonde could climb on top of the truck bed and walk over until they were on the white comforter laid out.

And that was when Izuku let go. And sat himself down on the comforter, kicking his shoes off, while his eyes were still trained on Katsuki. The blonde reached back to fluff out two pillows side by side and then the athlete laid down, staring up at the sky. And below their feet were the yellow flowers.

Izuku, after a moment, did the same. His tears had stopped and were beginning to dry up in his face. He was happy and devastated at the same time. But Izuku thinks about it. People fall in love all the time, and heartbreak happens every single day. But was anyone else's heartbreak this beautiful? Was anyone else's heartbreak attached to dozens of adventures and moments like this that he will never forget? Did anyone else's heartbreak take him out to a field at night and set up a bed for him amongst the stars?

No. If heartbreak was this beautiful, Izuku wouldn't mind it shattering.

They lay there for a long time, and watch the stars. And ate their snacks. Katsuki had connected his Bluetooth, and they listened to Never Gonna Let You Go by Sergio Mendes.

It was mesmerizing, and their conversations was quiet. It was as if they were scared the spell would break if they spoke too loud. It was gorgeous. And the fireflies that would flicker once in a while added to the heavens-like ambience.

Katsuki leaned his head close and began to point out constellations to Izuku. The boy in question listened intently and looked down Katsuki's arms where he was pointing.

"That one right there is Jupiter," Katsuki informed, "You see that really bright one?"

Izuku nodded, "Yeah! That's Jupiter?"

"Sure is," Katsuki grinned, "That fucker could fit about 1,300 Earths inside of it."

Izuku was in awe, and then pointed out another set of stars, "That's the Big Dipper."

"Is it?" Katsuki hummed, "Where's the Little Dipper."

Izuku scanned the skies, and they both looked for it, to no avail.

"I give up," Izuku pouts, "It doesn't want to be found."

Katsuki snorts, "It's probably ugly anyways."

Izuku giggles, “The gods will strike you down for that, Kacchan. You can’t insult the stars.”

“But I *am* a god,” Katsuki cackles.

And Izuku elbows him, “Which one?”

“Hm,” Katsuki ponders it, “Ares. The god of war.”

That was very fitting. Izuku smiles softly. Of course, he would be.

“And you?” Katsuki asks him.

Izuku bites his lip, and knowing the story of Ares and Aphrodite, Izuku tells him, “Aphrodite. Goddess of love.”

Katsuki snorts, “Of course you’d be.”

“Why so cynical?” Izuku asks with a cheeky smile, “They’re the same, you know.”

“What. Love and war?” Katsuki asks.

Izuku nodded while his eyes burned the stars into his mind, “What is love but a war of feelings? And what war has ever been fought for anything besides love? Love of country. The love of a woman or a man. Love of family.”

Katsuki laughs lightly, “Are you waxing poetry now, Deku? Is that your favorite quote or something? You memorized that shit by heart.”

Izuku shakes his head no, “No, I just like it. My favorite quote is something else.”

“Yeah?” Katsuki asked, “What is it.”

Izuku thinks back to the words his mother spoke to him before, and wondered why it stuck in his head so long, and he repeats, “Love is friendship set on fire.”

At this, Katsuki seemed to ponder. And then the athlete goes quiet for a moment.

“Pretty inspiring, shitnerd,” Katsuki says sarcastically.

And Izuku groaned, “I came with you tonight just to get bullied, didn’t I.”

Katsuki smirks, “Damn straight.”

Izuku grins, and then asks, “How about you? What’s your favorite quote.”

“My favorite quote?” Katsuki asked, and then thinks about it long and hard. So long that Izuku wasn’t even sure if he was even going to reply. However, eventually Katsuki did speak up, and the boy said, “Someone once told me this: ‘as someone who is always on the ground, seeing you fly, no matter how high, is good enough for me.’ I thought about that one for a while.”

Izuku turns his head, and looks at Katsuki, expression eyes showing awe, and he didn't know how the boy he loved could say something like that to him so inconsiderately to his feelings.

The greenette continues to look at him, wanting nothing more than to be closer.

And after a moment, Katsuki catches on that someone was staring at him, and the blonde looked over from his place on the comforter.

Those red eyes shone under the moonlight, and Katsuki's lips. My god, Katsuki's lips were tempting, and Izuku could still remember the sensations of them. He remembers Katsuki's hands on his waist. He remembers all of it. He wanted it so badly: the person he loved.

Could he at least have this night, if nothing else.

"Kacchan," Izuku calls out quietly.

Katsuki keeps his eye contact, and hums, "What is it."

"Remember what you told me...that one night?" Izuku asks, "That I won't want you in the morning?"

The blonde listens, and looks at him for a while before replying, "I remember."

"And then I asked you...what if I did?" Izuku felt his heart race, and he tried to keep his tone steady, "And you said I wouldn't."

Katsuki in a low tone asked him, "What are you trying to get at."

"Kacchan," Izuku wondered if he could at least have this, and just said it, "What if I told you I wanted you… like that. Just for tonight."

The boy in question seemed shocked at the statement, and seemed like he didn't know what to say. Izuku reached a hand out, but before he could, the blonde held him back.

"You don't know what you're fucking saying," Katsuki rolled onto his side and forward so that he was partially on top of Izuku, preventing his hand from touching him.

Izuku was afraid of this. His heart raced even faster, but he couldn't just give up. Not like this, "Why don't I? I'm sound minded. I'm not under the influence. Why can't I want this?"

"Because you know how I am with that shit," Katsuki warned, "I fuck. I don't do any of the fluffy bullshit you'll want."

Izuku furrowed his brows, and although Katsuki was right, wanted to save his pride, "And who said I wanted that?"

Katsuki laughs, "Deku. The fucking way you act. There's no way-"

"Don't assume you know what I want," Izuku was defensive, even though Katsuki was right.

“No?” Katsuki doesn’t believe him, “I’m wrong then?”

Izuku didn’t want to straight up lie, so he diverts, “If you don’t see me that way, then just say that. It’s fine. Don’t ins-”

“That’s not fucking it,” Katsuki sits up then, and looked conflicted, hands going through his hair, “Shut the fuck up.”

“Then what is the problem?” Izuku asked, sitting up with him.

But Katsuki says nothing. Just looks out onto the yellow fields, and Izuku was afraid he had just fucked up. And to be fair, he probably did. His heart was already beginning to crack. He had been hoping that if he couldn’t receive Katsuki’s love, then he could at least have this.

Izuku decides to get upset, and petty, “I could be getting fucked right now.” In reference to Kaito.

The blonde didn’t like this comment. Evident by the way Katsuki’s body seemed to tense up next to him, and the next sentence that leaves the boy’s mouth.

“With someone like Fuck Face? He would never be able to fucking satisfy you,” Katsuki’s tone was low.

Izuku’s breath hitched, and he asked then, “Kacchan, tell me why you hate the idea of me being with Kaito.”

Katsuki’s face soured and he turned away. But Izuku reached over to pull the blonde’s jaw back to face him, and left his hand on Katsuki’s face.

“Tell me,” Izuku pleaded with him in a whisper.

“I don’t fucking like him,” Katsuki growls.

“That’s it?” Izuku looks with his big eyes.

Katsuki confirms unconvincingly, “That’s fucking it.”

Izuku shakes his head and laughs, “You don’t like Iida-kun. But you don’t care about me being friends with him.”

“That’s different,” The blonde argues with him, voice holding a tone of warning.

Izuku pretends he doesn’t understand, “How so.”

Katsuki grabs Izuku’s hands off of his face and takes a hold of Izuku’s jaw, making sure the other listens as venom spills from his lips, “Four eyes doesn’t want to fuck you. Four eyes doesn’t want to shove his dick in your mouth,” His voice gets darker by the sentence, “Four eyes doesn’t want to bend you over and split you apart with his cock. Kaito does.”

Those filthy words coming out of Katsuki's mouth was making Izuku feel twisted things, he knew what he wanted. More than ever.

Izuku leans in a bit, "And why can't Kaito fuck me? Why can't he bend me over, Kacchan? Why can't he split me open with his cock? You won't."

Katsuki's eyes burned with the similar rage he saw that one night, but no words left his lips.

Izuku's face let's closer, and he says softly, "Kacchan, I've sucked his dick. He's had his fingers in me."

Izuku then watches as Katsuki's grip on his jaw gets a little tighter but not enough to hurt him.

Katsuki looked like he wanted to kill, "Did he now."

Izuku nodded innocently, "What are you going to do about it."

"You fucking bitch," Katsuki's sweet breath mingled with his, and they were so damn close, "You know exactly what you're doing, don't you."

The doe-eyed boy pushed more, "Should I tell you more? Should I tell you how many fingers he put in me?" His lips brushed up against Katsuki, and the blonde's hands were holding his waist firmly.

"Say another wo-"

"Four. He stretched me out really well, Kacchan," Izuku wanted Katsuki so badly that he found boldness he didn't know he had. "I was on all fou-"

And then suddenly, Izuku was slammed back onto the comforter, and Katsuki lips were on him in an instance.

Izuku lost all breath, as Katsuki's lips were on his, biting and tugging until they were sure to be bruised. Izuku melted into the pleasure, and the sensation of having the athlete on top of him, kissing him deeply and angrily, will never leave his mind. Izuku's body was pinned down to the bed of the truck, and there were hands on his waist, hands going up his torso, hands on his face, fingers on his neck.

Touching. Touching everywhere. All of these sensations. Izuku couldn't fucking breathe.

Katsuki pulled away only a centimeter to angrily whisper, "I'm going to fuck you open. And you're going to scream for me."

Izuku's eyes were dilated from those words, and he couldn't even nod, before Katsuki's lips were were his nears, biting his lobe and kissing down his neck, "I'm not going to coddle you. I'm not going to tenderly fuck you. I'm not going to love you. I'm not going to hold you to sleep afterwards."

Izuku knew all of this. He had known all of this, and knew this was not going to change. But what else could he ask for. What else could he expect. All he had was this night, “I know.” He whispered.

“I’m going to make you feel good,” Katsuki says between deep kisses, his hands exploring Izuku’s body thoroughly, “I’m going to make you cum. I’m going to tear you apart, and you’re going to beg for it. But I won’t fucking do more than that. Do you understand this, Izuku.”

Izuku could honestly lose his mind from that alone. And if this wasn’t someone he was in love with, maybe those words would burn a little less. But my god, was the burn delicious, as Katsuki’s hands go up to his shirt collar and pull apart slowly, until the fabric crumbles to shreds in the athlete’s fingers, and Izuku was left shirtless, with perky nipples all perfect and pink. His chest went up and down from the lack of breath. He didn’t need that anyways.

Izuku needed more, “Just fuck me,” And then, Izuku opened his eyes, looking up at Katsuki with hooded lids, “Katsuki.”

That did it. The boy in question looked drunk on the pleasure of having Izuku under him, and sat back, pulling his black shirt over his head and tossing it aside. Izuku took in the sight like it was his only hydration after days in the desert. He wanted this. He needed it.

“If you let me do this, Deku,” Katsuki looks at him with starving eyes, “I’m going to fucking ruin you.”

Izuku pushes himself up on his elbows and then keeps eye contact with the blonde, “Ruin me, then.”

His mouth watered, and he pulled Katsuki back down to kiss him, and they met in a blazing fire of heat. Lips locked and moving as if desperate. Katsuki shoved his tongue down Izuku’s throat, savoring the taste of mint and candy. They played a game of tug of war, fighting for control even though Izuku knew it was a losing battle. His body felt as if it was going to explode from all of the sensations. Katsuki’s hands knew exactly what they were doing. The way his fingertips glided from Izuku’s pert nipples to his waistband. The way his left hand gripped Izuku’s waist so tightly that it will bruise beautifully the next day. Izuku wanted it all. Katsuki didn’t leave marks.

Instead, the blonde just kissed his way down the doe eyed boy’s body, tasting any inch that he could. And when Katsuki’s tongue found itself on Izuku’s nipple, the sensitive male arched his back and let out a whimper. Katsuki seemed to like that sound, for he began sucking on Izuku’s left bud, while his fingers travelled to pull and twist at Izuku’s right.

The greenette panted, and his moans were getting more frequent as Katsuki ups the intensity, tugging gently with his teeth at the pretty nipples.

Izuku’s dick was slowly hardening, as Katsuki seemed to not be able to get enough. Every kiss, every touch sent electric like shocks down his body. And then it stops, and Izuku opened his eyes to see that the blonde had stepped back. And those large hands were on his pants, unbuttoning them and pulling them off of those perfectly smooth legs.

And then Katsuki kneeled back, and told Izuku in a commanding tone, “Use those pretty hands to take this off for me.”

And Izuku looked up with doe eyes at Katsuki for a second, liking how pretty the stars looked in the backdrop behind the blonde’s head, and got up until he was on his knees in front of Katsuki. His fingers reached up to the athlete’s belt, and he fumbled with the buckle for a second while he desperately tries to get it off. And when it does, Izuku unbuttons the pants and tug them down, enjoying how domineering Katsuki felt in front of him.

And when Katsuki was just in his boxers, Izuku just stared up at the taller. The blonde ran a hand through Izuku’s green hair, right underneath him, and then tilted Izuku’s chin up further.

“What are you afraid of, nerd,” Katsuki asks, voice low, “Have a taste.”

And then, with one hand gripping Izuku’s hair a bit tighter now, and the other hand reaching over his boxers and sliding them down, Katsuki pulls out his cock. And Izuku wanted to both drool and scream.

His eyes were now trained on the girth, the length, the veins, the curve of Katsuki’s delicious cock. Izuku thought his dildos were nice, but this was something else entirely. Izuku could not begin to comprehend this, or how someone could have such a massive, yet perfect cock. It must have strained greatly in whatever pants that the athlete wore. It would take both of his hands to try to handle that, and Katsuki knew it just from the smirk he was giving, having seen Izuku’s expression. The mushroom tip was leaking, and some beads of precum were collecting, threatening to drip. Two thick veins ran on the underside of that beautiful cock, and it was just so hard. But Katsuki was not kidding. That *will* tear him apart.

“Kacchan,” Izuku nervously said, “I’m not exactly sure how to…work…that.”

Katsuki’s hold on his hair softens, and his hand is on the base of his own cock, and he guides the monstrosity towards Izuku’s lips, “I’ll teach you. Open your mouth for me. Lick me up, Deku.”

It was if Katsuki’s words were magic, for Izuku, still keeping eye contact with the other, leaned his head forward until his lips bumped up against Katsuki’s cock. And a bit of the precum smeared on his lip, and Izuku lapped it up before wanting more. Fuck, he wanted more.

Izuku brought his hands up to the base of the thick cock, replacing Katsuki’s own, and brought the swollen tip into his mouth, drinking up as much precum as he could. Katsuki’s cock tasted so good, and my god, was it *so* big. Izuku felt as if he was struggling to put the girth in.

“That’s right,” Katsuki almost cooed to him, “Take me in, just like that.”

The praise fueled something in Izuku, and he wanted so badly to take in more. And so the greenette continues to not just suck on the tip, but take it in deeper. It would be impossible to

really shove it all in, but Izuku did his best, and slowly took in more of the cock with every bob of his head.

Going slow at first, the sweet and drawn out sensation made Katsuki turn his head up towards the sky in pleasure. Seeing this ignited a hot flame in Izuku, and he began to go faster. The pick up in pace made the blonde look back down, and raise an eyebrow at how eager Izuku looked, lips wrapped around his cock like that and moving faster by the moment. He was doing so good, but Katsuki wanted to make him choke.

Holding the back of Izuku's head, after the greenette begans to get a rhythm in, Katsuki ruins all of that by pushing his length deeper inside of Izuku's throat, immediately bringing tears into the other's eyes and then, Katsuki's hips begin to thrust in wildly. As if he was desperate just to fuck into Izuku's throat. There was no rhythm, but aggressive, desperate throat fucking, and Izuku was whimpering through the experience, but he didn't want it to stop. He wouldn't have minded if Katsuki came down his throat too. He liked how there was no rhythm, for it only proved how fucking desperate Katsuki wanted to be stuffed down his throat.

Izuku loved this. He loved the thick shaft of cock buried deep in his throat, slamming in and out. He loved the grip on his hair. He loved Katsuki's balls slapping up against his saliva soaked chin and the taller shoves his cock deeper and deeper. He didn't even care to think if he'll regret this.

And then it was gone. Katsuki pulled out, eyes looking almost wild as he leans back down to kiss Izuku deeply, knowing full well the boy just had a mouthful of his dick.

"Kacchan, you taste so good," Izuku begged. He wanted to be selfish and want more and more.

"Do I?" Katsuki asks him, body hovering above Izuku's as his hands wrap around the smaller's boxer waistband, "Spread your legs for me."

Izuku complied, spreading his legs. And Katsuki, like a madman, gripped the fabric and tore it apart. The plaid laid on the truck bed torn to death, and Izuku was suddenly exposed to everything. His hard leaking cock was nowhere as big as Katsuki's, but the look of it seemed to make Katsuki's eyes dilate and mouth water, so he wasn't too shy.

Katsuki reached for his wallet, and pulled out a packet of lube and a condom. Izuku raised a brow.

"Just in case," Katsuki grumbled, and then tore the lube packet apart, spilling it all over his fingers and with one arm, flips Izuku over, the pulls his hips up until his ass was thrusted into the air. Katsuki grabbed a handful of just beautiful plump cheeks and kneaded it.

Katsuki let out, going wild from the pleasurable sight.

Izuku's back was then pushed down against the comforter, ass up, and the greenette looked back as far as he can from the side, "Go easy on me, okay?"

“No fucking way,” Katsuki growls, and then within a minute, spread those cheeks to reveal that pink and puckered hole, then plunges one finger into Izuku’s hole. Izuku’s eyes go wide and his mouth gapes at the intrusion that didn’t wait for anyone.

Izuku lets out a cry, and he gasps, trying to adjust to Katsuki now ramming his finger roughly in and out of that right hole.

Katsuki says darkly, “If you can take four fucking fingers from that piece of shit, you’ll take mine.”

Izuku’s eyes roll back at the sound of that possessiveness, and he gets used to the ramming, thrusting his hip back. And feeling this, Katsuki adds another finger in and rams it in even harder and faster. The lube made sounds as Izuku’s ass was destroyed with just two long and thick fingers, and Izuku bit the comforter to suppress his moans.

Katsuki grabs the back of his hair and pulls it back out of the comforter, “Get your face out of the fucking pillow. I’m going to hear your scream.”

And Izuku does. Especially as Katsuki adds in a third and a fourth. It was thicker than his dildo, and Izuku was so fucking stretched as Katsuki fucks him solely on those rough hands. And somehow, he was still so damn tight. Izuku’s hips slammed back on the fingers, but he needed more friction. He needed Katsuki inside of him.

“Kacchan,” Izuku panted as his ass was getting finger fucked, “Please. Inside of me.” He couldn’t even string together coherent sentences.

“Tell it to me clearly, Deku,” Katsuki says to him.

Katsuki pulls out his fingers in one go, and Izuku whimpers at the loss, and begs the blonde, “Fuck me. I need you inside of me.”

“Shit,” Katsuki grabs his ass, “I can hear that all night.”

And holds up Izuku’s hips some more, pulling up back, and Izuku waited in anticipation. This would be his first time, and Izuku knew that nothing after this would never feel the same. Not after this cock. Katsuki positioned the tip at his entrance, and Izuku’s hole twitched at the touch. It was so warm, and prodded there, smearing what felt like more precum. Or maybe it was the lube. Either way, Katsuki rolled on a condom, as the tip hits up against his hole. And then began to push the tip in. And he pushed in slowly, which Izuku was grateful for.

Katsuki’s fingers were different from the long cock that belonged to the athlete. Izuku let out small cries and moans the entire time that Katsuki was trying to get his dick situated all the way inside of his ass. Izuku could not actually fucking believe it. He was getting fucked by the one person who he’s always been beside since he was little. The person who he’s watched fly for so long, and the greenette couldn’t help but revel in the fact that Bakugo Katsuki’s cock was getting pushed deep inside of him. So deep that it felt like his stomach was getting filled up. And then, after what seemed like forever, Katsuki bottomed out, and Izuku could barely breath from how filled he was.

Katsuki cooed him the entire time, waiting for the shorter male to give the go ahead. And Izuku stays there, head buried in the comforter collecting himself and trying to clear the pain out of his body, for a little bit longer. And the entire time, Katsuki's hands touch him all over, and his lips kisses the greenette's neck and down parts of Izuku's back.

Finally, the doe eyed boy turns back, and begs to taller, "Move."

And Katsuki does just that. The blonde was not merciful. Waiting for Izuku to be acclimated to the size of his cock first entering was the last ounce of consideration that Katsuki had. Because after that point, the blonde goes batshit, losing complete control as he pulls out and then pushes in immediately. Izuku lets out a cry of both pain and pleasure, and tells Katsuki to keep going.

He didn't need to, because Katsuki's pace was brutal. Not only was his pace brutal, the power in each thrust was insane. Izuku never imagined what his first time would feel like, but he couldn't imagine he would feel this full, this wrecked, or this fucking amazing. Every push inside of his ring of muscle made Izuku want to see stars more than the one he already was seeing above him. The music had stopped, and all the sound they had was the natural outside and the slapping of Katsuki's cock into Izuku's lubed up hole.

It was a good thing that they were not in civilization, because there was no way that the greenette wouldn't have woken up the whole neighborhood. And so, Katsuki tried to make the other scream as much as possible. The blonde pushed his shoulders down to the comforter, used the other hand to hold up Izuku's hip, and then at a borderline insane pace, slams his cock as deep as it could go inside of the greenette's pretty hole.

"God," Katsuki tells him, "You're so goddamn tight. How the hell."

Izuku couldn't even reply. He was too busy losing his mind from how good it felt to be torn in half like this. Katsuki hits his prostate over and over again, and Izuku had to pinch himself so that he would last longer.

And they've been going at this for a while, no less. Katsuki had fucked him missionary, on his lap, had Izuku bounce on his dick, all types of ways. And Izuku didn't know how much more he could take until his legs completely gave out.

"Kacchan," Izuku cried, "I can't…I can't hold it back much longer."

"Then cum," Katsuki tells him, as he thrusts harder and faster if that was even possible, "Come for me, Deku."

Izuku bit his lip, wondering if he could last any longer, but when Katsuki continues to ram into his prostate, the smaller couldn't keep it in any longer. He came hard, and his body collapsed as ribbons of cum leaves his cute cock. His arms gave out, so did his legs, but *fuck*, it felt so good. The orgasm shook his body, leaving him in shambles, as his brain scrambles for a way to collect itself. His moans as he came were like a drug to Katsuki, for even though Izuku's legs gave out, the athlete continued to thrust even harder. And Izuku rides out his

orgasm intensely, as his ass was still getting pounded roughly. The large cock continuously pushes into Izuku, until soon enough, Katsuki was getting to the end of his line as well.

“Fuck,” Katsuki groaned, as he tilts his head back, “What the hell.”

Izuku would probably build his orgasm up again if Katsuki kept going, but the greenette frowned, looking back, “What’s wrong?”

“I’m gonna cum,” Katsuki said, looking down at his dick as he keeps hitting it from behind, “I don’t ever fucking cum this fast.”

Izuku’s eyes widened. This was *fast* for him? They have been doing this for a while. And yet, the statement almost made Izuku smug and feel prideful.

Katsuki plants a kiss on Izuku’s back, “You’re so fucking tight.”

Izuku whimpers in a sadistic type of pleasure. His ass was extremely sensitive post orgasm, and so every additional thrust that led up to Katsuki’s orgasm threw him in shambles.

But the blonde did cum. And when he did, Izuku enjoyed knowing that *he* did that. He was the one who had made Katsuki like this, arms shaking as he falls onto his elbows while he rides out his orgasm inside of Izuku’s tightness. The cum collected inside of the condom, so cleaning up was going to be easy; however, Izuku wondered how it would feel for Katsuki’s cum to have filled him up. But he couldn’t wonder for long before waves of post-pleasure bliss come down upon him. Katsuki’s orgasm settles, and Izuku hears the taller catch his breath again, before sliding out of Izuku’s ass and collapsing on the side.

Izuku turns his head over to the handsome blonde, who stares up at the cosmos and peels away the used condom, putting it to the side to dispose of later. And then it hits Izuku.

He just had sex with Katsuki. He just fucking had sex with Bakugo Katsuki. The boy he was in love with. The boy he should definitely have not done this with. The boy who had been in a dry spell for what felt like a while, just to break it with Midoriya Izuku.

And this clarity gave him both a feeling of further doom, yet a desire for more. This sex was something he knew he would want again. The sensations, the kisses, the touching, the sounds. Izuku knew he will be thinking about this for days to come. The only question was if the other felt the same.

They lay there side by side for a moment, unsure of how to navigate their new development. Izuku was afraid any word will lead to awkwardness. And so, he continues to look at the stars and fields for a little while longer, as they let their heart rate calm and their breathing go back to normal. Still naked, they just lay there and pray no bugs come for them.

Finally, Katsuki mentions once more, deep voice breaking the silence of the night air, “Remember what I said,” He hesitated, “I’m not going to co-”

“You’re not going to coddle me, love me, or fuck me tenderly,” Izuku finished with a soft voice, and then he went quiet, “I know, Kacchan. I know.”

And it goes back to silence again. He really was at a loss of how to navigate this. Tonight had been a fucking ride. He had simultaneously accepted that he was in love with Katsuki, while having sex with the boy in question pretending that the blonde’s indifference didn’t bother him. When it did. And if it didn’t kill him right now, then it surely will later.

They lay there for a while. That was good sex. There was no need to ruin the night by discussing what the hell just happened. They always had tomorrow. In the meanwhile, Izuku will replay every second of tonight over again in his mind.

Until Katsuki once more, interrupted, saying with a humorous tone, “Thought I wasn’t your type, nerd.”

Izuku blinked up at the stars, letting a small smile grow on his face as he just tells Katsuki straight up, “I lied.”

And that was that. It wasn’t as admittance to feelings, which would be too dangerous. Just an admittance to attraction, and for now, that’s all Katsuki needed to know. As if having sex with the blonde wasn’t enough to indicate that.

And after a moment or two, Izuku felt nervous but wanted to ask the same question. His words were quiet, “I thought I wasn’t *your* type.”

And maybe he had been so quiet that Katsuki didn’t hear him, because after a couple minutes of silence, Izuku turned his head to the side, to find that Katsuki was still looking up towards the sky, awake. He must not have heard, so Izuku leaves it like that. He turns his head back up to the heavens, enjoying the gift Katsuki gave him.

And he was about to simply slip away into a world of daydreams where he got to relive this past night, but in a world where Katsuki loved him too, when—after so long—Katsuki finally responded to his earlier statement.

And Izuku heard it clearly.

“I lied.”

Chapter End Notes

I actually hate this chapter haha im so sorry for this shit chapter.
And I'm sorry for being late it'll go back to normal soon :(

But I love the discussion in the comments haha I want to just scream ‘HOLD ON TO THAT THOUGHT. JUST WAIT’.
Again thank you so much for everything. I love you guys so much
Twt: Suffocatingspr1

# Chapter 9: The Lighthouse

Chapter Notes

33.8k words! sorry for the late update <3
Hella smut ahead

spotify playlist (u need this) :
https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy

Currently : unedited. typos will be fixed tomorrow I just wanted to get this chapter out 😭

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The drive back from the flower field was awkward, and that was disheartening considering that they haven't been truly awkward around each other since the drive to Hana's Diner the very first time they hung out. They were both quiet in their seats, unsure of what exactly there is to say, and even the smallest bump in the road scared Izuku, as they drove back without music.

What was even more disheartening was the crash that came following the high of having sex with Katsuki.

As they sit quietly in the car, Izuku wonders to himself how he got to this point. How he ended up underneath Katsuki like that. Breathing heavily into the other's ear as he gets torn apart in the best way like that. Handing himself over to the domains of pleasure in a strictly erotic dance with Katsuki's body like that. Gripping the blonde's shoulders like that. Running his nails down Katsuki's back, leaving angry red lines down his shoulders, like that.

And that was when Izuku's gut twisted all over again, as he is reminded of the evening at the beach when he saw those same red lines on Katsuki's back, due to someone else.

And he comes to realization now that he, Midoriya Izuku, is now just a name added to a list. A list that had plenty of others before him, and will have plenty of others after him. Izuku's eyes widened at this thought, and he gripped the hem of his own pants to prevent a small cry of pain from slipping through his lips. He was essentially shirtless, considering that Katsuki had torn it off of him in the heat of the moment.

The thought didn't settle well in his already fragile heart. The thought that nothing Izuku did tonight was new to Katsuki, or special. Not in the way it was for him. The way Izuku kissed him, touched him, took him in, were sensations Katsuki had felt already numerous times with

other people. People who were better, had more experience, who knew exactly what to do and how to do it.

God, he felt like a fool. He felt heat rise to his cheeks as his retrospective embarassement made it hard for him to breathe. Compared to Bakugo Katsuki, whose hands were full of experience and whose body knew exactly where to move at all times, Izuku probably seemed like a fool.

He was just another name on a list. *Great*, Izuku thought to himself, so this was what it was like to have fucked Katsuki. He wonders if everyone else whose slept with the blonde had felt this sense of existential doom. He was probably the least experienced out of the people who the other slept with, and Izuku wondered if Katsuki knew it.

"What is it," Katsuki finally said the first words of the night since they've gotten in the car. The road back was bitch black, and the crickets' song was haunting. The blonde's voice sounded tired and low, and his eyes were still trained on the road, face expressionless. Of course it would be.

Izuku didn't think he was making his internal anxiety obvious, so with a forced confident voice, the greenette asked, "What do you mean?"

Katsuki didn't fall for it, and a moment later, said, "Your pants are going to rip off if you grip it any tighter. You're breathing heavier. And you look like you need to throw up." He said in a monotonous voice.

Izuku looked down at his lap, and very softly laughed with no humor, "For someone who pretends to be nonchalant about everything, you've been watching me pretty closely, Kacchan."

To this, Katsuki only had this to offer, "I'm just making sure you're not getting any wrong ideas about what happened."

This made Izuku both more sad and angry.

"Wrong ideas?" Izuku asked, "Geez, Kacchan. Do you get this paranoid about every piece of meat that you fuck?" He knew his words were harsh.

"Piece of-" Katsuki's eyes darkened, "Oi, Deku, wha-"

"Am I wrong?" Izuku felt unfamiliar anger bubble up, "Because you just wanted to fuck, right? You don't want any of the baggage, right? So what am I but a piece of meat for you to stick your dick into."

Katsuki's tone was not happy, "Careful, Deku."

The seriousness in the blonde's tone made Izuku stop, and breathe. He wasn't used to letting his anger and sadness loose like this. Katsuki has had years and years to control his anger, meanwhile, Izuku has had weeks to understand himself a little more. He knew that if he were to speak any more, Izuku would end up revealing to Katsuki more than he needed to. And so,

after a couple more moments of Izuku making sure he does not end up blowing up on Katsuki over something as stupid as him not loving Izuku back, the greenette settles back into his seat.

"Did you enjoy it? Or not," Katsuki asked, very objectively, eyes still staring at the road.

Izuku is honest, "I did." A lot. A whole fucking lot.

Katsuki nods, "Good. It was your first time, right? How much did it hurt."

Izuku had a funny look on his face as he plays with the loose fabric on his pants, "How can you ask that, like a customer satisfaction review. And how would you know it was my first time."

Izuku's previous thoughts about him being more inexperienced than others who Katsuki's been with before was only reaffirmed, and his face flushed.

"Was it not?" Katsuki's tone had an edge to it.

"Did it feel like it?" Izuku asked quietly.

To this, Katsuki replied rather quickly.

"No," The blonde says, while his knuckles visably gripped the steering wheel tighter, "It didn't. Not in the fucking slightest."

Izuku blinked, feeling just a little confused. Katsuki sounded angry.

Katsuki spoke up again, the speed of the car unintentionally getting faster, "So?"

Izuku looked out onto the road, "Yes?"

"So," Katsuki seemed as if he really didn't want to ask, "Has anyone touched you like that before."

Izuku wanted to know why Katsuki was so curious about this. But the greenette bit his lip before confessing, "No."

The speed of the car goes down, and Izuku has a feeling their conversation was intertwined. The doe-eyed boy looks over at Katsuki now, and points out the uneven playing ground they were standing on.

"I guess I wouldn't have to ask you," Izuku tells Katsuki.

At this, the blonde in question let out a slightly aggressive scoff, "What the hell is wrong with you. First, you asked me to fuck you. I told you that I'm not going to fucking treat you like a princess, and you didn't care. And now, after we fucked, you want to complain?"

"I'm not complaining," Izuku tried to salvage himself as he realized Katsuki was right. It was not Katsuki's responsibility to love him back, or anything of the sort, especially when it was

Izuku who had let this happen.

"Oh yeah?" Katsuki shook his head and chuckled, "Deku. I admit. I can often be the unreasonable one, but right now, you are. Get a hold of yourself. We just fucked. That's it."

Izuku's cheeks reddened, and he looked away, knowing Katsuki was right. In an apologetic voice, the shorter confessed, "I'm sorry."

Katsuki sighed, and lifted his right hand before putting it back down as if he didn't know what to do either, "Listen. Let's not make it a big deal, alright? Shit happens. You wanted to fuck, I wanted to fuck, and so we fucked. It was a one time thing. We don't gotta talk about it again."

One time thing. That's what Izuku heard, and he really wanted to just disappear, even though he knew damn well going in that this was how it was going to turn out. Like everyone else, he was a one-time fuck, and to be fair, he made it seem like that was what he wanted to. *Just for tonight,* he had said. Just for tonight, he had convinced himself that it was going to be okay. What a fool he was.

Izuku knew from the moment Katsuki entered him and fucked him like there was no tomorrow, that he wasn't going to have enough. Just for tonight was such a convoluted lie that will haunt him for the rest of his life, because God, if he could be fucked by Katsuki like that every day, he would. At least then, he'd have the closest remnant of a real relationship with the taller.

Izuku wanted Katsuki so bad. He loved him, how could he not? But he wanted Katsuki to want him so bad that it couldn't just be a one-night stand. He wanted Katsuki to desire him so badly that there will be a second time.

But Izuku just replies, "Okay."

Katsuki nods to himself, satisfied, "Good. Now tell me, are you okay."

Izuku would be limping tomorrow, and Katsuki knew it. Izuku knew that he was both mentally and physically not okay. Mentally, he was in agony knowing that tonight will stay on his mind for a long time while knowing he'll never be loved by this boy. Physically, his ass had just been pounded to death and there was no way he will recover by tomorrow.

But still, he wanted to make Katsuki angry.

"Why wouldn't I be," Izuku said with a happy smile, "Am I supposed to not be? Kacchan, don't tell me you think your dick is *that* good? I can barely feel it."

Katsuki slammed the breaks on the car, and Izuku's body flew forward, getting caught by the seatbelt, and his eyes widened as he looked over to the athlete. Katsuki's feet were glued to the break and they were stopped on the road, and the athlete turned over to Izuku then, challenge in his fiery eyes.

"Maybe you need a second fucking round," Katsuki tells him, words dripping with what could be anger or what could be desire.

Izuku's eyes were wide in shock, "Huh?"

"You heard me," Katsuki declares, "Mind opening your legs for me, Deku? Let me see that pretty little cock again."

Yes. Yes. Yes. Izuku wanted to say yes. He knew his body would refuse to move in the morning, but lord did he want to say yes. That being said, he didn't want to say yes now. Not when Katsuki's words throughout the night still stung him in way he couldn't explain.

Izuku looks at the boy now: ruby eyes lit up, watching his every movement, car stopped in the middle of the dark road.

"Why?" Izuku feigns disinterest, "I thought it was a one time thing."

"Feel free to let me make it two," Katsuki replied without missing a beat, eyes looking hungry as if he hadn't finished his meal mere hours ago.

Oh. That was new, Izuku thought to himself. In all his years of overhearing stories and whatnot of Katsuki's escapades, there has never been a second time. Katsuki fucked, and then he left. He didn't ask for extras. He didn't go for seconds. Yet just now, the blonde had offered a second round, and Izuku was one second away from throwing his sense of self-preservation out the window and saying yes. He wouldn't mind Katsuki refreshing to him what it felt like to be filled, to be stuffed all the way in his stomach.

Izuku was lost in thought, so Katsuki spoke up again.

"Give me the green light," Katsuki began his proposal, "And I'll make you cum twice."

"And if you can't?" Izuku said, while unbuckling his seatbelt, not breaking eye contact with the blonde.

Katsuki laughed, and leaned in, reaching over to grip Izuku's chin and tilting it towards the taller male, "Then we'll be here all morning."

That was a good bargain. And Izuku made his impulsive purchase. With desire too evident in his eyes, Izuku doomed himself again.

"I guess I can't deny such generosity," Izuku said, even though his gaze was already on the way Katsuki's adams apple swallowed as the athlete gave Izuku's body a look down.

Without wasting another second, Katsuki ordered him, "Come here."

Izuku glanced at the small space, and had no idea how they were going to fuck. Katsuki moved his chair back, and Izuku crawled over the median, swinging his legs around until he was slowly settling over Katsuki's hips.

The blonde placed both hands on his hips, and seductively whispered to him, "That's it, baby. Come down."

Izuku didn't know what possessed him to suddenly cut Katsuki off, "Don't call me that."

Katsuki didn't seem to take it seriously, and moved his hands over to Izuku's ass while giving the other a lazy look, "And why not, hm? You don't like it, baby?"

No, he didn't. Not because he didn't want to be called baby by Katsuki, but because he knew the ease at which the blonde said that showed him that Katsuki called all of his conquests baby. To make them feel special, to make them feel more in the moment. As if it was a small treat, for being such a good little fuck.

"No, not from you," Izuku kisses him, deeply.

And Katsuki reciprocates, moving in sync with the other in his lap, hands massaging parts of Izuku's body, before pulling back a mere inch, "If not from me, then who else?"

Izuku rests his forehead up against Katsuki, and his hands go down to his own pants, undoing them before Katsuki does it for him and rips apart the last piece of clothing he has on his body. He then leaves a light kiss on Katsuki's lips as he says, "Someone who means it."

There was a beat of silence, as the movement in Katsuki's body went more rigid than the smooth experienced actions that Izuku was used to. And the foreign hands on his body felt as if it wasn't exactly sure what to do for a second, as something unrecognizable passes briefly through Katsuki's expression. And Izuku wasn't exactly sure of what to make of it, but whatever it had been, passed, as Katsuki's body relaxed once more.

"Someone who means it, huh," Katsuki says outloud, as if contemplating it, "I hope when you find that someone, you're reminded of how much better my cock is when he's fucking you." Katsuki says nonchalantly, before moving them so that Izuku was brought up and his pants slid off completely, leaving the greenette completely naked once more.

Izuku's eyes widened, as he stammered, "Kacchan!"

"What," Katsuki asked, both bored and maybe even a little pissed.

Izuku furrowed his brows, "How can you say that?"

"Because I wanted to," Katsuki tells him, and gestures at Izuku, with his hands "Now sit back, and play with your cute cock. I'll tell you when to stop."

Izuku flushed, and he asked, "I thought you were supposed to make me cum, Kacchan."

"We'll get there," Katsuki tells him, before leaning back to watch, "Right now, I want you to touch yourself."

Izuku blinked at him, but felt a warm pool of desire settle in him, as Katsuki's hooded gaze looked on eagerly on his body. It made him feel preyed upon, as if Katsuki was admiring something he was planning to devour. He liked it. As Izuku sits back on Katsuki's lap, he

brings his hands down his body until it reached the base of his cock. And underneath him, Izuku could feel Katsuki shift into a better position to watch, and it made the greenette excited. He strokes up his shaft once, and licks his lips as he does so, breathing in as his still sensitive cock enjoys the touch.

Katsuki has his elbow leaning on the window sill, and the blonde's rough fingertips were thumbing at Katsuki's own bottom lip, as he watched. Izuku continues to touch himself, getting hard rather quickly from how incredibly erotic the situation is, and gradually, his hands on his cock speeds up, as well as his breathing rate. Parting his lips, Izuku let out tiny breathy moans that enveloped the car, and Katsuki's face was filled with unblemished desire.

"Stop," Katsuki tells him with a low voice, and the athlete's hands were on him in a second. As if he had been holding back everything in him just to sit back and watch, Katsuki's movements were desperate, hungry. He grabbed, and touched, and kissed Izuku with an intensity that Izuku could barely keep up with. Izuku found it difficult to handle all of the sensations coming at him, and held onto Katsuki's shoulders as the blonde buried his face in Izuku's neck, as his hands grab Izuku's ass to spread them apart.

"You were lying to me, Deku," Katsuki tells him, as his fingers circled the still lube-slick hole. Izuku's back arched at how sensitive that area still was.

Izuku panted, "About?"

"Barely feeling it," Katsuki chuckles, "You think I wouldn’t notice? You limping to the passenger seat?”

“If you noticed,” Izuku said while nipping at Katsuki’s bottom lip, “Why are you bothering to prove yourself, Kacchan?”

The blonde stuffed two fingers immediately into Izuku’s hole, causing the other to whimper out, before teasing him, “Maybe this is just my excuse for a second round.”

The greenette’s eyes flew open at the rough intrusion, and he almost forgot to register Katsuki’s words. The blonde wasn’t playing around, nor was he beating around the bush. Using the leftover lube still slick on Izuku’s hot walls, Katsuki finger fucked him in the front seat of the car, as Izuku rolls his head back in pleasure.

“ *Fuck* ,” Katsuki sounded exasperated, “How the hell are you still so tight.”

The boy in question bit into Katsuki’s shoulder to suppress a moan, but the blonde pulled away in a jerking motion, before warning Izuku, “Don’t leave marks.”

Izuku was taken out of his bliss for a second at the command, and his eyes open to stare up at Katsuki’s fierce ruby gaze. The blonde looked rather serious about it, and although it hurt a bit to see that the athlete seemed so appalled at the thought of being marked by Izuku, the greenette nodded. So nothing could be permanent with Katsuki, it seems. Their friendship, their intimacy, not even the touches that Izuku was allowed to give.

Before Izuku was able to think on it any longer, Katsuki continued, this time adding another finger.

Izuku, still shaken by the earlier command, told the blonde with lies in his mouth, “Hurry up. I’m getting bored.”

Katsuki begins laughing, even though nothing was humorous, “Bored, huh. That’s a first.”

The blonde then reached into the center console, and began to grab at something with his left hand, while his right fingers still worked at Izuku. Bringing what looked to be a condom to his teeth, Katsuki rips the package open and with one hand slips it onto his leaking cock.

“What,” Izuku asked, trying to calm his panting, “Not used to not being praised for every-*Fuck!* ” Izuku cursed, which he rarely did.

Because Katsuki. Fucking Katsuki Bakugo, without any warning, pulled his fingers out and without a moment of hesitation, began to stuff Izuku. The greenette’s legs immediately wrapped around the blonde’s waist, and he cried out in both pleasure and pain.

Katsuki laughed again, arms holding onto either side of Izuku, “No matter what you say, Deku, your body responds to me.”

Izuku couldn’t help but moan as Katsuki slowly bottoms out inside of him. His tight walls were still extremely sensitive, “Shut up.”

Katsuki continues, resting his forehead up against Izuku’s as he proceeds to push his thick length inside of the tiny hole, “So sensitive. How cute,” Katsuki stretches him apart, “Tell me again. You were bored?”

The blonde then lifts Izuku’s legs up and pushes even deeper at an angle, “My apologies, Deku. Let me show you just how exciting I can be.”

And then, without further notice, Katsuki began to slam his cock out and back in Izuku’s hole, not bothering to gradually pick up the pace. The athlete immediately went in at an intense pace, and Izuku’s mouth was open, bits of drool pooling at the sides of his mouth, as he attempts to watch Katsuki’s heavy cock ram its way inside of him. He ultimately gives up, not being able to hold his body together, as he is utterly destroyed from the inside and was loving it, and his head hits the back of the seat, chest breathing heavily, lips swollen with a sheen of saliva from Katsuki’s rough kisses.

“Kacchan,” Izuku moaned out his name.

“Katsuki,” The blonde corrected him, as he continued to hit every crevice deep inside of Izuku. The greenette will feel the gap in his stomach when this was over, he knew it.

The smaller boy complied immediately, “Katsuki, please,” He breathed out.

At this, the athlete flips their positions so that Izuku was back on top of the other, but instead of making Izuku do any work, Katsuki simply lifts Izuku’s hips from the riding position, and proceeds to fuck up into the smaller boy. Izuku’s eyes flew open as his chest collapses on top

of Katsuki's, while the blonde holds him up by the ass and his hips thrust upwards into Izuku. The car was shaking, and Izuku was grateful that they were in the middle of bumfuck nowhere, or else, being parked in the middle of a forest road just to fuck like desparate bunnies would've been a problem.

Their breathing was ragged, and Izuku's plump ass jiggled every time Katsuki fucked up into him. Izuku was in bliss. His head was clouded with the overwhelming feelings of Katsuki's touch, Katsuki's breathe, Katsuki's movements inside of him. His blood was rushing everywhere, heart pumping overtime. He could do this forever.

And Izuku, in his state of daze, voiced it too, "I c-could…" He panted, "...do this all night."

Katsuki chuckled, as he pulls Izuku in for a kiss that involved tongue play, before grinning, "Careful what you wish for."

And Izuku honestly was grateful he wasn't being careful, because he ended up lasting only about ten minutes longer before he came all over his own stomach, followed by Katsuki not too long afterwards. Izuku's body shakes as his second orgasm of the night hits, and his body buries itself in Katsuki's arms, unable to pick himself up.

Katsuki, without a word, moves Izuku off of him and to the side. And they don't lay in each other's arms, which Izuku's chest twinged at. But rather, next to each other, both boys collect their breathing, as Katsuki slides the condom off, tied a knot at the end, and puts it in a small bag for disposal.

Again, Izuku observes the smooth movement, and comes to the realization all over again just how experienced Katsuki was at this. Everything felt so fluid. And Izuku dooms himself to wondering in his post-orgasm clarity how many times the other has fucked someone just like this in this car. He knew it wasn't his business, his life, or his choices. And yet, the greenette could only do so much about his insecurity.

Izuku stares at the boy he was painfully in love with, a realization he had just mere hours ago, and felt a sick sadness knowing this was the only way he could have Katsuki. In the small hours in the night where the only ones who could see were the crickets that sang its song for them.

Katsuki sat forward, tapping his hand on the console, as Izuku just laid back to collect himself. The greenette raised a hand up to trace over the tattoo on Katsuki's back once more, gliding his fingers over the wings and then over to the intense eyes that almost resemble Katsuki's own. Strength. Flight. Hawks were predatory animals, with sharp talons deadly enough to pierce through hearts. And just about now, Izuku felt like the prey.

The blonde turned his head around, looking at Izuku's still naked body, and leaned down to run a finger over the boy's freckles, before asking, "I got three more," Gesturing to the condoms in the center console, "We could run through the whole pack."

Izuku's jaw dropped, and he blinked up at Katsuki, "We could what?"

Katsuki dropped his forehead down to Izuku's, "Run through the whole pack. Stay here until morning."

The other giggled, putting his hands over his face,, "Kacchan, you can't physically do that."

"Oh yeah?" Katsuki grinned, reaching up to remove Izuku's hands, "Try me."

Izuku gave Katsuki a funny smile, "We're in the middle of the road."

"We are," Katsuki nods, "We could do it in the middle of your driveway, if you prefer to be closer to home."

Izuku flicked Katsuki on the arm, "As if my relationship with my mom isn't strained enough."

"I wonder how…" Katsuki placed kisses along Izuku's jaw, "...Auntie would enjoy knowing her precious little son got fucked over," A kiss on Izuku's chest, "and over," Another one on the boy's stomach, "And over," And one on Izuku's hips, "And over again, by me." Katsuki chuckled.

Izuku's face flushed from the thought, and his legs pushed together as Katsuki got lower, "K-Kacchan."

The other hummed, tilting his head back up to look at Izuku then waited.

Izuku looked into those eyes, and knew that there was no way he was going to ever say no, which killed him. Because he knew what was good for him. He knew what would safeguard him when this all goes up in smokes. And yet, as he looks into the eyes that he loved, filled with lust for *him* and only him at this moment, Izuku knew he was done for.

"Run through the pack," Izuku tells him in a soft plea. If it was one night, then hell, Izuku was going to make the most of it.

It wasn't one night.

If Katsuki had been the one to propose that, then the blonde sure pretended that he forgot about it. In fact, not only did Katsuki pretend he forgot that what had happened was supposed to be a *one* night thing, but the athlete decided that he simply was not going to have enough.

Yes, they ran through the condom pack, and when 6 AM came and he had to practically carry Izuku inside, considering the other could not walk, the first thing Katsuki seemed to do was go buy another one.

How did Izuku know this, exactly? Because there was a knock on his window the very next day after classes, and when Izuku painfully walked over to the window, knowing exactly who was on the other side, Katsuki hopped in and stood up in front of Izuku, looking down at the much shorter male.

Izuku stared up at the massive 6’4 blonde with wide eyes, who looked down at him with complete and utter desire, and before he could even ask what was going on, Katsuki cupped Izuku’s soft face in his rough palms and pulled him into a deep kiss. Those sweet lips that tasted like sugar.  Izuku, shocked by the action, couldn’t move for a moment as Katsuki goes all in, but after a moment, the greenette, deciding he’ll ask questions later, wraps his arms around the taller and equally desperately returns the kiss. And for another five or so minutes, they roughly make out, as if running out of time, before Izuku pulls away.

“Is this what you’re here for?” Izuku asks him, a small trail of saliva leaving his lips, “To fuck?”

“Yes,” Katsuki nipped at Izuku’s bottom lip, “And to steal you away to play some basketball.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku gave him a look, “You can’t possibly think that after last night, I can play basketball right now.”

Katsuki hummed in consideration, “So just fucking then, huh.”

The greenette rolled his eyes, “What happened to this being a one night thing?”

“I don’t remember that,” Katsuki denied, “If you don’t want to, that’s fin-”

“I want to,” Izuku said, before his rational side could catch up. Yes, he wanted to. Even with the searing pain in his ass, the soreness in his thighs, and the hollow feeling in his gut, Izuku couldn’t stop thinking about the previous night. He wanted to. *Fuck* , he wanted to so badly.

Katsuki raised a brow, “You’ve seem to have given this some thought.”

Izuku stared up at the taller with big eyes, “You seem to have as well.”

“So I have,” Katsuki tells him then, “Tell me. What conclusions have you’ve gotten to, Deku.”

Izuku still has his arms around Katsuki’s shoulders, and his eyes lay on Katsuki’s lips. His heart was beating fast, and he was trying to find an answer that wasn’t too indicative of the emotional struggle he was dealing with internally.

Izuku answered, “I…” He wasn’t sure how to word it, “I want more.” He tells Katsuki.

If he were being honest, Izuku wanted more of everything. He wanted more tenderness. He wanted more time. He wanted more of Katsuki’s feelings, even if he knew he wouldn’t get it. But if all he could receive was more sex, then he’ll take what he can get.

“Good,” Katsuki tells him, forehead against forehead, “I need more.”

The slight change in wording surprised Izuku, but it only fueled the fire in his system. And Izuku’s eyes widened at Katsuki’s statement, and they held this strange contact for a while, where Izuku wonders if this was all just a game to Katsuki or if these words were actually coming out of the other’s mouth. He only had time to contemplate a little bit, before Katsuki

leans his head back down to take up Izuku's lips in his own, and the greenette closes his eyes to receive the kiss.

What was happening, Izuku wonders to himself. It always felt like just as he gets comfortable, some change blows in and makes him realize that there was more he needed, more he wanted. And he wonders just how long this new dynamic between them could last before another storm comes forth and leaves him needing more than just this soulless intimacy not meant for true lovers. Katsuki's hands loved to touch him, he knew that for sure. His shirt was runched up in Katsuki's palm, and the other was pressed up hard against him, and Izuku felt as if his breath was stolen straight from his lungs as Katsuki kisses him deeply. And just as it looked like the blonde was going to go further, Izuku put a hand on his chest.

"Wait," Izuku felt a little pained to even say it.

Katsuki pulled away, and looked down at the short doe-eyed boy.

Izuku swallowed, unsure of whether or not he should request this. But for his own good, feels like he needs to.

"Sex…" Izuku nervously says, "Can we not do it today? I'm still very sore from last night."

The reason Izuku didn't particularly want to ask this was because he was stupidly afraid. He was afraid that if he were to say no to Katsuki, then the blonde would just turn to someone else. And everytime he thought of that, no pain in his body matched the pain he felt in his head, imagining those hands on someone else, those lips on someone else. Izuku was afraid that if he wasn't going to take his place in Katsuki's bed, then someone else would.

But he knew that was flawed in so many ways. And that he shouldn't feel pressured to sleep with anyone when his body wasn't feeling up for it. Still, that didn't erase the fear of losing the closest thing he had to real intimacy with Katsuki.

And it seemed like it showed, for the blonde asks him then.

"Of course, you idiot," Katsuki gave him a look then, "Why the fuck do you sound so nervous."

Izuku looked away, scratching the back of his neck, "Ah, do I?"

The blonde forced Izuku to look at him, "You do. Tell me. Why."

Izuku desperately wanted to avert his gaze again, but couldn't, so he just said, "I just don't want you to feel...dissatisfied."

Katsuki tongued his cheek, looking up at the ceiling, before moving his gaze back down to Izuku, telling him then with a stern voice, "Oi, nerd. If you ever fuck a piece of shit who would feel dissatisfied if you're not in the mood to mess around, then I'll go after him myself. And then I'll slap the shit out of you for making dumbass decisions."

Izuku laughed, feeling both slightly relieved that Katsuki always had a way of watching out for him with some life lesson, and strangely enough, sad that Katsuki didn't want Izuku to himself enough to care about the possibility of Izuku sleeping with somebody else. It was stupid, but Izuku wanted Katsuki to hate the thought of it so much, that he didn't even bring up the suggestion. Everything Katsuki said, his attempted threat, those were things protective friends said to each other. And Izuku didn't want to be friends.

"Come on, then," Katsuki then tells him, moving back.

Izuku frowned, "Um, where?"

The athlete gestures down the stairs, "To play basketball."

Izuku shook his head, "Kacchan, did you not see me in school today? I can't play basketball today, I can barely walk."

Katsuki snorted, "Sure did. You should have seen Fuck Face's expression."

"Kaito?" Izuku's eyes widened, as he remembered.

"Seeing you fucking limp around," Katsuki recalls, "I hope the shithead knew it was me."

Izuku exasperated, "Kacchan! That's not funny. My friends were asking me what happened all day."

"Yeah?" Katsuki asked, intrigued, "And what did you tell them."

Izuku looked away, "I said I fell down my stairs," He blushed, before pointing fingers, "Which is what's going to happen if you try to make me leave my room!"

Katsuki rolled his eyes and then turns around, dropping slowly to a low squat, "Get on, then."

"Huh?" Izuku blinked at Katsuki.

The blonde's head looked up, "Hurry up, shitnerd. Get on my back."

Izuku gently pushed Katsuki's head forward, "And do what, exactly?"

"Do I have to spell it out, Deku?" Katsuki groans, "We're gonna hang out, you little shit."

"Oh?" Izuku teased with a smile, "You're going to carry me everywhere?"

The blonde rolled his eyes impatiently, "Obviously. Now fucking get on."

"Fine, fine!" Izuku says before lowering himself onto Katsuki's back. The blonde easily moves his hands to stabilize Izuku's thighs, and stands up as if the greenette weighed nothing. Izuku holds on tightly, resting his chin on the boy's shoulder. He wonders how life could be like this for them. Just yesterday, Katsuki pinned him under the moonlight and took his virginity with no promises to be tender, and today, he was carrying Izuku on his back everywhere just so they could get out of this house.

Once Izuku got settled, Katsuki easily made his way out of the bedroom door and down the stairs, making stomping noises as he goes down and pretends to drop Izuku forward down the stairs, causing the smaller to threaten to pull pieces of Katsuki's hair out.

"Katsuki?" A feeble, womanly voice came from the kitchen.

Katsuki stops at the bottom of the stairs, and looks out onto the dimly lit kitchen where Inko Midoriya stands, a mug of tea in hand. Her eyes look a little forlorn, but she watches the two of them curiously, more specifically, the smile on Izuku's face that dropped into a sad expression once he sees his mother. Her hair was a bit of a mess, and the atmosphere in the bottom floor of the house was icky.

"Auntie," Katsuki nods towards her.

"Mom," Izuku says softly, eyes averting her gaze out of both guilt, pain, and residual anger.

"I didn't see you come in," Inko tells Katsuki.

At this point, Inko knew that there were ways to sneak in and out of the house, particularly through Izuku's room. So Katsuki just didn't say anything at all. He's come over quite a few times since the entire fiasco between Izuku and his mother, but Inko has mostly kept to herself, while watching their interactions rather closely.

"W-where…" Inko began, her quiet voice filling the even quieter house, "Where are you two going?"

Izuku moved his face so that his cheek rested against Katsuki's back on the other side, not directly facing his mother.

And so Katsuki answered for him, "We're going to the basketball court. Near Hinto Street."

"Oh…" Inko replies, and just stares down at her cup of tea for a moment before continuing, "Have fun, and...stay safe."

Izuku just paused. He could tell how much it pained her to say, and out of habit, his mother tacked on the stay safe at the end. And so, quietly, Izuku just replies, "Thank you."

Katsuki leaves the house, with Izuku on his back still, stepping down the porch before telling the shorter, "Reach into my pocket and get my speaker and phone out."

Izuku purses his lips, "Reach...into your pockets?"

"Yes," Katsuki gives him an amused look, "You were bouncing on my cock just yesterday, and now you're too fucking shy to reach into my pocket? Jesus, Deku."

Izuku's eyes widened, "Kacchan! Don't just say that out loud."

"Oh, my bad," Katsuki gestured up at the telephone poles, "It would suck if these crows overheard us."

Izuku just shook his head before reaching to the side to grab the speaker, and connecting it to Katsuki's phone. He waved the face ID in Katsuki's face to get access, and opened up his music.

"What song?" Izuku asked.

Katsuki thought about it, standing on the side, "Into The Night. By Benny Mardones."

Izuku types it in and laughs, "Do you even know what that song is about?"

The blonde shrugs, "Do I need to? I like the way it sounds."

The greenette just laughs to himself at the irony that he couldn't tell if he hated, or appreciated.

"Something funny?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku hums, "It *is* a nice song. It's about a guy. He sees a girl, who has a broken home life. Hence the line 'watching it all fall apart.' And-"

"You really about to give me a full song analysis?" Katsuki snorts.

"Yes," Izuku bops him on the head, "Now listen."

"I'm listening, I'm listening," Katsuki says to avoid being attacked.

"Anyways, so seeing this girl, he has a desire to whisk her away. You can really hear it in the chorus," Izuku says before going into song, matching the chorus as it comes up.

"If I could fly, I'd pick you up," Izuku goes into song dramatically, "I'd take you into the night, And show you a love. Like you've never seen, ever seen," He puts his arm out towards the sky in the end for dramatic effect.

Katsuki nods to this, "Yeah?"

"Yeah," Izuku nods and then glances to Katsuki, "So now to ask you, Kacchan, did you choose this song intentionally?"

Izuku asked because the parallels were glaring in his face. Broken home life. Falling apart. If I could fly, I'd pick you up. I'd take you into the night. What more could Izuku be alluding to.

Katsuki has a simple answer to that, looking up at Izuku, "Why would I have."

Izuku pursed his lips. Guess not. And shrugs, "Never mind."

And then they kept on walking, listening to the groovy, but slightly sad 80s track.

"One more thing," Katsuki commented, "Why is it so fucking hard to breathe in that house? Christ, Auntie looks rough."

“I know right,” Izuku laughs sadly, “She’s been kind of odd lately.”

“How so,” Katsuki inquires.

Izuku shrugged, “I don’t know. She just...only says a couple words here and there.”

“She’ll come around,” Katsuki says, “And if not, there’s only so much time you can waste waiting.”

“She’s my mom, Kacchan,” Izuku reminds him with a light chuckle, “It’s easy to say that you’ll give up, or run away, or hate a person when you’re watching from the outside. But when she’s your own mother, has clothed and fed you from birth, and made a lot of both great and bad memories with you, it’s not that easy.”

Katsuki listens. And Izuku was grateful for that.

“Everyone likes to get mad at my mom on my behalf, you included,” Izuku smiles, “And I’m grateful. Because I’m upset too. But at the end of the day, I still love her.”

“I know,” Katsuki says, walking along the road with Izuku on his back.

The streets were beginning to be tinted with gold, as the sunset settles onto the sky. It wasn’t rainy this week, as far as Izuku checked, which was a nice break from the weeks of rain they had previously. Although that was beautiful, he can only be away from the classic Ise sunsets so much.

“Weird, how love is,” Izuku talks to the sky, swinging his legs as Katsuki piggybacks him, “Someone can have the ability to crush your heart in the palm of their hands, stab it with words that kill and actions that torture. And you’d still hand it over to them.”

Katsuki seemed to not know what to say to this for a while, for the blonde goes silent in what felt like contemplation. He kicked gravel on the road under his feet as he walked, and Izuku just held on.

“Why would anyone do that,” Katsuki finally asks, tone genuinely curious, yet cautious.

Izuku laughs and looks down at Katsuki’s side profile, mapping the blonde’s jaw, his eyes, the bridge of his nose, “Because, love feels like flying.”

Katsuki slows down to a stop, looking ahead, words on the tip of his tongue, before glancing to the side where Izuku was facing, but not exactly looking at the greenette.

And Katsuki tells him then, “Everything that flies eventually falls.”

*Oh* .

The basketball court looked like the ones Izuku sees in movies, if that even made any sense. The outdoor court had faded floors, with chain-link fencing around the perimeter. Nearby was a convenience store, some neighborhood houses. And in the backdrop of the court was Ise's mountains looming high, with the golden clouds hanging over them, with ribbons of orange and pink splashing over the landscape.

When the two of them arrived, there was no one using the court, but Katsuki goes inside anyways, and squats to pick up a basketball. Izuku gets off in the process, and stands up on his own two feet, stretching his back. His shirt lifted slightly to reveal his toned stomach, and Izuku felt relaxed as a gentle breeze whipped through his hair.

Katsuki, ready to go, wearing basketball shorts and a red tee, begins to bounce the ball in his hands, while looking over at Izuku.

"This isn't even fair," Izuku complained, "You have a whole foot on me in height."

"I can't help that I was blessed, Deku," Katsuki shrugged and tossed the ball over to Izuku, "Here, you get the ball first then."

Izuku caught the ball in his hands, and bounced it a couple of times, before skirmishing around Katsuki. This definitely wasn't fair. Everything from Katsuki's vertical, width, movement, and whatever else was that of a god-tier athlete, and Izuku wondered if Katsuki just brought him here to boost his own ego.

Izuku feigns a throw, intending to catch Katsuki off guard, before darting to the side of the court. Katsuki of course, did not fall for the feint. Moving quickly to the other side caused a ripple of pain to shoot up Izuku's spine, and he winced out in pain and held his side. Letting out a small cry, Izuku clutches the ball tightly and bites his lip.

"Fuck," Katsuki notices and rushes over to Izuku, "Shit, we should take it easy. Are you o-"

Izuku drops the exaggerated act as Katsuki's guard is completely down, and uses this opportunity to throw the ball and score himself a point from where he was. Making it in, Izuku threw his hands up and cheered for himself.

Katsuki gave him a horrendous look, and pointed a finger at the shorter, "You're a cheating piece of shit, aren't you Deku."

Izuku laughs, "You being 6'4 and being in tip-top shape, while I'm short and in pain is cheating in of itself, Kacchan. I was just using my resources well."

Katsuki ran a hand through his blonde hair, "I can't believe you used my rare kindness to your advantage."

Izuku shook his head with a grin, "I really do appreciate your concern, Kacchan! Don't get me wrong."

"Too late," Katsuki fakes being betrayed, turning away from Izuku, "Our friendship is over. Tell Mr. Toshinori that you ruined everything."

“It’s all my fault, isn’t it,” Izuku nods, playing along, “How can I make it up? Would you like me to top for once?”

Katsuki raised a brow at him and lifts the side of his lip in disbelief, “Nerd, what kind of suggestion is that.”

Izuku continues to mess around with him, “I mean, you *are* the one who always tells me to be more spontaneous.”

“Nope,” Katsuki shakes his head and head towards Izuku, “I’m gonna pretend you didn’t fucking suggest that.”

“Why not,” Izuku backs away, laughing.

Katsuki rolls his eyes, and goes behind Izuku, crouching down to stick his head between the smaller’s legs, before standing up. Izuku immediately lost balance, before Katsuki stabilized him so that the greenette was now sitting on the athlete’s shoulders. Katsuki still held the basketball in his hands and held it up to Izuku.

“You want to slam dunk?” Katsuki asked.

Delighted, Izuku takes a hold of the ball, “Absolutely.”

And so, with Izuku on Katsuki’s shoulders, the greenette was successfully able to land a slam dunk. Exaggerated of course, but it worked. In times like this, it was easy for Izuku to forget that there was less than innocence going on between them. Even with the crude comments, when Katsuki did silly things like help him with a slam dunk, or had ridiculous conversation with him like usual, it was hard to think that just the day before, the taller was whisked him away to a wonderland where pleasure only temporarily replaced pain.

And even now, as they--after playing for a little while longer--sit on the ground of the basketball court, with the sun’s residual heat radiating from the ground even though the sun was quickly setting, Izuku finds himself reminded of the painful love he was feeling in every fiber of his being.

From the speaker, Right Here Waiting by Richard Marx was playing. As the romantic piano intro comes in, Izuku turns over to Katsuki and let the sweet music enveloped the air in which they sat, staring up at the mountains beyond the basketball court and the pink clouds that were getting darker as the sun dips below the horizon.

The glow on Katsuki’s skin looked like a soft pinkish orange, and Izuku could stare forever. In Izuku’s eyes, Katsuki was one of the more beautiful things that he’s had the pleasure of seeing. The blonde was not looking at him, but it was still nice. It was in these candid moments, where Katsuki looked peaceful in his presence, that Izuku appreciated him the most, for simply just being here with him.

Izuku begins to sing softly, as he turns his head back up to the sky, “Whatever it takes, Or how my heart breaks. I will be right here waiting for you.” He wishes what he was singing wasn’t true. God, he wishes it wasn’t.

If last year, someone told Midoriya Izuku that he would be having sex with Bakugo Katsuki on a pretty regular basis, he would think it was some sick joke. But now that it was happening, the greenette barely knew what to think of it. Not because there isn't much to think of. No, that wasn't the case at all. Rather, it was because there was simply too *much* to think about.

Ultimately, the sex was *incredible* . To be fair, Izuku had no one else to compare to, yet he still knew that the dick he was getting was not like anything else. It was Katsuki's. The person who everyone wanted, desired to the fullest. And yet, the blonde's nights were spent in Izuku's bed. Or maybe his car. Or just about anywhere. To Katsuki, it didn't matter the surface or the time, it felt as if the athlete had enough stamina for everything.

As for Izuku, he could barely comprehend that he was getting utterly destroyed either every night or every other night. His body has gotten relatively used to it, where the pleasure heavily outweighed any residual soreness he'd have, but only barely outweighs the mental struggle he'd deal with afterwards.

Izuku has picked up several things about both he and his 'friend' at this point. The first is that they could go several rounds, if there was enough time in between to recharge. And this was a little problem if it was late into the night, and Inko Midoriya was down the stairs and to the left. There was no option for Izuku to scream, so Katsuki would just fuck him with a hand clamped over the shorter's mouth. Izuku's tears from pleasure would run down the blonde's rough hands clamped tightly over his mouth, as the athlete would fuck into him from behind. Izuku's ass in the air, face stuffed into the mattress, with the sound of his cock slapping against Izuku's cheeks seemed to be one of Katsuki's favorite positions, considering how often he wanted Izuku in it. As for the greenette, he loved when he was in missionary, with his legs bent over Katsuki's shoulders, with the taller roughly pounding at an angle inside of him.

Katsuki found his spot every single time, and Izuku was such a screamer that the blonde either had to stuff the greenette's face into the mattress or clamp his hand like this. To ensure that the boy's mother would go up and see what the hell was going on. But Inko was the extent to which Katsuki cared who heard, because everywhere else was a free for all.

A rather stupid incident came when Izuku was pulled into the locker room of the pole vault team, during their block practice that happened *during* school hours. He had been dropping by to deliver something from the school's office, when Izuku was pushed into the locker room by none other than Katsuki himself, and hands were all over him in minutes. Clothes were off in even less. And the foreplay barely lasted any time, as Izuku and Katsuki both were already ridiculously turned on.

"Kacchan," Izuku moaned out as quietly as he could, head thrown back against the locker that he was being held up against, "N-Not here."

"Not here?" Katsuki's lips sucked on those puffy, swollen nipples that were so deliciously pink for him. His hands were holding up Izuku's waist as his cock was already positioned at

the boy's entrance, "Hm, why not."

Izuku thought back to the copy room incident, which left a bitter taste in his mouth. The girl. She wanted to do it with Katsuki in school too. What had the athlete said?

Izuku closes his eyes and breaths out as Katsuki already begins to push in deliciously, and Izuku honestly didn't want him to stop, " Don't want you to get kicked out…You...got a big future."

Katsuki grumbles in his ear, as his cock pushes further inside of Izuku's walls, "And you don't? Don't give me that bullshit."

"So?" Izuku says, as he contradictingly sinks down further on the blonde's thick length, "Point still stands. We…" He gasps as the full feeling overtakes him, "...shouldn't be doing this here. You could get in trouble."

Katsuki pulls his head away for a moment to look at Izuku, and then bluntly confesses, "Honestly, Deku?"

Izuku looks up at the blonde.

"I really don't give a fuck right now," Katsuki tells him,

For some odd reason, Izuku found that *incredibly* sexy. Not that he wanted Katsuki to risk being benched because of him or worse, but the mere fact that Katsuki needed to fuck him so badly that he didn't care turned him on. And as Katsuki fucks him against the locker, sweat slick on their back, and makes him cum on the athlete's practice jersey, Izuku couldn't even bring himself to have any regrets.

All of this time, Katsuki stayed true to his promise. During sex, he never treated Izuku tenderly. Once they both came, Katsuki pulled out and laid near, but never close enough to hold. He never allowed for any extra seconds to think too hard about what happened.

Katsuki was a beautiful, but cruel partner.

Izuku could never guess his place in Katsuki's life, besides generally knowing that the other cared for him to some degree as a friend, even a close one. They had sex, and plenty of it too. Katsuki loved to put his hands on him, in such a desperate way that Izuku craved. And yet, they were supposed to be nothing but friends.

Izuku should have expected a shift in their dynamic. *Goddamnit* , he should have expected it.

For all of the talk about not taking it seriously or letting it affect anything, Izuku should have known better. In what universe does sleeping with the person you love, who only sees you as a friend, not result in some sort of change. In anything, Midoriya Izuku should have blamed himself for being so naive.

The greenette couldn't even pinpoint what kind of change it was, since it was happening so gradually. Katsuki had never forgot to remind him of one last thing. ' *Just tonight* .' Katsuki had told him.

Sure. That was fine. No, it definitely wasn't, considering that he lost his virginity and was now getting fucked to death by the boy who came in and turned his world upside down in one night, and was told that he'll never be loved by him. And yet, Izuku was forced to believe that it'll be okay. They would somehow be normal throughout all of this. Or so Izuku thought.

What he had not expected was the *tension* . No, it wasn't necessarily awkward tension, not in the sense that they would sit near each other and have nothing to say. No, that was never a problem. This? This was something else. This type of tension stirred a fire in Izuku's stomach, and made his mind go on overdrive over what the *hell* just happened.

First, there was the eye contact. It seemed like every time they passed one another, Katsuki's eyes raked over him before catching his eyes, and *fuck* , was it odd how Katsuki would look at him. As if there was something he wanted to say or do, but didn't. Until later, when Izuku was in the sheets, moaning into a pillow as Katsuki takes his place on top of him. And even during the lunch break, when Izuku would be sitting down with his friends, Katsuki would walk in, and they'd look at each other. The blonde wouldn't drop his gaze as he walked, until he neared his table, and then Katsuki would continue on with whatever conversation he was having as if it was nothing. Many times, it wouldn't even result in sex. Katsuki just looked at him like that, just to say nothing in the end.

Second, there were the words unspoken. This was what annoyed Izuku the most, even though he was also guilty of it. There were times when, caught up by the allure of Katsuki, he opens his mouth, ready to ask or say something ridiculous like *hey, Kacchan, I love you* , before closing his mouth in realization.

What he hadn't expected, was for Katsuki to begin doing it too. The few moments where it seems as if Katsuki wanted to say something to him, but would hush up again and never did, confused him to no end. And all Izuku wanted to know was what exactly had been lost in those few moments of silence when Katsuki decided not to say whatever it was that he was thinking.

The most baffling moments came when Izuku was walking alongside his lab partner after class, having a relatively simple conversation, and the last thing Izuku expected to happen was for Bakugo Katsuki to have come out of nowhere and pushed in between them, only turning to see the mess of papers that his lab partner dropped on the ground after he had done so.

"Oi, Bakugo!" Kirishima called out from the side, "That's not cool."

Izuku looked over at Katsuki, who put both hands up and shrugged his shoulders, "My bad."

His lab partner, however, was not having it, and stepped forward towards Katsuki, "Dude, what the fuck. There's a whole open hallway, and you just pushed through me by accident? I call bullshit, Bakugo."

Izuku tried to mediate, “Hey, Anta, let it go.”

“No,” His lab partner’s brows were furrowed, and he looked towards the athlete, “Again, what the fuck is wrong with you.”

Katsuki put his hands in his pockets and sauntered forward with a condescending expression, “Listen to the nerd. Let it go.”

Anta scoffed, “You’re such a fucking piece of work.”

And when Izuku confronts Katsuki on it later that day, all he received was a rough fucking and some cryptic words in his ears.

“He’s told Shit For Brains about how much he wanted to fuck you, you know,” Katsuki growls as he makes his cock home inside of Izuku’s tight ass.

The greenette grips the bed frame of Katsuki’s guest room, and through panted breaths, turns back slightly to ask, “So you went and knocked his stuff over?”

Katsuki puts a hand on Izuku’s shoulders to pin him down to the mattress, “Told you, shitnerd. It was an accident.”

“So it wasn’t because you’re-” *jealous?* Izuku couldn’t finish the word, before Katsuki seemed to intentionally pick up his speed and intensity.

Jealousy. It was a nasty creature, one that seemed to be well laced in whatever strange relationship they had. One that crawled its way into Izuku’s mind and multiplied like a parasite. It sometimes consumed his thoughts, and if he thinks about it too long, it becomes hard to breathe. And so, little moments where it looked like Katsuki feels the same sparked an unfair hope inside of Izuku’s starved heart.

The growing insecurity within Izuku still persisted. He knew that with Katsuki, whose positive emotions have only begun to be accepted, everything was an uncertainty.

Their strange friends with benefits relationship was an uncertainty. All he knew was that they were there to touch each other in *that* way. He didn’t know if there were any others. He didn’t know if Katsuki left him early in the morning, just to lie with someone else the next day. He didn’t know if he was anything even special, or if he was convenient. All he *did* know was that he was at least desirable enough to be slept with, again. And again. And again.

“You never run out of energy. It’s unbelievable,” Izuku tells him once, while they lay side by side in the guest room’s silk sheets, having finished twice already. At this point, he was very well acquainted with Katsuki’s body, and vice versa.

Katsuki lazily looked over to the side, “I know, right?”

Izuku giggled, “How can you say that? Its *your* body, Kacchan.”

Katsuki hummed in acknowledgement, “Doesn’t feel like it.” He turns over to Izuku, placing a kiss near the greenette’s jaw, “I thought I was getting older, not younger.”

Izuku quirked his lip, “What do you mean?”

“I mean,” Katsuki lazily threw a hand up and shrugged, “I don’t know where this energy came from. It wasn’t fucking there before.”

“Is that where your dry spell came from,” Izuku turned to his side, lying naked next to the blonde.

To this, it doesn’t seem like Katsuki had a reply, for the blonde just looks up to the ceiling and says nothing. And this pushes Izuku to ask.

“What’s on your mind,” Izuku looks at him from a distance.

Katsuki then switched his gaze over to Izuku, and pinched the greenette’s nose, “Nothing for you to be concerned about, nerd.”

“Well what if I want to be concerned,” Izuku asked, pushing the issue a little bit.

The blonde then huffs and smiles slightly, “Then that’s your problem.”

Izuku frowned, “You’re mean, Kacchan.”

To this, Katsuki takes a small break, choosing to stare up at the whirring of the ceiling fan once more batting away the slight heat, and then just tells the other, “I know,” He spoke into the silence, and then repeated in a smaller voice, “I know.”

Izuku never wanted to have sex in Katsuki’s bed. Anywhere but there. He’d fuck on the hood of Katsuki’s car before he’d lay down in that intimate way on Katsuki’s bed. For what reason, Katsuki didn’t know. For Izuku, it was the stupid fact that he couldn’t handle his own jealousy. It was stupid, he knew it, but he couldn’t help but want to throw up thinking that he’s just another body on that bed. He wasn’t the first one to spread his legs for Katsuki, and he knew he wouldn’t be the last.

All he wonders now is if he’s sharing the same space as others. In that bed, did Katsuki bring anyone home when Izuku wasn’t there? In those sheets, was someone else calling out the blonde’s name when he couldn’t hear? He knew it was stupid, yet, he still rejected the offer when it’s presented.

It was driving him crazy, and felt like Katsuki was playing him like puppets on a string. Because Izuku was falling deeper into love by the day, to the point where he was drowning in his own unrequitedness. Why? Sure, Katsuki was a rather cruel lover, but boy, was he an intensely breathtaking *friend* . Just because they were having sex, didn’t mean that everything else stopped.

The stupid adventures that sent rushes of thrill through Izuku's dopamine craved brain were still happening, as Katsuki whisks him away from his home off somewhere. Izuku, with the state of his house being what it was, could honestly just leave out the front door and meet Katsuki in the driveway. But in light of tradition, the blonde still chooses to surprise the other by knocking on the window to 'sneak him out'. In a way, it was charming.

A knock comes on Izuku's window on a quiet Tuesday afternoon. They had not discussed going out or anything, so like how it often is, the blonde's presence comes as a surprise.

Izuku waltzes over to open the window, letting the blonde hop in.

"Kacchan, if you were anybody else, consistently knocking on someone's window without notice would be really creepy," Izuku laughed as he lets the boy in. He doesn't get to this day how exactly it got to the point where they hung out all of the time. It became so often that taking a picture for proof of the project's progression slipped their minds.

Katsuki grinned as he sauntered in, and reached a hand out to run his fingers through Izuku's hair, ruffling it up a bit, "You open your window automatically nowadays. One day, you're gonna open it, and it's not going to be me on the other side. What are you going to do then, nerd?"

Izuku shudders at the thought, "Stop, don't even suggest that, Kacchan. That's so creepy."

Katsuki picked up a flyer off the ground, and observed the contents before holding it up, "You going to this?"

"What's that for?" Izuku tries to look and recall, "Oh, the night market?" He thought about it, "Most likely. You want to come with?"

Izuku has also been getting better at initiating the plans, not just with Katsuki, but with the occasional times he hangs out with his friends. It felt good taking initiative. The only hard part was if the initiative was rejected. But Katsuki has yet to say no.

Katsuki hummed, "What's there. Just fruits and shit?"

Izuku laughed, "Kacchan, no! Have you never been?"

The blonde shook his head, "Nah."

"My mom does custom prints, as you know, so she has a stall every year," Izuku explained, "It was one of the few fun things I got to go to. The entire town square gets blocked off and redecorated to the point that you don't even recognize it! There are colorful lights everywhere, tons of booths set up in tables or even on the street where people around Ise and in the county can sell artisan crafts or whatever they want. There's a lot of good food stalls too, and um," Izuku giggled, "in the middle of the square near the fountain, there's always an outdoor disco that only the old people do."

Katsuki watched the boy enthusiastically talk about the event, and smiled to himself while tossing the pamphlet to the side, "Sounds interesting. Let's do it, nerd."

“Really?” Izuku asked, leaning against his desk that still had things spilled *everywhere* from the time Katsuki fucked him over it, “Are you sure? It’s tomorrow, and you have the tournament on Saturday.”

“That’s plenty of fucking time, don’t worry about it,” Katsuki brushed it off, “Speaking of that, I’ve been working on some new shit. You noticed, yet?”

Izuku frowned, not exactly recalling what Katsuki was talking about. Of course, he made his way to the blonde’s practices like he did, and spent some afternoons just staring at how the athlete flies, wondering if he’ll ever come down to pull him off the ground. And so, it seems that whatever new thing Katsuki was working on, it was a minute enough difference that it must’ve been in the smaller details. Izuku would have to look closer the next time he has practice. The blonde was still attempting to clear 17’11 as it is.

“I haven’t,” Izuku blinked up with wide eyes, “What is it?”

Katsuki cracked his neck and grinned, “Just come watch, Thursday.”

The greenette gave him a funny smile, “Haven’t I promised you before? You don’t need to ask.”

“People like to make a lot of promises, Deku,” Katsuki reasoned, “Just making sure.”

“I know,” Izuku rolls his eyes playfully, then asked, “Are you here just to hang out, then?”

"Nah,” Katsuki shooed him away, “Go change.”

“Change?” Izuku considers, “Into what?”

“Something you can swim in,” Katsuki pushed him towards the closet, “Hurry the fuck up. The sun gonna set soon.”

“I’m going, I’m going!” Izuku said before rushing into his closet and grabbing a pair of swim trunks. He hasn’t had to use these much before Katsuki started whisking him away, but now, he has four or so, and they’re staples of his closet.

They end up driving towards the coast, which makes Izuku think that they were just going to the beach. The sun was moving across the horizon, and it looked like a scene from a movie. The windows were rolled down, Izuku’s green hair was bouncing in the wind, and Katsuki’s ray bans framed his face well. A nice track played in the background: Is This Love by Whitesnake. It was released in 1987 if Izuku could recall, and he tapped his fingers against the side of the car as the chorus comes in. Their whip cruises down the seaside road, and Katsuki takes a left towards the mountains a bit, more towards the undeveloped coastline.

“Where are we going?” Izuku asked over the music and wind blowing through the car.

Katsuki points towards the distance, “There. I haven’t been here before. I’m not even sure if we should be doing this.”

Izuku cranes his neck, “Where? And that’s a little scary, Kacchan,” He laughs, “If *you* aren’t sure we should do it.”

“My judgement ain’t that great sometimes, nerd,” Katsuki chuckled, “I fucked your brains out in a school locker room.”

Izuku flushed and shrivelled into his seat, “You know, Kacchan, if you don’t make comments like that, I would totally forget that we do that...kind of stuff.”

Katsuki raised a brow, as he drives towards the end of a road, where the rocky mountain side began, sitting right on the beach, fifty foot high rock cliffs that the waves were crashing against. And then above the cliffs were where the mountain’s green trees began, but Katsuki parked at the deadend.

“You’ve taken my cock at least thirty different ways now, and you can’t even say sex?” Katsuki sneered, “Come on, I like it when you dirty your mouth.”

Izuku elbowed him from the side and decides to ignore the comment, “Anyways, this is a dead end. Are we going to scale the rock or something?” Izuku takes a wild guess.

“Precisely, nerd,” The athlete confirms and exits the car, kicking off his shoes and taking his shirt off before tossing it in the back, “Come on, take off your shirt and shoes.”

“Wait, what?” Izuku says as he stumbles out of the car, questioning the other, but still taking off his shirt and flip flops anyways.

Katsuki locks the door and begins jogging across the sand towards the rock cliffs, and Izuku runs after him. The blonde walks towards the water’s edge, where the waves ebb back and forth inland, and his eyes scan the uneven rocks. Izuku just follows him.

Finally, Katsuki spots what looks like a path with little bars nailed into the side of the rocks to help with stability, “There it is. The old hag was telling me some shit she used to do when she was a teen.”

Izuku hummed as he listens.

Katsuki continues, “She said that they used to scale this rockside, and there was a path, but no one’s used it in a while ever since a kid slipped and died,” Katsuki laughs.

Izuku looks at him stupidly, “Kacchan, why are you laughing.”

The boy in question shrugged before grabbing onto a rung and lifting himself up, “Shit, I don’t know. The hag just said it so casually, it was hilarious,” Then looked back down at Izuku, “You got it?”

Izuku appreciated that Katsuki asked him if he could do it himself before putting a hand out. That was one of the things he silently appreciated about the athlete: his first assumption was that Izuku could do it himself. And if that was wrong, then Katsuki would offer his help. Too often, because of his size, appearance, and personality, people have the opposite first

assumption. That he couldn't do something, to which he had to work to have them believe otherwise.

Izuku grabbed onto a rung, and pulled himself up onto the first ledge, "I got it! Thanks, Kacchan."

The athlete looks up further, "Up there, it looks like there's a pretty steep incline. You ain't tall enough. I'll lift you up there."

Izuku nods, "Alright. Don't slip then, or I'm coming down with you."

"Thank you for the obvious, Deku," Katsuki sneered before grabbing the next rung.

And they continued that way. 50 feet was not actually too high. Izuku assumed that there is a good lookout or something at the top of the ocean, and just kept climbing after Katsuki. It wasn't a rigorous climb at all, aside from some of the taller ledges that he needed Katsuki to lift him up on. Other than that, it would take about ten minutes to scale up to what seemed to be the top. What Izuku was more scared of, rather than the possibility of slipping, was if he accidentally grabbed a rung and there was some type of spider on it. Which was why he let Katsuki go first.

When the two of them got up to the top, there was a big rock clearing, and behind them was where the forest line of the mountain started. When Izuku stands up, he sees the vast ocean in front of them, colored by the setting sun. The waves were not too powerful today, so the crashes against the sides of the cliff was gentle. Izuku stands there in appreciation next to Katsuki, and was about to sit down, when the blonde turns to him.

"You know how to dive?" Katsuki asked.

Izuku blinked, before shaking his head, "Not correctly."

The blonde nods, taking this into consideration, and spoke to him again, "In that case, just jump off feet first with your body straight, so that you're like a pin ripping through the surface."

Izuku's eyes bulged out of his head, "J-jump? Kacchan, this is 50 feet."

"Into water," Katsuki says, "You're a physics geek, ain't you? Decrease your surface area when you hit the surface, and you'll cut through the top and be fine."

Izuku knew all of that, but standing here near the edge, and looking down at the ocean from fifty feet above was a different story. That was about a 3 story building, into water. One wrong pivot, and the crash into water can feel like concrete.

"This is pretty high up," Izuku just stares down past his feet.

Katsuki comes up behind him, surprising Izuku, and stables his hips with the taller's rougher hands. Izuku tilts his head up and back towards the athlete who was so much taller and bigger than him. In these arms, he felt so safe, like he can do anything. Katsuki leans down slightly and looks out into the distance, talking closely to Izuku's ear.

“I want you to go first, Deku,” Katsuki tells him, hands still on his hip.

Izuku turns around to look at Katsuki, “Huh?”

“I want you to jump first,” Katsuki repeats to him, “Take the leap. I’ll be right behind you.”

Izuku gives him a funny look, “Why?”

At this, Katsuki shrugs his shoulders then tells him then, “At some point, I have to let you go, right? Let you live your own life. Start with this.”

The greenette looks at Katsuki then, wondering what exactly the boy meant by that. The sun illuminated the other’s eyes, and Izuku looked in them for any kind of answer. The wind was heavier up here, which made the jump even scarier. He felt as if he could be pushed in any second. Katsuki had a strange way of speaking, that never explicitly said what he meant. That was something that’s been difficult for the other to change.

Izuku asks him softly, “What’s wrong with staying?”

Katsuki shrugs nonchalantly, but Izuku could tell there was some hesitation in his face, “You’re gonna go to Waseda. Meet people who are actually able to…” Katsuki paused, “Shit, never mind.”

“No, tell me,” Izuku keeps looking up at him, “People who are actually able to what?”

“Nothing, nerd,” Katsuki gestures in front of them, “Point is, you’re gonna get busy. I’m gonna be busy. We’ll see each other once in a while when we come back to visit Ise. We’ll meet up over a drink,” Katsuki goes off, “I’ll ask you how you’ve been. You’ll ask me. And we’ll just part ways again.”

Izuku looks down at his feet, and suddenly, the jump doesn’t sound as terrifying as that thought. The thought of them becoming strangers again, of only watching Katsuki from behind a fence once more. Except worse. Izuku does not want to imagine them coming back to Ise every summer or winter break, just to briefly say their greetings and make small talk over a bottle of wine. Not when he’d be sitting there, talking with a boy who once took him out to lakes at midnight, spun him in the air in the edge of a wheat field, and showed him a love he’s never seen before. He imagines it now, and the jump beneath him doesn’t seem terrifying at all.

Izuku then glances back at Katsuki, but doesn’t meet the blonde’s eyes, “Is this...how you treat all of your close friends?” His voice was soft, but still heard over the wind. Izuku wonders. Is he really that disposable? Is their deal for the project still actually real? It couldn’t be, right? Not after all of this. Not after what they’ve managed to build up. Was it so easy for Katsuki to let him go like this? It hurt him to a deep degree.

“Dek-” Katsuki began.

But Izuku didn’t stay around to listen. Taking Katsuki’s hands off of his waist, Izuku stepped back a bit, took a deep breath, and began to jog towards the edge. His heart was beating fast,

but he was determined. He reached the edge, and pushed himself off, making sure to point his feet straight down with his hands by his side like a pin needle. The moment he jumped off, it hit him that he can't go back. That was the terrifying part about free falling. Once you made the leap, there was no stopping gravity. He can't rewind time to when it was safe and easy. The fall was three seconds at most, but it felt like an eternity when it feels like you were about to die.

And when Izuku hit the water's surface, it was exhilarating. The water's temperature hit him all at once as he fell in deep, before his body naturally swam up to the surface. That was incredible, Izuku thought to himself, and he almost forgot about the conversation he had mere moments ago.

Izuku got back to the surface, he treads water and yells out a *whoop* as he laughs out loud. Looking up, Katsuki was grinning watching Izuku swim underneath. His boy was going to be the death of him. Izuku swam a little further out so that there was no chance of Katsuki landing on him and dying on the spot.

The athlete then turns around so that his back was facing the ocean, holds his arms out. Izuku's eyes widened as he watches the form. It was like a bird with its wings outstretched. The muscles on his back rippled, and Izuku's breath was stolen as the skin on Katsuki's back shone like gold under the sunset.

And then, Katsuki fell backwards, arms still outstretched. His head pointed straight down as he fell, and Izuku watched him with awe. And in the last few moments before he hit the water, Katsuki put his hands together above his head in a diving motion and sliced through the water. It was so skillful that Izuku wondered what the blonde couldn't do.

He treads water until Katsuki's heads goes above water with a large gasp, "Fuck!"

Izuku laughs, "What is it?"

"Salt water just fucking swept through my sinuses," Katsuki shakes his head and scrunches up his face, "Shit burns."

The greenette giggles, and wishes it wasn't as easy to forget about the conversation they just had, "You got what you deserve."

Katsuki looked appalled, "What I *deserved* ? You little shit."

Izuku kicks in the water to keep himself afloat, and then looked up towards the edge of the cliff again, "That gave me a bit of existential dread."

Katsuki snorts, "Yeah?"

Izuku nodded, "It feels like you're about to die. Even if you know you aren't." *And yet, it didn't feel as bad as the thought of losing you.* Izuku asked himself what the hell was wrong with him, and looked over at Katsuki.

"It does, doesn't it," Katsuki hums in agreement.

And Izuku looks at the boy. The beads of liquid on those blonde lashes, the matted hair that looked darker now because of the water. His jaw, his lips, the same ones that loved to be on his, just never with the feeling that Izuku wants it to have. Izuku wants to kiss him now, but not like how they've been doing before. He wanted to kiss Katsuki with no promises that there were no feelings involved. He wanted to pour his heart out into the kiss, but he knew how well that was going to turn out. Bakugou Katsuki was not built for love. He was only now learning how to let it show that he was happy. Asking for love was far past the limit, and Izuku had to remind himself of this before he went too far.

Katsuki interrupted his thoughts, "Wanna go again?"

Izuku snapped out of his fruitless headspace and began swimming towards shore, nodding back, "Yeah."

"-to this song, and Mina is gonna drive us to the concert," Ochaco was speaking the next day while she, Izuku, Shoto, and Iida were hanging out at her house, "It's actually been amazing! Being project partners with her. I feel a lot more confident," She laughs. They have been going around the room and just sharing stories and having a good time. Izuku made sure to not say as much, because he was already the hot topic of the school for being around Katsuki an insane amount. He didn't want to talk about himself for the fiftieth time, especially since his friends always ask for updates. He wanted to know about *them* , and what's been going on in their lives.

Ochaco was stressed out about some paperwork with the school she was wanting to get into. Shoto recently burnt down part of the kitchen because he had no control over fire grills. And Iida was just preparing for a summer internship at his brother's company.

"I'm glad," Izuku beamed. He loved seeing his friends happy more than anything, "Mina's been dragging you out everywhere. I've missed you, Ochaco."

The girl in question rolled her eyes, "Please, Izuku. You have no right to speak. I was considering begging Bakugo to leave you alone so that we can get some time with you."

"Hey!" Izuku points out, "I've still hung out with you guys a lot."

"That is true," Shoto confirms. "Is your mom still ghosting you? Because same."

Izuku dropped his jaw at the dark joke, but then laid back on the mattress, "She's been talking a little more. I have been too, I guess. Just a good morning and a good night. I tell her really quick where I'm going when I go out, and she just nods and tells me to stay safe. I…" Izuku bit his lip, "I hate it. I miss her, guys."

"Have you tried approaching her again," Iida asked as he was toying with some mechanism on his laptop.

Izuku shook his head with a sad smile, “Not really. I guess I’m to blame as well, but...this is my last year. I don’t want it to end like this.”

“Talk to her then,” Ochaco chimed in, giving her advice.

But Izuku paused and looked down at his lap, taking a deep breath, “No, I can’t. Not until she apologizes...I deserve it,” His tone was quiet and sad, “I need to stand up for myself.”

Their friend group was a little quiet, before Ochaco smiles at him and took his hand, “I support it, Izuku. You really seem more confident these days.”

Izuku laughs, “Do I?” Before shrugging, “It sometimes feels like the opposite.”

“Ah,” Shoto mentions, “The struggle of love.”

Ochaco elbowed him, “Hey, that’s probably sensitive.”

Izuku never told them about his realization that he was in love with Katsuki. He hadn’t even told them that they’ve slept together, for that conversation was still unbelievable to him. He mentions the activities they do, and the other moments that happen, but leaves out the dirty details or that of his emotions.

Izuku blushes, “It’s fine.”

“So we can ask?” Ochaco suddenly widened her eyes, “About Bakugo?”

Izuku kicks his feet, “I tell you guys everything already. What is there to ask,” He complains.

“If you love him,” Ochaco points out, and the room goes quiet.

Izuku was as silent as a pin drop, but his eyes avert immediately. Which was answer enough to his group of friends, but the sad gait at which he held himself told them this wasn’t a matter to celebrate.

“I…” Izuku parted his lips, and then smiled sadly, “I can’t.”

“Why not?” Shoto asked, “He’s been much less of a prick ever since he started hanging out with you.”

The greenette shook his head, “He’s been good to me. Nicer. Sweet, even. He does things for me that no one else does,” Izuku then paused on his words, “But when it comes to love, it’s just not in the cards.”

Ochaco plays a game on her phone as she replies, “Honestly, now that you say that, I can’t really imagine Bakugo being in love,” And she rolls onto her back, “Being nice? I can imagine that. But actually being in love, opening up to that extent, not being able to live without someone? I can’t really imagine that for him.”

Izuku purses his lips. He thinks back to what Katsuki had said on the cliff. *I have to let you go, right? Let you live your own life* . Was it really that easy? And he says nothing in

response to his friend.

“That being said,” Iida multitasked, “Think about this rationally. He obviously doesn’t feel nothing for you. As far as I’m concerned, Bakugo Katsuki has never behaved this way.”

“True,” Shoto ad libbed.

Iida continued, “He doesn’t even hang out with Eijirou this much. And when they do, Bakugo definitely doesn’t go cliff jumping or plans out a moonlight star gaze session. He evidently feels *something* for you. He says a lot of things that seem careless, but his actions reveal a lot more.”

Izuku places his cheek on his palm, “We’re psychoanalyzing him, now? Should I take out my psychology notes?”

Iida didn’t appreciate being interrupted and held his hand up to pause the other, “I’m friends with you guys, but I would not caress your cheek one moment and then go brood in silence afterwards if I didn’t feel anything. I think Bakugo is having a hard time figuring out what he’s feeling. You two had that one argument, right?”

Izuku nodded, “Yes, and he says he’s trying. And...he really has.” Izuku thought of the victories and losses they’ve had.

“I think you should just go for it,” Ochaco urged.

The green eyed boy laughs, “Did you not just hear anything we said in this conversation?”

“I did,” Ochaco nudged him, “And it just seems like you’re just sitting there and doing nothing as it plays out. You’re just accepting whatever happens, but have you even tried to advocate for your feelings?”

Izuku’s eyes widened, but then he backs off, “What’s the point? Nothing is going to come from this except for…” pain.

“See, that’s exactly what I’m talking about,” Ochaco wags a finger at him, “I hate to say it, but when Katsuki told you to be more in touch with your negative emotions, you still need to be more assertive! Take your ground! Just go after him!”

Izuku playfully cat kicks her, “Mina is influencing you too much! That’s impractical advice, you know. I told you, nothing is going to happen.”

“Ugh,” She shrugs, “Maybe. But I’m sick of waiting for emotionally constipated men to figure out what they want.”

Izuku takes this into mind, but then raises his brow at her, leaning in with a grin, “Oh? Ochaco, do you have someone in mind?”

“No!” She exclaimed, waving her arms around, “I was just giving an example.”Izuku tries to divert the conversation elsewhere, “Are you sure?” He teased her with a giggle, “Not even that boy on the soccer team?”

“Okay, hold up,” Ochaco’s eyes widened, “Don’t get the wrong idea about that!” And she went on about it, to which Izuku was relieved. He didn’t want to spend the time he had with his friends mostly talking about himself and his messed up relationship with Katsuki that left him more confused than anything.

The night market was tonight, which meant that he had to go home soon. No matter how they were, Izuku helped his mother every year set up, and this year will be no different. He loved her, and he wasn’t about to stop a mother and son tradition on his last year before college. Sure, it may be a little awkward, but he would feel wrong not to come.

At around 6PM, Izuku rushed home, and came into his mother’s inventory room to find the woman sitting with a clipboard staring at a pile of boxes on the ground, thinking.

“Mom,” Izuku said through heavy breathing, “What do you need help with?”

Inko looked up at him with slight surprise in her eyes, and her demeanor was still relatively quiet, but he could see that there was a bit of surprise in her stance. Whether it was good surprise or bad surprise, he wasn’t sure. He was just here to help. Inko looked back down at the boxes and seems to think, as Izuku straightens his back and waits in the weird silence.

Finally, his mother pursed her lips and nodded, “‘Zuku, can you take the boxes labelled A9 out into the back of the car?”

Nodding, Izuku went to work. And he did this for about thirty minutes, and although it wasn’t much, he was happy that his mother was saying something other than five words to him, even if it wasn’t exactly an apology. He wanted normalcy so badly, but this was what he’ll accept for now. He and his mother put everything out in the car that they needed for her custom prints booth, and then after he was done, Izuku just stood off the side a bit awkwardly while his mother does the same. It’s been a little bit since they’ve had a conversation, and now that he’s had just a tiny remnant of one, even if it was just following instructions, Izuku wanted to cry.

He missed his mother so much. No matter what she’s done, the harmful habits that she’s instilled in him, the manipulative tactics that he still gets scared of thinking back to it, Izuku still missed her. He missed gardening together. Having lighthearted, funny conversation while their hands dig into the dirt. He missed watching a movie occasionally with her, and making commentary throughout the entire thing and seeing which male lead his mother thought was attractive. He missed his mother so bad, but he didn’t miss the negativity that was laced with being stuck under her control.

That didn’t mean it didn’t hurt. It hurt so bad, and he stands here now, in front of her, wanting to cry. They went from loving conversations mixed in with tension filled arguments, to absolutely nothing at all for weeks. *Weeks.* That is a long time to be in the same house with someone and barely interact aside from a good morning, good night, and awkward dinners where the only sound was clinking glassware.

And now that they are talking, even it was just her giving him directions on where to put things and how to load the car up. And considering that small interaction was enough to make Izuku want to cry at how much he missed his mother, he needed so badly for them to be

okay. At least before he leaves for Waseda. Izuku had already submitted the deposit and accepted the offer, but he would cry for weeks if he were to leave this year and have things with his mother be like this. It was difficult. Navigating a mother who was both unreasonable and kind. If she was just straight up unreasonable, this would be easier. But no. Inko was also an attentive mother, which made this so much harder.

And so, Izuku and Inko stand there now, across from each other. The job was done, so they were back to having nothing to say. Since when was it like this?

Izuku looked at his mother, who looked tired, and he hated that tears welled up in his eyes. They filled up his waterline, and trying to look strong for weeks now was taking a toll on him and he was tired.

Upon seeing Izuku's eyes tear up as they stand in their silence, Inko looked like her dam of emotions wanted to fall too, and her lips wobbled. It was bad that Izuku was so used to her previous behavior, that he expected for her next words to be something blameful.

But all she said, in a shaky voice, and longing eyes, was a scratchy and pained, "Izuku."

At the sound of his name coming from his mother's voice made his first tears fall, and Izuku stands there holding himself from a distance, upset at himself that he was crying once more in front of her. But Izuku was just an 18 year old boy, growing up in a single parent household. For a long time, *yes* , they were all that each other had. He couldn't help that this silence between them hurt him greatly, even if it was for a good cause. Even if he knew he deserved an apology from his mother, he could only do so much about the natural desire to be with your mother. He was still just a boy, after all.

Izuku's shoulders shook and he wiped away his tears, "Mom." He said in a shaky voice.

Inko looked like she wanted to go forward to embrace her son, but Izuku still looked very hesitant. Sensing this, the woman cried from a distance. However, it didn't seem like one of her hurt, emotionally exaggerated cries. Instead, this looked like a cry of longing and sadness, quiet with silent tears falling while her lips wobbled.

In a quiet voice, the woman looks down at the ground, and told Izuku while sniffling a bit, "I miss you, Izuku."

The green eyed boy shakes his head furiously while he cries and he soaks his tears in his t-shirt, "I…" he stammers, "I miss you too, Mom. So much," He cries silently. Weeks of silence hurt him more than words ever could.

"Izuk-" Inko began.

"But," The boy in question cuts in, calming himself so that his tone can be even so that he sounded more serious, and looks over at his mother's saddened eyes, "We...we can't go back to the way we were before," Izuku closes his eyes and his chests shakes from trying not to cry.

Inko was silent, but her quiet tears keep coming out. She doesn't bother to wipe at them, and just looks up at Izuku.

He continues, nodding to himself as he hiccups slightly, "Not until I get an apology," Izuku stammers, "And a promise."

Inko Midoriya stands there, looking at her feet, and it's quiet again for a while. The clock ticking was loud as he waited for a response. Then, her shoulders shake as she tries to speak, "A-Are you really going?" She then uses to sleeve to wipe at her face, "To Waseda?"

Izuku nods his head, his lips pressed tightly together as more tears drop from his ducts, "I am. I a-already submitted my deposit." He smiles at her sadly, "I'm going Mom. I'm going to Waseda," And then he glances down at the ground, water droplets collecting on the floor of the inventory room, and he fidgets with his fingers, "T-to pursue my dream." He sounded nervous about saying that.

And Inko cries some more, and Izuku watches her. He stands there, silently, as his own dry up. And slowly, her sniffles come to a stop, and the redness of her puffy eyes slowly went away as they both sit there at a distance. Izuku's heart was heavy, and he wondered if he'll get his apology today. And they sit there for a little longer. This hurts, Izuku thinks. A *lot* . Falling out with his mother was a heartbreak in of itself.

Finally, Inko said in a shaky voice while nodding, "You should get ready, Izuku. Is Katsuki picking you up?"

Izuku looks down at his feet in a moment of silence, before looking back up and nodding, "He is."

After a moment, Inko nods, "Okay," She pauses, then adds, "I don't...approve of all the places you go, especially the cliff. B-but, just...stay safe, okay?"

Izuku pauses, tracing back her words, then looked at her with furrowed brows, "Wait, how did you know? About that?"

Inko then smiled gently to herself, contemplating telling him something, which made Izuku more curious, before looking up at him, "He texts me almost every day."

Izuku felt his breath stop, and he was just utterly confused, "What?"

His mother looked out to the window and sniffles to clear her nose.

But the boy needed more, "Wait, what? What is he telling you? Did you ask him to do this? Kacchan has no right to give you life updates on m-"

"Just pictures," Inko tells him then, in a quiet voice, "I didn't ask him to do anything, 'Zuku. He just sends me pictures."

Izuku's lips parted and his eyes softened, "...pictures?"

Inko nodded, and wiped at her cheek, “Of you. Or him, if he’s feeling arrogant,” She laughs lightly, “That kid is such a brat.”

Izuku’s eyes widened. He’s never really heard his mother call anyone by any negative name, even as a joke, and so this caught him off guard.

Inko’s lips wobbles a bit again, “K-Katsuki sends me a picture about every day that you two go out. And says the same thing underneath every time,” She shakes her head.

Izuku feels his chest warming, as he thinks about the blonde boy, “W-what does he say?”

At this, Inko lets out a small smile again, telling Izuku quietly, “‘Look at him. He’s fucking fine.’ That’s all that he says.”

Izuku’s jaw drops, even though his face attempts to remain composure. First of all, he’s never heard his mother curse, much less use the worst one of them all. It sounded so wrong coming out of Inko’s mouth. Secondly, Katsuki was so unapologetically Katsuki. He took no shit, not with anyone, and Izuku knew that nobody else would have done this for him.

Third, Izuku was touched beyond anything. Initially, when Inko had mentioned that Katsuki had been texting her most days, his mind went to the worst. He assumed nothing positive. Izuku went through trains of thought that involved thinking Katsuki had been babysitting him for his mother this whole time, to Katsuki not viewing him as someone who could take care of himself and needed to constantly update his mother, while Izuku has an angsty rebellious phase.

However, this was almost worse, because it made Izuku fall in love with the blonde even more. Without ever mentioning a word to Izuku, Katsuki had been doing two things. Calming his mother’s nerves, so that although she doesn’t *know* where he is, she knows that he’s safe. And two, he was advocating for Izuku that he could do all of these things and still be fine. *Fucking fine* , to be exact. Proving to her every day that she didn’t need to watch over him like a hawk, and Izuku would still turn out fine.

Seeing Izuku floored, Inko pursed her lips and tells her son.

“We’ll...talk again,” Inko tells him, “Not today. I can’t...today. But we’ll talk again, ‘Zuku. Go get ready.”

It wasn’t as if his mother suddenly changed her ways. That just cannot happen, to anyone. But Izuku could tell that there has been some thought that’s been going through her mind. Since their conversation was so short, Izuku assumes that if they had a longer one, her habits will start to shine through back in the limelight. However, because their words were so limited these days, Izuku could tell that Inko was being extra careful to make them count. If she needed time, to figure out what to say to him, then Izuku can wait.

In the meanwhile, Izuku’s heart couldn’t stop beating as he goes up the stairs. *Kacchan, Kacchan, Kacchan* , was all he could think about. This boy. This fucking boy. It wasn’t just

flashy displays where the blonde would take him to a field of flowers at night and show him the stars. It wasn't just teaching Izuku how to vault, and bringing him up to the clouds that he's only seen Katsuki fly in. It was silent gestures like this, that the blonde would never tell him about or even mention, that ruined any hope Izuku had for his recovery out of love.

He felt stupid for feeling giddy. Katsuki had done this for him. Of course, the athlete could just be a good friend, but Izuku's heart didn't stop beating fast because of that. He involuntarily thought about what Ochaco was saying earlier. *Just go for it.* He shook his head. No, that was stupid. The little high he got from finding out about Katsuki's little gesture was manipulating his thought process. *Just go for it* , she said.

And although Izuku muttered to himself saying that was stupid and he wasn't going to do that, the way he dressed himself up said otherwise. He dressed with the intentions to impress. He knew there were going to be people there in nice shirts or pretty, flowy dresses, but he wanted to shine for someone. *Just go for it* , kept repeating in his head. And he's reject the notion, as he puts a light sparkle near his eyes with makeup. He lightly puts a bit of blush on, just so that he looked a bit more rosy.

Izuku digs out a flowy green satin shirt that was a bit oversized and hung down to his mid thighs and slips it on, only buttoning the middle two. Taking a white belt, he wraps it around his waist, clinching the satin shirt together, so that he looked hourglass. Sliding on ripped denim shorts underneath, he completed his look with some gold bangles on his wrist and a thick watch for a touch of masculinity. He twirled in the mirror, watching the bottom of the satin shirt that wasn't cinched by the belt flow around him. He smiled to himself, feeling confident, before he heard a text ding.

Checking his phone, Izuku's heart continued to drum faster seeing the blonde's text saying that he was here. His mother had left and had likely already set up the booth at the night market. Slipping on some sandals, Izuku stomped his way downstairs and out of the house, locking the door, before jogging towards Katsuki's car with a bright smile.

His smile didn't leave as he practically fell into the passenger seat, and shoved his seat belt in, "Kacchan!"

And he turned to look at the athlete, who just seemed to stare at his face as he smiled brightly, with a slight look of surprise or awe. For what reason, Izuku wouldn't know, but he cocked his head and asked.

"Kacchan…?" He repeated.

And Katsuki's attention snapped back into place, as he tears his eyes away from Izuku's face, and then looked down at the greenette's outfit, "Sorry," Katsuki mumbled, before clearing his throat, "Hey, nerd."

"Hi," Izuku grinned. He wasn't going to call Katsuki out on the text messages. No, that can be the blonde's secret.

"I didn't know I was supposed to dress up," Katsuki raised a brow, giving Izuku a look over. His eyes raked over the flowy satin fabric, that parted slightly to reveal Izuku's pretty thighs.

The athlete was wearing a pair of denim jeans, with a blue shirt on top, paired with a watch and a shark's tooth necklace.

"You look great, Kacchan," Izuku found the courage to say, as nonchalantly as possible.

" *Fuck* ," Izuku heard Katsuki mutter to himself, before glancing over once again at Izuku as he puts the car in drive, "You look fine, too."

Izuku laughed, hearing how slightly awkward the taller boy sounded, and teased him, "Don't be so hesitant. Say it with your chest, Kacchan."

Katsuki rolled his eyes, "You're fucking ridiculous, Deku. And speaking of fucking, you're going to get on all fours for me tonight."

Izuku flushed, "When I said 'say it with your chest', that wasn't what I meant, but that works too…"

Katsuki began driving towards the square, and he put on A Groovy Kind of Love by Phil Collins.

"You seem to like Phil Collins," Izuku nods as he listens.

"You ever watched Tarzan growing up?" Katsuki asked, seemingly randomly.

"Of course," Izuku beams.

"He did the soundtrack for those movies," The athlete informs, "I listened to him as a kid, and never stopped since."

"I like this," Izuku gestured towards the song, as they drive through Ise. It was nighttime now, and there was only a hint of twilight.

They drove past a group of kids with jars, running around collecting fireflies. Or adults sitting on a lit up porch, with a can of beer in their hands, enjoying the breezy weather that Ise had to offer. All around them was sound, and it looked like it was going to be a pretty lively night, even if it was just a Wednesday.

When Katsuki pulled up to the parking lot outside of where they had the town square blocked off, there was already a lot of people. Izuku had been right. It was unrecognizable. There were string lights hung up everywhere to provide a lot of illumination for the vendors. Many people were already walking around, looking at all of the crafts. Or getting a taste of some quick grab and go food. Or kids buying glow sticks from fun carts and waving it around chasing each other.

Izuku and Katsuki left the car, locking the vehicle, before heading towards the commotion. Izuku walked side by side with the athlete, not close enough that they were pressing up against each other, but just enough that their arms brushed here and there as they walked. They entered past the closed off line, and into where everything was, and it immediately struck as overwhelming. There was sounds and objects everywhere.

Plenty of people, vendors with beautiful lights to attract customers. Some vendors had booths with their items displayed and big handwritten signs. Some vendors were set up on a mat on the ground, with dozens upon dozens of handcrafted bracelets or woven flip flops on sale displayed. From food carts, there were smoothie stations, pressed drinks, coffee, or just fun concoctions. An ice cream cart was being pushed around too, with the person calling out ‘ *Ice cream, Ice cream, who wants ice cream!’* The food smelled delicious. Corn dogs, or potato sticks. Some traditional fare was also sold, and his senses were happy.

People were talking everywhere, and the sound of childrens’ voices filled the air. Teens too, as they travelled in groups to look at cool merchant items. Adults with their families were also walking around, buying little trinkets.

And then, from further out, near the fountain, a square was cleared for 80s disco music. It was mostly older people who went out there onto the floor, to relive their younger days, while the teens pretended it was embarrassing, even though it was actually quite charming. Izuku turned around in his spot, smiling widely. Katsuki watches him, he senses.

And then, the blonde leans down slightly to point over to the stall, “Yo, what the fuck are those.”

Izuku looks to where Katsuki was pointing, and his eyes widened, “Is that...handcrafted hero figures?”

Katsuki chuckles from beside him, “Looks like it. Come on, let’s go,” The blonde puts a hand on the small of Izuku’s back and they walk over there. Izuku pretends not to notice the touch.

And so they walk around like this for a while. Izuku felt as if he and Katsuki were the main characters of their own movie, walking around to different booths and admiring everything as faint music from the disco square plays in the background. There was plenty of beautiful things. Cool bracelets, earrings, bags, hand carved stones and wood. There were mangoes dipped in chili and salt, which tasted better than it sounded. Izuku bought a couple items for himself: a handheld fan, a ridiculous t-shirt that Katsuki definitely voted against, and some friendship rings for him and his friends.

He looked over to his mom’s booth once in a while, and was pretty happy to see that she was getting business. Katsuki mostly purchased food. The cotton candy milkshake intrigued him the most.

“My coach is going to fucking beat my ass for this,” Katsuki said as he paid for the drink.

Izuku put a finger up to his lips, “I won’t tell.”

“You better not,” Katsuki grumbled, “Unless you want to see me run fifteen laps.”

Izuku laughed, and tried a sip of Katsuki’s milkshake after the blonde did. It was awfully sweet, but that was expected. After all, it was just blended sugar and milk. But apparently, the milk used in the shakes were sourced from one of the local farms, which was nice. At some point, they bought one of those toys that spun in the air, and lit up into different colors. And like children, just tossed it up over and over again, attempting to catch it as it goes down.

They saw some people they knew too, and stopped for a moment to chat, before going off of their own to explore the night market. They eventually *did* get to the fruit stalls.

“There’s your fruit stalls, Kacchan,” Izuku points out as he sips on sugar cane juice.

“Ah,” Katsuki slaps a watermelon, “This is more like a night market,” He jokes.

“Hey!” The stall worker called out to him, “Don’t do that to the fruit.”

“Shit, my bad,” Katsuki backs away, and Izuku giggles.

“Your Kacchan privileges didn’t work this time,” He mentions.

“This is blasphemy,” Katsuki tsked in a joking manner, “How dare they not let me do what I want.”

Izuku smiled. When they walked around like this together, making jokes and looking at interesting stuff, it felt as if they were a couple. If he erases some facts from his head, then he could pretend that they were. And Katsuki had picked him up so they could have a little night market date. But life wasn’t that easy, was it.

It sure felt like it right then, though, as Izuku guides Katsuki by the wrist over to a stall that sold flowers, and grinned.

“My mom would know the names of all of these,” Izuku smiled as he looks at the beautiful array, and then as he realized what he said, his smile drops and a sad look replaced itself on Izuku’s face, and he stands back. He goes quiet for a second.

Katsuki takes the time then to speak up, pointing to a pink flower, “Do you know any?”

Izuku looks at that one and then nods, “Yeah, that’s a pink camellia! It represents…” Izuku paused, “longing for someone.”

Katsuki lifts a dainty petal with his fingertips, before letting go and pointing to another one, “How about that one?”

And the greenette spends the next couple of minutes going through some of the ones he knew and their meanings. Katsuki nods after each one, and looks at the gorgeous selection.

One of the two workers that was in charge of the floral station reached out to Izuku, “You seem very knowledgeable! Do you garden?”

“Oh, thank you!” Izuku smiles at her, “It’s actually my mom. I just kind of picked up some things from her.”

“Really?” The stall worker laughed, “You seem to know more than just *some* thi-”

And their conversation just continues about flowers a bit more. Izuku wasn’t a huge flower nerd, but his mother did tell him a lot about it when they gardened together. Inko kept pretty

flowers in their backyard as well. It was nice to talk to a kind stranger, and Izuku after five minutes, wished the woman a good night and stepped back.

He looked over to see that Katsuki was fishing out his wallet, and looked on curiously. He handed a bill to the other floral stall worker, who then reached down and takes out a beautiful red lily, handing it to the blonde. Izuku cocks his head at the choice of flower.

He had not remembered telling Katsuki about this one's meaning. And he stands there to the side waiting, as Katsuki looks at the flower now in his hands, as if he was contemplating something. And then, the athlete looks around before spotting Izuku to the side, and saunters over, with one hand in his pocket, and the other twirling the stem in his fingers. Izuku just looks on, and Katsuki approaches him.

The blonde looks down at the flower, and then back up at Izuku, looking once at those green eyes, before reaching his hand up to tuck the fiery red flower behind Izuku's ear, moving some green pieces of hair to the side. Izuku's eyes shone, as he watches the boy he loves tuck a red lily into his ear. A red lily.

Passion.

Katsuki looks at it for a moment, before dropping his hand and turning his back to walk away. Izuku was just a bit speechless, and after a moment of trying to calm his chest down, the boy caught up behind the other.

"Thank you, Kacchan," Izuku smiled up at Katsuki as they walked side by side.

Katsuki averts his gaze, but doesn't reply. Odd. The blonde looked down at the ground, which was definitely not something Katsuki did. But for a moment there, he had, and Izuku found it strange.

However, after a couple moments, he was back to his normal, joking self, and they walked the stalls some more. After a while, Izuku and Katsuki reached the disco floor, and felt unrepresented. It truly was just older people who was karaoking to 80s songs and dancing silly in typical 80s style. Izuku clapped from the sidelines, while laughing. And he could tell Katsuki was amused too.

The fast beat of Holding Out For A Hero by Bonnie Taylor began with its dramatic intro, and Izuku couldn't just watch anymore. He grabbed Katsuki's hand, and dragged the 6'4 athlete that practically everyone in Ise knew onto the dance floor, and began jumping up and down. He held his hand up like a fake microphone and began yell-singing the lyrics. His energy convinced Katsuki to begin doing the same, and boy, Izuku would not say it to his face, but Katsuki has a *terrible* singing voice. That being said, it was fun to see them performing the song stupidly to the audience of middle ages and elderly people. Izuku shook his head while pointing his fingers to the sky and jumping in place, dramatically singing the song in unison with Katsuki.

From the corner of Izuku's eyes, he could see his mom at her booth, glancing up at him. But he didn't look long to see her expression.

When they were done, Katsuki ran off with him before they could hear the ovation they received. Izuku laughed as he's dragged away. They stood near a drink stand, and Izuku contemplated getting some water for his now dry throat.

"I'm gonna get some water," Izuku looks up at Katsuki, "Do you want anything?"

"I'm good," Katsuki tells him, pinching Izuku's nose, "I'll stay here."

Izuku nods, and walks off to the nearby drink stand. It had a large selection of artisan sodas and what not, so Izuku felt bad just buying a bottle of brand name water, but he was thirsty and could only do so much.

As he pulls out a couple of bills to pay, Izuku glanced back over at Katsuki, and he quirked a brow in curiosity. His hands were holding the bills out, not letting them go just yet, as he sees a boy with light blue eyes and beautiful brown hair approached Katsuki nervously.

The boy was stunning, with a dainty and delicate build. Small shoulders, slim waist, and eyes that literally sparkled. He was gorgeous, and Izuku feels his stomach sink because if he were Katsuki, he would think Izuku didn't stand a chance. Not against this pretty boy with a nice smile, and kind looking eyes. Izuku was sure that the boy was nice, and had no prejudice against him at all. But that doesn't mean he didn't feel a little strange inside. For all Izuku knew, the other boy could simply be asking Katsuki for directions, or striking up a friendly conversation. He shouldn't get jealous. He *shouldn't* get jealous.

And then, he sees the boy holding out his phone, looking as if he was asking Katsuki for his number. And his heart began to beat fast. Izuku, before anything else, thought to himself, "Of course the blonde was going to give it. Of course, he was." But when it actually did happen, and Katsuki reached out to take his phone and type in some numbers, it did not hurt any less. Not at all. His stomach dropped, even though he knew he had no claim to Katsuki's heart and no right to feel jealous. They weren't exclusive. They weren't together. They just fucked, and Katsuki made it clear that there were no emotions to be involved. Which meant that it was only a matter of time before something like this happens. And Izuku hates that he couldn't even blame him. The other boy was so beautiful, in a 'once in a lifetime' kind of person, way. And the bills in his hands feel tighter.

"Excuse me? Sir?" A voice snapped him back to reality, and Izuku turned his head back with wide eyes that looked like they were about to cry. He glanced down, seeing how he had not let go of the money he was supposed to be giving the cashier, and he shakingly lets go.

With an apologetic and shaky voice, Izuku looks down and grabs his water, "S-sorry."

His legs feel wobbly, but he forces himself to stand. It wasn't that big of a deal, he told himself. He was in love with Katsuki, yes. God, he loved the other so much. But the thing about love is that if you truly feel that way for someone, then you know you cannot force them to feel the same.

He forced himself to look over once more, to see that whatever it was that Katsuki was saying made the beautiful boy laugh. And wow, that laugh was absolutely stunning to hear,

even from far away. He saw Katsuki's eyes glance down to that smile, before trailing back up to those beautiful light blue eyes. Izuku told himself that he shouldn't feel this way.

And not wanting to interrupt what was happening, Izuku forced his legs to move and he walks slowly to a nearby bench, and sits down rigidly. His hands shook slightly as he opened the cap of his water bottle, but he forced himself to drink as he sits there watching the crowd.

People walk past, childrens' laughs fill the air, lots of noises, and excitement, and Izuku tries not to let this hurt him too badly. He had been expecting this after all, so why did it hurt so badly? In the corner of his eyes, he could see that they were still talking. The boy's arms placed gently on Katsuki's forearm, and the blonde didn't move it.

Finally, when the beautiful stranger starts to drag Katsuki away, that was when the blonde then looks around. Izuku feels eyes on him then as Katsuki spots him, and he looks down at his lap, not wanting to get caught staring. His heart pounded in his chest. He glances over once more to see that Katsuki was giving some remark to the boy, who then looked over at Izuku, nodding and then said something back to Katsuki. The athlete then nodded, before parting ways, making his way over to where Izuku was sitting.

"Oi, nerd," Katsuki called out, "How's the water."

Izuku glanced up at him with doe eyes, and his voice was slightly shrill as he replies, "It's...just water."

"Just water?" Katsuki raised a brow, "Aren't you the one who always says you can taste the difference in every fucking water?"

Izuku just laughs airily, "Did I?" Before it goes to silence.

Katsuki nods after a moment, standing beside the bench, "What do you want to do now, hm?" And looks around.

Izuku bit the inside of his cheek, and he had to try extra hard to not let his emotions seep through, not looking at Katsuki, "W-We don't have to do...anything. You can go," Izuku tells him, not being able to look at Katsuki, "if you want."

Katsuki raised a brow, "Go? Without you? Nah. I took you here, nerd. I'm not gonna just go."

At this, Izuku frowned and looked up at the other, "Don't let me hold you back, Kacchan. If you want to go, then just go."

The athlete's eyes widened slightly at this response, before narrowing at Izuku, "And where the fuck are you implying that I want to go, huh."

Izuku turned his head away, "I...I don't know."

"Yes, you do," Katsuki blankly says.

Izuku denies, denies, denies, "I don't."

But Katsuki is smart. He catches on, “Is this about the person just now? That I was talking to?”

Izuku’s eyes widened before he controlled his expression, “No, it’s no-”

“Because if it is, then don’t fucking act like you being here is holding me back,” Katsuki tells him, tapping his foot impatiently, “If I want to fuck him, I’ll do it on my own time. Right now, I’m here with yo-”

“How kind of you,” Izuku lets it go before he can stop himself.

And Katsuki glares at his hand, kicking at the ground, “What the *fuck* is wrong with you,” The blonde growls.

“What do you expect me to say?” Izuku asks him, glancing up at the other, “Oh! Thank you so much, Kacchan! You definitely want to go fuck this other guy, but you are considerate enough to do it another time. You’re really sweet, aren’t you.”

Katsuki’s tone darkened as he looked around, then back at Izuku, “What I fucking do is none of your business.”

Izuku looks at him sadly with a smile, “It’s fine, you know. He’s…” Izuku’s voice tried to stabilize itself, “...beautiful. You can go,” His voice turned quiet.

“Christ,” Katsuki turned to the side, “Can you stop with the fucking pity party?”

“What?” Izuku looked at him with hurt eyes, “I wasn’t-”

“If you’re jealous, just fucking say so,” Katsuki tells him irritated, “Don-”

Izuku’s voice shook with anger now, “You have *no* right to speak, Kacchan. You’re such an assh-”

They just kept interrupting each other, and talking over one another. Izuku didn’t want to make a commotion, but Katsuki was being ridiculous. Why did it always feel like they went two steps forward, three steps backwards.

“Don’t fucking come to me, with this whole ‘go ahead and fuck him’ speech, Deku,” Katsuki told him, “You don’t want me to. It’s fucking obviou-”

“Kacchan, you’re a piece of shit,” Izuku told him, keeping himself in check so that he doesn’t cry right now, “You know that? You’re a piece of shit.” His voice was obviously breaking.

“Yeah?” Katsuki was good at insults. He says things he doesn’t mean, and they come out fast from his mouth without a second thought. He was good at this. He wasn’t good at soft words and sentimental feelings, but insults, hurting people was what he was good at, “Well, you’re a piece of work, Deku.” He snapped.

“Oh yeah? I am?” Izuku looked up at him with an irritated smile.

“You are.” Katsuki stepped closer and leaned his head down a little bit, “You’re so fucking difficult to deal with.”

“So why are you still dealing with me?” Izuku leans forward, voice challenging, but his hands were shaking, “Because I’m a good lay? If even. Maybe I’m just convenient.”

Katsuki’s expression darkened as he warned Izuku, “Oi, watch your fucking words, Deku. Who do you think I am.”

“I just…” Izuku turns around and holds himself to prevent him from crying then and there, before looking back over at Katsuki, “Don’t understand why you would say that. I’m not…”

His voice cracked as he lied, just to save his pride, “I’m not jealous. Or throwing a pity party.” He shook his head, “I just don’t want you to…” He breathed to try to even his heart rate, “feel like you’re missing out.”

Katsuki tells him then, and the words felt like a slap in the face, “Don’t overstep your boundaries.”

Oh.

Oh right. There were boundaries. Izuku stands there. Katsuki says this, and all Izuku could do was stand there, mouth shut. *Don’t overstep your boundaries* . Right. He probably looked stupid. He sure felt like it. Here he was, getting upset at something he knew was going to happen. Here he was, wanting more from a boy who didn’t have more to offer. Here he was, convinced by a few kind gestures that maybe he could give it a shot and just *go for it* . He had boundaries, and Katsuki just made it clear. Why did he have the right to say anything about Katsuki’s life. It wasn’t as if they were exclusive, or anything of the sort. They were just friends that fucked. This was an oversimplification, but at the core of it, what else gave Izuku the right to have acted like a fool tonight.

“O-Oh, right,” Izuku stammered out quietly, looking anywhere but Katsuki’s eyes. The taller was standing less than a foot from him, but Izuku felt like there was a universe worth of space. He was hurt, embarassed, and just felt utterly stupid.

He needed to leave. Because he felt it coming on: the tears. And he was not planning on being around Katsuki when it happens. If the taller sees, then he’ll know for sure. He’ll know exactly how Izuku feels.

And so, turning around rigidly, Izuku just says in an off-toned voice, “I’m...I’m gonna go home.”

“Wait,” Katsuki put a hand on his arm to stop him from moving away, “Deku, stop.”

“No, no,” Izuku shakes his head to reassure the other, “I’m fine! You’re completely right, and I’m...I’m sorry. I just want to go home because my head hurts a bit, that’s all.”

“I’ll take you home then,” Katsuki insisted, voice slowly showing a bit of emotion, “Come on.”

Izuku gently pulled away, looking up at the athlete apologetically, “No, it’s okay. I think I’ll walk.”

“You’re not walking home,” Katsuki tells him, and follows a couple of steps, “Deku. Izuku. *Fuck* , come here.”

The smaller just ignored Katsuki.

But the taller was persistent, a little too late, and went around to stand in front of Izuku, who was going to cry any second now and needed Katsuki to *leave* , “Deku. You’re not okay. It’s not just a headache, I’m not stupid. Come on, let me w-”

“Kacchan,” Izuku tried to say firmly, looking up at the other, “I’ll be fine, okay?” And reached out for Katsuki’s hand in extra emphasis and the athlete looked conflicted, “I’ll see you tomorrow, at practice. Just...let me walk home tonight, okay? I’ll be okay.”

And with a last smile, Izuku walks off, leaving Katsuki with a conflicted expression on his face. That conversation was such a fucking mess, and both sides acted out of line, and the resolution wasn’t even a damn resolution. Izuku didn’t care. He needed to get somewhere he can cry. He can’t hold it in. He was so stupid.

And he felt so embarrassed. He walks to the far end of the night market, where some trailers were parked with no people and little lighting, so it was darker. He walks pass the disco floor, and into the outskirts of the night market, until he was behind a trailer, half covered in the dark and half illuminated slightly by the market’s light. But no one was back here.

From not too far away, the speakers that were playing music began to run the track Carrie by Europe. And the introduction was just so damn depressing, that it only worsened Izuku’s emotions. *When the lights go down, I see no reason, for you to cry. We’ve been through this before* . He sure has. He’s been through this so many times with Katsuki, but this feels particularly bad. Because now, he knows that he is in love. He’s seen the smile on Katsuki’s face, the tenderness in the blonde’s voice here and there, and felt the sun shine on their skin as they sit in each other’s presence. He’s felt the warmth of Katsuki’s body, even if the other’s heart was cold. And now, being completely and utterly in love, it was hard to handle. *Can’t you see it in my eyes. This might be our last goodbye* . That line made Izuku sink his back down the side of the trailer as tears fell down his cheek, because he knew it could never apply to him. Our last goodbye. He cried because he knew, that no matter how many more of these moments happen, Izuku will still be in love with Katsuki. Izuku will still go back to the blonde, after everything. He knew that tomorrow, when he went to school, he’ll want to be around the taller. And that fact killed him. He was helpless against these feelings.

And so, as the song continues to play in the distance, Izuku was sunken down to his knees, against the back of this trailer in the hot humid night, with his face buried in his hands. His lungs hurt from crying, and Izuku knew it could be worse.

All Katsuki did was take the other boy’s number and from his words, could want to be with him intimately. It could have been much worse, and when the worst *does* happen, Izuku won’t know what to do with himself if this was how he was reacting now. He felt so dumb.

How could he have thought for even a second that he stood a chance. He felt like a fool, and was utterly embarrassed. He dressed himself up, laughed like a giddy kid, mustered up confidence he wouldn't usually have, and walked around pretending that this could maybe work. He felt so embarrassed.

And so, as Izuku cries, he takes the flower out of his hair and tosses it on the ground. The red lilly now tinged with dirt. Izuku wipes the blush off of his cheek. Stupid. Pathetic. He probably looked like a fool, dolling himself up and getting excited about doing his clothes and makeup for this boy. He scrubs at his cheeks and his eyes, getting rid of the evidence of his embarrassment. If he could take the clothes out of his body, he would too. He felt so dumb, to think that he could do anything.

And as he sits there, he thinks. And he knows: nothing will change. Nothing will change, because tomorrow, he'll just go back to this boy.

When tomorrow comes around, Izuku dreads the couple of minutes that it takes for him to walk past the sidewalk lining the track field on route to his home. It was solo practice day, and he hated that he had a cherry gatorade in his backpack. But he had gotten an extra one by accident last week, so he wasn't going to blame himself for it.

It was solo practice day, which meant that there won't even be a team to buffer the odd environment between them. He hasn't really seen Katsuki all day, and in classes, the blonde was particularly quiet.

Izuku plans to just walk past the field, straight towards home. He wasn't ready to talk to the other, and had a plan in mind to just keep his head down and walk briskly past. And so, as he's let out of the building, he makes his way towards the sidewalk and just keeps his head low and moves forward.

But that plans turns to shit once he hears frantic running coming towards him, and similar to the first time they interacted on this field, Katsuki was on the other side of the chainlinked fence, while Izuku just walked.

"Oi," Katsuki called out, "Deku."

Izuku looked over to him as he walked, with forlorn eyes, and Katsuki had a bit of a panicked look on his face as he walks alongside Izuku from the other side of the fence. The end of the fence was going to come up soon, and Katsuki looked like he was rushing so the greenette wouldn't walk past.

"Deku," The athlete tried again, "You're not going to come in?"

Izuku pursed his lips and then looked back down at his feet, "I'm a little tired."

Katsuki walked faster, looking around to see if he could do anything, before calling out to Izuku, "Fuck, Deku. Look, I wanted to...Shit," Katsuki was having trouble with his words

again, “Deku. Stop. Please, stop.”

Izuku felt a little shocked. He can’t recall the last time Katsuki has ever said please to him, but he didn’t want to stay in case he cried again.

“Kacchan,” Izuku tried to sound cheery, “I told you, I’m just a little tired!”

“No, don’t fucking do that,” Katsuki tells him, “Don’t pretend you’re all happy and shit. You’re fucking upset at me, and you…” Katsuki fumbled with his words, “And you, *fuck* , you deserve to be.”

Izuku slows to a stop, and raises a brow slightly at the taller. Now that he’s stopped, he could see a bit of panic in Katsuki’s face.

“It’s just…” The athlete looks to the side, and anywhere that wasn’t Izuku, which was out of character for the blonde, “It’s just that I’m a fucking idiot, okay. And I shouldn’t have…” He breathed, “I shouldn’t have said the shit last night. I was just frustrated.”

And then, Katsuki puts both hands on the back of his head, and paces around with a confused and pained expression as if he was struggling with how to handle himself. Izuku observed him closely. He paced back and forth, running his hands stressed out through his hair, and blowing out big breaths of hair.

“You just- Shit, I don’t kno- *Fuck* ,” Katsuki cursed and looked angry at himself, and Izuku looked on with a bit of surprise to see just how out of control the other looked, “I think I fucking wanted you to say something, and when you didn’t, I got angry.”

Izuku was quiet for a second, before asking, “What did you want me to say?”

Did Katsuki want him to admit that he was jealous? Or did Katsuki want him to say that he didn’t want the other to go off with the other guy? Izuku was confused.

“I...I barely fucking know,” Katsuki breathes heavily as he looks off to the side, “And I...I don’t know why I even wanted you to say it in the first place. Shit, I don’t know anything anymore.”

Izuku looks at the other, from outside of the fence, and sees the hard shell of Katsuki begin to crack. And he wasn’t sure what to do to help. And so, Izuku looked down at his lap, and pursed his lips with pain in his eyes.

“You...you weren’t completely wrong. I shouldn’t have…” Izuku admits his own faults, “...overreacted. You said it wasn’t a burden to stay with me, but I kept...I kept insisting you thought otherwise.”

Katsuki tongued his cheek as he looked at Izuku then down at the ground, but didn’t say anything. And they stand there in quietness for a second, as Katsuki kicks the dirt underneath his feet, and Izuku holds on tightly to his backpack strap.

Finally, the blonde spoke up, “I fucking suck at words. I’m...working on it. But, I can show you better another way.”

Izuku looked up at the athlete.

“Can you come in?” Katsuki asked him, voice serious, “And watch me today?”

Izuku looks at the other, and keeps the gaze as Katsuki stands his ground. He wasn’t angry. He was just exhausted, because who knew being hopelessly in love with someone was this hard work? But as the boy asks him now, Izuku just couldn’t say no.

And so, Izuku goes back into the track and field through the fence, and follows behind Katsuki from a distance. The blonde gestures towards the bench, and Izuku sits down with his backpack in his lap.

Taking a deep breath, Katsuki looks up to the bar, set at 17’11 feet, and takes a deep breath. Izuku wasn’t exactly sure what he was doing, but keeps watching. The blonde closes his eyes and concentrates, before turning to the starting position and picking up the pole. After looking at Izuku once, he fully focuses and then, began to take off. Katsuki sprints, and keeps doing so, until he bursts into a run, hits the box, and launches into the air.

He doesn’t clear the bar. But Katsuki wasted no time. The blonde set it back up immediately, grabs the pole, and goes back to the starting position. His eyes were set on the bar, high up in the sky, and his breathing was heavy. But as soon as his heart rate calms, Katsuki runs the bar again. And he does not clear it again.

And Izuku sits there, watching this. Katsuki fails again. And again. And again. Each time, getting back up to reset the bar and try once more.

“It’s going to work,” Katsuki tells himself out loud, and gets into starting position again.

It’s going to work? Izuku was confused. There must have been something the athlete was doing, that he wanted to work. Izuku watches Katsuki as he gets into form. The blonde takes a deep breath, and when he opens his eyes, he does the run again. And fails again.

He set the bar back up, and walks slowly to the starting position. This time, Katsuki raises his head to the sky and closes his eyes, letting the wind blow through his hair and lashes. Izuku watches as the other takes a deep breath, and then looked down at his feet, the bar, the pole, and takes in everything, looking determined. Izuku had a feeling he should sit on the edge for this, so he did.

Katsuki stands there, and then as he starts sprinting, Izuku watches Katsuki’s mouth. The boy was mouthing something as he sprints, and when he transitions into a run, he mouths it again. Izuku takes in everything with his eyes. Katsuki then hits the box, and his pole bent underneath his iron grip, and within seconds, the blonde was airborne. And Izuku watches, as if for the first time, as the sun shines behind Katsuki’s head like an explosion, and the athlete’s figure was incredible as he flew. He flew high, too. So high, that he seemed to touch the clouds with his fingertips. So high, that he looked like the hawk he admired so much.

So high, that he cleared the bar. The 17’11 bar, for the very first time.

Izuku stood up without thinking, and ran over to Katsuki, as the blonde falls back on the landing mat with the bar still in its place. Katsuki looks up, sees its there, and his eyes widen but he only looked at it for a split second, before his attention was on Izuku, who was coming towards him. Izuku's face was shocked, and he yelled.

"Kacchan!" Izuku called out, and he climbed onto the landing mat, "Y-you did it. You cleared it."

Katsuki begins laughing and nodded, standing up.

Izuku still couldn't believe it, after seeing Katsuki attempt for so long now, and repeated, "Kacchan, you cleared the bar! You did-"

But he was pulled into Katsuki's arms before he could finish his praise, and Izuku's eyes widened. And the athlete embraced him tightly, placing his chin on Izuku's head tenderly, as Bakugo Katsuki holds Izuku in a hug that was too intimate for Izuku's breaking heart.

Izuku goes completely quiet as he's being held like this. It was just a hug. They've touched each other in more erotic ways, in ways that would put them to shame. But it wasn't like this. No, it wasn't like this at all. Izuku couldn't say anything, as Katsuki holds him.

"I was able to do it because of you, nerd," Katsuki declares then, tone completely serious.

And Izuku waits for an explanation, as he's being held on the landing mat like this. *What* ?

"Sprint for 10 seconds, run for 6. That's what you told me, right?" Katsuki recalls, "The day I taught you how to vault. That's what you told me. To sprint for 10 seconds, run for 6."

And a pause, "That's what I did." So that was what Katsuki was mouthing. The number of seconds.

"I'm so fucking bad at words," Katsuki sounded frustated with himself, but Izuku listens patiently, "But I wanted to show you this. I fucking did it. I cleared the bar, because of you. I'm still a piece of shit, but a little less, because of you. I'm a goddamn mess, because of you. I don't get myself anymore, because of you."

Katsuki lets him go, and Izuku pulls away just enough to look up at the taller boy, "Kaccha-"

"But *fuck,* " Katsuki looks away, as if he couldn't understand himself as he spoke, "I'm fine with it, *because* it's you."

Izuku's eyes widened. The change of *one* word completely flipped the meaning, and before he knew it, tears were coming up to Izuku's eyes as he stared up at the beautiful boy that he was so in love with. They were so fucked up. Dysfunctional. Katsuki could say the sweetest things like this one moment, and the worst thing the next. Izuku has to deal with the fact that Katsuki doesn't even mean these things romantically, but as a friend. And that hurt, even if the words fulfill his heart. He knew how difficult it probably was for the blonde to say something like this, and he couldn't help but cry.

God, he loved this boy so much. He loved him so, so much, and Izuku stared at him as if Katsuki was the star to his skies. Izuku wanted to kiss him. He wanted to love Katsuki the way he wanted to. But he knew that this was Katsuki speaking as a friend, not as a lover.

This was Katsuki's way of telling Izuku that he was important to him, without directly saying it.

And when the tournament come around that Saturday, the feelings of love and pride that he feels for the boy does not go away, as he stands in the bleachers.

He had visited the tent earlier to wave at the blonde, who was still wearing Izuku's inverted headband on his wrist for goodluck. Izuku was wearing Katsuki's jersey, with a printed #1 and the athlete's family name on it, just like he asked. And when the blonde saw him, Izuku doesn't think he's seen a smile more pretty than that.

Katsuki tried to hide his grin as he turns back to his team, but Izuku could see it from the side that the blonde was still stupidly grinning to himself at the sight of Izuku in his jersey. That fact made his heart beat a little faster.

This was the last regionals tournament before the National Qualifiers happens, and it is at this one where Katsuki will probably have to jump 17'7 or so, which was about one inch above his last year's official record, to win the whole tournament. His personal record, now 17'11 once he can consistently get it, was to be used at the National Qualifiers, and with Katsuki's drive, Izuku knew that the boy will want to get into the 18 feet bars.

And so, Katsuki takes this tournament as the highest vaulting participant. Kirishima makes it to National Qualifiers as well, but the gap between Katsuki's jump and second place was too large of a margin that it wasn't even fair to compare.

When Izuku comes down, Katsuki smirks and tosses his trophy over to Izuku.

"This is gonna look good as hell in my collection," Katsuki tells him.

And Izuku grins, "Congratulations! Now, to beat everyone at National Qualifiers. You got three weeks, right?"

Katsuki nodded, "Yeah. Fucking ridiculous, right? They're trying to wrap up the season quick, but three weeks is no time at all."

"Is it enough to get to 18'3?" Izuku asked, with wide eyes.

"It's just qualifiers," Katsuki tells him, "If I can vault to 18'0, I'll get in fine."

Izuku nodded, and then saw the rest of the vault team, "Hey, guys!" The boy threw his arms up in a wave.

When the rest of the team approaches, Katsuki and Izuku break off temporarily as plenty of people were congratulating the blonde, and Izuku was just conversing with some of his

friends on the side of the stadium. It was a good atmosphere, and once again, Ise High reigns supreme with two vaulters that made it to National Qualifiers.

“Feels good to be on top, huh,” Izuku hears a familiar voice talk to him from the side.

The greenette turns his head and came face to face with Kaito Sen, who was approaching him. The tall brunette had a nice smile on his face. Those sultry eyes were on him, with his chin tilted up, as his hands stay in the pocket of Kaito’s sweatpants. The brunette’s hair was styled up well, and he looked over to the stadium, giving it a good look over.

“It still feels good to know some of your teammates are gonna be repping Ise at National Qualifiers,” Kaito nods with an appreciative smile, before turning his grey orbs back to Izuku, “How have you been.”

Izuku smiles up at the brunette, “I’ve been fine. And you?”

Kaito nods at this, and steps closer until they were standing side by side, looking out at the track field, “That’s good. I’ve been good. I got an internship coming up over the summer before university starts, so that’ll be fun.”

“Where at?” Izuku wonders.

“My mom’s law firm,” Kaito snorts, “The pleasures of nepotism.”

Izuku laughs out loud at this, and shakes his head up at Kaito’s remark.

“I missed hearing that,” Kaito leans back on a railing and looks down towards the ground, “That pretty laugh.”

Izuku smiled gently and looked over to the brunette. Kaito was undeniably handsome, with a nice jawline, smoky brown hair, and sultry grey eyes. But he just couldn’t feel anything deep with the other, and he knew it was his fault to a great degree. He really never gave the guy a genuine chance, considering that he has always been gravitated towards Katsuki from the very beginning. Still, Izuku knew that even if he *had* given Kaito a true chance, there were too many clashes in their personalities. The fact that the brunette had this idealized picture of who Izuku was supposed to be, that he projected onto him. The fact that Izuku wanted to enjoy his hobbies and interests which may seem less mature, while Kaito’s interests lies more within safe boundaries.

Either way, they were just not meant to be. But Izuku could appreciate Kaito as a person, that deserves respect as much as anyone else.

“Kaito…” Izuku begins.

“Hey, if you’re about to go into some sappy apology over what happened,” Kaito laughs, “Don’t bother. It’s all good.”

“No,” Izuku shakes his head, “You deserve an apology, not just for the night of the fair. But for me never really giving you a chance. I…” Izuku looks down, “wanted someone to distract me, and that just wasn’t fair to you.”

He wasn't a perfect person, he knew that. But not being a perfect person was not an excuse to ignore your mistakes.

"I told you, it's all good," Kaito nods, "Besides, it's not like I was completely genuine either," And then he scoffed at himself, "I hate Bakugo Katsuki as a person. That shit just won't change. I wanted to take away something from him."

Izuku pursed his lips, "Oh…"

"Don't get me wrong," Kaito assures him "I did like you a lot." He laughs, "But I know a losing game when I see one."

Izuku looks at him with sorry eyes.

"Anyways, have you figured it out for yourself yet?" Kaito asked him, "What I was saying about Bakugo?"

The greenette can't forget it, more like. He remembers Kaito's words clearly. Bakugo Katsuki was not built to love.

"What about Bakugou?" Kirishima comes in to throw an arm around the both of them with an enthusiastic grin, interrupting their conversation.

"Oh, just," Kaito turns and raises his voice a bit louder than needed, "How he's never gonna be able to love anyone. Because he's a lunatic and is emotionally unavailable." Kaito purposely jokes, out loud, but everyone in the vicinity knew it wasn't a joke.

Izuku really disliked how Kaito loved to stir the pot, and he glanced over to Katsuki, who looked at the two of them and then at the ground, following the statement Kaito made. Izuku's eyes widened. No snarky comment? Because the blonde just didn't hear.

"Kaito, why'd you do that," Izuku shook his head.

"Because I don't like him," Kaito laughs, and then looked over to Bakugo, "Is he looking? No? Wait, here he goes. He's looking now."

And then, Kaito Sen turns to him, and then leans down, whispering really closely to Izuku, "Forgive me for this one last time."

"Huh?" Izuku blinked.

And then Kaito moves his head to kiss him softly on the lips just for a second before pulling away, "What you said earlier, about me being a distraction. I could still be a distraction you know," The brunettes hints to him, "Think about what I said. If you ever need someone to be with," He offers, "I can show you a good time."

Kaito says, as he walks backwards and away. Izuku looks after him, knowing exactly who was meant to see that kiss. And he didn't want to turn his head to see. And so, Izuku just stands there.

People filter out of the stadium as it gets darker and darker outside, until it was just Izuku and Katsuki left. They had planned on going home together anyways, so when the last vaulter leaves, Izuku waves Katsuki's over. And the blonde makes his way.

"Kacchan," Izuku smiled, "Don't you ever get sick of winning?"

The boy in question snorts, "Can't say I do."

The greenette leans off of the railing and meets Katsuki halfway, "I want to take a walk. Around the track."

The crickets were calling. They weren't in Ise anymore, but the crickets were still loud here where the last regionals were held. Katsuki looks down at the track, the back at Izuku, before nodding, "Let's walk around the track then, nerd."

And so they climbed down onto the track field, painted red with white lines. It looked huge being down here, and Izuku walks side by side with Katsuki. They talk, about a lot.

Izuku doesn't really ever have to worry about conversation, because it just flowed so easily. Tonight, Katsuki seemed a lot more quiet though, and he answers questions a lot more seriously, without as many sarcastic jokes. There was something on the blonde's mind, for sure. But Izuku was just going to talk, about his day, about something interesting he read an article about, and whatnot.

It was nice, to just walk like this next to the blonde, on the platform that Katsuki performed on, and just talk. Katsuki listens well.

Currently, Izuku was just ranting about how cool he thought skin moved underwater.

"-nd it ripples really weird, too!" Izuku just goes on a tangent, as Katsuki listens and walks next to him, "I might have a video, but the gist is, if you use a very slow camera that films about 240 frames per second, you can see how skin kind of ripples with the tension of the water. You wouldn't ever really think of that, until you se-"

A hand moved his left cheek suddenly, interrupting Izuku's thought process, and his face was gently pulled towards Katsuki, who had stopped walking by now and stood next to him. Izuku's eyes widened as he then sees Katsuki's lean in all of a sudden to kiss him.

Katsuki, who had been pretty quiet all night after the tournament ended, who just decided to walk alongside him and chime in here and there to reply, all of a sudden stopped to kiss him, interrupting Izuku mid-sentence, as if he just couldn't wait.

Although Izuku was a bit surprised, he received the kiss well, and Katsuki kissed him deeply, moving closer then. Both of the athlete's large hands went up to cup Izuku's cheeks, and the shorter male stood up on his tiptoes to really get in on the action, and Katsuki just held his face and kissed him deeply.

It took Izuku's breath away, as Katsuki just kisses his lips without tongue or biting. Just sensual kissing that pulled him flushed together, in the middle of a giant track field stadium.

It was so odd, especially after he's been so quiet all evening, for a reason Izuku wouldn't get an answer for.

And so they make out like that for a little bit longer. At some point, Katsuki moved his left hand down to Izuku's waist to pull the smaller in even closer, while his right hand still held the greenette's face gently. Izuku's heart beat fast, and he wondered if he was supposed to move forward now, even if he really could just make out like this.

But he knew Katsuki wasn't like that. There was something to follow this, he was sure.

And so, Izuku moves his hands down to Katsuki's pants, hands on the waistband, slowly slipping down. Katsuki continues to kiss Izuku, and the shorter male began to untie the laces on Katsuki's pants, pulling away from the kiss a little to see.

To this, Katsuki puts a hand on his wrist and asks in a low voice, "What are you doing."

Izuku then stopped and looked up at Katsuki with confused eyes, "Aren't we…"

Katsuki waits for him to finish, but Izuku was now just confused and couldn't.

And so the athlete furrows his brows a little, asking in the same slow, deep tone, "Aren't we what."

"I mean," Izuku just shrugs, "I just assumed that we were going to...have sex," The smaller rubbed the back of his neck, "Because you started to kiss me."

At this, Katsuki's eyes widened, and Izuku didn't know why the blonde looked so shocked, but then, the athlete's gaze averted to the side.

"I did, didn't I," Katsuki says, blinking at Izuku's face.

Izuku just laughed a little sadly, "Kacchan, you wouldn't just kiss me out of the blue. I just assumed there's something you want after. That's all."

Something about what Izuku said struck something in Katsuki, it seemed, because the blonde then looked pensive, before he turned around, heading back to the car, "Fine, you want to fuck? Let's fuck."

Izuku looked a little surprised at the other's reaction, unsure of why it looked like Katsuki was a bit hurt and trying to cover it up, but he jogged lightly after, "Kacchan? Is everything okay?"

"Why wouldn't it be," Katsuki tells him blankly.

Izuku didn't believe him, and asks again, "D-Did I say something?"

Katsuki looked down at his hands then back over at Izuku, "Nothing you are wrong about. Come on, I'm going to give you what you want."

But as they kept walking out of the stadium towards the car, Izuku shook his head, “Kacchan, no. You need to want it too.”

“I do,” Katsuki then turns towards him and pulls Izuku in by the waist closely, this time kissing Izuku a lot rougher than he did before on the track field. *This* was more like how Katsuki usually did things. Aggressive. Rough. And for some reason, Izuku felt like there was still something wrong.

“Kacch-”

“You want it, right?,” Katsuki growls near his ear, as he lifts Izuku off the ground and puts the boy on his car hood.

“Yes, but-” Izuku began.

“Then take it,” Katsuki pulls Izuku’s shirt off, leaving the smaller boy’s skin exposed to the night air, and he immediately begins sucking roughly and pulling on those beautiful, pink nipples, and Izuku breaths out in pleasure.

“B-But,” Izuku tries to speak, as Katsuki works on his pants, “You need to want it too.”

“I do,” Katsuki takes off the smaller’s pants, “Why would I kiss you otherwise, right?” And then he paused, with both hands on either side of the hood, his head tilted down as if he was battling with himself about something, and asked Izuku genuinely with confusion laced in his face, “Right?”

It was like he needed Izuku to tell him he was right, as if he didn’t believe it himself. But Izuku was at a lost. He was laying here, on his elbows, on the hood of Katsuki’s car, and had no idea what to think. Something was wrong, but Izuku couldn’t tell at all what Katsuki was thinking. All he knew was that instead of waiting for an answer, the blonde begins to take off his own clothing, tossing it to the asphalt, and stands back, hot bare chest breathing heavily as he looks at Izuku’s naked body. They were absolutely ridiculous. This was just outside of the same stadium Katsuki swept a tournament out of.

When Katsuki fingers him, kisses him, and eventually fucks him tonight, he does so with a strange look in his eyes. One of both pleasure, hurt, anger, and confusion. Izuku just couldn’t decipher him. The only thing he could use as an indicator was the filthy words that came out of Katsuki’s mouth, the hard cock tearing apart his body, and the obvious fact that Katsuki was at least turned on, even if he felt a little off. Izuku was in a juxtopositoned state of enjoying the sex intensely and loving every inch of Katsuki that fucked into him, and worrying about what was wrong with the blonde before this happened.

And when the both of them came, with Izuku orgasming a couple of minutes before Katsuki did, after taking a couple minutes to rest, Katsuki pulls out and instead of laying next to Izuku, he slowly moves until he was sitting with his back towards the smaller.

Katsuki removed the condom, tied a knot, and walked buck naked a couple of feet to throw it away in the trash can, before coming back to slide his boxers on. And when that was done,

Izuku was still laid back on the trunk, while Katsuki sit on the edge, not looking at the greenette at all.

Instead, he looked up at the sky, before moving his gaze down to his feet for a while. His shoulders seemed dropped, and Izuku didn't understood what was wrong. They sit like that for a while, before Izuku pulled himself up to a sitting position. Very cautiously, the greenette reached his hand out place it on the athlete's bare back, and Katsuki turned his head partially to the side at the touch.

"Kacchan?" Izuku softly called out to the boy.

Katsuki just hummed to acknowledge that he heard the other.

"Something is bothering you…" Izuku tries to gentle talk to him, slowly bringing his head to rest against Katsuki's back as they sit there together, "I want to know about it."

Katsuki doesn't say anything, and he doesn't move Izuku off of him either. And for a while, Izuku just sits there waiting for a response, when the athlete finally speaks, "It's nothing."

"Kacchan, what did I tell you about hiding away y-" Izuku began.

"I do have a question," Katsuki then interrupts.

*A question* . Izuku quirked a brow in curiosity, then asked, "A question?"

"Yes," Katsuki's voice seemed a bit strained, "I'm fine, okay. Do you believe me? I won't fucking ask until you say you do."

Izuku doesn't believe him, but he says yes anyways, "I believe you."

Katsuki seemed to relax a bit more, but he looked to now be collecting his thoughts. Izuku waits patiently, as Katsuki ponders on how to word his question for a long time.

But even when the question comes out, it still didn't look as if Katsuki could ask it.

"Do you think that I'm not...that I can't…' Katsuki started, before sighing in frustration, and beginning again.

Izuku leans off of Katsuki's back, as his eyes widen, because he feels like he knew where the question was going.

" *Fuck* . Do you think that I'm never gonna be able to…" Katsuki can barely even say the damn word, but Izuku knew exactly what he was saying and what he was referring to. It had been what Kaito said. Love. Is the last word. *Never gonna be able to love anyone. Because he's a lunatic and emotionally unavailable.* And suddenly, Izuku's heart dropped for the other. So that has been what Katsuki had been thinking about all of this time.

"I mean," Izuku tries to recall, "Don't you think that way too?"

Katsuki then starts chuckling to himself, "I do, don't I."

Izuku's eyes widened. And he felt a deep pain for Katsuki, that he hasn't even thought of before. Sure, Izuku's always believed in the good of Katsuki. And that he could be more open, more vulnerable, more outwardly happy. But he hadn't even realized that like everyone else, Izuku has also fallen into the trap of already being convinced that Katsuki was just not capable of loving someone.

And it wasn't as if the blonde made the opposite case known. Because Katsuki had said it himself. He wasn't meant for soft, kind touches. Coddling. Loving. It wasn't as if there was not a case to be made.

But when other people begin to think the same, when the rest of the world also believes that you just cannot possibly love someone, Izuku can see how that made a person not even want to try to change or anything at all. And that was when Izuku realized that there was no one, not even Katsuki, who thought that the blonde was capable of love. And that hurt Izuku so badly. He was complicit.

"But whatever," Katsuki stood up and stretched, masking his face once more, "It's better this way."

"Kacchan…" Izuku looked up at the blonde, with a heavy heart.

"Let's go. It's getting late, nerd," Was all that Katsuki said, and Izuku wasn't sure when he'd be able to see this vulnerable side of Katsuki again, especially as he was watching it seal up more than it had even beed before.

But Izuku just sits there for a little while longer, just a minute or too, thinking of Katsuki, before sighing and grabbing his clothes to walk over to the passenger seat.

When he climbs in, Katsuki has his hands on the wheel, and his eyes ahead, ready to back out, "Are you free tomorrow evening."

Izuku looks over to the blonde, and slowly nods, "I am."

"At 7PM," Katsuki thinks of a time, and backs out of the parking lot, "I'll pick you up. Wear something nice."

Izuku quirked a brow. This? This was weird. This wasn't what Katsuki ever usually asked of him. Not only did the blonde specify a time, but also an attire that was more formal? That was definitely odd, and doesn't seem like it was in the realm of what the athlete usually did.

But the only thing Izuku could do was softly tell Katsuki, "Okay."

"Great," Katsuki nods to himself.

Izuku didn't know what to expect, but what Katsuki had in mind *definitely* was not it. They never did things like this. When Katsuki picked him up, he was dressed in a polo shirt and a nice pressed pair of pants, instead of the usual street attire. Meanwhile, Izuku just kind of wore something that was elegant without trying too hard. The outfits were fine.

What was completely out of the ordinary was the fact that Katsuki took the two of them to a pretty formal restaurant, and at first, Izuku thought they might have gone to the wrong place, but when the blonde checks into their reservation, which brings them to a table far back, the greenette was utterly confused.

“Kacchan, what exactly do you have in mind?” Izuku laughs lightly, as he sits down on the nice cushioned seat.

Katsuki looked over and nodded towards a waiter, before turning back to Izuku, “I thought we could, I don’t know, go to a restaurant or some shit.” He said as he lays the black towel on his lap. Katsuki’s obviously done this before, but it didn’t look like the blonde particularly enjoyed this atmosphere.

Izuku frowned, “You...like these kinds of restaurants?”

“They’re whatever,” Katsuki shrugs, as he brings a finger to rub at his bottom lip.

The doe eyed boy then asked with a chuckle, “So why are we here, then?”

“Do you not like it? Is it not nice?” Katsuki suddenly asked him, and Izuku’s eyes widened.

“No, it is!” Izuku shakes his head, “It’s really nice, but this doesn’t look like the thing we usually do.”

“Yeah, well,” Katsuki looks off to the waiter, “Dingey diners and sketchy places aren’t the best places to take people all the time.”

He orders a water when the waiter gets to them, and Izuku does the same. And Katsuki orders bruschetta as an appetizer. And if Izuku was being honest, this was just so out of character that he was almost awkward and uncomfortable. The atmosphere was stuffy, and Izuku knew Katsuki thought so too. So why was the athlete here.

“I...think dingey diners, and sketchy places are fine…” Izuku admits, “When they’re with you.”

Katsuki looked a bit surprised at this, before hiding his expression. A habit he hasn’t been fully able to kick.

“Cheesy nerd,” Katsuki tsked with a slight grin, before staring over at Izuku. It was a bit of an awkward dinner, only because Izuku was too confused to say anything of substance, and Katsuki just looked bored out of his mind, but determined to be there. Their food was delicious, but it was typical pricey restaurant food.

Izuku looks around the restaurant, with jazz music playing in the background, and asks, “So what are we doing after this?”

Katsuki took a hold of his glass of water, and took a sip, “We can walk around the park or some shit. I don’t know.”

Now something was *definitely* up. This wasn't the type of hang outs Katsuki and Izuku usually had. These were the types of hang outs that Izuku and Kaito usually had. No, this was wrong.

The greenette spoke up then, "Kacchan, tell me seriously, why are we here?"

"What do you mean," Katsuki went from thumbing his lip to looking over at Izuku.

"Why are you doing this?" Izuku asked softly, "I mean, restaurants are fine. And I'm really grateful you took me, but I'm not going to lie, this just feels a little not like you."

Katsuki gestured with one hand, while looking a bit stressed, "Isn't this what you're supposed to do? Go to nice restaurants and shit?"

"What *who* is supposed to do?" Izuku wonders.

The blonde leans back in his seat, "Fuck Face did this shit for you. Didn't you like it?"

Izuku's eyes widen, as his suspicions were confirmed, and he heart kind of wrenched itself a little as he looks at Katsuki and sees a waver of confidence. It seemed as if the usual arrogant flair Katsuki had was being challenged by whatever internal thoughts the blonde was going through.

"Kacchan, why are you trying to be like Kaito?" Izuku shakes his head.

"I'm not trying to be like that slimy motherfucker," Katsuki was quick to correct him, before rubbing his temples with his fingers, "Just...shit. It seemed like you liked him."

Izuku was still confused, "Are you trying to get me to like you?" He laughs at the end for the incredulous thought.

Katsuki was quick to shut that down, "No."

"Then what?" If it was one thing Izuku was relatively good at, it was his more sentimental side. It was funny. Katsuki saw him struggle first, as he tries to accept his more assertive side, and not knowing what to do with all of his anger and sadness, and still not exactly knowing what to do to this day. And now, it looked like Izuku was seeing Katsuki struggle with the opposite, trying to figure out and differentiate the odd things he was feeling, and failing to do so.

"I don't fucking know," Katsuki gave up, "I don't know why I'm doing this." And looks off to the side.

Izuku knew he had to be more patient. It was obvious that Katsuki was going through something. But this? Whatever this was? Isn't it.

Izuku tells him then, "Kacchan, let's get out of here."

The blonde perked up at this, and looked now to the doe eyed boy, "Eh?"

“Let’s get out of here,” Izuku asked him, “Take me somewhere I’ll never forget.”

Katsuki just looks at the other then, and then at their table, not having gotten the check yet. And then back up at Izuku, whose eyes were pleading. And Izuku saw it: the excitement brewing in the blonde’s ruby eyes.

Katsuki stands up then, fishing out his wallet to set down a fat bill that would surely be enough to cover their tab, and then grabbing Izuku’s wrist, begins to jog out of the restaurant.

The first hit of fresh air seeped into their lungs, and it felt so much better to be outside than in that slightly awkward atmosphere. He felt normal again, and looks up at Katsuki, who then grins to him.

“Somewhere you’ll never forget, huh,” The athlete asks.

Seeing that mischievous smirk on the pole vaulter’s face was enough to grow some butterflies in Izuku’s chest, as he feels something lifted, and he nods, “Yes.”

Katsuki drives them to the coast, except this time, towards the right. It was rare they they went this direction, since this side of Ise was mainly used for business. Commercial fishing. Marine ports. And so what. The waters weren’t meant for swimming. And at night, it seems a little eerie. But they keep driving further, until there just were not a lot of buildings in the vicinity. Izuku doesn’t question it. He just lets Katsuki drive him wherever.

When they stop, it is on the oceanside, and here, the waves were much more strong. So much that it crashed with a loud roar, which could be intimidating to anyone who dared to get near the water. There was mostly black rock everywhere, rather than sand, and the two boys exit the car. Katsuki grabbed a thin blanket from the trunk full of miscellaneous items in case they get cold, and begins walking towards what looked to be a lighthouse.

It most definitely was a lighthouse, with the classic red and white striped design. At the top was a lantern room, where the actual light of a lighthouse comes from. A very concentrated white stream of light moved back and forth from the top, and Katsuki got onto the rock pathway that led into the lighthouse. Izuku followed quickly behind.

“The lighthouse?” Izuku asked, as he follows closely behind.

Katsuki nods, ignoring the large crashing waves nearby, looking ominous at night, “I want to get to the top.”

Izuku giggles, “Not that it matters, but are we allowed in here?”

“Nope,” Katsuki reveals, “But apparently, it’s usually open from what I’ve read. Being public and all that shit.”

Katsuki tried the door handle, and although it was rusty and made an annoying creek, it did, in fact, open.

Izuku was cold, and shivered to himself while he followed Katsuki inside. It was less windy in here, but the air was still a bit cold. It wasn't completely dark, since the rotating light on top was bright enough that its residual light was enough to illuminate the bottom tiers of the lighthouse. This was really just staircases that winded around the circumference of the lighthouse, similar to what the bell tower looked like, except much less creepy.

Looking up, there were sounds of metal creaking and what not, but the two braved the flights of stairs anyways. It was a lot of stairs, and Izuku was convinced he has the most defined calves now. And the continued walking the circumerence of the lighthouse, looking once in a while to peer out an open window at the ocean below. These windows were where the light was flooding in.

When they got to the top, there was a small hole on the corner with a ladder to climb up onto the actual lantern room of the lighthouse. Katsuki came up first, with the blanket wrapped around his shoulders, and Izuku followed second. The lantern room was pretty large, and was completely open on all sides to the slight wind, except for the top, which had a large awning. In the middle of the lantern room was the rotating light that was too bright to actually look at, so the two had to shield there eyes if they saw the light in their peripheral. The light shone across the ocean, highlighting different sections of the black, roaring sea. Outside, there was a metal rail that wrapped the lantern room in case someone accidentally fell over, and when they stepped out near the ledge, the waves crashing below them were once again massive.

Katsuki fishes out his bluetooth speaker, and just shuffles his music, before sitting down in front of the large rotating light, with the blanket loosely wrapped around his shoulders. After Izuku was done exploring a bit, he comes over to sit next to Katsuki, and wordlessly crawls under the blanket with the blonde, so that it wrapped around the both of them. He was flushed against the athlete's chest, and Izuku hoped that this was okay. If it wasn't, Katsuki wasn't saying anything.

Because they were sitting in front of the light, it was a really interesting affect. Everything around them lit up super bright, including the falling dust particles in the air, and it looked like microscopic snow. In the distance, they can see how the spotlight shines over sections of the ocean, and that was beautiful to watch. The ocean always had a way of making a person feel in awe. It was a bit chilly up here, and he was happy to be snuggled up to Katsuki. The athlete's much taller and wider torso practically wrapped around him, and Izuku wanted this moment to last forever.

The slightly chilly air, the smell of salt water in their nose, the beautiful allure of the white light shining over everything, the dark and dangerous ocean. It was all so beautiful, and even more so when he was resting against Katsuki's chest like this.

"Play a song for me, Kacchan," Izuku whispered to the other, as they both stared out into the black ocean, having their vision disrupted like slow strobe lights by the bright white light.

Katsuki pulled out his phone before asking, "What is it."

"Fragile," Izuku says quietly, "by Sting."

The other, seemingly never heard of it before, types in the song, and it begins playing. The lantern room immediately becomes filled with very slow and soft guitar that involves hints of romance and sadness. It almost sounded Latin, especially with the first couple of chords played in the beginning. This song always left a beautiful, but sad feeling in Izuku's heart. The introduction was the most gorgeous part, and once the singer begins the first verse, Izuku knew that he was going to melt. It wasn't necessarily the lyrics that haunted him, but that beautifully dark melody that made him feel as if he was floating into an unsure paradise.

The song plays, and Izuku is right up against Katsuki's chest. The other had his chin resting on top of Izuku's head, and the greenette slowly pulls back, turning his torso partially around to look up at Katsuki. Upon seeing a pair of eyes on him, Katsuki looks down to Izuku.

*If blood will flow when flesh and steel are one*

*Drying in the colour of the evening sun*

A couple of words leave Katsuki's lips, in a soft tone that matched the music, "What do those creepy ass eyes want from m-"

But Izuku leans in to kiss him, cutting off his words.

And that kiss exploded like a bunch of little fireworks in his mouth, as Izuku had no self control to hold back the emotions he poured into it. That kiss called for the heavens to sing and for the earth's flowers to bloom. Izuku couldn't hide it. All of the emotion, the pain, the love in this kiss.

*Tomorrow's rain will wash the stains away*

*But something in our minds will always stay*

Izuku moves slowly, body still enveloped by Katsuki, as he sensually and lovingly kisses the athlete. He was making a mistake, he knew it, but he had already made the leap. Now, it was just freefall.

The music plays in the background, like a haunting lullaby. Izuku's kiss was too sweet, too soft, and too slow. They've never touched like this. Sure, Katsuki had kissed him slow the other night at the stadium, but even then, it wasn't like this. Completely vulnerable, and transparent with its intent. He just hopes it's opaque for Katsuki.

Izuku pulled away very gently, lashes fluttering as he moves his head just far enough to look up at Katsuki, who stares at him back during the sultry guitar solo with such a conflicted gaze.

"Izuku…" Katsuki says his name, and then tells the other, "… we shouldn't." ."

But he didn't want to, and so, Izuku now pivots his body so that he was completely facing towards Katsuki, still surrounded in blankets with the blonde's hands around his waist, and he brings his face forward once more, meeting Katsuki in such a deep and sensual kiss that his heart melted in the other's lips. Katsuki kisses him back, as if unable to resist himself.

Izuku places his hands on Katsuki's face as he sits on the other's lap, and very slowly makes out with him behind the backdrop of the ocean and a saddeningly beautiful tune. And when it ends, Izuku tells him to play it again. If he can keep this moment, and relive it over and over again, he thinks he'll be okay when this all comes crashing down. But then again, how many times has he said that already.

*On and on the rain will fall*

*Like tears from a star like tears from a star*

"Kacchan," Izuku closes his eyes as his face is kept near the other, and he hovers his breath over the other's sweet lips, "Make love to me."

He didn't want to open his eyes to see the other's reaction. He didn't know how he bothered asking. But he wanted it. He needed it. To touch and be touched by Katsuki in a way no other has even done so. He doesn't know if he's able to convince Katsuki that he didn't love him after this night, after this kiss, after this request.

The blonde tells him in a voice so gentle, "I can't."

He can't? Or he won't. Those words were too gentle to be real, so Izuku just asks the other, with his tone soft and open. He wanted a better answer than that he couldn't.

"Why?" Izuku asks him, kissing him again softly.

He doesn't open his eyes, but the words that he hears from Katsuki's lips wouldn't have hurt any less with his eyes open. He wished he never heard it. God, he wished he never heard it.

"Because I don't love you," Katsuki tells him.

*On and on the rain will say*

*How fragile we are how fragile we are*

Izuku opens his eyes then, and looks into Katsuki's own, hoping to find some trace of a lie, but they were so clouded that he couldn't find anything.

He won't cry. He refuses. Not right now. Not tonight. He will, however, repeat those words over and over again in his head until he falls asleep tonight. He wanted to protest.

How would Katsuki know? He didn't even know what love was, how could he know he didn't feel it? But that was fruitless. If Katsuki felt strongly enough to say that, then what would Izuku know.

*Because I don't love you.* Izuku wishes that he had never asked.

The green eyed boy traces Katsuki's lips then, mapping his face with those soft fingertips, before telling the boy, "I don't need you to." *Yes, I do* .

Katsuki is quiet, and pulls Izuku's lips in to kiss him gently once more, "Then why ask," Katsuki laughs quietly, "Do you love me?"

Izuku can't admit it. He refuses to. Not when the other had so blatantly confessed that he doesn't feel the same. He'd be a fool and a wreck to admit it. And he hated that Katsuki laughed. He hated that so much.

And so Izuku lies, "No," He lies so hard, and slowly reaches down to remove his shirt, "But can't we pretend for a night? Just to…" The greenette looks down so that his lies are hidden by his eyes, "Just to see."

Katsuki holds him in his lap, both of them still wrapped in blanket, and looks at him for a while. When Izuku composes himself and pushes the words of *I don't love you* away, he stares back, trying to hide all of the love he had to give. Because although his lips can pretend to lie, his eyes can't.

The blonde reaches over to get a hold of his phone, replays the song again, and then lifts Izuku and shifts so that he could gently lay down the greenette onto the ground, warmed up by the blanket and their body heat.

And there, Katsuki gets the closest thing to making love to Izuku.

The kisses he leaves were soft, and the ones that Izuku left were even softer. They cradled each other's bodies like precious jewels, and for a night, Izuku had convinced Katsuki to forget about their agreement. To not coddle, to not hold each other, to not caress one another tenderly. This was all of that, and more. And Izuku's heart both ached in simultaneous pain and joy.

These embraces were meant for private eyes, this song engrained itself in their ears, and every touched felt amplified with how sensual and slow it all was. This was different. If Katsuki claimed to not know how to make love, then Izuku wanted to believe he was lying.

Because the athlete, who was used to rough fucking, aggressive kisses, and high speed action, was so gentle and tender with Izuku's body, that for the night, *yes* , Izuku did felt loved. He felt loved as Katsuki stretched him, making sure to go slow and steady not to hurt him a bit. He felt loved as Katsuki trailed kisses up and down Izuku's body, as if worshiping him. He felt loved as later, Katsuki enters him, all while holding Izuku's body tight in a warm hold giving the greenette all the patience in the world.

And when Bakugo Katsuki calls out his name in breathy words that matched his own moans, he felt loved too.

If this was just pretend for one night, then consider Izuku convinced.

After they finished, Izuku knew immediately that he had fucked up. He had fucked up big time, not just for himself but for his stance with Katsuki. He just left himself out in a vulnerable position, claiming that this was all lies, but any fool could see that there were no lies present. But it wasn't even his own behavior that caused panic to boil in his gut.

They had laid in each other's arms after the both of them finished, breaking the explicit rule they had just for this one night. Katsuki's fingers rubbed circles into his hips as he was pressed up against the other adoringly. And it was a silence that was filled with words unsaid. Eventually, Izuku falls asleep, just to be jolted awake by a rush of wind merely two hours later or so it seemed.

When he woke, Izuku quietly gets up on his elbows and notices that Katsuki was no longer holding him any longer. Instead, looking into the distance, Katsuki was out onto the railing, arms on either side, head bowed down as if in a deep, painful thought. Izuku brings himself up to sit, and watches for a while.

In the moonlight, Katsuki's blonde hair looked almost white, outlining the boy in a beautiful glow. And Katsuki stays in that position for a little longer, before bringing his hands up to run through his face as if stressed. Under his breath, Izuku could hear the athlete tell himself *fuck* , before bowing his head over the balcony again.

The greenette sat up a little more, causing a little rustle, and his sound alerted Katsuki that he was awake, and the blonde turned around. A blanket was half draped across Izuku, and the greenette looked over at Katsuki to see that those ruby gems seemed even more conflicted than ever.

But then the expression becomes masked, and Katsuki asks the boy, "You ready?"

Izuku looks down at his body, and then goes for his clothes, slipping on each piece as Katsuki refuse to look at him, and afterwards, tells the other, "I'm ready." In a quiet voice.

The drive home was quiet.

And the next two days were quiet. So quiet that it was making Izuku panic a little bit to himself. It wasn't as if there was no word for Katsuki. The blonde still texted him, even if it wasn't as frequent. And they still saw each other in school, but it almost seemed as if the pole vaulter was avoiding him. But he could have well been paranoid. It was not as if they didn't go two, sometimes three or four, days without really communicating with each other much.

However, considering the context, Izuku had a feeling this was more than just both of them being busy. Katsuki was busy, for sure. He had 3 weeks to prepare for National Qualifiers, not to mention, they had to finish the report for Mr. Toshinori's class in a week or two as well, and turn it in a bit earlier so that the teacher will have time to grade and discuss before school actually lets out. And Izuku was busy as well; however, that had never stopped them

before from talking once they started. This was different, he knew it. He had gone too far a couple nights ago at the lighthouse, and these were the consequences of his actions.

Izuku spent the next two days trying to distract himself, so that he doesn't get overly concerned and make up things that were not true. He was just busy, Izuku convinced himself. Besides, it wasn't his job to keep up with everyday detail of Bakugo Katsuki's life.

But when he was barely getting a text, until really late at night. Or only gets a look sparingly, Izuku had to really focus on school work and other things just so that he doesn't think too hard on it. The physics homework he was working on while he and his friends were on a mandated school break outside on the lawn suddenly was very interesting. From projectile motion to what not, Izuku was suddenly very invested in this piece of homework, just so that he can stop thinking about Katsuki and where the hell the other has been the past two days. And he would have been happy doing that, if Izuku was not listening in to his friend's conversations.

"Oh, have you heard!" Mina lays back on the warm grass and wiggles her toes in them, "Bakugo has finally broken out of his dry spell!"

Izuku dropped everything. The pencil in his fingers dropped from his hands, and he had several thoughts. The first was if the school had somehow found out about them sleeping together. It wasn't as if they made sure to do it in private only. In fact, if Izuku or Katsuki was desperate enough, it barely mattered the location. He hated things being spread around about him, so Izuku didn't enjoy that thought at all.

But then he thought, if it was him they were talking about, then Mina's reaction would be much more bothersome. No.

This was different. This was Mina recounting a story she's heard about someone *else* . Izuku's heart dropped to his stomach.

Ochaco, Iida, and Shoto, who knew the situation with Izuku, was silent, looking almost nervous to have Mina continue.

But Denki, who was sitting with them, was none the wiser.

"No way!" Denki gets up in a sitting position immediately, "Really? After this long?"

Mina nods furiously, "Yeah, isn't it crazy?"

"Who?" The yellow haired friend asked for ample details, "Who was it. What did they do. How did you know. What did they say? When was this."

"This was yesterday," Mina scooted closer, and Izuku feels bile go up from his gut just from listening, "And it was actually Kimi!"

Izuku remembers her. He wanted to throw up. He felt absolutely sick to his stomach, and he wasn't sure if he could stand to listen any more, yet still sits there.

"That babe?" Denki tsked, "Bakugo's got some taste, though."

“Um, guys,” Ochaco sounded a little panicked, as she tries to get them to stop.

“I know right?” Mina giggled, ignoring her, “But…” The pink haired girl frowned a bit, “The way Kimi told the story left out a lot of details, and she seemed to look a little off about something. Anyways,” She waved her hand around nonchalantly, “Apparently, he took her to a lake. With lots of fireflies, is what she said. And how it was *so* beautiful and romantic. She raved a lot about that, it made me jealous,” Mina sighs.

Izuku felt like disappearing. Every word hit him like a truck. Every. Single. Word. The firefly lake, huh.

“And they just swam for a little bit, before he started making out with her,” Mina recalls, and this was where she frowns, “And sorry, this is anticlimactic, but she doesn’t really give a lot of detail after that. She just said they fucked, and then he left. You didn’t hear this from me, but I have a feeling he left without finishing. Why else would she not want to go into detail and sounded so nervous?” Mina giggles, “So is he *really* out of his dry spell?”

“You don’t know that though,” Denki says, and continued to say something else, but it was all a blur to Izuku.

It was bound to happen. It was. It truly was. But to hear it. God, Izuku wanted to disappear. His heart beat so fast that it threatened to burst out of his chest. He couldn’t breathe, he needed to get away. All sounds felt muffled, except for his own breath. No, no, no.

Right after Katsuki had sex with him so tenderly too. Right after all of that, and all of the sweet words the other gave, after everything, after Izuku has fallen in love beyond comprehension, this was when he finds out about this. Kimi. She was beautiful, in certain ways that Izuku wasn’t.

Katsuki slept with someone else. His heart was collapsing on top of itself, and he shakes his head. They weren’t exclusive. He knew that. He had no claim to Katsuki’s heart. He knew that. He knew all of it, and yet, he still hoped. He still prayed.

He still wished on that damn Cliff of Wishes that Katsuki would stay with him past the end, but now he prayed that didn’t come true, because he can barely handle the pain as it is right now. It ripped through his throat and tore the words from his mouth. It sliced through his gut, and made his stomach want to turn upside down.

Izuku gets up, body shaking, as he feels incoming sobs that will not be released yet. He will *not* be crying right now. Not here. Not on school grounds. But his body was shaking. From behind him, he could hear some of his friends call out, but their voices were blurred.

This was the tragedy of his love. This was a pain like no other, and he was foolish to think that he could have braved this. Who did he think he was. Izuku wanted to throw up so badly. And so he pushes past people, heading towards the entrance to the school.

But as he steps towards it, his luck will find that Bakugo Katsuki and a couple of his friends were coming out of the building, laughing at some conversation. Katsuki just looked on slightly bored, until he saw Izuku. And Izuku was sure he looked like a damn wreck right

now. Body was shaking slightly, chest heaving, and eyes on the verge of bursting out into tears.

The blonde's eyes widened at the sight, and he made a beeline towards Izuku, "Oi, nerd. What's wrong."
Izuku ignored him. *No, no* . Get out of the way. Izuku needed him to leave. He didn't want to look at him right now, not when he was like this. No, he can't. Izuku tries to walk past the taller, but Katsuki, being much larger than him and with a foot of height over him, easily blocked his path, reaching out an arm to keep Izuku still.

"Deku," Katsuki stops him, seriously, "You're fucking shaking. What the hell is going o-"

"Don't fucking touch me," Izuku looks at him, and this shocks the other, but the greenette shakes himself off of Katsuki's grip, and walks past, legs wobbling.

He ran to the bathroom, and threw up while crying. He hated how much he cried, and thought that he'd run out of tears by now, but here he was, sobbing once more over a boy who didn't love him. Who *told* him that he didn't love him. And yet, Izuku, responsible for his own mistakes, kept pushing it anyways. His chest rattled at how much strain crying was putting on him, and the green haired boy locked the bathroom so that no one else can come in.

He wasn't okay. He wasn't okay at all, and he sunk to the ground, hugging his knees as his eyes leaked a river, rocking back and forth, repeating to himself in a broken, tiny voice.

"It hurts," He cried, wanting so bad to get rid of the pain in his chest and his head, and rocks himself back and forth, "It hurts, it hurts, it hurts." It hurt so badly, and he just wanted to make it go away. He'd do anything to make it go away.

The pain. The thought of Katsuki with someone else. After all of those late night conversations, laughing about the dumbest shit. After those moments where he could look into Katsuki's eyes and see the world. After the nights where the blonde completely blows him away with something absolutely exhilarating to do, that he wouldn't do with anyone else.

Katsuki took her to the firefly lake. Izuku knew it wasn't exclusive. He knew it wasn't as if it was their thing. After all, they had only gone that one time. But even then, knowing that Katsuki was doing these kind of things with another person, the things that took Izuku's breath away and stole his heart with it, it killed him. It absolutely devastated him.

Izuku's lips wobbled as sobs wrecked his body, and he buries his face into his knees, tasting salty tears as he asks anyone outloud in a tiny voice, "Make it stop. Please, make it stop," He pleaded to himself. He didn't want to feel this any longer. It hurt too much, and he was so stupid to think that he was able to handle this.

And so Izuku sits there for a while longer, crying out his pain, his heartbreak, his frustrations. He sits there for a long time, completely ignoring that classes were back in session. He was going to skip today. He didn't care. He will sit inside of this bathroom until his tear ducts run dry, and he has nothing left to give. Until his eyes loses its puffiness, and stops being bloodshot red. Until he is able to breathe without hiccups.

And this is a while. And in that while, Izuku goes through many thoughts, all avoiding the subject of Katsuki, which he knew will only devastated. He thinks of everyone besides Katsuki, and tries to make himself happy. His mother, despite everything that was going on, care for him. He had friends that loved him, and supported him. Ochaco, who was always so sympathetic, and tried her best to do damage control. Shoto, whose comments and remarks were funny in a way that was unapologetically Shoto. Iida, who was such a reliable friend and Izuku couldn't be more grateful for the love he's been given. Kaito, who-

Izuku pauses. Kaito. The greenette pauses, and he is reminded of the pole vaulter with the brown hair and grey eyes. The one who had offered him that *one* thing. That one thing that Izuku wanted desperately right now.

A distraction.

And so, with a broken voice, but more calm hands, he texts Kaito Sen, who was likely in class right now.

"Distract me."

When five in the evening hits, Izuku was ready. He had stopped himself from thinking for hours now. Because if he did, then he knew he wouldn't stop. And it'll just spiral into that episode of pain earlier that he could not bare to relive. He can't think of Katsuki. Of the night at the school dance. Or the day spent with his grandfather. Or the flower field. He cannot think of any of it. And so, he goes through the rest of his day numb, barely thinking at all except for what he has to.

Izuku walks down the stairs now, with just a black slip that was just see through enough that you could tell that he was not wearing any underwear. He didn't need to. This slip will come off anyways, and underwear wasn't necessary for what he wanted to do, what he needed. His hair was a mess, his face looked a bit better now that he's stopped crying, and he goes down the stairs quietly, not wanting to alert Inko.

Izuku exits through the front door, and slowly closes it behind him. He doesn't even bring shoes. Stepping down the porch, he sees a car pull up. But it definitely isn't Kaito's white sports car. No, this one is much more familiar. Izuku's heart began to beat faster, and no, he knew this was a possibility. Especially with how they left off earlier. He knew that Katsuki wasn't going to just let that be. But not here. Not now. Maybe after Izuku left, but not now. Not when any second now, Kaito was going to pull up as well.

Izuku kept his head low, but that shit wasn't going to fly.

"Oi," Katsuki got out of his car, and briskly walked towards him, "What the *fuck* is up with you." His tone sounded both worried and a little upset.

"Nothing's wrong," Izuku decides to answer just to get the other off of his back.

“Bullshit,” Katsuki sounded annoyed that Izuku was so obviously lying, and stepped in front of the greenette.

“I’m fine!” Izuku looked up at him with wide eyes, then asked, “Kacchan, please move.”

“Yeah, no,” Katsuki laughed with no humor in his tone, “Not until you tell me what the hell is going on with you.”

“And I told you,” Izuku was stubborn.

“You’re fine?” Katsuki asked, disbelieving, “Oh yeah? If you’re fine, then come with me.”

The shorter looked up at the 6’4 blonde in disbelief, “Come with you?” He repeated.

Katsuki looked over to the side, “I...wanted to go to a boardwalk.”

Anger surged through Izuku. Katsuki was not allowed to be like this to him. He can’t handle it, so he wasn’t going to. Not today.

“I have plans,” Izuku said, before walking to the side to get around Katsuki.

The well built athlete wasn’t going to allow that, and stopped Izuku from moving forward with one arm, pushing Izuku back, “Plans.”

Izuku looked up at the boy and affirmed, “Yes.”

And this was when Katsuki decides to really take a look at Izuku. No shoes. A nearly sheer black slip that was either meant for sleeping, tearing off, or sex. And no fucking undergarments.

Katsuki’s voice suddenly changed, and he sounded a lot more dangerous, “With who.”

Izuku wasn’t dealing with this right now, and pushed Katsuki to the side, “None of your business. Go home, Kacchan.”

But the taller didn’t budge an inch, and held Izuku’s arm in place as he repeats, “With who, Deku.”

Izuku just looks at him frustratedly, “Kacchan, you don’t get to ask me those kind of questions. Just let me go.”

“You’re not going anywhere in that,” Katsuki warns him, eyes raking over Izuku’s body once more.

The greenette just laughs, wanting to cry, “Says who.”

“Says me,” Katsuki looked very dangerous at the moment, but Izuku couldn’t even bother, “ *Christ* Deku, you’re not even fucking wearing underwear.”

Izuku steps forward, “I know,” He tells the athlete, “That was intentional.”

Then, the sound of an engine rolls down the street, and once Izuku sees a glimpse of white, he feels relieved. He almost enjoys seeing this kind of rage on Katsuki's face. And as the white car pulled up, Izuku wonders if Katsuki would recognize it.

The blonde male looks at the car, before asking like it was a threat, "Who the fuck is that."

Izuku collected himself, and pushed past the pole vaulter, past the boy he loved so fucking much, and from behind, Katsuki put a hand out on his shoulders to pivot him around.

"Izuku," Katsuki's ruby eyes were both angry with a hint of fear in them, "Tell me that isn't fucking *him* ."

Izuku stares right back into those eyes that he had tragically fallen in love with, dry from crying himself all day, and then gently takes Katsuki's hands off of his shoulders. With a final look, Izuku opens his lips to tell the other.

"Kacchan…" Izuku said with pain in his voice, "Don't overstep your boundaries."

Chapter End Notes

thank you so much for reading, all of the support, and comments. I absolutely adore each and every single one, and hopefully this chapter isn't too much of a drag ! it was really fun to write hahahaha

twt: suffocatingspr1

# Chapter 10: The Hideaway

Chapter Notes

35k words!

these next couple of chapters are going to be very difficult to write, so please forgive me in advance if I don't handle the topics as well as you may have wanted me to. I'm only human & im trying really hard to satisfy the story, but it's really hard, so thank you in advance

Spotify playlist with all the songs ! You need this <3
https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy?si=HlVw_SzHTWWng9UyzmfkBQ&dl_branch=1

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Midoriya Izuku sits in the passenger seat of Kaito Sen's car as it takes the turn onto Hina Ave., looking partially out the window as his left elbow rests on the window sill. His index fingers fidget with the skin of his bottom lip, and a song he was too familiar with was playing on the radio.

I Can't Make You Love Me, sung by the beautiful voice of Bonnie Raitt, attacked his ears.

He remembered the happiness that filled his chest the night this song played, as Katsuki slow danced with him under the light sprinkler mist. For a good week afterwards, he remembered that he would replay that song while he walks, while he studies, while he does just about anything, thinking over the lyrics and having it bring him back to that very night all over again.

Back when things were not as complicated.

Back when he wasn't *as* wrecked over the uncertain future he'll face with Katsuki, when he wasn't plagued by his own misery, back when the decisions he made for himself didn't fuck him up nearly as bad. And *god* , that was the worst part, Izuku thinks.

The fact that he did this to himself, making the same mistakes over and over. Being naive enough, 18 and desperate for a love he's wanted for so long, to continuously give in to

Katsuki, to have false hope, to keep hurting himself. And then to have these realizations, just to repeat the same mistakes.

Even now, Izuku was sitting in the car of Kaito Sen, looking almost pathetically desperate for a distraction, whether it was how he's been behaving today or his need to just get his mind off of Katsuki. He knew that if he were with himself, no matter what he'd be doing, his thoughts would trail back to one person and one person only.

There's a slight twinge of embarrassment at just how desperate he likely seemed right now, brewing in his gut, but the greater feeling of despair outweighed any of that.

"Can we change the song?" Izuku's voice broke through the silence that took a hold over the car.

Kaito, grey eyes and cunning voice, looks over while driving, with a slightly raised brow, before turning the dial, "...sure."

Izuku looks down at his lap then, "Thank you."

And it's quiet for a while. The channel had switched to modern pop, and there's a slight feeling of vertigo as he's reeled back into the realization that he hasn't actually listened to modern songs in a long time. He doesn't recognize what were hits anymore on the radio.

After a moment, Kaito Sen decides to break the silence, leaning back into his seat as he drives, "So that was funny, huh," He lets out a chuckle, "I've never seen Cap look like that." In reference to Katsuki.

Izuku, already a bit on edge, spoke with seriousness in his voice, "Kaito, with all due respect," He turned to the brunette with pain in his large green eyes, "Please be quiet."

Kaito looked away as if a bit embarrassed, "I'm sorry."

But the words had already poisoned itself in Izuku's mind, and he knew what Kaito was referring to. It was that last look. That *very* final sequence of looks that Katsuki had on his expression as Izuku tells him:

*'Don't overstep your boundaries* ,' Izuku had said, looking up at the boy he loved to no end with pain in his tone.

Izuku remembered just about every detail of Katsuki's expression in that twenty second time frame between him delivering that line and him turning around to head to Kaito's car. There were three.

The first? The look on his face darkened with anger at how harsh Izuku's words were. Izuku reeled inside. Katsuki had no right being angry, when it would be the most hypocritical thing he has done, on top of every other hypocritical, just outright confusing, thing he has done. He had *no* right to be angry when Katsuki lost his shit whenever anyone even *dares* to come near

him, but sees no problem when he does the same. He had no right to be angry when the words that Izuku threw at him were the *exact* ones that Katsuki had said first.

The second? A sudden switch, Izuku noticed, from anger to...surprise? Those ruby eyes, so used to looking sharp, composed, and intense, widened as it looked like he realized something. That was when Katsuki seemed to realize:

Katsuki had heard those words before somewhere. Izuku watches as Katsuki comes to some sort of understanding that left the athlete stunned. And Izuku thinks, for a second there, that Katsuki finally knew how much it hurt for him to have heard those words the first time.

But it wasn't that which had lingered on Izuku's mind, ten minutes now that they had left his lawn. It wasn't that at all. It was the very final look on Katsuki's face.

The third: when that surprise settled, what came after was a look of acceptance. As if it was then that Katsuki had realized his own mistake, as if it was then that Katsuki *now* understood the consequences of his words. And without another word, Katsuki walked back to his car and left.

Izuku didn't want to think about it. No, he *wasn't* going to think about it. That's why he was here, with Kaito. So that he *didn't* have to think about it. Which was why it annoyed him that the brunette brought Katsuki up.

"So," Kaito cleared his throat, "Where do you want to go? We can go back to my place."

Izuku thinks about it. Where else could they go that wasn't tinged with the essence of Katsuki? Izuku wanted to laugh at the tragedy, but just tells the brunette, "Can we?"

Kaito nodded, "Of course."

Izuku then looked at the other, from the side of the car. The history that Izuku has had with his boy had been unfair, and he understood this with a heavy heart, even after apologizing. And he was not about to make the same mistake again.
"Kaito...one more thing," Izuku prefaced, his breath hitching, "This is just casual, right? I don't want to-I don't want to ever give you a hard time again."

Kaito nodded, in understanding, with his eyes on the road as they pulled up into a larger house, "Midoriya. You forget that I'm the one who suggested this to you. So don't worry about it."

Izuku still looked a bit hesitant as if still guilty, so the other spoke up again.

"Look," Kaito glanced over at Izuku, "Let's just have some fun, alright?"

Finally, the shorter gave him a slight smile, and turned his eyes back to the road, "Okay."

He was allowed to have some fun. No, he should.

Kaito's house sat upon a small hill, and if this even made sense, it gave off the same energy as Kaito. The house was structured very well, large and nicely designed, very formal, it

seemed. The brunette's room was the same way. There were frames of his pole vault pictures, travel photos, and whatnot lined neatly on the walls of the gray-painted room.

The gray walls matched the color of its owner's eyes. There were bookshelves with classic literature, and law books, even though the boy still had a long way to go until he would even be applying to law school. The bed had a backlit headboard, emitting a soft white glow, contributing to the very much contemporary theme of the house that didn't exactly mesh well with Ise's theme.

"My parents aren't home," The grey eyed boy says as he kicks his shoes off.

Izuku stands in front of the bed, looking at the artwork on top of the headboard, and asked, "Work?"

"Yeah," Kaito replied as he walks up slowly behind the other, "Dad's out for a firm dinner. Mom's got a case holding her up in the next town over."

Kaito stands behind him, with about 6 inches over Izuku's head, and those athletic arms reach down to hold his sides, thumbing circles into the fabric, and Kaito's head drops to Izuku's shoulders, until his lips found the skin of the greenette's neck.

Izuku's eyes fluttered closed, and he tilted his head back slightly, asking without actually paying attention, "What kind of law does she practice, again?"

Kaito begins to suck a little harder on Izuku's skin, bound to leave a mark, as those hands trail up to Izuku's shoulders. He pulled away for a moment just to mention, "Corporate."

And then, those hands on his shoulders slide the straps off, so that in less than a second, his clothes fall to the ground in a heap of soft fabric, and the slight chilliness in the room sends a shudder down Izuku's beautiful, bare body.

The hands then glide across his skin momentarily, enjoying the sensation of it all, before ending its journey on Izuku's muscles. That was where the hands drop, and where Kaito then preferred to grab onto places with a bit more 'meat.' Whether it be his ass, his thighs, or his face.

Oddly enough, never his arms, his calves, or his torso. Katsuki, when they fucked, the blonde seemed to be turned on by every single part of Izuku. This was a bit different.

But before his brain could spiral into other thoughts, Izuku forced himself to focus back onto the moment. Focus on Kaito. Focus on the feeling of his skin being nipped at and sucked on, as those hands grab onto his body.

And *damn* , Kaito liked to mark. Izuku knew this would be a pain in the ass to deal with in the morning. But he didn't mind it. Not right now. He could borrow some foundation, or just wear clothes that covered up any affected area. The problem with that was *everything* was becoming an affected area.

As Kaito's lips moved down his body, there were marks on his neck, his shoulders, his stomach and back, and between his thighs. Without context, Izuku knew this would probably look bad. But the sensations did help him. With every tug of his skin, or touch of another's lips that had a different taste than the ones he was used to, Izuku was able to muddle his mind from thinking of Katsuki.

Sex quite literally released endorphins, and he found nothing wrong with relying on that just for tonight.

"I'm always surprised that you're not as soft as I thought you'd be," Kaito chuckles lightly, as he hits Izuku's biceps gently.

The green eyed boy gave him a funny look, and smiled in confusion, "Why do you want me to be dainty so bad? I like being strong," Izuku laughed.

Kaito shrugged his shoulders before going back down to kiss Izuku, "It's just not expected."

Izuku kissed him back, but had to ask, "Is that a problem?" It's never been a problem with Katsuki. *No* , Izuku said, *Do not compare* .

Kaito, still with his lips making marks on Izuku's shoulders, shrugs, "Nah."

Kaito Sen was not small.

To be fair, it was not as big as the cock that *Izuku* was used to, but it was still by no means small. A good eight inches, with nice enough girth and compared to what Izuku was used to taking, this was more like a warm up. But nevertheless, it was sometimes more about the motion of the ocean, rather than the size of the boat, if Izuku decides to be cliche. If his 7 inch dildo could do the job before, then Kaito could surely do the job now.

"How do you want it?" Kaito asked him, after they had seemed to wrap up however long foreplay they had in order to get Izuku distracted and hard enough for them to fuck. After a fair amount of fellatio and long sessions of making out, Izuku would say he was quite turned out.

Izuku closes his eyes, and tilts his head back when he breathes out, "As rough as you can give it to me."

"Got it," Came the response.

Kaito Sen was a good partner in bed. He clearly had some form of experience, judging from the way Izuku's legs were held in the air as the other had thrusted inside of him, from the lack of hesitation when it came to putting on the condom and stretching out Izuku.

He didn't want to think of Katsuki. He didn't want to fucking think of Katsuki.

He didn't want to think about how Katsuki's hands were bigger, rougher. How Katsuki's cock was thicker, longer. How Katsuki fucked him harder, *better* . This wasn't about Katsuki. It was about Kaito, and the intimacy they were sharing now. But little snippets of the blonde

bypassed into his consciousness like intrusive thoughts, that he couldn't quite kick away even though he wanted to.

"Midoriya," Kaito bruises his lips between words and rhythmic thrusts, "You're so sensitive."

Izuku held onto the other's shoulders, as his breath is ragged, "Yeah?"

Kaito just hummed in response, before moving his lips down to suck on Izuku's pert nipples as his hip continued to thrust into the willing shorter male. Izuku lets out a breathy moan, as he grabs onto the brunette's hair with one hand and the sheets with the other.

It takes another twenty or so minutes for them to finish, with Izuku coming first, painting ribbons on both of their stomachs. Izuku rode out the wave, taking in as much of the dopamine rush as he could. Though he was emotionally in a volatile state, he was rational enough to decide that this was what he wanted to do. There was nothing wrong with seeking pleasure, and so he sought it. Which was why although it killed him, how could he get *mad* at Katsuki for doing the same thing when all they've claimed to be was friends. All he allowed himself to feel was sad.

When Kaito was about to finish, he pulled out, making Izuku look down in confusion. But he saw the brunette move his hands to take the condom off, and then leaned forward to hold Izuku by the back of his neck.

"Come here," Kaito tells him as he guides the greenette up into a kneeling position, "I want to finish in your mouth."

Raising a brow, he opens his mouth as Kaito leads his bursting cock up to his pink lips, and Izuku immediately tastes the rubbery aftertaste of the condom still on the flesh, but still sits there as Kaito then proceeds to finish in his mouth. The cum was bitter and warm, sliding down his throat smoothly, and dribbled slightly on the sides of his lips.

He swallowed, watching the brunette look down at him with a satisfied grin. Sex with Kaito was good, Izuku told himself. It did the job for both of them. He came, it was hot, and it was something he wanted, so *that* was no problem.

What *is* a problem was that now, Kaito Sen looked a little too smug.

"What is it," Izuku turned over to look at the boy.

The brunette just shrugged, "Nothing. Let's get you cleaned up. I'm a gentleman, after all."

Izuku pulled himself up to his elbows and laughed lightly at Kaito, "You have a strange asphyxiation with that, you know."

Kaito hops into the bathroom to get some things, and calls out from inside, "With what?"
"With being a gentleman," Izuku put the last word in air quotes, "So what am I supposed to be exactly?"

The brunette goes over to begin wiping at Izuku's stomach with a warm, wet towel, "The lady, of course. I've been trying to show you the good life this entire time, but you're too

preoccupied with Mr. Perfect," Kaito chuckles.

Izuku frowns at this, still taking the comment lightheartedly but disliking what Kaito was trying to imply, "I'm a boy, you know."

"I know," Kaito puts both of his hands up as if innocent, "I'm just saying. We could have had it good. I would've paid for all your meals, taken you out to nice places, do you like this every night."

Izuku decides to give Kaito the benefit of the doubt and stretched his torso as Kaito finishes cleaning him up, "Kaito," He laughs, "I never needed all of that. Besides, all of those are things I could do myself too."

The other goes to clean himself up and stands back, commenting, "Why would you? You could just sit back and let me be the gentleman."
"I can be the gentleman just as much as you can," Izuku blinked up at the brunette, voice still not that serious. He was, however, beginning to get sick of that word.
All of this time, Kaito had wanted him to be a certain way, and he's never said anything about it. From back when they still went out occasionally on dates, it always seemed like there were expectations on what he should or should not do, on how he should or shouldn't behave.

"Oh drop the act, Midoriya," Kaito tosses the wet towel into the bathroom, and slips on his boxers. The brunette's tone was a bit skittish, almost like he was amused with something. It didn't sound harsh, but the words struck him the wrong way.

Izuku slowly got up and reached for his clothes as well, feeling like this conversation was going somewhere bad, "...the act?" He asked slowly. They literally just had sex, and good sex too. He hopes the mood isn't going to be ruined within the next minute.

"The little Mr. Independent act you got going on," Kaito waved one arm around as he stepped into his pants.

Izuku laughed a bit, even though he wasn't sure what was funny, "I'm not exactly sure what you mean."

"Come on, Midoriya," Kaito then stood up straight across the bed, looking now at Izuku with a lazy throw of his hand and a funny grin, as if Izuku should have already known this, "You showed up to me in a *slip* and you follow Bakugou around like a puppy. And you're telling me you wanna play the gentlema-"

"Wait, wait," Izuku shook his head while sputtering, closing his eyes for a second to see if he was hearing correctly, " *What* ?"

Kaito could see that Izuku was raising his tone, and put both of his hands up in defense, "Hey, hey, I don't want to get into an argument. I was just stating the facts."

Something the brunette said struck a chord in him, and he tilted his head to look at Kaito funnily, "You think...that my masculinity and independence is invalid just because I chose to wear something more…girly?"

“I mean, a little, but,” Kaito could tell he was putting himself in dangerous waters, judging from the tone of Izuku’s voice, “There’s nothing wrong with you being that way. I actually kind of prefe-”

“You think…” Izuku looked at him as if Kaito was hilarious, “...that I’m incapable because I’m with Kacchan a lot?”

Kaito looked around, before tapping his feet impatiently on the hardwood floor, but there was still a composed gentleman-like smile on his face, “Look, it’s not that.”

“Then what is it,” Izuku asked him genuinely, eyes looking a bit wide in curiosity, “Because let me tell you this. Kacchan, as much of a bastard as he can be, in the time that we’ve started this project” Izuku slid off the bed then and stood up, his voice shaking in a build up of anger, “has *never, ever* made me feel like I couldn’t do anything. If it’s what I wanted.” He looked down at the ground.

Kaito seemed to completely ignore him, trying to get him to cool down, “No, look,” He had an easy smile on as if trying to get Izuku under control, “I told you. You don’t have to put up any act. I like it. I like how you’re kind of sof-”

“Of course you do,” Izuku said with a bite on his tone.

“Midoriya,” Kaito manages to get his word in, “Don’t get upset.”

Izuku’s mouth opened in shock, like something hit him, “Huh?”

“I said don’t get upset,” Kaito’s voice was calming, and guided Izuku.

“Don’t get upset?” Izuku’s eyes widened up at the brunette, and he goes into a state of numbness as if his brain was hardwired to react a certain way to those words. *Don’t get upset* . So, so familiar. And the greenette mutters it under his breath a couple more times quietly, “Don’t get upset. Right…”

He nods and then looks at the ground, “Right. I shouldn’t...I shouldn’t get angry.”

“That’s right,” Kaito says very calmly before coaxing Izuku to sit down by sitting on the edge of the bed himself, “Now let’s just end today off with a good note. We had a good time, right?”

But Izuku’s head was still fogged up by trying to not get himself angry, “Anger is not…” He breathes, “Not good. It’s fine. It’s fine, Izuku.” He tells himself as if to regulate his mind to get rid of the anger.

Kaito pats the spot next to him on the bed, “Exactly, now come here. We’re not going to get angry, okay? This isn’t you. Calm down.”

Izuku feels his feet walk over there, as his eyes look widely at the ground, “I-I’m calm.”

He takes in Kaito’s words. *We’re not going to get angry, okay* ? So, so familiar. *This isn’t you* . That sentiment was even more familiar, like it was a phrase tossed around his entire life if

he was ever even close to sounding upset. To make him feel as if he was doing something wrong, as if he needed to stay the same and constantly happy-go-lucky to appease everyone. *Calm down* . This, he's heard many times before. Within every room of his house, within every year of his life, within the lips of-

Izuku looked up at Kaito then. Within the lips of his mother. Over and over again. How could he even forget.

Kaito looks questioningly at him then, "Midoriya?"

"No," Izuku then says, before backing away, shaking his head as he repeats, "No, no, wait."

"What is it," Kaito looked as if he was running out of patience again, reaching a hand out to brush Izuku's arm.

But the greenette pulled away with the shake of his head, "I-I'm allowed to be angry," He tells Kaito with a shaky voice, "No, I *should* feel upset."

Everything Katsuki told him that one night flooded into his mind. Snippets of conversation under the humid parking lot next to their school at night, where they practically screamed at each other. He was allowed to be angry, just as much as he was allowed to be happy. He was allowed to stand up for himself, even if it leads to conflict, rather than stay silent just so people could feel better about themselves. He was allowed to not take shit, even if it breaks the peace.

It was crazy. How automatic his reaction could be. It was difficult to erase almost two decades of habituation. It was if he was Pavlov's Dogs. Trained to hear that he shouldn't get angry, and automatically agreeing and thinking he was in the wrong. *No* , that isn't true. Izuku told himself. He was allowed to feel negative emotions.

Kaito furrows his brows, "And who told you that?" And then he laughed, "I bet it was Katsuki."

Izuku didn't say anything. Still collecting his thoughts. The four walls of Kaito's bed felt a bit suffocating.

The brunette took this as an opportunity to assume, "Of course it was. The only thing that asshole feels is anger. What a piece of shit. Of course he'd want to mess you up."

"Mess me up?" Izuku asked, voice soft but sharp.

Kaito didn't think about what he was saying, "You were such a sweetheart, Midoriya. Before all of this. So good, and nice. And then Cap came in and fucked it all up. Now, you get all angry and-"

"You know what your deal is?" Izuku cuts in, having enough.

Kaito moves his head, but then just looks at the shorter, "Yes?"

Izuku gave him an angry smile as if finally understanding, “Kaito, you’re obsessed with this...idea,” Izuku stepped a bit closer, “You’re obsessed with being a perfect gentleman with a perfect partner and a perfect life.”

The brunette looked at his door, then back at Izuku, before sighing, running a hand through his hair, “I’m trying to see what the problem is here.”

Izuku shook his head then, looking frustrated, “You’ve been trying to put me in a box. All of this time,” Izuku took a deep breath and paced, “You’ve wanted me to be a certain way.”

Izuku continued, “You want someone who will sit back and make dinner when you go to work. Who will never do anything you don’t want them to do. You want someone digestible to your perfect job, perfect boss, and perfect family,” Izuku’s tone was upset, “You want someone who will look pretty and soft for you, so that you feel like more of a man.”

“Midor-” Kaito looked as if he was an animal tamer.

“T-that’s why you don’t,” Izuku looked around the floor as he remembered, “That’s why you don’t like that I’m strong and that my body looks this way,” He says as he remembers how Kaito touched him just now, “That’s why you don’t want me to go off to do childish things,” Izuku looked upset, “And that’s w-why you don’t like when I get angry.”

Kaito already had this image in his mind of what Izuku was supposed to be. A goodie-two shoes. Nice, sweet, submissive, and just a role in the relationship he had in mind. Because of how he was before due to his mother’s control, the athlete probably thought Izuku was perfect: he was nice without limits, a cute face, stayed home and didn’t do anything that would stain a reputation, a perfect little homebody that Kaito had the desire to take care of, just so he could feel better about his fake concept of masculinity.

“Don’t be so worked up,” Kaito tries again to calm him down, “You asked me to distract you, right? We did that, so let’s just enjoy th-”

Izuku laughed to himself, “I don’t regret sleeping with you, but,” He admits, “I regret speaking up in the first place afterwards. I should have just left…” He laughs again as if he couldn’t believe what this evening had turned into, “What’s wrong with me?”

Kaito looked annoyed, “Yeah. What *is* wrong with you. Did you ask yourself this when you let Bakugo fuck you?”

Izuku’s eyes snapped up to him, “Huh?”

“Yeah, you think I couldn’t tell?” The brunette raised a brow, “I’m surprised the whole school didn’t know, judging from how you’d limp everywhere.”

Izuku’s brows raise in surprise.

Kaito continued, taunting, “How does it feel to just be another body for him?”

The green eyed boy felt that statement strike his chest, and his stomach twisted. That hurt. And severely out of line. His lips parted, wanting to say something, but couldn’t in the face

of the brunette who looked so smug at this reaction out of him.

“You didn’t *actually* think he’d fall in love with you, did you?” Kaito asked, face amused.

Izuku’s lips began to quiver just slightly as he looked at the taller brunette with wide eyes, unable to say a word.

“Oh come on,” Kaito just laughs at him as if he was stupid, “You think Bakugo Katsuki, the emotional fuck up, could ever love you? The asshole, at the end of the day, only cares about himself.”

“Don’t say that,” Izuku says quietly, voice shaking once more.

“What, am I wrong?” Kaito throws his hands up, “You think that piece of shit could take care of someone? You think he can keep from ruining every relationship he touches?”

Feeling sadness simmer up his chest, Izuku tells Kaito, “Y-you’re wrong,” He argues with a wavering tone.

“Don’t be naive, Midoriya,” Kaito tells him as if he were a child, “He’s arrogant. Rude. And that’s all he’s capable of. Everyone knows it except you. I heard even his mom kno-”

“It’s because of people like you!” Izuku then said, angrily as the first hot tear slid down his cheek, “It’s because of people like you that Kacchan stays the way he is. No one ever bothers anymore! You all look at him, see his flaws and his attitude, and think ‘Oh, that’s just how he is. Why try. Why assume he’s capable of more.’ But how do you know?” Izuku staggers forward, “How do you even know? No one even bothers to try anymore.”

Kaito doesn’t say anything. Izuku feels weird defending the person who made his tears run dry just hours earlier, but who said he had a perfect grudge. At some point, he’ll have to interact with Katsuki again.

“Did you know he brings me food when I’m sick?” Izuku then asked, voice not as loud anymore, as he shuffles through his mind, “D-Did you know that I told him long ago that I wanted to see the stars in a yellow field, and he remembered that detail months later and took me to one? Did you know...that he brought the dance to me?”

“What does that even mea-” Kaito interrupted, not understanding the context.

“Did you know he sent pictures to my mom every day so that she can know I’m fine without ever telling me once?” Izuku laughed at the memory, “O-or that he’s the only person to ever not be afraid of my mother and would rather face her attitude than to let me live the way that I did?”

Kaito looks down at the ground.

Izuku does too, laughing to himself quietly, “He’s trying. He cares, in his own way. But nobody sees that,” Izuku’s voice cracked as his heart reached out for the person he loved so much. Even if it wasn’t as a lover, Izuku would still love him as a friend, “Nobody ever sees that. And now...and now he’s convinced himself to believe all of your stupid words Kaito,”

Izuku looked up with furrowed brows and glassy eyes at the brunette, “That he can’t feel. That he’ll never be able to be more than what he is. That he will never be able to....that he’ll never be able to…”

And then Izuku stopped.

*Oh* .

Oh.

And now, he was crying tears of both frustration and sadness.

Frustration because it seemed as if Kaito just couldn’t shake this thought: that Katsuki could barely feel anything. That Katsuki wasn’t capable of true happiness, of kindness, of care. And even more so because Kaito was right in that everyone thought it too. His mother stopped trying. His friends had accepted that it was all a part of who he was. And even now as they accept that Katsuki was kinder than he used to be, they still could not comprehend him truly caring for someone.

And then sadness because as he spoke, Izuku realized then and there, much after the fact. He was barely better than the rest of them.

He thought the same. When it came to love, he thought the same.

*He isn’t capable of love. He’ll never be able to love anyone. I can’t imagine him actually loving someone.* Izuku has heard those lines from multiple people, multiple times, and has at some point, convinced himself of the same idea. That love was where Katsuki drew the line. That the blonde could be kind, could be caring, but that didn’t mean he’d be able to actually love someone.

He’s heard those words a million times, and he never disputed them once.

In fact, when the blonde, that one day at the track stadium, kissed him out of the blue, the first thought Izuku had was that they were going to have sex. Because what else could Katsuki have wanted? To be fair, that wasn’t entirely his fault.

But what *was* ?

The fact that when they sat on the hood of the athlete’s car, after having sex, and the blonde’s voice quivered ever so slightly with vulnerability as he asked Izuku if the greenette also believed that he would never be able to love someone, the only thing Izuku had said was *Don’t you think that way too?*

That was all he had said. That was *all* he had said when Katsuki had began to be a bit more vulnerable around him about the topic. That was all he had said when Katsuki was probably looking to hear something different.

Something that negated the thoughts that Katsuki already had about himself to begin with.

Because when the whole world believes that you aren't able to do something, who are you to tell everyone otherwise? Because when Izuku, the person Katsuki admitted to be his closest friend and who spent the most time with him, responds in such a way that implied it was true, then who was Katsuki to believe otherwise? It was Izuku's fault as much as it was everybody else's.

Izuku then cried, silently as his hands came up to his mouth in realization and he looked down, "Oh."

From the edge of the bed, Kaito Sen stared at his own hands for a while, listening to the seconds go by on the grandfather clock downstairs, before asking with a serious tone, "What is it. Are you okay?"

But Izuku's lips just trembled as he then says.

"It's because of people like me, too," Izuku realizes and admits, before burying his face into both of his hands, asking himself in broken cries, " *No, no, no* , what have I done. What have I done," He repeats in a sad voice.

Neither he nor Katsuki were perfect, sure. Katsuki had absolutely crushed his heart, sure.

But that didn't mean Izuku was justified in perpetuating the thought that a person--who was human, who had shown in actions that he is capable of genuine care--could not love. He wasn't saying this as someone who was in love with Katsuki, but as a friend.

Who was he to say that Katsuki couldn't love.

Just because Katsuki didn't love *him* , Izuku thinks, didn't mean the blonde couldn't love at all.

"Kaito…" Izuku says, upset, but completely done with whatever conversation they were having before. Whatever it was, they weren't having one again. At least, not until the other apologizes.

After a moment of fidgeting, the brunette answers, "Yeah?"

Izuku takes a deep breath and then turns towards the other, asking as sincerely as he could, "Can you take me home?"

And when it was clear that there was a pleading need in the other's tone, Kaito looked down at his lap, before standing up and replying, tone more understanding, "Yeah," He goes over to grab his keys, "Of course, yeah.  I'll take you home."

Izuku thinks of his mistake for a long time. His own hypocrisy. He was upset at others for placing expectations for who Katsuki was supposed to be, while he himself contributed expectations of his own. But it was worse because he knew that the blonde took his opinion

quite seriously these days. Oh, how much it must hurt. Izuku felt as if the pain was his own, as he thinks of all the doubtful things that has been aimed towards the athlete.

As if he wasn't dealing with enough pain himself, at the unrequited love he faces. He knew that they never set terms or agreed upon anything exclusive, but that didn't mean hearing Katsuki with Kimi hurt any less. He had no right to say who Katsuki could or could not be with, just as the other had no right to ask the same.

It honestly would have been better if the blonde hadn't taken her to the firefly lake. Izuku had been thinking about it all day. It wasn't as if it was theirs. Or that their adventures were just exclusive to the two of them.

But to hear that Katsuki had taken this girl out to the lake that they first swam in together, it just felt as if Izuku was an old toy now tossed aside in exchange for a new one that he could do all of the same things with. That hurt him. Plenty.

Izuku wonders if Kimi had loved the twinkling lights of the fireflies above the water as much as he had. He wonders if Katsuki let her run her hands over his tattoo. And he wonders if they swam after each other, laughing while spraying lake water in each other's faces. But he doesn't let himself wonder too long.

Because it was the morning of the next day, and Izuku had to find a way to deal with the prominent hickeys dotting his entire body, which was something more pressing to worry about. His neck was a warzone, with marks on the side and on his collarbone. The back of his shoulders had some, the skin of his upper stomach, and between his legs. There were plenty between his legs, and Izuku stands in front of his mirror, naked, raking his hands over to different parts of his body to touch over the hickeys.

*"Shit* ," Izuku cursed he held up a turtleneck with a scarf, and decides that he'll just have to deal with the heat.

At Ise High, people were generally intuitive about things, and could connect dots relatively easily. In such a small town, any gossip was a good enough way to pass the time. Today's subject was why Midoriya Izuku was wearing stuffy clothing, although summer was approaching. A turtleneck, with a scarf. The only normal article of clothing was his pair of cargo shorts that covered up most of his legs.

It wasn't too hard to take a guess as to what had happened; however, with *who* was the question. There was talk of it being Katsuki, of it being Shoto, of it being Kaito. He just wished everyone would mind their own business.

Having people watching him all of the time, stirring up rumors or theories about him all the time, assuming things about his character: all of this had the potential to make him quite upset. Izuku wonders if this must be what Katsuki felt all of his life: this constant state of being seen as a museum exhibit for people to gawk and talk about it.

And so, as the day progressed, he had curious looks directed towards him while he walked down the hallways of the academic building.

But no look bothered or confused him more than the one he received from a certain someone as their first encounter arrived later on in the day. His heart has been pounding away at his chest the entire day just thinking about it, because he knew it was inevitable.

His and Katsuki's life circled around each other's. The blonde was integrated so deeply into Izuku's life, that he knew it was only a matter of time before they speak again. Katsuki was his project partner, his inspiration for passion, a main contributor to why he was as free as he was now, but most important:

Katsuki was his friend, before he was the object of his love.

And as a friend, since the project started, Katsuki was good. He wasn't sweet or overbearingly kind, he didn't baby Izuku or assume he was too weak to do certain things. As a friend, Katsuki had opened his eyes to what the world could be, and showed him his own wings that he kept tucked away.

It was his own fault that he had slipped into a love so deep that it was tearing him apart. A love that he knew Katsuki was unaware of. How could the other have known.

No matter how much it hurts, no matter how much it kills him, there was only so much Izuku could blame on Katsuki. All he could do now was try to revert back to a stage that they were in before. He could do it.

They haven't talked to each other through the weekend, and that killed him. If he remembered correctly, there has not been a weekend since the one that started the whole project where he had not had Katsuki around.

The blonde's hidden laughs, the adventures they'd go on, the inside jokes they'd share. It's been a while since he's been just with himself, and that was okay too. It was important to be content by yourself, but still, that was easier when they were on good terms.

Izuku just could not get that look out of his head from when they last parted ways.

Izuku thought to himself over and over again. What was he going to say the next time he saw Katsuki, if anything at all. What was *Katsuki* going to say? Was he going to get angry again? Make a commotion? Should he prepare himself for a yelling session? He could not begin to pinpoint what to expect.

But when he sees the other coming down from the opposite side of the hall, Izuku's breath hitched, but he forced his legs to continue walking normally. It was like tunnel vision everytime he saw the explosive blonde, and his heart always seemed to pick up. Now, even more so, considering the tense situation they had left off on. He prepared himself for anything.

But as they approached each other, the both of them slowed down to a stop. There was no one else in the hallways, leaving the silence simmering between them. Those last words repeated itself in Izuku's head. *Don't overstep your boundaries* . He hadn't even stayed for another word, so this was either going to be a continuation of that conversation or something entirely different.

Izuku watches as Katsuki takes a very quick look at his get-up with nothing quite malicious in his voice. Izuku's hands were tight on his backpack straps, while Katsuki had his hands shoved in the pockets of his sweatpants.

Finally, the other asked, and Izuku was just stunned by how unexpected the question was compared to what he had been preparing for.

"You cold?" Katsuki asked, voice not angry nor particularly giddy. Then again, Katsuki was rarely giddy.

Izuku wasn't sure what he was expecting the other to say, but it wasn't this. That was rather anti-climatic. The blonde was not stupid when it came to matters like this. He knew what exactly was going on, so Izuku wondered why he bothered asking.

Izuku just looked off to the side for a moment, before glancing up in those red eyes, "Um," He said softly before shaking his head, "Not really."
Katsuki took his time to reply to this. Izuku notices as his eyes get downcasted for a moment, before looking off to the lockers on either side and nodding to himself, moving back to Izuku, "Okay. I'll see you in class."

Before moving over to walk around Izuku, leaving the greenette standing there stunned. That was it? He looked down at his feet, utterly confused, before making himself move across the tiled floor.

He thinks about the interaction, even later when the psych class that they share comes around. During the lunch period, his friends had been particularly tender and careful with him, even though he didn't want them too. He wanted them to just act normally, so that maybe he could convince himself to feel normal as well. He's done his fair share of crying.

And now, as Izuku sits in his desk, materials splayed out on his desk, but his mind not really into whatever Mr. Toshinori was speaking, he was jolted out of his overthinking when the teacher's voice clearing interrupted his thoughts.

Mr. Toshinori had some lung issues, so once in a while, that would result in him clearing his throat very loud or going into a coughing fit. Occasionally, there'd be a little blood, but the older teacher told them not to worry about it, even though it was quite concerning.

Either way, this time, the psychology teacher was clearing his throat to get everyone's attention, and Izuku sat back up on his palm with his elbows resting on the table.

“As we’re moving onto the next topic, I want to begin with a bit of a fun activity,” Mr. Toshinori informs the class, “To see your individual thoughts on the matter, before we dive into the textbook.”

Fun activity. That was never a great sounding phrase, because it meant that the class had to actually participate rather than listen to lectures. That being said, Izuku paid attention for this.

“Module 8. Group consensus versus Independent Thought,” Mr. Toshinori turned to write on the chalkboard.

Izuku listens, figuring he should be taking notes in the first place.

“And so the debate is,” Mr. Toshinori turns around and then nonchalantly goes to drag a chair to one side of the middle podium, “Whether an individual is more shaped by the opinions of those around them, *or* if a human has the capability to be free of social restraints.” He goes to drag another chair to the opposite side.

“Some research indicates,” The teacher continues as he leans back now against the chalkboard, “that people are heavily influenced by external opinion, even if they don’t know it themselves. *Other* research indicates that humans are cognitive enough to shape their own opinions independent of other people’s beliefs.”

The class was listening, waiting for the teacher’s next words, before he gestured up to the seats in the front of the classroom, “Today, since we’re just starting this unit, I’d like to spend it having the class debate the topic with your project partners. I’d imagine you all are close enough to them by now to feel comfortable sharing your true opinions, yes?”
Izuku’s stomach dropped. The first time he’d be having a real conversation with Katsuki in a hot minute, and *this* was the topic that they are to discuss? It felt almost like fate that this was what they had to talk about. The subject matter was eerily something that he’s thought about a lot when it came to Katsuki.

From across the classroom, in his peripheral vision, Izuku could see Katsuki’s head turned downwards towards his lap. He didn’t want to be called first, but he had a feeling he would. Mr. Toshinori always called him first, because there were usually no other volunteers, and Izuku was often an active student. And so, the teacher kind of set him up as an example to spur other students to participate in class. However, now was *not* the time that he wanted to be called on first. But it was coming. He knew it was coming.

“Midoriya and Bakugo,” Mr. Toshinori called up, “We’ll have your partnership come up first.”

There it was. It was in times like these where Izuku regretted being an attentive student in class. Nervous, more than he needed to be, Izuku pushed his chair out and made his way towards the front. From the other side of the classroom, Izuku heard the sound of feet shuffling up to the other side of the podium, as he knew Katsuki was doing. And when he sat down, Izuku let out a breath and looked over at Katsuki.

The blonde was leaned back in the chair, his long legs stretching across the front part of the classroom, and his knees were bouncing as he looked over at the chalkboard. Izuku was just sitting straight up, hands in his lap. Katsuki turned his head then, and they caught each other's eyes. Izuku felt all the heat rise to his cheeks, just from a single look. That was how powerful the blonde was to his composure. One look, and it felt like everything was over.

Izuku pursed his lips, as a silence falls across the classroom in anticipation for how this debate was going to go.

"So boys," Mr. Toshinori prompted them, "What are your opinions on the matter? Are our self-images directly related to what other people's perception of us are? Or are humans free to independently develop their own."
Katsuki looks at a piece of lint on the ground as he ponders, and Izuku simmers on the question, biting his bottom lip as he collects his thoughts.

Finally, breaking the silence, Izuku states his viewpoint, "I think…" His voice was more timid than he wanted it to be, "...that people are heavily affected by other people's opinions and actions" He paused and then continued, "in ways they don't even know."

Katsuki's knees continue to bounce. This was making him uncomfortable. Izuku knew that cue about Katsuki immediately.

Izuku thinks on his experience so far, "I think it's irrational to think that you can live, and not actually care about what other people have to say. That would be ideal, yes, but not realistic."

"I disagree," Katsuki takes his stance.

*Of course, you do* , Izuku thinks to himself. But he doesn't say it.

"Tell us why you disagree, Bakug-" Mr. Toshinori prompted.

"I was getting there, geezer," Katsuki looked over at the teacher, and Izuku wanted to apologize on his behalf, "Anyways, as I was saying. I disagree. At some point, you realize that people are going to talk a lot of shit. Everyone always has something to fucking say. If you spend all of your time digesting everything everyone thinks about you, you'll have no time for anything else."
"But I don't necessarily think it's like that," Izuku frowns, offering his counterargument, "It's not like anyone is actually sitting down and thinking constantly about every opinion people have of them. I think it's more like…" Izuku tries to articulate his words, "...you go about your day like normal, but you haven't realized that your personality that you think is just strictly ' *you* ' has been shaped by public opinion that's been built up over time."

"So what you're saying is," Katsuki asks him, "there's no such thing as individuality. We're just vessels of different people's thoughts?"
"No," Izuku shakes his head, not understanding what was so hard to get, "Of course we have personalities, but some of it, even if we don't know it, has been influenced by other people."

Katsuki nods his head, digesting the information, before tapping his pen on the side of the desk, "Alright. Let me ask you this. Do you think there are things that are innate to certain

people."

"Innate?" Izuku asked for clarification.

"Innate," Katsuki repeated, "They were born that way. Nature versus nurture. That's at the core of this debate, ain't it? You're arguing nurture. I'm arguing nature."

Izuku thinks on it, "I *do* think there are innate aspects to humans, but I also think that there are other aspects that can be shaped by people. Kids learn not to hurt others and be mean through nurture."

"Hang onto that last thought, yeah?" Katsuki raised a brow, and then hit Izuku with the question, "Do you think that applies to everyone? Think about it. Haven't you ever met a kid who kept their innate trait, and never learned not to hurt others, even with fine parenting?"

Izuku was silent. There was something he needed to read between the lines for. Something that the rest of the class would not actually understand, hidden within the subtext of their conversation. Katsuki was implying something. Kids learn not to hurt others and be mean through nurture. That was what he said. *Think about it. Have you ever met a kid who kept their innate trait, and never learned not to hurt others* ? Was Katsuki talking about...himself?

Izuku spoke, "So you're saying that some people can't be nurtured into a better person?"

"No. Not necessarily," Katsuki says, "I'm saying there are certain things that you can only nurture so much, before a person's innate inability takes over."

"Like?" Izuku was afraid of the answer.

"You tell me," Katsuki diverts the question, "You don't think there are things people have a limit for in terms of what they feel?"

"I mea-" Izuku begins.

"You do," The blonde tells him, looking right into his eyes, "You think there are. And I know it for a fact."

Izuku shakes his head, "I don't, Kacchan. I don't," His voice getting soft and apologetic. He knew what Katsuki was referring to, but there was no malice in the blonde's voice.

But Katsuki didn't take it, "You do, and you'd be right about it," Katsuki rounded out his argument, "Which is why I'm saying that it *is* possible to not be shaped by public opinion. Some traits are simply innate. No one caused it, and no one can change it."

"But it's *not* innate," Izuku argues, "It can be harder for people, but it's not unchangeable, Kacchan. When the world has only told someone that they are one thing all of their life, then they're going to believe it and think that it's innate. That they can't change. That it's just how they are. It's not that a person innately is incapable of caring about other people's opinions. It's that they cared so much about *that* opinion, that they began to believe it too. And act on it."

The class wasn't sure if they were confused, or were getting something out of this discussion.

Katsuki leaned forward so that his elbows rested on his knees, "You think so."

"I know so," Izuku then looks down at his hands, "I used to think that I'm just innately a pacifist, but it turns out, I only thought that way because growing up, all of my life, everyone around me has told me that I was all of these things. And then I believed them, thinking I can't be anything else *but* that." *Everyone except you,* Izuku wanted to say.

He felt weird saying this in front of the class, but this conversation made it feel as if it was just him and Katsuki in this room.

"That's fair," Katsuki tells him, but Izuku knew there was more coming, "But in your situation, it's normal things like anger and sadness. No shit, you can feel those. But in m-," He pauses, then sits back "But for others, it could be things that are more...niche. Fear. Disappointment," Katsuki staggered for just a second, before saying rather blankly, "Love."

Izuku's heart felt like it was squeezed tight, as he listened to Katsuki believe over and over again that he was not capable of love. He felt guilty, and wanted nothing more than to tell the other that he knows now. He knows now not to believe in such things, not when Katsuki himself seemed so unsure. It felt as if he had been too late, because it looked like the blonde had already accepted the fact fully.

Izuku's voice was soft when he spoke again, "Are you sure? Or is it because…" Izuku swallowed, "Is it because everyone said so that you believe it too."
Katsuki's brow raised at this, and he asked the greenette with a bite in his tone, "What does this have to do with me?" He knew full well.
Izuku just laughed to himself, before meeting the athlete's eyes, "I misspoke."

"Oh yeah?" Katsuki didn't break their eye contact, "You sure about that, Deku?"

Izuku knew they were communicating something else in their eyes, but his lips said, "Positive."

To this, the blonde didn't say anything. Just nods once, then fingers his lip with his thumbs. Before they could speak up again, there was a knock at the door that jolted everyone's attention. Mr. Toshinori went over to open it, and a bald man of short stature poked his head in and scanned around the room until he saw who he was looking for.

"Bakugo?" The man called forth, "You got to go."

"Eh?" The blonde looked annoyed, "For what."

"A photoshoot for the Nationals roster. You were supposed to meet us at the front of the school," He reminded.

Cursing under his breath and getting himself up off the chair, "Shit. I forgot," And then turned to Mr. Toshinori, "Oi, what do I do about today's work."

The teacher gestured down to Izuku, “Midoriya can catch you up, I’m sure.”

Izuku blinked and then nodded, without looking at the other, “Yeah.”

Katsuki let out an annoyed breath, “The nerd doesn’t clearly doesn’t want to. Read the room, geezer. I’ll ask someone else.”

Izuku looked up at the other, before saying, “No, I can do it.” He had to remind himself. They were friends before anything.

The athlete looked as if he wanted to argue, looking around the room for a second, before back down at Izuku, “Fine. I’ll be home later.”

“Okay then,” Izuku said, face showing indifference.

“Okay then,” Katsuki repeated, and they kept an odd kind of eye contact for just a second, before the blonde went to grab his stuff to leave.

And when the pole vaulter exits the classroom, Izuku feels as if he could let out a breath. Finally feeling a bit normal, he turns towards the class to see that the group of students did not seem to have a very clear understanding of what all just happened. First, there was that debate that felt as if Izuku and Katsuki just knew something they didn’t. Words were being exchanged, but it seemed as if there was another conversation going on at the exact same time.

Izuku, a little shy now, apologizes to the class as he grabs his things to walk back to his seat, “I’m sorry.”

“No, no, that was great discourse,” Mr. Toshinori reassures him, “Both of you had very good commentary about nature versus nurture. Psychologists today still struggle with that, so it was a very fruitful discussion. That being said, we have a couple more groups to go through, so let’s get Mi…”

But the rest was drowned out in Izuku’s ears. All he could go back to was Katsuki’s adamance that he was incapable of love. And that it felt like Izuku was too late in doing anything about it.

The walk to Katsuki’s house felt so long, because now will be the first time in days they have seen each other in an out-of-school context. And he wasn’t sure how this will turn out either. Maybe it would be like earlier, where Katsuki had the most lackluster reaction. That might be easier. And then there was the debate in class. He wonders if Katsuki will bring that up again. Either way, he clutched his notes tightly to his chest as he walked up to the driveway of the Bakugo family home. It didn’t look as if either of Katsuki’s parents were home at the moment, as they often weren’t. The blonde’s car in the driveway, sitting there. Izuku had been in it so much that he swore he could practically smell the leather seats from the outside.

When he got to the door, the doorbell was rung several times without any answer. And so Izuku stood for a moment longer, before he fishes the house key from the garden pot that Katsuki had told him about, and used it to enter the house on his own. Setting the key behind on the table, Izuku kicked off his shoes and made his way up the stairs to where the blonde's bedroom was, which was where he was most likely to be.

When Izuku stepped inside, he didn't immediately see anyone. But the sound of rustling from the bathroom caused his attention to divert over there, and it didn't take more than a moment longer for the bathroom door to open, and out came Katsuki. Except fully naked.

Izuku flushed as he stares at the blonde walking out, with a towel rubbing his hair. It wasn't as if he hadn't seen the athlete naked before. He was most definitely acquainted with it. But it was like everytime was a new surprise. That gorgeous body, all 6'4 of it, jacked and in perfect form. Even his cock, not hard, looked large.

Upon seeing that someone else was in his room, Katsuki cocked his head to the side and asked, "Deku? You scared me."

"I did?" Izuku laughed nervously, "Who could tell? You sound very...unscared."

"Why do you sound nervous?" Katsuki looked at him, as he grabbed a pair of boxers and slid them on.

"Nothing," Izuku said a little too fast, "I have...um, notes. We can go over them."

There was a bit of awkwardness between them. What happened a couple of days ago has not actually been acknowledged yet, and Izuku was sure that was causing a bit of a barrier between the two of them.

Katsuki gestured over to his desk, "Just set them down."

Izuku nodded, and made his way over to Katsuki's desk to set the papers down while he waits for the blonde to get changed. And yet, it didn't seem as if the boy was moving.

Izuku turned in place to glance over at the athlete, to see what Katsuki's body was turned forward so that he wasn't exactly looking at Izuku, but looked deep in thought. He wasn't moving, but rather, just stood there with the towel draped over his shoulder, contemplating something.

Izuku was about to speak up and ask, but Katsuki beat him to it.
"I want to see," Katsuki tells him then, turning to direct that stunning gaze towards Izuku.

The green eyed boy was just a bit confused, evident as he asked, "You want to...see?"

And then, the taller began walking over, without a care in the world. The towel dropped off of Katsuki's shoulders, and Izuku found himself moving backwards until he hit the back of the desk. But that didn't mean the blonde stopped moving.

When Katsuki stood in front of Izuku, the blonde raised a hand to run his finger along the high neck shirt he had on, "I want to see just how good of a job he did."

Izuku's eyes widened, as he completely understood now, and stammered, "W-what?"

Katsuki's fingers went up to the hem of the neckline, and Izuku stared wide eyed, "Strip for me, Deku."

The shorter felt his breath catch at the back of his throat, and he was stunned. After everything that happened, Izuku had forgotten that they were still technically friends with benefits. But he saw how *that* turned out. There was no way to have the sexual relationship he had with Katsuki, and keep his sanity.

There was barely a way to keep the platonic relationship he had with Katsuki, and keep his sanity. However, Izuku knew that his friendship with the blonde extended past more than the pain and jealousy he felt. The friendship he had with Katsuki changed his life for the better. It was just love that changed it for the worst.

And this? Whatever foolish game he thought he could win only dragged him in deeper.

He was an accomplice in his own heart being crushed, and he knew it.

"Kacchan..." Izuku began, hands placing itself on top of the one Katsuki had rimming his shirt.

Katsuki hummed, and pulled down the fabric to reveal litters of sweet little hickeys dotting his skin. Marks that travelled around his neck, as if someone had so desperately wanted to claim him. Pretty little bruises of pinks and purples, and Izuku watches as Katsuki's eyes trail to each one, as if every single mark on his unblemished skin was an additional contributing factor to the flame that was igniting in those eyes. A similar fire grew in Izuku's groin as he sees Katsuki's body tense up from someone else's handiwork.

Katsuki leaned in closer, until their breaths mingled together, "You like this?" His rough fingers traced over the hickeys, "Tell me, you like when he did this?"

Izuku's eyes trailed from Katsuki's lips to his eyes as they stood a little too close. Izuku needs to back off. He really did. He knew where this hate-fueled conversation was going to go, and he needed to make himself not let his lust take over, "I didn't hate it."

"Didn't hate it, huh," Katsuki repeats, chuckling as they circle around each other. Katsuki has a hand on his waist now, underneath his shirt, "I do."

Izuku shook his head, while his own smaller hands rested on the blonde's broad shoulders. He whispered, "You're so unfair, Kacchan," He closed his eyes for a moment before looking right into the fire, "So, so unfair."

"How? I'm not stopping you," Katsuki whispered in response as he closed his eyes and they just stood close in each other's presence, lips hovering but never touching.

"You wanted to," Izuku counters, ever so softly, his hands going up to feel the scruff on Katsuki's freshly shaved face.

“And if I recall,” Katsuki’s tone lowered as he pulls the smaller in closer, “That was me...what was it? Overstepping my boundaries?”

Izuku smiled up at Katsuki funnily, “You can’t stand when I’m around others, but you have no problem going off whenever. You tell me not to mark you, but you hate when I get mar-”

“Do it then,” Katsuki pushed forward, pressing their foreheads together as his chest rises and sinks fast.

Izuku glitches, “Huh?”

“You want to so badly?” Katsuki offers, almost demands, “Do it.”

Izuku looks at Katsuki as if he heard incorrectly, “Kacchan, what are you say-”

Katsuki bent down slightly to then pick up the boy by his plush thighs before wrapping those thighs around his waist and walking over to the bed. He laid Izuku down on the edge, so that his bottom half was still in the air, wrapped around Katsuki’s hips as the blonde began to pull him into a kiss.

Between each one, Izuku gave Katsuki a little bit of his mind, wishing he had the will to not want Katsuki so badly, “I hate you.”

And he hated himself. Katsuki didn’t reply, just fumbled at pulling off the other’s shirt before kissing Izuku again.

The next time they pull away, Katsuki takes a good look at Izuku’s torso. Dotted with more hickeys. On his chest, near his hips. And when Katsuki pulled off his pants, there were some in between his thighs too. Those in particular seemed to drive Katsuki crazy.

“Everywhere, huh,” The unbridled rage in Katsuki’s voice fueled Izuku’s own. Katsuki had *no* right to get angry.

“Everywhere,” Izuku confirmed, matching his energy, and Katsuki was on him once more in an instant. Biting at his lip, tugging on his tongue, feeding the plethora of sensations that were going on. The blonde buried his face in Izuku’s neck and began to bite into the soft flesh.

Izuku held onto Katsuki’s shoulders, and told the other, “No. Not if I’m not allow-”

“Consider permission granted, then,” Katsuki tells him in almost a growl, before sucking and biting onto Izuku’s skin, feeling the sweet sensation between his teeth.

Izuku took that permission with no more hesitation, and flipped them over, so that the greenette was now on top, hips straddled on top of Katsuki whose back was against the fur comforter. The athlete looked at a lost in response to the angry expression on Izuku’s face, before the smaller lowered his body to pull Katsuki into an aggressive kiss that rivaled the athlete’s own. Izuku bit until he knew Katsuki’s lip would be swollen, and left red angry hickeys on the side of the blonde’s neck, on his shoulders, and down his sternum as if to

make up for all of the times he couldn't. As if to pretend that Katsuki was his, with these marks of artificial loyalty.

"We're not having sex on this bed," Izuku tells Katsuki as he lifts his head back up to play a game of tongues with the other.

Katsuki sits up, still with Izuku on his lap, and snakes his arm tightly around the smaller, "And why is that, Deku."

Izuku promises this will be the last time. He does. He swears it to himself, as he locks lips with the other. He just needed to let this anger out.

"I don't want to get fucked in the same place you fuck others," Izuku looks away a bit torn between sadness and anger.

At this, all Katsuki did was pull back and laugh. The taller set Izuku down on the bed, while he then stands off to the side and his chuckling proceeds for a moment longer. Izuku sits back on the comforter and watches with a confused expression. The blonde makes a funny noise, and then leans on one of the posts of his bed, looking amused at the shorter.

"You want to know something?" Katsuki asked him.

Izuku stared at him with big eyes, and took a moment to see if this was some sort of a trick question, before answering, "What is it?"

Katsuki then moved off of the bedpost and over so that both of his arms encaged Izuku on either side, staring the greenette directly in the eyes, "I haven't been with anyone that way except for your nerd ass since the day you fucking asked me to stay, much less this bed."

Izuku sits there with wide eyes. Both confused and stupidly hopeful again. Because what in the world was the thing with Kimi, then? What in the world was that, and why would the girl have the need to lie? Even then, the entire time they were fucking, Izuku had wondered if Katsuki ever went to someone else. If there was another that just haven't caught wind within Ise High. He guesses with what Katsuki just said, there wasn't.

"But what about K-" Izuku began.

But Katsuki had already started talking at the same time he did, "So tell me, Deku, are we going to fuck or not."

Izuku just stares at the boy he loves, and asks for one last time. Maybe this sex, a more normal agressive version of the sex they usually had, will get rid of the memory of the love making that seared itself in his mind from the lighthouse.

Just one last time, and Izuku swore he'll distance himself to simply friends.

"Because if we are," Katsuki continues, lips turning up to the side, "I want to fuck you raw."

"Raw?" Izuku's voice quieted to a whimper.

Katsuki looked up from his head tilted down, “Why not. You can swallow Fuck Face’s cum, but you can’t take mine?”

Izuku’s eyes widened fractionally as he asked, “H-How’d you…”

Katsuki leaned in, and told him with sharpness in his voice as his hands slide up and in between Izuku’s thighs, “He likes to talk.”

That was not okay. For Kaito to have gone around explicitly discussing their private matters like that. It was one thing to admit they had sex. It was another thing to tell others in detail about what exactly happened. Izuku’s face flushed, and he felt even more anger surge through his body.

“So how about it,” Katsuki asks.

Izuku’s eyes flutter close and he lays back down on the mattress, looking up at the beautiful blonde, “Okay.”

“Great,” Katsuki replies before going back down on Izuku’s neck, “Now to get back to what I was doing.”

And what exactly he had been doing, Izuku thought he knew. Izuku thought Katsuki was simply just leaving more hickeys, and the sadistic part of him loved it. The rational part of him didn’t. However, once he begins to feel familiar bruising that was already there get enflamed in hot heat again, he realizes Katsuki was doing something else.

And once the blonde travels down to his shoulders, and his chest, biting and sucking like a madman, Izuku confirms it. Katsuki was going around his body, and covering up the marks Kaito gave him with his own, but bigger, redder, more intense. Every hickey that the brunette gave him, Katsuki bit and sucked over it until even the ones in between Izuku’s thighs were covered up by Katsuki’s own. Katsuki’s head between his thighs brought great pleasure to Izuku’s body, and he needed this fucking to be incredible if it was going to be the last.

And it was. Because this wasn’t just any sexual encounter they had. It wasn’t the normal sex they participated in. Nor was it the sweet tenderness like how it was in the lighthouse. This was fueled by both passion and fury. Izuku’s fury at Katsuki’s stupidity, hypocrisy, stubbornness, and his own lack of self-preservation. Katsuki’s fury at the marks of possession on Izuku’s body that he knew better than anyone else. It created this: a night with anger, passion, and absolute destruction.

Katsuki’s grip on his hips were nearly bruising. Izuku’s hold on the blonde’s back was viscous. Angry marks of desire dotted both of their bodies. Katsuki’s neck, collar, shoulders were littered with bites and pink bruising. Izuku’s back, front, everywhere had evidence that Katsuki was thoroughly ruining him. The bedframe wanted to break underneath their passion, as Katsuki made sure that Izuku would not walk the next day.

Izuku’s hands pulled at the fur on the comforter, until little pieces of soft tufts float in the air as his sweet hole gets wrecked.

At some point, as their bodies mesh together like two parts working as one, Izuku paints Katsuki's body like modern art, with streaks of red running all over the athlete's back. It will sting later, evidence of a night well spent. Their breaths intertwine, and it feels like a dance. The ink of Katsuki's tattoo has a line of his fingernail running through it. There was no way for either Katsuki or Izuku to go shirtless for at least a week without someone assuming abuse.

Katsuki was rougher than he's ever been. Angrier than he's ever seemed. And Izuku matched every ounce of energy that the blonde gave with his own. And they played this game one last time, until soon enough, Izuku had his face pressed into the mattress, his pretty ass high in the air, shoulders shaking as his elbows collapse in preparation for his upcoming orgasm.

And when it came, Izuku's entire body rocked. Katsuki continued to hit his spot as he climaxes, milking out every single droplet he could have. It ruined the comforter with now missing patches of fur, ruined the silk sheets underneath, ruined his last bits of energy. And when Katsuki came, Izuku feels it immediately. Hot, ribbons of cum fill up his hole. In all the times they've had sex, Katsuki's always worn protection, despite being clean, for some reason. But this, feeling everything the athlete had to give him, every drop, ever thrust, brought him to the heavens as his body collapses onto the bed, chest heaving.

Izuku could feel Katsuki's cock twitch inside of him, as the taller milks out any spurt of cum he had in him. And he felt so full, beyond full even. The more Katsuki pushed in, the more cum spilled out from the sides, dripping in uneven lines down his thighs and onto the bed. It felt so hot, Izuku could barely handle it. It spilled from his hole when Katsuki finally pulled out, and Izuku lays there in exhaustion as Katsuki's seed sits inside of him.

After a moment or two for the boys to collect their breathing, Katsuki wordlessly gets up to clean the two of them up. There was nothing to do about the comforter for now, but to throw it off to the side and grab a spare blanket from the closet. A warm towel cleaned him up as his body relaxes into the memory foam mattress of Katsuki's bed.

Izuku watches the entire process, watching the lines of concentration on the blonde's forehead, and the tender touches to make sure Izuku's sensitive body doesn't feel overwhelmed, even though the blonde told him he wouldn't treat him with any tender care.

And when Katsuki comes back to sit on the edge of the bed, a silence had settled in the room. There was a pale orange lamp on the desk, with papers they still haven't gone over from class, that illuminated parts of the room, and left other parts in a romantic shadow. Half of Katsuki's face was illuminated in this orange-ish light, and the other half was hidden in the shadows.

In this silence, Izuku then tells Katsuki genuinely, "Kacchan…" He began, "That was the last time, okay?"

Katsuki turns his face towards where the light was shining on him, and looks down at the smaller, face looking relatively neutral, "Yeah?"

Izuku shook his head slowly, and just smiled gently, "Yeah..." He looks away, "I just think we're better off," He takes a breath, "as friends."

Katsuki looks down to the side, and after a moment, let's out a quiet but ironic laugh, "What a cliche fucking line."

Izuku is just quiet in response to this.

Katsuki nods to himself, "Sure. I ain't gonna do anything you don't want to."

Izuku knew that, and he was grateful for it. Yet this still felt hard to do even though all they had been doing was having sex. He pretends to laugh, "Going in circles, aren't we, Kacchan."

The blonde laughs, with little amusement in his voice, and looks at his clasped hands, "Yeah…" Before thinking on it, "Strangers, then enemies, then partners, friends, fuck-buddies, and now back to friends."

Izuku has a sad look on his face, "We're a mess."

Katsuki just continues to stare at that spot near the floor, thinking on something, before turning over to ask, "At some point, I guess we'll revert back to strangers."

Izuku doesn't like this comment. No, he doesn't like it at all. Not when Katsuki's shown him how to fly. Not when Katsuki's been the most impactful friend he's ever had, even if he hasn't been the best love interest. And so, he just doesn't answer.

"So what is it," Katsuki asked, eyes forlorn as it trains itself on the floor, "You found someone else?"

Izuku bit the inside of his cheek, and shook his head slowly.

But the blonde, turned away, didn't see it, and asks, "It's him, right? Fuck Fa- Kaito. It's him, isn't it," And then, it looked as if Katsuki had a difficult time calming himself as his hands go up to his mouth as if to wipe something off, and then through his hair with a puff of angry air, "Christ, I can't stand him. I can't *fucking* stan-"
"Kacchan," Izuku interrupted the anger that was firing up again inside of his friend, "Even if it's him, what will you do?" He was curious. He needed to know, why Katsuki got so jealous, when he didn't want them to be anymore more. He needed to know, to what extent Katsuki doesn't recognize his own hypocrisy.

At this, Katsuki turns his head finally towards where the light didn't hit.

His expression covered by shadows, but Izuku knew that the blankness previously on the blonde's face was gone. The athlete's knuckles clench until it was white, even in the pale orange light, and for just a moment there, it looked as if the blonde's shoulders were shaking. Katsuki tilted his head down, chest going up and down slowly as if he was trying to regulate his breath.

Izuku slowly sits up, seeing the reaction, staring at Katsuki's back. The dark lighting that hid away Katsuki's face also hid away any guesses Izuku could have had as to what the blonde was currently feeling. But from the clenching of the knuckles and the angry posture, Izuku could have guessed this was just going to turn out bad.

However, after a moment, it looked as if Katsuki, in deep thought, continued to breathe slowly. Izuku waited, in the quietness of the Ise night, with only the crickets and humming of the air conditioning to make up for the tense quiet. Slowly, Katsuki's hands relax, but the blonde kept his head turned away.

And when Katsuki speaks again, his voice is quieter than the loud, angry energy Izuku was used to.

"If you're happy with someone else," Katsuki pauses, "Even if it's him…." And then the athlete stands up, all without looking at Izuku as if he was afraid of revealing something, and walked to his closet, "Then what can I do."

Izuku watches as the boy grabs some clothes from the closet, and slips on a shirt. Before sliding into a pair of pants to sleep in. *If you're happy with someone else, even if it's him, then what can I do* . Izuku stares at the boy's back.

Katsuki finishes putting on his clothes, but doesn't move from the wardrobe area. Instead, he just stands there, back turned to Izuku, head bowed down as both of his arms hold onto each of the wardrobe doors. And it's just quiet for a second. Izuku wasn't sure who was supposed to speak first, after that.

But it was Katsuki who shattered the silence, revealing something Izuku was only guessing at.

"I took someone to the lake a couple nights ago," Katsuki says, tone quiet to match the fragility of the air they were sitting in.

Izuku's stomach sank, but figures that this was confirmation of some of the rumors that have been circling around. Izuku was hoping that when Katsuki said he hadn't been with anyone since him, that rumor had been all a lie.

Because funnily enough, what hurt him more was the fact they went to the lake together, more than the possibility that they had sex. Because although Izuku knew they didn't have any claim to the places they go, it just pained him to know that to Katsuki, it wasn't special enough with just the two of them. But how could he truly blame Katsuki. Were they not just friends?

Izuku felt his voice get caught in his throat, "Oh."

Katsuki's head was still tilted downward, "The one with the fireflies," The blonde says, taking a moment, before continuing, following himself up with a laugh, "I hated it."

The green haired boy looked down at his lap, "Then why did you go?"

More silence, and Izuku drowned in it.

Katsuki's voice seemed unsure when he speaks again, "Just to see what it would be like."

Izuku nods his head, "And what was it like."

Katsuki almost sounded like he didn't want to say, but the boy took a breath, "She was nice. Kimi's a nice girl. Pretty. Sweet. Energetic," Izuku's heart kind of broke with every word, "Kind of like you."

He stopped, "But *fuck* ," Katsuki sounded distressed, "She wasn't you."

*No, no, no*. Katsuki cannot say things like that. Katsuki *cannot* say things like that. It wasn't fair. It wasn't fucking fair, not after he cried himself to death in the bathroom of Ise High, not after he ran out of tears yearning for the other, not after he felt confident enough in the unrequitedness of this tragic love to convince himself they can back off as friends.

"Akio," Katsuki says, not moving from his position and his voice still quiet, "The boy at the night market."

Izuku listened. Akio. What a beautiful name, for such a beautiful person.

"I took him to a diner, the other night," Katsuki says, and that one hurt too. Katsuki laughs, "At that point, I was asking what the fuck am I even doing."

The greenette just listened. That one he didn't know about, likely because Akio might not be attending Ise High, or was respectable enough to not go spreading news around. Izuku was just *so, so* confused.

Katsuki continued, tilting his head up to the ceiling, arms still holding either side of the wardrobe doors, "He makes me laugh. You were right, you know. He's beautiful. Pretty eyes. Perfect hair. Nice guy."

"Kacchan, why ar-" Izuku's voice cracked just a little bit. *Pretty eyes* . Oh, how he wished Katsuki would ever find his eyes beautiful. To hear someone else earn that appreciation from the person he wanted to hear that exact thing from so badly, hurt like no other pain.

But Katsuki continued, voice sounding so utterly confused, "But *fuck* , he wasn't you."

Izuku's lips parted, "Kacchan…"

"What the fuck is wrong with me," Katsuki laughs in a quiet voice, and then closes the wardrobe door, "Tell me why I keep comparing everyone to you. What is it about you."

Izuku tried not to let tears well up in his eyes. He's worked so hard. He's worked so fucking hard to tell himself that he won't give in. That no matter how sweet the words, how beautiful the actions, he won't give in to this repeating cycle of pain and pleasure. He thought that after the situation with Kimi, that was his last straw. He needed it to be. But now, it was all in shambles, and Izuku could feel himself getting sucked back into the neverending wheel. It was all in shambles, because they *didn't* sleep together.

In fact, Katsuki hadn't slept with anyone. But he still took people to these places, even if it wasn't exclusive. And that still hurt like hell. But then, now, he's saying all of these things. These *sweet* things These fucking sweet things that was putting everything in shambles again. The fact that Katsuki had to go out with Kimi or Aiko to come to those conclusions was still a little fucked up, but Izuku could hear the confusion and distress in Katsuki's voice, and he couldn't even be as angry as he could've been. God, what was wrong with him. Everything was a mess. An absolute and utter mess.

And Izuku's voice quivered, "Kacchan, you can't say things like that…" He shook his head trying not to cry at his own utter weakness, "You can't say things like that," He repeated.

Katsuki still has not looked at him this entire time.

Izuku pleaded quietly, shaking his head, "What is it about me? You tell me, Kacchan. You…" Izuku ran his hand up his face in confusion and sadness, "You never tell me anything about how you feel, except for that you *can't* feel. But that's not true," He shook his head, "That's not true, Kacchan."

"I'm trying," Katsuki says, face still hidden in the shadows, "I'm so fucking shit at it, but I'm trying."

Izuku nods, chest hurting as he asks Katsuki with a quivering tone, "Can I be honest about something, Kacchan?"

Katsuki stays quiet, a sign of acknowledgement of the question.

Izuku then, with glassy eyes, smiles with sadness up at Katsuki, being completely honest with himself, "For my own sake…"

And he tried so hard not to let his voice break, but it did anyways near the end, "I don't know how much longer I can wait."

Patience was important. It really was, and Izuku knew that a person like Katsuki needed time. And that was something Izuku occasionally neglected about the other. But he also needed to make sure he'd be okay. And with every sweet sentence that comes out of Katsuki, he knew that soon enough, he'd be beyond salvation.

And for the first time in a while now, Katsuki looks over at Izuku, and the greenette catches a glimpse of what the other had been hiding this entire time.

Something about what Izuku just said must have caused some train of thought or shock factor in the blonde, for when he turns to catch Izuku's eyes, it was unmistakable what he saw: unblemished fear.

They lay side by side that night, close enough to be a bit more than friends, but far enough for Izuku to yearn. The notes on the desk were forgotten, and their backs were turned to each

other. Izuku was not asleep, and he wasn't sure he'd be able to for a while. All he could think of was that last look of fear in the blonde's eyes, as if he was afraid of Izuku leaving. As if he was afraid of the day Izuku doesn't even have the strength to even be his friend anymore.

After that, their conversation simmered down to nothing, as the two of them sit in the conversation they just had. And when Izuku doesn't get off of the mattress, Katsuki doesn't stop him. Just slides underneath the covers, and turns his back away in silence. And after a moment, Izuku feels exhaustion--from the entire week--hit him, and his back is then on the mattress too. His body rested on top of the new comforter. He didn't even have enough energy to climb underneath the covers, and so he just lays there, back turned away from Katsuki, as his head is plagued with endless thought. He doesn't even remember when he *did* go to sleep.

All he knew was that at some point during the night, the comforter was pulled on top of him to keep him warm. Once again, a silent act of care that never matched anything that Katsuki could ever say. Another point of confusion.

Katsuki was missing from practice the next day. In all of Izuku's time knowing Katsuki, the blonde has never been late for a practice, unless he was sick or had another pivotal event to attend. But everyone generally knew if there was other matters for the blonde to attend to. And he was usually considerate enough to inform someone on the team that he'd be missing practice.

But today, it seemed as if everyone was as confused as Izuku was. The previous night, it didn't look like Katsuki was sick or anything. And he was in class today as well. But as Izuku stands on the other side of the chain link fence, craning his neck to see if the blonde was just hiding somewhere. But alas, there was no sight of the other. Instead, it looked as if the team was looking around too. Ise's pole vault team didn't necessarily need their captain to be present for practice when the coach was there; however, they also found it odd that Katsuki was missing practice without a notice.

Seeing Izuku from afar, Kirishima called out, jogging a bit closer so that he didn't have to yell the distance, "Midoriya!"

Izuku waves his arms.

He slowed to a stop, and put his hands on his hips, "You know where Bakugo went today?"

Frowning, the greenette shook his head, "No idea. He didn't text anyone?"
"No," Kirishima scratched his head, "Kind of weird, right? He never misses practice."

Izuku ponders on this while he walks home. The Ise heat was getting more intense by the day, and a slight sheen of sweat covers his forehead by the time he reaches the turn into his neighborhood. And then, as he walks through the suburbs, with perfectly manicured lawns and cheesy yard signs, Izuku kicks some pebbles forth on the ground.

But he stopped when he heard a *shit* from a voice he could recognize anywhere.

Since it was a small town, Izuku wouldn't be too surprised to randomly encounter Katsuki somewhere, but he really wouldn't expect to see the blonde in the neighborhood block's badminton team's outdoor court. Izuku stops in his steps, and stares out to his left where the cursing had come from. There was breeze out today, which helped a little with the heat. The outdoor court was barely shaded by the trees, and to get there, you'd have to walk down some stairs where the court sat in kind of like a bowl on the edge of the neighborhood.

As of current, Izuku stares as Katsuki had a beaten up badminton racket in his hands, and was trying to repeatedly bounce a shuttlecock into the air without having it fall to the ground. But there was a reason why Katsuki was a pole vaulter, and not in a sport that required intense hand-eye coordination like badminton did. To be fair, the athlete was naturally a bit better than most people was going to be, but by no means great. Every couple of bounces, the shuttlecock would fall to the acrylic top of the court, and the annoyed blonde would let out a string of curses before picking it up again.

From Katsuki's pill speaker, A Groovy Kind of Love by Phil Collins played as the backtrack of the blonde's fail attempts.

The real question that plagued Izuku more than anything, was what exactly Katsuki doing at a badminton court rather than his own vault practice. He wasn't even doing very hot.

Slowly making his way down the white painted concrete stairs, Izuku cautiously approached Katsuki, who looked quite frustrated yet determined at the moment.

"Kacchan?" Izuku called out.

And the sudden intrusion caused Katsuki to lose focus and the shuttlecock drops to the ground.

Katsuki throws his head back in a groan and complained then, "Fuck. This is fucking hard. Why do you do this. Pole vault instead, nerd."

Izuku let out a small laugh, "Why are you here?"
"Hm?" Katsuki looked down from the sky over to Izuku, "What do you mean."

"Your team is wondering where you are," Izuku tells the other, "You never miss practice."

"I have once or twice," Katsuki grumbled, before picking up the shuttlecock once more and trying again.

"Because you were sick," Izuku replies.

"I hit 18'0 the other day at home, Coach will fucking survive," Katsuki's eyes were hyperfocused on the shuttlecock.

"So you're just taking a break and…" Izuku observes with an odd look, "picking up a new sport? I didn't know you liked badminton."

"I don't," Katsuki informs him, as the shuttlecock falls to the ground and the blonde kicks it across the court.

Izuku frowned, “Then why t-”

“Goddamnit,” Katsuki complained, “Why couldn’t you have chosen an easier sport.”
The greenette laughed, “What does this have to do with me, Kacchan?”

Katsuki didn’t answer for a moment. Instead, he jogged to where he had kicked the shuttlecock and picked it up, before spiking it over to where they were previously standing. The hit was not nearly as strong as it could have been because of how messed up the racket was. It was like Katsuki dug it out of his basement after years of no use. Izuku just stands there watching, holding onto his backpack staps as the sun beats down on them.

“So I can play with you,” Katsuki says nonchalantly.

“Even though you don’t like badminton,” Izuku states, amused.

“This is what friends do, right?” Katsuki’s eyes go back to the shuttlecock as he competitively bounces it on the racket, “Learn about each other’s…” His voice trails off as he gets intensely focused, “...interests?”

That was a rather surprising answer, and Izuku’s lips parted in question. Why was Katsuki doing this all of a sudden.

The shorter male asked then, “...why?”

The shuttlecock drops one more time, and Katsuki catches his breath, dropping his shoulders as his head tilts up towards the sky again, as if cursing the sun for being so damn hot. One arm goes up to wipe at the sweat collecting on Katsuki’s brow ridge, and those red eyes don’t meet his until a moment later.

And this was when Katsuki answers his question.

“So that you want to stay my friend,” Katsuki says, before trying again at the racket.

And *fuck* , Izuku was screwed.

He was brought back to their conversation from last night. When he had admitted that he wasn’t sure how much longer he could wait. The fear in Katsuki’s eyes could still be recalled in his mind, and this must have been the product of that fear. What Katsuki was doing now. *So that you want to stay my friend* . God, how could he say things like this, without knowing what it was doing to Izuku. He was trying so damn hard, almost too hard. Even though he seemed to strongly dislike badminton. He was trying because he knew Izuku liked it.

“What happened to…” Izuku looks down at his feet, “...having to let me go at some point or another?”

Izuku remembers the conversation at the cliff, right before he dived in. Oh, how that hurt.

Katsuki kicked at the floor, and didn’t look at him, “That was when I was feeling a bit more selfless.”

“And today, you’re not feeling as gracious?” Izuku asked, a slight amused look on his face.

“Who knows,” Katsuki shrugged, “I can’t really tell with myself these days. Anyways, how the fuck am I supposed to keep this in the air for more tha-”

“Kacchan, Nationals is around the corner,” Izuku’s voice was soft, “You should be at practice.”

“You’re not my mom,” Katsuki grinned as he managed to get in about fifteen consecutive tosses, “And even if you were, I wouldn’t listen to you.”

Izuku laughed, even though he felt like crying. It almost felt like the flower fields all over again to Izuku.

“But I’m serious, nerd,” Katsuki tells him, “I hit 18’0. I deserve a break for being so perfect.”

Izuku shook his head and rolled his eyes, “At vault? Maybe. But this?” Izuku smiles as he sets his backpack down, “Let me show you how it’s done.”

Katsuki stood back up, and watching Izuku bend down to retie his shoes, holds the racket out for Izuku to take.

When the shorter male does, Izuku turned it around in his hands, “First of all, you need a better racket,” He laughs to himself.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “Look, it was the only one I had in the damn house, alright?”
“It looks like a dog gnawed at the shaft,” Izuku holds up to the sun.

The blonde snorts, “It was.”

Izuku tosses the racket while it twirls in the air and catches again, grabbing the shuttlecock off the ground, smiles, “It’ll work.”

Izuku spends the next two hours or so trying to teach the other small tips and tricks on how to be better or practice better, which was not what he had expected to be spending his afternoon doing. What brought a little smile to his face even after he goes home was that the entire time, Katsuki looked as if he was really paying attention. Taking everything he said seriously and trying over and over again, even as he decides he hated the sport more and more as he played further on.

“Are you going to the bonfire party?” Katsuki asks him as they drive back.

“I didn’t know there *was* one,” Izuku looks out the window at the colorful houses they were passing by.

“Tokoyami is hosting it, ain’t he?” The blonde asks, “On the beach.”
“On the beach?” Izuku turns to ask, “Isn’t that illegal?”

“Nah. All the cops did the same shit when they grew up here,” Katsuki shrugs, “Anyways, you going?”

“When is it?” Izuku asked.

“Friday,” Comes the response.

Izuku thinks on it, “I’ll have to see.”

“Fine by me,” Katsuki shrugs, “Tell me if you need a ride.”

The greenette goes back to looking out of the window, “Thanks, Kacchan.”

The week goes by too slowly, but Midoriya Izuku was at least glad for the busy schedule that both of them had. Katsuki was amping up practice just about every day, doing it at home as well, in preparation. He was the talk of the school, with national qualifiers inching closer and closer. There was not nearly as much ample time for idle play, and that worked out perfectly for Izuku, who wanted to stay friends with the other but still maintain some type of distance so that his affections don’t get worse.

Izuku, on the other hand, was busy with other academic and extracurricular endeavors. The final paper was going to be due in about two weeks, which meant Izuku should at least have an outline. It was crazy to think that what started all of this, this adventure of a lifetime, was a psychology project. Izuku was not sure whether or not he wants to thank Mr. Toshinori, or never forgive him.

That week, they only met up for the project once due to time, and Izuku was annoyed at himself for how much he craved these little interactions with the blonde and how much he actually missed Katsuki. That day, due to exhaustion, all they did was watch a movie together in Izuku’s room, but just having Katsuki in the atmosphere felt like he was coming home.

And so, when Friday came around, Izuku was excited for a break in routine. He could sleep in on Saturday, not worry about classes or anything else, and what not. After having a relatively tough week, Izuku decided that the bonfire might actually not be a bad idea. And so, when he had messaged Katsuki this, the response was almost immediate. *Pick you up in fifteen minutes. Be ready* .

Izuku, upon reading the text, hurried himself to his closet. 15 minutes was not a lot of time in general to get ready for anything. Considering it was a beachside bonfire party, Izuku assumes that wearing his swim trunks as bottoms couldn’t be too bad of an idea, and so he shimmies on those, and throws on a t-shirt that he could take on and off easily. Running to the bathroom to make sure his hair looked relatively okay, Izuku fixed himself up a little bit, and by the time Katsuki was expected to pull up, he was already downstairs. Inko Midoriya was in her room, and Izuku made light footsteps out of habit just so that she doesn’t hear him exit, and walked over to the familiar black car pulled up on the driveway.

Katsuki sat in the driver’s seat, switching the music on his phone, so that when Izuku comes in and buckles up his seatbelt, Listen To Your Heart by Roxette begins to play. With its intro beat that set the tone of where they were about to go, Katsuki puts the car in reverse, and exits the driveway towards their destination.

The bonfire party was just hosted on the North end of Ise's coastline, a little before you'd reach the start of the mountains that cupped the quaint town. When they arrived, it seemed like a fair amount of people were already present. Although the sun had only began to set at 6 PM, the bonfire was already going strong. The fire formation they built was incredible, with a ton of long and short sticks alike pointing upwards like a tipi tent, and set ablaze. Immediately, the smell of campfire smoke stuck on their clothes and in their hair. There were some tables with food and others were grilling their own food. From large speakers, Nothing's Gonna Stop Us Now by Starship blared, but not loud enough to cover up conversation. The two of them walked up together, and was greeted warmly by their other classmates and friends. Izuku's friends stole him, and Katsuki's friends stole the pole vaulter, naturally.

There were mostly people talking to others, with maybe a lite beer in their hand but nothing crazy, and two or three people were actually in the water. Overall, it was a relatively chill atmosphere.

Not as boisterous as the boat party on Enid Lake, which was nice, because after such a busy week, Izuku didn't mind just kicking back and hanging out with some friends. There were people there Izuku has only talked to once or twice in passing, that he got to know a little more as the night progresses. Here and there, Izuku and Katsuki's group of friends congregated into one large group, but the two of them didn't necessarily interact with each other throughout the night all that much. In fact, Izuku might have said a couple of words to him the entire night in general. He made sure to treasure these moments, as his last little snippets of a picturesque and idealistic place to be plays out in front of his eyes.

He decides not to swim, once he realizes that his body was covered in hickeys.

Izuku doesn't know when he'll get to see any of these people again after he graduates. Who will he stay friends with. Who will he grow apart from. With many people, Izuku could generally guess. He'll stay close with Ochaco, Iida, Shoto, the sort. He'll drift from those whose presence in his class and the occasional group work assignment was the extent of their interaction.

The only person who he could not seem to place a finger on was Bakugo Katsuki. The enigma prevented Izuku from being able to determine what happens to them after this. After the project. After the year ends. He wonders if the extent he'll be seeing Katsuki will be on his TV screen. And then, before that thought could plague him with this unsettling sadness, Izuku kicks it out of his head.

At some point in the night, the fireworks start. How did people get their hands on some fireworks, Izuku had no idea. It wasn't as if the corner grocery just had fireworks for sale, so Izuku assumed that someone drive to the next bigger city to grab some of these. But some people made a little pit in the sand as a standard on where to place the fireworks, and they all just stood back and watched the show.

Now *this* was the rather more illegal things that could actually get them into some trouble: shooting fireworks on the beach unauthorized. But when the fireworks display showcase beautiful patterns of greens, blues, reds, and what not, or made funny whistling sounds when it goes up into the air, Izuku finds himself smiling a lot. There were also those little balls that

people would throw at the ground, and they'd pop. Firecrackers were always present, and everytime a person would throw one, any crowd would dissipate considering that no one wanted to be around to get hit by a firecracker.

It was overall a fun time, but the thing about fireworks, was that they attracted the authorities way easier than something like a bonfire or even breaking into an abandoned building would. Throughout he and Katsuki's sometimes illegal escapades, they realistically knew the chance was unlikely that the cops would be called. However, there was a clear difference between subtly slipping into a place or climbing a fence that says *Do Not Trespass* and setting up an entire fireworks show for the entire city of Ise that lived near the coast could see and hear.

Izuku wasn't keen on having to deal with a conversation with the authorities, and Katsuki, being who he was, could definitely not afford to get into major trouble weeks before Nationals, and so, as the fireworks show drags on, Izuku made his way over to where Katsuki was standing, hands in his pockets, staring up at the night sky.

The blonde must have sense his coming over, for Katsuki glanced down at Izuku when he approached. The boy in question was shocked every time by their height difference, and leans up on his tiptoes to talk to the other above the noise of the crowd, fireworks, and music.

"Let's get out of here!" Izuku tells him, "Before the cops come."

For the first time, Katsuki seems to consider the possibility rather high, and nods at the other, going off to collect his things that he set down, before walking side by side with Izuku across the sand towards the parking lot off to the side of the beach.

"I thought they were just gonna host a bonfire on the beach," Katsuki says once they could hear each other more clearly again, "Not shoot off a fuckton of fireworks."
Izuku nods while he looks back, "It's beautiful, though. I don't think I've ever been so close to fireworks."
"No way," Katsuki refuses to believe it as they trudge through the sand, "Do you never fucking celebrate holidays or something?"
Izuku laughs, "I do, but my mom, if you couldn't guess, would throw a fit if I got near anything that could burn me."

"Is that why you're shit at cooking," Katsuki asked with a snort.

"I'm not even that bad," Izuku rolls his eyes, "You're just hanging onto that one time I just wanted to make us sandwiches instead of real food."
"As I fucking should. Stop trying to starve your guests, Deku," Katsuki argued.

"Hello, I'm a wonderful host," Izuku rebuttals.

"Yeah, yeah," Katsuki waved him off, before asking, "You wanted to get out of here, huh. But did that mean you want to go home? Or do you wanna stay out for a little while longer."

Izuku hums, "How long is a little while longer, exactly?"

Katsuki thinks on it, as they reached the asphalt parking lot and it became much easier to walk, and they head towards Katsuki's car, "A couple days."
Izuku almost choked on his own spit, "A couple of days?"
The athlete shrugged, "Through the weekend."

"Don't you think that's a bit much?" Izuku asked, with a funny smile.

"Why would it be?" Katsuki asked, and glanced at Izuku, "We can call it a boys' trip."

"Boys' trip," Izuku repeated, "But without Kirishima, Denki, or any of your other friends. Just you and me."

The athlete shrugged, "Just you and me."

"Why?" Izuku asked.

"Because I need a goddamn break from all of this, because you need a break from all the shit you've been doing, and..." Katsuki trudged ahead and got into the driver's side door, just to finish his sentence once the both of them are settled in their seats, "Because I missed you. Is that good enough, shitnerd?"

Izuku keeps Katsuki's eye contact steady, trying to find any lies in those stunning sharp eyes. Because I missed you. Never would he think that he would hear those words come out of Katsuki's mouth in a context other than his dreams, but here they were, sitting in a car, with Katsuki asking him to come along somewhere because an underlying reason was that he missed him.

After his eyes dart around for a moment to detect for lies, Izuku just asks the other, "Where?"

"Haven't you learned by now, Deku?" Katsuki raised a brow, "You'll see."

The athlete's hands were on the stick, about to reverse out of the parking lot, but took a moment to look at Izuku, "So where will it be? Home? Or with me?"

Izuku finds it funny. To him, those two things are one and the same. Home. And Katsuki.

But he keeps that thought silent, and instead, responds to the other, "With you."

And so, with a satisfied smile, Katsuki puts the car in reverse.

And they drive for a bit. Not as far as they have before, but wherever it was they were going was still quite a bit of a drive from Ise. He could still be in the outskirts of Ise for all Izuku knew, but then they headed South towards the sparse forestry that cupped Ise on the other side. The shuffled playlist in the car relaxes him, as Katsuki drives with the windows down and his blonde hair blowing gently in the breeze they picked up while in the vehicle. Izuku has his hand out the window, pretending he could pull the air around his fingers. They talk and catch up for a bit, as the car actually drives through pretty sparse forestland with a lot of sand covering the forest floor, considering they were so close to the beach. These trees were

meant to grow near saltwater, so they were thin, sparse, and had very little branches or leaves except for at the top. The road runs near the beach, but not near enough that they could see the actual ocean. They just knew it was just beyond their field of view due to the woods, but the sand on the forest floor was indicative they were taking the scenic route to wherever their destination may be.

The moonlight was prominent amidst the clear skies tonight, so although it was dark, he could still see through the trees, which casted shadows on the ground like hauntingly beautiful figures.

Katsuki drives through these sandy forests for what seemed like forever, until once in a while, they'd find a small path with more sandy soil diverging left or right. These paths sometimes led to houses in the woods, or maybe they turned left further than what Izuku or Katsuki could see.

After another ten minutes of driving down this road, with rocks getting stuck in the crevices of Katsuki's wheel and the smell of salt water picking up in his nose, the blonde makes a left turn towards, which would be in the direction of the ocean. The left turn came about on a small sandy path as well, with a tiny mailbox in the front for the postman, indicating that at the end of this road was a house.

As they drove further on the path, the more sparse the trees and the sandier the ground, so whoever owned the place poured cement deep into the sand so that cars could drive on it, and not get stuck if they didn't have a four wheel drive. The cement driveway was long, cutting through the trees and up a hill, until when they reached the top of it, levels out again and Izuku finally sees where it was they were heading towards.

Right there on the edge of the beach, facing the water was a gorgeous off-white home with an open cabana connected to it facing the water. The home was situated with enough distance from the actual water that during months of heavy tides, hurricanes, and storms, it would be okay sitting where it was. From the back, it looked like a one story villa, incorporating both a contemporary theme and a classic beach cabin element.

There was a basketball goal nailed into the ground near the garage opening. The home was painted completely white, which looked like a faint blue under the moonlight.

"My aunt owns this," Katsuki spoke up as he pulls up onto the driveway and places the car in park, "She calls it the Hideaway."

"The hideaway…" Izuku repeats to himself, as he unbuckles and steps out of the car.

Immediately, that salt water smell gets stronger, and he hears the waves breaking on the shore, considering the beach was right there. Although the beaches directly parallel to Ise were beautiful, this was on a whole different level. Although the house was currently blocking his view of the ocean, Izuku could see that they were practically completely isolated. There was just sand and empty beach everywhere, except for about a couple hundred feet around the property, where the trees serve as a natural fence from other private land owners in the area. The sand was so soft, and white that it squeaked beneath his feet like

flour. Izuku stares up at the sky, and sees that accompanying the moon tonight were a plethora of stars that reigned over the heavens.

“She bought this shit a while ago, but probably uses it three times a year,” Katsuki says as he grabs some of his things, “So hag #2 gave everyone in the family the code in case we want to use it, to just get away.”

Izuku turned to Katsuki, “Only 3 times a year?” His eyes widened, “If I had this, I’d go every weekend.”

Katsuki chuckled, “You still could.”

The green eyed boy lowered his head from the sky back down over to Katsuki, who had then already moved on from the comment, and made his way up the back door, consisting of about five steps, to the tall white door. Opening up the keypad, the blonde pressed a couple of numbers in, before they heard the whirring of the lock opening itself, and Katsuki pressed in the handle, stepping inside.

Izuku followed suit, and was immediately floored by everything, even with the lights turned off. Katsuki went over to turn on a small lamp, that then highlighted the living space with a pale warm-toned light. It was barely enough light to actually illuminate anything, but there was no need to when the cabana-style beach house was designed to take in moonlight.

The back door opens up to the living room, and any and all guests would immediately be stunned by the completely open design. There were beautiful salmon pink couches with a handpicked jade coffee table in the center of the living room. The TV was off on the left wall, which would be strange since the couches faced the ocean. But the reason why the TV could not go in the front was because instead of a wall, the entire front of the one-story house was made of floor to ceiling glass. However, it was so transparent that it felt as if it wasn’t there at all.

Katsuki sets his things down, and walks over to the edge of the glass, grabbing onto a handle, before walking to the other side of the wall, dragging the handle with him so that the acrylic glass almost folds in on itself, opening up the living room to the ocean breeze.

Immediately, the wind picks up, but amidst the humid heat, it felt so nice. Outside, the sheer curtains billowed around the white pillars that framed either sides of the terrace. These dusty pink curtains that matched the color of the couches were made of a very light and sheer chiffon that looked almost ghostly as it twirled and blew in the wind, sweeping inside the granite floors of the home.

Moonlight spilled into the living room, casting everything in a bluish glow. There were decorative pieces everywhere. On the back wall, a minibar was set up and fully stocked. Out on the terrace which expanded across the entire width of the living room, and curved out into a semi-circle, there was an empty space in the middle of the terrace that led down some stairs for guests to walk out onto the ocean. And the terrace was completely empty aside from a table and four chairs, as if to invite people to just stand and look out onto the view.

And my *god* was the view incredible. The ocean seemed endless at night, with white streaks on the surface from where the moon's rays hit. Pale foam crashes into the shore along with the surprisingly gentle waves, but the sound of it was melodic. In the far distance, if he looked closely, there may be the faint red light of deep sea fishing charter boats.

On the left looked like a doorway that led into the kitchen. Another door on the left that was the half-bathroom.

And on the right were two rooms. A master bedroom closer to the ocean view, and then a guest bedroom, each with its own bath. From where he was standing, the glimpse he got into the master bedroom consisted of the same open balcony that presented an ocean view, with the same billowy rosy curtains that swept into the room. The bed itself was a king sized four-poster frame with a minx fur comforter and a plethora of pillows. And the guest bedroom had a similar design, except the balcony was parallel to the shoreline, so there was a view of both the forest line and the ocean on the left. The difference with this room was that there was a creme-colored theme, instead of a dusty pink.

This place really did look like a hideaway, mixing in a very 80s pastel beach house aesthetic with the color scheme and elegantly placed movie posters on the wall, with a contemporary design with the open glass front and greek-inspired pillars.

Katsuki came back from the kitchen with two bottles of room temperature water from the pantry, and tossed one to Izuku before pointing towards the bedrooms, "Oi, which one do you want? Master or guest. Pick whichever and I'll stay in the other one."

Izuku looked over to Katsuki, as he unscrewed the cap of the bottle, automatically going, "Oh, we're not going to…"

Izuku knew what he had been meaning to say. They had been intimate with each other so often that the thought of sharing a bed was almost automatic to him. Even when they laid a foot apart, it made Izuku feel so much closer. But Katsuki was right in suggesting this. They weren't like that anymore, and Izuku didn't need that type of incentive anymore either.

And so he covers up his mistaken assumption immediately by gesturing to the guest bedroom, "I'll stay in the guest room. You're the one that brought me here."

But it was too late. Katsuki was at least smart enough to pick up what Izuku was originally implying, and Izuku knew it by the way the blonde's brow raises ever so slightly. Izuku looked away, flushing just a bit.

"You sure?" Katsuki asked him, "The view is killer."

Izuku nods his head, "I'm sure," Before grabbing his bag, intending to drop it into the guest room. Since he hadn't been expecting this, he only brought what he was going to change out of if he decided to swim at the bonfire party, which wasn't much, but he set it in the closet anyways, to see that it was already lightly stocked with beach-type clothing. Loose t-shirts to sleep in, drawstring sweatpants or cotton shorts to lounge in, and plenty of towels. Overall, there were just clothes that could fit any size body for guests. He looked around the room, running his hands over the wooden chair to the rustic modern bedframe.

Heading over to the balcony, the billowy curtains tickle his arms as he moved past them. And then he stares outside, wondering if Katsuki's ideas to whisk him away will ever cease to knock the air right out of his lungs.

After about another five minutes of admiring the view, a voice came from the doorway, and Izuku turned his head.

"Oi," Katsuki called out to him from the doorframe, "I'm gonna go take a dip. You coming or staying?"
Izuku looked down at his swim trunks. He had worn them for a reason, but didn't have an opportunity to get in the water earlier, so he nods his head, "I'll come."

"Great, towels are on the top shelf of the wardrobe," Katsuki hits the side of the wardrobe, before backing out of the doorframe.

Izuku grabs some of his things and walks back out into the living room to see that Katsuki was already outside on the terrace, back facing him. A towel was draped on the stone railing of the terrace, and Katsuki lifts his arms behind his head, and grabs the back of his shirt, before pulling the plain fit tee over his head and off of his body, draping that over the terrace as well.

Izuku's eyes scanned the athlete's back, defined by muscle and now, the marks that have yet to fade on his skin from Izuku's nails. Harsh red lines covered the expanse of the blonde's back, and there were bite marks on his shoulder and the sides of Katsuki's neck.

Katsuki notices the approaching footsteps, and turns his head slightly, eyes darting to Izuku for a second. The boy in question takes his shirt off as well, draping it beside Katsuki's. He feels the blonde's eyes on his body, because he knew that as bad as Katsuki looked, Izuku likely looked worse.

The feeling of being looked at goes away, once the athlete begins going down the stairs of the terrace, prompting Izuku to follow quickly behind. He's gone to the beach many times at this point, but the feeling of soft sand underneath his feet, and the occasional sea grass here and there that would tickle his calves, always felt lovely to him. He leaves his slippers on the terrace steps, and breaks out into a run towards the water's edge.

He laughs as he touches the water, clear and reflective, and purposely falls onto his back, landing with a splash and spreading his arms apart. It was shallow enough that he could lay there, and the bottom half of his body would get wet. And then he yells out a large *whoop!* Into the night air.

He gets up immediately, and turns to see why Katsuki hadn't gotten in yet. The blonde stood on the shore still, feet getting kissed by the breaking waves, with his arms crossed over his chest. Katsuki was looking down at the sand as if he were trying to hide something, and Izuku squinted his eyes to see that Katsuki was...smiling? To himself. And then his eyes look up at Izuku, still with his head down tilted, as his shoulders move a little bit in a laugh, and that smile begins to show a bit a white teeth.

Izuku cocks his head to the side with an amused smile at the sight, and watches as Katsuki, still with his arms folded, tries to cover up his gentle laugh and look off to the side again, turning his body to the left so that Izuku might not see. But that slight stupid grin, the greenette could still see the edges of it.

“What?” Izuku called out to the other.

Katsuki turned back to him, clearing his throat, and shook his head, “You look happy.”

Izuku laughs at him, “So why were you looking at me like that?”

Katsuki just shrugged and nodded while grinning at the ocean floor, “It’s just nice to know I can do that.”

“Do what,” Izuku kicked the water underneath his feet, hands over his head as if trying to capture moonlight.

Katsuki looked up at the sky then, and over the sound of the water, Izuku barely heard him.

“Make someone happy,” He says.

They stay in the water for a while. It could have been one hour. It could have been three. With Katsuki, time was only relative. When they just kind of relax and tread in the water, enjoying the silence as they take in the beauty of the powerful ocean at night, it feels like time was going incredibly slow, enough that Izuku can convince himself he could stay in this moment forever and have it never end. And when they were swimming or messing around, making a ruckus at whatever hour it was, it felt like time wouldn’t stop for anyone, and Izuku would just wish it would slow down just a little. So he can capture that laugh in his head once more.

Katsuki picks the smaller up at one point onto his shoulders and tells Izuku, “Try to do a flip off my shoulder.”

“A flip?” Izuku asks, “I don’t think I can even stand on your shoulders.”

From the shore, Katsuki’s speaker shuffles to the song True by Spandau Ballet, and the iconic beginning plays. Izuku sits on top of Katsuki’s shoulders, as the athlete was about chest length in the water. His hands pulled at some matted strands on top of the blonde’s head.

“This song was in that movie,” Izuku commented, “Sixteen candles.”

Katsuki hummed in acknowledgement, moving deeper in the water, “The movie about the jock and the nerd?”

Izuku flicks Katsuki on the side of the head, a habit he’s picked up from the other, “Sam wasn’t a nerd, Kacchan. But yes, that movie.”

“You’re distracting from the conversation, Deku,” Katsuki looked up at the boy on his shoulders, “Do a flip.”
Izuku groaned, “I can’t.”

“You can,” Katsuki tells him, as if he was sure, “Try.”

Rolling his eyes, Izuku places his hands on top of Katsuki’s head to stabilize himself, pushing down.

“Oi, oi, shitnerd,” Katsuki cringed, “Stop putting all your weight on my- *fuck* , ow. Never mind, you were fucking right. You can’t do this. Get of-”

“No, you said I can do it,” Izuku laughed, as he folded his legs back one by one, so that he was in a kneeling position on Katsuki’s shoulders, using the blonde’s head as a stabilizer.

Transitioning one feet to step on those broad shoulders, Izuku immediately began to wobble a little bit, but held on tightly. But when he tries to switch into the other foot, that was when the boy lost his balance and in a shaky display, yells as he falls backwards into the water.

When he rises to the surface, with a nose full of saltwater, he hears Katsuki’s boisterous laugh amidst the music.

“Alright, your turn,” Izuku demanded as he coughs up water.

The athlete cracks his knuckles and rolls his neck, “Piece of cake.”

“This is going to look so weird,” Izuku giggles as he bends down in the water just a little bit, so that Katsuki could grab his shoulders, and in one swift move, hoists himself on. Izuku grabs a hold of Katsuki’s muscular thighs, and they probably looked like idiots. Having this 6’4 giant sitting on his shoulders was definitely not great for his balance, but Katsuki was determined.

“Fucking stay still, goddamnit,” The blonde tells him as he uses Izuku’s shoulders for stability instead of his head, like Izuku had done.

Izuku complained to the other, “I’m trying!”

Katsuki then, quickly, in order to maintenance his balance, jumped up to his two feet with his upper body as straight as possible, so that he doesn’t sway. Katsuki holds out his hands so that Izuku could take them, now that he was standing upright for balance.

“Kacchan, you’re heavy,” Izuku cringed as the weight on his shoulders was concentrated on the two blades.

Instead of replying, Katsuki lowered himself just a little bit and moved his elbows back, before letting go of Izuku’s hand and jumping up and backwards, body already flexible due to his form training as a pole vaulter, and he flips backwards into the water. It wasn’t fair, Izuku thought, how Katsuki was good at mostly everything. Well, at least there was badminton.

When Katsuki resurfaces, he shakes his head to get the water out of his hair, causing Izuku to shield himself from the incoming flinging of water.

“See? Told you, easy as shit,” Katsuki grinned arrogantly, before looking down at Izuku’s body, eyes lingering for a little too long before he meets eyes with the green haired boy once more, “Those won’t go away for a while.”

Izuku looks down at his body and blushes, “Neither will yours.”

Katsuki looked down, and reached his rough hands up to trace his own marks, trailing salt water across his chest, “I know.” They’ve both been wearing hoodies all week with the drawstrings pulled close.

“What has the vault team said about it?” Izuku asked, considering that the pole vault uniform was revealing.

Katsuki raises a brow, looking down at Izuku, “What the fuck are they going to say? You think they’re gonna ask me who ate me alive?”
Izuku laughed a little at the comment, “I guess not. Speaking of eating, I’m a bit hungry.”

“Yeah? Let’s get us some food then,” Katsuki playfully thumbed at Izuku’s cheek.

Izuku moves his head away, not liking how his stomach fluttered when Katsuki did that, and the reaction was immediate. Katsuki dropped his hand, and even under the water, Izuku could see his knuckles tightening as he looked away, like he regretted doing that.

Izuku felt a pain stabbing his chest when he sees the reaction, and tries to speak nonchalantly, “There’s food in the house?”

Katsuki looked towards the hideaway, before trudging towards the shore, “It’s not fresh vegetables or anything, but I’m sure there’s cup noodles somewhere.”
“Cup noodles?” Izuku laughed, “I’m sorry, but I’ve been spoiled too much by your cooking to eat instant ramen.”

Katsuki turned back with a slight grin, “Brat.”

“You caused this,” Izuku rose out of the water with a taunting tone.

“I did, didn’t I?” Katsuki hums, and as he steps out of the water, bends down to pick up his speaker, “I’m just too good.”

When they walk up the steps back onto the terrace, Izuku dries himself off and just forgets about the shirt altogether, leaving it hanging out the railing. Jogging into the house, he changes into a pair of white cotton shorts, and walks out past the living room and into the kitchen to see that Katsuki had generally done the same.

And so, the two of them sit now, about thirty minutes later, on the floor of the kitchen, with a pot of instant ramen in between them, and two bowls for them to get their food into. Why were they sitting on the floor although there was a dining table? Izuku didn’t know. But when he had walked into the white and yellow themed kitchen, his legs were tired so he just sat

down on the floor, while watching Katsuki rummage around the cabinets and pantry for something to eat. And when the blonde was done cooking, instead of making Izuku get up for a few steps to sit down at the table, Katsuki pops a squat across from him, and joins him on the ground. And so the two of them sit there with the slight breezeway from the ocean coming in, shirtless, and eating instant noodles on the floor of the hideaway's kitchen. There was something about this that was so pure and innocent, and Izuku couldn't help but enjoy the company a little too much.

"What's there to do during the day?" Izuku asks the other, as he slurps a noodle into his mouth.

Katsuki set down his bowl, fanning his mouth from the temperature, before replying, "Literally nothing. Did you see the road here? There's jack shit to do here except sleep, swim, tan, and do it all over again." Katsuki explains, "It's too damn hot during the day, so you sleep until 5PM and stay up until 3 in the morning."

Izuku looks down at his bowl, laughing quietly, "Is that what we're going to do?"

Katsuki leans back on his arms and looks up to the ceiling fan in the fluorescent light of the kitchen, "We're already doing it. It's 2 in the morning."

Izuku's eyes widened, "Is it? Already?"
Katsuki nodded lazily, "Sure is."

Izuku hummed, "And how about tomorrow?"

"We'll sleep in until 5, like I said," Katsuki lays back on the cool tired floor and spreads his arms, "I'll drag your ass out of bed and make you drive to the nearest market so we can get some real food, th-"

"Wait, wait," Izuku waved his hands in the air and his eyes looked surprised, "You're going to make *me* drive? Your car?"
"Why not," Katsuki shrugs as his eyes close, "If you actually fucking manage to wreck my car out here where there is literally no one, then I'll be damned."

Now, Izuku was getting a tad bit excited, "No way."

"Don't get too giddy or I'll change my mind," Katsuki joked with a light chuckle, "As I was saying before you interrupted me, bastard, we'll cook something to eat. Swim. Do whatever. Go to sleep again," The blonde opened one eye to gauge Izuku's reaction, "Unless you want to d-"

"No, that sounds good!" Izuku smiled. And it really did. It was nice. It was friendly. And all he really had to do was relax and hang out.

After the two of them clean up, watching the clock, Izuku figures it was time to head to bed, even though he wasn't necessarily tired. His body felt a little exhausted, but mentally, he was still stimulated from the sheer surprise of being where they were. Izuku would say that he and Katsuki talk about mostly everything while doing anything: swinging on a hammock above a

creek, walking along a dirt road at night, just driving around in Katsuki's car. They give each other mundane details about their day or their lives that no one else would really care about, but Katsuki hadn't really mentioned this place at all.

It felt like this little pocket of the world was just for them. No one else was here except for little creatures: little crabs on the shore, birds hunting nocturnally, the mosquitos that annoyed the two of them to no end. Izuku wondered how long they were going to be here. Friday night, and all of Saturday he assumes, and maybe they could go back Sunday morning. It didn't really matter, because Izuku couldn't imagine he'd be here tonight in the first place.

And so, he lays on top of his comforter, in the quiet confines of the guest bedroom. His door was open so that more breeze from the open living room could come in.

And as the minutes pass by, it felt like hours as he tries to sleep but can't. When he attempts to close his eyes, all he could think of was Katsuki. The way that the blonde acts was like no other. He says many things that strike deep into his heart, in all of the wrong ways. And yet, while saying he won't coddle him or care for him tenderly, Katsuki ends up doing just that, unintentionally.

Izuku checks his phone. 3:42 in the morning. He still wasn't tired, and as he was wondering what all he could do to get himself to fall asleep, the greenette begins to hear soft music coming from another room.

Using process of elimination, he could only guess that it was coming from the master bedroom where Katsuki was staying, and Izuku listened in to see what was playing. So it seemed as if the athlete couldn't quite sleep either. Izuku ponders if he should come ask why there was music playing at this time. The beginning was a very slow instrumental, and Izuku finds himself unable to recognize it just yet. He slowly pulls himself out of bed, and walks slowly to his door.

As he leaves the doorframe behind, Izuku turns slightly to see that the blonde's door was left wide open too. It was clearer now. Hold On to The Nights by Richard Marx was spinning on the record player that was situated in the corner of the room. The vinyl set to the side looked like Classic Soft-Rock 80s Mixes. This was Richard Marx's first song to hit number 1 on the Billboard charts, and for good reason.

The introduction was nice, but what was the selling point of the soft romantic piece was when Richard Marx's voice comes in, delivering a sad but incredibly heartfelt performance that hooks the listener right away.

With the intro of the track playing in the background, Izuku shifts his sight to where Katsuki was standing lonesomely. Past the open wooden casement-style windows that led out onto the thin balcony, Izuku sees him.

Katsuki was standing there, hands on either sides of the balcony, looking out on the ghostly ocean view with only a pair of sweatpants on. Izuku saw him through the sheer curtains that blew in the wind, fluttering everywhere like ghosts dancing. Izuku imagines that they were in a movie: with this somber song playing as he stares at Katsuki from a distance.

*Just when I believed I couldn't ever want for more*

*This ever changing world pushes me through another door*

*I saw you smile*

*And my mind could not erase the beauty of your face.*

Izuku must not have realized he moved, because a little creak of his feet causes the blonde to turn his head ever so slightly, acknowledging Izuku's presence while still turned towards the ocean. The greenette wants to ask why the other couldn't sleep, but he had no right to speak over such a gorgeous song playing. And so instead, Izuku just walks a little closer, until he was approaching the billowing curtains.

Katsuki steps back from the balcony, and turns around until he was walking to meet Izuku halfway, slowly so his feet matched the beat of the song. They meet with just a foot apart. Katsuki on the balcony still, standing in front of the curtains and looking down to where Izuku, on the other side, leans against the wood panel, staring at Katsuki through the dusty pink curtains.

If he stepped just a little closer, he'd get lost in them.

*I wish that I could give you something more*

*That I could be yours*

Katsuki mouthed these lyrics to himself, so subtly, that if Izuku wasn't mapping out every detail of the boy's face, he wouldn't have been able to tell. Izuku just stares up at the taller boy. Katsuki steps just a little closer, and slowly brought his hand up to place his palm gently against the sheer curtains, feeling the fabric move along his hands as the breeze pushes it back and forth in and out of the room. He lowers his palm, caressing the fabric ever so gently, until his hand was at the same level as Izuku's chest.

The green eyed boy, hesitantly, reaches out with his own hand, and touches the flowing fabric for himself, so soft underneath his fingertips and so fragile seeming. Eventually, as he lets the curtain flow through his fingers, on the other side, he meets Katsuki's larger palm.

Izuku stares at their palms touching each other, with only a thin flowing layer of fabric in between that was so transparent that it barely even mattered. But it was still there nevertheless. Izuku smiles to himself just a little bit. Maybe it was just getting late into the night, but he couldn't help but feel as if this was their relationship as a whole. Just transparent enough that Izuku knew that there was something special about them, but there was still always a barrier that held back everything. There was always a boundary between them that just couldn't be cut down, now matter how hard he tries to see through it.

Izuku whispers the next line of the lyrics, "Promises in vain, love that is real but in disguise."

Katsuki steps a bit closer, seeming careful not to do anything Izuku didn't want to, and his palm slides down until he could wrap the chiffon around Izuku's hand and bring the boy's

wrist up to cup Katsuki's face, red eyes looking into green ones between the moving sheets of fabric.

*What happens now*

*Do we break another rule?*

*Let our lovers play the fool.*

*I don't know how*

*To stop feeling this way.*

And then Katsuki drops his hand, letting the curtain between them unwrinkle and flow freely again. Izuku brings his palm back and rubs it with his other hand as if he had been burned with the most beautiful fire.

"Can't sleep?" Katsuki says then, pushing the curtain aside to see Izuku clearly now.

Izuku shakes his head, "It might be the new environment."
"What would make it more familiar," Katsuki asks, voice quiet.

Izuku knows what would. *You* , he wanted to say. But he couldn't. He wouldn't. And so, Izuku looks off to the side, "I'm not sure. I'll just have to get over it."

Katsuki steps through the frame and back into the bedroom, before sitting on the edge of the king bed, "You want me to turn off the music? I thought you were asleep."

Izuku shakes his head, staying in his spot, "No, I like it." Then asked, "How about you? Can't sleep either?"

The boy hummed in response, "No, I'm waiting for the season premiere of Yunso to release."

Izuku airily laughs, "Do you mind if I join you?"

Katsuki gestures his head to the bed, "Go ahead, nerd."

Izuku walks slowly to the side of the bed and sunk down on the mattress, keeping a small distance between them and leans back against the headboard

The next song on the vinyl plays, and it's gentle enough to rock him to sleep if he was any more tired than he was now. This was the type of song that would play when you realize how much of a fool that love made you. Bound to make the same mistakes over and over again, never realizing what you're doing wrong. Bound to hurt, to smile, to feel everything you didn't know you could feel: intense anger, happiness, sorrow, exhilaration.

And more often than not, *foolish* . Hence, the title of the track.

What Kind of Fool by Barbra Steisand and Barry Gibb.

Back to back, these were beautiful songs that felt unreal to hear right now, in the gorgeous master bedroom of a cabana style hideaway on private ocean land. Outside, the waves crash and the music of nature reigns supreme. But in here, the soft voice of Barabra Streisand fills the air.

*There was a place when we were starting over*

*We let the bough break*

*We let the heartache in*

Izuku asks Katsuki, “When does it come out?”

“In an hour,” Katsuki checks his phone, “I’ve been waiting for it all fucking year. I ain’t gonna miss it for sleep.”

The blonde leans his back against the bottom poster of the bed, and stretches his legs across the horizontal distance, with his feet hanging off the edge. His head was turned towards the window, to watch the waves thunder through the curtains.

*What, what kind of fool*

*Tears it apart*

*Leaving me pain and sorrow*

Izuku nudges Katsuki with his foot, “Oi, you need to take care of your body for the tournament.”

“Oi, did you just say ‘oi’?” Katsuki chuckled, “You know, I’ve been picking up on your shitty habits too.”

“Oh?” Izuku sits up and grins, “Like what?”

“Like being sappy and shit,” Katsuki grinned, “You think a year ago, I would have fucking said thank you when Round Face picks up my pencil?”

“How is that sappy?” Izuku shakes his head, throwing a pillow at Katsuki, “Kacchan, that’s the bare minimum!”

The music is getting louder as Barry Gibb comes in, but it matches the fun, peaceful vibe they had going on right now. It was easy to get lost in the moments of pain when you’re in love with someone, that Izuku sometimes forget that a lot of the times, there are joyful moments like these: when all they had to do to have fun was talk and laugh.

*Was there a moment when I cut you down*

*Played around*

*What have I done*

“Also,” Katsuki puts his hands up, as if about to say something really important, before repeating, “Also, listen.”

“Yes, yes, I’m listening intently, Kacchan,” Izuku leans forward on his palm in dramatic anticipation.

Katsuki leans forward as well, as if he was going to reveal something really intense, before telling Izuku, “Yesterday, I called Half and Half by his real name,” Katsuki pat himself on the back with a goofy grin, “He was so fucking surprised when I called him Iida.”

Izuku gapes, eyes in shock, and is quiet for a whole minute, before he sits back and doubled in laughter, holding his stomach. Katsuki looked so proud of himself and so confident the entire time, and Izuku lost it. He couldn’t even tell if that was a joke, or if the blonde was awfully good at keeping a confident face when he messes around.

“K-Kacchan!” Izuku says between laughs, “That’s not Shoto’s real name.”

The blonde sits back and looks at him in horror, “Hah?”

Izuku shakes his head and wipes a tear from his eyes, “Iida-kun is, um...what do you call him?” Izuku recalls and flushes, “Four eyes…”

Katsuki just continues to stare at him.

“Uh...half and half is Shoto,” Izuku corrects him while nodding his head, “Todoroki Shoto.”

“Fuck,” Katsuki hits himself on the temple once, “No wonder he looked like that,” He shook his head at his own stupidity.

Izuku continues giggling, “I appreciate the effort though, Kacchan.”

“Yeah, yeah,” Katsuki rolled his eyes, “Whatever.”

The song ends, and the next one on the vinyl plays. The introduction that everyone recognizes comes on, and Katsuki stands up immediately, going over to the record player to skip it. Izuku hops off the bed and blocks Katsuki’s path.

“Hold on a minute!” Izuku puts both arms out to keep Katsuki from touching the record player, “What’s wrong with this song? I love this song. No, we’re keeping this song. Sit down!”
Katsuki side steps, and tries to move Izuku out of the way, “Move your ass now, before I throw you out the window.”

“Try me,” Izuku threatens, “We *will* be listening to this song.”

The saxophone intro was one that anybody, regardless of whether their taste is in 80s music or not, would know immediately. Careless Whisper by George Michael. This song was legendary.

Katsuki groaned towards the ceiling, “I fucking hate this song, Deku.”

Izuku shakes his head, “Why? It’s amazing!”

“It’s been ruined by all the,” Katsuki waved his arms around, “memes and shit. I can’t fucking listen to the saxaphone without wanting to barf.”
Izuku giggled, and then began moving his hands in fists up and down, like he was shaking a tambourine, and moving his legs dancing funnily, and then began singing stupidly, “I feel so unsure, as I take your hand, and lead you to the dance floor.” He emphasize every beat dramatically.

“No, no, no,” Katsuki turned his head away and began to walk back to his seat, “I’m not doing this shit tonight.”

Izuku laughs, “Come on, sing with me,” And reaches out to grab onto Katsuki’s wrists, “As the music dies, something in your eyes, calls to mind a silver screen, and all its sad goodbyes.”

Katsuki, however, was like a boulder and unmoveable, as the tall athlete stands there looking as if he wanted to kick Izuku out, but a slowly forming grin was showing up at the corner of the blonde’s lips.

“You’re fucking crazy,” Katsuki rolls his eyes.

Izuku turns himself around and then grabs onto Katsuki’s wrists one more time, pulling him to the middle of the bedroom, and moving their arms in a dumb oscillating waving motion, before leaning his head in just a little bit with a smile, “Yeah, and you need some of it.”

Katsuki’s eyes widen in surprise, as Izuku repeats the line that the blonde said to him the day they stopped in the middle of the road on the way to Dolly for the drive-in movie theater. Katsuki had left the car, given a dramatic speech, and when he came over to Izuku’s window, this same exact conversation happened but in reverse.

Katsuki just begins chuckling, before shrugging his shoulders in defeat and moving their arms back and form like they were rowing a boat together, “Look at you now, nerd.”

Izuku, if nothing else, was proud of how far he has come from however long ago that was, in terms of how much he has done to enhance his life, his memories, how much he’s able to stand up for what he wants, how much he can look back on a day and feel like it has been well spent. Of course, there were problems, of course he didn’t have it perfectly down, but change doesn’t happen overnight.

Katsuki then gave in completely, “I’m never gonna dance again,”

And Izuku finished the lyrics, “Guilty feet has got no rhythm. Though it’s easy to pretend,”

Katsuki pretended he was soloing, “I know you’re not a fool.”

“See?” Izuku beams, “There you go!”

Katsuki flicks the boy in the side of the head gently, “I still hate this song.”

“But do you hate this memory?” Izuku asks, looking up at the taller, tangoing with himself side to side.

Katsuki tells him then, “Don’t call this a memory,” The blonde says as he reaches out to twirl Izuku, “Not yet.”

And then they dance some more, and when the song was over, Izuku begs for the taller to replay it. Again. And again. And although Katsuki says he hated the song to no end, the athlete does so anyways.

All he could see was orange. Some yellow. Lines of red. And Izuku wonders what in the world he was seeing, and twitches his eyes, until finally, the greenette realizes that, at some point in the night, or more like early morning, he had fallen asleep, just to now wake up at whatever time it was. The last thing he remember was the season premiere coming out, and Katsuki immediately turning off the music to get on his phone to watch it together. He remembers talking about the episode for a while, how long he wasn’t sure, but it must have been sometime then that Izuku fell into a deep slumber.

So deep, that as he sits up on the bed now, he was pretty sure it was well past the afternoon. This wasn’t the guest bed either. Izuku had fallen asleep in the master bedroom, and he looked around to see if Katsuki was around, when he spots the blonde at the foot of the bed, splayed out and looking like he wasn’t going to wake up for a while.

Izuku looks outside the open windows, and sees the view in the daytime for the very first time. And what a perfect time for a first daytime impression too. The blinding midday sun has eased up a little bit, and there was a softer orangish glow that made everything a lot easier to look at. The water was crystal clear until the drop off further out into the ocean and the waves came crashing in gentle folds. White sand blanketed the area around them, and the trees that cupped this little piece of property was a vibrant green.

“Kacchan,” Izuku goes down to the foot of the bed and shakes the other awake.

Katsuki takes a moment, but eventually, the peaceful slumber is interrupted and the blonde sits up and blinks at his surroundings, rubbing his eyes.

Izuku then sits back, “Take me driving.”

The pole vaulter laughs with sleepiness still in his voice, “You’re fucking up and ready to go, aren’t you.”

Izuku shrugs, “It’s almost 6 o’clock, a little later than what you said.”

“Oh fuck, is it really?” Katsuki glances out the window to see the hazy orangish-pinkish glow that was everywhere.

“Yeah,” Izuku laughs, “It was dark when we went to sleep, and it’s about to be dark again as we’re waking up.”

“Shit, I had something pl- Let’s hurry up,” Katsuki slides off of the bed and stretches. Izuku watches it all. And then the taller tells him, “Give me a couple minutes and we’ll go.”

“What’s the hurry for,” Izuku hummed.

Katsuki doesn’t answer, but instead, points outside towards the sun that was going to be on its descent soon, and spoke to it, “Oi, I’mma need you to slow the fuck down. Don’t fucking set yet. I’ll be back.”

“Are you…” Izuku cocks his head, “talking to the…”

“Go get ready,” Katsuki then turns to him and reaches over to toss Izuku the car keys, “And we’ll get you on the road, nerd.”

And so, Katsuki takes him driving. And it wasn’t like Izuku hasn’t driven before. He’s practiced and whatnot, but rarely does Inko give him an opportunity to get out and use the car by himself. When he does, however, Izuku likes to think he was pretty good at it. The greenette was so used to sitting in the passenger seat that switching over felt very odd. He had to pull the seat forward to make up for their height difference, and adjust the mirrors. Katsuki did the opposite, and slid the seat back so his legs could get more comfortable.

Izuku has seen the blonde do this enough times that he can repeat the actions without really being told. Putting the car in reverse, Izuku backs out in a six point turn that really should have been three, but he was practically a beginner and this was a narrow driveway, so Katsuki couldn’t even really blame him. And overall, he wasn’t bad at all, considering how little experience he had on the road.

The blonde was right in that it was a good thing this area was so incredibly isolated that Izuku didn’t feel as nervous driving. His hands didn’t grip the wheel too tightly, and he felt relatively relaxed as he drives out of the private property and back onto the forest road, even if Katsuki claimed he was going way too slow.

“The speed limit is 40 miles per hour,” Katsuki complained, “You are literally going 25.”

Izuku brushes him off, “Better safe than sorry, Kacchan.”

“Your inner Auntie is showing,” Katsuki snorted.

“She’s not always unreasonable, you know,” Izuku elbows Katsuki, which swerved the car to the right, “I think not wanting me to die in a car crash is pretty reasonable.”

“Fuck, keep both hands on the wheel, you maniac,” Katsuki tells him.

And when they arrived at the closest store, it was definitely tiny and sold very fresh produce from the lands in the area. There doesn’t seem to be a big store until people got back in Ise, so they were left with this small, but fresh selection. Katsuki grabbed a bunch of things that didn’t seem like it would make sense to put together, but Izuku trusts the process. They walked together like a couple picking vegetables and meats, arguing over which one looked more viable or fawning over how perfect an avocado felt, and Izuku wonders if he will have

this with someone when he was old and gray. Or will this one-sided romance at the young age of 18 be the once-in-a-lifetime experience that everyone dreams of.

And when they drive back, Katsuki is behind the wheel just to get them to the hideaway faster. And when they carry all of the groceries, enough for dinner tonight, late night snacks, and then breakfast and lunch on Sunday, into the house and into the kitchen, Izuku feels like his arms were about to break off. Katsuki too.

Both of them worked out plenty, but trying to exert enough energy to bring back all of the groceries in on one run barely an hour after waking up was definitely hard work.

The kitchen was about the only room in the hideaway that looked a bit older than the rest of the place. Instead of a contemporary design that looked newly furnished, the kitchen still kept its very 80s, outdated atmosphere, while still being clean. The white tiles were arranged in a diamond configuration, with faint teal blue paint on the cement fillings in between each tile. The cabinets were made of a light brown wood, and the wallpaper was this rustic yellow with tiny blue floral designs on it.

Seeing Izuku about to unbag the groceries and offer to help, Katsuki stops him.

“Hm?” Izuku looked up, as he was about to get some fruit out of a bag.

Katsuki shooed him away, “Go take a dip in the water before the sun completely sets. I’ll handle all this shit, and call you up when I’m done.”

The green eyed boy asked, “Wait, are you sure? I can help.”

“Deku, most of the time, when you offer to help cook, you just sit at the table and occasionally chop something,” Katsuki ruffles his hair, “Go take a swim. It’s nice out there.”

Izuku looks through the kitchen window, at the setting sun casting gorgeous warm tones on the water’s surface, and asks slyly, “Are you sure?”

“I’ll lock you out if you try to stay,” Katsuki rolled his eyes and shooed him away.

And so Izuku, getting the hint that Katsuki wanted to cook alone, takes his leave, jogging lightly to the guest room to grab his swim trunks again which were practically dry by now, considering he had hung them up on the balcony all day, and slipped out of his shorts and into those.

Grabbing a towel and a change of clothes from the wardrobe, Izuku ran out into the living room, outside to the terrace, and briskly went down the steps. Near the bottom, right before he reaches the sand, Izuku sets the clothes and his towel down so that he could change into them there when he gets up, without tracking sand and saltwater up onto the terrace. The worst thing was walking around barefeet and picking up leftover sand everywhere.

He leaves his things there, and jogs towards the water, kicking it back as he goes further past the sandbar into deeper water that went up to his waist. He dips his body down so that his hair could get wet, and feels the energy surge through him as he’s rejuvenated. The ocean was

warm, after spending the entire day collecting heat from the sun and trapping it until late at night, when its released. But it was more beautiful than any picture could do it justice.

The water looked like a mix of pink and red, but when he looks down at his feet past the surface, it was evident that it was clear. He could see some tiny fish swimming past his legs. It wasn't as if this was the first time he's seen the ocean as sunset. Ever since he's built this partnership with Katsuki, he's seen the most beautiful sunsets at some of the most beautiful locations. But it is still breathtaking every time.

And so he wades for a long time, floating on his back until a particularly large wave comes and shoves salt water up his sinuses. He hums music out loud, used to having Katsuki's speaker around to set the mood. But right now, he was content enough with his own humming and the natural sounds of the ocean, the birds, and the wind.

Occasionally, he'd look up onto the terrace, to see what was taking the blonde so long. He wasn't particularly starving or anything, surprisingly enough, but it was taking a bit longer than usual. Eventually, he would forget that he was waiting on Katsuki's call and had his fun down in the water by himself.

He couldn't believe that not too terribly long ago, he wouldn't dare go to a *school* event if his mother forbade it. And now, he was seeing beautiful sights and living the life he imagined for himself when he was little. Occasionally, Izuku thought of his dad. Hisashi. Were these the things he liked to do? The activities and sights he loved to see? If so, then sometimes, for a mere second and nothing more, Izuku understood. He understood why his father left his mother, even if he didn't understand why his father left *him* . Because this was like nothing else.

But then, Izuku looks at Katsuki. Katsuki, with his dire imperfections. Katsuki, with his fiery eyes and sharp tongue. Katsuki, with his stupid decisions and impulsive actions. Katsuki, with his adventures and gifts of experience to him. And then, Izuku thinks: No, *this* was like nothing else. Just as much as the pain was like nothing else, the pleasure was also like nothing else.

Katsuki, Katsuki, Katsuki.

They say that the more a word is said, the more it loses its meaning. But as Izuku repeats Katsuki's name in his head, hoping it'll mean less to him each time,  the more tragically beautiful it becomes.

He's lost in thought when faintly, Izuku hears his name being called, and he lifts his head above the water to turn towards shore. From the edge of the terrace, Katsuki waves him in.

"Dinner's ready," Katsuki shouts out into the sea.

Izuku begins to swim slowly towards shore and yells back, "Coming!"

He drags himself out of the water, dripping wet, and slightly cold as the sky turns into twilight. Soon enough, it'll be dark, but for now, there was still a deep mauve stroke of paint across the heavens. Izuku trudges across the sand, caking it onto his wet feet, before he

reached the steps. Drying himself off, and shaking as much water from his hair as possible, the greenette changes right then and there into drier clothes. It wasn't as if Katsuki hasn't seen him naked before, and there was nobody else on the property but them. Besides, the blonde wasn't even looking, so Izuku throws on the white cotton t-shirt and white cotton shorts from the wardrobe to match.

Holding his swim trunks and towel in his left arm, Izuku pulled himself up the stairs, legs already a bit tired from treading water for so long. He smells the food from halfway up, and smiles. Either the smell was pungent enough to reach outside, or they were going to eat out on the terrace.

And when he gets to the terrace, the boy was about to step forward when he stops in his tracks and stares out at the display in front of him. Izuku just stops. And tries to take in everything. The salt water was getting sticky on his skin, the humidity he feels upon getting on land was setting in, and he didn't know what to do about what was in front of him.

Katsuki had cooked dinner alright, but it wasn't just *dinner* . It looked like something that a person would do on them and their partner's three year anniversary, not something a person casually does for a friend that they refuse to love. This looked like something that came right out of a romance movie, not the tragic unrequited reality that was Izuku's life. He stands there still, as he takes in everything.

He should love this. He really should. Izuku should love the very stunning display of dinner that was made for the two of them. He should love the food that seemed like a lot of care was put into it. White chocolate macadamia nut cookies, some soda that Katsuki was definitely not allowed to drink, very prettily made sandwiches, and a soup that smelled great but looked like it would give him immediate high cholesterol.

He really should love it: the fact that all of this was set on top of one of the spare comforters taken out of the closet, white and fluffy so that if they spill anything, it's all over. He was grateful, and this warmed his heart more than anything. And if it was just this, Izuku thinks he wouldn't have the pained reaction that he has.

But it wasn't just this. Picnics on blankets? They've done that before, as friends and as intimate partners alike. There was no romantic undertone to picnics. Friends do it all the time. Izuku two weeks ago went out with some of his friends to a park, and brought a lot of beautiful food like this--albeit, store bought--, to picnic on a blanket that Shoto took from his own house. That was fine. But this? There was nothing platonic about this.

Not when there were candles, nicely placed here and there. The smell of them burnt like honey lavender. Not when there were *flower* petals, dotting the ground and around the food. Yellow flowers. And more red lilies. *Yellow flowers* . And more, Izuku repeated to himself, more red lilies.

Did Katsuki even know what he was doing to him, Izuku wondered. Did Katsuki understand the implications of actions like these, or did he just do them while saying he doesn't love Izuku without a second thought. Izuku didn't even know if he was being irrational, or stupid. He was grateful, yes. He both loved this and hated this at the same time.

Love, because this was the kind of thing that some people will go throughout their lives wishing they could experience, the kind of thing people didn't even believe lovers do anymore, the kind of thing you'll die never forgetting.

Hate, because they *weren't* lovers. And Katsuki did these *things* , all of these *things* that would say otherwise, only to tell the smaller that he could never love him, that Katsuki *would* never love him. It was unfair. It was so unfair, because this was exactly the reason why Izuku feels like he can never move on.

Because just as the blonde does something shitty, says something shitty, takes a bit of his heart day by day so that he's left with nothing, Katsuki then goes and does something like this: put on this overtly romantic display, bring him to a fancy dinner and makes love to him in a lighthouse afterwards, drops everything for Izuku. And it's just not *fair* . This cycle, it hurts. Izuku drops his shorts and towel on the ground, as he stares at the entire thing in both suffocating sadness and awe.

The blonde comes out onto the terrace, looking down at his phone, while he searches for a song to play on the speaker he held in his left hand. When he picks one out, Katsuki sets it down on the ground and lets "Lately" by Stevie Wonder play for them to hear.

It was objectively a good song, very people would agree. And Izuku usually loved this song, having grown up a Stevie Wonder fan, dancing in the living room with his mother singing Isn't She Lovely.

But right now? It feels like it was scratching his ears in the most painful ways. The piano, the smooth voice, all of it just hurt his ears, and added to the even more romantic aspect of it all.

"Kacchan…" Izuku asks with a quiet voice over the music, at everything from the candlelight to the purple-tinted water, "What is all of this?"

Katsuki just looked around, face pretty relaxed, and shrugged, "Dinner, nerd."

Izuku smiled, even though his eyes were beginning to feel a slight sting, "Just...dinner?"

Katsuki gives him an odd look, before replying, "Yeah. I thought it'd be nice to eat it on the terrace. Watch the sunset or some shit," He said before scratching the back of his neck, "But the sun fucking went away so here we are."

"W-Why all of this?" Izuku gestures to the entire display. The candles, the flowers, the outrageously romantic component of it all. He just wishes the music would stop. He was beginning to hate the sound of this piece.

Katsuki put his phone in his pocket, "It's just a friendly gesture, Deku. Don't think too hard on it, and let's just e-"

"Friendly?" Izuku asks, looking up then with slightly glassy eyes. He wished he wasn't so dramatic, but he couldn't help it. He could barely breathe as it was, and his body felt hot all over, simply from feeling overwhelmed with a plethora of emotions.

Katsuki opens his lips, “Oi, are you about to-”

Izuku continues, voice cracking just a bit, “Don’t think too hard on it? Kacchan, are you…” He swallows and breathes out slowly, “Are you serious, right now?”

The athlete stands there, across from the set up, saying nothing, as he didn’t know what was happening.

“You…” Izuku pursed his lips as his eyebrows pull together in pain and he squeezes his eyes shut so he doesn’t cry, “Kacchan, you set all of this up, you go and get flowers for this, you light candles, and play love songs. And you’re telling me…” He tries to regulate his breathing so his voice could even itself, “You’re telling me to not think too hard on it?”

“Fuck,” Katsuki cursed under his breath, before bending down to begin picking up the flowers, “I don’t know why I thought you’d- *Fuck* .” He says, while grabbing at the yellow and red flowers.

“What are you doing?” Izuku asked, standing there, watching Katsuki pick up the flowers off of the ground.

“Getting rid of this shit,” Katsuki sounded angry at himself, “ *Fuck* , I didn’t know you wouldn’t like it. Shit, you looked like you liked these at the…” He hesitated, “at the field and the night market.”

“No, stop,” Izuku shakes his head, his lips quivering again, “Stop it, Kacchan. D-Don’t blow out the candl-” He walks over to stop the blonde, “Stop it.”

Katsuki looked upset at himself, and just confused, yet stopping when Izuku comes up in between him and where the candles were. There was still a prominent glassiness in Izuku’s eyes.

“I love it, okay?” Izuku says, yet there was just sadness in his expression, “I love it so much. These flowers are my favorite. The candles are beautiful. The food smells good, okay?” His voice shook, “But do you know what you’re doing to me? Do you do these things, understanding what it’s doing to me?” He asked, almost in a plead.

Katsuki steps back and looks off to the side, breathing out, before staring down at Izuku, “Deku, if you like it, then I don’t fucking get it. I’m confused,” He ran a hand through his hair, “What do you mean do I know what I’m doing to you? The point of all of this,” Katsuki gestures as his brows furrowed, “is to make you happy.”

“And why do you want that so badly, Kacchan?” Izuku asks, stepping a bit closer, trying not to stagger. If he could only get Katsuki to admit, or hint, or even acknowledge that it might be because he might feel something for Izuku, then maybe this night could be saved.

“Because we’re friends, goddamnit,” Katsuki tells him, “What do you- What the fuck.” He sounded exasperated.

Izuku steps back as Katsuki speaks, his face morphing into one of pure pain as he shakes his head, “No, no, no. Kacchan, *no* .”

“What,” Katsuki asked, then again but louder, “ *What* ? You can’t just fucking say no, Izuku. I’m already shit at communicating as it is, you gotta help me here.”

“No, we are *not* friends,” Izuku completes his sentence, as the first tear of the night falls out of his right eye, “How can you do this? How can you do *all* of this? Take me here? Do this for me? Do *everything* for me, and still tell me that we’re just friends? You’re so unfair, Kacchan.”

Katsuki’s chest goes up and down, as the blonde’s breathing gets heavier, “I don’t fucking know what you want me to say, Deku. I made us dinner. It’s not a big fucking deal, Deku.”

“Not a big deal?” Izuku’s shoulder shook and he stares at Katsuki incredulously, before turning his head towards the speaker, “Turn off- Turn off the music,” Izuku begs of him.

Katsuki doesn’t move.

Izuku asks again, “Kacchan, turn off the music, please!” He says as he looks at the ground, lips parted as he breathes harder, silent tears falling from his eyes, “Not everything is a movie. You can’t just make everything into a movie, Kacchan. There’s a time and place for everything. This…” He shakes his head as he squeezes his eyes closed to trap in the tears, but his cracking voice hides nothing, “This is real life. I’m a real person, with real feelings.”

Izuku opens his eyes, and looks over at the red, conflicted ones, “You can’t just do all of these romantic things, and then tell me it’s for fun. I’m a *real* person, Katsuki,” He looks down at his hands, “Your words and actions have consequences, and I’m suffering from your carelessness.”

Katsuki’s eyes widened. And then he looked down, trying to collect his words. But Izuku couldn’t be here any longer. He could barely breathe as it was. No, no. He had to go. And it felt like he’s been through this before, except that it hurts a little more every time. And he knows that he’s been through this before, because he keeps putting himself in situations that let him go through it *again* .

“I…” Izuku shakingly takes his things and doesn’t look Katsuki in the eyes, “I want to go.”

This made the blonde look back up, and in a slight panic, ask, “What? Go?”

“I want to go home, Kacchan,” Izuku says as he moves around and collects some of his things, all while crying silently, “I’m gonna go home.”

“Wait,” Katsuki rushes to turn off the music, and the atmosphere becomes tenser immediately with the only noise being the waves crashing, “I-I turned off the music. What else do you need me to do. *Fuck* , Deku, wait,” The blonde goes after him as Izuku enters the house, “I turned off the music. I’ll get rid of all the other things. Just stay,” His voice slowly gets more frantic.

Izuku wipes his face with the sleeve of his cotton shirt, and his chest shakes, as he enters the guest room and starts grabbing things off of the floor or the bed, shoving them into his bag without a care. Katsuki enters in from the doorway, going for Izuku's wrist, but the greenette moved fast and past him. Izuku didn't want to say a word, just in case he loses it altogether, and he can't do that. Not right now. He needed out of this house.

"Izuku," Katsuki trailed him. The house is deadly silent, aside from the franticness in Katsuki's voice.

The boy in question opens the back door and closes it. He runs out onto the driveway, lit up by a pale whitish green light illuminating the white cement path amidst the sand. He'll just walk until he gets picked up.

Pulling out his phone in a hurry, Izuku dials in a number that he still feels nervous calling, and the three rings that it takes for her to pick up felt like years.

"Mom?" Izuku cries into the phone, his voice completely unstable as he clutches the device tightly.

On the other side, Inko sounded surprised and then terrified, "I-Izuku? Izuku, is that you?" He felt disgusting, his chest heaved, and snot blocked his sinuses from working correctly. It was a messy cry, and it was only a matter of time before the hiccups come in.

"Mom?" Izuku breaks down, "It's me. I...I'm not feeling so well. Can you come pick me up?"

"Oh god, oh god," She begins to cry on the other side, "Are you alright? Are you hurt? What happened. Please, hurry and talk to me, 'Zuku!"

"I'm not hurt," Izuku reassured her, hands shaking, "I-I'm not hurt at all. Unless y-you count my heart breaking," Izuku laughs with absolutely no humor in his voice into the phone.

As if she finally understood, Inko's voice softened, "Oh, Izuku…"

Izuku just cries harder, "Please pick me up. I-I'll send you my location. Can you please come?"

"I'm coming, baby," Inko sounded heartbroken for him, and it was in times like these when Izuku realizes just how much he needed his mother to be in his life, "I'm coming. Just stay where you're at, okay?"

"No, I can't," Izuku shakes his head, "I can't, I can't. Not here."

"No, 'Zuku," Inko insisted, "You have to stay there. Don't go wanderin-"

"I'll see you, Mom. Please hurry," Izuku interrupts her, and then hangs up the phone, sending her his location before shoving it in his pocket.

From behind him, Katsuki had come out just a minute after, "Deku," He called out.

Izuku ignored the other, not because of any spiteful reason, but because he knew if he began talking, he wasn't sure he could stop. Not when he's been silent all of this time.

"Deku, I'm not going to stop until you tal-" He begins.

Too late.

Izuku whips around, eyes pink and cheeks puffy, as he tells Katsuki with a wavering tone, "You've been wanting me to go away all of these years, why make me stay now?"

Katsuki looked furious at this statement, and bites back quickly, "Yeah? And you've been staying near me all of this time, why leave now?"

Izuku shakes his head, smiling at the stupidity, as he cries, "That's hardly a fair comparison. I'm not *nearly* the same person I was, Kacchan."

"And neither am I," Katsuki argued, "You still think I want you to fucking leave? After all of this, you still think I don't give a shit about you? What the *fuck* , Deku."

"I know you do!" Izuku tells the other, as they stand five feet apart in the humid heat.

"Then what's the damn problem," Katsuki asks, voice loud, and the both of them would be getting a noise complaint if they weren't so far away from everyone and everything.

"The problem is that I can't do this anymore, Kacchan," Izuku cries to him, knowing that his vulnerability was not a weakness but at the moment, feeling like it definitely was, "This *friendship* is both fulfilling me and hurting me, and I don't know which one outweighs the other."

"How am I supposed to know?" Katsuki throws his hands up in the air, "I'm…I'm fucking sorry, okay? I'm sorry that I'm hurting you, but I don't even know what I'm doing."

Izuku opens his mouth to speak, but Katsuki, frustrated, continues ahead.

"You don't ever fucking tell me what you really want from me," Katsuki's brows furrowed as he stands barefoot in the driveway, "You don't ever *fucking* tell me what you really feel about the shit that I do that might hurt you. And I know this for a damn fact. How do I know?"

Katsuki points at him, and then runs a hand through his hair in frustration, "Because you get sad, and you get angry. Like the other fucking week. But you never tell me why. You just go along with whatever the fuck I say, and then now you want to leave while telling me that I'm hurting you?"

Izuku cries, knowing Katsuki was right. He knew, he knew, he knew, that Katsuki was right in that he never communicated. But it was hard. It was hard to look at someone who you don't have a committed relationship with, who you agreed to their terms of no-strings attached with, who isn't obliged to do anything for you, and tell them how you actually feel.

"So how am I supposed to know, Izuku?" He asks, "Am I supposed to just read your goddamn mind? Am I supposed to read between the fucking lines? That's hard for me okay?

*Fuck* . I can pick up on your unhappiness at being stuck home with your mother, that I can do. I can read the little things about you, like your tendencies towards friends or enemies. But I can't do all of it, okay? I can't fucking pick up on all of it, especially not your goddamn feelings. You call me unfair, and maybe I am. But do you think you're being very fair?" Katsuki sounded frustrated out of his mind, "Do you think you're fucking fair either, De-"

"You want me to even the playing field?" Izuku asked, stepping forward, "I'll tell you right now, and see how you handle it. You told me you wanted to see me angry, right?"
"Do it then," Katsuki tells him then, voice angry.

"I'm like this because I'm jealous," Izuku begins, tone also loud and upset, looking down as his shoulders shake, "I'm jealous of every person that I hear you go off with. And I always think to myself," He hates admitting, "If they can make you laugh more than I can. If you like the way they smile. If you prefer their soft hands when you're feeling my calloused ones. If you prefer how elegant they are when you see how much of a mess I am. And I can't tell you because what right do I have?" Izuku turns to the side, holding himself for a second, before continuing.

"What right do I have, Kacchan?" Izuku asks him, pain in his voice, "To feel this way?

"I'm like this because I'm angry," Izuku continues, barely even looking at Katsuki's reaction to all of this, "I'm angry at you and I'm angry at myself," He tries to compose himself but can't, "At you, because you're a damn hypocrite, Kacchan. You do things that make me feel like you want me, like you're jealous too, like you know how I feel. You do things like that, and it gives me hope and this sick pleasure because I'm starved for your touch and affection. And then, you go and do or say the opposite of everything I just mentioned. And it *hurts* ."

Katsuki doesn't speak.

"And I'm angry at myself because after all this time, I'm still complicit in my own unhappiness," Izuku breaks down, "You said you hated people like that, right?" And he laughs painfully to himself, "Well, I still haven't kicked the habit. I've cried over and over again, just to go back to you over and over again. What is wrong with me?"

Izuku spoke again, "I'm like this because I'm frustrated!" He tells Katsuki, "I'm frustrated because everything you do points to one answer, but everything you say points to the opposite. And I know it's not all your fault because you're not used to this, but I can't sit here and wait for you to figure out everything while I feel like I'm dying inside," He begs, "I can't sit here and let you take me to the most beautiful places I've ever been and tell me some of the kindest things I've ever heard, only for you to say that we are *just* friends. Only to say that you won't ever…"

His heart started to pound away at his chest, and he can't finish the sentence. No, no, he can't.

Izuku tries again, "Only to say that you can't…" But he tilts his head up towards the sky, hoping to keep the tears in.

“Only to say that I can’t what,” Katsuki asked, sounding so at odds with everything that he was hearing, his tone almost desperate.

Izuku laughs at the way Katsuki couldn’t even finish his sentence, even though it was so clear, and he wonders how he fell in love with someone so unlike him. While Izuku was so expressive and obvious with his love, Katsuki over here could barely understand what it was.

“How could you be so blind?” Izuku asks, laughing and finally looking at the blonde, who stands there with a slight sheen of sweat from the humidity, “Kacchan, how could you be so, so blind?”

“What is it that I’m supposed to see?” Katsuki asked him.

And then, like it was nothing, like it wasn’t something that plagued him for so long, like it wasn’t a fact that crushed his soul, Izuku just tells Katsuki. Just tells him right there, as the waves crash onto the sand and the crickets from the woods scream for him to stop, he just says it.

“That I’m in love with you, goddamnit,” Izuku tells him.

And then,

And *then* , when Izuku sees Katsuki’s expression, he cries.

Because it was exactly as he had expected. But it didn’t hurt any less. Those eyes, those ruby gems that he sees when he closes his own, looked at him differently just then. And it’s that difference in those eyes that felt like a stab wound straight through his chest, and Izuku’s puts his head down, as he stands there nearly limp, and just cries. He was so sick of this. He was so sick of crying, over and over again, and just wished the tears would go away again. He was tired. Izuku was tired.

Katsuki’s body had gone rigid. His eyes had switched from confused to this shocked understanding. It was as if in Katsuki’s head, the dots were all connecting together into a final pictures, but it was not the final picture he wanted to see. That’s what it looked like to Izuku, and that? He could not handle that.

But what he couldn’t handle more was what Katsuki tells him next.

“You don’t love me,” The blonde just states, voice void of emotion. He just stands there, still, and tells Izuku this as if he was so sure, as if there was nothing else to it.

Izuku, devastated, laughs through his tears, “I don’t?”

Katsuki looks to the ground, “You don’t love me, Izuku.”

“But…” Izuku’s words break again “But I do.”

The blonde shakes his head and tries to tell him once more, “No you don’t. You lo-”

“How are you going to tell me that, Kacchan?” Izuku cocks his head, face wet and eyes puffy, but he was more humored than even his hurt, “Who are you to tell me tha-”

Katsuki looks at him, gaze searching, as if he was trying to figure something out at the same time he was speaking, “Do you love me? Or do you love the experiences I showed to you?”

Izuku staggered back a little bit, “Huh?” And his eyes widened in hurt.

But the athlete pushes forward, moving a bit closer with uneasy legs that he tries to hide behind a steady voice, “Do you love me? Or do you love your life more now, and think that it’s connected to me?”
“Kacchan, don’t sa-”
“Do you love me, Izuku?” Katsuki asked, “Or do you think you do because I’m the first person to stick near you? Do you love me,” Katsuki stepped forward again, as if wanting Izuku to tell him he was right, “Or do you love that I’m the only one to show you what’s outside of the four walls that is your goddamn bedroom,” His voice seemed to crescendo with every question, and Izuku shakes his head while crying wanting Katsuki to stop, but he didn’t, “Do you love me, or was I just the one to take y-”

Izuku slaps him.

The green-eyed boy slaps Katsuki across the face, leaving an angry red mark, and the blonde’s head turned down and to the side, hair hiding his eyes. Katsuki doesn’t even bother to reach up and feel his own skin, but rather just stands there with the sting. Izuku’s hand pulsed, even though he wouldn’t say he hit the other particularly hard. Izuku knew that was wrong.

But he was upset. Beyond upset. He was hurt beyond imagination, at how cruel Katsuki’s words seemed to be. And it wouldn’t stop. It just wouldn’t stop.

And so now, they stand there in the aftersilence, replaying the slap that landed right across the face. Katsuki doesn’t move, and he doesn’t say anything. Not for a long time. So Izuku made it his turn. His chest rose and sank rapidly, heart pumping fast from the will that it took to do that.

“Don’t….don’t say that,” Izuku’s voice quieted, his chest shaking, “Don’t invalidate my feelings like that, Katsuki.”

The boy in question did not move an inch. Just listens.

Izuku looks up at Katsuki with his head tilted to the side, lips pulled tight as he tries not to let out sound, and his eyes brimming once more, “W-what’s wrong with you? How can you even say that,” He looks away again, as his shaking fingers fidget with itself.

“Yes,” Izuku nods in admittance, sniffling and looking up at the moon before turning his gaze back down, “Yes, that’s true. You were the first for many things, and for all of that, I love you for.”

The word still feels weird on his tongue, “You were the first to sneak me out. The first to break into an ice cream parlour with me, and the first to take me to a yellow field,” He paused, “You were the first to stand up to my mother, when everyone else has given up. And you were the first to show me how to truly live and how to fly,” Izuku smiles at the fond memory, “You were the first to tell me it’s okay to be angry and to be upset. For all of this, I love you.”
Katsuki turned his head down, to look at the cement ground, just as Izuku looks up at the boy he loved with stars and glass that threatened to shatter in his large green eyes.

“But it’s not just that,” Izuku tells him, and wanted so badly to reach out to make sure Katsuki was real, “I love your eyes, even if you don’t love mine,” That one hurt a lot more to say than he’d admit, “I...I love how you hate fireflies, because you think they catfished you.” He laughs to himself, “I love how you will fight someone over the last piece of cherry pie, even though it’s not that good.”

Katsuki meets his eyes only partially, slowly looking more and more surprised.

“I love the way,” He hiccups, “You ruffle my hair, or tuck me in bed when I fall asleep on the floor. I love the way the sun looks behind you when you vault, and I’ll tell you that a million times. I love the way you never give up when you don’t clear a bar, the way your hands look like they’d be really aggressive, but when I catch you in the right moments, your touches can be tender, even if you don’t want them to be.”

Izuku’s fingers were so close to reaching out for Katsuki’s hand, but he knew how that would turn out, so he keeps talking so that he doesn’t get to hear the part where Katsuki replies.

“I love you because you text my mother pictures of me to tell her I’m okay and take care of myself, without having ever told me a single thing about it,” Izuku reveals, and Katsuki looks up at him fully when the greenette lets it out that he knows.

“Kacchan, I love you because you missed practiced right before National qualifies just so that you can practice a sport you don’t even like because you wanted to play with me,” Izuku shakes his head, “I love you because you believe that I’m capable--of taking care of myself, of defending myself, of being more than what everyone wanted me to be. No one’s…” He stammers, “No one’s done that for me, before,” Izuku cries so quietly, that if you weren’t looking at him, then no one would have known.

“So tell me you love me too,” Izuku looked directly in Katsuki’s shocked eyes, hoping he’ll see something that would ease his heartache. Izuku staggers forward, “Tell me you love me too, because I can’t do this anymore.”

“Tell me you love me too, because,” Izuku feels so exhausted admitting this, “Everytime I realize that I love you, I’m reminded of how much you don’t. And I ask myself, is it supposed to hurt this bad? Is it supposed to feel like this?”

He almost pleads, “In the movies, they make it look so nice. I want it to be nice too. Why doesn’t it feel good, Kacchan?” He couldn’t keep his tone level, “W-Why doesn’t it feel as good as everyone says it does. So tell me you love me too,” His tragic attempt.
Katsuki steps backwards, and that movement alone burnt itself to the core of Izuku’s heart and he wipes away at his leaking eyes. The blonde seemed so unsure of every movement, as if he was almost scared of Izuku, scared of Izuku’s emotions.

And when he spoke, Izuku wished that he didn’t.

“I…” Katsuki began, his words sounding like they were hard to get out, “I can’t…”

“You can,” Izuku tells him, “You just don’t know how. B-But I can teach you,” He nods, almost pleadingly as he steps forward as a last attempt, “Don’t you want to love?”

Izuku’s eyes were wide and glassy, praying for something, anything, “Isn’t that…” He stammers, “Isn’t that why you listen to all of those songs? Because you...Because you want to love?”

Katsuki’s expression was so muddled, as if he was vexed by his own thoughts.

“Say something,” Izuku whispers, wishing his mother was here already, “Anything.”

Katsuk just doesn’t reply, and it feels as if he has been monologuing this entire time, while Katsuki gradually gets quieter and quieter. Finally,

“I don’t want you to leave,” Katsuki says the first thing that’s sounded anywhere near how emotional Izuku was in the past however long. He says it quickly, but still doesn’t look at Izuku.

And the boy in question just airily laughs, “Kacchan, you can’t have everything.”

“I know, but-” Katsuki lets out a bit of frustration for a second, before quieting down again, as if understanding how his unfairness. And it goes back to silence again, and he dreads it. It was an answer as good as any, and maybe this was the final drive for Izuku to do what he really needed to do for himself.

For another two or so minutes, it’s just silence as they stood there, soaking in the humidity, watching the bugs fly around the whitish-greenish lamp that hung over the driveway, listening to the various sounds of the area, waiting for one of them to say something. And of course, it’d be Izuku.

Izuku glances up at the stars. So beautiful. At least that was something good tonight, “Kacchan?”

After a couple of seconds, the taller makes a low sound in response, serving as acknowledgement.

“I’ve...” He stares at the expansive night sky, “I’ve always been on the sidelines. Then,” He paused, “You showed me what it was like to be on the track field.”

Finally, Izuku looks back down at Katsuki, “But, I can’t run after you forever.”

Izuku’s words, as literal as they can be interpreted, revealed another idea that he wanted to get across. If Katsuki were to look right underneath the surface, Izuku believes that the blonde would be smart enough to know that he meant those words in deeper ways than just literal.

Izuku’s ears pick up something, and he turns his head to look behind him. Further out, the greenette sees the lights of a car ride down a road, and he knew that it was likely his ride. There are barely any people who cross this way, so Izuku assumes it was almost his time to go. He hears it, the sound of tires on sand and cement getting closer, the whirring of an engine.

When he turns back to Katsuki, Izuku finds that the pole vaulter had not stopped looking at him at all, lips parted as if wanting to say something, but couldn’t. And so he closed it, looking down. Was this it, Izuku wondered. In all his minutes of talking, was Katsuki going to leave after starting so strong, then saying nothing else but a couple of broken strings of sentences at the very end? He waits for a little longer, hearing the car get closer.

And when it didn’t seem like he was going to get anything, with a heavy heart, the green eyed boy nods and turns around, “I’m going to…” He gestures softly, “...meet her at the end of the road.”

But right as Izuku begins walking, the taller immediately calls out, voice laced with a hint of fear, “Wait.”

And Izuku does. He waits, because of course he does. Turning his body halfway around, Izuku sees that there is something that is *just* about to slide off of Katsuki’s tongue, something the blonde clearly was thinking about saying. But as the car becomes closer in the distance, those words seem to get lost in Katsuki’s throat again. And he turns his head away.

Izuku was tired of trying to pick at Katsuki’s brain, forever tormented and subjected to guessing what the other was thinking. Because this was not like books, or movies, where the narrator could tell the audience everyone’s thoughts. This was real life, Izuku realizes, and he’ll only know what Katsuki is thinking if he asks. So he does.

“What are you thinking right now?” He asks softly, voice carried by the gentle breeze now moving in, “I feel like I’m always trying to guess.”

Katsuki moves the sand around a little under his feet, before looking up at Izuku. Guarded, closed. Square one. Katsuki doesn’t answer him, like he hasn’t this entire time. Of course he doesn’t. Of *course* , he doesn’t. Izuku finds it amusing. How nothing seemed to make sense with the other.

As he hears his mother’s car shine its light on the Hideaway house, Izuku wipes at his eyes one more time and steps forward, searching so badly for anything.

As final words, Midoriya Izuku connects what he was saying earlier about wanting to know Katsuki’s thoughts.

“You know how,” He sniffles with a fake plastered smile with watery ears. His voice was falsely cheerful, “in books, there’s sometimes different perspectives of the story?”

He wipes at his eyes quickly, and pretends to be happier than he was as he reaches his hand up to lightly touch Katsuki’s face one last time. Behind him, he knew that his mother was just a couple dozen feet away, and he needed to leave soon, so he hurried it up. His chest occasionally hiccuped. Katsuki only looks at him, trying to see where he was trying to go with this.

And then, Izuku laughs, the humor not making it to his eyes, and tells Katsuki then, “I just wish I could have known yours.”

Chapter End Notes

:)

Take a guess as to what’s next

Twt: suffocatingspr1

thank you so much for everything, guys. im serious. i know none of this is perfect, but hearing everyone's support, thoughts, and opinions makes me so happy

# Chapter 11: The Words He Left Unsaid

Chapter Notes

57.9k words (uhh )

spotify playlist : https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy
*this ch. lowkey relies on you guys having good memory, or else its kinda dumb sorry for this i suckasdfasdf*

anyways, remember the end of ch.10?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There has always been an unreachable space between them, Katsuki thought as he stood from the inside of the chain-linked fence, separating the track field and the sidewalk.

Izuku always made his home on the ground, surrounded by friends and family who believed in the boy's genuinity, while Katsuki made his place in the sky, too far for anyone to ever reach, the distance between them forever a constant.

There was absolutely nothing wrong with the sky, and Katsuki loved it: the feeling of soaring over everyone else, the wind in his hair, all of the sort. He didn't need anything else. He didn't need anyone else.

The first time Bakugo Katsuki noticed Izuku stopping by on his way home from school to watch him practice was when he was 11, and had only begun pole vaulting. It was only a couple of minutes, so it wasn't even worth the energy to yell at the kid. And so he never bothered to acknowledge a certain set of wide green eyes watching him. Before he had a stadium audience of hundreds, before he ever even had an audience of dozens, he's always had one consistent audience: Izuku.

Katsuki had expected for the shorter to get bored one of these days, especially on days where he'd repeat the same bar height over and over again. Days where he'd waste sweat preparing the same run, just to fail, and make no progress by the end of the day. And yet, like clockwork, Izuku comes back each day.

Everyone on the team was used to it by now. Midoriya Izuku, the resident fanboy of Bakugo Katsuki, but only from a distance. Most if not all of the vaulters knew the boy by now, and are even friends with him, and Katsuki would catch them throwing a wave over to the boy at practice.

In the beginning, he'd get a comment or two from the other athletes about it, wondering why the proclaimed sweetheart of Ise stopped by for just a couple minutes every day just to watch practice, especially when the known interactions between the two of them have been anything but friendly.

And each time, Katsuki's reply was merely a simple shrug.

Occasionally, someone would even ask if Katsuki would want them to go talk to Izuku, and tell the kid to stop doing it. To this, for some odd reason, the blonde's immediate reaction would be to shut down the suggestion, words leaving his lips before his thoughts could even catch up.

"I don't give a shit what the nerd does," Katsuki would immediately tell anyone who'd suggest it, "And if I did, you don't think I could talk to him my fucking self?"

The truth was, and it was a truth that Katsuki didn't fully understand himself, was that rarely did people watch the mundane parts of his pole vaulting. The parts where he repeats the same bar repeatedly until his arms feel like breaking off, the parts where he just does practice laps around the track to warm up.

Katsuki had learned over time that most people don't care about that. All they want to see are those shining moments, at the tournament, as he makes his official runs. And even then, they'd only want to see it if he clears the bar. Otherwise, Katsuki was just a trophy for the town. The pride and jewel of Ise. The star athlete.

To be polished behind the scenes, and then presented perfect and prettily during performances for the population to praise. Pathetic. It was all a pathetic show of circustry.

And so, even if it was Izuku of all people, it was interesting to see that someone doesn't mind watching the mundane parts of his sport. Not that Katsuki would ever admit anything of the sort.

Besides, it barely bothered him, because when he was high up in the sky, nothing else mattered. Not those creepy green eyes, that were too big and too expressive for Katsuki's comfort. Not the people of Ise, who love to call him the pride of their town, but really, his athletic performance is just about the only thing they're proud of.

Nothing could get to him here, in the sky where the clouds look even more white up close and the hawks soar alongside him rather than above him.

It didn't get lonely up here. Much better than being down *there* with the masses, he's convinced. He's also convinced that the primary reason why he doesn't care about Izuku's presence on the other side of the fence was because he was trying to see: just how long it will take for Izuku to be like everyone else. How long will it take for the other to walk past, without sparing a minute.

It's been a long time since the ritual-like act has been going on, and Katsuki is convinced that Izuku does it more out of habit than actual interest.

Katsuki was no longer the lanky kid he was starting out in the sport, barely able to make it past 8 feet on the bar, with lean but thin arms and only 5’2 feet of height on him. Not at all.

At 18, Katsuki was the living, breathing image of desire, and he knew it. 6 feet 4 inches, broad shoulders, toned torso, muscular legs, and sharp, red eyes. He didn’t need to pretend he wasn’t sculpted by pygmalion himself. Even if he tried to, the whole school would be there to tell him otherwise. He also didn’t need to pretend that he wasn’t arrogant as shit. Even if he tried to, the whole school would still be there to tell him otherwise.

Being who he was, over time, Katsuki notices that eyes will be drawn towards him. Whispers always fill up a room when he walks in, rumors floating around. Screams always fill up a stadium when he steps out. Eyes. Eyes. Eyes. Everywhere, always on him when he was out. Almond eyes. Round eyes. Pink eyes.

And right now? Green eyes.

Well, not exactly. Today, Katsuki finished up his practice run, with a bit of spare time to kill while his teammates did theirs. Usually, Katsuki doesn’t bother acknowledging Izuku’s presence, not even once. In fact, in all of these years that he’s been pole vaulting, although he knew Izuku was watching, the blonde never looked his way once, unless it was a passing glance.

But today, Katsuki, as he was downing the last drop of his water bottle, curses and crumples the plastic in his hands.

Practice had barely started, and he had run out of water, which was his own damn fault, but he’s pissed off nonetheless. Standing up, he jogged over to the trash can, set off to the side of the track field, to throw the crumpled plastic away, when for the first time, he actually took the time to notice Izuku’s presence. It was barely intentional. The boy just happened to be somewhat adjacent to the trash can, body turned somewhat away as if he was just walking and decided to look to the side, but his feet were paused in their tracks as they usually were.

But his eyes, instead of meticulously watching every move as if he was analyzing Katsuki’s performance as they usually do, seemed to be lost in thought, staring blankly into space, hands clutching both straps of his backpack. Whatever the shorter boy seemed to be thinking about, it was making him frown, which was a bit of a rare sight to see on Izuku’s face. Of course it would be, Katsuki thought to himself, that the only time the boy frowns is when he was too lost in thought to notice his usual plastered smile was gone. Katsuki wonders for just a second there, as to what Izuku was thinking about.

Katsuki’s legs moved without his permission, suddenly feeling the urge to bother the other. As he approaches, feet shuffling across the grass, it was only now that Katsuki takes the time to really look at Izuku. When they were in class, or walked by each other, or anything of the sort, the last thing on the blonde’s mind was what the nerd looked like.

But as he walked towards Izuku now, Katsuki lets out an amused sneer. My *god* , the nerd was short. Katsuki knew he was taller than the average male, but that was only reaffirmed when he stood in front of Izuku from the other side of the chain-linked fence. There had to be

about one foot of difference between the two of them, with Izuku coming up right at his shoulder.

Over the years, it wasn't just Katsuki that changed, but Izuku had too. The blonde wasn't deaf. He heard the talk, the gossip.

Whispers floating around or comments made here and there about how Izuku's quite attractive. Some call him handsome. Others call him pretty. It wasn't uncommon to hear the boys in the locker room 'talk' or the girls in class tell each other their thoughts on people. Yuka has nice hair. Tanaka has shitty taste in t-shirts. And then Midoriya Izuku. Midoriya Izuku had grown up well, Katsuki would hear from others.

And it was only now that Katsuki observes. The head of green hair was still unruly, as if it hadn't been brushed in days. Izuku was also no longer the lanky, easily-breakable kid that Katsuki used to harass to death. The green-eyed boy, although still small, was clearly toned, as if he worked out regularly, with strong thick legs and small calloused hands. Freckles dotted his puffy cheeks, long lashes framed those large eyes. He wasn't ugly.

So this was Midoriya Izuku these days, huh, Katsuki thought, Ise's sweetheart and goody two-shoes.

Izuku was the reliable guy: the one with a smile always shining on his face, lots of joy and enthusiasm, the safe one. Katsuki thought that was all bullshit. All fucking bullshit.

If it's one thing the blonde was good at, it was detecting anger. And Midoriya Izuku was filled to the brim with it, all sorts of suppressed anger and whatever bullshit was going on under that 24/7 smile. It was all in those eyes that Katsuki couldn't stand. He can see everything in those eyes. No matter what anyone tries to tell him, he can see that--once in a while--when someone says something that definitely bothered the greenette, those eyes would flicker with hurt or irritation for just a split second before being covered up by that smile. The best part was that the nerd thought it was undetectable, but not to Katsuki. No. Katsuki saw everything, and it made him all the more annoyed.

To rid himself of the thought, Katsuki got closer until he blocked the sun from Izuku's angle, and placed both hands on the chain-linked fence, rattling it from the other side.

Immediately, he saw the shorter male step back and get shaken up slightly from the surprise and shock. He jumped at the rattling sound, and Katsuki put on a bothersome look.

"Oi, nerd," Katsuki snapped to get Izuku's attention. He wasn't exactly sure what he wanted to say, if anything at all.

Izuku blinked up at him, as if surprised that Katsuki had paused his practice, and Katsuki watched as the boy stood up straighter and stared up at him with wide eyes. Katsuki enjoyed the fact that Izuku had to tilt his head up so high to look at him.

"Kacchan," Izuku said, and Katsuki was observant enough to tell that the other had to muster up courage to be able to say his name so clearly.

Katsuki raised a brow, grinning as he cocked his head to the side, “How long are you gonna stalk me for?”

He knew watching for a few minutes every day on the boy’s walk home wasn’t stalking, but still, it was hilarious to see Izuku’s face begin to flush.

“I wasn’t…” The greenette frowned, face getting more and more red. Red was Katsuki’s favorite color, and so in turn, the blonde decides that if he doesn’t like anything else about the nerd, then he’ll like the way Izuku blushed so damn easily. This was fun.

“Oh? You weren’t?” He asked, “So you just stop right here a couple minutes on your way home every day just to, what, fucking bird watch?”

This was interesting. Katsuki couldn’t say he’s ever gone out of his way to have a semi-normal conversation with the boy, at least not in a long, *long* time. Not that this could even be a semi-normal conversation. As their little banter from across the fences continued, it was still clearly aggressive, but there was no real animosity. Just some baseless conversation.

“...get your ass home before your mom fucking goes beserk on you, goodie-two shoes,” Katsuki says at some point, and this immediately causes a wide-eyed reaction from Izuku, as the boy frowns.

Katsuki had always had mixed feelings about Inko Midoriya. He met the woman for the first time when he was young, and Mitsuki had insisted that Inko didn’t bring Izuku along for the first few times, because in his mother’s words, Katsuki was born with some nasty tendencies and was prone to hurting others. And so, for the first couple of times Katsuki had met Inko, she had been a nervous wreck.

Sitting there on the kitchen stools of the Bakugo Family home, trying to enjoy her time with Mitsuki, but her legs were bouncing, as if she was nervous. Katsuki could see that she was checking her phone every couple of minutes, calling what sounded like the babysitter to ask about the child. Her wide eyes always seemed a little nervous, and although she was sweet, had a bit of a shrill personality. Inko was sweet alright. It was practically all she was. There was only kind, buttery things to come out of that woman’s lips, and Katsuki, even as a kid, found it conflictingly annoying.

And when Mitsuki decided that it was finally okay for Katsuki and Izuku to meet, the very first time they met on that playground, Inko had the boy strapped to her hip, finally looking as if she had some peace of mind, only because she had her son in her arms. Katsuki didn’t think much of it at the time.

But all of the little actions add up over time. The check-ins every couple of minutes. The nervous look everytime it seemed like Izuku was going to do anything remotely risky. Looking like it was the end of the world if Izuku tripped and scraped his knee.

It was obvious that the woman was suffocating. As of current, Izuku was 18, and as far as Katsuki has heard from their mutual friends, the nerd was practically never allowed to go anywhere or do anything. Which only told the blonde that whatever dynamic Inko and Izuku had going on all those years ago, was still persisting today. Besides, the hag often mentions it

here and there, when Katsuki was only half paying attention. There were far more interesting things he'd rather hear about than Midoriya Izuku's babied lifestyle.

"R-right," Izuku says, before looking away, and began to walk towards the direction of his home. And Katsuki, having nothing else to say, starts to walk back to the track field himself.

And yet, when he was merely a couple of feet away, the blonde stopped. He eyed the trashcan once more, where the crumpled plastic water bottle lay on top of the heap of trash somebody forgot to take out. God, he was still thirsty.

And then, he turns around, calling out one more time to the boy who was slowly walking away with his eyes trained on the golden sky, "Deku!"

Izuku paused, turned around with the sound of hesitation in his voice as if he was expecting a fight, "Yes?"

"If you're gonna come be a stalker," Katsuki yelled, "Then at least make yourself useful, and get me a damn gatorade."

Izuku opened his mouth to yell back.

But he didn't care about the rest.

In fact, Katsuki couldn't say that he cared much about the trajectory of his relationship to Midoriya Izuku until the goddamn psychology teacher, Mr. Toshinori, decided to pair the two of them up for the school project. But suddenly, it looked like they were going to be acquainted with each for a good fucking while.

"Kacchan," Izuku had stepped into the conversation when Katsuki was going to continue his argument with Mr. Toshinori to reject the proposal, green eyes meeting his own, "If you just do this with me, I'll get out of your sight for the rest of the year."

Now *that* was one hell of a fucking offer, Katsuki thought to himself. If nothing else, it was one hell of a weird one. In all of the time that Katsuki had known Izuku, the greenette has never actively tried to rid himself of Katsuki's existence, as much as the blonde would've liked for him to. In small ways, Izuku had always made his presence known, whether it was from the other side of the fence during practice, or attempting miserably to annoy Katsuki with some conversation when they had to sit near each other, the smaller was persistently there.

And so, the sudden proposal that they complete this project, do it well, and then the nerd will simply fuck off for the rest of the school year came as a slight surprise. To be completely honest, Katsuki was more intrigued than anything. Now that he thinks about it, Katsuki couldn't remember a time before Izuku. Whether or not he liked it, the boy had always been there, in one way or another. From friends, to enemies, to the weird dynamic they had now that was more like a mix between rivals and strangers.

Either way, Katsuki wonders what it would be like, to live an Izuku-free life. The offer is tempting, and Katsuki thinks about it.

It's a semester right? Not much could happen in a semester. They'd...what...hang out for an hour once a week? That was tolerable. Anymore and the blonde might have a problem, but an hour was doable. It would likely be an awkward hour every week, that would feel like five hours, but Katsuki could do it. In the grand scheme of things, an hour a week was not time to atll. In exchange of Izuku not shoving his face in the blonde's life for the rest of the year and likely the rest of their lives? That wasn't too shabby a deal.

"Will you now?" Katsuki asked, raising a brow.

It looked as if all the confidence in the proposition Izuku had before had disappeared, as the green-eyed boy bit his lip and thought to himself for a split second before looking away. Katsuki watches this reaction, and finds it funny that the boy had gone from full confidence to this unsure state.

Katsuki, however, was sure. He'll do this project. And he'll do it well, because that was just who he fucking was. If he was going to force himself through an awkward hour with Midoriya Izuku every week, then he might as well get a good grade for it. All that was left now was the confirmation from the greenette.

Which came just a moment later, with just enough time for Katsuki to call it hesitation.

"Yes."

But they don't talk about it. Not at all, until the next day. And not even during the school day, but well after, when Katsuki was solo practicing on Thursdays. It wasn't as if the blonde was going to ignore the project forever, evidently by his self-promise that he was going to get a good fucking grade if he had to do this every week. But he hadn't necessarily been expecting Izuku to be the one to confront him with all of the demands, like ' *at least try being civil with me* ." Seriously, what the fuck does civil even mean anyways.

They were standing again on the opposite sides of the fence. Izuku was always on the outside where the yellowish sidewalk was, in need of a repaint. While Katsuki stood on the inside, practicing day in and day out. Having a conversation about project rules, which Katsuki only partially noted in his head.

"Well, what the fuck do you consider small things," Katsuki questioned Izuku, when the shorter demanded for him to stop arguing with him over the 'small things.' He stood with his foot slightly tapping the grass.

"I don't know, like" Izuku seemed to struggle to come up with an example on the top of his head, "like that time where you yelled at me for looking your way once in class."

Katsuki doesn't remember that, but fine. He doesn't doubt it happened, and if it did, then he could probably pinpoint the reason why.

"Your big ass eyes are creepy," Katsuki reasoned. And they were. He wasn't just saying that to be an asshole. Katsuki hated how those big eyes were always so damn expressive. He truly did.

Their conversation was definitely still full of banter. Katsuki is convinced that no matter what Izuku demands, that will never stop. He couldn't help it. Izuku was so fucking easy to rile up. They go back and forth for what seemed like forever, yet it didn't feel as hostile as it usually did. This was likely because Katsuki was still in his pole-vaulting mode, and that was one of the few times when people would see he was more tolerable as a human being than other times. What Katsuki doesn't expect is for Izuku to get a little attitude back. It was a pleasant surprise. And here he was, thinking that the nerd would only let himself reply kindly to all situations.

"You're just as much of a nerd," Izuku mumbled under his breath.

"The fuck did you just say to me?" Katsuki leaned down through the fence to Izuku's eye level. He was amused, to say the least. So the sweetheart of this little town can be a little mean, after all.

"I said," Izuku stood up confidently, which only made Katsuki more humored as he watches the 5'4 boy puff his chest out, "You're just as much of a nerd, and I don't take it back. Because we have a fence between us and you can't get to me."

Katsuki gave him a sneer. He had always taken challenges head on, for the most part. A fence was nothing, "And I'm a god at pole vault. Jumping over things is my specialty." Katsuki said before both hands were on the fence, and in a swift move, he pushed himself up and over the fence. It was nothing for him to do this, and he was on the other side of the fence in mere seconds.

The moment he hoists himself over, Katsuki sees the look of terror in Izuku's eyes, as the boy backs away and begins running. Katsuki decides something then. They'll start the project today. Right then, right there. Because of two reasons. The first being that as annoying as he was, Izuku was a bit more interesting than he originally thought. And the second reasoning being that he just wanted to get the damn hour done with, so he didn't have to worry about it.

And so, Katsuki begins to break out into a run after the greenette, who looked a little panicked. His footsteps got closer. His longer legs gave him the upper hand, so he caught up quickly.

"Don't kill me! They'll know it was you! You don't want that for your future, do you? Everyone will know it was you!" Izuku yelled out, and Katsuki only rolled his eyes.

Reaching down into a tackle position, Katsuki easily reached around to pick up Izuku and throw him on the opposite shoulder, with his backpack still dangling on. One of his arms were right above the back of Izuku's knees, while his other hand was on Izuku's thighs for stabilization. And for a split second there, the blonde allowed himself to be slightly surprised

by how thick these thighs felt in his hands, but that thought left as quickly as it came. And Katsuki was walking towards the gate that led into the track field. He trudged quickly, feeling Izuku squirm and struggle in his hold, hands tugging at his jersey.

Katsuki opened the gate to enter inside of the field that he was so used to. Izuku has likely never been inside of this gate before, having no reason to. The blonde continues walking, towards where there was a small bench where the pole vaulters usually set their drinks and backpack on.

But instead, Katsuki set Izuku down here, watching for a second as the greenette figures out where he was at and looks around with wide eyes. The inside of the field probably looked quite different from what Izuku could see from behind the fence. Out here, the bar looks formidable, and the track field looks wide and endless. He knew it, because this has been his playing field for years now.

“Why am I here?” The boy asked, eyes scanning the surroundings.

Katsuki ran a hand through his blonde hair and dropped into a lunge position to stretch out his calves, “To get our 1 hour in for the week.”

“For the project?” Izuku asked him then, “Here?”

“Yes, the project. What the fuck else,” Katsuki replies, rolling his eyes. God, the nerd was annoying, “And yep. Mr. Toshinori said to take you to see what I like to do, right? This,” He gestured to the complex in front of him, “This is what I like to do.”

And then Katsuki picks up his pole, and stares up at the bar. It was set at 17’5 feet, which he usually used for warm ups these days. It was strange to have the eyes that always watched him from a distance up close, just a couple of feet away, eyes that were already lit up like that, even though he hadn’t even jumped yet. Here, it was impossible to ignore Izuku’s presence.

There has always been a distance between them, one that has been carefully maintained throughout the years, with Katsuki in the sky and Izuku on the ground. But today, if only for today, that distance becomes one fence closer.

“Besides,” Katsuki finds himself turning partially to the side to look down at Izuku, seeing the shadow of his own body block the sun out of the boy’s eyes, and his lips felt compelled to speak words that held a double entendre that he didn’t even intend for it to have, “Aren’t you tired of watching from the sidelines?”

When Izuku practically invited himself to tag along when Katsuki planned to get dinner, the blonde takes note of something:

Izuku smells like lilies. The only reason he knew what lilies smelled like was because Inko had gifted his mother with one from her garden, and the subtly sweet scent of oriental lilies

sitting on the dining table lingered in his nose for days. When they died, Katsuki considered making his mom ask Inko for more.

His car had the smell of leather and cherry air freshener, but even over that, Katsuki's nose picked up the scent of floral fragrance coming from the boy. He hadn't wanted Izuku to come along, and thought he had made that pretty obvious. But when the mop of green hair began to trip everywhere and be a bit of a nuisance, he gave in. It wasn't worth the energy to shoo the boy away.

He should have. Because the car ride was fucking awkward. Katsuki was himself. Chilled out, driving with one hand on the wheel, looking bored. But from the passenger seat, he could tell the nerd was nervous, judging from the way he was sitting rigidly and the slight bounce of the knee as he hums along to Every Breath You Take by the Police.

"I wouldn't expect this to be your choice of music," Izuku laughs nervously at one point.

Katsuki just briefly glances over, then asks, "What'd you expect then, nerd."

The boy in the passenger seat looks down at his lap with a funny smile, "Heavy metal, or something like that."

Katsuki shrugs, "80s music is way better."

Izuku nods to himself, before questioning, "Why 80s music?"

To this, Katsuki simply continues driving through the warm-toned Ise streets and brushes it off, "Dunno."

And the conversation dies there. And the awkward silence settles back again.

The fact of the matter is that Bakugo Katsuki is convinced that he discovered 80s love songs when he was in the womb. It was easier than recognizing that at some point in his childhood, the buttery voices of Phil Collins and Madonna were all that he really had.

"The brat's a walking threat," Mitsuki had stood at the door frame with his grandfather, as she talked about Katsuki as if he wasn't there. But he had been there all right, sitting on the ground of the room he had as a kid, in time-out for pushing someone over, "No matter what I do, he just won't play nice."

"He's just a kid," His grandfather chuckles, "Kids are mean."

Mitsuki rubs her temples, "I know, but- Katsuki isn't like other kids. He's always angry. No matter what I tell him, it's like he won't listen."
Katsuki remembered his grandfather laughing fondly, "He gets it from you."

Mitsuki rolls her eyes and walks into the room, bending down to play with Katsuki's hair, "I wasn't even that bad. You'd think he'd get some softness from Maseru."

"Well, you're quite the dominant woman, Mitsuki," The older man reasons, as he steps away from the doorframe.

“So you’re telling me that all this is genetic?” Mitsuki looks at Katsuki’s frowning face, “He won’t grow out of this?”

“You did, didn’t you?” The elderly man reasons, “When you fell in love, remember?”

Mitsuki laughs and then softly pinches Katsuki’s cheeks, “Someone is gonna fall in love with this brat?” She jokes, “Katsuki, tell momma and grandpa. Do you think you can sweep someone off their feet?”

Katsuki stands up then, and proudly exclaims, “Yes!”

And Mitsuki laughs adoringly, and warns the boy, waving a finger in a *no* formation, “Not if all you do is hurt people, Katsuki. You can’t love someone if you’re like this.”

Katsuki remembered himself suddenly feeling spiteful. If the idea of love wasn’t meant for people like him, then he doesn’t need it anyways.

Frowning, Katsuki shakes his head, “Love sounds stupid then,” He decides then and there, not even sure of what love meant, “I don’t wanna.”

“Sure you do, boy,” His grandfather stands up and goes over to some cardboard boxes sitting in the corner of the room, and pulls out something. A vinyl.

Walking over to where the now defensive Katsuki stands, his grandfather gets down on one knee until he was eye-level with the small blonde, and hands Katsuki the vinyl, “Listen to these. 80s hits, especially this one,” His grandfather tried to read upside down on the vinyl cover before pointing out a song, “Lady in Red. By Chris de Burgh.”

“Ch-Chris de Burgh,” smaller Katsuki tried to repeat the name.

“That’s right,” His grandfather laughed and stood up, “These will teach ya how to sweep someone off their feet. Guaranteed. That’s how I did it.”

Mitsuki groaned playfully, “I grew up listening to your stuff, and now I gotta raise a brat who listens to it too?”

Katsuki now feels like listening to it just knowing his mother doesn’t like it. Grinning menacingly, he runs to the vinyl player over in the other room, ignoring the fact that he was on time out.

And ever since then, synthetic drums, drone chords, and sounds that came from a bygone era had just stuck to him, and he had never shaken it off. Sure, listening to upbeat Madonna songs as an 18 year old boy with the reputation of a tiger doesn’t exactly fit his image, but it only added to the list of oddities that shrouded the enigma that is Bakugo Katsuki. It just kind of stuck with him. He likes cruising up to school with some 80s track on his car stereo, windows down, and he steps out with a sucker in the corner of his mouth like a character from Grease, the movie.

And so, as they pulled up to the diner, with Katsuki lost in thought and Izuku awkwardly rubbing his arms in the passenger seat, his trip down memory lane was interrupted when Hana exclaimed his name.

“Katsuki!” The older woman with a blue dove printed apron tied around her waist calls out, and ushers the two of them to a table.

The next couple of parts from their conversation passes by in an uncomfortable blur. It was mostly Izuku and Hana introducing themselves, and the mentions of Niko. He was supposed to take the kid on a ride, but hasn’t come around to the diner in a while. As he sits across the booth, Katsuki doesn’t like the casualty in which Hana describes him, like he was better than he was. He wasn’t some sweet kid, like what Hana was portraying to Izuku, and Katsuki knew the greenette must have been thinking that everything the older woman was saying is some kind of lie.

“...Katsuki’s been coming here since he was a little boy, and has always been so generous with helping us o-”

“Hana,” Katsuki interrupted with a slight sternness to his tone, as he looked away.

In the moment of silence that followed, after Hana left their table, Katsuki could tell that Izuku was thinking of something. That boy was always fucking thinking of something.

Before Izuku piped up again, “Who’s Niko?”

Katsuki looked at him, finding nothing but curiosity in those eyes. It calmed him a little, and was glad that at the least the boy hadn’t pushed why he had been so stern with Hana.

He groans, relaxing in his seat, as his hands run down his face, “Hana’s grandson. The kid’s a total brat. Thinks I’m a celebrity or something.”

Izuku laughs, “You kind of are.”

Katsuki decides to be sarcastic, “You want an autograph?”

Izuku nodded and was quick to answer, “Yes, please. And then I can sell it in a few years when you’re in the Olympics and get myself some easy money.”

Katsuki was tempted to crack a small grin. So the nerd can make jokes, huh, “You’d sell my precious autograph, for some couple hundred bucks?”

“Please,” Izuku stuck out his tongue, and Katsuki’s eyes darted to it for a mere second, “You’d probably sell my liver for a gas station lollipop.”

It was a little uncanny and even a bit uncomfortable to Katsuki how seamless this conversation was going, even if it was laced with their usual banter. Katsuki didn’t like it. The ease at which they were bouncing back and forth with each other. If it was as despicably awkward as it had been in the car ride over here, then Katsuki would probably be more comfortable. But the natural atmosphere while Izuku talks to him was not what he had been

expecting. Not from the shy seeming greenette that doesn't leave his house and never speaks his mind.

Katsuki ends up leaving that conversation with an even greater disdain for mint chocolate chip ice cream, when he should be leaving with a greater disdain for Izuku.

"Oi, where the fuck do you think you're going," Katsuki called, after they exited the diner and he watches Izuku mindlessly begin walking towards the sidewalk adjacent to the parking lot.

The blonde looks down at his watch, one arm resting on the hood of his car. The sun had already set, and although Ise was a pretty safe place to live, it wasn't Izuku taking care of himself that Katsuki considered. It was the fact that Inko fucking Midoriya will likely have his head if she saw that her son had gone home by himself at night.

The shorter male called back to him, "I need to get home! It's about a twenty-minute walk, so I need to get going."

Katsuki looked at him as if he was crazy. He knew he wasn't very affectionate in any way, shape, or form, but did Izuku think that he was cruel enough to just leave the boy on the side of the road when he had a perfectly working car? It took no energy to drop him off on his way to his own house.

"Are you fucking dumb?" He called out, "I have a damn car right here."

Katsuki sees Izuku blink, as if he hadn't even considered that he would offer the boy a ride. But Izuku seemed glad, as they drove home, that he offered, Katsuki assumed, because on the ride back, there was a small smile on the green eyed boy's face. Katsuki couldn't come up with any other reason that would have him smiling like that. He was a lot more talkative on the way home, and Katsuki just wished Izuku would shut up a little. Because if he did, then Katsuki could easily go home and continue to call Izuku boring and fucking annoying. And yet, even as he wished this, the blonde still replied.

Inko Midoriya is already on the porch when they pull up, and Katsuki had a bad feeling about what was to come. Just judging from the way the woman was pacing the porch with a distressed expression on her face and muttering to herself--a habit similar to Izuku's--Katsuki had a feeling that the conversation that will ensue won't be that pretty.

The moment the boy opened the door to get out, the green haired woman's head whipped around and she began to walk briskly down the porch. Katsuki watches from the car, with his windows down.

"Izuku!" She called out. Katsuki hadn't seen her in a while, even though Inko comes over from time to time. When she was over, the blonde is either not home, or purposely chooses to stay in his bedroom. And so, seeing the short woman now, Katsuki isn't surprised to see that her overprotective nature hadn't died down with age, but seemed to heighten. Midoriya Izuku was fucking 18 years old, for Christ's sake.

“Mom, I texted you that I was going to be late ea-” Katsuki heard Izuku say as he met his mother halfway on the walkway.

Katsuki watches as Inko cupped Izuku’s cheeks and looks at him as if he was a ghost come back to life, “But didn’t tell me where you were, how long you were going to go out, or who you were with! Did you know how worried I was? What if you lost your way? Or if something happened to you?”

As the blonde listens, the more appalled he feels. This was none of his damn business, but even he felt a heavy irritation brewing in his gut, watching the woman talk to Izuku as if he was 2 years old. As much as he disliked Izuku, he disliked people like Inko even more. The hag was just about the opposite, with a very ‘do it yourself’ approach to parenting since he was a little kid, and he was grateful for that.

Katsuki’s eyes move to Izuku’s, and this was the particularly interesting part. There was no way that the greenette wasn’t annoyed. There was no way in hell, and for a second, Katsuki sees that annoyance evident in the way Izuku stands. With his fingers curling in on itself just slightly, and the little look to the side with the tiniest huff. And then, like it never happened, the shorter boy replaces it with a very careful and calm voice. A reassuring smile on his face.

So he hasn’t changed, Katsuki thinks to himself, as he watches Izuku force his feelings away in favor of his mother’s peace of mind. The little bubble of irritation ignites in his chest, before he reminds himself that he doesn’t care. It wasn’t his damn business.

“Mom,” Izuku then says with that very kind and calm tone, “Nothing happened to me. I was with Kacchan. I watched his practice, and we went out to eat at a diner.”

“Katsuki?” Inko then asked, curious, “You went out with Katsuki?”

Inko then looked a couple of feet away, and Katsuki averted his eyes to his phone, pretending that he was scrolling through it, even though he had been taking note of what was happening the entire time. Honestly, he could have driven off the moment Izuku left the car, but for some reason, he just didn’t.

Katsuki pretends to look up as if he just noticed them, and nodded to Inko.

“Y-yes. He’s my partner for my psychology project,” Izuku then says, looking down at the ground.

“Oh…” Katsuki wasn’t looking, but he heard the shift in her tone, as if she was more relaxed now, “I guess...if it’s Katsuki, then it’s okay.”

*Huh* , Katsuki thinks to himself. As long as it is him, then it’s okay? Was she joking? Or was Inko just that biased with Mitsuki that she thinks he’d be a good influence on the nerd? Had the woman not heard anything about him? Katsuki wanted to laugh to himself, but instead, just pondered in amusement.

Like he had discovered previously, Katsuki was the town’s ‘pride and joy.’ But the only thing they were actually proud of was his athletic accomplishments. They weren’t proud of his

attitude, the nonchalant, harsh way of speaking. They weren't proud of his leisurely activities. They weren't proud of anything about him other than what he can do on the track. Not that he cared. He could give less of a shit if they were proud of him or not. It's just what it was.

And so, with that in mind, Katsuki truly wonders if Inko hears nothing about him, to so easily say that *it's okay* if it was him. He had been so amused by the thought that when the women approached his window, it caught him a bit off guard.

"Katsuki! It's been so long. I barely see you when I come over to Mitsuki's. Look at you, all grown and handsome. In our household, we always keep track of your accomplishments, you know. Especially Izuku over here," Inko says with a kind of lightness in her tone, as if she realized how awkward it was to scold her son in front of someone.

Katsuki decides to ignore that last part, seeing how Izuku, from a distance, began to blush. It wasn't for Izuku's sake, but really for his own, so he doesn't have to address the details. What was he even supposed to say to that.

And so, instead, Katsuki just nods, "I'm usually busy, sorry Auntie."

And then, Inko reaches her hand in and pushed in his cheeks, which he was absolutely appalled at. He was a grown man, and could probably punt her across the yard. And yet, he was sitting in his car, getting his cheeks poked at by Inko Midoriya. From the side, Katsuki sees Izuku grinning a little bit, and *god* , Katsuki was going to give him hell for this.

They exchange a couple more words with each other, all baseless small talk, before Katsuki makes up some excuse that he had to get back home and do homework. Inko backs off then, and he puts his car out of park. Right before he leaves though, he looks up and catches Izuku's eyes.

And Katsuki just gives him an odd look. It was obvious that the boy didn't appreciate how suffocating his mother was, and yet, he was doing nothing about it. Still, from their interactions today, it seemed like Izuku was hungry. From the desire to stay out a little more, to tag along, even if he was hesitant, Katsuki could pick up that Izuku was hungry for something he didn't even know he wanted.

And so, as they made eye contact for the mere second that Katsuki was pulling his car out of park, the blonde just thought to himself: something told him that the nerd just needed a goddamn opportunity.

Feeling a combination of annoyance at Inko, spite at Izuku's unwillingness, and a bit of obligation that stems from that fact that he'll have to spend *some* time with the boy because of the project anyways, Katsuki decides then: he'll fuck up Izuku's life. He'll give the boy that goddamn opportunity.

The opportunity didn't actually come until the following Friday. It wasn't like Katsuki couldn't have made the time. The season was just beginning, and there was nothing particularly high at stakes yet, so if he truly wanted to, he could have allocated some of the

time he spent practicing. But if he was being completely honest with himself, he just didn't feel like it. There were better things he could do with his time.

On Tuesday, he practiced *after* official practice. He knew there was months before his jumps actually mattered for him to proceed to nationals, but it didn't hurt to practice now. Three months ago, his coach began to bitch to him about the other guy he'll be up against in Nationals. God, he couldn't stand Coach Shugo. The man was in his 50s, with no wife and kids, and a balding scalp. Which would be none of his fucking business, if the bastard didn't complain about not having a wife or kids every thirty minutes.

Katsuki had been tempted to tell the man numerous times now that it's likely because he's obsessed with work and drinking moonshine on the weekends until his clothes stink of it even after a wash, but he doesn't because whether he likes it or not, the man had helped him gain a couple of inches on the bar.

For the most part, Katsuki was self-taught. Who else was there in the town of Ise that could coach him. He didn't have the advantages that the bigger city gave. He sure wasn't underprivileged, but he was by no means rich enough to afford a world class coach. There's been plenty that offered to sponsor him, pay for him to move out to Tokyo and train with the 'big leagues' as long as they get a 30% cut of his ad deals 5 years down the road. But he wasn't for that shit. Katsuki hated those people.

The sleezy sports marketers with their crisp Armani suits and rehearsed way of speaking, offering him the opportunity to 'take it to the next level with the real players.' Real players. What the fuck does that even mean. Katsuki remembered reeling at those words in the conference chair. Was he not a real player? Did his official record, higher than any of their contractors, not impress them enough? God, fucking pricks. All of them.

They offer sweet deals with convincing grins on their lips, but their eyes look at him, and his small town upbringing, and rugged, rascal like attitude, and Katsuki knew they'd make him into one of *them* . Stuffy suited-up men, with an affinity for sketchy deals made in bachelor pad dinner parties and a depressing need for drugs to make them go to sleep after a long day of sucking in clients too naive to see that these assholes will drop them the moment they break a contract rule. Katsuki wasn't going to fucking fall for that.

No, he's going to stay in Ise. He's going to stay in Ise, train better, harder, faster than all of their clientele, even with their exclusive gyms, their notoriety, their coaches. He's going to be better than all of them, even the guy with the 18'2 record, and it's going to be all him. No fancy coach. No fancy gym. None of that shit.

If he had to stick with Coach Shugo, that was fine with him. Even if he did complain like hell. On Tuesday, after that practice, the man had put him in such a bad mood that Katsuki had no desire in the slightest to do anything relatively social, much less hang out with Midoriya fucking Izuku of all people. And so he just practiced until his mother called him in for dinner.

"So Inko told us you're partnered up with Izuku for your psychology project? That's great!" Maseru commented while forking his tenderloin during dinner, "You haven't spent time with him in a while, right?"

Bakugo Masaru was a timid man. Timid and nice. It was odd enough to the point where Katsuki used to wonder if his mom had him by cheating on his dad. He wore these square rimmed glasses and spoke with a relatively soft voice and lots of hand gestures. After 18 years, it still felt like when his dad talked to him, he was waiting for Katsuki to fucking blow up or something.

He just shrugged in response, setting aside the food that touches. Katsuki rarely liked food that touched.

At this, Masaru laughs, “Hopefully he’ll be okay.”

“Why wouldn’t he be?” Katsuki looks up then, replying quickly.

Mitsuki sat down after refilling her glass, chiming in, “He’s just saying to go easy on the boy, alright brat? Or else Inko will kill me too.”

Go easy. What, do they think he was going to kill the nerd or something? Katsuki just rolled his eyes and continued to wolf down his food. He can’t bulk up if he doesn’t eat after an intense practice.

On Wednesday, there was a small party at some kid who graduated’s house. If Katsuki remembered correctly, the guy was a loser, but since Ejirou was bitching about him coming, Katsuki decides it’s one way to waste time. And so he attends that until 10 P.M., not particularly interested in any of the conversation or activities that were going on. It was a Wednesday. He wasn’t going to drink, he wasn’t going to fuck. Even if he did want to fuck, no guy or girl at the function caught his eye.

“Oi Bakugo,” Ejirou slapped him on the back, “You good? Have a smoke or something.”

Katsuki waved him away, “I don’t smoke, you fucking idiot.”

Ejirou knows this fact, and yet, once in a while, the redhead still offers. Says he thinks it’ll make the blonde chill out or something. Even if it did, Katsuki wasn’t going to risk getting drug tested and his life literally ruined because of something staying in his system.

Ejirou laughed off the insult and plopped down on the couch next to Katsuki, “You do you, dude. Sorry I was late.”

“You better be,” Katsuki mumbled, “You left me here with only Fuck Face to talk to.”

Katsuki’s red eyes dart across the room to where Kaito Sen stands with that sleazy ass grin on his face talking to one of their mutual friends.

“Shit,” Ejirou huffs with an easy grin, “How was that.”

“How’d you think it went, Shitty Hair,” Katsuki leans his head back against the couch, “He came over, asking how my break went. And for a second there, I thought the dude might be less of a dick this year.”

“And then?” His friend prompted.

“And then the fucker didn’t let me get a word in before he says, and I quote,” Katsuki puts on his best Kaito Sen impression, “‘I did an internship at Miroshi LLC. What did you do, Cap? Fuck around?’ And then the bastard laughs like it was funny or somethin.”

Ejirou kicks his feet on the table, “Eh, don’t mind him. He likes to get under your skin.”

“Clearly,” Katsuki rolled his eyes, and grabs a dart off the couch’s arm rest and throws it at the board across the room. He missed. There’s a reason why he didn’t do precision sports.

“Anyways,” Ejirou pulls out his phone to habitually scroll as he talks, “I got held up because of the psych project.”

Katsuki gave him a look, “You’re in psych?”

“Yeah,” Ejirou looks offended, “I’m in the morning session though. You’re in the afternoon one, right?”

The blonde hums.

“Either way, yeah,” Ejirou keeps scrolling, “I’m partnered up with Momo. I went to her house today, and we just chilled. She’s pretty cool, but did you know she was fucking loaded?”

Katsuki half paid attention, “You can’t tell by the way she talks?”

“I guess not,” He shrugs, “How about you? I heard you’re paired up with Midoriya. Everyone’s been talking about it.”
Of course they are.

“It’s gonna be a shit show,” Ejirou whistled, “Try not to kill him, alright? Midoriya’s a really sweet guy.”

Katsuki rolls his eyes, “That’s the second fucking time I’ve heard this shit, now.”

“It’s not for no reason, man,” His friend laughs, “Have you guys hung out yet this week?”

The blonde boredly responds, “No.”

“Have he...asked you about it?” The redhead puts his phone away and asked.

“No,” Katsuki responds again.

Eijirou pauses, “Are you going to ask about it?”

Katsuki checks the time on his phone, before replying, “I’ll do it when I fucking want to.”

“So never?” Kirishima laughs.

Katsuki didn't get the chance to reply before someone comes over and interrupts their conversation, which was fine by him because he really didn't want to spend his Wednesday night contemplating his project, after all his school work had already been finished.

And Thursday, he honestly had no excuse to not hang out with Izuku. He really didn't, because after solo-practice, he was free for the day. No plans. Nothing. It would be the most optimal time to get their project hour done, because Friday, he had a placement test for another class to study for. His whole mental spiel about 'giving Izuku the opportunity' had completely been forgotten, and his disdain for the project had come back. And so, he made no move to approach the greenette. Honestly, it wasn't entirely his fault. The other didn't approach him either.

Their next interaction since the night of the diner comes during his solo practice, and Katsuki had the bar set up. 17'7 feet. It was an inch above his official record that he set last year, and since then, he's been able to jump this one consistently as well. But right as he was about to make his run, his ears picked up the sound of a fence creak, and when he looked, a particularly green-eyed, green-haired boy was timidly making his way through the gate, uninvited. Katsuki just watched him. Izuku's hands were gripped around his backpack, and he waited for the nerd to say something.

But instead, Izuku walked over to where the bench was and takes a seat, pulling out a notebook and pen. The fuck? Was he going to study here? And then, right before settling down, the blonde watches as Izuku reaches into his backpack and pulls out a bottle. A bottle of cherry gatorade, and sets it right next to Katsuki's practice bag. Katsuki remembered what he had said that day last week, and that had been mostly a way to poke fun at the boy. But now, fast forward, right there on the bench, was a cherry gatorade, his favorite flavor.

He liked it because of two reasons. 1. He liked cherry flavored things. 2. It was fucking stupid. All the expectations in the world for a cherry flavored drink would be that it is red, or pink, or some rendition of that. But instead, it was white. It was fucking white. In some weird way, Katsuki likes that it defies expectations. Like it was saying Fuck You to what the world wants from it. Katsuki was also sure that he came up with that stupid analogy while slightly tipsy last year after the season ended. Because he wouldn't have thought or come up with any of that embarrassing shit had he been completely sober.

After a moment of watching Izuku, Katsuki decides to just accept the damn drink, knowing he internally wants it, and goes back to practice. And *still* never ended up setting up some time to complete their project hour. Again, there were things he'd rather do after practice, like watch a documentary on how pole vault came to be.

And by the time Friday came, the project still was completely off of his mind. It was a busy day. He had a team practice, and then lots to study for afterwards. During practice, Katsuki noticed: instead of stopping to watch, the greenette went straight home. Hm, petty. The nerd was probably mad at him for not having said anything about the project. The thought made Katsuki sneer to himself momentarily, before getting back into practice.

It wasn't like Katsuki to slack on something he committed to doing, and it wasn't until about 11:20 P.M. that night, after he had finished doing everything that he needed to do, that this thought arose. He remembered what Mr. Toshinori had said. He'll be benched, if he doesn't do well on this shit. *Fuck* . The thought of being benched as he enters into his final season annoys the hell out of him, and Katsuki sits back on the armchair in his room, pen twirling in his fingers, as he leans on his palm in thought.

How many weeks were there in this semester? Who the fuck knows. But that's an hour a week, spent with Midoriya Izuku. It was doable. Katsuki looks at the clock again on his nightstand. 11:25. It was doable, if the nerd's mother wasn't a bitch about what her son does at every second of the day. Many of his friends were mutually friends with Izuku, and so by word of mouth, Katsuki knew that Inko required at least a week in advance to give Izuku permission to leave the house, and even then, there's a 50/50 chance she'd actually say yes. How annoying, Katsuki thought. A week in advance was ridiculous.

This meant that, even if he wanted to, there was no way in hell Inko would let her son go out at 11:25 at night to do who knows what. Katsuki could imagine the look in that woman's eyes now. The horror of the suggestion that Izuku will be out on the streets of Ise so late at night.

So there was practically no way to actually have the nerd leave the house at this time, Katsuki concludes, unless… *Unless* , and Katsuki grins menacingly at this next thought, unless he sneaks the bastard out.

And oh, suddenly, *all of a sudden,* this seems a little more fun.

He arrives at the Midoriya house not too long after he spontaneously decides to break the nerd out of jail, but parks a little further down so that the sound of his car engine or his headlights doesn't potentially wake up the mom-ster.

Climbing up the tree that was in front of what he still remembered to be Izuku's bedroom window was easy. His reach and height made things like this ridiculously easy for him, and he felt like a fucking creep now perched outside of the boy's window. If anyone drove past right now and saw this, Katsuki was sure there'd be a problem.

And so, he taps on the window, after peering into the messy room and not seeing anyone immediately. Katsuki can see a faint shadow coming from the light that was shining from the open bathroom, so someone was obviously in the room. After another moment, the blonde was getting impatient sitting there and tapped again. This time louder.

And after a moment, a mess of green hair dressed in a stupid-looking graphic tee and sleeping shorts came out of the bathroom, wielding a pair of scissors, and Katsuki snorts from the outside. Upon seeing him in the window, Katsuki watches amused as Izuku jumps in his spot, clutching his heart, and almost let out a scream. He rolls his eyes, and mouths *Deku* from the other side.

The nerd drops his scissors on the ground, and runs to the window, throwing it open. Katsuki sees the smaller's eyes widen with franticness in his expression.

“Finally, that took you long eno-” He began.

The boy interrupted him with a whisper-scream and looked as if he wanted to strangle the blonde, “Kacchan?! What are you doing here?”

Katsuki thought it was pretty obvious. What else would he be doing, at nearly 12 in the morning, at the shitnerd’s window, looking like a burglar.

“Serenading you,” He said with sarcasm, “No shit, what the fuck do you think I’m doing? Sneaking you out, come on.”

Izuku looked at him as if he had grown two heads, and flicked him on the side of the head, “Lower your voice, my mom is right downstairs. And what do you mean ‘Come on’. I can’t just go with you! It’s almost 12 in the morning, and I’ll actually be killed if my mom finds me gone.”

Izuku begins to shoo him away with those short arms, and Katsuki almost finds the action funny. He doesn’t plan to move.

“But we have a project to do,” He brings up.

Suddenly, the greenette looked partially annoyed, “Oh so now you want to worry about the project. Kacchan, if you didn’t know, in about 10 minutes, it’s going to be Saturday . I’ve been waiting for you to reply all week, and now you decide to show up?”

So he was right, Katsuki menacingly grinned. Izuku *was* upset about it. So he had been waiting, huh. That wasn’t very fair.

Katsuki wanted him to get a little more riled up, “Why didn’t you come talk to me in person, nerd.”

That did it.

Izuku sputtered, his voice level increasing, “Kacchan, you act like you are just the most approachable person in the wor-”

The way Izuku’s brows furrow when he’s frustrated, and that *slight* wrinkle in the nose. Oh, Katsuki decides then and there that there’s something about that. Something about it makes him feel spurred on.

He pushes it, “Woah woah, lower your voice. Didn’t you say your mom was sleeping downstairs?”

Immediately, Izuku looked as if he wanted to push him off the roof, and for a second there, Katsuki thought he might.

“I’m going to kill you,” Izuku warns. Wow, that’s pretty violent. Must have taken the nerd a lot to say something like that, Katsuki thought to himself.

“Great. Kill me in the car. Now come on,” He tells him.

And it takes him what seemed to be about two more tries to convince the boy to step out of his room, but eventually, Katsuki gets a faint feeling of internal satisfaction after he gives in. The entire time, Katsuki noticed he seemed nervous, and he made no move to tell him not to be. He'll figure out sooner or later. Doing things you aren't supposed to do is a lot easier than it should be.

Katsuki doesn't know why he drives towards the firefly lake. Honestly, he hadn't been there in years. The last thing he heard was that entering was prohibited because it hasn't been cleaned up, and there are 'hazards.' But as they drive through Ise, the blonde decides that'll be where they go tonight.

And that was where Katsuki decided that this wasn't that bad. At least, it couldn't have been if he lost track of time, and ended up spending about an hour over what they *actually* needed to do. It wasn't that bad, and that was all Katsuki could say.

At some point, after he had pushed Izuku into the water and the greenette surfaced sputtering and yelling all sorts of things at him, Katsuki let himself laugh. Well, it wasn't a choice. His body just began laughing, genuinely, and not out of sarcasm or whatever else. It was disgusting, because then, he saw the nerd's face go into shock at his reaction, and the last thing Katsuki wanted was for Izuku to think he had accomplished something. It wasn't the last time he sees this expression on Izuku's fast that night either. Because the second time was as he was taking off his clothes.

He wasn't blind. As he stripped off his shirt, Katsuki knew there was a pair of eyes watching him. He saw Izuku's expression for a split second, the slightly shocked look, and it made the blonde want to raise a brow. Oh? Katsuki was arrogant enough to know that he was attractive. And by the looks of it, he thinks that Izuku might know it too. Interesting. But then again, the shitnerd did say, after all, Katsuki wasn't his type.

The blonde goes home that night feeling just a tad bit annoyed. He's dripping wet, cold, and it's real fucking late, but that wasn't what he was annoyed about. God, he wished it was. Because that was better than admitting that he was annoyed at the fact that he had fun tonight. Katsuki was irritated *beyond* belief that chasing Midoriya Izuku around in a cold ass lake and scaring the fireflies away was actually not as miserable as he needed it to be. He was irrationally annoyed that when he took that damn picture of the nerd smiling so wide that his creepy ass eyes looked like crescent moons, in the water mid-laugh, he stared at it for just a moment longer than he needed to. And for what. He didn't even know. It just annoyed him. He was also irritated that when Izuku rambled his ear off on the car ride back to the boy's house, he didn't bother telling him to stop, as he should have.

But most of all, Katsuki was irritated that he wouldn't mind doing this again.

Because Midoriya Izuku is dangerous, as stupid as that fucking sounds.

He feels like barfing just thinking that. But it was true. Midoriya Izuku pries where he doesn't need to, while Katsuki hates priers more than anything. Because Midoriya Izuku is self-sacrificial, while Katsuki is self-absorbed and he knew it, so he also knew that those two

things do *not* mix well. Because Midoriya Izuku has that mother that pissed him off, and he knew it'll piss him off a little more everytime he sees the nerd comply with that woman's every demand.

Because Midoriya Izuku has those wide, green eyes that show every emotion possible, and it's only a matter of time before those eyes show disappointment, *again* . And the last thing Katsuki needed, after so long of purposely choosing not to give a shit as to how people view him, was to begin caring that Midoriya *fucking* Izuku is disappointed in him. Like hell, he would.

And so, when Bakugo Katsuki settles down in his bed that night, the air conditioning not cold enough so he strips down to his boxers to sleep in, the blonde makes a resolution in his head. Izuku was not a friend. He was a partner. And Katsuki needed to stay as he was: careless and nonchalant. And their one hour a week? Keep it strictly that. No more, no less.

And that lasted a whole couple-of-days. Because *somehow* , the nerd fucking convinced him to help with physics homework the day before the kick-off. He really did reject the request several times. And yet, he found himself sitting on the playground swings with the shorter boy later anyways. He didn't know why he had suggested this playground in particular. He knew it was the place they first met, and he was sure Izuku knew it too. And yet, when the greenette asked for a place to meet, it was the first thing he thought of. And so here they were, a little more than a decade later, back again at the place they first met as wee brats. Except Katsuki was begrudgingly helping the boy with physics homework. And he was pretending that he wasn't aware of the significance of the playground, and he'll try to as long as possible.

"I'm strong too, you know," Izuku said at one point, rolling his eyes. They had been talking about the fact that Katsuki's incredible athleticism lets him void his nerdiness, which he will stand by to his grave.

He raised a brow, "Oh yeah?"

He questioned, even though he knew. Or at least, he could tell. One thing Katsuki has picked up from being at the top of his sport was how to gauge people. He could guess a person's physical performance by the way they walk, the way they even move their arms. It was how he scouted his competition, and it was always important to do so. That way, he'll know who to watch during a tournament, see their weaknesses and strengths in order to determine whether he had them too. If he notices a technique that works, he'll see if he could make it his own. If he notices a technique that doesn't work, he'll keep it in mind when he practices. This was how Bakugo Katsuki got to the top. It wasn't merely talent and skill. It was observing what people do right and what people do wrong, and only collecting the good things.

And so, Katsuki, by default, has a good mental measure of strength and capability. A person of this build can likely do this. A person with that gait probably works out their legs more, or arms, or whatever. A person of that size could possibly accomplish *this* certain feat. He could generally gauge the sort.

Considering this, Bakugo Katsuki knew Izuku was strong. The nerd was short, and his growth spurt was long over, and so this was it for the guy. And yet, judging by his posture and more, Katsuki could tell that he could pack a punch if he wanted to. There were calluses on those smaller hands, signs that he lifts heavy in the gym. Relaxed, Izuku's arms weren't huge, but he knew that if the boy flexed, there will be prominent muscle definition. It was the thighs that were a dead giveaway. Izuku did his fucking squats, probably bulgarian split squats, and it showed.

All of this makes Katsuki a little more irritated. How the fuck does Inko look at her own damn son, and think that Izuku couldn't go out by himself. It was delusional.

"As a matter of fact, yes," The greenette huffed, before standing up to puff up his chest.

Oh, *this* was funny.

Sure, Katsuki will fairly admit that Izuku was likely very strong. But no way in hell was the blonde going to let the nerd get too comfortable with that idea. And so, with a grin, he hops off of the swing himself, and stands up to *his* full height, stepping closer.

He towers over Izuku, looking down in those wide eyes that stare up at him now, and for some odd reason, looking at the shorter boy like this tickles something in his brain.

"How about you come to the kick-off Thursday night, and we can see just how strong you are. You can probably take on Tokoyami or something," Katsuki spoke, knowing he was riling up the other.

Izuku then says something that made Katsuki internally *very* , *very* excited, against his own will, "I can probably take on you."

So the nerd wants to play. After practically at each other's throat for years and never having a real conversation until recently, Katsuki still gets just slightly surprised at the way the boy is able to talk sometimes, and he doesn't necessarily dislike it.

"Oh?" Katsuki takes a step forward until Izuku's back was against the post of the swing set. That confidence wavered, and Katsuki finds himself enjoying Izuku's smaller stature back up against the pole, and so he leaned down to the greenette's height, "You think so?"

Izuku looks at him then, before saying, "You never know."

And if he didn't know at that moment, then he sure finds out later. Later, as in, Thursday night, after Izuku does a fair amount of damage to him at the kick-off. He hadn't expected the two of them to actually fucking get matched up. On any given year that Katsuki had participated, he has had an indisputable win. And this year? Sure, it was clear he won. But he had not been expecting to leave that ring with two bruises and two small cuts. In fact, Katsuki hadn't been expecting much from the night.

The kick-offs were usually fun every year. The fights added some excitement, and this year, Tetsutetsu's house was a nice place to host the thing, right near the beach and large enough that plenty of people can fit comfortably both indoors and outdoors.

He had arrived at the same time as some of the vaulters around 6, and there was already plenty of folks there. And for a while, he spends time just hanging out with some of his buddies, until he was feeling a bit thirsty.

Katsuki beelines towards the cooler to grab himself a cherry gatorade, in order to avoid the dumb obligatory greetings that you always had to fucking do at parties when you first get there.

"A gatorade?" Someone approached him, "You're not going to have a drink?"

Katsuki looks to the side, and sees Sara, pronounced sah-rah, and not ser-rah. The girl was in Tetsutetsu's friend circle, so they've been to a couple of parties before together; however, he doesn't think they've ever officially talked one-on-one. She was pretty. Long black hair. Foxy eyes. If she showed interest, he wouldn't mind taking her home. He hasn't fucked in a couple of weeks, having been caught up with school and whatnot. Not to mention, the last season of pole vault excited him more and held much higher priority than wetting his dick in someone's son or daughter. That being said, he wasn't against the notion.

"You blind?" Katsuki asked, holding up his gatorade, "This is a drink."

"I meant," She walked closer and got herself a 5% seltzer, " *this* kind of drink." He knew what she meant.

"I don't drink often," Katsuki looks out into the party and leans against the kitchen counter.

Sara does the same, and nods as she cracks hers open and takes a sip, "I noticed. At Yoru's party a month ago."

The blonde still doesn't look at her, and just brings the bottle to his mouth, "So you've been looking at me, huh."

Sara laughs prettily, "Everyone does. You're Bakugo Katsuki."

"I'm aware," The blonde states. He knows his own name.

"And I'd have to say," She tilts her head to the side and smiles, "I can see why they stare."

Katsuki looks to the side at her now, "Well tell them not to. It's fucking annoying."

Sara doesn't seem deterred but looks at him funnily, "Although, I will say you're also as rude as people say you are."

The blonde sets his drink down and takes a breath, as if he was bored, and then turned fully towards her, his large stature almost caging her in, even though she has plenty of room to move if she wanted to.

“Yeah?” Katsuki then asked, like an asshole, “And yet, you still want me. So enough with the small talk. If you want to fuck, sure. Stick with me tonight. I’ll blow your back out. If you don’t, sure.”

Sara’s lips parted, as if a bit surprised, before she nods to herself and exasperatedly mutters, “Straight to the point, wow.”

“So what will it be?” The blonde asks. The fights were starting soon. He wants to be there for it.

The raven-haired girl, at his confrontation, then decides to drop the whole approach she had in mind, and just nods with a shrug of her shoulders, “First option.”

And that was that. It was easy for Katsuki to get people to reveal their true intentions. He is sick of the approaches at this point. It was always some rendition of ‘*oh, bakugo katsuki. You’re the guy everyone talks about*.’ As if they didn’t know that before. And then, they’d try to butter him up, but compliments don’t fucking work on him. And then, the small talk is excruciating, and Katsuki knows that they never have the intention of being friends with him. After all, like Sara mentioned, he was as rude as people say he was. Katsuki *knows* they don’t give a shit about being friends with him, because he *knows* a person would have to be downright masochistic to want to be friends with him--like Ejirou was--, so what was the only other option? They wanted to fuck. And Katsuki, in turn, wanted them to get straight to the point.

“Great,” The blonde says, “Let’s go watch the fucking fights.” And she holds onto his arm, walking on his left wing. He lets her. Everyone knew it didn’t fucking matter.

When he catches Izuku’s eye during one of the matches, Katsuki is surprised. The boy was wearing a white sweater and dark blue leggings. Leggings that stuck to him like skin, and Katsuki could see the calf definition. Izuku was sitting next to Round Face, and they both had a front row view of the ring, except on opposite sides.

Still, when he made eye contact with the nerd, Izuku was quick to avert his gaze. Interesting.

What was also interesting was merely thirty minutes later: their fight. Katsuki truly hadn’t been expecting to tussle with the nerd tonight. It was funny how people expected it to be a bloodbath. Katsuki, 6’4, ridiculously built, with a track record of being a bit violent. Izuku, 5’4, fucking *tiny* , with a track record of not being able to hurt a fly. But Katsuki knew better than to underestimate the nerd. If it was one thing Izuku was good at, it was analyzing. And after years and years of watching him, Katsuki knew that Izuku probably understood Katsuki’s physical abilities as well as he did. Which meant that if he leaves room for an attack, the greenette *will* notice it and he *will* attack.

And he does. Several times, because Katsuki wasn’t perfect, as much as he’d like to be. And so, he gets damage done on him. But the crowd was going wild. And Izuku was sweating, chest heaving, lips parted, even bleeding a little bit. It was an interesting sight. At that point, it didn’t take much longer for the shorter to yield.

Getting him off the tarp afterwards was a different question, however. At some point, he had slammed the boy a little too hard on what seemed to be his shoulders and left leg, because Izuku struggled to get off the tarp. *Shit* . He might have been an asshole, but he hadn't meant to actually do long-lasting damage. Great. Now Inko was going to kill him, and people are really going to think Katsuki is set out to actually kill the greenette, as if they don't already.

He makes quick work of carrying Izuku to the laundry room, where the first aid was, all while Izuku complains he could do it himself. Sure, on a normal day, Katsuki would believe that, and had no fucking problem doing less work than he needed to. But right now, he'd like to see the shitty bastard try. He picked up the boy effortlessly, and set him on top of the washer.

And as Katsuki treated the wounds, hands experienced from treating his own a million times throughout the years, and popped Izuku's shoulder back into the correct positioning, the nerd doesn't fucking sit still.

"Fuck, I said stay still," He grabs the boy's chin tighter. He was cleaning a cut on Izuku's face, and from this position, and this closeness, Katsuki could see every freckle, dotting the full cheeks like stars. And the smell of lilies was even stronger.

As he works, he felt it. Those eyes on him. And Katsuki made the mistake of looking up to see what Izuku wanted, only to be slightly jarred by how fucking green they were, framed by long lashes. Katsuki's met people with green eyes before, obviously, but never any that had the same effect as these. And his hands still for a moment, as Izuku stares back, aware that he had been caught. And for that moment, this odd tension laid itself in the air, and even Katsuki feels a bit disoriented.

Before he breathily speaks, breaking the silence, "What did I tell you. Stop looking at me with those creepy-ass eyes."

Izuku was quick to lie, "I wasn't."

And Katsuki *knew* he was lying, what he didn't know was why the nerd bothered covering it up.

"I told you before, Deku. You're a shitty liar," He replies, voice lower than he intended, and he needed to back the fuck up *now* and continue to clean the cut.

And not long after, that weird tension cleared itself from the air, and Izuku resumed not being able to shut up. And somehow ends up roping Katsuki into a conversation about movies that ended up lasting *far* past when he was done treating the wounds, and the worst part was that the blonde didn't even realize it. Just that sometime along the way, he had been sucked into whatever whimsical sentence that came out of Izuku's mouth, and next thing he knew, he was for some reason telling the nerd the kind of horror movies he liked.

"Kacchan, I know where I want to go. Pick me up tomorrow night after practice," Izuku requested at one point, looking up at him with his hands in his lap.

Katsuki paused. That was a no-go. The nerd could try again next week. They had already seen each other twice this week, for more than an hour each, which was already breaking his resolution. The playground, then the kick-off. Or did those not count or something. Still, the blonde didn't say no as immediately as he should have, but instead, diverted the request.

He leans his head back against the wall, "So you're making demands now, huh."

And by the end of that conversation, he still hadn't really answered Izuku's question, when Sara poked her head into the laundry room.

"Bakugo! I've been looking for you," She bounced her way in.

He turns towards her, "Sara. I was taking care of something." Obviously.

When he says this, the girl finally acknowledges Izuku's presence, although he was there the entire time, and bursts into a wide smile, "Oh! Right! Are you okay?"

Katsuki watches as Izuku nods with a smile, "I'm okay! Thank you for asking."

And then Sara goes right back to pretending the greenette wasn't there, evident by the way she goes up to Katsuki then. He looks down at her.

"Bakugo," She smiled, "You looked so cool in the ring."

She placed her hand on his chest, and another on his waistband. Katsuki wasn't quite sure what to think. Izuku was *right* there. He stole a quick glance, and it didn't seem like the nerd was paying attention anyways, so he looked back down at Sara.

Placing a hand on her waist, the taller boy leans down a little bit, whispering in her ear, "Patience. Not now."

And he turns his head up towards the other, "Oi, how well can you move?"

Katsuki watches as Izuku dangles his legs, and hops on the ground, testing out his ability, before looking a bit awkwardly at him, "Well enough! I'm gonna...go back out."

He could guess that Izuku had the awkward reaction because of Sara's sudden presence in the middle of their conversation. And once he left the room, the raven haired girl pulled him down by the neckline of his shirt to kiss him. And he kisses back, bending down a bit to meet her height. Her lips were soft, and tasted slightly like the seltzer she had been drinking. Her hands stay on his waistband, and his on her hips. But he pulls away after a minute or two.

"Not now," Katsuki tells her. He wasn't going to fuck her in the laundry room of Tetsutestu's goddamn house, nor was he particarly in the mood after cleaning up Izuku's wounds that *he* inflicted. He hadn't laid a hand on the nerd in years, and although it had been mutual, seeing his own damage on the nerd, as much as he disliked him, made him feel a certain way that he couldn't pin down. But regardless, he wasn't particularly turned on.

"Why not?" Sara frowned, "He isn't here anymore."

Katsuki furrows his brow, “Because I don’t want to right now.”

Sighing, the girl nods, “Okay.”

He was starting to regret his offer to Sara by that point. But what was the last straw was after Katsuki had pulled Izuku out of the pool. Fuck, he had been *so* goddamn angry. One moment, the blonde was across the front deck of the contemporary style home, sitting back while a couple of his friends talk. And the next moment, he hears commotion and looks over to see a mob of green hair before a splash is heard, and not too far away, that annoying brat from his calculus class Yosetsu was giggling a bit while some of Izuku’s friends were yelling at him. And then the next couple of moments after *that* , Katsuki goes through a blur of actions. From being soaking wet dragging the greenette out of the pool without a second thought to fuming over to where the drunk piece of shit was still standing, giggling to himself, Katsuki had a hard time recollecting his thought process from point A to point B, but had a *very* easy time expressing his fury, and an even easier time letting it go wild. He didn’t know what the fuck had gotten into him, but he was seeing red.

If it was someone else, he was sure he’d feel the fucking same. Because who the *fuck* pushes a guy into a pool that can barely move his limbs. Katsuki was an asshole, and he was more violent than not, he admits, but this could have killed someone.

He shoved Yosetsu in the chest, walking forward, wanting to slam his foot into the bastard, “You fucking idiot. Put down the damn drink, or I’ll fucking kill you.”

He hears Denki say something, but it doesn’t register in his mind. He knows the idiot was drunk. That doesn’t make him less of an idiot. Drunk or sober, the consequences were still the same.

“The shitty nerd can barely use the left side of his shitty fucking body, and you want to push him in the damn pool? Are you fucking dumb? Do you want to find out what it feels like?” He threatened and dragged Yosetsu until he was dangling and leaned over the pool, with only his feet on the sides, “Should I break your arm and throw you in?”

From behind him, the blonde hears Izuku call out, “Kacchan! It’s okay. He was drunk.”

Of course, the nerd would say it was okay. To Izuku, it seemed like everything was fucking okay. Getting pushed into a pool with limbs that barely worked was okay. Getting pushed around by his mother for 18 years was okay. Getting pushed around by *him* for for-fucking-ever was apparently okay.

Katsuki looked over at Izuku with his typical evil grin, “I can get drunk too.” And he looked back at Yosetsu, “Would that make it better, bastard? More accurate?”

The bastard in front of him stammered, “M-Midoriya said it’s o-okay, so just leave me alone! It was a mistake!”

“Tch,” Katsuki shoved him to the ground. Pathetic, “You don’t sound so drunk now, huh. And that’s because the nerd doesn’t have enough self respect to get angry.”

And he meant that. Izuku should have been angry. Sure, Katsuki gets it. Some people are just more forgiving than others. Fine, what-fucking-ever. But not shit like this. Not shit that could’ve killed him. Forgiveness without a second thought was more disrespectful than it was anything else, and Katsuki stands by that. So much, that the blonde rarely forgives at all.

And by the time the whole thing blows over, Katsuki regains his normal sense of self: the nonchalant version that presides over all other emotions, and he thinks that the crowd will dissipate.

And it honestly should have, and everything should have been left at that, yet instead, like a cherry on top, Sara walks forward with a nervous laugh while the blonde was already still a bit tense.

And she asks, “Bakugo, since when did you care so much about Midoriya?”

Yeah, that was fucking it. Whatever plans they had tonight were long gone. In his eyes, Sara just got *really* , *really* fucking ugly. Read the goddamn room, he wanted to tell her, but didn’t feel like wasting a breath. God, he knew he got annoyed easily, but tonight was really testing him.

He’d rather spend the five million hours he ends up spending upstairs trying to get Izuku out of his wet clothes all over again ten times, than spend another second with that girl. Scratch that. Maybe not ten times over again. Because now that he thinks about it, that interaction was fucking *odd* .

When he had pulled the wet sweater off of Izuku, Katsuki wasn’t sure what he had been expecting. But he sure wasn’t expecting himself to feel the way he did when his eyes glance onto Midoriya Izuku’s body. A toned torso, slightly tanned skin, dotted with freckles here and there, and smooth skin. Pink nipples, puffy from the cold. Katsuki doesn’t let himself dwell on it.

And shit, when he went to take off the goddamn leggings. There was no other reason as to why it was so hard to take these stupid pants off of the nerd other than the fact that Izuku’s thighs and hips were full. So full. He wasn’t looking, but he could tell from the way Izuku’s ridiculously soft skin spilled out of the leggings from his hands. What the *fuck* .

So maybe, he *won’t* relive that whole fiasco ten times over.

And as he takes the boy home not too long afterwards, Katsuki experiences a strange sense of vertigo when he realizes that it was much nicer listening to Elton John on the ride back and making small comments here and there with an exhausted Izuku than in the event he just left. And it wasn’t as if the party wasn’t fun. It was. Which was why Katsuki was feeling the faint vertigo.

So much so that when he drops Izuku off, and when the greenette tells him one more time to answer, he’s more curious than appalled.

“Are we on for tomorrow night?” Izuku asked him, eyes averted towards the ground, “You never actually answered.” It seems like as exhausted as the shorter boy was, he mustered enough energy to ask Katsuki one more time.

He shouldn’t. Katsuki figures he probably shouldn’t, and spend his energy elsewhere on a Friday night. Somewhere else. Or with someone else. Anywhere else. It would make sense. It would make less sense for him to do otherwise. And yet, maybe it was because he was fucking tired and couldn’t follow his rational thought. Maybe it was a mix of that and the look on Izuku’s dumb face as if there was something he was really eager to do.

But he considers it, “Auntie’s gonna let you go out with last minute permission?”

At this, it seemed as if the thought just now crossed his mind, that he actually needed permission. Huh, Katsuki finds it somewhat amusing. A couple instances of something *more* , something a little out of the boy’s comfort zone, was enough to spark something in the nerd. So he was right after all. All it took was an opportunity.

Izuku turns to him then, looking determined, “She’s going to.”

The blonde can’t disrespect the unwavering confidence, and so, he sits back in his seat, and all he has to tell the boy was, “Be ready by 6.”

And by 5:54 PM, the boy was already sitting on his porch when Katsuki pulled up, except for the blonde, it seemed as if Izuku was lost in some trance, eyes closed as his head tilts up into the sky to feel the breeze. Little wavy tufts of hair flutter across Izuku’s forehead, and he looked so peaceful, Katsuki observed. Time to disturb it.

“Oi nerd!” He yelled out of his car, “You gonna come here or what?”

He had expected to have scared Izuku, but it seems like the other had known he was there, for Izuku easily opened his eyes, green globes shining as he pushes himself up and lightly jogs over to his car, sliding in easily.

And with a large grin on that freckled face, he yelled out a “Kacchan!” Upon arrival.

Katsuki’s body cringed, “Christ. I know I’m fucking incredible, but calm down.” The scent of lilies greet him.

Izuku laughed, a sound that Katsuki was not yet adjusted to, “Why? When you’re happy, you should express it.”

Happy, huh.

He rolled his eyes, “Don’t tell me what to do. What’s got you all in a good fucking mood.”

He noticed Izuku’s bounciness from the moment the boy stepped into his car, bringing this unusual bright energy that seemed unique to Izuku. Something good must have happened. Maybe mother Gothel didn’t give the guy a hard time today.

But instead, when Izuku fastens his seatbelt, the green-eyed boy says without a moment of hesitation, “I’m hanging out with Kacchan.” He says with a smile.

And that was when he slipped. Katsuki slipped, and for a moment there, his eyes widened in surprise, because how could he not. Katsuki couldn’t tell if he was being lied to, and that was odd. He usually could detect such things. But no one’s ever said that to him before. Or implied that they were this excited--giddy with wide eyes and a cheeky grin kind of excited--just because they wanted to spend time with him. No one in the world had ever said that to him before, and why would they. Are they stupid?  Katsuki refuses to believe it.

He rests into a scowl once more, ignoring the comment, and hoped Izuku couldn’t see his lapse in expression. The last thing he needed was for the nerd to think that his words had any sort of affect on him.

“Tch. Shitty nerd,” He grumbled, and asked, “Where are we even going anyways.”

Dolly. They were going to Dolly. A small town about 45 minutes away from Ise, further inland away from the sea, and known for absolutely nothing. The only thing Katsuki knew about Dolly was that it had one high school, where all of the kids drive up to Ise for the weekend when they need something to do, and that there was practically nothing of note. Which is why, when Izuku reveals that was their destination as they were cruising down the half dirt, half gravel road, Katsuki gave him a look through his ray bans.

“The fuck are we gonna do in Dolly? Doesn’t that place have 30 residents?” He asks.

The other shook his head, “3000 residents, Kacchan. And you’ll see.”

Katsuki groaned. If *he* knew nothing of Dolly, then he was damn sure that Izuku who never gets out of his damn house knew nothing of Dolly, “This better be worth the gas.”

“If not, I’ll cover your dinner,” Izuku then offers him cheekily.

Dinner? So the nerd was extending their time on his own will now, huh.

“Since when are we getting dinner,” Katsuki looked over, right hand tapping the console.

From the side, he heard Izuku respond shyly, “Since you probably haven’t eaten yet because practice runs late on Fridays and you picked me up not too long after.”

Leave it up to Izuku to be the observant one, the nerd was absolutely right. He was going to get hungry really soon. Practice kills a lot of his energy, and he hated being late, so he only grabbed an apple to go on his way to pick up Izuku. Still, he’ll pester the other a bit more.

Katsuki begins, “Stalke-”

Izuku interrupts him, “I swear to god Kacchan, If you call me that again-”

Threats here. Threats there. All empty. All baseless. Katsuki rolled his eyes and started laughing. Ever since he began this project with the other, Katsuki been getting a handful of fun little threats and teases, but no real commitment. Katsuki wants to see the boy do something. He wants to see the nerd fucking let go, and *try* it. All bark, no bite wasn't his way to play.

And so he laughs, and in the middle of the road screeches his car to a halt and leaves it right there in the middle, with a cloud of dust behind them that got kicked up in the abrupt break.

He then turned to Izuku, and leaned over, closer than he intended but it was too late to back away now, and looked into those surprised green eyes before provoking him, "What are you gonna do."

Katsuki ignores the way the golden sun shines on Izuku's skin and illuminates it into a rosy-orange color. The boy seemed too shocked to reply. So Katsuki pushes.

"If I call you that again, what are you gonna do, Deku ." He grinned, as his mind went back to the fire in Izuku's eyes that he saw literally yesterday night, "Wanna tussle some more?"

"K-Kacchan. You can't just stop in the middle of the road," The boy breathlessly says.

His grin grows wider, and he taunts the other a little more, "Why can't I?"

"Because!" Izuku blinks at him, "People use this road. There will be cars coming soon."

So what. He didn't care. And he wanted Izuku to not care.

Katsuki, being who he was, has met a fair amount of people in his life, be it voluntary or involuntary. And most people genuinely are fine with playing it safe, living the mild life where their fun consists of yearly vacations to a resort with their significant others and parties with old friends. Even Katsuki's friends prefer to take it chill in the grand scheme of things. They'll drink, have a kickback, have some good ole fun, but at the end of the day, that was it.

But Midoriya Izuku was a little different, and Katsuki knew it. There was always hesitation in that tone, that expression, a bit of fear and apprehensiveness, but the blonde knew: there was a cauldron of dissatisfaction back there brewing. All Katsuki needed to do was turn up the heat, and it'll start to come out little by little.

Without thinking, Katsuki reaches his hand up to grab a hold of Izuku's chin, tilting his head slightly to take a good look at those freckles. Izuku was all smooth skin, dotted with freckles, and the boy glowed a little from the sunset coming in through the windows.

"Deku, Deku, Deku," He says in a comical tone, rolling the nickname on his tongue, "When are you going to learn? Here, let me tell you a little something."

A little something. That little something ended up being a speech in the middle of the road that turned out more dramatic than Katsuki intended for it to be. But fuck, did he mean it, and he needed to make sure Izuku *knew* it too. And when, not too long after, the boy decides to sit

on top of the sunroof, laughing his heart out, while Katsuki drives in the direction of Dolly, that was when the blonde decides to accept something.

It didn't matter whether or not he liked the boy: the fact of the matter is that Izuku, behind the apprehensive precautions, was *just* his speed.

The blonde likes to think he has a good understanding of Izuku's behaviors and motivations. He really thought he did. The first thing Katsuki does when anyone does anything to him is to pick out their intentions. And yet, Katsuki was drawing blanks when they pulled up onto an unassuming street in Dolly.

"Ah!" Izuku pipes up. The boy had climbed down from the roof, and was sitting with his legs held up against his chest for comfort, "We're almost there."

The blonde looked around, unsure of what he was referring to exactly, "Where is there? And why are we here."

Katsuki then looks over to Izuku, who then hugs his knees as if suddenly a little shy, and smiled, "You said you liked them."

Still confused, Katsuki tries to recall, "Like what?" He asked, raising a brow.

"Horror movies," The boy says, and his voice gets progressively more nervous as he speaks, "I wanted to go to a drive-in theatre. They're playing She Watches tonight, and I th-thought," Izuku averted his eyes from him, "...that it'd be fun."

And this was where the blonde was drawing blanks. A total loss. Because truly, he didn't understand. Tonight, he had watched Izuku climb into his car excitedly with a huge smile, claiming it was because they were hanging out, then now, the boy had taken them all the way here to a drive-in theatre just because Katsuki had mentioned briefly yesterday night that he enjoyed horror movies. Katsuki knew that Izuku was known for being the town's 'Sweetheart.' He knew that the green eyed boy was naturally kind and affectionate to most people. But this was foreign to Katsuki, and he wasn't sure what to think of it. Because he just couldn't think of an intention that would explain this. Because no one has done this for him before.

"You wanted to go because I said I liked horror movies?" Katsuki asked slowly.

Izuku buffers himself, "I mean, yes. But also because I like them too! It's not lame is it?"

Katsuki without a second thought denied that damn notion in a heartbeat, "It's not lame. Let's go."

This was the fucking weirdest shit someone has ever done for him, and he wasn't going to waste a second of it. That didn't even make *sense* , but all he knew is that he was feeling stupidly excited for this movie now and that pissed him off.

And it didn't make any sense that the movie, after an hour and a half, ended up not even scary, and yet, he still didn't feel like he wasted his time. And it wasn't just any time. It was *several* fucking hours. Much, much more than Mr. Toshinori required. Much, much more than the resolution he had the night of the firefly lake that wasn't going so well.

From picking the nerd up at 6PM to dropping him off well past 1 in the morning, somehow, one required hour turned into nearly eight, and yet, it felt like no time had passed. None at all. Even as Katsuki went home that night, stomach full of Gib's Burgers & Fries, mentally still disturbed from Izuku dipping his fries in ice cream, and eyes droopy, he gets that feeling again.

The feeling that he wanted to see him again.

What the *fuck* .

And when that fluff of green hair and doe-like eyes becomes a slowly integrated part of Katsuki's life, he knew he had fucked up somewhere in his resolution. God, he had fucked up. Because it started like nothing. Like *fucking* nothing.

One moment, he had been making dinner at the Midoriya family house, the Monday following their night at the drive-in movie. It was fine. It was relaxed. It was even a little nostalgic, not that he'd admit it, to see Izuku's room again, and small remnants of memories flooded back into his brain. And it was a fucking *power* trip to see that the nerd had a section on his shelf dedicated to him, complete with newspaper clippings, a jersey with his name on it, and some random box that the shitnerd wouldn't let him touch. That was all fine.

Then the next moment, it had been him who stopped the boy while he was walking home, to ask him to go somewhere that evening. Katsuki had no idea what the hell had gotten into him that day. One second, he was in the middle of practice. And the next, he found himself stopping the greenette, and he had originally planned to make fun of him or something just for shits and giggles, but what had came out instead was, "Be ready by the time I get off practice, and I'll pick you up. I got somewhere I wanna go." Just to later take the shorter male to an abandoned grain silo facility and chase him around with a condom on a stick. And the stupidest part was that it was more *fun* than he's had in a hot minute.

At some point, the moments begin to be noticeably *frequent.* Once? Twice? Sure, why the fuck not. He wasn't going to get hung up over it. But once the numbers begin to hit up to even three times a week that they saw each other, it got a little difficult to pretend that it was accidental. And that was exactly what Katsuki had been doing up until now.

The blonde would literally pretend, like an idiot, that he had forgotten they had went to a quarry to swim two days ago, and in the same week, ask the nerd if he was busy. And the next thing he knew, they were sitting on the scaffolding of a building on the edge of town whose construction never got finished, and so shrubbery and weeds grew all over the abandoned construction materials, scaffolding, and red bricks. And yet, the two boys still climbed up to the fifth floor or so, and sat on the creaking scaffold, legs hanging off of the metal bars, as they snack on some sandwiches that Inko packed for them before they left.

On his pill speaker, Saving All My Love For You by Whitney Houston plays, and the iconic singer's soulful face sets the scene as a pink sunset reflects on the red brick building, half exposed. Since they were on the outskirts of town, tall grass stretched from the right side of the building for a while, meanwhile, on the left side was Kuni Street where a car would drive past once in a while.

"You beat me to it, nerd," Katsuki barks out a laugh as he leans back on his palms. The structure was already so unstable, that his slight movement caused the scaffold to wobble. The blonde sees Izuku holding onto a metal bar in panic.

"Beat you to what?" Izuku's voice perked up.

"I'm usually the one who makes the excuses to Auntie when we go chill," Katsuki points out, "You beat me to it this time."

"Did I?" Izuku grins shyly and scratches the back of his slim neck.

"What'd you tell her?" Katsuki pretends to recall, even though he knew, "Oh yeah. You told her we were going to a fucking baking class together."

"Yeah!" Izuku didn't seem to realize the problem, and looked at Katsuki funnily, "What's the problem?"

Katsuki finds himself laughing, fingers rubbing his forehead, "That's the worst fucking excuse ever, Deku. Do I look like the type of person to attend a baking class?"
Izuku pauses, thinks about it, and then the boy's face turns a bit red, "Okay, maybe not. But I would! There's only one dessert I know how to bake."

Katsuki snorts, "What is it?"

"White chocolate chip macadamia cookies. They're my favorite," Izuku proudly says.

"That's awfully complex for the only fucking dessert you know how to make," Katsuki looked at him weird.

"It was the one time my mom forced me to watch her in the kitchen so I'd learn how to make more kinds of food," Izuku explains.

"Shoulda done that more often. Anyways, next time, just leave the excuses to the master," Katsuki points at himself, before he reaches out to wipe a piece of dust off of Izuku's chin. The boy's face scrunched up at the ticklish gesture, and Katsuki chuckled at the sight.

"No, I need to get good at this," Izuku huffed, and thought to himself, "Maybe my mom would be more convinced if I told her we were going to go kick puppies. Does that fit you more?"

"Oh yeah, perfect," Katsuki flicks the boy on the side of the head, "My favorite hobbies. Pole vault, dragging a nerd everywhere with me, and kicking puppies." He says sarcastically.

Izuku looks at him then, a faint smile on his pink lips, “Hanging out with me is one of your favorite hobbies, Kacchan?”

Well, *fuck* . He hadn’t even been thinking about what he was saying. It just came out naturally, and now Katsuki was stuck in his own self-made predicament, where all he could do was deny, deny, and deny. They had only been doing this for a couple of weeks, and yet, the green haired boy had already occupied a good chunk of his week, and he was doing nothing about it.

Katsuki deadpans him, “Of all things, *that* is the fucking part you decide to focus on, shitnerd?”

Izuku laughs, “You’re evading the question. So, is it?”

The blonde rolls his eyes, but Izuku was persistent, leaning in and tilting his head from side to side so that Katsuki couldn’t avoid looking at the boy. The entire time, a grin was playing at the greenette’s lips.

The movement caused the shaky scaffolding to move in his place, causing Izuku to lose a bit of balance since he wasn’t holding on to the metal bar anymore.

“Oh god,” Those green eyes widened, but Katsuki quickly reached an arm out to pull the boy closer into a more stable position.

“I got you,” Katsuki tells him, as his eyes were focused on the thin wood plank they were sitting on, making sure there was ample room for the two of them to be sitting this close, his hand on Izuku’s upper arm. And when his eyes move from the wood plank upwards, the blonde finds Izuku looking up at him through dark green lashes, lips slightly parted and giving Katsuki such a strange expression. And the blonde in turns, get caught in that gaze, and there is a slight change in atmosphere when he realizes how fucking closer they were. Katsuki lets go of Izuku’s arm, and the boy sits back up straight, a faint blush dusting his cheeks.

Ah, there was *that* happening much more often these days. Increased frequency of strange little lapses of time like what had just happened, when the atmosphere would change like the flip of a switch. And it was always when one of them would get a little too close, or say something with a tone a little suggestive just to pass it off as a joke. And suddenly, Katsuki wasn’t exactly sure *what* was going on.

Still sitting there on the scaffolding, they fall back into conversation, which came too easy. It was too easy that it was making Katsuki uneasy, because he wasn’t a talker. Katsuki’s never been much of a talker, when it comes to real conversation. There was no need to. There was no one he wanted to get particularly close to. And yet, Midoriya Izuku had a talent for making him talk. It could be anything. Their days, the stupid dream they had the night before, the difference between the words ‘affect’ and ‘effect’. It was too fucking easy.

And it was only when the sky was about to go completely dark, about an hour later, that they decided to head down. But before they do, it was like the darkness of the nighttime gives Izuku more confidence to speak his mind on a subject they passed a long time ago.

“Kacchan,” Izuku says.

And the blonde in question turns towards the green haired boy, the new moon showing nothing on that face tonight, and replies, “What is it.”

Without turning his head, Katsuki hears Izuku tell him, “Even if you were lying, being with you is one of my favorite hobbies too.”

Katsuki sweeps the first local tournament. By a landslide. It wasn’t a competition, more than it was a bloodbath. To Katsuki, it was almost boring. In the local tournaments, he was jumping, at max, less than what he would do for warm-ups at practice. But still, it felt so good to be on the track field again, with people in the stands, Coach Shugo yelling at everyone, and his blood pumped with energy to perform. He looked towards the stands before the tournament started. He sees some classmates, some parents. And then Midoriya Izuku up on the second row, adoring a billowy green shirt and when he catches his eyes, the boy smiles wide and waves. Katsuki just curtly nods at him, before turning away. They rarely acknowledged each other in front of others, and especially not at school or any school functions. Katsuki didn’t feel the need to.

And he forgets that if he doesn’t acknowledge the smaller, then someone else will. Which is fine by him. He didn’t give a shit. Or more like, he *wouldn’t* give a shit, if it was anyone other than Kaito Sen.

With his trophy weighing heavily in his gym bag, Katsuki’s post-win good mood soured against his will when he turns the corner around the outdoor bleachers and sees Fuck Face chatting up the nerd. Anything to do with the sleazy piece of shit made him irritated. Okay, so if Katsuki was being rational, then he knew that Kaito was really only a fucking pain in the ass to him. He chooses to believe it’s intense jealousy issues, and an inferiority complex. For the most part, Kaito Sen was a relatively decent person to others. But that didn’t mean Katsuki could help feeling something flare up in annoyance at seeing his teammate standing a bit close with his project partner. Kaito was about 6’0 tall, looking flirtatious as he spoke to Izuku with an interested grin, standing up as straight as he could to make himself look all big and bad. Pathetic.

“...you’re plenty interesting,” Kaito remarks, and Katsuki hears the last part of what he was saying as his legs approached the two of them, “And I’m not sure what your relationship to Bakugo is, but I can assure you that unlike him, I’m much more of a gentleman.”

Katsuki really fucking hated the guy. Over the years, the blonde likes to think he’s not as recklessly violent as he used to be as a middle schooler. But damn, if there was one more opportunity to beat someone to a pulp, Kaito Sen would be the one. And it’d be easy too. Katsuki was bigger than him. Taller than him. Better than him. Katsuki truly was annoyed that out of nowhere, the brunette decides to bring up his name. Much more of a gentleman, Katsuki snorts, of course that’s something Fuck Face would say. They exchange a couple more words that Katsuki didn’t make out as he approached closer.

“If you want, I can take you ho-” Kaito begins.

And Katsuki knew it wasn't his business, but he finds himself butting in anyways, "He's got a ride, Fuck Face."

Or at least, he did now.

Izuku's head turned around towards him, and his lips gape, "Kacchan! Don't call him that, that's mean!"

He knows.

Kaito laughs it off, making him look a lot more friendly than he was, "It's fine. Everyone on the team is used to it. I'm Fuck Face. Ejirou is Shitty Hair. Denki is Dunce Face. The list goes on." Great. Way to make him look like a fucking asshole.

Izuku was *just* the guy's type, and Katsuki knew it too. Kaito was the type of guy who liked nice things. And Izuku was just that. Nice, with a good reputation, smart, pretty. And Katsuki could say that: Izuku was pretty. He fit all the brunette's check boxes. Something about that didn't sit well in his head, even if it wasn't his damn business what the nerd did.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, then turned to Kaito, "Don't you got a shower to get to? You fucking reek. Good luck trying to get in the nerd's pants smelling like that."

He barely pays attention to the next couple of words with Kaito, caring more about getting out of here, preferably with Izuku, than getting into some petty passive aggressive feud with his teammate.

"Oi Deku, how long till Auntie gets here," Katsuki asks the greenette.

"I haven't texted her yet," Izuku turned towards him.

The annoying bastard inserts himself, "I thought you said he's got a ride."

Katsuki turns towards him, grinning with no friendliness, before tugging his bag forward, "He does now. Let's go."

From beside him, he sees Izuku hopping along, big eyes staring up at him, "Are you sure? My mom might make you come inside to tell her about the tournament."

Katsuki had no plans to do so. In fact, he had no plans to take him back in the first place, "Who said I was taking you home?"

The talk around the school grew like a wildfire, as it did when Bakugo Katsuki was involved. And the blonde wasn't deaf. He hears practically everything that everyone says, because at some point, it circles back to him, whether he wants to hear it or not. And so, this means that he hears the absolute confusion amidst the student body that cared about these kind of things.

Their partnership was the new ‘it’ thing to talk about, but like everything else, Katsuki knows it’ll die down soon enough. He remembered the first time one of his more *private* details got spread around. God, he was pissed off, and had confronted the guy he had slept with about it, only to receive a halfhearted apology and an embarrassed demeanor. Within a couple of days, it died down. And that was about the last time he gave a shit about rumors. He accepted at this point that people were going to talk. People were shallow. They wanted to be associated with him in some way or another, and talk about it with others. They liked to dig into his life, and come up with fake ideas like they have nothing else to do with their lives. Especially the spring of his 2nd year, and for an entire week, a rumor floated around that Katsuki beat his brother at home, Katsuki was never bothered to take anything seriously. He didn’t even fucking *have* a brother. And once the school realized that, they were *real* quick to be all sweet and syrupy, laying it on thick as if they hadn’t slandered his name mere days prior.

And so now, as gossip and talk is floating around, Katsuki just sits back and says nothing. Denies nothing. Affirms nothing.

‘They are hanging out much more than the required hour,’ some say. And Katsuki doesn’t know how they know. They just do. And the blonde knows that it wasn’t Izuku who was going around saying anything, because the greenette looked uncomfortable with the newfound attention, if anything. And so, he assumes it’s those eyes that glance when the two of them are driving through, or walking somewhere out in public. ‘Are they friends now?” Katsuki wouldn’t even know how to answer that.

‘They don’t talk in school, though,’ some notice. And then, they conclude, ‘They’re probably just fucking.’ And that one Katsuki makes sure to *not* have a reaction to. Because if he denies it, then they’ll go fucking crazy. Because he never denies a rumor.

And when the two of them were together, the topic of what everyone was saying never came up, because then that would force them to acknowledge what was the truth and what wasn’t.

On an evening where Izuku had something to do at home that his mother absolutely refused to let him miss, Katsuki decides to go to a party. It’s been a couple of weeks since he’s been to one, and the thought hadn’t really crossed his mind either. But as Denki repeatedly rings his doorbell shouting for him to attend, Katsuki drags himself out of his house, dressed in basketball shorts and a long sleeved black shirt. Throwing on a backwards cap, he grabs his keys and on his way out, shoves Denki playfully.

“You’re a piece of shit, Dunce Face,” Katsuki tells his friend.

“Nah, you’ll have fun,” The vaulter insists as they walk out, “This week it’s Taki’s party. And in a couple of days, it’s Kendo’s. You never miss Kendo’s, man!”

He hadn’t even thought about that either. Itsuka Kendo’s parties were always insane. Huge house. Loud music. Tons of people. Ever since he began to attend functions, he never missed them, yet he hadn’t thought about it once this year.

Taki’s party was at a classic Ise home, painted pastel yellow with a picket fence gate and twinkle lights decorating the yard. A pong table was set up outside, some hammocks where

some people were lounging with a smoke, and others just crowded on the porch of the house. Inside, there was loud music and a good amount of people already.

Katsuki did have fun that night. He had a single drink, just for the vibe. It wasn't enough to make him feel anything, but a slight tingle. And when he went home, he did so with a girl named Etsuko.

She had dark green hair, cut neck-length, and pouty lips.

And when he fucked her, at some point, he made her turn around so that he could only see her back and head. He didn't know why he asked this. He didn't usually.

And when he came, cock spilling his seed into the condom reservoir, he felt sick to his stomach at the realization that the entire time he was pounding into her pussy, he had been wondering why Etsuko's voice didn't match. And it was only afterwards that Katsuki fucking questions himself. What was it supposed to match, huh? What was it supposed to *fucking* match. He ignores it.

Katsuki skips Kendo's party the following week. He knew it was happening, and did have plans to go, but when Izuku calls him that evening, thirty minutes before he was planning to leave, and asked if he was free to hang out, Katsuki said he was. And they end up going to a stone factory, where there was literally nothing but huge piles of broken stone outside, sitting near big moving machinery. And all they did was attempt to climb on top of the big piles without slipping on all of the loose rocks, while the sun goes down, and it was probably externally seen as one of the lamest things to do, and yet, Katsuki had no regret about it when he goes home that night and even after he hears all the stories from Kendo's party.

Coming back to school after not being at the party, and instead spotted by someone at the stone factory with Izuku, was a bit tough to explain. And so he didn't. What was there to explain. He skipped the party, and went out with Midoriya Izuku instead. What more was there to say.

Izuku begins to call him sometimes at night. And it would be easy to not answer. He just had to let the phone sit there. And so it'd be *so* easy to not pick up.

"Again?" Katsuki grumbles through the other line. It was the third night in a row. He glanced over at the clock. 2 in the morning, and his sleep had been disrupted.

Izuku's voice was soft and a bit cracked on the other side of the line, "Oh, I'm sorry Kacchan. I forgot what time it was, I'll hang u-"

"No," Katsuki tells him, staring up at his ceiling in the dark with the phone held up next to his ear, "Stay on the line."

“Are y- Are you sure?” The boy’s voice sounded like it was trying very hard to be stable, but Katsuki could hear the staggered breathing on the other side.

“Ts’ fine. I wasn’t asleep,” Katsuki lied, “Not tell me nerd, the fuck’s going on with you.”

“Nothing’s wrong,” Izuku says quietly.

Katsuki chuckles, voice clearly still brittle from waking up at this time, “Just wanted to hear my voice, huh.”

Izuku sniffs with a laugh, “Yeah.”

Katsuki doesn’t miss it, “Is it Auntie.”

A bit of silence passed, and the blonde wondered how long Izuku was going to keep pretending he was fine and dandy. He waits with a patience he usually doesn’t have.

“Yeah,” The voice cracks from the other line, “It’s nothing out of the ordinary though. So don’t worry ab-”

“Who said I was worrying,” Katsuki was quick to shut down out of reflex, before he felt the need to somehow redact his words, and so the blonde takes a pause before speaking again, “Deku, everything that woman does is fucking out of the ordinary. What’d she do this time.”

Izuku laughs airily, “Just said some things that imply that I don’t love her as much anymore. But she doesn’t mean it.”

This makes Katsuki angry, and he talks into the phone, “How long are you gonna make shitty excuses for her. It doesn’t matter if she meant it or if she doesn’t. The effects are still the fucking same. Look at you. You’re fucking crying at 2 in the mo-”

This only makes the boy on the other line sniffle a little more on the other line.

“Fuck,” Katsuki cursed, and ran a hand through his hair as he sits up in the darkness of his own room, “Shit. I’m so bad at this shit. You shoulda went to Round Face or some-”

“No, it’s okay,” Izuku kept sniffling, but tried to keep his voice upbeat, “I c-called you because I wanted to laugh o-or something.”

“Laugh?” Katsuki snorts and then lays back down, one arm behind his head. He stares at his closed door. His parents were downstairs and wouldn’t hear him, “Not sure if you can tell, Deku, but making people laugh ain’t exactly my specialty.”

“T-Then sing me a song,” Izuku asks him, hiccuping quietly, “Please?”

“Deku, you know my singing is shit,” Katsuki tries to get out of it. He kicks the comforter off his legs and places his hand on his stomach.

“I like it,” Izuku insisted, still sniffling a bit.

Katsuki looked down and huffed with a small grin, “You like it, huh.”

“Yeah,” Comes from the other line quietly.

Katsuki squirms his way over until he could grab his laptop off of the nightstand, and he opens it, immediately being flooded with bright light. He squinted until his eyes adjusted, “Suit yourself, then.”

Getting onto youtube, the athlete types in the name of a song, and opens the video, before clearing his throat.

“Wait, you’ll actually-” Izuku began, voice small.

“Yes, now shut up,” Katsuki demands. And the introduction of the song plays, and the other seemed to immediately know what it was.

“Oh no, no, no,” The greenette pleads jokingly, through little sniffles and laughs.

Katsuki deepens his voice in the 80s style of exaggerating singing, just like Rick Astley, and stupidly sings into the phone, “We're no strangers to love. You know the rules and so do I.”

“Kaccha-” Izuku tries to interrupt, laughing airily.

But the blonde continues, nodding along to the infamous Never Gonna Give You Up by Rick Astley, “A full commitment's what I'm thinking of, You wouldn't get this from any other guy.”

His voice was horrible, but here he was, singing at 2 in the morning to make some shitty nerd feel a little better.

“I just wanna tell you how I'm feeling, Gotta make you understand,” Katsuki serenades with his off tune singing. He was about two beats off, as well.

“Are you actually-” Izuku begins.

“Rick rolling your ass? Fuck yeah,” Katsuki grins before going into the iconic chorus, “Never gonna give you up. Never gonna let you down. Never gonna run around and desert you.” Izuku starts to laugh on the other line, mixed with a little bit of pain, but the blonde kept trying to distract him.

“Never gonna make you cry. Never gonna say goodbye. Never gonna tell a lie and hurt you,” Katsuki passionately performs.

But then, the boy on the other line begins to cry again, but this time, a little heavier than the quiet sniffling before, and Katsuki wondered if he had done something stupid. He immediately stops, and pauses the music. The blonde could tell that on the other side, Izuku was trying to hold himself together, judging from the muffled sound that hinted to him that the boy was covering his mouth up to hide the sound.

“Shit, I’m sorry,” Katsuki feels a tiny bit stressed out, “That was meant to be funny.”
“No, no, it was,” Izuku reassures him, his voice messed up by the hiccups even though he tried to keep his tone stable, “I-I’m sorry, K-Kacchan. It’s j-just that,” He hiccups.

“Why the fuck are you sorry,” Katsuki asks the other.

Izuku struggles to string together a full sentence without it breaking between hiccups. From the side of the bed, Katsuki’s laptop was still shining with the paused Rick Astley music video on the screen. The happy atmosphere in the video, paused in the frame, juxtaposed with the quiet crying that filled his bedroom and Katsuki reached out to shut his laptop.

“It’s just th-that,” The boy tried to steady his voice, “No, it’s s-so stupid.”

“Tell me anyways,” Katsuki asks of him.

“It’s just that,” Izuku quivers, “s-sometimes, when I laugh a lot, I feel like crying too because I- I know the moment will e-end,” He hiccups, “And I’ll have to g-go back to what I was f-feeling before.”

Katsuki breaths in and out, thinking. It’s quiet. Crickets of Ise, singing outside, waiting for him to say something, anything.

And so he just tells Izuku, “Let’s not let it fucking end then. Tomorrow, let’s go to the beach, yeah?”

“The beach?” Izuku asked, tone so quiet.

Katsuki hums, “Yeah. I’ll tell you about the dream I had before you woke me up just now too. It was us as superheroes. You’d eat that shit up.”

“I thought y-you said you weren’t asleep,” Izuku remarked.

“Did I?” Katsuki pretends not to remember, “Can’t remember. Anyways, we’ll hit the beach tomorrow, alright nerd? Get some ice cream too. I know a place.”

At this, Izuku seems to cheer up a little, and hums through the other side of the line, “Okay.”

Katsuki had been right. When they swam at sunset in the beach the next evening and the blonde told Izuku about his dream, the nerd was all excited about it. At least, the second time he repeated it. The first time, the greenette seemed to be staring off into space.

“We were heroes. And we didn’t go to Ise High. It was a school with a weird name, two letters or something. UE? UA? I don’t know,” Katsuki recalled his dream, eyes still closed.

“UA?” Izuku laughed, “That was the name of the hero school we came up with when we were kids, remember?”

“Was it?” Katsuki couldn’t pinpoint exactly, but he’ll just go with that, “Anyways, I was saying. We were heroes. I had this fucking cool ass power, where I could make things explode from the palm of my hands using my sweat.”

It was funny how easily they could switch from one topic to a completely different one. Because not long after, suddenly Izuku’s hands were on his back, tracing the lines that raked down from his shoulders. He tensed up, not used to Izuku’s direct touch on his body like this, aside from the occasional brush of an arm or thigh.

“What are these,” Izuku asked him, as those smaller hands trace over the lines and then the muscles of his back.

Katsuki was *this* close to fucking shivering under those hands like a goddamn virgin, so he reaches back to take a hold of Izuku’s wrist, stopping the contact. There was no way the boy didn’t know.

He put it blankly, “Sex.”

He had fucked a pretty boy two nights ago, just to relieve some tension that he’s been feeling a lot lately, and it just doesn’t seem to do it for him. He had came, and it was fine, but it felt as if that was all it was. Katsuki wasn’t a ‘fuckboy’ by definition. He had a similar body count as a lot of people at Ise High. It’s just that his’s is publicized, and others’ aren’t. That being said, lately, his sexual frustration seems a bit high, but nothing’s been cutting it except maybe his own hand, but then he was a bit apprehensive about his imagination and what he might see.

Katsuki stares down at the much shorter boy, and watches those pink lips utter out a, “Huh?”

Then the blonde spoke, “Don’t tell me you’ve never been fucked so hard that you leave scratches on someone’s back.”

The truth was that Katsuki was really fucking annoyed when he had explicitly said not to leave marks, and the boy from two nights ago, just towards the end, leaves long scratches down his back. The last thing he needed was to have signs of possession on his body, from a person who he didn’t feel like he belonged to.

“That’s none of your business,” Izuku blinked up at him, with a faint blush on his cheeks, and that’s when Katsuki realizes he knew nothing of Izuku’s sexual life, when it was clear that the other knew a little bit about his. And now that he thinks about it, he wasn’t sure he wanted to know. The sudden image of those rosy cheeks, flushed after sex pops into his head, and he wondered if they were as warm as they looked.

Katsuki looked at him strangely then, before bringing a hand up, to gently brush his fingers across the boy’s face. It *was* warm, like a spring afternoon in Ise.

And when Izuku looked down to where he had just practically caressed his face, the boy asked, “What is it?”

To which Katsuki dropped his hand and lied, “An eyelash.”

When Katsuki leaves for his ‘appointment’ that night after taking Izuku home from the ice cream parlour his uncle owned, the blonde can’t help but think back to the slightly guarded look on Izuku’s face as he asked him: “You’re gonna go?”

It was almost as if the boy wanted him to stay.

Katsuki remembers the faint glow of the purple neon lights on Izuku’s face in the ice cream parlour, the faint sound of I Want To Know What Love Is in the background, the sea salt dried bed of green hair. He remembers the way those lips told him, *I’m not a kid anymore, Kacchan* . And wondered what Izuku meant by that. Not a kid anymore, huh.

When the school’s county inspectors come in for their lunch period, Katsuki and his team groaned at having to move tables. But where Izuku and his friends sat seemed like it wasn’t going to fill up, so they moved over there. And honestly, Katsuki fucking wished that he had just sped run his lunch and gotten out of there, so that he didn’t have to hear Fuck Face trying yet again to flirt with Izuku. A *coffee* date? That’s what the bastard was suggesting. Boring prick. But who knew, maybe Izuku was into boring guys.

The only time Kaito Sen wasn’t boring was when he had something to fucking say about Katsuki, and suddenly, it wouldn’t be so boring anymore.

“Bakugo, unlike you, I care about what Midoriya has to say,” The brunette tells him dead on, in the middle of lunch, after he had made a comment about Izuku’s tendency to speak for long times. He had said nothing about not caring what the nerd had to say. Obviously, Katsuki didn’t hate it enought to stop fucking hanging out with the guy. God, Kaito was an idiot.

Because now, the entire lunch table was tense, and Katsuki was taking no blame in this. Every single time, the brunette was the one instigating conflict, and he’d better pray there wasn’t going to be a day when it is *Katsuki* who is instigating it. The lunch table seemed tense, watching the interaction between Bakugo, Midoriya, and Kaito Sen.

“Oh? So you want to play a white knight now?” Katsuki asked, with humor in his voice. This was fucking funny to hear, “Talk to me when you work up the fucking balls to talk more than a couple sentences to the shitty nerd instead of jacking off to him into a sock.”

“Bakugo,” Ejirou ushered, “Remember, it’s just Kaito. He always does this.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku stammered from nearby, “You don’t have t-”

Kaito doesn’t quit, and Katsuki is surprised he’s held back so far, “You know, the only reason Midoriya is even friends with you, if anyone can even call you guys that, is because you’re good at vault. Without vault, you’d be nothing to him. Or to anyone. He’s way too good to be friends with y-”

Izuku cut him off harshly, and says some words that Katsuki could barely hear over the sound of his own ears ringing. The words that came out of Kaito Sen’s mouth were aim to evoke

some kind of feeling out of him, and right now, Katsuki was struggling between two: anger and frustration. Anger because he wanted to genuinely rip the brunette's spine right off of his body. Frustration because for a second there, he had been worried his teammate was right. And that was frustrating, because why the hell would *he* care.

Katsuki's frustration throughout the day does not stop. He had to leave immediately after lunch to go talk to some stuffy suited men and take some photos for a magazine. Sure, the recognition will help later on in his sports career, but he really couldn't stand it now. And still, he had to go while they dressed him up in clothes that were too expensive for what they looked like, and asked him questions he didn't feel like answering. That was arguably on par with the frustration he felt conversing with Kaito Sen today.

But the other frustration Katsuki had that day came in a different form entirely.

When the blonde sneaks into Izuku's bedroom through the partially open window, he had expected the nerd to scream and freak out.

What he had *not* expected was for a bit of Izuku's blanket to lift up, revealing a 7 inch pink dildo still slick with what seemed to be lube and cum. Katsuki made the connection quite quickly, and his eyes stray up to Izuku's naked upper body, down to the toy sitting there.

The moment he sees Izuku reach for it, Katsuki slaps the hand away and raises a brow, "So you've been having fun, huh."

And the nerd could barely say anything but, "O-obviously."

Hm. He likes that. The little stammer at this topic. The blonde reached down and grabs the dildo by it's shaft, until he feels the wetness of Izuku's cum and lube on his hand. Their conversation continues with Izuku trying to request it back, but Katsuki couldn't stop fucking thinking about it, and the thought sent a sensation straight down to his own cock. And no, that was *not* fucking good.

"Fuck," Katsuki didn't mean for it to come out breathy, but he looks at Izuku's body "You put this thing inside you?"

The boy with the big green eyes bit his lip then, "I m-mean, that's the whole purpose, right?"

To think that *this* was buried inside of Izuku… Katsuki drowns himself for a second in the thought of what the boy looked like with pupils blown wide, wet lips parted, and hole juiced up and filled like this.

"This is good enough for you?" Katsuki looks at it. 7 inches. Decent girth. Katsuki had better, bigger just right below his own waistline.

"What?" Izuku asked, flustered, "It's fine."

"You telling me this shit is big enough for you? It's a bit on the smaller end," Katsuki sneers, "You don't need something better?"

And no, *fuck* this shit. He shouldn't be saying this. Katsuki  mentally slaps the shit out of himself, and doesn't say much more before tossing it back to Izuku. The very last thing he fucking needed right now was to even have the *thought* in his damn head. He goes and washed his hands, and then stays for what he actually needed, which was to be caught up in class that he had missed today. And even after that, the blonde stays for a while longer, considering that the hag had some people over, and the last thing he wanted to do was sit down in the living room and answer stupid questions from her annoying friends. They've all tried to set him up with one of their older children, but when Katsuki says that isn't happening, that isn't fucking happening.

Izuku says his name that night, and Katsuki pretends that he found it weirder than he did. And as he finds himself drifting to sleep on the greenette's carpeted floor, the replayed sound of Izuku saying his name is what pulls him to sleep accidentally.

When Katsuki sees Izuku at the boat party, he knew that if the nerd was *anybody* else, he'd fuck him. God, Katsuki would fuck him easily. If the blonde could give Ochaco one thing, it was that she knew how to style. Izuku, normally, looked naturally pretty, apart from those creepy ass eyes. But dressed up, with a chain decor on those thick thighs, and a sheer blouse that hung loosely over spandex swim shorts, if Izuku were anyone else, he would've bent him over then and there for a crowd to see.

But this was Izuku. Midoriya Izuku, his project partner. His adventure buddy. This was the Izuku that took him to a drive in movie, something Katsuki's never done before, just because he had said he liked horror movies This was the Izuku who stupidly goes into a crazed laughing fit if Katsuki touches his ticklish spot right behind his ear. This was the Izuku that was way too fucking sweet to ever be considered a one-night stand.

And so, Katsuki separates the thought in his head, and mutters a *fuck* , before cracking open a selzter.

He should have saved the *fuck* for later, when they ended up swimming under the boat together, boat lights making the water glow bright blue, and Katsuki was hanging onto the boat hook while Izuku's thick thighs were wrapped around his waist. It was already bad enough that he had voluntarily spat alcohol into the boy's mouth, so close that their lips were barely a centimeter from touching. And now, he was underneath a boat, asking the nerd where his freckles went, instead of hanging out with his friends. He tried scrubbing at Izuku's face, wanting to get those fucking cute freckles back, but to no avail. But their conversation underneath the boat was nice. It was away from the main crowd, and Katsuki likes it more when it was just the two of them anyways. Because then, it just wasn't the same. After all, they didn't interact in public.

So when Katsuki hears Mina and Ejirou's voices approaching, the blonde quickly makes his way towards the boat, keeping a small distance from Izuku, and climbs up, waving over to his friends. And as he leaves, Katsuki looks back one more time, and barely catches the boy's eyes, before Izuku averts his gaze. And something told him, that *he* was the reason Izuku had done that.

Still, he let himself be taken away, back into the main crowd, where Katsuki tagged along with his buds and mingled between different groups on the boat party, before settling on a boat where a ton of people were either playing pong or chilling out. And that was how Katsuki reconnected with Kimi. From the school's volleyball team, they've known each other for a bit. She was always a pretty nice girl, while still understanding the whole no-strings-attached rule. Waist length brown hair, that was slightly wavy. Full lips and almond eyes, she was for sure sexy.

It was obvious where this was going, judging by the way that they talked throughout the hour, the touchiness that Kimi was a natural at, and the fact that she fucking kissed him after she had won the game of pong. It was *very* obvious where this was going, and Katsuki didn't mind. It would be a fun way to end off his night.

And yet, when Katsuki overheard the snippet about Ren and what seemed to be an intoxicated Izuku, any semblance of a fun night slipped his mind. And suddenly, Bakugo Katsuki was seeing red. Anything that he could have been thinking about before left his brain, and the blonde made a beeline towards where he knew the soccer player's boat was anchored. Katsuki had no authority on what the greenette did while sober, but drunk? Fuck.

When Katsuki threw open the door, the first thing he sees is the sight of Izuku, shirt thrown to the side, with someone else's hands all over his body. Touching that waste. Feeling those lips, slick with saliva. Those thighs were wrapped around someone else's waist, as Ren grinded into the smaller. Katsuki watches for barely a second longer, as Ren's fingers travel up to pull at those pink nipples, before he makes his way over.

Grabbing the soccer player by the back of his shirt, Katsuki threw his fist into the athlete's jaw, and sent him to the ground. Katsuki was taller, stronger. He felt his chest heave, and he says in the most deadly tone.

"I'll fucking kill you," And then lifts the poor guy by his shirt collar, "You hear me? I'll fucking kill you."

atsuki knew that he was going into a rage, and yet, it felt like an stopless spiral, and he all he could see when he closed his eyes was the terrifying thought of Izuku being taken advantage of while drunk, and the way the boy's lips were so pink and swollen right then.

"Woah woah! Bakugo. Calm down!" He heard his friend shout, and shuffling of feet as the captain's quarters became surrounded.

Katsuki ignores him, "The stupid fucking nerd is drunk as shit, and you want to fuck him? Zip up your pants, you piece of shit. I'll break your legs if you don't get out of my sight right fucking now."

And that was generous.

Ren slurs, "But...what...I'm…"

Kirishima finally forces Katsuki back, “Bakugo. Fuck. Listen! The dude is drunk too. Ren is drunk too. Neither of them can consent, it’s not just Midoriya. So calm the hell down, you’re losing your shit!”

He’s drunk too? It’s only now that Katsuki could kind of guess from the way Ren was speaking, but when he had barged in, those movements looked so fluid it was hard to believe

Katsuki turns to Kirishima, “Why the fuck didn’t you tell me before I beat the shit out of them?”

“I thought you knew!” Kirishima shouted, confused and frustrated, “I thought you’d just go pull them apart or something so they both don’t end up doing something they didn’t want. I didn’t think that you’d fucking try to break his jaw. Jesus, Bakugo. What the fuck?”

Katsuki stares at him for a second, incredulous. He had overreacted, yes. But he barely had an explanation. The moment he heard Izuku’s name in that conversation, it was all over for him. Fuck, what was happening.

Katsuki shakes his head then, and turns around for a second, before gesturing to Ren, “Take care of this son of a bitch. I’ll deal with Deku.”

“No offense,” Ejirou blurted out, “But I’m not sure most people here would trust you to deal with Midoriya.”

Katsuki took a step towards Izuku, but then he paused in his tracks, Ejirou’s words breaking his movement. What did that even mean. *Trust him* ? Katsuki liked to think that he could fucking function as a decent human being in a time of crisis when he needed to be. Christ, did everyone think he was going to haul the nerd outside then toss him into the lake to drown?

And so he asked, “What the fuck does that suppose to mean, Shitty Hair?”

Ejirou sounded a bit nervous“It’s just that you guys aren’t known to get along, even if you do hang out for the project...and I feel like someone who actually cares for him would be able to help him better.”

And I feel like someone who actually cares for him would be able to help him better. Katsuki thinks on that. He thinks on that for a while, and he feels spiteful and angry and that fucking statement made his gut involuntarily twist, but the entire time, he keeps a blank face on. He refused to reveal any of it, even though that line, from one of his own friends, was something he hadn’t expected to hear. Sure, it wasn’t unreasonable to say. But the way Ejirou said it. *Who actually cares for him* . Made Katsuki feel as if no one thought he could fucking take care of someone for real. And that made him spiteful.

Denki scooted through the crowd, and Katsuki hears him suggest, “Hey, maybe we can take care of Midoriya and you can just-”

Katsuki briskly ignores the both of them and walked over to Izuku, warning evident in his tone as he turns dead serious, “No one is fucking touching him. Do it, and I’ll break your damn hand. And trust me, as a pole vaulter, you’re going to need your wrists.”

The blonde thinks on what Eijirou had told him the entire ride back, and that made his grip on the wheel a bit more tense than it needed to be. In his passenger seat, Izuku seemed very dazed, but not as hyper-talkative as he was thirty minutes before. For a second, Katsuki wonders how much experience the boy has, to be touched like that. Katsuki remembers Ren's hands palming the boy's chest, like tits, and those fingers rubbing over Izuku's pink nipples. And he shakes that thought immediately. Like he had said, Katsuki didn't care what the other did, if it was in the right conditions. It wasn't his life, and he has his own private encounters too.

So, apparently, someone who actually cares for the nerd could take care of him better, huh. Katsuki keeps thinking about that. So Katsuki was incapable of doing so? Under what reasoning. Because of everything that's happened before between the two of them? He keeps his eyes on the dark roads of Ise, and heads towards his house. It didn't seem fair to him that *they* thought they could take care of the green-eyed boy better right now. As if they knew the intricate details about the situation with his mother. As if they were where his room was when they entered his house. As if they knew that Izuku liked the sleep with the blanket tucked under his feet, or else he feels really fucking uncomfortable.

But then, maybe Eijirou was right. Who was he anyways, to do anything. Katsuki could barely bring himself to call them project partners, much less friends even though they hang out all the time. Round Face, or whoever else, might have been better. They actually *cared* for the nerd, evidently, in some way that Katsuki apparently couldn't. He thinks back to how he had tried to cheer the boy up, but instead had made him cry more the other week on the phone. Shit, maybe he couldn't.

"What are you…thinking about?" Izuku asks him slowly, breaking the silence. He didn't play music on the ride back to his house.

And the blonde doesn't reply for a while. What could he fucking say. He knew the boy likely wondered what was going on in his mind, but he tries to keep himself as tightly locked as possible in times like this. The last thing he wanted to reveal was that Eijirou's comment about his ability to care for Izuku bothered him this much.

And so, all he said was, "Something somebody said."

And Izuku pries a little bit. Katsuki hated priers, who stuck their nose into places they weren't wanted. Who asks questions that make Katsuki uncomfortable with the introspection it implies. And so he evades it.

They arrive at his house, and Katsuki realizes the other hadn't been here in years.

When the blonde asks why he had gotten drunk in the first place, Izuku had told him, "I had a bad reaction to seeing something. It was my fault, really."

Katsuki is curious, "What'd you see."

Izuku smiles but Katsuki catches that there was some hidden emotion behind it that wasn't so happy. And there it was again, Katsuki thinks and is reminded of why he had hated Izuku so

much in the first place: that cover up of emotions, that fake smile in times it was clear he didn't want to.

And then Izuku said, "Something somebody did."

He comes over on the day that marked the middle of their spring semester. Homework, projects, clubs, and activities were picking up in intensity and difficulty. In all of this hecticness, the easiest thing to do was *their* project. It was completed every week de facto because of their overly saturated schedules full of each other. Katsuki hadn't meant to. But it felt as if every time he had free time, his first thought was Izuku before anything else: parties, other friends, etc. And he doesn't let himself think on it, because if he did, then he wasn't sure he'd understand the conclusion. For now, Katsuki was coming to terms with the fact that he liked hanging out with the boy, after many weeks now of doing so.

Izuku was busy planning for the Spring Dance, the biggest event of the year, and honestly, the biggest event at Ise High. Freshmen coming in are already dreaming of what they'd wear that magical night of Senior year, and even Katsuki was in with the hype. It was 80s themed, of course, and he knows the atmosphere was going to be fucking cool. Even pictures of last year's Spring Dance gave him and everybody else a feeling of FOMO and anticipation for their own.

Since Izuku was part of the planning committee, Katsuki made sure to use his connection to get a word in, "Oi Deku."

He was sitting in the nerd's bed, as Izuku pours over some papers in his desk nearby, and Katsuki bounces a foam ball up in his hand. They were going to watch a superhero movie after Izuku finished up whatever he was doing.

Izuku looked up, "Hm?"
"Make sure to get the DJ to play Footloose," Katsuki requests.

"Kacchan," He replied, throwing an eraser at him but Katsuki catches it, "This is the eighth song you've requested already. This is blatant nepotism on my part."

"As it should be," Katsuki sits up and grins and tosses Izuku back his eraser, "Come on, just this one song."

Izuku rolls his eyes, "Fine, but because I like that song too," Then he ponders, "Unpopular opinion, but I don't like the movie that much."

Katsuki gaped, not masking his surprise, "No fucking way. It's a classic."

"You like classic love songs, and classic romances?" Izuku giggled, and that sounds has such fucking weird affect on his chest, "Who even are you?"

"Someone with superior fucking taste," Katsuki defends himself.

"I can't imagine you watching Footloose," Izuku laughs, "Or, what, When Harry Met Sally?"

The blonde then sits up, and clears his chest, and with a serious expression, recites, “I came here tonight because, when you realize you want to spend the rest of your life with somebody, you want the rest of your life to start as soon as possible.”

Katsuki watches as Izuku’s eyes widen a bit at this, before grinning, “You can recite that line?”

“Of course,” Katsuki said as if everyone should be able to, and he thinks so too, “I’ve watched that movie fifty fucking times.”

“Hm,” Izuku thinks, “How about A Walk To Remember?”

“First of all, that was released in 2002, and set in the 50s,” Katsuki tsked, “But, nah.”

“Why not?” Izuku cocked his head, “It’s a good movie.”

“It doesn’t follow the movie formula,” Katsuki waves his hand.

“The movie formula?” He hears Izuku laugh again.

“Movies should have happy endings,” Katsuki points out, “If not, then what’s the damn point of watching a movie. If I wanted shitty endings and for everything to blow up and never get fixed, I wouldn’t need to watch a damn movie.”

“That’s just real life, huh,” Izuku shakes his head with a smile, “You’re so cynical, Kacchan.”

“Maybe, but that’s just how it is,” The blonde sits back, “Speaking of movies, we ever gonna watch?”

“Oh!” Izuku nods then gets out of his seat, “Yeah, I forgot.”

And so they throw popcorn at the TV, and watch some stupid super hero movie that Izuku ends up rating a 4/10. Katsuki finds it funny that they didn’t even have to go out and do something crazy. Moments like these weren’t bad either. The blonde would have thought that he hated hanging out like this, just chilling for hours in a room, but it didn’t bother him a bit.

And when Kimi texted him to go out, but Izuku asked him to stay, this choice barely took a second to decide. He just needed Izuku to ask him.

“ *Can you stay* ?” Izuku asks. And that was all he needed.

He jokes, “Since I’m staying, you better be entertaining.” Even though he knew that the other would be, regardless.

What he hadn’t expected to hear was that Izuku replied with a snort, “Do you want me to suck your dick or something to make up for it?”

Katsuki felt his jaw go slack, at the sudden suggestion, that he *knew* was a joke. But hearing such a blatantly crude statement coming from Izuku surprised him. Usually, it was Katsuki that made the outright suggestive comments, but the role reversal made Katsuki's face heat up. And *fuck,* he never blushed. He has kept a *very* tight control on his expression for fucking years now, just to blush stupidly at a *blowjob* joke? It wasn't as if he hasn't had his fill. But then, the sudden image of Izuku's lips--those pink, wet lips--wrapped around his head, throat being fucked by his thick member, it threw him out of the moment. And when he mentally slapped himself back into reality, Izuku was making fun of him.

He was practically shouting, "Kacchan! Are you blushing?! No way, no way, no way!"

Katsuki was going to fucking dissapear.

If it was one thing Katsuki didn't like, it was staticness. He craved progress, ambition. He was constantly searching for the next adventure, the next thrill, and the next bar he can jump.

And so, being stuck on 17'11, so fucking close to 18'0, was driving him crazy.

During solo practice that week, Katsuki felt himself slipping his nonchalant manner every time he doesn't clear the bar. He's been attempting this one for *weeks* , and although the blonde knew that the higher up he went, the harder it was going to be to gain inches, but this was frustrating him beyond belief. Everytime he showed up at team practice, Coach was bitching again. Reading him articles of the bastard who can jump 18'2, and Katsuki just *wished* he would fucking shut up. Because the blonde didn't like the way his heart was racing with every fail he got today, and it wasn't just because he was out of breathe. The more he failed to clear the bar, the higher it seemed.

He was frustrated, but knew that Izuku was there, sitting next to the Gatorade, and so he couldn't say anything, do anything. In his backyard set up, at least he can get all of his stupid feelings out, but here, in front of the green eyed boy that expected him to be some kind of fucking hero, he couldn't.

And so he needed the other to leave, "Can you go home." His tone was taut with how much tension was in it.

Izuku then asked him, "Why? So that you can let out your frustration where no one can see?"

The speed at which Izuku replied told Katsuki that this was something the boy already knew or could at least guess about him, and the thought that Izuku knew him that well made him uncomfortable. He covers up his surprise quickly, and scowls in anger, "And what the fuck do you know, Deku."

It was an easy request. It would have taken the greenette less energy to have just fucking walked home, then to stay there and argue with him some more about this. The last thing he needed during the miserable practice was a damn lecture from the nerd. He had a damn system. People have stupid expectations of him, what they wanted him to be, all of that shit. They wanted him to fly high, soar above the ground, so that they were far enough to admire

and put on a pedestal, but far enough for Katsuki's nasty and complicated attitude that he wouldn't embarrass them. He knew that if he didn't jump higher, he'd see all of their little dissapointed faces, and the blonde did not want to fucking deal with that. And so even as Izuku claims he would never be, Katsuki is convinced that it's what they all fucking say.

And so he leaves and sits on the edge of the tarp, collecting himself, because he knew that he was being off his ass with this. He knew that he needed a goddamn minute to breathe, and stared up at the 17'11 bar that felt way too way for him now. And he feels Izuku's eyes watch from a distance, and when the boy approaches, Katsuki felt that too.

The boy sits down next to him, handing him a gatorade, and Katsuki silently reaches out to take it. Prier. Izuku was a damn prier, Katsuki reminds himself. This was what made him so fucking dangerous.

You need to take a break for today," Izuku quietly spoke, "Your body is getting worn out." To which he says nothing.

But then, the shorter boy begins to swing his legs on the landing mat, and talk about Toro Ito, the guy from Tokyo who could jump 18'2. And Katsuki truly has nothing to say, because the nerd was literally going on and on about some boy in the city who was going to likely fuck him up in Nationals.

But then, after going on in praise, Izuku tells him, "But honestly, if someone were to ask me who I'd predict to be better by the time Nationals come, I wouldn't hesitate to say you…"

And that was surprising enough, that Katsuki looks over to the side at the greenette, where Izuku speaks with a shy smile on his face. And all Katsuki could stare at was the gentle smile on his lips, and the dotted freckles on his cheeks. His eyes were downtilted, staring at his kicking feet.

"You're so determined and passionate that it takes my breath away. Am I allowed to say that?" Izuku laughs.

And *no* . Izuku was not allowed to say that. Because from Katsuki's perspective, it wasn't as harmless as Izuku made it seem. Not in the slightest. When Izuku says things like that, it throws the blonde off balance. As if he shouldn't be hearing those things about himself. And yet, Izuku says it so easily, unwaveringly, as if he truly believed it. No, Izuku *wasn't* allowed to say that because it was making Katsuki's chest feel some kind of way, and he drinks more of the gatorade to wash it out.

And when Izuku tells him to whistle that cheesy George Benson song 'Nothing's Gonna Change My Love For You,' he does it. Because when Izuku asks him, with those creepy ass eyes shining or whatever the fuck they do, Katsuki couldn't untie his tongue.

The sweatband Izuku gave him was beyond hideous. And Katsuki was sure Izuku knew it too, by the embarrassment evident on the nerd's face. It was a white sweatband, with a kid's handwriting on it, and even dumber pictures. To think that Izuku had kept this for seven

years. It was almost...endearing. And Katsuki just holds it in his hand, seeing in his peripheral vision how Izuku looked nervous all of a sudden. And yet, when Izuku insists he wears it, Katsuki does so, wrapping the fabric twice around his wrist, inside out to hide the lettering.

And then, he looked over to the shelf. Where the pieces of things dedicated to him lay neatly. He didn't get it. He both understood Izuku and didn't at the same time, "Oi."

Izuku hums, "Yes?"

Katsuki then turned to look down at the nerd, so much shorter than him, "You have all this shit of me," He gestures to the shelf, "And you're trying to tell me you don't got expectations for me? What kind of fan are you."

Katsuki searches his eyes for an answer, pecking for the truth, where he knew it would be. These eyes never lie successfully, even if his lips do. He watches as Izuku blinks up at him. And he wants to know what was going on in that head of his. The blonde kept his eyes on Izuku's round green ones, waiting for a response. And then, Izuku answers.

"As someone who is always on the ground," Izuku smiles, "Seeing you fly, no matter how high, is good enough for me."

And oh *fuck* , this wasn't fucking good. Not in the slightest. Katsuki feels that overwhelming sensation fluttering in his chest again, and he isn't sure why he kept feeling this way when the nerd talked to him. But it was unfamiliar, and he didn't like this.

Izuku's words. No matter how high, was good enough for him? Katsuki thinks back to all these years, from the moment he was jumping low bars, until now, that look of awe on the greenette's face never changed. Every jump he's made, fail or not, Izuku really had watched. And goddamnit, he hated that Izuku says this. Because Katsuki has always felt like he'd rather be up in the sky, soaring above everyone else, rather than on the ground with the masses. He remembers the day he first approached Izuku during practice before their project started, that was exactly what he thought. He felt no qualms staying up there by himself, far from everyone. And so, he hates that Izuku says this to him now.

Because for the first time in his fucking life, he felt lonely up there by himself.

Because, as someone who was always in the sky, Katsuki thinks to himself with a twisting sensation in his stomach, he wanted for the first time in his life to be grounded.

Because the heavens didn't make up the world. The earth beneath his feet did as well. Both have its presence and necessity. And so, in the middle where the sky and the ground met, that will be where they'll be..

And so when Izuku shows up to Humphrey's Park in forty minutes, and the nerd asks him what he was doing, Katsuki answers him as simply as he could.

“Showing you how to fly.”

And when Izuku, after the millionth attempt, does, in fact, *fly* , Katsuki wonders if Izuku thinks the sky was as beautiful as it was to watch the boy here from the ground.

Sprint for 10, run for 6, Izuku tells him later. And he logs it in the back of his head for later.

The first regionals tournament arrives on Saturday, and when he was in the Ise High tent getting ready, Katsuki rummages through his backpack for his grip tape. But while he was digging through, he spotted something white and ugly. Grabbing it and holding it up, Katsuki stares at the charm for a good five seconds, before saying *fuck it* and wrapped the sweatband twice around his wrist. It wouldn’t hurt.

And he’ll say it worked. Because he takes the tournament, receiving a nice glass trophy as proof. It had been expected. He was Bakugo Katsuki, after all, with the title of Ise’s most notable soon-to-be alumni. And he’s in a good mood, as he usually was when he vaults during tournaments. The adrenaline, the sound of the crowd yelling his name, the sun beating down on the track, the absolute rush of thrill he feels seeing a bar set up and knowing he was going to soar over it. It was his element. And so, the post-win dopamine carries him through the whole clean up process, packing the tent up and bringing it back to the coach’s van.

And finally, he grabs his bag, and walks back inside the large foyer. It was a large stadium foyer that echoed when a lot of people spoke, and as he turned the corner, he saw Izuku on his phone. Seeing Izuku right after his win was a little fun cherry on top, because now he got to brag about his sick trophy. The boy’s eyes lit up at the sight of it, before he complained about the lack of care Katsuki had for the thing, just shoving it in his gym bag like that. It didn’t matter, he had a million more. Even if this one chips, as long as he had some display of what he had accomplished, that was fine by him.

He reaches out to ruffle the green hair that sat on top of Izuku’s head, a thing he’s been doing lately that he needed to stop before it became a goddamn habit. But the tufts of hair was softer than he’d ever imagine, strands of a deep green sifting through his fingers.

And then he notices it when his eyes look down. Katsuki’s gaze trails down to the shirt Izuku was wearing on top of another shirt. It was a jersey, and for a second, the blonde’s feels a rush of er-something, at the thought that Izuku might be wearing *his* jersey, walking around with his name on the boy’s back. But then he realizes that the number #1 was not on the breast pocket, but instead #7. And whatever he had been feeling before went down the drain.

His fingers lifted the jersey just slightly before asking, “Whose is this?”

Izuku’s answer annoys him, “Oh! It’s Kaito’s. He wanted me to wear it to cheer him on.”

Kaito Sen’s. Izuku was walking around with the fucker’s name and number on his back. He was officially annoyed, not liking how lately, it seemed like Fuck Face was weaseling his way through with Izuku. He looks off to the side and tongues his cheek, trying to decipher

why this was getting to him so much. If Katsuki had a say in it, he'd tear the thing right off Izuku's body then and there. But he didn't.

He feels Izuku's fingers at the hem of his shirt, "Kacchan?"

Katsuki couldn't help but let it slip out, "Wear mine next time."

He sees the boy's eyes widen, and mouth gape, "What?"

It was too late to go back on his words, so he stares down those green eyes, "Wear mine next time," He repeated.

Izuku looked confused, as he stammered, "You w-want me to actually wear it?"

Katsuki wanted him to wear it, alright. He wanted the nerd to fucking wear it, and to walk around with it during the tournment. A big #1 on his back, and Bakugo printed across the shoulder blades. And Katsuki wanted the boy right at the front of the bleachers too, right where Katsuki could see him loud and clear.

"Fuck," Katsuki looks back, tonguing his cheek, before stepping forward, so close that Izuku had a hand on his chest so they were pressed so tightly, he and looks down at the shorter male, and lifts the jersey up, "That Fuck Face really annoys the shit out of me you know."

Izuku looked a little flustered, and Katsuki thinks maybe he should back up, but the scent of lilies was intoxicating and he admitted that he likes the way Izuku has a hand on his chest but was making no effort to actually push them apart, "Kacchan, j-just because he annoys you, doesn't mean he annoys me."

"I know," He looks off to the side, before moving his gaze back down to Izuku's, and then lets go of the jersey, "This just fucking pisses me off."

He knows. He does. But that doesn't stop this stupid reaction from happening, everytime he thinks of Kaito Sen.

Yet when Izuku asked him, "Kacchan, are you...jealous?" He denies it.

What a stupid notion. Why would he be. What did Kaito Sen have that Katsuki didn't. Nothing.

But what *Katsuki* didn't have, was a clue as to what happened one of the days the following week in school. By the time Thursday practice came, Katsuki was reeling over the fucking *weirdest* interaction he's had with the nerd. On Wednesday, he had been pulled into the copy room corridors by one of his former hook-ups, who was a good enough lay but he never bothered to reach out again,  Chiha. Eh, he was down to have some fun. Not particularly inside of the school, but if she wanted to do something later, he wouldn't be completely opposed. The whole issue of Katsuki not feeling completely sexually satiated with anything that he does was still an ongoing problem.

And when Izuku, of all people, comes into the corridor, Katsuki wanted to absolutely go off at what Chiha ends up saying to the nerd.

"Hey," She had called out, "You're not going to snitch or anything, right? Aren't you, like, kind of a killjoy?"

Oh, *that* pissed Katsuki off. He didn't know when, but at some point in their partnership, Katsuki began to feel the need to shut down any case of these kinds of comments about Izuku. If they had only known the shit that the boy was capable of. Trapping the nerd into further boxes.

"Oi," He warns her, "Don't call him that."

At this, Izuku speaks up, but as Katsuki looks at him, he notices the boy avoiding his eyes, "Kacchan, it's fine." His voice was gentle.

"I don't care if you fucking think it's fine," Katsuki is upset, "Y-"

"Just please leave," Izuku tells him in a small voice, still refusing to look at him, "I'm trying to copy some papers, and you're in my way."

And Katsuki went silent. There was something wrong. He could detect it in the way Izuku refused to look at him, the timid tone that is similar to the one Izuku uses when he's about to cry. Fuck, had he done something? After a couple more moments of Izuku refusing to look at him, Katsuki blows out some air and leaves, Chiha following behind. But the moment they exit the corridor and she tries to cling onto him again, Katsuki shrugs her off.

"Chiha," The tall blonde says, "I'm not fucking interested."

"You seemed interested a couple minutes ago," She furrowed her brows.

Katsuki looked up and to the side, sighing in annoyance, "I can change my goddamn mind."

"Are you more interested in *him* now?" Chiha then asked, head gesturing to where Izuku had been.

Katsuki's head whipped around to her, "What the fuck does that mean."

"He's gorgeous, you know. Those big eyes and whatever," The girl shrugs, "I wouldn't blame you. But I'm a lot more fun. Doesn't he just sta-"

"I'm going to class," Katsuki pulls himself out of the spot, and leaves the girl behind, not bothering to look back in annoyance.

Whatever had been plaguing Izuku's mind seemed like it turned out fine by the time they hung out the next day, but when Izuku steps into his car, Katsuki immediately notices the difference in attire. He had hung out with the boy enough times by now to have a general understanding of Izuku's sense of fashion, which consisted of t-shirts, flannels, shorts, and

the occasional hoodie or sweater. He's seen the guy dress up a couple of times, but those were all occasions that Katsuki was generally there for, aside for the one time Katsuki was there to help him pick out an outfit for Inko's employee dinner at the custom prints shop.

But today, he looked a little different. A pair of light washed jeans hugged the boy's hips and thighs snugly, and on top, Izuku wore a long sleeved silk white blouse with the top couple of buttons undone, to where Katsuki could see the sliver of slightly freckled skin. He looked good.

It turns out, Izuku has a date! Would you look at that, Katsuki laughs internally. The fucking nerd has a date. With who? With *who* ? Kaito Sen. He was all dressed up now, sitting there all pretty, for Kaito Sen to later see. For Kaito Sen to take in the scent of lilies, to hear this laugh. The blonde didn't know why this annoyed him to no end. It wasn't his damn fucking business.

"So Fuck Face finally got what he wanted. Good for him," He says while he steers, words coming out a lot more irritated than he intended for it to be, and his palm hits the top of the steering wheel with every word, as a sarcastic smile makes a place on his face, "Good. For. Him."

Katsuki kisses Izuku in the back of his car, across from the airfield, on a warm spring evening, with the crickets in the background and ecstasy on his brain. And it wasn't just ecstasy in a figurative sense, Katsuki felt drugged.

He had already been stunned by the fact that Izuku had taken him to the coolest spot on this goddamn earth, just because the nerd knew he liked airplanes. He had already been in awe at the gorgeous sight of those huge machines soaring through the sky right above them, with Lady by Kenny Rogers playing in the background. And then, as he kisses Izuku for the first and likely last time, Katsuki feels absolutely drugged out of his mind, because how the *fuck* did it feel this good.

The blonde didn't know what had gotten into him when he told Izuku to *show him* . One moment, Izuku was revealing that he couldn't go to the dance. The next, Katsuki was talking shit about a hypothetical goodnight kiss Kaito would give Izuku at the door when the date ends.

And then the fucking next, Katsuki had Izuku on his back, legs riding high up his waist, as the blonde couldn't get enough of the sweetness that was Izuku's lips. The boy's skin was so fucking soft, and Katsuki's hand slipped under the silk shirt, desparate like a crazed animal. *This* . This was what he had been wanting to feel, and he didn't even know it. All these damn weeks of wondering why the hell no form of sexual gratification, not even his own hand, could make him feel the way just *kissing* Midoriya Izuku of all damn people was making him feel right now.

He was physically attracted to Izuku, and Katsuki was done denying that.

What was the use. His semi-hard cock was proof if he tries to argue with himself otherwise, and he made sure to keep that *far* away from the greenette as they're pulling and biting at each other's lips. Izuku had pretty lips, a pretty face, thick thighs, and from the numerous times they've gone swimming together, Katsuki could non-creepily say that *god* , Izuku had a perfect ass. And now, these lips were his, and Katsuki was going to do what he wanted with them for the time he had. Izuku synced with him better than the people he's fucked, and that was insane to him. The blonde wanted to eat the boy up, bathe in the nectar that was Izuku's lips, tug and pull like they were in a game of mercy, and roam his hands everywhere.

They shouldn't be doing this. They were project partners, and reluctant friends, even though Katsuki had never uttered those words aloud before. They weren't meant to be in the back of Katsuki's car like this, mouth on mouth, hotter, wetter than he's ever had it. Izuku's phone goes off, and Kaito's name appears on the screen. Katsuki doesn't care. The brunette can watch. He goes back to what felt like the first meal he's had after being starved. On the surface, he likely gave off the impression to the other that he was collected, experienced, and what not. And internally, this was unlike any experience of making out he's had. And he didn't get it. He didn't know there could be such a drastic difference, nor did he know what it could even be from. Had the nerd just gotten a shit ton of experience in this before? No way. There was no way.

When Izuku pulls away, Katsuki is reminded: that was just supposed to be a simple kiss. His hands weren't supposed to slip underneath the smaller's shirt. Izuku's legs weren't supposed to wrap around his waist. They weren't supposed to go any further, and *fuck* , in the whole commotion, the blonde had forgotten all manners and rules, and what not.

And he's so shocked, by the sheer surprise of making out with Midoriya izuku, of all damn people, that when Kaito Sen's white car pulls up, he can't even make a snarky comment. The after effects was wearing down, and he was coming to the realization that all of that was only leading to Izuku leaving with another guy. And it wasn't just another guy, it was Kaito Sen. And tonight, when their dinner ends and whatever they end up doing comes to a conclusion, Katsuki thinks about how the lips he just got hooked on may belong to someone else.

And he wants to stop the other. And for a moment there, Katsuki just might have, when he reaches his arm out to hold Izuku in place, just as the shorter was about to go. But he didn't know what to say. And he could tell Izuku was waiting for any words to leave him. But what could Katsuki even say. Stay? Don't fucking go with him? Because if he asks that, then the nerd will ask him why. And that was a question even Katsuki wasn't sure he knew how to answer. And so, instead, the blonde drops Izuku's hand and steps back.

If Izuku was going to go, to some restaurant and get wine and dined by a guy who will likely treat Izuku decent enough, then at least, he'd hope the nerd has a good time. Even if Kaito Sen hated his guts, Katsuki was somewhat rational enough to know that the same didn't apply to Izuku. Kaito would likely sweep the nerd off his feet, be the perfect gentleman and take Izuku to nice restaurants that everyone wants to be, say all the right things to make Izuku blush. That was fine by him.

"Have a good time," Katsuki says, and he knew that Izuku was trying to decipher what was in his eyes, but the blonde refuses to let anything show.

The car drives away just a couple of minutes later, and Katsuki sits in the back of his trunk, staring at the airfield again. The lights on the track were on, glowing different colors to direct incoming traffic. And after he pulls out his phone, leaning back, Katsuki plays Lady In Red, by Chris De Burgh.

The first 80s track he's ever been given, and he wonders if his grandfather, when telling him as a kid that he'll be able to sweep someone off their feet, if the man actually meant it. And if he did, then Katsuki wanted to ask his grandfather, what happens if someone else got there first. He only lets himself ponder for a moment, because then he backtracks. Why the hell did he need to know anyways. He wasn't that type of person who cared to do that kind of thing anyways, and even if he did, he wouldn't.

"Bakugo!" Mina whistled, as he arrived at the school's entrance dressed in a full three-piece suit tailored to his form, "You look sexy!"

"Fuck off," He tells her, rolling his eyes, before coming around to the other side, where his date probably expected him to open the door.

Sero leans off of his car, "Man, why'd you have to come and make us all look bad?"

The blonde just rolled his eyes with a smirk. Maybe it had been a good idea to let his mother bitch about him getting his suit tailored, because now, every piece of fabric was cinched to his body snugly. It tapered at the waist, and widened at the top, highlighting Katsuki's broad shoulders and athletic body. His date was just someone that the hag wanted him to bring, a family friend's daughter whose school didn't have a prom or any type of dance like this. He had argued with his mom over this, but ultimately just fucking gave in because the woman was sadly more stubborn than him. She was pretty, in a long red dress with an open back. But albeit, she seemed a lot more into the idea of going to the dance, than about going with Katsuki. Since they were family friends, Katsuki had encountered her about two or three times in passing, so his allure likely wore off.

"Thank you," Hina smiles at him, taking his hand as she steps out of the car, although the girl could have very well done it herself. Katsuki rolls his eyes as he turns back to his group of friends, but complies because his mom will give him hell if for one night, he doesn't try to give Hina a little princess prom treatment.

A huge balloon arch entryway lined the front of the school, with big lettering that said Spring Dance on it, and Katsuki grinned as he remembered Izuku saying it was such a bitch to agree on the front for that. And then he realizes again that the nerd wasn't even going to be at the dance that he helped plan. Suddenly, his disdain towards Inko Midoriya heightens a fair amount.

Especially once he walks into the main gymnasium where the dance was held, and saw just how well put together it was. As careless as Katsuki was about a lot of things, he did have an eye for aesthetics. Even if it was just courtesy of his parents being in the occupation that they were, and so, he knew that a lot of thought had been put into this. Katsuki and his group of

friends entered the gym, and it looked completely transformed. The bleachers were removed, and the nasty tiled floor with fading print that covered all of Ise High had a black carpet rolled out covering the entire gymnasium to give it a more clean look. Up ahead, dozens of beautiful purplish, bluish lights shone, flashing cool patterns like a true 80s dance, and people were already dancing on the floor to Don't You by Simple Minds.

On the far east corner of the room, rows of food was catered from the best restaurants in the area, served hot enough that it was steaming under the glass hoods. Tables covered in white clothes, and decor lined the back side of the gymnasium, where groups of friends set down their things or just sat to hang out. The DJ booth was up near the front of the stage. Katsuki remembered the two of them were in the middle of trying to sneak into an abandoned school, when this particular DJ called to ask for an invoice.

Izuku's phone had rung, and the greenette fumbles trying to silence it, before he sees who it was.

"Well what the fuck are you waiting for," Katsuki remembered telling him in a whisper, "Hang up the damn thing. A cop is right around the corner, ya dimwit."

Izuku looked like he was freaking out a bit, "I-I can't! It's the DJ for the Spring Dance. I think he's calling to confirm the invoice, and we need it today."

Katsuki looks around, muttering *shit* under his breath, before continuing to push open the window, "Tell him to text you or something."

"Hello? This is Midoriya Izuku? With Ise High's Student Council," The doe eyed boy puts on his customer service voice, and Katsuki turns around and gapes.

The blonde mouthed to him, *Are you fucking serious* .

Izuku just shrugged apologetically before answering into the phone, "Yes! That would be great. We were thinking of allocating the m…"

Katsuki shakes his head. It was a useless memory that wasn't really significant, but as he looks at the DJ, he was reminded of it. The blonde pushes a loose balloon away, but they were everywhere. Transparent ones filled with glitter, pink, green, yellow balloons, some tied in artfully packaged bundles, others just left floating around. On the right side corner were all of the photobooths and photo op stations, where cool neon signs and props were hung up for dance-goers to use. Katsuki remembered driving Izuku to the next town over, and the two of them messing around in the store instead of buying the props, and by the time they did, the stores were about to close. And so, as Katsuki looked at the neon sign that read *Love You* hanging on the wall, he's just reminded of the argument they had in the middle of the neon shop over whether they should buy the *Love You* sign for the dance or, Katsuki's vote, the *Fuck You* sign for the dance. Obviously, the nerd won that argument.

"Bakugo?" Hina tucked on his elbow.

And he turned his head down to her, "Yeah?"

“You were just kind of staring off into space, is everything alright?” She asked.

Katsuki nodded, and then looked around, “Looks like Mina’s got a table. Let’s set our stuff down.”
The dance was everything that everyone had imagined it to be, which was weird because usually, when you hype something up so much, it’s never as good as we think. And yet, the Spring Dance was absolutely great, and everyone gave their fair credit to the student council for organizing it. The food was great, the music was nice, and the atmosphere was lively. Everyone looked great too. So many dresses, suits, tuxes, or people who went some other unconventional route. Either way, the Spring Dance was perfectly done.

Katsuki danced to a couple of songs. Two with Hina, and that was fine since they weren’t actually talking and Katsuki was tall enough that he didn’t really look at her but instead, watched the door as if he was waiting for something, but he didn’t even know what he could be waiting for. Everything was here. For four years, all of the seniors waited for this day, that marked the last year of their high school careers. For four years, people wondered what they were going to wear and who they were going to go with to the Spring Dance.

He jumped wildly with some of his friends to about two other songs, just to get exhausted and chug water down afterwards, and it was a fun time, truly. But he kept looking at the damn door, and at some point, he flicked himself on the forehead to make him stop. At some point during the night, Katsuki spots Round Face walking off the dance floor to take a break. She was wearing a pretty pink dress that flared out and swept the floor a little bit, with a sweetheart neckline and dangly earrings.

Katsuki pretends to coincidentally walk past her, and then backtrack, walking backwards about two steps with his arm out. Christ, what the fuck was he doing.

“Oi, Uraraka,” Katsuki calls out over the music, matching her speed.

The girl stops at the sound of her name and turns, “Hm? Yeah-” Before she paused upon the sight of Katsuki and her jaw went slack. He didn’t understand her problem. Had he said something?

“Bakugo?” She went bug eyed, “What did you just call me?”

Oh, that was why. Goddamnit, Izuku was rubbing off on him. He only got away with calling the girl Round Face 50% of the time. The other 50%, Izuku forces him to correct himself or else he gets a slap on the wrist.

“It’s Uraraka!” Izuku would tell him exasperatedly.

“That’s a lot of r’s. You know what starts with an r? Round fa-” Katsuki would reply, and he’d get a slap on the wrist.

And so now, he tries to ignore the shocked face on the girl and just asks, “All your goons here?”

She looked around, wondering why Katsuki was asking, before looking up at the blonde with a nod, “Yeah! Iida and Shoto are with me. Well…” She frowned, “Everyone except Deku-kun.”

Katsuki looks around the crowd, listening to her even if his attention looks lost, “Yeah.”

“Which is kind of a shame because he helped plan this whole thing, you know?” Ochaco pouted.

Katsuki turns his attention back to her and grumbled, “I fucking know. It’s ridiculous.”

“It is,” Ochaco pulls out a pocket mirror from her clutch to retouch her blush, “He’s been dreaming of it for forever too.”

The blonde’s voice gets a little too quick to reply, “Has he.”

She nods as if Katsuki was stupid, “Yeah, it was like, the only night he thought he was going to get to wear something pretty and finally learn how to dance, and *lord* knows he needs it, haha,” She smiles brightly, “Oh my gosh, Bakugo, has he ever told you about the time we had to go dance in front of middle schoolers for service hours, and he sli…”

But Katsuki wasn’t paying attention to what she was saying after that point. It was the only night Izuku thought he was going to get to wear something pretty and finally learn how to dance. The one opportunity that the boy would have these four years to do so, and he’s stuck at home. Katsuki knows what he was about to do, he wasn’t thinking through. He definitely knows that he had spent $100 on his and Hina’s ticket combined, several hundred on this suit, and he knew that people had worked fucking hard on this dance. And then, from the DJ booth, Take Your Breath Away by Berlin was playing, and all Katsuki heard for two weeks was how Izuku was the one who requested this song, having wanted to dance to it here. And that was his last straw.

The blonde interrupts Ochaco in the middle of her story, “Sorry Round Face, I gotta go.”

And then he heads towards the table where some of their friends and his wallet and keys were. Grabbing them off the white cloth, he turned to Sero, “Oi, you ain’t here with a date, right?”

His friend looked a bit confused at the sudden rush in Katsuki’s tone, but nods, “Uh no, I’m not.”

Katsuki was a dickhead, he knows. But he gestures his head towards Hina, “She’s been stealing glances at you. You think she’s cute?”

His friend seemed a little flustered, “I mean, yeah.”

“Ask her for a dance,” Katsuki nudged him, “I’m leaving.”

“Leaving??” Sero turns around in his seat where Katsuki was heading out, “Where are you going?”

Katsuki wasn't sure how to answer this, and so instead, he just shouts back, "An afterparty." "Already?" Hanta Sero scoots his chair out to hear some response, but Katsuki was across the room.

As he was approaching the door, the blonde looked at the decorations around the door that formed an arch over it. There was another balloon arch in Ise's school colors, and on either side were stacked decorations from the 80s or just random items that looked like it would be from the time. An old letterman, draped on top of a jukebox. Cassettes and rubix cubes. And on the bottom right corner, a stereo speaker with an aux cord still connected. Was it a prop? Or…

He grabs it anyways before anyone could see. It wasn't a prop.

God, his mother was going to have his head for this.

It's 10:30 PM by the time his car revs onto Izuku's street, a little faster than he intended to drive, but Katsuki was afraid that if he lets himself think too long about why the fuck he was doing this, he'll come up with an answer he won't know what to do with. And so instead, Katsuki without a care in a damn world at how this looks, parks on the curb of the property behind some trees, and walks to the back where he had thrown the stereo. And plugging his phone into the aux via extension, he turns the thing on and pauses. Before typing in Take My Breath Away by Berlin.

And it played perfectly for about twenty seconds, before it paused and the connection broke for some damn reason even though the aux was still plugged in.

"Fuck," Katsuki cursed a little too loud.

He steps away from the car, and heads towards the lawn, all while messing with the buttons on the stereo. Although Katsuki liked 80s music and shit, he was glad he didn't have to live in the damn 80s and there was spotify these days. He sets it down on the asphalt for a second, trying to see what the hell was wrong, and kicked it to see if it'll realign a fucking wire or something. He hadn't expected it to actually work, but after a moment or two, it looked like his aux had connected again.

He restarts the song then, and jogs up onto the Midoriya household's front lawn. His dress shoes sunk into the grass, and he knew he looked like an idiot. He felt like an idiot, because who the *fuck* does this shit. It was nearly 11 at night, this street is definitely fucking asleep, and for some goddamn reason, Katsuki was here in front of Izuku's house with a cheesy 80s song playing on a shitty stereo speaker.

He looked up towards the window, to see that Izuku already had it open, mouth gaped as he stares. And Katsuki sets down the speaker.

Katsuki was already kind of fucked for being here in the first place, so he just decides to yell up, "Oi, nerd. You heard me coming down the street or something?"

Izuku says something down, trying to be quiet, but he couldn't hear the boy over the music.

"Can't hear you Deku!" He shouts up with his chest, "Come down here."

He sees Izuku look around, hair a little messy from being in bed, before talking a little louder, "Kacchan! I can't sneak out. She'll kill me!"

Katsuki grinned, "Oh, are you trying to be quiet and not wake her up? In that case, let me," He shouted louder, "yell louder! And turn the music up some more." It was killing his ears, but he wanted the nerd to meet him down here on the lawn.

"Besides," He practically had to yell, "Who said I was sneaking you out."

And so, the boy comes down, opening the white front door and stepping out on the porch. And Katsuki feels like *his* breath has been taken away. Tonight, he's seen plenty of gorgeous people, in all types of fancy, pretty, or handsome attire. He's seen long, flowy dresses embezzled in rhinestones, and he's seen silk tuxes. But none of them erased that feeling he experienced at the dance like something was missing quite like Izuku did. And that, Katsuki knew, was going to be a problem. And none of them made him feel anything like looking at Izuku now, with his oversized t-shirt and bare feet on the porch of his own home. And that, Katsuki knew, was also going to be a problem.

He turns the music down to a normal level.

"So what are you doing here? Aren't you supposed to be at the dance?" Izuku asks him, eyes wide.

Katsuki kicked the grass with his nice shoes, and he looked up at the sky. He really didn't want to stop and have to think about why he was doing this. Maybe because he was starting to view Izuku as more of a friend. But that wouldn't make much sense, especially when he didn't even talk to him in school, when he had other friends that he wouldn't have done this for. He doesn't want to think about it, "Well, I don't gotta be anywhere, Deku. No one tells me what to do."

Izuku grins at him incredulously, "You know what I meant, Kacchan."

He did. And *because* he knew what Izuku meant, he lied, "Got bored."

Katsuki just wants to dance. Izuku just wanted an explanation, which made sense. Katsuki probably would be persistent about one too, but he just didn't have one to give. They exchange words, and Katsuki noticed that because of the music, from behind Izuku, the front door quietly opens and Inko steps into the frame, just watching and trying to take in what was happening. He stares at her, even though Izuku was looking at him. Katsuki was not afraid of Inko, and he wasn't afraid to challenge her if need be, as kind as she can be.

Izuku was speaking, "...ow my mom's gonna freak out, right?"

"Not if I just stay here," Katsuki argued, and it felt like he was talking to both Inko and Izuku, "You told me you wanted to learn how to dance, right?"

“Huh?” Izuku asked.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “The other day, you fuc-...you freaking dimwit,” He didn’t want to curse like a sailor in front of the nerd’s mom, “you said you wanted to go to the dance to learn. Come on, nerd, I brought the dance to you, so get out here.” He paused, “I’ll show you.”

And then Katsuki held out his hand.

All Izuku had to do was take it.

And after some time, after a little more convincing--convincing Izuku that he looked fine as he was, which is true, that Katsuki would truly rather be here, which is also true--the boy takes his hand, and Katsuki was quick to pull him close. He wanted Izuku close to him, a feeling he couldn’t quite explain.

And as they begin dancing to the song that Izuku dreamed about dancing too for so long, the feeling that arose from that Katsuki couldn’t quite explain either. He just knew that he liked the feeling of swaying on the lawn with Izuku in his arms. Or jumping around, karaoking some of the more upbeat tracks.

This wasn’t the Spring Dance. There weren’t all of the allure, the decoration, or the friends that Izuku was probably imagining in his head all of these years, but Katsuki hoped this wasn’t too bad either. And when the sprinklers turn on, Katsuki towers over Izuku as they danced slowly in each other’s arms again, and Katsuki convinced himself that friends can do this. And friends can sing the words of this song, and not mean it. Because as Izuku was singing along to Bonnie Raitt’s I Can’t Make You Love Me, Katsuki couldn’t help but feel as if the boy sounded a little *too* intertwined with the lyrics. Or maybe that was just how he sings.

Either way, when Katsuki drives himself home that night, suit wet and ready to get a yelling from his mother, the only thing he can think of was the way those eyes looked at him near the end there, under the sprinkler mist, as if he had come to some sort of epiphany. He wonders what it was.

Katsuki was spiraling. He was spiraling and he didn’t even know if it was upwards or downwards. It feels like he has such a little grip on what he was doing, yet he was still doing it. Taking Izuku out on little expeditions that feel so out of the ordinary for him. Brushing his fingers up against the shorter’s cheek or placing a hand in the small of Izuku’s back too frequently. Dropping by just to see the nerd, even if it was five minutes in between something he had to do. Katsuki doesn’t remember the last time he’s been somewhere without Izuku. Ever since they had kissed in the back of Katsuki’s car, he couldn’t bring himself to look in someone else’s direction. He just knew that they wouldn’t do it for him. And then when he looks at Izuku, Katsuki also feels like he can’t fucking do anything about this strange

predicament because Izuku wasn't like that. They weren't like that, and if Izuku knows what's best for him, he'll never ask.

They were together all the damn time, that he barely saw any of his friends outside of practice.

The hag did actually threaten to kill him for what had happened at the dance.  And demanded to know where Katsuki had went instead that he couldn't have just brought Hina along, but Katsuki wasn't just going to say that he was at Midoriya Izuku's front lawn, slow dancing under the sprinklers. What kind of stupid shit was that. There was no way in hell Katsuki was going to tell his mother that, and so, instead, he just shrugs.

"You better be lucky that Hina had a good time with your friend Sero," Mitsuki had berated him, and honestly, Katsuki owed Sero one for that.

In return for ditching his date essentially, Mitsuki was sending him off to his grandfather's farm to run some errands. To be fair, since the man fell sick, she was going to send him out there anyways, but this way, it sounded more like a punishment now than a suggestion. And Katuski usually hated when other people worked with him. That's why he didn't play true team sports. Sure, pole vault was a team, but there was no collaborative effort towards winning as a group. At the end of the day, it was him and him only that was in charge of his performance. Same thing applied to group projects and what not. And so, the fact that he had texted Inko Midoriya the evening before, asking if Izuku could have permission to go work on a farm with him, felt out of character for Katsuki, and it was like he didn't understand himself these days. Or why he was doing things so out of the ordinary. Katsuki made the text sound as good as possible: They'll learn the value of a dollar through hard work and intense labor, and what not. Parents liked to hear that shit, and so Inko ate it up.

"Oh yeah," Katsuki stands in front of his grandfather's door, about to introduce Izuku, "This is…"

And then he stops. What was he going to say. This is Deku? This is the nerd, the shitty nerd much less? No, Katsuki couldn't say any of that. From the side, Katsuki knew that the boy was looking at him, as if understanding the conundrum, and Katsuki sees Izuku open his lips as if about to do it himself to spare Katsuki the trouble of saying his name.

But Katsuki just says it, because the fact that Izuku was just going to do it himself to spare *him* the trouble of doing something as simple as saying the nerd's damn name made him look pathetic. As if Katsuki couldn't even fathom saying something as filthy as

"Izuku," Katsuki lets it roll on his tongue, and it felt so unused, "Midoriya Izuku."

The blonde doesn't look at Izuku, not wanting to see the other's reaction, and keeps his face as blank as possible.

Katsuki's grandfather had always thought he was a better person than he was, and always thought he was capable of more than he actually was. It was sweet, Katsuki guesses, but naive. Even from a young age, the moment the older man gave him the vinyl, he said that

sure, Katsuki wants to love. Sure, Katsuki could sweep someone off their feet. But all of that was never true. Just the words of an old man eager to have great grandkids.

The evening at the farm did nothing to make Katsuki get sick of the nerd, even after spending the entire day from the crack of dawn to late that night with the boy. If anything, it heightened his desire to be around izuku. When Katsuki picks up the boy from the waist and turns him around in the air just to pull him close, the blonde takes in every fucking detail. The slightly rused hair. A small hair of corn that got stuck in there. Lashes that framed such large eyes that were looking at him now with an adoration that katsuki didn't fucking deserve. Lips that were pink and freckles that were plentiful. There was a gorgeous wheat field surrounding them, and yet, Katsuki couldn't fucking stop looking at Izuku. And then that strange feeling in his chest arose again, and when Izuku asks the blonde to say his name again, Katsuki does so.

*Izuku* .

Izuku, Izuku, Izuku.

Izuku was still going on dates with Kaito Sen. And everytime he hears, his fists clench a little. Kaito, with his cunning smile, his lawyer family, his 'gentleman' like approaches. Katsuki was sick of the guy.

But Izuku wasn't. And that was the part that he could do nothing about. It wasn't his business. All he could do was make snarky comments, and ignore the smug look in the locker room that the brunette gives him when they slide past. Was that supposed to do something? Katsuki wanted to laugh at the piece of shit. And potentially stomp his face in, but he knew he couldn't. Because Izuku. Izuku liked him. Or at least enough to go on dates with the bastard.

It was an unassuming Thursday when it decided to finally rain in Ise.

And it was an unassuming Thursday when they blew up at each other for the first serious time since this entire project started. It's been building. Something has. Ever since the night that Katsuki brought the dance to Izuku's house, something just kind of *shifted* . They were closer than ever, Katsuki will admit that, and yet, there were just some things that were wrong, or felt wrong.

They never spoke to each other within school. It was like Izuku didn't exist there. Katsuki knew that if he let himself actually talk to the other during school, then he wasn't going to be able to be as harsh while talking to the other as he used to be. He wasn't going to be able to stop himself from laughing, maybe even grinning like an idiot. And what Katsuki refused to have happen is for people to see him like that, with Midoriya of all people. And so, no matter how close they got outside of Ise High, within it, it was as if they were strangers.

And then there was the absolute lack of acknowledgement between the two of them. At this point, they were hanging out as many times in the week as they could. Katsuki barely even knocked anymore. He just climbs in through the window, which Izuku has decided to just keep open because of this. The blonde knew what the nerd disliked and what he *did* like, what his favorite childhood memory is, and what flavor of starburst he preferred. And yet, they've never even acknowledged once that they were friends. Project partners. That's the term Katsuki always used when he was speaking in reference to the two of them, and he could see Izuku cringe a bit beside him. They both never said what they wanted to say, and that was just a volcano waiting to erupt.

And it does. Badly. And suddenly, it was humid, nighttime, and wet in the parking lot of Ise High on that Thursday night, and Izuku was crying because of him.

*Not everyone is emotionally fucked up in the head, Kacchan.* Words were thrown fucking everywhere, left and right from the both of them. *You're just as fucked up as I am, Deku.* Izuku attacked him from every angle, and forced him to listen to his own fucking issues as he listed them out. And out of anger, Katsuki did the same. He did the same because he didn't know what the fuck else to do. Sit there? As Izuku tears away each one of his layers and is not wrong about a single thing?
The green eyed boy was not wrong about a single thing. Emotionally fucked up? That was him. A coward when it came to shit like this? That was him. Guilty and insecure, which was why he couldn't fucking fathom that Izuku wanted to be friends with him for so long? That was him. Everything that the damn boy said, it was him.

And how was he supposed to reply to that? Feeling as if his mind had been raided, Katsuki out of anger did the same. He calls Izuku out. On his complicitness. On his pathetic worldview that anger was a bad emotion. He calls Izuku out for letting everyone in the fucking world step all over him, including him. He destroys any image of comfort Izuku might have had. And they argue, only for Izuku to be reduced to tears and for Katsuki to have his nonchalant front destroyed.

By the end, Katsuki feels like he's got some clarity. That he's a little fucked up in the head, and could probably try to be a bit more outwardly open. That Izuku was also a little fucked up in the head, and could probably try to stand up for himself. Katsuki didn't even appreciate the conversation until the climax of it was over, and the two of them had simmered to a quiet resolution of promises to try harder. It was only then that Katsuki took in everything that Izuku said in a way that wasn't as defensive.

And just as Katsuki's been showing the doe-eyed boy how to fly, it felt like in moments like these, Izuku was grounding him. And he wasn't sure if he was retrospectively labeled.

When the cop, Mr. Hadashi, comes onto the scene, and Izuku had found out what happened with the 911 call, Katsuki watches for one of the few rare moments, as absolute deadly rage that's been in storage gets dethawed, and Katsuki steps back, knowing that this was going to be difficult.

He hadn't expected to end up seeing Izuku later that same exact night, at least two hours or so later, crying and soaking wet from the rain. Katsuki's stomach dropped, and he ushered the boy inside. And when Izuku began to cry some more, Katsuki could only make sure he was

going to be dry and not sick, and towel his hair. And when it doesn't seem like Izuku wanted to rehash what had happened in his home, Katsuki doesn't push him, just understanding already how the conversation went.

But when Izuku asked him to stay in bed with him, that was different. Because that was something that crossed the line a little. That was something that ventured into a zone Katsuki wasn't quite familiar with. And yet he does it anyways.

And when Izuku asks the blonde to hold him, *that* was different. Because that wasn't just venturing into an unknown territory. That was deep in the unknown territory. One that Katsuki didn't have experience navigating. How could Katsuki hold the nerd, without having that strange feeling in his chest arise again that he didn't want. And yet, later, he did it anyways.

But when the doe-eyed boy asks Katsuki to fuck him, that was something Katsuki knew how to do. The blonde knew how to fuck, and he knew how to do it well. He knows that he'd be able to make Izuku scream his name, make him feel good, make him cum at just his fingers if he wanted to. He knows that *this* he could do. And yet, he can't. He won't. And it wasn't even the fucking matter of attraction. As Izuku grinds his hips down on him, reaching up to play with his own nipples, Katsuki was enamoured. He wanted *his* mouth where izuku's puffy nipples were, he wanted his cock inside of the boy then and there, he wanted to hear more of those breathy moans. But he doesn't, because Izuku doesn't want this, and Izuku doesn't want *him* .

The boy was just distraught and hung up over a tough conversation that's long overdue, and sex would only be a way to distract him while he's emotionally unstable. Katsuki couldn't do that. He wouldn't. Because sober, Izuku would never fucking want him. And even if he did, Katsuki knew that the boy wasn't the type to comply with Katsuki's style of sex. The emotionless, rough sex that left nothing behind: just pleasure. Izuku was too sweet for that, too good for that.

So even when the greenette claimed that he gave great head, and his first thought went straight to Kaito Sen and it made his blood boil, Katsuki had to fucking control himself like crazy. Because hearing it made him want to kill Kaito. Just imagining those lips, sucking someone else's cock, drinking someone else's cum, much less Kaito's, made Katsuki want to fuck the boy into his mattress so hard that he'd forget all about what Kaito could do for him. And yet, he doesn't. Because Izuku doesn't want him. In the morning, he'll wish he never even asked. Katsuki was sure.

As per his promise, Katsuki begins to try. And his first step was him accepting the stupid bottle of cherry gatorade, right in front of the entire team. He knew they were watching as Izuku entered through the gate, likely surprised because they've never seen the boy in here before. And as he approaches, Katsuki stands still, as he hears the whispers behind him increase. They were likely expecting some kind of fight to break out. But all that happens is that the boy with the big green eyes comes up to him, hands him a bottle of cherry gatorade. And he accepts it. More than accepting it, he asks Izuku to stay. It was a first step.

His second step was to admit they were friends. If not to anyone else, then to himself. And when he sat down and thought about it, they were probably best friends? Was he allowed to call Izuku that? The thought of having a best friend made Katsuki internally a little giddy, but he shoves that down quickly out of habit. And when he realized that he had locked away that giddiness, Katsuki sat on his coach and groaned, “Shit.” Izuku’s words were fucking getting to him. He had promised the nerd. He had promised that he’ll try not to tell any feeling of joy and genuinity to fuck off as he usually did. And yet, it was so easy to.

“Is something wrong, Katsuki?” His dad crossed the living room with a can of ginger ale in his hands.

“Mom’s gonna kill you if she sees you with that,” Katsuki peeks his eyes from above where he had his face buried in his palms.

His parents are both on some health nut phase right now, and had made a little pact between the two of them to not drink any more sodas or buy chips around the house. But since Katsuki made no such pact, he bought whatever junk he wanted. He ate healthy, sure. He was an athlete after all, but he wasn’t going to stop himself from having a soda or some junk food when he needed it. Besides, those foods help him bulk and look even bigger.

Masaru gives him a funny grin and shrugs, “That’s why I’m drinking it while she’s out.”

“What if I tell her,” Katsuki jokes with his dad.

The man frowns, “That wouldn’t be very nice of you.”

Katsuki snorts. Wouldn’t be very nice of him, huh. Because kindness is just what *everyone* expects from him.

“Anyways,” Masaru shifts as if nervous to ask, “Was something wrong? You look a little frustrated.”

Katsuki leans back into the coach and stares up at the ceiling, “Nothing.”

Like he was expecting that answer, his dad nods, patting the side of his can of ginger ale, before just accepting that for the millionth time, his kid doesn’t like to talk, “In that case, you don’t mind if I go finish my episode of Game of Thrones, do ya?” He laughs.

Katsuki sighed to himself then closed his eyes. And he did it again. This was his own dad for fuck’s sake, and he couldn’t even… And he couldn’t even fucking talk to him?

“Wait,” Katsuki says, eyes still closed as his head was pointed towards the ceiling, “Wait.”

He hears Masaru sit back down carefully, and stammer out a “Yes?”

“First,” Katsuki looks at the man, “Can you stop acting like I’m going to blow up any second? Jesus fucking Christ, Mom doesn’t act like this and you don’t see me biting her head off.”

“Yeah, well,” Masaru waved the can around, “Mom’s a little different. She can handle all your energy. I’m a frail man.” He laughs.

“Second,” Katsuki pauses, not knowing how to word this without sounding fucking pathetic. And then he sighs. He can’t fucking do this. No, he has to, or at least he has to try, “How do I know if someone is my friend? Or my best friend?”

“Oh,” The man replies, “That’s unexpected.”

Katsuki rolls his eyes and sits up, leaning over on his knees and asks, “Whatever. So? How do I know, old man.”

“That’s too broad,” He waves the can around, talking with wide hand motions, “What are you confused about?”

Katsuki then leans back again, and kicks his feet on the coffee table, not able to keep still, “All of it. All this shit is confusing. Because Kiri, yeah? I hang out with him more than I do the other vaulters. We text back and forth, and I’m pretty close with him, even though we don’t talk about deep shit. But I don’t gotta be all sappy and shit to be best friends, do ya?”

“It sounds like he’s a close friend then. No, you don’t have to, even though it’d be good,” Masaru comments, “What’s so confusing about that?”

“Right. See, yeah. Sure, whatever. Kiri is a close friend, then. Sure,” And then Katsuki bounces his left leg, “I’m confused about this. Is there a *scale* of being best friends or something?”

“A scale?” Masaru looked a bit confused.

“Shit,” Katsuki thumbs his bottom lip as he looks at the grandfather clock, “I fucking suck at this.” He grumbles.

The older man scoots in a bit, and tries to help, “Try...Try starting with this. It looks like there’s something you have in mind. Try describing that? Rather than beginning from abstract concepts.”
It was a very fashion designer response of him.

Katsuki nods to himself, “Right. Right. That’s a good idea. Fuck. Um,” He thinks he can describe it, “Let’s say I got a friend, yeah?”

“Okay,” His dad nods along, looking like he was trying really hard not to ruin the good streak they were on.

“And I hang out with this dude like all the fucking time,” Katsuki finds it easier now to get a direction, “All the fucking time, and when I’m not, I think about where I want to go the next time we chill.”

“Sounds like a really good friend,” Maseru chimes, making small commentary to keep Katsuki going.

“And I’m doing shit that I never fucking do, now. Like dipping fries in my ice cream, because the nerd convinced me and it ain't half bad,” Katsuki didn’t even realized he slipped the nickname, “Or ditch everything for him. And I don’t even fucking know why I ditch everything for him. Parties. And whatever else. You remember the Spring Dance that mom bitched to me about? I ditched it to go dance with him.”

“Huh.” Masaru’s brows were furrowed now, but he nodded along, “Sounds like a *really* good friend.”

“And sometimes, when I see the dude do something stupid or funny, there this feeling in my chest, and it’s like it’s twisting and tickling me. I keep wanting to do dumb shit, like touch his hair or his stupid freckles. Or go stationery shopping with him even though I hate stationery. And I kissed him, and it didn’t feel normal.”

Masaru chokes on his drink, and Katsuki furrows his brows at the reaction. Can his fucking dad not drink soda correctly?

“Relax,” Katsuki rolled his eyes, “The context was platonic.”

After a couple more moments of calming down after his coughs, the man adjusted his glasses and cleared his throat one last time for good measure, “Katsuki, are you talking about Izuku?”
“No,” Katsuki straight up denies.

“You called this friend a…” Masaru purses his lips, “...a nerd.”

Katsuki shifted in his seat uncomfortably. Had he? “Listen, it don’t fucking matter who it is. I just wanna know on which scale of friendship this is. Because I don’t know what to call him, but I’m not stupid enough to just call him a regular bud.”

At the end of his spiel, Katsuki stares down his father, who sits there, looking at him through those wide rim glasses. He takes a sip from the ginger ale before looking at one of the magazines on the coffee table.

Masaru looked at a loss, and when he spoke, his tone was genuine, “This is hard. There’s a possibility you might be in lo-” He pauses, and then waves the notion away, “but then that doesn’t really make any sense with how you are. No, that’s not it.”

“What doesn’t,” Katsuki asks.

His father paused in his thoughts, before turning to him, “Katuki, do you think there’s any chance you might be in love?”

Love. Katsuki shuts that down as immediately as it’s suggested. He wasn’t built for that. Katsuki understood his own limitations to a certain degree, which meant that he understood that he just didn’t fit the mold of a person who can love someone, or at least love them well. He thinks back to what his mother had told him all those years ago. *You can’t love someone if you’re like this* . She was right, and he didn’t mind. Not having love hasn’t killed him so far.

Katsuki looks at the titanium ring in his index finger, “Nah.”

His father nods, “ That’s what I kind of thought. It wouldn’t really make sense for you, but…” He looked up through the glasses, “There’s no need to call it anything at the moment, son. You can just call him a close friend, it seems.”

Katsuki muttered it under his breath. A close friend. His bestest friend, even. He guesses it makes sense. They were always with each other, and what not. The rest of what he described probably fell into that category somehow.

And so, Katsuki begins to refer to Izuku internally as his closest friend. So that maybe one of these days, he might be able to say it out loud. He wonders what the green eyed boy will think then. He’d probably think Katsuki had made a lot of progress, and the thought of that makes Katsuki a little excited against his will.

The following weeks after the complete meltdown between Izuku and his mother, Katsuki is there in the aftermath of the destruction. It rains a lot, so much that the drainage system was flooding. But the two boys make do with what they have. Ise was known for its pretty sunsets and warm clear skies, so the days and days of constant rain threw the town off balance. And yet, Katsuki and Izuku went out like normal. Without rainjackets, running to the playground and using the slide as a waterslide.

“Kacchan, you slide down two feet and you’re already at the bottom,” Izuku laughs over the warm, prickling rain.

It was true. His legs were long enough that it wasn’t exactly much of a slide unless he bent his knees.

“They need to make playgrounds for adults,” Katsuki complains, “You think these stupid brats need it more than adults do?”

Izuku ran a hand through his matted green hair and brushes the water out of his face, “Hm, you’re right. We need it way more. Little kids don’t even pay taxes!”

“Nerd, *you* don’t pay taxes yet either,” Katsuki ruffled the wet hair.

They do what they can to distract from the somber mood of the rain. Sometimes, Izuku would just come over and they’d sit on the couch talking or doing their own thing. At some point, the greenette began to lay his head down on Katsuki’s lap. The first time Izuku did it, Katsuki looked down to see that the boy was looking down at his fingernails which lay next to his head, as if waiting to get kicked off. Katsuki says nothing, and stares back up at the sky. He didn’t mind. And then, the touches raise in levels a little each time. Maybe Izuku plays with Katsuki’s rough fingers one day. And another day, the hem of his pants.

And then the next time, when Izuku lays on his lap, it was Katsuki who hesitantly decides to reach down and run his fingers through the soft green tufts of hair. It was soft, and he hopes that when he pulls away, the faint scent of lilies stay on his fingertips.

At some point, Izuku falls asleep, and his soft breathing can barely be heard over the gentle rain outside. Katsuki's leg was falling asleep, but he didn't want to wake the other, and so he just waits it out. When asleep, Izuku's cheeks puff out even more, and it looked really fucking cute.

Katsuki sneered to himself, and before he knew it, he was pulling out his phone to take a picture. He caught a good one, and Izuku looked so peaceful. He mindlessly pulled up Inko's contact, and sent the woman the picture. Thinking of what to text along with it, Katsuki decides to just go *fuck it* .

He types out a quick message, 'Look at him. He's fucking fine.' There was no need for the woman to worry. The nerd could take care of himself. He knew as a fact that ever since they fell off, Inko was likely going crazy out of her mind, wondering where Izuku went on days like this where he would come over to Katsuki's place early in the morning and wouldn't leave until late at night. It wasn't Katsuki's responsibility to tell her, and the thought of that woman panicking over her sweet baby boy satisfied the slight sadist in him. And yet, he sends it anyways, hoping that if nothing else, Auntie could see that Izuku won't just die if he wasn't attached to her hip every second. He hadn't expected it to become an actual habit down the road, but at some point, it did. A picture, then those same lines. Another pictures, but those same lines.

The car was fucking *loud* , and Katsuki was annoyed that he was carpooling with two other people to the drive-in diner: Denki and Gunta. They had their own rides back, but on the way *there* , all of the other cars had already gone on ahead by about one minute, so Katsuki was stuck having to drive the two idiots to the diner. Once in a while, most of Ise High's pole vault team goes out on a little dinner trip, and all pile up in each other's cars to go grab some grub. Today, the crew had decided to go to a drive-in diner called Ben's Burgers & Shakes. Katsuki had been there once, and thought the food was only alright. He grew up on Hana's Diner so Katsuki was a bit biased, but since the whole team except for Fuck Face was going, he was going to go as well. Katsuki was the team captain, and highkey the team's second coach.

"Yo, yo! Look at the new mod I just got," Denki shouts to the front seats, slapping Katsuki and Gunta on the arms.

Katsuki shouted to the back, "I'm fucking driving right now."

"We're literally almost there," Denki frowns and points out the turn in front of them.

Katsuki takes it and enters the property that the drive in diner was at, already seeing a couple of cars from the team just now pulling up as well, "We ain't all gonna fit our cars on this side. Some people are gonna have to park on the opposite side."

The blonde cuts in front of a car and parks on the same side as most of the team, so that he didn't have to drive around to the other side where there were more slots, but just across the grass medium that separated the two sides.

“Well, we got one,” Gunta pats the car a good job, before stretching his neck to look, “Sero and Kaito’s car is stuck on the other side.”

Katsuki furrowed his brows, “Fuck Face? He ain’t coming.”

“No, I’m pretty sure that’s his car,” Gunta points out across the grass medium.

Katsuki looked to where he was pointing.

Denki shouted from beside his seat, “Holy fuck! Is that Midoriya and Kaito?”

The blonde sees it at the exact same time Denki practically screamed in his ear, and his jaw immediately clenched shut. If his tongue had been in the way, it would be cut off. His hands on the driving stick suddenly tightened, as his eyes spot a familiar white car. And Kaito Sen was *all* over Izuku. This twisted, sick feeling enters his gut, and Katsuki’s jaw was beginning to hurt from clenching so tight.

He watches, as Kaito has a hand at the base of Izuku’s neck, pulling into a kiss that was way too deep for a drive-in diner where everyone was *literally* in their damn car to eat. Those hands explore Izuku’s body, roaming down to slip the boy’s shirt so that it slid slightly off of his shoulders, before Fuck Face moved down to nip of the greenette’s jaw.

This piece of shit. Kaito Sen *knew* exactly where the team would be tonight, and he coincidentally just wanted to bring his date here too? Katsuki smells bullshit in the air, but apparently nobody else did. Because from the other cars, including his own, everyone else opened their doors and began to whoop and holler. A big group of the vaulters gathered together before yelling out to Kaito and Izuku all sorts of things. Taking a breath, Katsuki opens his own door and walks out, typical blankness on his face.

As he approaches where the group already formed around Kaito’s car, he catches Izuku’s eye through the windshield. The nerd looked a little confused. Katsuki just raised a brow, before turning his eyes back to Kaito, who looked just a little *too* smug. God, the twisting feeling in his gut just won’t fucking go away.

And it doesn’t go away throughout the night either. Even as he manages to get jabs in at Kaito a couple of times, it didn’t make Katsuki feel any better. And internally, he believes it was because he could do and think all he wanted about the brunette. But at the end of the day, he could do nothing to make Izuku think the same.

The only time Katsuki felt like he was a bit back to normal was when they were climbing the bell tower later that night, because Kaito Sen wasn’t fucking there. He wasn’t there to snake his arms around Izuku’s waist, or place some kisses on the boy’s nape when he thought no one was looking. Kaito wasn’t there to so easily kiss the greenette where Katsuki could watch, and *fuck* , he needed to stop giving a shit.

“Are you going to be...this close the entire time?” Izuku asked him breathily in the dark, as they ascended the stairs. Katsuki had switched their positions so that the shorter was in front, with Katsuki behind, in case he fell back. Then it would be easier for Katsuki to catch Izuku, than for Izuku to catch Katsuki, who was taller and heavier.

The blonde didn't think he was too close. He could be *much* closer.

He raised a brow, "Why? You want me to back off?" And then his mind flashed back to the car, and so he bent down right behind Izuku, whispering with a small growl, "You didn't seem to have a problem being real fucking close with Fuck Face, earlier."

"That's different," Izuku tells him, almost breathlessly. Katsuki likes that sound.

"Oh? Is it?" Katsuki asked, and before he could stop himself, his arms reached out and held Izuku's waist from behind, and pushed into the side of the wall. Izuku lets out a yelp.

Katsuki moved his lips down near Izuku's ear, and he notices the greenette has no resistance to him.

"K-Kacchan?" Izuku's voice was so breathy. *Fuck* .

"I want to know," Katsuki's hands slipped under Izuku's shirt, massaging his thumbs into Izuku's bare skin, feeling just how *soft* the skin was. He buries his lips into Izuku's soft hair, taking in the scent like a madman, "how it's different. Tell me, Deku, is it because you're just that into him?"

Was the nerd just *so* into Kaito that being in this position with Katsuki did nothing?

"T-That's not it," Izuku says, breathing a little heavily, and *fuck fuck fuck fuck fuck.* Katsuki needed to stop now. Izuku was his friend. Izuku was his closest fucking friend. He can't be doing this, pressing the boy up against the stairwell, feeling around the skin of his waist and burying his nose into the smaller's hair. He can't fucking be doing this. And so he lets go.

"No?" He sounds satisfied, "I guess that's good enough for me, then." Before letting the boy go.

They watched the meteor shower that night. Trickles of white light cutting its way through the emptiness of the night sky. In Ise, where there weren't skyscrapers with twinkling lights or hundreds of cars to pollute the sky, it was the ultimate place to view a meteor shower. They were priveledged enough to live in such a place for rare moments like this. Only a fool would look away, when the entire cosmos and its stars were dancing for them to see. Only a fool would not even try to look. And so, as Katsuki sat there, on the ledge of the bell tower, and as he watched Izuku's eyes light up at the sight of the meteor shower, Katsuki knew he probably should be watching too. After all, it wasn't as if meteor showers came across often. But he couldn't. He just couldn't, because the way Izuku looked absolutely in awe watching the heavens cry silver tears, was more hypnotizing.

And when Katsuki takes him back home that early morning, he asks himself since when did Izuku's eyes begin to look a little beautiful.

The following Friday, the much awaited county fair comes around.

Izuku arrives with Kaito, and that twisting feeling in his gut comes up again. They looked good together, and that was what Katsuki disliked the most. When the group parted ways, the blonde would only see them once in a while if their respective groups passed by. However, each time, Katsuki finds himself not wanting to look.

Because when he did, that *prickling* feeling arises, and he fucking hated it. Kaito, who could make Izuku laugh. Kaito, who the greenette liked enough to have gone out with him several times now. God, Katsuki didn't get how thinking of them together could bother him so much, when it wasn't any of his business. He tries not to let it get to him. He fucking doesn't, but when all of the groups met back up with each other to get food, he couldn't avoid it. He couldn't avoid how the two of them looked so good together that Katsuki couldn't even deny it.

When he walks past to throw his trash away, Katsuki hears it then.

Kaito's voice tells Izuku, "My favorite thing about you are your eyes, you know."

And he stops. Katsuki stops in his tracks, and oddly enough, his heart begins to thump a bit faster in his chest. And he just wanted to hear Izuku's response to this. Throughout their entire partnership, all Katsuki had done was insult his eyes. And for the boy who Izuku liked enough to go out with a couple of times to finally tell Izuku that his favorite thing about the nerd were his eyes, Katsuki just wanted to know.

Izuku seemed to pause, and Katsuki heard the smaller say, "Oh."

*Oh* . That was it.

Kaito speaks up, "What is it?"

And then, Izuku laughs gently, "No, I guess I'm just a little surprised. I don't hear that a lot, so…" He pauses, "It's really nice."

And he gives this *stunning* smile at Kaito, as if the comment made him happy beyond anything.

Katsuki drops his trash, and leaves.

And when he goes back to where he was sitting before, the blonde just didn't want to think. The knuckles on his hands keep moving, and he sits with his knees up, feet spread out and his elbows resting on either knee as he stares straight at the ground. Kaito likes, even loves, Izuku's eyes. Where all he's ever said was they were creepy, ugly, repulsive. And Izuku, in response, sounded so genuinely fucking happy when the brunette told him that. So happy, that Katsuki knew it must have been because he himself had failed to do the same for Izuku. Close friends. He's been really shit at it.

How did he tell Izuku to wait for him. To wait for him, because every single fucking day, Izuku's eyes are a little less terrifying to him because of how expressive they were. Each day,

he gets used to the emotion that they show. How did he explain to the boy that he thinks his eyes are pretty too.

*I like them too* , Katsuki lets out a breath as he thinks out loud, wishing that he could say the shit he thought of, *It's not just him. I like them too. It's not just him.*

"Do you love him?" Katsuki asks Izuku, not understand how he didn't even fucking think before asking. But he just needed to know.

Izuku's eyes widened at this question, and Katsuki wonders if the boy could see the internal anxiety he had while he waited for Izuku to answer, "You obviously don't know what love is if you can ask me that." Izuku said softly.

Maybe he didn't. No, he definitely didn't, but it's used in contexts like these, right? When Izuku smiles at Kaito like that, and walk around the fair with the brunette like that. When they talk to each other like that. Kaito didn't insult Izuku, or banter with him all the damn time, or anything like that with Izuku. Maybe Izuku likes that more.

"Maybe I don't," Katsuki quickly says, "Answer me regardless."

It takes a moment, as Izuku looks like he was trying to decipher him. Katsuki couldn't even fucking decipher himself at the moment, and his brain was in shambles.

"I don't," The greenette replies, and Katsuki feels as if he could breathe again.

Kaito comes to take Izuku away again a moment later. They were going to the ferris wheel. In the movies, the two people on a date always kissed at the top of the ferris wheel, Katsuki thinks. And that stupid, fucking feeling comes back. God, he wanted to get rid of it so badly. And so Katsuki closed his eyes, took a breath, and forced himself to return to normal. Cool, collected.

As they walked away, Katsuki noticed something fell from his teammate's pocket: a wallet.

"Oi, Fuck Face," Katsuki called out.

The brunette in question turns around, asking with an irritated voice, "What is it, Cap?"

He rolled his eyes, "You dropped your damn wallet."

At this, the guy's face looked a little sheepish, and he began to walk back.

Katsuki bends down to pick it up for his teammate, but as he reached for the wallet, he notices its contents. He picked it up by the middle and just held it in his hands. A condom was tucked into the clear pocket alongside a packet of lube.

His face is blank as he stares at it. Plenty of people kept condoms in their wallets. He did, even. But Katsuki just knew this was for Izuku. And that thought should not have bothered him. After all, it wasn't his damn business. But as he stands up and drops the wallet in Kaito's hand, all he could think of was the guy in front of him in bed with Izuku, and suddenly, this fair wasn't very fun anymore.

“Hopefully, I get lucky tonight, you know what I mean?” Kaito mentions to him. And he doesn’t respond, because he doesn’t know what he’ll do if he lets himself say a damn word to Kaito Sen.

And Katsuki shouldn’t have said anything to Izuku either, when the green haired boy comes back to throw his wrapper away. But he ends up stopping the other anyways, and asks a question he shouldn’t have, “You’re gonna let him fuck you?”

And when Izuku tells him maybe, Katsuki wishes he hadn’t fucking asked.

Because for however long he was at the damn county fair next, it was all he could think about. Goddamnit, God *dammnit* . Katsuki’s head was a mess, and he walked around with a group of people, yet didn’t hear a word they said. All of it was white noise to his ears. He was quieter than usual, but it wasn’t as if his head was filled with many thoughts. Rather, he was so damn focused on feeling nothing that he couldn’t concentrate on anything else. He knew Izuku wanted him to better express his emotions, but he wasn’t prepared for this. He internally apologized to the boy, but Katsuki couldn’t fucking do this tonight. Deal with all of the thoughts. He tries to block it out. To go back to feeling nothing, where he was safe, where he’d be fine.

But when Katsuki, still with a group of people, sees Izuku sitting by himself near a bench, seemingly waiting for Kaito, who was likely in the bathroom or getting something, the floodgates that held back all of his thoughts broke. And Katsuki lost control of his thoughts, that shuffled from Izuku being with Kaito tonight, it not being his fucking business, then back to the though to the greenette being fucked by Kaito, and then to the whole ordeal about the eyes. And how he must have caused Izuku all this time to think he was ugly, when he wasn’t. *Fuck* , Izuku wasn’t. And then, he thought about how many other things he may have done, might have said. And *goddamnit,* he wanted to be good to Izuku too. He wanted to show the boy that he could be a good friend as well. So that Izuku could smile at him the way that he smiled at Kaito, when the brunette told him his eyes were his favorite things. He wanted Izuku to smile at him like that too.

*Smile at me like that too,* Katsuki wanted to tell him. But *how* . Fuck, how. How. How. Ho-

Oh.

Katsuki doesn’t stop. He makes his way over to where the doe-eyed boy was sitting. “Fuck it,” He mutters.

When he got near enough, Katsuki reached for Izuku’s hand and began to pull the other up and towards the edge of the fairgrounds.

Izuku stumbled behind, “Kacchan? Is everything okay?”

“Let’s leave,” He says. He wanted to leave. His palms were sweating.

“Wait, what?” Izuku stammered.

“Let’s go. Let’s get out of here,” It was all that Katsuki felt he could say.

“Again,” Izuku asked as they pushed through people, “Is everything okay?”

*No.* He couldn’t make the right decisions. Any of them. Everyone was right. He was a shitty person. If he was any better of a person, he wouldn’t fucking feel this way. He would have left Izuku to be where he was clearly happy. But Katsuki was selfish by nature. And he wanted his chance, to prove that he cared too. That he could treat him well too.

“Everything’s fi- It’s pe-…” Katsuki couldn’t fucking control his tongue, and it scared the shit out of him. Because he wasn’t this person. He was articulate, cunning, whatnot. He didn’t fucking stutter, and so this? This frustrated him, “Nothing’s wro- Fuck. Everything’s fine, okay? Let’s just go somewhere. Get out of Ise for a little bit. Just leave this town with me for a night. We can come back in the morning.”

Izuku sputtered, eyes wide.

Katsuki could tell him now. But the atmosphere was so hectic. Noise everywhere. Should he tell Izuku now? Your eyes are pretty. Your eyes are fucking pretty. Should he tell him now? Would that be okay? He hadn’t realized that he looked so fucking frantic.

Izuku shakes his head, “Kacchan, I can’t just do that right now. I’m literally here with someone. I can’t just leave Kaito.”

Kaito, who told Izuku that his eyes were pretty. He could tell him now. But would it scared him away? Everything: the air, the atmosphere, it was so hectic. So loud. The fair music from different stalls blending in together.

“Leave him,” Katsuki tells Izuku, “Text him you’re not feeling well.”

Izuku looked at him like he was insane, “Kacchan, I can’t just do that.”

“And why not,” Katsuki argued. He just wanted to fucking leave.

Izuku looked at him now with concern evident, “Kacchan, what is up with you right now? Why do we have to leave?”

“Nothing’s up,” Katsuki states. He was conditioned to lying. It was the first thing he thought to do.

Izuku frowns, “You’re obviously lying. I told you that you need to be okay with openin-”

“It’s fucking hard, okay?” He frustratedly says, “I don’t even know…” And stops, looking around and wishing that he could unjumble all of these goddamn thoughts apart, “I don’t even fucking know what I’m feeling. I don’t fucking know okay? I just don’t want to be here.”

Katsuki needed a moment. To breath. This environment was driving him nuts, so Katsuki steps back and takes a deep breath. He was just overwhelmed. This happened. He needed to calm the fuck down, and so for a little bit, they just stand there as Katsuki forces himself to

take deep breaths. When he feels a bit better, he realizes their situation. To Izuku, this entire last few minutes must have been confusing and outright baffling. One moment, he was sitting there. The next, Katsuki was dragging him away insisting that they leave. Fuck.

Finally, the blonde, after calming down a bit, just tells him, “If you want to stay here, I shouldn’t make you leave. I’ll go. You can find your way back to wherever Kaito is, right?” He doesn’t bother calling the guy Fuck Face.

But Izuku doesn’t move from his spot, just stares up at him.

“Well what are you waiting for,” The blonde spoke, “I fucking dragged you away. Go back before the fucker wonders where you went.” He needed Izuku to leave now, before he gained any semblance of hope that the other would stay.

Izuku was conflicted. He knew he shouldn’t. But he wasn’t perfect. In some ways, Izuku was the asshole too.

“I…” Izuku starts, not budging from his spot, “I would. I would go, with you. But Kaito...He’s been really nice to me today, taking me out here, and spending time with me. He’s a good guy, Kacchan. I can’t just ditch him. He gave me flowers, a-and he’s been good to me.”

He knew. Katsuki knew. The flowers that were on the dashboard. He saw them. The nice comments that the brunette gave Izuku, he heard them. He knew that Kaito was kinder to Izuku than he ever was, but he was still pathetically trying.

“I know,” Katsuki speaks, “I fucking know he has. I know he’s fucking good to you. Just…”

How did he even word this. How did Katsuki even fucking begin to word this. He says it in the simplest way that he could, “Give me a chance to be good to you tonight, too.”

There was silence for a moment, and Katsuki tried not to look like a fucking confused wreck.

“What?” Izuku stammered, “Why?”

“I don’t…” Katsuki wished he couldn’t ask that, “I don’t fucking know. You’re just my,” He thinks back to his conversation with his dad. What was Izuku to him, “My closest fucking friend, okay? And there’s something I want to do, okay? There’s something I want to do.” He repeats, as if it will make Izuku want to go with him one degree more.

All the other had to say was yes. So Katsuki stood there, waiting, praying even though he wasn’t even religious that maybe, Izuku might say yes. And the wait seems excruciating, and *fuck* , Katsuki wished he knew what the other was thinking.

Finally, he hears, from the other boy, a soft, “Okay, let’s go.”

Katsuki remembers this flower field from when he was 15. His grandfather had taken him to it, since it was in the middle of the road from where the farm was, and the older man was always one for silly adventures too. He remembered the directions, and the entire time that he's driving Izuku there, he feels himself calming down a bit more. Izuku liked the stars. Izuku liked the idea of laying in a yellow field somewhere, and looking up at the stairs. So that it feels like he was floating in them. Katsuki remembers. He remembers that conversation, and so he was going to bring it to life.

And when they got there, when Izuku sees it, he's quiet for a while. He's quiet, after Katsuki tells him that it's for him. That it's because he liked it. Because he wanted to see it.

And then, Katsuki watches as the boy cries. Why did he cry?

Katsuki hadn't wanted him to cry, and he thumbs the tears off of Izuku's face, "Deku? Oi, what's wrong."

*Fuck* .

But when the boy tells him thank you, Katsuki sees now. Izuku was crying from happiness. Or at least that was what the greenette was trying to make it look like. And yet, when Katsuki looked into those eyes, he also saw a hint of sadness. As if Izuku had come to some kind of realization in the few moments that he was silent. A realization that upset him.

Katsuki hadn't meant to give in. Sleeping with Izuku that night was likely one of the worst ideas he has ever agreed to. And he knew this was going to fuck something up. Because Izuku wasn't like Kimi. Or Sara. Or any of the people that Katsuki has had sexual encounters with before. 1. Izuku was important. Because if this fucks up, which he knows *it will* , then he didn't want to lose the other. 2. Izuku wasn't *like* him. The boy didn't seem like the type to be okay with careless, simple sex. For Katsuki to fuck him rough, and leave him dry. Katsuki likes to believe that Izuku should be with someone who would treat him a little more tenderly, someone who he couldn't be. 3. Katsuki had this feeling. He had this *aching* feeling, that if he gives in, then he wasn't going to be able to make it a one time thing. If just kissing the boy made him go crazy, he didn't even want to think about what feeling Izuku, being inside of him, would make him feel. Because Katsuki had accepted a little while ago that he was sexually attracted to Midoriya Izuku. And he knew that the thought of Izuku in a lewd position could turn him on if he let it linger in his head too long, which is why he never does.

And so, when the gorgeous green-eyed boy teases him, tells him that he wanted him, it took all of Katsuki fucking willpower to hold back. It really did. But the moment Izuku mentions Kaito, he knows he's done for.

Katsuki fucks him.

He fucks him hard, and he fucks him well. And he lays down his ground rules, that he needed Izuku to fucking understand. He was not going to love him. He was not going to coddle him. He was not going to treat him tenderly, like a lover would.

And when Izuku agreed, Katsuki's strength goes out the window and he fucks Izuku as if he's never had sex before. Everything about the smaller was fucking perfect. His hips, his thighs, his chest, torso, the look in Izuku's eyes when they're hooded like that, the trail of saliva from the boy's lips to his cock, his deliciously tight hole, the way Izuku fucked back on his cock. Everything was fucking perfect, and Katsuki's never had it quite like this. This was different from anyone else he's ever been with. There was an extra element to this, one that the blonde couldn't quite point that, that made his feel so much fucking better. And his point number 4 was beginning to feel more and more true by the minute. With every thrust, every slap of his heavy balls against Izuku's body when his cock thrusts into that sweet, tight hole, Katsuki feels himself get addicted, and he's only had one hit.

And one hit turns into two. Then three, four, five. In the same fucking night, that turned into morning. By the end of the morning, he ran through the entire pack. Izuku's laying in the backseat, exhausted out of his mind. Katsuki sits there, naked, with the greenette's head on his lap. He's recovering. Katsuki couldn't get it out of his head. He had gone to the field, with the intention of showing Izuku something that might make him happy, that would show that he's trying to be a better friend. And he left having fucked Izuku five times until the morning was starting to creep up. So much for a platonic gesture.

And yet, he couldn't stop thinking about it. He couldn't stop thinking about what it was like to have Izuku under him, fucking *tiny* , but taking his cock so well. Or the boy's gorgeous expression, pupils blown wide, a flush on his freckles cheeks, panting and parted lips. It stays on his mind, and the next day, he makes his next mistake and shows up at Izuku's house.

And he had meant for the first thing he did to be to just talk to the guy. Reaffirm that it was a one night thing. But the second he sees that smile, Katsuki goes for it. He kisses him.

Somehow, that translated to the two of them fucking like actual *rabbits* , in the following weeks. He hadn't meant to. But Katsuki was a hypocrite and a liar, and those were two facts that the blonde was beginning to come to terms with. Because nothing was more of a big fat lie than that the night in the flower field was going to be a one night stand. He had fucked up there, and so, the only thing that Katsuki had left to do was make sure that the rules he put in place are *kept* in place. The moment Izuku broke that, they'd be done with this. Katsuki promises himself this.

The sex was fucking amazing. Katsuki, as experienced as he was, had no idea what control was in front of Izuku. There was no tempo when they fucked, no regulated rhythm. Just jackrabbit hammering, because Katsuki didn't care about the methods or the chivalry when the boy was splayed in front of him, naked with a beautiful pink hole for him to fill. All he cared about was how to get deeper, faster, harder, and how to make the doe-eyed boy scream louder.

Izuku was driving him insane, and it felt like he was on ecstasy or another level of cloud 9. The last thing he would have ever thought was that his project partner, Midoriya Izuku,

would be bouncing on his cock every other night. And even more than that, he would never have expected for himself to not be satisfied with anything else.

And yet it was more than that. Because when he thinks that he would not be satisfied with anything else, Katsuki wasn't just thinking about the sex. Even though that might have been easier.

When he thinks that he would not be satisfied with anything else, Katsuki meant quite literally anything. Because being Izuku's friend was an experience in of itself. When he took away the sex, it was still just as good. Because Izuku was the boy who goes to jump off cliffs with him into salty water. Because Izuku was the boy who could just sit in his room for hours and talk his head off about some random shit, and he never felt bored. Because Izuku was the boy who laughs and lit up the damn room after he's had a shitty day, and the best part was the greenette didn't even know that little sound had an effect on him. Because Izuku brought him a cherry gatorade every Thursday, and occasionally during other days when he wanted to see the whole team practice.

Because, Izuku grounded him.

But like all good things, Katsuki knew something was bound to happen. Because Katsuki has a tendency to mess up good things. And this was the best thing to happen to him in a while, and at some point, he's come to terms with that. And Katsuki sees Izuku grow too. Little by little, every day, the blonde sees Izuku a little more brave, a little more bold. Every day, Katsuki looks at Izuku and comes to the realization that the Izuku he first partnered up with months ago, was not the Izuku he knew now. The one he knew now still laughed and smiled like the old one did, but now, he also got angry when he needed to, sad when he needed to. The old one hid his emotions that didn't suit what everyone wanted from him, the one he knew now let it show blatantly in his eyes without the need to cover it up.

It was a matter of time before he goes to Waseda, and Katsuki goes to Keio. They weren't far apart. 20 minutes? Not bad. But Katsuki knew how the story was going to go. Izuku has changed so much already, and when he gets to Tokyo, where there are millions of people and millions of opportunities, he'll meet others.

Izuku will meet others that will treat him better than Katsuki could, nicer than Katsuki could. There was only so much that the blonde was able to do for others. He couldn't take care of Izuku the way that the boy should be taken care of. And so, when he goes off to college, Izuku was going to realize then. Right now, Katsuki could pretend that they are two peas in a pod.

But when the other boy leaves, Katsuki knows that Izuku will realize it: Realize that Katsuki was never as great as Izuku always thought him to be. That the years of watching him vault was just a phase, and there were other people out there who were even more passionate than Katsuki and could be a good person at the same time. He'll realize that he was only okay with being friends with Katsuki and admiring him like he did because in the small town of Ise, the blonde was the only one around. But when he leaves, when he moves somewhere bigger, better, Izuku will realize all of this.

And when he does, Katsuki knew that he'll leave. And that the blonde will have to let his new friend go.

Maybe in the beginning, they'll visit each other more often. After all, they'd be new students in a huge city, lonely, looking for comfort in whoever they knew. They'll come over to each other's dorms, go out for a drink or meal, sneak onto the rooftop of some building in Tokyo and look at the skyline. Maybe do something stupid, like they do in Ise, like break into another ice cream store or jump into the fountain in the city square.

And then, Katsuki just knows it, they'll start to get busy. Life settles in a little more. Izuku will find new friends. Katsuki will throw himself into vault like he always does. And the phone calls may get infrequent. The nerd might come over thrice a week at first. And vice versa. And then, it'll be twice a week. Then once a week. Then every other week. *I'm going out with some friends tonight* , he'll get a text one time. Before it becomes two times, then three. And that'll be a fucking good thing, because it means that Izuku would probably have found some friends who could treat him better than Katsuki could.

Then, at some point, they'll pass by each other at a train station or maybe just on the streets of a popular area once a month, maybe twice. Izuku will ask him how he's been. Katsuki, hopefully mellow and not as fucking sarcastic by then, will answer that he's been good, and that vault is going great. He'll ask the boy back. And he'll say the same. And they part ways, just to go through the same conversation again the next month or two.

Katsuki subjects himself to thinking like this. So that when it comes true, he won't feel as bad. After all, it was only a matter of time before something goes wrong.

That matter of time beings on the evening of the Night Market, and it never seems to fucking stop, as everything begins to go downhill. Everything was crumbling apart in his hands, like he was trying to pick up sand with a sifter. Why did he have to say that. *Why* the fuck did Katsuki have to say that, he wonders to himself, as he watches Izuku walk away from him that night, voice dejected and shoulders slumped. The lily in his ear that he bought, because it reminded him of Izuku's scent that he liked so much, looked like an insult after he realizes all that he's said to the boy.

It had started out so fucking great, and Katsuki had never attended the Night Market before in all his years of living in Ise, but he liked it from the moment they pulled into park. The music, the vibe, the lights and things being sold. Katsuki liked all of it, and he enjoys walking around with Izuku, looking at funny, dumb, or cool little trinkets being sold. He liked seeing the boy next to him laugh at something he said and then dance to Holding On To A Hero with him for the crowd of elderly folks to judge the hell out of them. Katsuki especially liked when Izuku decided to keep the red lily in his hair. It was tucked prettily behind Izuku's ear, between green locks, and today wasn't part of their project hour, so he didn't pull out his phone to take a picture. *Fuck* .

"The lights are really pretty here," An unfamiliar voice says from beside him.

Katsuki turns his head down and to the side, where he's face to face with what was a rather stunning boy, with eyes that sparkled and beautiful brown hair that looked soft to the touch. Izuku had left to go buy waters a mere moment ago.

Katsuki turns to look at all of the lights, before humming, "They are."

The stranger looks up to him, and he has this smile that was gentle and pretty, "My name's Akio."

Katsuki nods to him, "Bakugo."

"Bakugo…" Akio looks to the side as if the name is familiar, "That sounds so familiar."

The blonde snorts, "You new here?"

The boy nods his head enthusiastically, like Izuku did, "Yeah! I moved here about a month ago. I live in the west end? Near Jimon Street."

"That explains it," Katsuki says. It explains how the boy didn't immediately know who he was, "So tell me, any reason why you approached?"

At this, Akio blushed a little bit too red, like Izuku does, "Um, I'm trying to make new friends."

The blonde looks up for a second, before dropping his head, "I'm not exactly friendly."

"Then…" Akio pursed those pink lips, looking up at him with light blue eyes, "We don't have to be."

Katsuki raised a brow. He hadn't thought of anyone else ever since he began sleeping with Izuku, and didn't particularly care to either. He had it good. But then, his thoughts lingers to Izuku leaving. And Izuku, *will* , in fact, leave. And a bit of panic bubbles in his chest, but he pushes it down. Now wasn't the time to think about Izuku. They weren't fucking dating or anything. He had no obligation to think of the nerd. Still. He doesn't know what to say to Akio.

"Or you could just show me around town sometime," Akio laughs then, and it's a nice sound.

Katsuki lip quirk up for a second, "Those are my only two options? Take you out or dick you down?"

Akio blushes harder, and Katsuki likes that because it reminded him of-, "Well," He pursed his lips, "How about I take your number? And you can flip a coin?"

The blonde snorts, as Akio pulls out his phone. The boy was interesting. He didn't know who Katsuki was.

He could start over with someone like Akio, treat him the way he wasn't able to treat Izuku from the beginning. Not that he and Izuku were lovers.

But then what. The boy would want more. Katsuki didn't have the ability to give it. And the cycle will just repeat. Still, Katsuki punches in his number.

He fights with Izuku. Because of course, he would. Like he said, it was bound to happen. He just hadn't expected it to fucking feel like this. Katsuki didn't know what he had expected from the other. When he had come back to Izuku, the boy looked a bit forlorn, eyes staring off. And when he spoke, there was this slight pain that Katsuki could detect.

Izuku told him that he could go, if he wanted. And the blonde didn't understand. Where the fuck did the boy want him to go. Where the hell else was there to go, if Izuku was there, other than wherever the nerd was? There wasn't somewhere he'd rather be.

And then, the green eyed boy tells him, *don't let me hold you back* . And then it clicks. Hold him back. Izuku must have seen the interaction between him and Akio.

They fight. And Katsuki is angry. He didn't want to go. He'd pick Izuku over some stranger he just met any fucking day of the week, and yet Izuku kept insisting that he can go. That he *can* go. It was the word *can* that irritated the fuck out of him, because for some fucking reason, Katsuki wanted Izuku to admit it. Admit that he didn't want Katsuki to leave, so that Katsuki wouldn't feel like Izuku couldn't care less whether he went off with someone or whether he stayed.

Katsuki, for some sick reason, wanted Izuku to tell him to fucking stay.

Izuku tells him, voice cracking a little bit, "I'm not jealous. Or throwing a pity party. I just don't want you to…" He breathed to try to even his heart rate, "feel like you're missing out."

That wasn't Izuku's fucking job. This was such a mess. This was such a fucking mess, and Katsuki was angry. That wasn't the boy's job to decide whether or not Katsuki was missing out. If Katsuki felt like he was missing out, then he would have fucking left. But no, he was here. He was here with Izuku, and even if he had all the options in the world, he'd still choose to be here with Izuku. And so to have the boy in question go off and assume that Izuku was the second choice, or that Katsuki *begrudgingly* chooses to hang out with him, was fucking unfair. It wasn't Izuku's goddamn place to tell him that he was missing out, because honestly, what the fuck was he missing by being here.

Katsuki says it then, "Don't overstep your boundaries."

But when he meets silence. And when Izuku goes silent, when the boy backs off and his eyes go all apologetic and his words begin to quieten and stammer, Katsuki realizes then.

Izuku had interpreted it the wrong way.

And when Izuku leaves, red lily still tucked in his hair, Katsuki doesn't sleep that night. He didn't sleep that night because it was happening. They were falling apart, but much sooner

than he'd imagined. Much, much sooner. And it wasn't supposed to happen now. It wasn't fucking supposed to happen now. It was supposed to happen after they graduate, after they move away. Katsuki had an entire fucking scenario in his head. One that he's come to terms with. He had that whole internal spiel about college, about Izuku finding better people, about all of that bullshit, and he was fine with that. Not this was happening too soon. Too fucking soon, and the blonde hated this. Because of course he'd make Izuku cry again. Every time he made the boy cry, Katsuki thinks back to everything everyone has ever fucking said about him, no matter how fucking hard he tried not to. That all he fucking did was hurt people. That he destroys good things. That this was just the way he was, and there was no changing that. And that didn't fucking used to matter. All of those words never used to matter, until Izuku came along, and suddenly, Katsuki sees someone that he doesn't want to hurt anymore. And yet, Izuku cries again because of him.

Izuku doesn't stop by practice the next day, and *no, no, no, no , no.* It wasn't supposed to happen this soon. They weren't supposed to fall apart this soon, not after everything. Not after all of this. He tries to stop the boy, and he doesn't know why he had such a fucking hard time not sounding like a dick.

"Oi," He called out, "Deku." His voice was naturally harsh sounding. It invited no comfort. Izuku kept walking.

"Deku," He tried again, feeling his usually well-put together tone slowly waver, "You're not going to come in?"

He sees Izuku pursing his lips before looking back down at his feet, "I'm a little tired."

*No, no, no* . They did not have that conversation about trying to be honest with themselves just for Izuku to hide his real thoughts again when it mattered. They were *not* going back to this. They can't. *Fuck* , they can't.

Katsuki walked faster, looking around to see if he could do anything, before calling out to Izuku, "Fuck, Deku. Look, I wanted to...Shit," He was having trouble with his words again, "Deku. Stop. Please, stop."

And when he finally did get Izuku to stop, it wasn't enough. His apology was not enough, even though he knew that Izuku would likely forgive him anyway. He couldn't tell him this way. No. Katsuki had to show him. Maybe if Katsuki showed him, then the boy might understand.

And so, he tries. He takes Izuku in through the fence where the bar is set to 17'11, and he tries. In fact, he's been fucking trying for at least a week now, ever since he remembered what Izuku had said to him that one day he taught the boy to fly. Sprint for 10. Run for 6. And it was slowly working. There was a clear difference in his approach, at least to him, because he was used to this and every minute different felt a certain way. Already, even though he hadn't cleared it, he feels more confident that he would. The extra sprint time and decreased run time allows him to conserve more power for the jump. And although it was just a small difference, Katsuki knew it was going to work. And he was planning on showing

Izuku once he got it. But he was desperate now. He wanted to show the boy how important Izuku was to him. And how he was fucking dumb, makes mistakes, and says stupid shit, but none of it was ever going to mean he didn't care or value the other.

Katsuki doesn't know how long he tries, but it had to have been at least ten to fifteen times. But eventually, he does clear it. He fucking clears 17'11, for the first time. And he wasn't even as excited about clearing it as he was about seeing Izuku's face as he cleared it. And watching the nerd's face light up once more was worth every fucking second.

When the tournament comes around, he makes the cut. To National Qualifiers, with an inverted sweatband on his wrist. And when he saw Izuku, wearing his jersey, he began to grin like an idiot. The name Bakugo looked nice on Izuku, but he wasn't about to tell the nerd that. He'll never fucking let him live it down. But it did. And he couldn't stop his fucking grin, so he turns away, bringing his hand up to pretend to wipe at his nose, just so that it could hide his smile.

"What's got you all in a good mood, Cap?" Ejirou slaps his back.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, "Fuck off. Who said I was in a good mood."

"You were smiling like someone gave you a puppy," His friend laughs.

Katsuki stretches as he grumbles, "I prefer kittens."

After it ends, that was where all the joy for the night ends. Because at some point, when a small crowd of vaulters sits outside near the rails leading into the track field, Katsuki hears his name.

"What about Bakugo?" Ejirou's voice usually carried, being naturally loud, so Katsuki, who was currently talking to two other people about the tournament, turned his head towards the sound.

Ejirou was approaching Izuku and Kaito Sen, interrupting their conversation by throwing his arms around the both of them.

And Katsuki hears the brunette say, voice intentionally loud so that he could hear.

"Oh, Just," He says, "How he's never gonna be able to love anyone. Because he's a lunatic and is emotionally unavailable."

The blonde *knew* that was fucking meant to stir up the pot. He knew that Fuck Face just did that type of shit to fuck with him. But this time marked the first time it might have actually fucking worked because Katsuki was telling himself that he wasn't going to listen to a piece of shit, but this time, what Kaito had said was too similar--to coincidental with words that he's heard numerous times before. That even if it was Kaito who was the one to say it, the

fact that he's heard some rendition of it several times before from people that *weren't* the brunette, implied that there was truth.

*He's never gonna be able to love anyone. Because he's a lunatic and is emotionally unavailable.* Katsuki was fucking pissed off. But more than he was pissed off, he found himself repeating those damn words over and over again. And it wasn't as if he was not used to them. He fucking was. He knew that he was never going to be able to love anyone, the way that he was. He could only change so much. Sure, he can be nicer, whatever. But to love someone, and not end up hurting them, was something else entirely. That was above his capability. And yet, there are times. Times when Katsuki lays in bed, and wonders if maybe he could. Even if it was for a second, he wonders to himself if maybe in ten years or so, he could love someone well. And make them happy, without somehow hurting them down the line. And in those times, it was comments like the one from Kaito's on top of his own self doubts that caused him to shut down the thought immediately.

And god, after everyone leaves, Katsuki is still thinking about it. And so he takes a walk with Izuku. And it was like magic.

It was like magic the way that the boy was always able to distract him. As of current, they were just walking alongside the track, and Izuku was rambling. The boy was rambling about something Katsuki was only half paying attention to, because he was more focused on the way those eyes were shining. These days, it felt like it was a hit or miss, if Izuku's eyes glimmered for him or if it didn't. He wished it was all the time. And so he holds onto this moment for as long as he can, when they are just walking side by side like this, and Izuku was saying something about slow motion cameras underwater.

And he was so fucking adorable in this moment that Katsuki wanted to kiss the nerd. And so he does. He bends down, tilting Izuku's head to the side, and kisses him. This time, when Katsuki kisses him, he doesn't rush it or act nearly as aggressive as he usually was. This time, he just wanted to savor the taste of lilies and peppermint on his lips, so that when he pulls away, maybe it will linger on him when they part ways again.

The kiss continues, and Katsuki was holding onto Izuku's face as he bent down to meet the other. Izuku was so short, it was too fucking adorable. He feels hands on his waistband, fingers that travelled to the laces and begins untying them. Izuku pulls away to catch his breath, and the green eyed boy looks down.

Katsuki stops Izuku's wrist and asks the boy, "What are you doing."

Izuku then looked up at him with confused eyes, "Aren't we…"

Katsuki waited. The other didn't say anything.

So he asks again, "Aren't we what."

"I mean," Izuku shrugs, "I just assumed that we were going to...have sex," He rubbed the back of his neck, "Because you started to kiss me."

At this, Katsuki's eyes widened. He thinks back to what he had just done. Without any notice, he really had just kissed Izuku with no further intention. No sex, no nothing in his mind. He had broken his own rule. He had tenderly kissed Izuku, and there wasn't even any sexual intention involved. And the worst part was that he hadn't even realized he had done so until after the fact.

"I did, didn't I," Katsuki says, blinking at Izuku's face.

Izuku just laughed a little, "Kacchan, you wouldn't just kiss me out of the blue. I just assumed there's something you want after. That's all."

*I just assumed there's something you want after* . Right. Because that was who Katsuki was, he remembered himself. That was who he was. He wasn't meant for tender touches or what not. He only was intimate to fuck, and that was it. And if he were to kiss someone, then it was because he wanted something from them after. Right, that was the kind of guy that Katsuki was.

That didn't explain why Katsuki just felt this odd sense of hurt inside of his chest cavity. He knew this, and Izuku was completely right, which didn't explain why Katsuki suddenly felt so angry. He felt angry because what if he *had* just wanted to kiss him. He couldn't just do that? Why. Was it because he was, as everyone liked to say, emotionally unavailable? He knew this, and yet it still made him angry, "Fine, you want to fuck? Let's fuck."

And so Katsuki fucks him. He spreads Izuku's legs on the hood of his car and rams his cock deep into the green haired boy, until he bottoms out and he reaches as deep into Izuku as he possibly could. If the shitnerd wanted to fuck, then Katsuki will give it to him. Because that is what he was good at. He wasn't good at any of this introspection, or feelings. But he was good at this, and so he makes Izuku feel good. He wets his dick in the boy's tight hole, and goes to town, fucking into it like it was the last time he'll be able to. Izuku bites into his own arm to suppress moans, but Katsuki pulls it out so he could hear it. And he bends Izuku over until the boy's hips were lifted off of the hood, and with both hands on Izuku's hips, Katsuki fucks him that way too until the both of them come.

And then a couple moments later, when he asks Izuku the question, that stupid fucking question that he was barely able to get out, the answer that the green eyed boy gives him only confirms everything, and with that, he solidifies the fact. He can't love. He was bound, sooner or later, to hurt people. And that's just how he is.

Yet for some reason, Katsuki still tried so hard to figure out what was fucking wrong with him. And why he couldn't seem to keep the one true friendship that he had stable for more than a couple days before he does something to make Izuku cry, or sad, or any of that shit. Maybe, it was the way he did things. Kaito didn't seem to make Izuku cry. At least that he knew of. And what did he do. Katsuki thinks. What does he do.

He took Izuku out to nice dinners, where he got to dress up really nice and it was a mature thing to do. Katsuki's always made fun of that type of shit, but maybe Izuku liked it. And maybe that was why Izuku kept going out with Kaito. He took Izuku to parks, where they walked around and talked about who knows what, but Katsuki was sure they didn't argue like they did.

Katsuki hated the idea. Fuck, he hated stuffy dinners and all of that shit, but he takes Izuku anyways.

And it was likely one of the worst ways to spend his evenings. God, he couldn't fucking stand this. And as the dinner proceeds, their conversation gets more and more dry. Katsuki stares at the soup spoon still sitting in the dish, and his reflection in it seemed fucking miserable. And when he looked up at Izuku, the shorter boy didn't look too happy either. And *fuck,* goddamnit, why did it feel like he couldn't fucking do anything right.

"Kacchan, tell me seriously, why are we here?" Izuku asks him.

"What do you mean," He went from thumbing his lip to looking over at Izuku. Did he not like it?

"Why are you doing this?" Izuku looked around the place, before asking him softly, "I mean, restaurants are fine. And I'm really grateful you took me, but I'm not going to lie, this just feels a little not like you."

No shit, this wasn't like him.

Katsuki gestured with one hand, tone strained, "Isn't this what you're supposed to do? Go to nice restaurants and shit?"

"What *who* is supposed to do?" Izuku asks him with emphasis. Katsuki sees the boy's brows furrow..

Katsuki didn't want to fucking say, but he does so anyways, "Fuck Face did this shit for you. Didn't you like it?"

Izuku's eyes widen. And there is a moment of silence. Before the boy speaks.

"Kacchan, why are you trying to be like Kaito?" Izuku frowned.

"I'm not trying to be like that slimy motherfucker," Katsuki corrected him, rubbing his temples with his fingers, "Just...shit. It seemed like you liked him."

"Are you trying to get me to like you?" Izuku laughs then, looking at him funnily.

Katsuki on reflex says, "No."

"Then what?"

"I don't fucking know," Katsuki threw his hands up. This conversation was fucking tense, and he wanted out of here, "I don't know why I'm doing this."

Then there was silence between them at the table, and Katsuki feels his energy being seeped out.

After a moment, the other's voice perked up, "Kacchan, let's get out of here."

That was random. Katsuki asked, "Eh?"

"Let's get out of here," Izuku tells him then, "Take me somewhere I'll never forget."

It wasn't just Izuku who didn't forget. Katsuki doesn't forget either. And he doesn't forget because the lighthouse ends up being simultaneously the best and worst place possible. It had been fucking *fine* . The walk up to the lighthouse was cold, but bearable. The view on top was stunning, and the little seat they had got a perfect view. Everything was good as it was.

And then. And *then* , Izuku asked for that song. Fragile. Sting. Izuku asked for that damn song, and it all went to shit.

Because the sex they had that night, topped everything they have ever done before. Every. Fucking. Time. The roughest sex, the dirtiest sex, and most thrilling sex they've had up to that point, was absolutely nothing compared to the slow sex they had in that lighthouse. It was nothing compared to pretending to make love to Izuku. Katsuki felt as if he pretended so well, that he wasn't even sure how he knew what to pretend. Because it was so easy. It felt so easy to make love to Izuku, even if it was all fake.

It felt so fucking easy to touch him tenderly, break down all of the rules, and pretend for one night that Katsuki loved him.

Even when he said he didn't. Because he knew he couldn't.

All of Katsuki's rules and regulations, that he tries so hard to maintain, had been so easy to put down. He worshiped Izuku's body, and placed soft kisses up and down all of the beautiful expanses of skin. His arms, his waist, his legs, everything. He does everything a good lover does, and it was as easy as counting to three.

This wasn't the sex he usually had. This was the sex he has *ever* had. It wasn't rough, but instead, tender, in the sweetest way he could ever imagine. And yet, it fucks him up completely. And when Izuku later falls asleep in his arms after Katsuki automatically holds him there, it was as if he's been doing it forever.

Making love to Izuku was the easiest thing he's ever done. Even if it was pretend. And that is what fucks him up, as he breaks away from the boy an hour later and walks out onto the railing of the lighthouse. Up here, the breeze was strong, and it was much warmer back under the blanket with Izuku in his embrace. The crashing of the waves were strong against the rocks surrounding the lighthouse, and the lantern moved back and forth like a pendulum and he follows its movements.

He had his hands on either side of him, head down as he tried to get this fucking confusion out of his head. All of this damn time, he had told Izuku he wasn't going to ever do more than the whole no strings attached ordeal, because he couldn't. Because he knew that he wouldn't be able to love someone, hold them tenderly, make them feel more than just pleasure.

And yet, he had just done it, and it was the easiest thing he's ever fucking done. And he doesn't know how. He doesn't fucking know how. And that scares him.

Katsuki ignored him for the next two days. It was completely intentional, even if he tried to make it seem like he was just busy by sending a text here and there so that it didn't look like he was outright ignoring the other. This way, if Izuku wonders, he'll just think *maybe he's just busy.* The truth was, Katsuki wasn't busy at all, outside of practice. And *fuck* , did he practice. Katsuki trained until his arms couldn't pick up the pole. The sun beat down on him, but he didn't care. Anything to distract from Izuku. Because Izuku was all that he could think about, and the tender sex they had in the lighthouse was the only thing his mind can go back to. And just how easy it was. Nothing was like Izuku. Absolutely nothing was, and that was terrifying him because Izuku wasn't for him.

Izuku was going to leave him later on in the line, and the fact that nothing in this world was like Izuku made Katsuki panic a little bit, yet he kept a calm front.

"Isn't it a bit late," A feminine voice yelled to him from the sidewalk.

Katsuki, still on the practice track after the sun went down, looks over on the side, where Izuku usually stood to watch him, and with a heavy breathing chest, he faintly sees Kimi.

He asks her the same question, "Isn't it a bit late for you too?"

The girl shook her head, which Katsuki could only catch a small glimpse of in the dark, "We had a home volleyball game today."

Katsuki looked down at his pole, and back up at her, "Win or lose."

Kimi shouts back across the fence, "Won."

The blonde nods, and decides that it was probably too dark to practice effectively and made a move to pack up his things, when the girl speaks up again.

"You want to go chill?" Kimi asked, voice sweet.

Katsuki pauses, and he wipes some sweat from his brow.

Kimi asked again, "Come on, no one's seen you around in a while. We can have some fun."

The blonde purses his lips, looking up from the ground, and goes to put the pole away. Maybe this was what he needed right now. Just something else. Someone else.

“What kind of fun,” Katsuki packs his things into his gym bag.

Kimi speaks over the sound of crickets, “Any kind. I just kind of need a ride home, anyways.”

At this, Katsuki finds himself chuckling, and he decides to agree, “Sure.”

When the two of them get in the car, Katsuki sits for a second to let the air conditioning cool him off.

“So where do you want to go?” She asked from the passenger seat.

Katsuki had his head leaned back, “Somewhere I can swim. Get this sweat off me.”

Kimi jokes with him, tilting her head to the side, “My place?”

But Katsuki was thinking of someplace else, and he puts the car out of parking and into drive, “How about a lake.”

For what reason the blonde brings the two of them to the firefly lake? Katsuki thinks that it was because he wonders how different it’ll be. How different it will be with Izuku versus with Kimi. And he hopes that it isn’t, because then that’ll give him some peace of mind. Peace of mind that even when Izuku leaves, it’ll be fine.

But it’s different. *Fuck* , it’s so different.

“I don’t really want to swim,” The girl says as they both stand at the edge of the dock. She thinks it’s beautiful, Katsuki can tell. Because her eyes light up too at the sight of the fireflies floating right above the lake, similar to how Izuku’s eyes light up. But it wasn’t the same.

Katsuki hums, “Why not.”

Kimi tucks a strand of hair behind her ear, “I don’t like wearing damp clothes afterwards.”

“What if I pushed you in,” Katsuki suggested, beginning to take off his own shirt.

The girl laughs, and she’s sweet about it, “I’d get mad and climb back up. Bakugo, you’re not getting me to swim.”

“Suit yourself,” He says before diving in. The water was much warmer than when he had came with izuku the last time. And when he surfaces, Katsuki half expects to hear the sound of a pretty laugh followed by a *Kacchan!* But he hears none of the sort.

Instead, Kimi sits down on the edge of the dock, dangling her feet on the water’s edge, and leans down to look at him, “Is the water nice?”

“Sure is,” Katsuki holds onto the side of the dock, “You’d know if you came in.”

Kimi rolled her eyes with a smile, “I’m good,” And then she looks up, “This is very romantic. Thank you for taking me here.”

Katsuki doesn’t reply to her, but instead, swims on his back so that when he looked up, he’d see the occasional blinking of the fireflies. He hated hearing them buzz, because although they were pretty to look at at night, they were still bugs at the end of the day.

Kimi was nice. Or at least, nice enough, comparative to himself. And their conversation was fine. They mostly talked about school and some mutual friends that they have. It was nothing particularly riveting, and Katsuki was comparing everything to Izuku, and nothing was aligning.

At some point, he climbs up and sits next to her on the dock, water dripping off of his body, and he leans against one of the dock posts. He doesn’t know when, but at some point, Kimi leans forward, and when she kisses him, he returns it. Her lips tasted like strawberries in the ripeness of summer, and it was nice. Her hands place themselves on his shoulders, still slightly wet from the lake water, and Kimi tries to deepen their kiss. Katsuki pulls her in closer by the waist, until the girl was straddling his lap, they make out. Her tongue wanted in, so they played like that for a while. And Katsuki feels only a tiny fraction of the pleasure from kissing Kimi as he did Izuku. And everything felt wrong. The shape of her body didn’t fit with his the way Izuku’s does. Her lips don’t taste the same. Her hair didn’t smell like lilies, and Katsuki knew it wasn’t fucking fair to compare, but he couldn’t help it if he wanted to.

When the girl’s fingers move down to grab his waistband, Katsuki stops her and just tells her to wait.

“Wait,” The blonde says, closing his eyes and looking down, “We’re not gonna fuck.”

“We’re not?” Kimi asked, still straddling his lap, “Why not?”

Katsuki pursed his lips, before looking up at her, “I’m not hard.”

Kimi flushed red at this, as if embarrassed, and offered, “I can work on tha-”

“You can’t,” Katsuki says in the nicest way he can, “I’m just not going to get h-”

“Am I not…” Kimi waits for him to understand what she was trying to imply.

The blonde curses and shakes his head, “You’re fine. I just think I need to head back.”

“Head back?” Kimi climbs off of his lap but looked at him, “We’re seriously not going to fuck?”

Katsuki stood up and shook his head, “No, but this was fun.” It was just alright.

The girl bit her lip, and then gave him a small smile, “Is it because you’re in love with Mid-”

“Don’t finish that line,” Katsuki interrupts her, even though he knew what was coming next. His chest heaved, before he calms a bit, “Please…”

Kimi looked down at her feet, “Okay.”

She wasn’t Izuku.

Aiko texts him the next day, and Katsuki was still avoiding Izuku as much as he could. He could feel those big green eyes occasionally steal glances from him in class in his peripheral vision, but he couldn’t fucking bring himself to look back. The text comes in the middle of his lunch period.

An unknown number texted him. *Hey! This is Akio. From the night market? I was wondering if you just wanted to grab food sometime tonight?*

The diner, Katsuki decides. He’ll take Akio there. It was a staple of his experience in Ise, after all.

Akio drove himself there, in a small blue volkswagen. The boy showed up in a chiffon blue top and white bottoms. He was as pretty as he was when Katsuki met him at the night market. And when they entered, Katsuki slid into a seat on the opposite side of where he and Izuku sat last time.

And it was nice. Akio was funny. The boy travelled around a lot because of his parent’s work, so he had lots of stories to tell. And Katsuki finds himself chuckling from time to time. But it still felt so static. Like they were just buddies catching up over dinner. And Katsuki asks himself what the fuck was he even doing. Because he wasn’t Izuku.

He was further spiraling into confusion, and it felt like everything he did made the situation worse and worse.

Katsuki stops ignoring the other when he sees him on Friday, because he couldn’t. The moment the tall blonde sees Izuku walking briskly, shoulders shaking, back inside of the school building, right when he and some friends were leaving, how the fuck could he ignore the other. Because at the end of the day, if he saw Izuku like that, he was going to fucking worry his ass off.

But when he stopped the boy, after two days of barely even giving Izuku a glance, Izuku ignored him and tries to walk around.

“Oi, nerd. What’s wrong.”

He wouldn’t budge, but there was clearly something massively wrong. Judging from the way the boy’s shoulders were shaking and face looked incredibly distraught.

“Deku,” Katsuki tries to stop him again, this time reaching out to keep a hold on Izuku’s wrist, “You’re fucking shaking. What the hell is going o-”

“Don’t fucking touch me,” Izuku tells him then, voice small but cracking. And Katsuki goes into shock, having never heard Izuku seriously demand of him something like that, and the boy walks away behind him.

Katsuki spends the entire fucking day thinking about it. Because what the *hell* ? Don't fucking touch me, Izuku told him. So the greenette was going to get pissed at him for some fucking reason, not tell him what it is, and then take it out even though Katsuki had no way of knowing what the hell got him upset? Throughout the rest of his classes, Katsuki does not pay attention to a single one. Instead, he thinks of the first thing he was going to do when he got off of practice.

He was firstly, going to drive over to Izuku's house, immediately and ask what the *fuck* was going on. Then make up some excuse for being quiet the past two days, because god, it felt so shitty to see Izuku like that. Second, Katsuki tried to formulate some plan in mind in case Izuku wanted to go out, because it was obvious that the boy was clearly upset. And so if he goes in with an amicable plan in mind, it could help the other feel better. Katsuki knew that the boardwalk opened up again pretty recently after about a year of renovations, and he had been meaning to take the nerd to that. Today was as good of a day as any.

And yet, when Katsuki pulls up to Izuku's house, he already sees the boy with green hair stepping outside the porch. He sticks to the first step of his two step plan, and tries to get something out of the other.

"Oi," He got out of his car, and briskly walked towards Izuku, "What the fuck is up with you." That approach was not as amicable as Katsuki had intended.

"Nothing's wrong," Izuku tells him, but that was utter shit.

"Bullshit," Katsuki was pissed that the other was so clearly lying, and stepped in front of him, successfully blocking Izuku's way.

This doesn't seem to make the other happy.

"I'm fine!" Izuku looked up at him with wide eyes, then asked him, "Kacchan, please move."

"Yeah, no," He laughed in response, with no humor in his tone, "Not until you tell me what the hell is going on with you."

"And I told you," Izuku stubbornly insists.

"You're fine?" Katsuki could be stubborn too, "Oh yeah? If you're fine, then come with me."

Izuku looked up at him as if he was crazy, "Come with you?"

He decides to skip to the second part of his plan, and revealed, "I...wanted to go to a boardwalk."

Izuku is quiet for a moment, and Katsuki doesn't look at him.

"I have plans," Izuku says, and tries to move to the side of him.

Katsuki moved him back with one arm, cornering the shorter boy, "Plans."

Izuku confirmed, blankness in those usually expressive green eyes, "Yes."

And in all the moments of trying to get Izuku to talk to him, Katsuki hadn't even noticed before, but he notices now what Izuku was wearing. It was something that was *definitely* meant for intimate activities, and considering how they were talking to each other now, Katsuki had a strong feeling that this wasn't for him. And that twisted feeling in his gut began to pull tight. He keeps staring. It was sheer, and if he looked close enough, he could see a fair amount. Katsuki's throat goes dry.

His tone lowered significantly, "With who."

He thinks that he knows. But he wanted Izuku to tell him otherwise. *Fuck* , he wanted Izuku to tell him otherwise.

Izuku tries to push him to the side, "None of your business. Go home, Kacchan."

He knows. He fucking *knows* it wasn't any of his business, but god, the feeling was killing him. All of these weeks, and he was able to have Izuku in *that* way, to himself as far as he knew. To kiss those lips, feel his body, be with him intimately. And he knew what was going on, but he didn't want it to. And it was selfish of him. It was fucking selfish, but he wasn't even thinking about that. He pesters, and gets nothing out of Izuku.

And when the sound of a car pulls up, parked not too far behind him, Katsuki turns to see a very familiar looking white vehicle, and everything that Katsuki hypothesized was becoming more and more fucking true, and *no* . No way in hell.

"Who the fuck is that," Katsuki asks. At this point, he might have even been sounding desperate.

"Izuku," He tried to mask his fear, but he's afraid he might have let it show, "Tell me that isn't fucking him ."

And Katsuki stares right into those eyes that used to terrify him for different reasons than for the ones they do now, and watches as it fills with pain, the very thing Katsuki was afraid of from the beginning, and takes his hand off of the boy's shoulders.

"Kacchan…" Izuku tells him, voice so gentle for such harsh words, "Don't overstep your boundaries."

Katsuki's first reaction was to be angry. Because what the *fuck* did that even mean. Don't overstep his fucking boundaries? They have been fucking each other like rabits, for fuck's sake. He's had his cock buried deeper inside of Izuku and so much of it too that the greenette didn't even know what to do with it. Their boundaries were overstepped a long fucking time ago. And Katsuki opened his mouth to say something, before a sudden jolt of recognition hit him.

Wait a fucking minute. He's heard this. No, no. Wait a minute. He's heard that line, and he's tracing through his memories, sifting through the days that seem to get progressively heavier and heavier with the weight of all of these feelings. And that was when he realized. That those words...He had said those exact same things to Izuku not even that long ago. Exact same line, word for fucking word.

Except they had meant it two different ways, entirely.

And feeling the shock of recognizing his own words thrown back to him fade away, Katsuki settles into this form of acceptance. And he wanted to laugh at himself. Because what right did he have. What right did he have to tell a boy he only fucked not to go with someone else. What right did Katsuki have to say anything to Izuku like this, or even get upset. He had said the exact same words to Izuku a different time, and the blonde wondered if it had made Izuku feel the same way as he did now.

And so, without another word, he walked back to his car. And he drove away.

And as he drove away, Katsuki fucking knew what was about to happen within the next hour, or two, or three. And he refuses to think about it. He knows that someone else is going to hold Izuku tonight, touch him ways Katsuki has. And he isn't going to fucking think about it.

Not tonight. And Katsuki, for the first time in a couple of months, goes to bed early, in hopes that maybe he'd forget.

Fat fucking chance. Not when he bumps into the boy at school, and the first thing he sees was the clear coverup of skin. A scarf, high neck shirt, in this weather. Katsuki asks, even if he knew he was stupid for it, "You cold?"

And when the boy answers no, Katsuki wanted to laugh at himself for being foolish enough to think that could ever have been the case in the first place.

And he doesn't appreciate the goddamn debate for a damn second. Mr. Toshinori was the instigator for all of this. All of it. And the old man only continued to do so. Katsuki felt sick as their conversation went on. Izuku was playing with a fire he didn't know spread quite easily. And by the time he got interrupted, Katsuki kept his opinion. Some people were just innately bound to hurt others, to not being able to love, to not being able be certain things, and that was just that.

The blonde grabs his things, but needed to drop by the locker room in order to get his gym equipment for the photoshoot. God, he hated these kind of publicity things. All he wanted was to vault, and that was it. All of the extra stuff wasn't for him.

Pushing through the locker room doors, Katsuki walks over where his was, and threw his academic bag on the bench, and pushed open his locker. From the shower room next door, someone walks out and Katsuki makes sure to stay *fucking* silent, because he didn't, then he knew he was going to do something he'll regret in jail.

Kaito Sen walks out of the shower room, having changed, with a towel rubbing through his brunette hair, and upon seeing Katsuki pack his gym equipment and uniform, grins.

"Hey Cap!" Kaito announces his presence, and goes to his own locker to grab his gym bag, "You got that photoshoot today, right."

Katsuki says nothing. Kaito was there yesterday, and saw full well everything that went down on that lawn, so there was no use in the small talk. Or any talk.

“Must be nice,” Kaito slung the towel over his shoulder, “Being so known.” There was a playful smugness in his voice, and Katsuki could so easily reach over and choke the shit out of him. So fucking easily. But he continues to zip up his shit.

Fuck Face just won’t shut up, “Awh, you’re not going to talk to me? What’s wrong, Bakugo,” He could feel Kaito’s grin without turning around, “Is this about yesterday?”
Katsuki paused, staring into his locker. He knew what the piece of shit was doing, and he was not in the mood for violence nor an argument. And so, addressing his teammate by the name, Katsuki says in a warning but calm tone, “Kaito. Finish your packing. And leave.” He doesn’t bother cursing.

“Oh-ho! So this is about yesterday,” Kaito ignores him and Katsuki continues to stare into his locker, hand on the door, “If you wanted me to tell you all the details, you could have just asked, you know. No need to be so moody because I’m leaving you hanging.”

His grip on the locker door tightened, and his shoulders were getting tense.

“Let’s see,” Kaito chuckled, “Where do I start. Gee, I didn’t know he was such a screamer. Did you?”

The locker could likely break off if he didn’t let go soon.

“But it’s so pretty,” The brunette comments, “I love it when he tells me to go harder.”

Katsuki thinks to himself, *With me, he never has to* . But that didn’t mean he wanted this to continue.

“And god, that ass. It bounces like crazy, I could have fucked him all night long just to watch that,” Kaito chuckles, “I came down his mouth, and I wished I had taken a video and showed you how he took it. He swallowed every last drop, did you know?”

Katsuki was on his last straw. His last fucking straw, as he hears the details he didn’t want to ever fucking know, nor imagine.

“Anyways,” Kaito just shrugs off, “That was about it.”

Thank god.

“You should’ve seen his face when I asked him how it felt to be just another body to you, though. It was fucki-” Kaito begins.

But before the brunette could finish his sentence, Katsuki slammed his locker door shut and in less than two seconds, his fists were on the front of Kaito’s shirt and he slammed Kaito into the side of the lockers, getting real up close and personal. How dare he. How fucking *dare* he. Katsuki wanted to beat him up. Black and fucking blue.

“That’s right,” Kaito began to laugh at him, as Katsuki’s fury took over, “This is the real Bakugo. Selfish and arrogant. Come on, hit me. You can’t help who you are, bastard. All you do is fucking destroy everything you touch, so go ahead.”

And Katsuki was conflicted. He could cave in the other’s face if he wanted to, break a rib. One move, and Katsuki could easily prevent Kaito from vaulting again. But he thinks of Izuku. Izuku likes this guy. At least, enough to do all the shit that he’s done. And just because Kaito was a fucking piece of shit to him, didn’t mean he treated the greenette the same way. Izuku. *Fuck* , Izuku. He’d be so goddamn disappointed in him if he did something to Kaito. Over this. Over a decision that Katsuki had no authority to make for the smaller.

And so, even as Kaito taunts, Katsuki lowers his head and his grip on the brunette’s collar loosens.

Katsuki sees a flash of surprise in the other’s expression, but all he could do was keep his head lowered, as his hands just lay loosely on the guy’s collar, barely gripping it as his chest goes up and down.

“Izuku…” Katsuki says his name, and breathes, “If Izuku chose you…” Fuck. He hated saying it so much that it ached, “...then I’m not going to hurt him by hurting you.”

And then, the look was now undeniable there. Shock. Kaito Sen was shocked, as he goes quiet, and Katsuki honestly could care less. He had a photoshoot to go to, and he was actually excited to be there right now instead of here. And so, the blonde athlete turns back around, and picks up his stuff, zipping it all the way now, before heading out the locker room door. Even as he leaves, in his peripheral, he still sees Kaito Sen standing there, back against the locker walls, right where he had left him, staring off in thought.

Katsuki hate fucks Izuku later that day, and the entire time, he roams the smaller’s body for any hickeys that he missed and didn’t cover up. He hated Kaito Sen. And the marks adorning Izuku's body, his thighs, neck, chest, back, were all going to be his by the end of this. And he didn’t even care if he had his own, given by Izuku. If Izuku wanted to litter him with marks, then the smaller could do so freely. So long as Katsuki had the permission to destroy him. He fucks Izuku rougher than he’s ever had before, to the point where he feels intense stinging on his back from the way Izuku’s nails scratch down them as he fucks the hell out of the boy. He looked at Izuku, and wondered just how loud the boy moaned for Kaito. If his lips were parted just like this, head rolled back, completely breathless like this as Katsuki makes sure Izuku gets split apart. He turns the other around while standing on the edge of the bed, so that Izuku was on all fours, before lifting Izuku’s hips so that it looked like he was holding the backside of the greenette’s body up like a ragdoll, and there, Katsuki held those hips in place as he thrusts madly as deep and far as he could go. Essentially, Katsuki was moving Izuku’s hips back and forth on his cock, suspended in partial gravity, and he fucking enjoyed watching his hole stretch around Katsuki’s dick, and the wetness that filled the rim when he’d push in too hard and a little of bit of lube would spill in beads. Katsuki came buckets inside of the other, and even as Izuku’s hold gets filled with his cum, he continues to thrust into it, pushing out his cum from the rim of Izuku’s ass everytime he’d pull back and thrust forward.

Katsuki wanted to fuck away any sign that Kaito Sen had ever been there. And when he pulls out, he wants the entire bottom half of Izuku's body to be soaked and stained with his cum. He wanted it dripping all over Izuku's legs, and down his thighs, and he wanted it smeared all over that perfect ass.

Izuku tells him afterwards that *that* was their last time, and all Katsuki could do was say yes. Because what else could he say. His only fear was that it was because he wanted Kaito more. If that was the case, then the blonde wouldn't know what to fucking do. No, the question was, what *could* he do, but hope that the brunette somehow makes Izuku happier than he could.

"Can I be honest about something, Kacchan?" Izuku tells him at one point in the night. They were shrouded by the warm light coming in from the lamp he had in the corner of his room. Katsuki sits on the edge of the four poster bed, now. And Izuku lays back, voice gentle.

Katsuki stays quiet, but he listens. He was almost fearful, of what words come next. And he should have been.

Because then, Izuku smiles with sadness up at Katsuki and that was the last thing the blonde ever wanted to see, "For my own sake…I don't know how much longer I can wait."

Something about what Izuku said then jolted Katsuki, and he felt genuine fear coarse through his body. *I don't know how much longer I can wait* . It was supposed to be further down the road, Katsuki repeated to himself, It was supposed to be a while from now. They weren't supposed to fall apart now. Not now. It was too soon, Katsuki thinks throughout the night as he tries to fall asleep. It was way too fucking soon, and he wanted Izuku to stay. If nothing else, if absolutely nothing else, Katsuki wanted Izuku to stay his friend, at least until the end of the year.

It was funny. No, it was absolutely ironic how the situation ended up. Months ago in the very beginning, they were in opposite positions. Katsuki didn't know how much longer he could wait to get away from the greenette, while all Izuku had wanted to do was get closer. And now, it felt like Izuku was the one who couldn't be around him any longer, while Katsuki needed his friend to stay. And Katsuki knew, that he was the reason why Izuku couldn't wait anymore. It's because of him, and how he always fucking made the green eyed boy cry. There was something he was doing wrong, and it was making the other sad.

It seems like these days, Katsuki would see sadness in those eyes that always used to shine so bright, more often than he'd see happiness. And Katsuki wondered where it all went wrong.

He wondered at what point did those smiles turn into tears. He remembers the beginnings. The diner, the firefly lake, the silos, and the creeks, the beautiful sunsets, and the drive in

theatres. All of that. It had been so innocent then, so pure. The atmosphere didn't feel as heavy with unspoken words and complicated emotions.

In those days, Izuku looked at him with large, fucking beautiful eyes that he hadn't fucking appreciate enough at the time. In those days, when they'd go out, there'd be unadulterated laughter that didn't have to be bartered with some mistake that Katsuki would make afterwards. It had been so happy then.

What happened. Because these days, it felt like nurturing the happiness in his and Izuku's friendship was like blowing on a fire to ignite embers that were bound to die away.

He didn't want that. He wanted Izuku to stay. To stay his friend, if nothing else. Katsuki could go without the sex. He could go without all of that. It was fine. But he needed the boy with the green eyes to stay, and for him to *want* to stay.

So he needed to work harder, *fuck* . Katsuki skips practice the next day. He gained an inch in the bar, so it made sense anyways. It wasn't as if he was going to die if he skipped one practice. And instead, Katsuki tried to pick up badminton, which was, he had to say, a shit sport. He hated it, and yet, he knew that Izuku liked it. And this is what good friends do, learn about the thing the other person likes. And when Izuku joins him in practice, Katsuki feels like it was going to be alright. Because the moment is happy. And for a second, it feels a little bit like old times.

His practices ramp up, as he's getting closer and closer to the Nationals Qualifiers, and Izuku's workload increases as well. And so, the two of them don't get to spend *as* much time with one another, and this was fine, but it also made Katsuki feel a little bit nervous because there was only so much time.

So when the bonfire comes along, Katsuki was planning on asking Izuku to come to the Hideaway anyways. The place had completely slipped his mind until recently, just when he was in need of a place to get away. With the one person he wanted to get away with. He's been there a couple of times before, so he knows it was beautiful. And if he took Izuku to beautiful places more, like what they usually do, maybe that would make Izuku stay too.

It seems like the boy likes it. Or at least from the looks of it, Izuku seemed to be in awe of the Hideaway. Honestly, Katsuki had a similar reaction the first time he came. The place was stunning, and had this gorgeous open feel that makes the abode feel closer to the Earth. Not to mention, the view of the ocean from outside the glass windows or balconies was intense.

But not as intense as being near the water itself. Hearing its crashing roar, seeing the bright moonlight glow on its surface. The foam nipping at his feet, sand sinking everytime a wave crashes and washes some away. And yet, Katsuki really only cared about what he was seeing in the moment. Running into the water, and splashing onto his back letting out a *whoop!* , Katsuki watches as Izuku does this, a moment of pure joy. He hears it. It was unadulterated happiness.

Izuku then gets up, and looks at him, looking absolutely stunning, Katsuki admits, in the water with a big smile gracing his face. And Katsuki takes a mental snapshot. He tries to hide his fucking idiotic grin, but Izuku notices and cocks his head to look better. Katsuki's shoulder shook a little with a quick laugh at how funny the movement made the shorter male look. He turns to hide himself better, but he knew it was no use. He feels like, at this moment, that it was going to be okay. They were going to be alright.

"What?" Izuku called out to him.

Katsuki chuckles just slightly and tells the boy his observation, "You look happy."

Izuku laughs at him, the sound so melodic, "So why were you looking at me like that?"

He just shrugged while grinning at the ocean floor, barely able to help himself, "It's just nice to know I can do that."

"Do what," Izuku kicked the water underneath his feet, hands over his head as if trying to capture moonlight.

Katsuki looked up at the sky then, and he meant to speak in a way that maybe the stars that grant wishes could hear, but not Izuku.

"Make someone happy," He says. *To make someone happy.*

The next time he tried to do the same thing, it ends in disaster. The previous night had been so fucking perfect. They had danced to dumb songs on the vinyl, talked until Izuku had passed out on his bed, and then did whatever. But *fuck* , Katsuki just had to go and mess it up. He had planned the stupid sunset picnic the night before, when they were sitting on the kitchen eating instant noodles. The idea suddenly popped into his head to cook a nice meal for the other, with candles, and maybe even his favorite flowers. That'd probably do it.

And when they go to the store, after enduring Izuku's shit driving, Katsuki makes Izuku wait in the car when he pretends he forgot to grab something and goes back in to purchase some flowers. Red lilies, he remembered that Izuku had liked it that night. And yellow flowers. Izuku liked those too. And he shoos Izuku away the moment they got back, just so that Katsuki could race the sun in making food.

The sun won. But Katsuki came in at close second. The more difficult part was setting up all of the material rather than the cooking, which he was just good at in general. He grabbed a comforter and laid it out. Candles. Took forever to find a lighter. And then tore the flower petals apart to toss onto the set up. And when he was done, he had to go find his pill speaker, which would give Izuku enough time to get up to him.

And so, the tall blonde shouts down, "Dinner's ready."

He hadn't been expecting the reaction. And he didn't understand it, or understand why Izuku was upset if he claimed to love it. But the next thing he knew, the boy was crying, and *fuck,* he had done it all over again. Again, and again, and again, Katsuki couldn't stop fucking up somehow. And yet, this one baffled him the most.

Izuku doubted the friendliness of his gestures, but Katsuki didn't know what to fucking say to that. He didn't understand why this was that big of a deal, but upon seeing the glassiness in Izuku's eyes, he was at a loss at what to do. So he told the boy not to think too hard about it. And that makes it worse.

"You…" Izuku had told him, "Kacchan, you set all of this up, you go and get flowers for this, you light candles, and play love songs. And you're telling me…" Izuku sounded like he was about to break, "You're telling me to not think too hard on it?"

And it gets worse and fucking worse, until Katsuki was trying to salvage the moment. He bent down and tried to pick up the flowers, plucking the pink and red petals off the ground, if it meant Izuku would stop sounding like he was going to cry. And he would blow out all of the candles and throw them into the ocean, if it meant that Izuku didn't look at him with those sad eyes that he knew he caused.

Izuku cries, and then he says he wants to go home. And Katsuki panics. Was this the moment? When Izuku had told him he didn't know how much longer he could wait, was this the moment? No, no, it was too soon. He hasn't had enough time. Fuck, it was too soon. He needed Izuku to stay. He wanted Izuku to stay with him. This was too soon.

He turns off Stevie Wonder, and almost begs the other, "Wait. I-I turned off the music. What else do you need me to do. Fuck , Deku, wait," He goes after Izuku as the boy reenters the house, "I turned off the music. I'll get rid of all the other things. Just stay."

He sounded desperate, and that was because he was. Katsuki was about to lose his closest friend, and nothing was making Izuku stop.

Katsuki follows the greenette outside, and is bombarded again with the heat, humidity, and now, the blast of whitish green street lamps glow and the crickets chirping inland.

And they fight. But this time didn't feel like last time. Last time, Katsuki knew there was going to be a resolution. Last time, there was a clear purpose. Katsuki wanted Izuku to accept his negativity. Izuku wanted Katsuki to accept his positivity. That was a solvable argument. That was a fight that they could go home afterwards, and now that it'll be okay.

But this, this fight, in the driveway of the Hideaway, under the bright moonlight and amidst the sound of loud crashing waves, this fight was over the moment Izuku utters those words.

"That I'm in love with you, goddamnit," Izuku says.

And Katsuki's entire foundation collapses, as he never planned for this. And his mind goes completely blank, as he replays the sound of Izuku saying those words over and over again in his head like a broken record. *I'm in love with you, goddamnit. I'm in love with you. I'm in*

*love. With you.* No, no, no, no. It repeats itself over and over again, and Katsuki lets it sink in the implication. No, no, no, Katsuki stills.

And because of this, Izuku cries. And oh, Katsuki wishes he wouldn't. Not because of him, again. There was no way. There was no fucking way that Midoriya Izuku, sweet, kind, Izuku, was in love with him. Not him. He couldn't be, because Katsuki didn't make himself loveable. It wasn't true, and Katsuki knows what it is. He knows exactly what it is, and it isn't fucking love.

"You don't love me," Katsuki is convinced. He doesn't. Katsuki knows it.

He goes on a tangent. There was no fucking *way* in hell that Izuku loved him. Izuku loved the freedom, he loved the independence, and the places they have been, but he doesn't love *him* . Because there's no fucking way Izuku could love him, not the way that he's been.

When Izuku slaps him, it didn't sting. It left an angry red mark, but Katsuki couldn't even feel it. Not in comparison to what all Izuku was about to tell him next. Not in comparison to the list of reasons why Izuku really *did* love him.

And that was right about when Bakugo Katsuki realizes that the fight was over. Because this is beyond what he can do. And so, he listens, unable to say a single thing, as Izuku speaks to him.

Izuku loves him because he ruffled his hair. Izuku loves him because of his passion for cherry pies. Izuku loved him for all of the things that he didn't know you could love someone for. Izuku loved him for all of the things Katsuki didn't even know made a difference. But the green eyed boy says all of it, and more.

And all Katsuki could do was listen, as his best friend stands there, crying, and asks Katsuki to tell him he loved him too.

To say he loves him too, because Izuku couldn't do this anymore. To say he loves him too, because it hurts him. And it was now that Katsuki realizes how much he had probably hurt the smaller all of this time. All this fucking time.

Everyone had been right.

He was only bound to hurt him. That was all he was able to do, and he didn't want to hurt Izuku anymore.

Yet he still asks, voice quiet, as it seems like Izuku was giving up, "I don't want you to leave."

But he does. Izuku does leave.

Izuku stopped, right before he left, to ask him, "You know how in books, there's sometimes different perspectives of the story?" Katsuki is still unable to speak, like an idiot.

And when Izuku continues, saying "I just wish I could have known yours," there was only one thing Katsuki could think of, but couldn't get out of his tongue :

I wish you could have too.

But the shorter boy disappears into the car. Katsuki doesn't see Midoriya Inko through the headlights, but he could guess that the woman wanted nothing more than to get her and her son out of here, away from him. Because the car turns, and drives off of the lot.

And Katsuki stands there, alone, like he was before Izuku, and now, after Izuku. The sea continues to crash behind him, the crickets still chip, the occasional nocturnal bird still screeches. Life was moving on. It was only him that stopped.

He...He should start moving too, Katsuki thinks blankly, as he removes his heel from the spot he'd been digging into for the last however long.

Throughout that entire interaction, the blonde had kept himself intact. Just a little more, and he can go to sleep. Just a little more, Katsuki tells himself, although his entire body feels rigid. It was quiet now. The laughter of Izuku was gone, and so was the scent of lilies that often wafted by him.

Katsuki turns around, and begins to walk back to the Hideaway. And yet, his feet stagger, as if they could barely stand to pull him forward. So that was it, huh. All of these months, and this is what it had all boiled down to. Katsuki couldn't really feel anything, but if he didn't go to sleep soon, that will wear off really quick.

Like his body weighed a hundred pounds heavier than it did, Katsuki pulls himself into the hideaway, and he goes out back. The view of the ocean might ease him. He'll sleep here. He didn't want to sleep in his room, or Izuku's. Not when he knew it would remind him of the little moments spent in there. He could barely look at the damn curtain as he passed by his own bedroom.

He was stupid to think that out here was any better. Because the set up with all still there. The food, the candles, the flowers that were crumpled up in corners. Katsuki chests starts to go up and down a little faster, and he shakes his head. No, not now. He forces himself to numb, and he steps back, shaking his head.

Music. He needed music. Something that won't leave him with his fucking thoughts, or else-. Or else, he didn't even fucking know. But he needed something playing, and so, with fumbling hands, Katsuki digs out his phone and goes to take a hold of the pill speaker, turning it on. He didn't care if it was like a movie, like Izuku had told him. He didn't care, right now. He didn't fucking care. Because in the movies, they always came back. Because in the movies, there was always a happy ending. In a movie, he'd come back. Izuku would come back. And so, Katsuki just puts his playlist on shuffle and puts it away, needing anything right now.

"Hello" plays, by Lionel Richie. And no, this wasn't right. He needed something happy, not this song. He needed something that will take his mind away. And yet, as the somber voice of Lionel Richie fills the night air, Katsuki just couldn't move to change it.

*I've been alone with you inside my mind*

*And in my dreams I've kissed your lips a thousand times*

Katsuki's chest was beginning to feel a little heavy, and he shakes his head, muttering to himself, *no, no , no* .

And he sits up, pushing it back down again. He wasn't going to do this. Reaching out to the table, Katsuki pretends that he was always supposed to be here by himself. He tries to trick himself into thinking that it was just supposed to be like this in the first place. And so, picking up the white chocolate macadamia nut cookie, Katsuki cracks his neck to cool his nerves and his heart goes back to normal, and he takes a bite.

*I sometimes see you pass outside my door*

*Hello, is it me you're looking for?*

It was a good cookie, perfectly crisp on the outside, and chewy on the inside. Katsuki nods to himself, and feels okay. The sweetness of the white chocolate chip comes through, and he takes another bite, before remembering a past conversation. On the scaffold, what seemed like so long ago. He had remembered a certain green eyed boy telling him that there was only one dessert he knew how to make. ' *White chocolate macadamia cookies! They're my favorite,'* Izuku had told him.

And *fuck,* Katsuki's hands drop the cookie, and he swallows what he had before his stomach began to churn again, and the weight on his chest comes back at the reminder. And *no* , no. He tried what he had done just a few moments earlier.

Pretend he was always supposed to be here alone. Pretend that it was like this to begin w-

The image of Izuku sitting on the floor of the kitchen last night eating instant ramen with him at nearly 2 in the morning comes back, and Katsuki's head whips around to where the kitchen was, chest pounding a little more, but it was completely dark with all the lights turned off. And *shit* , Katsuki runs a hand up his face. He stands up, and fast walks inside of the kitchen, where he grabs a couple of trash bags, before going outside.

*I can see it in your eyes, I can see it in your smile*

*You're all I've ever wanted and my arms are open wide*

Opening one up, Katsuki almost stumbles to where the food was set up, and began to throw things in there in a hurry. The faster he gets this out of the way, the easier it will be to-

A flash of Izuku's eyes, glassy, as he asks Katsuki to tell him he loved him too replays in his mind, and Katsuki drops a bowl and it shatters.

"Fuck!" Katsuki drops the trash bag and steps back, grabbing the back of his hair with both of his arms and walking backwards, looking up at the sky. He paced back and forth, hoping the walking will get rid of the heavy, restless feeling in his body as if it was about to explode.

He looks where the plate of sandwiches shattered, and pieces of porcelain flew everywhere. He took deep breathes, in and out, in and out.

*I long to see the sunlight in your hair*

*And tell you time and time again how much I care*

It wasn't working, and the flickering of the candle was going to make him go insane. He needed to fucking get rid of them. ' *I like the thought of laying in a field, with yellow flowers, looking up at the stars so it's like I'm floating in them'* . Katsuki shoves the memory away, of the stars or the yellow flowers. He shoves it away, and begins to shove the candles off the stands. They fall, wax dripping onto the tiled ground and the flame disappears immediately. Katsuki gets hot wax on his fingers, and he waves his hand around as he tries to pace away the feeling that was getting heavier and heavier on his chest.

"Fuck, fuck, fuck," Katsuki's brows furrowed and he bit into his bottom lip hard, already feeling a bit of strain in his throat.

*Sometimes I feel my heart will overflow*

*Hello, I've just got to let you know*

He needs to sit down. He needs to stop pacing around, it was making it worse. Katsuki finds the chair again and sits down, hunched over the table, with his elbows leaning on the edge and his eyes buried deep into his hands, scrubbing at him. He was getting memory after memory, as if his brain was trying to remind him of what he lost tonight. He remembered when Izuku took him to the drive in theater, the way he had climbed in with a full smile and when he asked what got the boy in such a good mood, the greenette replied excitedly, *I'm hanging out with Kacchan!*

And it was so stupid, it had been so adorably dumb that now, Katsuki laughs while he sits hunched over the table, head buried in his heads. He laughs and his shoulders shake. No, no, his shoulders didn't need to shake, because if he lets his shoulders shake now, even if he was laughing, then soon-

*Cause I wonder where you are and I wonder what you do*

*Are you somewhere feeling lonely or is someone loving you?*

The memory of Izuku's face, lit up by different neon lights, in his uncle's ice cream parlour intruded, and he thought back to the dumb, but hilarious fake porn scenario they acted out, where Izuku was the customer that brought no money. The way Izuku's fingers slid across the glass of the ice cream hood with exaggerated seduction. Katsuki sits there, and his shoulders shake as he laughs some more, eyes still squeezed shut and covered by his hands. No that was a good memory, Katsuki wants to keep it. Keep it locked away.

Katsuki kept thinking back to the moments where it felt like Izuku was happy. When his smile wasn't masking a pain that Katsuki couldn't see. He wanted to turn back time. Those moments. They were perfect, and he didn't appreciate them enough.

*Tell me how to win your heart, for I haven't got a clue*

*But let me start by saying, I love you*

The blonde finally releases his eyes from his hands and he sits back up, taking a loud breath as his chest goes up and down heavily and he blinks several times to recalibrate, before leaning his head back up and whispering to himself, “What the hell. Katsuki, calm down. Shit. *Fuck* .”

Izuku had swung in after he had, the day they went to his grandfather’s farm and took their lunch break at the creek. The nerd had been so afraid of leeches, and yet, he jumped in anyways. And Katsuki laughs at that too, standing back up, and wiping the sweat off of his face. He remembers running up to lift the boy off his feet in the yellow fields, spinning Izuku around and touching their foreheads together, and that particular memory, of him saying Izuku’s name, makes a choking noise in the back of Katsuki’s throat. No. No, no.

*Hello, is it me you're looking for?*

*'Cause I wonder where you are and I wonder what you do*

*Are you somewhere feeling lonely or is someone loving you?*

It was the first sign. The odd choke. Katsuki shakes his head, and his hands were quivering so slightly when he reaches out to the clear the rest of the table. He wanted it out of his sight. In a shaky sweeping motion, Katsuki throws most of the items onto the ground, just so he didn’t have to see it. A red lily popped into his head, but it wasn’t the pretty moment where he put it into Izuku’s hair, it was the look of glassiness into Izuku’s eyes as he walked away. Katsuki had known that day that Izuku would cry the moment he left the Night Market. He knew that he caused that expression. And the choking sound happens again, and this time, it was in combination with his chest practically heaving.

Katsuki puts his hand on his chest, aching, as the other grips onto the edge of the table, and his eyes suddenly stinged, “What the fuck, what the fuck.” The blonde says to himself out loud, but it was one pitch higher than his usual voice, which meant that it would be coming soon.

*Tell me how to win your heart, for I haven't got a clue*

*But let me start by saying, I love you*

His mind was flooded then with more memories. Except he was no longer laughing. Because they were morphing. All of the pretty ones, the beautiful moments, they were shifting into uglier ones. A freckled face with tear streaks on them that day Izuku slept with Kaito. They had dried up, but Katsuki could see the faint lines of tears from hours before, and slight red puffiness.

Bakugo Katsuki lets out a strange noise, and his shoulders shook again in rapid succession. Twice. Then once. Then maybe twice again, as if he was trying to hold back intensely. His brows were furrowed together, and he tries to blow out air.

Izuku's smile as Katsuki brought the dance to him, was suddenly replaced with the dejected expression when they were in the lighthouse, right after they had slept together and Katsuki had coldly asked if he was ready to go back. He remembered those eyes well. And the blonde shakes his head now, and there it was.

The first tear, and no one would have ever known it was there, because Katsuki brings his entire arm up to wipe it away as quickly as it came.

*Is it me you're looking for?*

*Hello, is it me you're looking for?*

Those happy moments and beautiful memories were slipping out of his hands, and Katsuki felt like he was scrambling to grab them and keep them close in his arms, but every time he tries, others slip away. Like going to do laundry and dropping pieces of clothing as you walk, trying to bend down to grab it, only to see that you dropped some more as you did so. The moment he would think of Izuku's smile, maybe that night they swam in the lake or laughing at a dumb movie, the image would shatter and all he'd hear is Izuku's dejected voice, quivering lips as he could barely stand to look at Katsuki. The arguments, the passive comments, the absolute pain.

Katsuki was letting out smaller choked sounds now, and his hands were shaking, and he didn't know what to do with them, so he puts them both on top of his head, pacing around for just a couple of seconds before he couldn't do it anymore, and he sits on the ground, with both his knees up and elbows locked on top of them. And there, on the ground with his face buried in the inner corner of his elbow, Katsuki finally fucking gives up.

And lets himself cry.

In Katsuki's head, he was standing waist deep in the waters they always seem to swim in, with a million memories of Izuku falling from the sky like paper. And all he could do was try to desperately catch each one of them before it crumbled and stains in the water, sinking deeper until the ink runs and he could barely see it anymore. He wonders where it all went: the excitement in Izuku's voice, the carelessness of when they would sneak out of his house, the unadulterated laughter. He wanted it to come back. He wanted Izuku to come back. The song ends, and Katsuki, without moving his head from his elbow, using his opposite arm to reach out and search around for his phone. And when he finds it, he stops the music, and goes back to the position he was in before. His shoulders shake, and the inners of his elbow and neckline of his shirt was stained with his own tears. He felt alone again.

And so, after a while, when his tears calm down, and he was reduced to staring blankly at the ocean through the slits in the terrace balcony, Katsuki just lays down, back hitting the hard flooring. And closes his eyes. His cheeks felt stiff from the tear streaks and his under eyes puffed up.

And then Bakugo Katsuki tries to fall asleep, hoping that in his dream tonight, he gets to relive today.

But this time, Izuku stays.

Chapter End Notes

thank you so much for everything guys. i truly love everything yall do in fts town , & i know chapter 11 doesn't really bring us forward, but i think it's necessary for what i want to do next so ty for you patience! throughout the fic, we see circled quotes, circled themes, and the just concepts that go round and round. so i felt like the ultimate circle now, would be to go back to the beginning. and like how chapter 10 ends off, see it from the other side

twt: suffocatingspr1

# Chapter 12: The Maze

Chapter Notes

40.1k words

Forgive the pace, this one's kinda wack, but thank you so much for reading thus far. I love ftstwt & ftstown & just everyone in general to death.

Playlist w/ all FTS songs:
https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy?si=65af4d1dd21045d2

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It’s sunny.

God, it was sunny. Through closed eyes, Katsuki could see the veins running through his skin, and the bright yellow rays piercing through his lids. And the air, it felt good on his face, brushing his hair across his brow ridge. It wasn’t too hot, with a bit of breeze sweeping through and the gorgeous sound of waves crashing and seagulls filled the morning air.

Underneath his back, Katsuki feels the soreness from the hard granite tiled floor, and if at any point he decides to get up off of the ground, he knows there will be a slight ache. Stuck to the underside of his arm were the tiny fragments of the porcelain he had shattered the previous night that. He had laid down on them without knowing, lost in the intensity of last night.

Bakugo Katsuki wishes that it would be one of those mornings where he got to enjoy a bit of oblivious peace, with a couple minutes of happiness before the memories of everything that has happened comes back. But he didn’t even get that luxury: the luxury of forgetting for the few hours that he went to sleep.

No, in his dreams, he relived the same day again, over and over until it felt like he could recite Izuku’s words of goodbye. Until he felt like he could count the tears falling from the boy’s sweet face. And everytime, Katsuki does something different, says something different, to make Izuku stay. And yet, the green eyed boy never does.

Because out of all the things he says, it’s never the one phrase that would make a difference.

Katsuki opens his eyes finally, and comes face to face with a blue morning sky filled with gorgeous tufts of pure white clouds and equally white birds flying overhead. It was a beautiful morning, and that almost made him more upset than if the weather had matched the mood. Because it felt as if the world was already moving on from the events of yesterday,

while he still could not grasp the fact that Izuku was gone, that Izuku loved him, and that he can barely handle it.

Reaching his arm out and feeling around for his phone, Katsuki takes a hold of it and tries to connect to the pill speaker. Music could help. The day just started, it wasn't too late to get in the right mood. When a notification on his phone tells him the speaker had no battery left, Katsuki cursed just once under his breath.

*Shit* , the blonde says, closing his eyes again for a couple of seconds, before deciding to just play it from his phone and sets it next to his head. His movements were ragged, as if he was having trouble acting normal. Putting the playlist on shuffle, Katsuki rubs his temples at the song that comes up.

The downtrodden sound of Chris Isaak's Wicked Games plays through his phone speakers, and Katsuki immediately dislikes how the song embodies just how defeated he felt. And this feeling. This *sensation* of defeat was something he's never felt before to this extent. He was Katsuki. Katsuki Bakugo. And defeat was not something he knew of. And yet, there it was in his chest and in his head. He is about to change the song, when the words come in, and Katsuki decides that he'll just let it play.

Katsuki just breathes out, "Fuck this shit."

*The world was on fire and no one could save me but you*

*It's strange what desire will make foolish people do*

Katsuki looks up at the sky once more, still not having gotten up from his spot on the ground, and how sunny everything looked made him angry. And when he sits up, tiny pieces of porcelain fell from his back and arms to the tiles. How perfect and joyous the waves and the animals in the vicinity seemed made him angry.

He hated that it was a perfectly sunny day. He fucking hated that the birds were chirping. He hated that in the world, nothing seemed to change when in fact, everything *has* .

The sky should be storming with him, Katsuki thought. The ocean should be murky and muddled alongside him, Katsuki thought. Time should have stopped when Izuku left him, but no. Instead, it's beautiful this morning.

It's so fucking beautiful, and it just drives Katsuki crazy. To Katsuki, it felt like the aftermath of a storm after everything being ruined. And there is just this painful acceptance that life moves on, even when you can't get rid of the constant pain that's killing you to feel. He sits there, drowning in his own misery, as the Earth continues to revolve around the sun. As the animals, blessed with ignorance of human emotions, carry about their day singing their beautiful songs and jumping up from the waters majestically.

This was the sad reality, wasn't it. In movies, when something like last night happens, the weather for the next week was always rainy, stormy. All of the sorts. Life stops for the main characters, and everything around them is put on pause until they fix whatever shit they had

going on. But as Izuku so bitterly reminded him last night, life wasn't a movie. Life was cruel like this: it moved on. It produced sunny skies as if to spite his pain.

*I never dreamed that I'd meet somebody like you*

*And I never dreamed that I'd lose somebody like you*

Ise. Why does nothing never seem to change in Ise? It's like the same cycles over and over again. Sunny skies, gorgeous sunsets, perfect weather and appearances. Nothing fucking changes, and even after a night like last night, the world goes back to normal. The neverending cycle was killing him inside, because he was no different. It's like they say: the environment makes the person. Katsuki couldn't fucking change either. He was just like this town, stuck in a constant loop of false content. False satisfaction with the person he was. And yet, it felt like he couldn't change. Felt like he could try for a million years, and end up back in this cycle.

*No, I don't wanna fall in love.*

The frustration makes him grit his teeth, and Katsuki picks up his phone and himself off of the ground and stands up, stretching his legs for the first time this day, and taking a look at the wreck in front of him. A broken dish, candles put out on the ground with wax that stuck to the tiles, food that was half shoved into open garbage bags and half just left out on the table or floor. Red and yellow petals shoved to the side, swept up by the wind and carried to the other side of the terrace.

His chest began to feel heavy again, and Katsuki grabs at it to stabilize his breathing, as he looked at the destruction. The blonde shakes his head, then turns around, refusing to look, and Chris Isaak's voice accompanies him back into the house where he leans over the bar counter in the back of the living space. His phone is set to the side, and Katsuki looks up to the array of different liquors and mixers on the shelves. From the behind him, the open windows let in the sound of pretty ocean waves and the sun shines in and casts a nice yellow glow on the bar countertops, and Katsuki tilts his head up to the ceiling and lets out a strained breath.

If he could burn down this house so that it would get a little uglier, he would. But everything was perfect: from the dusty pink couches to the matching curtains, to the pattern of the marble on the countertop. It was perfect, and yet, he couldn't fucking enjoy any of it because the only person who made any of this worth a damn thing was gone.

His red eyes move back up to the liquor shelves, and he wonders if now would be a good time to down a glass of scotch. Maybe the burn in the back of his throat and numb in his brain would feel better than the uncomfortable weight on his chest. Katsuki wasn't a big drinker.

He had a drink or two at parties for the fun of it, but his substance of choice was Izuku. Izuku, with those sweet lips that stumbled over its words and laughs really prettily when Katsuki makes a dumb joke. Izuku, with those wild tuffs of green hair that would smell like lilies drowned in saltwater when they would get up from the beach. Izuku, with those *beautiful* green eyes that Katsuki never got to tell him about.

As the blonde reaches up to grab a bottle of Scotch, aged 15 years in some fancy-pants distillery, he makes up all the ways that it could have happened. All the ways he could have told Izuku his eyes were beautiful. Where could they be? On the dock somewhere in Ise maybe, watching the sky turn from pink to purple, legs swinging over the water that's crashing against the dock legs. Yes, that was good, Katsuki thought to himself. And just before it goes to twilight, Katsuki would have told him then, just how beautiful Izuku's eyes were. But.

It wouldn't have made a damn difference, Katsuki dryly chuckles to himself as he reaches down to the built-in freezer behind the countertop and pulls out pre-molded ice for the whiskey glass he had set out. It wouldn't have made a damn difference, because he could tell Izuku all he wants how much he's grown to like those eyes, but he couldn't ever say that he loves him. And so what's the point. What then? If he were to sit side by side in that dock in his imagination, if he were to tell Izuku just before twilight hits, what then? Katsuki pours out a quarter glass, and swirled it in his hand.

Izuku would just be more hurt. That's what. Because apparently, he has been treating the other like more than a friend, while promising that it can never be anything more. He chuckles humorlessly. He brings the glass to his lips, eyes looking forlorn in the distance. What did that even mean.

Tilting his head back a little, the scotch burned the back of his throat, and although everyone says whiskey is smooth going down, it really wasn't. It was this harsh, burning feeling that immediately hit him with its intensity, sure to leave its essence in the back of his throat for a while. He knew this wasn't quite the healthiest coping mechanism. And Katsuki, being who he was, having Nationals Qualifiers so close, didn't have room to be fucking around with his body. He didn't have room to be drinking liquor, or any of the sort. But in this state of mind, all Katsuki could say to everything else in this world is fuck it.

He takes down the rest of the scotch glass, and then two more, until he can feel his brain lagging by two seconds with his vision when he turns his head from side to side. Because of his size and muscle composition, it took a lot more for him to get a bit tipsy than it would for most people. He was waiting for the positive effects to come in, the numbness and lack of recall. If he can just not recall the past 24 hours, he'll be fine.

What Katsuki forgot was that alcohol was a depressant and an amplifier. If a person wasn't already happy, then alcohol wasn't going to make them happy. It only amplifies the emotions that were already there. And by the time he remembered that little fact, Katsuki was standing with both hands situated on either side of the bar counter, staring intently at the shine of the whiskey glass to distract himself from that intensely heavy sinking feeling in his gut again.

It felt as if at some point last night, the floodgates had been opened, and now, he was trying his damn hardest to close them up again. He was *not* going to repeat last night.

But as Katsuki brings his hands over to grab onto his phone, wishing for some happier tunes than this desolate guitar from Chris Isaak's song, he notices his fingers shaking. And in his slightly influenced mind, it jogs the memories of how he had reacted last night, which then sent him into a spiral of preventative panic.

Because last night. Last night, it started with his hands shaking too, and he knew how *that* turned out. Shaking his head, heart pounding a bit from fear of having another unwanted breakdown over *Izuku* fucking leaving, Katsuki tried to take any preventative measure. He needed to talk. Now. If he were to be left with himself, it'll happen again. He'll break down again. He needs to talk to someone, about anything. Pole vault. That's it. He needs to talk about pole vaulting. That'll drive his mind away.

Grabbing his phone, he opens it up to the front screen, and stares at the notifications he has on every platform. At any given time, at least 50 messages. At any given time, at least 10 missed calls. At any given time, more notifications from socials that he could count. And yet, when his brain went through the motions of finding someone to call, he could think of no one. His eyes travelled from contact to contact, before pressing Kirishima's number.

On the third ring, his red headed friend answers, "Bakugo!" He drags out the blonde's name.

And yes, this was good. Kirishima was a high energy source, which he needed right now.

Clearing his throat, and almost out of reflex putting on a collected show, Katsuki speaks into the line, "Shitty Hair."

"What's up, All Star?" Kirishima replied with a big whoop, "Have you seen the news? Ise is naming you their All Star Athlete 2021."

Katsuki gruffly laughs, "For the 4th year in a row?"

This was good. They were on the subject of pole vault. Katsuki feels a bit more relaxed. This is good, he repeats internally. If they keep talking like this, he'll calm down from his delirium.

"Hey bud, if you don't want the title, I'll gladly take it," Ejirou offered on the other side.

"Nah. Fail a grade and try again next year when I'm gone," Katsuki wipes at his nose.

"So harsh," Eijirou tsked, "Honestly, I don't think I'll have to fail on purpose. At the rate I'm going in trig, I actually might."

"Dude," Katsuki snorts, "It's trig. You're literally just solving triangles."

"That's not even fair man," Eijirou complained, "In that case, pole vault isn't hard. You're literally just jumping over sticks."

"Woah now, asshole. Don't blaspheme," Katsuki clicks his tongue jokingly.

"My bad, my bad," Kirishima chuckles before letting out a sound of curiosity, "Anyways, so what's up. You need anything?"

Katsuki looked down at his fingernails tapping on the side of the crystal glass, "Just wanted to talk."

“Oh-ho! You just wanted to talk, huh,” Kirishima seemed excited, “Who is this and what have you done to Bakugo? Mr. I’m-All-Cool-And-People-Approach-Me-Not-The-Other-Way-Around lookin’ motherfucker.” He laughs.

The blonde rolls his eyes, “You’re really milkin’ it now, you son of a bitch.”

“I’m just messing with you, man. Of course I’m happy to talk,” Eijirou settles down now, and then asks, “But I gotta ask, did Midoriya finally get sick of you or something?” Eijirou laughs, but Katsuki wants to throw up. God, he wants to throw up right fucking then.

Kirishima says the absolute worst words to hear at the moment, and Katsuki involuntarily reels, speaking into the phone with an almost dangerous edge in his voice, “Change the subject right fucking now.”

“Woah, woah,” Eijirou has known Katsuki long enough to back up immediately at the sound of that tone, “I was just playing again.”

“I don’t care,” Katsuki says blankly, “Change the subje-”

“You two are super tight, I was just joking,” Kirishima continues, as if trying to save his skin, “No seriously, I don’t think anyone’s ever gotten to you like Midoriya has. That dude really cares for y-”

Katsuki hangs up the phone, and sets it down on the counter. No. Not today.

He’d rather just go back to sleep. And so, with a slight heaviness in his steps, Katsuki avoids both of the bedrooms and collapses on the couch, unfolding a blanket and pulling up to cover his eyes from the disgustingly sunny day. He'll sleep this away. It was a Sunday. What did he need to do anyways. Stay awake and think of Izuku? Hell fucking no.

And when he wakes up again, it was dark enough that the blonde didn’t want to wretch. With his anger simmered and his internal strife numbed down, the blonde drives back. The radio is turned off, and the road back into town is silent aside from the crickets and cicadas. He hates how he used to listen to music so mindlessly, with no attention to the lyrics, and now, it’s all he can focus on when he plays a song. *Isn’t that why you listen to all of those songs? Because you want to love?* No, Katsuki refutes. No way. He doesn’t even let himself think about it. Instead, Katsuki blocks out all thought from within his mangled mind, and numbly drives back all the way home, forcing himself to think of the road and only the road.

The thought of going back to Ise High on Monday didn’t sit well with Katsuki, because what the *fuck* was he supposed to do when he sees Midoriya Izuku again. When he got back to his house last night, from his stature alone, neither his mother or father tried to make conversation or tried to ask him where he was this past weekend.

Of course they wouldn’t, Katsuki snickers to himself as he throws his shit on the floor and heads straight for the shower. The moment they see a scowl on his face, they back off and don't even bother.

And so, as Katsuki makes his drive up to Ise High at 7:35 in the morning on Monday, he has one hand on the wheel and one hand distractedly rubbing his bottom lip. Inko had picked up the greenette Saturday night. Katsuki wonders what Izuku had been doing since then. Did the boy cry any more? Katsuki hoped he didn't. Not over someone like him. Has he been getting enough sleep, or enough to eat? Has he been okay?

Katsuki doesn't fucking know what there is to do now. It was the last week of class, and they were still project partners. He didn't even know why Mr. Toshinori made the project partners hang out up until the very last week. It didn't even matter since the final analysis was due Thursday of this week anyways. Katsuki knew that some of their classmates was simultaneously writing their final report and doing the project, but the blonde hasn't started yet, and he was sure Izuku hadn't either or else that would have come up sometime in the months they've been doing this together. But what they were going to do for this final hour, Katsuki had no fucking clue.

Because from how their conversation turned out, it didn't seem like Izuku was very fucking keen on seeing him. And if Katsuki were to be honest with himself, at this point, he didn't know what to say to the damn nerd if he were to see him anyways.

Stay? Stay and do what. Pretend that Izuku wasn't in love with him, and go back to how it was? Pretend that Katsuki didn't get addicted to those eyes, and that Izuku didn't feel a part of him die inside when Katsuki spends yet another day not able to feel the same way?

Katsuki's had his fair share of awkward encounters. When girls or guys want something more of him after a one-night stand, and when Katsuki sees them at school the next day, it's usually awkward on their part. But never has Katsuki *himself* felt nervous.

And yet now, as he approaches the school parking lot, he's so fucking distracted at the thought of seeing Izuku again that he barely saw another car in his peripheral vision, and when he did, his foot slammed on the brakes so hard that his entire body lurched forward at the rapid stop.

"Fuck, *shit* ," Katsuki furrows his brows and rested his head back against his seat for a second, before looking over to the vehicle that he had almost cut into, only to curse even more, left leg bouncing intensely on the floor of the car. His luck was just incredible. It was a cop car that he could have t-boned. A fucking cop car.

A cop car that was currently turning so that it could park on the side and flag Katsuki down. Bringing one hand to rub at his temples, Katsuki took in a deep breath at how *shit* this day was going already and turned on his hazard lights to wait on the side of the road. Tickets here in Ise weren't usually expensive, but he didn't have to deal with going to court to turn it in.

When a knock comes on his windows, Katsuki rolls it down to begrudgingly talk to the cop.

The blonde's eyes look slightly forlorn as he looks out the window at the hunched over cop, "Oh, Mr. Hidashi."

"Bakugo?" The policeman in question raised both his brows and breaks into a grin, patting the roof of Katsuki's car, "How have you been, son?"

Katsuki turns back to face the front and shakes his head slightly, “I’ve been fine.”

The cop whistled, “You don’t look fine, and hey,” He put both hands out in defense of the boy, “That’s perfectly okay. You got a lot of pressure on your shoulders, don’t ya. With Nationals Qualifiers coming up and all. Make Ise proud, alright? I bet you're working real hard,” He pumps his fist.

Like it was an automated response coded into his system, Katsuki nods, “Of course.”

And there’s a bit of an awkward silence between the two of them for a moment.

Before Katsuki furrows his brows and looked over and up at the cop, asking, “I almost ran the stop. I almost hit your car. You ain’t gonna give me a ticket?”

Katsuki knew all he needed to say. He’s told Izuku this before, long ago. All he needed to say was *sorry sir, I won’t do it again* . Or any rendition of that. And he knew he would be fine. But this morning, Katsuki decides to push it out of annoyance. No one seems to fucking care about anything he does around here. All he does is win, and yet, none of it felt that great anymore.

The cop waved an arm off with a careless look, “You’re good, kid. It happens to everyone. Besides, I’m sure you got a lot on your mind because of the tournament, I don’t blame ya.”

Katsuki nods slowly and grips the steering wheel tight, “Right. Of course I’m good.”

“What’s that?” Mr. Hidashi leaned down, ears pointing towards Katsuki, “Sorry, my hearing is-”

“I said,” Katsuki should shut up right about now, but he doesn't, “Let’s say I hurt someone. Let’s say I *actually* did hit someone. Would having a lot of my mind be a good enough excuse?” *Or is it just because it's me*.

Why was he invincible in this little town? Why is he, someone who hurt people and didn’t deserve half the damn praise he gets, immune from any real consequences. Why did he deserve this. Because he jumped well? Why was he invincible to everything, except for a certain  pair of fucking green eyes and a nice laugh.

“Oh, um,” The cop stood back up with his back straight, almost as if he was embarrassed, before shrugging, sticking by his original verdict, “There’s no point in dwelling on what hasn’t happened, Katsuki. Just don’t worry about it, okay? Just head into school, and have yourself a nice day, alright?” He patted the top of Katsuki’s car and let him off.

Without another word, Katsuki left.

Izuku wasn’t there on Monday. Katsuki had been internally dreading seeing the other all damn morning, just to find the greenette’s seat empty in the first class they had together. Immediately, a feeling of concern washed over him, followed by guilt, because he had a strong intuitive feeling that Izuku’s absence was linked to the events of this weekend. As if

out of habit, his hands reach into his phone and opened up his text message conversation with the boy. And his fingers actually managed to type in a “U okay?” before his brain caught up, and his actions froze in their tracks. If no one was around, he’d be laughing right now, because what made him think sending a text like this when everything is so fresh would be okay. Putting his phone back into his pocket, Katsuki accepted that he just wasn’t going to find out unless Izuku wanted him to.

Izuku’s absence makes going about the day a little easier, especially if he convinces himself that he was fine, and that the past two days had just been a moment of weakness. But Katsuki knew that the moment that he sees Izuku again, all the beautiful memories and all of those nights spent laughing at something fucking stupid with Izuku’s head on his lap will resurface. He just knows it.

He won’t know what to do when he looks into those eyes again and sees a world of love just waiting for him that he feels he can’t return. The blonde doesn’t blame the boy. All of this time, he’s been internally needing Izuku to stay, not even aware that by staying, Izuku was hurting more with a love he can’t get returned. He doesn’t blame Izuku.

But that doesn’t mean that Katsuki doesn’t numb his mind just to get through the day. Teachers’ voices drone on endlessly, and he takes notes just so that his hands and mind would be actively doing something. Lunch is quiet on his part, and surprisingly enough, on Kaito Sen’s part. The brunette did not seem like he was in the mood to talk much, and for the first time, Katsuki felt as if they had something in common. Because honestly, he didn’t either. Sitting back, Katsuki chewed on his food and sipped on his drink until the time ticked down to his next class.

Bakugo Katsuki practiced like he was making up for a semester’s worth. Monday meant team practice. Katsuki didn’t bother to look towards the sidelines. Izuku wasn’t there. Even after the team left, the blonde set up camp, intending to be there at the practice track for as long as he could before his muscles gave out. He needed this. He needed to focus on Nationals Qualifiers, the most important thing at the moment, and hopefully, that will tear his mind away from thinking of anything else.

As he stands on the track, pole in hand, and bar set to 18’2, he breathes in and out, sweat dripping down his brow ridge and sharp eyes focused only on the impossible height before him. He wasn’t good at emotions. He wasn’t good at making someone as bright and fucking wonderful as Izuku happy. He wasn’t good at any of that shit. What he *was* good at was this: this sport. This sport is all that he has left.

The athlete practices until his hands feel like they had probably worn down the pole, until his arms feel like mush. But even then, he kept going. As long as he was careful enough not to tear a muscle, he’ll be fine. From his pill speaker, music was playing, but his mind was practically so drowned out that all he could hear was the blood pumping in his veins, the labored breathing from his mouth, and the clank of the pole slamming into the vault box in the moment before he’s launched up into the sky.

He’s trying to chase that feeling. The feeling that was so easy for him to get before: of flying so high above everyone else and being so close to the clouds that it’s euphoric. He needed that euphoria again, now more than ever. He fails the 18’2. That’s fine. He doesn’t need it for

Nationals Qualifiers. It'll help though. If he manages to vault an 18'2 at Nationals Qualifiers, then that will be his new official record ever since his last recorded one in Youth Nationals last year. If he manages to vault an 18'2, then that will practically guarantee him a victory in semis and finals level Nationals. That's what he needed to focus on right now.

When 9PM hits, his body gives out and he collapses onto the landing mat with his entire being sore and done for the day. He feels his chest inhale and exhale a million times. On the drive home, his music was blared loudly as if to drown out the phantom sound of Izuku's laughter in the passenger seat. And upon arriving home, he beelines towards the shower, and does all that he can to expedite the time it takes for him to drift off into sleep, where he prays his dreams will be more pleasant than his reality.

"No fucking way," Mina Ashido screeches near them, "You're kidding me. That did *not* happen."

"I'm not lying, I swear," Denki puts both hands up in defense, "I couldn't make this up if I tried!"

"That's true," Ejirou snorts, elbowing the yellow haired friend, "That takes a little too much brain power."

As of current, Denki had just finished telling a story about something he saw walking home just the other night, but Katsuki only picked up bits and pieces even though he was sight *right* there, because just a couple meters away, Midoriya Izuku was sitting *right* there.

Tuesday, the greenette shows up, and upon seeing the pretty boy in physics, Katsuki's stomach fucking sinks and he contemplates calling in a sick day right then and there just so that he doesn't have to relive every fucking memory they've ever had in his head every single time his eyes dart towards Izuku's direction. The worst part of this all was that the boy with the sun kissed freckles and pretty lips didn't avoid his eye or anything. When they walked past each other on the way to turning in an assignment, Izuku caught his eye and with the tiniest, pained smile, simply nodded.

It was just as he said the very last time they slept together. From strangers, to rivals, to friends. And now, it felt as if they were back to strangers. Katsuki hates seeing those saddened eyes, the lack of substance in their interaction just now, the nod as if they were just those kind of friends that see each other once a year rather than three to four times a week.

So this was the reality of how relationships die. It isn't like in the dramas where a blow up happens, and everything absolutely erupts into chaotic flames. In reality, it's a bit more harsh. Katsuki gets to see it as it all goes down. The small half-hearted smiles with the meaningless nod, the slow drift apart until their eyes won't even meet anymore, and maybe one day in the future, a distant "how have you been" once its all ash and dust.

“Bakugo?” Their professor takes him out of his thoughts, and Katsuki realizes then that he’s been holding on to his worksheet, not having dropped it in the bin, for a good minute now, just staring intently off.

Being brought back to reality, the blonde drops his work and wordlessly turns around. And the entire class period, he couldn’t stop thinking about that solemn face, marked with slightly dark circles and a smile that wasn’t quite there. It looks like even after all this time, Izuku still had trouble not pretending he was happy when he wasn’t.

And as of right then, everyone was in the cafeteria. Katsuki on one side of the table, sandwiched between some of his teammates. Izuku, just a couple of meters away, close enough for earshot and for Katsuki to occasionally look over and see that similar to him, Izuku was sitting to the side eating quietly while his friends were doing most of the talking.

“Oi Bakugo,” Denki called his attention back to the conversation at hand.

Katsuki hums in acknowledgement.

“What shift are you taking tomorrow?” His teammate asked.

The blonde completely blanks, “Shift?”

“At the fundraiser,” Denki blinks as if there was no way Katsuki could have forgotten, “You know...the one Ise High does every year? The one our team volunteers at every year? The one w-”

“I got it, you shithead,” Katsuki thumbs his temple and asked out of obligation, “What are we working this year.” He's been so preoccupied that he had forgotten entirely.

“The mirror maze,” Ejirou cuts in, “There’s a couple of shifts left. You need to sign up before Coach gets onto you, man.”

"I'm captain, you idiot," Katsuki reminded him, "I'm forced to take any and all shifts you motherfuckers don't sign up for anyways."

Remembering this, Eijirou remarked, "Oh yeah, my bad."

“Besides, Coach ain’t gonna do shit to me,” Katsuki grabs a napkin to wipe at his mouth, “I just gave him an 18’1 PR.”

“You’re kidding me,” Mina stares at him with wide eyes, “When did you hit that?”

“Not too long ago,” Katsuki answers plainly, as he pulls out his phone to check what shifts were left empty that he had to take.

Every year, Ise High does a giant fundraiser in the back of the school grounds, where there was a good amount of open land, where all of the proceeds get donated to Alzheimer’s research, and it’s the same stuff every year. Mini bumper cars, those inflatable jungle gyms and slides, lemonade stands, crafts tables, and the mirror maze were always popular. It was mostly for kids, but the parents *chaperoning* the kids were the main targets. After all, if it was

an event targeted for teens, then parents would have an easy time saying no if their brat were to ask for this or for that.

But since the activities were generally more geared towards younger children in the community, what was a parent going to say to their 4 year old brat that wanted a t-shirt with the worst fucking design on it. No? And look like an asshole in front of the other more generous parents? Nah. It was a trap scheme. But it was a trap scheme that was designated towards a good cause, so Katsuki doesn't mind taking a couple hours of his day every year to help work it.

“You’re a god,” Sero stared in shock, “I’ve barely gotten my PR up 3 inches in the last semester. Lend us your secrets, now.”

Katsuki ran a hand through his hair while his eyes averted the others and without really thinking, just replied quietly, “Found new motivations.”

This caused the table to *ooh* and *ahh* at the strange comment, with some poking at Katsuki.

“New motivations? Tell us more, All Star,” Sero had a huge grin on his face.

“Nothing more to tell,” Katsuki would like this conversation to end now.

“Hey man, you brought it up,” Sero wagged his brows, before holding out a fake mic formed from his fists as if he was interviewing the blonde, “So tell us, Mr. Bakugo. What has been your newfound motivation for these incredible feats of athleticism?”

Coming towards them and sliding into an open seat at the table, a feminine voice chirped in playfully, “A lover is my guess.”

Katsuki’s sharp eyes turned to Kimi right away at her comment, and the statement almost shocked him, and his expression broke for a moment. From the side, he hears the sound of choking from what seems to be Izuku’s table, but he doesn’t turn to look.

Instead, Katsuki just looks back down and relaxes his shoulders.

Mina points to Kimi with a playful accusation, “You’re not referring to you, are you, hot stuff?” She asked with a wink.

The brunette girl rolls her eyes with a smile, “I wish. We're just friends," She smiled before scolding Katsuki, "Although, you still owe me one for embarassing me last time." Katsuki's neck turns red at the memory.

"Last time?" Mina leans in and asks with a wag of her brow, "Tell us, Kimi. What happened last time?"

"Mina," Katsuki warned, just looking at his drink, tone telling her to back down.

"Oh uh," Kimi flushed, "Mina, I already...mentioned to you in...private..." She stammered, and her eyes looked over to Katsuki apologetically, and she turns quickly to Bakugo, "I promise I only told Mina. I didn't tell any-"

"It's fine," Katsuki waves off. He was more than used to people blabbing the day after, and most people didn't even bother to apologize, so he excused Kimi, but who he wasn't excusing his friend who was trying to imply something, "Min-"

"Yes, but come on, girl," Mina tried to milk something out of the brunette volleyball player, "How can you say you're just friends," Mina turned to wink at a blank faced Katsuki, "Since you know, you guys *did* it?"

Kimi's eyes widened, and she shook her head, "What? No, that's not what I told y-"

"First of all," Katsuki grips the leg of the table tightly just so that there is some form of control in his facial expression. His chest was filled with a bit of a rage, and it seems like each day presents some new breaking point. He directed his statements at Mina, "If we *did* , that's none of your damn business, much less at the fucking table right now," His crimson eyes go up to meet her wide eyes, "Do you have no respect for me at all?" He spat.

The table tensed up. Mina was his friend, Katsuki would say. She was funny, gave somewhat good advice when it came to general things, smart, but her fatal flaw was that the girl had a flair for the dramatic. And that was fine. Plenty of people do. Aoyama. Tokoyami. Even Katsuki occasionally had a flair for the dramatic. But Mina had the benefit of being likeable enough that everyone tells her *everything* that's going on, and when it's relayed, details are usually added or missing to make stories more juicy. He's teased her before for it, but this time, it wasn't nearly as funny.

"Secondly," Katsuki knew he probably shouldn't say this, "If you actually listened to the goddamn gossip you're told instead of picking and choosing what makes for the better story, maybe you would have heard Kimi right the first time. Instead of spreading shit that's ruined everyth-"

"Oi, oi, Bakugo," Kirishima reached for his shoulder, "You're going back to your old ways, man. Calm down."

"Don't fucking put your hand on me," Katsuki brushed him aside, "So what. I'm just supposed to fucking sit here and listen to you make up shit about my fucking life as if I'm not here? And I can't get angry, or else I'm the asshole? Well guess what, maybe I haven't changed." He said out of impulse, even though he knew it wasn't true.

"B-Bakugo," Mina looked a bit embarrassed, but still tried to salvage herself, "Of course I respect you. Just...can you chill out? It's just for fun."

Katsuki rolled his eyes, "Stop treating me like I'm some fucking caged animal. This goes for the rest of you. Dunce Face, you aren't much better."

It was at this point that Kimi jumped in, face looking a bit concerned at how the conversation was going, "Hey, I didn't mean any harm by telli-"

"I know," Katsuki pushed his face in his hands as if a bit stressed out, "I know you didn't. You're fine."

Kimi was a nice girl, Katsuki understood that. She hadn't done anything wrong, or at least, anything that wasn't normal for people to do. She had a likeable personality, pretty face, and she hadn't even seemed overly antagonizing or offended at his lack of performance the night they hung out. Obviously, she was embarassed, but who wouldn't be if the person they were trying to hook up with won't get hard for them. For what it was, Kimi took it relatively well. It was just that with Katsuki, everything and anything that *can* get twisted, *will* get twisted. And he's just *stuck* in this box, where he will forever be reduced to an arrogant fuckboy with emotional issues, and that's all that society deems him fit to be.

Moving his face out of his hands, but still holding a clasped hand up to cover his mouth, Katsuki stares out at the table with blank eyes. He had nothing left to say, and the strain in the air was thick, but that wasn't his problem to deal with. Katsuki knew it was irresponsible to just throw all civility out the window because his personal life was going to shit, but he could barely help himself.

To clear the tension and get the conversation back on track, Eijirou just chuckles a bit nervously and makes a show out of elbowing Katsuki.

"So, it's not a lover then. Got it," Eijirou laughs, and the table laughs too. The sound of amused chuckling rippled through the table, from all except Katsuki and two others.  Kaito and Kimi.

"Of course not," Sero threw a carrot at the redhead jokingly, "This is Bakugo we're talking about here."

And as if it was some trophy or accomplishment, the vaulter with raven hair threw an arm over Katsuki's shoulder and told the table, "He's a legend. He can do everything and have anything he wants. You think this hunk," pointing towards Katsuki who sat there with both hands clasped in front of him and elbows on the table, "...is gonna fall in love and settle? Why would he!"

He said it like it was a good thing, like the last thing anyone could ever expect from a man like Katsuki was love. He's had these comments thrown at him over and over again throughout the years, and they've never bothered him. But right then, it feels just a little too close to home for this taste. Still, Katsuki sat there, eyes looking off while he just sits in the commotion, with everyone at the table praising him.

"Ah, very true words spoken," Mina Ashido seemed to have gotten over the past few minutes and looked at Katsuki playfully, "Tell us, can a god like you feel love?"

"Nahh," Eijirou speaks to the crowd while shaking Katsuki's shoulders. He was pulled in by Sero on his left, and Eijirou on his right, and they were both trying to make him feel all big and unstoppable, yet in this moment, Katsuki has never felt more small and ripped apart, "That's for mortals. Don't ask for too much, guys. We're lucky if we can even get a clap on the back after practice," He laughs.

Katsuki simply sits there. He knew they were all playing around, but it felt like all of these statements were derived from some common perception of him. And so, he just sits there,

and simmers in the words. After all, their goal was to make him feel cool and untouchable. A couple months ago, he might have said a *hell yeah!* and laughed with them.

“ *I’m* lucky if I can get him to say my actual name,” Another vaulter blurts and the table laughs in agreement.

And like they were going around in an icebreaker circle, yet another person added to the potluck, “I’m lucky if he even *remembers* my name. Oi, Bakugo,” the boy with pink hair turns to their captain, “I’m starting believe you only know your own name.” He laughs.

From his peripheral, Katsuki saw Kimi’s eyes dart back and forth between the interactions of the vaulters and their captain, and with a confused laugh, she takes Katsuki’s side, “Oh come on guys. Bakugo, tell them you’re a cool guy. Isn’t this a bit...” Her expression looked a little nervous.

Katsuki doesn’t plan on saying anything.

He didn’t have to. Denki waved her off, “Don’t worry about it, Kimi! We’re always like this with each other. Bakugo doesn’t mind, right Cap?” Denki looks over to Katsuki’s stoic face. Everyone starts to chime in to reassure her.

“Seriously, don’t worry about it. Throw something at him. The harshest thing you've got. It's amazing actually. We’re all convinced he can barely feel pain-”

"Then again," Someone calls out in response, "We're also convinced he can't feel happiness. Which is it! Choose one or the other," He says, and the table laughs again.

“But yeah, it’s all good," People kept reassuring Kimi, who still looked hesitant, "Cap can handle anything. This is nothin-”

"Let's just say this, he's heard a lot wors-"

“-on’t get too worked up over it, Kimi. Seriously, he doesn’t mind.”

“He couldn’t if he tried,” Someone piped in, in response to the previous statement, reassuring Kimi, “Cap’s really chill. Honestly, I admire it. He really doesn’t care about anything except for pole vau-”

From just a couple meters away, a foreign voice broke their conversation with a sternness they haven’t really heard before.

“Guys, stop it,” Midoriya Izuku turned his body partially to address the table of vaulters crowding Katsuki, but his eyes met each person’s gaze dead on. Even with those bags and faint dark circles, there was clear disdain in those green eyes, as Izuku revealed he had been listening. From his side, the boy’s friends looked like they stopped too, and looked surprised at Izuku’s sudden declaration.

Katsuki doesn’t move from his positioning, but that didn’t mean his attention didn’t go immediately to the voice he knows by heart, probably better than his own, when Izuku spoke up. The greenette had only said three words, yet there was this internal feeling of rescue that

Katsuki felt in his gut when Izuku had spoken up for him. All of these words thrown at him were ones that he was used to and has accepted himself for the most part, but they hit a little hard today.

Inside of his jaw, his teeth was locked tight together and Katsuki refused to say anything because he knew nothing coming out of his mouth would matter.

"...Eh?" Mina blinked, a little confused by the sudden intrusion, "Stop...what?"

Izuku looked down, lips opening and closing, before stammering out, "All of it. Kacchan cares."

Katsuki felt his entire heart fucking turn in his chest at the acknowledgement. And never in his life did he miss hearing that nickname than he did now, and all he wanted to fucking do now was take Izuku's arm and they run away to do something stupid together. But *fuck* , he couldn't. He knew he couldn't.

"Oh you don't have to say that because you're afraid of Bakug-" Someone says.

Izuku stands up suddenly, eyes fuming with anger, and mouth open ready to say something in refutation, and by the looks of it, everyone knew that something was about to burn up in flames. However, before the greenette could even let a word out, someone even *more* unexpected came into the conversation.

"He's not afraid of Bakugo," Kaito Sen says from the other end of the table, eyes staring intently at his grapes as his fork pushes them around. It was the very first time that the brunette spoke up during this entire debacle, and what more, it almost seemed like he wasn't teasing the blonde. Kaito continues, tone completely serious, "If anything, it's more like the other way around."

Everyone's ears were turned towards Kaito, who most people knew to have never liked Katsuki in the slightest, almost afraid of what the brunette could say to add fuel to the fire. The last thing they expected was for the rival to extinguish that fire. The tension at the table was tight. Izuku looked like he was willing to fight someone. And Kaito looked thoroughly irritated.

"One more thing," Kaito pops a grape into his mouth, not looking at Katsuki or anyone in particular, "Shut up. All of you need to shut up."

And for now, that was all that the brunette had to say.
Katsuki felt internally surprised himself. After what happened the last time they interacted, in the locker room, the last fucking thing that he expected was for Kaito Sen to take his side. He didn't let it show on his face, or in his body language. But he catalogues it in his mind. For some fucking reason, Kaito Sen took an opposite take from his usual approach.

"What is it now," The vaulter with pink hair from earlier who claimed Katsuki didn't know anyone's name but his own laughs, "You spend all these years saying the same things we're saying but worse, and now, you want to give us shit for i-"

“Taichi Ishihara,” Katsuki said then, slowly shrugging himself out of the seat and standing up, grabbing his bag, and his face was blank as he moves casually, “Number 6. Record: 13’4. You’re 5’10. 163 pounds. You like to go into a vault starting from the left side of your body due to the injury you got last October. You’re stressed out because your damn girlfriend wants to do long distance for college, but you want to go to the same one,” Katsuki recites the things he overhears during practice, “You got a C in calculus, but you haven’t told your dad who’s an accountant. You’re planning on dying your hair green with the help of some friend of yours. You want to get your mom a nice necklace for her birthday, so you’ve been taking extra shifts at the restaurant.”

Katsuki does this all without breaking his movement of swinging the backpack over his shoulder, tying his shoe on the seat he was just in, and turning around to head out of the cafeteria before lunch even ends, all while rendering Taichi, who had claimed just minutes earlier that he’d be lucky if the captain even knew his *name* , speechless and internally and unequivocally guilty.

"Yeah," Katsuki says, not revealing that he is affected in his voice, "I guess you could say I know your fucking name."

And as he exits the cafeteria, Katsuki shoves in his headphones and doesn't even notice the silence he left behind.

It’s on his mind all damn day, and Katsuki wishes that he could get it out. He wishes he could get all of those damn words out, but now, more than ever, it seems like his brain wanted to remind him of every single fucking time he’s ever been told of how fucking emotionally useless he was. The day passes like a blur, for strings of words occupy his mind without a break. *He couldn’t if he tried. You can’t love someone if you’re like this. ...he’s never gonna be able to love anyone. Because he’s a lunatic. -only cares about himself. He’s not capable of love.* It’s like mantras in his head, repeating again and again, until he was sick of it all. And that was barely scratching the surface. And he knew these things.

He *knew* everything that people were saying wasn’t too far off, but my fucking god, this did not feel good.

Katsuki repeats his routine from yesterday, and when practice comes along, he breezes through team practice without mentioning a word about what happened earlier, and each time someone tried to approach him about it, he’d just brush them off. Katsuki’s chest felt fucking heavy throughout the entire day, and he knew that he was just building up all of these damn emotions again.

It seems like since the first breakdown he’s had, the rest have been coming out easier and easier. And that did not sit well with him. Almost two decades worth of never shedding a tear over any fucking thing, hit its boiling point three nights ago, and now, it seems like the water refused to cool down.

He takes it out on his pole after team practice ends, and the bar that was set on 18’2 never felt more desirable.

Turning on his speaker, Katsuki puts on Heaven Only Knows by Richard Marx, and uses the electric guitar to get his motivation up.

He focused his attention on making the jump, desperate to get all of the words thrown at him today out of his mind. He shouldn't fucking care about what those extras had to say. But internally, Katsuki knew that those weren't just extras, no matter how much he likes to say it. Those were his friends, his teammates, all in agreement that he was like this: that he's always been fucking like this. If his own damn friends and teammates were saying this, then of course they'd be right. Sure, they were exaggerating on some stuff. He knew their names, he knew plenty of things about them. He cared about their performances, and if they were hurt, he'd worry.

But were they right about everything else? If they were wrong, why would they say it so often over the years? If they were wrong, why would his own mother and father believe the same shit. If they were wrong, why would Katsuki had convinced himself all this time of the same shit.

That's right. It's because they *weren't* wrong. He knew this, and yet, coming to the realization again hit him like a jolt of lightning, and he collapsed on the back of the mat, after *so close* to getting the 18'2, and instead of feeling ecstatic over his progress, he feels the side of him that was mentally obsessing over the events of today win over, and that heavy weight in his chest got even more damning and he put a hand on his heart while blowing air out of his mouth to calm himself. He shouldn't have played Richard Marx, knowing how the 80s singer tended to sound like the will to live has been sucked out of him in everything he sings.

The whole reason he was throwing himself into vault tonight in the first place was to get all of this shit out of his mind, but he was on the losing end, and before he knew it, Katsuki was hunched over the landing mat, both hands holding himself up with his head tilted down as he forces his eyes to dry up. He takes audible breaths, and talks himself out of it.

"Get ahold of yourself, asshole," Katsuki tells himself between breaths, eyes almost bloodshot as he forces the wetness to redact itself, "Fuck. Get ahold of yourself."

And all the words flash back in his head again. All the claims, all the jokes that he can't love, that he is coldhearted and that it was how he'll always be. These were the reasons why Izuku left. Everything around him constantly reaffirms this fact, and having that constant reminder is fucking with him immensely. Not the mention having the greenette so near, yet so far at the same time.

Katsuki was losing his shit again, and he wonders when it got so easy for him to break down like this. It was like, prior to three days ago, getting him to this point was damn near impossible. Yet now that the floodgates were open, he couldn't fucking stop himself. Katsuki wonders if this was how Izuku had felt when the boy begin to get himself get angry after years of never doing so. His shoulders were shaking, and his grip on the mat got tighter as the veins in his forehead bulged out more from the pressure he was putting on his body to not let himself go. He just needs to stay like this, and not say anything, and not think of anything, until it goes away and he goes back to nor-

“K-Kacchan?” A worried voice ran up to him, and Katsuki’s immediately looked away automatically.

He knew what it looked like. His shoulders were fucking shaking, he was hunched over, and his voice and face made it obvious what was going on. And he did *not* need fucking Izuku to see this right now. The boy had enough on his plate, and Katsuki knew that Izuku’s tendency to worry over him overrides his own sense of self-preservation.

“Go away,” Katsuki’s voice was warning, and if it wasn’t for the slight quiver in his tone, he might have sounded intimidating. But due to that tiny mistake in his presentation, it was obvious that Katsuki was more nervous than he was irritated.

Katsuki assumes that the boy had just gotten out of some late meeting with the student council, likely about the fundraiser event tomorrow. He wants to look at Izuku, drink in the sight of the beautiful boy for as long as he can before they’re back to practically strangers, but Katsuki knew that the moment the shorter male sees him, he’ll worry himself to death.

“A-Are you ok-” Izuku began, voice soft with worry.

“Izuku,” Katsuki says, head still hunched over and eyes shrouded by his hair, and he’s still trying his damn hardest to keep himself together, “I…” His voice sounded more pained than he intended for it to be, “...can’t talk right now.”

He still doesn’t look at the boy, but he hears Izuku shifting a bit and then, the greenette takes a seat on the landing mat. But the boy doesn’t say anything. From what it feels like, Izuku was just sitting there. Just having the boy’s presence felt a bit overwhelming to him, so he knew that to Izuku, it probably felt even more intense.

And so, after what felt like five minutes of just silence aside from the classic Ise crickets, Katsuki asks in a low tone. There was no one else around. They didn’t need to speak very loudly.

“What are you doing here,” He quietly asks.

After a moment, the boy replies softly, “Getting our last hour in.”

At this, Katsuki finally looked up and caught Izuku’s gaze, momentarily shocked at how downtrodden he looked, before chuckling lightly, “We’re just going to sit here for an hour?”

Izuku tucks his legs up, wrapping his arms around, and setting his chin on his knees, “Yeah.”

And so they do. Right where it all began. At the track and field.

Izuku sits there, and says nothing, just taking in the last couple moments they had left in this god forsaken project. And Katsuki stays hunched over the mat, hands on either side, working hard to keep himself together. And for a long time, it was just like this, until the blonde feels like he’s relatively okay enough to stand up and sit down on the landing map, a foot away from Izuku. And they watch the sky turn to twilight, cutting the lights out in Ise. And in a way, cutting the lights out on the two of them and what they had.

This was exactly the ending that Katsuki wanted back when this project started. Back then, he imagined that the last hour would happen like this: with the two of them, awkward and quiet, spending their last 60 minutes as project partners before parting ways for what seemed like forever. It was *exactly* the fucking ending that Katsuki and Izuku had agreed on at the beginning of the semester. It was now that Katsuki thinks back to that one famous quote: “Be careful what you wish for.” Funny little mantra, but true nevertheless, as he takes in the situation. He got exactly what he had originally wanted.

It was as if the world was mocking him. *You got what you wanted* , the universe told him, *Aren’t you happy* ? It mocks him.

The ending they got was exactly the one he imagined. His reaction to it, however, was not.

When twilight bleeds into darkness, Katsuki is the one to offer Izuku first, as if wanting to savor any last moment with the boy, “Let me drive you home.”

And in the quiet of the night, Izuku replies with a soft whisper, “Okay.”

After tonight, they won’t even be project partners.

As he drives Izuku back home and they both sit in silence, the feeling of becoming strangers again starts creeping in, and Katsuki hates it. When contrasting it to memories of Izuku laughing so hard in the passenger seat at some life story they made up for strangers walking across the road that his stomach hurt, or memories of them doing car karaoke to 80s dance hits together down a boulevard, this was a bittersweet finale.

Izuku tells him thank you when he leaves.

“I’ll see you tomorrow, Kacchan,” The boy tells him.

And immediately, Katsuki’s ear perked up and he faces Izuku quickly, “Tomorrow?” As if they were back to their old selves, making plans out of the blue, always promising each other to see one another soon. For a second, he was thrown back in time, and he forgot that *no* , they can’t just hang out anymore.

Izuku nods, “In class. And...the fundraiser.”

Right.

Katsuki turns on the radio when Izuku leaves his car. Immediately, a song he was only slightly familiar with comes on, and Katsuki decides to listen to it on his way home in order to freshen up. The heavy weight is still in him, and being around Izuku for so long only made it worse, but if he can just make it home, take a shower, grab something to eat, then go to sleep, that would be all that he asks for tonight.

An English rock band, 10cc, sung this song and it blew up pretty well. *I’m Not In Love* , it’s called. Katsuki’s car drove at moderate speed on his way back home, so that he can listen to the lyrics, having forgotten how the song went.

*I’m not in love*

*So don't forget it*

*It's just a silly phase I'm going through*

Katsuki chuckles.

“Fucking hell,” Katsuki laughs to himself, even though nothing was funny, and just keeps driving as the song proceeds. He thinks about what he wanted to eat tonight for dinner. His parents would probably have leftovers sitting on the counter. He could eat whatever that was, and if he was still hungry afterwards, he can cook his own food.

*And just because, I call you up*

*Don't get me wrong*

*Don't think you've got it made*

His brain circles back to the evenings spent at either his or Izuku’s place, rummaging around in the kitchen for ingredients to put something together to eat. Them throwing flour at each other and having Mitsuki throw a pissy fit, forcing the two boys to clean up every inch of the kitchen spotless. He chuckles again to himself. Damn, he hates this song. He hates these lyrics.

*I'd like to see you*

*But then again*

*It doesn't mean you mean that much to me*

Katsuki hears a string of *ding!* Indicating that he’s receiving a couple of messages on his phone, and he reaches back and pulls his gym bag to the passenger seat where Izuku was sitting. Keeping his eyes on the road, Katsuki unzips the bag and reaches his hand in, reaching around for his phone. The blonde feels around, and stops when he makes out the shape of something unfamiliar that he shouldn’t have in his bag.

Frowning to himself, Katsuki knows the shape of what it is, but he didn’t have one the last time he checked. Pulling it out to confirm, Katsuki looked over at the object in his hand.

At some point in the evening, Izuku had slipped him a cherry gatorade in his practice bag.

*Fuck* , Katsuki began to laugh outloud to himself like a maniac, but there was evident pain in his voice. Although it was a gesture of care, to Katsuki, it almost felt like a final parting gift and he did *not* fucking handle that well. Katsuki laughed until his stomach felt like twisting in on itself, and after he finishes laughing, that was when the first drop of water left his lashline. This is what it felt like. A parting gift.

The blonde blinks it away, and airily laughs some more, “My fucking god. It just can’t stop coming, huh.”

The cherry gatorade is left rolling around on the floor of the passenger seat. Katsuki doesn't want to look at it. Funny how something that used to bring the blonde a fair amount of joy was causing him physical pain at just the sight of it. He laughs at how fucking stupid he was, and then, he laughs at all the words everyone told him today, and yesterday, and last year, and five years ago, and if he was being honest, all his damn life.

*Ooh, you'll wait a long time for me*

*Ooh, you'll wait a long time*

*I'm not in love, so don't forget it*

Katsuki leaves his car in the driveway, and locks it with a press of a button, before he drags his body inside. It felt like all the mental weights that he's been dragging was making it hard for him to walk. From the tip of his toes to the highest hair on his head, Katsuki felt drained and dejected. Oh, how dejected he felt. It was carving out his fucking soul. His hands barely had the energy to open the door, and it felt as if he had to put in more effort than normal to just keep his head up.

When he entered the house, it was completely dark except for in the far back where the kitchen was, where two of the edison bulb lights were on above the kitchen island. Other than that, the living room, stairs, and everything else seemed dark. So dark.

And he would have thought everyone was asleep if not for the sound of rummaging in the kitchen.

He just stands there, near the front door as it slowly closes by itself, barely having the energy to walk.

He's been practicing like his body had no limit, straining his damn heart and mind, hung up over a friend he lost that he can barely even call a friend, confused to hell and back about who he was, what he was capable of, and what he even *wanted* to be capable of. Every sentence that was said to him regarding his emotions felt like another shackle tied to his feet, preventing him from moving inside of his own home. Every emotion he's been afraid of also added another shackle, until he was carrying the weight of two cars behind him.

Katsuki tilts his head up, swallowing, and his jaw quivered for a second. His hands are loose by his side, and his shoulders were dropped.

Behind him, the door finally shut closed by itself, and at the sound, the rummaging in the kitchen paused.

Mitsuki peeks her head over really quickly and called out to her son.

"Brat, you're finally back?" Mitsuki asks across the house. She was in view. Her hands was holding a seran-wrapped bowl, and she set it on the kitchen counter.

The blonde in question didn't reply. Silence continued to infiltrate the house.

Her back was still turned to him as the blonde woman opens the island drawer and fishes out a pair of utensils, “I texted you asking where you were, did you not see it? Anyways, I made some pot roast tonight for dinner, and thought you’d want some, so I saved you a plate. Although, you might need to heat it up a little b-”

“Mom?” Katsuki croaked out. His voice cracked in the middle of the word, and there was a very audible pain evident in just the way he said it alone.

His body was still slightly sticky with sweat and the humidity from the outside. The house was dark enough to conceal his face and body. His brain was muddled with every single thought that could possibly go through his head. And he feels like he barely has the energy to move. The Bakugo Home was shrouded in darkness save for the kitchen light, and he can’t take it anymore.

At the sound of her son’s voice sounding uncharacteristically coarse, Mitsuki stopped what she was doing and turned towards the dark living room, eyes focused more towards the front door where Katsuki was standing, covered by darkness. She took a pause. Something felt off. Standing in the doorway, she could barely see anything but the sillhouette.

“Katsuki?” Mitsuki called out in response, not yet too concerned, but definitely a little curious.

The brat was just standing there, near the front door, after having called out her name in such an odd manner. And it was quiet for a while. And then.

“Mom?” Katsuki breaks his voice again as he called out towards his mother, jaw shaking a bit as he head tilts up more up as if to conserve his pride, yet when he spoke, defeat was clear in his broken words, “Am I-” He swallows, “Am I able to love?”

He asks, and at the end, his voice tapers out into a tiny sound, and his head drops down as his eyes squeeze shut, and his stomach and chest began to convulse slightly as he tries so hard to not fucking cry again. It was in the way that by the end of his sentence, his voice broke into tiny pieces and the pitch cuts off that did it for him. His eyes squeeze shut as if it’ll force away the wetness, and his drooped shoulders shake a little.

From the kitchen, Mitsuki drops the utensils in her hand, and the metal hits the floor with a clang, before the woman was making her way quickly out of the kitchen, and across the dark living room. Footsteps echoed as she quickly walked.

“Katsuki?” This time, there was a clear panic in the woman’s voice as she makes her way to her son. The athlete looks at her, and sees worry--as clear as day--in those familiar red eyes, and Bakugo Mitsuki sounds concerned, “Katsuki? What’s wrong? What’s wrong, baby.” Her eyes dart back and forth, taking in his appearance, checking his body to see if he was okay.

The 6’4 athlete who has built the reputation to be as cold as Antarctic ice loses all composure he had left at that. To hear his mother, after so many years, finally call him baby. Finally ask him what’s wrong. Finally show him the tenderness of a mother. To finally experience all this in a time where he feels like he needs it most, Katsuki lost hold of the floodgate doors.

It wasn't as if Mitsuki did not care. She did, but in her own way. She was the type of mother that tended to play the tough-love card. She was the independent woman who raised her kid to be the same way. She was one of those mothers that have a more lax, hands-off approach to parenting, and could joke around with her kid easily like friends.

But there are many times in a child's life where they need their parents to be tender. To treat them more like a child, rather than a friend. To be the pillar that the child leans on. Katsuki didn't know until just now, when he was seeing it for the first time, that he never got that.

If Inko Midoriya was the type of mother to give too *much* tenderness, then Mitsuki Bakugo was the opposite. But life was a balance. You can't just treat your child like they'll forever be naive, but you also cannot treat your child like they're born as adults. You can't keep in all of your positive emotions, but you also cannot keep in all of your negative emotions. You can't spend all of your days dreaming of the sky, when there is so much beauty on the ground to appreciate as well. You can't blame all your problems on nature, when it's obvious that nurture plays a role too. There is a middle ground that is oftentimes too difficult to navigate. Too much history has shaped why he thinks and feels the way he does today about things, too much to go through piece by piece. But this, by confronting the very place, the very person where it all began and stemmed from, was a start to some form of mental resolution.

"Katsuki, talk to me," Mitsuki begged him, her hands going up to cup the boy's face, "Please. Tell me what's wrong."

Katsuki was taller than his mother by a fair amount, larger than her. He's outgrown his shoes plenty of times, and everyone in Ise including his own family knows that he's a grown boy. He can take care of himself. He can do everything himself. But it was just now, that it became obvious that at the end of the day, Bakugo Katsuki, no matter how big he grows, like everyone else, can still be a child in need of care and tenderness. Mitsuki had her head tilted up to her son, hands cupping his face, and eyes searching frantically for answers. The woman has never seen her own son like this before, and it was making her panic.

"Why can't I love, Mom," Katsuki asks, voice cracking left and right, as he wipes away tears, not wanting to look at her, "Why can't I love." He repeats.

Mitsuki's hand freezes, and she stares up at her boy in shock.

"...love?" She asks in barely a whisper.

The athlete nods, shaking as he asks, "You told me once," He swallows heavily, "That I can't love or sweep someone off their feet, because I'm like this, because I hurt people," Katsuki looks down at his feet ashamed, "All this time, and I've never been able to prove you wrong."

Suddenly, Mitsuki breathes in, face contorting into a pained expression, as her hands hover just slightly above Katsuki's face as if she was afraid to touch him, and her fingertips begin to quiver just slightly. Her lips open partly, as her brows raise in concern and recognition. It's then that Katsuki figures that his mother recognizes that line. She recognizes it all right.

Katsuki’s voice gets quieter and a tad bit higher in pitch as he continues to ask through painful silent cries, “I ruin everything."

Mitsuki's face cortorted more into pain, and her hands shake more as she realizes what she's done.

"I can’t love anyone, because I’ll ruin that too. Because I’m not made for that, right?” Katsuki bites the inside of his cheek, before begging for an answer through bloodshot eyes filled with plea.

Mitsuki could barely let out a whispered, *"No*." Oh god. *Oh* god.

“Everyone tells me that, Mom. Did…” Katsuki swallows and he tastes salt, tone vibrating through his tears, “Did you know that? Everyone tells me that. Except for…Except for...”

He looks to the side, and an intense pain shoots through his chest. He doesn’t finish his sentence.

Katsuki’s drops his shoulders further, and his gym bag slides off of his body and hits the ground with a thud, the contents without shaken around, and Katsuki faces up, with only his eyes looking down at his mother. A few streaks of tears staining his cheek and running along that sharp jaw. *You can’t love anyone if you’re like this.*

He asks her desperately, with a strain in his words, “Why’d you say that, mom,” He closed his eyes again, trying to control the way his jaw shook, before asking in a whisper, “Why’d you have to say that.”

Mitsuki shook her head slowly, tears welling up in her eyes now as she realizes what she has done, and her shaking hands reach back up to place itself on Katsuki’s face, and Mitsuki rests her head against her son’s chest. She’s never thought much about it. Not even once, has she thought about it again. They were just passing words, said to warn a child that was born with too many anger issues and management problems. She never meant any harm by it.

But even as Katsuki grew up, and everyone was right in that the brat *did* tone down a fair bit, by then, Katsuki had closed himself off so much that she was sure it was just his personality. Not for a second did the woman think that it wasn’t just Katsuki’s personality. Not for a second did the woman think that *maybe* , it was all that this boy heard growing up. Careless words tossed around about his unlikeability, his actions towards others as a *child* , his terrible personality--often played out as jokes, but to a kid, were very impressionable words. Mitsuki thinks back now, and wonders how she could have been so stupid. Of course her boy was confused now. Hurt. In agony. What kind of mother was she, Mitsuki thought to herself. What has she done. This all hits her like a truck. The late consequences of her own actions, that she had been pushing the blame off to Katsuki's natural personality this entire time.

Looking at her son now, seeing Katsuki cry for things he didn’t know he was feeling, caring so much about whether or not he could love, Mitsuki thinks: how could he not be able to? Of course this boy-- this brash, arrogant brat who has grown to show such sentimental sides that would surprise the woman herself --Of course this boy could love. Would a boy who wasn’t able to love be able to cry over love like this? Would a boy who wasn’t able to love want so

badly to understand love like this? How could she be so stupid. Did it really take Katsuki breaking down like this for her to have realized that she's been ignoring his sentimental side all of this time?

“Katsuki,” The woman who was usually firm, and sure of every decision she made, says with guilt and pain, “My baby…” She says to her grown adult son who’s never received this treatment from his own parents before even though he should have, “I’m so sorry.” She repeats over and over again, “I’m so, so sorry.”

It feels like a crescendo of emotions, because Katsuki shakes his head in disbelief and tries to shake Mitsuki off. He doesn’t remember the last time he hugged her. Their relationship wasn’t like that. They were the chill parent-child duo. She does her mom duties, like provide from him, have fun bickering conversations with him, and what not. But they were never the sentimental kind. So this. This felt odd.

Katsuki’s shoulders rack at this point, and his head was hung low and he just stands there limp, “What if I want to?” He whispers while he cries quietly, “Why can everyone else love, but me? I want to have someone to hold too. I want to sweep someone off their feet, too. I want to wake up next to someone every morning too. What is so wrong with me that I can’t do that without ruining it all. Why can’t I lo-”

“You can,” Mitsuki looks up at him, face ruined with tears as well as she tries to fix the mistake she amongst others have made, “You can love, Katsuki.”

“I can’t,” Katsuki shakes his head, chest shaking. He thinks back to all the hurt he’s given Izuku. People in love don’t hurt the ones they love, do they?

Mitsuki pulls him down in a tight embrace, as if giving back all of the affection she’s held out on over the years, knowing that it couldn’t fix nearly two decades worth of habituation. But still, she held her son in her arms as tightly as she could. She knew she was far too late. That she should have done this a long time ago. That all the times she and Masaru saw the boy upset, she should have hugged and talked to him instead of letting him deal with it on his own, even though he could. And now, as she tells her own son that he *can* love, Mitsuki knows it's her fault that the boy doesn't believe her.

“You can,” Mitsuki assures him through her own crying, “And I’m sorry for ever making you think that you can’t. I’ve ignored your compassion, and care, and kindness all this time, but it’s always been there,” She nods, and speaks hurriedly in case it was too late, “It’s always been there.”

“No, no,” Katsuki shakes his head but makes no effort to move from the embrace, he hiccups once, “You’re just saying that. You’re just saying that, Mom.”

“I’m not,” Mitsuki tries to convince him with a crying plea, knowing that she had a big role in why her son was standing in their living room at night crying to her about wanting to be in love, “You’re so capable. And I was wrong. You-”

“No one thinks I can. No one,” Katsuki’s voice raises as tears soak his mother’s blouse, “What-What the fuck makes you think I believe you? I don't believe you. I don't *fucking*

believe you.”

It was too late to keep up the tough act, not when he was falling into his mother’s arms like this, although he was 19 and ready to be shipped off to college to play professional sports.

"I'm telling the truth Katsuki," Mitsuki cries, and Katsuki tries to push her off, but she holds on tightly, "I promise you, I'm telling the truth!"

The blonde raised his voice, "You never believed in me. No one had. I don't even believe that I can. And now, I go home, looking like...like this, and suddenly, you go against all that you've ever told me?" Katsuki asks, still crying, "And you expect me to accept that bullshit?"

Mitsuki looks up, tear soaked face, begging Katsuki as she shakes her head, "And that's my fault! It's my fault that it took you getting to this point for me to realize. I'm not just saying this. I'm not, baby, I'm not."

Katsuki turns his head, and tries to break out of the embrace, "Get off of me!" He yells, "Let me go."

"No," Mitsuki refuses, and buries her face in his chest, pulling her son in tightly, knowing she helped cause this, "I've let you go for long enough, Katsuki. I've ignored your needs for long enough. I can't let go now. Please."

Katsuki gives up and his chest shakes from crying. He was fighting against the hold, but he knew that he internally needed it. The embrace of a parent.

"Please, let me make up for everything," Mitsuki holds him close. And they both cry right there in the living room. Katsuki finally reaches his arms up to hug her back, and her big kid who looked too grown to be doing this melts into his mother's embrace. And Mitsuki holds them there for a long time, while Katsuki lets out all of the frustration, sadness, and whatever else was in his system. And she lets out her own guilt. Katsuki wasn't even sure what time it was, but it was too late in the night to be doing this shit. His climb down from the heightened emotions was slow, but steady. Mitsuki *shhs* him, while rubbing circles into his back, and until Katsuki's breathing calms a little bit, she continues to do so.

"I still don't..." Katsuki whispers, "...believe you."

“Don’t believe in me then,” Mitsuki rocked him gently, “You believed me once, and look at this mess I created." She admits.

"If you’re going to believe in anyone,” She sniffled, unable to see her son like this, much less because of her careless words, “then believe in yourself.”

The blonde didn’t understand. He stood there, eyes squeezed shut in her shoulder, and didn’t say anything. It wasn’t just her fault. It wasn’t just his mother, or his father, or his friends’, or this town’s fault that he was like this. Katsuki knew it was also his own fault. He’s convinced himself so deeply, that he fucked himself over too.

Mitsuki continues, “You’ve always been a man of action, Katsuki,” She swallows, trying to keep her voice even, “So believe in your actions. Don’t believe in me. Believe in your ability to care for your teammates and always make sure they’re doing the best they can. Is that not love?”

She pauses to collect herself and swallow her saliva, “Believe in your passion for vaulting and how much you’ve dedicated to it. Is that not love?”

And Mitsuki doesn’t know whether or not she should go through with saying this, but by now, she practically *knew* , “Your father was telling me the other day...how the night you left the Spring Dance, you went to Izuku’s house, and danced with him instead.” She could feel the boy stiffen in her arms at the mention, and that’s when she knew she hit a sensitive spot, “That was very kind of you, Katsuki. Mr. Hidashi told me the other week that when he does his patrols, he sees you and Izuku a lot just out and about, even when knowing how Inko gets, you still do it. That’s very sweet of you too, Katsuki.”

She swallows again, “Auntie called me the other day. Said you left a note on the counter when her maintenance people came to clean up, saying you and a friend were there together,” That was a fresh one, “If you don’t believe in anything else, then trust in those actions, Katsuki. Is that…” She paused, “Is that not love?”

*Is that not love* ? The blonde male listens to every word his mother says, and hangs onto them as if they were his life. It wasn't as if a couple of words in one night can change nearly two decades of thinking. But it was a start. It was definitely a start. And Katsuki barely knows what to do with this new information, with this new opinion.

Katsuki’s voice lowered back down to barely anything at all, “I don’t know. I don’t even know.”

Mitsuki rubs his back as he continues to slump over her, “It’s alright not to, right now.”

Katsuki saddeningly admits, “ I can’t just go from not believing that I can even love for 18 years, to deciding that I am in love with someone right now.”

“It’s alright,” She ushers him softly, “No one is expecting you to.” She rubs his back some more to soften his hiccups.

“I don’t...know how to know,” The blonde boy can barely tell if he was making any sense.

His mother pulls away slightly then and wipes some tears off of Katsuki’s cheek, before giving a piece of her own advice that she learned a while ago, “Your grandaddy,” She chuckles, “He was the biggest romantic. You know what he used to say to me when I was a teenager?”

Katsuki didn’t say anything, but Mitsuki knew the soft brat was listening quietly.

She then quietly repeats to him his grandfather’s words, “You know you’re in love, when the love songs you listen to feel less like stories and more like reality.”

At this, Katsuki's heart began to thump faster, as he tries to decipher whether or not that was true. He was almost afraid of the conclusion he'll come to. And just as his mind begins to sift through the memories, Mitsuki stopped him.

"But don't worry about it tonight, okay?" Mitsuki Bakugo told him, sniffling once as she pulls away to look up at him, "Tonight, you need to eat the leftovers and get some sleep."

Katsuki's tear stained face was still solemn, but it felt as if one of the weights was being untied from his feet, after hearing his mother, after all this time, tell him that he *can* love in the way that barely anybody else thought he could.

Nodding and sniffling to get the wetness out of his nose, Katsuki replied in a croaked whisper, "Yeah. Yeah, that's a good idea," He bent down to grab his bag that had been left on the floor, "Food sounds good."

Mitsuki still felt overwhelmed with concern, and walked alongside Katsuki towards the kitchen, "Are you okay?"

"I'm on top of the world, what do you mean, hag," Katsuki jokes in his hoarse tone.

"Brat," Mitsuki laughs lightly as she wipes at her eyes before cleaning his throat, "I'm serious."

Katsuki looks down at the ground then sets his bag on the kitchen island barstool, "You're serious, huh." He says quietly.

"I'm serious. I'm long overdue with worrying about you," Mitsuki admits, barey looking at him, as they stand around the kitchen island of this odd home, listening to crickets and the occasional owl.

"It's all good, mom," Katsuki replies quietly, "I can take care of myself."

It wasn't said in an outrageous, hostile way, but rather, an assuring way, as if to tell her that he's grown up this far handling himself, he'll be fine.

"Doesn't mean you have to," Mitsuki croaks, "You never should have had to."

To this, Katsuki doesn't say anything. He looks back into the living room. His father was usually a heavy sleeper, but he didn't expect Masaru to be *this* heavy of a sleeper.

So Mitsuki looks up at him, "Let's hug each other more from now on," She wasn't a woman who was tenderly affectionate or even softly worded, but that doesn't mean she couldn't be here and there if it means her son can slowly unlearn all that she unintentionally taught him, "Let's tell each other about our thoughts more from now on. Let me do all the things for you that I should have done a long time ago."

Hearing this almost made Katsuki want to fucking cry again, but no more of that tonight.

Without directly replying, Katsuki references back to her earlier question and answers seriously this time, "I'll be fine," Emphasis on the word *be* , "I just need a little time to figure

everything out."

Mitsuki nods as she turns away from the kitchen island, grabbing a glass of water, "Of course," She fills it up, before sliding it over to where Katsuki is now sitting, "Take all the time you need. And t…" She paused, feeling a little awkward because she's never been like this with her own son before, "...talk to me. Anytime you want."

From the other side of the island, Katsuki takes a hold of the water, and nods to himself.

"I'll heat up some dinner," His mom then tells him, and Katsuki is just left with the words of earlier.

*You can. You can love, Katsuki .*

The fundraising event this year was projected to be the biggest one they had yet, judging from the trends in the past decade or so. Slowly, the Ise High Annual Fundraiser was becoming embedded as one of the city's own traditions, so they get a higher turnout every single year. And since this year marked the 10 year anniversary since this fundraiser tradition began, Ise High planned on making it even more extravagant.

Festivities usually started around 4 PM, and all day long, students left and right are excused from their classes to set up before 4 PM. It seemed like everyone in the school was involved. The fundraiser was held outside in the open plot of land behind the school, and people ran back and forth all day to get things set up.

All the clubs had a booth. The chess club had a station where they'd teach kids from the Ise community how to play. The volleyball squad had a net set up, and people to take shifts to monitor the mini-games they plan to hold. The community service oriented clubs were all scrambling to get drink stations, games, and entertainment set up. The Ise High radio station team led by students were in charge of music. The soccer team was on call to help out if any club or really if anyone needed their help to set up, as well as carrying equipment from people's cars to the booths. Whether it was inflatable devices, sound systems, or help with carrying food from trucks to the coolers. Even the teachers were out there on the grounds helping out.

Some things, students weren't allowed to help with. Setting up any heavy duty machinery for example. For the fundraiser event, Ise High usually rented out some typical fair equipment. However, since their budget was not as big as the county fair, it wasn't as if they could get a ton of rides. Instead, since this was an event mainly geared towards kids and preteens, the school would rent out collapsible rides that just went around a track and had something cute like Thomas The Train as its theme or something.

And the mirror maze. That was a fun one. The mirror maze took about a day to be set up by the company that rents them out, since it had to be put up slowly and in multiple parts, so they started that yesterday. In the end, it looked like a house. It was called The Mirror Maze.

Very original. And right through the door was a maze full of mirrors, backlit by LEDs. Katsuki's done it a couple of times, but the route changes every year.

This was the first year that the pole vault team would be manning the Mirror Maze. That must mean that one of the members must have called dibs on the sign up sheet earlier. Thank fucking god. The mirror maze was the easiest job to do, really. Only two people need to be on shift at any given time. One person at the front, to collect tickets, and one person on the second floor of the maze standing next to the slide that served as the exit down to the outside ground again, in order to make sure that everyone who comes in can actually find their way out.

Last year, the pole vault team was stuck with the "Dress Up" job, and basically, what that meant was that all the team members had to be stuck in sweaty and hot costumes of animals or popular pop culture characters and parade around the fair all damn night taking pictures with little kids. Katsuki almost got into a fight with Denki over getting the Batman costume, which he later regretted because it was stuffy as *fuck* in there.

Tonight, Katsuki was stuck with four shifts, since as captain, he had to sign up for any shift that doesn't have a volunteer from their team. All shifts were 30 minutes long, and since the fundraiser lasted from 4 to 9PM, that means there were 11 30-minute time intervals. Two people at the mirror maze each time. So there were 22 shifts total to be filled. 11 shifts at the front of the mirror maze. And 11 more at the slide within the maze. Since there were 9 people on the pole vault team, everyone was required to sign up for 2 shifts.

Which left the four that Katsuki had to do himself. This was bullshit.

All day, he hadn't had the time to be thinking, due to having to run around doing errands, which was a good thing. He didn't need to be thinking, anyways.

From left and right, he was being called to do this or do that.

"It's because you're so big and strong that everyone's working you like a horse," Kirishima told him as the red head was carrying a box of utensils to the grounds.

Ever since the blow up in the cafeteria just yesterday, people have been pretty quiet to him about it. It was if they were choosing to let it go to the past, and never bring up the subject again. That was fine by him.

Katsuki, jogging past to get back into the school building, rolled his eyes, "I fucking hate all of you."

There's a bit of air conditioning inside the school as he slides past the crowds of people.

Mr. Toshinori called out to him as Katsuki was slipping through in order to grab some boxes of string lights from the storage room, "Young Bakugo! You're skipping my class today?"

The blonde whipped his head to nod at the old teacher, "I'm excused to help out with the fundraiser set u-"

“I know, I was just jesting, my boy,” The teacher held his stomach with a laugh, “How’s the essay going?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes at the useless interruption, and replied quickly, “I’ll get it to you by Friday.” That's in two days.

“Well, that’s when it’s due,” Mr. Toshinori frowned.

“Exactly,” Katsuki clicked his tongue and pointed to him, before jogging back off.

“Midoriya has already turned his in, by the way,” Mr. Toshinori called out behind him.

And this causes Katsuki to stop in his tracks, staring straight forward for a second, before he turns and swallows. Mr. Toshinori stares him in his eye, and he wants to punt the old man, but instead, Katsuki just asks, “How is it.”

The teacher put both hands in his pockets, and hummed, trying to figure out words to describe it, “It’s quite beautiful. And well...more than I expected.”

“I’m sure it was,” Katsuki finds himself saying, fearful of what was in Izuku’s papers and what Mr. Toshinori knows, “I’m sure it was.” He repeats before walking away.

And as he does, Mr. Toshinori adds one more comment, “I’m sure yours will not be any less surprising.”

Fuck off, old man, he wanted to say. Fuck off.

He sees Izuku many, *many* times today. The greenette was practically everywhere, considering he was part of the student council and was in charge of helping out and allocating tasks. Izuku was going around, assigning tasks and making sure everything was coming together smoothly. The boy also seemed to be caught up talking to any sponsors or people from the outside that they had coming in to deliver food, or equipment, or what not. Katsuki could see just how tired the boy was, and felt such an intense urge to go talk to the boy. But this fundraiser was more important than the bullshit they were going through. Katsuki worked himself like crazy, so that every time he saw Izuku, his mind doesn’t linger on him for too long.

By the time 3:00 PM rolls around, the fundraiser event was practically all set up an hour before the gates open. Coming into the Ise Parking lot, in really stupid looking block letters, was a string with balloons that read “Ise High Annual Fundraiser.” People would have to walk from the sidewalk to the back of the school, where they’d be ticketed and there would be a box for donations. The boxes for donations were stationed all throughout the fair. The more tickets people buy for activities, the more money that gets raked in for the charity. But there were plenty of free booths too, if there were people here who didn’t want to spend any extra money outside of the entry fee.

Because of the fundraiser, there was no practice today, since all team members were required to be there at the event at one point or another. Some people who had a later shift went home to shower and eat, before coming back to the school to work. Others just stayed the entire

time, exploring the other booths or bothering their friends that were working for different clubs, before coming back to the mirror maze for their shifts.

Katsuki's first shift started at 6:30 P.M. and he'll be there for consecutive hours until 8:30 PM before he switches out for the last half hour before the fundraiser event closes down. That meant he had about 2 hours and 30 minutes to do whatever he wants until he's forced to stand there at the front of the maze, pretend he was jolly to be there, and collect tickets for two hours. He didn't necessarily want to go walk around because 1. He scares children simply by existing and walking around with his resting scowl. And a lot of the children aren't old enough to be in awe of the Great Bakugo Katsuki yet, so his reputation didn't even matter. 2. He's done this event for the past four years. He knows what's here.

And so instead, Katsuki sits outside in his car with the air conditioner on and music playing, with a legal pad open and a black gel pen twirling in his fingers as he thinks about how to start this fucking analysis paper. What the fuck to write about. How to summarize the best couple months of his life into an analysis that would be 7 pages at most. How to put his pen to paper without having to think of Izuku's face, Izuku's laugh, and Izuku's love every part of the way. How the hell was he going to write this.

After almost two hours, he's gotten about two paragraphs down that he knew he was likely to erase later. And this was getting ridiculous.

Outside of his car, he often got distracted from the paper watching all the people filter into the parking lot with their kids, and heading over to where the fundraiser was hosted. The weather today was perfect. Lately, it's been getting hotter and hotter, but tonight, there was a faint breeze that Katsuki could feel through his partially cracked window. The sky was a deep purple-orange, and once Katsuki turns his car off, he could hear the faint sound of Michael Jackson's Billie Jean blaring through the speakers from far away.

T aking a look at the time, Katsuki let out a sigh before climbing out of the car and doing a light jog towards the fundraiser. The monkey maze was in the far right corner of the fundraising event, and so the blonde wove in and out of the event grounds until he can see Sero at the front, who he was supposed to be switching out with. The pole vaulter was standing around, chin on his palm at the podium sitting on his swinging chair, until he sees Bakugo jogging up.

"Cap!" Sero gave him a cheeky grin with a wave, "Ready to stand here for two hours?"

Katsuki rolled his eyes and booted him out, "Oh fuck off."

"It's not too bad," Sero stood up to stretch and stepped down from the raised platform, "Better than *their* job."

The raven pointed to the booth set up straight across from the mirror maze, and Katsuki turned so that they were both now staring at the group this year that was assigned to wear all of the costumes, and snorted. That had been them last year, but it seems like the tennis team was stuck with that duty this time around.

Katsuki turned back to Sero, “You ain’t wrong.”

“Anyways, you know what to do, right?” His friend asked.

The blonde nodded and hummed in response.

“In that case, I’m going to go look around and then call it a night, yeah?” Sero grinned, “Take it easy, alright?”

Katsuki just settled against the podium where he’ll be for a while and waved the vaulter off before signing into his shift. Katsuki knew he wasn’t the most approachable looking person, especially to kids, and so he purposely tries to not scowl.

It really wasn’t that hard of a job, and in the time that he wasn’t actively ticketing someone, the blonde was just on his phone scrolling through or doing something to waste time. While he was on shift, some people would drop by here and there to bother him for a moment or two before leaving. The fundraiser was getting relatively packed for a school event. There were a ton of kids dragging their parents around, wanting to try all the activities. At two or three points during his shifts, there were long lines for the mirror maze.

However, he was only allowed to get 7 people in at any given time, so Katsuki was subjected to replying to the small talk of parents waiting in line with their kids to go in. Many parents seemed to be a little in awe that the Ise High legend Bakugo Katsuki does normal people stuff like helping out with fundraisers. Katsuki was not into small talk, ever, but for the sake of Alzeimer’s research, he tried to respond sarcastically to the adults and occasional teen in line that was a big fan of his.

“I hope this is not weird, but,” A kid that looked to be about 11 or 12 came up to him when the mirror maze wasn’t as busy, “Could I-Could I get an autograph?”

Katsuki looked down at the boy, who was holding out a random fundraiser t-shirt that the kid probably won from another booth.

*“You want an autograph?”* Katsuki had asked Izuku that one night they went to Hana’s Diner. .

Izuku had nodded *, “Yes, please. And then I can sell it in a few years when you’re in the Olympics and get myself some easy money.”*

Katsuki remembers almost wanting to laugh then *, “You’d sell my precious autograph, for some couple hundred bucks?”*

At the memory, Katsuki finds himself reeling and his chest felt tighten again, and he breaths in and out slowly to get rid of the memory of Izuku that surfaced when the little boy had asked him for an autograph.

“S-Sir?” The kid blinked up at the strange reaction coming from Katsuki.

Clearing his throat, the blonde nodded, “Yeah, sure. What’s your name kid?”

“Botan,” The boy’s eyes brightened, “B-Both our names start with B’s, Mr. Bakugo!”

“So it does,” Katsuki chuckles slightly as he writes down the character with a sharpie nearby, “So you wanna be a pole vaulter, Botan?”

Botan looks around his shoulders for somebody, before turning his head back up to Katsuki, “Yeah! A lot! But my dad said it’s too dangerous. He doesn't like me doing dangerous things.”

Katsuki’s eyes flickered to where the kid was staring earlier, to find a man that shared some features who he assumed was Botan’s father, “He ain’t wrong.”

At this, the kid looked a little disheartened and tilted his head towards the ground, “He isn’t?”

Katsuki nods, “Yeah, it’s hella dangerous. If you’re not careful, it’ll suck you in ‘cuz you’ll love it so much.”

Botan’s eyes widened, and his face broke out in a grin then. Katsuki shoos the boy away after a moment or two, and leans back again against the podium. He looks at his watch. It was about 20 minutes until his shift ended, and he can trade out with the next person. These next 20 minutes are likely going to go by slow as hell, he complained under his breath.

“Careful, Cap,” A familiar annoying voice interrupted him, “If that kid follows your footsteps and becomes an asshole too, it’ll be all your fault.” Kaito Sen chuckled, except he was missing that usual snarky tone.

Katsuki turned his head to his teammate for a moment and then stared forward once more, before finding the energy to say something sarcastically back, “I can’t help being so inspiring to kids, Fuck Face.”

“What a burden, huh,” The brunette tacked on, “Being such a role model,” He chuckled.

“The weight of responsibility cripples me,” Katsuki rolls his eyes sarcastically, before raising a brow at the other male, “So what. You here to test my patience again?”

“Of course,” Kaito responded, and leaned his side against the podium while looking out on the festivities with his arms crossed, “And also because I’m taking over your shift next.”

“That’s in 30 minutes,” Katsuki grumbled. The last person he wants to fucking talk to is Kaito Sen.

“I know, Cap. I can read a clock too, you annoying fuck,” Kaito muttered, and shoved his hands in his pocket.

Katsuki ignores the insult and cracks his neck, “You know, huh. So you got something to say to me then, Fuck Face?”

The brunette shrugs and shakes his head, still observing the crowd, “Nah. I walked around this place for the last hour, and it’s all the same stuff as last year. Figured I’ll just get to the shift a bit early and wait here.”

Katsuki doesn't reply to this, and instead, just stands there doing what he was doing before, until he had to ticket the next couple of people in line. He was getting less and less people, as the fundraiser event headed into the last hour or so. The music still played loudly from the speakers on the other side of the event grounds, and some booths looked a little excited to close down soon after a long day. The grass was flat against the ground from so many walking over it throughout the evening, and Katsuki just clasped both hands together as he watched people walk back and forth.

Kaito Sen does the same from where he was leaning against the side of the podium, a step down from Katsuki. The brunette just stood there watching, and in a rare moment, the two men stood near one another without a fight breaking out. Katsuki still would have preferred it if the son of a bitch decided to loiter somewhere else, somewhere preferable away from him, but he didn't have the energy to complain today. And so, they both stand there for what seems like forever, as Katsuki's last shift runs its course.

"You ever get sick of winning, Cap?" Kaito Sen suddenly asks, head leaning against the raised podium, and he craned his neck slightly to get Katsuki's attention.

The blonde's eyes looked at Kaito's for a split second, before Katsuki leans on his elbows and thinks about it. He knew there was something playing at the brunette's approach. Because in what world does Kaito Sen voluntarily stand next to him in silence for over ten minutes. Now to see if Fuck Face was looking for a fight or not.

Katsuki blew out some air, before replying, "What kind of fucking question is th-"

"I'm fucking serious," Kaito furrowed his brows but still wouldn't look at Katsuki, "Just answer the question."

"What makes you think you're in any place to make demands," Katsuki's tone darkened.

Kaito went silent at this, and it was one of the very few times, if not the first, where it seemed like the brunette wasn't up to get into an argument over something like this. It made him slightly curious to see what the hell the guy was getting at, and he contemplated talking. After a moment, he figures it's either that or stand here for another awkward 15 minutes.

Before he could decide whether or not to answer, Kaito spoke up again.

"From the moment I was introduced to you, I was sick of you, you know that?" He says.

Katsuki scowls, "I don't need a damn backsto-"

"I thought, *damn* , this piece of shit won every fucking thing, and it's always assholes like you that get everything they want," Kaito laughs dryly, "It's like no matter what anyone does, they're always second place to you. In school. In vault. In life. And I couldn't wrap my head around how the world lets someone with no character, humility, or care get all this shit, and someone nice and civil like me gets your leftovers."

Katsuki stares blankly forward. He's heard Kaito's claims of him lacking humility, character, and whatnot a million times already. It wasn't new, and the blonde wasn't going to give the

other any satisfaction of his reaction again.

“I think,” Kaito kicks at dirt with his hands in his pockets, “I really loved the fact that you suck at emotions, because it was the one thing you didn’t seem to have. And I told myself that no matter how shitty I feel in comparison to you, at least I know how to love and care for others. Poor Bakugo Katsuki, I’d say, pitying you. Has everything in the world: best grades, best sex, best jumps. But no capacity for anything genuine. I’m way better than him, I’d say. Poor Bakugo Katsuki,” He repeats.

Katsuki’s gaze averted to his hands at this comment.

“And then Midoriya and his sweet self came into the picture,” Kaito chuckled, “And I thought it’d be fun to take him away from you. I like the look on your stupid face when he’d leave with me, or be near me. Poor Bakugo Katsuki. Such a piece of shit that he can’t even stand it when one of his toys is with someone else, huh.”

Katsuki tries not to clench his fists, as he warns Kaito, “Deku isn’t a fucking to-”

“Isn’t a toy, yeah I know,” Kaito then looked up at Katsuki with an amused grin laced with what looks to be a bit of guilt, “It’s ironic, really. How in the end, it’s me using him as a toy for my own revenge, while you’re the one who’s in love with him.”

At this, Katsuki’s eyes widened. Because the motherfucker didn’t just say that he was a genuine friend to Izuku. Or that he wasn’t using Izuku for any ulterior motive. No, none of that. Kaito Sen went straight to *you’re the one who’s in love with him* . After years of shoving it in his face that he couldn’t. After calling him incapable a multitude of times. It threw Katsuki off guard, despite wanting to keep his composure in front of his rival.

“What are you talking about,” Katsuki almost croaked out, unable to decide whether or not he had misheard.

Kaito Sen took a deep breath, still staring at the dirt he was digging up under his shoe, “You heard me, Cap. Trust me, I don’t want to believe it either.”

Katsuki swallowed, and still looked a little shocked. Everyone seemed to be sure except for himself.

“Because,” Kaito looked up to the sky, looking as if he was ashamed to admit this to Katsuki’s face, “This means that you really do have fucking everything. At the end of the day, you’re still an asshole. A little less these days, but still arrogant. Still rude. Still dislikable, and trust me when I say that I *do* dislike you. But with this whole thing that’s going on, it means that you really do have it all. Everything. Love? You aren’t even lacking that, huh.”

Katsuki dropped his shoulders a bit and breathed out before replying, ignoring the last little snippet, “Did someone drug you? What’s with the change of heart.”

Kaito shrugged, “Not drugged. I just think I didn’t want to believe it. That there truly was nothing you didn’t have. My last straw was in that locker room, the last chance to assure myself that you hadn’t changed. That you’re still the same selfish asshole you’ve always

been," And then Kaito takes a breath, "That turned out in my favor, didn't it." He said sarcastically.

"Anyways, working myself up to this conversation was awkward enough as it is. I'm going to stop before this gets any more embarrassing, but yeah," Kaito turned and slapped Katsuki on the shoulder twice, "Just wanted to say sorry. For, you know, saying all that shit about you. I was only partially wrong about you."

"Partially," Katsuki repeats with a snort, internalizing the unexpected apology in his head that meant a lot more than he would care to admit.

The last thing Katsuki thought to get relief from was his rival and least likeable teammate telling him that he was sorry, not that sorry was an end-all-be-all. Sorry was just a word. But it was a start, and an acknowledgment of some wronged behavior. As someone who can barely find it in him to apologize for anything, Katsuki knew the amount of pride it took to set aside in order to apologize to someone. And so, even if he still hated Kaito Sen, he can at least feel some sort of settlement with the apology he had just received. Katsuki didn't want to feel as if he needed this apology, but now that he had it, he realizes just how much he *did* .

"Only partially," Kaito joked with a sneer, "You're still a piece of shit."

"As expected," Katsuki murmurs.

"As expected," Kaito nods in agreement.

And the two men stand there for a bit, letting the conversation settle in. There were less and less people in the fundraiser bounds, since it was getting late and the only people that seemed to still be here were pre-teens who slept later or kids with no curfew.

"You're wrong, Fuck Face," Katsuki says the nickname without the usual harsh bite to it.

"Again, as expected," Kaito snorts and asks, "Tell me. What am I wrong about."

Katsuki puts down the sharpie he's been messing with and tells his rival, "I ain't got everything. If I did..."

Katsuki's head was tilted towards the podium where he was doing some sums for people who came in during his shift, but he paused in his writing, and his eyes move to look up past his hair and over diagonally at the lemonade stand, where a certain boy with green hair and big doe eyes was grabbing a drink from the math honor society who ran that booth.

"..." Katsuki finishes his sentence just a moment later, looking back down at his paper before admitting, "We'd still be friends, me and him." The blonde knew that Kaito would know exactly who he was talking about.

Kaito looked a bit surprised, unaware of what had happened between Katsuki and Izuku. The last time they were actually seen together was at the bonfire party last Friday, and during school, it didn't look like they was bad blood or anything. Just an air of silence from both Bakugo and Midoriya, but towards everyone, not just each other.

At Kaito's silence, Katsuki laughed, "What is it. You surprised I drove him away?" He clears his throat then.

The brunette looked towards Izuku, whose back was turned towards them, "More surprised you're just accepting it. Doesn't sound like the captain I know."

"Yeah, and you just know me so well, don't you," Katsuki said bitterly, "What is this. The first real conversation we've had?" Don't act so chummy all of a sudden, Katsuki wanted to say, but he didn't. He knew that this conversation as a whole probably took a pride set aside by Kaito to have, and that was something he struggled with himself.

"Something like that," Kaito replies, reaching over to grab a water bottle and taking a swig, "And it kind of sucks."

"It does," Katsuki agreed, "We shouldn't do this very often."

"We shouldn't," Kaito affirmed, and continued to kick dirt up, "But don't kid me, Bakugo. I don't know what happened, but I know you enough to understand that you aren't the type to just give up."

Katsuki blew out some air and checked his watch, "There's a first for everything. Anyways, times up. Kaito, sign in for duty. I'll help you close up at 9."

"You're gonna stay in the area?" Kaito looked around and then down at his watch, before stepping up onto the platformed podium to take Katsuki's spot.

The blonde signs off for his teammate and shrugs, "I'm gonna grab a drink and come back. Might as well take a tour of the maze."

Kaito fishes around a couple dollar bills from his pocket, "Can you be a good captain and get me the flank steak salad?"

Katsuki rolled his eyes. It wasn't as if he didn't often get his teammates food or drinks, considering that yes, as captain, he was supposed to look out for them and make sure they're eating and hydrating well. But Kaito is a different case. The brunette has never wanted shit from Katsuki, so now as the blonde reaches out to take the bills, he asks.

"You gonna be a good teammate?" Katsuki asks, grabbing the money.

"Since when have I not been," Kaito argued.

The blonde tched as he turned, "Bastard. Who eats a flank steak salad at a damn fundraiser."

"A gentleman," Kaito replied earnestly, "I don't want to eat with my hands in front of these kids."

"Yes, because the kids are going to grow up corrupted because they saw a random guy eat a greasy burger while working a fair," Katsuki tsked, but goes to get it anyways.

Katsuki goes off to grab the food and then just a bottle of water for himself, before weaving through the crowd to get back to the Monkey Maze. As the end of the fundraiser was getting closer, the fewer and fewer people there were. A lot of the booths were already starting to clean up and getting ready to leave, setting aside *just* enough material for about 3 or 4 more people if anyone comes by. A lot of people now who were working the booths also ditched their stations to go walk around for a bit before returning.

The grass was thoroughly trampled on, and there was plenty of trash that dropped on the ground that the volunteer club was going to have a bitch of a time cleaning up later. Katsuki downs his water in one go on the spot, and tosses it in recycle.

He then drops the flank steak salad off to Kaito Sen, tempted to bum a piece off since it smelled so fucking good and he was hungrier than he had realized.

“Thanks,” Kaito stands up from his podium seat and takes the meal out of Katsuki’s hands as well as the change, “Have fun with the maze. Denki tried it earlier before your shift started. Took him thirty minutes.”

Katsuki snorts as he steps up the six or seven glass stairs that led into the mirror maze, “It’ll take me five.”

Kaito rolled his eyes and forks a piece of flank steak into his mouth, “Arrogant piece of shit. See you tomorrow Cap. Good luck figuring your mess out.”

Katsuki waved an arm as he stepped through, “Good luck finding a housewife. Or househusband.”

The mirror maze was immediately disorienting. The floor and ceilings were all black. And all around him, he could see himself. Infinitely. The sides of the mirrors had neon running from the ceiling to the ground, slowly switching between shades of dark blue to royal purple, to black. The black would leave the entire mirror maze in complete darkness for the four seconds that it lasted, but when the lights would come back on, it was incredible to see infinite versions of himself everywhere. In the far left, he could see a little kid and her sister running through the mirror maze together. They could be five feet away. They could also be fifty feet away, and he wouldn’t know.

Katsuki walked foot first, using his forward feet to scan the mirrors in order to see which of the four walls that surrounded him was a walkway. The mirror maze was just constructed of a ton of panels looping into a pretty extensive maze for the size that it was.

Some panels were mirrors. Some were glass. All was pretty difficult to navigate, especially with the slowly changing lights and abrupt darkness that would disorient people once every couple of minutes. The mirror maze had a different route every year, but even if it didn’t, it wasn’t as if Katsuki could remember what it was from the previous year.

In speakers scattered throughout the entire mirror maze, 80s music played in the typical Ise fashion. The last thirty seconds or so of Out Of Touch by Daryl Hall and John Oates was playing, an instant recognizable hit that Katsuki was kind of sick of by now. The blonde found himself fortunate that he was born and raised in a town that oddly enough was as

obsessed with his favorite genre of music. He almost felt bad for those who vehemently hated 80s music, since everyone is constantly surrounded by it in Ise.

As the last few notes of the song plays, he waits for the next one to come on. But it takes a while. There was a long five or so minute pause between the end of that song and the beginning of the next one, which was dumb. The preprogrammed music was probably some old machinery from decades ago that they're still using today.

When the new song comes on, Katsuki recognized it to be Can't We Try by Dan Hill and Vonda Shepard. It wasn't his favorite, that was for sure, but he knew of it and liked it well enough. The melody was nice, but the last two minutes of the song is ruined by Vonda Shepard screeching into the mic and Dan Hill failing to harmonize currently, not that Katsuki was a music critic or anything.

That being said, the soft chords of the digital piano at the first half of the song vibed with him in the moment, and the song already has a natural echo in it, which gets amplified in this maze of mirrors.
Katsuki walks, and when he turns the corner, from across the mirror maze or so it seemed from his perspective, also walking parallel to him was a certain boy with fluffy curly hair and doe-like green eyes. There were many of him in the mirrors. A plain white t-shirt with the Ise High Student Council logo on the front breast pocket in small font, and a pair of black shorts. Under the slowly changing lights, the purple and blue hue envelopes the boy beautifully.

Katsuki walked parallel and suddenly, red eyes met green, and Izuku's eyes widened at the sight of the blonde standing on the other side of the maze. They could be three feet apart, or thirty. The music continues to play, and Vonda Shepard's verse comes in.

The lighting cuts to black for three seconds, and his sight of Izuku is gone. He's only left with the sound of music and his own breathing. His eyes dart back and forth in the darkness, and like a mirage, when the lights turn back on again, Katsuki walks towards Izuku as if the sight was going to disappear.

And he walks straight into a glass panel, stumbling back just one step with a shout, "Fuck!"

Katsuki clutches his nose, and winces at the pain that resulted from his own idiocy, before looking back across the glass panel. And right then, he sees just a sliver of Izuku's laugh. The dark circles that laid a little bit underneath the boy's eyes were forgotten for a second in exchange for the nice little crinkle of a smile that bloomed. It wasn't all the way there, but it was more than he's gotten and Katsuki was a starved man.

Katsuki quirked one brow, and then his gaze dropped to the ground for a second, listening into the song.

*Can't we try just a little bit harder*

*Can't we give just a little bit more*

When the blonde looks back up, Izuku from the side still had his head turned towards him. Katsuki follows that gaze and he starts to walk to his right. At the same time, Izuku slowly

walks parallel, like they were mirroring each other's movements. And then, Katsuki no longer sees him, the view covered up by mirrors until he can only see himself in all directions.

Putting his hand up against the wall, Katsuki felt around as he strolled slowly for different paths. As he makes a corner, Katsuki sees Izuku again. The boy notices him straight away, and just keeps his gaze as they slowly stroll. It was almost like a trance, as the colors change from blue to purple to black, shrouding them in darkness until he could see that face again.

*Can't we try to understand*

*That it's love we're fighting for*

One moment, Katsuki would see Izuku in the mirrors. The next, he'd turn a corner and only see himself. It alternated like this back and forth as the blonde got closer and closer to where the *real* Izuku was, or at least where Katsuki thought he was. He comes up to a wall, and his foot taps against glass. Midoriya Izuku stands on the other side, staring through the glass, wondering if it was a mirror, but figuring that wouldn't make sense. Behind Izuku, Katsuki could see both of their reflections repeating until infinity. He was so close. Just a panel away.

The greenette brings a hand up slowly to tap against the glass, before asking in a quiet voice, "Is this you?"

Katsuki continues to walk towards his right very slowly, Izuku walking parallel on the other side. The blonde drags his fingers against the panel.

"Yeah," He responded. They could hear each other through the glass, contrary to earlier when they were further apart.

The glass panel ends and the mirror begins again. Katsuki stares at himself as he proceeds, before it once more turns into glass. His fingertips connect to Izuku through a glass panel, and he's reminded of the Hideaway in his bedroom balcony, and the memory jolts him in the wrong way. Once again, it is as if everything between them was just glass and mirrors, going around in circles, trying to get to each other only to end up so close, yet not quite there. Able to see each other and be in each other's presence, but that ever lasting boundary was always there. They were fated to be forever stuck in this maze, always *this* close, but never on the same side.

Izuku leans his head up against the glass, and turns so that the smaller's back was sliding down against the wall. Izuku slides down until he was sitting on the floor, back leaning up, head resting back against the pane. After a moment, Katsuki turns his back, and does the same, until the two of them were sitting with their backs towards each other, a sheet of glass in between and an infinite series of mirrors in front of them. It might be easier this way to be in the boy's presence, if he wasn't directly looking at him. They let the music run its course, and watched as the lights morph in and out.

"I hate the ending of this song," Katsuki whispers.

After taking a moment, Izuku asks him, voice sounding soft, "Why?"

“Gets repetitive,” Is the only thing Katsuki has to offer as an explanation, and he cannot begin to describe how much he misses Izuku’s voice. He acts as if it’s been a year, when it’s only been a couple of days. When his ‘normal’ is out of balance like this, it felt like it.

“Oh,” He hears Izuku say, “I can kind of see that.”

To this, the blonde says nothing. He wishes this panel between them was gone so that he could smell that lily scent another time, and feel the green hair tickle his neck. And they sit here as the last stretch of the song plays. And it's quiet again.

“Kacchan,” Izuku then speaks up, and the sound through the glass was a lot clearer than he would have thought. It was probably less than a centimeter thick of plexiglass, “Have you…” There was hesitance in his soft tone, “Have you been okay?”

At this, the blonde puts his knees up and legs apart, resting an elbow on each of them, toying with the edge of a chocolate wrapper he found in the pocket of his pants, and he chuckles quietly, “You’re asking *me* that?”

Izuku laughs airily in response, before excusing himself, “Yeah. You didn’t look so good the other day on the field.”

Katsuki hummed in response, and bit the inside of his cheek, before telling the other, “You don’t look so hot either, nerd.” The last word came out softly.

“Oh, really?” Izuku asked, sounding unsurprised by the observation. Katsuki wanted to ask what they were doing, having this conversation.

“Yeah,” The blonde swallowed, before asking, eyes tilted down towards his feet, “Have you been getting enough sleep?”

He could hear the sound of Izuku moving, before the boy answers with a small laugh, “I get a couple of hours here and there.”

That didn’t settle well in Katsuki’s stomach, but he had to ask some more, “Have you been getting enough to eat?”

“I’m fine, Kacchan,” Izuku assures him then, gentle with his words, “I’m okay.”

“Are you really?” Katsuki asked, swallowing again, as the music fades out a little bit. *Because I’m not* .

Silence. And the lights turn slowly from that royal blue again to a pitch black in the time interval where Izuku didn’t answer.

“I’ll be okay, yeah,” Izuku reassured him again in his warm voice. There was this air of finality to this conversation, and Katsuki doesn’t like where it was headed. There was no yelling, no heated tears, no tension. Just this after-the-storm sadness.

“Right,” Katsuki coarsely responded.

The song ends, and they sit in the silence for a while, waiting for the next one to come. But it'll be a little while before it comes on.

Izuku began again, before hesitating, as indicated by the thoughtful pause in between his words, "I didn't mean to...overwhelm you that night."

So they *were* going to talk about it. Katsuki's heart rate increased a bit at the flashbacks of memories. It's been four days. He thought that he'd be fine by this point. Fuck.

"Overwhelm me?" Katsuki asked, voice hoarse, wanting clarification.

"Looking back, I realized I said a lot of things in the heat of the moment," Izuku admits in a lower tone.

And Katsuki doesn't turn to look, but in the mirror in front of him, he could see the back of Izuku's hair shift as the greenette slumps a little.

The blonde asks, "Like that you love me?" What a stupid question. Of course it wouldn't be.

"No, that one is true," Izuku laughs with a hint of pain in his voice, "But…"

There was a long pause, and Katsuki plays with the wooden beaded bracelet on his wrist as he waits.

"..." Izuku took a breath, it sounded like, "I shouldn't have asked you to feel the same."

*Tell me you love me too* . Katsuki remembers that tear soaked face, those pained eyes.

Katsuki's stomach involuntarily twisted at this, and he wanted to know exactly what Izuku meant.

As if trying to make himself as clear as possible, the greenette spoke up again quickly, "Not because you can't. But because that's...that's unfair of me."

Katsuki says nothing, just stares off into the mirrors.

"I don't regret telling you how I feel," Izuku brightens up his voice as best as he could, and Katsuki just wishes he wouldn't do that, "Because it was killing me to hold it in. I don't regret telling you *why* I feel the way I do. Because you deserve to know that you are easy to fall in love with."

Easy to fall in love with. The last thing Katsuki would ever expect to be said of him was that he was easy to fall in love with. He wasn't the most rational person, the most calm, the most kind. Hell, he was barely kind at all. And yet, this boy who knew all of this and more, still claims that he was easy to love.

And finally, the music starts up again. A much more sentimental one turns on, and the sweet sound of piano echoes through the mirror maze. This one, Katsuki hasn't heard in a long time. He thinks the last time he's heard this particular song, he was too young to remember it.

The only reason it rings a bell now was the unmistakable bittersweet piano intro that stole his attention.

Goodbye by Air Supply reverberated through the chamber of mirrors as they both sit there back to back. The piano at the beginning was such a beautiful sound.

*I can see the pain living in your eyes*

*And I know how hard you try*

*You deserve to have so much more*

He did. Izuku deserved the world, and the pain in that boy's eyes resonated with the lyrics too well. Katsuki gets a sick feeling.

Izuku speaks up again just as the words come in.

"What I do regret, is asking you to tell me you feel the same," Izuku's composure then begins to crack at the edges, for Katsuki could hear the slight break in his voice as he speaks, "Because...what was that one song?" Izuku thinks on it, before laughing a little bit and then quietly says, "Right. Because...I can't make you love me," He swallows, "...if you don't. So I'm sorry."

Katsuki's mind flashes back to the night of the Spring Dance, under the sprinklers, and that song started to play with Izuku singing along. At the time, he was curious, as to why exactly it felt like the boy sounded so in tune with the lyrics. Well, now he knew. It had been a precious memory. Only now that Izuku repeats the title that it began to turn a little retrospectively painful.

"Deku," Katsuki spoke up, "Don't fucking apologize. It's fin-"

"No, it's not," Izuku argued gently, "I've been doing a lot of thinking these past couple of days, Kacchan."

Katsuki doesn't like the sound of that. He doesn't know what it is yet, but he doesn't fucking like the sound of that. He feels as if he's been trying to do the opposite. As little thinking as possible.

*I can feel your heart and I sympathize*

*And I'll never criticize all you've ever meant to my life*

"..." Katsuki swallowed, and his eyes are forlorn as he asks, "Yeah?"

The blonde hears a small sniffle, and he knew what was going on, on the opposite side of this glass and his chest feels heavy thinking of it.

"I've been thinking a lot. And...And I'm g-going to try extra hard, okay?" Izuku asked him, voice cracking left and right. And Katsuki wanted so badly to shatter these walls between them, but he could barely even bring himself to *look* at the boy.

Try extra hard? Katsuki thought to himself, wondering what the fuck Izuku was getting at. In the background, the bittersweet song continues to ring through the halls. It was overwhelming. It feels as if everything was happening at once. Izuku talking, Izuku's voice cracking, his own lack of articulation, the music, the song, the song's lyrics that he found himself paying attention to, all while simulataneously trying to keep his composure. It was getting a little much, and Katsuki wishes that it was just one thing or the other, not everything happening all at once. If he was going to listen to the song, then he wanted to listen to the song. If he was going to talk to Izuku, then he wanted just to talk to Izuku. And yet, he was juggling everything at once, unable to separate one from the other, as it seems the two are tied.

*I don't want to let you down*

*I don't want to lead you on*

*I don't want to hold you back*

*From where you might belong*

He doesn't like these lyrics. He doesn't like this song that much anymore. He listens to them, and all he can fucking think about was that *he* didn't want to let Izuku down, *he* didn't want to lead Izuku on unsure of his own ability to feel, and *he* didn't want to hold Izuku back, even if he wanted to be by the boy's side so fucking badly.

Izuku expands on his thoughts, "I-I don't want you to worry, Kacchan. Because I won't let it be a burden to you any longer, I promise," Izuku tried to make his voice cheerful as he promises, although it was obvious by this point that the greenette was fighting back a cry.

*There's nothing left to say but good-bye.*

Not that line. He hated that line, Katsuki thought to himself while simultaneously trying to interpret what the fuck Izuku was saying. Everything was crescendoing and it was about to be a *lot* all at once. In combination with this song, and Izuku's slow words that was getting to *some* point that Katsuki wasn't sure he even wanted to hear, the blonde couldn't do anything but sit there. The colors changed, but he was barely noticing that either.

*You deserve the chance at the kind of love*

*I'm not sure I'm worthy of*

"I promise I'll get over you," Izuku tells him, with a sad but optimistic tone that was shaking, "I know you care for me, a-and that you've probably been feeling g-guilty. But I'll try my best," His voice tapers out into a whimper and he tries to finish his sentence, "I'll try my best to get over you, I promise Kacchan. I promise." He lets out a tiny cry at the end, and Katsuki hangs onto every word.

“Izu-” He tries to speak up, but his voice stops and his tongue finds itself unable to say anything. What was he supposed to say. What the fuck was he supposed to say. All that Katsuki knew was that right now, this horrible sensation in his gut was making him sick. Izuku was going to get over him. Izuku is not going to love him anymore. But this is good, right? This is a good thing. But then, that didn’t explain this feeling, of dread and fear.

Katsuki, out of shock, turns around, and at the movement, Izuku feels movement against the glass on the other side and turns his head to the side too, body moving to partially face the blonde. And Katsuki could see now the tear streaked face, and the eyes that looked dulled out. But there was a genuine smile playing on Izuku’s face.

He sees Izuku take a labored breath, before continuing, “It’ll be okay.”

"What do you mean it'll be okay?" Katsuki breathlessly asked.

And Izuku for a while doesn't say anything. And they sit there. Katsuki facing the Izuku through the glass panel. Izuku staring down at his feet, which were drawing shapes on the ground. The colors changing from purple to blue to black over and over again.

Izuku then looks off to the side, as if daydreaming things that brought a bit of pain to his face, before softly vowing, “One day, I’m going to meet someone.”

Bakugo Katsuki’s heart fucking dropped, and he’s completely silent as he listens. Everything else is drowned out. Those words were enough to punch him in the gut.

Izuku purses his lips, before sniffling in to clear his nose and continuing with a small smile, “He won’t have ruby eyes like you do, or hands that hold me like you do...

A pause, and then a brief moment of happienss flashes through Izuku's eyes as he finishes, "...but he’ll love me too."

Izuku then squeezes his eyes shut momentarily to prevent himself from crying further but it doesn’t work, and quiet tears stream down his cheek, and his words are shaky, “He might not make me laugh until I cry as much as you do, o-or take me to pretty fields like you have, but he’ll love me too."

*No*. This is. Fuck. No. *Fuck*.

"H-He’ll love me too,” Izuku repeats, voice breaking.

Katsuki wants this to stop. He wants all of this to stop, because the way he was feeling right now, it felt like someone took a million knives and pierced it into his lung.

Izuku’s lips wobbled as he spoke, but he tries to keep his tone as even as he could, “He might not jump off piers with me, or sneak into abandoned school buildings with me...” Izuku laughs sadly.

And then Izuku clears his throat, “But he’ll kiss me on top of the ferris wheel. And he’ll pick me up and spin me around in public, show the world how much he loves me.” Izuku smiles at the thought.

Taking a deep breath, the green eyed boy admits painfully, “A-And it’ll take a long time, but maybe, one day, your voice will be replaced with his."

"Your laugh, replaced with his smile,” Izuku’s voice continued to break as he speaks, “Sunsets with you, replaced by sunrises with him.” Izuku looks up towards the ceiling and takes a deep breath, wiping away his eyes with the sleeve of his shirt.

Katsuki can’t fucking hear this anymore. Every word slams him like a goddamn car moving at full speed towards his chest.

Izuku then looked into his eyes and give him a very soft, genuine look, “And some day after that, maybe I’ll love him too. The way that I love you.”

A million things run through Katsuki’s head, but nothing more prominent than the searing pain that hits him right where it hurts.

“And I’ll get married,” Izuku’s shoulder shake, and his voice is higher pitched now from the final breakage, “And it’s going to be like what I always dreamed of, with the beachside ceremony and the five layer mint icing cake.”

The thought of Izuku married, to some man. Izuku, in a beautiful suit or whatever he chose to wear, blush sprinkled on his cheeks, staring into someone’s eyes as they vowed to love each other till death does them apart, dancing the first dance and slicing into the cake like all the newlyweds do. The thought of Izuku spending the rest of his life with someone else, waking up in the morning next to someone else who would kiss all of the boy’s freckles and wrap his arms around that soft, warm waist. The thought killed Katsuki more than he could describe right then.

“Maybe I want kids,” Izuku very faintly laughs as he thinks about it, “It would be nice to adopt. Have some little ones running around, and I can tell them stories about the cool adventures I had with my childhood best friend, or new ones with their dad. And we’ll all be big fans of yours, Katsuki,” He says the blonde’s name, “I’ll watch you on TV, wonder what you’ve been up to, if you’ve been happy and healthy...” Izuku nods his head slowly then before looking back at the athlete, “But no matter what, I’ll get over you, Kacchan. I promise, I will,” He couldn’t help crying as he repeats, “I promise.”

“Fuck, Izuku,” Katsuki ran a hand over his face, and buried his fingers in his own hair for a moment, before looking back at the other, barely able to say anything of substance in response, “How the fuck are you going to-” He couldn’t even finish.

It looks like the greenette wasn’t done, as he continued to sniffle and wipe away at his nose and face, before opening his pretty lips.

“One more thing. You’re capable of loving, Kacchan. And I need you to know that,” Izuku breaths in with a sniffle and then exhaled.

Katsuki’s heart thumped in his goddamn chest like drums. Capable of loving. Love. What even is that? Was it simply caring for someone? No, because he cared for his teammates, but he wouldn’t say he was in love with them at all. Was it spending a lot of time with someone?

No, because he spent plenty of time with Kiri, but he definitely wasn't in love with the guy. Was it that feeling of heated passion that you share with someone? No, because Katsuki has had his fair share of intimate heated exchanges, yet he's never even *once* considered that to be love.

Or was love more like this? That feeling of losing his goddamn breath every single time he looks upon that face and counts those freckles. This feeling of overwhelming, excruciating pain at each and every word Izuku was saying This feeling that he can't fucking imagine two weeks in the goddamn future without this kid, much less the rest of his life. Was it? Was love more like this? He doesn't know. All he knows is that he was looking at Izuku, and the glass between them felt like prison, and all he wanted to fucking do was break it.

Izuku continued to speak.

"And y-you're going to be great to someone one day. You're going to be an amazing lover to a very, *very* lucky person one day." Izuku genuinely smiled at him with clear pain in his eyes, and *no, no, God no* , Katsuki didn't want to hear Izuku say this, any of this, but the greenette still spoke, "If the way you've treated me as a friend is indicative of anything, then I know that sometime in the future, you're going to make someone so, *so* happy," Izuku closed his eyes and squeezed the tears away as his lips wobbled at the last word.

"Stop," Katsuki's voice came out so hoarse, and he couldn't bring himself to say anything else. He needed Izuku to stop. Someone else? He was going to make someone else happy? At the moment, all Katsuki wanted to do was stomp on the notion. He imagines it now. Somewhere down the road, can he even picture a someone else? It was like when he closes his eyes and thinks of where he wants to be ten years from now, the only image that appears is that of messy green hair and a lazy smile at 8 in the morning, half covered in white linen bedsheets and complaining to Katsuki about not wanting to get up for work. The only image that fucking appears is wide green eyes looking up at him, warm hands on his face, soft lips reminding him of summers and springs in the youthful Ise lakes and rivers. Was *this* love? How would he know? How would he fucking now.

"And I hope they love all your favorite songs too, and doesn't mind going with you to the creek, even if it gets a little muddy," Izuku cries a bit while laughing gently to himself, "And I hope that your little surprises bring them the most joy, and that they'll wake up every morning more in love with you than the day before," He breaths in and doesn't like at Katsuki, "Don't ever doubt your ability to love again, because I promise you Kacchan, you'll do an amazing job."

He pauses, and his head is tilted towards the ground, eyes trying to hide the silent crying to no avail, just before he whispers, "I hope it wasn't so wrong of me to wish that it could have been me."

Katsuki feels his head pound, and he was struggling to find something to say, but there was too much in his mind that he was trying to process. Like gears turning in his brain, but they weren't connecting just yet.

It isn't like anyone has a definition for love. On google, love is defined as this: "An intense feeling of deep affection." But what did that even entail, goddamnit? He could feel that shit

with a kitten. That didn't mean he was in love with a kitten. Katsuki was sure he could ask anybody, and he doubts a single person could describe what it means to be in love in simple words. It isn't just commitment. You can be committed to a job or a friend, that doesn't mean it's love. It isn't just passion. You can have passion with a sex partner or a hobby. That doesn't mean it's love. It isn't just affection. You can feel affection towards any regular ole friend.

Could it be described as a combination? Loyalty, passion, and affection? No, because all those goddamn terms could be applied to a very devoted company employee or someone's housepet. No, no that's not it at all.

In all the times Katsuki's ever heard talk of love, it's been wrapped up in two ideas, two concepts.

The first is specific feelings, scenarios. Love is abstract, described in feeling and scenarios that are specific to each person. He's heard his mother say that love was dark chocolate strawberries and roller skating rinks. He didn't get it as a kid. And to literally anyone else, love doesn't feel like that. But to his mother, who adores the dark chocolate strawberries that Maseru makes and who met her husband at a roller skating rink, it made sense.

He's heard his grandfather say love was running through the storm with his wife and playing bean bag toss at the farmer's market on Sunday afternoons. To anyone else, love may not feel like that. But to his grandfather, who fell in love through those activities, it made sense.

He's heard Izuku say that love was like flying. And to anyone else, to Katsuki, who's been flying all of his life, it didn't feel like that. But to Izuku, who loved him like no one else ever had and ever will, and who's looked up to the sky wondering what freedom and exhileration tasted like, it made sense.

And now him, love, if it was going to be like anything, *anything* at all, then it's going to be like falling. Turbulent, terrifying, exhilarating, intense, a loss of control. And to anyone else, who had a stronger grasp of this emotional shit than he did, love probably didn't feel like this. But to him, to Katsuki, who's flown all his life and has only been shown the beauty of the ground that he was now falling towards, it made sense.

If everything that flies eventually falls, then Katsuki wouldn't mind.

As long as there was someone on the ground to catch him.

And *fuck* , he was sinking deeper and deeper into a realization that his mind and body feel overwhelmed all of a sudden. The music, the atmosphere, the feelings he was going through, the self-spiel he just made: it all pointed towards one conclusion.

He fucking- Was he? Oh fuck. Katsuki's hand twitched. He moved on, his brain processing everything too intensely.

The second concept that love is always wrapped around in: music. If the first grasp of love he's got was how it was described in objects, scenarios, sensations, then the second most predominant one was music. Because what better outlet for love than music?

Katsuki usually didn't care for lyrics, and in fact, he used to listen to his playlist mindlessly. He liked the melodies and the beats, and that was all to it. But fuck, he's been paying more and more attention to the lyrics for what seems like most songs these days. Those devilish 80s love songs and ballads, he can't help but pay attention to the words. These songs *always* talked about love, heartbreak, and whatnot.

And the memory jolts him.

*You know you're in love when the love songs you listen to feel less like stories, and more like reality.*

And as he listens to Goodbye now, he doesn't like it. He doesn't like it at all.

Because fucking hell, he stills and his heart starts beating fast. These lyrics, these melodies, this everything reminded him of Izuku. It didn't just remind him of Izuku, it felt like the song was truth unfolding in front of his eyes. And it wasn't just this song. It was the one before that. And the one before *that* . All of these fucking songs.

All this time he's been with Izuku and wondering why he's been noticing the goddamn lyrics more when he hadn't before, he didn't even stop *once* to think that maybe, just maybe, it's because for the first time in his life, he was relating to these damn lyrics. For the first time in his life, a singer would talk about some concept, and he'd understand it. Oh fucking hell. Katsuki's grip on his own knees got tighter, and his eyes are wide open, and his breathing gets heavier. Because. *Because*.

For the first time in his life, Bakugo Katsuki realizes that he is in love. And this fact hits him like a damn truck, because fuck. *Fuck* . Why here? Why now, just when Izuku seems to have made an ultimatum? Why not back at the Hideaway? Why not even earlier? Why couldn't he realize this while he still had the ability to put a smile on Izuku's face? And even now, what is he supposed to do? Was he ever sure? Was Katsuki sure? Or was this incredibly explosive, painful yet beautiful feeling in his entire body something else? Has he fucking been in love all this time, and it took this long, this moment where it's all crashing down, for him to get slapped in the face with it? Izuku's eyes, Izuku's lips, Izuku's laugh, Izuku's hair, Izuku's ramblings, Izuku's pout, Izuku's ambition, Izuku's kindness, Izuku's intensity, Izuku's fucking entire being. God, was this love? This was it, right? Katsuki's breathing gets heavier.

He loved the boy in front of him. And this realization causes him to go into a bit of a shock, and he doesn't know what the do. Because what now? What was he even supposed to do now with this information? Say it? But how? How did everyone make it look so easy? He couldn't do it. Not now. He could barely process the realization, much less do something about it. He wasn't even sure. Was he?

The crux of the song was approaching, and he hated it more than ever.

*Though it's gonna hurt us both*

*There's no other way than to say…*

No. Oh, god no. If this love song's story was to turn into their reality, then Katsuki wants another one. He wants another story. A different one. A different song, because this one? This one was too sad, this one felt like-

"Deku…" Katsuki breathes out, and looked at Izuku's bittersweet expression, and he wanted it to go away, "Why does this feel like-"

...*goodbye* , the lyrics conclude.

"Goodbye?" Izuku synced his words to the end of the song, and it goes quiet again.

They sit across from each other, separated by a panel of glass. Katsuki could barely talk or listen after coming to the conclusion that he had and now not knowing how to fucking handle it after 18 years of believing this was never meant for him. But Izuku's words of goodbye stabbed him in the heart, as he knew it did for Izuku.

"That's because it is," Izuku sniffled, "We're about to be on break, right? Besides," He wipes at his eyes and gave Katsuki a small smile, "I told you. I'm going to try my hardest to get over you, Kacchan."

*No. No, don't do that* . Katsuki needed to say it. He just needed to fucking say it. He was so damn frustrated with himself, that he was internally going inside. He was still in a fucking shock from his realization, that he was listening to the boy he realizes that he is in love with, and letting him give up on them. Before Katsuki could even get started.

But his tongue was tied. Because he still can't comprehend it. He was in love. He was fucking in love, and it is the most painful, rewarding, excruciating feeling. And he had no goddamn idea how Izuku kept this inside for so long, and that made him ache some more. Katsuki needed to say something. Say something now, goddamnit, he cursed out his lips. Say something, you fucking idiot.

"Wait," Katsuki asked, for the fiftieth time. And there was panic clear in his expression, he was sure.

Izuku paused then, and looked at him. Katsuki stared back, tongue tied. There was so much to say. So fucking much to say, that he doesn't know how to say it. He hasn't completely comprehended it yet, either. So anything that he says right now, if he *could* say anything, would sound so fucking disingenous. He didn't know what to do. Fuck.

And so as Katsuki look into Izuku's eyes now, he thinks of sunlit forests of magnolias and oaks, freshly cut grass pulling up to the Midoriya's house, greenish-blue tinted waters of the clear creeks they swim in. And he wonders what he has been doing all this time, because just as this is all ending right in front of his face, Katsuki finds Izuku's eyes too beautiful to look away from.

The mirror maze was going to be closed down very soon, and he knew that Kaito Sen was outside somewhere waiting for the last person to come out so they could shut down. Inside, the lights still strobed slowly, and these infinite reflections were beginning to exhaust him.

Mirrors, everywhere. Mirrors reflecting back on him. Mirrors reflecting back on Izuku. On the two of them together On the two of them separately. He wanted to reach through to the other side of the glass, and have Izuku sit in his mind for just a moment. Because if he did, then Izuku would know: some semblance of how he felt. But the mirrors only reflected himself. He will forever be subjected and limited to his own perspective.

So as Katsuki looked across the glass and mirrors, he finds himself wanting so badly to fuse into the other side, to see what Izuku sees. Did he look as nervous as he felt? Did he look as scared as he felt? Did Katsuki look as panicked and in shock? What did he see? Could he see that Katsuki had just had the biggest realization of his life and it's wrecking him? What did he fucking see?

Red eyes.

Red eyes. As bright as roses, as sharply hot as embers. A bit of shock, nervousness, for a reason that he couldn't quite decipher why. Lips that parted slightly as if they wanted to say something, hands that were large and calloused slightly clammy looking from the sweat. Why? Why, why, why? What for?

As Izuku looks into Katsuki's eyes now, he thinks of cherry pies, and red lily petals. Intense sunsets washing over the ocean turning the entire thing ruby, and neon signs above ice cream parlours. And he wonders what has happened to get to this point, because just as this is all ending right in front of his face, Izuku finds Katsuki's eyes--eyes that he usually could spend eternity staring into--Izuku finds them too painful to look at.

In fact, everything has been a little too painful lately, and a day feels like a month when he spends all day doing anything to keep his mind off of Katsuki. Katsuki. Katsuki. Katsuki. That name stays on his tongue, and what used to taste like sugar and cherry gatorade now tastes like ash and heartbreak. He feels the phantom touch of Katsuki's fingers tucking a strand of hair behind his ear, or the ding of Katsuki's text that wasn't going to come on the afternoons where he found himself craving the athlete so badly that he is *this* close to going back into the wheel he broke on Saturday night and playing hamster, bound to go in circles over and over again breaking his heart every time with a boy who had no intentions of loving him back.

Katsuki tells him 'Wait,' but nothing comes. Nothing comes for a while, even though Izuku still has a hopeless dream that something will. The last time Katsuki told him to wait, it ended up like this too.

And Izuku was a patient person, and he didn't mind being so. All good things come with time. Bakugo Katsuki, for example. Izuku doesn't know how long he's been waiting for the athlete to merely be his friend. Midoriya Inko, for example. Izuku didn't know how long he's been waiting for his mother to let him breathe a little bit. And in the end, none of that

happened until he put his foot down and thought about what he needed. His mother wasn't going to stop her behavior until he took a stand for what he wanted.

And Katsuki. Izuku wasn't going to stop breaking his own heart until he took a stand for what he needed. And that is distance and time. Patience is a virtue, but when the process of waiting ends up harming you, then patience can become a vice.

And so now, as Katsuki tells him once more to wait, Izuku wonders if anything was coming. If anything was ever going to come. He could feel his face slightly slimy with tears, and he wished he could have had this conversation with Katsuki while keeping full composure. But he should have known better. He was a cryer. And for the last couple of days, it seems like the one thing he knew how to do best.

Looking at Katsuki now from across the glass panel and then all around him in the mirrors, Izuku sees a mixture of emotion on the blonde's face. Amongst them was what looked to be nervousness. Was it because of what Izuku had said about this being goodbye? Because if it was, then Izuku understood. He was nervous too.

Katsuki was likely nervous because after all, before anything else, they were friends for a long time that spent so many waking hours with one another. And now that Izuku decided that he needed to do this for his own good, it made sense that the athlete could get nervous about losing a close friend. Izuku wanted to reach out, touch that handsome face, and tell him it's okay. That Katsuki was wonderful in many ways, that Katsuki will have many friends who care and love him, but he refrains.

After a long moment, and no words come out of the athlete's mouth, Izuku accepts this as the end. The lights in the mirror maze fade to black, and in the four seconds that it stays that way, Izuku gets up from the floor and stands up, wiping his face one more time. This was a bittersweet goodbye. Izuku just wanted to go home and shove his face in his pillow for a while.

When the blue LEDs take over again, Katsuki seemed to have noticed him stand and the blonde quickly stands up following suit, mouth still partly open but no words coming from it. Izuku dropped his arm, done wiping at his face, and smiles one last time even though his heart ached like hell. If he could give Katsuki this one last thing, it would be his smile and his hope that the boy is happy. And he began to walk towards his right where he had left off in the mirror maze.

Katsuki placed a fist on the glass panel, and Izuku could hear the boy tell him to wait again, but Izuku keeps walking, keeping his face tense so that he doesn't break down again. From his peripheral, right before he slips through a mirrored tunnel, Izuku sees Katsuki frantically feeling around the mirror maze for a path, but coming to a dead end and panicking, turning back around.

Izuku's face scrunched up as if he was about to cry, but he looked up towards the ceiling and blinked a couple of times, before calming his breath, and feeling around the mirror maze for the exit. He feels like he is close, and he focuses his energy on navigating his way out until he reached the spiral staircase that led up to the slide on the second floor.

Up there, a member of the vault team spotted him.

“Hey, Midoriya!” He waves, “Are you the last one in there? We’re about to close up.”

Izuku keeps his face hidden, and he shakes his head, “Kacchan is still in there.”

“Oh shit, Midoriya, are you alright?” He asked, and Izuku figures that he can try to hide, but the cracked voice, sniffling, and tear streaked face is a dead giveaway even if he looks down.

“Yeah, I’m fine!” He found himself slipping into his old habit of pretending he was okay when he was not.

That was normal, he told himself. Fixing bad habits is not an overnight adjustment. A lifetime of habituation will not be erased in months. These days, he’s got it 75% down, but in times like these, he rather people not worry.

“Are you sure?” The vaulter looked concerned.

“Yeah! Thank you for worrying, but I’m okay!” Izuku nods, before sitting down on the black slide, grabbing the top handle, before letting go.

The fundraiser is already in the process of getting cleaned up, as most people have left aside from the clean up crew and those in charge of the booths. Trash can being picked up, tables were being put down and transported back into the school’s storage rooms, and the inflatable slides and what not were slowly deflating. As for the more heavy duty equipment, the companies that rented them out will come first thing tomorrow to pick it up. For now, everyone’s job is to shut down any mechanism, and then clean up in their area. Izuku, as Student Council Member, didn’t have to do anything. But there only needed to be four council members on duty at a given time, and his shifts were over an hour ago. Which meant, he could head home.

He grabs a cap from a table of unused prizes, and puts on his head to cover his eyes. Pieces of hair stuck out on the side, but as long as his face was mostly hidden, maybe people will stop asking questions.

Izuku walks briskly to where the parking lot is, ears overwhelmed by how loud the cicadas are tonight, and from behind him, Iida Tenya catches up.

“Midoriya-kun,” Iida called out, “Do you have a ride?”

Izuku stopped, swung his arms a bit, then looked around, before turning to his friend and shaking his head, “No.”

“I can take you home, if you’d be comfortable,” Iida responded with a vigorous head nod.

Izuku breaths heavily and looks back at the fundraiser event, “That’d be great, Iida-kun.”

Iida Tenya drives a Range Rover that Izuku has only been inside of twice. Usually, when they went out as a group, they took Ochaco’s car. Iida keeps his car clean. That was nice..

“I’m excited to see the announcement on how much we raised,” Iida proudly stated.

Izuku was not listening, but he hums in response. Instead, his mind was taken back four days ago when he was going home in his Mother’s car that was similar in shape, color, and size as this one. Except it was a Toyota, and not a Range Rover. The Hideaway was tucked into a rather peculiar corner of the area, but his mother had managed to find it.

Izuku’s mother had pulled up, tires crunching the sand and gravel underneath the poured drive way, and Izuku left the athlete there as he had turned to get to Inko’s car. The conversation weighed heavily in his mind, and he just needed to get away as far as possible

The moment Izuku got into the vehicle, all the boy could beg was, “Go, please.”

His mother’s eyes were blown wide with concern, and she stared at him as if her own heart was broken as well. And Izuku for just a mere second wonders what she’s going to say, because they haven’t really talk a lot, much less about how he had fallen madly in love past the point of return. Was she going to get upset? Say that she was right all along? Say that in the end, the only person he had was her? He wonders.

But as the woman turns the car around and bumpily drives out of the sandy driveway, Inko says nothing. The stroboscopic shadows of the trees move across his vision as they drive through the forest, and the owls cooed at night.

On the radio, a song plays, and Izuku was tempted to turn it off, wincing in recognition.

How Am I Supposed To Live Without You by Michael Bolton. This was a notoriously sad song, but he knew his mother liked it, so he doesn’t ask her to turn it off. Izuku had let the first verse play, head leaning up against the car window as they drive through the sparse forest road, tears streaming down the side of his face. He was glad his mother wasn’t asking, because he wasn’t ready to talk about it. If this was months ago, the woman would have bugged him to death to tell her every single strife and thought he had, or else he would have been called a bad son who didn’t want to be close to her. If nothing else, this was a nice change that he needed, for the argument was still completely fresh.

His hands were still shaking from that entire interaction with Katsuki. Leaving him there, leaving the love of his life there, after the most beautiful dinner, after the most beautiful friendship and experiences, was the hardest thing that Izuku has ever done besides confront his mother. How could it not be, when Katsuki meant so much to him, when he loved the other so damn much?

*So tell me all about it, tell me 'bout the plans you're makin'*

*Oh, then tell me one thing more before I go*

The involvement of an electric guitar probably meant the song should be happy, but goddamnit, it wasn’t. And Izuku pursed his lips so no sound could come out, but his face was squeezed together and his chest was shaking from holding it down so his mother doesn’t get too concerned. A hand comes up to his mouth, and he tries to muffle his sobs. He curls up into a little ball in the passenger seat, and time is relative. Every single second passed so

slowly as he anticipated being home, and the lights on the streets of Ise looked like bokeh through his tear soaked eyelashes.

*Tell me, how am I supposed to live without you?*

*Now that I've been loving you so long*

How. How was he going to. Izuku wonders how he is going to navigate all of this, when his life thus far has been integrated with Katsuki's for as long as he could remember. Even before this project started, Katsuki was his inspiration. For passion. For so much. Seeing that boy leap into the sky was the highlight of his days. His legs were habituated to stopping in front of the fence for a couple of minutes every day. His lips were habituated to breaking out in a smile every time he saw the spikey blonde hair. His mind was habituated to always thinking of him. Trying to navigate these new waters was comparable to ripping away a component of someone's life that has been so deeply integrated and telling them all of a sudden to live without it. Izuku's shoulders rack, and he feels a warm hand on his wrist.

Looking over slowly at his mother with tears in his eyes and red puffiness in his face, Izuku let out a small mangled, *Huh?*

Inko kept her eyes on the road, but a solemn expression played on her face, as the woman's sweet voice tells him gently, "It's okay, 'Zuku. Let yourself cry."

At this, Izuku drops his hand, drops his head, and continues to curl up as his shoulders shake even more from the pain.

*How am I supposed to live without you*

*And how am I supposed to carry on?*

*When all that I've been livin' for is gone*

Falling in love with Katsuki was so easy. When that boy went out of his way to show him the world, take him to the most beautiful places, tell him some of the most beautiful things, it was so damn easy to fall in love with him. To get lost in that gaze, and drunk in those kisses. But *being* in love with Katsuki? That was the hard part. Because to live every day in this intense friendship, knowing that the other doesn't love you back, but acting as if he does. Was he not allowed to be confused and hurt?

And now, to continue a life with minimal Katsuki, the world already looks a lot less colorful.

*It's just a dream of mine is coming to an end*

*And how can I blame you when I built my world around*

*The hope that one day we'd be so much more than friends?*

They pull up into the Midoriya house's driveway, and Izuku steps out onto the familiar concrete, and stares up at his two story classic home. The front yard reminded him of too much. The tree that led up to his window reminded him of too much. Even the porch brought

back memories of lazy evenings sitting outside sipping on lemonade and talking until nightfall. He knew his room wasn't going to be any better.

*I don't wanna know the price I'm gonna pay for dreaming, oh*

*Even now it's more than I can take*

*Tell me how am I supposed to live without y-*

The car turns off then behind him, and his mother stepped out of the car, jolting Izuku from his trance. And quickly gathering himself, the greenette walks with a slight wobble in his legs up the porch and then inside of the house. He bypasses everything, the living room and headed towards the stairs. Quickly going up the creme carpeting staircase, Izuku turns the corners until he was in their house's guest room, before he collapses on the bed, kicking his shoes off just before. But overall, not caring that he still had dirty clothes on.

When a person cries too much, the strain on his temple can cause a headache, and so Izuku wanted to stop because he could already feel the headache coming on. But the tears just wouldn't stop. In his head, he could still hear Michael Bolton's voice singing, and he mouths along to the song while salty tears slipped into his mouth and his voice shook.

"Tell me how am I supposed to live without you," Izuku sung quietly to himself in a shaky tone as he cries, head buried into the crook of his elbows, body laying on its stomach. He remembers the sight of Katsuki's eyes when Izuku told him that he was in love with him. That immediate cloud over, the unwanted shock. It makes him cry harder, and man, was he sick of this.

It feels like these days, he was crying left and right, and Izuku wonders when it will all end. Even now as he laid here, he still wonders if Katsuki was okay. He must have felt so overwhelmed, Izuku thought, and some guilt racked through him as well. He hadn't meant to blow up as he did, but he must imagine that Katsuki likely felt bombarded by his emotions, and all of this makes him feel worse.

He continues singing, "Now that I've been lovin' you so long."

And he has. He's loved Katsuki for a long time. He loved the way Katsuki moved in pole vault since he was 11, standing on the other side of the fence. He loved the way Katsuki did things, and talked, since they started the project and began going on these crazy adventures. And he loved *Katsuki* , all of Katsuki, sometime along the road, adoring the boy's disdain for umbrellas and even Katsuki's love for airplanes. He loved the little parts about Katsuki, as much as he loved the big details that everyone else liked.

He laid there for a long time, and it was like he was laying in a pool of his own misery, because the pillow his head was resting on was damp with tears. But slowly, he calms down just enough that he isn't sobbing between his hiccups, but occasionally, one or two tears will slip easily through his ducts.

He lays on his side, so when Midoriya Inko hesitantly came into the guest room with some water in her hands, Izuku notices her right away. The carpeted ground over wood boards

creaked a little bit as she walked in, and Inko sat on the edge of the bed, setting the water down on the nightstand, before she lowered her upper body to embrace her son and rub circles into Izuku's back.

The doe eyed boy has a distant glazed over look in his eyes, cheeks cracked with dried tears except for the undereyes which were still shimmering with fresh ones, and Izuku just appeared like he's been drained of all soul and energy. When his mother began to gently rub circles into his back, Izuku was reminded of how much he missed this. Of how much he missed her.

It's been a while. And a situation like this was the last thing the boy thought would have him in close contact with his mother again, but he needed her now more than ever. And Inko sits there for a long time with him, wiping at his face, and then softly running her fingers through his hair. It looked as if Inko missed doing this too, because there was a bittersweet expression on her face as she do all the things they used to do together all the time when hanging out, just mother and son.

His beautiful mother has aged well. She was a nice woman in her mid-40s with no husband, doing well enough for herself. The years hadn't caught up to her, and there was still firmness in her face. But Izuku could tell the last few months *did* age her a bit, and he feels just a little bit guilty because he had a strong guess why. Now, the woman's undereyes were slightly dark, and face a little more worn out. But there was more gentle and genuine movement to her demeanor, and Izuku knows that *something* at the very least had changed.

Inko then sat at the head of the bed, and lifted Izuku's head enough so that Izuku was now laying in her lap, and she continues to play with his hair, except now, he couldn't see her face unless he turned his body upwards which he had no intention to do. And for a bit, she just does this.

And it's only about ten minutes later, does the first word get spoken, and Izuku's sensitive ears perked up.

"When I met Hisashi, oh let me tell you, I was smitten," Inko said very quietly.

Izuku stays quiet, not understanding where this conversation was stemming from, but wanting to listen regardless. Maybe it will distract him from Katsuki.

Inko took a breath and laughed a little, "He was tall, handsome, with brown eyes. That's probably where you get the golden flakes in your eyes from, 'Zuku," She recalls with an airy chuckle, "And *oh my* , he was a troublemaker."

A pause.

"I remember the first day we met, he was climbing that magnolia tree in front of Ise High that's been there for forever and called me up there with him even though I was a stranger," Inko recollected, "Well, he ended up falling off and breaking his arm, which was quite a fun first meeting story, but even then, after 3 months recovery, the first thing he did was climb that tree again."

At this, Izuku finds himself letting out a small smile, at the thought of his parents when they were younger. The scene played out in his head. He's watched VHS tapes of them before in the attic, but those were after they were in an established relationship. His mother had never really talked about him otherwise. So this? This was new.

"And Hisashi did that for a lot of things. He went everywhere in this little town, and exhausted each place. I was always his chaperone, making sure he doesn't get into any serious trouble. He'd always tell me 'Inko! Come with me. Inko! Come up here, it's beautiful.' But I never would. It was fun to watch him, but I was too sheltered to try."

Izuku can believe that. His mother standing guard as his dad goes and does something wild. He smiles a little more, a tear sliding down his face.

"He would break his bones over and over again, end up with a fracture or a sprain. And I wouldn't understand why he continues to want more. But I loved his spirit. I think it was because it reflected all I was lacking in my own," Inko then sniffled once but she sounded steady, "I had always thought to myself how Hisashi didn't belong to this world. It was too small to confine him, and that would scare me. Because a small town like Ise would never be enough to satisfy him. Hisashi wanted to see the world. He wanted to travel, and take me along. Do more. Be more."

This was something Izuku has heard before, but usually, his mother said it in a spiteful tone, but this time, it felt somber if anything. A lace of sadness was detected in her words.

"And I would just play along with his dreams, even though mine were to build a life here, start a family, and watch them grow up in this small town. I figured that by the time we would get married, he'd let go of those dreams and realize what was important," Inko took a shallow breath, "But he never did. In fact, as he got older and the less time he had left, the more impatient he got with wanting to do more with his life. And I remember late night arguments asking him what more did he want?" Now, it seems like Inko's voice was shaking a bit, "We had each other. We had you, a mere baby. We had this house, and this town. Our neighbors and our community. What more did he want?"

Izuku closed his eyes, and lets a couple more tears slip.

"To see the world, he said. To show us and our baby all the beauty there is to see, he said. To be someone more than a bank teller from a small town, he said," Inko recited as if these memories never left her, "I told him I don't need all of that. I didn't *want* any of that. And…" She swallowed, "And so he left."

Izuku was crying once again, wondering when this will end.

"I don't think I'll ever forgive Hisashi for leaving you, 'Zuku," Inko admits, bending down to kiss Izuku's forehead, "And for the longest time, I pushed all of the blame to him. It's easier to blame someone who is gone, than to accept that I never tried to see his point of view, always expecting him to cater to my dreams and my wants."

Izuku buried his face in the fabric of her pants, because this story was beginning to sound a little familiar. The parts weren't all the same. The people were definitely not the same. But

the regret. The blame pushing. The lack of perspective. It was all sounding familiar to him.

“But you aren’t like me, are you, Izuku?” His mother cooed in a sad tone, “All of this time, I was terrified of you leaving me like he did, that I ended up being the one to drive you away.”

“Mom,” Izuku sounded out, whimpering slightly, “You don’t have t-”

“I do, baby,” Inko insisted in a plea, “I do. Because you deserve this. Because…” Her breath was getting raggedy, “Because I didn’t do my job well enough as a mother, that someone else had to teach you what it means to be angry, to be sad, to be human.”

Izuku doesn’t say anything, just continues to bury his head in her lap.

“I never wanted you to be any of those things, because if you did, then I’m afraid it would mean you were unhappy with me. Unsatisfied with how we are. If you got angry, or sad, then maybe you’d want to leave too. If I raised you so that you were always happy, always smiling and taught to be grateful, then I thought that you wouldn’t feel the need to leave,” Inko admitted, sniffling in once, “I was a fool wasn’t I?”

She continues, “To think that you were just *my* son and no one else’s, to think that you were going to share my dreams, adopt my personality,” Inko laughed ironically to herself, “How could I think that, when Hisashi so clearly left his sense of adventure in you and his ambition. Your dreams of going to a good college outside of Ise. Your want to go do all kinds of exhilerating things. Deep down, I was scared of the day that a Bakugo Katsuki would come in and push you just enough to open up your dad’s side.”

Izuku bit his lip, “It-It’s not all or nothing, Mom,” He says muffled, “I’m not just you. And I’m n-not just Dad. I’m my own person.”

“I know,” Inko whispers, “I know now.”

“A-And I can have both your kindness and value for family, while still loving adventure and exploration,” Izuku tells her, trying not to hiccup, “Just because I leave, doesn’t mean I’m not coming back. I’ll al-always come back to you, Mom.”

Inko cries silently, and cracked a joke, “You better. I know you can’t live a whole year without having my katsudon.”

Izuku cries too and nods his head, clutching the fabric of her pants tightly.

The mother takes a deep breath then, letting out a sound of relief, before she clears her throat and continues to speak, “You are not me. And Katsuki is not Hisashi.”

Izuku suddenly wonders where Katsuki came from, even if he internally could connect the dots.

“Katsuki is a fine boy. Handsome, smart, athletic, and I know he has some deep rooted issues, but I can tell his heart acts before his head does,” Inko took a deep breath, “And he’s kind to you. And he cares deeply. But I’m sure you know that.”

Izuku nods his head slowly from below. He wasn't sure if he wanted to hear about Katsuki tonight. Not after what had happened at the Hideaway. But still, he listens.

"He does," Izuku whispers. Katsuki cared a lot.

"Adventurous too. Always wanting to whisk you away to do something that looks like it's from a movie," Inko thinks back to all the pictures on her phone that she's received from the blonde boy, "If it were me, I know I would never go along. I'm still too scared. But you aren't like that, are you Izuku." She says softly, knowing the answer, "You match that boy's pace, and he matches yours."

The doe eyed boy can't do this. This was hard. This was oh so hard, but his mother changes the conversation right then and says something completely unexpected.

"Two weeks ago when I went to the city to pick up supplies for an important client, I met up with your father," Inko reveals to him.

And Izuku's eyes open then, and out of shock, he attempts to move his head from her lap. But Inko keeps him still there, and Izuku realizes that she was likely about to say something that she doesn't want him seeing her reacting to. His heart beat fast. So many years. So many years has past since he's had any semblance of updated news from his father. He was stuck with memories from so long ago, that slipped from his grasp as time went on. He could barely remember what Hisashi looked like anymore unless he pulled out a VHS tape or looked through photo albums locked away in their attic. And to think that just two weeks ago, his mother met up with him in a city after *she* hadn't even seen him for nearly two decades, he couldn't imagine how it went down.

"W-What do you mean?" Izuku asked, head laying on the side, eyes wide as he anticipated any news.

"Aunt Kita, she had told me the day before that Hisashi was going to be in the country in that specific city that week. Said she saw a post on his Facebook. I never lost his number, so in a moment of spontenuity, I called and we decided to meet up at a cafe," Inko tried very hard to keep herself calm for Izuku.

"How was he?" Izuku asked quickly, "What is he like now? Is he doing alright? Did he talk about me at all? And what's he-"

"He's married again," Inko interrupts suddenly, her voice a bit more high pitched and breathless, "I saw pictures. She's a sweet looking woman from Vietnam. And they have two kids together. A boy and a girl, named Homura and Ngoc. Both under thirteen years old."

Oh. Izuku hears this, and he doesn't quite know how to feel. It was almost like hearing a stranger's life update. His father got remarried, and now has a new family. Oh. Well, Izuku hoped that he was happy.

"He seems very happy with his new family," Inko whispers, "And I think that part of him put in so much effort into this one, because of the guilt he felt about leaving us," She brushed that aside, "But that's just me wishfully thinking."

Izuku swallowed, asking his mother, “Does he live in Vietnam?”

“No,” Inko shakes her head while she plays with Izuku’s hair, “They travel a lot. He’s one of the head architects for a company in Seoul, so he’s based there. But he travels around a lot to help with the company’s infrastructure expansion.”

Izuku’s lips quiver, but he replies, “That’s nice.”

A bit of silence ensues before Inko moves forward.

“He said he thinks of you a lot, but is too ashamed to ever contact you,” Inko sniffled, “I told him that we shouldn’t talk about what happened between us in the past, and I think...that I was trying to make it seem to him that I have everything together, since he looked like he did. So I told him that we’ve all moved past it.”

Izuku could hear his mother struggling to keep her talking straight. He squeezed her hand.

“And so we sat in that cafe and talked for *hours* , Izuku,” His mother recounts with a whimsical sound to her words, “He was a busy man, and I had to go pick up some things, but two hours in, we both cleared our schedules for the day and decided to sit there until nighttime, just talking,” And then she laughs, “I think I ordered four chai lattes that day.”

“You should have tried something different from the menu every hour,” Izuku attempts to make a joke, but his voice comes out too quiet.

Either way, Inko laughed airily, “I should have, you’re right.”

“What’d yall…” Izuku swallowed, “What’d yall talk about?”

After a moment of silence, Inko answers with a lightness in his words, “Everything, Izuku,” She says, “We talked about everything. The good ole days. And then we exchanged stories from the present. He had a lot more to say than I did, that’s for sure,” She laughed again painfully, “And it was so nice, Izuku. The next time he’s in the country, we should all meet up again. See what your father is like.”

Izuku isn’t sure how he felt about that, but he knew if the opportunity ever came, he’d be too curious not to come, and he asks Inko now, “What *is* he like now?”

His occupation doesn’t really say much about his personality.

“What is he like?” Inko repeats, and her hands rest on Izuku’s shoulder, “He’s still handsome. I think that time has made him even more handsome. Time and experience. I could tell that he’s experienced a lot of beautiful things that he’s always dreamed of, just by looking into his eyes. It was those same eyes that I fell in love with, except now a bit older and a bit more wise.” She smiles briefly.

“He’s still adventurous, but instead of falling out of trees, he likes to go mountain biking and sight seeing,” Inko recalls, “He told me that no matter where he goes and how world-class he becomes, he still has that Ise charm to him. The little Ise twang in his speech, and the need to stop and listen to the crickets everywhere he goes,” Inko lets out a chuckle.

Izuku was quiet, taking this information in.

“He still makes me laugh, Izuku,” Inko sounded forlorn, before he hears her choke on her words a bit and say, “I sat there for just about 8 hours that day, talking to him in that cafe. It felt like three hours, at most. He made me laugh until I cried, and I managed to get him laughing and reminiscing too. After more than 15 years of not seeing this man, I thought that my heart would have scarred over by now.”

And then she asks Izuku, “But you know what, Izuku?” She begins to cry, not loud but enough that he hears her jagged breath.

Izuku waits for her to continue, as he clutches onto her pants leg.

“As I sat there till dark that day, and I listen to his stories, and laugh at his old jokes that he’s been saying since we were teens. And as I look back in his eyes and watch him smile,” Inko cries and puts her head down as well, “I feel so pathetic because I know that a part of me is still in love with him.”

And as much as it hurts Inko, it hurts Izuku as well. To see his mother admit this, he felt that pain from within her radiate inside of him too, and he tries to put himself in his mother’s shoes. All this time, in the small ways, she’s never moved on, in the way she hid all of Hisashi’s memories, in the way she raised Izuku fearing that he’d leave in the same manner, in the way that his name was a forbidden word in their house. And she had to sit here, pretending to be okay, as she hears her ex-husband talk about his new life, with his new family and job, while memories of their high school and college days flash through her head, while images of Hisashi picking her up in a motorcycle and buying her dinner at some dingy diner on the outskirts of Ise get pulled to the surface. Izuku had been right. She was stuck in the past, and at no other moment was that more evident than right then in that cafe, realizing a part of her was still in love with this man who had left her and has clearly moved on.

“Mom,” Izuku wanted to reach out to her, wanted to get up, but his mother clearly didn’t want him to see, and she sounded like she wasn’t done. Inko took another deep breath, and calmed her crying so that she can talk seriously again.

“Izuku,” Inko tells him, “There’s a reason why I’m telling you this,” She insists, before hesitantly continuing, “You know what I kept asking myself when I left the cafe that night?” A pause. “I kept on asking myself, *what if* .” And she sniffles as her voice breaks up and down, “What if I had taken his hand that one day long ago, when he asked me to join him up in that magnolia tree,” She laughs, “What if I had been brave enough to join him in the water when he’d dive into the ocean in early spring when it was still cold out. What if we had sat down and talked about our goals and came to a compromise, rather than fight each other for one solution.”

She swallows, “What if, when we got married, I didn’t place my expectation on him to give up his dreams for mine, and he didn’t expect me to give up my dream for his? What if we both tried a little harder? Take a vacation here and there? He could get another degree in the city, and travel for work, and when he comes back home for a couple weeks at a time, we would still have been a happy family, wouldn’t we?”

Izuku curls up, and his own head is swirling with his own what if's.

"I'm telling you this, Izuku, because," Inko hugs him from her position then, tightly as if he was going off to Waseda tomorrow, "Because I don't want you to ever have to ask 'what if.' I don't want you to wonder what if I had let you go to Waseda? What if I had let you pursue your dreams and come visit once in a while with food and snacks from home? But above all that, I don't want you to ever wonder any *what if's* when it comes to Katsuki."

Inko then gently pushes Izuku up, and the boy sits up then, tears stained face, and she cups his face in her hands while telling him with tears brimming in her own eyes, "You love this boy, right?"

Izuku slowly nodded, "I do."

"Then don't ever allow yourself to ask *what if* you had done this, *what if* he had said this," Inko tells him, "You don't want to end up like me, 'Zuku. I'm a 45 year old woman, still in love with a man who left her 15 years ago. You don't want to become me, Izuku. Sitting in a cafe across from Katsuki, 10 years down the road, wondering what could have been different."

Izuku shakes his head, "Mom, you don't understand," His voice quivered, "He doesn't want to love me. And I can't make him."

"Regardless of whether or not he wants to, Izuku, he does," Inko shook her head, assuring her boy.

"You're just saying that because you don't believe someone won't love me," Izuku smiled at her, warmed by her thoughts, but it didn't align with the truth.

"That's true, but trust me Izuku, that boy is as in love with you as the sky is blue and as the grass is green. He just doesn't know it yet, but his actions are much more telling than his words, I promise you that," Inko wiped at his face.

"But words are important, too," Izuku makes a case, "I can't keep guessing at his actions, when his words tell me that he doesn't love me, that we'll only ever be just friends. What am I supposed to do? Tell him, 'Kacchan, even though you say you don't love me, you act like you do, and therefore, *I* am going to tell you how *you* feel?'" Izuku wipes at his eyes before softly saying, "Mom, you can't expect me to walk up to this man who tells me he doesn't love me, and argue with him about his *own* emotions and how he's wrong. Who am I to tell him he's wrong."

Izuku takes a breath, "Everyone likes to think in black and white, but that's not how life is. It's not nurture *or* nature. It's not actions *or* words. It's not always this or that. But it's both, mom. It's both. I…" He drops his head, "I can't just have actions, actions that are negated by words that contradict and confuse me. I also need words. Words that he doesn't plan on giving me."

Inko watches him with sad eyes, and her hands are still thumbing the saltwater off his cheeks.

“B-But that’s okay,” Izuku smiles up at her, “It’s okay, because I will move in. I need to.”

“Izuku, baby,” Inko shakes her head, “You haven’t even tried to sit down and talk to ea-.”

“Let’s leave,” The boy suddenly asks, bringing his shirt up to soak up his face, and then clutches his mother’s hand in both of his home.

“Huh?” Inko’s eyes widened at the random statement.

“Come with me. Tomorrow,” Izuku nods, “Let’s do something fun together, and we could go to some cool places. Come on, we can even leave tonight."

“Izuku, you sound like your dad,” Inko laughs and wipes at her own face, “But I don’t know…”

“And you wondered, right?” Izuku asked, eyes pleading, “What if you had taken his hand? Mom, you don’t have to wonder anymore. Take mine. I’ll show you.”

Inko looked hesitant, and asked him, “Why so sudden? You're just trying not to talk about Ka-”

“I just…” Izuku breathed in deeply, distress slightly in his face, “I just need to get away. And do something fun, just me and you. Lead my own adventure, you know? At some point, I have to stand up on my own two feet as well.”

This was true, but even more so, a disguise for the fact that he needed to get out of Ise. Fuck, he needed to get out of Ise so badly. And his mother. There was still a lot to talk about. A lot to discuss. He was sure she still has a lot of her old bad habits, just like he still has a lot of his own. But they were trying. Look at them, they were trying.

“‘Zuku…I don’t know…” Inko looked apprehensive, “I’m not sure if I can.”

Izuku shakes his head, “You can. It won’t be anything crazy, Mom. We can just go to the city, and have a little trip. Just me and you,” And his voice shakes as he says this, “Make up for lost time.”

Inko looked at him for a while, eyes searching, a little nervous because she only travels occasionally for work, and it’s to the same stores or shops over and over again. The woman wasn’t keen on exploring, and the rate at which the world proceeded outside of Ise could be overwhelming for her slow life here in this small beach town. But seeing that look in Izuku’s eyes, of want, adventure, and desperation, she knew that it was now or never to open herself up more.

“Alright, let’s do it,” Inko replies. And to see her son’s face light up for the first time tonight was all worth it.

They drove four hours away, to a large metropolitan area, a city much bigger than any Izuku has ever been to, and his eyes widened upon seeing the skyline. His mother had actually let

him drive, but she was pointing the directions and he just tried not to kill the both of them. As they entered the vicinity of the city, Izuku read the sign and recognized this place. Nagoya.

It was the place where the National Pole Vault Association was based in, and therefore, Nationals Qualifiers, Semi Finals, and Finals, were held here for the adult league.

The Youth Nationals was held about two hours away, so Izuku could go every year. But this one was in a league of its own. The city was huge, and Izuku couldn't imagine what Tokyo would be like if Nagoya was this large. He doesn't know why his mother led them here, but there doesn't have to be a reason for everything. Seeing the big city, he immediately feels a bit of a draw back to Ise, but he knew that experiences like these were valuable, and that home was always there when he needs it, but time won't be.

Inko books a hotel room that had a cute bed and breakfast theme to it, and Izuku nods to himself. They're doing this. Yes, they're doing this.

The mother and son duo ends up doing a lot that day. Went to a Noh theatre, ate at some unique restaurants, and visited the Nagoya castle or two other historical sites. And at the end of the day, Izuku convinced his mom to sneak up onto the rooftop of some building, and watch the world move around them. And they stay up there for a long time, Izuku temporarily distracted and happy in this moment.

"Can I miss school tomorrow?" Izuku asked her softly.

Inko looked over at him, "Miss school? Why?"

Izuku looked down at his lap, "I...I think I need one more day until I can face him. I think if I saw him tomorrow, I'd just break down all over again."

Inko thinks about it, hesitant, before pursing her lips and nodding, "Okay."

"Besides, it'll keep you from waking up super early tomorrow morning to drive me back in time for school," Izuku gently elbowed her with a smile.

"That's true, I suppose," Inko smiled.

"Plus, I need to get started on the analysis paper," Izuku took in a deep breath, feeling a jolt of pain in his chest at the thought of it.

"The analysis paper," Inko looked up towards the sky. They couldn't see the stars here in the city, only airplanes passing through the night sky. Nothing like the milky way that could be seen in Ise, "Oh 'Zuku, what are you going to write for that?"

Izuku pursed his lips and sighed, "The truth. I'm a senior, it barely matters."

And that's all he manages to say about it. It was obvious what to write about considering the prompt of the project. B eing around Katsuki constantly this past semester *had* completely changed his life. *Had* turned him into a more confident, more stable, and more free person all around. It had introduced him to how beautiful and exhilarating the world can be. He'll write about that for sure, and give appreciation towards Katsuki where it was due. But how was he

going to tell Mr. Toshinori that somewhere along the way, he had fallen in love? Was he going to tell him at all? Izuku doesn't know.

The next day was also fun. He spent the first half of it with his mother, dragging her through the fountain that sprayed up from the ground in the city and then inside of an interactive light museum that displayed all sorts of visual affects. And the other half of the day, he spent in the car staring at blank pieces of paper as they returned to Ise. It had been fun, and Izuku valued this time a lot, but it was time to head back to this small town, where his heartbreak was waiting for him to return.

When he saw Katsuki again the next day in class, Izuku had to use every single nerve in his body to keep his appearance normal. Every *single* one. They had to turn in their homework sheets for physics, and had walked up at the same time, and the moment he sees the tall blonde, as handsome and rugged as he always was, Izuku wanted to immediately freeze up and break down. Every single flashback from two nights ago came rushing in at once, and he doesn't know how he is going to stand in Katsuki's presence at any point and not want to crumble to the ground.

But he forces himself to. Dropping the paper in the bin, Izuku caught his eye, those beautiful red eyes, lifted his lips in a tiny smile and nodded. He didn't know why he bothered trying to act calm. Katsuki could probably tell through all of his bullshit. Of course he wasn't okay. He confessed his undying love just two days ago and that ended with tears and heartache, why would he be okay after two days? He probably looked like a fool trying to hide it. But as Izuku goes to sit down in his seat, he wonders if Katsuki was okay. Because for a split second there, when they made eye contact, the blonde's solemn expression wasn't too different from his own.

The day passes by too slowly. Way too slowly, and Izuku throws himself into work. The annual fundraiser was literally the next day, and he knew he had been slacking. Too caught up in the drama of his own life, Izuku feels bad for not being as active as he should with a fundraiser that means fo much for the community. He remembered when he was a kid, Inko would take him to the Annual Fundraiser hosted by Ise High, and how special that night was for him every year. He'd go home having learned new crafts, with his face painted with Ise High's mascot, the Shark, which made sense considering they were in a beachtown, and a tummy full of food and soda. And now that he was on the committee that was planning and organizing it, there's this sense of responsibility Izuku feels to make it as magical for kids in the community now as it had been for him.

And it turned out extremely well. Every year, they get more and more people, and Izuku works himself crazy running around all day trying to get everything in order. He sees Katsuki doing the same, and for a moment, makes himself set aside their personal issues to focus on the event at hand. And it turns out incredible. The show out was good. The food all came on time. The games were well equipped, and everyone seemed to be having fun, whether they worked the booth or visited the booths. A couple of times, Izuku was called to sort out some issues, but even that didn't happen too often. Keeping himself busy like this was a good idea.

And then, the mirror maze happened. And my god, Izuku couldn't have imagined that he'd end his night like this, riding home in Iida's car after crying once more, because of a conversation inside of a *mirror maze* with Bakugo Katsuki. He had slipped past Kaito who was stationed at the front, and wanted to check the Monkey Maze out. The routes changed every year, and Izuku, who loved puzzles, always had a fun time trying to figure out the maze. He expected that it'll be difficult. He didn't expect, however, for it to be difficult not because the maze itself was just hard, but because that conversation was *hard*.

And now, as Izuku steps out of Iida's car, thanks him, and heads inside, the boy paces the bedroom floor trying to console himself. He holds his own arms, and walks back and forth on the carpet, with the lights off in his room aside from the windows. His mother should be asleep at this time, considering she slept pretty early, but he wasn't going to talk to her about this anyways. None of it was new information.

But he just made an ultimatum with Katsuki. He was going to get over the blonde. And this wasn't out of spite, or hurt, or anger. No. None of that at all, because Izuku could say without a doubt right now, that he adores that boy to no end, even now. He was going to get over Katsuki because it's what both he and Katsuki deserved.

He deserved a love that was returned, didn't he? And he didn't blame Katsuki in the slightest for not being able to give it to him. Because who would he be to force a love that isn't there? Or isn't wanted? That wasn't Katsuki's fault in the slightest, and Izuku knew that no one was obligated to love anyone. And Izuku was going to move on, because he deserved to, even if he didn't actually think he was ready to.

And Katsuki deserved it too. His love was a gift, but to someone who never asked for it, Izuku could see how it could be a burden. And knowing the blonde, Izuku could tell that the boy cared deeply for him, even if it was as some twisted version of a friend. And so, that night at the Hideaway, hearing that Izuku had fallen in love with him, probably made the athlete feel guilty in some ways, pained in some ways, and worried. Izuku didn't want Katsuki to live with that burden, and so he was going to get over the other.

Izuku keeps pacing, and then his eyes catch movement outside on the window sill, and his heart rate increases exponentially. His first thought, his first hope, his first desire is that it's Katsuki, there to finally tell him what came after all of those "Wait"s that were met with silence. And oh how he wanted so badly for it to be Katsuki, despite having promised the both of them that he'll be better. But what was dangerous is the fact that when it turns out to just be the slightly overgrown branch of the tree hitting up against the tiles of his house, his disappointment radiated through the room. *That* was dangerous, because although he made his ultimatum, his heart was still hopeful.

Izuku goes downstairs and into the garage, turning the light on and grabbing a saw with a shaky hand. Then, the boy goes outside at this time of night and climbs the tree, keeping the saw's sharp side turned away from him. The climbs the tree that brought back so many memories of late night sneaking out, until he is near the branch that led across to his bedroom.

And once the boy finds a good spot to sit, he begins to saw the branch off, all while trying not to cry again. It was a thick branch, thick enough to hold his weight and Katsuki's weight

combined and some change, so this was going to take a while. But he needed to do this, or else, he'll sit in his room every night, doing homework or watching TV, forever anticipating the sound of knocking on his window. Izuku sits up there and saws the branch until he could see a pile of dust on the ground far beneath him. And when he gets to the last few saws until the branch breaks off under its own weight, Izuku stopped for just a moment to lean down and kiss the tree, thanking it for the memories it helped bring to life, before cracking it down in two more saws. The thick branch falls the height of the first story and lands with a loud thud, but no louder than if a car were to be riding down his street with the music up. Izuku tosses the saw down, and it lands on the grass, before he slowly climbs down himself. At the bottom, looking up, the boy finds that it looks so barren. So empty. But this way, he knew that he would no longer fantasize. No one could make that jump.

Izuku attempts to avoid Katsuki all the way right up to when the last day of the semester ends, which was just that Friday. He drove himself to school, a privilege his mother finally granted him, and he drove himself home. This was how it should have been, had his mother been less strict with him when he was 16, but late was better than never. That being said, he missed his routine. The walk home through Ise, the few minutes outside of the fence or inside of it meant to watch Katsuki fly, he misses it like nothing else in the world. They shared two classes together. In physics, Izuku makes sure to arrive one minute late, and to leave one minute early. Because if he lets himself talk to Katsuki, he knew his resolve was over. And with that in mind, the oddest thing was that it seemed as if Katsuki *really* wanted to talk to him. The blonde's walk would get a little faster if he was in the vicinity, and there always seems to be words playing on his lips.

Katsuki's been practicing harder than ever, he's heard. Izuku hopes that these days, Katsuki brings enough drinks to practice so that he stays hydrated, and that he doesn't overwork himself.

The Nationals Qualifiers were right around the corner, just at the start of Summer break on a Friday afternoon, and almost every minute of free time he had, Izuku's heard that the blonde had been using it to practice.

Keyword is *almost* every minute.

Izuku was confused the first time he heard it. It was two days after he had decided to cut the tree branch, and the boy was sitting in his room, the last part of his calculus final project coming together and due tomorrow, the literal last day of the semester. Izuku was about to glue the very final component on, when the sound of something thumping distracted him. It wasn't directly outside of his window, but somewhere below.

Taking out his headphones, Izuku slowly got up out of his seat and walked to his window, only moving the curtain to the side a little bit so that he could see just enough, and his heart begins to race and he blinks multiple times, trying to see if he was imagining this. Because what he was seeing was almost ridiculous.

Bakugo Katsuki's car was parked on his driveway, and the blonde had a shovel in his hand, and was wacking at the ground of his front yard. Izuku's jaw dropped. What the *fuck* . He couldn't even be sad at the sight of Katsuki, not when he was this confused. The blonde was digging up a storm, a little hole in the ground, and it causes such a ruckus that he hears his front door open.

Inko walks out in a hurry, eyes wide. And for a second there, Izuku fears for Katsuki's life, as his mother takes her gardening and yard work *very* seriously, and this boy here is now just hacking away at her grass like no tomorrow.

"Katsuki!" Inko screeched, "What are you doing! What are yo-" She sputters, "What are you doing!"

Katsuki wipes sweat from his brow, "I want to see him."

Izuku's eyes widened, and he steps back to put a hand on his beating heart. Katsuki wants to see him. That flutter of hope arose in his chest, and he could barely breath.

"And say what!" Inko looked at her poor dirt and grass.

Katsuki scratched the back of his head and looked frustrated, "I-I don't know," He admitted with an irritated tone, "I don't fucking know, I just want to see him."

*Oh*, Izuku thought, so there was nothing that Katsuki had to really say. Izuku had to wonder why the blonde wanted to see him so badly after everything. Did he not understand? Did he not understand how much it hurts to be near him? Did Katsuki simply forget everything? If the athlete had nothing to say, then Izuku doesn't understand why he was making it so hard for Izuku to just get over him. Still, the blonde's actions sparked curiosity.

Inko sighed then and looked solemn herself, "He told me not to let you in."

"I figured," Katsuki said before whacking the ground again, "Which is why I'm doing this," He said before shoving more dirt up.

"No!" Inko made a grab for his shovel and pushes Katsuki to the side, although she was much shorter and smaller than him, "Why are you digging a hole into my yard!"

"I need to do it, ya damn crone! Give me my fucking shovel back," Katsuki makes a move for it.

But Inko takes the shovel and proceeds to whack him with it, not hard enough to cause any real damage, and she does it repeatedly until the boy was shielding himself, "No, no! Stay away from my lawn."

"Goddamnit," Katsuki curses, before leaving his shovel and getting in his car, driving away.

The entire interaction confused the hell out of Izuku, and when he ate dinner with his mother that night, she was honestly at a loss too.

But it happens again the very next day, except this time around, Katsuki was quieter. He has a new shovel now, with the tag still on it, and he digs up the dirt slowly, until there is a trapezoidal shape in the middle of Izuku's front lawn. The green eyed boy had been staring wide eyed through the curtains, and it is just when Katsuki moves away and unblocks his view that he saw that it was a declined trapezoidal dent in the ground. And *oh* , Izuku knows what that is. He's been watching for way too long and way too closely to not know what that is.

It's a pole vault box. Dug into the dirt, and packed tightly on the sides. A very...DIY one, but the shape was very evidently there. Izuku's lips parted, as he watched Katsuki wipe sweat from his brow and go back into his car, before going to his car. And Izuku hadn't even noticed because the car is black, that strapped on top of the vehicle was a pole bag. A vault pole was usually way too long to fit within a car, so there were specially designed bags that get strapped to the roof where vaulters put their equipment in.

Katsuki goes over, and unzips the black tubing case, before sliding out a 16 ft pole. His roof was 13 feet, so that was cutting it *close* . Izuku was in shock.

The blonde must have gotten back from a long practice, for there was still tape around his hands, and Katsuki takes the pole, and gauges his position. And when he figures he had found the right one, Izuku sees him get into stance and then begin running. A small sprint, and then a run, before the athlete sticks the pole within the DIY vault box and launches himself up into the air. Izuku's hand reach into his pockets in case he needed to call an ambulance, but there was no need.

There was a very graceful manner in which Katsuki landed, twisting his body mid flight so that his back bent and he could land on his feet on the edge of the tiles leading right next to Izuku's room, and there was only minimal noise. Unlike actual vault, Katsuki holds onto his pole, which Izuku assumes is how the blonde planned on getting down. Using the pole to slow his momentum as he jumps off.

And then, Katsuki stood there looking proud of himself for a moment, before coming towards his window. Izuku backed off, face still full of shock, and he sits on the floor, back crouching beside the window. After a moment, he hears Katsuki sit down too, right outside the window, and catch his breath for two minutes or so.

"It's a miracle I didn't fucking get whacked by your mom today," Katsuki says softly, and Izuku could hear him through the windows aside from a slight muffle.

Izuku pulls his knees up to his chest, and places his chin there as he listens, unsure of whether to tear up or to smile.

The athlete sighs, "Going this far just to talk to you makes me feel like a yandere. I can't believe your nerd ass managed to watch me all these years without feeling like a creep, geez."

Izuku then leans his head back towards the wall, eyes looking up to where he sees Katsuki's shadow leaning with his back against the window as well. Why was he doing this?

“Today, I had breakfast with the hag and uh...dad,” Katsuki recounts to him, “And it ain’t that bad. Me and the hag are going shopping tomorrow to pick out some new shit for the pre-tournament banquet. And dad’s gonna go fishing with me the weekend after qualifiers. I’m gonna outfish him for sure.”

Izuku smiles sadly at this, and is internally so happy that Katsuki was spending time with his family.

“And listen to this crazy shit, Deku. Fuck Face gave me an invite to his birthday dinner this year. This is probably the first time I’ve been invited, even though the whole damn team always is,” Katsuki chuckled, “I ain’t gonna go. Because I have a dentist appointment that day, but I’m not gonna tell him that. I’m just gonna let him think it’s because I hate him, which is true. He’s an asshole with a fucked up idea of relationships, but that’s just how he is.”

At the mention of Kaito, Izuku pursed his lips and looked down. They still haven’t talked since the day he dropped Izuku off. But even Izuku was surprised the other day in the cafeteria when Kaito had indirectly stood up for Katsuki.

“Listen, I know you don’t want to talk to me, but,” He could hear Katsuki swallow, “I’m asking for just one more time.”

One more time to do what? Izuku thought.

“See me one more time,” Katsuki asks him quietly, “I’m...I’m not exactly sure how to say what I want to say, but I can figure it out when I get there. I just need to see you, nerd.”

No, that isn’t fair. Izuku frowns sadly. Katsuki doesn’t know what to say, yet he wanted Izuku to go suffer one more time? For what? Izuku wanted to know. For what?

“I can’t stop thinking about you, Izuku,” Katsuki whispered through the window and Izuku barely catches it, “Am I allowed to say that?”

No, *No he isn’t* . Izuku thinks to himself. How could he say something like that, and made Izuku long for him even more.

“That’s about the only thing I think I’m able to say right now. Everything else is still kind of new and terrifying to me, but I’ll get there,” Katsuki was speaking in cryptic tongues, and Izuku didn’t understand what he meant by *everything else* , “I’ll get there.”

Izuku holds his breath, and lets it out slowly, listening to Katsuki simultaneously.

"You there?” Katsuki’s shadow turned it’s head, and waited. Izuku doesn’t say anything, so the blonde turns back around and then gets up, “Take care of yourself, Deku.”

And as he hears Katsuki leave, pole aligning with the box, and then bending so that Katsuki could lower himself with slowered momentum, Izuku finally replies in a whisper, “You too, Kacchan.”

Except it wasn't just that evening. It was the evening after that, for a couple of minutes, Katsuki stopped by to vault right up to his window, and say a couple of words, a little update before leaving. And this happens the evening after too. Sometimes, Izuku was there, listening in quietly, wondering why this boy wants to see him so badly considering everything. Sometimes, Izuku wasn't in his room. He still knew Katsuki came by though by the displacement of the roof tiles when he would come back to his room later.

Summer break starts, and Katsuki's visit get shorter and shorter as Nationals get closer and closer, as in 3 days close. And when the blonde boy comes to say a couple of words, Izuku could hear the slight stress and anxiety in his voice.

3 days till.

"Today was my signing day," Katsuki tells him through the window, while munching on what sounded like an apple, "Which means it's now public information that I'm going to Keio. The university is already wanting to do some promotional material. But they're holding back until after the National Qualifiers. I think they're going to gauge how well I do before they plaster me in their campus magazine," Katsuki snorts.

Izuku sits there, fidgeting with his hands. National Qualifiers. He shouldn't go. And more so, he can't because his mother needed him to help out with some things that day. But he'll be watching on TV for sure.

"It's in 3 days, 'Zuku," Katsuki says, "I'm fucking psyched out. Coach Shugo tells me to stop trying to aim higher and to keep practicing at the height I got, but I feel like I can't."

Izuku wonders to what height Katsuki has managed to get up to now.

"Anyways," The boy says, "I gotta go. Shit's getting busy. By the way, your neighbor just walked by. She probably thinks I'm insane."

2 days till.

Katsuki doesn't come at all today, and that was fine. Izuku was still nursing a heartbreak, and if Katsuki didn't show up with his sweet daily recaps every day, it would probably be better for his still fragile heart. Izuku doesn't have anything planned for the break yet, but it's okay if he didn't. He spent this past semester doing so many things, that taking this time now to rest is a good idea. The grades were submitted, and Mr. Toshinori had left comments on his final paper, but he hadn't read them yet. He wasn't sure exactly when he planned to.

His mother has definitely noticed the trapezoid shaped hole in her front yard, but has yet to say anything, because Izuku hadn't mentioned anything. The situation with his mother was better, and that was a good news that Izuku really needed. After a long time of awkward exchanges, getting back into a close relationship with the woman was so needed. His mother must have gone through a period of deep reflection during the time they fell apart, because Izuku could tell, she was actively trying to not be as overbearing.

That being said, they were both only human. And there were still moments where Inko would say something that can perceived as manipulative or guilt-tripping, but Izuku makes sure to stand his ground and call her out of that. And instead of arguing and perpetuating the issue further, the woman seems to retrospectively realize she was doing it out of habit, and would try again next time. And there were moments where her overprotectiveness was still quite strong, but they're working on it so that her concerns come out more like suggestions, rather than oppressive demands. Over all, when it came to his mother, he was happy. Happy that even though it wasn't perfect, he had her again.

1 day till.

Katsuki *does* come today, and it's while Izuku was folding his laundry on the floor. He could hear the car pulling up, and then the pole hit the makeshift vault box. Through the curtains, he faintly sees Katsuki's silhouette, as the blonde crouches down for a moment. And just sits there, looking out on the neighborhood. And Izuku wonders if the boy will say anything at all. Outside, the Ise sunset washed over the sky, and Izuku could probably never begin to count how many of those beautiful skies he got to see with Katsuki. Outside, he can hear the cicadas ring even though it wasn't even nighttime yet.

Finally, after a while, the athlete speaks up and just says a couple of words.

"It's tomorrow at 4:00PM. I'm leaving tonight and sleeping in Nagoya," Katsuki says before taking a deep breath as if trying to calm his nerves.

A minute or two more of silence, and then, "You promised, right? I'll see you there."

Izuku looked up from his laundry with sad eyes at the figure sitting outside of his window sill, knowing he wasn't going to be there. Katsuki doesn't say another word for the next couple of minutes, before the blonde lets out a small sigh and then takes his leave. And Izuku felt bad. Yes, he was in pain. Yes, he needed to keep his distance and understand what was good and what was bad for him.

But there was no harm in wishing the blonde good luck. Not when it was obvious by his demeanor that Katsuki wanted to hear it so badly. And sounded nervous for the tournament. Izuku would feel horrible, if he were to just sit here, and say nothing this one time. He promises, after this, he'll be good.

Standing up quickly before Katsuki leaves, Izuku runs towards the window and opens it, pushing the curtain aside. Outside, the breeze immediately rushes in, and Izuku's vision is flooded with a mesmerizing pink as the Ise sunset never fails to impress. The crows perched on top of the telephone towers hopped around, and the crickets were already singing its song. Katsuki's black car stood parked on the side of the road. And in front of him, standing on the sloped tiles, pole in hand, the object of his love and adoration.

Katsuki was in his vault uniform, probably just having come back from practice, and stood tall. Izuku didn't know how euphoric seeing him would feel like until he opens the windows, and could see the man that he loved so dearly in the flesh. But he knew what he opened it for.

Katsuki had turned around at the sound, and looked shocked that Izuku had opened the window. If Izuku looked closely, he could see small stress lines near the blonde's forehead and rougher calluses on his hands.

Looking up at the athlete, Izuku tells Katsuki, "Good luck, Kacchan."

Izuku should back up now, close the window. But he was caught in those eyes, and Katsuki didn't want to look away either. Katsuki looked deep into him as if he was seeing Izuku for the first time, and the boy felt self conscious under that intense gaze. After about twenty seconds passed, Izuku was about to stick his head back inside and close the window, but before he could do that, Katsuki moved.

Swiveling just one leg forward, Katsuki bent down towards the window, and with one hand, tilted Izuku's chin up just as his head leaned in to place just one deep kiss on Izuku's lips, so sweet and tender it reels Izuku, and the doe eyed boy was stunned.

Stepping back, Katsuki tells him, "Tell me in person tomorrow."

Before he left.

0 Days Till.

The Paloma Mizuho Stadium sat in the Mizuho Ward of Nagoya, with a capacity of 27,000 people during high profile events like major international-level track and field events or concerts. It was hot outside, with the coming summer heat, and the drinks concession had a long line that stretched around the corner. People with visors and jerseys sat up in the stands, pumped for the tournament to come. Dozens and dozens of tents surrounded the field, each with a different sector of the Nationals competitors. Large speakers were being rolled out onto the equipment area of the stadium as tournament preparations were being made last minute. The energy was outstanding. For a national-level event, the average attendance is about 6000 people. Pole vault is a small sport. That being said, the numbers on this fine Friday afternoon were high.

In fact, 4,319 people filled up the stadium that day.

Amongst that number, none of them were Midoriya Izuku.

Chapter End Notes

hello! I just wanted to say thank you so much for all the love, guys. I am floored by how supportive everyone is of the fic, and i can only hope the last (?) chapter does them justice (don't be scared of the last chapter).

twt: suffocatingspr1

i'll answer 2 FAQ really quick!
yes, you'll see their final analysis
yes, i forgot an angst w/ happy ending tag
bonus: yes, i know them going around in circles is frustrating haha

next chapter coming out same day next week, unless i die.
UPDATE : Never mind. My parents decided to do a surprised visit up to my university so it won’t come out Tuesday unless Im drugged w some performance enhancer

# Chapter 13: The National Tournament

Chapter Notes

43k words.
Please read the ending note when you're finished ! READ THE ENDING NOTE. I REPEAT. WHEN YOU FINISH, READ THE ENDING NOTE.
We've reached the end. Thank you so much for coming along on this journey, I couldn't be more grateful if I tried. God, I love you guys to death. Sorry for this horrible ending. I tried to be as true as possible to what I had in mind, but I'm human after all, so I'm really sorry ahhh!

Spotify playlist : https://open.spotify.com/playlist/0snFtSvokWIcPVSb62VXIy

A quick I love you to FTS, the BKDK that exists within FTS, the community created from FTS, and all the support that you all have given this story <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A bead of water falls down the side of the glass. It falls and joins the little pool of iced liquid that formed a circle at the bottom, staining the table. *Oh* , Izuku realized.

He had forgotten a coaster. Usually, his mother had a pet peeve about leaving water stains on the tables, so, from when he was little until now, Izuku's always gotten a little scolding every time he forgot to use a coaster for cold glasses of water. He's surprised that his mother, who was talking to him right now, hadn't gotten onto him for it yet.

Or maybe she did. Izuku wouldn't know, for all the words sounded like buzzing and white noise to his ears, as his mind drifted off somewhere else. It's curious how the world can feel numb when the most exhilarating aspect of your life just...stops. And suddenly, even the water droplets on the side of a glass feels more interesting than the Katsuki-less reality that he's forced himself into. The ticking of the grandfather clock set up against olive green walls was all but a faint noise mixed with the zoned out murmuring of whatever it was that his mother was saying. Being underwater was a similar sensation, everything muffled and muddled.

On his lips, Izuku still feels the remnants of the kiss from yesterday evening. The ghosts of cherry gatorade and Katsuki's natural scent still lingered in his mouth, or maybe, his stupidly wishful heart tricked himself into believing so. If he lets himself think about it, then he can still remember the slight pressure of Katsuki's lips on his, pulling him into a deep but very

brief kiss, and the fingertips that tilted his chin up. Was he really that touch starved that even that faint touch was enough to set him back three steps?

However, if he *does,* in fact, let himself think on it, then he will spiral into madness. What had that meant? If anything at all? Why did he do that? Why did Katsuki have to go and do that? Did he not care about Izuku's wish to get over the blonde? Had he forgotten? Or did Katsuki kiss him knowing full well the situation. If so, *does that...does that mean…* And that's as far as Izuku would let himself hopelessly dream, before reeling him back in.

He doesn't want to think about Katsuki anymore, but it's easier said than done. He wants to be thinking of other things right then. Badminton, for example. Block matches will be starting soon. Or college. Filling out more paperwork, and buying things for Waseda. Or quite literally anything else.

Because if he begins to think about Katsuki, then he will also think about where Katsuki is right now, and where Izuku *isn't* . And the moment Izuku allows himself to think about National Qualifiers, he knows that he will lose his willpower. He had excuses, he told himself. Even if he had been dreaming of this for literally forever: seeing Katsuki at Nationals. Even before they became partners, Izuku's always wanted to see him there. In the past, the greenette hadn't been able to attend Youth Nationals either because it had been so far away. It was only in his freshman year that his mother was willing and available to drive all that way for him to watch. And so, it would've been like any other year if Izuku didn't come.

But he knew deep down that it wasn't. It wasn't the same. Because every other year, Katsuki wasn't so adamant that Izuku come make his appearance as he was now. Because every other year, Katsuki didn't pole vault onto his roof--just because the tree branch leading to his window had been cut off--just to kiss him right before a tournament. Because every other year, they weren't best friends.

But what could he do. What could Izuku fucking do. He's always been mesmerized by Katsuki's vaulting, and so he knows that if he stood there today, on that stadium in Nagoya, and sees Katsuki fly again, then he would fall in love all over again. He knows it'll be over for him, because from the very beginning, watching the blonde jump was the very thing that stole his breath away in the first place. And then to see it now at Nationals where Katsuki, in all his glory, was at his peak performance? There's no chance he'll be able to make it through alive.

Besides, it wasn't as if he could drive. His mother had to renew her business licenses on the other side of town later today, and she needed the car. It wasn't as if he could just take it if he wanted to. Sure, the woman had plenty of other friends whose cars she could borrow but he wasn't going to acknowledge that option existed. Either way, there would be a high chance that he'd die in a car accident if he tries to drive 4 hours straight without someone in the passenger seat correcting him, considering that he's never really been allowed the freedom to drive before recently. Not only that, but there were errands that his mother wanted him to do. Go grocery shopping. Pick up something from Kei's house. Bring some boxes from her home inventory up to the shop.

It wasn't as if him being there was going to make a big difference to Katsuki. Katsuki had so many people there already supporting him. All of the Ise High's pole vault team attended to support, but also, every year at the big tournaments, people from Ise High or just Ise in general occupied an entire section of the stadium just to support their main star. And so the blonde will already have plenty of support. Family, friends, strangers. Izuku would have gotten drowned out by the crowd anyways because of his height. It didn't matter, he told himself, even though every fiber of his body was itching to be there. Every single nerve in his skin was-

"Izuku?" A voice dragged him back into the moment, "Izuku, are you listening to me?"

It was like his brain was getting pulled back into his body, for his vision focused more. And it was like a pin dropped, and he was thrown back into the present again. The water bead on the glass was now part of the bigger picture, and Izuku realized that he had been blanking out into space this entire time while his mother was talking. They were sitting on the couch in the living room, and the movie Pretty In Pink was replaying on the TV in the background. The weather was fine in Ise today. Not cloudy. Not particularly bright and beautiful either, or maybe it was because he didn't find many things beautiful these days. The first thing he had done in the morning upon seeing the slightly out-of-the-ordinary sky was check the weather in Nagoya. Was it better than here? *Thank god,* he remembered thinking. Full sunny skies, 81 degrees. Katsuki will be fine.

The kettle had been boiling for a minute now, but he hadn't even noticed until now. Inko was looking at him with wide, waiting eyes, as she sits there for an answer after telling him a story about who knows what.

"Oh, I'm sorry," Izuku shakes his head, rubbing his temple with the back of his hand, "I completely zoned out. I'm really sorry."

Inko gave him a small comforting smile, before reaching over to squeeze his knee, "It's alright. It wasn't anything important. Let me go get the water off the stove. Do you want any tea? I bought a new one the other day, and it sounds interesting! Cherry black tea."

Izuku looked at her, muttering to himself, "...Cherry?"

Was he that obsessed? To the point where even the mention of cherries hurts him?

"Yes, doesn't it sound wonderful?" Inko got up from her seat, "Do you want a cup?"

Izuku slowly shook his head, sinking into the back of the couch, "I'm alright. Thank you."

Inko leaves for a moment, to head into the kitchen, pouring herself a cup of tea, before setting it back down on the coffee table in front of him and letting the bag steep in the hot water.

"I took a whiff of it while pouring, and my my, is it fragrant," Inko laughed.

Izuku nods slowly, "Ah, is it?" Even though his eyes were once again about to stare off.

“It is,” She nods profusely, “It’s very unique. You can smell it from here. Have you ever smelled anything like it before, ‘Zuku?”

The boy in question didn’t really want to reply, so he just mindlessly lets out a small, “I don’t know, Mom. I don’t know.”

At this, Inko frowned, before speaking, “‘Zuku. Could you please not act like this? You’re bringing down the house, baby. My ‘Zuku is always smiling, and I just can’t bear seeing you so out of char-”

The woman stopped when Izuku looked up into her eyes all of a sudden.

Izuku knows that there are a lot of times like this where his mother slips into an old habit or says some things that trigger a part of him that still is affected by the past, and he doesn’t expect any less. His mother has been like this for decades, and to expect her to completely drop her habits within a couple of months is unrealistic. That being said, it still hurts a bit when Izuku is hit again with statements like this. Because just as Inko was still learning to be less emotionally restrictive, Izuku was still trying to unlearn his immediate reaction of agreeing with her.

Even now, as Inko told him with her usual sweet tone that he was not being himself, and that he should be smiling, Izuku’s gut instinct was to nod along and put on a fake smile. But he refrained himself from doing so, and instead, just looked up at her.

Upon pausing, it was as if Inko Midoriya realized what she had said, and Izuku could see her physically shrink into herself.

And then after a moment, the woman gave him an apologetic smile, “I’m sorry. That was...insensitive of me, wasn’t it.”

Izuku just pursed his lips and told her genuinely, “It’s okay.” And doesn’t confirm or deny her insensitivity. She knows it was. He doesn’t need to tell her.

Sighing, Inko waits for the tea to cool down a little bit, which takes a couple of minutes, before the woman brings the cup up to her lips and takes a small sip. They both sit in silence for a bit.

“When is it his turn on the track?” Inko ask him, no need to specify who *he* is. It was obvious who was on Izuku’s mind.

Taking a small breath, Izuku tells her, “4 o’clock.”

"Everyone here will be watching it on TV," Inko laughs, knowing how heavy the atmosphere is, "He'll be the talk of the town for months."

Izuku smiled down at his lap, "He always is, isn't he."

"That's our Katsuki, isn't it," Inko speaks, not feeling any real anger against the blonde boy who she knew had his reasons, "Always the talk of town."

Izuku doesn't say anything.

Inko hummed, and then checks the time, “If you go now, then you can get to Nagoya with one hour to spare before it’s his turn to go up.”

Izuku doesn’t like when opportunity that he shouldn’t take is dangled in front of his face like this, tempting him, so he shakes his head, “You have to pick up the license later.”

“I can always have our neighbor take me. Jun is free today,” Inko countered.

Izuku laughs lightly, “You’ve been spending a lot of time with Jun recently, Mom. Are you sure all of those trips over to his house lately were to borrow a drill or the paprika?”

Inko flushed red at this, and playfully tapped Izuku on the arm, “‘Zuku! Me and Jun are just friends. He’s...he is-”

“A really nice man in his mid-40s who’s single and living alone, and likes to garden?” Izuku wagged his eyebrows. It was a recent development.

Once in a while, his mother would go over to their neighbor’s house, and just sit and talk for a little while. And when she’d come home, there’d be this soft youthful glow to her face that Izuku hadn’t seen in a while. With him, Inko always had a mature, loving look, but the one that she’d sport when coming back from Jun’s house was like a schoolgirl harboring a crush for the first time. Although Izuku knew that his mother was still, somewhat, in love with Hisashi, he still wanted so badly for her to get her *own* happy ending. And whether that happy ending is just the two of them--Izuku and Inko--living and being happy with one other, or if it someday along the road involves another person, Izuku didn’t mind.

“Izuku, you’re distracting from the point,” His mother pointed out, partially because she wanted to get back on topic and partially because she was getting flustered.

Izuku dropped his playful grin, and then looked down at his lap, “Mom, even then, you wouldn’t let me drive 4 hours by myself in the first place.”

Inko Midoriya frowned, “Izuku, you’re just making excuses. Why would I have said all of this if I wasn’t going to let you go?”

The doe-eyed boy acknowledged this already, and was hoping she wouldn’t actually say it out loud, but she had, and now, Izuku was forced to admit, “Mom, if I go, then I’ll never get over him,” He swallowed heavily, “If I go, and I see him jump with all the passion that made me enamored with him in the first place, then I’ll just fall in love all over again.”

Inko looked at him now with a sympathetic expression, but Izuku didn’t catch her eye.

Instead, the boy shrugged his shoulders with a small smile, “Besides, I don’t have tickets even if I wanted to.”

From a few feet away from him, Inko sighed and scooted forward, scooping Izuku’s hands up in her own, and rubbing her thumb over the back of his hand, making the boy look up at her.

“Okay,” She tells him with a nod, “Are you sure?”

Izuku nodded, “I’m sure, Mom. But I can’t sit around or I’ll keep thinking about it, so can I go run your errands for you?”

Seeing it’s a good idea, Inko nodded and resituated herself so that she can think more comfortable, “Hm, I need to pick up Mrs. Raki’s cake pans that she borrowed last week, so can you do that for me?”

The green eyed boy shook his head yes.

“After that, I have some small boxes that need to be dropped off at the post office, and they’re already addressed and labelled so you don’t need to worry about that. And then one more then, could you go to the corner grocery and get me eggs, potatoes, cream, and garlic? I’ll write it down so you don’t forget,” His mother listed off, and Izuku took mental note.

“Yeah, I’m on it,” Izuku made himself get up off of the couch and stretch his arms for a moment. He was allowed to take the car to run the errands, since nothing was particularly far away and it was about time he had a little more practice driving by himself.

The first two tasks took a total of an hour, and the only reason it took that long was because Mrs. Raki talked his ear off for thirty minutes upon arrival. Don’t get him wrong. Izuku enjoyed talking to people, and in fact, doing so would probably distract him. The problem was that Mrs. Raki was avidly religious, and upon seeing the young man, went on a tirade warning him about staying away from the devil. There were a lot of these types of people in Ise. The religious fanatics, whether it's christianity or buddhism or what not. Which was fine. People should be free to worship who they want, but Izuku must admit, Mrs. Raki sometimes scared him.

“These days, you teens have lost the way of God,” Mrs. Raki held his hand with concern in your eyes, “Drinking. Doing drugs. Skipping Sunday service. And having premarital intercourse. Izuku, tell me dear, have you had premarital sex?”

Izuku blinked several times, sputtering at the overly personal question. He knew that if he told the truth and said yes, Mrs. Raki would likely go into another crying tirade and begin prayers for him, and convince him to go to confessions to ask for forgiveness.

And so, saving his skin, Izuku shook his head, “No.”

A look of relief washed over the woman’s face, “Oh thank God, Izuku. I always knew you were a good boy. Inko raised you well,” She pinched his cheeks.

After the fiasco of that whole interaction, Izuku drove to the grocery store, feeling a tad bit guilty that he lied but also relieved that the conversation was over. There was no way in hell that Izuku was going to admit that he had ravenous, delicious sex with Bakugo Katsuki. Keyword: *had*. Izuku felt bad for Mrs. Raki’s children. If he thought his situation with Inko was bad, then her children had it much worse. His mind amuses this thought all the way up until he pulls into the corner grocery, a red-brick building with flowers lining the entryway,

and electronic sliding doors leading into the largest grocery store in Ise, which wasn't even that large to begin with.

As Izuku scanned the isles, looking down occasionally at the list of food he was supposed to get, Izuku tries not to think about the countless times he and Katsuki messed around in this grocery store trying to get food in order to make some concoction in their kitchen. Or 9PM trips here to grab ramen and snacks for late night movie marathons. He shakes his head to push the thought away, before grabbing the cream and setting it on top of the eggs that he gathered up in his arms.

"Garlic...garlic, garlic," Izuku's eyes scanned the produce section, muttering to himself the ingredient that he needed.

He was so deep into his search, that when Izuku hears his name being called out, the boy jumped a little in place and nearly dropped all of his ingredients.

"Young Midoriya?" The familiar voice of Mr. Toshinori shocked him, and Izuku turned to see the teacher pushing a cart full of groceries approaching him. It was strange to see the teacher out of class and dressed in a t-shirt and jeans, rather than the white button up and slacks combo that all male teachers at Ise High had to sport. Izuku hadn't really seen anyone since summer break started, so Mr. Toshinori would mark the first.

"A-Ah, Mr. Toshinori," Izuku laughed, "You scared me."

"Oh my apologies," He waved his arms, "I didn't mean to scare you," He laughed.

"It's no worries," Izuku smiled, "How's your summer been?"

"It hasn't really been much of a summer yet," Mr. Toshinori replied, "I'm already planning the syllabus for my next course."

"That's pretty early," Izuku notices.

"It is," The teacher nods, "But when duty calls."

"You work too hard," Izuku has to admit with a grateful smile.

"They used to call me All Might back in the day you know, after that one super hero," Mr. Toshinori laughs, "Because I always took on all the jobs in the faculty board that no one wanted, and then everyone in the office started to say 'It's fine now! Why? Because *he* is here' everytime I walked into work."

Izuku smiles but doubts him, "Are you *sure* it isn't because you used to have an uncanny resemblance to All Might?"

"Ah, that might have been the case as well," Mr. Toshinori shyly admits.

"Oh, it definitely was," Izuku laughs. He's reminded all over again of how much he truly enjoys having him as a teacher, and was sure going to miss him when he goes off to Waseda.

"And how about you? How was your summer been?" Mr. Toshinori follows up with him.

Izuku smiled while looking down, "It only started a couple of days ago, but I guess it's been okay."

It really hasn't, but whose fault was that.

"Are you holding up okay?" Mr. Toshinori asks.

"Hm?" Izuku looked up at him, eyes wide in confusion, "What do you mean?"

"With the whole…" The teacher waved an arm around, trying to get around saying it straight up, before clearing his throat, "With what you talked about in the final paper."

Oh. That. Izuku suddenly felt small, as he remembered that his teacher knew of mostly everything that happened between him and Katsuki. Not all of it, for Izuku respected the athlete's privacy enough to leave out personal details concerning Katsuki. But still, he had forgotten entirely that the secret of his affection wasn't his own anymore.

"Oh that?" Izuku pursed his lips and shook his head, "I'll be okay. Thank you for asking."

"Beautiful paper, I must say," Mr. Toshinori nods profusely, "I'm very proud of you. I'm assuming you've checked your grades and comments for it?"

Izuku shook his head no, "Um, actually, not yet," He looked apologetic, "I've been caught up on some things. I'll check them out later though!"

"No, no, do it when you have time!" The teacher shook his head, "Anyways, I was very proud of how much effort everyone put into that paper. Everyone took it very seriously."

"I'm glad! We did spend a lot of time on it, after all," Izuku reaffirms, shrugging the groceries better in his arms so that they don't fall off.

Mr. Toshinori nods at this, before looking off to the side, and for a moment he was quiet, before revealing, "Although. I must say that Bakugo cursed a lot in his paper, which I would normally count off points for but…"

Izuku bit the inside of his cheek. Katsuki cursed in his final paper that was a good hefty chunk of their grade? *Was he crazy?* Izuku was curious, for sure.

"But?" Izuku asked.

Mr. Toshinori laughed, "But I didn't, because despite the language, it was such a well written paper that I chose to overlook it."

Izuku's brows raised, "Was it?"

The teacher nodded, "Very much so. The formatting and subject material was very interesting, and if you ever get the opportunity, I'd say you should ask young Bakugo if you take a read."

“A-ah, I’m not sure about that,” Izuku shook his head, finding that a bit too personal.

Mr. Toshinori ignored him unintentionally, “If I were to make a critique though, his paper was wonderful, but I couldn’t quite decipher the first line.”

Izuku opened his mouth to speak, but the teacher continued.

“I didn’t really see what it had to do with anything, but it was curious nevertheless,” Mr. Toshinori looked up in thought, “I suppose it wouldn’t hurt if I told you just the first line. See if it interests you any.”

Izuku cocked his head to the side, “The first line of his...paper?"

“Yes,” The blonde teacher affirmed, “Ah, what did it say?” He thinks. And thinks.

Izuku stands there, holding his eggs and cream, waiting. But ultimately, his former psychology teacher pulls out his phone and rummages around for a bit.

“Here...let me…” The man pulls up the PDF file while squinting at the screen, “...pull it up, really quick.”

The doe-eyed boy spots the garlic, an aisle over in the produce section, and keeps a mental note of it in his mind so that he can go grab it after this conversation. After a moment, Mr. Toshinori seems to have finally gotten it pulled up.

“Here. Just the first sentence,” Mr. Toshinori turned his phone screen to Izuku, who turns his head back and looks at the screen. He holds his groceries tighter, and takes a step forward to read.

*People say beauty is inside. Beauty is grace. Beauty is kindness. I say all of that is bullshit. Beauty ain’t nothing but a pair of green eyes and a stupid grin sitting out the sunroof going down a dirt road.*

What?

Izuku took a moment to read it all over again, before blanking and asking himself *what* ? Beauty ain’t nothing but a pair of green eyes. Whose? His? But Katsuki’s always called them-

*What* ? It wasn’t as if many people had green eyes, but Izuku was finding it hard to comprehend how this could possibly be about him. Beauty ain’t nothing but a pair of green eyes. He repeats it internally, hoping that it might make sense. Katsuki couldn’t possibly be talking about him, not after all that he’s said before about his eyes.

But this paper. The paper was supposed to be about *them* . And the next part. A stupid grin sitting out the sunroof going down a dirt road. Izuku didn’t even need to think too hard to remember. He still remembers every part of that memory as if it was yesterday. Them, on their way to Dolly in order to catch that drive-in movie. Katsuki stopping in the middle of the

road to give him that dramatic speech. Izuku finding the nerve to climb up onto the sunroof while the blonde drives down that dirt road, arms spread wide and laughing like a maniac. How could he forget. One of the first moments that he lost himself to the pleasures of freedom.

Katsuki was talking about him. Katsuki was talking about *him* , but why? Izuku was so confused, and all of these thoughts swarmed his head like gnats. To have heard all of this time that his green eyes were creepy or undesirable, just to now read that to Katsuki, he was beautiful, was confusing. He couldn't wrap his head around it, even though all of the signs pointed to the fact that it was true. He repeated the line over and over again in his head, until its essence was embedded into his brain. Beauty ain't nothing but a pair of green eyes. Green eyes. *His* green eyes.

Izuku felt his chest constrict, and his hands begin to shake. He was *so, so* confused, because why would Katsuki say that? What is the point? Why did Katsuki mention that in his final analysis paper? That his eyes were beautiful. That he thought Izuku was beautiful? Why now? Just as Izuku was intending to get over him. It was one of the very few things that Izuku so desperately wanted to hear from the blonde, and there it was, written on paper. Yet it didn't feel real. It couldn't be real. Not after all this time.

Mr. Toshinori then put away his phone, and went back to conversing normally, not noticing the way Izuku stood frozen with groceries bundled up in his arms and a look of shocked confusion etched on his face. Everything felt a little muddled in his head, as he attempts to straighten up every thought that was slipping through his head. Katsuki, Katsuki, Katsuki. Why did he say that? Why must he say that and get Izuku's hopes up over and over again?

Mr. Toshinori spoke, but Izuku was only half paying attention. It was as if all sound was muffled against his own loud thinking.

"Anyways," Mr. Toshinori derailed the conversation, "Speaking of young Bakugo, I truly was looking forward to attending his tournament today, but alas, my old mentor from out of town is coming by to visit. Back in the old days, we used to call him Gran Torino. Say, you might have even heard of him! In the 60s, he was a pretty well known track star. Super fast to this day, I'd say."

Izuku's eyes were glazed over, as his thoughts wandered off elsewhere. Still not able to fully take in the fact that Katsuki finds his eyes beautiful. Or was it even a fact. Could it have been real? What he had read? All of this time. His chest restricts and it feels like his lungs are about to explode, and the only air that could satisfy him was the one that Katsuki breathed.

"Back to the point," Mr. Toshinori reigned himself in, "Bakugo didn't seem too bothered when I told him I couldn't make it, so I asked him if he was nervous about the whole tournament when he came to turn in the paper," Mr. Toshinori recalled, "The boy then told me he'll be fine as long as his good luck charm is there. I sure hope he didn't forget it at home today," The man laughs.

But Izuku didn't find it funny at all. Not in the slightest.

As long as his good luck charm was there. Izuku remembers the conversation well. It was brief, barely lasted a minute, but he remembered it nevertheless.

*"Just be there and cheer me on,"* Katsuki had told him, *"And drag all of your goons too. I want a huge crowd, a giant banner saying I'm the fucking best, and a whole band."*

Izuku remembered shaking his head and laughing *, "Okay, now you're being greedy."*

Katsuki's left side of his lip quirked up *, "Just the first thing is fine too."*

Izuku had then rested his cheek on his hand as he looked over to Katsuki *, "Why does it sound like I'm a good luck charm?"*

And Izuku felt the urge to laugh now as he remembered Katsuki's response, *"It's your shitty aura. It scares all the competition away."*

*Fuck.*

He was the good luck charm. Even if he didn't consider himself very lucky, Katsuki at least considered him it. Before the sweatband. Before anything else. It was him, even if it was just his presence as a friend, an enemy, or however, it had always been him watching Katsuki as he won his tournaments throughout the years. Panicking, Izuku knew that it was too late to stop himself, for his body was already thinking ten steps ahead of his brain. Mr. Toshinori might have said something, but Izuku didn't hear it. He could only hear the blood rushing through his brain, and the tingling nervousness in his hands. As long as his good luck charm is there, he'll be okay. Katsuki never believed in something like luck, always wanting to claim victory for himself without attributing it to something like fate. There was only ever one thing that Katsuki ever closely remoted admitted to being his good luck charm, and that was him.

Izuku drops the eggs and cream. The carton of cream rolls off to the side, and the eggs crack inside of the cardboard casing upon impact. A splatter of yolk seeps through the edges, and Izuku backs away. If this was him normally, he'd apologize a million times and clean it all up. And even now, he recognizes that it's what he *should* do, but he can't.

Instead, Izuku turns away, hands empty of any grocery and any sense of self-preservation, and he runs. Izuku runs out of the corner grocery, leaving behind a confused and shocked Mr. Toshinori, leaving behind the tasks he was supposed to do today, and he hops inside of the car, turning the engine on before he has the opportunity to change his mind.

Izuku looks at the clock inside of the vehicle. It was 1PM. It took 4 hours to drive to Nagoya. Katsuki's event begins at 4PM. Unless he broke a couple of traffic laws and went at 100+ MPH, he wasn't going to make it on time. His chest was heaving as tears of frustration threatened to spill from his eyes, but Izuku knew he had to try. Putting the vehicle in reverse, Izuku takes the car out of the parking lot and onto the main road, placing the name of stadium into his GPS. He was moving so fast that he barely had time to think about what he was doing.

He was going to see Katsuki jump. And when he does, he knows he'll fall in love all over again. He knows that it'll be so much harder to get over the blonde. But he owes Katsuki this. He had promised. Just like Katsuki said. He had promised, so he must keep it. Stupid, how stupid could he be, to think that he could avoid this. When it means so much to Katsuki? When it means so much to him? How much of a fool he was to think he could escape the promise. What kind of friend was he.

Izuku doesn't realize that he has small streams of tears running down his cheek until he feels the droplets getting cold on his chin, and so he brings a hand up to wipe them away so that his vision doesn't get blurry while he drives. Izuku takes a deep breath, following the directions towards the highway where he can then drive a straight shot to the big city.

Running a hand through his messy hair, Izuku sighs deeply and then turns on the radio, switching it over to the 80s pop channel. He doesn't have a plan. He doesn't have tickets. He has no way of getting into the stadium. And yet, he'll figure it out when he gets there. *Spontaneous* , right? Katsuki was the person who taught him the value of spontaneity, so Izuku considers this while following the blonde's example.

The Winner Takes It All, by ABBA begins to play on the radio after the small ad break ends, and Izuku smiles through his light tears. ABBA was one of the greatest artists of the 80s, and was the name behind Dancing Queen and Mamma Mia; however, Izuku's favorite song by them will forever be The Winner Takes It All.

And so, as the music plays, Izuku whips through the streets of Ise until he can see the city limits. There was no going back, Izuku understood, before he left Ise. The entire ride, he was sitting rigidly, straight into his seat, feeling like time was passing too slow. The bright afternoon sun was threatening to make his head hurt, and the monotonous road ahead of him looked like it goes on for forever. And he's afraid that he'll never make it. That it'll be too late by the time he comes. Izuku does not necessarily have a sense of self-importance. That being said, if there is *any* chance, *any* chance at all, that his absence could be the reason why Katsuki doesn't do his best, then Izuku would never forgive himself.

And so, Midoriya Izuku steps on the gas, not seeing any cops around, and drives even faster than he was before. He was going to make it there, even if it is by the skin of his teeth. Izuku's eyes looked at the clock about every four minutes on that drive there, as if time would go faster if he convinced himself it did. 4 o'clock approaches faster and faster, and Izuku feels more anxious the further along time passes.

Stupid. Stupid. Stupid. Only idiots speed down the highway at 100 MPH when the speed limit was 70MPH, regardless of whether there were other cars on the road or not. If a deer crossed the road, he'd be done for. Everytime he'd see a car, he'd slam on the break and slow down just enough to look normal, before speeding up again right after it passes. Izuku knew what Katsuki would have said right now if he were in the passenger seat. The blonde would be berating him, and pretending to have a heart attack over Izuku's driving, and the thought of that makes Izuku laugh sadly. Of course, he forgets that if Katsuki were here, it doesn't solve the issue they have of Izuku being madly in love with the other unrequitedly.

Or was it even that? From an outsider's perspective, Izuku wonders what the situation looks

like, he truly does. Because he cannot personally disconnect himself from his biased perception of their relationship, and what it looks like to *him* . To Izuku, here was a boy who has time and time again treated him like the greatest friend and greatest lover, just to tell him every time that he will never do so. And who was Izuku to tell him that he's wrong? Here was a boy who has time and time again insulted the appearance of his eyes, directing Izuku not to look at him numerous times, just to come out in a paper that Izuku's eyes were the very definition of beauty to him. How could anyone blame him for being confused, for wanting answers, but being afraid of what those very answers entailed.

But, regardless of Izuku's confusion on their friendship and relationship, one thing was clear on Katsuki's end, and it was that Izuku made a promise to show up to National Qualifiers. Izuku promised this, and despite that, when he woke up this morning, he still made excuses not to go because of his own feelings. He hadn't considered that Katsuki, who has told him before that he considers Izuku one of his closest friends, might need him there. Not that Izuku felt that much self-importance, but if what Mr. Toshinori said was true, then Izuku should be there, up in those stands, cheering him on just one more time. After that, he can do whatever.

But for now, there was somewhere he needed to be, and Izuku currently has thirty minutes until Katsuki's event starts.

The problem was, it was an hour until he would get to Nagoya.

It feels like a scene from a movie. It truly does. It felt as if someone copied the script from a cheesy hallmark movie, and pasted it into Izuku's fate, because for what other reason would the greenette find himself slamming on the gas to get to Katsuki's tournament? He doesn't even know what he'll do when he gets there. Katsuki was likely going to win, as he usually does, and then the blonde will get crowded by the masses of people there to congratulate him. And Izuku was then just going to drive back home.

Even then, he should at least be there. If for nothing else, but to keep one final promise.

Izuku goes through a whole playlist of songs that jolted memories into his heart, and he's tempted to turn the radio off or at least switch to a different channel, but his hands were instead glued to the steering wheel, clutching it so tight that it felt like it could break off with just a bit more force. If a cop were to pull him over, it wouldn't be Mr. Hadashi, the local sheriff in Ise, who probably would just let him get away with a small berating and a high five. It would be someone who would easily ticket him heavily and get him into massive trouble. But with the spirit of Bakugo Katsuki in his mind, Izuku pushes away the need to care a ll the way up until he gets within the city limits of Nagoya.

He can see the skyline in the distance. At this point, if he does speed, then he wouldn't just risk harming himself, but other people, considering that he was approaching a more densely populated area.

The last time he was here, he at least had his mother. Inko, to be fair, didn't go out very much, and only occasionally went to bigger cities for special clients or what not, but even then, she knew more than him about the city. But now, approaching the city, Izuku felt a slight bit of panic. He wasn't used to this. He rarely travelled with anyone, much less by himself. Midoriya Izuku was a small boy from Ise, a coastal city stuck in the olden days, and

he had small town ways and a small town charm. Suddenly being in a city as big as Nagoya trying to navigate the hecticness was overwhelming, and for a moment there, Izuku felt himself redact into his seat, and begin to revert back to the old Izuku.

The Izuku from months ago, before Katsuki came in and shoved independence down his throat, before Izuku learned what it meant to explore and be free and to live truly for himself. Izuku felt himself shrivelling up into the boy who was scared of doing anything without someone to hold his hand, to give him permission, to take the safe route that he knew well rather than take a chance with the riskier more spontaneous decision.

As he enters within the city, and sees buildings as tall as mountains, and more people than the entire county that Ise was in times four, Izuku looks around and feels a small sense of anxiety seep into his chest, and his breathing becomes a little bit more labored. His hands are gripping the wheel even tighter, and Izuku jumps in his seat when the car behind him honks at him to move forward.

“Sorry!” Izuku panics and squeaks out, before pressing the gas a little too hard and lurching the car forward, almost hitting the back of the vehicle in front of him.

Seeing the disaster of how this is going, Izuku bites the inside of his cheek tightly and takes a deep breath. He takes a deep, deep breath, and thinks to himself. Yes, growth is not instant. Growth is not a straight forward path. Yes, he is allowed to take five steps forward, and three steps back, and what matters most is that he was able to take five steps forwards in the first place. Yes, usually, all of that is true.

However, not now. He cannot allow himself to go backwards right now. Not when it matters the most. Not when he came all of this way, broke all of his rules, and got this far. Because this is *exactly* what Katsuki had tried to teach him all of this time. That he *can* do things by himself. That he *will* be okay. That he *is* in control of whether or not he gets to where he wants to be.

Without Inko, yes. But also, without Katsuki. And now was the best time to prove to himself that he can hold his own.

Relaxing himself a little, Izuku scooted forward in the line. There was traffic all over the city center of Nagoya.

Looking down at his phone, the red lines marking heavy traffic was coming from all directions that surrounded the stadium. Izuku’s guess was that people are leaving once their event is over, and others were coming right before their team started. Considering that National Qualifiers was a long, long event, it made sense that some teams didn’t want to stay the entire time leading up to their event or following the end of their event. Not to mention, people who lived in the area and were coming out of work at rush hour were trying to get home as well, which made the streets all the more busy.

Midoriya Izuku looked down at the clock, and felt his heart clench over the fact that it was 4:00PM. It was 4:00PM, which meant that Ise High’s representatives will be up right about now. He looked forward. He can’t even see the stadium from here, because it was about 10 more blocks forward, and then 9 blocks to the left, before taking a right. He was *far* . And at

the rate that traffic is going, it would be another hour before he would get close to the stadium. On a free day with no traffic, the distance would take less than 5 minutes to drive to. This was ridiculous, and Izuku could see officers directing traffic up ahead, and closing certain lanes that people were trying to crowd into.  Izuku out of panic accidentally slammed his horns, which caused the car in front of him to slam it back.

Feeling that rise of panic in his chest again, Izuku looks around frantically at the unmoving traffic and then at the unwavering red lines in his phone GPS. There was no way in hell. No way that he was going to make it. Izuku rolls the windows down, and sticks his head out of the window. Although it was a distance away, he could hear it. He could hear the faint sound of screaming amidst all of the city noises, and unrecognizable speaking on what was likely huge megaphones that blasted commentary over the tournament. And even more faintly, he could hear some music playing from speakers, but he couldn't make out what song it was. It was so far. Too far, and Izuku looked around once more, as if anything in his car would make the traffic move faster. From outside of his car window, he hears the announcement go on again, saying words he couldn't pinpoint. It could have been Katsuki's name. It might not have been. All he knew was that he was too far, and he had not sped like a maniac from Ise to Nagoya just to miss this. And he did not promise Katsuki that he would come, just to not show up.

"Fuck this shit," Izuku uncharacteristially lets out, out of determination and anxiety, before turning the car, cutting it completely out of the road and into the adjacent parking lot of the building parallel to the street.

The car behind him immediately took advantage of the extra room and moved forward the very moment Izuku cut out of the lane and into the parking lot, and he whipped the car right into an empty parking space, not caring to see if it had a metered ticket in front of it or not, and grabs only his phone and the car keys, before Izuku locks the car behind him and begins to *run* .

Running wasn't his sport. Izuku wasn't a cardio person. He was a weights person, and at the gym, he lifted and squatted heavy weights, which is what blessed him with the thick legs he has today. But running? Cardio? That was not his activity of choice, not like Katsuki. Even in badminton, the only running required was in a 13m by 6m court.

That being said, Izuku ran like his life depended on it. 10 blocks forward. He counted each one. Jumping over mediums, potted plants, pedestrian crosses, weaving through people, he was barely careful as to what was in his way. He ran with every ounce of energy in his body. His lungs wanted a break, but he refused to give it one. The only pause Izuku had was to look down at his phone ever so briefly in order to see when to turn, only to run again.

Izuku knew he looked like an idiot. The sound of flip flops clapping against the city concrete and asphalt was loud and obnoxious, and his loose t-shirt wasn't meant for compact running. The amount of times he had to exasperatedly call out 'excuse me' or 'sorry!" as he passed groups of people or ran around barking dogs was adding up, but he could see it.

He could see it, and Izuku wanted to cry upon seeing the huge stadium. For four years, Katsuki's dreams were to attend the real *adult* National tournament at this very stadium, and

to think that Izuku thought about missing it. What was wrong with him? Izuku let out a verbal cry upon seeing the stadium, and running towards it. He was *so* close.

So close that he could smell the concessions from inside. He was so close that he could hear the announcer commentate, but his ears were so full of his own loud heartbeat that he didn't pay attention. As he ran across the pedestrian walk and onto the huge outdoor front area where people usually waited to get checked in, or scanned, or have their tickets looked at, he weaved through people just standing around.

Up ahead, only a couple of people were checking in at this time, having a worker scan their tickets before going through the security metal detector. Izuku as he approached the line, felt that sense of impatient panic rise again, for he didn't know what to do now. He didn't have tickets. He didn't have any tickets whatsoever, and if he even *thinks* about running past the ticket lady, then there was no way he was going to get past the security guards with *guns* in their holsters standing in front of the metal detectors. He has to find a way in. He has to find a way i-

"Excuse me sir?" A voice cut out his thoughts, and Izuku looked over to the woman wearing a staff shirt that had her scanner out to take his tickets, "May I see your ticket please?"

Izuku just stared at her, mouth dry from running all of his way, chest still heaving, and in need of water, as his crackly throat asks, "...Tickets?"

She gave him a deadpan look and sighed, before repeating herself, "Your ticket, sir? I can't let you in without scanning your ticket."

"Oh…" Izuku looked down, his lungs still trying to get air in so his breathing was labored, but he was saddened and at a loss of what to do now. He should get out of line. There was someone behind him, and Izuku felt like he was about to cry, when like it was fate, a familiar voice called out his name.

"Midoriya?" Kaito Sen calls from inside of the stadium gates.

Izuku's head perked up, and made eye contact with the brunette. He hadn't talked to the other since the whole fiasco between them, and it looks like Kaito Sen was surprised to see Izuku *outside* of the gate, rather than within it. The brunette was wearing an Ise High varsity jacket and had his hair styled up really nice, and upon seeing Izuku, the athlete walked up towards the gate on the other side.

Izuku's eyes were watery, and he opened his lips to speak, but didn't know what to say.

"Midoriya?" Kaito called out again once he got closer.

The woman in charge of ticketing looks back and forth between Izuku and Kaito before craning her neck in and asking the brunette, "You know him, sir?"

Kaito, upon seeing Izuku's glassy eyes and lost expression, wasn't stupid and could take a hint on what's going on, and in turn, the boy cleared his throat and nodded to the ticketer, "Yeah. This is one of my buds. He came in with our crew from Ise High, remember? I asked

him to go get my camera for me from my car." And then looked towards Izuku, "Did you find it?"

Izuku, looking down at his hands, knowing he was supposed to lie. Reeling himself in from his panic, Izuku then shakily replied, "No…"

"So you already scanned in," The woman asked to confirm.

Izuku looked up at her, and Kaito stepped in to answer for him, "He already did. The line's getting long, can you just let him through, ma'am?"

With a huff and a wave of her arm, the ticketing woman waved Izuku through to the security checkpoint, muttering, "Should've just said that coming in."

Izuku moves forward, and puts his keys and phone in the little basket before stepping through the detectors. The boy lets out a deep breath upon coming in, and looked up at Kaito Sen, who stands there giving Izuku a conflicted gaze.

"Thank you," Izuku tells him genuinely, pursing his lips together afterwards.

Taking a breath, Kaito looked up towards the metal backs of the stadium seats and admitted, "You always looked prettier inside of the track stadium where I could see you, than outside of it."

Izuku's cheeks heated up, and he looked down at his feet again, and was about to open his mouth to say something when the brunette beat him to it.

"Just consider this me trying to make up for being a bit of a dick," Kaito said.

Izuku shook his head, "No, Kaito, it's okay. You don't have to do th-"

"Not just to you," Kaito interrupts him, which makes Izuku look up with wide eyes, "To Cap."

Izuku was speechless. The last thing he expected was for this man, who he has never heard say a kind word to Katsuki in his life, feel apologetic.

"I'm one of the reasons why Cap thinks he can't love you," Kaito kicks at the concrete underneath his feet, "Hopefully, me helping you get in here might give him an opportunity to prove to you that he can."

Izuku sputters, and looks away for a second, not understanding where the sudden change of heart came from, "I-I don't understand why you're suddenly-"

"Why I'm suddenly all for the little thing you and Cap got going on?" Kaito laughs to himself, "Hell if I know. Maybe I realized I'm miserable so I've been making others miserable. I don't even know."

It seems, just from Kaito's words, that there was some internal strife that the brunette has been struggling with as of recent, and the boy was trying to deal with it in some way, shape,

or form. Although Kaito didn't explicitly express it, Izuku could still tell. There was something that's been on the boy's mind.

"Anyways," Kaito Sen stretched his arms and then looked towards the stairs that led outside to the stadium seats, "You better get up there. He's on his last attempt."

Hearing this, Izuku's eyes widened as his panicked voice asks, "His...last attempt?"

At pole vault tournaments, each vaulter has three attempts to clear a bar. Three. Don't clear it within three attempts, and you're out. Your highest bar will be recorded. Katsuki, in all of his tournament history, has only had to use one attempt to clear any bar. And so, to hear that the blonde, was currently up, and used a second attempt and failed, pushed all of the adrenaline back into Izuku once more. He stares at Kaito, waiting for an explanation.

"Yup," Kaito looked down at his watch, "Toro Ito already jumped. The dude who cleared 18'2? He cleared it again in one attempt, and maxed out there. Couldn't get 18'3. Cap cleared 18'2 on his third attempt, so they're tied. Right now, Cap is attempting 18'3. And so-"

"And so in order to have the best chance of winning, Kacchan has to clear 18'3," Izuku rushed his words, understanding what this meant.

"Exactly. Because if he doesn't make 18'3, then both Toro Ito and Bakugo's highest jumps would be 18'2. And the person who took the least amount of attempts to get that height is the winner. And Toro Ito cleared 18'2 on his first attempt, while Baku-" Kaito was explaining.

But Izuku was already gone, calling back, "I know the rules, Kaito. Where is our section!"

Kaito shut himself up and yelled back, "Section 2C!"

Of course Izuku knew the rules. He knew them by heart since he was 11 years old and saw Katsuki jump for the first time. Which made the stakes feel all the more scary. 3 attempts. At each height. And if Katsuki didn't clear 18'3, then that means he tied with Toro Ito at 18'2. And if that was the case, then it was all over. Toro Ito took 1 attempt. Katsuki made 18'2 on his third one. Toro Ito would be the crowned winner.

And from the looks of it now, with Katsuki being on his third attempt for the 18'3 bar, Toro Ito probably thought he was going to win. Izuku felt a churning feeling in his gut at how this tournament was turning out.

He knew that he personally did not care if Katsuki jumped 18'5 or if he jumped 13'2. But he knew that it mattered a lot to the blonde, who saw vault as a big important part of his life. Who has never lost before, and refused to ever lose. Izuku ran his way up the stairs, seeing the light of the outside world fill his eyes as he rose above the stairs, and sees the stadium in all of its glory.

The track field was huge, but the pole vault arena was situated on the left side of the red track. Tents were once again, lined up alongside the track on the outskirts and people were hustling in and out everywhere. A camera crew was set up in multiple places.

Large speakers was situated on the far right side of the stadium, and was currently not playing anything. While an athlete jumps, no music plays. The speakers are only there for intermissions, breaks, and any moments in between jumps, for better focus. There was a hefty crowd. Izuku estimates a little over 4000. People everywhere, representing different colors and different teams.

This was an entirely different crowd than the ones at regular tournaments. Alongside high schoolers who were talented enough to qualify for Nationals, there were actual adults participating in the sport too. There was chattering everywhere, and Izuku looked around until he saw section 2C, which was right up in front not too far from where the vaulters jumped. It was at the lowest level, which means the closest to the track field, but still about 15 or so feet off of the ground from the field so that crazy fans can't just jump the railing and attack their favorite athletes.

Izuku descended the metals stairs then, weaving past the people in the walkway, until he could spot some familiar heads of people from Ise. Some, but not all, of his friends were there. Most of the pole vault team showed up, donning their varsity jackets. Down at the Ise High tent, Izuku figures that only the coach and Katsuki's parents were allowed in there. Everyone else was up here in the stands.

But any thoughts or details of anything else slipped his mind the moment Izuku spotted Katsuki.

Katsuki, who was down there at the staring point on the track field, staring at the bar set up to 18'3. Izuku knows that he saw the blonde just yesterday at his window, but seeing Katsuki never ceases to awe him. Especially when the athlete was on a track field, doing the sport that he loved. Today, Katsuki sported his tournament attire: a white and blue skin tight under armour tank top, and a pair of tight athletic pants for minimal air resistance. Vault shoes were donned on his feet, and-

*Oh* , Izuku felt his heart melt all over again and along with it, bittersweet pain, when he sees the sweatband inverted out of habit on his wrists.

Izuku hears his name called out a couple of times by his friends as he walks down.

"Midoriya!" Mina waved from her seat, "Where were you? You're usually the first person at these tournaments." She laughs.

Getting taken out of his thoughts, Izuku gave her a shy look, "I got stuck in traffic," He whitelied.

"It's no problem," Denki urged him over to an empty spot, but Izuku stays put standing, "You're here at the juicy part."

"Will the great Bakugo Katsuki make it," A random kid from Ise High asks dramatically.

From the side, an adult voice intruded the conversation, "Of course he will! He's our boy!"

Denki turned towards the adult voice, “Mr. Hidashi!? You’re here? Aren’t you on duty today?”

The cop rubs the back of his neck and looks away, “Eh, I got Mrs. Koka to fill in for me today. I took a vacation day.”

Izuku smiled a little bit at the interaction, seeing how it looked like everyone from Ise was excited and came all the way here to watch. He should have been with them in the beginning.

“Deku-kun?” Ochaco stood up from where she was sitting with some of her friends and walked towards him, “You’re here? I thought you said you weren’t going to be-” She got cut off. Izuku was still standing in the walkway, not yet finding a seat in the section.

The announcer’s voice filled the stadium once more, “This year, we have a lot of talented high schoolers entering Nationals. In fact, this year will be number #1 on the Ise High pole vault team, Bakugo Katsuki’s, debut into the adult sector of Nationals. Already, he’s doing a tremendous job, beating out all the adults within his competition bracket already. Tell me, Eichi, you’ve been doing this for over two decades now. Have you ever seen youth as talented as the ones coming in this year?”

The second announcer, named Eichi who Izuku’s known to be one of the rather famous track and field sports commentators, speaks up with a gruff laugh, “No, Misuo, I must say I have not. The vault community have been keeping an eye on those two boys--Bakugo and Toro--for years now, and now is the day we get to see them shine. And as expected, they are doing *phenomenal* for their debut stage.”

Misuo, the first announcer comes in again, this time clearing his throat, “With Bakugo Katsuki’s third attempt at 18’3 coming up right now, this final jump will be the decider between first and second place in his division today. If he misses, then Toro Ito takes the win with his single attempt clear at 18’2.”

“Yes, the stakes are high, and even the crowd is tense!” Eichi speaks into the microphone, “With that, Bakugo Katsuki. Ise High. Participant #59. Be in your position.”

Everyone sits down, but Izuku couldn’t bring his legs to move, and so he stands there staring down at the arena. Two huge screens were projecting Katsuki so that the audience further back could see. The greenette watches as Katsuki stables his feet and takes two steps forward, where the 40 meter mark was, and stands in position. Izuku’s heart raced and he was afraid it might jump out of his chest as he watched the blonde prepare himself for the last and final attempt.

“Your third attempt will begin in exactly *two* minutes. Starting, now,” The formal announcement came on, and from a large screen, the two minute timer was counting down. Each second that passed, Izuku felt more and more nervous. If Katsuki didn’t jump before the two minutes is up, then that was an automatic failed attempt. And so, knowing the patterns of Katsuki’s jumps, Izuku knew that the blonde usually started his run with about 1 minute and 15 seconds left on the clock. And so, as the timer counted down.

1 minute 32 seconds. 1 minutes 28 seconds. 1 minute 23 seconds. 1 minutes 15 seconds.

Katsuki should be prepping himself to run right about now.

1 minute 14 seconds. Now! Izuku thought, holding his chest. Now! 1 minute 13 seconds. Izuku's eyes moved between the real Katsuki, both screens, back and forth as he waited in anticipation. Katsuki is supposed to run about now.

But as Izuku watched on, and more seconds passed, Katsuki didn't move an inch. He didn't budge in the slightest. The blonde was staring parallel to the ground, as if he was about to begin running, but his legs were moving. Izuku's chest constricts as he looks around in panic. The whole crowd was silent, as they wait for the deciding moment. The clock ticks down to 1 minute and 4 seconds and Izuku knew there was something wrong. He's watched this boy for long enough to know that Katsuki would not change such a fundamental part of his vault routine days before a huge tournament. And yet, the athlete wasn't moving.

In fact, the only thing that was moving was...Izuku noticed then...his fingers.

Katsuki's fingers were shaking. *Oh god* , Izuku thought to himself. The boy was nervous.

And now that he noticed Katsuki's fingers, Izuku looked around for tell tale signs. The slightly forlorn look in his eyes as if Katsuki's mind was running around with a million thoughts, the slight shaking in his fingers, and the rigidness in his leg positioning. Izuku looks at the screen, and he could see a bead of sweat drop from Katsuki's neck down to his shoulders, and the blonde swallows heavily, looking up at the clock.

And before Izuku could stop himself from acting out and looking like a fool, the green eyed boy runs down to the railing of the stadium, so that his body was pressed up against the railing and he was practically leaning over the edge towards the track field. And on his right, he grabs the megaphone out of the hands of one of the parents in Ise. Inko was friends with the mom who had the megaphone, but Izuku didn't know her personally. It didn't matter,

Izuku with a pleading look, takes the megaphone out of her shocked hands, and directs the sound towards Katsuki.

And like a complete fool in love that would do anything to see the man he loved succeed, Izuku begins to whistle.

As loudly as he can, in the silence of the arena that was waiting for the prized athlete to jump, Izuku disrupts the silence of the stadium by whistling the tune of a certain song as loud as he can.

Nothing's Gonna Change My Love For You by George Benson.

Izuku doesn't know if it will help. Hell, it may not. But it was worth a try. He remembers it helping once to distract Katsuki from feeling nervous.

They had been sitting on the landing pit of the practice field, after Katsuki finally admitted to him that he felt nervous. Nervous about beating Toro Ito. Nervous about Nationals. And it

was an important moment, before their blow up, before everything, because it was one of the very first times that Katsuki had ever let his guard down around Izuku. The very first time that the blonde allowed himself to admit that he was nervous, even before their blow up in the parking lot that rainy day.

Izuku remembered him telling the blonde, *"Hm, when you're nervous, I read that you should do an activity that makes your brain focus on something entirely different. Although it's just rec badminton, I sometimes get nervous too, and I like to whistle a song. It makes me focus on what note comes next, and calms my nerves down a little so I'm not as tense."*

He remembers Katsuki snorting, before asking, "What song."

Izuku had told him the song. The very song that he was whistling his heart and lungs out right now in a stadium that was now looking at him as if he was crazy. The megaphone amplified the whistle that it carried throughout the air, and Katsuki would have to be deaf to not hear him. Nothing's Gonna Change My Love For You.

*"By George Benson?"* Katsuki laughed at him that day, *"My god, you're so fucking cheesy."*

He teased him, and yet, that day, Katsuki still whistled along. And it made him laugh for a moment whistling alongside Izuku, distracting him from the nervousness he felt about vaulting. It worked then, even if just for a moment.

If there was any chance that it would work now, Izuku was going to take it. Even if he looks like an idiot. Even if everyone in the stadium was now turning their heads to the source of the whistling of the familiar tone. People from Ise, who grew up on 80s music, knew the song instantly. Others, from different parts of the country, once they recognized it, felt like they were rediscovering the song for the first time all over again. But it didn't matter what any of them thought.

If it got to one person, then that's all that Izuku could ask for.

From the track field, the tune carried through from the stadium section 2C, and a certain blonde athlete that should be beginning his run *very* soon, catches wind of it, and his head turns immediately to the stands. Izuku sees red eyes searching around, as Katsuki steps out of his position, and *no no no that's not what you're supposed to do.* Katsuki steps out of his position and his head scans the crowd for the source of the whistle, face suddenly morphing into that of recognition, hope, and simultaneous fear, when Bakugo Katsuki finally spots Izuku in the crowd, leaning right up against the railing, finishing up his whistle and setting down the megaphone. Freckles, plenty of them, with beautiful doe eyes, and an adorable loose tshirt slightly drenched in sweat. Katsuki's attention was completely stolen.

Red eyes meet green, and Izuku stares back in the eyes of the love of his life, and mouths to Katsuki, " *Your turn."*

But instead of finishing the melody, instead of getting into position, instead of doing anything that he was supposed to do, the blonde raises his arms in a "T" formation, signalling a time-out. There was less than 15 seconds on the clock. That wasn't enough time to jump anyways, but even then, Katsuki called a time out.

Murmurs erupted across the stadium, and suddenly, everything was in shambles.

Bakugo Katsuki has never called a time-out before in all his years of doing the sport. According to the National Pole Vault Associations, these time outs *were* technically and rarely allowed per person and lasted about 5 minutes each, but the rule was so deep in the book that no one ever uses them. Questions of whether or not that was allowed floated through the air. Coaches began to talk amongst themselves.

And Izuku sees Coach Shugo emerge from the tent, mouth full of words ready to fire off at Katsuki, but the blonde didn't seem to care. Everyone was absolutely confused, Izuku included. Katsuki has *never* called for a time out before, much less at a moment so pivotal.

"Participant #59 has requested a time out. Requested granted. A 5 minute break will begin now, and upon conclusion, the two minute timer will begin again," An announcement was made, which causes even more murmurs and talk to be spread across the crowd.

But even before the announcement, Bakugo Katsuki already began moving. Upon the announcement of the 5-minute break, the people in charge of the music began to play the intermission music. Inspired by the random whistler in the crowd just a few moments ago, from the large speakers, Nothing's Gonna Change My Love For You by George Benson began playing, and Izuku feels his heart melt even further. And then beat faster as it looks like Katsuki was headed towards him.

From behind him, Coach Shugo and three other people from the staff was running up behind the blonde, but Katsuki already began running across the track and towards Section 2C by the time they started to rush towards him. Izuku's eyes widened, as he sees Katsuki jump up vertically to grab onto a bar. The stands were about 15 feet off of the ground, but the athlete grabs onto one of the metal bars hanging off, and does a chin up to pull himself upwards. What the *fuck* .

"Bakugo!" Coach Shugo yells from behind him, "Get back down here!"

"Participant #59?" One of the staff members called out, looking up at the boy who was scaling the sides, "I'm going to have to ask you to climb back down from there!"

Katsuki completely ignored the pleas. And he definitely ignored the sudden outbursts of conversation amidst the entire stadium at this particularly odd stunt. The music was loud, but the murmurs and conversations about what the fuck was going on was even louder. Everything felt overwhelming, and Izuku felt it too.

Jaw dropped, the greenette stepped forward and held onto the railing to stabilize himself once Katsuki swings himself over the railing just 9 feet away from him, and began to brisk walk towards him. Everything was happening at once, and the doe eyed boy didn't know what the fucking do, or decipher what the fuck was going on. To be honest, Katsuki didn't either.

From below, another staff member began to speak into the walkie talkie, probably calling people up the stands to drag Bakugo Katsuki back down the stadium or at least outside to explain what the hell he was doing. Coach Shugo was still yelling up at him, and was

walking back underneath the stadium, so that he could come up to the other side and probably drag the athlete back down. And everything felt loud, and overwhelming.

“K-Kacchan?” Izuku’s eyes widened as the blonde stepped forward with a pained and panicked expression on his face, “Ka-”

“Why weren’t you here!” Katsuki borderline calls out to him in panic as the blonde closes their distance, pulling Izuku into his arms, and cradling the greenette by the head, as his other arm wrap around Izuku’s shoulders as if he was afraid of letting the other go. Izuku could hear the clear panic in his voice as he asked more painfully, “Why weren’t you fucking here?”

At this, Izuku breaks down and he feels the tears right before he tastes it in his lips, and the greenette buries his face in Katsuki’s chest but was scared to hold him back, “K-Kacchan, what are you doing up here?” He asked, crying.

“Answer my question,” Katsuki demanded with hurt and anger in his tone, “Where were you?”

How could Izuku tell him that he was so close to not coming at all? How could Izuku tell him that he was home not too long ago, and had to rush here like his life depended on it.

Crying, Izuku let out a pained, “I’m sorr-”

“You promised,” Katsuki’s voice broke, and Izuku’s eyes widened at the sound, pulling away momentarily but the athlete didn’t let him and held him tightly, but it was clear by the next words that Katsuki was about to cry as well, “You fucking promised me, Deku.”

Hearing Katsuki nearly cry, because of him, hurt more than his own tears, and Izuku wanted to make it stop now.

"I know," Izuku admits with a cracked voice, "I know."

"If you knew then why didn't you come," Katsuki asked out of irrationality and hurt, which was clear in his tone. And Izuku feels terrible for having made Katsuki waits. How could he have thought for a second that it wouldn't be that big of a deal, he asked himself. Was he a fool?

Pulling back, Katsuki held Izuku’s head with his hands, thumbing the freckled, tear-stained cheeks as if he was doing so for the first time, and looked all over the greenette’s face as if he wasn’t really there, before repeating, with teams brimming in those ruby red eyes, “You said you’d be here.”

Izuku gave him a wobbly smile through his tears, and brought his own hands up to cup over Katsuki’s, reassuring the taller with his own touch hopefully comforting the other, and nod his head in more reassurance, “I’m here now, Kacchan. I’m here.” His own voice broke.

From the crowd of people from Ise and Ise High to the side of them sitting in the stands of section 2C, everyone’s face was stunned and in shock. Everywhere else, the murmurs were

still loud as ever, as people try to figure out what in the *world* was happening in section 2C that caused this sudden time out.

"For how long," Katsuki swallowed, words barely calm. Izuku looks up at the other, lips wobbling as they part and he's speechless.

"Ka-" Izuku began, but the athlete interrupts him by asking the question again.

“How long will you be here?” Katsuki searched his eyes for an answer. His voice was desperate in asking this.

Izuku never craved the taste of cherry and burnt sugar more than he did now, and being near Katsuki right then feels like an undeserved rain after a long drought. And he knew that it wouldn’t be good for him to stay for more than the tournament. Izuku was here to support Katsuki for the tournament, but any more than that and he couldn’t. He shouldn’t.

“I…” Izuku began, intending to truthfully answer, he could feel a little bit of snot threatening to run down his nose, “I don’t kn-”

“You’re going to leave afterwards, aren’t you?” Katsuki assumed in a fearful voice, eyes widening, “You’ll leave.”

Izuku couldn’t say anything, which only confirmed Katsuki’s suspicions even more. And the blonde drops his hands from Izuku’s face, before looking around frantically. From the stands, all of his friends were staring at what was happening in shock. Everyone except for Kaito Sen, who was instead, looking down at his hands. And Kimi, who rested her cheek on one hand, and stared at the scene romantically. No one in the stands had expected for anything like this to happen, and to see what was unfolding before them left the crowd speechless.

“No, no, no,” Katsuki shook his head, “Don’t go. You can’t go.”

Katsuki looked back to the track field, then to the stands, and then back at Izuku, stepping back just one step, as Izuku watches him with his own chest slightly shaking and tears brimming again in his eyes.

“Kacchan?” Izuku asked, voice cracking and raising its pitch a little.

From the other entrance to the stands, at the top, Izuku could see Coach Shugo and some staff members coming down and heading towards Izuku. And it looks like Katsuki sees them too, because the athlete then grabs Izuku’s wrist and began to walk the opposite direction towards another exit from the stands.

“We’re leaving,” Katsuki says while looking over his shoulders at Coach Shugo and then down at Izuku, who followed him for a couple steps.

But Izuku pulled back, staying in place, and in absolute shock, turned Katsuki back around to look at him, “L-leaving? Kacchan, what do you mean? We’re not leaving! Your tournamen-”

“Izu-” Katsuki softens his gaze just a bit, before saying.

But out of panic and confusion, Izuku shakes his head, “N-No, you can’t leave. You’ve worked so hard for this, Kacchan. You’ve worked so, so hard and so long for this moment, how can you just think about leaving?”

“Listen, I don-” Katsuki tries to begin again, his eyes constantly darting from Izuku to his coach and the staff that are surely going to drag him out of the stands.

“You can’t. Not for me,” Izuku shakes his head while wiping away some tears, before telling Katuki once more, “Do you not get it, Kacchan? You’ll lose the tournament! You’ll lose. You n-never lose, because you hate los-”

“I’ll lose it then, goddamnit,” Katsuki then declared loudly, interrupting Izuku’s ramblings and putting his word down.

The green eyed boy stares up with a wide shocked expression, and Katsuki’s chest was heaving from the sudden outburst, but there was nothing but stability within those fiery red eyes. Izuku is quiet. And not just Izuku. But everyone in section 2C who could hear what was going on was quiet. To see Bakugo Katsuki, the notoriously apathetic, playful of Ise High, the god who was untouchable and invincible. To see this man weak for Midoriya Izuku, to see this man be willing to *lose* for Midoriya Izuku, was leaving every single one of them speechless.

“I’ll lose the damn thing,” Katsuki choked on his word, before clearing his throat and speaking firmly, “I’ve got a million trophies. I’ve gotten all the damn recognition and awards I’d want. I’ve won a million times. And you’re damn right. I hate losing. But losing this ain't jack *shit* compared to losing you .”

Izuku’s lungs feel collapsed, for it doesn’t seem like he can breathe as Katsuki continues to speak.

“Say the word, and I’ll leave right now and not look back once. Say the word, and I’ll lose a million times just to have you stay an extra *minute* ,” Katsuki reached out, but redacts his hand just as he was about to. There was determination in his gaze, but also, a pain that Izuku could see, "Say the word, and I'll fucking do it."

In barely a whisper that Katsuki could only hear, Izuku asks with a slow shake of his head, “Kacchan, how could I ever ask that of you?”

“I don’t car-” Katsuki began, determination in his voice.

“Knowing how much you love pole vault, knowing how much this tournament matters to you, how could you ever think I’d be able to do that to you? Take you away from all of this?” Izuku gives him a smile through his tears, and shakes his head. He could never even dream of it. He didn’t want Katsuki to purposely lose, not if he had no reason to.

“Says a lot about my feelings, don’t it Deku,” Katsuki swallowed, as he stares Izuku down.

But the boy in question looks up at Katsuki with wide eyes, pausing for a second, barely comprehending what was said, before asking, “Huh?”

“Deku, listen, we got a lot to talk about,” Katsuki steps forward to cup both of his hands, asking desperately, “Say the word, and we’re out of here. I need to talk to you. If not now, then you’ll leave. You’ll fucking leave after the tournament. It has to be now. I don’t-Fuck, I don't even know what to fucking say, but we owe each other a conversation.”

Izuku couldn’t even bring it in himself to disagree. All of this time, and did they ever truly have a conversation about their feelings? Or has it always been him ranting one sidedly about his feelings while Katsuki sits there quietly, and never had any follow up to say. Even now, Katsuki admits to him he doesn’t know what to say, yet it looked like the blonde was more willing to talk than other times. But will he? Or will this just be another instance where Katsuki tells him to wait, and not say a single word while Izuku suffers.

A hand goes over Katsuki’s shoulders, but the blonde shoves it away and tells Coach Shugo, “Get your hands off me.”

“Bakugo,” The coach barks half in panic and half in anger, eyes glancing to the time-out clock that read 1 minute left, “You *need* to get back on the damn track. Now!”

Katsuki ignores him, but two staff members try to intervene, “Bakugo Katsuki? Participant #59. We’re going to have to remove you from the stadiums for the disturb-”

Katsuki ignores him, shoving them off once more, and tries further to convince Izuku, “There’s always next year. I’ll lose this shitty thing today if it means that there’s *any* chance I can convince you to be there by my side next year when I come back to win it."

"No," Izuku shakes his head, "You're not go-"

"I'm serious," Katsuki tells him desparately, "I’ll fucking disqual-”

“Kacchan,” Izuku wipes away a tear, and steps forward, smiling gently with cloudy eyes as he brings a hand up to gentle hold Katsuki’s face, “Fly." He says, "Go down there, and fly for me.”

Katsuki’s eyes widened a bit, before he shakes his head, just as two arms of staff members wrap around his, “No. You’ll leave afterw-”

"I won't," Izuku tells him then.

“No, I’ll fucki-” And then, when it hits him what Izuku said, the blonde’s face morph into one of surprise, “What?”

Izuku stares at him, watching different emotions he can't point out play out in those red eyes he loves so much.

“I’ll be right here,” Izuku tells him, softly but sure of his decision, “I’m not going anywhere afterwards.”

As the people, including Coach Shugo, tries to pull him back as if he was some feral animal, Katsuki brushes forward to hear Izuku say it again.

"Don't lie to me, Izuku," Katsuki uses his name for emphasis, voice shaking.

Izuku knew that it must have pained Katsuki to even *think* about losing the tournament. Because as much as Katsuki valued their friendship or relationship, Izuku knew that pole vault has been there for the blonde a lot longer. Pole vault was the boy's passion, his art. And Katsuki has built up every day to this moment for years, and to think that he was willing to give all that up for Izuku was heartfelt, but Izuku knew that it must also have been hard to even consider. The very least Izuku could do was listen to what Katsuki had to say if he was willing to give up his dream for Izuku.

Izuku needed to learn from his mother and father, who made each other choose.

Izuku would never forgive himself if he ever made Katsuki choose between one dream and another. Never. Izuku would never forgive himself if he was the reason that Katsuki gave up something he's been working towards for forever, even if the blonde convinced himself that it was okay.

"I'll be right here," Izuku nods as he repeats, swallowing his spit and smiling through his bittersweet smile, "If you go down there and jump--win or lose--I'll be right here," Izuku promises, "You don't have to forfeit just to get me to stay."

Katsuki stares at him as if he couldn't believe it, "Are you serious."

"Kacchan," Izuku tells him, "I'm never going to make you choose between two things you care about."

The blonde gets pulled back, but he still steps forward, swallowing, staring at Izuku with wide eyes, asking once more, "You're for real."

Izuku nods furiously, stepping forward to squeeze Katsuki's hands once, right before they're taken up again by the staff.

"Bakugo, you have less than a minute left to get down there," Coach Shugo yells at him, "It's either you go down there, or I'm dragging your as-"

"Promise me," Katsuki breaks one arm out to hold his pinky finger out, like they were children again.

Izuku hurries and reaches out to hook his pinky finger around, as he says softly, "I promise. Now go do your best, Kacchan."

Katsuki was getting pulled back, and berated some more, but the look in the blonde's face was both shock, doubt, and sudden inspiration.

"You're fucking serious? You'll stay after," Katsuki asks one more time as if to get rid of his doubt.

"I'm serious," Izuku laughs at him through his cracked voice, although he wanted to cry.

“Wait for me then,” Katsuki tells him as he steps back with the staff members, “Right here. Wait for me. If I’m going to jump, I’m going to win the goddamn trophy. Wait for me, okay?”

Izuku nods, with an encouraging smile, and lets him go. And Katsuki takes one last look at him, before the blonde shrugs off the people trying to grab at him one last time, giving them a glare.

“Get the fuck off of me. I’m coming,” Katsuki tells them, before walking alongside Coach Shugo who was still yelling at him for the stunt he just pulled.

Izuku was left there, hands shaking slightly, staring at Katsuki’s back as he makes sure to keep his word this time. And when it feels like he can reign himself in again, Izuku looks to his right where all of section 2C was sitting. If people weren’t whispering, then they were staring either at him, Katsuki, or at nothing in contemplation. In consideration. Because most people weren’t exactly sure of what they just witnessed. To the students of Ise High, it was a moment of reflection, about Bakugo Katsuki, about themselves, and about words and beliefs that had been solidified about the athlete all of these years. To the adults that came from Ise, it was a rare moment where the delinquent rascal of Ise looked a little more human, when before, even they were guilty of only viewing Bakugo Katsuki as a trophy winner for Ise.

Izuku has nothing to say to them, and so he does just that. Says nothing.

Instead, the greenette turns to the track field once more, as Katsuki’s figure walks back to the starting position, as the two minute timer to begin his final attempt starts again. Except this time, there was less anxious hesitance in his walk or his nature. Izuku takes a look at the blonde’s hands, to find at his fingers had stopped shaking. And instead of a forlorn look in those red eyes, Katsuki sports a gaze of determination as he looked at the 18’3 bar.

Katsuki leans down and gets into the correct positioning as the clock starts to count down. The music had been turned off, and once more, the crowd waits in anticipation.

1 minute 55 seconds. Bakugo Katsuki removed the sweatband off of his wrist, and flattens it out in his hands, taking a good look at it. The camera zooms in to read the text, with the ugly written ‘Izuku believes in me’ scribbled in a kid’s handwriting, and Izuku watches as Katsuki rolled his eyes and grins. And then, Katsuki pulls some of his hair back, and slips the sweatband over his head, and under his hair like how it should be worn, not inverted and right there on his forehead displaying for the entire stadium to see exactly what it says. Izuku melts even further and falls further in love than he could have ever imagined.

1 minute and 39 seconds. Bakugo takes a deep breath, and begins to finish the tune. He finishes the tune of Nothing’s Gonna Change My Love For You that Izuku left off for his turn, and right as he finishes the tune, the timer hits 1 minute 15 seconds.

Katsuki begins to sprint. He begins at the 40 meter mark, and Izuku could see his lips were mouthing numbers. Sprint for 10 seconds. Run for 6.

*1, 2, 3, 4, 5,*

Each second felt like an eternity has passed, and the entire crowd seemed to hold its breath in silence as they await the jump. After all, this was, in fact, the deciding jump. If Bakugo Katsuki clears this bar, he wins. If he fails to do so, then the tie breaker will automatically go to Toro Ito. From the tent that Toro Ito was currently sitting in with his coach, the competitor watches closely with his breath held as well.

6, 7, 8, 9, 10.

Katsuki breaks into a run. His arms clutching the pole with a perfect grip, one that he has practiced for a million times. That he's sweated for a million liters. That he's poured his soul into. This run, this grip, this placement, this dream was something that he's worked so fucking hard for. And he has a moment as he's running, where he thanks Izuku for staying, for letting him run this round, because as he approaches the final stretch, Katsuki is reminded all over again how much this sport means to him. Izuku didn't make him choose. And so, after this all ends, Katsuki won't make Izuku choose either. Izuku won't have to choose between loving him or self-preservation. Because Katsuki was going to show this boy the world, and give this boy all the love he had to give, so that Izuku could continue to love Katsuki without fearing what it might do to himself.

1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6.

Katsuki hits the pole into the vault box like he's done a million times, and it bends. The pole does a *deep, deep* bend, and Katsuki can feel the dexterity of the pole underneath his fingers. He hates how cheesy it sounds, but Katsuki feels the pole as if it was his own body. When the pole bends, there is a pivotal moment, where the fiberglass hits its full potential energy, and he just *feels* it. There's a science to it, sure. But Katsuki just *feels* it. And when that feeling comes underneath his fingertips, Katsuki knows to lift up off the ground.

And so, the pole bends, and Katsuki gets a jolt in his hand at that maximum point, and his legs push off. And in a split second, he is launched up. In all, the whole jumping sequence takes less than 3 seconds, but when he's up there, soaring, waiting to see if he makes it above a bar or not, it feels like a millenia. And so Katsuki flies. He feels the sun in his eyes when he approaches the maximum trajectory, it's glaring, so he just closes them. He bends his back once he feels he has reached the max height of his parabolic trajectory, and stretches his legs out in front of him to minimize chances of contact with the bar.

He feels the slightest brush of something underneath his calf, before he begins to fall. The slightest brush of the bar, and he knew he touched it. The question was, did he touch it with enough force that it will fall.

When Katsuki lands on the mat on his back, he opens his eyes again, and bounces up once before landing on his knees. And so there, as the crowd is yelling in anticipation for the final result, everything seems to be moving in slow motion. On his knees, Katsuki then looks up to the bar set at 18'3 feet. And he waits.

The bar wobbles, like it was threatening to fall, and Katsuki holds his breath as much as the next person. And in his peripheral, he sees Coach Shugo on one knee, arms pointed up towards the bar, as if begging and praying to the gods that it won't fall. The commentators

were going off on the mic, but Katsuki didn't pay attention to a word they were saying. He just stares. And stares at the bar.

And after a solid 5 seconds, it stills.

He cleared it.

At once, everything came rushing back in. All the sensation. All of the screaming, from all corners of the stadium, but loudest from Section 2C. Coach Shugo yelling and shouting in his ear from joy. The commentators announcing the clearance and his victory. The huge screens zooming in on him, and then on Toro Ito, who is now by default, the 2nd place winner. Music began to play. Let's Groove by Earth, Wind, and Fire. Katsuki didn't like this song, but he was feeling victorious, so he didn't even care that much for it.

Grinning from ear to ear, Katsuki turns his head towards section 2C, where Izuku was standing against the railing, crying but also laughing from joy as he waved to Katsuki. The blonde waved back, and then let out a shout of victory. He had been working on this like crazy, and he knew this was one of his biggest goals from the moment he discovered what pole vault even was. And now that he was here, it felt almost surreal. Like it wasn't actually happening. And yet, this victory, as good as it was and as amazing as it felt, lost its appeal on him after about five minutes. And suddenly, he wanted to be somewhere else.

He had been shuffled around the track field to different coaches and cameras, and people who were interested in talking to him for a good five minutes, but he was over it. The awards ceremony began in thirty minutes, but he was over that too. Coach Shugo will get it for him.

And with that in mind, Katsuki breaks away from the man, who once again, frustratingly calls out after him, and begins to run the *normal* way up the stadium, rather than scaling the sides like a freak even though it was only 15 feet, and over to Section 2C, where as promised, Izuku was waiting for him. Immediately, he was bombarded by his friends and classmates trying to congratulate him and he gives them a nod and a thanks, but his goal was clear.

Katsuki makes his way over to where the green haired boy was standing.

"Kacchan, you did it!" Izuku exclaimed, still crying happy tears as the green eyed boy stared up at the athlete with overwhelming happiness and pride.

Katsuki stops right in front of the shorter, and lifts one side of his lips into a smile, "Hell yeah, I did. "

Izuku says this genuinely, and truly from the bottom of his heart, "I'm so proud of you. You've worked so, so hard for this."

Katsuki ignores all of that. In fact, he ignores any praise he gets, in his true assholish nature, and instead, focuses on something else, "You promised to stay."

Izuku looked down at his feet, swallowed, and then up at Katsuki, "And here I am."

“And here you are,” Katsuki felt residual confidence from the victory, and so he was going to carry this out for as long as he possibly could before he strips himself emotionally bare for Izuku, “Let’s go.”

“Go?” Izuku’s eyes widened as he looked around, “But the awards ceremony. You have to get your trophy.”

But Katsuki was already leading him out of the section, and out of the stadium seats, nodding to those on either side of the walkway who were congratulating him, “Fuck the trophy. If tonight goes as well as I hope it does, then that’ll be worth more than any damn trophy.”

“What’d you say?” Izuku asks over the crowd bombarding the both of them.

Katsuki just turns around briefly, right as they exited the outdoor stadium space and back inside the indoor stairs, “I said fuck the trophy. Let’s go.”

Izuku fast walks behind Katsuki, as the blonde rushes forward. They get to the bottom of the indoor stairs, where a ton of people were walking around in the lobby area. For those who weren’t staying for the awards ceremony, they were rushing to get out and onto the road before the leaving traffic gets too heavy. Katsuki gets stopped several times, but he only nods before brushing them off, holding onto Izuku’s wrist gently enough to pull along the entire time. Moving through the crowd, Izuku watches as Katsuki soars above the crowd in height. He couldn’t lose the other if he tried. Katsuki makes a quick stop into the locker rooms and dissapears into there for a quick three minutes, and when he comes out, he's changed into a letterman jacket thrown over a white tshirt and a pair of ripped jeans.

And then they move through the crowd again, weaving in and out of people trying to get the fuck out of there. Izuku feels his excitement from the whole tournament die a little as he realized that they were now going towards having a conversation he was terrified of. To be fair, he was *so, so* proud of Katsuki. But this fear was insistent.

Suddenly, in the middle of the crowded lobby, Katsuki stopped and stepped closer to him, looking down at the boy.

“How did you get here?” Katsuki then asked him, having to talk a little louder of the loud echo present in the building.

Izuku chewed on the inside of his cheek and looked towards the gate, “I drove.” Embarrassed to admit that he was driving like a maniac all the way from Ise to Nagoya.

At this, Katsuki’s brow raised, “You drove? Auntie let you?”

“Well,” Izuku wasn’t exactly sure what to say, because on one hand, she technically gave him permission, and on the other hand, he didn’t exactly tell her he changed his mind last minute, “Technically.”

“Mind if we take your car? My parents need to drive mine home since I took them here,” Katsuki requested.

Izuku nodded, and walked ahead, leading the way as he exits the building. Katsuki walks closely behind him, keeping a hand gently at the small of his back in order to not fall too far behind, and Izuku's cheek heats up. Katsuki has touched him in far more intimate ways before, but even a small touch like this never seems to get old.

"Um," Izuku coughs and tells the other, "I parked a bit far."

"You got stuck in Lot C, huh," Katsuki tried to make conversation.

It felt weird, trying to talk to each other again when there was a lot of *heavy* subtext in between them that was still unresolved. How were they supposed to have any semblance of a normal conversation when so much needed to be addressed before they could so much as breathe normally in each other's direction again. There was a slight tenseness in the air between them, filled with residual sadness, longing, and unsaid words. Katsuki should be celebrating his win right now. He should be celebrating for hours to come. But instead, there was nothing that the blonde seemed to want to do but this. And so, the excitement of winning quickly died down, and they were reminded that things weren't normal between the two of them.

"Not exactly," Izuku bit his lip, walking forward onto the pedestrian walk and across the busy street.

"Where the fuck did you park then," Katsuki now asks out of curiosity, matching pace with the shorter male as they weave through the sidewalks.

Izuku gives him a shy look, admitting embarrassed, "Take a left, 9 blocks to the right, and then 10 blocks forward."

"Jesus Christ, what the fuck Deku," Katsuki raised a brow as they fast walked, and then looked forward with a down expression, "Don't tell me that's why you were late. Trying to find a parking spot?"

Izuku took a breath and sighed to himself, not finding it in him to make lighthearted conversation like this, "I was late because I left at 1."

The blonde continues to walk for a little bit, before suddenly realizing what that entailed, in which he then stopped to look at Izuku, "1?"

Izuku nodded, feeling guilty internally.

"How the hell did you cut out an hour of drive time?" Katsuki asked him, brow raised.

Izuku scratched the back of his neck and admitted, "Speeding."

At this, Katsuki puts his hands in his pockets and lets out a breathy laugh, "You're kidding me."

And Izuku doesn't say anything in response to that. Katsuki doesn't push any details either, finding it a bit exhausting to continue trying to talk normally when nothing about them right now is normal. And so, the two walk the long distance from the stadium to the car. The traffic

was still undesirable, but not as bad as it was when Izuku was initially coming into the city. Especially now that they were more than 15 blocks away, things seemed to get less jam packed. That being said, it will likely start up again within an hour once the bulk of people attending the tournament begins to shuffle out and head back home. It wasn't a bad idea to get a head start. Walking next to Katsuki, Izuku felt nervous. He didn't know exactly what they were to do now, or what this conversation they were supposed to have entailed, and so, he was currently preparing himself for another fit of crying. He knew that crying was not a weakness, but that doesn't negate the fact that it's draining to the soul. He doesn't know how much more his eyes could take.

"Car keys?" Katsuki asked, once they approached the familiar vehicle that the blonde often sees in Izuku's driveway.

Izuku looked over to the taller man and asked in confusion, "Car...keys?"

Katsuki held out his hand and looked over at Izuku, expression more serious now as it seems the athlete has given up on faking normalcy, "I'm driving. You take a break."

Izuku looked down, "Shouldn't you be the one taking a break? You just won a whole tournament, Kacchan."

The blonde in question shrugs and keeps his hand open for the car keys, "I'm fine. I want to drive."

Pausing, not understanding why Katsuki insisted so much, Izuku just decided to go with it, and fishes out the car keys, placing them in Katsuki's hands. The boy then walked forward and unlocked the car before slipping into the driver's seat. Izuku followed suit to the passenger side, and settled in.

The entire time Katsuki was navigating the car out of the city streets and back onto the less dense highway towards Ise, no words were exchanged between the two. The radio was turned off, and the only sounds were of rocks kicking underneath the tire, the mechanical whirring of the exhaust, and the occasional shuffling of some boxes in the back of the car. Katsuki drove with one elbow resting against the window sill, fingers thumbing his own bottom lip, and his right arm placed casually on top of the steering wheel. Meanwhile, Izuku sat in the passenger side, head leaned up against the window, and eyes staring straight forward, watching as the sun gets more and more golden. By the time they get back to Ise, it should be night. Maybe then, under the cloak of darkness, he'll feel brave enough to say something. In the meantime, Izuku wasn't exactly sure how this four hour drive back to their small town was going to go. Was it going to be this quiet the entire time, while both of them collect their thoughts?

Izuku gets the answer to his question soon enough once Katsuki breaks the silence.

"If we have this conversation now, I'm afraid I won't be able to drive at the same time," Katsuki tells him in all seriousness.

And this makes Izuku realize that whatever it was that the boy had to say, must take a fair amount of consideration to speak about if they couldn't even drive and have the conversation

at the same time. This fact made him even more nervous.

Izuku nods in understanding, softly replying, “That’s fine.”

“So can we talk about something else in the meantime?” Katsuki asked, eyes glued onto the road, not glancing over to the greenette for even a moment.

Izuku laughs airily at this, and once more looks out the window at the endless farmland being basked by the sweet golden glow as they drove far out from the bustling city, “Something else?”

Katsuki lets out a low hum in affirmation.

Izuku brings his knees up forward to his chest and asked quietly, “And what are we supposed to talk about?”

The athlete leaned his head back against the headrest and shrugged his large shoulders slowly, “Shit, anything’s fine.”

A beat of silence passed between them, before Katsuki spoke up once more.

“Let’s just pretend for a while that I still made you happy,” Katsuki asked of him, still not averting his gaze from the road, “That it’s just one of those days I pick you up to go do some dumb shit together. Just for a little while longer.”

Izuku looked over to the blonde, who had since taken off the sweatband and had thrown on his Ise High letterman jacket that framed his broad shoulders well.

Katsuki more seriously followed up, “And we can deal with all the fucked up bits later.”

It’s quiet for a bit, and Izuku counts every little rock that the car’s tire’s pick up. The road was long and straight, and would go on for a very long time. So, so long that the thought of that entire ride being made in silence was uncomfortable.

With his knees still pulled up to his chest, Izuku knew it wasn’t a good idea, but he lets himself slip into nostalgia anyways, sighing, “I found out that my dad has a new wife and two kids.”

Katsuki shifts a little bit at the sudden initiation of conversation, but the blonde was quick to pick it up, “Did he?”

“Yeah,” Izuku frowns a little bit, “According to Mom, he’s a really caring and doting dad to them, too. And I can’t tell if it makes me sad or relieved.”

“Should make you mad,” Katsuki offered his input, “Piece of shit leaves without keeping in touch for over 15 years, and suddenly, he shows up and claims he’s been a good dad? I call bullshit.”

“You call everything bullshit, Kacchan,” Izuku shakes his head.

“Because everything *is* bullshit,” Katsuki argues, “So what. You and Auntie good now?”

At this, Izuku smiles genuinely, “We’re going to be.”

“Great. Is she ever going to apologize to me for whacking me with my own damn shovel?” Katsuki demands.

At this, Izuku even finds himself laughing a bit, “Are you ever going to apologize for digging up her lawn?”

In response to this, Katsuki was quick on his feet, shrugging, “Got nothin’ to apologize for.”

Izuku flushed a slight red from this. It was stupid how easily a simple statement from Katsuki was able to make him heat up or shy.

And so, to reply, Izuku just derailed from the conversation, “I don’t know what you’d think would happen,” He mutters quietly, “My mom’s obsessed with her yardwork.”

“She’ll get over it,” Katsuki sneered, “I knocked over Auntie’s dad’s cremation urn when I was 4, remember? And she got over that. I think...”

“That was you!?” Izuku sat up in his seat instantly, staring at Katsuki with bug eyes, jaw dropping at the casual statement.

Someone had knocked over his grandfather’s cremation urn a long time ago, and the culprit has never been found all of these years. Thank goodness, only a little bit spilled out, but it was a moment of terror for both him and his mother nevertheless. He thought that they’ll never solve the mystery, only for now, many years later, to figure out who had done it.

Katsuki then looked a little embarrassed, “Ah fuck, have I never confessed to that? I swear to God I have.”

“You’re going to hell then! Because you’ve never said *anything* about it!” Izuku waved an arm around.

“I was gonna go to hell anyways, shitnerd,” Katsuki bantered, “I thought I told her okay?”

And for a second there, it felt like everything was okay again, even if it was temporary.

“You sure didn’t,” Izuku keeps him in check, shaking his had, “Those were my grandpa’s ashes, *Kacchan* .”

“I was 4!” Katsuki defends himself, “I didn’t know the words ‘I’m sorry’ until, like, 5 fucking months ago!”

“Hah hah, that’s funny Kacchan,” Izuku says even though it was, albeit just a *little* funny, “No wonder she’s been doting on you like her own son all of these years! Poor lady doesn’t even know what you’ve done all those years ago.”

“Good! And I’d like to keep it that way, so if you say shit to her, you’re *dead* ,” Katsuki turns to him and points a finger in Izuku’s face, “If Auntie stops inviting me over for her spicy curry nights, I’m gonna fucking know you snitched.”

And for some reason, a deep sadness instilled in Izuku as he realized that there might not be anymore nights where Katsuki’s invited over for dinner, unless his mother does so in her own time. And the thought hurts him deeply, as he’s reminded of those sometimes awkward, sometimes heartfelt nights before all of the fights between his mom or between the two of them occurred when they’d all come together for a nice, hot meal.

“I’m *so* scared,” Izuku waves his fingers around sarcastically, “What are you gonna do. Huh?” Izuku tries to act tough.

“Don’t forget, you bastard,” Katsuki sneers at him, and it looks unfairly attractive, “I still have that picture of you drooling in your sleep like a damn dog.”

Izuku gasped, “You wouldn’t.”

“I would,” Katsuki negated, “Consider this blackmail.”

“You’re the worst,” Izuku groaned with a hint of a smile on his lips.

“Yeah, yeah,” Katsuki snickered, “And yet, you still love me.”

Silence. In the natural rambunctiousness of their conversation flow, Katsuki had completely forgotten that no matter how much he wanted to pretend, the fact of the matter was that they were still in a fucked up situation that has yet to be resolved. And that he had just made light of a very serious issue. *And yet, you still love me.* That had been what Izuku’s been considering was a problem all this time, and he, like a complete idiot, made the absolute worst joke possible.

Seeing Izuku’s shocked expression and silence, Katsuki immediately takes back all of his words, and curses to himself.

“Fuck, Deku,” Katsuki looked over to the greenette while he drives, “I didn’t mean it like tha-”

“I know you didn’t,” Izuku just shook his head with a forgiving smile. He knew that Katsuki wouldn’t say something like that, but he had to admit, the line definitely shocked him at first, “Don’t worry about it.”

“Shit,” Katsuki cursed under his breath, “This is going fantastic, ain’t it.”

Silence.

Looking down at his lap, Izuku just shuts up for a moment, before saying, “I’m...a little tired.”

Katsuki looks back over the steering wheel and takes a deep breath, knowing he fucked up, before asking, “Yeah?”

Izuku slowly nods his head, “I get a little motion sickness riding for long hours.”

Katsuki knew what Izuku expected him to say next, but he’d be lying if he said he didn’t want Izuku to stay awake a little longer and be with him, but instead, the blonde sighs, “Take a nap then. I’ll wake you up when we’re close to home.”

Settling in deeper into his seat, and closing his eyes, Izuku mutters out a soft, “Okay,” Before trying to get a little rest. Even before he closed his eyes, he knew it was futile to try. How could he fall asleep, when the love of his life was sitting in the driver’s seat with an intent of having a serious conversation with him later when they get closer to home? How could he fall asleep, when all he sees when he closes his eyes are the painful flashback memories of the two of them that gets triggers every single time he sees the handsome blonde. How could he fall asleep, when Katsuki’s victory still had his heart in jitters even now, at least an hour after they’ve hit the road.

It turns out, when your head is reeling from a bit of motion sickness, and you want so badly to temporarily forget the internal struggle you’re dealing with, sleeping under those circumstances aren’t *impossible* . For Izuku, after another thirty minutes of sitting there with his eyes closed, drifts into a very light, permeable sleep. In which the slightest bump in the road would cause him to jolt back awake, just to drift back out a couple minutes later. And this would happen again and again until each time he gets jolted away, the sky looks to get a little darker. The passage of time was unknown to him, but that was okay, because the minutes would likely feel too slow if he were to keep himself awake in this silent car with Katsuki.

When Izuku wakes up a final time, it wasn’t because anything jolted him awake. No bump in the road. No sudden loud external sound. In fact, it was because of the opposite. Somewhere in his dream, he realized that it was too smooth. Too peaceful. The constant rhythmic feel of a car driving down a road was gone, and instead, he was still.

And so, upon opening his eyes, Izuku blinks a couple of times to finally comprehend that they were stopped. And the car was pulled over to the side and turned off. To keep air flowing through the vehicle, the doors were left open, and so now, the consistent sound of crickets filled his ears, and leaves rustling gently in the wind.

It was now night time, and there was a slight cloud coverage tonight. Illuminated by the moonlight, it looked like the clouds were moving fast across the sky, reading to get out of this small town. Izuku sat up in his seat and realized then that Katsuki was sitting outside on the hood of the car, with one leg hiked up where his right elbow rested, and the other on the ground for stabilization.

As of the current moment, the blonde was looking out towards the view, fidgeting with the decorative titanium ring around his index finger as he seems to wait for Izuku to wake up.

After a couple of moments, Katsuki stands up, and began to walk closer to the edge of the cliff before stopping a couple of meters before, just to get a better look at the landscape.

The boy in question takes a look around at where they were, and finds the location familiar. They've been here before. Not for too long, but they've definitely been here before.

It was the Cliff of Wishes. He remembers the first time they came here. Izuku had made a wish, throwing a rock down the cliff. While Katsuki made none at all.

Tonight, it looked even more brilliant. A lot of people came here for the view, and it was understandable. From this vantage point, they were able to see practically all of Ise and some change. The curved mountain road that led off to a wide open area where cars could park their cars and hang out around the edges of the cliff was a popular spot. There weren't many twinkling lights in Ise, considering that there were not any skyscrapers or plentiful light sources, other than that of street lamps, but he could see a few. Neighborhood houses with their window lights still turned on, street lamps casting that familiar orange glow, and the occasional headlights of a car passing through the streets.

He could see the plentiful trees that surrounded Ise, and further inland, if he squints, he can see where the farmland began on either side of the highway leading out of Ise. What was stunning was the shoreline of the ocean. Even from this distance away, he could make out the small white foams that would come every time a good wave crashes into the shore. And it was neverending. The ocean stretched on and on forever, a magnificent beast of nature.

Stepping quietly out of the car, Izuku steps forward slowly towards Katsuki and stands about a feet away to the right of the blonde, overlooking the sight as well. And for a little while longer, they share a moment of silence. Izuku didn't know if this conversation was going to run smoothly, or through choppy waters, or if it was going to be productive at all, but if he can enjoy this bittersweet peace for a little while longer, then he will.

Being high up like this, the breeze was a bit heavier than it was on the ground, but amidst the humid summer heat, it felt quite wonderful. If he could keep this peace just a bit longer.

"Tell me again," Katsuki's deep voice cut through the silence. The timbre of it sent a slight shiver down Izuku's spine, and while his eyes were glued to the view, his attention immediately focused on the athlete.

Izuku wasn't quite sure what exactly the other was referring to, and didn't know where to begin with his guesses. Tell him what again? They've probably exchanged billions of words over the last couple of months, beautiful words and ugly words alike. How was he to figure out which ones Katsuki wanted to hear again?

And so, with his eyes still trained ahead, Izuku asked gently, "Tell you what again?"

After a moment of hesitation, and a sharp intake of breath as could be heard, Katsuki requests from the green-eyed boy, "Tell me again that you love me."

Izuku's eyes widened at this, and he finally takes a look over at Katsuki, who stood there still looking out, seeming like he was trying to figure out what to say as he went along. And Izuku is just a little shocked by the request.

Because it was one thing to ask Izuku to stay and have them interact with an actual conversation with one another. It was another thing to take him out all of this way just to make Izuku tell the taller boy once more that he was hopelessly in love with him. What was the point? Izuku just couldn't wrap his head around what there was to gain from this.

With a confused and small voice, the boy looked up at Katsuki, asking with reminded pain in his large eyes, "...Why?"

Katsuki looks down at the ground then, and began to kick the dusty dirt into the ground like he was hammering it in, "I just want to hear it again, without all the pain in your voice this time."

Izuku shook his head and stepped away, feeling slightly distressed and unfair from the sudden request, "Kacchan, you c-can't just ask me that."

The blonde looks over to the side, watching Izuku back away a bit, and steps forward once more towards Izuku, "Please, I need to hear it aga-"

"Kacchan, this is *not* the way to start this conversation," Izuku shook his head, closing his eyes, voice in a whisper as he tries to control the damage before it's further done.

Katsuki reaches out for Izuku's hands and cups them, "Why not?" And the greenette pries himself away.

"Why *not* ?" Izuku asks with wide eyes, voice breathy, "You, knowing how I feel, knowing I'm trying to move on, how can you ask me to tell you that again."

"*Fuck*. That's not h ow I meant it," Katsuki said, now realizing how wrong it sounded now from Izuku's perspective, and trying to repair his little mistake. For hours, he's been trying to formulate how to go about this conversation, but it was as hard as ever. There was no easy way to go about this, and no matter what he tries to say or do, it feels like he was bound to fuck up. Like how he just did now.

Cushioning some more, Katsuki told Izuku in a slight panic, "That's *not* how I meant it. I just-I just fucking suck at words,"

Izuku understands that, and would have no problem giving Katsuki patience with his words, if it didn't *hurt* so damn much, and Izuku waits there for a moment to see if Katsuki would clarify himself.

"I shouldn't have asked you that," Katsuki managed, feeling like he was going to lose Izuku all over again. And yet, it felt so hard for him to go about this, because he didn't know what to fucking say. It was like he's gotten this far, only to blank and get stuck upon looking into those green eyes, and suddenly, he was fucking up left and right.

It feels so heavy between them, like a weight of uncomfortability chaining them down. Every word was a potential cut deeper into an open wound, and both of their stomachs twist in a bit of anxiety over the course of this conversation. Izuku, because he doesn't know where this conversation was going. Instead of being the one to talk and ramble like he usually did in

their heated conversations, this time, he was letting Katsuki speak. And Katsuki, because funnily enough, he didn't know where this conversation was going either.

It was frustrating. Like they were going around in circles. Repeating the same damn mistakes over and over again, and trying to fix them, but ending up in a bigger mess than they were in before. The amount of times Katsuki had told himself 'we could have not dragged this damn thing out longer if you just said *one* thing, or did *something* different' followed him to sleep some nights. And he had vowed to himself that he won't make decisions anymore that would allow him to think that way every again.

But as he stood up here on this cliff tonight with Izuku, he realizes just how much easier said than done it is. It was easy to say *Just say it. Tell him you love him. Tell him all of that,* when he was sitting in his bed alone at night, wishing the greenette was there wrapped up in his embrace. But when he's right here, right now, and the pivotal moment has come, all of the doubts he had about himself started to come back. Because unlike other times, what he does now will have its final consequence. And looking in Izuku's eyes right then, he had no doubt that he loved the other, but he was bombarded once more with the fear of not being able to love Izuku well, the fear of intimacy and saying the words that he's been habituated never to trust himself with for decades. No matter how much preparation he could have had, it almost felt inevitable that it would boil down to this point, where he's once again thrown into the cycle of self-doubt and habituation. What is more frustrating than this.

He knew that when he watched movies, it always made him angry that when the main pairing makes some dumb decisions or drags out their drama so long, when it could have been solved with *one* little change. His legs would shake in impatience, and he'd leave the theater berating how stupid the film was. And yet, he never really understood how hard it can be to have these conversations, where it's him that's speaking on *his* feelings, until now.

He tries again, just saying anything to maybe buffer out his previous mistake.

"Deku, I don't-" He says something that he thinks might lead them back on track, "I don't want you to leave."

It's the same words he's repeated over and over again. At the Hideaway. At the tournament. Maybe it'll have a different impact this time.

Izuku holds himself in his arms, looking back out onto the view but ultimately not being able to focus on it. He replies in a quiet voice, "You've told me."

"And I mean it," Katsuki stepped forward, "I need you."

But it doesn't have the impact that he wanted it to have. It sounds almost bland, like Katsuki was just trying to throw out all the words he hears in romance movies that don't really have connections to *them* in order to maybe make Izuku realize. It was his cop-out plan.

The *I need you* only seems like a further affirmation of a friendship that is tied too deep, and Izuku shakes his head.

“Kacchan, d-did you bring me up here just to say that?” Izuku cocked his head, eyes appearing a little pained as he pursed his lips to keep himself in check.

Katsuki brought a hand up to run through his hair frustratingly, “No!” He felt heat rise, “We’re here to *talk* , about us.”

“Okay,” Izuku nods his head, “What, then?”

“What do you mean *what,* then?” Katsuki gives him a look, “I’m trying to convince you not to give up on us, and that’s all you have to say?”

“Kacchan,” Izuku shakes his head, “You’re saying the same thing you’ve always been saying. That you don’t want me to leave. And I’ve told you a *million* times that I,” Izuku emphasizes his next words, “ *can’t* do that! Because how can you tell me that, knowing how I feel about you? How can you tell me that, knowing that to this *day* , I wake up and my aching for you makes me fall in love a little more instead of the contrary?”

Katsuki looked at him wide-eyed, knowing he needed to say something.

“And now,” Izuku felt himself wanting to cry again, but he keeps a dry face, albeit with a hint of frustration, “You stand here, and tell me again that you want me to stay? What- do you want me to forget, somehow? Pretend that I don’t feel the way I do, so that we can get our friendship ba-”

“That’s not what I want, damnit!” Katsuki interrupted and did a small pace in place just to get his legs moving, “Can’t you see what I’m trying to say?”

Katsuki asks this knowing full well he had been cryptic and not upfront with his emotions this entire time, that he’s using cop-out techniques to maybe get the point across just enough that Izuku might pick up the hint. If he says those things enough times, maybe Izuku might understand that he wanted to the greenette to stay because he wanted a relationship. Except, this was all to avoid saying a certain three words that would change everything. And yet, it didn’t feel right, right then. If he were to say it now, first of all, he didn’t know if he could. Second of all, Izuku would be more confused than anything.

Because he had *never* made anything clear. Even now, he was evading any form of letting his raw emotion seep through, and instead, throwing out lines that seem simple and true enough to say that it might do something. And to suddenly throw out those heavy words now, would throw Izuku off. Might even make him think that Katsuki was just saying it to appease him.

Izuku gave him a frustrated laugh, “No, Kacchan. I don’t. Because we’re going around in circles again.”

“I know, I know,” Katsuki picked up quickly, and put his hands over his face as he rocked backwards, feeling a slight sheen of sweat collect on his skin, “I’m not- Shit. I’m not asking you to stay because I don’t care about your feelings, Izuku.”

The boy in question nods at this. He knew that Katsuki cared about his feelings, for the blonde proved time and time again that he was a wonderful, attentive friend. But that didn’t

make him less confused. He's made it clear before, and yet, the blonde seems to keep asking for the same thing, not exactly saying anything new. And at this point, they've had a conversation like this two or three times now, and he just feels *drained* . He doesn't want to do this anymore, and the moment it looked like he made an ultimatum or resolution within himself to get over Katsuki, the athlete refuses to accept it. Whether it is with the whole pole vault up to his window stunt, or taking up here right now, it feels like he's trying to escape this cycle of sadness, but Katsuki kept pulling his leg back.

And Izuku *knew* . He knew that the blonde had more trouble collecting his words than others did, and that, he should be patient for. But after the third or fourth time of caving in when Katsuki tells him to "Wait" only for the blonde to not say anything that changes a damn thing, was it so wrong of him to feel exhausted?

"I'm...aware," Izuku swallows and says very plainly. He kept his words to a minimum so that he can control his face.

Katsuki takes notice of this and takes a deep breath, ignoring it before trying again, "I care *a lot* about your feelings. And I just want us to work this out and be normal again. I want you to stay with me. Don't you get what I'm trying to get at?" Fuck, nothing he was saying had the impact he wanted it to. He was trying to be civil, romantic, all of the fucking shit that he hears people say in movies, all without saying commiting to it.

Izuku shakes his head again, "I don't, Kacchan," He says, tiredly, "I don't."

Katsuki will be the first person to advocate raging, letting your anger shine, and accepting your negative emotions, but Katsuki also knew that with love confessions, people didn't usually do that. In all the love confessions he's seen, aside from Izuku's, it's been sweet, and romantic, kind, and soft. He thought that maybe bringing the boy up here to this cliff might make him more brave and make the scene a bit more romantic, but it looked like everything he's saying and everything he's doing was having no impact.

His borrowed words, mimicked after those swashbuckling romantic leads that always sweep their lover off their feet with the ' *I need you* 's and ' *Stay with me* ' *"* felt lazy and pieced together with no context. His restricted emotions didn't feel like *him* , but love confessions aren't supposed to be angry and full of rage, so what choice did he have. And even now, it felt like Izuku was responding in the most curt way possible.

At the blankness of Izuku's response, Katsuki throws Izuku a frustrated look and wipes at his mouth even though nothing is there, "Why are you being so fucking curt with me, damnit?" Katsuki had tried to keep a calm demeanor this entire time. He still was, but it was slipping.

Izuku's eyes widened, and then he looked down again, "Kac-"

"Everything I've said so far, you've given me half-assed curt answers," Katsuki said in frustration, "I know I'm not fucking great at this, but *damnit* , try to work with me here!"

Izuku gave him an accusatory look and turned halfway, "You don't get to say that when you've given me half-assed responses, and then expect me to know what to do with them!"

"It's all that I can say right now!" Katsuki says, knowing that it wasn't true, but it was all he's willing to say, out of his own fear of vulnerbility still embedded in him.

"Then what do you expect me to do?" Izuku asks, begging for a reasonable answer.

"I-" Katsuki tries to think. Why couldn't Izuku just read his damn mind, goddamnit, "I fucki-"

"Kacchan, tell me if it makes sense. You take me here, and you tell me that you need me, that you want me to stay, and that you don't want to hurt my feelings, and with just those three pieces of information, I'm supposed to deduct something from that? How can I?" Izuku asks.

"God! I know! I fucking know it's stupid," Katsuki was frustrated too, at himself and at Izuku. Why can't the fucking boy get it without him having to say all of the *real* words? Katsuki wasn't prepared for how hard that actually was, and now that he was here, he wanted to avoid it, "But can't you fucking see I'm trying?"

"And can't you see that I'm exhausted!" Izuku replied passionately, as the emotions on his face begin to spill out of his eyes through the first droplet of the night. And goddamnit, Izuku had been trying so hard not to do it tonight during this conversation, and his voice lowers in volume as he brokenly asks, "Do you know...how exhausted I am?"

Katsuki doesn't say anything, and just lets the three seconds of silence wash over them, as the wind blows some dust up onto their ankles.

"People...expect me to do all the kind things, all the things that nice boys do," Izuku looks down, with watery eyes as he speaks, "But at what point am I allowed to be a little selfish? Am I…" His voice cracks, "supposed to be patient forever? Even if I understand completely that this is difficult for you, does that mean I am now obligated to sit here, and let myself get cut a little deeper everytime you fumble on what you want to say? H-How is that fair?"

Katsuki swallowed heavily, understanding where Izuku was coming from, but still desperate not to let him go regardless, but apparently, not desparate enough to lay it all on the line.

"I've gone through this pain a million times already Kacchan. If not in these repeated conversations with you, then in every waking moment I have and then later again in my dreams. I've relived this pain a *million* times." Izuku then looks up at him with watery eyes.

Katsuki, desperate for Izuku to not go away, asks him one more time, "Then relive it a million and one times. Just give me one more time, Izuku."

"Kacchan," Izuku closed his eyes to stop the tears from falling. Katsuki comes in, desparate.

"Goddamnit! When couples fight, they're patient with each other," Katsuki began to compare frustratingly, "They wait for one another, and they're willing to go through a little bit more pain just so that they'll be okay, damnit. Why can't you!"

Izuku couldn't believe what Katsuki was asking of him at the moment.

"Because we're not a couple!" Izuku looked at him with incredulous eyes, now crying, "We're not a couple, Kacchan! You know why couples do that? Why they can wait forever?

Why they're willing to take this kind of pain? Because they know how each other feel. They can wait for an eternity and take all the pain in the world, because both people know that at the end of the day, their goal is fueled by mutual love for one another."

Izuku wipes the humidity and wetness away from his cheeks, "It's easy to sit in pain when you know that the other person loves you! It's easy to wait a million years when you know that the person you're waiting for is going to come back to you. Kacchan, don't you understand? I don't have that…" His voice tapered out at the end.

"I don't have that assurance," Izuku shakes his head, ripping away at his heart, "I don't know how you *feel* , Kacchan. And you do anything else but tell me! You can tell me that you don't want me to leave and all of these sweet words that make me want to cave in, but you've never once told me how you feel for a fact. And that's why I can't just stand here and take it all and know that it will be all okay in the end. Because I *don't* . I *don't* know if it will be okay in the end. And that scares me, Kacchan." His voice goes soft, and he refuses to look at the other.

Katsuki knows that it's now or never. God, it's now or never. And yet, it still doesn't feel right. Izuku's going to leave. He's going to leave again, and this time, the blonde had a feeling, he wasn't coming back. This was his very last chance, and he needed to say something that's worth more than some worthless lines that he modelled after movies and everyone else's relationships but their own. He's so frustrated with himself. God, he never hated himself more than he did right then. Why can't he *say* anything, fuck. It just didn't feel right. None of this conversation felt right.

"Katsuki, why are we here," Izuku whispered, opening his eyes up to Katsuki one more, and swimming inside those beautiful green eyes was a sense of finality. Conclusion. And that threw Katsuki into panic mode once again. The softness of Izuku's tone, the airiness with how he carried himself, it felt so final. More than other times. And Katsuki feels the panic rising again.

"No, no, don't say that," Katsuki shook his head, and scooped Izuku's smaller hands up in his own, rubbing his palm and trying to make Izuku stay for the fiftieth time, "We're here because we care about each other. Because we don't want this to end like this. We don't want it to end like this, right? Don't say that, Deku. Don't ask that."

But Izuku already had his eyes closed in pain, and gently shakes Katsuki off, prying his hands away, before turning back towards the car, "We need to head home, Kacchan," He says quietly in a broken voice, "It's been a long day. You've worked very hard for this tournament, and now, you need some rest."

But Katsuki doesn't move from his spot. Even when Izuku begins to walk towards the car, the blonde doesn't move from his spot.

Instead, Katsuki stands there, simmering in the disaster of it all. His formulated plans of taking Izuku somewhere pretty, and sweeping the nerd up off his feet with some smooth lines were destroyed by the reality that life never was that easy. And that even though he can recognize now that he was in love with Midoriya Izuku, it didn't make confessing or expressing that emotion any easier, especially when he is still struggling to come to terms with being able to love someone *well* .

And so, he had tried to compensate for this difficulty, by just spitting out words, any words, that seem like they'd work. That might mean something. But everything that came out sounded emotionless, impactless.

He's tried to be civil about this, keep himself under control. Because love was supposed to be a beautiful emotion, wasn't it? It was supposed to be happy, and joyous, and wonderful. And it was Izuku all this time who had taught him to embrace those positive emotions, which is what he was trying to do now.

Because love was a positive emotion, yes? And yet, it wasn't working. It didn't feel right. It didn't feel like *him* , which probably contributed to why it feels so hard to say it. Katsuki was an angry person, he was a rageful one, and a intensely fierce individual. And although he knew that was generally okay and should be accepted, he thought that for this...for *love* , he should switch to his more tame, civil side.

But now he saw how that turned out. And so, as Izuku continues to walk towards the car, Katsuki feels the frustration and the anger that is so inherent to him build up again. He feels it in his fingertips first, the tingling and restlessness to punch something, throw something, to act out. It travels up his arms, through his legs, and settles itself deep into his chest. His anger and rage at himself, at the situation at hand. And it connects all together at his head, where it's the most concentrated.

In Izuku's case, the greenette at this point knows it was okay to be angry and frustrated once in while but to still be true to yourself. And for Izuku, 'true to yourself' means to be kind, and sweet, because he truly was so naturally, and to be a generally positive person. Life was about balance after all.

In Katsuki's case, the blonde can say he was the opposite. That he *can* be kind, and sweet, but it's important to still be true to *hisself* . And in Katsuki's case, "true to yourself" is this. It's this anger and frustration within him, the harshness, and brash behavior. The one that didn't care what he was going to say, the one that flung his emotions everywhere and acted out. Once again, life was about balance.

And for a moment there, as he's feeling himself drop the whole idea that love was sweet, pure, and beautiful, and settles into his skin of frustration, exasperation, and intensity, Katsuki wonders if there's any chance at all that *love* could also be like this. If it could be angry, as much as it was sweet. If it could be aggressive, as much as it can be gentle. If it can be as ugly and messy, as it can be beautiful. And he wonders if love has a place amongst aggression and ferocity, not just with tenderness and purity that he sees in movies.

Because right now? Katsuki doesn't know of any other damn way he could have express it.

Izuku can barely feels his legs as he walks back to the car. It was like jelly, as it usually did every time he has an intense conversation with Katsuki. The blonde will forever have the ability to make him feel all the emotions in the world, no matter how much he tries to safeguard against it. Izuku remembers the sweet days of driving around in the athlete's car, finding some new adventure to behold, drinking a capri sun they bought for a barely any money at all at the corner grocery, or maybe even eating a gas station sandwich covered in

seran wrap while sitting in the trunk overlooking some pretty sight. And all of those memories make walking away hurt more.

At this point, he's walked away many times. And you'd think it gets easier after each time, but in fact, it's the contrary. Because after each time, Izuku begins to wonder if this will ever end. If he'll ever get to escape this cycle, or if he'll just find another way to end up in one of these heartbreaking conversations with Katsuki.

Izuku gets closer to the car, and he could see that Katsuki left the keys on the hood from where he was sitting earlier. Reaching over to grab them, Izuku tries to force himself to calm down and do anything but go running back into those arms. And he shuffles towards the driver's side, intending to sit there until Katsuki comes back to the car, and he can drive them home.

But as he was doing so, Izuku hears rustling behind him. Rustling that wasn't exactly getting closer, and so it wasn't as if Katsuki was coming closer to him. It looked like the blonde was doing something behind him, for the rustling continues for a little while longer. It was the sound of clanging is what it was, and then it stopped.

And Izuku paid it no further attention, just continued to head over to the driver's side door, which was left open, and with a heavy heart, trudged forward. Until he heard something over the crickets chirping and the gentle wind blowing.

It was quiet, so much so that Izuku would definitely have missed it if he had kicked at the dirt while walking any louder, but still, he heard it nevertheless.

From a barely stable, but quiet voice, Izuku listens as Katsuki says.

"I wish…" A moment of hesitation, before the voice picks up again, "that mint chocolate chip ice cream gets banned from ice cream shops around the country."

And then the sound of a rock hitting and bouncing off several times from the cliff commenced.

*Huh* ? Izuku was so disoriented from the drastic and confusing change of topic that he completely stopped in his tracks. Mint chocolate chip ice cream? That was...random.

This was the cliff of wishes after all, but this sudden change of topic was jarring. So much that Izuku found himself turning around to see what in the world Katsuki was doing. His eyes confused and a little curious. The blonde was standing there where he left him, wearing the varsity jacket and a pair of ripped jeans. Izuku could only see the back of Katsuki's head, and in arm arm, the boy had a rock in his hand. And in the other hand, he had a couple more gathered there. The previous rock hit the bottom, and the echoing stops.

"I wish…" Katsuki hesitates again, before stepping back once again getting in position, "that Careless Whisper could be taken off of all music platforms and all radio channels."

And then he throws the rock. It clangs into the sides of the cliff upon impact, and bounces off several more times, echoing as it goes down. Izuku swallows. *Careless...Whisper?* He knew

that the blonde was referring to the song of course, but this randomness was still bewildering to him, and he doesn't even know how to react. And so, Izuku just stands there watching.

Katsuki takes another rock from his left hand, and then bounces it upwards on his right hand as he thinks.

"I wish that," Katsuki steps back once more, and gets himself ready, "I'd fucking remember to get my car tire pressure fixed before I get that annoying notification on the dashboard that keeps blinking red."

And then, he throws the rock again. And waits for it to get to the bottom. Katsuki then looks up to the sky, as if asking if the gods granting these wishes were listening. And then, he turned his head back for just a moment to look at Izuku, and in that moment, the greenette could see the clear frustration in those red eyes.

Katsuki turns back around, and grabs the last rock in his left hand, "I wish Coach Shugo would get a damn girlfriend so he finds something better to do than blow up my phone bitching to me about shit." He throws the rock. This one was bigger, and makes a loud sound as it travels down the cliff.

Katsuki jumps in place, getting his adrenaline pumping, and cracked his neck from side to side. Izuku just watched in confusion and his grip on the car keys got tighter.

The athlete then bent down and picked up a rock, before swinging his arm back.

"I wish that Richard Marx didn't have to play everytime something shitty was going to happen." He chuckles deeply at this one, even though there was barely any humor laced in his tone, and he throws the rock. Izuku blinked at those words. Richard Marx. That was an iconic one, and shows up in their playlists more often than not. And the songs are usually ruined for him afterwards, Katsuki was right about that, Izuku realizes. That said, he was still confused. What was Katsuki doing?

"I wish," Katsuki begins, this time with another chuckle, and steps back again, "That my grandpa was around more often growing up. To tell me more about how to sweep people off their feet and what songs to play at the perfect moments." *To tell me I can love* , "Maybe I'd be a different person if he was."

Izuku's green eyes widened as he listens, and watches Katsuki throw the rock with a little more ferocity this time. There was a bit more anger and intensity in that throw, and it hits the cliff edges loudly. Katsuki's grandfather. He wasn't like any of Kacchan's other family members, Izuku knew that. His grandfather was an old soul, a romantic one. And saw things in Katsuki that many others never saw or could never see until much later. Izuku knew that much. But to hear Katsuki now express with a sense of frustration in his voice about how he might have been a different person if it were true, Izuku feels like this was one of the rather first times he got to delve deep into Katsuki's head. And see what his wishes were, and his internal desires.

"I wish I was driving on some lonely road with you right now, karaoking to a cheesy Madonna song, not knowing where we'll end up in an hour and not giving a fuck either,"

Katsuki laughs, but the way he bends down, picks up the next rock, and throws it showed anything but humor. It was aggressive. Katsuki threw it with such force, that his body slightly swung to the left after he let it go.

Izuku's lips parted as he listened along. And god, how he wished that too. Fuck, he wished that they could without all of this pain between them preventing him from doing so. And fu-

"I wish I was a better person," Katsuki laughs again, and picks up another rock, chucking it even harder than he did before, and when he let go, Izuku could see that the blonde's hands were shaking. And there was a hint of anger in his voice, raw unfiltered anger. Izuku was speechless. Better person?

Katsuki ran both of his hands through his hair, and keeps his arms on the back of his head there for a moment, taking a deep breath, but not one that seemed aimed to calm himself down. Instead, the breath looked like it was aim to fuel himself further.

The blonde bends down to pick up a couple more rocks in his left hand, and just one in his right throwing arm, "I wish that the green of the trees didn't always remind me of your eyes, and that the pink of the sunsets here didn't always remind me of your lips, and the blue of the damn ocean didn't always remind me of that stupid shirt you always like to wear. Because I know that I'll never be able to look at that shit the same if you walk away from here tonight, which you very well could."

Katsuki spoke with such vigor that it glued Izuku to his spot.

"Kacc-" Izuku began, voice soft.

But Katsuki stopped him before he could, tone laced with frustration and fervor, "No. You've poured yourself out to me a million times, and I've never been able to say shit in return." Katsuki takes another rock into his hand, and stared forward at the view, "It's my damn turn. All I ask if that you listen."

And then he preps his arm for another throw, as his teeth almost seeth the words, "I wish..." He says, "I didn't push everyone away for fucking decades to the point where I convinced myself that I'll never be able to pull someone close."

There was so much hatred, frustration, and anger in those words, that it caused a shiver down Izuku's spine as he listens to Katsuki let out his internal strife. And for this odd little twilight zone they had going on, Izuku feels as if their thoughts and feelings, their perspectives, were being more transparent with each other. Like for one of the very first times, Izuku didn't have to wonder what Katsuki Bakugo was thinking. Like he didn't have to want to switch perspectives in order to understand, like he was coming into Katsuki's thoughts.

"I wish," He begins again, "that I was selfless enough to bring an extra drink to practice , so that you don't have to keep spending a dollar every thursday to get me one, but I don't because of the very reason that I *know* you're gonna get me one," Katsuki once more laughs at this, but the way he fiercely chucks the wishing rock down the cliff showed just how much everything effected him.

And Izuku found himself staggering two steps forward, towards Katsuki. His fingertips dying to reach out to the blonde.

“I wish that I wasn't like this,” Katsuki’s voice raised, and he got even rougher with his throws, settling into his anger.

The blonde knew his fingertips were shaking, but he didn’t care. He was coming into a strange understanding. Love was not just all the fluff, the sweeping of the feet, the pretty moments. Love can be angry, fierce, full of frustration, and it can get real ugly. And seeing as he was about to lose Izuku, Katsuki was willing to let it get as ugly as it can get.

Izuku swallowed heavily, hearing the conflict that brewed inside of Katsuki’s head. *I wish that I wasn’t like this* . Izuku didn’t know what to even say to that. Like what? He could hear such clear pain and desperation, more so than he had before, in Katsuki’s voice. And Izuku knew that the Katsuki from 5 minutes ago was not the Katsuki he was talking to now. This one was unhinged, ready to give it all up, and lay it all on the line.

And although Izuku knew just how difficult it must have been for the other to do, he couldn’t help but think that they *both* needed this.

Katsuki’s voice broke out of anger and frustration at his next words, “I wish I didn’t make you cry.” He throws the rock. It breaks into two upon impact, because then, Izuku heard two different bounces as the pieces go down.

The blonde gets even more intense and overwhelming, “I wish it was fucking easier for me to tell you shit, so that you don’t go home after we hang out wondering if I’m thinking about you still,” Katsuki follows up with a broken, “Because I do, Izuku. You’re all I fucking think about.” He still doesn’t look at Izuku, who takes another staggered few steps towards the blonde.

“I wish the world didn’t fuck me up,” Katsuki angrily throws another rock, “Because I know this ain’t all my fault, even if a lot of it is,” His tone breaks again, but there was still a lot of roughness to it, “If it didn’t...then maybe,” Katsuki takes a labored breath, “Maybe we wouldn’t be in this mess.”

Katsuki moves spots, because all the rocks in his surroundings before were gone, and he picks up another one, “I fucking wish,” Katsuki’s angered breathing turns into one that sounded like he was about to break down again, but if that happens then so be it, “I fucking wish,” He repeats with a broken but strong voice, “that every time we speak nowadays, I don’t have to wonder if it’ll be the last time.” He clutches his chest through the white shirt he was wearing underneath the varsity jacket, as if it would make the pain go away. And Katsuki feels the first tear leave his eyes, but his resolution was still firm, and it didn’t matter if he had a breakdown right then, he was going to fucking get through his conversation.

Izuku was already crying by now, shoulders shaking, as he listens to the emotions laced in every single syllable of Katsuki’s words. He held himself, but it didn’t stop the shaking of his body as silent tears stream down his face. It feels as if the distance, the ever constant distance, between them was getting smaller and smaller. As if the curtains are getting thinner.

As if the glass was being taken down. And Izuku didn't expect for it to feel this painful and cathartic at the same time.

Izuku takes a couple more steps towards Katsuki, and at this point, the blonde hears it behind him. And finally, Katsuki turns only slightly to look at him. And Izuku could see then the amount of emotion swimming through the athlete's expression, and he could see tears that he's never ever seen before silently falling, but Katsuki doesn't let it stay long, wiping it away instantly with his free hand.

Izuku walks forward a little more, until he was only about three feet away, both of them in a moment of crisis. But now that Izuku was here, Katsuki could say this to his face. He swallows.

"I wish," Katsuki throws his head back up to the sky and takes another labored breath, before looking back down at Izuku's eyes, "that I could have told you how much I love your *beautiful* , creepy ass eyes before you began to convince yourself that I never could." Katsuki lets out a pained chuckle at this, as he refuses to look away from those watery forest green globes that he could stare into forever.

Izuku cries harder at this, because it didn't feel real. When he read it in Katsuki's final paper, it didn't make any sense. It made no sense at all. But with Katsuki's words now, with his outburst, the picture was coming together. And when Katsuki tells him now that his eyes were beautiful, it's a cathartic moment. Cathartic because to finally hear these things spoken to him after nights and nights of dreaming about it made him feel like a long lost fantasy that he's given up on was coming true. And he doesn't know how he could fall in love with Katsuki more.

From the left hand, which still held three rocks, Katsuki didn't throw it this time. Instead, as if his body was calming down from the rage, Katsuki simply opens two of his fingers, and lets one slip off the edge, and fall down. Two left.

Katsuki steps forward, and brings a hand up to wipe away at a tear resting on Izuku's freckled cheeks, and tells Izuku with a soft voice, "I wished that in that lighthouse, I could have told you that making love to you was easier than breathing to me."

The tenderness with which Katsuki said that completely broke Izuku's ability to function, and the greenette can barely comprehend it all. *Easier than breathing* . The Lighthouse. Izuku remembers the pain he felt that night, hearing that he wasn't loved by the other, that them making love wasn't real. All of this was swarming in his head for the longest tim-

Katsuki lets go of his cheek, and turns back forward towards the cliff. He lets one rock go. And he has one left. Katsuki gets a hold of himself, and he takes a while. Izuku just stands there, watching as Katsuki brings himself together and stands up straight, letting out a deep breath. The wind picks up a little, and Katsuki closes his eyes for a second. Under the moonlight, his blonde hair looks beautiful and little stray pieces blow in the breeze. The crickets sing for them, and the occasional hoot of an owl sounded off from the treeline. Underneath their feet, there were no rocks to be found, all thrown by Katsuki at the bottom of the cliff as he listed off his wishes one by one. And now. Katsuki opens his eyes, feeling it in his gut that this should be his final wish, and looks forward.

Katsuki brings this final rock up to his lips, and kisses it as it if was more special than the rest. And then, he steps back, bringing his arm back ready to throw.

“And as selfish as it is,” Katsuki prefaces, pulling his arm back further as he stares forward, “I wish…”

Izuku holds his breath.

“I wish,” Katsuki thinks on it, “that you won’t ever fall out of love,” And then oddly enough, Bakugo Katsuki chuckles just twice before speaking with determination.

“Because I know I won’t.” He finishes.

And then, he throws the rock. His final wish, down the cliff. It falls, bounces three or four times, and then silent.

And it was a silence that was *so* much so that you could hear a pin drop. Katsuki stares forward, and Izuku’s eyes were on him, wide and frozen.

*I wish that you won’t ever fall out of love, because I know I won’t. I wish that you won’t ever fall out of love, because I know I won’t. I wish that you won’t ever fall out of love, because I know I won’t. I wish that you won’t ever fall out of love, because I know I won’t. I wish that you won’t ever fall out of love, because I know I won’t. I wish that you won’t ever fall out of love, because I know I won’t. I wish that you won’t ever fall out of love, because I know I won’t.*

It felt like the only thing Izuku was able to do was repeat those words like a neverending mantra. All he could hear was those words. All he could *feel* was those words. All he could see were those words. It didn’t even make sense, but ever single fiber of his soul had been aching for some rendition of those words for the longest time, that right now, every single inch of his being clung onto those words. I wish that you won’t ever fall out of love, because I know I won’t. I won’t. *I won’t. I won’t.* Fuck. Fuck. Izuku knew what this meant. He did. He could connect the dots, he could. But he couldn’t believe it is what’s happening. He can’t. He can’t. After all of this time, after convincing himself that it’ll never happen, to hear this now. It didn’t feel real.

“Tell me now,” Katsuki then says, finally turning towards Izuku and stepping forward, “Do you see what I’m trying to get at?”

It was the same words from less than 30 minutes ago. And yet, the meaning came out completely different. However long ago when they first got up here on the cliff and Katsuki had asked that, there was no *way* Izuku would have figured out what he was trying to get at. It was a mess of confusion, and hurt, and whatever else.

But now, after this entire sequence of events, it was still a mess. But rather than a mess of confusion, it instead feels like they were standing on the rubble of the aftermath,

understanding the pieces and what role it plays, now trying to figure out how to build up again from the ashes of their beautiful destruction.

Izuku couldn’t even say anything, all he could do was begin to cry again. Because it didn’t feel real. It didn’t feel *real* .

“What?” Izuku’s voice came out in a whisper, and it feels like he was dreaming. If this was truly a dream, then the universe was playing some kind of sick joke on him, "No..."

"Why not?" Katsuki asks, keeping himself calm after letting himself go moments earlier.

Izuku shook his head, "This isn't...this isn't-"

"Real?" Katsuki finishes, laughing airly into the night atmosphere, "I couldn't believe it either. To ever think that I was able to love someone. Took me a while to realize too, you know."

Izuku was speechless, and his legs were tempted to buckle.

"But it's real," Katsuki says breathlessly, "I promise you it is."

The boy in question still couldn't believe it. His head was swarming with doubt. Maybe he interpreted it wrong. Maybe Katsuki meant something else, even though the blonde made it clear. At this point, Izuku was so habituated into thinking he'll never be mutually loved by the blonde that this felt like a break in the simulation, like it wasn't actually happening to him. And he's internally a mess.

"Kacchan," Izuku says, eyes still wide in shock, and all he could say once more was "What?"

“I said,” Katsuki speaks carefully, and raises one hand up to once more rest on Izuku’s cheek, “That I *wish* you won’t ever fall out of love with me, because I know I won’t.”

Izuku shakes his head, “I don’t unders-”

“Yes you do,” Katsuki reassures him, understanding how this could feel unreal right now, because it barely felt real to him. It had been so difficult before to say it, but after letting out *everything* else, it was only then that it felt right to tell Izuku, and the feeling was indescribable.

"N-No," Izuku refutes, "No I don'-"

"Yes you do," Katsuki says again gently, “Don’t think about other ways that I could have meant it. Just take it as it is, Izuku. I’ve been cryptic for the longest time, but believe me now when I say I couldn’t have been more clear.”

Izuku’s eyes search around Katsuki’s entire face, but the blonde kept his eyes straight into Izuku’s green ones, swiping a thumb gently across those soft cheeks, and repeats with firmness, as a feeling of relief settles into his chest, “So let me repeat myself one more time, nerd. I wish that you won’t ever fall out of love with me, because I won’t,” He takes a pause,

“As in. I won’t fall out of love with you. Because Midoriya Izuku, to hell with it, I’m in love with everything that you are and everything that you’ll ever be.”

Izuku’s jaw was dropped to hear it framed like that, and he's silent for the longest time, just staring up at Katsuki.

And when he speaks, his voice barely comes out with sound, "You...love me?"

Katsuki stares back into the eyes of the boy he adored to no end, "More than anything."

Izuku then looks down, eyes far away, as he repeats it, this time to himself with a shocked voice, "You...love me."

Katsuki takes a step forward and leans his head to make Izuku look at him, but the boy looked anywhere else, so Katsuki tells him again, "I do, Izuku."

Suddenly, as it all sinks in somewhat, everything is overwhelming and he couldn’t help but cry even more. Kacchan loved him. Kacchan *loves* him. And the fact hasn’t settled in completely, and how can it? Like a rain shower coming in to relieve a drought, like food given to an empty stomach, like the stars showing again after a year of clouds, Izuku gets bombarded with emotions he couldn’t handle so well right now. The shock mixed with happiness and disbelief was too much that his chest and mind threatened to explode. It didn’t matter if he didn’t know what to do now. It didn’t matter that they have *no* clue how to navigate from this point forward or pick up the pieces. Katsuki loves him. And lord knows by now that he loved the blonde. To finally, after so long of convincing himself it would never happen, know that the feeling was mutual was indescribable.

And all Izuku could say in response was, “Don’t look at me, Kacchan.” Through his tears.

Katsuki laughs lightly, and plays with a lock of Izuku’s hair, looking softly at the shorter boy, “Why not, nerd.”

“I look ugly when I cry,” Izuku shakes his head, closing his eyes.

“No, nope,” Katsuki puts both hands on Izuku’s cheeks and lean their foreheads together, “Don’t look away from me. I don’t want those eyes to ever look away from me again.”

Izuku shakes his head, but doesn’t move away from Katsuki, “This isn’t real. This isn’t real.” He whispers to himself.

“It’s real,” Katsuki whispers back, wanting to be closer to Izuku, “And I’m so fucking sorry I couldn’t have said it earlier, *fuck* . And I’m so fucking sorry that it took this damn long for me to get my shit together. But I promise you, nerd, this is real.”

Izuku peeks his eyes open, and stares up at the taller male, a little bit of snot running down his nose and tears making his eyes bloodshot, “When? How? I d-don’t -” He could barely speak, “Why?”

Katsuki continues to wipe away at Izuku’s tears, “When? Once I fucking got over the illusion that I couldn’t love anyone. Once you began to leave and I hated every second without you,”

He chuckles with a reminiscent pain in his voice.

“How? Why?” Katsuki smiles and closes his eyes as well, both with their foreheads still resting together, “Izuku, no matter how high I fly, I’ll never be as close to heaven as I am when I’m with you. That’s fucking why.”

Katsuki loved him for all of the reasons that exist in the universe, and to come to an understanding of this is a special moment for the both of them. Because Izuku made music more beautiful, for every lyrics reminded him of the greenette. Because Izuku took the person he was, and unlike other people, who had given up on him, Izuku cultivated his kindness, his gentleness, while not minding the natural brashness of Katsuki’s personality. Because Izuku loved him when he thought he was unlovable. Because Izuku’s eyes were as beautiful as any gem and any diamond, and his lips were sweeter than any dessert and any sugar. Because when he goes to sleep, Katsuki still smells the salt water and lily off of Izuku’s hair, and still hears the pretty sound of that laugh he craves so much. Because Izuku was sweet, kind, and strong in ways that Katsuki wasn’t, yet is still full of energy, life, and fierceness when it comes down to it.

Izuku looked up at the blonde now, love swimming in his eyes, and it’s like he can’t breathe.

“I hear a lot from people that…” Izuku says through his hiccups, “falling in love was the best decision they’ve ever made. But..” The greenette looked down, “But it never felt like I *had* a decision to make. You came in with your smile, and your adventures, your ridiculous life lessons, and I had no choice but to fall in love with you,” Izuku reaches a hand up to hold onto Katsuki’s wrist, as the blonde stroked his cheek, “You know what the funny thing is though?”

Katsuki doesn’t say anything.

“Even if I had a choice,” Izuku cries, “I think I still would have chosen to love you. Even when I accepted that I needed to get over you, even when all of this went down the drain and it hurt like hell, I never regretted loving you one bit. Because even if you never loved me back, loving you has made me a better person. And loving you has made living more beautiful, knowing that there are people like you in the world.”

Katsuki feels his heart beat faster at the words, and all he wants to do is kiss the boy.

“T-The point of me telling you this,” Izuku sniffles, “is so that you know how much this means to me. So you can't lie to me about this, Kacchan. You can't. I won't be able to handle it if you're lying.” The greenette says before crying some more.

Katsuki pulls him into a hug then and rocks Izuku, telling the other, “Come on, don’t say that, nerd,” He whispers, “I'm not lying, damnit. And don’t say it like I’m doing you a favor by loving you. You’ve fucking changed my life, give yourself some credit,” And he buries his face into Izuku’s soft hair, grateful to be smelling lilies again, “And I know you’ll probably want to argue otherwise, but…”

Katsuki thinks about it, and continues, speaking genuinely, “I don’t think anyone else but you could have shown me what it meant to love.”

Izuku breaks down even more, barely being able to handle the first wave of unbelievable words, only to get hit with more and more.

“Fuck, don’t cry,” Katsuki says as he holds Izuku tighter.

Izuku shakes his head, and holds onto the taller boy, “K-Kacchan, how can I not right now?”

Katsuki backs away for a moment and wipes at the smaller’s face, “How do I make you laugh again. I’m sick of making you cry.”

Izuku looked up at the other, “I-It’s okay now though. Because I-I’m not crying out of s-sadness.”

“Doesn’t matter,” Katsuki mutters, “I want to hear you laugh because of me again.”

Izuku takes his hand and holds it up to his cheek, a gaze of adoration and disbelief at his reality in his eyes, and he whispers, “Kacchan, it’s okay.”

But the blonde was already in the process of thinking. He wanted to make the boy laugh, to start this new leaf off with joy and happiness. Something that he’s been absolutely shit at. If he could at least end this night making Izuku laugh, then he could go to sleep easy. Throughout their entire friendship, Katsuki’s hounded on Izuku for being cheesy. For always saying sappy shit that could be considered borderline embarrassing. But maybe while he’s on this train of emotions, he could give up a little bit of his pride and be the cheesy one for once.

Katsuki begins to speak, and at first, Izuku didn’t get it. There was something weird all right, but the odd speech pattern Katsuki was giving off could very well just be part of his imagination.

“You know, nerd,” Katsuki kicks away his pride, “When I first realized that Somebody’s Watching Me,” Katsuki calls back a reference to one of the very first songs they listened to together that night they went to the firefly lake, “I thought you were a Maniac.” Again, another reference, this time, to the Michael Sambello track they listened to while they were driving on the way to Dolly for the theatre.

Izuku just listened, hearing Katsuki emphasize certain words, but not really picking anything up yet. His shoulders still shook as he buried his face in Katsuki’s chest.

“And then the damn project started, and *fuck* , I’ve never been more grateful for that shitty old teacher in my life,” Katsuki says, head holding up towards the sky as he cringes at his next words, all to maybe make Izuku laugh, “Because Time After Time, the more I was with you, the more you Take My Breath Away.”

And that’s when Izuku knew something was up. The grammar was butchered. The more you *Take* my breath away, rather than *Took* my breath away, almost like Katsuki was saying the name of the song by Berlin that was played the night Katsuki brought the dance to him. Was he…? Izuku’s thought drifted off, and he was still sniffling.

“And no matter how many times I thought to myself I’m Not In Love,” Katsuki calls out the song he played to himself on the ride home before his conversation with his mother, “And no matter how many Little Lies I told myself about how I felt, Heaven Only Knows the damn truth.” He was never going to live this down.

At this point, the sentences were so odd, that Izuku was picking up on what Katsuki was doing, and the greenette slowly pulled away, looking up at the athlete with a tear stained face, lips parted.

“Kacchan, are you…?” Izuku asked in a curious tone.

But with a red face, Katsuki just gives him a small grin and tucks a lock of hair behind Izuku’s ear, “Because *fuck* , for the first time, I understand what the songs I listen to mean. For the first time, I Want To Know What Love Is,” Katsuki turns back to the song they listened to in the ice cream parlour, “And I Want To Dance With Somebody. I want to whisk you away Into The Night and all of that stupid cheesy shit they do in movies.”

Izuku looks at Katsuki as if he was both an idiot and the most precious person alive and begins to laugh through his tears, “I can’t believe you call *me* cheesy.” He laughs.

And Katsuki grins at this, but keeps on going, seeing how it made Izuku smile, even at his own expense, “I don’t want to play these Wicked Games anymore. I don’t want to say Goodbye, I don’t want to fucking walk around these subjects like we’re Fragile. Because Nothing’s Gonna Change My Love For You,” Katsuki finds himself laughing as Izuku laughs and shakes his head.

“Kacchan, oh my god,” Izuku wipes at his eyes, “Stop!” He jokingly says.

But Katsuki pulls him closer, and forces Izuku to look at him, teasing the smaller into staring up at his grinning face. He didn’t plan on stopping just yet, “No matter how long it takes, I’ll be Right Here Waiting.” It was fitting that Katsuki ends with a Richard Marx song.

And Izuku is giggling now, with Katsuki watching that beautiful smile like it’s the first time he’s seeing it. He could listen to this forever.

To save Katsuki from further getting red in the face, Izuku looks up at the blonde adoringly and says with a laugh, “Okay, that’s enough.”

“Okay good, because I was running out of ideas,” Katsuki feigns relief, to which Izuku laughs again, and the blonde tells him, “Now that’s more like it…”

Izuku smiles, as Katsuki rubs his face. He missed having those hands caressing him like this. Nothing felt more right. And nothing that there was love laced in those fingers, in those words, in his red eyes, made it all the more special, that Izuku still couldn’t fully believe it. And it’s quiet again for a moment, while Izuku stops his crying. But there was still the occasional hiccup, but Katsuki found that a bit cute anyways. The crickets chirped, the clouds moved, and the car was probably full of bugs, but it didn’t matter.

“You know,” Izuku then whispered, “People say that beauty is inside. Beauty is grace. Beauty is kindness,” He repeats familiar words and he smiles up at Katsuki. It feels like a weight was lifted off of them, even if they still had a lot of things to work on, “I say all of that is bullshit.”

He laughs once he sees Katsuki recognize the words, but he continues anyways, deciding to be cheesy himself, “Beauty ain’t nothing but a pair of red eyes and a stupid smirk pushing me into lakes at night.” He repeats the same pattern of words from Katsuki’s final paper.

Katsuki recognizes the line, and for a second, just looks a little embarrassed before flicking Izuku on the forehead like he usually did, “Who the fuck let you read that?”

Izuku hiccups a little, “Mr. Toshinori. He only let me read that first line though.”

“Good,” Katsuki says, “The rest was cheesy as fuck. I’m never gonna let you touch that shit.”

Izuku laughs softly, “As cheesy as the speech you just gave me?”

“Nah,” Katsuki closed his eyes and shuddered, “Nothing’s ever gonna be as stupid as that. I’ve peaked.”

Izuku hums, and just looks up at the taller boy. Katsuki enjoys the way the moonlight casts itself onto Izuku’s face. He could see every freckle, every glimmer in his eyes, every lash. And he could honestly look at this face forever, and leave the rest of the world behind.

Finally, the doe eyed boy asks, words quiet as he wonders, “What now?”

Katsuki takes a moment to think. What now? The uncomfortable tension between them had felt so heavy, that now, without it, things feel almost disorienting. And he wasn’t sure what to think of it either. Just an hour ago, Katsuki for sure thought he was going to lose Izuku. To have him here, in his arms, with hopes and promises that everything will be alright, was more than he could ask for.

It wasn’t like everything that was wrong with them could be fixed with a simple *I love you* confession, and be done with it. In an idealistic world, that would be true. They still had things to sort out. They weren’t perfect. They weren’t before, and they aren’t now. But those steps can come later.

“Now?” Katsuki says, “I’m gonna figure out how to not be a shit boyfriend, which is pretty bare minimum, but cut me some slack, this shit is new to me. And we’re gonna pick up the pieces, and work with what we’ve got, yeah?”

Izuku finds this a good deal, even though he begs to differ on one thing, “That sounds good to me,” Izuku whispers, and adds, “But Kacchan, you were being a perfect man to me before already. The only thing that I hated was the ambiguity. But that’s not a problem anymore, right?” Izuku searches Katsuki’s eyes for confirmation that yes, he hadn’t been dreaming and that this *was* real, “So don’t worry about all that, okay?”

And that, Katsuki chooses to trust. The thought of being not just someone's, but *Izuku's* boyfriend made him internally giddy, and *damn* , did he feel like a little kid. Because Izuku was *his* lover, and vice versa. And to be able to call the smaller that without feeling weighed down by the tension between them brought him more internal happiness than he cared to admit. It was almost goofy, how giddy he was inside. They had a long history, for sure. A messy one. But the beautiful thing about history is that it continues to write. And as long as he had Izuku by his side, he's going to do his damn best to make sure their story ends well. Old and gray, with a couple of grandkids and a house out in Ise after they both retire. All of that cheesy shit, he wants it with Izuku.

"You haven't eaten dinner yet, have you," Katsuki asks, drying Izuku's face one more time.

Izuku, feeling himself getting reigned back in, slowly shakes his head, "No, but you haven't either, right?"

"I haven't," Katsuki replies, and looks over at the car, "It's getting late, you want to head back and grab something to eat?"

Izuku purses his lips, and admits to himself, "I...don't want to head back."

The athlete hums and thinks, placing a small kiss on Izuku's forehead, making the greenette blush even though they've shared far more intimate touches before.

"I want to…" Izuku swallows, "...catch up on what we missed." He also just did not want to leave Katsuki's side, afraid that the moment he did, all of this might disappear and he'll be left with himself again.

Katsuki rubs a hand on his upper back and suggests, "Should we book a room, then?"

Izuku cocks his head, "A room?"

The blonde then pats Izuku's shoulder and moves his head in the direction of the car, "Come on, let's head out."

Without really questioning, Izuku sniffles one last time and collects himself, following Katsuki over to the car, and handed the taller the keys once they both got settled in. Opening his phone, Izuku wasn't too surprised to see about a million messages. Many from his friends who wanted to know what the *fuck* was going on at the National Tournament today, others sending him videos of the clip of Katsuki climbing the arena caught on television, and his mom texting him a million times asking him if he was okay. This time, it was warranted considering the car was gone, and he was blowing up on the social medias of Ise parents. Inko must have seen by now where he was at, which was likely the reason why the cops weren't called to track him down.

Putting the car in drive, Katsuki takes them out of the mountains, and further out of Ise.

The drive there was quiet, but not in a tense way. In contrast, the quiet was necessary, for both of the boys to let everything that happened sink in, and take it piece by piece. After a long and winding conversation such as the one they just had, it was important to just sit in

silence for a little while afterwards and bask in the aftermath. The only sound was the radio playing quietly. Currently, the nice melody of If You Don't Know Me By Now by Simply Red played as they sit there quietly.

“Where are we going?” Izuku asked after they’ve been driving for a while. They were just about the only car out on the road, the stark contrast between the headlights and the dark surroundings was almost creepy.

To this question, the athlete only shrugs, “Not sure. I’m just gonna stop at the next place to rest I see. Didn’t want to stay too close to Ise. A lot of people like to gossip.”

Understanding, Izuku just sits back and lets him drive. The car just stays on the lonely road for a while, until it was clear that they were out of Ise. Instead, it looked like they were headed to a much more rural area, with forests and farmland on either side of them. At least in Ise, there were tiny shops and what not here and there, but out here, it was all trees, wheat, grass, and whatever else they were farming. Once in a while, there’d be a gas station, but for the most part, familiar emptiness surrounded them as the car drives along. They picked up some food from a slightly sketchy drive through as they kept going down the road, and it was enough to satisfy them until tomorrow.

Ultimately, sitting on the right side of the road, tucked down a small dirt path and surrounded by a couple acres of forestry, a sign hung overhead from a wooden post with an arrow leading in, reading Fin’s Bed & Breakfast.

Katsuki pulled into the little road, and followed the dirt path a couple hundred meters until up ahead, they could see a quaint two story bed and breakfast. The house still kept the old retro style, even though they were outside of Ise by now. A wrap around wooden porch decorated the place, and kerosene lamps hung over the arched doorway. There was a stone path leading up to the house, and there was a very quaint feeling associated with the entire place.

Parking his car next to someone else’s in what looked like a communal parking lot, the two of them exited and followed each other to the door. A boy that looked to be just one or two years younger than them welcomed the two of them inside, saying that his grandparents owned the inn since 1952, and giving a whole spiel as he shows them inside the house. It was charming, with a heavily decorated interior and a slightly rustic vibe, with the wooden cabinets, carpeted floors, and warm lighting throughout the entire bed and breakfast. There were dark red couches, and chess sets on the coffee table.

“Breakfast is served from 7 in the morning to 10 in the morning, but you’re welcome to use our kitchen whenever,” The host says, “How long will you be staying?”

Katsuki looks at Izuku, then answers, “Two nights or so.”

“That’s great! Do you have any preference for rooms? We have the Magnolia Room, which is on the furthest left suit-” He begins.

But Katsuki only had one criteria, “I want the room furthest away from anyone else’s.”

Izuku raises a brow.

“Oh,” The boy flushes, and takes the time now to look at Katsuki for the monstrous hunk of a man he was, and flushes some more when he turns over to Izuku, “In that case, let me show you to the Orchid Room.”

And so, they follow the boy as he moved through the house. The old wood floors creaked beneath their feet, and they looked at all the old portraits and photos framed up against the panelled walls of the hallway they were walking down. Give or take, this place, although beautiful and quaint, also looked like it could be haunted. At the turn of the hallway, the boy leads them up the stairs, and on the far right corner, opens the door to their room.

“Do you need anything else at the moment, sir?” He asked kindly.

Izuku turns to the boy and shakes his head, “Everything’s great right now, thank you!”

And they were left alone once more in this large room, that was, like the boy said, pretty separated from everyone else’s.

It was a nice and large room, with an arched glass window that had black out curtains on either side.

Immediately, the most notable feature of the room was the old upright piano that was lined up right next to the window. It was old, with keys that were probably out of tune, and a bit of chipping on the white keys. Above it were some sheet music from a book of Chopin pieces, and a vase with an orchid sat on top.

The view from the window was the back of the bed and breakfast, which consisted of a large plot of land, with a forest line that stretched on for a while. In the corner, there was a small pond that reflected the light of the moon, and when Izuku squinted further, he sees a small doe drinking from it. From the second floor, he can see above the treeline a little bit, but not far enough. However, it looked like the forest line went on for a while, before it seems to stop. He couldn’t be too sure, and would have to ask the owners of the bed and breakfast in the morning.

As for the room, a four poster bed with a mahogany frame was put up against a wall that had a painted mural on it of an orchid. In fact, there was a theme of orchids all over the room, with a fake orchid planted on top of the dresser, and orchid scented hand soap in the bathroom. The whole flower theme, and wallpaper was very, how to put it, retro. Other than the bed, piano, and dresser, the room had a lot of open space aside from a fireplace built into the wall. In this weather, there was no need to put it on, but it was a nice addition to the room.

“Two nights?” Izuku looked back towards Katsuki, who was setting down his gym bag on the floor, and closing the door behind them.

Katsuki hummed, raising his head then to look at Izuku dead in the eye with a small gleam in that ruby red, “One for just resting with you and catching up, and another for making love to you in the way you deserve.”

Izuku’s reds turned beat red instantly as his mouth gaped open at Katsuki’s response.

At this reaction, the blonde was quick to preface, “If you’re up for it, of course. I’m not gonna do shit you don’t want to.”

“No! I was just a little…” Izuku flushed, “Surprised, that’s all. I assumed that’s why you want the far room then?”

Katsuki laughs, “Maybe.” Katsuki swears his head isn't in the gutter already.

And then, the vaulter crosses the room and takes off his letterman, putting it on the edge of the bed before heading towards Izuku, taking the boy’s face into his hands.

“But tonight’s been a whole fucking lot,” Katsuki gets close and whispers to him, “And I don’t want to move too quick, so I just want to hold you tonight, yeah? And talk until my throat gets sore or until you fall asleep. And kiss you till my lips get chapped.”

Izuku leans up and flutters his eyes a couple times, whispering back as Katsuki steps a bit closer, flushing their bodies together, “I’m okay with that.”

Katsuki takes a good look at those pretty eyes, muttering a deep “ *Good* ,” Before he leans down to kiss Izuku. And they’ve probably done this a million times before, but none of it’s ever felt like this. Because this was a kiss full of love, and Izuku knew it. The slow pace at which Katsuki went at it, the soft caressing touches on his face, and the tenderness of it all. And Izuku knows that he will remember this feeling for an eternity. Lost in the sensation, Izuku takes in the sweet cherry flavor of Katsuki’s lips and the smell of the blonde’s skin. Oh, how he missed this. To think he almost never had this again.

Katsuki eventually pulls away, and Izuku keeps his eyes close for an extra few seconds to savor the feeling, before he opens them.

“I’m gonna take a shower, and get all this gross ass grime off of me, and then you got me all night, yeah?” Katsuki says, stepping backwards, and peeling off his shirt from the bottom, revealing his chiselled body that cut down to a sharp v-line, and Izuku wonders if he’ll ever really get over that.

And the boy nods, “I’ll join you in a moment.”

And so later into the night, after their bodies were freshly showered and the smell of orchid soap kissed their skin, the two lay in bed and savor every second like it was the last time they’ll get to do this, even though they knew it was only the beginning.

Whether this beginning had an end, who knew. Izuku understand full and well that reality wasn’t like in the movies, where the couple finally gets together and they live happily ever after. Katsuki knew this too. Inside, both of them understood that this--what they have--could easily become volatile. That some day along the road, it might be rocky. Even now, there were still ways for them to go, with themselves and with each other. But even if one day, they’re destined for different paths, Katsuki knows that he’ll never love like this again. And so, he’s going to take every second as it comes, and waste nothing.

Even tonight, neither wanted to go to sleep, afraid that this might not be real when they woke up in the morning.

It may be dramatic to say, yet Izuku feels as if they've gone through war together. And he thinks back to their conversation about which god they'd be. Him being aphrodite, the goddess of love, and Katsuki being ares, the god of war. It was funny how that played out. Because what better way to describe all of the shit they've put themselves through other than a war for love.

And it really did feel like it. And so now, as they lay together, Katsuki makes sure to interlace their fingers, and lay so that they were facing one another, so that he could look at Izuku while he speaks and vice versa. Quiet whispers were exchanged throughout the night, a little laugh here and there, and maybe at some point, a couple of tears as it hits them all over again just how much of a mess had to happen for the two of them to get to this point. Promises of forever were exchanged knowing that fate could write anything for their future. Sorries and thank yous that were never said loudly enough.

At some point, Izuku asked Katsuki in a whisper underneath the covers where they just lay cuddling and talking, "Are we going to be okay?"

To this, Katsuki had no doubt, as he placed a kiss on Izuku's lips, telling the other, "We're going to be okay.

It doesn't feel real. To have spent weeks building this immense tension, then have it fall into a horrid breaking point, just for tonight to end up how it did and for them to lay here by each other now. It didn't feel real, but hell, if they didn't fucking work for this moment. And so, even as the hours passed by and the clock above their heads tick into the morning, it was only when the black sky began to turn a slightly lighter blue that Katsuki, exhaustion from everything catching up to him, drifts asleep.

Right before Izuku joins him in their dreams, he closes the black out curtains before slipping back in.

Katsuki wakes up with a pain jolting up the left side of his body.

"Fuck!" The blonde yells out, and his eyes shot open as he turns over on his back, and sit up.

Izuku had dragged the sheets out so that Katsuki would fall on the floor and wake up, and it definitely worked because the boy in question was fuming at the sudden wake up. The curtains were now spread wide open and Katsuki could see in the back that the sun was a golden orange, looking to be about 6 o'clock or so. Give or take an hour and it will probably begin to set. He must have been fucking exhausted, from the tournament yesterday and the whole fiasco of last night, that he had slept like a baby all the way up to this point.

"What the *fuck* ," Katsuki groaned, throwing a pillow that had fallen off the bed at Izuku.

The boy in question laughed and caught it, and Katsuki was about to rage when he looks up and sees the boy with the brightest smile on his face, so wide that it reaches his eyes and crinkles at the edges. At the sight of that, and the freckled cheeks bunching up, Katsuki loses his breath and he forgets any annoyance he might have had prior.

“Sorry, Kacchan!” Izuku explained, “I tried to wake you up three times already, but you were dead asleep.”

Katsuki ran a hand through his wild hair and laid back on the floor, grabbing another pillow that fell and pressed his face back into the pillow, about to fall back to sleep on the floor.

“No, no,” Izuku whined, and bent down, grabbing Katsuki’s hand and began to drag the blonde up off the ground, “You can’t go back to sleep. You have to get up!”

Katsuki groans into the pillow, not budging, and instead, in one move, drags Izuku down to the floor with him and gathers the boy up in his arms, “Why,” He grumbled.

“Because! We have to get our day started,” Izuku frowned, and used his strength to pry Katsuki’s arms off of him, before pulling the blonde up again, “Get up, get up!”

After a couple more minutes of Izuku hounding the other, Katsuki then sits up and yells out a, “Fine, fine!”

Izuku laughs, not having felt this lighthearted in a bit, and gets up on his feet, “Great, go get ready. Shoo, shoo.”

Katsuki gets up off the ground and stretches, “What do you got planned, nerd.”

Izuku looks out the window towards the golden sun, and turned back to Katsuki, “You’ll see. Hurry up!” And then he points at the sun, “You. I’m gonna need you to slow down,” Izuku demands, “Don’t set yet.”

Katsuki’s brows raise at the familiarity of the words. He’s said them before, he was sure. At the hideaway. Aside from a couple of curse words, Izuku was almost mimicking him. And then, the greenette disappears out into the hallway, and Katsuki could hear footsteps stomping down the stairs. Katsuki goes into the bathroom and does all that he needed to do, and it takes a total of 15 minutes before he is dressed and downstairs where Izuku was talking to the boy from earlier.

“-nt-shaped boulder on the left, and you’ll see it immediately,” The boy was telling Izuku, who looked excited about something.

Nodding profusely, Izuku grinned, “Thank you.”

The greenette was wearing flip flops and on his back, Izuku was carrying a large, black, rectangle like box. And honestly, looked a bit heavy. But Izuku looked like he was handling it, and Katsuki knew the boy lifted heavy weights, so he’ll offer to help if the nerd got tired.

Katsuki walked forward, which caught Izuku’s attention, and the green eyed boy smiles gently, walking over to Katsuki.

“What’s with the box?” Katsuki asks him, gesturing towards the bulky thing.

“Oh this?” Izuku looked behind him, “Nothing. You’ll see.”

“Oi, you scheming something?” Katsuki flicked him on the forehead gently.

Izuku shook his head, “No, but let’s head out.”

And that was all the boy really had to say before dragging Katsuki out through the back sliding door of the bed and breakfast, and heading out into the woods that was situated in the back. The woods here were different than the ones back in Ise. The ground seemed to consist of a lot less dirt, and more rocks. Here and there, they’d see boulders of limestone too peeking out, and random rock formations as Izuku moves through. Using his phone as a compass, Izuku heads Northeast, and Katsuki would definitely say he was curious. A bit of sand was dusted on the forest floor too, even though they were far from the ocean.

He thought something about the geography of this place was a little different, but he didn’t think much about it. It was more flat out here, less mountainous for sure, but there was still a lot of trees with branches high up rather than lower down on the trunk. They kept on walking for a while, and up ahead, birds shook the tree leaves and the sun was turning into a deeper orange.

Although they were making lighthearted conversation as they walked, Katsuki could tell that Izuku was excited about something or getting to the location, for the nerd kept on craning his neck as if hoping to see something. It began to happen so often that ultimately, Katsuki had to straight up ask.

“Alright, Deku, tell me now. Where are you taking us,” Katsuki is eager to know.

As if waiting for him to finally ask, Izuku turns around and with a pretty smile, tells him simply.

“Showing you where the earth and the sky meet.”

Katsuki raised a brow, and had to ask, “And what the fuck does that mean.”

Izuku laughed, fueled by lots of energy, and drags Katsuki along, smelling it in the air already, “Come on, we’re close.”

And so, Izuku begins to run towards the smell. And Katsuki picks it up too, and he sniffs the air. Is that... *salt* ? They were no where near the ocean. The fuck? And the further they ran, the more different the landscape became. There were still trees, but less and less of them. Instead, the amount of rocks and boulders they needed to cross through or walk around became more frequent. Up until it looked like very short canyon crevices that they were running through, made of white limestone. A tree popped up here and there, but for the most part, ahead of them, a walled off boulder blocked their view, surrounded by both sides by a canyon-like path, with the only path forward around the right side of the boulder.

Now that he was looking at it, Katsuki finds that the large limestone rock, with some trees growing out of it, *kind* of looked like an-

“The elephant shaped boulder,” Izuku looked up at it and whispered, walking forward again before pausing, and turning to Katsuki.

“Do you have your pill speaker on you?” Izuku asked, looking up at the taller, a little out of breath from speed walking here.

Katsuki fishes it out of deep pockets, “Of course.”

Izuku then grinned, “Can you play music?”

Rolling his eyes, the blonde turns it on, and opens up his phone, shuffling the songs.

Nicely enough, one of Izuku’s recent favorite songs begin to play. And he’s perfectly content with this selection, especially with everything that’s been happening.

Through The Fire by Chaka Khan. Released in 1984, it was a rather hopeful and passionate love song, filled with nice beats and a chorus to *die* for. Izuku could sing this whole thing by heart, other than the falsettos at the end. It has a very classic 80s beginning, and once it starts, Izuku begins to sing along as he drags Katsuki around the bend of the boulder and almost immediately, the both of their feet are submerged into water.

*I look in your eyes and I can see*

*We've loved so dangerously*

Katsuki doesn’t think he’s on Earth. There was no way.

*You're not trusting your heart to anyone*

*You tell me you're gonna play it smart*

They’re definitely not on Earth. Up ahead of them, for what looks like at least two or three miles, brilliant salt flats stretched on and on, and with the windless day they were having, the three inches of water sitting on the white salt flat’s surface was completely still, and reflected the sky *perfectly* . The stream tributaries that leaks in caused the salt flats to constantly be flooded with about 1 to 4 inches of water on a normal day like today. And looking down at his feet now, he was glad he wore sandals for his feet were soaked in the water. No wonder it had smelled like salt.

The top of the salt flat, because of the stillness of it all, acted like a mirror to the sky. And so now, as the gorgeous sun glows in the deep shade of orange and pink, that very same image was reflected perfectly onto the surface. And so, as he slowly stepped forward into the water, little ripples formed, disrupting the image of the water, but he couldn’t believe that a place like this existed.

*We're through before we start*

*But I believe that we've only just begun*

And he thinks back to what Izuku had said. A place where the earth and the sky met. In a way, this was more than just somewhere to be on a nice little evening. It was a beginning point for the new relationship they were navigating. From the start, they were both in their own separate realms. Izuku on the ground, and Katsuki in the sky. Their feelings, their thoughts, their lives closed off from one another. Just as much as Katsuki wanted to dive into Izuku's mind and read what he was thinking, Izuku thought the same towards Katsuki. Always separated by *something* .

Izuku sings from his left, staring out at everything, "When it's this good, there's no saying no. I want you so, I'm ready to go."

Katsuki continues to stare.

But here, marked a place of new beginnings. Where they could start again. In the place where the earth met the sky.

He looks over to Izuku, who then  kept on walking forward, as if he could barely comprehend what he was seeing himself.

Katsuki took off his shoes, and ventured forward. It was like a different dimension, and he could feel the salt grains shifting around beneath his feet. And he watches Izuku, who stands about 20 or so meters ahead of him, still, watching the clouds of the sky move above him at the same time it moves below his feet. The boy had set the black box down in the water, and just stood there watching. Izuku then looked back at him, with an expression filled with nothing but love.

Then, Katsuki finds his feet moving, splashing through the water, as he walks fast towards Izuku. The music following him in his pockets. And the splashes he makes in the ground hits the back of his calves and he knew his clothes were going to get all wet, but he didn't care.

Once he nears Izuku, Katsuki picks up the smaller and like he had done once before, spins the boy around once before pulling Izuku down to kiss those tender lips. And Izuku kisses back deeply, pouring all the love he had into this emotionally driven kiss. He held onto Katsuki's shoulders tightly, and the beauty of this moment made him want to cry. How could this get any more perfect.

When Izuku pulls away and gets settled back down on the ground, he sings the chorus, "Through the fire. To the limit, to the wall. For a chance to be with you, I'd gladly risk it all."

And with the fiery sunset reflected in all directions around them, how could that not be more true. And they just stare at each other for a moment, looking at how far they've come, before Izuku reaches up and places a hand on Katsuki's face.

*"I love you,"* Izuku says gently. Without the pain. Without the sadness. And it's words that were so simply, yet so powerful.

Because Katsuki brings a hand up to cup over Izuku's, and leans down to kiss the green haired boy's forehead, whispering his own, " *I love you* ." He says with all intent. And Izuku promises he won't cry again. Everything was too beautiful to be blurred out by tears.

There was no breeze, but the weather didn't even feel that hot. Nothing was out of place in this moment. And so they just admire everything for a couple moments more.

And then, as the song plays, Izuku steps back and crouches down to the black box.

"So you gonna tell me what that is now?" Katsuki asks.

Izuku's cheeks then heat up, as he unlocks the clasp, "I didn't really think this through," He mutters to himself, "The ground is wet. How am I going to...Dang it. Why didn't I think about bringing something to set all of this on. I mean, we could always just leave the box open and e-"

"Nerd," Katsuki interrupts him.

And Izuku was taken out of his thoughts, before he looks up at the blonde and then looked a little apologetic and shy, a small flush running up his cheeks, before he smiles, "I'm not a great cook or anything, but…"

Izuku continues to open the box, "I'm finishing the little picnic that we never got to have." His voice gets smaller at the end, at the reminder of that night in the Hideaway.

And Katsuki is a bit shocked, but he feels his heart warm seeing the boy fumble to get the box open, and seeing all of the poorly made sandwiches and what not inside of the sturdy thing.

"Izuku," Katsuki speaks with tenderness in his tone. But he honestly, had nothing to say afterwards, and so he just watched.

"Ah," Izuku shyly said, "The box is pretty big, we can just leave it open and eat from there. Hm, there's some sandwhiches. I can do those pretty well. And the grandma who owns the bed and breakfast helped me with the potato dauphinoise. And I know I can't make cherry pies like your mom can, but I know it's your favorite so I tried my best," Izuku looked more red as he spoke.

And all Katsuki wanted to do was sweep this boy up and kiss him crazy.

Izuku plops down on the ground, soaking his entire bottom and legs, and Katsuki does the same. And like a bunch of idiots, the two of them began to eat a much needed dinner. And if Katsuki was being completely honest, it wasn't half bad. He wasn't sure if he was being biased because everything was so perfectly, or if it actually did taste great, but the cherry pie was even up to his standard. And the two of them stay there for a long time.

Even after they finish eating, the two stay at the salt flats for another two or three hours. Whether it was running around, tackling each other into the water, or seeing how many ripples they can make into the ground, they play as the sun goes further and further down.

Izuku's favorite part was when it got purple, and that brilliant color washed over the entire terrain, and he spins around in the water, unable to believe this place existed. At some point, the two of them lay on the ground and make little snow angels out of the salt. The grandson of the establishment was the one who told him about the existence of this place, and Izuku thought what better place to begin their journey together.

And once it got completely dark, Izuku prayed for a clear night, and damn did they get one. So the two boys laid side by side, soaking the entire back half of their body, staring up at the starry skys. And when that was tiring, they stood up and stared at the ground, where there was *also* starry skies. Katsuki reached down to grab at the water, pretending he was grabbing a star. And it was just a happy, sweet moment, that both knew was going to stay in their minds for a long, long time.

They only travelled back towards the bed and breakfast once they saw that their feet was getting extremely pruny, and their throats extremely dry from being in salt and smelling salt for the entire evening.

Through the dark forest, Katsuki runs ahead.

"You'll never beat me in a race, short-legs," Katsuki laughs maniacally as he weaves in and out through the trees and rocks.

Izuku runs after him, "This isn't fair!"

"Sure it is," Katsuki yells back behind him, "I'm carrying the picnic basket to slow me down, and you're still falling behind."

Izuku throws a small pebble at the other, "You've been on the track since you were 11! I don't do cardio *ever* ."

"Great," Katsuki says with a knowing smirk, "We're about to do a *ton* of cardio."

Izuku almost chokes at the suggestive comment, and trips, falling forward, before he got himself up again, "Kacchan!"

Katsuki barked out a laugh, "I'm fucking joking."

Izuku muttered, thinking he was being rather quiet, "You better not be."

"What'd ya say?" Katsuki slows down, turning to ask.

And Izuku catches up, leaning down to put both hands on his knees, breathing heavy, "Huh? I didn't say anything."

"Really?" Katsuki lifts a corner of his mouth with a knowing look, "You aren't quiet you know."

Izuku flushed deeply, "W-Why'd you ask then if you heard?"

“Cuz I wanted to,” Katsuki nonchalantly shrugged, and grinned mischievously, pulling Izuku’s chin up to look at him and Katsuki let the picnic basket slip, hitting the forest floor, and backed Izuku up against the bark of a tree, “We could do it here, you know.”

“H-here?” Izuku looked around. They were in the *woods* , “We’re in the woods.”

“Nerd,” Katsuki said with full honesty, bringing his face closer until their lips were hovering above each other’s, “I’d fuck you in front of your mother. You think I won’t do it here?”

The boy in question was at a lost of words, sputtering, “My m-mo-”

“Nah, come on. The house is right there,” Katsuki laughs, and pulls Izuku, along, picking up the basket as he jogs.

From behind him, Izuku let out a whine, “Kacchan!”

The moment they reached the stairs, Izuku climbed Katsuki like a damn tree. 6 feet 4 of muscle and the most perfect body that Izuku’s ever seen, ready to eat him up. Katsuki lips were on him in an instant, taking in the taste that he’s missed so badly. If Izuku wanted to, Katsuki would wait a year before touching him again. Katsuki would wait as long as the other needed. But hell, if the boy was down to get intimate again, then Katsuki wasn’t going to say no. Izuku tangled his fingers in Katsuki’s hair as the latter keeps his large hands on those thick thighs, holding the smaller up on his waist as they stumble into the room. It’s only been moments, but Izuku’s lips were already bruised with the intensity that Katsuki was going at it.

It feels different knowing that Katsuki loved him. This all feels different. He feels more secure in everything, where he doesn’t need to wonder if the blonde has anyone else after he leaves. Or if he’ll leave at all. He holds onto the blonde’s shoulders tightly, as their bodies get flushed together.

And right before they made it to the bed, Izuku couldn’t help but ask, “Make love to me, Katsuki.”

And this time, the other man doesn’t resist. Not in the slightest. If Izuku was asking him to make love, then he’ll gladly do so with all intent to make the other feel as good as possible.

“Gladly,” Katsuki says, before he deeply kisses Izuku one last time and sets the other down on the mattress. Izuku, with a flushed face and flushed lips, looked absolutely beautiful.

And Katsuki stands back, taking his shirt off from the bottom, and tossing it to the side, and just stares for a moment. Izuku still had all of his clothes on, and was looking at the taller man shyly, but damn, if the nerd wasn’t the prettiest thing he’s ever seen. And this time, he makes it known.

“ *Fuck,* you’re beautiful,” Katsuki tells him, hands playing with Izuku’s knees, slotthing his palm inbetween those gorgeous legs, and teasing the inside of Izuku’s thighs.

Blushing deeper from the words, Izuku stammered a bit as he replies awkwardly, “Y-you too.”

Katsuki chuckles in his deep timbre at this, finding that Izuku’s little stammer turns him on even more, and leans forward, hands on Izuku’s waistband, and tugs his pants off in one solid motion, “You’re so fucking cute. Keep talking.”

“H-huh?” Izuku asks, moving his hands to cup over his hardening dick, feeling a little bit shy even though they’ve done this many times, but Katsuki isn’t having it. Removing his hands, the blonde kisses him slowly, and relaxes his body as those rough fingers caress his thighs and travels down his legs.

“Deku,” Katsuki says as he gets down on his knees off the edge of the bed, and brings his lips to Izuku’s ankle, “Tell me what you want.”

He kisses the boy’s ankles, and slides up a couple inches, sharp eyes looking up at Izuku’s hooded ones the entire time, trailing gentle kisses up his sexy legs.

“W-What I want?” Izuku feels himself losing his breath. He watches Katsuki’s shoulder blades move and the muscle move along with it as the man travels further up his legs, getting closer to his inner thigh, where Izuku was particularly sensitive.

The blonde hums into his skin, sending vibrating through his inner thigh and Izuku whimpers a bit. Katsuki only answers with a whisper in between kisses, “Tell me what you want.”

Izuku didn’t know what to say, too focused on Katsuki’s movements, and he tells the other, “I w-want you inside me.”

Katsuki chuckles at this and nips at his inner thigh, now so close to Izuku’s cock, and the blonde couldn’t help but kiss the sides of it, making Izuku let out a little cry of pleasure at the teasing stimulation, “I’ll get there, baby. You sure there’s nothin you want before that?” And Katsuki moves his left hand so that his finger tease a little bit at Izuku’s entrance, and he quirked his head up with a bit of an evil grin, “Nothing at all?”

Izuku’s breathing was labored at the touches, and he swallowed, nodding his head as he pleads then, “Taste me, Kacchan.” He can barely use his words right.

And Katsuki’s lips move to where the tip of Izuku’s hardened and pretty cock was, but just as he did, Izuku corrects the other, “Not *there* .”

And Katsuki raised a brow, “Oh?”

Before smirking, and leaning back, pulling Izuku by the thighs closer to him, before flipping the boy over onto his back, and pulling his hips up so that Izuku was laying shoulders down, plump, beautiful ass faced up.

And kissing his way down Izuku’s back, Katsuki makes sure the other knows just how sexy he was, and Izuku feels it too as the blonde worships his body.

“You know how hard you make me, Deku?” Katsuki says as he kisses his way down the freckled, smooth expanse of the smaller’s back, gliding his hands over Izuku’s waist, “Nothin’ makes me feel anything anymore after I got a taste of you,” And when he got down to that pretty, perfect shaped ass, Katsuki gives it a little bite, leaving a mark on the supple and soft flesh. Izuku lets out a little cry underneath him.

“So fucking pretty,” Katsuki leaves another bite, as he growls, “All mine.”

Izuku nods with his head in the pillows, breathless, “All yours.”

Katsuki spreads Izuku’s soft and pillowy cheeks apart so he could see that delicious pink hole, so perfect for him. And to tease the other a bit, Katsuki gives it a little kiss, and the sound coming from Izuku makes him grin.

“What a shame,” Katsuki spits right onto the puckered hole, “No one else is ever gonna know how delicious you taste. It’s too bad, ain’t it.” He chuckles, before rimming the fuck out of Izuku. His tongue begins to fuck into Izuku’s ass slowy and excruciatingly, already making the boy a moaning mess above him, and that sound spurs him on further. God, Izuku tasted so delicious, he was hooked on how sexy the greenette was.

Izuku shakes his head with a cry from above, “No one.”

“If someone so much as touches you, I’ll kill them,” Katsuki takes a small break to half whisper and Izuku couldn’t help but be a little turned on by the thought of that. The blonde doesn’t feel half as bad about saying that shit now that Izuku was his boyfriend.

Izuku speaks into the sheets, but Katsuki still heard him mutter, “And vice versa.”
Pulling his tongue out, Katsuki chuckles and stands back up, “Oh yeah? You will, huh.”

And moving his index finger to the dripping hole, he teased the entrance, admitting breathily, “Not gonna lie, Deku. I kind of like the thought of that.”

And that was before, he plunges his index finger in, making Izuku mewl a little into the sheets and grab at the blankets. He hadn’t put anything in himself in a hot minute, so Katsuki stretching him out now felt ultra sensitive. Despite the atmosphere of it all, Katsuki’s movements were careful, making sure that Izuku was okay, that he was gentle enough that the boy wouldn’t hurt any, and prioritizing Izuku’s pleasure. Spit was not nearly enough lube to make this experience not hurt, especially knowing how well endowed he was, so Katsuki reaches over and rummages around the drawers if there were any condom and lube set out, and thankfully, in the second drawer, he finds both. Leaving the condom, Katsuki grabs the lube and tears it open with his teeth, pouring a generous amount on his fingers before going back to work, stretching Izuku out nice and well.

“W-wait,” Izuku called out.

Katsuki stops and looks up, “What is it, baby.” And Izuku almost coos at how Katsuki calls him baby, because he knew that he *meant* it.

“D-Don’t you want me to do anything for you?” Izuku asked, eyes watery from pleasure.

Katsuki leans forward to kiss the other deeply and strokes his face once, speaking near his mouth, “No, tonight’s gonna be about you.”

“But-” Izuku begins.

“No buts,” Katsuki denies him, and he pushes in a third finger. Izuku bites his lip, feeling so much pleasure that he doesn’t feel the need to touch his dick. With Katsuki, he’s never had to. The blonde has always been able to make him cum untouched. He pushes his hips back so that he was fucking back on Katsuki’s fingers, and he hears the blonde praise him.

“So good,” Katsuki tells him, pleased, and loved seeing Izuku’s ass shake on just his fingers. He twists them in the tight hole to add a little more friction, and Izuku’s knees wobble at this, but Katsuki with one arm, keeps him up and stable. The sound of lube squelching as Katsuki hammers away in Izuku’s hole filled the room alongside Izuku’s moans, and Katsuki considers grabbing his phone and making a *movie* that he can watch to fuck into his fist with whenever Izuku wasn’t there. But too caught up in the moment, the thought slips his mind when Izuku tells him.

“Kacchan,” He says breathlessly, “Fuck me now before I cum.”

“Already?” Katsuki teases him, knowing full well that he was just as desparate as Izuku to get inside of the other, “Fuck, I want to be inside of you too, but have a little patience.”

“No,” Izuku shook his head, crying, begging Katsuki, “Now. I need you now.”

Katsuki tugs his pants down, already too tight against his body, and frees his leaking cock from his boxers. The thick member was pulsing, desperately wanting to fuck into the beautiful ass displayed in front of him. His veins were more prominent than ever, cock searching for something to suck it in. He was leaking precum at the top, and he smeared it on some freckles that dotted Izuku’s ass. The moonlight from outside made a little sheen there, and he thinks he likes that very much so.

Positioning his swollen, mushroom tip at Izuku’s pulsing and wet entrance, Katsuki wonders how he was going to keep himself from coming quick. Pushing in slowly, Katsuki bends over to whisper reassuring and comforting words in Izuku’s ear, all while his fingers play around with Izuku’s perky nipples, enjoying how it feels in his rough fingers. Izuku breathes heavily, and keeps his eyes close the entire time Katsuki pushes in, listening to the whispers of *good boy* and other praises in his ear.

“You’re taking me in so well,” Katsuki kisses his neck, and moves his body up, “You should see yourself right now. So fucking sexy.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku breathes out heavily, “Please.”

The blonde in question bottoms out inside of Izuku, and throws his head back, closing his eyes for a second to fully enjoy this sensation of having Izuku’s walls wrap around him. So warm, wet, and tight. *Fuck* . He could drown in this.

Katsuki starts out slow, making sure to make good on his promise to make love to the boy. And he was gentle at first, ensuring that Izuku wouldn't feel pain from the stretch of his fat cock nestled in such a tight hole. And *damn* , did Izuku stretch well. Katsuki wanted to coo at how pretty it looked when Izuku's hole was trying so hard to accommodate for how long and thick his cock was.

But the slowness only lasted so long, before Izuku begged him to go faster. And like the merciful god he was, Katsuki couldn't help but obliged. And so, he began to fuck his length into Izuku with free reign. Katsuki made sure to stretch and fuck him good, so that Izuku will still remember the shape of his cock inside of his body even after he pulls out. The sound of his balls slapping against Izuku's skin as he bottoms out with every thrust fill the room, and he makes Izuku scream in pleasure. He couldn't stop his own groans if he wanted to.

Pulling out, Katsuki moves Izuku further into the bed and flips him over so that they could go into missionary. This way, Katsuki could see that pretty face that he loved so much. Izuku spreads his legs for him, and Katsuki pushes his cock back in, and Izuku sucks him in so well. And there, Katsuki moves back inside, fucking the other hard and fast, burying his lips into the crook of Izuku's neck, placing kisses near his ear and on his shoulders. It feels a bit like heaven, that if Katsuki died, he probably wouldn't be able to tell the difference. The heat and passion is there, and they go at it like goddamn animals.

Izuku pants, and grabs onto the blonde's shoulder blades as Katsuki fills him up so well.

"I'm so fucking in love with you," Katsuki whispers into his neck as he nears his climax, and he holds onto Izuku's leg, hiking it up so he could push in deeper, "There's no one else for me on this damned earth *but* you."

Izuku cries from both pleasure and immense happiness as he nears his own orgasm, "Katsuki, I-"

Katsuki continues to abuse his prostate, which cuts off his words, but the blonde already knew.

"Fuck, fuck, fuck," Izuku cries as he gets closer.

Katsuki chuckles as he rams even harder, "Don't dirty your mouth so much. Maybe I should clean it out. Tell me Deku," Katsuki asks him, nipping at his ear, "Want something to wash it out with?"

Izuku shakes his head, eyes closed with tears coming out the side, and *yes, yes,* he wants that, "Yes, yes," He responds enthusiastically. He wants it. He wants Katsuki's cum in his mouth. He loves it.

But Katsuki lets him cum first, spraying ribbons of cum over both of their stomachs and some of the bed sheets, probably making it a bitch to clean up later. But fuck it, who cares. Izuku's body shakes below him as he rides out the orgasm, and when Katsuki gets right about there, he pulls out. And sits back, watching as Izuku clamor up, cum still stained on his body, and get in front of Katsuki, pretty hands grabbing the base of his cock while Katsuki guides

his head towards the tip. And from the slight contact of Izuku's wet tongue, Katsuki releases his load into his mouth.

And Izuku takes it all. The hot liquid slips down his throat, and there's so fucking much of it that it dribbles off the side of his mouth, but he loves it. And it's such a pretty little sight too, Katsuki thinks. Izuku swallows all that he can, and licks his lips afterwards, staring up at Katsuki with a dazed look.

And the blonde leans in to kiss him, with one hand on the back of his neck and the other cradling Izuku's waist. The green-eyed boy melts into the hold, and he sighs into the kiss, feeling blissed out from it all.

After Katsuki cleans him up and they get rid of the sheets, Izuku shyly goes downstairs to ask for new ones, and they replace it on the mattress. Izuku dives in first into the mattress, and rolls around in it before Katsuki joins him. The curtains were open, and the moonlight filtered into the room. Katsuki laid shirtless with his boxers on, and laid on his arm, while Izuku traced circles into the other's skin with his head on Katsuki's firm chest. And there they laid and just talked for a while longer.

Izuku didn't know when his eyes got heavy, but he remembered the last thing he heard being the sound of the crickets chirping outside and Katsuki telling him more about what happened at the tournament before Izuku arrived before his mind drifted off to sleep.

When Katsuki realizes that his lover had fallen asleep, he takes a moment to absorb the picture. Here he was, laying back shirtless after amazing sex, with the person he loves who had then fallen asleep on his chest. And he wonders if life could get any sweeter. And it feels even more sweet when contrasted to the bitterness between them just days prior. Izuku pouts when he slept, bottom lip slightly jutted out and blowing out air while he's at it. And his long lashes rested gently against his skin. Katsuki could cradle the boy in his body like this forever.

When he didn't see Izuku up in the stands the day of the tournament, the first thing Katsuki did was go to the ticketing lady and ask to check the roster and see if a Midoriya Izuku was there at the tournament. And when she had said no, Katsuki went through several stages of emotion within an hour. The first was undeserved anger. He knew that Izuku was not obligated to be there by any means, but his first irrational response was to be angry and hurt that the boy didn't show up after all, even if he knew he was not entitled to Izuku's presence. The second was sadness. Because of course Izuku didn't fucking come. It was a four hour drive to see a guy who has done nothing but convince the other that he didn't love him. And the thought that the rest of his tournaments and life would be like this: Izuku-less, brought him more pain than he'd ever care to admit. The third was a sudden fit of nervousness, because he was already nervous about the tournament regardless to begin with. And now to add onto it, the person who's always been there to watch him, cheer him on, and convince him that he was someone worth watching even if he didn't win, wasn't there. And Katsuki suddenly didn't know how well he would do.

And so, when Midoriya Izuku, like a damn fool, showed up against the railing, whistling the George Benson song into the megaphone, Katsuki moved before he could even begin to

think. There was no length he wouldn't go to at this point for the other, and he was going to spend every day proving it to Izuku.

Katsuki found it difficult to sleep tonight, still shocked by the happiness he felt that he had done it. The feat that he never in a million years thought he'd be able to accomplish. He was able to sweep someone off of their feet. Even if it took a shit ton of tries, he had fucking done it. And now, he was blessed with the opportunity to wake up to this beautiful face, knowing that Izuku loved him and did cheesy shit like plan a picnic out in a salt flat for him, and whatnot. The adrenaline of it all hadn't worn off, and even after two or three hours of Izuku haven fallen asleep, he still finds himself wide awake.

Glancing at the piano that sat up near the window, Katsuki wonders if he remembered anything. He took drum lessons when he was young, and could retain that pretty well. But after he quit the drums, the piano and guitar enticed him. After all, piano and guitar were major instruments used in a lot of his favorite 80s tracks. And so he spent a couple of months trying out the guitar, did a half decent job, and then got bored. And moved onto the piano. That, he did for about a year, and enjoyed it well enough, but ultimately, pole vault became his entire life by the time he started to wane out of piano.

Careful not to wake the other, Katsuki slides a pillow under Izuku's head, and gently pries himself out of bed. Stretching his back upon standing up, the adonis-like man walks over to the piano. The floorboards creaked beneath his feet, considering this was a rather old bed and breakfast, and he made his way across the bedroom and over to the piano, whose keys were half hit by the moonlight and half-covered by darkness. A petal of the orchid had fallen onto the keys, and Katsuki brushed it off.

He pulls out the seat and stares up at the sheet music book set up on the piano. He looked over to Izuku who was sleeping, and plays a note with not a lot of pressure. The boy didn't budge. He plays it again with a bit more pressure. Still no budge. And so, Katsuki assumes it was safe to say the boy was rather deep in sleep.

The piano was slightly out of tune, but he didn't care to go tune it. Looking up at the sheet music, Katsuki could read some of it, but he knew he wouldn't be able to do it well enough to read while playing. If he thinks hard enough, his muscle memory could pull out a couple of songs he knew how to play when he was little.

And so he tests it with a couple of notes, to get his fingers used to it again. And Katsuki, in the moonlight, plays for a while. Not super well, but not super terribly either. It was mostly him messing around, trying to find ways to pass the time until he got tired, but it was enjoyable enough. The blonde hadn't checked his phone in about a day, knowing that it has been bombarded. Not only is the hottest topic in the town right now, but the entire pole vault community. If it wasn't about him winning the tournament being a fresh into Nationals, then it was about him acting like a crazed maniac for Midoriya Izuku in front of over 4000 people. He knew that the moment he turned on his phone, he wasn't going to see the end of it. Katsuki was not too excited about all of that. The only people he bothered contacting were his parents, just so they knew his whereabouts, and Coach Shugo just *one* time to ensure that his star athlete and prize winner didn't fucking die.

Katsuki was interrupted from his thoughts by the sounds of rustling, and he turns to his left to see Izuku up on the bed with the blankets wrapped around his head and body. Fucking adorable, Katsuki thought to himself, before he felt a little guilty.

“Did I wake you up?” Katsuki asked.

Izuku shuffled a little bit before trying to excuse it, “The piano jolted me a little, but it’s no problem! I had a good nap.”

Katsuki turns back and pushes his seat out to get up, “You should go back to slee-”

“No!” Izuku says very suddenly, causing Katsuki to pause, and the boy asks shyly, “I want you to keep playing.”

Looking at Izuku for a moment, Katsuki finally gave in and sat back down, pulling the seat back in and shrugged, “I ain’t very good.”

“Kacchan? Not very good at something? No way,” Izuku waved off jokingly.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, “You only think that because you’re obsessed with me, nerd. Don’t think I’ve forgotten your shrine.”

“I’m not obsessed with you,” Izuku throws a pillow at the blonde and fakes anger.

Katsuki just chuckles, “I didn’t say I minded.”

“I’m *still* not ob-” Izuku goes to defend himself.

“I know, I know,” Katsuki says before cracking his knuckles, “I’ll just play what I can remember.”

And so Katsuki plays the piano for him. Again, not great, and not terribly. Nevertheless, it makes Izuku happy. And he could watch and listen to this forever. Even when Katsuki messes up a note, it’s more endearing than anything, until Katsuki curses out the piano at least. And for a while, they just do that. Sit and play piano in the moonlight. If there was a sound problem, then at least they were in the room furthest from everyone else, although it didn’t look like many other people were staying at the bed and breakfast.

After about thirty minutes of this, Katsuki ran out of songs to play, and just sits there, tilting his head up to the sky and observing the popcorn ceiling while wondering if he’ll ever feel tired enough to fall asleep tonight. Or if his happiness over being with Izuku finally was enough to keep him awake forever.

And in that silence, Izuku speaks up, “This reminds me of a song.”

Katsuki turns his head, and looked over to the boy bundled in sheets adorably, and asks, “Ya know how to play it?”

Izuku shakes his head, “Absolutely not, but it’s pretty. I think you’d like it.”

The blonde hums in response, before asking, “What is it.”

Reaching over the nightstand to grab his phone, Izuku pulls up his playlist and scrolls until he finds the song.

“Piano In The Dark by Brenda Russell,” Izuku says and he begins to play it. The romantic melody begins to fill the air.

“Fitting,” Katsuki comments, “That one came out with her album in ‘88, right?”

Izuku nodded, “Yeah, it was called Get Here. It’s one of my mom’s favorites actually.”

Katsuki snorts, “Mine fucking hates 80’s music.”

“No way,” Izuku laughs, “Living in Ise, she still hates it?”

“Living in Ise is *why* the hag hates it,” Katsuki snorts and then stops to listen to the song.

“It has a very romantic intro, doesn’t it?” Izuku asks, “I want to play it on the piano.”

Brenda Russell’s voice begins to sing, and she’s got quite the beautiful voice. Katsuki admits that. And Izuku was right. He did like the song so far.

And so as it plays, Katsuki waves the other over, “Come try it then, nerd.”

Izuku bundles further into the blanket, “I don’t know how.”

“And?” Katsuki raised a brow, “I’ll show you the basic melody. You can generally feel around and get it right.”

*I turn around in the still of the room*

*Knowing this is when I'm gonna make my move*

*Can't wait any longer*

*And I'm feeling stronger, but oh*

Izuku laughs and shakes his head again, but Katsuki continues to urge him as the song continues to play. And it’s a happy moment right then. Who knew what time it was, and who cares. All Katsuki wanted was for Izuku to come over here with him and they can listen to the song and play shitty piano together until he knocks out.

“Fine, I’m coming,” Izuku finally gives in with a dumb smile.

*Just as I walk to the door*

*I can feel your emotion*

*It's pulling me back*

*Back to love you*

It's just a pretty song is what it is, and the melody just feels a bit romantic. Izuku loves it a lot because his mom used to play it a lot.

He gathers his blanket, and drags it across the floor as he climbs out of bed and headed towards Katsuki, who sat there on the piano waiting for him. He brought his phone along, with the music trailing him.

"The fuck does this song even mean," Katsuki asked once Izuku sat done, still huddled the white blanket that trailed across the floor and almost glowed in the bright moonlight.

Izuku hums, "It's about a woman who is slowly falling out of love with the person she's with," Izuku says, "And she sometimes finds herself wishing she was somewhere else, but when he plays the piano for her," Izuku thinks, "She remembers all over again why she loved him."

*I know, caught up in the middle*

*I cry just a little*

*When I think of letting go*

Katsuki considers this and kisses Izuku's exposed shoulders, "That's damn depressing."

Izuku laughs a little and nods, "A little."

And then Izuku stretches, all while asking Katsuki a question shrouded in nonchalance, but the both of them knew there was a slight insecurity inside of both of them about the subject at hand, "You think that'll be me and you one day?"

*Oh no, gave up on the riddle*

*I cry just a little*

*When he plays piano in the dark*

Izuku thinks about it. And laughs. How could a love top this? How could he ever fall in love harder than this? Sure, he was only 18. Fresh out of high school. And yet, he couldn't be more sure that Katsuki was where his home was. It was all on Katsuki.

The blonde paces a kiss on his forehead then, and responds quite simply, "Ya forget the shit I told you yesterday already? I already told you. I'm not falling out of love with you, nerd." And Katsuki didn't know how he was so sure of this, he just was.

And the topic drops off after that in exchange for Izuku messing around with the piano keys at the same time the song is playing on his phone, making a confused mess of notes and melodies. And yet despite all that, it was fun and beautiful in a way: the mess they were making. The sheets were dragged across the ground. The pillows were thrown across the floor. And there under the moonlight, the two of them just played piano.

“Not that one, you idiot,” Katsuki scolded him at some point.

“You literally pressed that note five seconds ago!” Izuku complained at the unfairness of it all.

Katsuki thinks about it, “Oh did I.”

“Yes!” Izuku harks, “Kacchan, you’re ridiculous.”

“Maybe,” Katsuki sneers and then looks at Izuku adoringly, “But you still love me.”

This time, when Katsuki says it, it doesn’t hurt. And Izuku has the confidence to say, “I do.” Only to follow up with a, “But not when you’re being like this.”

“Oh fuck off,” Katsuki feigns offense.

“No, you fuck off,” Izuku fights back playfully, before they go back to trying to figure the song out. It probably replayed about three times, as they listened to it again and again trying to figure out the notes together.

And after a while of trying, Izuku rests his head on Katsuki’s shoulders, feeling a bit tired as the hours catch up on him. He had taken a nap before, but a couple hours of sleep wasn’t really enough to sustain him. And finally, Katsuki was beginning to feel a bit of that tiredness as well, for the blonde found himself pretty quiet, a sign that he was feeling a little exhausted. And so, Izuku’s hands slip from the piano keys down to his lap as his head just rests there on his lover’s shoulder.

Just before he plans to move, Katsuki has one last thought in his head, and he asks Izuku, “You know the first line to my paper.”

Izuku hums, eyes closed, blanket wrapped around him, “Hm.”

Katsuki then asks, “What was yours.”

“Mine?” Izuku asks, simmering through his thoughts to remember what it was before his head pinpoints it.

The blonde waits for an answer, only curious because he didn’t really have a clue about how Izuku’s paper could have went, considering he struggled with his own, and was grateful he even got an A on it, considering the language he used here and there in the paper.

Izuku lets the words marinate on his tongue for a second, never having said it out loud before.

“Remember when I told you what my favorite quote was?” Izuku asks him.

Katsuki thinks, and he does remember, so he asks, “Was it just that?”

Izuku shakes his head, still resting on Katsuki’s shoulders, “Not exactly.”

So the blonde had to ask, “So what was it.”

Izuku pauses for a bit, before he opens his eyes just slightly to look at the pretty orchid petal that just fell on top of the piano. It was a nice little addition, and Izuku couldn’t help but remember that orchids were a symbol of love and beauty. In the dark, they sit in a bit more silence. And for a moment, Katsuki thought that the smaller might have fallen asleep. But then, after a couple more beats of quietness where the sound of crickets chirping fill the night air, he hears Izuku speak in a soft voice and he listens intently.

“If love is friendship set on fire,” Izuku begins, taking a pause, “Then let me burn to ashes.”

---

A green eyed beauty stands at the crossroads of a barber shop and a cigarette store on a summer evening around 6:00 PM, when the sun was climbing it’s way across the sky towards the horizon. It was a humid day, as it has been for the past week or so, with temperatures so high that most people in the small town of Ise kept themselves cooped up inside waiting for the midday heat to pass before venturing out during the evening or night. Fans kept themselves on throughout the day and night, and it often got so quiet in the afternoon, that laying on the couch, a person might even hear the TV playing classic 80s reruns coming from their neighbor’s window. There weren’t that many clouds out this day, and the boy with the green eyes and green hair wondered where they went. Maybe they took a break, went back to where they came from.

He would too if he had to stay up there for so long and so close to the sun. The boy then leans against the traffic light that’s been out of order for about a decade now, and waits.

A car passes. And after it does, jogging along the corner comes a boy with blonde hair and fierce red eyes, wearing a simply tank with a pair of athletic shorts, just having come out of summer practice. This boy stood tall, had to have been over 6 feet 4 inches or around that height, with a big athletic build. And upon seeing the beauty waiting at the crosswalk, breaks off into a run and goes over to spin the other around, as if he hasn’t seen the boy in years even when it’s been a day at most.

Any stranger would walk by and oggle for a little bit at the beauty of young love. Anyone could see it in their eyes. Somewhere within those smiles and looks of adoration, any given person could guess that there was a story behind those two. The taller boy leans down to kiss the pretty one with the green hair, who leans into it like it's the most natural thing in the world.

From a small pill speaker that stayed in the pocket of the blonde one, a song begins to play.

Dreams, by Fleetwood Mac. Like the title, it was a dreamy song. It reminded the two of them of childhood nostalgia, playing by the creeks, and sweet memories of growing up in Ise. To be fair, they were still growing up, not even in college yet technically, with lots to grow and lots to learn. But it was still sweet to think about as they listened to the song.

And so, with the song in the background, the two boys do the thing they always do. Something stupid that would make the adults in Ise mad, more likely than not. On the outskirts of the small 80s themed town, they run after one another through tall grass, past some abandoned buildings and crumbling establishments, a little past the woods where the tall one's grandparents used to play in as a boy before he grew up and moved out onto the farm. And a little past the woods was an abandoned bridge, full of rust and graffiti on the sides.

It wasn't a driving bridge or a pedestrian bridge though. It was a railroad bridge, designed for trains to go over. And so, the bridge only had the support structure and beams, and a broken railroad track running in the middle of it. One step and someone would fall in between the tracks and into the river.

The bridge's structure was all out of wack, having been abandoned alongside the railroad for decades now,  and the gentle river that flowed beneath it was clear and reflected the sun's rays prettily. It wasn't deep enough to jump into from the height of the bridge, but it was enough to admire. And so the boys sat on the edge of the bridge, legs dangling off of the edge of the beams that they had riskily climbed onto. The blonde boy sipped from a bottle of white gatorade, oddly flavored cherry for some reason, while the greenette drinks from a bottle of pop. It fizzles down his throat in a satisfying manner, and they talk and joke around for a while.

And once they finish their drinks, the two continued onto the railroad track, walking alongside it and moving apart the tall grass. Bugs were everywhere, especially mosquitos in this pesky summer weather, but the two paid it no mind. And when they found abandoned boxcars with graffiti and what not all over the sides, the first thing the idiot bastards thought to do was explore the damn thing, no mind if a squatter was in one of them. Hopping from boxcar to boxcar, freight to freight, the two played a small game of tag where the rule was to stay on the boxcar and not get down onto the railroad track.

And once that got a bit tiring, the green haired beauty plops down on top of a boxcar, and leans back on his strong arms, watching the sun go down over Ise. Moments later, the blonde joins in, sitting right behind the other, so that now, the greenette can lean back into the taller's chest as they watch together.

It’s been about a month since the night on the cliff of wishes, and the adjustments were still coming, but this was the happiest they’ve ever been. And each of them knew it. A lot of conversations had to be made, uncomfortable ones sure. But that was fine. Looks were constantly thrown at them when they walked around. Some of guilt, at the accusations made about one or the other in the past. Some of awe. Some of jealousy. It wasn’t hard to say they were the talk of town. The couple that bloomed out of some project that an old psychology decided to give out. It was a bit of phenomenon. It was a pairing that the small old city was coming to accept as a beautiful one. Especially when the two were seen everywhere. At diners, parks, beaches, here and there. Their old friends, and even people they used to consider enemies or rivals, hung out with them, and saw a clear change in their demeanors. Felt happier. Lighter. Even if there were still problems to work on, it all just felt *happier* .

The future was unknown, and that was okay. For now, they focused on the present.

Finally, after a humid day with raging temperatures, the two begin to feel a bit of breeze once the sun begins to set a little more. It was a classic Ise sunset, with its stunning orange and pink shades, ribboning across the sky is pretty patterns aimed to mesmerize any beholder. And the two sit there, enjoying it.

The green eyed boy closes his eyes, allowing his senses to overtake him. The smell of cherries, burnt sugar, and lilies melded together. A rough hand on his waist, and his head leaning up against a firm chest. The faint breeze brushing against his cheek and moving pieces of his curly hair to the left. He takes it all in. The blonde does the same, listening the the music playing from the pill speaker. Other than that, it’s quiet for a long time as they take in the atmosphere.

When Bakugo Katsuki, the rascal of this quiet beachtown, finally speaks up, it’s a quiet question to his lover, filled with awe and all intent to live in this memory forever.

“How did we get to end up here,” He speaks, asking as if he was the happiest man in the world.

And Midoriya Izuku, the green-eyed sweetheart of Ise, turns to his lover, and stares into those ruby red eyes for a moment, before smiling softly, replying, “I got tired of watching from the sidelines.”

Chapter End Notes

I don't even know what to say, I'm just incredibly in shock that this is all over. And I'm not going to lie, it hurts a lot.
That being said, there's still one more thing I will post very soon, and it's an extended Author's Note.

In the next chapter, titled The Author's Note, you will find the following:
I. Author’s Note. Because I can't say thank you in this tiny little box. I'm going to need a whole letter to express how grateful I am.
II. Katsuki & Izuku’s analysis papers
III. The outline to FTS. This might be interesting to you guys! It's very long though.
IV. A memorialization of all FTS fanworks and fanarts
V. A homage to FTStown memory highlights, so that future readers can kind of see the beautiful community that was created.
VI. Talks of a potential hard copy. Not many details yet. Just a consideration for those who expressed they wanted one.
VII. The sequel outline. I don't plan on writing a sequel. But for a moment there, I thought about it. And even made a very detailed outline. So I wanted to share it with you guys in case you wanted to see what a sequel would look like.
VIII. A link to my FTS Prompt Week submissions. Thank you to Ophelia for coming up with the idea and bringing it to life.

Now with that, I want to say now that I thank each and every one of you so, so much for everything. This journey has been literally unbelievable, and I can't believe that we're finally here at the end. And this chapter was kinda shit, but it truly was the original ending I had in mind for FTS. So I wanted to stay true to that. Thank you for everything. I can't even say I deserve it, you guys are the absolute best. And we've created a little family in FTS Town, and I never want to let it go. I love you all.
And I love you, Bakugo Katsuki and Midoriya Izuku of Ise High. I will miss you more than anything. I hope you grow together and love each other more and more every day, even if we aren't here to watch it.

Twt: suffocatingspr1
Join us at FTS Town!

# Chapter 14: The Author's Note

Chapter Notes

sorry it took months haha i was trying to pull my grades up that suffered from me putting so much time into this fic :((

First, I want to start with the bad news, which is that I will not be posting their final papers (which is really shitty I know because the whole plot of this story kind of revolves around the papers and I know a lot of you guys wanted to read them); however, I tried writing different versions of their final papers, and I cannot really put into words a way that would be able to summarize their experience in an academic context, and so I'm sorry for that! Now to get into the meat of things :D

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## I. The Author's Note

I don't know if you believe in alternate universes, but let's just pretend for a moment that there were. In another universe, we're all the fiction and the world in which FTS BKDK exists in is the reality. And maybe there, this story continues. Maybe there, somewhere out there, these two boys are still chasing sunsets on the river banks, laying on the floor of the library at 2AM during their second year of university studying for an organic chemistry test,

coming home for summer break and rope swinging into the creek near grandpa's farm. I'd like to think so, because over the past few months, I've poured a lot of my soul into building this world so deeply that somewhere along the way, I forgot that this was a piece of fiction. That none of these characters are real. None of the quiet whispers into the night, neighbors sitting on the porch, crickets chirping in the background, soft and tender touches shared in the fic were real. After 13 chapters of FTS and me getting way too emotionally attached to the little town of Ise, I guess it's just easier to pretend that we--this wonderful community we built up both on Ao3, Twitter, and even Tiktok--do exist in the tiny coastal town called Ise, where the houses are painted pastel colors, all the radios blare 80s tracks, and where maybe I'm just a part-time worker at Midoriya's Custom Prints shop and you might be a student on the soccer team of Ise High. And maybe, after school, we grab a milkshake at Hana's Diner, and gossip about the surprising new couple Midoriya Izuku and Bakugo Katsuki, the hot topic of Ise at the current moment. Especially now as we've reached the end, it's hard not to want to pretend a little longer. What *isn't* pretend though were the friendships made along the way, the phenomenal and loving community that stemmed, the emotions that were felt, and the memories shared. I'm never going to forget the thrill of scrolling through #FTSTWT, which I will take this moment to take pride upon for a second: trended on twitter in the U.S. upon the release of chapter 12. I'm never going to forget the joy and adoration I felt reading each and every comment on people's thoughts and analyses, or the awe of seeing wonderful art made for the fic. And so I know it might be annoying to have read another thousand or so words of the author's ramblings at the end of a fic (I know, I should have just posted Chapter 13 and then left it at that); however, I am so grateful to you guys for reading FTS that I felt like it would have been wrong not to express my gratitude separately like this. Especially after all you guys have done for FTS Town. FTS wouldn't be what it was without all of your love. Home is not just the place, it's the people.

## II. The Outline & Making of FTS

*So this is a very long document that I will put in here anyways because why not. I also have a link to the google doc, because it's color coded IRL but you can't really see it on Ao3.* ***Skip to III. A Homage To FTS Town*** *if you don't really care about the outline hehe <3*

Link:
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1_XjbXyOS1_RLmsQR9JFTnrFbPnWy7E884KBrTA9lMDY/edit?usp=sharing

{Note: Deku is abbreviated to D in the outline. Katsuki is abbreviated to K}

This is my exact outline word for word. And so, I apologize in advance if a lot of it makes no sense.

- **Title Ideas:** Everytime I Win, From The Sidelines, To Meet Me In The Middle idk about this one,
- Inspirations-Random thought images that initially inspired the fic: flipped, dirty dancing, grease, my romanticized daydreams, childhood, mississippi, north carolina, arkansas, velvet creme, myrtle beach, funnel cakes, creeks, 80s playlist, old cars, wet clothes

- **Tags!** : coming of age, beachtown aesthetic, top K, bottom D , retro, coming of age?
- **Overall intended emotion for readers:** heartache, but delve deep into a nostalgic lifestyle. About young love, hesitations, and fears, embracing our anger and our kindness. Embracing life and enjoying the beautiful things, even if you know you have to eventually get out of this small town, maybe even have that be a theme. A feeling in your heart that kind of wrenches in this kind of beautiful pain, where even the happy moments are laced with this sense of bittersweet nostalgia where you know it's so good and sweet that it might end soon. Really play on the beauty of young love and living for yourself rather than *just* for other people. Growth and heartbreak. Slow-ish burn. Have this be around 100k and 12 chapters because lord knows you can't write short things. Pace it so that there is a week between each chapter.
- **Rating:** explicit lmao

- **Blurb:**

  - When long-time enemies, Bakugo Katsuki--the all-star athlete and rascal of Ise--and Izuku Midoriya, the town sweetheart, are paired together for a long-term project, the quiet town of Ise suddenly gets a bit louder.
  - In which, Katsuki is an asshole pole vaulter, Izuku is going to fail psychology, and both are about to have the most intense spring semester yet.

- **POV:** 3rd person limited in D's POV for 70% of the fic, really hammer in on D's emotions and thoughts here and make it unbearably frustrated that the POV doesn't extend to K's. And then, at climax/pivotal point, transition to 3rd person limited but in K's POV. Have that running for a little bit, settle in, and let people adjust to feeling K's emotions and thought processes similar to how they did w/ D. And then after that point, post climax, slowly switch back and forth between their POVs and for the love of god try not to do it so abruptly, i s2g if you do some shit like insert a paragraph spacing and then in bold, write **K's POV** in the middle of a chapter i'll kill you. Slowly switch back and forth as they begin to feel more for each other and crack pieces each other's mind apart, until by the end, it becomes 3rd person omniscient rather than 3rd person limited. Represents the fact that theyre finally communicating and in tune w/ one another?

- **Brief plot draft**

  - K & D same kind of bullied backgrounds in Canon but it's not anything absolutely horrible and unforgivable. K is emotionally closed off to positive emotions. D is emotionally closed off to negative emotions. At the end, D

gives him a piece of his mind and confesses to his anger, his jealousy, etc. K can't find himself doing the same. K plays a sport. Pole vault bc like, he flies and is explosive and stuff. Plus, it's an individual sport. They both have like a really beautiful semester. Lots of tension. Lots of lake and stuff. Fireworks on the water party. Rope swings. Diners. Massive 80s aesthetic. Make it so nostalgic it hurts by nature

- K is emotionally closed off to positive emotions because "the more people who like you, who are close to you, the more people who have the ability to be disappointed in you."and also bc of habituation from childhood and people all around him growing up. if he shuts himself out, then if people are disappointed in him, he won't care. D says "the people who care about you: no matter what happens, they won't be disappointed in you."
- D is emotionally closed off to negative emotions because that is what people expect of him. And that is what his mom expected of him: to be a perfect son. How to be nice. Overbearing mother, so he's a bit sheltered, yet you can tell he's longing for more. By the way he watches K fly, wondering what it feels like. He doesnt stand up for himself even tho he very well could, bc he's taught to always be the sweetheart and bundle of joy for others, even if its to the detriment of himself.

- **Main symbols**

- **Circles. Cycles.**

  - Going around in circles. Bc life just isn't that easy, where you can just recognize a flaw and get over it like that. Where you can just be a better person every day. Where you can easily break your habits. Life is frustrating. It can be hard to break habits, to say words that you never usually say, to stop going around in circles.
  - how? Circled quotes. Have little details sprinkled out that you circle back to later through a call back or whatever. Have a section in the outline for that. Big component. Have them repeat the same mistakes, and grow, but get frustrated bc it doesnt feel like they're doing good enough. Circled items that grow in meaning over time. Cherry gatorades. Pole vaulting. The sky. Etc. but focus mostly on the circled quotes. For a nice little touch, the end of chapter 1 should mirror the end of the last chapter except with a heightened flare. Kind of like a sense of 'look how far we've come. Where we can say the same thing, but have it mean completely different things.'

- **Music**

    - Fun stuff at first, sad stuff in the middle, nostalgic/happish stuff at the end.
    - In the beginning, none of the songs' lyrics will be mentioned. The songs are just there.
    - Katsuki listens to them mindlessly because he liked the sound, just like how readers will likely brush over the songs in the beginning. So make sure to write it so that you don't go into the lyricism in the first 5+ chapters, so to the readers, like Katsuki, the songs are fun to listen to but you're not emotionally there with it— just like he is.
    - Have the music be more upbeat too. But over time, throughout the fic, we should see more introspection with the songs, more attention to lyrics, and even incorporate them into scenes as centerpieces to emotional moments. This will be because slowly, katsuki is beginning to understand what the lyrics in these love songs mean.
    - He's beginning to find himself relating to the music he's only listened to previously for the sound. Just like how subtly readers will also be more attentive to the music.
    - Richard marx, george michael, madonna, whitney , put classics and also weird ones
    - Make a playlist actually. A fic playlist , link it on every chapter it'll be cool even tho no one will listen to it bahahahahh :') cries

- **Perspective**

    - Goes w/ the circles thing. Perspective is big in here. And it's the very reason for their whole repeating of cycles. The lack of pov. The entireeee fic, or well, before you switch pov for the first time, have D crave K's pov. Crave it so badly as time goes on. Have him want it more and more, because it gets harder and harder to continue loving K when not knowing a single thought that goes through k's head. The ambiguity of it all. And keep on leaving pauses and strange unexplained expressions on K's face with narration like 'and he's quiet for a song, and Izuku wonders what he's thinking about' but never actually resolve it, so that readers get the exact same feeling of not knowing and the growing frustration that comes with it. Yeah. nice thats good. Anyways when u go do chapter 11 and do K's pov, go back to all those moments and explain what he was thinking at the time. Good stuff
    - When D's POV switches to K's POV at the end of ch 10 into ch 11, make sure that there is significance in the ending line. So that it flows into the

other. “I wish I knew yours” or something like that. Then BOOOOOM. K’s POV. Expand more on this in the chapter outline.
    - Sky/Earth. Mini theme. Goes along with this. In the beginning, they’re so far apart. D on the ground. K in the skies. D pining for what’s up there. K never haven been grounded before. Over time, they try a little bit of each. D gets to fly. K gets to feel the warmth of being grounded or whatever. Unreachable theme. But POV changes kinda go hand in hand with this. And further they progress thru the fic and the more they begin to see each other’s side, especially in the last couple of chapters, the more they meet in the middle.
    - The whole thingie with the transparents curtain and mirrors also do this. How they get so close. So so close, but never completely there. Align with their perception of each other’s POV. so close  but never there. Glass is like that. The curtain islike that. This goes under the circles theme too

- **Details that need to be brought full circle:** “love is friendship set on fire”  The cliff of wishes oHHHH yeah. Losing and K’s inability to lose, and then at the end, have him willing to.  An article of clothing that K wears to a final match, maybe a bracelet or a sweatband or a tshirt?. Ooh, and maybe, we can do a izuku says “because you said you liked it” to k everytime he does something nice. And at a pivotal point in their relatioship, K does something for D. And repeats that line. Nice thats a plan. This should be before the climax. “Aren’t you tired of watching from the sidelines?” have that repeat at some point oh yeah. Cherry gatorades.

**Jotted Ideas** [ Here is where, **before** I start a fic, I jot random ideas with no context and coherency down that I just ~feel~ is right for the fic. And then in the chapter outline, I connect it all together. So literally, it’s just a jumble of random shit like dialogue pieces for example. Sometimes, I might be doing homework or some shit, and suddenly, two lines of dialogue come and there is NO context for it, but I just know that it has to be in the fic. So I jot it down here, and build around it in the chapter outlines. Or maybe scene ideas. Or just anything. Here is just a dumpster fire of different little FTS pieces without the connectivity.] Not all of it makes it into the fic.

- Record shop scene ? yes? No? Maybe?
- Don’t correct me if I’m wrong.”  “Don’t?” Katsuki asked to clarify the strange choice of wording. Isn’t it usually *Please, correct me if I’m wrong*?  But Izuku just nodded, “Don’t. Because I’d really like to believe it. Even if it’s not true.” He smiled.
- “I never know what you’re thinking” “All stories have point of views, and I just want to know yours.”

- At some point, insert a conversation about marriage. Towards the end ofc, when it's clear D loves him. And K has some feelings. Have it be sad. Like bittersweet bc D isn't talking about K even tho he wishes he was
- K's lack of vulnerability: the diner scene ch.2, the headband, the dislike for cheesiness or really deep convo, hides his thoughts and feelings, opens his mouth to say something but closes it again, looks at D weird but never says it outloud, shut down conversations that he doesn't like,
- Some ideas for final report quote : 'love is friendship that has caught on fire.' 'if love is friendship that has caught on fire, then i'm submerged in flames.' or something like that : or a dr. suess quote "You know you're in love when you can't fall asleep because the reality is finally better than your dreams." and then 'i couldn't fall asleep last night. Because it felt like reality is better than my dreams." or something about D's eyes on K's part idk
- Scene where K admits he's nervous when the bar is above 18'. D says he likes to whistle a little tune to clear his head. 'That's stupid' D starts whistling. Harasses K to finish it. So he finishes the song. Call this back at the tournament, right when people forgot that the scene even existed. Hm what song what song what songggg should it have? Against All Odds by Phil Collins? FUCK THATS A GOOD ONE. or maybe She's Like The Wind by Patrick Swayze. Shit im conflicted. Or or or , Nothing's Gonna Change My Love For You by george benson?
- Scene where K takes D up into the sky with him. Symbolizes the closing of the space between them.
- "You love me" in a moment of realization. "And you don't."
- "There's no way you're a virgin" scene.
- During sex scene, beforehand, have katsuki whisper to him that he isn't going to coddle him, love him, give him what he thinks he wants. D cries during sex. K wipes away his tears and tells him not to cry. Really emphasize the difference in experience.
- Drive in theater (izuku's thing)
- Insert !! More about izuku not getting mad enough. Switch the order for the circled quote, add more in about the progression of izuku's explicit feelings. And then add more hints at k's emotions
- "You know, you talk a lot about me being emotionally closed off, but you're even worse off than I am. You gonna let all of that anger and shit build up forever?" at the character development arc. "Have you ever told your mom about med school? Have you ever told anyone about how frustrated you are with your dad? Have you ever told me how much you hated me for all that I did? Hah, and you think I'm emotionally closed off." "aren't you sick of being the perfect son? With the perfect plans, and the perfect mom? I want to see you angry."
- "You've been closed off to emotions for so long, that you can't even recognize kindness anymore. I don't watch you because I expect you to win. I do it because I like seeing you fly, even if you don't make it past a bar. I don't care for you because I want something from you. I just do." D's quote
- "After this ends, don't leave me alone."
- should I do a county fair scene?
- Also, during a party or something: have K spit alcohol into D's mouth. nice.
- First time kissing scenario: hm, maybe D goes on a date. And K shows him how to kiss. Phone rings. It's the date. K turns it off. "You're gonna go out on a date now, just having kissed someone else?"

- D secondary love interest: ????????
- “I want someone who’ll _____, who’s not afraid to show me off, write their name on their forehead like an idiot just to show the world” this should be the scene where D says the dr. suess quote, where K repeats later at the climax.
- Maybe: “Tell me you love me too. Tell me that you do this because you _____ and not because you _____.”
- A “you know what your problem is” scene.
- Running through the field scene. & scene where K comes to spin D around. Calm perform storm
- A conversation where they ask what superpower they’d want . “maybe in another world, we could have been superheroes” hahahaha
- Should there be a dance scene? Is it really a retro themed fic without a school dance? WAIT A FUCKING MINUTE. What if ?? Inko doesn’t let him go. Because idk , something. And D is just feeling FOMOin his room, watching people’s post. Then, K comes with a speaker and dances with him. Inko comes out confused. And its sweet as fUCK. Okay but when should this happen...
- climax: on a cliff of wishes. K picks up a handful of rocks and then makes plenty of wishes ending in a confession. It’s a throw back to a night where they went to the cliff of wishes.
- I want K to find D’s toys. ~~“I could make you stretch even further.”~~

**Brief Individual Characterizations of important characters**

**Bakugo Katsuki**

Probably the hardest one to do. Bc the bitch doesn’t even know his own emotions, how am I supposed to. Physical characteristics: extremely tall, built, works out a ton, has this kind of rugged 80s jock charm. Other characteristics: emotionally closed off, you don’t know much about why he is the way he is or anything else until his POV. He’s adopted behaviors that he doesn’t even know are a coping mechanism to his growing belief that he cannot love. And for most of his life, he didn’t care that he ‘isn’t able to love’. Bc all that didn’t matter to him. If everyone around him his entire life has convinced him that he was too brash, too harsh, too apathetic for love, then hell, he doesn’t need it anyways. He’s a thrill seeker, trying to find something to make his soul feel alive. Has a pretty pessimistic view on life, and other people. Believes that most people just kind of live their lives too afraid to try new things and too pathetic to change things that they internally complain about, and just live out their years unhappily. He refuses to do that. Doesn’t like those kind of people. And so, he always wants to find something that thrills him. But he doesn’t really have anyone that shares the sentiment. Which is why Izuku, no matter how conflicted he is about the boy, can’t help but be angry bc he can tell that Izuku wants the same things as he does: that thrill, except unlike him, he hods himself back and gets restricted by his mother’s overprotectiveness and etc. Without knowing, he’s romantic, and he shows his feelings through action for sure. Even if he doesn’t realize it. Has a hard time articulating.

**Midoriya Izuku**

An easier character, but still complex and human to write. Like canon, he's extremely attentive and caring, almost too much. Selfless, but not in a healthy way. Pushes aside his own needs and wants in order to appease everyone else. If he makes another person feel bad, then it haunts him. And he always has a plastered face on. Like in the blurb, he's the 'sweetheart' of Ise. And he truly is. He's sweet and beautiful. Physical characteristics: 5'4, also toned because of weight lifting, thick thighs from squats, dresses in a more comfortable and nerdy style like he does in canon.  Anyways, he believes anger is a forbidden emotion. Anger, frustration, etc. etc. all of those emotions that cause his chest to swell up and his veins to threat to burst are horrible, and end up making others feel bad. Because they have the potential to hurt people, he pushes them down because it's not civil and it's not 'happy', and he should be happy and grateful all the time. He gets all of these thoughts instilled by his mother, who's the same way. From little to now, he's been oppressed by his loving but overbearing mother's ideals and values, and has never really experienced anything else aside from that. And so, he's habituated false happiness and  doing what would appease the masses instead of himself. He's understanding, and has the ability to make K open up. He's a wistful type of person, a bit longing.

**2nd love interest : Kaito Sen**

D's 2nd love interest, but D doesn't ever really give him a chance internally. Kaito Sen: 6'0, brunette, grey eyes, has a smug appearance much of the time, likes finer things like clothes, cars, restaurants, etc. Kaito's a bit insecure about himself and his destiny. He wants to be someone of note, yet he doesn't know if he'll be able to accomplish this. And so, he tries to compensate for his insecurity by wanting so badly to be a gentleman. A nice, classy and well established 'man,' hoping to be someone's provider and pillar. He likes a good image, and holds outdated views on sexuality, gender identity, and roles. He thinks his partner should be a little meek, pretty in an elegant effortless way, smart, with a good background, and has suitable hobbies and interests. One of the reasons why D attracted him at first. As well as D's connection to K. K has the ability to further heighten kaito's insecurities. Because K is already what he wants to become: someone of note. Someone who has already made an impact, someone who already has his name plastered in history. And K has everything: all the talent, the intelligence, the notoriety. And yet, K is rude, brash, apathetic, etc. It makes Kaito angry, because someone who tries as hard as him, who was a proper gentleman with moral and values such as him, doesn't get to be blessed by that talent, yet Katsuki, the town asshole, does? It wasn't fair. And so, he holds onto the only point he has over K, which is that he can feel emotion and isn't a shitty person, and uses that over the years to harass the other.

**Inko Midoriya**

Has abandonment issues for sure, and it translates in her parenting. Inko is someone who is heavily flawed, but still a good person. She doesn't even know that her actions and words are manipulative or harmful, for she genuinely believes she's doing it for the both of them. Inko

is sweet, for sure. So sweet that she never raises her voice, never gets overly upset at anything, so that others feel guilty when *they* raise their voices and get upset. Because to her, anger and all of that were ugly emotions. Ungrateful emotions. And ungratefulness is something she cannot stand. It's what caused her husband to leave, she believes. Hisashi was ungrateful: they had it all: a nice house, a kid, a beautiful town with neighbors and places they grew up being around, and everything was fine as they were. She doesn't consider that it was only her dream to stay in Ise, and she never listened to his. And she's about to make the same mistake in regards to D. Somewhere deep inside, she knows that she has fault, but it's difficult to bear knowing she still kind of loves him. With D, she freaks out when things begin changing, bc it makes her believe D is going to leave her too. So she goes through any lengths to make things stay the same. Like the city of Ise, she doesn't want anything to change.

**Mitsuki Bakugo**

An interesting one. She's not too far off from many parents in the world. In fact, she, for the most part, is a normal parent. Not overbearing at all. Gives her child freedoms and still has a good relationship, where they talk and everything. But they mostly talk like friends. Mitsuki does everything so that she qualifies as a mother: cooks food, pays the bills, signs K's parental permission papers before he turned 18, and took care of things that were necessary to take care of. However, on a sentimental, emotional level, she wasn't that type of mother. Because from the beginning, K wasn't that type of son. He was a brash one, rude and just his own little character, and so, Mitsuki didn't bother trying, and instead, since she always was naturally sharp tongued, developed this sense of tough-love relationship. Where they play around, argue, and has a very baseline surface level mother-son connection. But the woman has never given K the tender loving and care that a child needs, even if they have a tough exterior. And this is where she went wrong. She likes to say all sorts of things on the spur of the moment, thinking it won't ever hurt K because nothing has ever hurt K before. And so, she's just convinced that the boy has a hard time with emotions like love and tenderness, and so it is what it is. She still loves him, but they don't get deep with each other *ever* and she doesn't watch her words around him *ever* . Because in her mind, why would she need to? He doesn't seem to care what anyone says.

**Specific Chapter Outlines (only 95% made it into the story)**

**Ch.1 the track field**

- Introduce the main plot driver aka the project. Introduce the characters. Incorporate the beginning about the sky and the ground. Have that come back around later. Symbolism heavy on the fence, but they don't really know that yet. Dynamic between D and K are rivals. And K has a vibe in which he almost seems repulsed by D. D is a sweetheart, who is inspired by K.
- go into details of Ise. set up scenery and vibe immediately of it being kind of quaint, quiet, and feels very old. Kids in the street playing hopscotch, orange sunset, etc.
- End with the callback to the title. This chapter is slow, so hopefully, that being the ending is strong enough to make people curious.

**Ch. 2 the diner**

- make sure the map of Ise is very detailed. When they drive, make sure you detail what's on either side of them.
- Pick up on D watching K practice. Take a pic together as project proof. Afterwards, K is hungry. D wants to come with. "No." and walks away. But D ends up convincing.
- Settle into K's whip. Smells like cherry car freshener. Awkward car ride. Neither know what to say.
- Ends up at a diner. The people there know him, but he tries to hide it. D is intrigued at a potential secret side of K that the athlete tries to hide. Begin the banter and it's not too bad between the two of them, even if it's still a little mean.. Split the check. Talk about the project's next week plans. D realizes that he doesn't go out much. His hobbies are mostly staying inside. He says K can pick what they do.
- K is quiet. Says he doesn't like to plan things. And throws a diss hinting at D's overprotective mom and hesitant nature. Spontaneous is better. D mentions his strict schedule & diet saying how can he be spontaneous.
- K says its different. says his mom wouldn't ever agree to that. Later, K drops D off. His mom shows up. Was about to berate him when she sees K. D looks back as he walks in. K looks away.
- Next week of school is wordless. They don't really talk. After the day ends, D still comes by to look at K practicing. But once K notices, D turns away. After seeing it up close, he didn't want to be on the sidelines. On solo day, he doesn't say anything. He brings a cherry gatorade. And sits there, watching. K doesn't say anything either. When he's done, he looks at D once. And then drives home.
- Friday comes around, and no word from K.
- That night, D hears a knock on his window. K climbed up a tree. D freaks. Sneak out. Go out onto the lake. K pushes D in. K has a tattoo. Hawk tattoo. After his first vault. Fun times. Water photo w/ flash. It's cold bc spring just started. D catches K try to hide a smile. Helps climb up the tree. Wet clothes coming back in.
-

**Ch.3 the kickoff**

- Have K's friend come up and invite them to the pole vault season kick off party.

- Explain the tradition of the fights. It's a cookout near the beach that starts at around 6pm. Someone's beach house.
- He has to ask mom. Tension. Details. Mention something about dad. She gets mad. Walking on eggshells.Wednesday: physics hw. D needs help. Hesitantly calls. K helps him. They end up talking for a little bit (make it banter). Maybe k only helps if he leaves himself idkk Have something to do w toshinori probably just a brief mention about what it was like at school for the next few days.
- . D dresses okay, not super hot or anything. But still decent enough. He has a beer, and watches the fights. There's a girl on K's arm. It makes him shy, but doesn't bother him per se.
- Izuku analyzes the fight, and some stranger says "if you know so much, why don't you?" D and K fight. "K hasn't raised a hand to me in years. I'll be fine." A bit of a struggle bc D is surprising, but K ultimately wins. Pins down. D has a cut on his jaw, cleans it. 'Stop with those creepy ass eyes.' and applies ointment on his side. K has experience w bruising bc of pole vault. As for his arms and legs, don't move it too much. Now, they have a pretty long convo. Light hearted. D realizes he likes talking to K like this. K mentions horror movies. Finally tells K, 'i know where i want to go.' "did this not count as our one hour?" "no." and to pick him up Friday night after practice. A girl goes up to K and drags him away. D hangs out with a group. Someone pushes D into the pool : drunk person, accident. K gets mad. Takes him into owner's bedroom. D strips , slips on a big tshirt. K looks for a second. K takes D home bc his ride is going home w someone.

Ch. 4 the drive in

- Picks him up on Friday. He's only able to go bc it is K. ask about arm. Go to a drive in. 'why are we here/ cue' complain about the movie. D explains the movement of something. It's really cute. Haunted house--they could walk. D would never, but K drags him anyways. They find nothing. Go back and sit on the roof of K's car in the empty movie screening lot. Crickets. Stars. They talk. Conversation about It Follows. D thinks he likes this side of K. K gets a text. Looks frustrated. D asks. K's coach sometimes complains about his record. He hasn't actually gained an inch for months now. He says he doesn't care. D frowns. He should. It's okay to care. D asks why K pole vaults. K says to win. Why does he want to win. To be the best. But he already is the best. So what when? K gets defensive. Closes up. Gets light hearted again. They see something. Run away. Laughing.
- Hm maybe a montage here of 2-3 weeks. Bike ride scene: K behind D, hands on his waist. If you do, make it extrmely in depth. Barely make it a montage. "Sunday , you gonna be there?"
- Sunday is a local competition. It should practically be illegal to let K compete. Wait, K calls D the night before. D says something motivating. Heart flutters when he sees K clear a bar. "Oh no oh no. not this."

Ch. 5 the lake party

- Beach then break into an ice cream shop. They visit the beach at sunset. There's scratches on K's back. I asks about them. K tells him 'sex.'. Deku feels jealous. Mention that K likes hiking. Hawaii-esque. When it got dark, D wanted ice cream. K's uncle owned the shop so he picked the lock and they go in and eat ice cream.D's phone rings. Looks distraught. It's mom. Conv about that. K shows sign of impatience
- "Got an appointment" "At this time?" "What kind of appointment do you think it is" d is curious. K "why u wanna threesome" d says he does swing that way. "What. With a dude?" "No, with a woman"
- Convo w/ friends the next day about it.
- Their groups sit at lunch together for some reason. The tables were pulled Bc of some event. .
- Maybe this should be the scene that D is masturbating , falls asleep w window open. K comes in and teases him about the dildo. "You put that in you?"
- K needs to be caught up in something, so they stay in D's room. Super domestic. Maybe K accidentally stays the night and D finds himself staringZ
- Are you going to the lake party? Mom says i've been going out a lot. And? 'You dont hang out w me in public anyways.'
- Inko interaction. Make them hang out, talk about dad. D asks.
- Lake party. He looks pretty hot. They go swim under the boat. Kind of hot proximinitt. Some point, K spits alc into D's mouth. Tells him to swallow. During a would you rather game or something , oh make the second love interest do that too. . K doesn't get drunk. Or do drugs. D sees K with someone making out and shit. Feeling stupid.Feelingheat. He knows what it is: it's jealousy. D goes and drinks away his feelings. Lmao scene where shoto mentions D doesn't have a gag reflex. Maybe someone tries to take advantage not on purpose. They're drunk too. Probably a dance floor and D is going wild. .K steps in. K tells ppl to back the fuck up. deals w/ drunk D. 'you're acting fucking ridiculous, come on" his mom would kill him. So K takes D to his house.

Ch. 6 the stereo

- Pick up from the party-- morning after, D sees K practicing outside, frustrated, goes down & sees Mitsuki. Have a convo over coffee. She tells D not to go out there. And so, K comes in later and D is taken into his room. There's a pic of them from a long time ago, K stands in the way but D sees it. Says nothing. Wonders why it hasn't been thrown away. End scene with convo about the previous night. Go back and insert something about mitsuki's revelation not being related, so it doesn't confused people.
- Begin with a chill scene. Something kind of sweet. Make sure to talk about K liking planes. have a scene where K has another appointment and D asks "is there any chance you'd stay if i asked?' "you wont know if you dont ask.' K leaves and comes back moments later .
- Thursday again. D comes to watch. K is frustrated. He couldn't clear a certain bar. D decides that everyone has given up on reaching out to K, so he won't be another statistic. After all, people did the same to him except opposite. They talk after a bit of defensiveness. Admits nervousness. Whistle scene. Doesn't resolve much. D asks if they could go back to his house. D tells him when he was 11, he made this in case they

ever made up. K was like ‘lmao im not wearing that’ D was pushy. And K wore it on his wrist, inside out. Save this detail for chapter 11

- K doesn’t answer, but tells D to meet him at a scene at sunset.
- Scene where K teaches D how to pole vault. Fluttery feelings. “K takes him up to the sky with him. For thefirst time, Right then, it feels like the distance between them disappeared, as D touches the same clouds he always sees K flying through.’
- In the morning, Inko and him have a conversation. She decides not to let him go to the dance. I is upset, but just accepts it. He’s allowed to g o out for his project, but he needs to limit himself. He’s getting out of hand. D mentions dad and how he would have let him go. I gets upset.
- K’s regional meet. D watches. There’s the inverted headband on his wrist. Kaito jersey scene . K is pissed.
- Toshironi asks him. D asks him why he had done that. And then to run an errand. K is somewhere w a girl, who has her hands on his waistband. Super awkward encounter.
- D is feeling weird things. His friends urge him to go on a date. They suggest maybe it’s Bc he spends too much time w K. Or something like that. Has something scheduled. W Kaito
- Project day: so Inko allows it: Ride around in shopping carts. End up watching planes take off or something. D’s suggestion. When asked why. Because u said u liked it. Kiss scene after teasing D.. “how’s he gonna like living with the fact that no matter how close you get and how many dates you go on, you’re only going to be watching me at practice?”
- Or maybe have k looks like he’s conflicted and then let’s D go , saying “have a good time”
- Been so busy he doesn’t have to time to tell his friends about the kiss.
- Put the dance scene here. Hm. or maybe earlier?? Do you want izuku to accept his feelings at this scene or when he’s up in the air. K asks about the date. D says it’s good. K asks ‘did he treat you right’ Also have the sprinklers turn on at night and they laugh

Ch. 7

- characterizations: make it so that K is making subtle changes that gets hammered in later in the fic. “That’s when D realized: he hasn’t slept with someone for weeks.” Hasn’t gone to a single party. None of that.
- Scene where K is frustrated w his head down. ‘What the fuck is wrong with me’ where shold this even be? Idk.
- Make more obvious points that K is attracted to D. Have a dialogue where K admits that D is beautiful , or that he’s important while still leaving vulnerability there.
- And also build up exactly WHY they fell off in the first place and make it fucking worth it brUH. People are waiting.

- Day trip to the creek and rice field?. What even happens here? They should run through a corn maze. K finds him and picks him up. Talk about college too.
- Go to an official pole vault court. Talk about love and the dr sures quote “Why , are you in love with Kaito ?”
- Bakugo Katsuki?”Convo : “when did you notice me first watching you’

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- Okay wait: make a decision: do you want kaito & D to have like… a thing? Or do you prefer to have the occasional date and not have their romantic ties so deeply connected. That might make the end a little more intense. I mean, you could mention they've gone out 1 or 2 more times. And there's the same lackluster feelings. Literally, why do people want D to get with Kaito? Like he's literally so annoying. I need to make him more annoying.
- On D's mom. Get worse. ".
- Another instance of K still being emotionally reserved.
- Cliff of wishes. K doesn't have a wish.
- There should be a jealousy scene on D's part. Or a scene where for some reason D dresses really nice & there's sexual tension. Maybe a themed day at school. Afterwards they get hot dogs from a food truck. Go to a vinyl store.

- Rain on his way home from school. K is pole jumping in the rain. Reaches his hands out. Establish a scenes of normalcy in their hangouts. D accepts it. Maybe they go out and kayak. Idk. stops raining.
- "You haven't slept with anyone in a while" "don't really feel the need to".hasn't actually done it since they've started the project. "If you're so frustrated why do you still stay when i ask" vulnerably confesses "Because there's places I'd rather be" They go back to his car. It's humid. Crickets. Argument. About their personalities. Silent. 'We got shit to work on.' they lay back on the asphalt. Cops come. Ask them if they're drunk. Says inko knocked on his door. "So that's it? I'm just a charity case to you?" "God, how stupid do you think I am?" "You're so closed off you don't know what's good anymore" "I was fucking fine before you came" maybe D should call him a coward "you don't even know the songs-"
- Okay but why did they fall off. Bruh im gonna actually cry if ppl are expecting some super deep back story, and then it's lackluster. Or it's not built up enough. I feel like that's what I'm scared of most, that it won't have a big enough impact. Something i want is for someone who's reading to think 'that makes so much sense' instead of 'huh, so that's why.' like, i want the stories to connect the dots, not pull backstories out of a hat and roll with it.
- Obviously, the reason they stopped talking is bc a turn of events happened. Somehow connect it to k's character habits.
- So let's dissect this a little bit: what *are* K's emotional habits. He's closed off, doesn't want people to be disappointed in him so he turns them away, and he obviously *hates* the fact that I is complacent in his own life. And have no sense of anger, etc, and just accepts his shortcomings with force smiles.
- Therefore, the backstory needs to connect that. Maybe the photo connected to it somewhere. Something i've been thinking this entire time is: K asks them if D remembers a certain day (the one before or on the day the photo he keeps was taken), D says no (bc WHAT ELSE CAN HE SAY. LITERALLY I DID NOT DO WELL ENOUGH BUILDING IT UP PLS KILL ME). K recounts the story. In which K in a moment of rage hurt D, hit him or whatever, or did something really bad to D. And instead of getting mad or angry, D jst smiled and accepted it. Even though there was slight disappointment in his eyes. And K hated that about D so much, and thought he was fucking pathetic. Bc D was happy go lucky about everything: his mistreatment. He would have forgiven K for anything he did. Baseless and blind adoration disgusted him,

bc he knew that D gave him the power to destroy him, and that made him angry. No matter what i did to you, you would have smiled and pretended it was okay. Do you know how much it pissed me off? I fucking *hate* people who are complicit in their own shit. I hate it because you shove all your anger and shit away, but i can see it in your damn eyes how much it hurts you and that fucking dissapointment is not something i'm gonna take.

- Hm, that might work. Who knows. Anyways, make this emotional. Lots of crying. However, make it clear, that the bulk of how katsuki is was NOT because of izuku. It was bc of everything combined together: the expectations, the fact that he couldn't help his shitty personality, the pressure, the insecruity of losing "I can't lose." all cumulated to make K who he is now. And it's gonna be a process to unwind all of that.
- D goes home and talks to his mom. Feels bad. Thinks back to what k said. He's allowed to feel mad. "You're like this town, mom! Stuck in the past." "I… I can't even control myself when I'm like this Bc I don't know what to do" "Everythme we argue, I tell myself to calm down , to not get mad, but I'm so sick of holding it in" Leaves the house back in the rain "sorry for showing up so early again" while crying. End up in guest room's bed. "Hold me" "Deku I can't" "then hold me *that* way" rubs over k's crotch. tries to seduce k who resists and insists they go back to sleep and that d only wants to so he can distract himself. Trails kisses or hovers his lips. Is sweet to him and learns a little bit how to be more affectionate . in the end, holds him after D doesn't want his pity. 'Only for tonight'
- Promises to be different.
- Next practice, D comes to K. See if he's bark and no bite. , in front of everyone, hands him a gatorade. K hsitates but takes it. Asks him if he wants to watch.
-

Ch. 8

- County fair and everything else gets postponed bc it rains a lot for the next week or so. The only thing open is the diner. Hence. The diner scene. Kaito should make out w D in front of K (Kaito took them there on purpose) & his group of friends. At some point, they get left alone bc K wanted to do something crazy. And D was easily like 'sure' . Kaito didn't want him to
- "Did you not come to the kick off ? The shitty nerd could beat your ass any second he wanted to. You think you can protect him? Don't fucking treat him like a child." Kaito gives in but before he does kisses Izuku and there's a bit of tension.
- They sit on a rooftop and talk. K admits he was a little harsh. Maybe here is where they talk about love? Meteor shower. K looks at D instead of the meteor shower. 'Is something wrong.' 'and before you say no, remember what you promised me.' 'everything. And yet, nothing at all.' 'you're still being cryptic you know' 'i know.'
- Briefly mention regionals maybe. D should stand up for himself at some point. Hold his ground. Him & his mom are *not* on good terms. They barely talk. Inko is just quiet all the time.
- Katsuki should admit D is beautiful in this chapter at some point. Or maybe not Bc that is going a little too fast.

- County fair. Maybe inko should really quietly tell him to have fun. I think she should see k taking care of D first though. D goes w/ Kaito since he promised. It's only been a bit awkward since that night.. Anyways Kaito gives him flowers at the fair. They go do stuff. Ferris wheel. Swings. Good food. Kaito go gets him some. "He's brunette. He's nice to you, gives you flowers. Do you love him?"
- Kaito comes back w/ food, and as they walk away, he drops his wallet. Opens and there's a condom and a packet of lube. Katsuki picks it up, stares at it, then looks up , 'this yours?' 'yeah.' K gives it back, but keeps his hands on it. Kaito says something like 'hope i get lucky' . K does't say anything, glances over at D for a moment, before turning away.
- Talk about jealousy as a theme. And how it relates to the struggle of not being transparent.
- 'You're gonna let him fuck you?' as D goes to throw his plastic wrapper away. 'Maybe' .
- at some point, K's like nope, when kaito goes to the bathroom. "Let's get out of here" and D is like 'what? I can't.' K isn't being fair. K looks frustrated. 'Please. I…." he's lost on words.
- Okay so currently in contemplation : should the sex scene be on the waterside somewhere ? Or in the middle of a field on K'a dad's truckbed and they're gonna watch the fireworks. Scene where K repeats 'because you said you liked it." 'what' and repeats the quote from chapter 3/4 .
- Realization of love.
- Hm. how do they transition into the sex scene. 'Do you remember what i asked you?'
- Sex scene. Condom and stuff in the wallet. Near waterside . "i thought i wasn't your type" "i lied"
- Maybe have K embarrassed. 'What's wrong..' 'fuck.' 'i usually...last longer.' (to be fair, he lasts really long).
- Really emphasize the difference in experience and their "roles." K the athlete with everyone on him. D with no experience. And yet, he drives K insane.
- Either end w the "i lied" quote, OR end with Izuku realizing he is so so so so so fucked. Or both?
- Characterizations: Katsuki struggles but clearly tries and making improvements in his sentimental ness but make sure the readers know that it's hard and it's never a straight path. And Izuku also advocates for himself more. Stands his ground. And maybe even talks back and doesn't accept something someone does. Have Katsuki make more obvious comments that seem laced with confusion about his attraction to Deku. Aka , make it seem like Katsuki is really struggling with himself about how to feel on his clear attraction to D , when he is unsure on what exactly to do about it.
-

Ch. 9 NEEDS SOME WORK

- Shift in their dynamic. Tension. Constant thinking. Awkwardness?? Or maybe k pretends to not be exclusive and tells him that he'll be w others and then tells a chick who tries to talk to him to fuck off.
- Okay hold your horses. First, how should the chapter start? Literally, it can't just go into the meat of the chapter. It needs to start with what happened after they fucked.

Have a convo about what happened. Unsure of whether they want to do it again. Izuku feels weird knowing that he's now a name on a list.

- However, as the week unfolds, it's very obvious the both of them want to have sex again. Eye contact in the cafeteria in the middle of a conversation. Someone tries to touch D casually, but K wordlessly cuts through.
- A really tension filled discussion that leads back to sex. They should go out and do something that made them dirty. Maybe they play basketball until sunset.
- Montage time. They continue to have a lot of sex. All the time. Everywhere they can. D feels growing insecurity. Bridge jump / pier jump"Don't overstep your boundaries"
- WAIT. KATSUKI should never initiate.
- Still have sex. Mention about D's insecurity
- Make Izuku realize more about his own flaws and mistreatment of Kaito.
- Have Izuku talk to his friends. And t alk to them more than just preface/.
- Have a sex scene where someone is likely to come in , but K needs to fuck so bad he doesn't care. "Honestly Deku?" "I really don't care right now."
- He passed his current record, spins D around.
- D wants to cry. He's so in love.  Lots of sunsets in this chapter.
- Domestic  and have dinner with inko .
- do something vullllnerable
- Scene where k shows emotional care and tries to change himself a lot , but Deku doesn't like it . Go to a restaurant, have a typical date or so. And it's just a mess but a cute mess. Literally make people go awH, in a sad way. This is after K gets the impression that Kaito takes Izuku out and stuff.
- 'Is this how you fuck others"

- Training arc. K consistently gets a good bar.
- Have a bigger really SWEET scene here. Idk what it is yet, but make it unbelievably romantic.  It should maybe be a night market scene. Festival? Izuku in traditional clothing?
- Maybe there's a scene where D has slow sex but K doesn't like it even tho he came, and leaves right afterwards. In K's flashback, he goes to the vault afterwards and yells his frustrations away
- mention more about the paper too.  Lighthouse scene.
- this is a pretty anti climatic thingie. Add more drama that isn't just jealousy .
- Characterizations: again, have Katsuki truly struggle to express himself. But do so kinder, and more on Izuku's favor rather than his own.

Ch. 10

- Okay now, for more of a detailed outline that follows real chronological order. Decide whether or not to input last scene w/ K. Anyways, D and Kaito go skinny dipping. They fuck. Kaito leaves a lot of hickeys, everywhere. Inner thighs, back, neck, it's crazy.
- "Tell me…tell me you love me too."
- Conversation after where Kaito digs into K again, talk about his emotions, izuku realizes he's been unfair. Places the same expectations. But then he thinks of kimi. And then thinks of good moments. He's just so confused. Kaito asks why he keeps going

back & forth. I says it's really easy to say all of that when you're not the one experiencing it. "I wish i could make all the right decisions. I wish i can help it.' He goes to school the next day completely covered up, and K doesn't say anything, just walks past.

- They have a debate in another class together: it's tense. K leaves early. Later, D goes to drop something off. K goes out of the shower. They fuck. Hate sex. Explain the situation w kimi. D is still mad. Both came really intensely. Shit talks kaito. Izuku asks, what if i want to or whatever. K looks so upset, and angry, but he turns away to where D doesn't see him. His face just won't turn to Izuku. And it's a while before he speaks. His shoulders look like they were on the verge of shaking.
- Admits there's nothing he can do, if D is happy w someone else. In a quiet voice. "If you're happy with someone else...even if it's him, what can I do." here they have a sentimental convo, about their own toxicity. Scene where K sucks at badminton but D sees him practicing. So that he can play with D. another scene where K gets slandered in school or something, and he just sits there with his hands clasped together in front of his face, staring blankly.
- "It's because of people like you!" and then he cries, looking down at his hands "A-and, it's because of people like me…"
- Gets mad at kaito. Goes to see his friends. Should have thought about that in the first place. He thinks that internally, a part of him did want to make katsuki jealous. And he laughs out loud at how stupid love drives people. How little self preservation there is in this game.
- "You're still not going to love me?" -----
- (Kimi is near, is nice w convo, says that K left marks. D said k never does that.)
- "Don't you want to love ? Isn't that why you listen to all those songs"
- Mention writing the paper.
- Maybe he should go skinny dipping with Kaito and do stuff. If he does then have it ends by going somewhere w k and he sees hickeys that d avoids. He plans to get over k. Before it gets too late.
- . HM it should be at a beach bonfire and D leaves early when he realizes he's way too deep. Beforehand have D drop something off at K's house and K has mad hate sex w him fueled by jealousy. Covers up existing hickeys on D with his own on neck, chest, thighs. D refuses to fuck on the bed bc he doesnt want to be another statistic. K tells him "shut the fuck up. No one's been on here since i first fucked you." D is confused "What?" Turns out, the other shit was a lie. But that didn't negate the fact that K was saying that he's just fucking him
- Run across parking lot. Have it be a musty vibe under a white street lamp w the ocean waves breaking not too far and they could hear their friends from a distance
- "You've been wanting me to go away all this time, why make me stay now?" "You've been staying near me all this time, why leave now?"
- "Everytime I realize that I love you, I'm reminded of how much you don't. And I ask myself, is it suppose to hurt this bad? Is it supposed to feel like this? In the movies, they make it look so nice. I want it be nice too. Why doesn't it feel good kacchan?"
- "You connect being in love to losing. But it's not!"
- Confession on D's part. Have him spill his guts "you want me to express my negative feelings right?" Maybe he doesn't look at him at first.'why dont u look at me' 'bc youdont like my eyes'

- “Do you love me? Or do you love the experience I give you? Do you love me? Or do you love how I was the only one who showed you the outside of the four walls that is your bedroom? Do you love me? Or do you love your life more now and think it’s connected to me? Do you love me? Or do you just love how I make you feel?” slaps him.
- “I’ve always been on the sidelines. You showed me the track field. But I can’t chase after tou forever
- D cries and goes “dont...don’t say that. Don’t invalidate my feelings like that. What is wrong w/ u . yes, that’s all true. Etc etc. but I love your eyes. I love how you hate fireflies and how you never finish your pecan pie so you can save it for later. Do you believe me now? Or do I need to rip my heart out and .
- Maybe he kisses him one last time before leaving.
- “Do you remember when you said I was complicit in my own unhappiness? I still am.”
- Theme: the whole story, you get quotes that are tossed back and forth, circling around eventually, showing up one place just to show up again in another. And so, when we switch over to Katsuki’s perspective, that is ultimate full circle.

Ch. 10 conti

- D cries his heart out & skips school for two days, Inko goes into the whole “when i fell in love” and comforts D. gonna go to the city (with? Or without his mom. Living on his own) for the weekend.
- You’re all I think about.
- Goes back, and plays tennis or something -- slams K in the face, treats his wounds. D needs a ride home & and up taking him somewhere afterwards. Awkward. But somehow K has sex w him again. (or maybe, D tries to get over him but knows they have one hour left and so he asks for one more time” . ‘What are we doing.” D is so fucking in love w him. K is selfish: wants to continue what they had. They talk about the future. Then about marriage. K asks D “you’re not talking about me, are you?”
- D smiles softly, “No. Someone who will love me, too.”

‘What are you thinking. I feel like I’m always trying to guess.”

“You know how in books, there’s different perspectives of the story?” “i just wished that I could’ve read yours.”

- End chapter. Last chapter begins K looking like a *mess*. with I cutting down the treee. Pole vaults onto his window every night: “Talk to me.” “About what” “I don’t know, I just nee”

Ch. 11

- Relay their entire relationship from Katsuki’s POV. this however, may ruin the element of angst for the final chapter. Since the mysteriousness of how katsuki feels is gone.

Lmao never mind no it won't. Bc by then, hopefully, if i did K's character right, then it'll be obvious what he feels, except there's clear struggle to accept it. I feel like having this ch be in K's POV is important, bc the entire fic, we only see D's perspective. And at the absolute climax, when all the shit hits the fan, D wishes that he could have seen what K was thinking this entire time, bc it hurts so much to forever guess what the person you love is thinking. And then BOOM, very next chapter is reliving the relationship through K's lens.

- Kaito scene in locker room: have k try to hold his chill while Kaito taunts him. And then Kaito goes 'i asked him what it was like to be just another one of your bodies' Kaito says , 'that was a fun reaction' and that's when k loses it -- 'dont you fucking dare call him… he's not. He's not-"
- Here, make sure that K is clearly struggling, in a behind the scenes way that D never saw. With his emotions. Make it clear that he thinks more deeply on things than it looks, and that many of the events that happened between him and D affected him too, not just D.
- When izuku says 'as someone who ____" katsuki thinks, "for the first time, katsuki feels lonely up in the sky." call back to the beginning of the chpater
- Do some scenes where it's *just* K. like after D gets fucked by someone else in chapter ...was it 10? Idk. and make him get ridiculously angry in the locker room. A huge fight. We never see this in D's perspective. But it goes to show that K doesn't just think about D when they're together. Also have Kimi call him Kacchan and he get angry
- God i need to pee, sitting on the side of an airport gate trying to fill in more of this outline is not fun. Anyways recap scenes where D only heard from other people. For example, the dance. Go into why he actually left the dance.
- Izuku GROUNDS him, and Katsuki allows Izuku to FLY. They make up the heaven and the earth, both of which are necessary to live. While Izuku's theme is the sky, Katsuki's should be the ground. Life goes in circles.
- Katsuki gets flowers bc he subconsciously remembers that izuku said his type were people who did that stuff. Feels insecure about his shittiness
- Since you practically go through the whole fic again, at the end, since it's really fresh on the reader's mind, really hammer in on the 'how did it get to this point" aspect of it al.
- Katsuki's birthday scene. He doesn't want to make it a big deal, just go w him somewhere.
- Scene towards the end where katsuki is on his phone and wants to call him. Im not in love plays in the background.
- Talk about promises of the future. Fall, apple icking
- A mirror maze ??

"Because in a movie, he'll come back. In a movie, they always come back."

He's scared he'll drown in those green eyes

Ch. 12 : The Maze

- Revised version: okay so probably pick up at the beach house, have a very sad after-the-storm-and-everything-is-ruined-and-there-is-this-painful-acceptance-of-how-life-moves-on-while-you're-stuck-in-this-constant-pain type of emotion playing. Aka, bright sunny skies, beautiful weather & sunsets, birds chirping, ocean roaring. Ise never changes. It's just so beautiful. And this fact, once Katsuki wakes up, frustrates him. Because why do things never seem to change. It's like the same cycle over and over again. He can't fucking change. Just like Ise, he's just stuck in this loop of false content. And so he calms himself down. He opens his phone, wants to call someone. Realizes he can't call anyone. Goes to school.
- Also im gonna be completely honest, i have no idea how the timeline for this fic works, but im gonna pretend i do and roll w it. Anyways, he goes back to school. Doesn't fucking know what he's going to do when he sees the other, and sees the world in Izuku's eyes. A world swimming with love that he can't return. Doesn't blame izuku.
- In school, he doesn't see Izuku. Numbness. He practices like crazy. Doesn't see izuku pass. Memories flash some more. He pushes it away by practicing harder and harder.
- The next day, cafeteria. Or somewhere. You should probably make this some kind of like...80s event. Kimi goes and talks. Says something about being in love. Everyone fucking hops on that, and makes fun of katsuki, who just kind of internalizes it. Sits back, eyes staring straight, drinks water. Acts unbothered. Izuku asks them to stop from the other table. People claim that izuku shouldnt just say that bc he's afraid of katsuki. Before he could say something, kaito speaks up, after being pretty quiet, and is the one who tells them to stop it. Whole room is surprised. Katsuki considers this, thinks whatever, and grabs his backpack to leave. It's on his mind all day, and he does the same shit again -- pole vaults till he literally cries again. It's like floodgates are open. Izuku sees him. Katsuki tells him to go away. They just sit where it all began, a foot a part, in the twilight. Izuku apologizes for some stuff. And then he leaves, but katsuki offers to take him home --all while looking a little stressed. He drops izuku off. There's this feeling of strangers that he doesn't like creeping in. when he goes back, he looks into his bag because he forgot something in there. A cherry gatorade. He lets out a pained chuckle. He honestly wants it out of his sight.
- Goes to his mom, at night. Stands sweaty and defeat. Voice croaks. "Mom, am i able to love?" mitsuki is shocked. They drop everything. They sit down together. He's this big boy, etc. but he's still so small, and so in need of love and care like a little boy. Calls his grandfather (?).
- Next day or so, there is a fundraiser event. Mirror maze is there. Katsuki works it. Kaito comes by for the next shift. They stand there side by side for a bit. And talk. Goes to the lemonade stand, sees izuku standing off to the side, and katsuki feels the need to be near him. Right as the mirror maze is about to close, katsuki decides why not and goes in. izuku comes in. they see each other. Have some wordless scene where they keep walking past. Do the metaphor shit. Side by side, until they sit back and back against a mirror pane---going in circles trying to get to each other but not being able to (metaphorically and literally)-- and they talk a little bit through the panes. "You'll always stay in my heart, but I don't think you can stay in my life." "you know you're in love when the love songs you listen to feel less like stories and more like reality." "no. no, no. if that is true. If this love song's story was turning into their reality, then katsuki wants another one. He wants another story."
- At some pivotal point in their conversation, katsuki turns around to look at Izuku.

AND BOOM. THE POV CHANGES INTO IZUKU'S. IMMEDIATE FUCKING DEPRESSION.

Take it back to the scene where they left off. But have it really be smooth. Katsuki's last pov lines "And when he looked into those eyes, Katsuki wonders what he has been on all this time, because just as this is all ending in front of him, he finds Izuku's eyes too beautiful to look away from."

"When he looked into those eyes, he thinks of ____. For one of the first times, just as this is all ending in front of him, Izuku finds Katsuki's eyes too painful to look at.

Now run it backkkk. Leaves the hideaway. Car with mom. Quiet. All he can do is cry. The song "Tell me how am i supposed to live without you" on the radio. Or maybe have this play during the mirror maze scene. Whatever, just make it sad as fuck, yeah? But the drive home is sad. Izuku can't go up to his room, bc all he can think of is katsuki and how much he loved him. And so izuku stays in their empty guest room. Inko comes in, with a blanket and pillow and is just there for him. She then talks. About hisashi. And about her. And about them. About everything. And they cry together. And izuku asks his mom "let's leave. Tomorrow, let's go some places. I want to show you" after all, i can't keep running after him forever. I have to stand up on my own two feet, as well.

They go out, to wherever. Idk fucking make it nice. Inko is apprehensive. But at some point, the fun dies down to a silence. And inko tries to enlighten izuku on katsuki's side. Plays both cards. Izuku understands how unfair he had been being or so.

He goes back. And hears the people talking shit, says something. Sees katsuki practice and was he...crying? Concerned, he comes in. notices he has a gatorade out of habit (maybe). And they sit. For an hour. And that's how they fill out their hour for the week. The papers were going to be due soon. And so, he sits down and writes. The next few days feel like a blur, but is katsuki-less. The world feels a little less beautiful without the blonde. And izuku itches to see him. But he knew that it would only be a cycle of neverending heartbreak if he were to. He cuts the branch off from the tree that led up into his bedroom bc he would imagine katsuki up there too much.

And for a little while, it's silent. And then he hears rustling. Katsuki pole vaults every day right up to izuku's window, and gives him a little recap.

"I'm going to Keio, it's official." and then as the days leading up to the tournament comes, the visits get shorter but they're still there. The semester ends, and nothing happens.

Ch. 13 The National Qualifiers [or The End]

- Start with izuku in the middle of a conversation with his mother. Everything feels zoned out. He muted his phone. His mind is on katsuki and the kiss. What did it mean. Why did he do that? He was angry and confused and more in love and just out of it. And he's thinking of katsuki's tournament. And how he had excuses. There were things to be done. His mother needed grocery shopping. He needed to finish up some applications. Etc. but internally, he knew that he just wanted a reason not to fall in love w katsuki all over again. Bc he knew that the moment he sees the blonde jump, it'll be over for him. Besides, it's not like katsuki needed him. He has many friends. Etc. family. If izuku came, he wouldn't even be able to see in front of the crowds. His mom calls him back, and it feels like everything is pinched back to reality. His mom knows why he's out of it, and tells him he should go. Izuku shakes his head. And says no. it'll be over anyways. It's a 4 hour drive. Plus, he doesn't have tickets. It doesn't matter. Izuku goes and he runs errands. And finally, he gets groceries at 1pm or so. See's mr. toshinori while grocery shopping. And they talk. About summer. And stuff. Finally gets to the point, and mr. toshinori asks how izuku has been holding up. Blah blah. Then he talks about how katsuki's paper was funny to read because he was cursing so much. But it was so well written that he didn't count off for it bc it was a personal analytic essay. Katsuki says something really interesting in his beginning line. Couldn't say why it mattered though. Izuku asks what it was. And mr toshinori looked confused, and says "People say beauty is inside. Beauty is grace. Beauty is kindness. I say all of that is bullshit. Beauty ain't nothing but a pair of green eyes and a stupid grin sitting out the sunroof going down a dirt road." Izuku panics. Why would katsuki say that. Why would he say that to him. Overwhelming emotions. Bc it can't be real. Not after being told he has creepy ass eyes all this time. It can't be real. Mr toshinori doesn't see the panic and keeps talking. Mentions the tourney. Wished he could come support, but he's hosting a little dinner tonight for his friend grand torino coming into town. Kept rambling. Izuku was only half listening.when he came to turn in his paper, i asked how he felt. And he told me as long as his good luck charm was there, he'll be fine. I sure hope he didn't forget it at home today.
- But izuku dropped his eggs and milk, and RANNNNN. Ran to the car, and dialed his mom. And drove. And pressed the fucking GAS. CUTS DOWN the time. When he gets to the stadium, it's 4pm, which should be when katsuki began jumping. He's stressed out. And there is a long line bc of traffic coming in and out. Izuku parks somewhere random. And begins to run. Cross fucking country. Starts to run. Goes past security. However, at the ticket officer, he just fucking books it and yells back "sorry sir, i won't do it again". But keeps running, even if people are confused. He goes up, sees katsuki and looks clearly nervous. It's approaching the higher bars. Huge crowd. Izuku sees on his wrist was the inverted headband. Izuku grabs a megaphone, and takes a deep breath and whistles Never Gonna Change My Love For You, waiting for katsuki to finish. Crowd goes quiet. Confused. His friends at the back confused too. Callback moment.
- Immediately, katsuki turns. Sees izuku's panting. Calls for a timeout. First timeout ever taken. And he runs towards the stadium, and climbs up the sides. Starts panicking 'why weren't you here? Where were you?' while izuku overwhelmed shook his head and says "i'm sor-" "you promised. You fucking promised me, deku. You promised you'll be here." "i'm here." Katsuki grabs his head, both of them have tears brimming in their eyes, "You said you'd be here," katsuki's voice was breaking. Izuku holds onto his hands, "kacchan, i'm here." "How long will you be here?" Izuku replies "i-"

- “You’ll leave afterwards won’t you. You’ll leave,” Katsuki looks around, “no, no, you can’t go.” tells him they’re leaving. Everyone is in a panic and they can see people approaching katsuki. Izuku says they can’t leave. He’ll lose. He’ll lose the tournament. “Goddamnit, i’ll lose it then!” and goes on a tirade. But izuku tells him to win. Everyone is shocked. Everyone is shocked as fuck. Katsuki makes him promise then, promise he’ll stay. They need to talk. Even if he doesn’t know what to say, he’ll figure it out. Izuku promises. He’ll stay, as he’s practically being forced away. He whistles.
- Katsuki breaks 18’3 and he’s in semi finals.  The stick wobbled on the last attempt. Izuku comes in before the last attempt by the way. He doesn’t accept the trophy or even waits for results. He just leaves.
- Anyways, after the crowd clears out, they drive back. And it was quiet. Katsuki says he’ll drive somewhere quiet for them to just talk. Ends up at the cliff of wishes again. Hard time. Little spat that begins with “tell me again” (that you love me). Izuku finds it unfair.
- “Everyone always says that falling in love was the best decision they’ve ever h
- ad. But it never felt like i had a decision. You came in with your _____ and i have no choice but to fall in love with you. You know what the funny thing is though? Even if i had a choice, i’d still choose to love you.” maybe this line? Idk. it’s kinda much. no matter how high I fly, I’ll never be as close to heaven as I am when I’m with you.”
- Little argument, and they squabble about how they’re from two different worlds anyways. And katsuki sucks at expressing his shit, until izuku looks like he wants to leave. Again, theme of going around in circles. But katsuki was determined to break the circle. And then katsuki reaches down to grab some rocks, and starts to list off wishes. Izuku can’t believe it.
- Izu: “because i love you more than
- Havent eaten dinner yet btw
- “I wish that mint chocolate chip ice cream gets banned from ice cream shops around the country.”
- “I wish that careless whisper could be taken off of all music platforms and all radio channels.”
- “I wish i’d remember to get my car tire pressure fixed before i get that annoying notification on the dashboard that keeps blinking red.”
- I wish that richard marx didn’t have to play everytime something bad was going to happen
- “I wish i was driving on some lonely road with you right now, kareoking to a chessy madonna song, not knowing where we’ll end up in an hour and not caring.”
- I wish my grandpa was around more often, to tell me more about how to sweep people off their feet and what songs to play at the perfect moments. Maybe id be a different person if he was.
- I wish i was a better person.
- “I wish that the green of the trees didn’t always remind me of your eyes, and that the pink of the sunsets here didn’t always remind me of your lips, and the blue of the damn ocean didn’t always remind me of that stupid shirt you always like to wear. Because i know that i’ll never be able to look at that shit the same.
- I wish i didn’t push everyone away for fucking decades to the point where i convinced myself that I’ll never be able to pull someone close.
- I wish that i was selfless enough to bring an extra drink to practice , so that you don’t have to keep spending a dollar every thursday to get me one, but i don’t because of the

very reason that I *know* you're gonna get me one'
- "I wish that i wasn't like this."
- "I wish i didn't make you cry"
- I wish i could tell you how much i love your eyes before you began to convince yourself i never could.
- "I wished that in the lighthouse, i could have told you that making love to you was easier than breathing to me.
- "And as selfish as it is, I wish that you won't ever fall out of love,"... "Because I know I won't."
- Keep talking. Drag it out until it feels like they can work with the rubble they're standing on. Izuku is crying. Katsuki tries to cheer him up. Starts saying those cheesy lines incorporating song titles. Izuku laughs. That's more like it. Kisses him.
- "Fuck, and for the first time, I understand what the songs I listen to even mean. Because I Want To Know What Love Is. I want to dance with somebody, somebody who loves me. Because you Take My Breath Away. Everytime you Call Me, it's like the fucking First Time." make it really cheesy as a comic relief moment after they recover from an intense fight.
-
- Katsuki giddy at the thought of having a boyfriend.
- "I got a place we could be" go somewhere with a bed or piano. Both preferably. Hold each other. Make love?
- Lots of commentary here. About how it feels like they've gone through war. Bittersweet possibilities here.
- Salt flats.
- Izuku finishes the picnic that they never got to finish. Where, where, where: on an abandoned bridge. Railroad track.
- Abandoned train cars. Come here. And sit and talk. About the fall. About future seasons. More bittersweet conversation. Izuku tells katsuki to meet him at the boardwalk. At this point, do a call back to one of their mommy issues.
-

Idk how this should end. But end it with the line "if love was friendship set on fire, then let me burn to ashes."

"How did we end up here." "I got tired of watching from the sidelines."

**III. A Homage to FTS Town Highlights**

*This is so that future readers who read FTS after it concluded can kind of have a sense of the shenanigans that went on while chapters were being released, and the really cool things that happened!*

*To future readers, I'm sorry that you were not able to experience the family that was created and the billion twitter screenshots of pain and agony that were posted under #FTSTWT, but here were just some snippets of things that I am still stunned about to this day.*

#FTSTWT trended in the United States. there are several thousands tweets under it, if not more!
People wrote fan fiction about FTS, which is already a fan fiction and it has its cute tiny tag on AO3
More than 2000 likes in the Spotify playlist
People's parents listen to the spotify playlist, how cool is that
The beautiful FANART. And some people made music for the fic!!
The role play accounts and that crazy era where people made role play accounts for odd things. ie. izuku's ass, the fence in ise, the air of ise, coach shugo
Those who have so kindly told me that FTS changed their life and the way they think and view the world as well as love. That is so special to me.
OPHELIA hosted an FTS PROMPT WEEK??? And it was amazing.
Author of really popular works and fanart sites read it and I fangirled a lot because i love them
The people, man. They're amazing in FTS town
A kahoot night with more than 70 people came to take a quiz on the fic and then assigned themselves roles in the town
No we literally are a town online. A super supportive community. this is amazing
FTS is trending on tiktok!!
The 60k chapter that killed my fingers
That time people quote retweeted an anti with dozens and dozens of FTS quotes like 'don't overstep your boundaries"
The way cherry Gatorade's are being bought left and right .
Someone made an FTS CAARD! It was so cuteThe way I wrote a lot of this in Hawaii in the middle of a conference
There's a lot of group chats ! Different language group chats too hehe. And a discord server. It was so cool to see people talk about it

**IV. Talks of a Potential Hard Copy**

Sadly, due to copyright and legality stuff, it's still just "talks of". :(

**V. A Masterlist of Collected Fanarts!**

*There are more that I have missed, and so, please tell me if I have missed yours and I'll add it in! The link below goes to a compiled masterdocument of some FTS Fanworks that I was able*

*to get together! Thank you so much for all of these. They are so treasured.*

**LINK HERE: https://docs.google.com/document/d/1v-AmpfOtg8UFK1MuTzWFbRi0MIxgsBgVYz0lzq0e3J0/edit?usp=sharing**

**VI. FTS Prompt Week Submission! I only did two because of time constraints & school, but they're just two short drabbles with no important information in it haha. Just for fun.**

(unedited)

Day 1 : The Town of Ise - Halloween Edition

They say Ise is a summer town. And for the most part, they were right. Summer was where Ise shines best, for the trees were a lush green, the deep blue waters were perfect temperatures to swim in, and there was always a beautiful sky with a clear breeze. Teens dove off of piers and docks into the lakes or at the beach, even when the sign says "No jumping off dock" because what else are teens supposed to do when they see a warning sign besides doing the opposite. Not to mention, there was something about driving down the quiet streets of Ise with hair still sticky from saltwater, the windows down, and Take On Me by A-Ha blaring on the radio that just takes the spotlight. People who grow up and move out of Ise, when thinking back on this small coastal town, only really ever think of their summer memories. Drinking juice pouches on the bank of a river that they've been wading in with a group of friends. Riding a bike down the road to get away from that one neighborhood dog that got loose from it's owner, the crabby lady who lives in that blue house on Elm Street. Or even just sitting in the kitchen table of their homes, staring blankly at the cheesy floral print wallpaper in the afternoon, listening to the analog clock tick, and fanning oneself with a hand fan, wondering when this heat was going to let out. All in all, it was very obvious and agreed upon by every resident of Ise that *yes* , Ise is a summer town.

But this year, *boy* did Autumn look great on Ise. More than any other holiday, even Christmas, Ise dressed itself up nicely for Halloween. From the very first day of October, there were people already in the front yards, balancing themselves on metal ladders, trying to hang decorations up. Fake cobwebs and spiders hung over people's doors. Some houses went all out with the decoration, turning their driveways into mini haunted mazes. Or buying at least 10 different blow up Halloween characters to display on their front lawn.

Sure, this wasn't a traditional holiday, but Ise wasn't a traditional town. The leaves had already turned to vibrant shades of red, yellow, and orange. And with the smallest shake from the wind, it would fall to the ground from the tall oaks and magnolias that made its presence

known. The mountains that served as the backdrop of Ise was also a sight to behold in the fall foliage. The wind is chillier than it is in summer. While summer presents Ise with a nice little breeze that picks up their hair slightly when they walk, the wind in autumn crept into their lungs and chilled their soul just a little bit, just enough that it's satisfying. In every store, halloween music and jack-o-lantern lullabies played.

For fun, teens drove just a little bit outside of town in order to go to the corn maze that a local farm hosts every year. The farm boasts a large pumpkin patch, a 10 acre corn maze, bonfire pits for people to just come hang out around, and different small haunted attractions set up. On the weekdays, the regular corn maze was open from 11AM to 8PM at night. On the weekends, for a raised price, it turned into a Haunted Corn Maze that was open from 7PM to 11PM. And the lines were always long for that one. Katsuki and Izuku had gone to that one just the other week, in which an actor dressed up as Pennywise the dancing clown jumped out from one of the corn stalks, and out of reflex, Midoriya Izuku jumped a whole foot in the air before punching the clown in the face. The actor immediately yelled out a *Fuck!* , breaking character, as he clutched his nose, smearing white face paint on his hands, and Izuku felt bad instantly, apologizing profusely and refusing to let the clown go without some form of emotional compensation. Meanwhile, Bakugo Katsuki stood about a foot away laughing his ass off at the entire fiasco, finding it hilarious that his sweet, precious boyfriend had punched a haunted maze employee in the face. And having taken Izuku's punches before a while back during the Kick-Off event for his senior year season of vault, Katsuki knew for *sure* that Izuku could throw a damn good punch that hurts. Of course, laughing at this only earned him a scolding from Izuku after they left the corn maze, but Katsuki didn't mind. He enjoys the little pout that the greenette does when he was upset, but not *really* upset.

That was last week. *Tonight* , however, was Halloween, which meant that Ise was going to go batshit crazy. Many houses in the different neighborhoods of Ise liked to put on a show on Halloween night for kids trick or treating. Whether it was parents who dressed up as monsters to scare little kids on the driveway or having a small haunted house apparatus for trick-or-treaters to walk through. Regardless, it was a pretty fun holiday. And Izuku often expressed to Katsuki just how much he wished that he could go trick or treating again.

"I miss trick-or-treating,," Izuku frowns as they drove back from the annual Ise Halloween Fall Bake Sale together around 3PM. The two of them were forced to go by Inko Midoriya, who participates every year with a different baked dessert. This year, Inko went with a Dutch Oven Apple Cobbler with a cinnamon sugar coated top. And so, at Inko's booth set up, not only were Katsuki and Izuku called to decorate the booth with fake plastic plants and fall decorations all over the thing, but they were expected to *stand* there both holding signs in their hands for two hours to promote traffic to their stall. Of course, it worked, mostly because Katsuki was the National Tournament champion and everyone wanted to go see what was up with him, and once they were there at the stall, Katsuki would say nothing but to eat the cobbler.

"You've told me," Katsuki replies very monotonously, "A million fucking times actually."

"Ugh," Izuku groans and melts into his seat, "I know, I know."

"I'm surprised Auntie used to let you go trick-or treating," Katsuki chimed in his opinion.

“She did, but I was never allowed to go with friends,” Izuku frowns, “She’d walk me around the neighborhood in my All Might costume, and then when we got home, she’d open up all of the candy to make sure there weren’t razor blades in them.”

“What the fuck,” Katsuki says in response.

Izuku then sighs, “Anyways, now I’m too old. At this point, if I tried to go trick-or-treating, I’d probably end up on the Mr. Hidashi’s watch list.”

“Not if you dress up with something that covers your face, nerd,” Katsuki offers, eyes kept on the road as they drive back to Izuku’s place, “You’re short enough that you could pass as a kid with a large growth spurt.”

“Kacchan, what am I going to say when I ring the door bell, say trick-or-treat and the parents or whoever asks,” Izuku mimics a parent’s shrill voice, “‘Gee, kid! Where’d you get all that muscle from?”
“Er, body suit?” Katsuki suggested in a questionable tone, as if he wasn’t sure himself.

Izuku groaned and put his hands in his face, “Kacchan, you’re supposed to steer me *away* from stupid decisions, not encourage me to do them!”

“Maybe,” Katsuki smirked, “But who would I be if I actually encouraged you to do the right thing, eh Deku?”

Izuku murmurs to himself, agreeing with Katsuki’s analysis, “That’s very true...I suppose you aren’t wrong. That wouldn’t be yo-”

“I got an idea,” Katsuki piped up.

“Hm?” Izuku turned his attention to his boyfriend.

“You dress up or whatever, yeah?” Katsuki began, using his free left arm for hand motions, “And I can act as your parent as you go around trick-or-treating. It’ll be more convincing, You already call me daddy,” And taking a moment to think, Katsuki says to himself, “Damn, I’m a genius.”
Izuku just blinked at him, cheeks flushing, before sputtering, “Y-yes, except you missed the part where *everyone* in Ise knows who you are, Kacchan. Which means they know that you don’t have a kid, much less a kid who is grown enough to be my height and weight.”

“Fuck, I forgot,” Katsuki cursed.

Izuku tsks, “Now, I have to grow up,” Izuku makes sarcastic hand motions, “And be a good adult, and pass out candy.”

“Pass out candy? You aren’t going to the Halloween party later?” Katsuki asked, recalling that they were going together as far as he remembered.

“Yes, but,” Izuku replied, “Mom wants me to pass out candy *before* then.”

Katsuki grumbled, “Again, didn’t think Auntie even participated in Halloween,” He offers, “Seems a little too risque and dangerous for her tastes.”
“She’s a changed woman, Kacchan!” Izuku defended his mother playfully, “She and Jun went out to an adult’s haunted ghost tour the other day, and that’s pretty thrilling!”

“Tch, Jun,” Katsuki smirks knowingly at the name of Auntie’s new *friend* , “Crazy how getting a good dicking changes your life.”

Izuku drops his jaw, and had to pick it up off the floor of the car, “Bakugo Katsuki!”

The blonde in question pulled up into Izuku’s driveway, and turns to the greenette, grinning mischievously as he leans in and says in his deep voice, “Midoriya Izuku.”

The sound sends a shiver down the smaller’s spine, and Izuku flushed at how close they were, and then he gathered himself together, “She’s not doing anything with him!” And then Izuku thought about it for a second, “...yet.”

“Nah, she definitely is,” Katsuki sits back and turns off his car, insisting, “The walls in your house are thin, Deku.”

Izuku stares in horror, “What does that mean?”

“Means that,” Katsuki says, shrugging, “While your nerd ass falls asleep before me, I’m awake, scrolling my phone or some shit. And then I hear repeating thuds that definitely sound like a headboard coming from downstairs. And unless Auntie likes to pound mochi in the kitchen at 1 in the morning, I’d say *she’s* the one getting pounded.”

The greenette shakes his head profusely, not wanting to think about his mother and Jun like that. Don’t get him wrong, he really likes Jun, their neighbor. And when he was a kid, he’d come over a lot to look at the man’s extensive collection of Lego Landmarks. And as of the past few months, Jun’s been coming over more to his house for various reasons to do with his mother. Whether it was just to talk, discuss a book they were reading, or to return something, they hung out a good amount. But as far as his mother told him, they were just *close friends* at the moment. But if what Katsuki was saying is true, then Izuku does *not* want the picture in his head when he closes his eyes.

“Oh god,” Izuku whispers, staring forward.

“Anyways, enough of that,” Katsuki leans back, “Am I picking you up tonight? Or are you driving yourself?”

One improvement with Izuku’s transition into real adulthood was that he drove more often now. His mother was finally letting him take the care more and more often, which Izuku was grateful for. Although Katsuki says he didn’t mind, Izuku felt bad for always mooching off of the blonde’s gas. And so, sometimes they ride in Izuku’s car. Other times, they drive separate and meet at the location. But most of the time, it was just more fun to ride with Katsuki in the blonde’s car, listening to 80s tracks.

“I think I’ll drive myself tonight,” Izuku reasoned, “I don’t know what time my mom’s going to get home to let me off of candy duty, so I don’t want to keep you waiting.”

“I don’t mind, nerd,” Katsuki runs a hand through his hair, “But that’s fine. You got an ETA, at least?”

Izuku thinks of when he should be done passing out adequate enough amounts of candy and his mother would be coming home from a small work-related trip, “Um, around 9?”

“Alright,” Katsuki nods, “What’s your costume. Ya ever end up deciding between All Might or Jeff The Killer?”

Izuku then blushes for some odd reason and shook his head, “A-Ah, I actually decided to go with something else.”

Katsuki in return raises a brow, “Eh?”

Izuku stays quiet, but continues to blush red.

This piqued his curiosity, so the blonde leans forward in his chair, “You gonna tell me or what?”

To this, Izuku gives him a small smile and responds, “You’ll see!”

“I’ll see, huh,” Katsuki repeats and just shrugs in acceptance, “Alright, I’m about to head home, try to dig up my costume from last year.”

“What did you go as last year?” Izuku asked, eyes bright and curious, as he opens the car door, intending to exit. He climbs out, and leans into the car, awaiting Katsuki’s answer.

Last Halloween, he wasn’t allowed to leave the house. Inko had strictly forbade it, and told him to just pass out candy to children at home, but only after peeking through the doorhole. If the child looked taller than 4’10 or so, then he wasn’t allowed to open the door. This year, with the new improvements between his mother and him, Izuku could finally go to a Halloween party for the first time.

Katsuki just gives him a sleazy smile, and replied, “You’ll see.”

At twilight today, the atmosphere was absolutely incredible. And there’s a reason why Halloween was one of Ise’s favorite holidays to celebrate. By the time 6 o’clock came around, the sky had already darkened to a light purple. The sun had *just* slipped below the horizon, so it was still relatively light outside. But what was the most stunning was the intense wash of purple over the city, which added to the Halloween ambiance. The purple contrasted with the amber street lamps made for an unbeatable vibe. There were already plenty of kids dressed up in his neighborhood walking around with treat baskets. There were interesting costumes for sure. There were always the classic ones: the Scream ghoul, Jason, Pennywise, ghosts, and vampires. And then, there were the more creative ones: like a plague

doctor, or a cockroach. Yes, one of the kids that Izuku passed out candy to dressed up as a cockroach.

It was warm in the house, and Izuku would sit in front of the TV waiting for the doorbell to ring while watching a Halloween classic movie, huddled up in his fleece blanket. And when he'd come to open the door, the slight chilliness from the outside would make his breath fog up just slightly when he speaks and gives the children candy. It was a joyous holiday, and for fun, he had creepy halloween music playing from the stereo that Katsuki left on his lawn the night of the Spring Dance.

His mother had set up a fog machine in the walkway leading up to the porch, and cobwebs above the door. Inko had suggested he dress up in costume when he opens the door to pass out candy, but his costume for the Halloween party was not exactly...kid appropriate.

He remembered having the conversation with Ochaco the other day when they were hanging out to catch up.

"-ll Might, but if I do Jeff the Killer, then I'd have to go buy the mask. I mean I could always order it online, but the shipping to Ise is always so expensive," Izuku pouted as he laid on her bed, while the girl searches the web for her *own* Halloween costume. He honestly wasn' feeling either of them, but he had run out of ideas. He already *had* an All Might costume, and Jeff The Killer for some reason just popped up on his mind.

"Deku-kun," Ochaco then pointed at him, "The point of a Halloween party is for everyone to have an opportunity to put on a sexy costume, and feel hot for the night. Not to actually *be* scary."

Izuku ponders it, "That *does* sound fun."

"It is! I'm being a sexy cowgirl, like from the Western movies," She affirmed, "I mean, you can do your original ideas if you want, but I'm just giving you a suggestion."

And at first, when Ochaco presented the idea, it *did* look interesting, but he wasn't really for it solely due to the fact that he had no idea how to dress himself for this kind of event, and felt bad for borrowing Ochaco's clothes all of the time. But as a couple of days went by, the more appealing the idea sounded, and the more appealing one *specific* idea he had in mind sounded.

And so when 8:45 PM rolls around, and Izuku gets a text from his mother saying she's coming home, Izuku hurried to turn off the porch light so that no more kids come until his mother gets home, and rushes upstairs to his room where his costume was already splayed out on his bed. His cheeks flushed looking at it, but he remembered how nice it felt to occasionally dress up a little bit when going out. He had no problems with his t-shirt and pants combo, but it was fun to put on something sexy. And Izuku was not going to lie, although he was doing this mostly because he knew that he'd feel cool, he also hoped a little bit that Katsuki might find it pretty alluring too.

And when Izuku put on his Halloween costume, he felt *great* . He had brought all the materials for it the other day, and it took him about three hours to get it all together, but the

boy likes to think the outfit suited him well.

Going as a little fairy, Izuku kept his green hair a little messy, with some clips that were shaped like golden leaves stuck in different places, so that it looks very naturesque in an elegant way. Izuku had also designed his own top, having bought a dark green lacy bodysuit in which the lace was in floral designs to fit the whole nature fairy theme, and on top of the body suits, the greenette had ironed on some golden appliques to different places so that it looked like there were golden flowers and designs growing out of his green vine-like body suit. And for bottoms, he had just brought a pair of flared shorts in a matching dark green color. The shorts were made of a chiffon-cotton blend, so that it flowed like a skirt when he walked. And the bottom hem of the shorts were purposely shredded in lines, so that it looked like the ends of leaves. The flowy shorts were cut short, so that it covered his ass, and just about nothing else, but that was heavily encouraged by Ochaco who jumped on the idea when he texted her about it. And right below the shorts, after browsing a pop up halloween store for about half an hour, Izuku found a pair of dark green fishnet stockings which hugged his skin well. For shoes, the greenette just wore slippers that he glued a cute little golden bell onto. And for a final touch, he had bought translucent fairy wings to strap onto his back, and pointy prosthetic ears to go along with the whole costume. Overall, he was *very* proud of what he was able to do with the costume.

And when the boy drives along the road to Denki's house, who was hosting it, Izuku must admit he was excited to have some fun, and see what everyone else came up with as well.

Twilight was gone, replaced by darkness when he pulls up onto the busy street, where cars already lined up the street. Parking a little far away, Izuku steps out of his vehicle and was reminded all over again of how he should have brought a jacket at least. The weather was a bit cold outside to where the wind slightly nipped at his cheeks, turning it pink. On the walk up the sidewalks through Denki's neighborhood, Izuku took his time to admire the decorations and liveliness of the whole place. Down the row of houses, orange string lights or sometimes even green and purple lights decorated people's driveways and houses, blow up pumpkins and ghosts stood on their front lawns, and he begins to hear music as he gets closer to the party.

All the way out to the entrance of the party, there were people who loiters on the lawn and what not. Overall, it was a *very* busy halloween party, and Izuku was impressed by how all-out Denki did with the whole set up. On his front lawns, there were hammocks set up between the trees where some people chilled and had a smoke. And jack-o-lanterns were everywhere, alongside scarecrows and small animatronics. Thriller by Michael Jackson was playing on huge speakers set out on his porch, and Izuku found it funny how even with Halloween music, in Ise, it's always 80s.

A crowd stood in and out of the porch, setting on the white railing or hanging out by the stairs. The door to the inside of the house was left open, and Izuku could see that it was plenty busy. The house interior was decorated with lots of halloween themed lights, and even a fog machine on the floor that filled up the first feet with a bit of smoke. Scary posters and masks were hung on the walls, and plastic black spiders were strung everywhere. If Izuku looks up, he sees the window lights of Denki's house glow red, like that of a horror movie, and he grinned.

Izuku was immediately getting compliments on his costume upon walking onto the lawn, looking around to find his friends. Some people he knew had waved to him while they were playing pong on a table set up outside, and gave him their seal of approval on the costume. Izuku noticed their nurse and patient costume, and complimented them as well, before stepping up the porch and heading into the house.

Right away, the music was quiet loud, and it took him a moment to adjust to the sound. In Denki's living room, people were either dancing or just chilling out with some drinks and food in costume. There were weird punches with fake eyeballs in them, and a mock witch's brew that had dry ice coming out in smoke out of the bowl. Even the plates were halloween themed, and the food was dyed black, green, orange, and red, fittingly. There was a crowd of people in the corner playing Truth or Scare, another group of people having a mini dance competition, and plenty of others just hanging around their friends or what not. There were a ton of sexy and great costumes here tonight, Izuku notices with awe. From a playboy bunny to a zombie cowboy, people were doing it all.

Looking around for his close friends or Katsuki, Izuku couldn't find any of them anywhere when he craned his neck to see. And the boy was about to pull out his phone to text his boyfriend, when the enthusiastic voice of Denki Kaminari approached him. Grateful to be seeing the host, Izuku gave his friend a hug and a bright smile.

"Wow, look at you!" Denki gestures to his costume, "I thought you were going with uh- what was it? All Might or…?"

"Jeff the Killer," Izuku laughed.

"This is," Denki pointed finger guns at Izuku, "neither of those."

"You're right," Izuku looked down at his costume with a grin, "I wanted to go for something a little different."

"Well you look great," Denki gave him a pat on the back.

"You too!" Izuku returns the compliment, and took a good look at Denki's outfit. A werewolf, complete with the ears, tail, and fur coat, "The ears suit you well." He laughs.

"Nice!" Denki claps for himself at the compliment, and then excused him, "Oh right, it's nice seeing you here, Midoriya! I gotta go be a good host no-"

"Wait!" Izuku paused him before his fun yellow-haired friend could leave, asking, "Do you know where Kacchan and everyone else are?"
"Oh! Oh yeah," Denki then pointed up the stairs, "All of my close buddies are just up there chillin out away from the crowd. Just go up the stairs, and it's the first room on your left. It's my dad's bar room, but he won't care if you guys are in there!"

Thanking him, Izuku finds his way up the carpeted stairs, and up to the second floor, where the music is not as loud for sure. The hallways were entire dark, nearly pitch black, which was a bit creepy to stare into, but Izuku hears talking from a room near his left. Turning, he

sees a door with a sliver of red light coming out from underneath, and goes up to it, pushing the knob to open the door slowly.

He opens the door and peeks his head in, immediately impressed by Denki's Dad's bar.

The ceilings were lined with red glowing lights, so the entire room was also under a red hue. And only a yellow lamp in the corner of the bar provided some dichotomy. There was a full bar in the back wall with an extensive liquor shelf, and the bar counter was lit up white with gold tints. There were bean bags and comfortable chairs all over the room, and a TV hanging on the left wall. A foosball and pool table sat on the right side of the room, and there were some pizza boxes up here as well.

Ttaking note of the crew up here. Some of his friends were up here. Ochaco for one, wearing her cowgirl outfit looking amazing as always. And Shoto was up there, wearing a monocle, old tweed suit, with a fake plastic gun, and Izuku assumed that he was a 20s mafia mob boss. Overall, it was a lot of the pole vault team, which made sense considering those were Denki's closest friends. Mina took on the alien look, painting her skin pinkish-purple, putting in these black and gold contacts that took up most of her eyes, and looking cool as well. Kirishima went as a Spartan Warrior. And everyone else had pretty great outfits as well.

But like a moth to a flame, in any given room that Izuku walked into, his eyes were drawn to Bakugo Katsuki. And Izuku asked himself how he was blessed enough to be in love and be loved back by someone so completely unreal. By right that he was Bakugo Katsuki, he was already the hottest person in the room even if he chose not to dress up and wear a hoodie and sweatpants. But in his pirate costume, Izuku was swooning.

The blond was currently sitting at the bar, even though he wasn't drinking anything, talking to one of his teammates. On his head, across his forehead, Katsuki was sporting a red silk bandana that tucked under his hair and tied in the back, leaving the tail loose, like a pirate's bandana. On the bar counter was a dark brown pirate's hat, complete with a skull emblem on the front. Katsuki had gold rings on his ear, clip ons, and gold rings on his fingers. For a top, Katsuki wore an off-white colored lantern sleeve shirt loosely tucked into dark brown trousers that accentuated his long, strong legs. Half of the buttons on the blonde's shirt were undone, revealing a toned, smooth chest and sternum, in which he had a faux gold medallion with a pirate skull in the middle strung on a piece of leather hanging around his neck and over his chest. And *boots* . Katsuki wore calf boots that folded over at the top. God, he looked amazing, and Izuku would be laying if he said he didn't grow a little flustered all over his body just looking at the man.

"Midoriya?" Shoto noticed him lurking in the doorway and slowly got off of the bean bag to wave at him, "Why are you just standing there? You should come in."

At the mention, Izuku got a bit shy, waving to him and to others who have started to notice him as well, "A-Ah, right! Sorry, I was just admiring everyone's costumes," He says as he moves through the door and into the room, closing it behind him.

"Admiring everyone's costumes?! Geez, Midoriya! Admire your own," Kirishima called out from the other side of the room, closer to where Katsuki was sitting.

And as Izuku walks further into the room to join everyone, the mention of his boyfriend's name causes Katsuki to pause his conversation and turn his head slightly to Izuku, and when he did, one very handsome brow lifted.

And with just one look, Izuku feels as if he could probably buckle his knees. All Katsuki had done was look at him with a raised brow, yet he was feeling internally hot, like he was burning up internally. And they keep eye contact for a hot minute, but Katsuki has no shame in being the first to break the stare as Izuku got closer. In fact, the blonde let himself get a good eyefull, Izuku notices. The athlete's eyes trail his entire body, and Izuku feels practically naked under his gaze.

Izuku gives his boyfriend an earnest look, and Katsuki quirked the corner of his lips up for just a quick second, and then swiveled around in the barstool to where he was leaning over with his elbows on his knees, and his hands clasped together, staring up at Izuku through the fringes of his hair. It was that gaze that Izuku fell in love with over and over again. And *fuck* , this was going to be a fun night.

**I kind of blue balled you guys on the ending, but this was supposed to just be a fun little halloween prompt for day 1 and I got lazy on writing smut, but yall have imaginations hehe. This was mainly to see what Ise is like during the fall hehe**

Day 2: Hawk Tattoo

He got his consultation done the very day that the letter arrived in his dorm P.O. box with the invitation. He knew right away he was going to get it. And so, before telling Izuku, before telling literally anyone, the very first thing Bakugo Katsuki did upon receiving a certain letter was book a consultation with a renowned tattoo artist in the area near Keio University. The consultation was quick, considering he already knew the design he had in mind. It was simple, and he could get it done within a couple hours, and so he booked his session then and there.

Izuku noticed immediately upon Katsuki's entrance into his singlet dorm room late that night that something was up with the blonde, from the more confident strut to a mischievous grin donning his face.

Izuku raised a brow, "You're in a good mood."

Katsuki made his way over to where Izuku was sitting at his desk, and in a quick sweep, pulled the smaller up into his arms with a little spin before setting Izuku down, pressing a sweet kiss onto those lips that tasted like cherry dum-dums. Cherry. Katsuki liked that.

“I am,” Katsuki admits.

The greenette cocked his head to the side, and gave him a suspicious look, “What is it. New record?”
“Nah,” Katsuki keeps him guessing.

Izuku ponders and sways in his spot, “Hm, is Phil Collins going on an international tour?”
Katsuki snorts, “That son of a bitch is at least 80. If he has any vocal chords left, they’re frayed by now.”

Izuku lets out a laugh before giving up, “Okay, I give up. Tell me, what is it? I’m terrible at guessing.”

“You are,” Katsuki doesn’t miss the opportunity to affirm the remark, before he turns around and peeks over his shoulder for a mere second to say, “How about this for a hint, then.”

And putting his hands on the bottom of his t-shirt, Katsuki pulls upwards until it falls off of his shoulders and onto the ground. He stands up straight, and flexes his back, turning slightly to see Izuku’s reaction. The boy’s face fell into shock immediately as he stares.

“Kacchan!” Izuku practically screams.

On his left shoulder, a hawk tattoo.

On his right shoulder, the Olympic rings.

**VII. Sequel Outline [Please Read Warning] [Not Edited. Typos everywhere]**

**<u>WARNING</u>**

**Do NOT read if you currently like the ending of From The Sidelines.**

**This sequel outline has a lot of continuity errors with FTS, and doesn’t really continue with the story well because their characters in here are VERY out of character from FTS. It’s basically a different story. AND IT’S NOT A REAL SEQUEL. So don’t take it as one, please!**

**This is a very brief outline. Doesn't really go into detail much, but depicts generally what goes through my head when I think of a potential sequel. It's not really what happens though, because this is alllll hypothetical.**

***** I sometimes shorten Deku to D, and Katsuki to K so that I can type faster.**

Outline picks up in the middle of their second year in university. At the status quo, the two are still together, obviously. Healthy relationship, aside from the bickering but they've always been like that. They always go home to Ise during Summer and Winter breaks. And it's a nice time when they're home. Everytime they go home, it feels exactly like how it did when they first fell in love. It was a lot of work getting to where they are now, and sometimes when they're back home, they'll sit on a seaside cliff or on the ledge of Izuku's window laughing at the stupid things they went through just to be together. But when they're in college. It's a little different. Of course, it would be though. They're going from a podunk town near the sea with a slow pace and plenty of beautiful outdoor things to do, to a concrete jungle that's fast paced and they'd have to be a little more creative with their dates. It isn't as if there are creeks just around the corner, or abandoned train tracks to follow, or 80s diners they can hop into. After 2 years of being away from Ise, Izuku has grown a lot in terms of getting out of the small town mentality, but the transition is a bit harder. He's still learning to let go of his past habits, but he's come a long way. Katsuki acclimates to the city well. Perfectly well, because even before college, he's always been exposed to travelling and the city, having been and is a competitive pole vaulter. And so, he fits right in, and helps Izuku in the process as well. Although Izuku can tell that Katsuki has a much easier time than he does, but that doesn't deter him from studying and enjoying the experience of going to university. If their relationship back in Ise felt more bittersweet, nostalgic, and remindful of being young and carefree, then their relationship in university is that of a couple growing up. Because the city can do that to people. The city doesn't have time to take it slow, to enjoy the sunsets on the horizon over the ocean, or jump off boats at lake parties. Instead, the city is *different.* The parties are in condos & dorm rooms, and the stars can't really be seen. Instead, there's twinkling lights that never sleep, and traffic that never stops. And the environment definitely morphs their relationship from a youthful one to a mature one. Of course, they still have their fun. Sneaking onto rooftops of skyscrapers to see if they can touch the stars, climbing scaffolds to get into abandoned buildings, or exploring a new lunch spot that's in the area of where they go to school. They go to school 20 minutes away, which is an easy commute back and forth. Izuku comes over pretty often when he has time, and vice versa.

Izuku makes a nice little group of friends at Waseda. There's this guy there. Let's call him Jae. Jae is a handsome, tall, and an all around good guy, who has an enjoyable personality and isn't toxic or anything. Good guy. Anyways, he's one of Izu's friends.

And Katsuki is constantly surrounded by people at Keio. He's more dedicated than ever to pole vault, and he's progressing ridiculously fast that it's scary. They make time for each other, and that's nice. They love each other, they do. But things are just a little different. That's fine. Izuku thinks it's fine. Katsuki's sure it's fine. When they hang out, Izuku likes to do things that kind of remind him of the things they used to do in Ise. Of course, he loves

exploring new things too, but there's something he deeply misses about the quiet, small town love that they had back in Ise in their last year of high school. And so, when they hang out, Izuku wants to do something reminiscent, like drive an hour or two out of Tokyo to go to the lake, or hike out to a mountain nearby, even if it's a tourist mountain. Meanwhile, although Katsuki does enjoy those reminiscent things, he is constantly pushed by school, coaches, etc. to move forward in the world with his vault. And so, he doesn't understand the point of reminiscing. It won't be for a long time that he'll be able to go back to Ise, and so he doesn't really understand why they're trying to recreate things from the past, when there's nothing wrong with the present. But he doesn't say anything, because it's fine. He loves Izuku to death, and seeing the other happy is good enough for him. Katsuki gets busy. Actually they both do. Izuku is neck-deep in a research lab for a project he's passionate about. (also, Jay, slowly expresses more interest in Izuku, but Izuku makes it clear that he has a boyfriend. And Jay respects that.) And Katsuki is really deep into competition season and improving his PRs. Izuku goes to every single tournament, wearing K's jersey, with a bottle of cherry gatorade waiting for K. Who always gets mobbed for at least 30 minutes before he's able to make it to where Izuku is. And Katsuki squeezes time in his schedule to make room to hang out with Izuku. Sometimes though, they're be settled, watching a movie or doing something, and the blonde will have to leave for an event or meeting he needs to be at. Whether it's with his coach, a promoter/sponsor, someone. And he promises Izuku that he'll get to stay longer next time. Izuku understands, even if he's a little sad inside. He knows that this is Katsuki's dream, and this is the life that entails dating practically a super-athlete. That being said, Katsuki *does* get busier and busier, which means that sometimes, plans are cancelled regrettably or cut short even more or are infrequent in occurrence. But that's okay, Izuku tells himself, because it's worth loving him and worth seeing Katsuki shine brighter and brighter as he flies in vault. But sometimes, it does feel a bit lonely. Especially when it's starting to feel like he's finding some things out about Katsuki from the news first before he hears it from the blonde himself. "I didn't know you just signed with redno." Izuku tells him one day when Katsuki found time to hang out, and they are laying in bed cuddling. Katsuki groggily hums into the boy's neck, "Oh yeah. I signed with them the other week." And there's just this weird feeling in the pit of his stomach, because he doesn't like this. And he realizes very clearly the difference between life in the city and life out in the countryside. And although he wouldn't trade the education and opportunity he and Katsuki are getting for the world, it does feel a little sad knowing that there are sacrifices to be made in terms of time to be with each other and the things that they can do. But Izuku and Katsuki know that they can make this work. This goes on for a while. When one day, Katsuki and Izuku both find time to hang out. And Katsuki kisses him deeply, having missed him a lot. They both internally wish that they didn't have to say they missed each other in the first place. It was getting to the point where Izuku knew more about the lives of his day to day friends than he did of Katsuki's, even if they texted a lot and called most nights that Katsuki didn't have a mandatory event to go to. And Katsuki probably was more updated with his teammates and the parties and whatever that is going on in Keio than he was with what Izuku was doing, simply because the schedules didn't align. Anyways, so K asks what D wanted to do. And D thinks about it, and replies that he wants to get out of Tokyo and maybe go to a shrine or up in the woods? And Katsuki is quiet for a moment. But ultimately nods, and tells him let's go. However, while getting ready to go, Katsuki speaks up. Asks Izuku why he feels the need to recreate the past so much. Katsuki says this because of his internalized fear that Izuku isn't satisfied with the present and that this will lead to Katsuki losing him, and so, Katsuki wants Izuku to be okay

with the present even if it's a bit miserable just so that he doesn't lose the other. And Izuku is a little confused by the question, and asks what he means.

"Nothing," Katsuki waves off the question, figuring that he's being irrational but more so, not wanting to put a damper on the mood on one of the few nights that have together.

Izuku frowns at his answer, setting down his jacket for a moment, before asking once more for clarification, "No, Kacchan, what did you mean by that?"

Katsuki plays with the cap of his gatorade bottle, not making eye contact with his lover as he ponders whether it was a good idea to say it or to leave it be. But he knows well at this point that Izuku wasn't just going to let him *leave it be* , so the blonde chooses his words carefully, "I just mean…that it *seems* you're trying to recreate the shit we did in Ise." He pauses, not wanting to see Izuku's face, "But what I'm saying is that we're not in Ise anymore."

And Izuku denies that he's doing this, feeling a little hurt that Katsuki thinks this, after all that they have endured this past year or so to make this relationship work. If Izuku was so desperate to recreate what they had in Ise, then he would have given up on this a long time ago, seeing as almost *nothing* is like what it was in Ise. And Izuku tells him this too. And Katsuki understands, but he still voices his slight irritation that when they hang out these days, it feels like Izuku is chasing the past. And Izuku is offended, saying that out of everyone, he knows the *most* the dangers of chasing the past and being afraid of change, considering how he grew up and the whole situation with Inko. So how dare Katsuki discredit all the hard work he's put in to his character. And the night is sour, but after a bit, Katsuki comes around and apologizes. Izuku accepts it, even though a bit of his heart is beginning to break.

He doesn't remember the last time Katsuki's played a song for him. Lately, he's been playing songs by himself, and closes his eyes pretending that it was Katsuki playing them for him instead. But Izuku pushes the thought away, and tries alongside Katsuki to pick up the broken pieces of their night together and make the best of it. They just end up watching a movie and cooking dinner. When Katsuki leaves that night, he hugs Izuku a little tighter not knowing when he's going to see the greenette again. Izuku's never made him choose between vault and their relationship. Even now, Katsuki knows that Izuku is putting in so much effort to keep their relationship afloat despite their schedules, and he holds on to the hug tightly wondering if there's going to be a point where it's a little too much to juggle.

Their relationship gets a little more strained after that. And not in a blow-up in your face way, not at all. But rather, it's a more sad, slow strain. One where Izuku's calls to Katsuki went straight to voicemail. Where he'd see Katsuki on someone's social media at a team party that he feels obligated to go to, and then not hear from the blonde until the morning after. And they've talked about it. And everytime, Katsuki says he's trying. And yet, it seems to get more and more distance, slowly. Inch by inch. Until their hang outs are coffee shop dates for about an hour, where the time is taken up by catching up with what happened in the past two weeks or so. And so, gone are the days where Izuku and Katsuki would just talk about random things for hours, and here come the days where it's all just playing catch up.

"So how's the lab going? Did Dr. Loser finally give you the second authorship?" Katsuki asked, using the derogatory nickname for one of the lab coordinators that Izuku didn't get

along with.

Izuku takes a sip of his matcha, before setting down the cup, his eyes settling on the foam on top of the tea and a bit of a pained smile on his lip, “Lab ended weeks ago, Kacchan…” He tells the other, “And he gave me second authorship even before that. I’m at a different lab now. I told you this. Over text, Kacchan.” His voice tapered out in the end.

“Ah, *fuck* ,” Katsuki leans back in his seat and runs a hand through his hair, “It must have gotten lost in my-”

“Thousands of text messages? Emails? Things you always have to do?” Izuku still stared at the foam on the cup, laughing a little to himself, “I know, Kacchan.”
At this, Katsuki furrowed his brows a little bit, and bit the inside of his cheek, “Izuku,” He tells the other seriously, “I can’t help it, you know.”

“Kacchan,” Izuku finally looks up at the other, a bit of water brimming at the bottom but he refuses to cry, not at this, “I’m your boyfriend. You can’t even bother to check *my* messages?”

“And this is my *dream* ,” Katsuki emphasized, referring to vault.

And Izuku drops his head again, this time bringing both hands over to hide his face and his elbows resting on the table, as he says very understandably, “I know…I know it is.”

And Izuku tries not to think about the time where Katsuki believed that his dream included *both* pole vault *and* Izuku in it. To the point where the blonde almost gave up Nationals for him. But Izuku could never ask of that in the first place. Still, he thinks.

And so, it just continues like this, until it’s almost suffocating.

When Katsuki has time, Izuku is working in his new lab or at a meeting.

Izuku still comes to all of his tournaments, no matter what, but it feels like the time that it takes to see Katsuki after a tournament is done is getting longer and longer. Until one day, after a tournament, Katsuki is bombarded. The amount of fans, admirers, sponsors, is almost overwhelming. And when Izuku gets down to the track, he can’t even see his boyfriend over the crowd. And so, he stands to the side, a flower bouquet in his hand, and waits for Katsuki to emerge from the crowd to come find him. And waits. And waits. And he waits.

And then as the track clears out, Izuku doesn’t see Katsuki anywhere. Which means, he must have left somewhere in the crowd. And so, the greenette calls his boyfriend. Katsuki picks up, and Izuku can hear music in the background, lots of voices.

With a small voice, Izuku clutches the bouquet of flowers to his chest and stares down at Katsuki’s jersey on his body and then at the empty stadium, “Where are you?”

Katsuki takes a moment to yell at someone in the background to shut up so he can hear, before asking into the phone again, “Deku? What did you say?”
Izuku says louder this time, but in turn, his voice cracks a little and he feels tears welling up,

“I asked where are you, Kacchan.”
“I’m at a party right now. The team dragged me out to the clubhouse, to celebrate the win. Cheesy little fuckers,” Katsuki laughed with a bit of a gruffness to his voice, before asking, “Hm, why.”

*Why?* Now, Izuku really wanted to cry. But instead, he just tells his boyfriend, “I waited for you, that’s why.” With as little malice in his voice as possible, just exhaustion.

From the other line, Izuku hears a quiet *Fuck* before Katsuki speaks again into the phone, “Fuck. ‘Zuku. I’m sorry. I’m so sorry, dammit. I didn’t think you were coming.”

Izuku frowned into the phone, feeling a little more sad by the minute, “D-didn’t think I was coming?” And then he laughs painfully, “Kacchan. I’ve been watching you since I was 11. What could *possibly* make you think I wasn’t coming?”

“I don’t know,” Katsuki says, “Fuck. You seemed mad at me the last time we talked and I-”

“I was upset *because* we didn’t get to see each other as often,” Izuku reasoned with incredulousness in his voice, “And you *think* that my solution to that would be to avoid you so that we don’t get to see each other even *more* ? Kacchan, do you even understand what you’re saying? Why-Why would I-” But before he could finish, Izuku’s voice cracked.

And upon hearing that, Izuku could hear movement on the other side, and Katsuki asked him with a bit of a panicked tone in his voice, “Fuck. Izuku. Where are you right now.”

Izuku almost didn’t want to say, but ultimately admits ashamed, “I’m at the stadium.”

“Stay there.”

But the last thing Izuku wants to do is to keep standing there, and look stupid as his boyfriend comes back and realizes that he’s been waiting for so long and so the greenette packs up his things. And is heading towards the exit of the stadium, when he sees Katsuki under the outdoor awning walking towards him, calling his name. And fuck, Izuku forgot that the clubhouse wasn’t that far from the stadium.

“Izuku!” Katsuki calls after him.

And Izuku can’t really leave without having to pass Katsuki, and so when the blonde approaches him, Katsuki pauses. The blonde stares at Izuku, still in his jersey, with a bouquet of flowers meant for him. And fuck, Katsuki’s heart drops to his gut.

“Izuku…” He approaches.

But Izuku backs away one step, knowing that Katsuki’s voice sounding so apologetic like that will just make him cry, and he shakes his head, dropping the flowers to the ground.

“Fuck, i’m so sorry,” Katsuki tells him, approaching once more.

But Izuku just looks away, and then smiles to himself, eyes staring hard at the ground as a tear slides down his cheek, and his shoulders shake just a tiny bit, “Look at me. I look so

stupid."

"Fuck," Katsuki approaches to pick up the flower bouquet off the ground, "No you don't. 'Zuku, you don't. This is all my fucking fault. These," He smells the flowers, "are perfect. You're perfect. I'm so sor-"

Izuku wipes at his face with his sleeve and tries to walk around Katsuki. But Katsuki tries to stop him.

"No, Deku," He stops the smaller, "Let's spend tonight together. Come on. I'll take you out, and we'll do something fun and stupid. Let's g-"

Izuku is angry and pushes away, "You're just proving to me that if you wanted to, you could make time for us." And then he stammers, crying a bit more, "Why is it that it has to get to this point where you do me wrong and then feel sorry, that you suddenly have time to take me out and do something fun. Go back to your party, Kacchan. You did amazing, today, and you shouldn't spend your night with me just because you feel bad, when you obviously had somewhere you rather be."

Katsuki gets angry, "Look. I get it. I haven't made the damn time. I've been shitty at schedules. But don't you dare say that I'd just be with you because I feel bad. Because that ain't fucking true."

Izuku cries and shakes his head, "Let's say I didn't come to watch you today. Let's say I didn't wait, and bring flowers, and do all of this. Let's say that you really thought I wouldn't come because I was 'mad at you.' The fact is you would go to the party anyways, that your own *teammates* have told me wasn't mandatory, instead of talking it out with me or trying to spend time with me." Izuku hesitates "And I know I sound needy and maybe I sound selfish, but is it really so much to ask for *some* time? You go to these 'events' that aren't mandatory several times a week. Can I not just get one night?" He cries, "I-I'm your boyfriend, right?" "Izuku-"

"And the last thing I want to do is keep you from your new friends and community," Izuku shakes his head, "And so if you can't give me that, then just tell me so, okay?" He begs, "Tell me, so that I don't spend all day wondering if you might have time to get dinner with me tonight. So I don't constantly hope that you might even *text* me before the day ends."

Silence. And there's this sad feeling in the atmosphere. As Izuku calms down, and Katsuki is unable to refute that he hasn't been attentive or as good as he could have been. Katsuki has always been a man of action, and yet, for the past however, the only way he's been justifying his love for Izuku is through his words.

And so, as the atmosphere quietens, which is funny considering that Tokyo is *never quiet,* and when it is, it's for this exact moment-- Izuku is still sniffling. Katsuki stands a couple of feet from him.

And Izuku looks up at Katsuki finally, and asks softly with a broken voice, "Is this…the part where I should play piano in the dark?"

This is a reference back to chapter 13 of FTS where in one of the final scenes, they listen to Piano in the Dark by Brenda Russell, and it's about a couple. The woman feels bored with the relationship, doesn't really love him anymore, and doesn't really make time anymore for their relationship. However, whenever the man plays piano in the dark, she falls in love with him again.

And so, when Izuku says this, he's implying that Katsuki is the woman from the song who fell out of love and is getting bored with the relationship. And wonders if he should play piano in the dark, if it means Katsuki would fall in love with him again.

Katsuki's mouth is parted, and he's shocked at Izuku's words and implication.

"If -If I do," Izuku stammers as his tears begin again but silently this time, "Will you fall in love with me again?"

Katsuki is silent.

[[[ haven't really thought about this part in detail. But obviously they break up or at least take a break. And this is facilitated by Izuku, who feels more and more saddened every day. He knows he'll forever be in love with Katsuki, but it really hurts. And it doesn't seem like Katsuki is trying, even if he says he is. Because after the night that he was left at the tournament, Katsuki tries really hard for about a week. But after that, it went back to the same old thing. And the very last straw is when drunkenly, Katsuki participates in a drinking game. He's shitfaced drunk, and kisses someone else. Very cliche ik ik, but hey this is a fantasy sequel. Anyways, izuku gets word before Katsuki can even tell him (and yes, katsuki was planning on telling him immediately but the video was sent before he could even get to Izuku) and that's it. That's the last straw. They talk, and Izuku understands that he was drunk, but wants katsuki to also understand that "Kacchan. I know what happened was mostly an accident. But look at it from my perspective, *please* ," He begs, "We've been rocky. I've been missing you for forever. And on a night where you could have *tried* and made an effort to be with me, you went to a party to get drunk, and happened to kiss someone." Katsuki makes the excuse that the party was important because one of the younger sponsors were there. And Izuku calls bullshit with a large cry, because the person who sent him the vid told him none of that stuff is mandatory, sponsor there or not. And since *when* did Katsuki, the man who claims he hates stuffy suit sponsors who only care about him for money and etc. care for sponsors?? Now that he's actually out here in the city, and has given into the competitive pressure? Is this even the katsuki that he knew anymore? It makes no sense. And so they argue. And D repeats heartbrokenly something that Katsuki had said to him a long time ago, "Don't fall out of love with me, because I won't?" Izuku then laughs and wipes at his face, "It looks like in the end, that should have been my wish on the cliff that night." They break up, and fuck, both are very very very very heartbroken. Etc etc blah blah blah.. Anyway, they're broken up and it hurts like crazy. At this point, we lose complete perspective of K. So Jay gets closer to Izuku. But they don't progress into anything else. Because Jay understands that what Izu needs rn is a friend. End this segment with Izuku trying to pick up the pieces of his heart, with a lot of struggle, but he's determined to move forward, while accepting that he'll always love Katsuki. ]]]

Time skip--- (I hate time skips. Which is why the only place you'll see it is in this fake sequel outline). Time skip about 7-8 years.

The setting of the fic circles back to Ise. Rest of the story takes place here. Izuku had earned his degree, and found a job (idk what it is. Just imagine something) back in Ise that allows him to travel and do everything that he's wanted to do career wise without sacrificing the love he has for the small town he grew up in. And so, he's stationed in Ise, but he's constantly going in and out to different cities, and doing what he loves career wise. He lives in his own house, but that's not the only thing that's new. We'll get to that later. Ise is as beautiful as it's ever been. Izuku doesn't really go back to the places that are steeped in memories of him and Katsuki, unless it's very public places like the beach or etc. But that's okay, because there's endless things to do in Ise. And it feels refreshing to be able to breathe again at his own pace. He's been back for over 4 years now, since he graduated 1.3 years after Katsuki and him parted ways. And even though he doesn't talk about it as often as he did when he was younger or make it public, he still keeps up with Katsuki's accomplishments. But that's it. And accomplished, he has been. Very accomplished. Anyways, Izu's living a very stable and great life in Ise, yeah?

Yeah. Until, take a guess, a very cliche guess. A very public injury plagues the news involving the top pole vaulter in the country, and some argue Asia, Bakugo Katsuki. And Izuku knows about it, and he's even been offered the job of being part of the team that looks at Katsuki's injury, as someone who works in sports medicine. But he of course denied it, knowing that although he is very good, there are many others who are also very good and don't have a personal history with the patient. He's worried though. But anyways, so the news of that is very prominent in the headlines, especially in Ise, where everyone practically praises bakugo katsuki for breathing since the athlete is from Ise. And for days, no one really knows the whereabouts of Bakugo, only that he is relocating for the time being, and is considering a possible retirement even if he recovers completely. This is outrageous news, because Katsuki isn't estimated to retire for a good 8 more years, which is much longer than the average shelf life of a top athlete.

When Katsuki shows up in Ise again a week later, we now know exactly *where* he relocated to. Izuku stays calm, or at least as calm as he can. He's moved on, and is living a good life. And he tells himself that if he sees Katsuki, then he'll just treat him like an old friend. Because that's really what they are. He hears that Katsuki's bought a house for himself on the other side of town. And for two weeks, Izuku doesn't see the other at all, which he is internaly grateful for. He just works, and does his own things. Although, he does hear about katsuki *all the fucking time.* Everyone is going batshit insane bc bakugo katsuki is back in ise. And doing weird stuff, like gardening and going to the beach every single day. And Izuku knows it's only a matter of time.

That day happened when he hears a knock on his door. And Izuku opens it to see the man himself, still handsome still perfect still everything that izuku had fallen in love with when he

was 18 years old. And he's internally like *fuck* , but knows he's moved on so it should be okay. Izuku greets him with a smile.

"I heard you were back."

"I am."

Silence. Katsuki stares at him, as if he was trying to take in every single detail of Izuku's face. Katsuki doesn't take his eyes off of the man for a second, and there was this look in the blonde's eyes that was a mix of longing, awe, and whatever else.

Katsuki cleared his throat, and says, "I asked the hag, and she said you lived here now."

Izuku nods slowly, "I do, and I heard you live on oceanside dr."

Katsuki tips his head, "Yeah. It's a nice place, with a good view of the mountains and beach." And then he lets out a breath, "Listen, I just wanted to see if you had any time to maybe grab dinner and catch up. For old time's sake."

Izuku's eyes dart to the ground. He knows there's no harm in doing it. There's someone he has to tell first though… but there's no harm in catching up with an old friend. This way, it might get some curiosity out of his system at what the athlete had been up to since they've been separated. And so after a little bit more small talk and slight awkwardness, Izuku agrees.

"How about the river, by Dina's farm. Like we used to," Katsuki suggested, "I can bring some foo-"

"Kacchan, I don't think that's a good idea," Izuku shuts the idea down gently.

Awkward pause. "Right," Katsuki nods then looks back at Izuku, "Leonard's then? I'll pick you up at 7?"

Leonards is a restaurant. A pretty casual one. And Izuku agrees.

K picks him up, and the ride is pretty normal actually. There wasn't 80s music in the car. In fact, katsuki hasn't listened to that genre is a long time. Several years. Anyways. There has been enough time that's passed after their break up that although there's this sad feeling inside of Izuku, it's enough years that they can just kind of act like old friends catching up. It's not anything super crazy and exciting, because there is still that reservation between them, considering that they were past lovers and very passionate ones at that. But it wasn't as awkward as Izuku has been expecting.

Until this comment.

"I heard you're gardening." Izuku says in between a sip of dessert wine, recalling some gossip that he's heard.

“Damn. I’ve been back for less than a month, and Ise is back at talking about everything I fucking do, huh,” Katsuki jokingly sneers.

Izuku rolls his eyes, crosses his legs. Katsuki’s gaze follows the movement, “So? True or not.”

“You’d think after your mother hit me with a shovel that one time that I’ll never pick one up again,” Katsuki reminisced on their past.

Izuku isn’t quite comfortable with that, so he just clears his throat and takes another sip of his drink.

And so, Katsuki just nods, tapping slightly with his fork, “I am. Gardening, I mean.”

“What are you gardening?” Izuku asks, curious.

“Red lilies.”

Izuku fucking spits out his drink, and spills a bit on his lap. Waitress comes to help him, but Izuku says it’s fine and they’re left alone again. Katsuki’s gaze is piercing into him. And Izuku feels his gut sink, because he knows what red lilies mean.

Katsuki sits back and then gestures towards Izuku, “Enough about me and my incredible athletic feats. How about you, Deku. Anything exciting with you?”

Izuku purses his lips, and then smiles down at his hands that has been in his lap the entire time unless he was eating. Before looking up at Katsuki.

Softly, he tells the blonde, “Kacchan,” He gives the other a smile, “I’m engaged.”

(Katsuki’s world practically collapses inside of his head. And his heart that hasn’t really even been given fully to anyone but Izuku is torn to shreds right then and there. And fuck. What the *fuck* .).

There’s a moment of silence. And a look of shock on Katsuki’s face. Before his eyes travelled down to Izuku’s left hand, which is under the tablecloth on his lap anyways. Seeing Katsuki looking in that direction, izuku says *oh yeah, the ring* to himself, and lifts his left hand to show the blonde, showing off the beautiful ring that he’s been given. (Tada~ After their break up, Izuku and Jay from college were friends for a long time, before Jay decided to ask him out. And they were together for a while, before Jay proposed this past following year. In fact, like three months ago.)

“You’re getting married,” Katsuki just says, something off in his voice as he stares at the ring, then up at Izuku’s smiling face.

And suddenly, the conversation they had in the mirror maze so long ago where Izuku outlined the day he was going to get married to someone else flashed in his head. And his chest feels constricted.

Izuku smiled shyly at his lap, “I am.”

Katsuki swallowed, “Who’s the lucky man.”

Izuku looks up at his former lover, “His name is Jae. We went to college together. I think I introduced you to him before back then. He’s a…” Pause, “Really good guy, Kacchan.”

Katsuki’s gaze towards to the table clothe, before going back to Izuku and saying, “He better be.”

Then K follows up by asking, “When are you…” he can’t really finish the sentence.

“Probably in a year and a half,” Izuku thinks on it, “Things have been a little hectic with work, so there’s no time to think about having the wedding anytime soo-”

“You love him?” Katsuki asks, voice sounding almost scared.

Izuku gives him a funny look, “Of course, I do kacchan. Why would I marry someone I don’t love?”

“Right,” Katsuki says, before looking around again. There’s a moment of silence.

Izuku gives him a grateful smile, before asking the other, “If you don’t mind me asking, why’d you move back here? Just to be near home again?”

At this, Katsuki meets his eyes, and Izuku almost chokes on how those red eyes make him feel, and then Katsuki chuckled to himself before telling Izuku, “Well, I can’t really tell you now.”

Izuku frowned in confusion, “what do you mean?”

“Nothing,” Katsuki waves off, before giving the smaller man a smile, “I’m happy for you, ‘Zuku.”

[[[anyways, i don’t want to go into detail of the next arc because it’ll probably take forever and i’d actually end up writing a fic. So to even more briefly outline: so they talk some more after the dinner, and Katsuki tries to have a normal conversation with Izuku even though all he could fucking think about was that the one that got away is now engaged to someone who probably treats Izuku better than he had. And so after they part ways that night, both admit they had a nice time catching up. Izuku knows internally that this cannot be a regular thing: catching up and talking to Katsuki. Because from the two or three hours alone of them catching up, Izuku already felt something very dangerous brew in his stomach that he is just chalking up to old feelings that aren’t valid anymore. And so they part ways. Izuku goes in, and tells Jay about the encounter with Katsuki while theyre in bed. Jay knows how much Katsuki means to Izuku, so it doesn’t bother him. But there’s this internal insecurity Jay has with Katsuki, because when he and Izuku had first gotten together, Izuku had made it clear to him that a part of him always will love Katsuki, even if it’s no longer romantic. And for the first year or two of them dating, Jay obviously felt like Katsuki was still someone that he’ll never really compare to in Izuku’s eyes. But now, since they have been dating longer and are now engaged, Jay hopes that all of those thoughts are gone, even if he feels a little insecure.

Jay proposes that the three of them get dinner together sometime. Internally, he hopes that this may erase his insecurity, to actually meet Bakugo Katsuki for real and see that there's nothing to worry about. Izuku doesn't know if that's a great idea, but says if he Jay wanted to, then whatever. Anyways, blah blah blah a week or so passes. And Jay encounters Bakugo while at the grocery store in Ise. And on impulse, goes over and introduces himself, and invites Bakugo to their house for dinner. Katsuki is hesitant for a moment, but ultimately agrees. Filler. Fast forward to the dinner. It's kind of awkward. But Katsuki can see that Jay is very obviously a nice and good guy. He's not stuck up, or prudish about having fun and doing spontaneous things here and there. He's truly a good person. Fuck. What hurts the most is knowing that Izuku loves the guy, and probably for good reason.

After dinner, they had all planned on going out to the lawn concert that a local band in Ise was hosting in the greenery of some park. And so as they were about to go, Jay gets a call from work since he's on-call on weekends. And he has to leave, but Izuku understands (because unlike someone, Jay knows how to make time for work and relationships) and kisses the man goodbye. Katsuki looks away when they kiss, hands in his pocket. And Jay tells them to go on without him, now trusting Katsuki more after seeing that Katsuki, although he seems to look at Izuku as if he still loved him, was a respectful and good dude, even if he cursed excessively. Anyways, so Izu and Katsuki go to the lawn concert, and for a moment, it feels like old times. And what more, it feels like old times when Katsuki gets bored and decides that they'll go climb a tree instead (even w/ katsuki's injury) so that they can look at the view of the town from a tall oak. And it's nice. And Izuku is reminded of the Katsuki he had fallen in love with, except more mature. Katsuki seemed a lot more sure and mature now, despite not having lost his rebellious and fun streak. And Izuku knows that this is just friendly, but there has always been an undeniable connection between them that's more than just platonic, and so, Izuku knows that what is best is that nights like these are kept to a minimum, even if he and katsuki end up having wonderful conversations like old times. After all, they still have not addressed the elephant in the room that IS THEIR breakup all those years ago, and what had happened then. And all of those broken promises.

[[again, fast forward a bit. So obviously, we all know what will happen here. Izu and Jay are a good couple, they are. And Katsuki respects that, but he can't fucking stay away. And all he wants to be is friends with Izuku. And Izuku makes his boundaries clear. Jay doesn't mind, because he actually likes Katsuki too. Which makes Katsuki feel really guilty, because although he promises to himself that he'll only want Izuku as a friend, the more he sees Izuku --whether it be in randomly in town or he comes over to see the engaged couple for dinner -- the more he gets slapped in the face with the fact that he is still in love with the boy, and had fucked up that bridge a long time ago. And now that Katsuki is also friends with Jay and genuinely thinks the dude is a good guy, he feels even worse.

On Izuku's part, this is really not good. Because he will never be unloyal to someone. Never. Especially not someone like Jay, who has been very good to him. But fuck. Katsuki was Katsuki. And this was not fucking good. And there were too many times where they were alone. Because now that both katsuki and izuku were in Ise again, their mothers Inko and Mitsuki would have the family dinners again, where izuku and katsuki both attended like old times. And they'd leave midway to go and do something just fun. And it was all friendly

because boundaries and you know, engagement. But that doesn't stop the tension from happening. And it doesn't stop Izuku from realizing that he needs to be clear and upfront to both Katsuki, himself, and Jay about a couple of things.

1. That katsuki being around him like this, even if they aren't doing anything bad, is bringing back emotions he thought he had gotten over.

And so, Izuku makes a pact with himself, that he will limit his contact purposely with katsuki from now on to not jeopardize the good thing he has going on with Jay. Here's the thing. He didn't even need to. Because Katsuki starts avoiding him too, unprompted. And avoiding the both of them. (on katsuki's part, it's because he realizes the exact same thing that he still loves Izuku more than fucking anything, but love is about wanting the best for the other person. And so, he knows that he can't impede on Izuku and Jay's life any longer no matter how much he wants Izuku. And so, he's keeping himself away.). And so, there is this weird period where Katsuki very actively avoiding the both of them. Jay is a little hurt by it, because he likes Katsuki as a buddy a lot. And although Izuku knows that this avoidance is a good thing, he also feels internally a little confused and hurt by katsuki's sudden disappearance from their lives. But again, he knows it's for the best, no matter what reason it is.

Some time later, Jay asks Izuku to return something to Katsuki.

"Where'd you get this?" Izuku asks Jay.

Jay tells him that the other day, he came over to Katsuki's just to talk and borrowed whatever it was. But he doesn't have time today to return it. And so Izuku is just shocked that Jay can just come over to Katsuki's place to talk. And so, this means, that Katsuki was avoiding *him* specifically. That kind of hurts a little bit. But Izuku just nods and confusedly drives to Katsuki's house to return the thing. It's raining the entire time. Around 5:00 PM, so the sky is a greenish-teal color. Katsuki's house, which Izuku has been to on several occasions by now, is next to the beach. There are mountains behind him. He's in a nice neighborhood for sure. And so, the blonde is out in the side yard, chopping wood in the rain bc well, why not. Izuku looks to the garden to see that the red lilies have bloomed. And more so, Katsuki has planted *yellow* flowers as well. So Katsuki is doing that, he hears Izuku approach, and he turns back to what he was doing and continues. Izuku says he's here to drop off the thing. Katsuki just grunts, and tells him to just throw it on the ground right over there. And so he does. And then watches Katsuki for a good minute or so, unsure of what to say if he should say, if anything at all.

Just as he was about to turn and leave, Katsuki drops his ax to the side and looked at Izuku annoyingly, "Are you going to fucking say something? Or just stand there."
At this, Izuku is confused and upset, and he keeps his umbrella up. Asks Katsuki wtf is his problem all of a sudden.

Katsuki realizes that he needs to shut up and stop letting his emotions affect him like this and hurt Izuku unintentionally, and so he just waves it off, trying not to create conflict.

But Izuku pushes it, stepping forward, and asking Katsuki to tell him why he's avoiding *him* specifically. They go back and forth, until it becomes an annoyed screaming match. Where

Katsuki doesn't want to admit why he came back to Ise. Why he's avoiding Izuku. Why he wants to retire from the sport. And Izuku just wants to understand. And they're yelling, and the rain is pouring. And Izuku is just begging why.

And Katsuki loses self constraint , and rushes forward, soaked, and he knocks the umbrella out of Izuku's hand on the way to cupping the smaller man's face, and kissing Izuku passionately, pouring his entire heart and years of longing and regret into that kiss. Knowing that it damn well is the last time he'll ever be able to do it. And he knows he's a piece of shit, and that this is wrong. But he kisses Izuku like there's no tomorrow, and then he pulls back, and now, he's nearly crying too, yelling at Izuku "This is fucking why, Deku." And Izuku is shocked.

Katsuki continues, "Because I'm still fucking in love with you, and I'm still suffering from my mistake in college almost *9* fucking years later, Izuku. And I can't get over you. No matter what I do!" He yells frustratingly, "I threw myself into vault, and I work myself for years until I break an ankle, and the worst part is that I should be devastated. But a bigger part of me was fucking excited because this meant that I didn't have to do this anymore. Be an athlete with no one to jump for. A bigger part of me was fucking exciting because maybe there was some hope I could find you and make it all right again."

And then, he drops his head, and his chest is heaving, Katsuki says with a pained voice, "But you're engaged. You're getting married, 'Zuku. And I just fucking kissed you, like the piece of shit I am. You don't deserve that. Jay doesn't deserve that. But *fuck* , I still love you more than anything."

Shocked Izuku. In a quiet, voice, Izuku breaks, "no, no, no, you can't do this to me, katsuki." Referring to telling Izuku that he loves him, when Izuku knows that his own heart is currently in a divided state.

And then more dialogue. About their past, finally addressing what happened. Katsuki explains himself (idk just come up w something and make sure it connects). And Izuku can't believe this is happening. And Izuku knows that he still loves Katsuki , even though he can't. He also loves Jay, and it's not fair. And they're both pieces of shit, really.

And this ending is disastrous.

But Katsuki doesn't make him choose. Once upon a time, Izuku didn't make *him* choose between two things that he loved (vault and him). And so now, Katsuki wasn't making him choose either.

"You belong with him, 'Zuku," Katsuki says in a quiet voice after the height of their yelling session calms down and they're settled in this quiet intermission, "Jay's a good man. And the things I lack, he makes up for it and more. I'm not telling you I love you so that you'll have to consider me."

The sound of rain persists. And the waves from the beach are still crashing. The sky is getting a bit darker. There's an air of somberness.

“I’m telling you so that you know,” Katsuki says, then looks at Izuku, “In a few months, you’re gonna get married.”

Izuku meets his eye, red and teary. Knowing that yes, he still loves Katsuki so much. And this isn’t fair for anyone.

Katsuki staggers forward a few steps, “You’re gonna get married, and it’s going to be all you’ve ever hoped for.” And then Katsuki recalls the conversation in the mirror maze again, “On the beach. With a five layer mint icing cake. All your friends and family. And you’re going to look beautiful.”

Izuku is now crying more. And Katsuki’s heart is breaking all over again.

“And I’ll wear a nice suit for the day. Take a shot or two of liquor, make it easier on me. And when you recite your vows, no matter how badly I wish it was me, I’ll sleep easy knowing it’s him,” And Katsuki steps close enough to put their foreheads together, and assure Izuku that it’s going to be okay. It’ll be okay.

Izuku goes home after the interaction. And he’s still a sobbing mess. And he goes up to his and Jay’s bedroom. Jay wake up, and wonders why Izuku is just getting back now. Izuku is wet, cold, and a sobbing mess. And Jay holds him, and rocks him. And Izuku doesn’t really need to say much. Jay knows.

“You still love him,” Jay says very softly.

And this makes Izuku cry even more as he shakes in guilt and coldness, and knows that he needs to admit the truth if this was someone he was going to marry, “I do.”

Jay just continues to rub his back, and for some odd reason, the insecurity he felt against bakugo didn’t heighten or anything from the confession. Jay thinks it’s because after meeting and befriending the blonde, he could really tell that Katsuki loved Izuku. And as someone who also loves Izuku, Jay knows that Katsuki wouldn’t do anything that would jeopardize Izuku’s current happiness. And it was clear by the way Katsuki set clear boundaries with them, even if it was also obvious that the blonde was still in love with Izuku. At the end of the day, he (jay) guesses that Katsuki was Katsuki. And it’s always been Katsuki.

Izuku urges, and he means this with all of his heart, “I also love you, Jay. I love you.”

“I know,” Jay tells him. And he does. He knows that Izuku loves him.

And then more dialogue between them. Izuku feeling guilty and knowing he’s not being fair. And he also says that if Jay wants to call off or put off the engagement, he’d understand. Jay tells him the only way that he’ll put off the engagement is if Izuku chooses to. Because even though he knows Izuku still loves Katsuki to some degree, he still has confidence that what he and Izuku has built together is stronger, and more important that even with this roadblock, it’s one they can work to clear together. And even if Izuku doesn’t choose him, love is kind of

self-sabotaging like that. You want the best for the other person, even if it's not the best for you.

{2 months later}

Izuku is standing on the altar. And everything is exactly as Katsuki says. It's perfect. Izuku looks beautiful. He's taken a shot or two to make it easier on himself as he stands there and watches the man that he fell in love with at 18 and still loves to this day, which many would call pathetic, getting married to someone else. Someone who had treated him better. Someone who was there when he had made the mistake not to be. And so Katsuki is dressed in his nicest suit, and he sits in the back, watching the ceremony. He listens to Izuku make his vows, and just as he says, wishes it was him. And he watches as Izuku gets married to someone loves. Since the night where they blew up in Katsuki's backyard in the rain, it's been surprisingly okay. He was still very welcome to the couple's home, and in fact, Jay doesn't harbor any negative feelings towards him. And Izuku, the love of his life: it was like they had a silent understanding.

Later that evening, as the wedding party commences and the sky begins to darken under a classic perfect Ise sunset, Katsuki sits and reminisces on all the memories they had together. The smiles, the cries, all of it. And he pulls out his phone. And for the first time in many years, he plays an 80s song. It's one he's played before. Goodbye by Air Supply.

(sorry)

**VIII. Upcoming Work**

Hello!! So I'm finally done with finals.

Thank god. I don't think I can survive any longer. Anyhow! I have about a month of Christmas break to relax, get my mental health in order, and also relean into my hobbies, which include writing!! Yay!! So I already have an idea for the next fic I want to write, and I do probably plan on starting it in December. However, unlike FTS, the chapters will come out very slowly and also the length for each chapter won't be nearly as long, because I kind of… sacrificed some of my grades in order to write as much and as fast as I did for FTS. And I can't afford to do that anymore even though it's really all I want to do.

The new fic that I'm thinking about doing is completely different than FTS is all ways, shape, and form. And it's also not going to be as good, or as deep, or anything. And so, because I'm really insecure about my writing as yall can probably tell, please don't read the new fic unless you genuinely like the plot summary, because it's nothing like FTS in the slightest. That being said, I'm excited and scared because this one is more experimental, so yeah!

And with that, I want to wish everyone a wonderful day/night, and to tell you guys once more thank you for the journey, and that I love you guys to death.

Works inspired by this one

Let's Leave Everything In The Background by orphan_account

How to Overanalyse Every Song on Your Playlist by technicolrs

when words fail to reach by burntoutcrimson, ragingdynamight

Jumping Hurdles by orphan_account

call me for your lover's alibi by LOVillains

but this time, they were hand in hand by Point12fandoms

Hanging Out...Just About Everywhere by revaliwrites

Don't Look by revaliwrites

I Love Him Too by Sewoona

A Green Tinted Window (Straight Into My Soul) by orphan_account

"To Fuck Face" by Bakugou Katsuki by revaliwrites

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All Fires Turn to Ashes Eventually by lily0fthev4lley

His Red Eyes by soifitsyou

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